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Matthew

Matthew 1:1

Section 1:1–17: A list of Jesus' ancestors

Matthew began his book by listing the names of Jesus' ancestors. He did this to show that Jesus came from the family line of King David and Abraham. By doing this, Matthew showed his readers that the Messiah had come and that he was Jesus.

In this list, Matthew divided the names into three groups of fourteen. In order to get fourteen names in each of the three groups, Matthew omitted several names. (Omitting names to achieve numerical groups was a common practice at that time.) So sometimes the word "father" actually refers to the grandfather. As a result, it may be better in some languages to translate the word "father" with a more general term such as "ancestor."

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The ancestors of Jesus

Matthew wrote/gave the list of the family line of Jesus

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 3:23–38.

Paragraph 1:1

In this paragraph Matthew introduced the list of family names.

1:1a

This is the record of the genealogy of Jesus Christ,

- ¶ This is a list of the ancestors of Jesus Christ
- ¶ Here are the people whom Jesus the Christ/Messiah descended from.

This is the record of the genealogy: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the record of the genealogy also means the "list of the ancestors" (as in the GNT).

In Greek, there is no verb in 1:1. Many languages will need to supply a verb here as the BSB has done. For example:

This is the list of ancestors of Jesus Christ (GW)

Here are the names of the ancestors of Jesus Christ

of Jesus Christ: In the phrase Jesus Christ, Jesus is a personal name and Christ is a title. The title Christ is the Greek translation of the Hebrew word "Messiah." The words Christ and Messiah have the same meaning.

Make sure that your translation does not imply that the word Christ is the surname of Jesus.

To make it clear that Christ is a title, you may want to:

- Put the title before the name. For example:

Christ Jesus

- Translate it as Messiah. For example:

Messiah Jesus

Jesus the Messiah

- Indicate in some other way that Christ is a title. One way to do this in English is to use the article "the" before a title. For example:

Jesus the Christ

Christ: The word Christ is the Greek translation of the Hebrew word "Messiah." "Messiah" refers to the person whom God had appointed and promised to send as king and savior. The words Christ and Messiah have the same meaning.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- Transliterate Christ and indicate in some way that it is a title. For example:

the Kristi

- Transliterate Christ and include a phrase that explains the meaning. For example:

Karisiti, the appointed one

Cristo, the Savior whom God promised to send

- Use a title or a descriptive phrase in your language that has the same meaning as Christ. For example:

Messiah

Promised Deliverer

The Rescuer-King whom God sent

If you do not indicate the meaning of Christ in the text, you may want to include a footnote to explain the meaning of Christ. Or you may want to explain the meaning in a glossary. For example:

The word/title “Christ” refers to the King and Savior whom God had promised to send.

See also Christ in the Glossary.

1:1b

the son of David, the son of Abraham:

- the son/descendant of David and the son/descendant of Abraham.
- He descended from King David and also from Abraham.

son of David: The phrase son of David here means that Jesus was a “descendant of David.” It does not mean that David was the earthly father of Jesus. There were many generations between David and Jesus. (Notice that in 1:6, this same David is referred to with his title: “David the king.”)

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

a descendant of King David

he descended from King David

The Jews of that time commonly referred to the promised Messiah as the son of David. Since many of the first readers of this book were Jewish, they would recognize this phrase. They would understand that Matthew was claiming that Jesus was that Messiah.

You may want to include a footnote to explain this. A sample footnote is:

God promised hundreds of years before Jesus that the Messiah would be a descendant of King David (Isaiah 9:6–7, 11:1–5; Jeremiah 23:5).

son of Abraham: There are two ways to interpret the phrase son of Abraham and who it refers to:

1. It refers to Jesus Christ. For example:

Jesus...a descendant of King David and of Abraham (NLT) (BSB, NLT, CEV, GW, JBP)

1. It refers to David. For example:

David came from the family of Abraham (NCV) (NCV, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This interpretation has the most support from commentators. Some English versions are ambiguous, so it is not possible to tell which interpretation they follow.

Just as in the phrase “son of David,” the phrase son of Abraham means that Abraham was an ancestor of Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

and also a descendant of Abraham

he also descended from Abraham

General Comment on 1:1b

If it is more natural in your language to mention the oldest ancestor first, you should list Abraham first. For example:

he was a descendant of Abraham and of David.

Matthew 1:2

Section 1:1–17: A list of Jesus’ ancestors

Matthew began his book by listing the names of Jesus’ ancestors. He did this to show that Jesus came from the family line of King David and Abraham. By doing this, Matthew showed his readers that the Messiah had come and that he was Jesus.

In this list, Matthew divided the names into three groups of fourteen. In order to get fourteen names in each of the three groups, Matthew omitted several names. (Omitting names to achieve numerical groups was a common practice at that time.) So sometimes the word “father” actually refers to the grandfather. As a result, it may be better in some languages to translate the word “father” with a more general term such as “ancestor.”

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The ancestors of Jesus

Matthew wrote/gave the list of the family line of Jesus

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 3:23–38.

Paragraph 1:2–6a

This paragraph contains the first group of fourteen names of men in the family line of Jesus. It starts with the oldest ancestor, Abraham, and ends with David. It is important that you make clear that the list goes in the order of ancestor (or “father”) to descendant (or “son”).

1:2a

Abraham was the father of Isaac, Isaac the father of Jacob,

- ¶ Abraham was the father of Isaac. Isaac was the father of Jacob.
- ¶ Abraham fathered Isaac. Isaac fathered Jacob.

Abraham was the father of Isaac: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as was the father of means “caused to be born” or “brought into being.” This Greek verb can also be translated in English by the verb “fathered.” New Testament authors also used this Greek word to refer to a grandfather (or a distant ancestor) “fathering” a grandson. For example, in 1:11, Matthew used this word to describe the relationship between Josiah (the grandfather) and his grandson, Jeconiah.

Isaac the father of Jacob: The same Greek verb that was in the previous clause occurs here and in each clause until the end of this genealogy at 1:16a. However, in this clause, and in many of the clauses in this genealogy, the BSB does not translate the clauses with a verb. In many languages, it will be more natural to repeat the verb in each clause. For example:

Isaac was the father of Jacob. (NLT)

Isaac fathered Jacob

1:2b

and Jacob the father of Judah and his brothers.

- Jacob was the father of Judah and his brothers.
- Jacob fathered Judah and his/Judah’s younger brothers and older brothers.

Judah and his brothers: Some of Judah’s brothers were older than he was and some were younger. If your language has different words for “older brother” and “younger brother,” you should use these two words here. For example:

Judah and his older-brothers and younger-brothers

Matthew 1:3

Section 1:1–17: A list of Jesus’ ancestors

Matthew began his book by listing the names of Jesus’ ancestors. He did this to show that Jesus came from the family line of King David and Abraham. By doing this, Matthew showed his readers that the Messiah had come and that he was Jesus.

In this list, Matthew divided the names into three groups of fourteen. In order to get fourteen names in each of the three groups, Matthew omitted several names. (Omitting names to achieve numerical groups was a common practice at that time.) So sometimes the word “father” actually refers to the grandfather. As a result, it may be better in some languages to translate the word “father” with a more general term such as “ancestor.”

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The ancestors of Jesus

Matthew wrote/gave the list of the family line of Jesus

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 3:23–38.

Paragraph 1:2–6a

This paragraph contains the first group of fourteen names of men in the family line of Jesus. It starts with the oldest ancestor, Abraham, and ends with David. It is important that you make clear that the list goes in the order of ancestor (or “father”) to descendant (or “son”).

1:3a

Judah was the father of Perez and Zerah by Tamar,

- Judah was the father of Perez and Zerah by Tamar.
- Judah fathered Perez and Zerah, and Tamar was their mother.

Perez and Zerah: Both Perez and Zerah are male names.

by Tamar: The phrase by Tamar indicates that Tamar was the mother of both Perez and Zerah.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

whose mother was Tamar (NIV)

(their mother was Tamar) (GNT)

The mother of these two men was Tamar

Matthew mentioned mothers four times in this list of ancestors: 1:3a, 1:5a, 1:5b, 1:6b. All the rest of the names in this genealogy are names of the fathers or male ancestors.

1:3b

Perez the father of Hezron, and Hezron the father of Ram.

- Perez was the father of Hezron. Hezron was the father of Ram.
- Perez fathered Hezron. Hezron fathered Ram.

Ram: Most English versions spell this name Ram. A few versions (NRSV and KJV) spell it Aram. You should follow the spelling of the national language version, but spell it according to the rules of your language.

Matthew 1:5

Section 1:1–17: A list of Jesus' ancestors

Matthew began his book by listing the names of Jesus' ancestors. He did this to show that Jesus came from the family line of King David and Abraham. By doing this, Matthew showed his readers that the Messiah had come and that he was Jesus.

In this list, Matthew divided the names into three groups of fourteen. In order to get fourteen names in each of the three groups, Matthew omitted several names. (Omitting names to achieve numerical groups was a common practice at that time.) So sometimes the word “father” actually refers to the grandfather. As a result, it may be better in some languages to translate the word “father” with a more general term such as “ancestor.”

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The ancestors of Jesus

Matthew wrote/gave the list of the family line of Jesus

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 3:23–38.

Paragraph 1:2–6a

This paragraph contains the first group of fourteen names of men in the family line of Jesus. It starts with the oldest ancestor, Abraham, and ends with David. It is important that you make clear that the list goes in the order of ancestor (or “father”) to descendant (or “son”).

1:5a

Salmon was the father of Boaz by Rahab,

- Salmon was the father of Boaz by Rahab.
- Salmon fathered Boaz, and Rahab was his mother.

by Rahab: The Greek grammar in this phrase is the same as in the phrase “by Tamar” in 1:3. You should translate this phrase in a similar way. For example:

whose mother was Rahab (NIV)

(his mother was Rahab) (GNT)

His mother was Rahab

1:5b

Boaz the father of Obed by Ruth,

- Boaz was the father of Obed by Ruth.
- Boaz fathered Obed, and Ruth was his mother.

1:5c

Obed the father of Jesse,

- Obed was the father of Jesse.
- Obed fathered Jesse.

Matthew 1:6

Section 1:1–17: A list of Jesus' ancestors

Matthew began his book by listing the names of Jesus' ancestors. He did this to show that Jesus came from the family line of King David and Abraham. By doing this, Matthew showed his readers that the Messiah had come and that he was Jesus.

In this list, Matthew divided the names into three groups of fourteen. In order to get fourteen names in each of the three groups, Matthew omitted several names. (Omitting names to achieve numerical groups was a common practice at that time.) So sometimes the word “father” actually refers to the grandfather. As a result, it may be better in some languages to translate the word “father” with a more general term such as “ancestor.”

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The ancestors of Jesus

Matthew wrote/gave the list of the family line of Jesus

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 3:23–38.

Paragraph 1:2–6a

This paragraph contains the first group of fourteen names of men in the family line of Jesus. It starts with the oldest ancestor, Abraham, and ends with David. It is important that you make clear that the list goes in the order of ancestor (or “father”) to descendant (or “son”).

1:6a

and Jesse the father of David the king.

- Jesse was the father of King David.
- Jesse fathered David who later became chief.

David the king: It may be more natural in your language to indicate that David became king many years after he was born. For example:

David who later became king

king: The word king refers to a ruler who has highest authority over a large region, usually a country.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

high/supreme leader

chief

Paragraph 1:6b–11

The second group of fourteen names of men in the family line of Jesus starts at 1:6b.

1:6b

Next: David was the father of Solomon by Uriah’s wife,

- ¶ David was the father of Solomon, by the wife of the late/former Uriah.
- ¶ David fathered Solomon. His mother was the woman who had been Uriah’s wife.

Solomon by Uriah’s wife: In this verse, Solomon’s mother is identified as the Uriah’s wife. Her name was Bathsheba. But when Solomon was born, Bathsheba was married to David. This is because David caused Uriah to die in a war and then married Bathsheba. Solomon was born after David married her. (The full story is in 2 Samuel chapters 11–12.)

In some languages, it may be important to indicate that Uriah was dead when Solomon was born. For example:

whose mother had been the late Uriah’s wife

by the former wife of Uriah

by the widow of Uriah

(his mother was the woman who had been Uriah’s wife) (GNT)

Matthew 1:7

Section 1:1–17: A list of Jesus’ ancestors

Matthew began his book by listing the names of Jesus’ ancestors. He did this to show that Jesus came from the family line of King David and Abraham. By doing this, Matthew showed his readers that the Messiah had come and that he was Jesus.

In this list, Matthew divided the names into three groups of fourteen. In order to get fourteen names in each of the three groups, Matthew omitted several names. (Omitting names to achieve numerical groups was a common practice at that time.) So sometimes the word “father” actually refers to the grandfather. As a result, it may be better in some languages to translate the word “father” with a more general term such as “ancestor.”

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The ancestors of Jesus

Matthew wrote/gave the list of the family line of Jesus

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 3:23–38.

Paragraph 1:6b–11

The second group of fourteen names of men in the family line of Jesus starts at 1:6b.

1:7a

Solomon the father of Rehoboam, Rehoboam the father of Abijah,

- Solomon was the father of Rehoboam. Rehoboam was the father of Abijah.
- Solomon fathered Rehoboam. Rehoboam fathered Abijah.

1:7b–8a

Asa: A few English versions (NRSV and ESV) spell this name Asaph. Most English versions spell it Asa, as the BSB does. You should follow the spelling of the

national language version, but spell it according to the rules of your language.

1:7b

and Abijah the father of Asa.

- Abijah was the father of Asa.
- Abijah fathered Asa.

Matthew 1:8

Section 1:1–17: A list of Jesus' ancestors

Matthew began his book by listing the names of Jesus' ancestors. He did this to show that Jesus came from the family line of King David and Abraham. By doing this, Matthew showed his readers that the Messiah had come and that he was Jesus.

In this list, Matthew divided the names into three groups of fourteen. In order to get fourteen names in each of the three groups, Matthew omitted several names. (Omitting names to achieve numerical groups was a common practice at that time.) So sometimes the word "father" actually refers to the grandfather. As a result, it may be better in some languages to translate the word "father" with a more general term such as "ancestor."

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The ancestors of Jesus

Matthew wrote/gave the list of the family line of Jesus

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 3:23–38.

Paragraph 1:6b–11

The second group of fourteen names of men in the family line of Jesus starts at 1:6b.

1:8a

Asa was the father of Jehoshaphat, Jehoshaphat the father of Joram,

- Asa was the father of Jehoshaphat. Jehoshaphat was the father of Jehoram.
- Asa fathered Jehoshaphat. Jehoshaphat fathered Jehoram.

1:8b

and Joram the father of Uzziah.

- Jehoram was the father of Uzziah.
- Jehoram fathered Uzziah.

1:8a–b

Joram: Some English versions spell this name Joram, as the BSB does. Other English versions spell it Jehoram. You should follow the spelling of the national language version, but spell it according to the rules of your language.

Matthew 1:10

Section 1:1–17: A list of Jesus' ancestors

Matthew began his book by listing the names of Jesus' ancestors. He did this to show that Jesus came from the family line of King David and Abraham. By doing this, Matthew showed his readers that the Messiah had come and that he was Jesus.

In this list, Matthew divided the names into three groups of fourteen. In order to get fourteen names in each of the three groups, Matthew omitted several names. (Omitting names to achieve numerical groups was a common practice at that time.) So sometimes the word "father" actually refers to the grandfather. As a result, it may be better in some languages to translate the word "father" with a more general term such as "ancestor."

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The ancestors of Jesus

Matthew wrote/gave the list of the family line of Jesus

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 3:23–38.

Paragraph 1:6b–11

The second group of fourteen names of men in the family line of Jesus starts at 1:6b.

1:10a

Hezekiah was the father of Manasseh, Manasseh the father of Amon,

- Hezekiah was the father of Manasseh. Manasseh was the father of Amon.
- Hezekiah fathered Manasseh. Manasseh fathered Amon.

1:10b

Amon the father of Josiah,

- Amon was the father of Josiah.
- Amon fathered Josiah.

1:10a-b

Amon: A few English versions spell this name Amos. Most English versions spell this name Amon, as the BSB does. You should follow the spelling of the national language version, but spell it according to the rules of your language.

Matthew 1:11**Section 1:1-17: A list of Jesus' ancestors**

Matthew began his book by listing the names of Jesus' ancestors. He did this to show that Jesus came from the family line of King David and Abraham. By doing this, Matthew showed his readers that the Messiah had come and that he was Jesus.

In this list, Matthew divided the names into three groups of fourteen. In order to get fourteen names in each of the three groups, Matthew omitted several names. (Omitting names to achieve numerical groups was a common practice at that time.) So sometimes the word "father" actually refers to the grandfather. As a result, it may be better in some languages to translate the word "father" with a more general term such as "ancestor."

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The ancestors of Jesus

Matthew wrote/gave the list of the family line of Jesus

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 3:23-38.

Paragraph 1:6b-11

The second group of fourteen names of men in the family line of Jesus starts at 1:6b.

1:11a**and Josiah the father of Jeconiah and his brothers**

- Josiah was the grand father of Jeconiah and his brothers.
- Josiah fathered Jeconiah and his younger brothers.

Josiah the father of Jeconiah: According to 1 Chronicles 3:16-17, Josiah was actually the grandfather of Jeconiah. If your word for father means only the actual biological father, you may want to use another word here. For example:

Josiah was the grandfather of (NCV)

Josiah was the ancestor of

Jeconiah: Most English versions spell this name Jeconiah or Jeconiah. A few English versions spell this name Jehoiachin. You should follow the spelling of the national language version, but spell it according to the rules of your language.

and his brothers: Jeconiah was the oldest brother. If your language has different words for older-brothers and younger-brothers, you should use the word for younger-brothers here. For example:

and his younger-brothers

1:11b**at the time of the exile to Babylon.**

- During their lifetimes, they were exiled/deported to Babylon.
- Then the enemies of the people of Israel forced them to go and live in the land of Babylon.

at the time of the exile to Babylon: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as at the time of the exile to Babylon means that Jeconiah and his brothers were born before the deportation to Babylon.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

They lived at the time when the people were exiled to Babylon. (GW)

Then the deportation to Babylon took place. (NJB)

exile to Babylon: The Greek word that the BSB translates as exile refers to forcefully moving people away from their homeland and causing them to live somewhere else. People who are deported are not permitted to return to their homeland.

In this case, the king of Babylon conquered Israel and forced many of the people of Israel to live in his country. They lived there for seventy years.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

forced to move to Babylon and live there

the king of Babylon forced the people of Israel to go live in his country

Babylon: The word Babylon can refer either to the capital city or to the country. Here it refers to the country.

In some languages, it may be natural to include some of this information. For example:

the country/land of Babylon

Matthew 1:12

Section 1:1–17: A list of Jesus' ancestors

Matthew began his book by listing the names of Jesus' ancestors. He did this to show that Jesus came from the family line of King David and Abraham. By doing this, Matthew showed his readers that the Messiah had come and that he was Jesus.

In this list, Matthew divided the names into three groups of fourteen. In order to get fourteen names in each of the three groups, Matthew omitted several names. (Omitting names to achieve numerical groups was a common practice at that time.) So sometimes the word "father" actually refers to the grandfather. As a result, it may be better in some languages to translate the word "father" with a more general term such as "ancestor."

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The ancestors of Jesus

Matthew wrote/gave the list of the family line of Jesus

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 3:23–38.

Paragraph 1:12–16

This paragraph contains the third group of fourteen names of men in the family line of Jesus.

1:12a

After the exile to Babylon:

- ¶ After they went to Babylon,
- ¶ After they were forced to go to the land of Babylon,

After the exile to Babylon: The phrase After the exile to Babylon refers to the time after the exile began. It does not mean "after the deportation/exile was over."

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

After they were taken to Babylon (NCV)

After they were forced to go and live in Babylon

1:12b

Jeconiah was the father of Shealtiel,

- Jeconiah was the father of Shealtiel.
- Jeconiah fathered Shealtiel.

1:12c

Shealtiel the father of Zerubbabel,

- Shealtiel was the grand father of Zerubbabel.
- Shealtiel fathered Zerubbabel.

Shealtiel the father of Zerubbabel: According to 1 Chronicles 3:19, Shealtiel was actually the grandfather of Zerubbabel. If your word for father means only the actual biological father, you may want to use another word here. For example:

Shealtiel was the grandfather of Zerubbabel.
(NCV)

Shealtiel was the ancestor of Zerubbabel

Matthew 1:16

Section 1:1–17: A list of Jesus' ancestors

Matthew began his book by listing the names of Jesus' ancestors. He did this to show that Jesus came from the family line of King David and Abraham. By doing this, Matthew showed his readers that the Messiah had come and that he was Jesus.

In this list, Matthew divided the names into three groups of fourteen. In order to get fourteen names in each of the three groups, Matthew omitted several names. (Omitting names to achieve numerical groups was a common practice at that time.) So sometimes the word "father" actually refers to the grandfather. As a result, it may be better in some languages to translate the word "father" with a more general term such as "ancestor."

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The ancestors of Jesus

Matthew wrote/gave the list of the family line of Jesus

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 3:23–38.

Paragraph 1:12–16

This paragraph contains the third group of fourteen names of men in the family line of Jesus.

1:16a
and Jacob the father of Joseph, the husband of Mary,

- Jacob was the father of Joseph, who was Mary's husband.
- Jacob fathered Joseph. Joseph married Mary.

1:16b
of whom was born Jesus, who is called Christ.

- Mary was the mother of Jesus who is called the Christ.
- Mary gave birth to Jesus. He is the Christ/Messiah.

1:16a-b
Joseph, the husband of Mary, of whom was born Jesus: The Greek pronoun that the BSB translates as whom is feminine. Therefore, it refers to Mary only. It does not refer to Joseph.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Joseph, who married Mary, the mother of Jesus (GNT)

Joseph, who was the husband of Mary. Mary was the mother of Jesus (GW)

who is called Christ: The phrase who is called Christ indicates that Jesus is described or addressed with the title Christ. He received this title because he actually is the Christ.

The verb is called is passive. The text does not specify who will call Jesus this. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- Use a passive. For example:

Jesus is called the Christ. (NCV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

They call him the Christ

- Use a form to focus on the fact that Jesus is the Christ. For example:

he is the Christ/Messiah

he has the title "Christ"

Christ: Here Matthew used the word Christ as a descriptive title for Jesus. Christ is not just a name for

Jesus. It has meaning, and the meaning of the title is in focus in this context.

See the note on Christ in 1:1a for advice on translating this title.

Matthew 1:17

Section 1:1-17: A list of Jesus' ancestors

Matthew began his book by listing the names of Jesus' ancestors. He did this to show that Jesus came from the family line of King David and Abraham. By doing this, Matthew showed his readers that the Messiah had come and that he was Jesus.

In this list, Matthew divided the names into three groups of fourteen. In order to get fourteen names in each of the three groups, Matthew omitted several names. (Omitting names to achieve numerical groups was a common practice at that time.) So sometimes the word "father" actually refers to the grandfather. As a result, it may be better in some languages to translate the word "father" with a more general term such as "ancestor."

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The ancestors of Jesus

Matthew wrote/gave the list of the family line of Jesus

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 3:23-38.

1:17a

In all, then, there were fourteen generations from Abraham to David,

- ¶ So then, there were fourteen generations from Abraham to David.
- ¶ So, the number of generations from Abraham to King David is fourteen.

In all, then: In this context, the Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as In all, then indicates that 1:17 is a summary of 1:2-16.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

Thus (NIV)

So then (GNT)

All those listed above include (NLT)

there were fourteen generations: The word “generation” here refers to a person and the people in his age group. A father and his age group represent one generation. His son and his age group represent a second generation. His son’s son and his age group represent a third generation.

1:17b

fourteen from David to the exile to Babylon,

- There were fourteen more generations from David until the people of Israel were exiled/deported to Babylon,
- The number of generations from King David to the time the people of Israel were forced to go and live in the country of Babylon is also fourteen.

the exile to Babylon: Translate this phrase as you did in 1:11b.

1:17c

and fourteen from the exile to the Christ.

- and there were fourteen more generations from when they were exiled/deported until the birth of the Christ.
- And the number of generations from the time the people of Israel were forced to live in the country of Babylon until the birth of the Christ/Messiah is also fourteen.

to the Christ: The phrase to the Christ refers to the birth of the Christ.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

to the birth of the Messiah (GNT)

until Christ was born (NCV)

up to the time that the Messiah was born

Translate the Christ here as you did in 1:16b.

Matthew 1:18

Section 1:18–25: Jesus Christ was born

This section tells us how the Messiah came into the world. The Holy Spirit miraculously caused the virgin Mary to become pregnant with the child Jesus. Such an event had never happened before.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Birth of Jesus Christ (NIV)

The Birth of Jesus the Messiah (NLT)

Here is how Jesus was born

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 2:1–7.

1:18a

This is how the birth of Jesus Christ came about:

- ¶ This is the story about the birth of Jesus Christ.
- ¶ Here is how Jesus the Christ/Messiah was born:

The Greek of 1:18a begins with a word that is often translated as “and” or “but.” It indicates that 1:18 is the beginning of a new section. Some English versions indicate this with a conjunction (ESV: “Now”). The BSB, like other English versions, does not introduce this section with a conjunction. In your language, translate it in a way that is natural to indicate the start of a new story.

This is how the birth of Jesus Christ came about:

This clause introduces the story of Jesus’ birth.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Now the birth of Jesus Christ happened this way.
(NET)

the birth of Jesus Christ was as follows: (NASB)

This is how Jesus Christ was born. (CEV)

Jesus Christ: Here, the name Christ is a title. Another word for this title is Messiah. For example:

Jesus the Messiah (NLT)

The phrase Jesus Christ also occurs in 1:1a. You should translate it here as you did there.

1:18b

His mother Mary was pledged in marriage to Joseph,

- His mother Mary was engaged to be married to Joseph.
- The name of Jesus’ mother was Mary. She had promised to marry a man named Joseph.

His mother Mary was pledged in marriage to Joseph: The word pledged refers to an agreement to marry. This agreement was made by a young man and

woman and their families. Mary had formally agreed to marry Joseph.

Some English versions translate this word as “engaged.” However, the marriage agreement among the Jews was more strict than the word “engaged” implies in western society. It legally joined a man and woman, and it was as binding as marriage. If either the man or the woman ended the agreement, people considered them to be divorced.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

was pledged to be married (NIV)

was engaged to be married (NCV)

had been promised...in marriage (GW)

had made an agreement to marry

After the marriage agreement was made, the man and woman usually waited for a year before their wedding. As part of the wedding ceremony, the man took the woman into his house to live.

1:18c

but before they came together,

- Before they^(dual) were married,
- But before they^(dual) lived together as husband and wife,
- But before the marriage took place, while she was still a virgin, (NLT)

but before they came together: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as before they came together refers to getting married.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

but before they were married (GNT)

but before they lived together (NRSV)

Matthew’s point is that Mary became pregnant while she was still a virgin. It was a miracle. In some cultures, sexual relations are common before marriage. So it may be necessary to make it more explicit that Mary had not had sexual relations when she became pregnant. For example:

But before the marriage took place, while she was still a virgin (NLT)

before they slept together

1:18d

she was found to be with child through the Holy Spirit.

- she became pregnant through the Holy Spirit.
- the Spirit of God did a miracle which caused her to be pregnant.

she was found to be with child: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as she was found to be with child is an expression that means “she was/became.” See also passages such as Luke 9:36 and Luke 17:18 where the passive form of the verb *εὕρισκω* (find) is an expression meaning “is” or “realize.” pregnant” or “she learned/realized that she was pregnant.” For example:

she learned that she was going to have a baby (CEV)

Mary realized that she was pregnant (GW)

she became pregnant (NLT)

through the Holy Spirit: The phrase through the Holy Spirit indicates that the Holy Spirit caused Mary to become pregnant. It was a miracle. The Holy Spirit did not cause Mary to become pregnant in the same way a man causes a woman to become pregnant.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

through a miracle of the Holy Spirit

by means of the power of the Holy Spirit

the Holy Spirit caused it

the Holy Spirit: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the Holy Spirit refers to the Spirit of God. The Holy Spirit is God, together with God the Father and God the Son. The Holy Spirit is Spirit in the sense that he is a living being who does not have a physical body. He is Holy in the sense that he is divine. He is perfect in every way and is completely pure and sinless. Because of these qualities, he is worthy of awe.

Here are some other ways to translate Holy Spirit:

Spirit/Breath of God

Sacred Spirit

Spirit from God

Spirit belonging to God

Do not imply that the Holy Spirit is like the ghost of a dead person or that God has died.

Matthew 1:19

Section 1:18–25: Jesus Christ was born

This section tells us how the Messiah came into the world. The Holy Spirit miraculously caused the virgin Mary to become pregnant with the child Jesus. Such an event had never happened before.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Birth of Jesus Christ (NIV)

The Birth of Jesus the Messiah (NLT)

Here is how Jesus was born

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 2:1–7.

1:19a–d

Before you translate 1:19, there are at least two main issues to consider:

Issue 1: Structure of the verse

Notice the overall structure of this verse. The BSB translates the Greek literally:

^{19a}Because Joseph her husband ^{19b}was a righteous man ^{19c}and was unwilling to disgrace her publicly, ^{19d}he resolved to divorce her quietly.

The main part of the verse is “he [that is, Joseph] resolved to divorce her quietly.” In the middle are two clauses which describe Joseph:

^{19b}he was a righteous man

^{19c}he was unwilling to disgrace her publicly

There are several ways to connect the parts of this verse. Here are some examples:

- Reorder the clauses to show the main part. For example:

^{19a}Joseph her husband ^{19d}had in mind to divorce her quietly. ^{19b}He wanted to do this because he was a righteous man ^{19c}and he did not want to expose her to public disgrace.

- Use the conjunction because to introduce the reason part of a reason-result relationship. For example:

^{19a}Because Joseph her husband ^{19b}was a righteous man ^{19c}and did not want to expose her to public disgrace, ^{19d}he had in mind to divorce her quietly. (NIV)

- Use the conjunction so to introduce the result part of a reason-result relationship. For example:

^{19a}Her husband Joseph ^{19b}was an honorable man ^{19c}and did not want to disgrace her publicly. ^{19d}So he decided to break the marriage agreement with her secretly. (GW)

Issue 2: Implied information

There is some implied information here. Joseph did not yet know that it was the Holy Spirit who had caused Mary to become pregnant (1:18d). So when he found out that she was pregnant, he assumed that she had committed adultery. Therefore he no longer wanted to marry her. In some languages, it may be necessary to make some of this information explicit. For example:

^{19a}But Joseph her husband did not know how she became pregnant. ^{19b}He was a righteous man...

^{19a}But Joseph her husband assumed that she had committed adultery. So he no longer wanted to marry her. ^{19b}He was a righteous man...

In other languages, it will be good to put some of this implied information in a footnote.

1:19a

Because Joseph her husband

- Her future husband Joseph
- Her fiancé, Joseph, thought that she had committed adultery.

Joseph her husband: In Jewish law, a man and woman who were engaged were legally considered to be husband and wife. So Joseph was considered to be Mary's husband, even though they were not yet formally married.

In many languages, the phrase Joseph her husband will imply that Mary and Joseph were already married. So it may be necessary to modify this phrase. For example:

Joseph, her fiancé (NLT)

Joseph, her future husband (JBP)

Joseph, the man she had promised to marry

Verse 1:18b already says that Mary and Joseph were pledged in marriage. So in some languages, it may be best to simply omit the phrase her husband. For example:

Joseph (CEV)

1:19b was a righteous man

- was a man who always did what was right. (GNT)
- He always followed/obeyed the law,

was a righteous man: The clause was a righteous man is the first of two characteristics of Joseph. There are two ways to interpret this clause and which part of the sentence it goes with:

1. It means that Joseph did what was just/right according to the law, and it goes together with the word "divorce." The law required that a man divorce a woman for adultery, and Joseph thought that Mary had committed adultery. In order to follow the law, he decided to divorce her. For example:

Joseph was a man who always did what was right (GNT) (BSB, NIV11, GNT, and many commentaries) The commentators who support this interpretation are: Turner (2008), pages 65–66; Filson, page 54; Lenski, pages 42–43; France (2007), pages 51–52; Nolland, pages 94–95; Hagner, page 18; Gibbs, pages 96–97, 104–105; Carson, page 75; Mounce, page 10; Hendriksen, pages 130–131; Morris, pages 27–28.

1. It means that Joseph was a good/kind man, and it goes together with the word "quietly." As a kind

man, he did not want to embarrass Mary. So he decided to divorce her quietly or in private. For example:

Joseph was a good man (CEV) (CEV, NLT, JBP, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) because many commentaries support this interpretation. Many English versions translate this clause in a way that makes it difficult to tell which interpretation they follow.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Joseph obeyed the laws of Moses

Joseph always wanted to do what the law said

It is also possible that the word righteous includes elements of both interpretations. So if possible, translate in a way that both interpretations can be understood. For example:

Joseph was straight/upright

Joseph obeyed the law and was also good/kind

1:19c and was unwilling to disgrace her publicly,

- But he did not want to publicly shame her,
- and yet he did not want to embarrass/disgrace her before people.

and was unwilling to disgrace her publicly: This clause is the second characteristic of Joseph. If you follow interpretation (1) above for the word "righteous," this clause contrasts with 1:19d. The contrast is that Joseph followed the law (and so had to divorce Mary), but yet he did not want to divorce her in a way that would shame her.

Here are some ways to show this contrast:

but he did not want to disgrace Mary publicly (GNT)

and yet he did not want to shame her

was unwilling to disgrace her publicly: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as disgrace her publicly in this context refers to publicly announcing that someone had sinned or broken the law. This act would

have caused Mary great shame. It would also have prevented her from getting married to someone else.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

did not want to expose her to public disgrace (NIV)

did not want to embarrass Mary in front of everyone (CEV)

1:19d

he resolved to divorce her quietly.

- so he decided to end the marriage agreement with her privately.
- So he planned to secretly end/break the engagement with her.

he resolved: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as resolved also means “planned” or “decided.” For example:

he made plans (GNT)

Joseph...decided (NJB)

to divorce her: In Jewish law, ending an engagement to marry required a divorce. At that time, a Jewish man only had to give the woman a certificate of divorce (Matthew 5:31, Mark 10:4). He could write the certificate himself with two people as witnesses.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

end the engagement

break the marriage agreement (GW)

not marry her

separate from her

quietly: The Greek word that the BSB translates as quietly also means “secretly.” It refers to doing something in a way that no one will know.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

privately (GNT)

secretly (GW)

without making it public

Matthew 1:20

Section 1:18–25: Jesus Christ was born

This section tells us how the Messiah came into the world. The Holy Spirit miraculously caused the virgin Mary to become pregnant with the child Jesus. Such an event had never happened before.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Birth of Jesus Christ (NIV)

The Birth of Jesus the Messiah (NLT)

Here is how Jesus was born

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 2:1–7.

1:20a

But after he had pondered these things,

- ¶ But while he was thinking about that/this,
- ¶ One night while Joseph was thinking about these events, he fell asleep.

But: There is a contrast between 1:19 and 1:20. The contrast is between what Joseph planned to do, and what the angel told him to do. Some English versions are like the BSB and indicate this contrast with the conjunction But.

after he had pondered these things: This clause indicates that Joseph was still thinking about Mary’s pregnancy and his decision to divorce her when the angel appeared.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

While he was thinking about this (GNT)

While Joseph thought about these events

these things: The Greek word that the BSB translates as these things refers to the events surrounding Mary’s pregnancy and his decision to divorce her.

Here is another way to translate this word:

these events

1:20b

an angel of the Lord appeared to him in a dream and said,

- an angel of the Lord God suddenly appeared to him in a dream and said,
- He dreamed that an angel from the Lord God unexpectedly appeared. The angel said,

The Greek of 1:20b begins with a word that is usually translated as “behold.” It literally means “look” or “see.” This word focuses attention on what follows and indicates that it is important, unexpected, or amazing. The BSB omits this word. In this passage, an angel unexpectedly appeared to Joseph. If you have a term that gets the attention of people that is natural in this context, you should consider using it here. Here are some examples:

suddenly

Look!

unexpectedly

an angel of the Lord: The phrase an angel of the Lord refers here to an angel that the Lord (God) sent.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

an angel who came from the Lord God

an angel who was sent by God

angel: The Greek word that the BSB translates as angel means “messenger.” Here it refers to a supernatural, spiritual being who serves God.

Here are some ways to translate this term:

- Use a descriptive word or phrase. For example:

messenger from God

holy spirit-being

- Use a local term that fits the biblical meaning.
- In some areas the churches may already be using a borrowed term or a transliterated word for “angel.” Be sure that this term fits the biblical meaning. If some people do not understand the right meaning from this term, you may need to indicate the meaning in some way. For example:

an angelos messenger from God

a sacred angelos spirit

See angel, Meaning 1, in the Glossary for more information.

the Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the Lord is here a title for God himself. The Greek word means “master,” “owner,” or “a person who has great authority.” If the word in your language for Lord is too general, you may want to include “God” in your translation. For example:

the Lord God

appeared to him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as appeared can also mean “became visible” or “was revealed.” The angel appeared to Joseph while he was dreaming. This indicates that in his dream, Joseph saw an angel.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

revealed/showed himself to him

he saw an angel

in a dream: Joseph was sleeping, and he saw the angel while he was dreaming.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in a dream while he slept

He dreamed that an angel of the Lord appeared to him

1:20c

“Joseph, son of David,

- “Joseph, son/descendant of David,
- “Joseph, descendant of King David!

Joseph, son of David: The phrase Joseph, son of David means that Joseph was a descendant of King David. For example:

Joseph, descendant of David (GNT)

You should translate the phrase son of David as you did in 1:1.

1:20d**do not be afraid to embrace Mary as your wife,**

- do not be afraid to take Mary to be your wife,
- Do not hesitate to marry Mary.

do not be afraid: The phrase do not be afraid indicates that the angel was telling Joseph not to worry. The angel was telling Joseph to go ahead with the marriage.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Do not be reluctant

Do not hesitate

Go ahead and marry her. (CEV)

to embrace Mary as your wife: This clause refers to Joseph marrying Mary and beginning married life together.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

to take Mary to be your wife (GNT)

to marry Mary

1:20e**for the One conceived in her is from the Holy Spirit.**

- because the Holy Spirit is the one who caused her to conceive.
- The Holy Spirit did a miracle which caused her to become pregnant.

for: The Greek word that the BSB translates as for indicates that 1:20e is the basis for the angel's command in 1:20d. Another way to translate this word is:

because (NIV)

In some languages, it may be natural to simply begin a new sentence here.

the One conceived in her: The clause the One conceived in her refers to the baby in Mary's womb. The word conceived refers to becoming pregnant.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the child conceived in her (NRSV)

She is pregnant (GW)

the child she carries

is from the Holy Spirit: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as from the Holy Spirit is the same phrase as in 1:18d. This phrase indicates that the Holy Spirit caused Mary to become pregnant. It was a miracle.

You should translate this phrase here as you did in 1:18.

General Comment on 1:20d–e

In some languages, it is more natural to put the basis for the command (1:20e) before the command (1:20d). For example:

^{20e}the One conceived in Mary is from the Holy Spirit. ^{20d}So, do not be afraid to embrace her as your wife.

Matthew 1:21**Section 1:18–25: Jesus Christ was born**

This section tells us how the Messiah came into the world. The Holy Spirit miraculously caused the virgin Mary to become pregnant with the child Jesus. Such an event had never happened before.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Birth of Jesus Christ (NIV)

The Birth of Jesus the Messiah (NLT)

Here is how Jesus was born

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 2:1–7.

1:21a**She will give birth to a Son,**

- She will bear a son,
- She will have a son.

1:21b**and you are to give Him the name Jesus,**

- and you^(sing) will name him Jesus,
- Name^(sing) him Jesus which means 'the Lord saves/rescues',

you are to give Him the name Jesus: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as you are to give Him the name Jesus means "name him Jesus." This clause is future tense with the force of a command. Some languages may be able to use the future tense in the

same way. Other languages will need to translate this clause simply as a command.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

name him Jesus (CEV)

you are to name him Jesus (NLT)

you must name him Jesus

Jesus: The name Jesus is the Greek form of the Hebrew name “Joshua.” This Hebrew name means “the Lord saves.” In order for people to understand 1:21c, they must understand the meaning of Jesus.

Here are some ways to explain the meaning:

- Include the meaning in your translation. For example:

you will name him Jesus (which means the Lord saves)

- Put the meaning in a footnote. A sample footnote is:

The name Jesus means “the Lord saves.”

1:21c

because He will save His people from their sins.”

- because he is the one who will save his people from their sins.”
- because he will save/rescue his own people from the guilt and power of their evil deeds.”

because: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as because introduces the basis for the angel’s command to name the baby “Jesus.” The name “Jesus” means “the Lord saves.” Joseph should name him Jesus (the Lord saves) because he will save his people. The name Jesus fits his purpose in life.

In some languages, it is more natural to put 1:21c before 1:21b. See the General Comment below for translation advice.

He: The pronoun He is emphasized in Greek. If there is a natural way in your language to emphasize this pronoun, you may want to do so.

Here are some other ways to translate this emphasis:

it is he who (JBP)

he is the one who (NJB)

will save His people from their sins: The word save refers to rescuing from harm. Sinning separates people from God, but Jesus rescues believers from that separation and brings them back to God.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

deliver/rescue his people from their sins

liberate his people from the guilt and power of their sins

His people: The phrase His people refers to the people of Israel. Do not translate this phrase simply as “people.”

Another way to translate this phrase is:

his own people

from their sins: The word sins refers to offenses against God or another person. Sins include acts, thoughts, and attitudes that are not what God wants or approves. A person can also offend God by not doing what God wants him to do.

Try to translate sins with a general term that can include any wrongdoing against God. Here are problems to avoid:

1. The term should not imply that only serious crimes like murder or stealing are sins. Other offenses like gossip and greed are also sins.
2. The term should not include accidents or mistakes that are not against God’s will.

Here are some other ways to translate sins:

Wrong acts

evil/bad deeds

offenses against God

General Comment on 1:21b–c

In some languages, it is more natural to have the basis of the command (1:21c) before the command (1:21b). For example:

^{21c}He will save his people from their sins, ^{21b}that is why you shall name him Jesus.

Matthew 1:22

Section 1:18–25: Jesus Christ was born

This section tells us how the Messiah came into the world. The Holy Spirit miraculously caused the virgin Mary to become pregnant with the child Jesus. Such an event had never happened before.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Birth of Jesus Christ (NIV)

The Birth of Jesus the Messiah (NLT)

Here is how Jesus was born

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 2:1–7.

Paragraph 1:22–23

Verses 1:22–23 interrupt the story of Mary and Joseph to give us some background information. This background information shows that an Old Testament prophecy was fulfilled. It is not part of what the angel said to Joseph.

1:22

All this took place to fulfill what the Lord had said through the prophet:

- ¶ This all happened so that the words that the Lord spoke through the prophet would come true:
- ¶ All these events happened in order to make the Lord God's message come true. The message is the one that he gave long ago to his prophet to speak to the people. He said,

Verse 1:22 begins the background information. If you have a word or phrase to introduce background information, you may want to use it here.

All this took place: The clause All this took place refers to the all the events that happened in 1:18–21.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

This all happened

All these events occurred

to fulfill: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates here as to fulfill means “in order to make come true.” For example:

in order to make come true (GNT)

to bring about (NCV)

what the Lord had said through the prophet: The phrase what the Lord had said through the prophet refers to the words/message that the Lord God told the prophet Isaiah to tell the people. Isaiah then spoke these words to the people. He also wrote them down.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the Lord's message through his prophet: (NLT)

the message that the Lord God spoke through the prophet. He said,

the words that the Lord told the prophet to say to the people. He said,

prophet: A prophet is a person who spoke on behalf of God. He told people what God revealed to him. A prophet is someone who has had direct communication from God.

It has a different meaning than either “angel,” “preacher” or “apostle.” See prophet in the Glossary for further information. Some ways to translate prophet are:

- Use the word that has the same meaning as prophet in your language.
- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

spokesman for God

one who speaks God's message

one who brings words from God

- Borrow a loanword from a major language.

Matthew 1:23

Section 1:18–25: Jesus Christ was born

This section tells us how the Messiah came into the world. The Holy Spirit miraculously caused the virgin Mary to become pregnant with the child Jesus. Such an event had never happened before.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Birth of Jesus Christ (NIV)

The Birth of Jesus the Messiah (NLT)

Here is how Jesus was born

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 2:1–7.

Paragraph 1:22–23

Verses 1:22–23 interrupt the story of Mary and Joseph to give us some background information. This background information shows that an Old Testament prophecy was fulfilled. It is not part of what the angel said to Joseph.

1:23a

“Behold, the virgin will be with child

- “A virgin will become pregnant
- “Listen, a young woman who has never lain/slept with a man will become pregnant.

Behold: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Behold literally means “look” or “see.” It focuses attention on what follows. Here, it introduces the prophecy that a virgin will give birth to a baby.

the virgin: A virgin is a person who has not had sexual intercourse. Here, this word refers to a young woman who has not had sexual intercourse. In some languages, there may be an idiom for this. Or you may have to use a descriptive phrase. For example:

a young woman who has not lain/slept with a man

a young lady who has not had sexual relations with a man

will be with child: The phrase will be with child means “will become pregnant.” In 1:18, a similar phrase occurs: “was found to be with child.” You may want to translate it here as you did there.

1:23b

and will give birth to a son, and they will call Him Immanuel”

- and will bear a son. People will call him ‘Immanuel.’”
- She will have a son, and he will be called Immanuel.”

they will call Him Immanuel: The pronoun they probably refers to people in general and not to his parents.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

people will call him Immanuel

people will refer to him as ‘Immanuel’

he will be called Immanuel (GNT)

Immanuel: The word Immanuel is a Jewish name. Here, it is used as a title for Jesus. It is not literally his name. It is used prophetically and indicates that Jesus will be the “Messiah.” Its meaning is explained by Matthew in 1:23c.

1:23c

(which means, “God with us”).

- This word translated is “God with us^(incl).”
- Its meaning is, “God is with us^(incl).”

1:23c is Matthew’s own words to explain the meaning of the title “Immanuel.” It is not a part of the Old Testament quote.

which means: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as which means is more literally “which is translated.” For example:

which translated means (NASB)

God with us: The Greek text has no verb in this phrase. It may be more natural in your language to have a verb here. For example:

God is with us (GNT)

God accompanies us

us: The word us refers to God’s people.

Matthew 1:24

Section 1:18–25: Jesus Christ was born

This section tells us how the Messiah came into the world. The Holy Spirit miraculously caused the virgin Mary to become pregnant with the child Jesus. Such an event had never happened before.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Birth of Jesus Christ (NIV)

The Birth of Jesus the Messiah (NLT)

Here is how Jesus was born

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 2:1–7.

Paragraph 1:24–25

In this paragraph, the story of Mary and Joseph resumes. It explains what Joseph did after the dream he had in 1:20–21.

1:24a

When Joseph woke up,

- ¶ When Joseph awakened,
- ¶ After Joseph woke up,

1:24b

he did as the angel of the Lord had commanded him,

- he did as the angel of the Lord had told him to do
- he obeyed what the angel from the Lord God had ordered him to do:

he did as the angel of the Lord had commanded him: The clause as the angel of the Lord had commanded him means that Joseph did what the angel told him to do in 1:20c–21. He married Mary. Matthew states this clearly in 1:24c.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he did what the angel of the Lord told/ordered him to do

he did that which the angel of the Lord said he must do

1:24c

and embraced Mary as his wife.

- and took Mary to be his wife.
- he married Mary.

and embraced Mary as his wife: This clause refers to Joseph marrying Mary and beginning married life together.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Joseph took Mary as his wife (NCV)

he married Mary (GNT)

A similar expression is in 1:20. You should translate these two passages in a similar way.

Matthew 1:25

Section 1:18–25: Jesus Christ was born

This section tells us how the Messiah came into the world. The Holy Spirit miraculously caused the virgin Mary to become pregnant with the child Jesus. Such an event had never happened before.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Birth of Jesus Christ (NIV)

The Birth of Jesus the Messiah (NLT)

Here is how Jesus was born

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 2:1–7.

Paragraph 1:24–25

In this paragraph, the story of Mary and Joseph resumes. It explains what Joseph did after the dream he had in 1:20–21.

1:25a

But he had no union with her until she gave birth to a Son.

- But he did not have sexual relations with her until her son was born.
- However, he did not lie/sleep with her before she gave birth to a son.

But: After Joseph married Mary, he did not do what is normally expected for a newly married couple. He did not have sexual relations with her. In grammar, when something happens that is not expected, it is called “contra-expectation.” Many English versions introduce this contra-expectation with the conjunction But.

Here are some other ways to introduce this:

However

Contrary to what was expected

he had no union with her: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as had no union with her is a euphemism. It was a polite way in Jewish culture to say that Joseph did not have sexual intercourse with Mary while she was pregnant.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he did not lie/sleep with her

had no marital/sexual relations with her

kept her a virgin (NASB)

Be careful to use an expression that will be appropriate for public reading. Also see the note at 1:18c on “before they came together,” which is a similar expression.

until she gave birth to a Son: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as until refers to the end of a period of time. While Mary was pregnant, Joseph did not have relations with her.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

before she gave birth to her son (GNT)

up to the time she bore her son

1:25b

And he gave Him the name Jesus.

- Then he gave the name Jesus to the child.
- After the baby was born, he named the baby Jesus.

And he gave Him the name Jesus: In Jewish culture, it was the father who named the child. Joseph was the legal father (but not the physical father). So he was the one who gave the name to the baby.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Joseph named the child Jesus. (GW)

Then Joseph named him Jesus. (CEV)

Matthew 2:1

Section 2:1–12: Wise men came and honored Jesus

In this section, Matthew showed his readers that:

1. Jesus was indeed born in Bethlehem as scripture predicted (even though he would later move to Nazareth, and people considered him to be a Nazarene).
2. The Jewish religious teachers who knew the law did not go to worship the king of the Jews. It was the Gentile wise men who worshiped him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Visit of the Wise Men (NET)

Visitors from the East (GNT)

2:1a

After Jesus was born in Bethlehem in Judea,

- ¶ One day after Jesus was born in Bethlehem in Judea,
- ¶ Mary gave birth to Jesus in the town of Bethlehem in the province of Judea.

This verse part begins with the Greek conjunction that many English versions translate as “Now” here. Here “Now” means “at that time.” It does not mean “today.” Many English versions, including the BSB, do not translate the Greek conjunction here, but rather let the context indicate that what follows took place at that time. In some languages, it may be natural to begin 2:1a by translating this Greek conjunction to show that what happens in this section happened after the preceding section and “during the time of Herod” as 2:1b indicates. For example:

Now (ESV)

After Jesus was born: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as After Jesus was born tells us the setting of the time that the wise men came.

Here are some other ways to begin this section:

One day, after Jesus was born

When Jesus was born (CEV)

The main clause in this verse is in 2:1c. In some languages, it may be more natural to translate the main clause before the background information. See the General Comment after 2:1c for some ideas.

Jesus was born: The Greek word that the BSB translates as was born is passive.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

- As a passive verb. For example:

Jesus was born

- As an active verb. For example:

Mary gave birth to Jesus

Mary bore Jesus

in Bethlehem: The word Bethlehem is the name of a village about eight kilometers (five miles) south of Jerusalem. Another way to translate this word is:

in the village/town of Bethlehem

in Judea: The word Judea is the name of a province in the country of Israel. Another way to translate this word is:

the province/region of Judea

2:1b

during the time of King Herod,

- during the time that Herod was king,
- In those days, the king of Judea was a man named Herod.

during the time of King Herod: The phrase during the time of King Herod refers only to the time when Herod was king. It does not refer to the thirty or so years of his life before he became king.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

during the reign of King Herod (NJB)

during the time when Herod was king (GNT)

when/while King Herod was ruling

This phrase is also background information. See the General Comment after 2:1c for other ways to translate this phrase.

2:1c

Magi from the east arrived in Jerusalem,

- some astrologers who came from the east came unexpectedly to Jerusalem.
- One day, some men from an eastern country suddenly arrived in the city of Jerusalem. They were men who studied the stars.

The Greek of 2:1c begins with a word that is often translated as “behold.” It literally means “look” or “see.” This word focuses attention on what follows. It indicates that what follows is important, unexpected, or amazing. In this passage, the wise men unexpectedly arrived in Jerusalem. The BSB omits this word.

If you have a term that gets the attention of people and is natural in this context, you should consider using it here. Here are some examples:

suddenly

Look!

unexpectedly

This word also occurs in 1:20 and 1:23. Consider how you translated it there.

Magi: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Magi refers to men who studied the movement of stars and planets. They believed that the movement of stars and planets could predict future events.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

astrologers (REB)

men who studied the stars (GNT)

men who watched the stars to learn the future

men who could tell the meaning of the stars

Some English versions such as the BSB transliterate this Greek word as Magi.

from the east: The phrase from the east means that the wise men came from a country or countries that were east of Jerusalem. Their journey probably took a long time. Your translation should not indicate that they were from nearby.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

from eastern lands (NLT)

from a country to the east

arrived in Jerusalem: The word Jerusalem is the name of the main city of the province of Judea. It was the most important and largest city in that region. Strangers such as the wise men would naturally go there when searching for someone.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

arrived in the city of Jerusalem

General Comment on 2:1a–c

In verse 2:1, 2:1c is the main clause and 2:1a–b add background information. You may want to change the order of the clauses in this verse to better show what is the main clause and what is background information. One way to do this is to put 2:1c earlier in the verse. For example:

One day, ^{1c}some astrologers from the east arrived in Jerusalem. ^{1a}This happened after Jesus was born in Bethlehem in Judea. ^{1b}At that time, Herod was the king of Judea.

One day, ^{1a}after Jesus was born in Bethlehem in Judea, ^{1c}some astrologers from the east arrived in Jerusalem. ^{1b}At that time, Herod was the king of Judea.

Matthew 2:2

Section 2:1–12: Wise men came and honored Jesus

In this section, Matthew showed his readers that:

1. Jesus was indeed born in Bethlehem as scripture predicted (even though he would later move to Nazareth, and people considered him to be a Nazarene).
2. The Jewish religious teachers who knew the law did not go to worship the king of the Jews. It was the Gentile wise men who worshiped him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Visit of the Wise Men (NET)

Visitors from the East (GNT)

2:2a

asking, “Where is the One who has been born King of the Jews?”

- They asked, “Where is the child who has been born and who is king of the Jews?”
- They asked some people, “The child who has been born as king of the Jews, where can we find him?”

asking: The word asking introduces the question that the wise men asked. The Greek text does not state whom the wise men asked. They probably asked people whom they met after they entered the city.

In some languages, it may be more natural to state who was asked. If that is true in your language, you should do so in a general way. For example:

asked the people of the city

asked people whom they met in town

Where is the One who has been born King of the Jews?:

There are two ways to interpret this question:

1. It refers to the baby who was King of the Jews when he was born. For example:

Where is the one who has been born king of the Jews? (NIV) (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, NLT, NASB, NET, REB, KJV, ESV)

1. It refers to the baby who will become King of the Jews sometime after his birth. For example:

Where is the one who was born to be the king of the Jews? (GW) (GNT, GW, CEV, JBP, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). In support of this interpretation, Morris says, “The words they use mean “born king,” not “born to be king,” as is often said; they are talking about what he is, not what he will be” (Morris, page 36).

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the baby who has been born, and who is the ruler of the Jews

the newborn king of the Jews (NLT)

the Jews: The word Jews here refers to the people of one particular ethnic group. They are also called the people/children of Israel. The word Jew comes from the name of their ancestor Judah, the great-grandson of Abraham.

If you do not have a word in your language for Jews, you could form a word based on the Hebrew name “Yehuda” (Judah). You could also borrow the term from a major language translation used in your area. Use the form or phrase your language naturally uses for names of tribes called after a common ancestor. For example:

Yahudi (Arabic)

2:2b

We saw His star in the east

- We^(excl) saw his star when it rose

- We^(excl) ask this because we saw a star that indicated/announced his birth as it rose,

The Greek of 2:2b begins with a word that is often translated as “for.” It indicates that 2:2b–c is the reason for the question in 2:2a. Some English versions such as the BSB do not translate this Greek word.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

We^(excl) ask this because

Our^(excl) reason for asking this is

His star: In the way that the wise men studied the stars, one particular star somehow indicated the birth of the king of the Jews. In that way, this star was His star.

If it is not natural in your language to use the possessive pronoun His with the word star, you may want to include some implied information. For example:

the star of his birth

the star that announces him

in the east: There are two ways to interpret the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as in the east:

1. It refers to the star rising in the sky. For example:

his star when it rose (NET) (NIV11, NRSV, ESV, NJB, NLT, GW, NET, REB)

1. It refers to the location of the star or the location of the wise men being in the east. For example:

his star in the East (RSV) (BSB, NIV, RSV, NASB, CEV, JBP, KJV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The commentators who follow this interpretation are: Turner (2008), page 80; Filson, page 56; Gibbs, page 117; Carson, page 89; Meyer, page 60; Blomberg, pages 62–63; France (2007), page 82; Nolland, page 109; Hendriksen, page 153; Morris, pages 36–37; Hagner, page 27.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

his star rising (GW)

as it rose (NJB)

2:2c

and have come to worship Him.”

- and have come to prostrate/kneel before him and worship him.”
- so we^(excl) came to bow before him to honor/adore him.”

worship Him: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as worship literally means “prostrate before.” It involves kneeling and putting one’s face to the ground. This is done before God and kings to show great honor and submission.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

kneel before him to honor him

bow down to honor/adore him as king

Matthew 2:3

Section 2:1–12: Wise men came and honored Jesus

In this section, Matthew showed his readers that:

1. Jesus was indeed born in Bethlehem as scripture predicted (even though he would later move to Nazareth, and people considered him to be a Nazarene).
2. The Jewish religious teachers who knew the law did not go to worship the king of the Jews. It was the Gentile wise men who worshiped him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Visit of the Wise Men (NET)

Visitors from the East (GNT)

2:3a

When King Herod heard this,

- ¶ When King Herod heard about this/that,
- ¶ When someone told King Herod what they said,

When King Herod heard this: The word this refers to the words of the wise men (2:2). Someone told their words to Herod.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

When King Herod heard that report/news

When King Herod heard a report of those words

Someone told King Herod what they said

2:3b

he was disturbed,

- he was very upset
- he became deeply disturbed.

he was disturbed: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as was disturbed refers to being upset emotionally and mentally. Herod was probably disturbed by the news that another king was born. It was someone who might take his place.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

he was very upset (GNT)

he was alarmed (NET)

he was troubled (ESV)

2:3c

and all Jerusalem with him.

- and all the people in Jerusalem were also upset along with him.
- Many people living in Jerusalem who heard this news were as deeply disturbed as he was.

and all Jerusalem with him: The Greek phrase that the BSB literally translates as and all Jerusalem with him is an exaggeration called a hyperbole. It means “many of the people of Jerusalem were also troubled along with him.” It does not refer to every man, woman, and child in Jerusalem.

The verb “was disturbed” from 2:3b is implied in this clause. In some languages, it may be more natural to repeat the verb here.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

all the other people living in Jerusalem

many of the people who lived in the town of Jerusalem were also troubled/disturbed

with him: The phrase with him refers to experiencing the same alarm as Herod. It does not mean that the people were gathered together in one place with Herod when they became upset. When the people

heard the news of the wise men, they were also troubled.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

along with him

just as he was

Matthew 2:4

Section 2:1–12: Wise men came and honored Jesus

In this section, Matthew showed his readers that:

1. Jesus was indeed born in Bethlehem as scripture predicted (even though he would later move to Nazareth, and people considered him to be a Nazarene).
2. The Jewish religious teachers who knew the law did not go to worship the king of the Jews. It was the Gentile wise men who worshiped him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Visit of the Wise Men (NET)

Visitors from the East (GNT)

2:4a

And when he had assembled all the chief priests and scribes of the people,

- He called a meeting of all the leaders of the priests and all the teachers of the law
- So he told/ordered all the leading priests and teachers of the law of Moses to meet with him.

Verse 2:4 is the result of Herod being disturbed (in 2:3b). Herod was disturbed (2:3b), so he called together some men and asked them where the Christ would be born (2:4). In some languages, it may be natural to introduce this result with a connecting word or phrase. For example:

So (JBP)

Therefore

he had assembled: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as assembled means “brought/gathered(people) together.”

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

called together (NIV)

summoned

told to come to him

all the chief priests and scribes of the people: In this clause, the word all goes with both chief priests and scribes. The phrase of the people also goes with both chief priests and scribes.

chief priests: The Jewish priests were men who offered sacrifices to God on behalf of the people. They also performed other rituals for them. The phrase chief priests refers to the leaders among these priests.

Here are some other ways to translate chief priests:

- Use a descriptive term that focuses on the function of a priest. For example:

the leaders of the sacrificers

the elders among the men who offer sacrifices to God

the leaders of those who represent people to God

- Use a local word for priest. This option may be acceptable if the duties of a local priest are similar to those of a Jewish priest. You may need to indicate that the word refers to a Jewish priest. For example:

Jewish people's leading priests/sacrificers

See also priest in the Glossary.

scribes: The Greek word that the BSB translates as scribes refers to men who studied, interpreted, and taught the law of Moses. These men were called scribes because their original work was to copy the laws of Moses by hand. In New Testament times, this was no longer their main task.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

teachers of the Law of Moses (CEV)

teachers of religious law (NLT)

teachers of the law (NIV)

experts in the law

See scribe in the Glossary.

of the people: In this context, the word people refers to the Jews. For example:

of the Jews (REB)

In some languages, the phrase of the people is not necessary or natural here. If that is true in your language, you do not have to translate these words. For example:

Herod called a meeting of all the leading priests and teachers of the law (NCV)

2:4b

he asked them where the Christ was to be born.

- and asked them where the Christ would be born.
- Then he asked them, "Where will the Christ/Messiah be born?"

he asked them where the Christ was to be born: This sentence indicates that Herod asked the chief priests and scribes a question. He wanted to know in what town or what place the Christ would be born.

Here are some other ways to translate this sentence:

- As a direct question. For example:

and asked them, "Where will the Messiah be born?" (GNT)

- As an indirect question. For example:

he asked them where the Christ was to be born. (NET)

Christ: Here the word Christ is a descriptive title. The word Christ is the Greek translation of the Hebrew word "Messiah." "Messiah" refers to the person whom God had appointed and promised to send as king and savior. The words Christ and Messiah have the same meaning.

Translate this word as you did in 1:1a. See also Christ in the Glossary.

Matthew 2:5

Section 2:1–12: Wise men came and honored Jesus

In this section, Matthew showed his readers that:

1. Jesus was indeed born in Bethlehem as scripture predicted (even though he would later move to Nazareth, and people considered him to be a Nazarene).
2. The Jewish religious teachers who knew the law did not go to worship the king of the Jews. It was the Gentile wise men who worshiped him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Visit of the Wise Men (NET)

Visitors from the East (GNT)

2:5a

“In Bethlehem in Judea,” they replied,

- ¶ They answered, “In Bethlehem in Judea,
- ¶ They told him, “Our king, he will be born in the town of Bethlehem here in the province of Judea.

“In Bethlehem in Judea,” they replied: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as they replied can also be translated as “they answered” (as in the GNT). The BSB places this phrase in the middle of sentence. This is good English style. However, in some languages, this phrase should be in the beginning of the sentence. For example:

They told him, “In Bethlehem of Judea...” (ESV)

In Bethlehem in Judea: The phrase In Bethlehem in Judea is the answer to Herod’s question in 2:4b. In some languages, it will be more natural to translate this phrase as a complete sentence. For example:

He will be born in Bethlehem in Judea

In some languages, it is necessary to address the king in a respectful way. For example:

Our king, he will be born in Bethlehem in Judea.

Bethlehem in Judea: As mentioned in the note on 2:1a, Bethlehem is the name of a town, and Judea is the name of a province.

2:5b

“for this is what the prophet has written:

- because the words of God that the prophet wrote are these:
- We know this because many years ago the prophet wrote this/that:

for: The conjunction for introduces the reason that the leaders knew that the Christ would be born in Bethlehem. They knew he would be born in Bethlehem for/because that is what the prophet had said.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

We know this because

He will be born there because

In some languages, it will be more natural to put the reason clause (in 2:5b) before the result clause (in 2:5a). For example:

^{5b}The prophets have written that ^{5a}he will be born in Bethlehem of Judea.

this is what the prophet has written: The Greek word that the BSB translates as this refers ahead to the words in 2:6a–d.

The clause this is what the prophet has written introduces 2:6. In Greek, this clause is more literally “so it has been written through the prophet” and is passive.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- As a passive clause. For example:

it is written this way by the prophet (NET)

- As an active clause. For example:

this is what the prophet wrote (GNT)

here is what the prophet wrote about this issue

the prophet wrote about this matter as follows

the words that God spoke which the prophet then wrote down are these:

These words were written hundreds of years before the time of Jesus. You may want to include some of this implied information. For example:

the words of God which the prophet wrote long ago are these:

the prophet: The phrase the prophet refers to the prophet Micah. He wrote down God's words that are quoted in 2:6.

The word prophet first occurs in 1:22. See the note there for help in translating this word. Also see prophet in the Glossary.

Matthew 2:6

Section 2:1–12: Wise men came and honored Jesus

In this section, Matthew showed his readers that:

1. Jesus was indeed born in Bethlehem as scripture predicted (even though he would later move to Nazareth, and people considered him to be a Nazarene).
2. The Jewish religious teachers who knew the law did not go to worship the king of the Jews. It was the Gentile wise men who worshiped him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Visit of the Wise Men (NET)

Visitors from the East (GNT)

2:6

Verse 2:6 contains a figure of speech called apostrophe. The name of this figure of speech is spelled and pronounced the same as the punctuation mark used to show contractions. But the meaning is different. For more information about the figure of speech called apostrophe, see Translation Problems A to Z, Apostrophe. In this figure of speech, God speaks to the town of Bethlehem as if it were a person.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse:

- Keep the apostrophe as in the BSB.
- Translate it in a way that God is speaking to the people of the town. For example:

^{6a}You people of Bethlehem in the land of Judah,

^{6b}your town is by no means least among the towns of Judah, ^{6c}for out of your town will come a ruler

^{6d}who will be the shepherd of my people Israel.

- Translate it in a way that God is speaking indirectly about the town. For example:

But Bethlehem, in the land of Judah, it is by no means least among the leading towns of Judah;

for out of it will come a ruler who will be the shepherd of my people Israel.

2:6a

'But you, Bethlehem, in the land of Judah,

- 'Bethlehem in the land of Judah, you^(sing)
- 'You^(plur) people of the town of Bethlehem in the land of Judah, you
- 'Bethlehem in the kingdom of Judah

But: In the Greek, this verse begins with a conjunction that is usually translated as "And." In Matthew, only part of a longer passage from Micah is quoted. In that longer passage, there is contrast. However, here in Matthew, the incomplete quote indicates no contrast. Only the BSB, NIV, and the NCV translate the conjunction as But. Most other versions, such as the RSV and NJB, have "and." Still others, such as the GNT, do not use a conjunction here.

Since Matthew quotes only part of Micah, you may leave this conjunction untranslated.

you, Bethlehem, in the land of Judah: In some languages, it will be more natural to put the pronoun you at the end of this clause. For example:

Bethlehem, in the land of Judah, you

the land of Judah: The phrase the land of Judah refers to the country/kingdom of Judah. When the prophet Micah wrote these words, Judah was a kingdom. When Jesus was born, this area was no longer its own country. It had become a province and was then called Judea (2:5a). If possible, Judah and Judea should be spelled differently in your language.

2:6b

are by no means least among the rulers of Judah,

- are not the least important town among the leading towns of Judah.
- are/live in one of the most important towns in Judah,
- is a very important town in Judah,

are by no means least: The phrase are by no means least is a figure of speech called litotes. For more information about the figure of speech called litotes, see Translation Problems A to Z, Litotes. In this figure of speech, God through the prophet makes an emphatic statement. He does this by stating that the opposite is not true. Bethlehem is not the least important town. This is a way to emphasize that Bethlehem is an important town.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- Keep the apostrophe of 2:6 and the litotes here in 2:6b. For example:

are not least (NLT)

- Keep the apostrophe but not the litotes. For example:

you are very important (CEV)

- Keep neither the apostrophe nor the litotes. For example:

you people are in a very important town

among the rulers of Judah: The Greek word that the BSB translates as rulers refers to a person who rules over a province. God was speaking to Bethlehem as if it were a person, so he referred to Bethlehem as a ruler of Judah.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- Keep the apostrophe. For example:

among the leaders of Judah (GW)

- Do not keep the apostrophe. In that case, you should translate the word rulers as towns/cities. For example:

of the leading cities of Judah (GNT)

among the great towns of Judah

2:6c

for out of you will come a ruler

- because from you^(sing) will come a ruler
- because a leader will come from your town
- because a ruler will be born in it.

for: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as for indicates that 2:6c is the reason for what was said in 2:6b. ^{6b}Bethlehem is not the least among the towns of Judah, ^{6c}for/because a ruler will come from Bethlehem.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

because

The reason is that

In some languages, it is more natural to translate 2:6c (the reason clause) before 2:6b (the result clause). For example:

^{6c}out of you will come a ruler who will be the shepherd of my people Israel. ^{6b}So you, Bethlehem, are by no means least among the towns of Judah.

out of you will come a ruler: This clause indicates that a ruler or “great leader” will be born in Bethlehem.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

From your town will come a leader (CEV)

It is from you that a ruler will come

2:6d

who will be the shepherd of My people Israel.”

- who will shepherd/tend my people the Israelites.”
- who will be like a shepherd for my people the tribe/nation of Israel.”
- He will lead and care for my people the descendants of Israel.”

who will be the shepherd: The Greek word that the BSB translates as will be the shepherd also means “tend.” It refers to watching over, protecting, and leading animals to places where there are plants to eat. Here it is used figuratively to represent a leader who watches over, protects, and provides for his people.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

- Literally, as a verb or noun. For example:

will shepherd (NASB)

will be the shepherd (NLT)

- With a simile. For example:

will be like a shepherd (CEV)

will lead...like a shepherd

- Without the figure of a shepherd. For example:

will guide (GNT)

My people: The pronoun My refers to God. It does not refer to the prophet Micah.

Israel: The word Israel refers to the people who were the descendants of the man whose name was Israel. (This man was first called Jacob.)

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

the descendants of Israel

the tribe/nation of Israel

the Israelites

Matthew 2:7

Section 2:1–12: Wise men came and honored Jesus
In this section, Matthew showed his readers that:

1. Jesus was indeed born in Bethlehem as scripture predicted (even though he would later move to Nazareth, and people considered him to be a Nazarene).
2. The Jewish religious teachers who knew the law did not go to worship the king of the Jews. It was the Gentile wise men who worshiped him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Visit of the Wise Men (NET)

Visitors from the East (GNT)

Paragraph 2:7–8

Herod tried to trick the wise men. He wanted to know exactly how old the baby Jesus was. And he wanted to know exactly where the baby was. But he did not want them to know that he was planning to kill the child (2:13).

2:7a

Then Herod called the Magi secretly

- ¶ Then Herod secretly called/summoned the astrologers to meet with him,
- ¶ When Herod heard this, he invited the men who studied the stars to a private meeting.

Then: The word Then here implies that Herod's meeting with the chief priests and scribes (in 2:4–6) had ended. It introduces the next event.

In some languages, it may be natural to add some implied information here. For example:

After the meeting ended then

When Herod heard this, then

Herod called the Magi: The Greek word that the BSB translates as called also means "summoned."

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

summoned (ESV)

told to come to him

invited

secretly: The Greek word that the BSB translates as secretly indicates that Herod did not want other people to know about the meeting. Here is another way to translate this:

privately (NJB)

2:7b

and learned from them the exact time the star had appeared.

- and he learned from them exactly when the star had appeared.
- Then he asked them to tell him the exact time/day when they first saw the star, and they told him.

learned from them the exact time the star had appeared: The Greek word that the BSB translates as learned refers to gaining clear and exact knowledge about something. Herod asked the wise men about the precise time the star first appeared. He perhaps even asked them the exact date. And they told him. Herod probably assumed that the child was born on the same day that the star first appeared. He then calculated the age of the child from the time they specified.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

learned from them the exact time when the star had appeared (NRSV)

asked them the exact date on which the star had appeared (NJB)

exact time the star had appeared: The Greek word that the BSB translates as appeared can also mean "became visible."

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the first time they saw the star

when the star arose

when the star showed itself

This same word occurs in 1:20.

Matthew 2:8

Section 2:1–12: Wise men came and honored Jesus

In this section, Matthew showed his readers that:

1. Jesus was indeed born in Bethlehem as scripture predicted (even though he would later move to Nazareth, and people considered him to be a Nazarene).
2. The Jewish religious teachers who knew the law did not go to worship the king of the Jews. It was the Gentile wise men who worshiped him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Visit of the Wise Men (NET)

Visitors from the East (GNT)

Paragraph 2:7–8

Herod tried to trick the wise men. He wanted to know exactly how old the baby Jesus was. And he wanted to know exactly where the baby was. But he did not want them to know that he was planning to kill the child (2:13).

2:8a

And sending them to Bethlehem, he said:

- He sent them to Bethlehem saying,
- Then he told them to go to Bethlehem. He said,

And: This verse begins with a conjunction that the BSB translates as And. In some languages, it may be natural to begin 2:8 with a conjunction to show that this was the next thing that Herod did. For example:

Then (NRSV)

Next

sending them to Bethlehem, he said: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as sending them to

Bethlehem, he said indicates that the sending and saying occurred at the same time.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

As he sent them to Bethlehem, he said (GW)

Then he sent them to Bethlehem with these instructions (GNT)

Another way to translate sending them is to put it at the end of 2:8. For example:

^{8a}He said to them, ^{8b}“Go to Bethlehem and make a careful search for the child. ^{8c}As soon as you find him, report to me, ^{8d}so that I too may go and worship him.” ^{8a}Then he sent them away.

2:8b

“Go and search carefully for the Child,

- “Go and thoroughly search for the child.
- “Go to Bethlehem and look carefully for the young child.

search carefully: The phrase search carefully indicates that Herod wanted them to make sure that they had found the right child.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Look carefully (NCV)

search diligently (ESV)

Child: This word Child refers to a young child, but in this context probably not a baby. Use a term for a child around two years old or younger.

2:8c

and when you find Him, report to me,

- When you^(plur) find him, come back and tell me,
- After you^(plur) find him, return here and inform me.

report to me: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as report to me refers to telling someone about something or someone. Also, it is implied Herod wanted the wise men to return to him and then tell him.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

come back and tell me (NLT)

return here and inform me

bring me word (ESV)

2:8d

so that I too may go and worship Him.”

- in order that I too can go and prostrate/kneel before him and worship him.”
- Then I also will go and bow before him to honor/adore him.” He said this deceitfully/lying.

so that I too may go and worship Him: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as so that indicates the purpose for the wise men to tell Herod where the child was. Herod wanted them to report to him in order that he too could go and worship the child. This was what he said.

Herod lied about wanting to worship the child. He really wanted to find him so that he could kill him. If people in your area will think that Herod was truthful about going and worshipping the child, you may want to include some implied information. For example:

“...so that I too may go and worship him.” He said this deceitfully/lying.

Then he lied saying, “Then I too will go and worship him.”

worship: See the note on 2:2c and translate this word as you did there.

Matthew 2:9

Section 2:1–12: Wise men came and honored Jesus

In this section, Matthew showed his readers that:

1. Jesus was indeed born in Bethlehem as scripture predicted (even though he would later move to Nazareth, and people considered him to be a Nazarene).
2. The Jewish religious teachers who knew the law did not go to worship the king of the Jews. It was the Gentile wise men who worshiped him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Visit of the Wise Men (NET)

Visitors from the East (GNT)

2:9a

After they had heard the king, they went on their way,

- ¶ After they heard the king’s words, they left him.
- ¶ When the king finished speaking, they left him and started going to Bethlehem.

After they had heard the king: This clause indicates that the king had finished giving instructions to the wise men.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

After they heard the king’s words

When the king finished speaking

they went on their way: The Greek word that the BSB translates as they went on their way simply indicates that the wise men left Herod. It is implied from 2:9b–c that they continued their journey.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

they left Herod and began traveling again

then they left Jerusalem and started going to Bethlehem

2:9b

and the star they had seen in the east went ahead of them

- Suddenly, the star appeared. This is the star that they had seen when it first rose. It continued going ahead of them
- Then amazingly, the same star again showed itself. This is the star that they had seen rising. This star guided/led them

The Greek of 2:9b begins with a word that is often translated as “behold.” It literally means “look” or “see.” This word focuses attention on what follows and indicates that it is important, unexpected, or amazing. In this passage, the star that the wise men had seen earlier unexpectedly appeared again. See the note at 2:1c and consider how you translated the term there.

the star they had seen in the east: The phrase in the east is the same phrase as in 2:2. You should translate it here as you did there.

There are two ways to interpret this phrase:

1. It refers to the star rising in the sky. For example:

the star they had seen rising (REB) (NRSV, NJB, GW, NET, REB, ESV)

1. It refers to the location of the star or the location of the wise men being in the east. For example:

the star which they had seen in the East (RSV) (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NASB, CEV, JBP, KJV, NCV, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the star they saw when it rose (NET)

the star they had seen rising (NJB)

went ahead of them: The Greek form of the verb that the BSB translates as went ahead indicates that the star continued to move before them as they traveled.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

kept going ahead of them as they traveled

guided them (NLT)

led them (NET)

2:9c

until it stood over the place where the Child was.

- until it stopped above the place where the child was.
- to the place where the young child Jesus was located. Then it stopped above that place.

until it stood over the place where the Child was:

The phrase place where the Child was refers to the location of the Child. It may indicate the house (2:11a) or the village. Use a general expression in your language for this phrase.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

until it stopped above the place where the child was

to the place where the child was. Then it stopped above that place.

the Child: The phrase the Child refers to Jesus.

Matthew 2:10

Section 2:1–12: Wise men came and honored Jesus

In this section, Matthew showed his readers that:

1. Jesus was indeed born in Bethlehem as scripture predicted (even though he would later move to Nazareth, and people considered him to be a Nazarene).
2. The Jewish religious teachers who knew the law did not go to worship the king of the Jews. It was the Gentile wise men who worshiped him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Visit of the Wise Men (NET)

Visitors from the East (GNT)

2:10

When they saw the star, they rejoiced with great delight.

- When they saw the star again, they were extremely happy!
- When these men saw the star appear, they were thrilled.

When they saw the star, they rejoiced with great delight: There are two ways to interpret this clause:

1. The wise men were overjoyed when they saw the star reappear. The GNT shows that it follows this interpretation by reordering 2:9–10:

^{9b}and on their way they saw the same star...

¹⁰When they saw it, how happy they were, what joy was theirs! ^{9b}It went ahead of them... (GNT) The commentators who follow this interpretation are: Carson, page 88; Lenski, page 69; Meyer, page 63; Blomberg, page 65; Mounce, page 15; Nolland, page 116; Hendriksen, page 169; Morris, page 41; Hagner, page 30.

1. The wise men were overjoyed when they saw the star stop over the place where Jesus was. For example:

When they saw that the star had stopped (NRSV) (NRSV) The commentators who follow this interpretation are: France (2007), page 74; Newman & Stine, page 41.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Most English versions are ambiguous and it is not possible to tell which interpretation they follow. But most commentators follow interpretation (1).

When they saw the star: Evidently, the wise men had not seen the star for some time. Then it appeared and they saw it again.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

When they saw the star appear

When they saw the star again

they rejoiced with great delight: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as they rejoiced with great delight means “they became extremely happy.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

they were filled with joy! (NLT)

they were very happy

General Comment on 2:9–10

In some languages, it may be more natural to put 2:10 in the middle of 2:9. For example:

^aSo after hearing what the king said, they left.

^bOn their way they saw the same star that they had seen rise. ¹⁰When they saw it, they were extremely happy. ^bThe star continued going ahead of them. ^cIt moved on until it stopped over the place where the young child was.

Matthew 2:11

Section 2:1–12: Wise men came and honored Jesus

In this section, Matthew showed his readers that:

1. Jesus was indeed born in Bethlehem as scripture predicted (even though he would later move to Nazareth, and people considered him to be a Nazarene).
2. The Jewish religious teachers who knew the law did not go to worship the king of the Jews. It was the Gentile wise men who worshiped him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Visit of the Wise Men (NET)

Visitors from the East (GNT)

2:11a

On coming to the house,

- Then they went into the house, and
- They entered the house.

2:11b

they saw the Child with His mother Mary,

- they saw the young child with his mother Mary.
- There they saw the child Jesus with Mary, his mother.

2:11c

and they fell down and worshiped Him.

- Then they knelt down and worshiped him.
- They quickly bowed down and honored/adored him.

fell down: The Greek word that the BSB here translates as fell down means “quickly lowered themselves to the ground to show great respect.” They did not fall down accidentally.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

knelt down (GNT)

quickly lowered themselves

bowed down (NIV)

and worshiped Him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as worshiped also occurs in 2:2c and 2:8d. This word usually includes the idea of kneeling or bowing down and putting one’s face to the ground to show great honor and submission. But in 2:11c, a separate Greek verb occurs first which indicates that the men “bowed down.” So you can translate this word as:

to honor him

to adore him

2:11d

Then they opened their treasures

- Then they opened their treasure boxes/chests
- Next they unpacked their loads

Then they opened their treasures: In this context, the Greek word that the BSB translates as treasures refers to a strong box used for keeping valuable things. For example:

treasure chests (NRSV)

treasure boxes (NET)

If people in your area do not keep valuable things in boxes, you may want to translate this passage using another word. For example:

They opened their containers/bags

They unpacked their loads

2:11e

and presented Him with gifts of gold and frankincense and myrrh.

- and gave him gifts of gold, and of incense and of myrrh.
- and gave to him their gifts. They gave him gold, expensive tree resin/sap called incense that is burned for a sweet smell, and an expensive perfume called myrrh.

presented Him with gifts: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as presented means “brought, offered.” The wise men may have placed the gifts in front of or near Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

offered to him gifts

brought gifts to him

gave gifts...to him

gold: The word gold refers to a shiny, yellow metal that is very valuable. The wise men’s gold may have been in its unworked or unshaped state. Or it may have been formed into a shape or made into coins.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

valuable/yellow metal

- Use a borrowed word.
- Use a borrowed word plus a descriptive phrase. For example:

valuable metal called gold

frankincense: The Greek word that the BSB translates as frankincense is a type of incense. It comes from the sap of several similar kinds of trees. People made the sap into a dry powder. Then they burned the powder to make a sweet-smelling smoke. They often did this as a part of worship.

Here are some other ways to translate frankincense:

- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

tree resin/sap burned for a sweet smell

- Use a borrowed word plus a descriptive phrase. For example:

sweet smelling tree resin/sap called incense

myrrh: The word myrrh also refers to a product made from the sap of a tree in Arabia. People made it into medicine and expensive perfumes.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

General Comment on 2:11e

- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

an expensive perfume

a sweet smelling oil

- Use a borrowed word plus a descriptive phrase. For example:

an expensive perfume called myrrh

myrrh tree sap made into perfume

sweet smelling thing called myrrh

You may want to explain “gold,” “frankincense,” and “myrrh” in a footnote instead of in the text. A sample footnote is:

gold: is a very expensive yellow metal. It is used as money and also in making jewelry.

frankincense: is an expensive product which is burned to give a sweet smell. It is made from the resin of several similar kinds of trees.

myrrh: is an expensive perfume made from the sap of a tree.

Matthew 2:12

Section 2:1–12: Wise men came and honored Jesus

In this section, Matthew showed his readers that:

1. Jesus was indeed born in Bethlehem as scripture predicted (even though he would later move to Nazareth, and people considered him to be a Nazarene).
2. The Jewish religious teachers who knew the law did not go to worship the king of the Jews. It was the Gentile wise men who worshiped him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Visit of the Wise Men (NET)

Visitors from the East (GNT)

2:12a

And having been warned in a dream not to return to Herod,

- ¶ Later, they were warned in a dream not to return to Herod.
- ¶ Then God told/instructed them in a dream, “Do not return^(plur) to King Herod.”

And: In some languages, it may be natural to begin 2:12 with a word or phrase that shows that the wise men’s dream occurred some time after they gave gifts. For example:

Later (CEV)

Then (GNT)

having been warned in a dream: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as having been warned is passive.

Here are some ways to translate this verb:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

Later they were warned in a dream (CEV)

And having been warned by God in a dream (NASB)

- Use an active verb. For example:

God had warned them in a dream (GNT)

God instructed/told them in a dream

warned: Here are some other ways to translate this word:

advised

told/instructed

informed

not to return to Herod: The phrase not to return to Herod was God’s warning in the dream. It is implied that they should not return to Herod and tell him where Jesus was.

Also, it may be more natural in some languages to make this direct speech. For example:

“Do not go back to Herod.”

“You^(plur) must not return to Herod.”

2:12b

they withdrew to their country by another route.

- So they went back to their country on a different road.
- So they got up and traveled back to their own country by/using another way/road.

they withdrew to their country: The wise men went back to their own country where they lived. They returned to their homeland. For example:

they went back home (CEV)

by another route: They returned a different way. They did not go back the same way they had come. They did this to avoid seeing Herod again.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

by another road (GNT)

a different way

Matthew 2:13

Section 2:13–15: Jesus' family escaped to Egypt

In this section, Matthew showed how God protected Jesus by warning Joseph to take him to Egypt. Matthew also showed how the move to Egypt fulfilled scripture.

Egypt is a country to the south of Judea. 1,500 years before Jesus' time, the people of Israel had lived in Egypt (Exodus 12:40). Then Moses led the people of Israel out of Egypt. Many years later, God said, "When Israel was a child, I loved him, and out of Egypt I called my son" (Hosea 11:1). This prophecy referred back to when God brought the nation of Israel out of Egypt (Exodus 12:41–42). This prophecy also referred ahead to the time when God would call his Son Jesus out of Egypt (Matthew 2:15).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus' Parents Take Him to Egypt (NCV)

The escape to Egypt

2:13a

When the Magi had gone,

- ¶ After they left,
- ¶ Then after the men who studied the stars had gone,

When the Magi had gone: This section begins with a time clause that the BSB translates as When the Magi had gone. This clause refers to the wise men leaving Mary and Joseph and Jesus to return to their own country.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

After they had left (GNT)

After the wise men had gone (CEV)

2:13b

an angel of the Lord appeared to Joseph in a dream.

- an angel of the Lord God unexpectedly appeared to Joseph in a dream
- Joseph went to sleep and he was dreaming. Suddenly he saw an angel from the Lord God.

The Greek of 2:13b begins with a words that is often translated as "behold." It literally means "look" or "see." This word focuses attention on what follows

and indicates that it is important, unexpected, or amazing. In this passage, an angel unexpectedly appeared to Joseph in a dream. If you have a term that gets the attention of people that is natural in this context, you should consider using it here.

Here are some ways to translate this:

behold, (ESV)

Unexpectedly

Then strangely

This same word occurs in 2:1c and 2:9b.

an angel of the Lord: The phrase an angel of the Lord refers here to an angel that the Lord (God) sent.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

an angel who came from the Lord God

an angel who was sent by God

This same phrase occurs in 1:20.

angel: The Greek word that the BSB translates as angel means "messenger." It refers to a supernatural, spiritual being who serves God.

Here are some ways to translate this term:

- Use a descriptive word or phrase. For example:

messenger from God

holy spirit-being

- Use a local term that fits the biblical meaning.
- In some areas the churches may already be using a borrowed term or a transliterated word for angel. Be sure that this term fits the biblical meaning. If some people do not understand the right meaning from this term, you may need to indicate the meaning in some way. For example:

an angelos messenger from God

a sacred angelos spirit

See angel, Meaning 1, in the Glossary for more information.

the Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the Lord refers here to God.

appeared to Joseph: The Greek word that the BSB translates as appeared can also mean “became visible” or “was revealed.” The angel appeared to Joseph while he was dreaming. This indicates that in his dream, Joseph saw an angel.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

showed/revealed himself to Joseph

Joseph saw an angel

in a dream: Joseph was sleeping, and he saw the angel while he was dreaming.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in a dream while he slept

He dreamed that an angel of the Lord appeared to him

2:13c

“Get up!” he said. “Take the Child and His mother and flee to Egypt.

- and said, “Get up and take the child and his mother and flee to the country of Egypt!
- The angel said, “Arise, take the young child and the child’s mother, and go quickly to the land of Egypt!

In some languages, it may be more natural to put 2:13c after 2:13e. See the General Comment after 2:13e for an example.

Get up!: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Get up! refers to rising from a bed or rising after being asleep. Another way to translate this word is:

Get up (NIV)

Take the Child and His mother: The phrase His mother refers to Jesus’ mother Mary.

Here are some ways to make this clearer:

take the child and the child’s mother

take the child and your wife

take Mary and Jesus

and flee: The Greek word that the BSB translates as flee refers to moving quickly away from danger.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

escape (NIV)

go quickly

hurry and go

to Egypt: The word Egypt is the name of a country located south and west of Judea. It was at least 240 kilometers from Bethlehem to the border of Egypt. It took more than a week to walk there.

Here is another way to translate this word:

the country/land of Egypt

2:13d

Stay there until I tell you,

- Stay there until I tell you^(sing) to come back,
- You^(sing) must remain there until I tell you to return.

In some languages, it may be more natural to put 2:13d after 2:13e. See the General Comment after 2:13e for an example.

Stay there until I tell you: The angel will one day tell Joseph to return. It may be more natural in your language to include that implied information. For example:

Stay there until I tell you to return (CEV)

2:13e

for Herod is going to search for the Child to kill Him.”

- because Herod will soon look for the child in order to kill him.”
- The reason is that King Herod intends to send soldiers to search soon for the child in order to kill him.”

In some languages, it may be more natural to put 2:13e before 2:13c–d. See the General Comment below for an example.

for: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as for introduces the basis for the command that they should flee to Egypt and stay there.^{13c–d} Escape to Egypt and stay there^{13e} for/because Herod wants to kill the child.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

because

The reason is

Herod is going to search for the Child: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as is going to search for indicates that Herod intended to search soon for the Child. Herod would not do the actual searching, but would send his soldiers to do it for him.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Herod intends to search for the child (NJB)

Herod is about to send his soldiers to search for the child

to kill Him: The phrase to kill Him means “in order to kill him.” It tells Herod’s purpose in searching for Jesus.

General Comment on 2:13c–e

In some languages, it may be more natural to put the basis (in 2:13e) before the command (in 2:13c–d). For example:

He said, ^{13e}“Herod is going to search for the child to kill him. ^{13c}So get up, take the child and his mother and escape to Egypt. ^{13d}Stay there until I tell you.”

Matthew 2:14

Section 2:13–15: Jesus’ family escaped to Egypt

In this section, Matthew showed how God protected Jesus by warning Joseph to take him to Egypt. Matthew also showed how the move to Egypt fulfilled scripture.

Egypt is a country to the south of Judea. 1,500 years before Jesus’ time, the people of Israel had lived in Egypt (Exodus 12:40). Then Moses led the people of Israel out of Egypt. Many years later, God said, “When Israel was a child, I loved him, and out of Egypt I called my son” (Hosea 11:1). This prophecy referred back to when God brought the nation of Israel out of Egypt (Exodus 12:41–42). This prophecy also referred ahead to the time when God would call his Son Jesus out of Egypt (Matthew 2:15).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus’ Parents Take Him to Egypt (NCV)

The escape to Egypt

2:14

So he got up, took the Child and His mother by night, and withdrew to Egypt,

- So he got up and took the child and his mother, and left for Egypt that night.
- When Joseph finished dreaming, he rose immediately and departed that same night with the child and the child’s mother and went to Egypt.

So: Verse 2:14 is the result of the angel’s command in 2:13. The angel told Joseph to flee to Egypt (2:13c–e). So Joseph did what the angel told him to do (2:14).

Here are some ways to begin this verse:

- Use a word or phrase that indicates that 2:14 is the result of 2:13, as the BSB does.
- Use a word or phrase that indicates that 2:14 is the next event in the story. For example:

Then (NET)

Some English versions do not begin this verse with a connecting word. You should begin this verse in a way that is natural in your language.

he got up: Joseph probably arose immediately after the dream.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he rose immediately

he quickly rose

took the Child and His mother: The phrase His mother refers to the child’s mother. It does not refer to Joseph’s mother.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

went with the child and his mother

left with his wife and the child

by night: The phrase by night indicates that they left the same night. For example:

that night (NJB)

on that very night

withdrew to Egypt:

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

went to Egypt (NRSV)

departed to the country of Egypt

Matthew 2:15

Section 2:13–15: Jesus’ family escaped to Egypt

In this section, Matthew showed how God protected Jesus by warning Joseph to take him to Egypt. Matthew also showed how the move to Egypt fulfilled scripture.

Egypt is a country to the south of Judea. 1,500 years before Jesus’ time, the people of Israel had lived in Egypt (Exodus 12:40). Then Moses led the people of Israel out of Egypt. Many years later, God said, “When Israel was a child, I loved him, and out of Egypt I called my son” (Hosea 11:1). This prophecy referred back to when God brought the nation of Israel out of Egypt (Exodus 12:41–42). This prophecy also referred ahead to the time when God would call his Son Jesus out of Egypt (Matthew 2:15).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus’ Parents Take Him to Egypt (NCV)

The escape to Egypt

2:15

Matthew interrupts his story here and gives his audience some background information. Verse 2:15 tells about what would happen later after Herod died. But verse 2:16 says that Herod had not yet died.

2:15a

where he stayed until the death of Herod.

- He stayed there with them until Herod died.
- He, the child Jesus, and Mary lived in Egypt until after King Herod died.

where he stayed until the death of Herod: There is some implied information here. It is that Mary and the baby Jesus all lived in Egypt with Joseph until King Herod died. Then they went back to Israel shortly after Herod’s death. You may want to include some of this implied information in your translation. For example:

where he stayed with the child and the child’s mother

2:15b

This fulfilled what the Lord had spoken through the prophet:

- This happened in order to make come true what the Lord had said. He spoke through the prophet, he said:
- When this happened, the words that the Lord had said long ago though his spokesman came true. He said:

This fulfilled: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as This fulfilled is literally “in order to be fulfilled.” This phrase indicates purpose. God told Joseph to take the child and his mother and leave Egypt (2:13), in order to fulfill what he (the Lord) had said through the prophet (2:15).

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

This happened to fulfill

This was done to make come true (GNT)

fulfilled: As the previous note suggested, the Greek word that the BSB translates as fulfilled is literally “be fulfilled.” This word means “came true” or “happened.” God spoke the words of 2:15c hundreds of years before Jesus was born. And now those words came true regarding Jesus.

In the Greek, the verb “was fulfilled” is passive.

Here are some ways to translate this verb:

- As a passive verb. For example:

In this way what was spoken by the Lord through the prophet was fulfilled (NET)

- As an active verb, as in the BSB. For example:

When God told Joseph to take the child and his mother and leave Egypt, this fulfilled

- As a stative verb. For example:

came true (CEV)

happened

what the Lord had spoken through the prophet: The phrase what the Lord had spoken through the prophet refers to the words/message that the Lord God told the prophet Hosea to tell the people. Hosea then spoke these words to the people. He also wrote them down.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the message that the Lord God spoke through the prophet. He said,

the words that the Lord told the prophet to say to the people. He said,

This same clause also occurs in 1:22. You should translate it the same way in both places.

prophet: The word prophet also occurs in 1:22 and 2:5. Also see prophet in the Glossary.

2:15c

“Out of Egypt I called My Son.”

- “I called/told my son to come out of Egypt.”
- “I summoned my son to return from Egypt.”

Verse 2:15c is a quote from Hosea 11:1. You may want to include this information in a footnote.

Out of Egypt I called My Son: This clause means that Jesus was in the country of Egypt when God told Joseph to leave and bring his family back to Israel.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I called my son to come out of Egypt

I told/commanded my son to leave/exit Egypt

I summoned my son to return from Egypt

Out of Egypt: The phrase Out of Egypt refers to the “Son” being in Egypt when God “called” him. It does not refer to the location of God when he said these words.

The phrase Out of Egypt is emphasized in the Greek. That is the reason that it is put first in the BSB. If you

have a natural way to emphasize the phrase Out of Egypt in your language, you may want to do so.

I called: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as called refers to telling someone to come.

My Son: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as My Son refers to Jesus here. However, this is a quote from the Old Testament long before Jesus was born. So do not translate this as “my son Jesus.”

Matthew 2:16

Section 2:16–18: King Herod killed the children

In this section, Matthew showed another way that scripture was fulfilled. Herod killed the children in and around Bethlehem, and so caused much mourning in that area.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Killing of the children (CEV)

Herod Kills the Baby Boys (NCV)

2:16a

When Herod saw that he had been outwitted by the Magi,

- ¶ But before that, when Herod learned that he had been tricked by the astrologers,
- ¶ Soon after Joseph began the journey to Egypt with the child and his mother, King Herod found out that the men who studied the stars had outsmarted him.

When: The storyline resumes here. The narrative jumps back to the time soon after Joseph, Mary, and Jesus began their journey to Egypt (2:14). You may want to do one of the following:

- Indicate here that the narrative returns to an earlier time. For example:

Soon after Joseph began the journey to Egypt with the child and his mother,...

- Indicate in 2:14 that Joseph began the journey and indicate that 2:15 temporarily jumps forward in time.

Herod saw: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as saw indicates that Herod knew that the wise men had deceived him.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

realized (NIV)

found out (CEV)

knew/understood

that he had been outwitted by the Magi: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as outwitted also means “deceived.” The wise men outwitted Herod in the sense that they did not follow his command to return to him and tell him about the child (2:8). God warned them not to go back to Herod. So they did not participate in Herod’s evil plan to kill the child. This word does not indicate that, from the beginning, the wise men intended to “deceive” Herod in an evil way.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

that the wise men were more clever than he thought

that the Magi were not going to return

This verb is passive.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

- As a passive verb. For example:

he saw that he had been tricked by the wise men (RSV)

he saw that he had been deceived by the Magi

- As an active verb. For example:

Herod saw that the wise men had tricked him (NCV)

2:16b he was filled with rage.

- he became very angry.
- Then he became enraged.

he was filled with rage: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as he was filled with rage means that Herod “became very angry.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

he became enraged

he was very angry (CEV)

2:16c

Sending orders, he put to death all the boys

- So he ordered his men to kill all the boys
- So he sent his soldiers to kill all the young boys

Sending orders, he put to death all the boys: It is implied that Herod sent his soldiers to kill all the boys. In some languages, it will be natural to include this implied information. For example:

he gave orders to his soldiers/men to kill all the boys

all the boys: Herod was only concerned about male children who were two years old and younger. You should use a term appropriate for that age group. For example:

baby boys

young boys

2:16d

in Bethlehem and its vicinity who were two years old and under,

- in Bethlehem and the surrounding area who were two years old or younger.
- who were up to two years old in Bethlehem and villages nearby.

in Bethlehem and its vicinity: The phrase its vicinity refers to the villages and settlements near Bethlehem.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in and around Bethlehem (NRSV)

in Bethlehem and in the area near it

in the town of Bethlehem and its surrounding communities/towns

who were two years old and under: The phrase two years old and under includes boys from two years old all the way down to newborns.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

two years old and younger (GNT)

newborns up to two years old

2:16e

according to the time he had learned from the Magi.

- This was based on the date that he had learned from the astrologers.
- He estimated/calculated this age from the time that these men told him that they had first seen the star.

according to the time he had learned from the Magi:

The clause according to the time he had learned from the Magi indicates that Herod calculated how old the child would have been based on the date that the wise men gave him. The wise men probably first saw the star less than two years before. But Herod wanted to make sure that his soldiers killed Jesus. So he told them to kill boys as old as two years.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

This was based on what he had learned from the wise men. (CEV)

He calculated this age from the time that the astrologers had first seen the star.

He estimated this age based on the wise men's words.

General Comment on 2:16c–e

It may be more natural in your language to have 2:16e before 2:16c. For example:

and ^{16e}counting from the time he had learned from the wise men, ^{16c}he gave orders to kill all the boys ^{16d}in Bethlehem and its vicinity who were two years old and under

The soldiers did as Herod ordered. It may be more natural in your language to include that implied information at the end of 2:16:

...And they did so.

Matthew 2:17**Section 2:16–18: King Herod killed the children**

In this section, Matthew showed another way that scripture was fulfilled. Herod killed the children in and around Bethlehem, and so caused much mourning in that area.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Killing of the children (CEV)

Herod Kills the Baby Boys (NCV)

2:17

Then what was spoken through the prophet Jeremiah was fulfilled:

- So then what the Lord said through the prophet Jeremiah came true:
- So then the words that the Lord long before told the prophet Jeremiah to say, they happened. Here are those words:

Then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Then introduces the result of Herod's action (2:16). Herod killed the baby boys (2:16), and as a result the words of the prophet were fulfilled (2:17).

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

In this way (GNT)

So (CEV)

what was spoken through the prophet Jeremiah:

The clause what was spoken through the prophet is very similar to the clause "what the Lord had spoken through the prophet" (in 2:15b). It refers to the words/message that the Lord God told the prophet Jeremiah to tell the people. Jeremiah then spoke these words to the people. He also wrote them down.

This clause is passive.

Here are some ways to translate this clause:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

the words spoken through the prophet Jeremiah (GW)

- Use an active verb. For example:

what God had said through the prophet Jeremiah (NCV)

the words that the Lord told the prophet Jeremiah to say to the people

was fulfilled: The Greek word that the BSB translates as was fulfilled means "came true" or "happened." God

spoke the words of 2:18 hundreds of years before Jesus was born. And now those words came true.

The verb was fulfilled is passive. Here are some ways to translate this verb:

- As a passive verb. For example:

Then was fulfilled (RSV)

- As an active verb. For example:

Herod's brutal action fulfilled (NLT)

- As a stative verb. For example:

Then the words spoken through the prophet Jeremiah came true (GW)

The same verb occurs in 2:15b.

Matthew 2:18

Section 2:16–18: King Herod killed the children

In this section, Matthew showed another way that scripture was fulfilled. Herod killed the children in and around Bethlehem, and so caused much mourning in that area.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Killing of the children (CEV)

Herod Kills the Baby Boys (NCV)

2:18

Verse 2:18 is a quote from Jeremiah 31:15. You may want to include a footnote with this reference in your translation.

2:18a

“A voice is heard in Ramah,

- “The voice/sound of someone crying was heard in Ramah,
- “People heard the voice/sound of someone crying in the town of Ramah.

A voice is heard: The Greek word that the BSB translates as voice can also mean “sound.” It refers to the voice (sound) of Rachel weeping and mourning.

The verb is heard is passive.

Here are some ways to translate this clause:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

A voice/sound was heard by people

- As an active verb. For example:

People heard the voice of someone

A sound comes/came

in Ramah: The word Ramah is the name of a town. It was about eight kilometers (five miles) north of Jerusalem.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in the town of Ramah

from the village of Ramah

2:18b

weeping and great mourning,

- it was someone crying and wailing loudly.
- It was the sound of someone sobbing and moaning greatly.

weeping and great mourning: The phrase weeping and great mourning further describes the “voice” in 2:18a. It is not describing a new event. As 2:18c indicates, it was Rachel who was weeping and mourning.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

it was the sound of weeping and great mourning

someone was weeping and mourning

The two words weeping and great mourning have almost the same meaning. In some languages, both words can be translated by one emphatic word or phrase. For example:

loud sobbing

the sound of bitter weeping (GNT)

weeping: The Greek word that the BSB translates as weeping refers to loud crying. It does not refer to quiet weeping.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

crying (CEV)

wailing (RSV)

much/extreme crying

great mourning: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as great mourning refers to the sounds that people make when they have extreme grief. It is the sounds that people make when a relative has just died.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

loud wailing (NET)

loud lamentation (ESV)

weeping loudly (CEV)

2:18c

Rachel weeping for her children,

- Rachel was crying for her children
- It was Rachel sobbing for her children.

Rachel weeping for her children: This clause identifies the “voice” or “sound” in 2:18a. The “voice” was the sound of Rachel weeping. It is figurative in this context. Rachel represents all the mothers who were weeping for their children who were killed.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

That sound was Rachel weeping for her children

It was the voice of Rachel weeping for her children

Rachel: The word Rachel is the name of a woman. She was the favorite wife of Jacob (Israel). The Jews considered Rachel to be the mother of their nation. She lived more than a thousand years before Jeremiah prophesied, and Jeremiah lived several hundred years before Christ was born. Jeremiah’s prophecy was fulfilled in his lifetime when many Israelites were killed in a war with Babylon. It was fulfilled again when Herod killed many baby boys in Bethlehem.

In some languages, it may be necessary to indicate that it was Rachel’s descendants who were weeping, not actually Rachel herself.

Here is another way to translate Rachel here:

Rachel’s descendants

weeping: The Greek word that the BSB translates as weeping is the same word as in 2:18b. It refers to loud crying, not quiet whimpering.

her children: In the time of Jeremiah and in the time of Christ, the children mentioned were the children of Rachel’s descendants, not her literal children.

Notice that if you translate Rachel as “Rachel’s descendants,” you will have to translate the phrase her children as “their children.”

2:18d

and refusing to be comforted,

- and she refused to be consoled,
- She did not want anyone to comfort her,

and refusing to be comforted: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as refusing to be comforted also means “not willing to be consoled.” Rachel did not want anyone to help lessen her grief.

The verb comforted is passive.

Here are some ways to translate this entire phrase:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

she refused to be consoled (RSV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

she did not want anyone to comfort her

2:18e

because they are no more.”

- because they no longer exist.”
- because her children are dead.”

because: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as because introduces the reason for what was said in 2:18a–d.

In some languages, it may be more natural to put 2:18e before 2:18c. For example:

^{18e}Rachel’s children are dead. ^{18c}So she is weeping for them, ^{18d}and she does not want to be comforted.

they are no more: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as they are no more indicates that “the children were dead.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

they are dead (GNT)

her children are dead (NCV)

they were gone (NET)

Matthew 2:19

Section 2:19–23: Jesus' family moved from Egypt to Nazareth

In this section, Matthew showed another way that scripture was fulfilled. When Joseph moved Mary and Jesus back to Israel, he intended to live in the district of Judea. But God warned him in a dream not to live there. So he went to the district of Galilee and lived in the town of Nazareth. In that way, the scripture was fulfilled that said that Jesus would be a Nazarene.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Return from Egypt (GNT)

The Return to Nazareth (NET)

Jesus fulfills scripture by living in Nazareth

2:19a

After Herod died,

- ¶ Later Herod died.
- ¶ While Joseph and his family were in Egypt, King Herod died.

The Greek of 2:19a begins with a conjunction that is often translated as “but.” Here, it functions to introduce the next part of the story. It does not show contrast. The BSB and most English versions do not translate this conjunction here. You should begin this paragraph in a way that is natural in your language.

After Herod died: In some languages, it may be more natural to make the clause Herod died a complete sentence. For example:

One day, Herod died.

Later, King Herod died.

In other languages, it may be more natural to begin 2:19a with some of the information from 2:19b. For example:

While Joseph and his family were still in Egypt, Herod died.

2:19b

an angel of the Lord appeared in a dream to Joseph in Egypt.

- One night while Joseph was still in Egypt, an angel of the Lord God unexpectedly appeared to him in a dream.
- One night, Joseph went to sleep, and he was dreaming. Suddenly/Unexpectedly he saw an angel from the Lord God.

The Greek of 2:19b begins with a word that is often translated as “behold.” It indicates that something unexpected and extraordinary will happen. In this passage, an angel again appeared to Joseph. You should translate this expression in the same way as you did in 2:13b.

an angel of the Lord: This expression also occurred in 2:13. See how you translated it there.

appeared in a dream to Joseph: This clause is the same as the clause in 2:13b.

Matthew 2:20

Section 2:19–23: Jesus' family moved from Egypt to Nazareth

In this section, Matthew showed another way that scripture was fulfilled. When Joseph moved Mary and Jesus back to Israel, he intended to live in the district of Judea. But God warned him in a dream not to live there. So he went to the district of Galilee and lived in the town of Nazareth. In that way, the scripture was fulfilled that said that Jesus would be a Nazarene.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Return from Egypt (GNT)

The Return to Nazareth (NET)

Jesus fulfills scripture by living in Nazareth

2:20a

“Get up!” he said. “Take the Child and His mother and go to the land of Israel,

- He said, “Get up and take the child and his mother and go back to the land of Israel,
- The angel said, “Arise, take the young child and the child's mother and return to the land of Israel.

“Get up!” he said. “Take the Child and His mother:

This clause is identical to the one in 2:13c where the angel told Joseph to take his family to Egypt. See how you translated it there.

and go: Since Joseph and Mary came from the land of Israel, in some languages it is more natural to say “go back” or “return.” For example:

and go back (GNT)

to the land of Israel: The phrase the land of Israel included the districts of Judea, Samaria, and Galilee. At that time, Israel was not its own separate country. But the Jews still called this area their homeland. Use a general term for land that refers to a large area.

2:20b**for those seeking the Child’s life are now dead.”**

- because those people who were trying to kill the child are dead.”
- The people who wanted to find and kill Jesus are now dead.”

for: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as for introduces the basis for the command that Joseph should go back to Israel. ^{20a}He should return to Israel ^{20b}for/because Herod is dead.

In some languages, it is more natural to put the basis for the command (in 2:20b) before the command (in 2:20a). For example:

^{20b}Those who were trying to take the child’s life are dead. ^{20a}So get up, take the child and his mother and go to the land of Israel.

those seeking the Child’s life are now dead: Scholars are divided over the word those and who it refers to. They are divided as to who, in addition Herod, wanted to kill baby Jesus. Some say it refers to Herod’s servants. Others say it refers to the chief priests and scribes. It is suggested that you translate this to simply indicate the plural in a general way. For example:

those who tried to... (GNT)

the people who were trying to...

seeking the Child’s life: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as seeking the Child’s life means “wanted to kill the child.” They wanted to kill the baby Jesus. For example:

wanted to kill him (CEV)

2:20a–b

(reordered) The angel said, “The people who wanted to find and kill the child are now dead. So rise and take him and his mother and return to the land of Israel.”

Matthew 2:21**Section 2:19–23: Jesus’ family moved from Egypt to Nazareth**

In this section, Matthew showed another way that scripture was fulfilled. When Joseph moved Mary and Jesus back to Israel, he intended to live in the district of Judea. But God warned him in a dream not to live there. So he went to the district of Galilee and lived in the town of Nazareth. In that way, the scripture was fulfilled that said that Jesus would be a Nazarene.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Return from Egypt (GNT)

The Return to Nazareth (NET)

Jesus fulfills scripture by living in Nazareth

2:21a**So Joseph got up, took the Child and His mother,**

- So he got up and took the child and his mother
- When Joseph finished dreaming, he rose and then departed with the child and the child’s mother,

So Joseph got up, took the Child and His mother:

The phrase His mother refers to Jesus’ mother Mary. It does not refer to Joseph’s mother.

Here are some ways to make this clearer:

took the child and the child’s mother

went with Mary and Jesus

This clause is identical to 2:14. You should translate this clause in the same way.

2:21b**and went to the land of Israel.**

- and went back to the land of Israel.
- and they returned to the land of Israel.

Matthew 2:22

Section 2:19–23: Jesus' family moved from Egypt to Nazareth

In this section, Matthew showed another way that scripture was fulfilled. When Joseph moved Mary and Jesus back to Israel, he intended to live in the district of Judea. But God warned him in a dream not to live there. So he went to the district of Galilee and lived in the town of Nazareth. In that way, the scripture was fulfilled that said that Jesus would be a Nazarene.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Return from Egypt (GNT)

The Return to Nazareth (NET)

Jesus fulfills scripture by living in Nazareth

2:22a

But when he learned that Archelaus was reigning in Judea in place of his father Herod,

- ¶ But when Joseph heard that Archelaus had taken the place of his father Herod as the king of Judea,
- ¶ But then Joseph learned that Herod's son Archelaus had succeeded his father as ruler of the province of Judea.

But: When Joseph returned to Israel, he probably intended to live in Bethlehem in the district of Judea. So there is a contrast between 2:21 and 2:22. The contrast is between Joseph's original intentions and then his fear of actually going there when he heard that Archelaus was the king of Judea. Joseph probably thought that Archelaus would want to harm Jesus as Herod had wanted to.

Most English versions indicate this contrast with the conjunction *But*, as the BSB does. Translate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language.

Archelaus: The word Archelaus is the name of Herod's son. When Herod died, Archelaus became king of Judea.

was reigning in Judea: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as *was reigning* refers to ruling as the highest authority/leader over a province.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

was now ruler (CEV)

was ruling (NRSV)

was the king

in place of his father Herod: The phrase in place of his father Herod means that Archelaus became the king after his father Herod died.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

took his father Herod's place

replaced his father Herod

succeeded his father Herod (GNT)

2:22b

he was afraid to go there.

- he was afraid to go live there.
- So he was afraid to return to that area.

he: The pronoun *he* refers to Joseph.

was afraid to go there: Joseph was probably afraid that King Archelaus would be as cruel a ruler as his father Herod was. He feared that Archelaus would want to kill Jesus as Herod had.

to go there: Joseph, Mary, and Jesus had already returned to Israel. Joseph may have been planning to live in Bethlehem, which was in Judea. In some languages, it may be more natural to include some implied information here. For example:

to go and stay/live there

2:22c

And having been warned in a dream,

- Then he was warned in a dream not to go there.
- Then God told him in a/dream that he must not go to Judea.

having been warned in a dream: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as *having been warned* is passive. The Greek text does not mention who warned Joseph. It was God acting either directly or through an angel.

Here are some ways to translate this verb:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

being warned in a dream (RSV)

Then he was warned in a dream

- Use an active verb. For example:

God warned him in a dream

As he was dreaming, God told him

warned: Here are some other ways to translate this word:

told/instructed what to do

advised not to go there

This same verb occurs in 2:12.

In some languages, it may be necessary to say what God warned Joseph about. If that is the case in your language, you can say:

warned him not to go there

warned him not to go to Judea

2:22d

he withdrew to the district of Galilee,

- So he went instead to the region of Galilee with the child and his mother
- So he continued with his family to the province of Galilee

withdrew: The Greek verb that the BSB translates here as withdrew is the same word translated as “withdrew” in 2:14.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

went (GNT)

continued

The verb is singular, indicating that Joseph left. But, of course Mary and Jesus went with him. In some languages, it will be more natural to include Mary and Jesus. For example:

went with Mary and Jesus

to the district of Galilee: The Greek word that the BSB translates as district refers to a “region” or “province.” Galilee was the name of a province/district of the

Roman Empire. It was located in the northern part of what is currently the nation of Israel.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the province of Galilee (GNT)

the region of Galilee (NJB)

Matthew 2:23

Section 2:19–23: Jesus’ family moved from Egypt to Nazareth

In this section, Matthew showed another way that scripture was fulfilled. When Joseph moved Mary and Jesus back to Israel, he intended to live in the district of Judea. But God warned him in a dream not to live there. So he went to the district of Galilee and lived in the town of Nazareth. In that way, the scripture was fulfilled that said that Jesus would be a Nazarene.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Return from Egypt (GNT)

The Return to Nazareth (NET)

Jesus fulfills scripture by living in Nazareth

2:23a

and he went and lived in a town called Nazareth.

- and went/came to the town called Nazareth and lived there.
- and settled in the town of Nazareth.

and he went and lived: In 2:22d, the verb that the BSB translates as “withdrew” already indicates that Joseph and his family had gone to Galilee. So in 2:23a, many English versions do not translate the Greek verb that the BSB translates as went. These versions only translate the Greek verb that the BSB translates as lived. For example:

There he settled (NJB)

a town called Nazareth: In some languages, it may not be natural to literally translate the phrase a town called Nazareth. You may want to translate this phrase as:

the town of Nazareth

2:23b**So was fulfilled what was spoken through the prophets:**

- They did this so that the words which the prophets spoke might be fulfilled:
- That all happened to make come true what the Lord had said long ago through his spokesmen:

So was fulfilled what was spoken through the prophets: There are two ways to interpret the way 2:23b is connected to 2:23a:

1. It is the purpose for Joseph's move to Nazareth. According to this interpretation, Joseph moved to Nazareth so that scripture would be fulfilled. For example:

so that what had been spoken through the prophets might be fulfilled (NRSV) (ESV, NRSV, RSV, KJV, NASB, REB)

1. It is the result of Joseph's move to Nazareth. According to this interpretation, Joseph moved to Nazareth, and as a result scripture was fulfilled. For example:

And so what the prophets had said came true (GNT) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NET, GW, CEV, NCV, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as So clearly indicates purpose. From a human perspective, Joseph's move resulted in scripture being fulfilled. But from a divine perspective, God caused Joseph to move to Nazareth in order to fulfill scripture.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

They did this so that the words of the prophets might be fulfilled.

God caused them to do this so that what the prophets spoke might come true.

was fulfilled what was spoken through the prophets: The word translated as was spoken is passive. The verb translated as was fulfilled is also passive.

Here are some ways to translate these words:

- Use passive verbs. For example:

so that what had been spoken through the prophets might be fulfilled (NRSV)

- Use active verbs. For example:

They moved there in order to fulfill what God said through the prophets

- Use both a passive and an active verb. For example:

God caused them to go there so that what he/God said through the prophets would be fulfilled.

See how you translated a similar clause in 1:22 and 2:17. But remember to use the plural prophets here rather than the singular "prophet."

2:23c**"He will be called a Nazarene."**

- "He will be called a person of Nazareth."
- "People/They will call him a person/man from Nazareth."

He will be called: The verb will be called is passive.

Here are some ways to translate this clause:

- Using a passive form. For example:

he will be called

- Using an active form. For example:

people will call him

The verb "call" also occurs in 1:23.

a Nazarene: The word Nazarene refers to a person whose hometown is Nazareth. You should translate this word to properly indicate a person from Nazareth. For example:

a Nazareth man

a citizen of Nazareth

a person from Nazareth

Matthew 3:1**Section 3:1–12: John the Baptist taught people to repent and obey God**

The story starting at 3:1 occurred about twenty-eight years after 2:23. Matthew did not tell what happened

during those twenty-eight years. But he restarted the story at this time in Jesus' life because Jesus was ready to begin the work that God gave him to do. He began at the time God chose for him.

John the Baptist was the last prophet before Jesus. The story of how John was born is in Luke chapter 1. He was the prophet whom God said would come (3:3). John wore the kind of clothes prophets often wore (3:4). He baptized people who repented. John preached that Jesus would be greater than he was (3:11).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The work of John the Baptist/Baptizer

The work of John who baptized people

John the Baptizer preached repentance and submission to God's rule

John the Baptizer prepared people to receive the Lord

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 1:1, Luke 3:1-18 and John 1:19-28.

3:1a

In those days John the Baptist came,

- ¶ Many years later, John the Baptizer came and began
- ¶ Years passed, then John, the man who baptized people, started

In those days: The phrase In those days may indicate “during the time when Jesus was living at Nazareth.” However, about twenty-eight years had passed since the end of chapter 2. If people in your area will think that the phrase In those days means that 3:1 happened soon after 2:23, you may want to include some implied information. For example:

Years later (CEV)

Years passed

Later, during the days that

John the Baptist: John had baptized many people. As a result, he became known as John the Baptist or “John the Baptizer.” For more information on the

meaning of “baptize,” see “were baptized” in the note at 3:6b.

Here are some other ways to translate this title:

John the Baptizer (GW)

John the one who baptized people

John who cleansed people for God

John the Ritual Purifier

John who initiated people with God's washing

the Baptist: The word Baptist has the same meaning here as the word “baptizer.” It refers to a person who baptizes people. The verb “baptize” means to purify people with a special ritual that uses water. In this context, the ritual involved purification from sin. It did not mean that the person was cleaned to remove dirt. Baptism was an initiation that marked the beginning of a person's life as one of God's pure people.

came: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as came can also mean “appear,” or “make a public appearance.” It indicates that at this time John began his work.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

appeared (NRSV)

began (NCV)

3:1b

preaching in the wilderness of Judea

- to preach in the wilderness of Judea.
- to publicly announce God's message to the people. He was in a part of the province of Judea where no one lived.

preaching: The Greek word that the BSB translates as preaching means to publicly “announce,” or “proclaim.” John was announcing the message that God had given to him. The words of 3:2 indicate what he was preaching.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

publicly announcing

proclaiming this message (REB)

telling people God's message

in the wilderness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as wilderness refers to a wild, desolate area where few people lived. Some English versions translate this word as "desert" (NIV). It was often a dry area, but it was not just sand and barren. Some wild grasses and bushes grew there. Many people went out to this wilderness to hear John preach. The focus here is that few people lived there, not that it was dry.

Some languages have a special word to refer to such an area, such as "the bush" (Africa) or "steppes" (Asia). It may be appropriate to use such a word here.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Desert (NIV)

empty land

region where no one lives

of Judea: The noun Judea refers to a district or province. It was one of the areas where Jews lived.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in the province of Judea

that was in the district of Judea

Matthew 3:2

Section 3:1–12: John the Baptist taught people to repent and obey God

The story starting at 3:1 occurred about twenty-eight years after 2:23. Matthew did not tell what happened during those twenty-eight years. But he restarted the story at this time in Jesus' life because Jesus was ready to begin the work that God gave him to do. He began at the time God chose for him.

John the Baptist was the last prophet before Jesus. The story of how John was born is in Luke chapter 1. He was the prophet whom God said would come (3:3). John wore the kind of clothes prophets often wore (3:4). He baptized people who repented. John preached that Jesus would be greater than he was (3:11).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The work of John the Baptist/Baptizer

The work of John who baptized people

John the Baptizer preached repentance and submission to God's rule

John the Baptizer prepared people to receive the Lord

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 1:1, Luke 3:1–18 and John 1:19–28.

3:2a and saying, "Repent,

- He said, "Turn to God,
- He said, "Turn away from your sins and turn to God,

Repent: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Repent refers in a general way to changing one's mind. In this context, it refers to changing one's mind about sin and God. It means to stop sinning and begin to obey God.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Turn from your sins and turn to God (NLT96)

Turn back to God! (CEV)

Change your hearts and lives (NCV)

Leave/Abandon the ways of sin and follow the ways of God

3:2b for the kingdom of heaven is near."

- because the kingdom of the one who lives in heaven has begun."
- because God is ready to rule his people!"

for: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as for introduces the reason why people should repent. They should repent because the kingdom of heaven is near.

In some languages, it will be more natural to change the order of 3:2a and 3:2b. For example:

^{2b}The kingdom of heaven is near, ^{2a}so repent!

the kingdom of heaven: When you translate the phrase the kingdom of heaven, there are two issues to consider:

Issue 1: The meaning of heaven

In the phrase the kingdom of heaven, the word heaven is a figure of speech called metonymy. In this figure of speech, heaven refers to God, but it refers to him indirectly by naming the place where he lives and rules. The Jews considered God's name to be so holy that they hesitated to say it. So instead of pronouncing God's name directly, they often used the name of the place where he lives and rules. Because Matthew was writing primarily to Jews, he often used the word heaven to refer to God.

Therefore, the kingdom of heaven means the same thing as "the kingdom of God." The phrase the kingdom of heaven only occurs in the book of Matthew. The expression "the kingdom of God" is found in all other books, and it even occurs five times in Matthew.

Some ways to translate heaven in this context are:

- Make some information explicit. For example:

the one/Lord who lives in heaven

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

God

Issue 2: The meaning of the kingdom of heaven

Both the kingdom of heaven and "the kingdom of God" refer to God's activity of ruling over his people. God's rule is not simply giving orders or commands to people. It also includes his protection, care, and blessing for them. God leads, protects, and cares for his people. They obey, trust, and submit to him as their king. The phrase the kingdom of heaven does not refer to a land or country that God rules over.

Here are some other ways to translate the kingdom of heaven:

- As a noun. For example:

the kingdom/rule of the one who lives in heaven

the kingdom of God

God's kingship

God's rule over people

- As a verbal expression. For example:

God rules his people

God cares for his people as king

See kingdom of heaven in the Glossary for more information.

is near: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as *is near* is more literally "has approached." This clause probably means that God's kingdom had already started. God was ready to rule and save his people through Jesus' teaching and miracles. It was time to repent.

John was preaching that the kingdom of heaven is near in a time sense, not in a physical sense.

So the entire clause "the kingdom of heaven is near" means:

the kingdom of heaven is being established

now is the time for the one who lives in heaven to rule over you^(plur)

the time for God to rule over people has come

God's kingship/chieftaincy has begun

Matthew 3:3

Section 3:1–12: John the Baptist taught people to repent and obey God

The story starting at 3:1 occurred about twenty-eight years after 2:23. Matthew did not tell what happened during those twenty-eight years. But he restarted the story at this time in Jesus' life because Jesus was ready to begin the work that God gave him to do. He began at the time God chose for him.

John the Baptist was the last prophet before Jesus. The story of how John was born is in Luke chapter 1. He was the prophet whom God said would come (3:3). John wore the kind of clothes prophets often wore (3:4). He baptized people who repented. John preached that Jesus would be greater than he was (3:11).

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There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 1:1, Luke 3:1-18 and John 1:19-28.

3:3a

This is he who was spoken of through the prophet Isaiah:

- This was the man whom Isaiah the prophet told about long ago, saying,
- The person who was saying this is the man whom God's spokesman Isaiah spoke about long ago when he said,

The Greek of 3:3a begins with conjunction that is often translated as "for." This word often introduces a reason. However, here it introduces some information about John the Baptist. Do not translate this verse as if it were the reason for 3:2. The BSB and many English versions do not translate this conjunction.

This is he who was spoken of through the prophet Isaiah: This clause means that God, through the prophet Isaiah, had spoken about John the Baptist. Many years before this time, the prophet Isaiah (in Isaiah 40:3) had prophesied about John the Baptist.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

This was the man whom God's prophet Isaiah spoke about

God, through the prophet Isaiah, spoke about this man when he wrote

spoken of through the prophet Isaiah: See 1:22 and 2:23b for a similar phrase and consider how you translated it there.

3:3b

"A voice of one calling in the wilderness,

- "A voice of someone in the wilderness is shouting this:
- "A person is calling with a loud voice in a land where no one lives, saying:

A voice of one calling in the wilderness: In the BSB, as in the Greek, this is not a complete sentence. In some languages, it may be necessary to make it into a complete sentence by including another form of the word calling. (See the note below for the meaning of calling in this context.) Isaiah was talking about something that would happen seven hundred years later. So you should use the verb form that is natural for a prophecy about the future. In English it is possible to use either the present or the future tense. For example:

There is a voice crying in the desert.

A voice will cry out in the desert.

A voice of one calling: The voice is the voice of a person. Someone was calling out in order to proclaim a message.

The Greek word that the BSB translates as calling means "shout or call out loudly." Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

A man is shouting

Someone will call out

the wilderness: The word wilderness is the same word as in 3:1b. See how you translated it there.

3:3c-d

Before you translate 3:3c-d, there are at least two issues to consider:

Issue 1: Parallelism

Verse 3:3c-d is a Hebrew form of poetry called a parallelism. In a parallelism, an idea is repeated. In this particular parallelism, the idea in 3:3c is repeated and made more specific in 3:3d.

The parallel parts in 3:3c-d that are similar in meaning are shown here:

^{3c} Prepare the way **for the Lord,**

^{3d} make straight paths **for Him.**

In some languages, people will think that the parallel parts in 3:3c-d describe different events. In other words, they will think that "Prepare the way" and "make paths straight" describe different events.

If that is true in your language, you should:

- Indicate that both expressions refer to the same thing. For example:

^{3c}Prepare the way for the Lord,

^{3d} I repeat more specifically, make straight paths for Him

- Combine the parallel parts. For example:

Prepare straight paths for the Lord

Issue 2: Metaphor

In addition, 3:3c–d uses metaphors. In these metaphors, the person in the wilderness asked the people to prepare their hearts to receive the Lord. He did this by comparing preparing their hearts to preparing a road to welcome the Lord.

In biblical times, when someone important was about to visit a town, the people living there would make sure that the road was prepared for him to travel on. It had to be smooth and straight. This was a way to welcome and honor an important visitor. In the same way, people should prepare their hearts to receive and welcome the Lord. See below for some translation advice.

3:3c

‘Prepare the way for the Lord,

- ‘Make^(plur) the road ready for the Lord to come,
- ‘Just as you prepare a road for an important person, so prepare your hearts for the Lord.

Prepare the way for the Lord: This clause is the first part of the parallelism. It means approximately the same thing as 3:3d. The difference is that it is more general.

This clause is also a metaphor. In this metaphor, the person in the wilderness told the people to prepare themselves to receive/welcome the Lord. He compared preparing their hearts (or themselves) to preparing a way/road for the Lord to come. He was not literally commanding the people to make their roads better.

The way that “hearts” and “way/road” are similar is that people need to prepare these things to welcome the Lord.

Here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor and explain the meaning in a footnote. A possible footnote would be:

This is a metaphor. Matthew quoted Isaiah as saying that the people needed to get ready for the Lord to come. They needed to repent and prepare their hearts and lives for his coming. Isaiah compared this to improving a road to receive the Lord.

- Change the metaphors to similes. For example:

Prepare yourselves for the Lord like you prepare a road for an important person

Just as you prepare a road for a king when he comes, prepare your hearts for the Lord to come.

- Translate the meaning without the metaphor. For example:

Prepare yourselves to receive the Lord

Make the necessary changes in your life to receive/welcome the Lord

This verse refers to people preparing themselves in a moral and spiritual way. Your translation should not imply that they should prepare themselves only in a physical way, such as cleaning their houses.

way: The Greek word that the BSB translates as way refers to a “road/path.” In this metaphor, a person’s heart or life is compared to a “road” or “path.”

the Lord: Here the word Lord refers to the “Lord God.” Matthew understood this to mean that God would come to Israel in the person of Jesus the Messiah.

3:3d

make straight paths for Him.”

- make^(plur) the paths straight for him.”
- I repeat, just as you^(plur) make roads straight for receiving an important person, so make your lives straight for receiving the Lord.”

make straight paths for Him: This clause is the second part of the parallelism. It means approximately the same thing as 3:3c. The difference is that it is more specific.

This clause also repeats the metaphor in 3:3c. In this metaphor, the person in the wilderness told the people to make their hearts (themselves) correct so that they could receive and welcome the Lord. He compared making themselves correct to making straight paths for the Lord. He was not literally commanding the people to make their paths straight.

The way that “hearts” and paths are similar is that people need to prepare these things to welcome the Lord.

Here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor and explain the meaning in a footnote. A possible footnote is presented above in 3:3c.
- Change the metaphors to similes. For example:

Just as you make straight paths for a king make yourselves straight/correct for the Lord to come.

- Translate the meaning without the metaphor. For example:

Make yourselves ready for him

You should translate 3:3d in a similar way to 3:3c.

straight paths: The Greek word that the BSB translates as paths is a synonym of “way/road” in 3:3c. If your language translates both “road” and “path” with the same word, you can repeat it. Or you can use the pronoun “them” or “it.” For example:

^{3c}Prepare the road for the Lord, ^{3d}make the road straight for him.

^{3c}Prepare the road for the Lord, ^{3d}make it straight for him.

Matthew 3:4

Section 3:1–12: John the Baptist taught people to repent and obey God

The story starting at 3:1 occurred about twenty-eight years after 2:23. Matthew did not tell what happened during those twenty-eight years. But he restarted the story at this time in Jesus’ life because Jesus was ready to begin the work that God gave him to do. He began at the time God chose for him.

John the Baptist was the last prophet before Jesus. The story of how John was born is in Luke chapter 1. He was the prophet whom God said would come (3:3). John wore the kind of clothes prophets often wore (3:4). He baptized people who repented. John preached that Jesus would be greater than he was (3:11).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The work of John the Baptist/Baptizer

The work of John who baptized people

John the Baptizer preached repentance and submission to God’s rule

John the Baptizer prepared people to receive the Lord

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 1:1, Luke 3:1–18 and John 1:19–28.

3:4

Verse 3:4 is background information. It speaks about John’s simple clothes and simple food while he lived in the wilderness. His simple lifestyle and clothing indicated to the people of that day that he was a prophet. He resembled the prophet Elijah (2 Kings 1:8). You may want to put this information in a footnote.

3:4a

John wore a garment of camel’s hair,

- ¶ John wore clothes that were made from camel’s hair.
- ¶ As for John, he wore a robe that people had woven from a desert animal’s hair.

In the Greek, 3:4a begins with a common Greek conjunction that is often translated as “now” (ESV). Here it functions to introduce new information about John the Baptist. The BSB and many English versions do not translate this conjunction here. Introduce this background information in a way that is natural in your language.

John wore a garment of camel’s hair: John wore clothes that were made from the hair of an animal called a camel. A camel is a large, domesticated animal that carries people and cargo in the desert. People wove a rough kind of cloth made from the hair of this animal.

If camels are not known in your area, you could:

- Transliterate the word camel and explain the term in the text. For example:

John’s clothes were made from the hair of a large desert animal called a camel

- Transliterate the word camel and explain the term in a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

A camel is a large domesticated animal that carries people and cargo in the desert.

- Translate using a general term:

The clothes that John wore were made from coarse hair of a desert animal

garment: The word garment is a general word that refers to all types of clothes. Here is probably refers to John's outer robe or tunic.

Here is another way to translate this word:

clothes (NIV)

3:4b

with a leather belt around his waist.

- He wore a leather strap around his waist.
- He tied his robe around his waist with a cord/rope of animal skin.

with a leather belt around his waist: The phrase leather belt refers to a strip of animal skin tied around the waist. It kept one's outer robe close to the body. It also made it possible to tuck up the robe in order to walk or run unhindered.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

and he wore a long strip of animal skin around his waist

and he tied his clothes around his waist with an animal skin rope

3:4c

His food was locusts and wild honey.

- His food was large grasshoppers and honey from wild bees.
- He ate locusts/grasshoppers and honey.

His food was locusts: The word locusts refers to a large kind of grasshopper. They are insects which jump and can fly. Large numbers of locusts frequently migrate together to eat and destroy crops. People who live in the desert sometimes eat locusts.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

His food was large grasshoppers

He ate large insects/bugs that jump and fly

wild honey: The phrase wild honey refers to honey that wild bees of the desert made. People found it

under rocks or in cracks between rocks. It was not honey made by bees that people raised.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

honey of wild bees

honey

Matthew 3:5

Section 3:1–12: John the Baptist taught people to repent and obey God

The story starting at 3:1 occurred about twenty-eight years after 2:23. Matthew did not tell what happened during those twenty-eight years. But he restarted the story at this time in Jesus' life because Jesus was ready to begin the work that God gave him to do. He began at the time God chose for him.

John the Baptist was the last prophet before Jesus. The story of how John was born is in Luke chapter 1. He was the prophet whom God said would come (3:3). John wore the kind of clothes prophets often wore (3:4). He baptized people who repented. John preached that Jesus would be greater than he was (3:11).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

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There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 1:1, Luke 3:1–18 and John 1:19–28.

3:5a

People went out to him from Jerusalem

- People from Jerusalem were going there to listen to him.
- People from the city of Jerusalem were going to the wilderness to listen to him,

3:5b

and all Judea and the whole region around the Jordan.

- This included all the district of Judea and from the land on both sides of the Jordan River.
- even people from all parts of the province of Judea and people from the whole region along the Jordan River.

3:5a-b

People went out to him from Jerusalem and all Judea and the whole region around the Jordan: This phrase is literally “Then came out to him Jerusalem and all Judea and the whole region of the Jordan.” For example:

Then Jerusalem and all Judea and all the region about the Jordan were going out to him (ESV)

In the Greek, the words Jerusalem, Judea, and Jordan are used in a figurative way to refer to the people of those places. In many languages, it is more natural to refer to the people from these areas.

Here are some other ways to translate this sentence:

People from Jerusalem and from all of Judea and all over the Jordan Valley went out to see and hear John (NLT)

Many people from the city of Jerusalem and all the district of Judea and from the Jordan River valley went to John

went out to him: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as went out to probably indicates that people went to see John over a period of time. People may have gone to see him over a period of weeks or months. (Some people went one day, other people went the next day, and still other people went the following day, and so on.) They went to see him and to listen to him preach.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

were going (NRSV)

continued going out to see him and listen to him

all Judea: The word Judea refers to a district or province. The phrase all Judea refers to all the areas in the district of Judea.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the whole province of Judea (GNT)

they also came from all the regions of Judea

the whole region around the Jordan: The phrase the whole region around the Jordan refers to the land on both sides of the Jordan River. This land was outside of the district of Judea. People from the areas along the Jordan River also went to see John.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

all the area around the Jordan River (NCV)

they also came from the land on both sides of the Jordan River

Matthew 3:6

Section 3:1-12: John the Baptist taught people to repent and obey God

The story starting at 3:1 occurred about twenty-eight years after 2:23. Matthew did not tell what happened during those twenty-eight years. But he restarted the story at this time in Jesus’ life because Jesus was ready to begin the work that God gave him to do. He began at the time God chose for him.

John the Baptist was the last prophet before Jesus. The story of how John was born is in Luke chapter 1. He was the prophet whom God said would come (3:3). John wore the kind of clothes prophets often wore (3:4). He baptized people who repented. John preached that Jesus would be greater than he was (3:11).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

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The work of John who baptized people

John the Baptizer preached repentance and submission to God’s rule

John the Baptizer prepared people to receive the Lord

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 1:1, Luke 3:1-18 and John 1:19-28.

3:6

The BSB reverses the order of the Greek phrases in 3:6. In some languages, it may be more natural to follow the example of the BSB. For example:

^{6b}They confessed their sins, ^{6a}and he baptized them in the Jordan River. (NCV)

However, in some languages, it may be more natural to follow the Greek order. For example:

^{6a}and they were baptized by him in the river Jordan, ^{6b}confessing their sins. (ESV)

3:6a

Confessing their sins,

- When they declared openly their sins,
- As they publicly admitted their wrongs,

Confessing their sins: The phrase Confessing their sins refers to publicly admitting what their sins were. It is implied that the people were sorry for their sins.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

They told how sorry they were for their sins (CEV)

They were admitting to God that they had sinned

sins: The Greek word that English versions translate as sins refers to anything that people do or do not do that is against God's will. This includes acts, thoughts, and attitudes. In other words, sin is anything that violates God's standard of what is right and good.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

wrong acts

offenses against God

evil deeds

This word also occurs in 1:21c. You should translate it here as you did there.

3:6b

they were baptized by him in the Jordan River.

- they were being baptized by John in the Jordan River.
- John baptized many of them in the Jordan River.

they were baptized by him in the Jordan River: The verb were baptized is passive. Some ways to translate this verb are:

- As a passive verb. For example:

they were baptized by him (RSV)

- As an active verb. For example:

he was baptizing them (NET)

The Greek verb probably indicates that John was baptizing people during a period of time. He may have been baptizing people over a period of weeks or months.

Only some of those who came confessed their sins and were baptized. And John baptized only the people who confessed their sins. You should not imply that John baptized everyone who went to see him.

were baptized: The Greek word that the BSB translates as were baptized means to be ceremonially washed/purified with a special ritual that uses water. In this context, people were purified from their sins. They were not washed to remove dirt from their bodies. A person was baptized as an initiation into a new spiritual condition.

Here are some other ways to translate the word baptized:

- Use a descriptive term. For example:

ritually washed

initiated people in/with water

- Use a term for a similar ritual that is already part of your culture. You may need to indicate that in this context it has a special connection with God. For example:

ceremonially/ritually wash

wash you to make you pure before God

give you an initiation bath

purify people with God's ceremonial bath

wash people in initiation water for God

- Use a term that is already accepted by the local churches. In some areas this term may have been borrowed from the national language or transliterated from Greek or English.

See baptize, Meaning 1, in the Glossary for more information.

Matthew 3:7

Section 3:1–12: John the Baptist taught people to repent and obey God

The story starting at 3:1 occurred about twenty-eight years after 2:23. Matthew did not tell what happened during those twenty-eight years. But he restarted the story at this time in Jesus' life because Jesus was ready to begin the work that God gave him to do. He began at the time God chose for him.

John the Baptist was the last prophet before Jesus. The story of how John was born is in Luke chapter 1. He was the prophet whom God said would come (3:3). John wore the kind of clothes prophets often wore (3:4). He baptized people who repented. John preached that Jesus would be greater than he was (3:11).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

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There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 1:1, Luke 3:1–18 and John 1:19–28.

Paragraph 3:7–10

In this paragraph, John the Baptist spoke to the Pharisees and Sadducees.

3:7a

But when John saw many of the Pharisees and Sadducees coming to his place of baptism,

- ¶ But when he saw many Pharisees and Sadducees coming to be baptized,
- ¶ When John saw many men from the Jewish religious groups called the Pharisees and Sadducees coming to receive baptism,

But when John saw: Verse 3:7 introduces John's reaction to the Pharisees and Sadducees. His reaction to them contrasts with his reaction to other people who came to be baptized. Some versions indicate this

contrast with the word But. Other versions have no conjunction here. For example:

When John saw (GNT)

the Pharisees: The word Pharisees refers to men who were members of a particular Jewish religious group. The Pharisees believed that it was necessary to strictly obey all the laws of the Old Testament. It was also very important to them to carefully obey many other religious laws that they added. They also said that other people must obey these laws.

The Pharisees along with the Sadducees were the two most influential religious groups of the time. There were many more Pharisees than Sadducees.

Some ways to translate Pharisees are:

- Transliterate the word Pharisees according to the sounds of your language and indicate that it refers to a group of people. For example:

Farisi members

Parise adherents

- Transliterate the word Pharisees and indicate that it refers to a group of people with certain beliefs. For example:

people belonging to the Farise religious sect/group

members of the Jewish group called the Farasi

You may also want to explain the word Pharisees in a footnote or glossary. A sample footnote is:

The Pharisees were a conservative Jewish religious group. They carefully followed the Old Testament laws and added other rules as well. They were the dominant religious group among the Jews and were highly respected by other Jews.

Sadducees: The word Sadducees refers to men who were members of another Jewish religious group. They believed that people must follow the laws in the Old Testament and not add other rules. They did not believe that God would bring people back to life again after they died (Matthew 22:23). They also did not believe that angels or spirits existed (Acts 23:8). They

also accepted some ideas held by the Greeks. Many Sadducees were priests.

The Sadducees along with the Pharisees were the two most influential religious groups of the time. Even though they were a much smaller group than the Pharisees, the Sadducees were wealthy and more politically important.

Here are some ways to translate Sadducees:

- Transliterate the word Sadducees according to the sounds of your language and indicate that it refers to a group of people. For example:

Sadusi members

Saduce adherents

- Transliterate the word Sadducees and indicate that it refers to a group of people with certain beliefs. For example:

people belonging to the Sadusi religious group

members of the Jewish group called the Saduce

You may also want to explain the word Sadducees in a footnote or glossary. Here is a sample footnote:

The Sadducees were another Jewish religious group. They claimed to follow only the laws in the Old Testament because they added no other rules. But they did not believe in angels or spirits or in the resurrection from the dead. They also accepted some Greek ideas. They were a small group but had much political power. They usually were wealthy.

coming to his place of baptism: There are two ways to interpret the Greek clause that the BSB literally translates as coming to his place of baptism:

1. They were coming for John to baptize them. For example:

coming to him to be baptized (GNT) (GNT, RSV, NJB, NASB, NLT96, REB, GW, CEV, JBP)

1. They were coming to where John was baptizing, but they were not necessarily coming so that they themselves could be baptized. For example:

coming to watch him baptize (NLT) (BSB, NIV, NCV, NET, ESV, KJV, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) as do the majority of the English versions. The parallel passage in Luke 3:7 also supports this interpretation.

See also baptize, Meaning 1, in the Glossary for information on the word baptize.

3:7b

he said to them, “You brood of vipers,

- he said to them, “You^(plur) children/family of poisonous snakes!
- he criticized them by saying, “You^(plur) are as evil/dangerous as poisonous snakes!

You brood of vipers: The word vipers refers to poisonous snakes. Another name for this type of snakes is “adders.” The phrase brood of vipers means “children/offspring of poisonous snakes.”

This phrase is a metaphor. In this metaphor, John compared the Pharisees and Sadducees to a brood of vipers. John used this metaphor to criticize the Pharisees and Sadducees.

The way that these men and snakes are similar is that both are evil and dangerous.

Here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Use a simile. In some languages, it may be necessary to make the point of comparison clear. For example:

You^(plur) are as evil/dangerous as a group of vipers!

- Translate the metaphor but leave the word brood untranslated. John was not saying that the people were young or childlike. So some English translations do not explicitly translate the word brood. For example:

You snakes (GNT)

- Translate the meaning without a simile or metaphor. For example:

You^(plur) dangerous hypocrites!

You^(plur) wicked people!

- Use a simile and explain the meaning. For example:

You evil people! You are like poisonous snakes.

If calling someone a poisonous snake is not an insult in your culture, you may also need to add a word to “John said to them.” For example:

John insulted/criticized them by saying

3:7c

who warned you to flee from the coming wrath?

- Who has warned you to run away from God’s coming judgment/punishment?
- God is angry at you and will punish you. Apparently someone warned you to try to escape! Ha!

who warned you to flee from the coming wrath?:

This is a rhetorical question. John asked this question to rebuke the Pharisees and Sadducees. He implied that the only reason that they wanted to be baptized was so that God would not punish them in the future. John also implied that they did not really intend to repent of their sins.

Here are some other ways to translate this rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Who warned you to run away from God’s coming punishment? (NCV)

Why are you here? Do you think that you can flee from the coming judgment?

- As a statement. For example:

Ah ha! So someone has told you to try to escape God’s wrath!

Translate this rebuke in a way that is natural in your language.

flee: The word flee means “run away from something” or “try to avoid/escape something.” For example:

run from (CEV)

run away from (NCV)

escape (GNT)

try to avoid

the coming wrath: The word wrath means “anger” or “the punishment that comes as a consequence of someone’s anger.” In this context, the phrase the coming wrath refers to the fact that God will judge and punish people because of their rebellious attitudes and their sins.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the coming judgment (CEV)

God’s coming punishment (NCV)

In some languages, it may be necessary to translate this phrase as a clause. It may also be necessary to change the order of the words in 3:7c. For example:

God is angry at you and will punish you. Who warned you to flee from that?

Matthew 3:8

Section 3:1–12: John the Baptist taught people to repent and obey God

The story starting at 3:1 occurred about twenty-eight years after 2:23. Matthew did not tell what happened during those twenty-eight years. But he restarted the story at this time in Jesus’ life because Jesus was ready to begin the work that God gave him to do. He began at the time God chose for him.

John the Baptist was the last prophet before Jesus. The story of how John was born is in Luke chapter 1. He was the prophet whom God said would come (3:3). John wore the kind of clothes prophets often wore (3:4). He baptized people who repented. John preached that Jesus would be greater than he was (3:11).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The work of John the Baptist/Baptizer

The work of John who baptized people

John the Baptizer preached repentance and submission to God’s rule

John the Baptizer prepared people to receive the Lord

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 1:1, Luke 3:1–18 and John 1:19–28.

Paragraph 3:7–10

In this paragraph, John the Baptist spoke to the Pharisees and Sadducees.

3:8**Produce fruit, then, in keeping with repentance.**

- Produce fruit that shows that you^(plur) have repented.
- Just as trees bear fruit and thus show what kind of trees they are, so you^(plur) must do the things that show that you have abandoned your sins.
- Do the acts/things that show that you^(plur) have really turned away from sin and turned to God.

In this verse John told the Pharisees and Sadducees what they should do in response to his rebuke in 3:7c. They should repent and show their repentance by thinking and acting the way God wanted them to.

then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as then connects this verse to 3:7. Many English versions do not translate this conjunction here.

Here are some other ways to translate this connection:

Therefore produce fruit that proves your repentance (NET)

In order to escape judgment, you should...

If you want to avoid God's punishment, you must...

Connect these two verses in a way that is natural in your language.

Produce fruit...in keeping with repentance: The phrase Produce fruit is a metaphor. A person's good moral conduct is compared to fruit. They are similar in that both are the result and evidence of something. Fruit is the result and evidence of the type of tree it came from. A holy life is the result and evidence of someone who has truly repented.

Here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Translate it literally. For example:

Produce fruit that shows that you have repented.

Repent and produce the fruit that shows it.

- Translate it as a simile and make the point of comparison explicit. For example:

Just as trees bear/produce fruit and show what kind of trees they are, so you must do the things/acts that show that you have really repented.

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

Behave in a way that shows that you have repented.

Prove by the way you live that you have really turned from your sins and turned to God. (NLT96)

in keeping with: The Greek word that the BSB translates as in keeping with is literally "worthy of."

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

that will show (GNT)

that proves (NET)

that accompanies

that corresponds to

that goes together with

repentance: The Greek word that the BSB translates as repentance means "a change of a person's mind, heart, or will." In the Bible it refers specifically to a change of mind and heart about sin and about God. The person who repents is sorry for his past sins. John was saying that these people should quit sinning and instead obey God.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

you have left/abandoned your sins

you have really turned from your sins and turned to God (NLT96)

you really have changed your hearts and lives (NCV)

The verb form of this word occurs in 3:2a.

Matthew 3:9

Section 3:1–12: John the Baptist taught people to repent and obey God

The story starting at 3:1 occurred about twenty-eight years after 2:23. Matthew did not tell what happened during those twenty-eight years. But he restarted the story at this time in Jesus' life because Jesus was ready to begin the work that God gave him to do. He began at the time God chose for him.

John the Baptist was the last prophet before Jesus. The story of how John was born is in Luke chapter 1. He was the prophet whom God said would come (3:3). John wore the kind of clothes prophets often wore (3:4). He baptized people who repented. John preached that Jesus would be greater than he was (3:11).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The work of John the Baptist/Baptizer

The work of John who baptized people

John the Baptizer preached repentance and submission to God's rule

John the Baptizer prepared people to receive the Lord

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 1:1, Luke 3:1–18 and John 1:19–28.

Paragraph 3:7–10

In this paragraph, John the Baptist spoke to the Pharisees and Sadducees.

3:9a–b

And do not presume to say to yourselves, 'We have Abraham as our father.' The people to whom John was speaking were descendants of Abraham. John did not want them to think that because they were descendants of Abraham, God would not punish or destroy them for their sins. God would judge them if they did not repent and obey him.

In some languages it may be necessary to make some of this information explicit. For example:

do not think, 'We have Abraham as our father and so God will never punish us.'

do not say to yourselves that nothing can happen to you because you are Abraham's children.

Don't just say to each other, 'We're safe, for we are descendants of Abraham.' That means nothing... (NLT)

Do not think that having Abraham as your father/ancestor will help you.

In other languages, it may be better to put this information in a footnote. For example:

God chose Abraham to begin a people who would be his chosen ones. Therefore, many of the Jewish people in the time of John felt that since they were God's chosen ones, they were sure of being considered righteous before God. They thought that God would never punish them at the final judgment.

3:9a

And do not presume to say to yourselves,

- And do not suppose that you^(plur) can say to yourselves,
- And do not let this thought enter your^(plur) minds:
- Do not think that

do not presume: The word presume means to "believe something to be true without proof," or to "assume." Here is another way to translate this word:

think (GNT)

to say to yourselves: There are two ways to interpret the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as say to yourselves:

1. It means say in your own minds. For example:

say within yourselves (KJV) (BSB, NIV, RSV, NJB, NASB, NCV NET, KJV, ESV, JBP, CEV)

1. It means tell one another. For example:

say to each other (NLT) (NLT; perhaps GW, REB, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). John was saying that the people should not think in this way.

Here are some other ways to translate 3:9a:

do not let this thought enter your minds

do not think that

do not trust/rely on the fact that

3:9b

'We have Abraham as our father.'

- 'Abraham is our forefather/ancestor.'
- 'Since we^(incl) are descendants of Abraham, God will not punish us.'
- Because Abraham is your^(plur) father/ancestor, and he will protect/help you.

We have Abraham as our father: This clause is a quote within a quote. John quoted what the people might say or think. In some languages, it will be more natural to translate this clause using "You" instead of We. For example:

^{9a}Do not think that you^(plur) can say to yourselves

^{9b}that you^(plur) have Abraham as your father.

that you belong to Abraham's family (CEV)

our father: The Greek word that the BSB translates as father can also refer to an ancestor. Abraham lived many generations before the Jews to whom John was speaking. In some languages, you may need to indicate specifically that Abraham was their ancestor. For example:

Abraham is our ancestor.

We are descendants of Abraham.

3:9c

For I tell you that out of these stones God can raise up children for Abraham.

- I assure you that God can make descendants for Abraham even out of these stones!
- Do not think like that because God is certainly able to change even these stones and make them into descendants of Abraham!

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For introduces the reason that the Jews should not depend on Abraham being their ancestor to save them. They should not expect the fact that they are

descendants of Abraham to save them, because God can create other children for Abraham.

In some languages it may be helpful to make this connection more explicit. For example:

You should not depend on that, because

I tell you: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as I tell you emphasizes the following statement. Here John used it to introduce a fact that was amazing but true. He implied that people should carefully listen to what he was about to say.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- Use a phrase before John's statement. For example:

I assure you that

I can guarantee that (GW)

- Use an emphatic word within John's statement. For example:

Out of these stones God can certainly raise up children for Abraham.

that out of these stones God can raise up children

for Abraham: This clause means "God can turn/make these stones into Abraham's descendants." John was saying that the Jewish people should not depend on the fact that Abraham was their ancestor to protect them from being punished or destroyed. God could replace them. If he wished, he could create other people to be Abraham's descendants. He could even create them from stones.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

God can turn these stones into children for Abraham. (CEV)

God can create children of Abraham from these very stones. (NLT)

God can give life to these stones and change them into descendants of Abraham to replace you.

Matthew 3:10

Section 3:1–12: John the Baptist taught people to repent and obey God

The story starting at 3:1 occurred about twenty-eight years after 2:23. Matthew did not tell what happened during those twenty-eight years. But he restarted the story at this time in Jesus' life because Jesus was ready to begin the work that God gave him to do. He began at the time God chose for him.

John the Baptist was the last prophet before Jesus. The story of how John was born is in Luke chapter 1. He was the prophet whom God said would come (3:3). John wore the kind of clothes prophets often wore (3:4). He baptized people who repented. John preached that Jesus would be greater than he was (3:11).

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The work of John the Baptist/Baptizer

The work of John who baptized people

John the Baptizer preached repentance and submission to God's rule

John the Baptizer prepared people to receive the Lord

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 1:1, Luke 3:1–18 and John 1:19–28.

Paragraph 3:7–10

In this paragraph, John the Baptist spoke to the Pharisees and Sadducees.

3:10

Verse 3:10 is a metaphor. Its literal meaning is that someone has aimed his axe at trees that do not produce good fruit. He is ready to cut down these trees and burn them.

John the Baptist was comparing the Pharisees and Sadducees to these trees. He compared their behavior to the fruit of the trees. He compared God to the man who is ready to chop down the trees that had not produced good fruit. John was warning them that just as trees that do not produce good fruit will be chopped down and burned, so they will be severely punished by God if they do not show good works.

Here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Translate it literally. For example:

There is an axe already at the base of the trees, and every tree that does not bear good fruit will be cut down and thrown into the fire.

The axe is already at the base of the trees. If a tree does not produce good fruit, it will be cut down and thrown into the fire. If you translate the metaphor literally, you may wish to explain the meaning in a footnote. A sample footnote is:

John was saying that just as a man is ready to chop down any tree that does not produce good fruit, so God was ready to punish people who do not do good deeds that show that they have repented.

- Translate the metaphor as a simile. For example:

God is like a man holding his axe at a tree trunk. If you do not show good works, you will be punished. This is like a tree that does not bear good fruit. He will cut it down and throw it into the fire.

Just as a man is holding his axe ready to chop down a tree that does not bear fruit and throw it into the fire, in the same way God is ready to punish you if you do not do good things/deeds.

- Translate the meaning without the metaphor. For example:

You will soon be punished eternally by God if you do not do good deeds

God is ready to judge/punish you who fail to do good deeds that show that you have repented

3:10a

The axe lies ready at the root of the trees,

- Right now there is an axe placed/held at the base/foot of the trees.
- You are like trees that have an axe pointed/aimed at their base.
- God is like a man who is holding his axe at a tree trunk and is ready to chop it down.

The axe lies ready at the root of the trees: This clause indicates that an axe is ready to cut down trees. It is implied that someone is holding the axe. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

someone has his axe pointed/aimed at the trunk of trees ready to cut them down

a man is holding an axe at the base/trunk of trees. He is ready to cut them down

the trees will soon be cut by a man with an axe

These words are a metaphor. For advice on translating this metaphor, see the examples above.

The axe lies ready: The Greek word that the BSB translates as ready emphasizes that the danger is immediate. The axe is right there, ready to strike. The tree is about to fall.

Here is another way to translate this word:

The ax is already (NIV)

Even now the axe is laid (ESV)

at the root of the trees: The phrase at the root of the trees refers to the part of the tree that is just above the ground, where an axe could cut it. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the base/trunk of the trees

at the bottom/foot of the trees

In some languages, it is not necessary to specify where the tree is cut down. For example:

to cut down the trees (NCV)

the trees: John did not name a specific type of trees, but it is clear from the context that he was referring to fruit trees such as fig trees.

3:10b

and every tree that does not produce good fruit will be cut down

- Any tree that does not yield/bear good fruit will be chopped down
- Therefore, if you^(plur) do not do good deeds, you will be destroyed/punished. This is like a tree that does not produce/bear good fruit. It will be cut down
- God will punish every person who does not do good deeds, just like a man will cut down every tree that does not bear good fruit,

The metaphor continues here in 3:10b. People who do not do good works are compared to trees that do not produce good fruit. God will punish these people. They are compared to trees that are cut down.

For translation advice, see the examples above in 3:10.

and every tree: The Greek conjunction that the BSB here translates as and introduces what happens as a result of the situation in 3:10a.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

so then

as a result

the result will be that

that does not produce good fruit: The Greek words that the BSB translates as produce...fruit also occurred in 3:8. You should translate these words here as you did there.

will be cut down: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as will be cut down is passive.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

- As a passive verb. For example:

is cut down (RSV)

- As an active verb. For example:

he will cut it down

3:10c

and thrown into the fire.

- and thrown into a fire.
- and thrown on a fire to burn.
- and he will put them into a fire and burn them.

The metaphor continues by describing how the tree is burned and so destroyed. This refers to being punished by God.

thrown into the fire: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as thrown is passive.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

- As a passive verb. For example:

thrown into the fire (RSV)

- As an active verb. For example:

and will throw it into a fire

then he will throw it on a fire and burn it.

Matthew 3:11

Section 3:1–12: John the Baptist taught people to repent and obey God

The story starting at 3:1 occurred about twenty-eight years after 2:23. Matthew did not tell what happened during those twenty-eight years. But he restarted the story at this time in Jesus' life because Jesus was ready to begin the work that God gave him to do. He began at the time God chose for him.

John the Baptist was the last prophet before Jesus. The story of how John was born is in Luke chapter 1. He was the prophet whom God said would come (3:3). John wore the kind of clothes prophets often wore (3:4). He baptized people who repented. John preached that Jesus would be greater than he was (3:11).

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There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 1:1, Luke 3:1–18 and John 1:19–28.

Paragraph 3:11–12

In 3:7–10, John had been speaking to the Pharisees and Sadducees. In this paragraph, he was apparently speaking to the entire crowd. He was baptizing only those who had changed their behavior from bad to good.

3:11a

I baptize you with water for repentance,

- ¶ “I baptize you^(plur) with water as a sign that you have repented.

- ¶ “I am baptizing people using water to show that they have turned away from their evil ways and turned to God.

I baptize you with water: The phrase I baptize you with water means “I baptize you using water.” When John baptized people, he did so using the water of the Jordan River.

If your word for “baptize” is a term like “wash/cleanse with water,” it may be redundant or unnatural to add the phrase with water. In such a case, you may need to say something like:

I wash/cleanse you with only water

I bathe you with water using this water

I: The word I is emphatic in Greek. In addition, a word in Greek follows the word I that indicates the first half of a contrast. The contrast is between what I (John) did and what he (Jesus) was to do. I, John, baptize with water, but he will baptize with the Holy Spirit and fire.

baptize: The word baptize also occurs in 3:6. You should translate it here as you did there.

you: John used the word you to speak in general about anybody whom he baptized. This included those listening to him, and many others besides. So in some languages, it may be more natural to translate the pronoun you more generally. For example:

I baptize people with water

I baptize with water (NLT)

for repentance: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as for repentance can also be translated as:

to show that you have repented (GNT)

as a sign of your repentance (JBP)

to show that your hearts and lives have changed (NCV)

See repentance in the note at 3:8 for more information about this word.

3:11b

but after me will come One more powerful than I,

- But someone is coming after me who is much greater than I am.
- But a person following/succeeding me will soon come. He is much superior to me.

but: There is a contrast between 3:11a and 3:11b–d. The contrast is between what John did and what Jesus will do. John baptized with water, but Jesus will baptize with the Holy Spirit and fire.

English versions indicate this contrast with the conjunction but.

after me: Here the phrase after me refers to being later in time. It does not refer to coming behind someone. John had already begun his work for God, and Jesus was about to begin his work.

Here are some other ways to translate the clause “after me will come One”:

the one who will come following/succeeding me

the person who will come later

One more powerful than I: The expression more powerful in this context means “having more authority,” or “greater.” For example:

he who is greater than I am (NCV)

One who is superior to me

One: Here the word One refers to the Christ/Messiah.

3:11c

whose sandals I am not worthy to carry.

- I am not even worthy to carry his sandals for him.
- He is so far superior to me that I am not even good enough to be his servant and carry his shoes.

whose sandals I am not worthy to carry: With this statement, John emphasized how much greater the Messiah was than he was. In New Testament times, it was the work of a slave to carry his master’s sandals. John was saying that the Messiah was so much greater than he was that he was not important enough even to be his slave.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- Keep the image of carrying the sandals. For example:

I am not worthy to carry his sandals. (NRSV)

- Keep the image and add a footnote to explain the meaning of carrying someone’s sandals. For example the CEV footnote says:

carry his sandals: This was one of the duties of a slave. (CEV)

- Translate the meaning of the image. For example:

I am not even worthy to be his slave. (NLT96)

sandal with thongs

sandals: The word sandals refers to a type of open shoe. The sandals people wore in that time were usually pieces of leather that made a shoe sole (bottom). This leather sole was tied on the foot with leather straps or thongs.

Here is another way to translate this word:

shoes

I am not worthy: The Greek word that the BSB translates as worthy means “qualified” or “adequate” to do something. John felt that he was not important enough to even act as Jesus’ slave. He felt he did not deserve the honor of serving him. He was emphasizing how great Jesus was.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I do not have enough worth/value

I am not good/important enough

it is not acceptable for me

In this context, the focus of worthy is on John’s status, not his character. Do not imply that John was a bad or evil person. Also do not imply that John was not physically able to do this task.

3:11d

He will baptize you with the Holy Spirit and with fire.

- He will baptize you^(plur) by means of the Holy Spirit and fire.
- As for his baptism, he will use the Holy Spirit and fire to baptize you.

In 3:11d, John told the people another way that the Messiah was superior to him: The Messiah’s baptism would be superior to his baptism. John’s baptism was

a physical baptism. He baptized with water. But the Messiah would baptize people with the Holy Spirit and fire.

He will baptize you with the Holy Spirit and with fire: Here the word baptize is used in a figurative sense. Scholars interpret this figurative meaning in two main ways:

1. Jesus would cleanse/purify God's people with the Holy Spirit and with fire.
2. Jesus would cleanse/purify God's people with the Holy Spirit and judge others with fire.

You should translate this so that people can interpret this part of the verse in either of these ways.

If possible, you should try to use the normal term in your language for "baptize," in order to keep the contrast between John's baptism and the Messiah's baptism. For example:

When he baptizes you, he will use the Holy Spirit and fire.

As for him, he will baptize you by means of the Holy Spirit and fire.

When he baptizes you, he will cause the Holy Spirit to initiate/purify you. He will also cause you to experience fire.

In some languages, it may not be possible to use the normal term for "baptize" with a figurative meaning. For example, it may not be possible to use the term "initiate with water" with the words Holy Spirit and fire. If that is the case in your language, you may need to use different verbs and express the contrast in different ways. For example:

In contrast, what he will do to you^(plur) is to initiate/purify you with the Holy Spirit. He will also cause you to experience fire.

See also baptize, Meaning 2, in the Glossary.

He: In Greek, the pronoun He is emphatic. It refers to the Messiah/Christ, and contrasts with the pronoun "I" in 3:11a.

with the Holy Spirit: The Greek word that the BSB translates as with indicates the means by which the Messiah will baptize people. He will baptize them with or "by using" the Holy Spirit. It does not mean that the Messiah along with the Holy Spirit will baptize people.

Holy Spirit: The phrase Holy Spirit refers to the Spirit of God. The Holy Spirit is God, together with God the Father and God the Son. The Holy Spirit is Spirit in the sense that he is a living being who does not have a physical body. He is Holy in the sense that he is God and unique from every other being. He is perfect in every way and is completely pure and sinless.

Here are some other ways to translate Holy Spirit:

Spirit/Breath of God

Holy/Sacred Spirit

Do not imply that the Holy Spirit is like the ghost of a dead person or that God has died.

Matthew 3:12

Section 3:1–12: John the Baptist taught people to repent and obey God

The story starting at 3:1 occurred about twenty-eight years after 2:23. Matthew did not tell what happened during those twenty-eight years. But he restarted the story at this time in Jesus' life because Jesus was ready to begin the work that God gave him to do. He began at the time God chose for him.

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There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 1:1, Luke 3:1–18 and John 1:19–28.

Paragraph 3:11–12

In 3:7–10, John had been speaking to the Pharisees and Sadducees. In this paragraph, he was apparently

speaking to the entire crowd. He was baptizing only those who had changed their behavior from bad to good.

3:12

Verse 3:12 is an extended metaphor. In this metaphor, John the Baptist compared the actions of Jesus the Messiah to the actions of a farmer at harvest time.

Here are some ways that the Messiah and a farmer are similar:

1. They are both ready to perform their tasks.
2. Their task is to separate what is good/useful from that which is not good/useful. Their task is then to store or destroy them accordingly.

In that culture, after a farmer harvested grain, he “threshed” it by rolling something heavy over the grain. This caused the seeds to separate from the stalk and the husks. He did this on an area of ground called the “threshing floor.”

Then the farmer “winnowed” the grain by using a large fork to throw the mixture of straw, seeds, and husks into the air. The wind would blow away the lightweight straw and husks so that only the grain seed was left. The farmer would then put the grain seed into bags. Finally, he would gather the straw and husks to burn them as fuel in the ovens where the women baked bread.

John used the images of a farmer threshing and winnowing grain to figuratively describe that the Messiah will separate those who repented from those who refused to repent. He used the image of a farmer storing grain to figuratively describe that the Messiah will receive those who repent into his kingdom. He used the image of a farmer burning chaff to figuratively describe that the Messiah will destroy those who do not repent.

In some languages, a literal translation of this metaphor may be difficult to understand.

Here are some other ways to translate the metaphor:

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

^{12a}He is like a farmer who already has his winnowing fork in his hand.

- Add a footnote to explain the metaphor. Here is a sample footnote:

Verse 3:12 compares Jesus to a farmer. A farmer separates the grain from the chaff. He stores the grain and burns the chaff. When Jesus comes, he

will separate the people who have truly repented from those who have not repented. He will receive all those who have repented into his kingdom, but he will destroy those who have not repented.

3:12a

His winnowing fork is in His hand

- He is ready with his winnowing fork in his hand,
- He is like a farmer who is already holding his tool for separating grain from the husks and straw.
- He is ready to separate people who have repented from the others, like a farmer who separates the seed from the husks and straw.

His winnowing fork is in His hand: This phrase begins the extended metaphor which compares the Messiah to a farmer. It means “he is holding a winnowing fork.” It indicates that the Messiah is ready to act.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

He has picked up his winnowing fork and is ready

He is like a farmer who is already holding his winnowing fork.

winnowing fork: The Greek word that the BSB translates as winnowing fork refers to a big shovel-like tool that looked something like a fork. People used it to throw the mixture of seeds, chaff, and straw into the air so that the wind would separate the good grain from the useless chaff.

The winnowing fork represents the Messiah’s ability and authority to separate those who repented from those who refused to repent.

Here are some other ways to translate the term winnowing fork:

- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

The tool for separating the seed/grain from the chaff is in his hand.

- Describe the function. For example:

He will come ready to clean the grain (NCV)

He is ready to separate the good grain from the chaff.

man holding a winnowing fork

3:12b**to clear His threshing floor**

- and he will thoroughly clean/clear his threshing floor
- He will thresh and winnow the grain, then he will clear away the area where the grain was threshed.
- After he does that, he will clear away the grain and the chaff.

to clear His threshing floor: There are two ways to interpret the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as to clear His threshing floor:

1. It means to clear/clean the threshing floor. This refers to what is done after the grain has been threshed. For example:

he will clean out his threshing floor (NET) (BSB, NIV, RSV, REB, KJV, NASB, NJB, NET, GW, NLT, ESV)

1. It means to thresh out all the grain. For example:

he is ready to separate the wheat from the husks. (CEV) (GNT, CEV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The farmer would clear or clean his threshing floor by putting the good grain in the barn and burning the chaff. However, since the farmer first threshed the grain before clearing the threshing floor, some languages may need to include both steps. So you may need to include parts of both interpretations.

threshing floor: A threshing floor is a flat area outdoors where the farmer “threshes” the grain. He “threshes” it by rolling something heavy over the grain. This causes the seeds to separate from the stalk and the husks. The threshing floor is also the area where the grain is winnowed.

Here are some other ways to translate the phrase threshing floor:

place on the ground for separating grain from the chaff

area where the seed is beaten/removed from the chaff

3:12c**and to gather His wheat into the barn;**

- by putting his grain in the storehouse,
- He will put his grain in a granary.

to gather His wheat into the barn: The farmer put the good seed or grain in a safe place where he kept his grain. This represents the Messiah saving people who believe in him.

wheat: The word wheat refers to a certain type of grain plant and to the grain that the plant produces. Wheat plants have a stalk. On top of the stalk there are clusters of seeds, which are the wheat grains.

head of a wheat plant

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

- Use a more general term. For example:

grain (NCV)

- Use a different type of grain that is grown in your area and is similar to wheat. For example:

rice

millet

barn: The Greek word that the BSB translates as barn refers to a storage area for grain. Here are some other ways to translate this word:

granary (RSV)

storehouse (NET)

3:12d**but He will burn up the chaff with unquenchable fire.”**

- and by burning the chaff in a fire that cannot be put out.”
- But he will burn the chaff in a fire that never goes out.”

but: There is a contrast between 3:12b–c and 3:12d. The contrast is between what will happen to the wheat (3:12c), which will be saved, and the chaff (3:12d), which will be burned. Many English versions indicate this contrast by translating the Greek conjunction here with the English conjunction “But.”

He will burn up the chaff: The chaff was the husk and the stalk (or straw). People burned all of this because it was not good to eat. This represents the Messiah punishing those who refused to repent.

unquenchable fire: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as unquenchable fire refers to a fire that

people cannot put out. It is also a fire that never stops burning.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

a fire that never goes out (GNT)

never ending fire (NLT)

Matthew 3:13

Section 3:13–17: John baptized Jesus

In this section, Jesus came to John the Baptist and asked John to baptize him. John thought that the man who was greater (Jesus) should baptize the man who was not as great (John). This is why John at first did not think that it was right for him to baptize Jesus. But Jesus said that it was the right thing at that time. So John agreed to do it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Baptism of Jesus (NIV)

Jesus is Baptized by John (NCV)

John baptizes Jesus (GW)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 1:9–11 and Luke 3:21–22.

3:13a

At that time Jesus came from Galilee to the Jordan

- ¶ Then Jesus went from Galilee to the Jordan River
- ¶ At that time, Jesus left/exited the district of Galilee and went to the Jordan River.

At that time: The events in this paragraph happened after John talked to the crowds in 3:11–12.

Here are some other ways to connect this paragraph to the previous one:

Then (ESV)

Shortly after that

Next

Jesus came from Galilee to the Jordan: This clause indicates that Jesus left his home area in the district of Galilee and went to the Jordan River. In some

languages, it may be more natural to translate the verb came as “went” or “left.” Matthew uses the verb that the BSB here translates as “came” to introduce main characters into the story. (See 2:1 (the magi), 3:1 (John the Baptist), and 3:13 (Jesus as an adult).) The NJB translates this unique verb as: “Then Jesus appeared: he came from Galilee to the Jordan.” In some languages, it may be necessary to use natural devices to introduce Jesus here. However, since Jesus as a baby has already been mentioned in chapters 1–2, it may not be necessary to introduce him again here in any special way. For example:

Then Jesus went from Galilee to the Jordan River (NLT)

Jesus left Galilee and went to the Jordan River (CEV)

Galilee: Galilee was the name of a district or area in the north part of Israel.

Here are some other ways to translate this name:

the district of Galilee

the region of Galilee

to the Jordan: The phrase the Jordan refers to the Jordan River. For example:

the Jordan River (NLT)

3:13b

to be baptized by John.

- in order to be baptized by John.
- He went there so that John would baptize him.

to be baptized by John: The purpose of Jesus’ coming was for John to baptize him.

Here are some other ways to indicate this purpose:

in order to be baptized by John

for the purpose of being baptized by John

The Greek verb that the BSB translates as to be baptized is passive. Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

- As a passive verb. For example:

to be baptized by him (RSV)

- As an active verb. For example:

so that John would baptize him

baptized: See how you translated this word in 3:6.

Matthew 3:14

Section 3:13–17: John baptized Jesus

In this section, Jesus came to John the Baptist and asked John to baptize him. John thought that the man who was greater (Jesus) should baptize the man who was not as great (John). This is why John at first did not think that it was right for him to baptize Jesus. But Jesus said that it was the right thing at that time. So John agreed to do it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Baptism of Jesus (NIV)

Jesus is Baptized by John (NCV)

John baptizes Jesus (GW)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 1:9–11 and Luke 3:21–22.

3:14a

But John tried to prevent Him, saying,

- But John refused. He said,
- But John did not want to baptize Jesus. He said to him,

But: There is a contrast between 3:13b and 3:14a. The contrast is between what Jesus wanted and what John wanted. Many English versions indicate this contrast by translating the Greek conjunction here with the English conjunction “But.”

John tried to prevent Him: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as tried to prevent refers to attempting to stop something from happening. John did not want to baptize Jesus because he felt unworthy.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

John tried to make him change his mind (GNT)

John did not want/agree to do it

John refused

saying: The verb saying introduces a direct quote. For examples of how this can be translated with an indirect quotation, see the General Comment following the note on 3:14c.

3:14b

“I need to be baptized by You,

- “I am the one who needs to be baptized by you!
- “It is you who should baptize me!

I need to be baptized by You: John thought that Jesus should baptize him. He understood that Jesus was the Messiah/Christ and was much greater than he.

The pronouns I and You are emphasized in the Greek. If you have a way to emphasize these pronouns in a natural way, you should do so. Some examples are below.

The verb baptized is passive. Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

- As a passive verb. For example:

I ought to be baptized by you (CEV)

I am the one who needs to be baptized by you (NLT)

- As an active verb. For example:

I need you to baptize me.

On the contrary you are the one who ought to baptize me.

It is I who need baptism from you

You: The pronoun You is singular and refers to Jesus.

3:14c

and do You come to me?”

- Why do you come to me to be baptized?” (NCV)
- I am surprised that you are coming to me.”
- You should not come to me to be baptized!”

do You come to me?: This is a rhetorical question. It expresses both surprise and protest. John was surprised that Jesus would ask him to baptize him, and he tried to prevent it.

Here are some other ways to translate this surprise and protest:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

What? You are coming to me to be baptized?

Why do you come to me for baptism?

- As a statement. For example:

You should not be coming to me to get baptized!

No, no, no! It is not proper that you come to me to baptize you!

Translate this surprise and protest in a way that is natural in your language.

You...me: As in the previous clause (3:14b), the Greek words for the pronouns You and me in this clause are emphatic. In your language, you will want to translate them here in a way that is consistent with 3:14b.

General Comment on 3:14b–c

In some languages, it will be more natural to put the rhetorical question in 3:14c before 3:14b. For example:

^{14c} What? You are coming to me to be baptized?

^{14b} It is I who should be baptized by you!

General Comment on 3:14a–c

Verse 3:14 is a direct quotation. In some languages, it is more natural to translate this as an indirect quotation. For example:

^{14a} But John tried to deter him by saying that ^{14b} he needed to be baptized by Jesus. ^{14c} He told him that he was surprised that Jesus had come to him for baptism.

Matthew 3:15

Section 3:13–17: John baptized Jesus

In this section, Jesus came to John the Baptist and asked John to baptize him. John thought that the man who was greater (Jesus) should baptize the man who was not as great (John). This is why John at first did not think that it was right for him to baptize Jesus. But Jesus said that it was the right thing at that time. So John agreed to do it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Baptism of Jesus (NIV)

Jesus is Baptized by John (NCV)

John baptizes Jesus (GW)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 1:9–11 and Luke 3:21–22.

3:15a

“Let it be so now,” Jesus replied.

- ¶ But Jesus answered, “Allow/permit it at this time,
- ¶ But Jesus said, “On this occasion, let us^(dual/incl) do it like this. You^(sing) will baptize me,

There is a contrast between 3:14 and 3:15. The contrast is between John trying to prevent the baptism and Jesus telling him to allow it. Some English versions show this contrast with the conjunction “But” (ESV). However, the BSB and some other English versions do not explicitly show the contrast.

Let it be so now: In this context, the Greek word that the BSB translates as Let it be so refers to permitting something to happen. John had tried to prevent the baptism (3:14a). But Jesus told him to allow it.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Permit it at this time (NASB)

For now this is how it should be (CEV)

now: In this context, the word now indicates that that particular moment in time was the right time for John to baptize Jesus.

Here is another way to translate this word:

at this time (NASB)

Jesus replied: The Greek word that the BSB translates as replied sometimes introduces an answer to a question. In this passage, it introduces a response to a rhetorical question, not a real question.

The BSB places the words Jesus replied at the end of what Jesus said. This is good English style. However, in some languages, it may be more natural to follow the Greek and place these words at the beginning of the sentence. For example:

But Jesus answered him... (ESV)

If you translated 3:14c as a question, you may want to use a word here meaning “answered.” But if you translated it as a statement, you may need to use a different word meaning something like “said” or “stated.”

3:15b

“It is fitting for us to fulfill all righteousness in this way.”

- because it is proper/correct for us^(dual/incl) to do this baptism in order to do/accomplish God’s will.”
- because this baptism is the right thing for us^(dual/incl) to do in order to do the righteous/good things that God wants us to do.”

The Greek of 3:15b begins with a conjunction that is often translated as “for.” It introduces the basis for Jesus’ command in 3:15a. The BSB omits this conjunction. Here is another way to translate this conjunction:

because (CEV)

In some languages, it will be more natural to put 3:15b before 3:15a. For example:

^{15b}It is proper for us to do this in order to do what God wants. ^{15a}So for now, let it be so.

It is fitting for us: The word fitting refers to something being morally right or correct. It was proper or correct for John to baptize Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

it is right for us (NET)

we must do (CEV)

it is proper for us (NIV)

to fulfill all righteousness: The phrase to fulfill all righteousness indicates that when John baptized Jesus, they would accomplish God’s will. The word righteousness refers here to doing the right/good things that God requires. It was God’s will at that moment for John to baptize Jesus, and it was God’s will for Jesus to undergo John’s baptism.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

do all that God requires (GNT)

to do the right/good things that God wants

This phrase probably refers only to the baptism. It does not refer to all the things that God wanted Jesus to do. Your translation should not indicate a general reference for all time.

in this way: The Greek word that the BSB translates as in this way can also be translated as “thus” or “this.” For example:

it is proper for us to do this (NIV)

This is the proper way to do everything that God requires of us. (GW)

General Comment on 3:15a–b

Verse 3:15a–b is a direct quote. In some languages, it is more natural to translate this as an indirect quote. For example:

^{15a}But Jesus told him to allow it at that time
^{15b}because it was proper for them to do it in order to do what God wanted them to do.

3:15c

Then John permitted Him.

- Then John agreed/accepted.
- When John heard this, he agreed to baptize Jesus.

Then John permitted Him: The word permitted indicates that John agreed or accepted. For example:

So John agreed (GNT)

It is implied that John agreed to baptize Jesus. In some languages, it may be natural to make this information explicit. For example:

So John agreed to baptize Jesus (NCV)

So John accepted to baptize Jesus

Matthew 3:16

Section 3:13–17: John baptized Jesus

In this section, Jesus came to John the Baptist and asked John to baptize him. John thought that the man who was greater (Jesus) should baptize the man who was not as great (John). This is why John at first did not think that it was right for him to baptize Jesus. But Jesus said that it was the right thing at that time. So John agreed to do it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Baptism of Jesus (NIV)

Jesus is Baptized by John (NCV)

John baptizes Jesus (GW)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 1:9–11 and Luke 3:21–22.

3:16a

As soon as Jesus was baptized, He went up out of the water.

- ¶ Jesus was baptized, and right away he came up out of the water.
- ¶ After John baptized him, Jesus immediately left/exited the water/river.

As soon as: The phrase As soon as here means “immediately” or “without waiting.”

Here are some ways to connect this phrase to the rest of the sentence:

- Connect it to the word “baptized.” For example:

And when Jesus was baptized (ESV)

- Connect it to the verb “went up.” For example:

he went up immediately from the water (RSV)

Jesus was baptized: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as was baptized is passive. Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

- As a passive verb. For example:

After Jesus was baptized (GW)

- As an active verb. For example:

John baptized Jesus

It is clear from the context that John baptized Jesus. It is not clear what the form of baptism was like. You should translate this word in the same way that you did previously in this chapter (3:6b, 3:11, 3:13, and 3:14).

He went up out of the water: The Greek word that the BSB translates as went up can also mean “came up” (as in the GNT). In this context, it means that

“Jesus came out of the river.” Jesus had stepped down into the river in order to be baptized. This word indicates that he returned to the edge of the river and stepped onto dry land.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he walked out of the water

he exited the river

3:16b

Suddenly the heavens were opened,

- Suddenly, heaven opened,
- Unexpectedly, God opened the sky,

Suddenly: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Suddenly is often translated as “behold.” It literally means “look” or “see.” This word brings attention to the words that follow. This word is often used when something unexpected and extraordinary happens. In this passage, heaven opened and the Holy Spirit descended upon Jesus.

If you have a term that gets the attention of people, you may want to use it here. Here are some English examples:

and behold (ESV)

Unexpectedly

Look!

the heavens were opened: There is a textual issue in this verse. In some Greek manuscripts, this clause includes a Greek word that means “to him.”

1. Many Greek manuscripts do not have this Greek word, and most English versions do not translate this word. For example:

the heavens were opened (RSV) (BSB, RSV, NJB, NIV, NASB, CEV, GW, NET, NLT, REB, NCV, JBP)

1. Some Greek manuscripts have the word that can be translated “to him” after “heaven was opened.” For example:

Then heaven was opened to him (GNT) (GNT, KJV, ESV, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) as the majority of English versions do.

heavens: The word that the BSB translates as heavens can have two different meanings, depending on the context:

1. the place where God lives
2. the sky: the place where the sun, moon, and stars can be seen

In the New Testament, God often showed supernatural signs from the sky. Some signs were a voice, fire, and a bright light. In this verse, either the meaning “heaven” or “sky” would fit the context: The Holy Spirit came down like a dove and God’s voice came from heaven or the sky.

were opened: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as were opened is passive. Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

- As a passive verb. For example:

heaven was opened (GNT)

- As an active verb. For example:

God opened heaven

This phrase illustrates heaven opening like a door or curtain is opened.

3:16c

and He saw the Spirit of God descending like a dove

- and he saw God’s Spirit come down like a dove
- and Jesus saw the Spirit of God in the form of a dove/ pigeon. It descended toward him

He saw: The pronoun He refers to Jesus here.

the Spirit of God: The Spirit of God refers to the Holy Spirit.

See the note on “the Holy Spirit” at 1:18d, and consider how you translated 1:18.

descending like a dove: There are two ways to interpret the phrase that the BSB translates as descending like a dove:

1. The Spirit of God took the bodily form of a dove and came down on Jesus.
2. The Spirit of God came down upon Jesus in the same way that a dove would fly down. God’s Spirit took some bodily form, but it was not necessarily the form of a dove.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

coming down in the form of a dove

flying down in the shape of a dove

dove: A dove is a small, gentle bird. It is like a pigeon. It symbolized something that is gentle and peaceful. There are at least two ways to translate this word:

- If doves or some similar birds such as pigeons are known in your areas and are considered good birds or a good sign, you can use your word for a dove or pigeon.
- If doves are unknown or if they are considered a bad sign, use the general name for “bird.”

3:16d

and resting on Him.

- and land/sit on him.
- and came and sat on him.

and resting on Him: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as and resting on Him is literally “coming upon him.” The text does not indicate exactly where on Jesus the dove landed. So you should not specify that it was on his head or his shoulder.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

coming down on him (NJB)

landing on him

descending to him

sat/perched on him

Matthew 3:17

Section 3:13–17: John baptized Jesus

In this section, Jesus came to John the Baptist and asked John to baptize him. John thought that the man who was greater (Jesus) should baptize the man who was not as great (John). This is why John at first did not think that it was right for him to baptize Jesus. But Jesus said that it was the right thing at that time. So John agreed to do it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Baptism of Jesus (NIV)

Jesus is Baptized by John (NCV)

John baptizes Jesus (GW)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 1:9–11 and Luke 3:21–22.

3:17a

And a voice from heaven said,

- Then suddenly a voice spoke from heaven; it said:
- Also unexpectedly, God spoke from heaven. He said:

The Greek of 3:17a begins with a word that is often translated as “behold.” It is the same Greek word that occurs in 3:16b. This word indicates another unexpected and extraordinary event: a voice from heaven spoke. The BSB omits this word.

Here are some ways to translate this word:

behold (ESV)

Suddenly

And just as unexpectedly

In some languages, it is not necessary to translate this word.

a voice from heaven said: The word voice is used figuratively here. It stands for the words that were spoken or the person who spoke the words. In this case, the voice was the voice of God. God spoke from heaven. The words that follow in 3:17b are what God said about Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Someone spoke from heaven and said

God spoke from heaven and said

God who was in heaven spoke. He said

heaven: Here the word heaven refers to the place where God lives. See how you translated this word in 3:2.

3:17b

“This is My beloved Son, in whom I am well pleased!”

- “This is my dearly loved Son. I am very pleased with him.”
- “This person is my Son. I love him and am very happy with him.”

This is My beloved Son: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as This is My beloved Son is literally “This is my son the beloved.” The words “the beloved” indicate here that Jesus was God the Father’s one and only dear son. This phrase does not imply that God has other sons whom he did not love.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

This is my own dear Son (GNT)

This is my dearly-loved Son (JBP)

This person is my son. I love him.

My...Son: The phrase My...Son describes the relationship that Jesus had with God the Father. “The Son of God” or “God’s Son” is a title that was often used to refer to a savior who would be a descendant of King David. God would send this savior to rescue his people. This person was often referred to as the “Messiah” or “Christ.”

The title “the Son of God” also indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God. The relationship between God the Father and Jesus, his Son, is similar in some way to the relationship between human fathers and sons. God the Father does not have a physical body. He did not have a sexual relationship with Mary that resulted in her becoming pregnant and giving birth to Jesus. The Son of God existed eternally as the Son with his Father.

In areas where people do not understand the title “the Son of God” in this way, you may want to include a footnote that explains the correct meaning. Here is a suggested footnote:

This title refers to Jesus. It indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God. It does not mean that God the Father had a sexual relationship with Mary that resulted in her becoming pregnant and giving birth to Jesus. Mary became pregnant with Jesus in a miraculous way by the Holy Spirit of God.

In some languages, it is natural to speak of a son as a “child,” without specifying male or female. If that

is true in your language, you may use a more general term, such as:

my Child
A translation of the title “the Son of God” must include a familial term such as “son” or “child.” Translations such as “the man who is God,” “the divine man,” or “the God man” are not acceptable, since they do not retain familial language. Examples of acceptable translation options include “the Son who comes from God,” and “the divine/unique/eternal Son of God.”

Other verses will usually make clear that Jesus was a male child. If you use a phrase such as “my male child,” be sure that it does not imply that God had another child who was female.

in whom I am well pleased!: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as I am well pleased means, “I am delighted” or “I am very pleased/satisfied.” Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

He makes me very happy/pleased.

in him I take great delight (NET)

he makes my heart glad

Matthew 4:1

Section 4:1–11: The devil tempted Jesus

In this section, God allowed Satan to tempt Jesus so that Jesus could show that he always obeyed his Father. The children of Israel had failed to obey God during their forty years in the wilderness. But Jesus, as the Messiah, proved his obedience to God during his forty days of fasting and temptation in the wilderness. He “passed” this test and demonstrated that he truly was the “Son of God.”

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The temptation of Jesus

The devil tried to make Jesus sin

Jesus was tempted by the devil

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 4:1–11, and a shorter version occurs in Mark 1:12–13.

4:1a

Then Jesus was led by the Spirit into the wilderness

- ¶ Then Jesus was led/guided by the Holy Spirit up into the wilderness
- ¶ Soon afterward, the Spirit of God led/took Jesus into an area where no one lived.

Then: The conjunction Then introduces a new story. It also indicates that 4:1 happened after 3:17. The Greek text does not indicate how much time passed between these two stories. Use a general term that indicates that the events in this section happened shortly after the events in chapter 3.

Here is another way to translate this conjunction:

Soon afterward

Jesus was led by the Spirit: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as was led means to “guide or direct someone from a lower to a higher elevation.” Here the Holy Spirit led Jesus from the low area of the Jordan River to a higher elevation where the wilderness was located. The NIV translates this phrase as:

Jesus was led up by the Spirit

In some languages, it is important to say whether people go up or down when they walk somewhere. In other languages, this will be unusual or may be confusing. If it is not natural in your language, you may use a more general expression as the BSB and some English versions do. For example:

Then Jesus was led by the Spirit into the wilderness (NET)

The verb was led is passive.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

- As a passive verb. For example:

Jesus was led by the Spirit

Jesus was guided by the Spirit

- As an active verb. For example:

the Spirit led Jesus (NCV)

the Spirit directed Jesus

the Spirit went with Jesus

the Spirit: The phrase the Spirit refers to the Holy Spirit. This is the same Spirit as the “Spirit of God” (in 3:16) and “Holy Spirit” (in 1:18).

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

God’s Spirit

the Spirit from God

Spirit belonging to God

Sacred/Pure Spirit

See the note on 1:18d for more information.

into the wilderness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as wilderness refers to a wild, desolate area where few people lived. It was often a dry area, but it was not just barren sand and rock. Some wild grasses and bushes grew there. Some English versions translate this word as “desert.” But the focus here is that few people lived there, not that it was dry.

Some languages have a special word to refer to such an area, such as “the bush” (Africa) or “steppes” (Asia). It may be appropriate to use such a word here.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

desert (NIV)

empty land

region where no one lives

This same word occurs in 3:1b.

4:1b

to be tempted by the devil.

- to be tempted/enticed to sin by the devil.
- There Satan tried to make him sin.

to be tempted by the devil: The clause to be tempted by the devil indicates the purpose for which the Spirit led Jesus into the desert. The Spirit led Jesus into the desert in order that he would be tempted by the devil.

This clause is also passive. Here are some other ways to translate this:

- As a passive clause. For example:

in order to be tempted by the devil

- As an active clause. For example:

so that the devil could tempt him

for the devil to tempt him

tempted: The Greek word that the BSB translates as tempted means “tried to cause someone to sin.” The devil tried to make Jesus sin by telling him that obeying his advice would have good results. He lied to Jesus to encourage him to do what was wrong.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

encouraged/enticed to do wrong

tried to get Jesus to disobey God

test (CEV)

the devil: The phrase the devil refers to the chief of all evil spirits. One of his names is Satan. (In Hebrew this name means “enemy.”) He is the enemy of God and God’s people.

Here are some other ways to translate the devil:

- Use a local name or idiom that refers to the chief of all demons. Some languages say something like:

the left-handed one

the barking one

- Transliterate the term for “devil” or “Satan” in the national language. Make sure it sounds natural in your language. For example:

debili

Shatani

- Use a descriptive word or phrase. For example:

chief/boss of the evil spirits

main enemy of God

Try to use a term that will be acceptable to churches in the area. It is suggested that you also add a footnote or glossary entry that further explains who the devil is. For example:

The devil is the leader of all evil spirits/demons. He had previously been an angel in heaven, but he rebelled against God. God expelled him from heaven, and now he tempts people on earth. Here are other names for Satan that are used in the Bible: “Beelzebul,” “the Evil One,” “the Enemy,” and “the Tempter.”

Matthew 4:2

Section 4:1–11: The devil tempted Jesus

In this section, God allowed Satan to tempt Jesus so that Jesus could show that he always obeyed his Father. The children of Israel had failed to obey God during their forty years in the wilderness. But Jesus, as the Messiah, proved his obedience to God during his forty days of fasting and temptation in the wilderness. He “passed” this test and demonstrated that he truly was the “Son of God.”

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The temptation of Jesus

The devil tried to make Jesus sin

Jesus was tempted by the devil

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 4:1–11, and a shorter version occurs in Mark 1:12–13.

4:2

After fasting forty days and forty nights, He was hungry.

- After Jesus ate nothing for forty days and nights, he was hungry.
- Jesus stayed there forty days and nights without food/eating, so/and he became very hungry.

After fasting forty days and forty nights: The word fasting means choosing not to eat food for a certain period of time. This is done for religious or spiritual reasons.

If fasting for religious reasons is not a familiar idea in your language, you can translate this word with a descriptive phrase. For example:

spending forty days and nights without food (GNT)

Jesus ate nothing for forty days and nights (NCV)

Jesus fasted the entire forty days. Matthew does not say whether or not Jesus drank anything during this time. In your translation, avoid using a word that makes drinking explicit.

He was hungry: Jesus did not eat for forty days, so he was hungrier than someone who had not eaten one or two meals. Jesus’ hunger was intense. In some languages, it may be more natural to make this fact explicit. For example:

he was very hungry (CEV)

he was famished (NET)

Matthew 4:3

Section 4:1–11: The devil tempted Jesus

In this section, God allowed Satan to tempt Jesus so that Jesus could show that he always obeyed his Father. The children of Israel had failed to obey God during their forty years in the wilderness. But Jesus, as the Messiah, proved his obedience to God during his forty days of fasting and temptation in the wilderness. He “passed” this test and demonstrated that he truly was the “Son of God.”

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The temptation of Jesus

The devil tried to make Jesus sin

Jesus was tempted by the devil

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 4:1–11, and a shorter version occurs in Mark 1:12–13.

Paragraph 4:3–4

In this paragraph, Matthew reported the first way that the devil tempted Jesus. The devil tempted Jesus to perform a miracle by turning stones into bread to feed himself. The devil wanted Jesus to disobey God by not trusting God. If Jesus had turned the stones into bread at this time when he was fasting, it would have proved that Jesus did not trust his Father to take care of him and meet his most basic needs.

4:3a**The tempter came to Him and said,**

- ¶ Then the tempter came to him and said,
- ¶ After this, the devil, the one who tempts, came to him/Jesus and said,
- ¶ After that time, Satan, the one who tries to make people sin, came to Jesus and said to him that

The Greek of 4:3 begins with a word that is often translated as “And” (ESV). This word indicates that the events in this paragraph occur after the events in 4:1–2. However, the BSB omits this word. In some languages, it may be natural to begin this paragraph with a time word or phrase. For example:

Then (CEV)

After this

The tempter: The phrase The tempter refers to the devil (4:1b). Tempting people is one of his main activities. He is always trying to make people sin.

There are at least three ways to translate this phrase:

- Literally. For example:

The tempter

The one who tempts If you choose this option, you may want to include a footnote indicating that The tempter refers to the devil. For example:

The phrase The tempter refers to the devil, the chief of demons. Tempting people is one of his main activities. He is always trying to make people sin.

- Literally, but with a word or phrase that makes clear that The tempter is “the devil.” For example:

The tempter (the devil)

The devil, the one who tries to make people sin

- Translate as your term for “the devil.” For example:

the devil (CEV)

Satan

The chief of demons

4:3b**“If You are the Son of God,**

- “If you really/truly are the Son of God,
- “If it is true that you are God’s Son,
- he should prove that he was the child of God

If You are the Son of God: Satan said this clause to challenge Jesus to prove that he really was the Son of God. Satan knew that Jesus was the Son of God. He was not expressing doubt here. He was saying this to tempt Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

If you really are the Son of God (JBP)

If it’s true that you are the Son of God

Prove that you are the Son of God

the Son of God: The phrase the Son of God is a title for Jesus. This title indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God. It also indicates that the relationship between God the Father and Jesus, his Son, is similar in some way to the relationship between human fathers and sons. God the Father does not have a physical body. He did not have a sexual relationship that resulted in Mary becoming pregnant and giving birth to Jesus.

For further information, see the note on “My...Son” at 3:17b.

4:3c**tell these stones to become bread.”**

- order these stones to turn into loaves of bread.”
- command these stones to become bread to eat!”
- by speaking and making some stones there become food, then eat it. Helovesme2day

tell these stones to become bread: There is some implied information here. The devil wanted Jesus not simply to command the stones to become bread, but actually to turn them into bread. Then he wanted Jesus to eat the bread.

Here are some other ways to make this information explicit:

Speak to these stones and cause them to become bread for you.

change these stones into loaves of bread that you can eat.

tell: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as tell is the same verb that usually means “say” or “speak/tell.” Here it is used in the sense of “order” or “command.”

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

order (GNT)

command (ESV)

these stones: The phrase these stones probably refers to some stones that were near Jesus. The devil probably pointed at some of the stones, or perhaps picked up some of them, as he was talking with Jesus.

bread: The Greek word that the BSB translates as bread refers to pieces or units of bread. Loaves of bread were baked in a round shape and were flat.

In Jesus’ time, bread was the main food of the Jewish people. The bread that the Jews ate was made of wheat or barley flour.

If you do not already have a word for bread in your language, here are some other ways to translate this word:

- Use a generic term such as “food.” For example:

food

something to eat

that which you may eat

- Borrow the word for bread from the national language or major language in your area.

Matthew 4:4

Section 4:1–11: The devil tempted Jesus

In this section, God allowed Satan to tempt Jesus so that Jesus could show that he always obeyed his Father. The children of Israel had failed to obey God during their forty years in the wilderness. But Jesus, as the Messiah, proved his obedience to God during his forty days of fasting and temptation in the wilderness. He “passed” this test and demonstrated that he truly was the “Son of God.”

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The temptation of Jesus

The devil tried to make Jesus sin

Jesus was tempted by the devil

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 4:1–11, and a shorter version occurs in Mark 1:12–13.

Paragraph 4:3–4

In this paragraph, Matthew reported the first way that the devil tempted Jesus. The devil tempted Jesus to perform a miracle by turning stones into bread to feed himself. The devil wanted Jesus to disobey God by not trusting God. If Jesus had turned the stones into bread at this time when he was fasting, it would have proved that Jesus did not trust his Father to take care of him and meet his most basic needs.

4:4a

But Jesus answered, “It is written:

- But Jesus responded, “It is written in the Scriptures,
- However Jesus said to the devil, “The Scriptures say,
- But instead Jesus refused. He said that God’s book says that

But: There is a contrast between 4:3 and 4:4. The contrast is between the devil’s desire and Jesus’ desire. Jesus refused to do what the devil wanted him to do. Some English versions indicate this contrast with the word “but.”

Here are some other ways to translate this contrast:

However

Instead

But instead Jesus refused

Jesus answered: The Greek word that the BSB translates as answered here means “replied” or “responded.” Jesus was not answering a question. He was responding to what the devil was suggesting.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he replied (NJB)

Jesus responded by saying

It is written: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *It is written* introduces words from the Hebrew Scriptures.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

The scripture says (GNT)

It is written in the Scriptures that God said

4:4b–c

In 4:4b–c, Jesus quoted Deuteronomy 8:3. That passage teaches about true life. A person needs physical food, but for a complete life, he also must depend on God and obey all that he tells him to do.

4:4b

‘Man shall not live on bread alone,

- ‘A person does not live only by eating bread/food.
- ‘People need more than food to truly live.
- Life does not come just from what people eat.

Man shall not live on bread alone: Jesus was saying that bread (food) alone does not give true life. There is something more important than food.

Be careful not to translate this clause in a way that implies that Jesus was saying that people need a variety of foods in addition to bread. He was not saying that bread is not nutritious enough to sustain life. He was saying that food alone does not give true life.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

A person does not live by eating only bread (NCV)

No one can live only on food. (CEV)

It takes more than bread for man to live.

Food by itself is not enough to give people true life.

Man: The word *Man* here means a human being. It refers to both males and females.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Human beings (NJB)

People (CEV)

A person (NCV)

bread: In this context bread represents food in general. This is the same word as in 4:3c.

4:4c

but on every word that comes from the mouth of God.”

- But he will live by obeying every word that God says.”
- They need all the words of God to truly live.”
- Instead, it comes from doing what God commands.

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *but* indicates a strong contrast. The contrast is between what man cannot live on and what he can live on.

Here are some other ways to translate this contrast:

instead

rather

on every word that comes from the mouth of God:

There is some implied information here. If the implicit information is included, it will say:

he will live by/on every word that comes from the mouth of God.

Jesus meant that obeying God is more important than eating food. Jesus implied here that he would be disobeying God if he turned the stones into bread and ate it.

The phrase *every word that comes from the mouth of God* is a figure of speech. It refers to the words that God speaks.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

every word that God speaks (GNT)

by everything God says (NCV)

what God commands

Matthew 4:5

Section 4:1–11: The devil tempted Jesus

In this section, God allowed Satan to tempt Jesus so that Jesus could show that he always obeyed his Father. The children of Israel had failed to obey God during their forty years in the wilderness. But Jesus, as the Messiah, proved his obedience to God during his

forty days of fasting and temptation in the wilderness. He “passed” this test and demonstrated that he truly was the “Son of God.”

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The temptation of Jesus

The devil tried to make Jesus sin

Jesus was tempted by the devil

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 4:1-11, and a shorter version occurs in Mark 1:12-13.

Paragraph 4:5-7

In this paragraph, Matthew reported the second way that the devil tempted Jesus. In this paragraph, the devil tempted Jesus to put himself in danger. If Jesus had put himself in danger, he would have been testing God to save him from danger. This would have been a sinful thing for Jesus to do.

4:5a

Then the devil took Him to the holy city

- ¶ Then the devil went to the holy city and took Jesus with him.
- ¶ Next, Satan went with Jesus to the holy city of Jerusalem.

Then: The conjunction Then introduces a new part of the story. It also indicates that 4:5 happened after 4:4. The Greek text does not indicate how much time passed between these two stories. Use a general term that indicates that the events in this paragraph happened after the events in 4:3-4.

This same word occurs in 4:1a.

the devil took Him to the holy city: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as took refers to someone taking along another person. The devil went to Jerusalem and took Jesus with him. You should not imply that the devil used physical force to take Jesus along with him.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

the devil went to the holy city and took Jesus with him

the devil led Jesus to the holy city (NCV)

the devil went with Jesus to the holy city

the holy city: The phrase the holy city refers to Jerusalem. The Jews thought of Jerusalem as the “holy city” because the temple of God was there. You may want to include this implied information. For example:

Jerusalem, the Holy City (GNT)

the holy city of Jerusalem (NCV)

4:5b

and set Him on the pinnacle of the temple.

- He caused Jesus to stand on the highest place of the temple.
- He put/placed Jesus on top of one of the towers/roofs of God’s sacred house.

and set Him: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as set Him also means “placed him.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

caused him to stand

had him stand (NIV)

put him (NCV)

The Greek text does not indicate whether the devil was with Jesus on top of the temple. So it is best to leave this point vague. If you must indicate where the devil was, remember that he had a conversation with Jesus. So he was probably close.

the pinnacle of the temple: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the pinnacle of the temple probably refers to the top of one of the temple towers. Towers were built into the wall of the temple complex. If a man fell or jumped off from there, he would die when he hit the ground.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the highest part of the temple (CEV)

the roof of the temple

temple: The Greek word that the BSB translates as temple refers to the temple building and the walls and courtyards that surrounded it. The temple was in Jerusalem and was the most important place where Jews worshiped God.

Here are some other ways to translate the word temple:

- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

house/building of God

place of sacrifice

house/place of worship

holy/sacred house

- If your language has a word for “temple,” consider using it. But you may need to modify it by saying:

temple of the Jews/Lord

Be sure to use a different term from the one you have chosen for “synagogue.” There was only one temple, but there were many synagogues.

See the word temple, Meaning 1, in the Glossary for more information.

Matthew 4:6

Section 4:1–11: The devil tempted Jesus

In this section, God allowed Satan to tempt Jesus so that Jesus could show that he always obeyed his Father. The children of Israel had failed to obey God during their forty years in the wilderness. But Jesus, as the Messiah, proved his obedience to God during his forty days of fasting and temptation in the wilderness. He “passed” this test and demonstrated that he truly was the “Son of God.”

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The temptation of Jesus

The devil tried to make Jesus sin

Jesus was tempted by the devil

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 4:1–11, and a shorter version occurs in Mark 1:12–13.

Paragraph 4:5–7

In this paragraph, Matthew reported the second way that the devil tempted Jesus. In this paragraph, the devil tempted Jesus to put himself in danger. If Jesus

had put himself in danger, he would have been testing God to save him from danger. This would have been a sinful thing for Jesus to do.

4:6a

“If You are the Son of God,” he said, “throw Yourself down.

- He said, “If you really/truly are the Son of God, jump down from here.
- He said to him, “If it is true that you are God’s Son, jump off of this tower/roof to the ground!
- He told Jesus to prove that he was the child of God by jumping to the ground.

“If You are the Son of God,” he said: The BSB places the words he said in the middle of what the devil said. This is good English style. However, in some languages it may be more natural to put these words at the beginning of 4:6a. For example:

and said to him, “If you are the Son of God...” (ESV)

If You are the Son of God: These words are the same words as in 4:3b. You should translate it the same way as you did there.

throw Yourself down: The phrase throw Yourself down means “leap off,” “jump down,” or “make yourself fall down.” Normally someone who jumped from such a great height would hit the ground and die. The devil tempted Jesus to sin by taking this unnecessary risk in order to prove who he was and that God would protect him.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

jump off (NLT)

jump down (NCV)

jump and fall to the ground

4:6b

For it is written:

- The Scriptures say,
- You will not be hurt, because it is written in the Scriptures,
- He said that he/Jesus would not be injured, because God’s book says that

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB here translates as For also means “because.” It introduces the reason clause (4:6b) of a reason-result statement. The

result is implied. The implied information is: “You will not be injured.”

result (implied)	You will not be hurt,
reason (4:6c)	for/because God will command his angels to protect you.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- Include the implied information and the conjunction “because.” For example:

You will not be hurt for/because it is written...

It is written..., so you will not be hurt.

- Do not translate the conjunction and leave the relationship implied. For example:

It is written in the Scriptures (NCV)

Scripture says.... (GW)

it is written: The phrase it is written again introduces a quotation from the Old Testament Scriptures. The quotation is from Psalm 91:11–12. See how you translated this phrase in 4:4.

4:6c

‘He will command His angels concerning You,

- ‘God will give orders to his angels about you^(sing).
- ‘God will order his angels to protect you^(sing).
- God will tell his angels to protect/help him.

He will command His angels concerning You: The clause He will command His angels concerning You means that God will give his angels a command/order about Jesus. This implies that God will order his angels to protect Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

God will give orders to his angels about you (GNT)

He will order his angels to protect you (NLT)

His angels: See how you translated the word angel in 1:20 or 2:19. Also, see angel, Meaning 1, in the Glossary for more information.

4:6d

and they will lift You up in their hands,

- They will hold you^(sing) up with their hands

- They will support you^(sing)
- They will carry him

and they will lift You up in their hands: This clause means “the angels will carry/support you.”

The devil was quoting Psalm 91:12. In that verse, angels lift up someone so that he will not hit his feet on the stones and stumble as he walks. But here, the devil applied this verse to mean that if Jesus jumped down, the angels would catch him before he hit the ground.

Because the devil was quoting from Psalm 91:12, you should use a verb from your language that fits the context of the psalm. Use a verb that means “carry” or “support.” Do not use a verb like “catch.” For example:

they will hold you up with their hands (GNT)

They will carry you in their arms (NJB)

with their hands they will lift you up (NET)

in their hands: In some languages, it will be more natural to translate this phrase as “in/on their arms.” For example:

in their arms (NJB)

In some languages, the phrase in their hands is implied by the verb used to translate “lift You up.” If that is true in your language, you do not need to translate this phrase explicitly.

4:6e

so that You will not strike Your foot against a stone.”

- so that you^(sing) will not hit your foot on a stone!”
- so that your feet will not be injured on the rocks.”
- so that his feet will not even be hurt on a stone.

so that: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as so that links two actions. This Greek conjunction *mēpote* marks negative purpose. One action prevents the other action from happening. The purpose for which the angels carried someone (4:6d) was to prevent that person from being harmed (4:6e).

In this context, the devil quoted the psalm to say that angels would protect Jesus. They would protect him so that he would not be harmed if he jumped from the temple.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

in order that you not injure your foot

to prevent your foot from hitting a stone

You will not strike Your foot against a stone: The phrase strike Your foot against a stone means “hit a stone” or “stumble over a stone.” Psalm 91:12 describes someone who is walking along a path. As he walks, God’s angels protect him from hitting his foot on a stone, stumbling, falling down, and hurting himself.

Satan quoted this psalm to mean that Jesus would not be injured if he jumped from the top of the temple. But because the devil was quoting from Psalm 91:12, you should use a verb from your language that fits the context of the psalm. If possible, use a verb that can refer to both stumbling on a stone and hitting a stone. For example:

your foot will not hit a rock/stone

not even your feet will be hurt on the stones (GNT)

General Comment on 4:6b–e

In some languages, it may be more natural to translate the quotation from the Scriptures as indirect speech. For example:

^{6b}The Scriptures say that ^{6c}God will order his angels to protect him. ^{6d}They will lift him up in their hands, ^{6e}so that he does not strike his foot against a stone.

Matthew 4:7

Section 4:1–11: The devil tempted Jesus

In this section, God allowed Satan to tempt Jesus so that Jesus could show that he always obeyed his Father. The children of Israel had failed to obey God during their forty years in the wilderness. But Jesus, as the Messiah, proved his obedience to God during his forty days of fasting and temptation in the wilderness. He “passed” this test and demonstrated that he truly was the “Son of God.”

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The temptation of Jesus

The devil tried to make Jesus sin

Jesus was tempted by the devil

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 4:1–11, and a shorter version occurs in Mark 1:12–13.

Paragraph 4:5–7

In this paragraph, Matthew reported the second way that the devil tempted Jesus. In this paragraph, the devil tempted Jesus to put himself in danger. If Jesus had put himself in danger, he would have been testing God to save him from danger. This would have been a sinful thing for Jesus to do.

4:7a

Jesus replied, “It is also written:

- Jesus responded, “It is also written in the Scriptures,
- But Jesus said to the devil, “The Scriptures also say,
- But Jesus refused. He said that God’s book also says that

There is a contrast between 4:6 and 4:7. The contrast is between the devil’s desire and Jesus’ desire. Jesus refused to do what the devil wanted him to do.

In Greek, there is no conjunction at the beginning of this verse. But it may be more natural in your language to have a conjunction here as in 4:4a. For example:

But...

Jesus replied: Here Jesus replied/responded to the devil’s attempt to make him sin. Jesus refused to do what the devil wanted him to do.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus replied/responded

But Jesus refused. He said...

It is also written: The phrase It is...written is the same as in 4:4a. See how you translated it in 4:4 and in 4:6.

4:7b

‘Do not put the Lord your God to the test.’”

- ‘Do not test the Lord your^(sing) God.’”
- ‘Do not demand that the Lord your God prove himself.’”
- people should not test God, their Lord.

Do not put the Lord your God to the test: The clause that the BSB translates as Do not put the Lord your God to the test means “Do not test the Lord your God” (as in the NLT96).

Here in 4:7b, Jesus was quoting from Deuteronomy 6:16. God had forbidden people to test him. In this context, Jesus meant that jumping down from the temple would be testing God to rescue him. That would have been a sin. Jesus would have been taking an unnecessary risk in order to prove that God would do a miracle to protect him.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

You must not test the LORD your God. (NLT)

Do not force the Lord your God to show/prove his power

These words were a command to each of the people of Israel. In Greek, the verb Do not put and the pronoun your are singular. However, since the command is given to everyone, in some languages it may be more natural to use plural forms. For example:

Do not test the Lord your^(plur) God.

We must not test the Lord our God.

People must not test the Lord their God

the Lord your God: The phrase the Lord your God indicates that the Lord is the God with whom people have a relationship. It implies that the Lord guides and cares for them as God, and they worship and serve him.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the Lord, who is your God

your Lord/Master God

God who is your Lord/Master

In some languages, the phrase your God is not natural. If that is true in your language, here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the Lord God, whom you worship/serve

God the Lord, who cares for you

the Lord, the God whom you worship

General Comment on 4:7a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to translate the quotation from the Scriptures as indirect speech. For example:

The Scriptures say that no one should test the Lord their God.

Matthew 4:8

Section 4:1–11: The devil tempted Jesus

In this section, God allowed Satan to tempt Jesus so that Jesus could show that he always obeyed his Father. The children of Israel had failed to obey God during their forty years in the wilderness. But Jesus, as the Messiah, proved his obedience to God during his forty days of fasting and temptation in the wilderness. He “passed” this test and demonstrated that he truly was the “Son of God.”

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The temptation of Jesus

The devil tried to make Jesus sin

Jesus was tempted by the devil

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 4:1–11, and a shorter version occurs in Mark 1:12–13.

Paragraph 4:8–11

In this paragraph, Matthew reported the third way that the devil tempted Jesus. Here, the devil tempted Jesus to make an agreement with him. The devil asked Jesus to worship him as God, and then the devil would reward him.

4:8a

Again, the devil took Him to a very high mountain

- ¶ Once more the devil tempted Jesus. He went to the top of a very high mountain and took Jesus with him.
- ¶ Then/Next the devil went with him/Jesus up a very high mountain.

Again: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Again indicates a repeated action. The devil tempted Jesus “once more” but in a different way. This word does not indicate that he repeated the same temptation.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

- Use a word or phrase to indicate a repeated action. For example:

Once more (GW)

- Use a more general word or phrase such as:

Then (GNT)

took Him: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as took refers to someone taking along another person. This same verb occurs in 4:5a. See how you translated it there.

a very high mountain: The phrase a very high mountain may have been a literal mountain, or it may have been a mountain in a vision. Scholars are divided in their understanding of this passage. It is probably best to translate a very high mountain literally. It is not clear whether or not this was a real mountain. There is no mountain high enough for a person to see from it all the kingdoms of the world. Perhaps this was a vision that Satan gave Jesus, a picture in his mind. But it was so clear that it was like he was standing on top of a high mountain.

4:8b

and showed Him all the kingdoms of the world and their glory.

- He showed him all the nations of the world and their greatness/power.
- There he showed him all the countries on earth and how strong and beautiful they were.

and showed Him all the kingdoms of the world: The devil showed Jesus all the nations of the world of that time. It is not physically possible to see every part of the world from one place, but the text does not state how he did this. So it is recommended that you translate these words literally without further explanation.

all the kingdoms of the world: A “kingdom” refers to a large area or country where a king or other high authority rules. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

all the nations of the world

all the countries on earth

and their glory: The Greek word that the BSB here translates as glory expresses the idea of the greatness, magnificence, and beauty of the nations.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in all their greatness (GNT)

and their magnificence (JBP)

and how powerful and beautiful they were

Matthew 4:9

Section 4:1–11: The devil tempted Jesus

In this section, God allowed Satan to tempt Jesus so that Jesus could show that he always obeyed his Father. The children of Israel had failed to obey God during their forty years in the wilderness. But Jesus, as the Messiah, proved his obedience to God during his forty days of fasting and temptation in the wilderness. He “passed” this test and demonstrated that he truly was the “Son of God.”

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The temptation of Jesus

The devil tried to make Jesus sin

Jesus was tempted by the devil

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 4:1–11, and a shorter version occurs in Mark 1:12–13.

Paragraph 4:8–11

In this paragraph, Matthew reported the third way that the devil tempted Jesus. Here, the devil tempted Jesus to make an agreement with him. The devil asked Jesus to worship him as God, and then the devil would reward him.

4:9

“All this I will give You,” he said, “if You will fall down and worship me.”

- He said to him, “I will give all those things/countries to you if you will kneel/bow down and worship me.”
- Then the devil said to him/Jesus, “If you kneel down and worship me, I will give you all of these countries to rule.”

“All this I will give You,” he said: The BSB places the words he said in the middle of what the devil said. This is good English style. However, in some languages it may be more natural to put these words at the beginning of 4:9. For example:

And he said to him, “All these I will give you...” (ESV)

All this I will give You: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates All this refers to “all the kingdoms of the world and their splendor” (4:8b).

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

All those/these countries/things I will give to you

I will give to you all that you can see

if You will fall down: The Greek word that the BSB translates as fall down refers to showing great respect by getting close to the ground. This can be done by bowing or kneeling. This word does not mean to accidentally fall down.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

bow down (CEV)

kneel down (GNT)

This same word occurs in 2:11c.

and worship me: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as worship is literally “prostrate before.” It usually involved kneeling and putting one’s face to the ground. This was done before God and also kings to show great honor and submission.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

and/to honor me

and submit to me

and show me respect

See the note on worship in 2:2c for more information on this same word.

General Comment on 4:9

In some languages, it may be more natural to have the “if” clause first. For example:

The devil said, “If you will bow down and worship me, I will give you all these things.” (NCV)

Matthew 4:10

Section 4:1–11: The devil tempted Jesus

In this section, God allowed Satan to tempt Jesus so that Jesus could show that he always obeyed his Father. The children of Israel had failed to obey God during their forty years in the wilderness. But Jesus, as the Messiah, proved his obedience to God during his forty days of fasting and temptation in the wilderness. He “passed” this test and demonstrated that he truly was the “Son of God.”

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The temptation of Jesus

The devil tried to make Jesus sin

Jesus was tempted by the devil

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 4:1–11, and a shorter version occurs in Mark 1:12–13.

Paragraph 4:8–11

In this paragraph, Matthew reported the third way that the devil tempted Jesus. Here, the devil tempted Jesus to make an agreement with him. The devil asked Jesus to worship him as God, and then the devil would reward him.

4:10a

“Away from Me, Satan!” Jesus declared.

- Then Jesus said to him, “Go away from me, Satan!
- But Jesus said to the devil, “Satan, leave!
- But Jesus refused. He told Satan to leave him

“Away from Me, Satan!” Jesus declared: The BSB places the words Jesus declare in the middle of what Jesus said. This is good English style. However, in some languages it may be more natural to put these words at the beginning of 4:10. For example:

Then Jesus said to him, “Be gone, Satan!” (ESV)

As in the previous two temptations, Jesus here refused to do what the devil wanted him to do. In some languages, it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

But Jesus refused. He said to him

Away from Me, Satan!: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Away from Me is a command. Jesus commanded Satan to leave him.

Here are some other ways to translate this command:

Go away, Satan! (GNT)

Go away from me, Satan! (NCV)

It may be more natural in your language to have the name first. For example:

Satan, leave me!

Satan: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Satan is simply a transliteration of the Hebrew word which means “enemy.” Satan is one of the devil’s names. This is the first time in Matthew that the devil is referred to by his name Satan.

You should transliterate the word Satan in a way that sounds natural in your language.

4:10b

“For it is written:

- For/Because it is written in the Scriptures,
- I will never worship you because the Scriptures say,
- because of what God’s book says. It says that

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB here translates as For also means “because.” It introduces the reason clause (4:10c) of a reason-result statement. The result is implied. The implied information is: “I will not worship you.”

result (implied)	I will not worship you,
reason (4:10c)	for/because it is written that only God is to be worshipped.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- Translate the implied information and the conjunction. For example:

I will not worship you, for/because it is written...

It is written.... So/Therefore I will not worship you.

- Translate “For it is written...” as a separate sentence and leave the conjunction and relationship implied. For example:

It is written in the Scriptures... (NCV)

Scripture says.... (GW)

it is written: As in 4:4a and 4:6b, Jesus used the phrase it is written to introduce words from the Hebrew Scriptures.

Here is another way to translate this:

The scripture says (GNT)

The quote in 4:10c are words that God gave to Moses, and Moses wrote them down. So you could translate this phrase as:

Moses wrote

4:10c

“Worship the Lord your God and serve Him only.”

- “You^(sing) must worship the Lord your God and serve only him.”
- “It is the Lord your God whom you^(sing) must honor. He is the only one you must submit to.”
- a person must bow down and adore only the Lord God.

“Worship the Lord your God and serve Him only.”:

This sentence is a quote from Deuteronomy 6:13. These words were a command to each of the people of Israel. In Greek, the verbs Worship and serve and the pronoun you are singular. However, since the command is given to everyone, in some languages it may be more natural to use the plural forms. For example:

You^(plur) must worship the Lord, who is your God, and obey only him.

People must worship the Lord their God and serve only him.

Jesus quoted this command in order to tell Satan that he would never worship him. He was declaring that he would obey the Scriptures and only worship the Lord God.

Worship...serve: The two verbs Worship and serve are a doublet. This means that these two words mean almost the same thing. To Worship God is to bow before him and adore him. (See the note on “worship me” in 4:9.) To serve God means to do the things that show that you honor him as your God. These two verbs work

together to describe how people should act toward God.

Here are some other ways to translate these verbs:

Bow down to the Lord your God and respect only him.

You must submit to the Lord your God and honor him alone.

General Comment on 4:10b–c

Jesus was not commanding Satan to worship the Lord. In some languages, a literal translation may imply that Jesus was telling Satan what to do. If that is the case in your language, you may need to say explicitly to whom the command was addressed. For example:

This command to the people of Israel is written in God's book: You shall worship the Lord your God and serve him alone.

Another possibility is to use indirect speech. For example:

The Scripture says that a person must worship the Lord his God and serve only him.

It is written that we^(excl) must worship the Lord our God and serve him alone.

Matthew 4:11

Section 4:1–11: The devil tempted Jesus

In this section, God allowed Satan to tempt Jesus so that Jesus could show that he always obeyed his Father. The children of Israel had failed to obey God during their forty years in the wilderness. But Jesus, as the Messiah, proved his obedience to God during his forty days of fasting and temptation in the wilderness. He “passed” this test and demonstrated that he truly was the “Son of God.”

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The temptation of Jesus

The devil tried to make Jesus sin

Jesus was tempted by the devil

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 4:1–11, and a shorter version occurs in Mark 1:12–13.

Paragraph 4:8–11

In this paragraph, Matthew reported the third way that the devil tempted Jesus. Here, the devil tempted Jesus to make an agreement with him. The devil asked Jesus to worship him as God, and then the devil would reward him.

4:11a

Then the devil left Him,

- Then Satan left him,
- After this, the devil went away from Jesus.

Then: The conjunction translated as Then is the same word as in 4:1a and 4:5a. It introduces a new development in the story. Here are some other ways to translate this word:

At that time

Next

the devil left Him: The phrase the devil left Him means that the devil went away from Jesus. He stopped troubling him for a while. For example:

the devil went away (NLT)

4:11b

and angels came and ministered to Him.

- and suddenly some angels came to him and helped him.
- Then unexpectedly, some angels appeared and gave him what he needed.

and angels came: The Greek is literally “and, behold, angels came.” The word “behold” brings attention to the words that follow. The BSB omits this word, but it often indicates something unexpected and extraordinary.

If you have a term that gets the attention of people that is natural in this context, you may want to use it here. Here are some other examples:

and suddenly angels came (NRSV)

and unexpectedly some angels came

Look! Some angels came

and ministered to Him: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as ministered to Him means “helped him” or “took care of him.” This may have included providing Jesus with food, comfort, and protection.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

helped him (GNT)

took care of him (NCV)

gave him the things he needed

Matthew 4:12

Section 4:12–17: Jesus began preaching in Galilee

After Jesus’ temptation, he left the district of Judea and went to his home in the town of Nazareth, which is in the district of Galilee (2:22–23). Later he moved from Nazareth to the town of Capernaum (4:12–13).

In this section, Matthew again showed how Jesus’ life fulfilled the words of a prophet (4:14–16). This section shows that the main idea that Jesus preached in this early part of his work was: “Turn away from your sins, because the kingdom of heaven is near” (4:17 in the GNT).

Here are some other headings for this section:

Jesus began his work in Galilee

The ministry of Jesus began

There are brief parallel passages for this section in Luke 4:14–15 and Mark 1:14–15.

Paragraph 4:12–16

In this paragraph, Matthew told his readers how Jesus fulfilled one of Isaiah’s prophecies. He returned to the province of Galilee and moved to the town of Capernaum.

4:12a

When Jesus heard that John had been imprisoned,

- ¶ When Jesus heard that John the Baptist was arrested,
- ¶ Later, Jesus learned that they/officials had put John the Baptist in prison/jail.

When Jesus heard that John had been imprisoned:

This clause tells us the setting of Jesus’ move from Judea to Galilee. Some English versions begin this clause with the word “Now.”

The Greek text does not indicate how much time passed between the events of 4:1–11 and 4:12. So you should begin this clause with a general time expression. For example:

Afterward, Jesus heard that...

Later, Jesus heard that...

At the time that Jesus heard that...

Jesus heard: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Jesus is literally “he.” The pronoun refers to Jesus. Matthew does not say how Jesus heard about John the Baptist’s situation. It is likely that someone told him that John was in prison.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

When someone told Jesus

Then Jesus learned that

John: The name John refers to John the Baptist. If this will not be clear to your readers, you may use the same name/title as you did in 3:1a.

had been imprisoned: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as had been imprisoned literally means “was given/handed over.” Some versions translate this verb by focusing on the fact that he:

1. had been arrested.

Other versions translate this verb by focusing on the fact that he:

1. had been put in prison.

Both are true. You may use either or both expressions, depending on what is natural in your language.

This verb is also passive. Some ways to translate it are:

- As a passive. For example:

had been arrested and put in prison by the authorities

- As an active. For example:

people/they arrested John and put him in prison

King Herod had put John in prison

Herod ordered his soldiers to arrest John

4:12b

He withdrew to Galilee.

- he went back to Galilee.
- So he/Jesus left the district of Judea and returned to the district of Galilee.

He withdrew: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as withdrew means “went back” or “returned.” Jesus left the district of Judea and went back to Galilee.

Jesus had been in the district of Galilee. That is where his home was. Then he went to the district of Judea where John baptized him. He was still in Judea when the devil tempted him. When he heard about John the Baptist, he went back to Galilee.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

went back (GW)

went (CEV)

he left Judea and returned (NLT)

to Galilee: The noun Galilee is the name of a district or area in the north part of Israel. See the note on “the district of Galilee” at 2:22d for more information.

Matthew 4:13

Section 4:12–17: Jesus began preaching in Galilee

After Jesus’ temptation, he left the district of Judea and went to his home in the town of Nazareth, which is in the district of Galilee (2:22–23). Later he moved from Nazareth to the town of Capernaum (4:12–13).

In this section, Matthew again showed how Jesus’ life fulfilled the words of a prophet (4:14–16). This section shows that the main idea that Jesus preached in this early part of his work was: “Turn away from your sins, because the kingdom of heaven is near” (4:17 in the GNT).

Here are some other headings for this section:

Jesus began his work in Galilee

The ministry of Jesus began

There are brief parallel passages for this section in Luke 4:14–15 and Mark 1:14–15.

Paragraph 4:12–16

In this paragraph, Matthew told his readers how Jesus fulfilled one of Isaiah’s prophecies. He returned to the province of Galilee and moved to the town of Capernaum.

4:13a

Leaving Nazareth, He went and lived in Capernaum,

- He left Nazareth and went to live in the town of Capernaum.
- He went to the town of Nazareth. Later, he left Nazareth and went and lived/stayed in the town of Capernaum.

Leaving Nazareth: The noun Nazareth is the name of Jesus’ hometown. It was a small town in the district of Galilee. It is implied that Jesus first went there. Then he left that town. You may want to include some of the implied information. For example:

He went to the town of Nazareth, and later he left

He first went and stayed in his hometown of Nazareth. Then he left

went and lived in Capernaum: The noun Capernaum is the name of another town in the district of Galilee. Jesus moved to Capernaum and it became his home.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

moved to Capernaum (CEV)

went and settled in Capernaum (NJB)

went to stay in the town of Capernaum

4:13b

which is by the sea

- That town was beside the big lake
- Capernaum was located on the shore of Lake Galilee.

which is by the sea: The phrase by the sea is the first of two phrases that describe where the town of Capernaum was located. Capernaum was by/beside the Sea of Galilee.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

This town was beside Lake Galilee (CEV)

on the shores of the Sea of Galilee (GW)

the sea: The phrase the sea refers to the largest freshwater lake in Israel. It is the Sea of Galilee. This lake is about 21 kilometers long and 11 kilometers wide. If your language has different words for “lake/sea” based on its size, this information may help you decide which word to use.

The Sea of Galilee is a body of freshwater, not saltwater. The word “sea” is often associated with saltwater. But it can also refer to a lake of freshwater, as is the case in this passage. Several other versions, such as the NIV, say “lake.”

If your language has a separate word or phrase for a freshwater lake, you will want to use it here. In languages that do not have a word for “sea/lake,” you may be able to use a descriptive phrase. For example:

the big pond/water

large water

wide/large river

4:13c

in the region of Zebulun and Naphtali,

- in the lands of the clans of Zebulun and Naphtali.
- It was in the territory of the clans/descendants of Zebulun and Naphtali.

in the region of Zebulun and Naphtali: The phrase in the region of Zebulun and Naphtali is the second of two phrases that describe where the town of Capernaum was located. Capernaum was in the area of Zebulun and Naphtali.

The nouns Zebulun and Naphtali are the names of two of the tribes/clans of Israel. The land that belonged to these two clans covered some of the same area as the district of Galilee.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in the region/area of Zebulun and Naphtali

It/Capernaum was in the land that belonged to the descendants/clans of Zebulun and Naphtali

Matthew 4:14

Section 4:12–17: Jesus began preaching in Galilee

After Jesus’ temptation, he left the district of Judea and went to his home in the town of Nazareth, which

is in the district of Galilee (2:22–23). Later he moved from Nazareth to the town of Capernaum (4:12–13).

In this section, Matthew again showed how Jesus’ life fulfilled the words of a prophet (4:14–16). This section shows that the main idea that Jesus preached in this early part of his work was: “Turn away from your sins, because the kingdom of heaven is near” (4:17 in the GNT).

Here are some other headings for this section:

Jesus began his work in Galilee

The ministry of Jesus began

There are brief parallel passages for this section in Luke 4:14–15 and Mark 1:14–15.

Paragraph 4:12–16

In this paragraph, Matthew told his readers how Jesus fulfilled one of Isaiah’s prophecies. He returned to the province of Galilee and moved to the town of Capernaum.

4:14

to fulfill what was spoken through the prophet Isaiah:

- This happened to make come true the words that were spoken through the prophet Isaiah:
- Jesus went there in order to fulfill/accomplish what God had said long ago through his spokesman Isaiah. He said:

to fulfill what was spoken through the prophet Isaiah: The Greek word that the BSB translates as to indicates that 4:14 is the purpose for Jesus’ move to Galilee. He moved to Galilee, in order that scripture would be fulfilled.

In some languages, it will be more natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

Jesus moved to Galilee so that what was spoken... might be fulfilled.

He did that in order that the words...might be fulfilled.

to fulfill: The Greek word that the BSB translates as to fulfill means “to come true” or “to happen.” God spoke the words of 4:15–16 hundreds of years before Jesus was born. And now those words were about to happen.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

to make come true (GNT)

to accomplish

would happen

what was spoken through the prophet Isaiah: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as what was spoken through the prophet can also be translated as “the words that were spoken through the prophet.” In 1:22 and 2:15, Matthew used a more complete formula to introduce scripture: “fulfill what the Lord had said/spoken through the prophet.” This shows that the agent is the Lord. He spoke words through the prophets. Here in 4:14, the phrase “by the Lord” is implied. What was spoken was through the prophet Isaiah, not simply by the prophet Isaiah. Isaiah spoke words that the Lord had instructed him to tell the people. Isaiah also wrote down these words.

This clause is passive. Here are some other ways to translate this:

- As a passive. For example:

what had been spoken through the prophet Isaiah (NRSV)

the words that were said by God through the prophet Isaiah

- As an active. For example:

what God said through the prophet Isaiah (NLT)

the words that the prophet Isaiah said

the prophet Isaiah: The phrase the prophet Isaiah also occurs in 3:3. You should translate this phrase the same way as you translated it there.

Matthew 4:15

Section 4:12–17: Jesus began preaching in Galilee

After Jesus’ temptation, he left the district of Judea and went to his home in the town of Nazareth, which is in the district of Galilee (2:22–23). Later he moved from Nazareth to the town of Capernaum (4:12–13).

In this section, Matthew again showed how Jesus’ life fulfilled the words of a prophet (4:14–16). This section shows that the main idea that Jesus preached in this early part of his work was: “Turn away from your sins,

because the kingdom of heaven is near” (4:17 in the GNT).

Here are some other headings for this section:

Jesus began his work in Galilee

The ministry of Jesus began

There are brief parallel passages for this section in Luke 4:14–15 and Mark 1:14–15.

Paragraph 4:12–16

In this paragraph, Matthew told his readers how Jesus fulfilled one of Isaiah’s prophecies. He returned to the province of Galilee and moved to the town of Capernaum.

4:15–16

Matthew 4:15–16 is a quotation from Isaiah 9:1–2. Much of the quote is poetry, so you should translate it as poetry.

4:15a

“Land of Zebulun and land of Naphtali,

- “In the land of Zebulun and the land of Naphtali,
- “You people who live in the land of Zebulun and you who live in the land of Naphtali,

Land of Zebulun and land of Naphtali: The Greek phrase that the BSB has literally translated as Land of Zebulun and land of Naphtali is a figure of speech called apostrophe. God (through Isaiah) spoke directly to these two lands as if he were speaking to two people. The implied information is that God had a message for those who lived in those areas. So they needed to listen carefully to it. For example:

Listen, lands of Zebulun and Naphtali (CEV)

If it is not natural to use apostrophe here, you may want to translate these phrases something like the following:

You people who live in the land of Zebulun and you who live in the land of Naphtali

In the land of Zebulun and of Naphtali (NLT)

Or you may want to speak indirectly about the land. For example:

Regarding/About the land of Zebulun and the land of Naphtali

This is a message for those who live in the land of Zebulun and those who live in the land of Naphtali

4:15b

the Way of the Sea, beyond the Jordan,

- in the land which is beside the lake and across the Jordan River,
- the land which is near/beside the lake, the land which is on the other side of the Jordan River,

the Way of the Sea: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the Way of the Sea describes where the lands of Zebulun and Naphtali are located. There are two ways to interpret this phrase:

1. These lands are located near/beside the Sea of Galilee. For example:

beside the sea (NLT) (RSV, NCV, NLT, JBP)

1. These lands are located along a road that went through them to the sea. Some think that this refers to a Roman road that went to the Mediterranean Sea. For example:

on the road to the sea (GNT) (GNT, CEV, NRSV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It has more commentary support.

the Sea: The Greek word that the BSB here translates as Sea also occurs in 4:13b. This word is used in the New Testament to refer to both the Sea of Galilee and the Mediterranean Sea. English versions do not specify which sea this word refers to. However, the Sea of Galilee contains fresh water, and the Mediterranean Sea contains salt water. If your language has different words for these two types of seas, you should translate this word as the one that contains fresh water.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

lake

lake of Galilee

beyond the Jordan: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as beyond the Jordan also describes where the lands of Zebulun and Naphtali are located. It describes where these lands are located from the perspective of someone who was on the east side of the Jordan River. So the word beyond refers to the west side.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

on the other side of the Jordan (GNT)

across the Jordan River (GW)

4:15c

Galilee of the Gentiles—

- in the land also called Galilee, a land where many who are not Jews live,
- the land whose other name is Galilee, a land where foreigners/non-Jews also live.

Galilee of the Gentiles: The phrase Galilee of the Gentiles is another way to describe the land of Zebulun and the land of Naphtali. As mentioned in 4:13c, the land that belonged to these two clans covered some of the same area as the district of Galilee.

The land was referred to as Galilee of the Gentiles because both Jews and Gentiles lived in the district of Galilee.

of the Gentiles: The Greek word that the BSB and many other English versions translate as Gentiles also means “nations” or “ethnic groups.” The Jews used this word to refer to all the people groups besides themselves.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

where foreigners live (GW)

where the non-Jewish people live (NCV)

where the non-Jews also live

Matthew 4:16

Section 4:12–17: Jesus began preaching in Galilee

After Jesus’ temptation, he left the district of Judea and went to his home in the town of Nazareth, which is in the district of Galilee (2:22–23). Later he moved from Nazareth to the town of Capernaum (4:12–13).

In this section, Matthew again showed how Jesus’ life fulfilled the words of a prophet (4:14–16). This section shows that the main idea that Jesus preached in this early part of his work was: “Turn away from your sins, because the kingdom of heaven is near” (4:17 in the GNT).

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Jesus began his work in Galilee

The ministry of Jesus began

There are brief parallel passages for this section in Luke 4:14–15 and Mark 1:14–15.

Paragraph 4:12–16

In this paragraph, Matthew told his readers how Jesus fulfilled one of Isaiah's prophecies. He returned to the province of Galilee and moved to the town of Capernaum.

4:16

Before you translate 4:16, there are several issues to consider:

Issue 1: Parallelism

Verse 4:16 is a Hebrew form of poetry called a parallelism. In a parallelism, an idea is repeated. In this particular parallelism, different words are used in the second part of the verse, but they have the same basic meaning as the words in the first part.

The parallel parts in 4:16a–b that are similar in meaning are shown here:

^{16a} the people living in darkness **have seen a great light**,

^{16b} on those living in the land of the shadow of death, **a light has dawned**

In some languages, people will think that the parallel parts in 4:16 describe different things. In other words, they will think that the clause “the people living in darkness” and the clause “those living in the land of the shadow of death” describe different groups of people. They will think that the clause “have seen a great light” and the clause “a light has dawned” describe two different things.

If that is true in your language, you should:

- Indicate that both expressions refer to the same thing. For example:

^{16a} the people living in darkness have seen a great light;

^{16b} I repeat, a light has dawned on those living in the land of the shadow of death

- Combine the parallel parts. For example:

a great light has dawned on the people living in the land of darkness and death

Issue 2: Metaphor

In addition, this verse uses metaphors of darkness and light. In the Bible, darkness and light are common metaphors. Darkness is a metaphor for sin and its effects: misery, destruction, punishment, folly, ignorance (lack of knowledge of God), and death. Light is a metaphor for God and the Messiah and the good things that the Lord gives: prosperity, wisdom, knowledge of God, life, joy, happiness, laughter, hope, justice, truth, spiritual and material redemption, salvation, revelation, God's presence, God's glory, and God's favor.

Since this is a quote from the Old Testament, it is recommended that you translate this verse using the same metaphors. But it may be necessary to add some additional words to make their meaning clear.

4:16a

the people living in darkness have seen a great light;

- the people who are living there in darkness have seen a bright/powerful light;
- You people who are sitting in the darkness of sin will see the bright light of the Messiah.

the people living in darkness have seen a great light: This clause is the first part of the parallelism. It has the same meaning as 4:16b.

This clause contains two metaphors. Parts of these metaphors are implicit.

In the first metaphor, people who are sinful are compared to people who dwell/live in darkness. They are similar in that neither group of people can see things properly. People who live in spiritual darkness have difficulty seeing/recognizing their sin. They cannot see the truth.

In the second metaphor, the Messiah is compared to a great light. They are similar in that both show something. The Messiah shows people the way to salvation and eternal life.

Here are some other ways to translate these metaphors:

- Keep the metaphors, but explain them in the text. For example:

the people who live in spiritual/moral darkness have seen the great light of the Messiah

the people who live in the darkness of sin have seen the great light of the Messiah

- Change the metaphors to similes. For example:

People who sin are like people who live in darkness. When they see the Messiah, it is like they have seen a great light.

the people there live in sin. It is like they are living in darkness. But now they have seen the Messiah. It is like they have seen a great light

- Translate the metaphors literally but explain them in a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

The “people living in darkness” refers figuratively to those who are sinful. They are like people walking around in the dark. The “great light” refers figuratively to the Messiah and his gospel. When Jesus came, the people finally saw the truth.

the people: The phrase the people refers to all the people who live in the land described in 4:15. It does not just refer to the Gentiles who are mentioned in 4:15c.

living: The Greek word that the BSB translates as living is literally “sitting.” For example:

the people who sat in darkness (RSV)

This Greek word is a figurative way to say “live.” This word refers to people “inhabiting” a house or a town or a country for a long time. So some English versions prefer the word “dwelling/living” rather than “sitting” which implies a temporary situation.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

dwelling (ESV)

sit (NET)

stay

have seen: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as have seen is past tense. It can also be translated as “saw.”

Isaiah wrote this prophecy hundreds of years before Jesus came to earth. But God spoke the words of this

prophecy in the past tense as if viewing this event after Jesus began his work. In addition, Matthew wrote this book some years after Jesus went to heaven. So it may be natural in your language to follow the Greek and use the past tense here, like the BSB.

However, some English versions view this event from Isaiah’s time. So they use the future tense. For example:

will see (GNT)

You should use the tense or aspect that is most natural in your language.

a great light: The phrase a great light refers figuratively to God’s truth as revealed in Jesus, the Messiah, and his gospel.

In this context, the word great refers to something bright. It does not refer to something large.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

bright light (CEV)

4:16b

on those living in the land of the shadow of death, a light has dawned.”

- on the ones/people living in the land where death casts its shadow, a light has risen.”
- the light of the Messiah has risen/shined on those who live in the land where people are under a cloud of death.”
- To repeat, the Messiah will come to give spiritual light to those in spiritual darkness.”

on those living in the land of the shadow of death, a light has dawned: This clause is the second part of the parallelism. It has the same meaning as 4:16a.

This clause contains two metaphors. Parts of these metaphors are implicit.

In the first metaphor, people who cannot recognize the truth are compared to those living in the land of the shadow of death. They are similar in that neither group of people can see things properly. People who cannot see spiritually cannot recognize the truth or their own sin.

In the second metaphor, the Messiah is compared to the sun. Just as the sun rises and shines on the earth, Jesus reveals the truth so that people can see it.

Here are some other ways to translate these metaphors:

- Keep the metaphors, but explain them in the text. For example:

These people cannot see the truth. It is as if they are living in the region and the shadow of death. But the light of the Messiah has dawned/shone on these people.

- Change the metaphors to similes. For example:

The Messiah is like a light that has dawned on those people who cannot see the truth. It is as if they are living in the region and shadow of death.

- Translate the metaphors literally but explain them in a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

The “those living in the land of the shadow of death” refers to people who are living in danger, fear, and hopelessness. It refers figuratively to people who are living in sin and cannot see/recognize the truth. The phrase “a light has dawned” refers figuratively to the Messiah and his gospel. When Jesus came, sinful people finally saw the truth.

living in the land of the shadow of death: The phrase in the land of the shadow of death is a figure of speech. This particular figure of speech is called a hendiadys. The two nouns “land” and “shadow” can be rephrased as a noun and a modifying phrase, for example “the land which has the shadow of death.” See Translation Problems A to Z, Hendiadys. This figure of speech can be restated as “the land where death casts its shadow.” Living in the shadow of death refers to living close to death. This is figurative language that refers to a land where people live in constant danger, fear, and hopelessness. It is a land of spiritual darkness. The phrase “shadow of death” comes from a Hebrew word in the Old Testament. It occurs in places like Isaiah 9:2, from where this quote is taken, and Psalm 23:4. In the past, English versions translated this word as “shadow of death.” However, it is now recognized that a better translation of this word is “deep darkness.” In Isaiah 9:2, the ESV translates this clause as “those who dwelt in a land of deep darkness.” In Isaiah 9:2 the BSB has translated this clause as “those living in the land of the shadow of death.” In Psalm 23:4, the ESV has retained the familiar “valley of the shadow of death” in the translation, but in a footnote says “or the valley of deep darkness.” The BSB has also retained the familiar “the valley of the shadow of death” in Psalm 23:4 but has a footnote that says “or

the valley of deep darkness.” The NIV 2011 translates Psalm 23:4 as “the darkest valley.” Whether it is translated as “shadow of death” or “deepest darkness,” it refers to spiritual darkness that was enlightened by the Messiah. This clause is parallel to “living in darkness” in 4:16a.

In some languages, it is not possible to talk about death having a shadow or living in death’s shadow. If that is true in your language, here are some other ways to translate this clause:

living in the land of death and darkness

living in a land that is as if under clouds of death

living in the land of spiritual darkness

living close to death/danger and in darkness

Remember that this clause is parallel to “living in darkness” in 4:16a. So your translation of this clause should also have the idea of darkness in it.

a light has dawned: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as a light has dawned is literally “a light has risen.” This clause refers to the sun rising and shining on everything on the earth. As mentioned above, it represents Jesus revealing God’s truth to people.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

A light has risen (GW)

a light has shined (NLT)

As mentioned above for the verb “has shined,” some English versions use the future tense. They view this event from Isaiah’s time. For example:

a light will shine (CEV)

Because this is a quotation from the prophet Isaiah, you should keep the figure of light if at all possible.

Matthew 4:17

Section 4:12–17: Jesus began preaching in Galilee

After Jesus’ temptation, he left the district of Judea and went to his home in the town of Nazareth, which is in the district of Galilee (2:22–23). Later he moved from Nazareth to the town of Capernaum (4:12–13).

In this section, Matthew again showed how Jesus' life fulfilled the words of a prophet (4:14-16). This section shows that the main idea that Jesus preached in this early part of his work was: "Turn away from your sins, because the kingdom of heaven is near" (4:17 in the GNT).

Here are some other headings for this section:

Jesus began his work in Galilee

The ministry of Jesus began

There are brief parallel passages for this section in Luke 4:14-15 and Mark 1:14-15.

4:17a

From that time on Jesus began to preach,

- ¶ From then on Jesus began to preach this message:
- ¶ After returning to Galilee, Jesus began announcing God's message to the people. He said:

From that time on: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as From that time on refers to the time after Jesus returned to Galilee.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

From then on (GW)

From that time (ESV)

Starting from then

After returning to Galilee

Jesus began to preach: The Greek word that the BSB translates as preach means to publicly "announce," or "proclaim." Jesus was announcing the message that God had given to him. The words of 4:17b-c were a part of what he preached.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus began to proclaim the message (REB)

Jesus began to tell God's message to other people

This same word occurs in 3:1b.

4:17b-c

Repent, for the kingdom of heaven is near: This same clause also occurs in 3:2a-b. You should translate

it here as you did there. Some translation advice is in the notes below.

4:17b

"Repent,

- "Turn back to God,
- "Turn away from your sins and turn to God,

Repent: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Repent refers in a general way to changing one's mind. In the Bible, it refers specifically to a person changing his mind and heart about sin and about God. When a person repents, he is sorry for his past sins. He decides to stop sinning and obey God.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Turn from your sins and turn to God (NLT96)

Turn back to God (CEV)

Change your hearts and lives (NCV)

Leave the ways of sin and follow the ways of God

See how you translated this word in 3:2.

4:17c

for the kingdom of heaven is near."

- because the kingdom of the one who lives in heaven will soon be here."
- because God will soon begin to rule his people!"

for: The conjunction for introduces the basis for Jesus' command to repent. People should repent because the kingdom of heaven was near.

In some languages, it is more natural to put the basis before the command. For example:

^{17c}The kingdom of heaven is near, ^{17b}so/therefore you must repent.

the kingdom of heaven: When you translate the phrase the kingdom of heaven, there are two issues to consider:

Issue 1: The meaning of heaven

In the phrase the kingdom of heaven, the word heaven is a figure of speech called metonymy. In this figure of speech, heaven refers to God, but it refers to him indirectly by naming the place where he lives and rules. The Jews considered God's name to be so holy that they hesitated to say it. So instead of pronounc-

ing God's name directly, they often used the name of the place where he lives and rules. Because Matthew was writing primarily to Jews, he often used the word heaven to refer to God.

Therefore, the kingdom of heaven means the same thing as "the kingdom of God." The phrase the kingdom of heaven only occurs in the book of Matthew. The expression "the kingdom of God" is found in all other places in the New Testament, and it even occurs five times in Matthew.

Here are some other ways to translate heaven in this context:

- Make some information explicit. For example:

the one/Lord who lives in heaven

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

God

Issue 2: The meaning of the kingdom of heaven

Both the kingdom of heaven and "the kingdom of God" refer to God's activity of ruling over his people. God's rule is not simply giving orders or commands to people. It also includes his protection, care, and blessing for them. God leads, protects, and cares for his people. They obey, trust, and submit to him as their king. The phrase kingdom of heaven does not refer to a land or country that God rules over.

Here are some other ways to translate the kingdom of heaven:

- As a noun. For example:

the kingdom/rule of the one who lives in heaven

the kingdom of God

God's kingship

God's rule over people

- As a verbal expression. For example:

God rules his people

God cares for his people as king

See kingdom of heaven in the Glossary for more information.

is near: The Greek word that the BSB translates as is near literally means "has approached." In this passage it indicates that something will "soon happen."

So the entire clause "the kingdom of heaven is near" means:

the time for God to rule over people is about to happen

God's kingship will soon happen/occur

the kingdom of heaven will soon be here (CEV)

the time is near when God will rule over you^(plur)

Matthew 4:18

Section 4:18–22: Jesus chose his first four disciples

This section describes two related events that happened near Lake Galilee during the early part of Jesus' ministry in Galilee. First Jesus asked Peter and his brother Andrew to become his disciples. Later he asked James and his brother John to become his disciples. All four of these men were fishermen. These became four of his twelve disciples.

Here are some other headings for this section:

Jesus chose four fishermen to be his disciples

Jesus asked four men to follow him

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 1:16–20 and Luke 5:1–11.

4:18a–e

Verse 4:18b–e gives four pieces of information about Simon and Andrew:

^{18b}they were brothers

^{18c}their names were Simon and Andrew

^{18d}they were casting their net into the lake

^{18e}they were fishermen

You should put these four pieces of information in the order that is most natural in your language for introducing these new characters. Here is one example of a way to reorder:

^{18a}As Jesus was walking beside the Sea of Galilee,
^{18e}he saw two fishermen ^{18d}who were casting their net into the lake. ^{18b}They were brothers, ^{18c}and their names were Simon called Peter and his brother Andrew.

4:18a

As Jesus was walking beside the Sea of Galilee,

- ¶ While Jesus was walking along the shore of Lake Galilee,
- ¶ One day Jesus was walking next to Lake Galilee.

As Jesus was walking: This clause describes the setting for the story that follows. In some languages, it may be natural to introduce this story with a time word or phrase. For example:

One day as Jesus was walking (NLT)

beside the Sea of Galilee: The Greek word that the BSB translates as beside indicates that Jesus was walking close to the Sea of Galilee. Here are some other ways to translate this word:

by the Sea of Galilee (ESV)

along the Sea of Galilee (GW)

along the shore of Lake Galilee (CEV)

the Sea of Galilee: The Greek word that the BSB here translates as Sea is the same word that is translated as “sea” in 4:13. You should translate it here as you did there.

4:18b

He saw two brothers,

- he saw two men who were brothers.
- He saw a man and his younger brother.

He saw two brothers: The phrase two brothers refers to two men who were brothers of one another. These men were not brothers of Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

he saw a man and his brother

he saw two men who were brothers

Simon was the older brother of Andrew. If your language needs to indicate whether it is an older or a younger brother, you can say:

he saw a man and his younger brother

4:18c

Simon called Peter and his brother Andrew.

- They were Simon, who was also called Peter, and Andrew his brother.
- The one/older brother’s name was Simon. His other name was Peter. The other/younger brother’s name was Andrew.

Simon called Peter: This phrase indicates that Simon had another name. This other name was Peter. Matthew probably included the name Simon because that was his birth name and included the name Peter to avoid confusion with the other disciple named Simon (10:2–4).

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Simon who was also called/named Peter

Simon, also known as Peter (CEV)

and his brother Andrew: Some languages use different words for brother or “sibling,” depending on:

1. whether a person is younger or older
2. whether a person is the brother of a woman or brother of a man
3. whether they are brothers of the same father or mother
4. whether it is important to specify whether a sibling is male or female

Most scholars assume that Peter was the older brother, because he was mentioned first in this passage. We may also assume that Peter and Andrew had the same father and mother. For Peter’s brother Andrew, use whatever term is natural in your language to refer to a younger male sibling with the same father and mother. For example:

his younger brother Andrew

4:18d–e

They were casting a net into the sea, for they were fishermen.

- They were throwing a net into the lake to catch fish. They were doing this is because they were fishermen.
- Their work was to catch and sell fish, and they^(dual) were throwing their fishing net into the water to catch fish.

4:18d

They were casting a net into the sea: In Greek, the phrase casting a net is a single word. It describes someone who stands on shore or in a boat and repeatedly throws a net into the water to catch fish. The net mentioned here was made of string or thread knotted together. The net was circular with small weights attached around its edge to make it sink quickly. It was small enough for one man to handle.

In some languages, it may be difficult to translate the idea of throwing a net into the water. In these languages, it may be necessary to use a more general expression. For example:

catching fish...with a net (GNT)

fishing with a net (NLT96)

catching fish

Be sure not to use an expression that implies that Simon and Andrew were throwing their nets away.

into the sea: In areas where people are familiar with net fishing, it may be redundant to include the words into the sea. That information will be clear from the context. So you can leave it implicit. In other areas, it may be necessary to include this information. Do whatever is clear and natural in your language.

4:18e

for: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as for introduces some additional background information about Simon and Andrew. This information is that these men were fishermen. In some languages, it will be more natural to put this information at another part of the verse. See the note above on 4:18a–e for an example.

Some English versions translate this word as “because.” However, 4:18e is not a direct reason for 4:18d.

they were fishermen: The word fishermen refers to men whose job is to catch fish and sell them.

If your translation of “casting a net” in 4:18d already made explicit a phrase such as “to catch fish,” you may not need to repeat that information here. You may be able to say:

that was their work

Their work was to throw a net into the lake to catch fish. They earned their living by fishing. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

their work was fishing

Matthew 4:19**Section 4:18–22: Jesus chose his first four disciples**

This section describes two related events that happened near Lake Galilee during the early part of Jesus’ ministry in Galilee. First Jesus asked Peter and his brother Andrew to become his disciples. Later he asked James and his brother John to become his disciples. All four of these men were fishermen. These became four of his twelve disciples.

Here are some other headings for this section:

Jesus chose four fishermen to be his disciples

Jesus asked four men to follow him

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 1:16–20 and Luke 5:1–11.

4:19a

“Come, follow Me,” Jesus said,

- Jesus said to them, “Come and follow me,
- Jesus said to them^(dual), “Come follow me and be my disciples.

“Come, follow Me,” Jesus said: The BSB places the words Jesus said in the middle of what Jesus said. This is good English style. However, in some languages it may be more natural to put these words at the beginning of 4:19. For example:

And he said to them, “Follow me...” (ESV)

When Jesus told Simon and Andrew to follow him, he meant two things: It is important to understand the meaning of the word “follow” in the context of the New Testament. At that time students or apprentices normally accompanied their teacher in order to learn from their teachings and from their lives. It was also the custom for students to show respect for their teacher by allowing him to lead them whenever they went somewhere. The students literally walked behind the teacher.

1. He wanted them to literally go with him;

2. He wanted them to become his disciples.

In trying to express these two meanings, you should be aware of the following problems that some translators have faced:

1. A translation such as “Come with me” may not adequately express the teacher-student relationship that the word follow implies. It may imply that Jesus and the disciples had equal status.
2. A translation such as “Follow me” may imply that Simon and Andrew were simply supposed to walk behind Jesus on the road or were to follow Jesus at a later time.

NLT96 may provide a model that avoids these wrong implications. It has made clear that the word follow refers to being a disciple:

Come, be my disciples.

If you follow this translation model, use the same term for “disciples” as you will use in 5:1c.

4:19b

“and I will make you fishers of men.”

- and I will teach you^(plur) how to catch people.”
- I will show you^(dual) how to search for people like you have been catching fish.”
- Until now you^(dual) have been working as fishermen. But now I will teach you to do the work of bringing people into the kingdom of God.”

and I will make you fishers of men: This clause is a metaphor. In this metaphor, the work of gathering people into God’s kingdom is compared to the work of fishermen. The way that these two occupations are similar are that both catch/gather things. Both bring/move things from one situation to another.

Jesus used this metaphor to tell Simon and Andrew that he wanted them to change occupations. He told them that he would train them to do the work of fishing for people. They would fish for (catch) people like fishermen fish for (catch) fish.

Here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Translate the metaphor literally. For example:

I will show you how to fish for people (NLT) In many languages, it will not be possible to use a word combination like “fish for people.” Another solution will have to be found.

- Explain the metaphor. For example:

I will teach you how to catch people instead of fish (GW) In some languages, an expression like “catch people” refers to someone who gathers people to do forced labor. Or it refers to a policeman who catches a criminal. If that is true in your language, it may be necessary to express the meaning in a different way. For example:

I will teach you how to bring in people instead of fish (CEV)

I will teach you to bring people into the kingdom instead of bringing in fish.

Your work has been to catch fish in a net. But now I will teach you to do the work of bringing people into the kingdom.

- Use a simile. For example:

I will teach you to search for people like you have been catching fish.

I will make you: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as I will make you means “I will teach you” or “I will train you” to do a different kind of work. For example:

I will teach you (GW)

I will show you (NLT)

It does not imply that Jesus will force them to change their work.

men: The word that the BSB translates as men refers to people in general. For example:

people (GNT)

You should use a word in your language that includes both men and women.

Matthew 4:20

Section 4:18–22: Jesus chose his first four disciples

This section describes two related events that happened near Lake Galilee during the early part of Jesus’ ministry in Galilee. First Jesus asked Peter and his brother Andrew to become his disciples. Later he asked James and his brother John to become his

disciples. All four of these men were fishermen. These became four of his twelve disciples.

Here are some other headings for this section:

Jesus chose four fishermen to be his disciples

Jesus asked four men to follow him

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 1:16–20 and Luke 5:1–11.

4:20

And at once they left their nets and followed Him.

- They immediately left their nets and followed Jesus.
- Right away they^(dual) abandoned their nets and their fishing work and went with Jesus to become his disciples.

And at once: The Greek word that the BSB translates as And at once introduces an important event in the story. Simon and Andrew obeyed Jesus without delay.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Immediately (ESV)

Right away

Right then (CEV)

they left their nets: The clause they left their nets implies that Simon and Andrew stopped their work as fishermen. They abandoned their fishing work and became Jesus' disciples. You may want to include some implied information to make this clear. For example:

they left/abandoned their nets and their fishing work

and followed Him: As mentioned in 4:19a, the words followed Him imply that Simon and Andrew became Jesus' disciples. They accepted Jesus' request to follow him and become his disciples. You may want to make this information explicit. For example:

and followed him and became his disciples

and went with him to become his disciples

Matthew 4:21

Section 4:18–22: Jesus chose his first four disciples

This section describes two related events that happened near Lake Galilee during the early part of Jesus' ministry in Galilee. First Jesus asked Peter and his brother Andrew to become his disciples. Later he asked James and his brother John to become his disciples. All four of these men were fishermen. These became four of his twelve disciples.

Here are some other headings for this section:

Jesus chose four fishermen to be his disciples

Jesus asked four men to follow him

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 1:16–20 and Luke 5:1–11.

4:21a

Going on from there,

- ¶ As he/Jesus went further along the shore,
- ¶ Then he/Jesus continued walking along the lake.

Going on from there: The phrase Going on from there connects 4:21 with the preceding paragraph. Jesus continued walking along the shore from where he had met Simon and Andrew.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

As Jesus continued walking by Lake Galilee (NCV)

A little farther up the shore (NLT)

Then he went further (JBP)

4:21b

He saw two other brothers,

- he saw two other men who were brothers.
- He saw another man and his younger brother.

He saw two other brothers: The phrase two other brothers refers to two other men who also were brothers of each other. They were not brothers of Simon and Andrew. They were not brothers of Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

another man and his brother

two other men who were brothers

4:21c**James son of Zebedee and his brother John.**

- They were James and his brother John. They were sons of Zebedee.
- The older brother's name was James. His younger brother's name was John. Their father's name was Zebedee.

James son of Zebedee and his brother John: In New Testament times, Jewish people used the name of their father to identify the family they belonged to. Zebedee was the father of James and John.

The phrase his brother refers to James. James' brother was John. The phrase his brother does not refer to Zebedee. Zebedee was the father of both James and John.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he saw two other brothers, James and John, the sons of Zebedee (GW)

Jesus saw two more brothers, James and John, the sons of Zebedee. (NCV)

he saw two more men, who were brothers of each other, James and John, Zebedee's sons

See the note in 4:18c for ways to translate the word brother. Since John was mentioned last, he was probably the younger brother.

4:21d**They were in a boat with their father Zebedee, mending their nets.**

- They were in a boat with their father Zebedee and were getting their nets ready.
- They^(dual) were sitting in a fishing boat along with their father, and they were repairing and preparing their nets to go fishing.

They were in a boat: The boats used on Lake Galilee were small boats used for fishing and travel across the lake. They could hold from about four to fifteen people. People used oars (long paddles) to cause the boats to move across the water. Larger boats also had sails. (Sails are very large pieces of strong cloth that are attached to tall posts on the boat. The wind blows against the cloth which in turn pushes the whole boat.)

If you do not have a word for this kind of boat in your language, here are some other ways to translate this word:

- Use a word for a specific kind of boat in your culture. For example:

canoe

- Use a phrase that describes the function of a boat. For example:

a vehicle for crossing water

something for carrying people on top of water

Think about how your language talks about people being in a boat. In some languages it may be more natural to say that they were riding or sitting in a boat.

with their father Zebedee: In some languages, it may be natural to use the name Zebedee only once in this verse. So you would not repeat it here. For example:

with their father (CEV)

mending their nets: The Greek word that the BSB translates as mending means "restoring to its former condition." This includes:

1. repairing/mending the parts of the net that were broken or torn. For example:

repairing their nets (NLT)

1. cleaning and folding the nets to get the nets ready for the next day of fishing For example:

getting their nets ready (GNT)

preparing their nets to go fishing (GW)

4:21e**Jesus called them,**

- Jesus also called them to follow him.
- Jesus asked/invited the two of them also to come and be his disciples.

Jesus called them: In this context, the Greek verb that the BSB translates as called means "invited" or "summoned." The text implies that Jesus was inviting them to become his disciples. It does not mean "called out" or "shouted."

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

Jesus asked them to come with him too (CEV)

Jesus told them also to come and follow him

Jesus invited them to be his disciples

This invitation may also be expressed as a direct quote. For example:

Jesus said to them, “Come with me and be my disciples.”

them: The pronoun them refers only to James and John. It does not include their father Zebedee. If this is not clear then you may want to translate this as:

Jesus invited the two of them to be his disciples

Matthew 4:22

Section 4:18–22: Jesus chose his first four disciples

This section describes two related events that happened near Lake Galilee during the early part of Jesus’ ministry in Galilee. First Jesus asked Peter and his brother Andrew to become his disciples. Later he asked James and his brother John to become his disciples. All four of these men were fishermen. These became four of his twelve disciples.

Here are some other headings for this section:

Jesus chose four fishermen to be his disciples

Jesus asked four men to follow him

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 1:16–20 and Luke 5:1–11.

4:22

and immediately they left the boat and their father and followed Him.

- They immediately left the boat and their father and followed Jesus.
- Without delay they^(dual) left the boat and their work as fishermen. They also left their father and went with Jesus to become his disciples.

immediately: The Greek word that the BSB translates as immediately is the same word as in 4:20. See the translation advice there.

they left the boat and their father: The Greek word that the BSB translates as they left is the same word

as in 4:20. This word implies that James and John abandoned their boat and stopped their work as fishermen.

You may want to include some implied information to make this clear. For example:

they left their father, abandoned their boat and their fishing work

and followed Him: The words followed Him are the same words as in 4:20. These words imply that Simon and Andrew became Jesus’ disciples. They accepted Jesus’ request to follow him and become his disciples. You may want to make this information explicit. For example:

and followed him and became his disciples

and went with him to become his disciples

Matthew 4:23

Section 4:23–25: Jesus taught, preached, and healed many people

Before this time, not many people knew about Jesus. But soon the news of his teaching and healing spread throughout Galilee and then into neighboring regions and beyond as well. Some of these regions were Jewish and some were non-Jewish.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The ministry of Jesus in Galilee

Jesus did God’s work and the news of him spread beyond Galilee

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 6:17–19.

Paragraph 4:23–25

This paragraph tells where Jesus began his ministry of preaching, teaching, and healing, and how the people responded it.

The events in this paragraph probably happened soon after Jesus called his first disciples. In some languages, it may be natural to begin this paragraph with a time word. For example:

Then

4:23a**Jesus went throughout Galilee,**

- ¶ Then Jesus went all over the district of Galilee.
- ¶ At that time, Jesus traveled from place to place all over the district of Galilee.

Jesus went throughout Galilee: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as Jesus went throughout Galilee means that Jesus went from village to village and from town to town in the district of Galilee. The Greek tense of the verb indicates continuous or repeated activity. Jesus did this over a long period of time, perhaps a few months.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus went everywhere in Galilee (NCV)

Jesus was going throughout all Galilee (NASB)

Jesus traveled throughout the region of Galilee (NLT)

4:23b**teaching in their synagogues,**

- He taught about God in the synagogues of those people,
- At each place, he taught the Jews in their prayer/worship houses.

teaching: In this context, the verb teaching probably indicates that Jesus taught from the Scriptures. He made the meaning clear.

in their synagogues: The word synagogues refers to buildings where Jews gathered to pray, read Scripture, teach their beliefs, and worship God. The Jews also gathered in synagogues for cultural activities. There was only one temple, but each Jewish community had a synagogue.

The word their refers to Jews in those locations.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

prayer-houses of the Jews

meeting-places of the Jews

buildings for worship

houses for gathering together

The term you use for synagogue should be different from the term you use for “temple.” The temple was the main Jewish house of worship, which was located in the city of Jerusalem.

If the word synagogue is already known in your area, you may write it according to the sounds of your language. You may want to include a word or phrase to explain the meaning. For example:

sinagog house/building

See synagogue in the Glossary for more information.

4:23c**preaching the gospel of the kingdom,**

- and he told people the good news/words about the kingdom of God,
- He also announced the good news that God is starting to rule over his people.

preaching: The Greek word that the BSB translates as preaching also occurs in 4:17. Here are some other ways to translate this word:

announcing (NLT)

proclaiming (ESV)

telling people

the gospel of the kingdom: The Greek word that the BSB translates as gospel is sometimes translated as “good news” (NIV). In the New Testament, this Greek word specifically means “the good news that God has made a way to save sinful people through Jesus.”

In Matthew, the word kingdom is usually referred to by the fuller expression “kingdom of heaven.” It refers to God’s rule in a person’s life.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the good message about God’s kingdom

the good news concerning God’s kingship/ruling

the good news about submitting to God’s rule/authority

You may want to look at kingdom of heaven in the Glossary for more information.

4:23d and healing every disease and sickness among the people.

- and he healed people who had every type of disease and illness.
- He cured people from all types of diseases, illnesses, disabilities, and other sicknesses.

healing every disease and sickness: The words disease and sickness are a doublet. This means that these words have almost the same meaning. Together, these words refer to every type of illness and physical problem that people can have.

Different cultures categorize diseases and physical problems in different ways. As you translate this clause, remember that Jesus healed people of leprosy, fever, blindness, demon-possession, and various handicaps. You should find terms that cover all (or most) of these.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Use two terms. For example:

healing all the people's diseases and sicknesses (NCV)

healing every disease and handicap

curing every illness and injury

- Use more than two terms. For example:

he cured people who were sick, handicapped, and injured

he healed people who had every type of disease, illness, disability, and other sickness

- Use one term. For example:

healing every kind of sickness

curing everyone who was not feeling well

Matthew 4:24

Section 4:23–25: Jesus taught, preached, and healed many people

Before this time, not many people knew about Jesus. But soon the news of his teaching and healing spread throughout Galilee and then into neighboring regions

and beyond as well. Some of these regions were Jewish and some were non-Jewish.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The ministry of Jesus in Galilee

Jesus did God's work and the news of him spread beyond Galilee

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 6:17–19.

Paragraph 4:23–25

This paragraph tells where Jesus began his ministry of preaching, teaching, and healing, and how the people responded it.

The events in this paragraph probably happened soon after Jesus called his first disciples. In some languages, it may be natural to begin this paragraph with a time word. For example:

Then

4:24

The Greek of 4:24 begins with a word that is often translated as “and” or “so” (ESV). This word indicates that verse 4:24 is the result of 4:23d. Jesus was healing every disease and sickness among the people in Galilee (4:23d), so as a result of that, news of his healing spread to all of Syria, and the people from there brought their sick people to Jesus (4:24).

Here are some other ways to show this connection:

Consequently

As a result

Because of this

Some English versions leave the connection implicit, as the BSB does.

4:24a

News about Him spread all over Syria,

- The news about him/Jesus spread throughout Syria,
- As a result, people in all parts of the district/province of Syria heard about him.

News about Him: The phrase News about Him refers to the news about the miracles of healing that Jesus did.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

his fame (ESV)

a report about him (NET)

His reputation (JBP)

spread all over Syria: The word Syria is the name of another district/province like Judea and Galilee. Jesus was traveling throughout Galilee, and even people in the neighboring district of Syria heard about his miracles.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

spread all over Syria (CEV)

became known in the entire province/district of Syria

4:24b

and people brought to Him

- and they who heard brought to him
- So they brought to Jesus

people brought to Him: The clause people brought to Him means “people brought their sick to him/Jesus.” Another way to translate this clause is to use a passive. For example:

^{24c-g}all those who were ill with various diseases...
^{24b}were brought to him

4:24c

all who were ill with various diseases, those suffering acute pain,

- all the people who were sick and were suffering from an illness and/or great pain,
- all of their sick people, and all of their people who were suffering,
- everyone who was not well.

all who were ill with various diseases, those suffering acute pain: In this clause, the word ill is a very general term that includes all those who were not well or who had a physical problem. The terms with

various diseases and those suffering acute pain are two categories of people who were sick.

Here is one way to translate this clause:

all the people who were sick and were suffering from different diseases and pains

Different cultures categorize sicknesses, diseases, and physical problems in different ways. So you should translate the clauses in 4:24c using terms and categories that are natural in your language to refer to sick people.

Here are some other ways to translate these clauses:

people who had various diseases, people who had pain

sick people, and people who were suffering from pain

people with every kind of illness

people who were not well

all who were ill with various diseases: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as all who were ill with various diseases indicates that one person was suffering from one type of disease, another person was suffering from a different type of disease. It does not mean that each person had several types of diseases.

4:24d

the demon-possessed,

- and those who had a demon/evil spirit,
- They brought those people whom evil/bad spirits controlled,

the demon-possessed: The phrase the demon-possessed refers to people who were controlled by demons. Demons controlled the thoughts and actions of these people.

Languages have different ways to refer to possession by demons or evil spirits.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Some of them had a lot of demons in them (CEV)

people controlled by demons

people on whom evil spirits had fastened

demon: The word demon refers to a spirit being who was once an angel, but who rebelled against God. A demon is also referred to as “evil spirit.” A demon is not the spirit of a dead person.

Here are some other ways to translate demon:

- Use a general term in your language that refers to a spirit that is evil and can control people. For example:

a demon

a devil

- Use a specific term in your language that refers to a certain type of spirit. Do not use a term that refers to the spirit of a dead person.
- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

an evil spirit

See demon in the Glossary for more information.

4:24e those having seizures,

- and those who had seizures/spasms,
- and those people who were epileptic,

those having seizures: The Greek word that the BSB translates as those having seizures refers to people who have epilepsy. A person who has an attack of epilepsy has a seizure. During the seizure, this person suffers various things. He loses consciousness, he falls down and may injure himself, and his body stiffens and begins to shake violently. After a while, the person stops shaking and regains consciousness.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

people who have spasms

epileptics (ESV)

people who faint and shake/tremble violently

4:24f and the paralyzed—

- and those who had paralyzed/crippled legs,
- and those people who could not walk.

and the paralyzed: The word paralyzed refers in general to people whose legs are paralyzed. They cannot walk. It can also refer to people who cannot move some other part their bodies.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

people who are crippled/lame

others could not walk (CEV)

4:24g and He healed them.

- and he healed/cured them all.
- Jesus cured all the sick people and made the other people well.

and He healed them: The word healed is the same word as in 4:23d.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

he cured them

he made them well

he caused them to be healthy again

In some cultures, paralyzed people are not considered to be sick. So it is not possible to use the verb healed to describe what Jesus did to all the people. It may be necessary to use two or more verbs here. For example:

he healed the sick and made the others well

Jesus healed miraculously through God’s power. If people in your area will think that Jesus only healed as a doctor does, you may want to include some implied information. For example:

he miraculously healed them

Matthew 4:25

Section 4:23–25: Jesus taught, preached, and healed many people

Before this time, not many people knew about Jesus. But soon the news of his teaching and healing spread throughout Galilee and then into neighboring regions and beyond as well. Some of these regions were Jewish and some were non-Jewish.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The ministry of Jesus in Galilee

Jesus did God's work and the news of him spread beyond Galilee

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 6:17-19.

Paragraph 4:23-25

This paragraph tells where Jesus began his ministry of preaching, teaching, and healing, and how the people responded it.

The events in this paragraph probably happened soon after Jesus called his first disciples. In some languages, it may be natural to begin this paragraph with a time word. For example:

Then

4:25a

The large crowds that followed Him came from Galilee,

- Very many people traveled/went with him. They came from Galilee,
- Large crowds followed him. Many people came from the district/province of Galilee.

The large crowds that followed Him came from Galilee: The phrase large crowds indicates a very great number of people. The word crowds is plural because many people came from Galilee, many others came from Decapolis, many others came from Jerusalem, and so forth.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Very many people

Large numbers of people

that followed Him: Here the phrase followed Him probably means "went with Jesus." In other contexts, it can mean "became a disciple of Jesus." Some people in the crowd may have followed Jesus for the purpose of being his disciples, but others followed him only to see his miracles. Here you should translate followed in a literal way. For example:

went with him

accompanied him

followed him wherever he went (NLT)

4:25b

the Decapolis, Jerusalem, Judea,

- the area called "the Ten Towns," Jerusalem and the district of Judea,
- Many other people came from the area called "the Ten Towns." Other people came from the city of Jerusalem and other areas of the province of Judea.

the Decapolis: The word Decapolis means "the ten cities." It refers to a region where there was a group of ten cities that had special status under Roman law.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

- Transliterate the term as the BSB and some other versions do. For example:

the Decapolis

Dekapolisi

- Translate the meaning of the term. For example:

the Ten Towns (GNT)

the Ten Cities (GW)

Jerusalem, Judea: The names Jerusalem and Judea are mentioned together, but Jerusalem is a city and Judea is a district. Jerusalem was the main city in Judea. You may want to make it clear that Jerusalem was in Judea. For example:

Jerusalem and other areas of the district of Judea

4:25c

and beyond the Jordan.

- and the area on the other side of the Jordan River.
- Other people came from the region on the east side of the Jordan River. They all came and followed him wherever he went.

and beyond the Jordan: The phrase beyond the Jordan refers to land on the east side of the Jordan River. Jerusalem was on the west side of the Jordan River. Other land was referred to as land beyond, across, or on the other side of the Jordan River.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the land across the Jordan River (NCV)

from east of the Jordan River (NLT)

the land on the other side of the Jordan River

Matthew 5:1

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 5:1–2

This paragraph describes the setting for the entire Sermon on the Mount in chapters 5–7.

5:1a–b

When Jesus saw the crowds, He went up on the mountain: The last verse in chapter 4 mentions that large crowds came and followed Jesus. Here in 5:1, we read that when Jesus saw the crowds, he went up a mountain. Jesus probably went up the mountain to escape the crowds. He did not go up the mountain so that he would have a better place to speak to the entire crowd. The teachings in chapters 5–7 were intended primarily for his disciples. So he wanted to find a more private place where he would be away from most of the crowd. See France (2007), page 153 and page 156; Turner (2008), page 149; Osborne, pages 164–165; Hagner, page 85.

In some languages, it may be important to make some of this information explicit. For example:

^{1a}When Jesus saw the crowds, ^{1b}he went up a mountainside to be alone with his disciples.

^{1a}When Jesus saw the crowds, ^{1b}he went up a mountainside to get away from the crowd.

By the end of his sermon, many people had gathered (7:28–29), and they also heard what he said. But his first desire was to speak to his disciples in a more private place.

5:1a

When Jesus saw the crowds,

- ¶ When he saw the large group of people,
- ¶ When Jesus saw all those people following him,

the crowds: The phrase the crowds refers to the same large group of people mentioned in 4:23–25.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

those same crowds

the very large group of people following him

5:1b

He went up on the mountain and sat down.

- he went up a hill/mountain, and he sat down to teach.
- he climbed up a hillside to be alone with his followers/learners. Then he sat down to teach,

He went up on the mountain: The BSB literally translates the Greek phrase here as the mountain. But the exact mountain or hill is not known. In languages that distinguish between definite and indefinite articles, it will be better to say “a mountain/hill.” For example:

he went up on a mountainside (NIV)

and went up a hill (GNT)

he climbed part way up a mountain to be alone with his disciples

The mountains/hills near Lake Galilee vary in height from about 30 meters (about 100 feet) to as high as 500 meters (1640 feet) above the lake. Use a term in your language that refers to this size of mountain/hill.

sat down: Jesus sat down because it was the Jewish custom for a teacher to sit down when he taught. Jesus did not sit down because he was tired and wanted to rest.

To make it clearer in your language why Jesus sat down, you could translate these words as:

sat down to teach them (NLT96)

5:1c**His disciples came to Him,**

- His disciples came to him,
- and his followers/learners gathered around him.

His disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples refers to “learners” who are in a special relationship with a teacher. The learners commit themselves to their teacher in order to learn from him and live according to his teaching and example. In the New Testament, disciples refer specifically to people who were learning from a religious teacher. Disciples often lived with their teacher and followed him wherever he went.

Here are some other ways to translate disciples:

- Use a term that refers to people who learn from a teacher or an expert. It is helpful if the term also implies that the learners are often with their teacher. For example:

learners/students

apprentices Be careful not to use a term that would refer only to students in a school or classroom.

- Use a term that refers to people who follow a teacher or leader by obeying his teaching. It is helpful if this term also implies learning from the teacher and actually following the teacher wherever he goes. For example:

followers

those who are committed/faithful (to a teacher/leader)

See disciple in the Glossary for more information.

Matthew 5:2**Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain**

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 5:1–2

This paragraph describes the setting for the entire Sermon on the Mount in chapters 5–7.

5:2**and He began to teach them, saying:**

- and he began to teach them. He said:
- This is what he taught them:

and He began to teach them, saying: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as He began to teach them is literally “he opened his mouth” (as in the ESV). The phrase is an idiom. This idiom means “he began.”

The verses that follow are the things Jesus taught. Your translation should clearly indicate that. For example:

Then he began to speak. This is what he taught them: (NJB)

he opened his mouth and taught them, saying: (ESV)

them: The pronoun them refers to the disciples. Other people came later to listen. But in the beginning, Jesus’ primary audience was his disciples.

Matthew 5:3**Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain**

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 5:3–10

There are eight “blessings” in verses 3–10. Each of the eight blessings has two parts. Each blessing starts with the words “Blessed are” and tells what kind of person is blessed. Each blessing ends with the reason why that kind of person is blessed. Each blessing is a short statement like a proverb.

Some English versions begin a new section at 5:3. One possibility is to put a general heading like “The sermon on the mountain” at 5:1 and the heading of “God blesses his people” here.

5:3a**“Blessed are the poor in spirit,**

- ¶ “Fortunate/Favored are the people who know that they are lacking spiritually,
- ¶ “God will bless/favor those who realize their need of him,
- ¶ “Those who recognize that they are dependent on God are in a good/favorable position.

Blessed are: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Blessed refers to the good situation/condition that a person is in when a superior person does something good to him. When God does something good to a human being and is kind to him, that person is in a good situation. He is “blessed,” “fortunate,” and “favored.”

Here are some other ways to translate Blessed are:

Favored/fortunate

God favors/approves

Joyful/desirable is the situation of

How good it is for

This word does not primarily refer to a feeling. However, a person in this good situation will frequently have good feelings like happiness and joy. Do not use a word that only refers to material prosperity or physical health. Do not use a word that refers only to being lucky. See also bless, Meaning 2, in the Glossary.

the poor in spirit: The word poor often means “lacking money or material resources.” However, here the word is used in a spiritual sense. It means “lacking spiritual resources.” People who are poor in spirit know that they are lacking spiritually. They are lacking what it takes to please God. As a result, they know that they

need God’s help. They are dependent on God, and they gladly accept his rule over them.

Every person is lacking spiritually without God, but not every person recognizes it.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

those who know that they are lacking regarding the things of God

those who recognize that they are dependent on God

those who realize their need for him (NLT)

5:3b**for theirs is the kingdom of heaven.**

- because the kingdom of God belongs to them.
- because they are the people/citizens of his kingdom.
- God accepts them as the people whom he rules over.

for: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as for introduces the reason that the “poor in spirit” are blessed. They are blessed because the kingdom of heaven belongs to them. For example:

because the kingdom of heaven belongs to them (NCV)

In some languages, no conjunction is necessary here. For example:

The kingdom of heaven belongs to them. (GW)

In other languages, it will be more natural to put 5:3b before 5:3a. For example:

The poor in spirit have the kingdom of heaven, so they are blessed.

The kingdom of heaven is for the poor in spirit, so they are blessed.

theirs is the kingdom of heaven: The word theirs refers to the people who are “poor in spirit.” They are the kind of people who share in the kingdom of heaven. They belong in it, and it belongs to them. These people who let God rule over them are the ones he blesses.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

the Kingdom of heaven belongs to them! (GNT)

God accepts them into his kingdom

they are citizens of the kingdom of God

the kingdom of heaven: The phrase kingdom of heaven has the same meaning as the phrase “kingdom of God.” Both phrases refer to God’s activity of ruling and caring for his people as their king. Both refer to the relationship that God has with his people. He leads, protects, and cares for them. They obey, trust, and submit to him as their king. The phrase kingdom of heaven does not refer to a land or country that he rules over.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

- As a noun. For example:

the kingdom of God

God’s kingship

God’s rule over people

the rule of the one/Lord who lives in heaven

- As a verbal expression. For example:

The way God rules his people

The way God cares for his people as king.

See kingdom of heaven in the Glossary for more information.

This same phrase occurs in 3:2b and 4:17c.

Matthew 5:4

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 5:3–10

There are eight “blessings” in verses 3–10. Each of the eight blessings has two parts. Each blessing starts with the words “Blessed are” and tells what kind of person is blessed. Each blessing ends with the reason why that kind of person is blessed. Each blessing is a short statement like a proverb.

Some English versions begin a new section at 5:3. One possibility is to put a general heading like “The sermon on the mountain” at 5:1 and the heading of “God blesses his people” here.

5:4a

Blessed are those who mourn,

- Fortunate/Favored are the people who mourn now,
- God will bless/favor those who grieve,
- Those who are sad/sorrowful are in a favorable position.

Blessed are: For help in translating the word Blessed, see the note at 5:3a.

those who mourn: The Greek word that the BSB translates as mourn refers to being very sad or grieving. The word is probably used in a general way and does not refer only to mourning because someone has died. It refers to situations in the world that cause grief and sorrow.

Here are some other ways to translate those who mourn:

those who are sad now (NCV)

those people who grieve (CEV)

those who are sorrowful

5:4b

for they will be comforted.

- because they will be comforted/encouraged by God.
- because God/he will console them.
- God will cause them to no longer be sad/sorrowful.

for: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as for introduces the reason that “those who mourn”

are blessed. They are blessed because they will be comforted. For example:

because God will comfort them (NCV)

In some languages, no conjunction is necessary here. For example:

They will be comforted. (GW)

In other languages, it will be more natural to put 5:4b before 5:4a. For example:

Those who mourn will be comforted, so they are blessed.

God will comfort those who mourn, so they are blessed.

they will be comforted: The clause they will be comforted is passive. In this context, it is God who will comfort those who mourn.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- Use a passive form. For example:

they will be comforted by God

- Use an active form. For example:

God will comfort them (NCV)

God will cause them to no longer be sad/sorrowful

They will find comfort! (CEV)

Matthew 5:5

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 5:3–10

There are eight “blessings” in verses 3–10. Each of the eight blessings has two parts. Each blessing starts with the words “Blessed are” and tells what kind of person is blessed. Each blessing ends with the reason why that kind of person is blessed. Each blessing is a short statement like a proverb.

Some English versions begin a new section at 5:3. One possibility is to put a general heading like “The sermon on the mountain” at 5:1 and the heading of “God blesses his people” here.

5:5a

Blessed are the meek,

- Fortunate/Favored are the people who are gentle,
- God will bless/favor those who are humble,
- Those who are not aggressive are in a favorable position.

Blessed are: For help in translating the word Blessed, see the note at 5:3a.

the meek: The Greek word that the BSB translates as meek refers to people who are gentle and humble. A person who is meek is not aggressive or quick to retaliate.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

those who are gentle (GW)

those who are humble (GNT)

those who are not aggressive

5:5b

for they will inherit the earth.

- because they will possess the earth.
- because they will receive the whole earth.
- The earth will belong to them! (CEV)

for: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as for introduces the reason that “the meek” are blessed. They are blessed because they shall inherit the earth. For example:

because the earth will belong to them (NCV)

In some languages, no conjunction is necessary here. For example:

They will inherit the earth. (GW)

In other languages, it will be more natural to put 5:5b before 5:5a. For example:

The meek will inherit the earth, so they are blessed.

they will inherit the earth: In this context, the word inherit means “possess” or “acquire.” In your translation you may want to use a more general term as well. For example:

The earth will belong to them (CEV)

they will receive the whole earth

the earth: There are two ways to interpret the phrase the earth:

1. It is literal and refers to the whole earth. It probably refers to the promise of the new earth (Revelation 21:1) in God’s kingdom. For example:

because the earth will belong to them (NCV) (BSB, RSV, ESV, NIV, NJB, NASB, GW, CEV, NET, JBP, REB, KJV, NCV)

1. It is figurative and refers to all that God has promised to his people. For example:

they will receive what God has promised (GNT) (GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and the majority of English versions.

Matthew 5:6

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 5:3–10

There are eight “blessings” in verses 3–10. Each of the eight blessings has two parts. Each blessing starts with the words “Blessed are” and tells what kind of person is blessed. Each blessing ends with the reason why that kind of person is blessed. Each blessing is a short statement like a proverb.

Some English versions begin a new section at 5:3. One possibility is to put a general heading like “The sermon on the mountain” at 5:1 and the heading of “God blesses his people” here.

5:6a

Blessed are those who hunger and thirst for righteousness,

- Fortunate/Favored are the people who desire to do what is right as much as someone who is hungry desires food and someone who is thirsty desires water,
- God will bless those who strongly want to do what he wills/requires,
- Those who very much want to do what is right are in a favorable position.

Blessed are: For help in translating the word Blessed, see the note at 5:3a.

those who hunger and thirst: The verbs hunger and thirst are both used figuratively here. Both verbs refer to desiring something very much, just as people desire food when they are hungry and water when they are thirsty.

Here are some other ways to translate these verbs:

- Change the clause to a simile. For example:

those who want righteousness like people who are hungry and thirsty for it

those who desire righteousness as much as those who are hungry desire food and thirsty desire water

- Translate the meaning of the figure. For example:

greatly desire

want to (NCV)

for righteousness: The word righteousness refers to doing the right and good things that God wants. A righteous person has good morals and is honest. A minority opinion held by some commentators (see Hagner, page 93 for example) is that the Greek word refers to “justice.” According to this interpretation, people who hunger and thirst for righteousness are those who desire God to exercise justice in the world. The REB (Blessed are those who hunger and thirst to see right prevail) probably follows this interpretation.

Here are some other ways to translate righteousness:

do what is right

do what God wills/desires

do what God requires (GNT)

do what God considers right

This same word occurs in 3:15b.

5:6b

for they will be filled.

- for they will be satisfied.
- because they will be given the power to do it.
- God will help them do it.

for: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *for* introduces the reason that “those who hunger and thirst for righteousness” are blessed. They are blessed because they shall be satisfied. For example:

because God will fully satisfy them (NCV)

In some languages, no conjunction is necessary here. For example:

They will be satisfied. (GW)

In other languages, it will be more natural to put 5:6b before 5:6a. For example:

Those who hunger and thirst for righteousness will be satisfied, so they are blessed.

they will be filled: The clause they will be filled refers to satisfying or filling those who “hunger and thirst for righteousness.” Like a hungry person eats and is

filled, God will satisfy/fill those who desire righteousness. This means that he will help them to become righteous.

Your translation of this clause will depend on whether you literally translated “hunger and thirst” in 5:6a. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

1. If you have kept the verbs “hunger and thirst,” you may be able to literally translate “filled/satisfied.” Here are some other ways to do this:

- Use a passive form. For example:

they will be satisfied (NET)

- Use an active form. For example:

God will fully satisfy them (NCV)

1. If you have not kept the figures of “hunger and thirst,” you may have to translate the verb will be filled in another way. Here are some other ways to do this:

- Use a passive form. For example:

they will be given the power to do it

- Use an active form. For example:

God will help them to do this

Matthew 5:7

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 5:3–10

There are eight “blessings” in verses 3–10. Each of the eight blessings has two parts. Each blessing starts with the words “Blessed are” and tells what kind of person is blessed. Each blessing ends with the reason why that kind of person is blessed. Each blessing is a short statement like a proverb.

Some English versions begin a new section at 5:3. One possibility is to put a general heading like “The sermon on the mountain” at 5:1 and the heading of “God blesses his people” here.

5:7a**Blessed are the merciful,**

- Fortunate/Favored are the people who show mercy to others,
- God will bless those who pity/love other people,
- Those who are kind/compassionate to others are in a favorable position.

Blessed are: For help in translating the word Blessed, see the note at 5:3a.

the merciful: The phrase the merciful refers to people who have or show “mercy” or “pity” toward other people. Here “mercy” means:

1. to show compassion to those who suffer or are in physical need
2. to refrain from punishing someone for the wrong he has done

This phrase includes both compassionate feelings and compassionate actions.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

those who show mercy (GW)

those who are merciful to others (GNT)

the people who show pity/love/sympathy to other people

those who are kind to others

5:7b**for they will be shown mercy.**

- because mercy will be shown to them.
- because God/he will pity/love them.
- God will be kind/compassionate to them.

for: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as for introduces the reason that “the merciful” are

blessed. They are blessed because they will receive mercy. For example:

because God will show mercy to them (NCV)

In some languages, no conjunction is necessary here. For example:

They will be treated mercifully. (GW)

In other languages, it will be more natural to put 5:7b before 5:7a. For example:

Those who are merciful will receive mercy, so they are blessed.

God will be merciful to those who are merciful to others, so they are blessed.

they will be shown mercy: The Greek verb that the BSB literally translates as will be shown mercy means that people who are merciful to others will receive mercy from God. He is the one who will show mercy to them. He will pity them and help them in their suffering and physical needs.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

because God will show mercy to them (NCV)

God will be merciful to them! (GNT)

God will show pity/love/sympathy to them

Here this phrase does not mean that if someone is merciful to people, those people will show mercy to him in return.

Matthew 5:8**Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain**

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 5:3–10

There are eight “blessings” in verses 3–10. Each of the eight blessings has two parts. Each blessing starts with the words “Blessed are” and tells what kind of person is blessed. Each blessing ends with the reason why that kind of person is blessed. Each blessing is a short statement like a proverb.

Some English versions begin a new section at 5:3. One possibility is to put a general heading like “The sermon on the mountain” at 5:1 and the heading of “God blesses his people” here.

5:8a

Blessed are the pure in heart,

- Fortunate/Favored are the people whose thoughts are pure,
- God will bless those who have good/right desires,
- Those who have nothing evil in their insides are in a favorable position.

Blessed are: For help in translating the word Blessed, see the note at 5:3a.

the pure in heart: The word pure means “clean” and “without sin.” People who are pure in heart have nothing in their hearts for which they can be blamed or accused. They are completely devoted to God and his will/commands.

The word heart here refers to one’s inner life. It indicates the essential person, where one’s emotions, thoughts, and motives occur.

For the word heart, use a term that is normally used in your language for “inner life.” It may be a different organ such as “liver” or “throat.” Or it may be a more general term such as “insides” or “spirit.”

Here are some other ways to translate the phrase the pure in heart:

those whose thoughts are pure (GW)

people who only have morally pure desires

those who have nothing evil in their insides

5:8b

for they will see God.

- because they will see God.

- because they will see him.
- One day, they will see God in heaven.

for: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as for introduces the reason that “the pure in heart” are blessed. They are blessed because they will see God. For example:

because they will be with God (NCV)

In some languages, no conjunction is necessary here. For example:

They will see God. (GW)

In other languages, it will be more natural to put 5:8b before 5:8a. For example:

Those who are pure in heart will see God, so they are blessed.

they will see God: The clause they will see God refers to seeing God in the next life.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

they will see God face to face

they will see God in heaven

Matthew 5:9

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 5:3–10

There are eight “blessings” in verses 3–10. Each of the eight blessings has two parts. Each blessing starts

with the words “Blessed are” and tells what kind of person is blessed. Each blessing ends with the reason why that kind of person is blessed. Each blessing is a short statement like a proverb.

Some English versions begin a new section at 5:3. One possibility is to put a general heading like “The sermon on the mountain” at 5:1 and the heading of “God blesses his people” here.

5:9a

Blessed are the peacemakers,

- Fortunate/Favored are the people who help others be at peace,
- God will bless those who help people reconcile,
- Those who help others stop quarreling/fighting are in a favorable position.

Blessed are: For help in translating the word Blessed, see the note at 5:3a.

the peacemakers: The word peacemakers refers to people who help others to reconcile. They try to make peace between people or groups of people who are involved in serious disagreements, quarrels, or fights. People who are peacemakers try to calm down the quarreling people. They try to get each person to forgive the other. And they try to help the adversaries find a favorable solution to the conflict.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Those who work to bring peace (NCV)

those who help people reconcile

those who help others find harmony with one another

those who help others get along with one another

5:9b

for they will be called sons of God.

- because they will be referred to as children of God.
- because God will call them his children.
- God will say to them, ‘You are my children.’

for: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *for* introduces the reason that “the peacemakers” are blessed. They are blessed because they will be called sons of God. For example:

because God will call them his children (NCV)

In some languages, no conjunction is necessary here. For example:

They will be called God’s children. (GW)

In other languages, it will be more natural to put 5:9b before 5:9a. For example:

Those who are peacemakers will be called the sons of God, so they are blessed.

God will call the peacemakers his children, so they are blessed.

they will be called sons of God: The clause they will be called sons of God is passive. God is the one who calls peacemakers sons of God.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

they will be called God’s sons/children

- Use an active verb. For example:

God will call them his children (GNT)

God will say that they are his children

In some languages it may be more natural to use direct speech here. For example:

God will say to them, “You are my children.”

sons: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sons can also refer generally to “offspring,” both male and female. It refers to adults who are children of someone. Several English versions translate this word as “children.”

Matthew 5:10

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

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Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 5:3–10

There are eight “blessings” in verses 3–10. Each of the eight blessings has two parts. Each blessing starts with the words “Blessed are” and tells what kind of person is blessed. Each blessing ends with the reason why that kind of person is blessed. Each blessing is a short statement like a proverb.

Some English versions begin a new section at 5:3. One possibility is to put a general heading like “The sermon on the mountain” at 5:1 and the heading of “God blesses his people” here.

5:10a

Blessed are those who are persecuted because of righteousness,

- Fortunate/Favored are the people who are persecuted because they do what is right,
- God will bless those people who do what he wills/ requires and as a result people treat them badly,
- Those who do what is right and therefore others mistreat them, they are in a favorable position.

Blessed are: For help in translating the word Blessed, see the note at 5:3a.

those who are persecuted because of righteousness: This clause refers to people who do what God says is right, and for that reason other people persecute them.

persecuted: The word persecuted means “deliberately harm someone,” “mistreat someone” or “cause someone to suffer.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

mistreated

caused to suffer

oppressed

harmed on purpose

because of righteousness: The phrase because of righteousness indicates the reason for the persecu-

tion. It is because God’s people do what is good or right.

Here are some other ways to translate because of righteousness:

for doing good (NCV)

because they do what is right

for doing what God approves of (GW)

because they do what God requires (GNT)

The word righteousness also occurs in 5:6a. You should translate it in a similar way here.

Here is another way to translate this verse part:

God blesses those people who are treated badly for doing right (CEV)

5:10b

for theirs is the kingdom of heaven.

- because the kingdom of God belongs to them.
- because they are the people/citizens of his kingdom.
- God accepts them as the people whom he rules over.

for: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as for introduces the reason that the “those who are persecuted because of righteousness” are blessed. They are blessed because the kingdom of heaven belongs to them. For example:

because the kingdom of heaven belongs to them (NCV)

In some languages, no conjunction is necessary here. For example:

The kingdom of heaven belongs to them. (GW)

In other languages, it will be more natural to put 5:10b before 5:10a. For example:

Those who are persecuted because of righteousness have the kingdom of heaven, so they are blessed.

The kingdom of heaven is for those who are persecuted because of righteousness, so they are blessed.

theirs is the kingdom of heaven: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as theirs is the kingdom of heaven is exactly the same clause as in 5:3b. You should translate this clause here as you did there.

Matthew 5:11

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

5:11a

Blessed are you when people insult you, persecute you,

- ¶ “You^(plur) are fortunate/favored when people insult you, and mistreat you,
- ¶ “God will bless you^(plur) when people say bad things against you, treat you badly,
- ¶ “You^(plur) are in a favorable position when people mock you, and make you suffer,

In 5:11 the pronoun changes from “Blessed are those” to “Blessed are you^(plur).”

Blessed are you when people insult you: The Greek word that the BSB translates as insult can also be translated as “revile” (as in the ESV). It means to “treat someone or speak to someone with scorn or great disrespect.” It can also mean to “say or do something that hurts or intends to hurt the feelings of someone.” People insult Jesus’ followers in order to make them feel sad, shame them, or make others think that they are evil.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Blessed are you when others revile you (ESV)

You are blessed when people say bad things about you^(plur)

God blesses you when people mock you (NLT)

persecute you: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as persecute means “deliberately harm someone,” “mistreat someone” or “cause someone to suffer.” This word also occurs in 5:10a. You should translate it here as you did there.

5:11b

and falsely say all kinds of evil against you because of Me.

- and tell all kinds of evil lies about you^(plur) because of me.
- and lie saying that you^(plur) do all sorts of bad things. They will do this because you are my followers.
- and lie and say all kinds of evil things about you^(plur) because you follow me.

and falsely say all kinds of evil against you: The Greek word that the BSB translates as say means to “say/speak.” Jesus said that when people say all kinds of evil against his followers, what they are saying is a lie. This is indicated by the word that the BSB translates as falsely. Some people will lie and say that Jesus’ followers practice all sorts of bad behavior.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

tell all kinds of evil lies against you (GNT)

They will lie and say all kinds of evil things about you (NCV)

lie concerning you saying, “These people have done many evil things.”

because of Me: The Greek phrase that the BSB literally translates as because of Me gives the reason why people insult Jesus’ followers, persecute them, and say evil things to them. The reason is because they are Jesus’ followers. Those who oppose Jesus and his teachings will also oppose his followers who believe and teach the same message.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

because you are my followers (GNT)

on my account (ESV)

the reason is that you obey me

Matthew 5:12

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

5:12

Before you translate 5:12, consider what is the most natural order in your language for the clauses in this verse. In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of the BSB. Compare the BSB with the other examples below.

^{12a}Rejoice and be glad, because great is your reward in heaven; ^{12b}for in the same way they persecuted the prophets before you. (BSB)

^{12a}Your reward in heaven is great. So rejoice and be glad. ^{12b}For/Because they persecuted the prophets who were before you in the same way.

^{12b}They persecuted the prophets who were before you in the same way. ^{12a}So rejoice and be glad. Your reward in heaven is great.

5:12a

Rejoice and be glad, because great is your reward in heaven;

- Be very happy, because you will receive a big reward/gift in heaven,
- In heaven God will honor you greatly. So be extremely joyful!

Rejoice and be glad: The two Greek verbs that the BSB translates as Rejoice and be glad are a doublet. This means that the two words mean basically the same

thing. Saying the same thing in two different ways is a Hebrew way of making the command stronger.

Your language may be able to indicate a stronger command in the same way. But it may be more natural in your language to emphasize it in some other way. For example:

Be very happy/glad

You^(plur) should be extremely glad/joyful

Be glad then, yes, be tremendously glad (JBP)

because: The conjunction because introduces the reason why the disciples and the crowd should rejoice. They should rejoice because God will give them a big reward in heaven. For example:

because you have a great reward in heaven (GW)

In some languages, no conjunction is necessary here. For example:

You will have a great reward in heaven. (CEV)

In other languages, it will be more natural to change the order of the clauses in 5:12a. For example:

Your reward is great in heaven. So rejoice and be glad.

great is your reward in heaven: The phrase great is your reward in heaven means “you will receive something of great value when you go to heaven.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

a great reward awaits you in heaven (NLT)

you have a great reward waiting for you in heaven (NCV)

God will reward/honor you very much in heaven.

reward: The word reward normally refers to something good that people receive because of something that they have done. Here, the meaning of reward focuses on being honored for being faithful to Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate the word reward:

payment

gift

honor

heaven: Here the word heaven refers to the place where God lives.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

the place where God is

paradise

5:12b

for in the same way they persecuted the prophets before you.

- because they/people persecuted the prophets of long ago just like they persecute you.
- Those same kinds of people did the same evil things to the prophets who lived long before your time.”

In some languages, it will be more natural to put 5:12b before 5:12a. See the example above under 5:12.

for: The Greek word that the BSB translates as for introduces the reason why people who were insulted, persecuted, and spoken against should rejoice and be glad. They should rejoice and be glad because Jesus is praising them. He is praising them by comparing them to the Old Testament prophets.

In some languages, it is not necessary to put a conjunction here. For example:

People did these same things to the prophets who lived long ago. (CEV)

in the same way: The phrase in the same way introduces a comparison. Jesus was saying that people would do evil to Jesus’ disciples just as people had done evil to the prophets years earlier.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

like that

so (ESV)

what people do to you, that is what they did

they: The pronoun they refers to the people who persecuted the prophets many years before Jesus. The pronoun is also connected to the “people” of 5:11 because there are people in every generation who oppose God and mistreat his followers. You may be able to use the pronoun they with that connection here. But it may be more natural in your language to explain the connection. For example:

those same kind of people

people like them

persecuted: The word persecuted means to “treat someone cruelly and cause the person to suffer.” This same word occurs in 5:10a and 5:11a.

the prophets: The word prophets refers to men who spoke on behalf of God. They told people what God revealed to them. God gave some prophets power to work miracles. These miracles helped people realize that God sent the prophets.

Here are some other ways to translate prophets:

spokesmen for God

men who speak God’s words

God’s message-speakers

When choosing a term for prophets, consider how you will distinguish prophets from other words which are similar in meaning, such as “angels,” “apostles,” and “preachers.”

The word “prophet” also occurs in 1:22 and 4:14. See also prophet in the Glossary.

before you: The words before you refer to time. These prophets lived hundreds of years before the time when the disciples lived.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

who lived before you (GNT)

who lived long ago (CEV)

These prophets lived long before your time

Matthew 5:13

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

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Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 5:13

Jesus continued speaking here. If your audience would not understand that Jesus was speaking here, you may want to indicate this. For example:

Jesus continued

5:13a

You are the salt of the earth.

- ¶ “You^(plur) are the salt of the earth/world.
- ¶ “You^(plur) are like salt for the people of the earth/world.
- ¶ Jesus continued, “Just as salt is good for food, you^(plur) are good for the people of the world.

You are the salt of the earth: The clause You are the salt of the earth is a metaphor. In this metaphor, Jesus compared his disciples to salt. Here are some other ways that they are similar:

1. they both improve the lives of people
2. they both prevent deterioration

Salt improves the lives of people by making food taste better and by preventing food from spoiling. In the same way, believers improve the world and the people in it. They do this by living as God requires and by helping keep the people from being destroyed.

In some languages, a literal translation of this metaphor may be difficult to understand. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

You are like salt for everyone on earth. (CEV)

- Change the metaphor to a simile and make explicit the way that they are similar. For example:

You are good for the people of the world like salt is good for food.

- Translate it literally and put the meaning in a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

Salt makes things better. It makes food taste better, and it prevents food from spoiling. In the same way, believers improve the world and the people in it by living as God requires. They also help keep people from being destroyed.

You: The pronoun You is plural in Greek.

of the earth: The word earth is used in a figurative way. It refers to the people who live on earth.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

for everyone on earth (CEV)

for the whole human race (GNT)

5:13b

But if the salt loses its savor, how can it be made salty again?

- But if salt loses its taste/flavor, how can it be made salty again?
- However, if salt no longer has its flavor/strength, it is not possible to regain it.

But: There is a contrast between 5:13a and 5:13b. The contrast is between salt being salty in 5:13a and salt losing its saltiness in 5:13b. Most English versions indicate this contrast with the word “but.”

Here are some other ways to translate this contrast:

However

In contrast

if the salt loses its savor, how can it be made salty again?: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus used this rhetorical question to emphasize something. He emphasized that a person certainly cannot make salt salty again after it has lost its taste.

There are two ways to translate this emphasis:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

if salt loses its taste, how will it be made salty again? (GW)

- As a statement. For example:

if the salt loses its salty taste, it cannot be made salty again. (NCV)

if salt loses its saltiness, there is no way to make it salty again (GNT)

Translate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

5:13c

It is no longer good for anything, except to be thrown out and trampled by men.

- It is good for nothing, except to be thrown away and walked on by people.
- It is useless and will be thrown out, and people will walk on it.

It is no longer good for anything: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as good for anything also means “useful.” So this statement means that if salt has lost its saltiness, then it is no longer useful.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

It is good for nothing (NJB)

It is completely useless (JBP)

It is worth nothing

People can no longer do anything with it

except: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as except is literally “if not.” This phrase connects the two clauses in 5:13c.

Here are some other ways to connect these clauses:

- Use another conjunction. For example:

It has become worthless, so it is thrown out and people trample on it (GNT)

It is no longer good for anything, but is thrown out and trampled under foot. (NRSV)

- Connect them without a conjunction. For example:

It is no longer good for anything; it is thrown out, and people walk on it.

to be thrown out and trampled by men: The verb thrown out refers to removing the salt from the house by throwing it into the street or path.

The verb trampled refers to stepping on something while walking. It does not refer to deliberately stepping on something to smash it. Here it simply refers to people walking on the salt as they would walk on any other bits of trash that are thrown into the street.

Here is another way to translate trampled:

walked on (CEV)

In Greek, both verbs are passive.

Here are some other ways to translate these two passive verbs:

- Keep both verbs passive. For example:

All it is good for is to be thrown out and walked on. (CEV)

- Translate one verb as passive and the other as active. For example:

it is thrown out and people walk on it

- Translate both verbs as active. For example:

people throw it out and others walk on it

trampled by men: The word men is general and refers to people, both men and women.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

trampled under people's feet (ESV)

people trample on it (GNT)

Matthew 5:14

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

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Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

5:14a

You are the light of the world.

- ¶ “You^(plur) are the light for the people of the world.
- ¶ “You^(plur) are like light for the whole human race.
- ¶ “You^(plur) show the people of the world the way to God as a light shows them their path.

You are the light of the world: The phrase the light of the world is a metaphor. In this metaphor, Jesus compares his disciples to light. One way that light and the disciples are similar is that both help people in darkness. Light shines for people in darkness and shows them the path. In the same way, believers speak and live God’s truth to people in spiritual darkness and show them the path to God.

Here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

You are like light for the world

- Change the metaphor to a simile and make explicit the way that they are similar. For example:

You show the people of the world the way to God as a light shows them their path

- Explain the meaning in a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

Jesus compared his disciples to light. A light shines for those in darkness and shows them their path. In the same way, Jesus’ disciples should show the path to God to people in spiritual darkness.

You: As in 5:13a, the pronoun You is plural in Greek.

the world: The term the world refers to “the people of the world.” It means the same thing as “the earth” in 5:13a.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

everyone in the world

the people in/of the world

5:14b

A city on a hill cannot be hidden.

- A town located on a mountain cannot be hidden.
- People/They cannot hide a town that is on top of a hill.

A city on a hill cannot be hidden: This clause is like a saying or proverb. A city located on a hill is in plain view. No one can hide it or keep people from seeing it.

city: In this context, the word city refers generally to cities, towns, or villages. For example:

town (JBP)

on a hill: The Greek word that the BSB here translates as hill is the same word translated as “mountain” in 5:1. Since people do not usually build cities on tall mountains, the BSB translates the Greek word as hill.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

located on a hill (NET)

built on a hill (GNT)

built on top of a hill (CEV)

cannot be hidden: The verb be hidden is passive.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

cannot be hidden (NET)

- Use an active verb. For example:

they/people cannot hide it

Matthew 5:15

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

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Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

5:15a

Neither do people light a lamp and put it under a basket.

- In the same way, people do not light a lamp and then put it under a basket.
- Likewise, people do not light a lantern/candle and then cover it with a pot/gourd to hide it.

Neither do people light a lamp and put it under a basket: In 5:14b, Jesus said that people cannot hide a city on a hill. The Greek grammar here indicates that people also do not put a lighted lamp under a basket.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

nor does anyone light a lamp and put it under a basket (NASB)

And people don't hide a light under a bowl (NCV)

In the same way, people do not light a lamp then cover it with a bowl

light a lamp: At that time, a lamp was a small clay container that people put oil in. It had a wick that they lit to make a light for their house at night. In your translation you should use the word for the traditional type of light that people in your area use in their homes.

oil lamps

under a basket: The Greek word that the BSB translates as basket refers to a basket or clay pot that held approximately 8.8 liters of grain. You should use a word for a fairly large container that will not let light out.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

bowl (NIV)

clay pot (CEV)

gourd/calabash

In some languages, it may be natural to explicitly say why a bowl would be put over a lamp. For example:

under a bowl to hide it

5:15b

Instead, they set it on a stand, and it gives light to everyone in the house.

- Rather, they put it on its shelf/stand to light the house for everyone.
- No, they put it in its high place to shine for everyone in the house.

Instead: There is a contrast between 5:15a and 5:15b. The contrast is between what people do not normally do in 5:15a and what they normally do in 5:15b.

Here are some other ways to introduce this contrast:

but (ESV)

But rather

On the contrary

stand: The Greek word that the BSB translates as stand was a stone, metal, or wooden shelf. People normally put a lamp in such a place so it would give more light inside the house than if it had been put on the ground.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

a high/elevated place

lamp-support

lampstand (GNT)

they hang it from a nail/rafter

and it gives light to everyone in the house: This clause means that the lamp shines and this benefits all the people in the house. The houses of most people in that time had only one room. Therefore one lamp would light the entire house.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

it shines for everyone in the house (NJB)

the light shines for all the people in the house (NCV)

Matthew 5:16

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

5:16a

In the same way, let your light shine before men,

- Similarly, cause your^(plur) light to shine before people,
- Likewise, just as a light shines before people, let your^(plur) good deeds be seen,
- Likewise, just as people see the light from a lamp, in the same way let people see the good ways that you^(plur) live/ behave,

In the same way: The Greek word that the BSB translates as In the same way indicates that 5:16 is similar to what precedes. A lamp should be put on a stand so that everyone can see the light and be helped by it (5:15b). Similarly Jesus’ disciples should do good deeds so that everyone can see them and praise God (5:16a).

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Like the lamp (REB)

Likewise

Similarly

let your light shine before men: The clause let your light shine is a metaphor. In this metaphor, Jesus compared the good deeds of his disciples to the light of a lamp. One way that they are similar is that both should be seen. Neither should be hidden. A number of commentators point out the apparent contradiction between Jesus’ command here in 5:16 to do good

deeds before people and his warning in 6:1 not to do good deeds before people. These same commentators also point out that the difference is between doing good deeds so that people praise God (5:16) and doing good deeds so that they themselves receive the glory.

Here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor, but make explicit the meaning of light. For example:

let your good deeds shine out for all to see (NLT)

- Change the metaphor to a simile and make parts of it explicit. For example:

like a light that shines before people is visible/ seen, let your good deeds be visible

just as people see that light, in that same way make sure that people see the good way that you live/ behave

- Translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

do your good works/behavior openly

before men: The Greek preposition that the BSB translates as before can also be translated as “in the sight of” or “in the presence of.”

The word men is general and refers to people, both men and women as in 5:13c.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in people’s sight (NJB)

in the presence of others

5:16b

that they may see your good deeds

- so that they may see your^(plur) good actions
- in order that when they see them,

that: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as that here indicates that 5:16b is the purpose for believers to shine their light before men (5:16a).

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

so that (ESV)

in order that

for the purpose that

they may see your good deeds: The phrase your good deeds means “the good things that you have done.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the good things you do (GNT)

your good works (ESV)

5:16c

and glorify your Father in heaven.

- and praise your^(plur) Father in heaven.
- they will give honor to God our^(incl) Father. He lives in Heaven.”

and glorify: The Greek word that the BSB translates as glorify means “speak well about someone” or “honor someone.” Here it refers to giving praise to God.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

give honor to (NET)

praise (NIV)

your Father in heaven: In this verse, Jesus speaks of God as your Father. In some languages, that would imply that God was only the Father of those to whom Jesus was speaking, but not Jesus’ Father. If that is so in your language, you may want to translate this phrase as:

our^(incl) Father who lives in heaven

our^(incl) Father. He lives in heaven.

Matthew 5:17

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

5:17a

Do not think that I have come to abolish the Law or the Prophets.

- ¶ “Do not think^(plur) that I have come to destroy/cancel God’s law or the words of the Prophets.
- ¶ Jesus continued, “You^(plur) must not think that I came to set aside the laws of Moses or the teachings of the prophets.

Do not think that: Jesus knew that some Jews would later accuse him of trying to destroy God’s laws. So he said here that they should not think such thoughts.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

You^(plur) should not think that

Don’t suppose that (CEV)

Do not say in your mind/heart that

I have come: The clause I have come refers to Jesus coming into the world.

So here is another way to translate this clause:

I have come to the earth

This clause does not refer to Jesus’ coming to the mountain where he was preaching.

to abolish: The Greek word that the BSB translates as abolish means “do away with, make invalid, repeal.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

to destroy (NCV)

to do away with (CEV)

to set aside (GW)

the Law or the Prophets: By itself, the phrase the Law refers to the first five books of the Old Testament. The phrase the Prophets refers to the Old Testament books from Isaiah to Malachi. When these two phrases are used together, they refer to the entire Old Testament including all the books between the law and the Prophets.

Jesus used the conjunction or to indicate that he would abolish no part of the Old Testament.

Here are some other ways to translate these phrases:

the books of the law that God gave to Moses or
the books of the Prophets

the books of the laws of Moses or the books of
the Prophets

The Scriptures starting from the laws given to
Moses through the writings of the Prophets

5:17b

I have not come to abolish them, but to fulfill them.

- I have not come to destroy/cancel them. I have come to complete them.
- I have come to make them come true and reveal their true meaning, not to set them aside.

I have not come to abolish them, but to fulfill them:

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of the clauses in 5:17b. For example:

I have come to fulfill them and not to abolish them.

to fulfill them: Here, the Greek word that the BSB translates as to fulfill has a broader meaning than its meaning in previous contexts like 4:14. Here this word includes the aspects of:

1. to make them come true (as in GW). Jesus made come true the Old Testament prophecies which refer to the promised Messiah.
2. to complete them (as in the NJB). Jesus finished the requirements of the Old Testament, like sacrifices. (As such, it is not necessary for us to do these sacrifices again.)
3. to obey them. Jesus obeyed all the Old Testament commandments (though not always in the way that the religious leaders thought that he should obey them).
4. to teach their true meaning. Jesus, by his life and teaching, revealed the true meaning and implica-

tions of the Old Testament Scriptures. He revealed how to apply the Scriptures.

To adequately translate this word, it may be necessary to include several of the aspects above. For example:

to fulfill them and show/reveal their true meaning

to complete them and make them come true

to make their true meaning clear and to cause them to come true

Matthew 5:18

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

5:18a

For I tell you truly, until heaven and earth pass away,

- I assure you^(plur) that, as long as the sky and earth remain,
- Listen^(plur) to this: until the earth and sky end/finish,

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For introduces the basis for Jesus’ statement in 5:17. It does not introduce the reason for something. Many English versions do not translate this conjunction.

I tell you truly: Jesus often used the words that the BSB translates as I tell you truly to introduce a statement that he wanted to emphasize. When he began a statement with these words, he was asking people to listen with extra attention.

Here are some other ways to introduce this:

I assure you (NLT96)

Listen to this:

Let me tell you this:

If you have another way in your language to emphasize a statement or to alert people to listen with special attention, consider using it here.

until heaven and earth pass away: The phrase until heaven and earth pass away is another way of saying “until the end of the world.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

as long as heaven and earth last (GNT)

as long as earth and sky are still here

until the earth and heaven cease to exist

heaven: In this context, the word heaven refers to the sky (including the place where the sun, moon, and stars are). It does not refer to the place where God lives.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

the sky

the above

5:18b–c

not a single jot, not a stroke of a pen, will disappear from the Law: This clause indicates that no part of God’s law will ever be removed or become invalid, not even the smallest part.

This clause uses the parts of writing words to refer figuratively to the commands and teachings in the law. It may be more natural in your language to refer to the commands and teachings directly rather than use parts of writing figuratively. For example:

not the least point nor the smallest detail of the Law will be done away with (GNT)

even the smallest detail of God’s law will remain (NLT96)

5:18b

not a single jot, not a stroke of a pen,

- not even the smallest letter nor the smallest part of a letter
- even the smallest point and the smallest detail of the law of God

a single jot: The Greek word that the BSB translates as jot is literally “iota.” An “iota” is the smallest letter in the Greek alphabet. It can also refer to a very small stroke of a pen or it can represent a small letter, like the English letter “i.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

the smallest part of a word

the shortest word

the smallest point of writing

not a stroke of a pen: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as not a stroke of a pen is more literally “not one pen stroke.” This phrase refers to the smallest part of a letter. It would be like the dot above the letter “i” or the cross mark on the letter “t.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

a dot (ESV)

even the smallest part of a letter

5:18c

will disappear from the Law

- will disappear from the law of God
- will certainly/indeed remain valid

will disappear from: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disappear is the same word as in 5:18a. There the BSB translates this word as “pass away.”

Some languages may not use the same verb in both places. Here are some other ways to translate this word:

pass (ESV)

be removed

be changed

the Law: Here the words the Law refer generally to the whole Old Testament. Use a phrase that can refer to the whole Old Testament. For example:

God's Law (NLT)

5:18d

until everything is accomplished.

- until all that must happen has happened. (REB)
- until everything in it has happened.

until everything is accomplished: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as until everything is accomplished is more literally “until all (things) happen.” This indicates that the law is in effect until everything happens that is supposed to happen. Every prophecy must be fulfilled, and every commandment must be completed/accomplished. Then the end will come, and only at that time will the law no longer be valid.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

until everything has happened (NCV)

until all that must happen has happened (REB)

Matthew 5:19

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

5:19a

So then, whoever breaks one of the least of these commandments

- Therefore, every person who does not obey one of those less important commands
- So if you^(sing) do/follow all except one of the smallest/lightest of God's commands,

So then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as So then introduces the conclusion to 5:17–18. Some English versions do not translate this Greek word. But in some languages, it may be more natural to use a word or phrase to indicate that this is the conclusion. For example:

Therefore (NJB)

So (NLT)

then (RSV)

Consequently

whoever: The Greek words that the BSB translates as whoever introduces something that is true of everyone.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

every person who

if you (NLT)

breaks: The Greek word that the BSB translates as breaks in this context means “disobeys a law.” The person may disobey a law even though he recognizes that it is still valid, or he may disobey a law because he thinks that it is no longer valid. In either case, he does not do what the law says.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

disobeys (GNT)

refuses to obey (NCV)

does not do

ignore (NLT)

one of the least of these commandments: The words these commandments refer to the law of Moses in the Old Testament (5:18).

The word least is used in regard to importance. The Jews considered some laws to be more important (or heavier) than others.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the least important command in the Law (CEV)

the smallest commandment (NLT96)

the lightest of the laws of God

5:19b and teaches others to do likewise

- and teaches others to not obey it,
- and you^(sing) teach/tell other people that it's all right if they also do not do/follow it,

teaches others to do likewise: The clause teaches others to do likewise refers to teaching other people to also disobey one of the least of these commandments (in 5:19a).

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

teaches other people not to obey that command (NCV)

teaches other people that it is all right if they do not obey/follow that law

5:19c will be called least in the kingdom of heaven;

- he will be considered/counted as the least important person in the kingdom of God.
- then you^(sing) will be one of the smallest/lowest of the people/citizens whom God rules.

will be called least: In this context, the verb called means “referred to as,” “spoken of as,” or “acknowledged as.” The word least is used in regard to importance (as in 5:19a).

The verb is passive. God will say that such a person is least or “less important.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

will be the least important (NCV)

will be unimportant (GW)

God will consider him/that person to be the smallest/lowest person

the kingdom of heaven: This same phrase occurs in 5:3b. Translate it here as you did there.

5:19d but whoever practices and teaches them

- But whoever obeys these commands and teaches others to obey them
- But if you^(sing) keep these laws and teach others to keep them as well,

but whoever practices: The Greek word that the BSB translates as practices means “obeys” in this context.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

obeys (GNT)

keeps (NASB)

and teaches: In some languages, it may be natural to say who is taught. For example:

and teaches other people

and teaches other people to obey

them: The word them does not occur in the Greek. The BSB has supplied this word because it is implied from 5:19a. It refers to “these commands.”

Here are some other ways to make this information explicit:

these commands (NIV)

the Law (GNT)

God's laws (NLT)

what the commands say (GW)

By practicing and teaching the least of those commands, it is implied that this person also practices and teaches all the other commands.

5:19e will be called great in the kingdom of heaven.

- will be considered by God as very important in the kingdom of the one who lives in heaven.
- then you^(sing) will be one of the biggest/highest of the people/citizens whom God rules.

will be called great: This expression means that this person will have a higher position of honor.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

will have an important place (CEV)

will rank high (REB)

God will highly honor

God will consider that person to be one of the biggest/highest people

Matthew 5:20

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

5:20

The Jews considered the Pharisees and the teachers of the law to be the most righteous people because they closely followed the commandments. So what Jesus said here would have shocked his hearers. He did not consider most of the teachers of the law and the Pharisees to be truly righteous.

5:20a–b

unless your righteousness exceeds that of the scribes and Pharisees, you will never enter the kingdom of heaven: The Greek text has a negative in each clause:

if your righteousness does not surpass..., you will certainly not enter...

In some languages, it may be necessary to adjust the way the negatives are used in order for the correct meaning between the clauses to be clear.

Here are some other ways to translate these clauses:

you will be able to enter the kingdom of heaven only if you are more faithful than the teachers

of the law and the Pharisees in doing what God requires. (GNT)

your goodness must be a far better thing than the goodness of the scribes and Pharisees before you can set foot in the kingdom of Heaven at all! (JBP)

You must obey God’s commands better than the Pharisees and the teachers of the Law obey them. If you don’t, I promise you that you will never get into the kingdom of heaven. (CEV)

5:20a

For I tell you that unless your righteousness exceeds that of the scribes and Pharisees,

- I assure you^(plur) that you must be more righteous than the Pharisees and the teachers of the law. If you are not,
- So listen: you^(plur) must do what is right more completely than the Pharisees and the teachers of the law of Moses do. If you are not more righteous than they,

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For indicates that the words in 5:20 are a further explanation of the ideas in 5:17–19.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

then (GNT)

So

Therefore

Many English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it may not be necessary to translate it either.

I tell you: The words I tell you emphasize the importance of the words that follow. This phrase is similar to “For I tell you truly” (in 5:18a) except that it does not have the word translated as “truly.”

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

I assure you

listen

unless your righteousness: The word righteousness refers here to doing what is right and good in God’s

sight. A righteous person has good morals and is honest.

Here are some other ways to translate righteousness:

you do what is right

you do what God wills/desires

doing what God requires (GNT)

you do what God considers right

This same word occurs in 5:6a.

exceeds: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as exceeds also means “surpasses” or “is better/greater than.”

Here are some other ways to translate exceeds:

is greater/more/better than

goes beyond (NET)

scribes: The Greek word that the BSB translates as scribes refers to men who studied, interpreted, and taught the law of Moses. These men were called scribes because their original work was to copy the laws of Moses by hand. In New Testament times, this was no longer their main task.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

teachers of the law (NIV)

teachers of the Law of Moses

teachers of religious law (NLT)

experts in the law (NET)

This word also occurs in 2:4. You should translate it here as you did there.

Pharisees: The Pharisees were a Jewish religious group or party known for teaching a very strict obedience to the law of Moses. See how you translated this term in 3:7.

5:20b

you will never enter the kingdom of heaven.

- you^(plur) will not enter the kingdom of the one who lives in heaven.
- you^(plur) will never become a citizen/member of the kingdom of the one who lives in heaven.
- you^(plur) will never be among those whom God rules.”

never: The Greek words that the BSB translates as never is a stronger way to say “not.”

Here are some ways to translate these words:

certainly not (NIV)

never (RSV)

enter the kingdom of heaven: In this context, the word enter refers to “becoming a citizen of.” When people believe in Jesus, they become citizens/members of the kingdom of heaven.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

become a citizen of the kingdom of heaven

become one of those who are in the kingdom of the one who lives in heaven

be added to those over whom God rules

Matthew 5:21

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 5:21–22

In 5:21, Jesus continued his sermon. In some languages it may be natural to indicate that Jesus continued speaking here. For example:

Then Jesus said,

Jesus continued speaking

5:21a

You have heard that it was said to the ancients,

- ¶ “You^(plur) have heard that many years ago our^(incl) ancestors were told:
- ¶ Jesus continued speaking, “You^(plur) have heard the teachers of the law say that the law of Moses told/ commanded our^(incl) ancestors:

You have heard that it was said to the ancients: The clause it was said to the ancients refers to the law that Moses gave to the Israelites. The people listening to Jesus would know that he was referring to the law of Moses.

In some languages, it may be necessary to use more direct language. For example:

You have heard that the law of Moses says (NLT96)

You have heard what Moses commanded our ancestors long ago

You have heard: The clause You have heard indicates that most people had not read the commandments themselves. They had heard someone read them or explain them. In addition, this clause implies that everyone was familiar with the words that Jesus would say.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

You have heard the teachers of the law say that

it was said to the ancients: The word ancients refers to the ancestors of the Jews who lived several hundred years before Jesus.

This clause it was said to the ancients is passive.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Use a passive form. For example:

our ancestors were told (NLT)

our forefathers were told (REB)

- Use an active form. The law, Moses, or even other teachers are all possible agents who could have

spoken this command to the rest of the Israelites. For example:

the law commanded the people long ago

the people long ago received this command:

5:21b

‘Do not murder’

- ‘Do not kill/murder another person,
- ‘Never unlawfully kill anyone.

Do not murder: Most versions are like the BSB and use the word murder to translate the Greek verb in this clause. Most scholars also understand the Greek word to mean murder, rather than the more general word “kill.” To murder means to kill someone unlawfully. Murder generally does not occur when a person kills someone in war, or when the government executes a criminal, or when a person accidentally kills someone.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Do not kill anyone

Do not unlawfully kill another person

Here Jesus quoted one of the Ten Commandments from the Old Testament (Exodus 20:13; Deuteronomy 5:17). In Moses’ time, when God spoke to the people of Israel, he often used the singular “you,” as in this verse. He did this because he considered the people to be one nation. In the same way, the clause Do not murder is singular in Greek just as it is in the Hebrew Old Testament. But this commandment is general and addressed to everyone.

In some languages, people make general commands by using “you” (plural), or by using “we,” or by using “he,” “one,” or “a person.” For example:

You^(plur) must not murder anyone.

A person must not murder anyone.

Here, and in similar contexts, use whichever form is most natural in your language.

5:21c

and ‘Anyone who murders will be subject to judgment.’

- and anyone who kills/murders another person must be judged.’

- If anyone unlawfully kills someone else, they/judges will try/examine him and punish him.’

and: Here the word and indicates that 5:21c is the second part of what the people had heard regarding murder.

Anyone who murders:

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

If you commit murder (NLT)

the person who kills another person

whoever murders (ESV)

will be subject to judgment: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as will be subject to judgment refers to being tried before a judge (or judges). This probably implies that the person who commits murder will be both judged and punished.

This clause is passive. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive form. For example:

will be judged and punished

will be brought to trial (GNT)

- Use an active form. For example:

the local authorities will judge him

they will judge/try him and punish him

Here, this clause refers to a human court of law. But 5:22a repeats this clause, where it probably refers to God’s judgment. If possible, translate this clause in a way that you can use it in both contexts.

Matthew 5:22

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 5:21–22

In 5:21, Jesus continued his sermon. In some languages it may be natural to indicate that Jesus continued speaking here. For example:

Then Jesus said,

Jesus continued speaking

5:22

Here Jesus taught that a person’s inner attitudes are as important as his outer actions. He taught that we will also be judged for our inner attitudes.

5:22a

But I tell you that anyone who is angry with his brother will be subject to judgment.

- But now I tell you^(plur) that anyone who is angry at his brother or sister will be judged.
- But me, I tell you^(plur), if any one of you is angry at another person, God will try/examine you^(sing) and punish you.

But I tell you: The clause But I tell you indicates that there is a contrast between what the people had heard from their religious leaders and what Jesus taught. The Israelites understood that someone who murders deserves punishment. No one had ever taught them that anger and insults also deserve punishment.

Here are some other possible ways to translate this phrase:

But now I tell you (GNT)

But I say to you (ESV)

But me, I tell you

But I myself assure you

I: The pronoun I is emphatic in Greek.

you: In the Greek text, the pronoun for you is plural. It refers to Jesus' disciples and the crowd of people listening to him at this time.

anyone who is angry: The Greek word that the BSB translates as angry is the most common Greek word for "anger" in the New Testament. It refers to a feeling of displeasure, and it often makes someone want to fight against the person causing the feeling.

This word does not refer to extreme anger like the word "furious." But it is more than simply being slightly "annoyed" with someone.

brother: In this context, the Greek word that the BSB translates as brother can refer to one of the following:

1. fellow believer
2. fellowman

If people in your area will think that the word brother refers only to a real brother, you may want to use a more general term. Also, if people in your area will think that the word brother refers only to a fellow believer, but anger against a non-believer is acceptable, you may want to use a more general term. For example:

someone (CEV)

will be subject to judgment: In Greek, this clause is exactly the same as the clause in 5:21c. It is a passive. It is unlikely that a human court would judge someone for being angry. So here, this clause probably refers to God judging the angry person.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Use a passive form. For example:

will be judged (NCV)

will be judged and punished

will be brought to trial (GNT)

- Use an active form. For example:

God will judge him

5:22b

Again, anyone who says to his brother, 'Raca,' will be subject to the Sanhedrin.

- And anyone who calls his brother or sister 'Raca' ('stupid') will be required to appear/stand before the supreme court.
- Also, if you^(sing) insult another human being by calling him stupid, the council of elders will try/examine you and punish you.

Again: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Again is a conjunction that is often translated as "and" or "but." In 5:22b, Jesus continued with a teaching that is similar to 5:22a. For this reason, some versions begin 5:22b with the conjunction "and." Other English versions use no conjunction. You should connect 5:22b to 5:22a in a way that is natural in your language.

anyone who says to his brother, 'Raca': The Greek clause that the BSB translates as anyone who says to his brother, 'Raca' is literally, "whoever might say to his brother 'Raca.'" The word Raca is a transliterated Aramaic word that means "empty-headed person" or "stupid." This term is an insult.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Transliterate Raca, but show what it means in parentheses. For example:

whoever says to his brother 'Raca' ('stupid')

whoever calls his brother 'Raca' ('idiot')

- Use a word or phrase in your language that means "stupid" or "idiot." It may be an idiom. For example:

if you call your brother 'You good-for-nothing!' (GNT)

if you call your brother 'hardheaded'

- Transliterate Raca, and include a footnote explaining what it means. Here is a sample footnote:

"Raca" is a word in the Aramaic language that means "empty-headed person" or "stupid." It was an insult to call someone "Raca."

- Use a general phrase that explains the meaning of Raca. For example:

whoever insults his brother (RSV)

will be subject: The Greek words that the BSB translates here as will be subject are the same as in 5:21c

and 5:22a. (Notice that this time, the words “to judgment” are not present.)

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

will be judged (NCV)

will be brought before (GNT)

to the Sanhedrin: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Sanhedrin refers to the Supreme Court of the Jews. This court was the highest authority for the Jews. There were seventy two men in the Sanhedrin. Each member was either a priest, an elder, or a teacher of the law. The high priest was the leader of the council.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

the council called ‘the Sanhedrin’

the supreme court (JBP)

the group of judges/elders

5:22c

But anyone who says, ‘You fool!’ will be subject to the fire of hell.

- And anyone who says to his brother or sister ‘You fool!’ he will be guilty/deserving of the fire in hell.
- If you^(sing) tell someone that he is a worthless idiot, God will condemn you to the fires of the place where the dead are punished.

Verse 5:22c is similar to 5:22a and 22b in the sense that it also is dealing with anger.

But: There are two ways to interpret the way 5:22c is connected to 5:22a–b:

1. It is another example of insulting a person. According to this interpretation, 5:22c should begin with and, or it should be a new sentence. For example:

And if you call someone a fool, you will be in danger of the fire of hell. (NCV)

Whoever calls another believer a fool will answer for it in hellfire. (GW) (GNT, NET, RSV, ESV, NJB, NASB, REB, GW, CEV, NLT, NCV, JBP)

1. It is a more severe way to insult someone, and the punishment is more severe. According to this inter-

pretation, 5:22c should begin with but to show the contrast in the degree of punishment. For example:

but whosoever shall say, Thou fool, shall be in danger of hell fire. (KJV) (Probably NIV, KJV, BSB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The majority of commentators agree that Matthew did not intend to increase the degrees of anger and punishment from 5:22a to 5:22b to 5:22c.

fool: A fool is a stupid person; or one lacking in judgment and understanding. The word fool is an insult like “Raca.” Both expressions indicate that the person saying them despises his fellowman.

Here is another way to translate this word:

worthless fool (GNT)

will be subject to: The Greek words that the BSB here translates as will be subject to are the same words as in 5:21c and 5:22a. You may want to translate them here in the same way as you did in those verses.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

is worthy of

will go to

will be thrown in

the fire of hell: The phrase the fire of hell refers to the place of eternal punishment where God will send unbelievers following the final judgment. In that place, unbelievers will be punished with fire.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the hell of fire (ESV)

the place where the dead are made to suffer in fire

the place where the dead are punished with fire

Matthew 5:23

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on

the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

5:23a

So if you are offering your gift at the altar

- ¶ “So if you^(sing) are giving your offering/gift to God at the altar at the temple,
- ¶ “So when you^(sing) are ready to put your sacrifice on the altar in the temple,

So: The Greek word that the BSB translates as So introduces a conclusion. In 5:23–26, Jesus concluded what he said about being judged for anger and insulting others in 5:21–22. He concluded by saying that we must reconcile with a brother whom we have offended. He implied that if we do not reconcile, we too will be judged.

Here is another way to introduce this conclusion:

Therefore (NIV)

if you are offering: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as you are offering also means “you bring.” This verb probably indicates that the person has come near the altar but has not yet placed the gift on it.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

if you are about to place (CEV)

if you bring (NET)

when you are ready to give

you: In this paragraph and the next, the pronouns “you” and “your” are singular.

your gift: The word gift refers to an offering that someone makes to God. It could be an animal, grain, or another type of gift.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

offering (NASB)

sacrifice (NLT)

If it would not be clear that this offering was to God, then you may want to add that information. For example:

offering to God

gift presented to God

at the altar: An altar was a platform where offerings were made to God. In this context, this altar probably refers to the one in front of the temple where animal and grain offerings were burnt. The Jews usually built their altars from stone. But the altar in front of the temple was like a table made of the metal bronze. This is probably the altar that is referred to here.

Here are some other ways to translate altar:

place for giving offerings/sacrifices

place/platform where people offer sacrifices to God

5:23b

and there remember that your brother has something against you,

- and while there you^(sing) remember that your brother or sister has a complaint against you,
- and at that place you^(sing) suddenly remember that you have done something to anger someone,

and there: The word there refers to the area where the altar is located.

your brother has something against you: The clause your brother has something against you implies that you have done something to offend your brother. As a result, your brother is upset or angry with you.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

your brother has a grievance against you (REB)

someone is angry with you (CEV)

you have done something that angered/offended your fellowman

your brother: As in 5:22a, the word brother here refers to “fellow believer” or “fellowman.” It does not refer to a biological brother.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

someone (CEV)

fellowman

fellow believer

Matthew 5:24

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

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Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

5:24a

leave your gift there before the altar.

- leave/set^(sing) your offering there before the altar.
- you^(sing) should put the sacrifice on the ground in front of the altar.

5:24a–b

leave your gift there before the altar. First go: This clause indicates that you should wait to make your offering. Instead of presenting the offering at that time, you should put it down on the ground in front of the altar for a later time.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

leave your offering there before the altar (NJB)

set down your gift on the ground by the altar

put your offering down in front of the altar

First go: Some English versions put the verb go at the end of 5:24a and before the word First in 5:24b. For example:

^{24a}leave your gift there before the altar and go.

^{24b}First be reconciled to your brother, and then come and offer your gift. (ESV)

However, the BSB and most English versions put the verb go in 5:24b after the word First. You should do whatever is most natural in your language.

5:24b

First go and be reconciled to your brother;

- First, go and make peace with your^(sing) brother or sister.
- First you^(sing) should go and find that person and restore your friendship.

First: The word First indicates that before giving your gift, you should be reconciled.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Before giving the gift

at once (GNT)

As mentioned in 5:24a, many English versions put the verb “go” here after the word First.

be reconciled: The word reconciled means “make peace between people or groups.” You must go to the person you have offended, settle the problem, and restore the relationship.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

make peace (GNT)

find your fellowman and resolve your differences

make things right with each other

restore your friendship

5:24c

then come and offer your gift.

- Then come back and make your^(sing) offering to God.
- Then you^(sing) can go back to the temple and make your sacrifice/offering.

then come and offer your gift: After you have made peace with your fellowman, then you are permitted to come back to the temple and offer your sacrifice to God.

Matthew 5:25

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 5:25–26

In 5:25–26 in the Greek text, the pronouns for “you” or “your” are all singular. But the teaching applies to all of Jesus’ followers. So in some languages, it is more natural to use the plural form of “you” here.

5:25a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of the clauses in 5:25a–b. Compare the BSB with the NLT and NCV below.

^{25a}Reconcile quickly with your adversary, ^{25b}while you are still on the way to court (BSB)

^{25b}When you are on the way to court ^{25a}with your adversary, settle your differences quickly. (NLT)

^{25b}If your enemy is taking you to court, ^{25a}become friends quickly, ^{25b}before you go to court. (NCV)

5:25a

Reconcile quickly with your adversary,

- ¶ “Settle a dispute quickly with your^(sing) accuser
- ¶ “If your^(sing) enemy is taking you before the judge, resolve the dispute quickly

Reconcile: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as Reconcile means “settle matters” or “make friends.” A

believer who has wronged someone must resolve the problem.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Make friends (RSV)

Settle matters (NIV)

settle the dispute (GNT)

make peace

quickly: The Greek word that the BSB translates as quickly means “at once, without delay.” In this context, it refers to settling matters before court begins.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

while there is time (GNT)

immediately

before you arrive at the court

your adversary: The Greek word that the BSB translates as your adversary refers to the person who is against you. He is the person taking you to court to accuse you before the judge.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

accuser (ESV)

opponent (GW)

enemy (NCV)

the one who has accused you of wrong

5:25b

while you are still on the way to court.

- while you^(sing) and he are going to court,
- while you^(plur) are still on the way there.

while you are still on the way to court: The Greek text that the BSB translates as while you are still on the way to court is literally “while you are with him on the road.” The BSB has added the words to court. By doing this, the BSB makes it clear that “your adversary” is the one who initiated the court case. Your

adversary has accused you of doing something wrong. The two of you are going to court so that the judge can hear your case. This clause does not mean that your enemy is literally carrying or dragging you to court.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

while you are on the way to court with him (GW)

as he is taking you to where the judge is

while there is time, before you get to court (GNT)

5:25c

Otherwise, he may hand you over to the judge,

- so that he will not bring/give you^(sing) to the judge.
- If you^(sing) do not do that, he will deliver you to the judge.

Otherwise, he may hand you over to the judge: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Otherwise can also be translated as “so that not” or “lest.”

This clause and 5:25d indicate what will happen if matters are not settled quickly. You may need to translate this clause somewhat differently in order to make it clear. For example:

so that your opponent will not hand you over to the judge

lest, your accuser hand you over to the judge (ESV)

If you do not settle matters quickly, he will hand you over to the judge

hand you over to the judge: The words hand you over refer to putting someone under the power or authority of another. This accuser will bring you before the judge, and the judge will decide how to punish you.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

will deliver/take you to the judge

will give/bring you to the judge

will cause you to appear before the judge

5:25d

and the judge may hand you over to the officer,

- And then the judge will bring/give you^(sing) to the court officer
- And the judge will deliver you^(sing) to the policeman/guard

and the judge may hand you over to the officer: In the Greek, this phrase is literally “and the judge to the officer.” There is an ellipsis here. The words may hand you over are implied from 5:25c.

officer: The Greek word that the BSB translates as officer refers to a policeman or similar official who fulfills the judge’s orders. He has the authority to put someone in jail or set him free, as the judge tells him to.

Here are some other ways to translate officer:

guard (ESV)

warden (NET)

person in charge of prisoners

5:25e

and you may be thrown into prison.

- and then you^(sing) will be put in prison.
- who will put you^(sing) in jail.

you may be thrown into prison: The verb be thrown is passive. The guard in 5:25d obeys the order of the judge and puts the believer in prison. Some ways to translate this clause are:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

you will be put in jail (GNT)

you will be locked up

- Use an active verb. For example:

he will put you in prison

who will put you in jail (CEV)

Matthew 5:26

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to

include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 5:25–26

In 5:25–26 in the Greek text, the pronouns for “you” or “your” are all singular. But the teaching applies to all of Jesus’ followers. So in some languages, it is more natural to use the plural form of “you” here.

5:26a

Truly I tell you,

- I assure you^(sing) that
- Listen^(sing) to this:

Truly I tell you: The clause Truly I tell you is the same clause as in 5:18a except here the pronoun you is singular.

5:26b

you will not get out until you have paid the last penny.

- you^(sing) will not leave prison until you have paid the last coin that you owe!
- you^(sing) will not be freed from jail until you have paid everything you owe!

you will not get out: This clause refers to leaving prison.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

you will not leave there (NCV)

you surely won’t be free again (NLT)

There you will stay (GNT)

until you have paid the last penny: The word until indicates that before you can leave jail, you will be required to pay the whole amount. The money may either be a debt owed to the adversary of 5:25 or a fine by the judge for the wrong you have done to the adversary. If possible, you should translate this phrase in a general way that can refer to both.

the last penny: The Greek word that the BSB translates as penny refers to a coin that was one of the least valuable coins used at that time. The words the last penny indicate that the whole amount must be paid.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- Use a general term for the smallest amount of money. For example:

the smallest coin

the least valuable bill

- Use the term for the smallest amount of money in your language, as the BSB does.
- Translate without using a term for money. For example:

until you have paid everything you owe (NCV)

until you have paid every last bit you owe

Matthew 5:27

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

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Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 5:27–30

Jesus continued speaking here to his disciples. If your audience would not understand that Jesus was speaking here, you may want to indicate this. For example:

Then Jesus said,

Jesus continued speaking

5:27a**You have heard that it was said,**

- ¶ “You^(plur) have heard that the law of Moses said/commanded:
- ¶ “You^(plur) have also heard the teachers of the law say that the law of Moses told/commanded us:

You have heard that it was said: The same clause also occurs in 5:21. However, here the words “to the ancients” are not repeated. You should translate this clause in a similar way.

You: In the Greek text, the pronoun for You is plural. It refers to all those to whom Jesus was speaking.

5:27b**‘Do not commit adultery.’**

- ‘Do not have sexual relations with another man’s wife.’
- ‘Do not have sex with a married woman.’

Do not commit adultery: The Greek word that the BSB translates as adultery refers to having sexual relations with a woman who is married to another man.

Here are some other ways to translate this commandment:

Do not have sexual relations with another man’s wife

Do not take another man’s wife to bed with you

Do not sleep with a married woman

Matthew 5:28**Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain**

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 5:27–30

Jesus continued speaking here to his disciples. If your audience would not understand that Jesus was speaking here, you may want to indicate this. For example:

Then Jesus said,

Jesus continued speaking

5:28a**But I tell you that anyone who looks at a woman to lust after her**

- But now I say to you^(plur) that anyone who looks at a woman and wants her
- But me, I tell you^(plur), if anyone stares at another woman who is not his wife and then desires/plans to have sexual relations with her,

But I tell you: The clause But I tell you also occurs in 5:22a. Translate it here as you did there.

anyone who looks at a woman to lust after her:

The Greek words that the BSB translate as looks at a woman to lust after her refer to looking steadily on a woman and wanting to have sexual relations with her. It is also implied that the woman is not his wife.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

whoever looks at a woman and desires her (GW)

anyone who looks at a woman and wants to possess her (GNT)

if you look at another woman and want her (CEV)

anyone who stares at a woman who is not his wife and wants to have sex with her

The term or expression you use should be polite enough for reading aloud to a group of men and women.

5:28b**has already committed adultery with her in his heart.**

- has already had sinful sexual relations with her in his heart/mind.
- he is already guilty of sexually sinning with that woman in his inner-being/spirit.

has already committed adultery with her in his heart: This clause indicates that even though the man

only desired to commit the sexual sin, it is just as if he had actually done it.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

he has already had sexual relations with her in his heart

in his heart, he has already committed the sin of sleeping with her

in his heart: The word heart here refers to one's inner life. It indicates the essential person, where one's thoughts and motives occur.

For the word heart, use a term that is normally used in your language for "inner life." It may be a different organ such as "liver" or "throat." Or it may be a more general term such as "insides" or "spirit."

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in your thoughts (CEV)

in his mind (NCV)

Matthew 5:29

Section 5:1-7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5-7 as "The Sermon on the Mount." In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5-7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1-12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 5:27-30

Jesus continued speaking here to his disciples. If your audience would not understand that Jesus was speaking here, you may want to indicate this. For example:

Then Jesus said,

Jesus continued speaking

5:29-30

In these verses, Jesus used two figurative examples to show that sinning is to be strongly avoided. They are also called examples of hyperbole or exaggeration. Jesus used these examples in order to emphasize a truth. A literal eye or hand cannot cause a person to sin. The only things that cause sin are wrong attitudes, desires, and thoughts that come from the heart. These examples show that it is very important to remove from one's heart the nonphysical things which cause sin.

Throughout 5:29-30, in the Greek text, the pronouns for "you" or "your" are all singular.

5:29a

If your right eye causes you to sin,

- If your^(sing) right eye causes you to sin,
- If you^(sing) are tempted to sin using/with your right eye,

5:29a-b

If your right eye causes you to sin, gouge it out and throw it away: In this context, the right eye is a figure of speech. The right eye represents sins that a person commits with his eyes.

Here is another way to express this figure of speech:

If you are tempted to sin with/using your right eye, gouge it out

If people in your area will think that this verse is literally commanding someone to remove his eye, you may want to:

- Indicate that this is a figurative example:

If for a figurative example your right eye causes you to sin

- Include the non-figurative meaning and also make the figurative example into a simile:

Remove and throw away any cause of sin! Remove it as completely as if you were removing your right eye that causes you to sin.

- Include a footnote to explain. Here is a sample footnote:

In this verse and the next verse Jesus talked about parts of the body that we use when we sin. He

used the right eye and the right hand as symbols that stand for what we look at and what we do. When he said that we should remove our right eye or right hand, he meant that we should do everything possible to keep ourselves from sinning

5:29b

gouge it out and throw it away.

- take it out and throw it away.
- it is as if you should pull it out and throw it away.

gouge it out and throw it away: The Greek word that the BSB translates as gouge...out means “take/pull out.” This verse part continues the exaggeration in 5:29a.

Here are some other ways to translate gouge it out:

take it out (GNT)

tear it out (ESV)

pluck it out (RSV)

5:29c–d

It is better for you to lose one part of your body than for your whole body to be thrown into hell:

This sentence is a comparison. The two events here are both bad. But to lose one part of your body is not as bad as your whole body being thrown into hell. In that way the first clause is better than the second clause.

Here are some other ways to translate this comparison:

To lose one part of your body is not as bad as your whole body being thrown into hell

Losing one part of your body is good compared to your whole body being thrown into hell

Losing one part of your body is good. Having your whole body thrown into hell is bad.

5:29c

It is better for you to lose one part of your body

- To lose one part of your body is better
- If you lose one part of your body while on earth, that is not as bad

The Greek of 5:29c begins with a conjunction that is often translated as “for.” it indicates that 5:29c is the basis for the command to tear out your eye in 5:29b.

Many English versions like the BSB do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either.

lose one part of your body: The clause lose one part of your body refers specifically to losing your right eye. It also refers to losing that eye while still living. It may be more natural in some languages to make some of this information explicit. For example:

It is better to lose one part of your body while living

Losing your right eye is better

5:29d

than for your whole body to be thrown into hell.

- than your whole body being thrown into hell!
- as for God to throw your whole body into the place of unending punishment!

your whole body to be thrown into hell: The verb be thrown is passive.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- Use a passive verb as the BSB.
- Use an active verb. For example:

God will throw your whole body into hell.

hell: The word hell refers to the place of eternal punishment where unbelievers will go after the final judgment. The devil and his angels will also go there.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

place of eternal punishment

place of unending fire

the place where the dead are made to suffer

Matthew 5:30

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

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Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 5:27–30

Jesus continued speaking here to his disciples. If your audience would not understand that Jesus was speaking here, you may want to indicate this. For example:

Then Jesus said,

Jesus continued speaking

5:30a

And if your right hand causes you to sin,

- If your^(sing) right hand causes you to sin,
- Likewise, if you^(sing) are tempted to sin using/with your right hand,

5:30b

cut it off and throw it away.

- cut it off and throw it away.
- then you should chop it off and throw it away.

5:30c

It is better for you to lose one part of your body

- To lose one part of your body is better
- If you lose one part of your body while on earth, that is not as bad

5:30a–c

This verse is almost exactly the same as 5:29, but here the part of the body in focus is the hand. You will want to translate 5:30 in a way similar to how you translated 5:29.

5:30d

than for your whole body to depart into hell.

- than for your whole body to enter into hell!
- as God sending off your whole body to the place of unending punishment!

to depart into hell: Here, the Greek says to depart into hell rather than “to be thrown into hell” as in 5:29d.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

to enter into hell

to be sent to hell

for God to send your whole body into hell

Matthew 5:31

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

5:31a

It has also been said,

- ¶ “The law of Moses also said/commanded:
- ¶ “The teachers of the law have also said that the law of Moses told/commanded us:

It has also been said: The clause It has also been said is a shortened form of 5:21a (“You have heard that it was said to the ancients”) and 5:27a (“You have heard that it was said”). You should translate this clause similarly to the ones in those two verses.

This clause refers to the law that Moses gave to the Israelites. The context implies that the Israelites had heard someone read the laws or explain them. It is a summary of the way the passage was understood rather than an exact quotation, which accords with the fact that Jesus is opposing scribal interpretations rather than Scripture. (Morris, page 120)

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

It has also been said (NJB)

You have heard that the law of Moses says (NLT96)

They have also said that the law of Moses told/commanded us

5:31b

‘Whoever divorces his wife must give her a certificate of divorce.’

- ‘Any man who divorces his wife must give her a divorce paper.’
- ‘If anyone wants to divorce his wife, he must give her a paper that says that their^(dual) marriage is finished.’

Whoever divorces his wife: The word divorces refers to formally and legally ending a marriage. The verse in the Old Testament (Deuteronomy 24:1) referred to here speaks particularly about a man divorcing his wife. It is recommended that you keep that meaning here.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Any man who ends the marriage to his wife

If a man sends his wife back to her family

must give her a certificate of divorce: A certificate is an official paper (document) stating certain facts. So the phrase certificate of divorce refers to a legal document stating that the woman is no longer married to the man. The husband had to write this paper and have witnesses.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

a written divorce paper (NCV)

a letter of divorce (NLT96)

a paper to end the marriage

Matthew 5:32

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

5:32

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of 5:32b and 5:32c. Compare the order and structure of the clauses in the BSB and the NCV below.

^{32a}But I tell you that anyone who divorces his wife,
^{32b}except for sexual immorality, ^{32c}brings adultery upon her. (BSB)

^{32a}But I tell you that anyone who divorces his wife
^{32c}forces her to be guilty of adultery. ^{32b}The only reason for a man to divorce his wife is if she has sexual relations with another man. (NCV)

5:32a

But I tell you that anyone who divorces his wife,

- But now I tell you^(plur) that anyone who divorces his wife,
- But me, I tell you^(plur) that if a man ends the marriage to his wife

But I tell you: The clause But I tell you also occurs in 5:22a and 5:28a. Translate it here as you did there.

you: In the Greek text, the pronoun for you is plural.

anyone who divorces his wife: The Greek word that the BSB translates as anyone refers only to men.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

any man who divorces his wife (GW)

if a man divorces his wife (GNT)

5:32b

except for sexual immorality,

- unless she has committed adultery,
- when/and she has not had sexual relations with another man,

except for sexual immorality: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as except for sexual immorality means “except on the ground of sexual immorality” (as in the ESV). This indicates that the only acceptable reason for divorce is sexual immorality.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

except for marital unfaithfulness (NIV)

for any reason other than unfaithfulness (GW)

unless she has committed some terrible sexual sin (CEV)

sexual immorality: There are several ways to understand the Greek word that the BSB translates as sexual immorality:

1. It refers specifically to adultery. This means that the woman has been unfaithful to her husband after the marriage. For example:

she has sexual relations with another man (NCV)

1. It refers generally to any kind of sexual immorality before or after marriage.
2. It refers to an unlawful or illegal marriage. For example:

an illicit marriage (NJB)

Most English versions use a word or phrase that follows interpretation (1) or (2), but it is often not possible to tell which one. It is recommended that you also follow interpretation (1) or (2).

5:32c

brings adultery upon her.

- causes her to commit adultery.
- if she marries someone else, he has caused her to do a sexual sin.

brings adultery upon her: In that culture, a divorced woman almost always remarried. She remarried because there was no satisfactory way for her to support herself alone. If the first husband has divorced her even though she has been faithful, he has caused her to become unfaithful to him if she marries another man. In that sense, he brings adultery upon her.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

causes her to commit adultery (NLT)

makes her guilty of sexual sin if she marries again

5:32d

And he who marries a divorced woman commits adultery.

- And if another man marries that divorced woman, he is also committing adultery.”
- And if someone else marries the woman whose first husband ended the marriage, he too has done a sexual sin.”

And he who marries a divorced woman: In this context, the phrase he who refers to another man who marries a divorced woman.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

if another man marries that divorced woman

if someone else marries the woman whose first husband divorced her

commits adultery: In God’s view, it is as if the second husband is having sexual relations with another man’s wife. God wants a man to stay married to his first wife, and he wants the woman to remain married to her first husband. Their marriage binds them together as if the two of them were one person.

You will probably want to translate this expression the same way as in 5:32c.

Matthew 5:33

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

5:33a

Again, you have heard that it was said to the ancients,

- ¶ “You^(plur) have also heard that many years ago our^(incl) ancestors were told:
- ¶ Jesus continued speaking, “You^(plur) have also heard the teachers of the law say that the law of Moses told/commanded our^(incl) ancestors:

Again: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Again here indicates that Jesus would talk about another command.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Also

Furthermore

you have heard that it was said to the ancients: This clause is the same as in 5:21. You should translate it the same way in both places.

5:33b

‘Do not break your oath,

- ‘Do not fail to do what you^(sing) have sworn/vowed to do.
- ‘You^(sing) must not break any promises that you make in God’s name.

Do not break your oath: There are two ways to interpret the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as do not break your oath:

1. It refers to not keeping an oath or promise. For example:

Do not break your promise (GNT) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NJB, NLT, GW, NET, REB, CEV, NCV)

1. It refers to not giving false testimony. For example:

You shall not swear falsely (RSV) (RSV, ESV, NASB, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and the majority of English versions. It also fits the context better. In 5:34, Jesus continued by saying that his followers should not make any oaths at all.

break your oath: The Greek word that the BSB translates as break your oath refers to a strong promise to do something using the name of God (or something related to God in some way). People made oaths to show that they were telling the truth or that they would keep their promise. If someone broke such an oath, it was considered a misuse of God’s name.

An oath is stronger than simply saying “I promise that I will do it.” An oath is a strong promise like “I swear to God that I will do it.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

You must not break your vows (NLT)

Do not break a promise/vow you have made in God’s name

5:33c

but fulfill your vows to the Lord.’

- But do the things that you have sworn/vowed to the Lord to do.’
- Rather, you must keep the promises that you have made to the Lord God in his name.’

but: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between “breaking your oaths” in 5:33b and keeping them in 5:33c.

Here are some other ways to show this contrast:

however

rather

fulfill your vows to the Lord: The clause that the BSB translates as fulfill your vows to the Lord can also be translated as “keep the oaths you have made to the Lord” (as in the NIV). This clause is the opposite of “break your oath” in 5:33b.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

fulfil your oaths (NJB)

keep the promises that you make to the Lord in/using his name

do what you have sworn to the Lord that you would do

to the Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the Lord is here a title for God himself. The Greek word means “master,” “owner,” or “a person who has great authority.” If the word in your language for Lord is too general, you may want to include “God” in the way you translate it. For example:

the Lord God

Matthew 5:34

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

5:34a

But I tell you not to swear at all:

- But now I tell you^(plur), do not make oaths at all.
- But me, I tell you^(plur) not to make any vow.

But I tell you: The clause But I tell you also occurs in 5:22a, 5:28a, and 5:32a. Translate it here as you did there.

not to swear at all: This clause means “Do not make an oath at any time.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

don’t swear an oath at all (GW)

make no vow at all

Jesus was not against promises. He was against making promises using the name of God and substitutes for God’s name. See below.

5:34b–36a

The Jews took seriously an oath made in God’s name. They thought that if someone made an oath in God’s name, and then broke that oath, God would punish him. To get around this, they made oaths using substitutes for God’s name.

Each of the clauses in 5:34b–5:36a refers to commonly used substitutes for making an oath in Jewish culture. The four items, heaven, earth, Jerusalem, and one’s head, are all closely associated with God. Jews thought that an oath made using the name of one of them is powerful, but less serious than using the name of God himself. However, the Greek grammar indicates that Jesus prohibited using any of these names.

5:34b

either by heaven, for it is God’s throne;

- Do not make an oath/vow using/saying the word ‘heaven,’ because heaven is where God rules.
- For example, heaven is where God rules as king, so do not make a vow by referring to heaven.

either by heaven: The word either indicates the first of a list of examples for “not to swear at all” from 5:34a. It may be more natural in your language to repeat some of the words or include some implied information. For example:

For example, do not make an oath using the word “heaven”

heaven: Here the word heaven refers to the place where God lives. This word also occurs in 5:16.

for: The Greek word that the BSB translates as for introduces the basis for the command not to swear by heaven (in 5:34b).

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Do not swear by heaven, because it is God’s throne

Heaven is God’s throne, so don’t swear by heaven. (CEV)

it is God’s throne: A throne is the chair in which a king or queen sits during ceremonial occasions. In this context, the words God’s throne means “the place where God rules as King.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

where God sits to rule

the place from which God rules

Matthew 5:35

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

5:35a**or by the earth, for it is His footstool;**

- And do not make an oath using/saying the word ‘earth,’ because it is like a place where God rests his feet.
- And the earth is under God’s complete control, so do not make a vow by referring to the earth.

or by the earth: The word or introduces the second item in the list of examples. It may be more natural in your language to repeat some of the words. For example:

or do not make an oath using the word “earth”

for: The Greek word that the BSB translates as for introduces the basis for the command not to swear by earth.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Do not swear by earth, because it is God’s footstool

The earth is God’s footstool, so don’t swear by the earth. (CEV)

it is His footstool: A footstool is a small, low seat on which someone rests his feet while sitting down. Here the word footstool represents the earth as the place where God the King figuratively rests his feet while he is sitting on his heavenly throne. Using the earth as God’s footstool implies that he subjects the “earth” and all on it to his will.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

the resting place for his feet (GNT)

the place where he stretches out his legs

In some language, it may be more natural to translate non-figuratively. For example:

because the earth belongs to God (NCV)

because it is under God’s control

5:35b**or by Jerusalem, for it is the city of the great King.**

- And do not make an oath using/saying the word ‘Jerusalem,’ because it is the city of the Great King.

- And Jerusalem belongs to God, the Great King, so do not make a vow by referring to Jerusalem.

or by Jerusalem: The word or introduces the third of the list of examples. It may be more natural in your language to repeat some of the words. For example:

or do not make an oath using the word “Jerusalem”

for: The Greek word that the BSB translates as for introduces the basis for the command not to swear by Jerusalem.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Do not swear by Jerusalem, because it is the city of the Great King

Jerusalem is the city of the great king, so don’t swear by it. (CEV)

it is the city of the great King: The phrase the great King refers to God. God’s temple was in the city of Jerusalem. So God has a special relationship with Jerusalem.

If people in your area will not understand that the words the great King refer to God, you may want to make that clear. For example:

for it is the city of God, the Great King

Matthew 5:36**Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain**

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

5:36a–b

Nor should you swear by your head, for you cannot make a single hair white or black.

- And do not make an oath using/saying the words ‘by my head,’ because you^(sing) cannot make one hair become white or black.
- And you^(sing) cannot turn even a single hair on your head black or white, so do not make a vow by referring to your head.

5:36a

Nor: The Greek word that the BSB here translates as Nor is the same Greek word that the BSB translates as “or” in 5:35a and 5:35b. As before, this word introduces another example.

should you swear by your head: The clause swear by your head means that people should not “make an oath using/saying the words ‘by my head.’” This is prohibited just as the other items in 5:34–35.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Do not make an oath using the words ‘my head’

Don’t even swear, ‘By my head!’ (NLT96)

Do not swear indicating your own head as witness/proof

In the Greek text, both the verb for swear and the pronoun for your are singular.

5:36b

for: The Greek word that the BSB translates as for introduces the basis for the command not to swear by your head (in 5:36a).

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Do not swear by your head, because you cannot make one hair white or black.

You cannot make one hair white or black, so do not swear by your head.

you cannot make a single hair white or black: A person cannot permanently change the natural color of his hair. God is the one who controls a person’s head just as he controls heaven and earth. So a person cannot prove that his oath is true by saying “by my head.” He must not promise to do something by saying “by my head.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

you cannot make one hair on your head become white or black (NCV)

you can’t turn one hair white or black (NLT)

Matthew 5:37**Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain**

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

5:37a

Simply let your ‘Yes’ be ‘Yes,’ and your ‘No,’ ‘No.’

- If you^(plur) mean ‘Yes,’ just say ‘Yes,’ and if you mean ‘No,’ just say ‘No.’
- Just speak the truth, a simple ‘yes’ or ‘no’ without adding a vow.

Simply let your ‘Yes’ be ‘Yes,’ and your ‘No,’ ‘No.’:

This clause indicates that believers are to say only Yes when they truly mean Yes. In the same way, they are to say only No when they truly mean No. They must not use oaths to persuade people to believe what they say. In both cases Jesus emphasizes that believers must be perfectly truthful in their answers.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Just say ‘Yes’ or ‘No’ (GNT)

All you need say is ‘Yes’ if you mean yes, ‘No’ if you mean no (NJB)

5:37b

Anything more comes from the evil one.

- Any words more than this come from the Evil/Wicked One!”
- If you^(plur) add a vow to your ‘yes’ or ‘no’ so that people will believe you, the devil is influencing you.”

Anything more: The phrase Anything more refers to any kind of words that are stronger or in addition to a simple “yes” or “no.” This phrase includes using oaths. Here are some other ways to translate these words:

Anything more than that (GW)

If you say more than yes or no (NCV)

comes from: The phrase comes from indicates the origin or source of such oaths. In this verse, it is “the evil one” (that is, the devil) who causes or inspires the oath taking. It is not of God.

the evil one: There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as the evil one:

1. It refers to the evil one, Satan. For example:

the devil (CEV) (BSB, NIV, NRSV, GNT, NJB, GW, CEV, NET, REB, NCV, NLT)

1. It refers to evil. For example:

anything more than this comes from evil (RSV)
(RSV, NASB, JBP, KJV, ESV, NLT96)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and the majority of English versions and commentators.

Here are some other ways to translate this entire clause:

Any statement more than that comes from the Evil One, the Devil.

If you add an oath to your “yes” or “no” so that people will believe you, it comes from the Devil, who is the Evil One.

Matthew 5:38

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

5:38a

You have heard that it was said,

- ¶ “You^(plur) have also heard that our^(incl) ancestors were told:
- ¶ “You^(plur) have also heard the teachers of the law say that the law of Moses told/commanded our^(incl) ancestors:

You have heard that it was said: This clause is the same as in 5:21a, 5:27a, and 5:33a. Translate it here as you did there.

5:38b–c

The two clauses in 5:38b–c indicate that the punishment for purposely harming another person must be the same as the harm caused.

5:38b

‘Eye for eye

- ‘An eye is the payment for an eye
- ‘If a person injures someone else’s eye, then his eye must also be injured.

Eye for eye: In the phrase Eye for eye, words are left implied to make this saying like a proverb. This phrase means that if a person causes someone to lose an eye, his own eye must be removed. Jesus quoted this commandment from the Old Testament (Exodus 21:24; Leviticus 24:20; Deuteronomy 19:21).

In some languages, it may be more natural to include some of the implied information in your translation. For example:

An eye is the payment for an eye

The person who injures/blinds the eye of his fellowman must have his own eye injured/blinded.

This punishment was the maximum punishment that God allowed. It was a guideline for the courts so that they did not punish an offender more (or less) than his offense deserved. This rule was not for personal revenge.

5:38c

and tooth for tooth.’

- and a tooth is the payment for a tooth.’

- And if a person knocks out someone else's tooth, then his tooth must be knocked out.'

tooth for tooth: You should translate this clause similarly to 5:38b. Here are some other examples:

A tooth is the payment for a tooth

The person who knocks out the tooth of his fellowman must have his own tooth knocked out.

Matthew 5:39

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

5:39–42

As mentioned above, Jesus' teaching went beyond forbidding retaliation. Jesus taught that a disciple must show love to a person who mistreats him by doing good to him. Verses 5:39–42 talk about four different situations in which to do this. In the first three cases, a disciple is to show love by doing even more than the unjust person demands.

5:39a

But I tell you not to resist an evil person.

- But now I tell you^(plur), do not oppose someone who does evil to you.
- But me, I tell you^(plur), if someone wants to do something evil to you, do not fight him.

But I tell you: The clause But I tell you also occurs in 5:22a, 5:28a, 5:32a, and 5:34a. Translate it here as you did there.

not to resist an evil person: There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as resist:

1. It means resist or oppose. According to this interpretation, Jesus' teaching went beyond forbidding retaliation. Jesus taught that his followers must even be willing to accept mistreatment from evil people. For example:

not to oppose an evil person (GW) (BSB, NIV, RSV, ESV, NET, NASB, REB, NLT, NCV, NJB, JBP, KJV, GW, JBP)

1. It means retaliate or take revenge. According to this interpretation, Jesus was saying that his followers must not retaliate or seek revenge. For example:

do not take revenge on someone who wrongs you (GNT) (GNT, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and the majority of English versions.

5:39b–c and 5:40a–b are two examples of not to resist an evil person.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Do not resist those who wrong you (REB)

Do not fight those who do evil things to you

5:39b

If someone slaps you on your right cheek,

- If someone slaps you^(sing) on your right cheek,
- If someone hits you^(sing) on the right cheek with his hand,

The Greek of 5:39b begins with a word that is often translated as “but” or “and.” For example:

But if anyone slaps you (ESV)

There is a contrast between 5:39a and 5:39b–42b. The contrast is between the idea of opposing an evil person and Jesus' commands to allow such a person to do what he wants. Most English versions like the BSB do not translate this conjunction here, possibly because we are told not to oppose an evil person. So the contrast is not obvious. In many languages, it will not be necessary to have a conjunction here either.

If someone slaps you on your right cheek: The Greek word that the BSB translates as slaps also means “hits” or “strikes.” Here it implies using the hand. Such an action was a serious insult.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

If anyone slaps you on the right cheek (GNT)

If someone insults you with a slap on the right cheek

If a person hits you on your right cheek with his hand

5:39c

turn to him the other also;

- turn your^(sing) other cheek to him also.
- then offer your^(sing) other/left cheek to him to hit/slap as well.

turn to him the other also: The purpose of turn to him the other also is implied here. It is also “to be slapped,” as in the previous clause. The one who has received the slap is to offer the other (left) cheek to be slapped as well. It may be more natural in your language to include the implied purpose. For example:

turn to him the other cheek to be slapped as well

Matthew 5:40

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

5:40a

if someone wants to sue you and take your tunic,

- And if someone wants to take you^(sing) to court to take your shirt,
- If someone wants to accuse you^(sing) before a judge in order to get your undershirt as payment,

if someone wants to sue you and take your tunic: In this clause, the tunic is the payment that the person wants. It may be more natural in your language to state the second clause as purpose. For example:

if someone wants to sue you in order to take your tunic

sue you: The verb sue refers to someone trying to force you to pay him by having a judge order you to pay him.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

file charges against you to take your tunic

take you to court to make you pay him

accuse you before a judge and cause you to give your tunic as payment

tunic: The Greek word that the BSB translates as tunic refers to a long “shirt” or “undergarment.” These were clothes both men and women wore next to the skin to cover their bodies. The cloak (in 5:40b) went over the tunic.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

shirt (NCV)

undershirt

5:40b

let him have your cloak as well;

- allow him to have your^(sing) coat too.
- give your^(sing) outer garment to him also.

let him have your cloak as well: This clause means that you should also give the person your cloak.

cloak: The Greek word that the BSB translates as cloak refers to an outer garment.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

coat (NCV)

outer/over shirt

garment that goes on the outside

General Comment on 5:40a–b

The word “tunic” is an example of things that people might sue for. Giving something extra shows love to an evil person. You may want to include a footnote that explains the probable implied meaning.

Here is an example of a footnote:

The “tunic” is an example of things people might sue for. Giving something extra shows love to an evil person.

Matthew 5:41**Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain**

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

5:41a**and if someone forces you to go one mile,**

- If someone forces/makes you^(sing) to go with him and carry something for one kilometer/mile,
- If someone in authority orders you^(sing) to carry a load for a kilometer/mile,

and if someone forces you to go one mile: The Greek word that the BSB translates as forces...to go means “force into service.” It originally referred to a Roman soldier who had authority to make a person carry something for him, as the GNT translates (see the second example below). But it can also refer more generally to someone in a position of authority who can force you to do something for him.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

if anyone requires you to go one mile (NJB)

And if one of the occupation troops forces you to carry his pack one mile (GNT)

And if someone forces you to carry his load for one mile

one mile: The word mile refers to a Roman mile, which is about one and a half kilometers. The exact distance is not important to the teaching.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

one kilometer

one length of ground/land

5:41b**go with him two miles.**

- go^(sing) with him for two kilometers/miles.
- carry^(sing) it for him twice as far.

go with him two miles: Use the same term for “mile” as you used in the previous clause, but now it is two of them or “twice as far.” Jesus’ point here was that the person forced to help another person should do more than he is asked to do.

Matthew 5:42**Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain**

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

5:42a**Give to the one who asks you,**

- Give to the person who asks you^(sing) for something.
- If/When someone asks you^(sing) for something, give it to him.

Give to the one who asks you: In this example, Jesus did not say explicitly what the person is begging for. It may be more natural in your language to include an object for the verb Give or the verb asks. For example:

When someone asks you for something, give it to him (GNT)

Be ready to give something to a person who asks for it

5:42b

and do not turn away from the one who wants to borrow from you.

- And do not refuse the person who wants to borrow something from you^(sing).”
- And if/when someone wants you to lend something to him^(sing), lend it to him.”

and do not turn away from the one: This clause refers to denying the request of the one who wants to borrow.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

do not reject the one (NET)

It may be more natural in your language to translate do not turn away from in a positive way. For example:

lend it to them (CEV)

who wants to borrow from you: The word borrow refers to receiving something temporarily and promising to return it. The person who gives the object, lends it.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

when someone wants to borrow something (GNT)

a person who wants you to lend something to him

Matthew 5:43

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

5:43a

You have heard that it was said,

- ¶ “You^(plur) have also heard that our^(incl) ancestors were told:
- ¶ “You^(plur) have also heard the teachers of the law say that the law of Moses told/commanded our^(incl) ancestors:

You have heard that it was said: These same words are found in 5:27a and 5:38a. Translate it here as you did there.

5:43b

‘Love your neighbor’ and ‘Hate your enemy.’

- ‘Love those living next to you^(sing) and hate your enemy.’
- ‘Show great kindness to your^(sing) fellow countryman and despise your opponent.’

Love your neighbor: This part of the verse is a quote from the Old Testament (Leviticus 19:18). The Greek verb for Love is in the future tense, but is used as a command. It is also in the singular, but applies to all.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Love^(plur) your neighbor

You^{(sing)(plur)} must love your neighbor

Everyone must love his neighbor

Love: The word Love in this context means to show kindness to someone and value him highly.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Care greatly for

Show great kindness toward

Treat very well

Be very concerned for

your neighbor: The Greek word that the BSB translates as neighbor originally referred to someone who lives nearby. In this context it refers to a fellow Jew.

Here are some other ways to translate “Love your neighbor”:

Love your countryman/fellowman

Show kindness to your own people

Love your friends (GNT)

Hate your enemy: This part of the verse is not a direct quote from the Old Testament. But the teachers of the law were teaching it as a command from God.

Hate: The verb Hate means to have strong dislike and hostility toward someone. Just as in “love” above, the Greek verb is in the future tense, but is used as a command. It is also in the singular.

enemy: An enemy is a person who hates and opposes you and may try to harm you physically or in some other way.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Despise the one who wants to harm you^(sing).

Do not love the one who opposes you^(sing).

Matthew 5:44

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

5:44a

But I tell you, love your enemies

- But now I tell you^(plur), love your enemies
- But me, I tell you^(plur) to show great kindness to your opponents as well as to your fellow countrymen.

But I tell you: The clause But I tell you also occurs in 5:22a, 5:28a, 5:32a, 5:34a, and 5:39a. Translate it here as you did there.

love: You should translate the word love here in the same way as in 5:43. But here the verb is plural (“all of you”).

5:44b

and pray for those who persecute you,

- and pray for those who mistreat you^(plur),
- Pray that God will do good to the people who want to harm you^(plur).

pray for those: There is a textual issue here: (1) The earliest Greek manuscripts say “Pray for those who persecute you.” Nearly every major English version follows these manuscripts. This text is followed by the BSB, NIV, GNT, RSV, NASB, NLT, NCV, GW, CEV, NET, ESV, JBP, REB, NCV, and NJB. (2) Some later Greek manuscripts add the following underlined words in 5:44b: “bless those who curse you, do good to those who hate you, and pray for those who threaten/mistreat you and persecute you.” The KJV follows these manuscripts. It is recommended that you follow option (1). It has early and strong manuscript support. Also, nearly every major English version follows this option. The Greek word that the BSB translates as pray means “speak/talk to God.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Pray to God for those

Speak to God concerning those people

Ask God to help/bless the people

Some languages may use different words to refer to specific kinds of prayer, such as requests, thanks, or praise. Here you should use a word or expression that has a general meaning. Avoid a term that may imply magical or meaningless words.

who persecute you: The word persecute means “deliberately harm someone,” “mistreat someone” or “cause someone to suffer.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

mistreat

cause to suffer

oppress

harm on purpose

This same word occurs in 5:10a.

Matthew 5:45

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

5:45a

that you may be sons of your Father in heaven.

- so that you^(plur) will be true children of your Father in heaven.
- In this way you show that you are children of your Father in heaven. (GW)
- If you^(plur) do this, you will be like your Father who lives in heaven,

that: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as that introduces the purpose for loving enemies and praying for them (5:44a–b). We should pray for our enemies so that we will be like our Father.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

so that (ESV)

in order that

In this way (GW)

If you do this (NCV)

you may be sons of your Father in heaven: The words be sons indicate that believers who love their

enemies and pray for them are acting like their Father in heaven. The word sons is general and refers to both men and women.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

you show that you are children of your Father in heaven (GW)

you may be like your Father in heaven (NET)

you will be acting like your Father in heaven (CEV)

your Father in heaven: Here, Jesus spoke of God as your Father. Jesus further described God and distinguished him from our earthly father by saying in heaven.

In some languages, the phrase your Father would imply that God was only the father of those to whom Jesus was speaking, but not Jesus’ father. If that is so in your language, you may want to translate this phrase as:

our^(incl) heavenly father

God our^(incl) father who lives in heaven

heaven: The word heaven also occurs in 5:34b.

5:45b

He causes His sun to rise on the evil and the good,

- He makes the sun to rise on evil people and good people,
- in the sense that he/God makes the sun to rise and shine equally on both good and bad people,

The Greek of 5:45b begins with a conjunction that is often translated as “for.” It introduces an explanation of 5:45a. When we pray for our enemies, we are sons of our Father (5:45a). We are acting like him in the sense that he also does good to both evil and good people (5:45b).

The BSB and some English versions do not translate the conjunction. The meaning is implied in these versions. If you have a word or phrase that introduces an explanation, consider using it here.

He causes His sun to rise on the evil and the good:

The phrases the evil and the good refer to “evil people” and “good people.” For example:

on good people and on evil people (NCV)

This clause indicates that God loves all people. An example of his love is that he causes the sun to rise and shine on both evil people and good people.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

He makes his sun rise on people whether they are good or evil (GW)

He causes the sun to rise and shine on both good people and evil people

His sun: The phrase His sun is a literal translation of the Greek. In some languages, it may be more natural to say:

the sun he created

the sun (NET)

5:45c

and sends rain on the righteous and the unrighteous.

- and causes rain to fall on righteous people as well as on unrighteous people.
- and he also gives rain to those who do right as well as for those who do wrong.

sends rain: This is the second example of God's love. The words sends rain refer to God causing the rain to fall on both groups.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

lets rain fall (GW)

gives rain (GNT)

the righteous: The phrase the righteous refers to people who do what is right and good in God's sight.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

ones who do right (CEV)

people who live as God requires

upright people

This phrase refers to the same group referred to by the phrase "the good" above. Your translation should

allow for this phrase to refer to the same or similar group as the phrase "the good." For example:

and he sends rain on these upright people

the unrighteous: The phrase the unrighteous refers to people who do not do what is right and good in God's sight.

Here are some other ways to translate the unrighteous:

ones who do wrong (CEV)

people who do not live as God requires

people who do not obey God

This phrase refers to the same group referred to by the phrase "the evil" above. Your translation should allow for this phrase to refer to the same or similar group as the phrase "the evil." For example:

these people who do wrong

the ones who do wrong (CEV)

General Comment on 5:45b–c

The BSB follows the poetic form of the Greek text with the order of the phrases:

^{45b}the evil and the good...

^{45c}the righteous and the unrighteous...

Repeating two similar phrases in opposite order is a poetic form in the Greek. But some versions repeat the two similar phrases in the same order. For example:

both good and bad people... (CEV)

the ones who do right and...the ones who do wrong

Use an order that is most natural in your language.

Matthew 5:46

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

5:46a

If you love those who love you, what reward will you get?

- If you^(plur) love only the people who love you, do you deserve a reward/gift?
- If you^(plur) are kind only to those who are kind to you, God will not honor/bless you for that.

The Greek of 5:46a begins with a conjunction that is often translated as “for.” It introduces one basis/reason for the commands to “love your enemies” (in 5:44a) and “pray for them” (in 5:44b). We are commanded to love our enemies and pray for them for/because we will not have a reward if we pray only for those who love us.

The BSB and many English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either.

If you love those who love you, what reward will you get?: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus used this rhetorical question to emphasize that you should not expect a reward for loving those people who love you.

Here are some other ways to translate this emphasis:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

If you love those who love you, do you deserve a reward? (GW)

Why should God reward you if you love only the people who love you? (GNT)

- As a statement. For example:

If you love only the people who love you, you will get no reward. (NCV)

If you only show kindness to those who are kind to you, God will not reward you.

Translate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

love: See love in the note at 5:43b above.

what reward will you get: In this context, the word reward refers to a gift given for behavior that God approves of. It could be a special honor or blessing that God gives to that kind of person.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

what gift will you get

will God pay you for that

God will not do something special for you for doing that

5:46b

Do not even tax collectors do the same?

- Even the tax collectors love those who love them, don't they?
- Even evil/dishonest tax collectors show kindness to those who are kind to them.

Do not even tax collectors do the same?: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus used this rhetorical question to emphasize that even the tax collectors love the people who love them. The point is that no one expected God to reward corrupt people such as tax collectors. So if Jesus' followers expected God to reward them, they must be better than people like tax collectors.

Here are some other ways to translate this emphasis:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Even the tax collectors do the same, don't they? (NET)

Do not even the tax collectors do the same? (RSV)

- As a statement. For example:

Even the tax-collectors do as much as that. (REB)

Even the tax collectors love those people who love them.

Translate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

tax collectors: The term tax collectors refers to Jews who collected taxes from their fellow Jews. These Jews were employed by the conquering Romans to do this. The Romans did not pay them wages. Rather they allowed the tax collectors to take extra taxes as their pay. But many tax collectors took a lot extra and made themselves rich. So most Jews considered them to be traitors who worked for an oppressive foreign power. They also considered them to be thieves as well. And since they had contact with the Gentile Romans, they were also considered to be religiously contaminated (“unclean”).

You may need a footnote explaining tax collectors. Here is a sample footnote:

Tax collectors were hated by their fellow Jews for three reasons:

(1) They often unjustly took extra money from people and kept it for themselves and became rich.

(2) They worked for the Roman oppressors.

(3) Because of their frequent contact with the Romans (non-Jews), they were considered to be ritually contaminated (“unclean”).

If people in your area will not think of tax collectors as bad people, you may want to include that implied information. For example:

corrupt tax collectors (NLT)

evil tax collectors

Here are some other ways to translate tax collectors:

people who collect taxes

people who gather money from other people for the government

Matthew 5:47

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

5:47a

And if you greet only your brothers,

- And if you^(plur) only greet your brothers and sisters,
- If you^(plur) greet with a wish of peace and blessing only those of your own group,

5:47b

what are you doing more than others?

- are you^(plur) doing more than others?
- you^(plur) are certainly not doing anything better than other people do.

5:47a–b

And if you greet only your brothers, what are you doing more than others?: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus used this rhetorical question to emphasize that if you greet only your brothers, you are certainly not doing more than what other people do.

Here are some other ways to translate this emphasis:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

If you greet only your brothers, are you doing more than others?

If you greet only your brothers, how are you doing anything beyond what others do?

- As a statement. For example:

If you greet only your brothers, you are certainly not doing anything better than other people do.

Translate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

if you greet only your brothers: In the Jewish culture of that time, part of the greeting was to ask God to bless and give peace to the other person. You may want to include some of the implied information. For example:

if you greet only your brothers with a blessing

if you only greet your brothers wishing them peace and blessing

you: The you of this clause is plural.

your brothers: In this context, the word brothers probably refers to “those of your own group,” either men or women. If people in your area will think that the word brothers refers only to biological brothers, you may want to use a more general term. For example:

your friends (GNT)

your fellowmen/relatives

those from your own ethnic group

5:47c

Do not even Gentiles do the same?

- Don’t even unbelievers do that? (CEV)
- Even those who do not know God bless and greet those who bless and greet them.

Do not even Gentiles do the same?: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus used this rhetorical question to emphasize that even pagan Gentiles are kind/friendly to their friends.

Here are some other ways to translate this emphasis:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Even the Gentiles do the same, don’t they? (NET)

Don’t even unbelievers do that? (CEV)

- As a statement. For example:

Even the pagans do that! (GNT)

Even people who do not know God do that!

Translate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

Gentiles: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Gentiles refers to people who were not Jews. Such people worshiped idols, not the true God.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

unbelievers (CEV)

those who don’t know God (NCV)

pagans (NIV)

Matthew 5:48

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

5:48

Be perfect, therefore, as your heavenly Father is perfect.

- So, be blameless just like your^(plur) Father in heaven is blameless!
- Therefore, as our^(incl) Father who lives in heaven is without fault, you^(plur) also must be without fault!”

Be perfect, therefore: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as therefore introduces the conclusion of the previous teaching. In many languages, it will be more natural to put the conjunction first in this verse.

Here are some other ways to translate the clause Be perfect, therefore:

So then, be perfect (NET)

That is why you must be perfect (GW)

perfect: The Greek word that the BSB translates here as perfect means “morally mature,” “complete,” “satisfying all requirements,” “lacking nothing,” or “without flaw.” In the context of the preceding teaching, it particularly refers to showing love and kindness to all. The Greek tense is future, but it is used as a command.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Be blameless

You^(plur) must be without fault

You^(plur) must be complete/mature

as your heavenly Father is perfect: The word as indicates a comparison. In this verse, it shows that Jesus’ followers should act in the same way God acts. For example:

But you must always act like your Father in heaven. (CEV)

The phrase your heavenly Father has the same meaning as “your Father in heaven” in 5:45. Translate this phrase in a similar way.

General Comment on 5:48

In some languages, it is more natural to put the comparison first. For example:

Therefore, as your heavenly Father is perfect, you also must be perfect.

Matthew 6:1

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 6:1

Verse 6:1 is a summary of 6:1–18. It gives the general rule: Jesus’ disciples should want God’s approval, not human praise.

6:1a

“Be careful not to perform your righteous acts before men

- ¶ “Be sure that you^(plur) do not do your good deeds in front of people
- ¶ Jesus continued, “When you^(plur) do good deeds/works, never do them where there are lots of people.

Even though a new chapter begins at 6:1, Jesus continued “the Sermon on the Mount” which he began in chapter 5. In some languages, no introduction is necessary here. In other languages, it may be natural to begin this chapter with something like:

Jesus continued,

Jesus continued to teach and said,

But Jesus warned them,

Be careful not to perform: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as Be careful not to perform is a strong way to say “Do not do.” The Greek word that the BSB translates as Be careful refers to being alert or on guard about something. Here the warning is to be alert “not to do something.”

Some languages have other ways to strengthen a command. For example:

Make certain you do not perform (GNT)

Be careful not to do (NIV)

You must never do

your righteous acts: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as your righteous acts refers to right/good deeds that are done to honor and worship God. In this context, the phrase specifically refers to giving to the poor (6:2–4), praying (6:5–15), and fasting (6:16–18). It includes other good actions as well.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

your good deeds (JBP)

your deeds which honor God

your religious duties (GNT)

something good/upright

The word righteous also occurs in 5:6a.

Jesus expected his followers to do good deeds. His warning here was against doing good works for the wrong reason. In some languages, it may be more natural to first state what Jesus expected, and then state the warning. For example:

When you do good deeds, be careful never to do them only so that other people will see you.

before men: The phrase before men refers to doing something “openly” or “in an obvious way.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in public (GNT)

to attract attention (GW)

in order that people see you

to impress people

The word men is used in general way in this phrase and refers to people, both men and women.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

before other people (ESV)

in front of others (NIV)

6:1b

to be seen by them.

- in order that they see you^(plur).
- Do not do good deeds only so that people see you and praise/honor you^(plur),

to be seen by them: The clause to be seen by them implies more than just being seen by other people's eyes. It implies a desire to be praised by people. In

some languages, it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

to be seen and honored/praised by them

to be admired (NLT)

to impress people

The clause to be seen by them is passive.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

in order that you are seen by them

- Use an active verb. For example:

so that they/people will see you

6:1c

If you do, you will have no reward from your Father in heaven.

- If you^(plur) do that, you will receive no reward/gift from your Father in heaven.
- because if you^(plur) do them in front of people, God our^(incl) Father who lives in heaven will not give a reward to you.

If you do: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as If you do can also be translated as “for then” (as in the ESV). It refers to doing good deeds in order that people will see you.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

If you do that (NCV)

In that case

because then (NLT96)

If you do those deeds in that wrong way

you will have no reward from your Father in heaven: This clause is like a passive clause. In some languages, it is more natural to use an active clause. For example:

your Father in heaven will not give a reward to you

reward: The word reward refers to a gift given for behavior that God approves of. It could be a special honor or blessing that God gives to that kind of person.

In some languages, it is more natural to use a verb or clause to express this idea. For example:

your Father in heaven will not reward you. (GW)

your Father in heaven will not honor/bless you

This word also occurs in 5:46a.

your Father in heaven: In this verse, Jesus spoke of God as your Father. Jesus further described God and distinguished him from our earthly father by saying in heaven.

In some languages, the phrase your Father would imply that God was only the father of those to whom Jesus was speaking, but not Jesus' father. If that is so in your language, you may want to translate this phrase as:

our^(incl) heavenly father

God our^(incl) father who lives in heaven

This phrase also occurs in 5:45a. You should translate it here as you did there.

Matthew 6:2

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 6:2–4

In the Greek text of this passage, the pronouns for “you” and “your” are all singular (except for 6:2e,

which is plural). But the teaching applies to all of Jesus' followers. So in some languages, it is more natural to use the plural form of “you” here.

6:2a

So when you give to the needy,

- ¶ So/Therefore, whenever you^(sing) give alms/money to a poor person,
- ¶ “For example, when you^(plur) help poor people with money or another gift,

So: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as So indicates that the following verses (in 6:2–18) are the applications of the command in 6:1. These verses contain three examples of how to apply the command not to do good works before people.

¹Do not do your good deeds before men if you want a reward from God. ²Thus,

1. do not give to the needy sounding a trumpet (6:2–4)
2. do not pray where people can see you (6:5–15)
3. do not fast in a way that shows people you are fasting (6:16–18)

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

Therefore (KJV)

Thus (ESV)

For example

As a result

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction.

when you give to the needy: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as when you give to the needy is more literally “when you do/give alms” (as in the RSV). It means “when you give money or aid to poor people.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

when you give something to a needy person (GNT)

whenever you help a person in need

any time you give money/aid to poor people

when: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as when means “whenever” or “each time.” Jesus assumed that his followers would give to the needy.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

whenever (NRSV)

Every/each time

At any time

6:2b

do not sound a trumpet before you,

- do not blow/sound a trumpet/horn to draw attention to yourself,
- do not make a lot of noise to cause everyone to notice.

do not sound a trumpet before you: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as do not sound a trumpet before you also means “do not blow a trumpet before you” (as in the NET).

This clause is a metaphor. In this metaphor, doing good deeds in a way that causes people to notice you is compared to blowing a trumpet. Some ways that they are similar are that both of these things:

1. attract people’s attention
2. make people look at you

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

do not blow a trumpet before you (NET)

- Replace the metaphor with a simile and make explicit the way they are similar. For example:

Do not call attention to yourself like someone blowing a trumpet

Do not cause people to watch your giving like a person blowing a horn before he gives.

- Translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

do not make a lot of noise to draw attention to what you are doing

do not do it in a way that everyone will look/notice

trumpet: A trumpet is a musical instrument that makes a loud noise when someone blows into it. In the time of Matthew, some trumpets were made from the horns of rams. Other trumpets were made from metal tubes.

If you decide to translate the metaphor of blowing trumpets, here are some other ways to translate trumpet:

horn

instrument

6:2c

as the hypocrites do in the synagogues and on the streets,

- like the hypocrites do in the prayer houses and on the street corners.
- Do not be like the pretenders who give to poor people in the worship houses and along the streets where there are a lot of people.

as the hypocrites do: The Greek word that the BSB translates as hypocrites literally refers to actors (in the theater). Figuratively it refers to people who pretend to be something they are not. They say that they believe one thing, but they do something different. Or they appear religious or spiritual on the outside, but they do not have true hearts that desire to please God.

In this context, Jesus was referring to people who gave money or other help to poor people. But they did it in the presence of other people so that these other people would think highly of them and honor them. They did not do it out of love for the needy person.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

those who pretend to be good/pious

those who just act like they are obedient to God

those who pretend to be devout people

Some languages have an idiom for this word. For example:

two-tongued

double-hearted

in the synagogues and on the streets: The phrase in the synagogues and the phrase on the streets both indicate very public places. Many beggars gathered in these areas, because many people would be there. In these areas, people could easily see someone giving money to a poor person.

Here are some other ways to translate these phrases:

in the meeting places and on the street corners
(CEV)

in public places where many people are there and
can see them

synagogues: The word synagogues refers to buildings where Jews gathered to pray, read Scripture, teach their beliefs, and worship God. The Jews also gathered in synagogues for cultural activities. There was only one temple, but each Jewish community had a synagogue.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

prayer-houses of the Jews

meeting-places of the Jews

buildings for worship

houses for gathering together

The word “synagogue” first occurs in 4:23b. Translate it here as you did there. See also synagogue in the Glossary for more information.

6:2d

to be honored by men.

- They do it so that people will praise them. (GNT)
- They do this in order that people will see them doing good and praise/admire them.

to be honored by men: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as to be honored can also mean “to be praised” or “to be admired.”

This verb is passive.

Here are some ways to translate this verb:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

in order to be praised by people (GW)

- Use an active verb. For example:

so that people will praise them

men: The word that the BSB translates as men means “people.” It is identical to the word “men” in 6:1a.

6:2e

Truly I tell you, they already have their full reward.

- I assure you^(plur), they have received all the reward that they will ever get.
- Let me tell you that their only reward is the praise from people, because God will not reward/honor them more than that.

Truly I tell you: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as Truly I tell you introduces a statement that the speaker wants to emphasize. Also, the statement is often surprising. When Jesus began a statement with these words, he was asking people to listen with extra attention.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I assure you

Certainly/Truly,

Listen to this:

Let me tell you this:

If you have a way in your language to emphasize a statement or to alert people to listen with special attention, consider using it here.

This clause first occurred in 5:18a. Translate it here as you did there.

you: The Greek word for you here is plural.

they already have their full reward: This clause indicates that the praise that the hypocrites received from people is the only reward they will get. That honor is their complete reward. God will not give them any additional rewards.

God rewards people who do good deeds for the right reasons. But these hypocrites did good deeds for the wrong reasons. So God will not reward them.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

they have received all the reward they will ever get (NLT)

That will be their only reward (GW)

they will not receive any other reward/wages

that praise/honor from people will be their only reward because God will not reward/honor them any further

their full reward: The noun reward is the same word that occurs in 6:1c.

In some languages, it is more natural to use a verb or clause to express this idea. For example:

people have rewarded them by honoring them, but God will not reward them

people have already praised them, so God will give them nothing more

Matthew 6:3

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 6:2–4

In the Greek text of this passage, the pronouns for “you” and “your” are all singular (except for 6:2e, which is plural). But the teaching applies to all of Jesus’ followers. So in some languages, it is more natural to use the plural form of “you” here.

6:3a

But when you give to the needy,

- But you^(sing), whenever you give alms/money to a poor person,
- But as for you, when you help poor people with money or another gift,

But: There is a contrast between 6:2 and 6:3. The contrast is between the actions of the hypocrites and the way that Jesus wants his followers to act. The BSB and many English versions indicate this contrast with the conjunction But.

Here are some other ways to translate this contrast:

As for you

However, you

when you give to the needy: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as when you give to the needy uses the same words as the clause translated as “when you give to the needy” in 6:2a. The meaning is the same.

In this clause, the pronoun you is emphasized in the Greek text. If your language has a way to emphasize the pronoun you, you may want to do so here.

Here are some examples:

when you yourself give

as for you, when you give

you, when you give to the needy

6:3b

do not let your left hand know what your right hand is doing,

- do not tell your left hand what your right hand is doing,
- let no one know it. Do it in a way as if your left/one hand does not even know what your right/other hand is doing,
- give in a way so that no one will know that you gave/helped.

do not let your left hand know what your right hand is doing: This clause is a metaphor. Doing things without letting others know is compared to not letting your left hand know what your right hand is doing. One way that they are similar is that one group/side does not know what the other is doing.

Here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

don't tell your left hand what your right hand is doing (NLT96)

do not let one hand know what the other hand is doing

- Translate this clause as a simile and give the meaning. For example:

give privately in a way that is like your left hand not knowing what your right hand is doing

give so that even your best friend does not know what you are doing. It is like one of your hands does not know what the other hand is doing.

- Translate the meaning of this clause without the metaphor. Here are some examples:

don't let anyone know about it (CEV)

give in a hidden/private way so that no one will know that you gave

Matthew 6:4

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 6:2–4

In the Greek text of this passage, the pronouns for “you” and “your” are all singular (except for 6:2e, which is plural). But the teaching applies to all of Jesus’ followers. So in some languages, it is more natural to use the plural form of “you” here.

6:4a

so that your giving may be in secret.

- in order that you^(sing) give secretly/privately.
- In this way, other people will not see/know that you^(sing) gave money to poor people.

so that: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as so that introduces the purpose of not letting your left hand know what your right hand is doing (in 6:3b).

^{3b}Do not let one hand know what the other is doing, ^{4a}in order that your giving may be in secret.

Another way to translate this conjunction is as the introduction of a result clause. For example:

Then (GNT)

your giving: In some languages it is more natural to translate the phrase your giving with a clause. For example:

what you give

the alms/help you give to the needy

may be in secret: The Greek word that the BSB translates as secret refers to something “hidden” or “unseen.” By not letting others know that you are helping the poor (6:3b), your “giving” is in secret. Other people do not see or know what you give because you are “giving” in a private way.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

it will be a private matter (GNT)

no one will know/see what you have done

Use an expression that can be used both here and in 6:4b.

6:4b

And your Father, who sees what is done in secret, will reward you.

- Then God your Father, who sees all that is done in secret/private, will reward you^(sing).
- God your Father will see what you do when no one is watching. He will honor/exalt you^(sing).

And your Father: The phrase your Father refers to God.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

And your Father God

Then your heavenly Father

Our^(incl) Father God

The phrase your Father also occurs in 6:1c. See how you translated it there.

who sees what is done in secret, will reward you:

The phrase in secret is the same phrase as in 6:4a, and refers to the same thing.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

who sees all that is done in secret will reward you (NJB)

knows the deed that you have done when no one can see you, and he will reward you.

Be careful to translate the clause in a way that does not imply that you have two Fathers: one who sees in secret and another who does not see in secret. In some languages, it is more natural to translate this as two sentences. For example:

Your Father sees what you do in private. He will reward you. (GW)

Matthew 6:5

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 6:5–8

In these verses, Jesus taught his disciples the manner in which they should pray. They should not pray in a way that people will see them (6:5–6). Rather, they should pray in a private place by themselves. They also

should not make their prayers long by repeating the same words over and over (6:7–8).

6:5

This verse has similar grammar and similar phrases to 6:2. Translate it in a similar way.

6:5a

And when you pray,

- ¶ “Whenever you^(plur) pray to God,
- ¶ Jesus gave another example. He said, “Each time you^(plur) talk with God,

And: Verse 6:5a begins the second example of how to apply the command (in 6:1) not to do good works before people.

Here are some other ways to begin this verse:

Another example is

Jesus gave another example and said,

Similarly

Some English versions do not use a word or phrase to introduce this example. You should use whatever is most natural in your language.

when: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as when means “whenever” or “each time.” It assumes that believers will pray.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

whenever (NRSV)

Every/each time

At any time

you pray: The word pray means “speak/talk to God.” Some languages may use different words to refer to specific kinds of prayer, such as requests, thanks, or praise. Here you should use a word or expression that has a general meaning. Avoid a term that may imply magical or meaningless words.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

speak to God

talk with God

This word also occurs in 5:44b. See how you translated it there.

6:5b

do not be like the hypocrites.

- do not pray like the hypocrites do.
- do not talk with him in the way that the pretenders talk with him.

do not be like the hypocrites: The clause do not be like the hypocrites means “do not pray like the hypocrites pray.”

The phrase the hypocrites first occurs in 6:2c. Translate it here as you did there.

6:5c

For they love to pray standing in the synagogues and on the street corners

- Because they very much like to stand and pray in the prayer houses and at the street corners
- They greatly enjoy standing and talking with God in the worship houses. They enjoy standing and talking with God on the street corners where there are a lot of people.

For: The Greek word that the BSB translates as For introduces the basis for the command in 6:5b.

^{5b}Do not pray like the hypocrites, ^{5c-d}for/because they love to pray where people can see them.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

because they love to pray... (NET)

who love to pray... (NLT)

In some languages, no conjunction or connecting phrase is necessary here.

In other languages, it will be more natural to put the basis for the command before the command. For example:

^{5c}Hypocrites love to pray standing in the synagogues and on the street corners ^{5d}to be seen by men. ^{5b}Do not be like them.

they love to pray standing: The word love refers to liking or enjoying something very much. The hypocrites greatly enjoyed standing and praying where other people would see them, because they wanted those people to think highly of them and praise them.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

they very much enjoy standing and praying

they greatly like to stand and pray

in the synagogues and on the street corners: The phrase in the synagogues and on the street corners refers to very public places. Many people would be in those places, and they could easily see someone praying.

Here are some other ways to translate these phrases:

in the meeting places and on the crowded street corners

in public places where there are many people

This expression is almost the same as the one in 6:2c. See how you translated it there.

the synagogues: The word synagogues also occurred in 6:2c. Translate it here as you did there.

the street corners: The phrase street corners refers to places where two streets joined or crossed. The place where the edges of the two streets met is a street corner. In cities such as Jerusalem, there would be many people passing by street corners who would see those praying there.

If busy street corners are not common in your area, you may want to use an expression for a busy outdoor place. For example:

in public places where there are many people

6:5d

to be seen by men.

- in order that people see them pray.
- They do that so that people see them and praise/honor them.

to be seen by men: As in 6:1b, the clause to be seen by men implies more than just being seen. It implies a desire to be praised by people. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

to be seen and honored/praised by them

to impress people

The clause to be seen by men is passive.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

in order that they are seen by people

- Use an active verb. For example:

so that they/people will see them

men: Here the word that the BSB translates as men means “people” and refers to both men and women. Here it has the same meaning as the word “men” in 6:1a and 6:2d.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

others (ESV)

everyone (NLT)

6:5e

Truly I tell you, they already have their full reward.

- I assure you^(plur), they have received all the reward that they will ever get.
- Let me tell you that their only reward is the praise from people, because God will not reward/honor them more than that.

Truly I tell you, they already have their full reward:

This clause is exactly the same as the clause in 6:2e. Translate it here as you did there.

Matthew 6:6

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 6:5–8

In these verses, Jesus taught his disciples the manner in which they should pray. They should not pray in a way that people will see them (6:5–6). Rather, they should pray in a private place by themselves. They also should not make their prayers long by repeating the same words over and over (6:7–8).

6:6a

But when you pray, go into your inner room, shut your door,

- But as for you^(sing), whenever you pray to God, go into your inner/private room alone, close the door,
- But you, when you^(plur) talk with God, go to a place where you are alone.

But when you pray: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between the public way that the hypocrites pray (in 6:5) and the private way that Jesus wants his followers to pray (in 6:6). Some English versions indicate this contrast with the word But. In addition, the word you is emphasized in Greek.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

But you, when you pray

However, you, when you pray

As for you, when you pray

you: In Greek, the pronoun you is singular. However, it refers to each person individually. In some languages, it will be more natural to use the plural form of you.

go into your inner room, shut your door: The Greek word that the BSB translates as room refers to an inner room. In other words, it is a room within a house. This refers to a private place. It is implied that the person is alone in the room. For example:

go into a room alone (CEV)

If those meanings will not be clear to people in your area, you may want to include some implied information. For example:

go into your private/inner room alone and close the door

If houses in your area do not have inside rooms, you may want to use a general expression for being alone. For example:

go into your house alone

go to where you can be alone

go to a place where there are no other people

6:6b

and pray to your Father, who is unseen.

- and pray to your Father who is in that secret place.
- Then talk with God your Father. He is there in that secret/hidden place.
- Pray to him there. God your Father is there in that place where no one can see you.

and pray to your Father, who is unseen: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as who is unseen is more literally “the one in the secret.” There are several ways to interpret this Greek phrase. The three main interpretations are:

1. It refers to God’s omnipresence. According to this interpretation, the focus is on God’s presence in that secret place. Jesus instructed his followers to pray in a room where no one can see them. Only God is there, and he can see them. For example:

pray to your Father who is in that secret place (NJB) (NJB, GW, and probably RSV, ESV, NASB, KJV, REB)

1. It refers to praying privately. According to this interpretation, the phrase is adverbial and goes with pray. Jesus said that his followers should not pray in public. Rather, they should pray in private. For example:

Pray to your Father in private. (CEV) (NET, CEV, NLT, JBP)

1. It refers to God’s invisibility. According to this interpretation, the focus is on the fact that no one can see God, but he can see them. For example:

pray to your Father, who is unseen (GNT) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

Be careful not to translate this phrase in a way that implies that there are two fathers: one who is in the secret place, and one who is somewhere else. In some languages it is more natural to translate this in two sentences. For example:

Pray to God your Father. He is there in that secret/hidden place.

Your heavenly Father is there where no one can see you. Pray to him there.

6:6c

And your Father, who sees what is done in secret, will reward you.

- Then God your Father, who sees all that is done in secret/private, will reward you^(sing).
- He sees what you do when no one is watching. He will honor/exalt you^(sing).

And your Father, who sees what is done in secret, will reward you: This clause is exactly the same as the clause in 6:4b. Translate it here as you did there.

Matthew 6:7

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 6:5–8

In these verses, Jesus taught his disciples the manner in which they should pray. They should not pray in a way that people will see them (6:5–6). Rather, they should pray in a private place by themselves. They also should not make their prayers long by repeating the same words over and over (6:7–8).

6:7a

And when you pray, do not babble on like pagans,

- When you^(plur) pray, do not say lots of words that have no value/meaning. That is the way that the pagans/heathen pray,
- Also, when you^(plur) talk with God, do not be like people who do not know God. They continue to repeat the same words without thinking.

And when you pray, do not babble on: The Greek word that the BSB translates as babble on refers to “speaking meaningless words” or “speaking without thinking.” In this context it probably includes excessive repetition.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

do not use a lot of words that have no meaning/
value

do not continually repeat and repeat

do not pray a long time without thinking what you
are saying

like pagans: The Greek word that the BSB translates as like pagans refers to “people who were not Jews.” Such people worshiped idols, not the true God.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

non-Jews who do not worship God

those people who don’t know God (NCV)

6:7b

for they think that by their many words they will be heard.

- because they mistakenly think that they will be heard when they pray long prayers.
- They believe that their god/gods will hear them if they say many words. But they are wrong.

for: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as for introduces the reason that Gentiles pray long prayers.

^{7a}The Gentiles heap up empty phrases, ^{7b}because they think that they will be heard because they use so many words.

In some languages, it is not necessary to have a conjunction here. For example:

They think God likes to hear long prayers. (CEV)

In other languages, it is more natural to put the reason first. For example:

^{7b}The Gentiles think that they will be heard because of their many words. ^{7a}So when they pray, they heap up empty phrases. Do not pray like them.

they think: The Greek word that the BSB translates as think means “imagine something to be true.” In this case, they are mistaken in what they think. Hagner, page 147 says, “They “think” they will be heard by means of their devices, but in this they are mistaken.” It may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

they mistakenly think/suppose

they believe wrongly

they assume.... But they are wrong.

by their many words: These Gentiles think that their “gods” will listen to them if they use many words and make their prayers long.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

because of their many words

by using many words (NJB)

when/if they pray a long time

they will be heard: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as they will be heard is passive. The “god” or “gods/idols” that these people pray to are the ones that “hear.”

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

they will be heard (RSV)

their prayers will be heard

- Use an active verb. For example:

their gods will hear them (GNT)

whomever they are praying to will hear them

Matthew 6:8

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 6:5–8

In these verses, Jesus taught his disciples the manner in which they should pray. They should not pray in a way that people will see them (6:5–6). Rather, they should pray in a private place by themselves. They also should not make their prayers long by repeating the same words over and over (6:7–8).

6:8a

Do not be like them,

- Do not pray like they pray,
- Therefore, do not talk^(plur) with God using many words like they do.

In Greek, 6:8 begins with the conjunction that is often translated in English as “therefore/so.” For example:

So do not be like them (NASB)

This conjunction indicates that 6:8 is the conclusion to something that came before it. The part that comes before the conclusion has some implied information.

Here is one way to show the conclusion and what is implied:

^{7b}they think they will be heard because of their many words, but they are wrong. ^{8a}Therefore/So, do not be like them.

The BSB and most English versions do not translate this conjunction.

Do not be like them: The clause Do not be like them means “Do not pray like they pray.” Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Do not pray the way that they pray

Do not do what they do

Do not imitate them

them: The pronoun them refers to the “pagans” of 6:7a. You may need to repeat the expression you used for “pagans” instead of the pronoun them. For example:

Do not be like those pagans/Gentiles

Do not pray like those non-Jews

6:8b

for your Father knows what you need before you ask Him.

- because your heavenly Father knows all that you^(plur) need before you ask him for it.”
- God your Father already knows what is necessary for you^(plur) even before you ask him to give it to you.”

for: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as for introduces the basis for the command in 6:8a. In some languages, it is not necessary to have a conjunction here. For example:

Your Father knows what you need before you ask.
(CEV)

In other languages, it is more natural to put the basis of the command before the command. For example:

^{8b}Your Father knows what you need before you ask him. ^{8a}Therefore, do not be like the pagans who pray using many words.

your Father: The phrase your Father refers to God. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

your Father God

your heavenly Father

our^(incl) Father God

This phrase also occurs 6:1c and 6:4b. See how you translated it there.

knows what you need: Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

knows the things that are important to you

knows the things that are necessary for you

before you ask Him: Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

before you ask him for those things

before you ask him to give you those things

Matthew 6:9

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 6:9–13

In this paragraph, Jesus gave his disciples a model prayer to show them how he would like them to pray. Many English speaking Christians call this prayer “The Lord’s Prayer.”

Several English versions print each part of this prayer on a different line. For example:

⁹Our Father in heaven,

hallowed be your name,

¹⁰your kingdom come,

your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven.

¹¹Give us this day our daily bread,

¹²and forgive us our debts,

as we also have forgiven our debtors.

¹³And lead us not into temptation,

but deliver us from evil.

When you prepare the book of Matthew for printing, you will have to decide how to format this prayer.

6:9a

So then, this is how you should pray:

- ¶ “Therefore, pray in this way:
- ¶ Jesus continued, “So, you^(plur) should pray to God like this example:
- ¶ “I will tell you how you should pray. Say:

So then, this is how you should pray: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as So then also means “therefore” or “so” (as in the NET). This conjunction introduces the conclusion to what was said in 6:7–8. The words that follow in 6:9b–13 are an example of how to pray.

this: The pronoun this refers ahead to the whole prayer in 6:9b–13.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

So you should pray like this: (NJB)

Therefore, when you pray to God, here is the way to do it:

So, when you talk to God, say this:

6:9b

‘Our Father in heaven,

- ‘Our^(excl) Father in heaven,
- ‘God our^(excl) Father who is/lives in heaven,

Our Father: Here Jesus addressed God as Our Father. If it is not clear that Jesus was referring to God, you may need to make it explicit. For example:

Our Father God

God our Father

in heaven: The words in heaven refer to God living there.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

who is/lives in heaven

God our heavenly Father

6:9c–13b

Verses 6:9c–13b are a series of requests to God. In Greek, these requests are third person commands. In some languages, when praying to a deity, requests are expressed very politely. For example:

We pray/request that your name be hallowed

Our request is that your name be hallowed

Please help us to hallow your name

You should translate these requests in a way that is natural for people making requests to God.

6:9c

hallowed be Your name.

- may your^(sing) name be honored.
- we pray that people will honor/respect your name.
- please cause everyone to honor you^(sing).

hallowed be Your name: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as hallowed be Your name is a prayer. It is a prayer that God would cause his name to be recognized/honored as holy. In some languages there may be a more natural way to begin a prayer. For example:

May your holy name be honored (GNT)

we pray/ask that your name be recognized as holy

In some languages it may be more natural to remove the passive verb and say who should honor the name of God. It is possible to supply either “we/us” or “everyone.” For example:

help us to honor your name (CEV)

we pray that everyone will honor your name.

hallowed be: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as hallowed comes from the same Greek word as “holy.” It means “make or cause something to be holy.”

This verb is passive. The text does not specify who should make God’s name holy. This action involves both God and people. God makes his name holy by revealing to people that he is holy. He is completely perfect and sinless and is worthy of awe. People make God’s name holy by honoring or treating him as the holy God who deserves their worship and obedience.

If possible, translate this clause in a way that both God and people can be understood as the ones who make God’s name holy. Here are some other ways to do this:

- Use a passive verb, as in the previous two examples.
- Use an active verb. For example:

cause people to recognize that your name is holy

reveal to everyone that you are holy so that they will recognize you as the only God

help us to honor your name (CEV)

If you need to specify that either God or people are the ones who make God’s name holy, it is recommended that you specify people. For example:

we pray that all people would honor/respect your holy name

may all people recognize that you are holy

Your name: In Jewish thinking, a person’s name represented the person himself. When people honored someone’s name, it was the same as honoring him. If this would not be understood in your language, it may be necessary to translate the meaning of name. For example:

may you be honored as the holy God

may people treat you with the respect you deserve as God

we ask that you will cause men to say, “You are holy”

Matthew 6:10

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

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Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 6:9–13

In this paragraph, Jesus gave his disciples a model prayer to show them how he would like them to pray. Many English speaking Christians call this prayer “The Lord’s Prayer.”

Several English versions print each part of this prayer on a different line. For example:

⁹Our Father in heaven,

hallowed be your name,

¹⁰your kingdom come,

your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven.

¹¹Give us this day our daily bread,

¹²and forgive us our debts,

as we also have forgiven our debtors.

¹³And lead us not into temptation,

but deliver us from evil.

When you prepare the book of Matthew for printing, you will have to decide how to format this prayer.

6:10a

Your kingdom come,

- May your kingdom come. (NCV)
- We^(excl) pray that you will rule over all people.
- Please establish your rule as king.

Your kingdom come: The clause that the BSB translates as Your kingdom come has a similar structure to the previous clause. It is a prayer that expresses a desire that God’s kingdom will come.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

may your kingdom come (NET)

Most scholars agree that this prayer refers to more than one aspect of God’s kingdom/rule. This is a prayer that:

1. God will truly rule now in the lives of his people
2. God’s rule will be extended over more and more people
3. God’s rule will be established in the future over all the earth

If possible, you should translate in a way that allows for all these meanings.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Cause your kingdom/chieftaincy to be established

May you rule everyone/everywhere

We pray that you will rule over all people

May the time begin/arrive for you to rule as king

See “kingdom of heaven” in the note on 5:3b.

6:10b

Your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven.

- May your^(sing) will/desire happen/occur on earth just as it happens/occurs in heaven.
- We^(excl) pray that what you want/desire may be done/obeyed on earth just as it is done/obeyed in heaven.
- Please cause people on earth to do what you^(sing) want just as those in heaven do what you want.

Your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven: The clause that the BSB translates as Your will be done has a similar structure to the previous clause. It is a prayer that expresses a desire that God’s will/desires will be done.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

may what you want to be done, happen on earth
just as it happens in heaven

The word will refers here to “what one wishes to happen.” God has made known his will primarily through his word, which reveals his commands and purposes. The prayer is that people who live on earth will do God’s will just as those who live in heaven do his will.

This clause is passive. In some languages it is more natural to translate this as an active clause. For example:

May those who live in this world do your will just
as those who live in heaven do it.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

may everyone on earth obey you, as you are
obeyed in heaven

we pray that everyone on earth will obey you just
like those in heaven obey you

Matthew 6:11

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

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The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 6:9–13

In this paragraph, Jesus gave his disciples a model prayer to show them how he would like them to pray. Many English speaking Christians call this prayer “The Lord’s Prayer.”

Several English versions print each part of this prayer on a different line. For example:

⁹Our Father in heaven,

hallowed be your name,

¹⁰your kingdom come,

your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven.

¹¹Give us this day our daily bread,

¹²and forgive us our debts,

as we also have forgiven our debtors.

¹³And lead us not into temptation,

but deliver us from evil.

When you prepare the book of Matthew for printing, you will have to decide how to format this prayer.

6:11

Give us this day our daily bread.

- Today, give^(sing) to us^(excl) the food that we^(excl) need for today.
- We^(excl) pray that today you^(sing) will provide the food that we^(excl) need to live.
- Please give^(sing) us^(excl) what we need to eat for today.

Give us this day our daily bread: This clause is a request to God to provide the food that we need for one day.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

We pray that you will give us today the food that we need.

Today, please give us the food we need for this day.

our daily bread: The phrase our daily bread means “the food we need for today.” The word that the BSB translates as bread is the generic term for food.

In many languages the staple food, such as rice or cassava, has become the generic word for food. In some languages it is more natural to use a verb.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Give us something to eat today

Give us our food for today. (CEV)

Matthew 6:12

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

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¹²and forgive us our debts,

as we also have forgiven our debtors.

¹³And lead us not into temptation,

but deliver us from evil.

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6:12a

And forgive us our debts,

- And forgive^(sing) our^(excl) sins
- We also pray that you^(sing) will pardon what we have done to offend you,
- Please forgive/cancel^(sing) the wrongs that we^(excl) have done,

And forgive us: This clause is a prayer that expresses a desire that God will forgive us.

The word forgive always involves at least two people. One of them has done something wrong to the other and offended him. When forgive refers to God, then people are the offenders and God is the offended. “Forgive” in this context means that God chooses not to punish us for an offense that deserves punishment. God cancels our offense and treats us as though we had never offended him.

Here are some other ways to translate forgive:

Pardon

We pray that you will cancel

Please erase/remove

our debts: The literal meaning of the Greek word that the BSB translates as debts is “what someone owes to another.” In the Jewish culture, sin/offense was regarded as a debt. So in this context, debts is used as an idiom that means “sins” or “wrongs.”

Here are some other possible ways to translate this clause:

our sins (NCV)

the wrongs we have done (GNT)

what we have done to offend you

6:12b

as we also have forgiven our debtors.

- in the same way that we^(excl) forgive people who have sinned against us.
- even as we^(excl) pardon those who have offended us.
- just as we^(excl) forgive/cancel the wrongs that others have done to us.

as we also: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *as* here means “in the same way that.” It does not mean “because” or “since.”

Here are some other ways to translate this:

like we do

the same as we do

have forgiven: In this context, the verb *have forgiven* refers to forgiving those who have sinned against us each time they wrong us. It does not refer to forgiving them one time. In your translation, the tense/aspect of the verb “forgive” should indicate this. For example:

forgive (GNT)

our debtors: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *debtors* is similar to “debts” in 6:12a. It refers to “those who owe something to another person.” In this verse it is an idiom meaning “those who have done wrong to us.” For example:

the wrongs that others have done to us (GNT)

those who sinned against us (NCV)

those who have done bad things to us

Matthew 6:13

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

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The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

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Several English versions print each part of this prayer on a different line. For example:

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hallowed be your name,

¹⁰your kingdom come,

your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven.

¹¹Give us this day our daily bread,

¹²and forgive us our debts,

as we also have forgiven our debtors.

¹³And lead us not into temptation,

but deliver us from evil.

When you prepare the book of Matthew for printing, you will have to decide how to format this prayer.

6:13a

And lead us not into temptation,

- Do not lead^(sing) us^(excl) to anything that will tempt us to sin.
- We pray that you^(sing) will keep/protect us^(excl) from going where someone/something will try to make us sin.
- Please do not allow^(sing) anything/anyone to persuade/cause us^(excl) to sin.

And lead us not into temptation: The Greek word that the BSB translates here as *temptation* is ambiguous. There are two ways to interpret this word:

1. It means *temptation*. This refers to being tempted to sin. It means “enticed/encouraged to do what is wrong.” For example:

Don’t allow us to be tempted (GW) (BSB, NIV, RSV, NET, CEV, NCV, GW, NLT)

1. It means testing. This refers to difficulties and persecutions. For example:

do not bring us to hard testing (GNT) (GNT, NRSV, NJB, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with a majority of Bible scholars.

lead us not into temptation: The clause lead us not into temptation means that we should ask God to lead/guide our lives away from situations that expose us to temptation. It is a request that God will protect us from situations where someone or something will persuade us to sin. God himself does not tempt people (James 1:13).

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

lead us away from temptation

don't let us yield to temptation (NLT)

Don't allow us to be tempted. (GW)

Keep us from being tempted (CEV)

cause us to stay far from temptation to do wrong/
evil

This clause is passive. In some languages it may be more natural to translate this as an active clause. For example:

Do not allow anyone/anything to tempt us to sin

This clause is the same as in Luke 11:4.

6:13b

but deliver us from the evil one.'

- But rescue^(sing) us^(excl) from the evil one.
- Instead, keep^(sing) us^(excl) safe from the evil one, Satan.
- Rather, protect^(sing) us^(excl) from the evil one, the devil.

but: There is a contrast between 6:13a and 6:13b. The contrast is between "leading us to temptation" and "delivering us from evil." The BSB and many English versions indicate this contrast with the conjunction but.

Here are some other ways to translate this contrast:

Instead (GW)

Rather

deliver us: The Greek word that the BSB translates as deliver refers to saving, rescuing, or protecting someone from harm or danger.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

keep...safe (GNT)

rescue (NLT)

protect (CEV)

the evil one: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the evil one can be interpreted in two ways:

1. It refers to the evil one. This phrase refers to Satan. For example:

but keep us safe from the Evil One (GNT) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NJB, NRSV, NLT, NET, GW, REB, NCV)

1. It refers to evil in general. For example:

and protect us from evil (CEV) (RSV, NASB, CEV, JBP, ESV, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Most commentaries follow this interpretation.

The words "the evil one" also occur in 5:37b. See how you translated it there.

6:13c

[[For Yours is the kingdom and the power and the glory, forever. Amen.]]

- [[For the kingdom and the power and the glory are yours^(sing) forever. Amen."]]
- [[Because for all time you^(sing) have the complete right to rule, and you have all power, and you have all majesty. Let it be so."]]
- [[We pray this because authority, power, and greatness all belong to you. May it be so."]]

There is a textual issue here. The words in 6:13c are not in the earliest Greek manuscripts. As a result, most English versions put this part of the verse only in a footnote, as the BSB does. However, many churches include the words in 6:13c in the version of the Lord's Prayer that they recite. For this reason, you will probably want to translate these words, even if you put them neither in the text nor in a footnote.

If you do put these words in a footnote, a sample footnote is:

Only some of the later Greek manuscripts include extra words at the end of 6:13, which reads: For yours is the kingdom and the power and the glory forever. Amen.

To show that the words in 6:13c are not part of the normal text, the BSB source line for 6:13c is in double square brackets in the Display.

For: Verse 6:13c expresses praise to God. It is also the closing of the prayer in 6:9b–13b. Furthermore, it is the basis for the requests in the prayer. We can pray that God’s name be hallowed, that his kingdom come, and so forth because authority, power, and glory belong to him.

The BSB introduces this part of the prayer with the word *For*. Here are some other ways to introduce this part of the prayer:

Because

I/We pray this because

In some languages, it will not be necessary to begin 6:13c with a connecting word or phrase.

Yours is the kingdom: The Greek words that the BSB translates as *Yours is the kingdom* indicate that only God has the right to rule as supreme.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

you alone have the authority/right to rule over all

authority belongs to you

See how you translated kingdom in 3:2 or 4:17.

and the power: There are implied words in this phrase as shown below:

and yours is the power

The entire phrase means “God has all power.” Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

you have all power

you are all-powerful/almighty

all power belongs to you

and the glory: Just as in the previous phrase, there are implied words here:

and yours is the glory

In this context the word glory refers to the “majesty” or “greatness” of the Lord.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

you are the greatest one

you are the most majestic one

all greatness belongs to you

Amen: The word Amen comes from the Greek word *amēn*, which is a transliteration of a Hebrew word. It means “let it be so,” or “truly.” If the people in your area already use the word Amen, you may want to use it here. Or you may want to translate the meaning:

Let it be so

Let it happen that way

May it truly be that way

General Comment on 6:13b–c

Since this is the end of the model prayer, it may be natural in some languages to indicate that the prayer has ended. For example:

Pray like that.

That is how you should pray.

Matthew 6:14

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

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Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 6:14–15

And lastly, Jesus taught that when his disciples pray for God to forgive them, they must also forgive others (6:14–15). The understanding is that if they do not forgive others, then God will not forgive them.

6:14a

For if you forgive men their trespasses,

- ¶ “You can pray for God to forgive you because if you^(plur) forgive people for their sins against you,
- ¶ “If you^(plur) forgive others when they wrong you,

For: Verses 6:14–15 are the reason why we can ask God to forgive us (in 6:12). The Greek indicates that these verses are the reason with a conjunction that the BSB translates as For.

Jesus taught us to pray ^{12a}“Forgive us our debts...for/ because ^{14b}your heavenly Father will forgive you ^{14a}if you forgive others their trespasses.”

Since 6:13 comes between the two parts about forgiveness, it may be necessary to make the connection more clear. For example:

You should pray for God to forgive you for/because

Pray this way because

Many English versions do not translate this word. In some languages, it may not be necessary to translate this word either.

if you forgive: The word forgive is the same word as in 6:12a. For help in translating this word, see the notes there.

men: The Greek word that the BSB translates as men refers to people in general.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

other people

people

their trespasses: The Greek word that the BSB translates as trespasses is another word for “sins.”

Here are some other ways to translate their trespasses:

when they sin against you (NIV)

the wrongs they have done to you (GNT)

the bad things that they have done against you

6:14b

your heavenly Father will also forgive you.

- your heavenly Father will also forgive your sins.
- then God, your Father who is/lives in heaven, will also forgive you when you do wrong.

your heavenly Father: The phrase your heavenly Father refers to God. It is very similar to the phrase “Our Father in heaven” in 6:9b.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

God your heavenly Father

God your Father who is/lives in heaven

Matthew 6:15

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

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Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 6:14–15

And lastly, Jesus taught that when his disciples pray for God to forgive them, they must also forgive others (6:14–15). The understanding is that if they do not forgive others, then God will not forgive them.

6:15a

But if you do not forgive men their trespasses,

- But if you^(plur) do not forgive people for their sins against you,
- However, if you^(plur) do not forgive others when they wrong you,

6:15

But: There is a contrast between 6:14 and 6:15. The contrast is between forgiving and not forgiving. The BSB indicates this contrast with the word But.

Here are some other ways to indicate this contrast:

However

On the other hand

Otherwise

6:15b

neither will your Father forgive yours.

- your Father will not forgive your sins.”
- then God, your Father, will not forgive you when you do wrong.”

your Father: The phrase your Father also refers to God. It means the same thing as “your heavenly Father” in 6:14b.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

God your Father

your Father in heaven

Matthew 6:16

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

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Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 6:16–18

This paragraph contains the third example of how to apply the command (in 6:1) not to do good works before people. This third example is about fasting.

6:16a

When you fast, do not be somber like the hypocrites,

- ¶ “Whenever you^(plur) fast, do not look sad like the hypocrites do.
- ¶ Jesus continued, “Each time you stop eating food for a time to honor God, do not make your face sad/unhappy like the pretenders.

When: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as When also means “whenever” or “each time.” It assumes that believers will fast.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

whenever (NRSV)

Every/each time

At any time

See how you translated When in 6:2 where it has the same meaning.

fast: The word fast means “choose not to eat food temporarily for a religious/spiritual reason.” Generally, when someone fasts, he does not eat any food, but he can drink water. People usually fast for a day, but the fast can be a shorter or longer period of time. People fast to humble themselves, to show sadness for their sins, or to seek God’s will or help.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

stop eating for a time for religious reasons

not eat for a day/time to seek God’s help

abstain from eating in order to pray

do not be somber: The Greek word that the BSB translates as somber means “sad.” Jesus was referring to looking sad in order that people will realize that you are fasting and will think that you are religious. The full clause warns against making one’s face look sad or unhappy.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

do not put on a sad face (GNT)

do not look sad

do not let it be known by your appearance/face

the hypocrites: The word hypocrites refers to people who pretend to be something that they are not.

This word also occurs in 6:2c. Translate it here as you did there.

6:16b

for they disfigure their faces

- They make their faces look sad
- They act like they are suffering

for: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as for introduces a more detailed explanation of what was said in 6:16a. Do not translate this verse as if it were the reason for 6:16a. It further explains 6:16a, but it is not a reason. Some English versions begin a new sentence here and do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, a conjunction will not be necessary here either.

they disfigure their faces: In this context, the Greek word that the BSB translates as disfigure refers to not washing their faces and not keeping their hair and beards looking neat. They did this to look like people who were very sorrowful.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

They neglect their appearance (GNT)

They make their faces look sad (NCV)

they act like they are suffering

they do not wash their faces nor comb their hair

6:16c

to show men they are fasting.

- so that people may see that they are fasting.
- to show people that they have stopped eating food for a time to honor God.

to show men they are fasting: In Greek, this clause is literally “so that fasting may be seen by men.” This clause gives the purpose for their “disfigured faces” (in 6:16b). They made their faces look sad in order to make it obvious to others that they were fasting.

Although the BSB uses an active phrase here (to show men), the Greek verb is passive (“may be seen”).

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- As a passive. For example:

so that they may be seen by others that they are fasting

- As an active, as the BSB does. For example:

so that people may see that they are fasting (JBP)

so that everyone will see that they are fasting (GNT)

to make it obvious that they’re fasting (GW)

men: The Greek word that the BSB translates as men refers to people in general here, both men and women.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

other people

people

6:16d

Truly I tell you, they already have their full reward.

- I assure you^(plur), they have received all the reward that they will ever get.
- Let me tell you^(plur) that their only reward is the praise from people, because God will not reward/honor them more than that.

Truly I tell you, they already have their full reward:

This clause is identical to the clause in 6:2. You should translate it here as you did there.

Matthew 6:17

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 6:16–18

This paragraph contains the third example of how to apply the command (in 6:1) not to do good works before people. This third example is about fasting.

6:17–18

In the Greek text of 6:17–18, the pronouns for “you” and “your” are singular. These pronouns are in commands that apply to everyone. In some languages, it is more natural to use plural pronouns. Translate these pronouns in the way most natural for general commands in your language.

6:17

But when you fast, anoint your head and wash your face,

- But you^(sing), whenever you fast, wash your face and put oil on your head as usual,
- Instead, every time you^(plur) stop eating food for a time to honor God, wash your face and make yourself look neat like you do on normal days.

But: There is a contrast between 6:16 and 6:17. The contrast is between the wrong way that hypocrites fast and the right way that Jesus wants his followers to fast.

Here are some other ways that English versions indicate this contrast:

But (RSV)

Instead (CEV)

when you fast: In Greek, the pronoun you is emphasized. This further indicates a contrast between the hypocrites and Jesus’ followers. If your language has a way to emphasize the pronoun you, you may want to do so here. Here are some examples:

when you yourself fast

as for you, when you fast

you, when you fast

anoint your head and wash your face: The clause anoint your head means “put oil on you head/hair.” This clause and the clause wash your face both refer to everyday personal grooming in the Jewish culture at that time.

If people in your area will not understand that the clause anoint your head refers to a clean appearance and neatness, you may want to use a normal personal grooming activity from your area.

Here are some other ways to translate these clauses:

put oil on your head and wash your face (NIV)

wash your face and comb your hair (GNT)

wash your face and make your hair neat

clean and prepare yourself as you usually would.

Matthew 6:18

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

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Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 6:16–18

This paragraph contains the third example of how to apply the command (in 6:1) not to do good works before people. This third example is about fasting.

6:18a

so that your fasting will not be obvious to men,

- in order that people will not see that you are fasting.
- Do this so that no one will know/realize that you are not eating food for a time to honor God.

so that: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as so that introduces the purpose for washing one’s

face. Jesus asked his followers to ¹⁷wash their face and comb their hair ^{18a}in order that it is not obvious to people that they are fasting.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

in order that

for the purpose that

Yet another way to introduce this clause is as a result. For example:

Then no one will notice that you are fasting (NLT)

your fasting will not be obvious to men: This clause is similar to 6:16c, except that it is negative. People who fast should look clean and neat as usual so that other people will not see that they are fasting.

The verb will not be obvious is passive.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- As a passive, as the BSB does. For example:

you may not be seen by others that you are fasting

- As an active. For example:

people will not see/realize that you are fasting

no one will know you are fasting (NJB)

your fasting won't be obvious (GW)

6:18b

but only to your Father, who is unseen.

- But you will only be seen by God your Father. He is in that secret place.
- Only God your Father will realize/see it. He is in that secret place.

but only: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but indicates a contrast. The contrast is between the people who will not know that you are fasting and God, who will know.

You should wash ^{18a}so that your fasting will not be obvious to other people, ^{18b}but it will be obvious to God.

to your Father: The verb phrase “be obvious” from 6:18a is implied here. It will be obvious to your Father. He alone will know that you are fasting.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- As a passive:

your fasting will be obvious to God your Father

- As an active. For example:

only your Father will know that you are fasting

but your Father God alone will realize/see it

your Father: As in 6:15b, the phrase your Father refers to God. You should translate it here as you did there.

who is unseen: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as who is unseen also occurs in 6:6b. It refers to the fact that God is everywhere and sees everything. In the context of fasting, it is probably implied that the fasting should also be done in a place where no one will see. But God is there in that secret place.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

who is in that secret place

who is with you in private (GW)

6:18c

And your Father, who sees what is done in secret, will reward you.

- God your Father, who sees all that is done in secret/private, will reward you^(sing).
- He sees what you do when no one else sees you. He will honor/exalt you^(sing).”

And your Father, who sees what is done in secret, will reward you: This clause is identical to the clause in 6:4b. Translate it here as you did there.

Matthew 6:19

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 6:19–21

In this paragraph, Jesus warned against trying to save a lot of money or things here on earth. They just disappear. Rather, be eager to increase your spiritual worth, because that is what lasts. And what you strive to have will become what you think about and desire.

6:19a

Do not store up for yourselves treasures on earth,

- ¶ “Do not collect for yourselves wealth/ riches here on earth,
- ¶ “Do not gather many possessions/ belongings here in this world,
- ¶ Jesus continued, “Do not accumulate for yourselves things that are worth much here on earth,

Do not store up for yourselves: The Greek word that the BSB translates as store up refers to gathering or accumulating things.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Do not accumulate for yourselves (NET)

Do not lay up for yourselves (ESV)

You must not collect/gather

treasures on earth: The phrase treasures on earth refers generally to the earthly, physical possessions that are most important and valuable to people. They are things such as money, expensive clothing, jewels, livestock, food, houses, and lands.

Here are some other ways to translate the word treasures:

- Choose a term that can be used both here and in 6:20a. Such a term could be used to refer to (a) both physical treasure and (b) figurative or spiritual treasure. Here are some examples:

wealth

that which is worth much

- Choose a term that can only be used here, but not in 6:20a. Such a term refers specifically to physical treasure. Here are some examples:

possessions

belongings

6:19b–c

The main idea in 6:19b–c is that possessions here on earth do not last. Insects will eat some of them, rust will destroy some of them, and thieves will steal some of them. So trying to gather many possessions and put them aside will not be helpful.

6:19b

where moth and rust destroy,

- where moths and rust ruin things,
- because here in this world, insects eat some things and destroy them, and rust corrodes/spoils other valuable things,

moth: A moth is a flying insect that produces worms that eat holes in clothes. If moths are not known in your area, you may want to use another insect that destroys things. For example:

termite

weevil

(boring) insect

The word moth is singular in Greek. But it represents the entire group of insects. So many English versions translate it as “moths.”

rust: The Greek word that the BSB translates as rust is literally “eating.” Here it refers to anything that eats away or corrodes another material. This includes rust spoiling iron, or gold and silver becoming tarnished. It also may include insects eating holes in clothing, and rats eating grain.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

corrosion

decay

destroy: The Greek word that the BSB translates as destroy refers to ruining something.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

spoil (JBP)

ruin

Both the noun “moth” and the noun “rust” go with the verb destroy. In some languages, it may be necessary to use a different verb with each noun. For example:

moths eat them and rust destroys them (NLT)

6:19c

and where thieves break in and steal.

- and where robbers break into houses and steal things.
- and thieves sneak into houses and steal other things.

thieves: The word thieves refers to people who break into houses to steal things from others.

Here is another way to translate this word:

robbers (GNT)

break in: The Greek word that the BSB translates as break in is literally “dig through.” Most Jews of that time built their houses with dried mud bricks. So thieves would dig a hole through the dried mud wall to enter the house.

The BSB uses the usual English verb phrase break in for the way thieves enter a house. Use the usual verb in your language for a thief entering a house. For example:

thieves sneak in to steal

thieves break the door and enter

Matthew 6:20

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 6:19–21

In this paragraph, Jesus warned against trying to save a lot of money or things here on earth. They just disappear. Rather, be eager to increase your spiritual worth, because that is what lasts. And what you strive to have will become what you think about and desire.

6:20a

But store up for yourselves treasures in heaven,

- But collect for yourselves wealth/riches in heaven,
- But gather rewards in heaven by doing good,
- Instead, accumulate in heaven that which is worth much,

But: There is a contrast between 6:19 and 6:20. The contrast is between storing up treasure on earth (6:19) and storing up treasures in heaven (6:20).

Here are some ways to introduce this contrast:

but (RSV)

Instead (GNT)

Rather

store up for yourselves: This phrase is identical to the phrase in 6:19a. Translate it here as you did there.

treasures in heaven: The phrase treasures in heaven is parallel to and contrasts with the phrase “treasures on earth” in 6:19a. If possible, use the same word for “treasures” here as in 6:19a.

This verse does not specifically say what these treasures are, but it probably includes rewards from God. God will reward his people for doing their “acts of righteousness” such as giving to the needy (6:2–4), praying (6:5–8), and fasting (6:16–18), and doing all these in secret.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- Use the same word for treasures as in 6:19a. Such a word can be used to refer to figurative or spiritual treasures. Here are some examples:

treasures

wealth

- Use a word or expression that refers to spiritual treasures. For example:

rewards in heaven by doing good

that which is worth much in heaven

6:20b

where moth and rust do not destroy,

- where moths and rust do not ruin things,
- because there in heaven no insects eat things and destroy them and no rust corrodes/spoils things,

6:20c

and where thieves do not break in and steal.

- and where robbers do not break into houses and steal things.
- and no thieves sneak into houses and steal other things.

6:20b–c

where moth and rust do not destroy, and where thieves do not break in and steal: Except for the negatives do not, the words of this clause are the same as those in 6:19b–c. The negative do not is also implied before steal. You should translate this clause the same way as you did there, but add the negatives.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

where there are no moths and no rust to destroy them, and no thieves to steal them

Store your treasures in heaven, where they will never become moth-eaten or rusty and where they will be safe from thieves. (NLT96)

Matthew 6:21

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

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Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 6:19–21

In this paragraph, Jesus warned against trying to save a lot of money or things here on earth. They just disappear. Rather, be eager to increase your spiritual worth, because that is what lasts. And what you strive to have will become what you think about and desire.

6:21

For where your treasure is, there your heart will be also.

- I command this because the place where your treasures are stored, at that same place will also be your heart/thoughts.”
- Your heart/desires will be at the place where your wealth is located/gathered.”

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For introduces the basis for the commands in 6:19–20. Jesus commanded his followers:

^{19a}Do not lay up treasures on earth, ^{20a}but lay up treasures in heaven. ²¹For/Because where your treasure is, there your heart will be also.

In some languages, it is more natural to put the basis for the commands (in 6:21) before the commands. For example:

²¹Where your treasure is, there your heart will be also. ¹⁹So/Therefore, do not lay up for yourselves...

In some languages, no conjunction or phrase is needed to introduce 6:21.

where your treasure is, there your heart will be also: This sentence refers to the fact that a person’s thoughts and actions will be focused on those things that he values most. A person who desires material things will spend his life trying to accumulate material things. A person who desires things that please God will spend his life trying to please God.

Here are some other ways to translate this sentence:

The place where your treasures are stored, at that same place will also be your heart/thoughts

Your thoughts will want to be at the place where the things you value are.

heart: The word the BSB translates as heart refers to your inner life, your thoughts and desires. For the word heart, use a term that is normally used in your language for “inner life.” It may be a different organ such as “liver” or “throat.” Or it may be a more general term such as “insides” or “spirit.” See how you translated heart in 5:8.

Matthew 6:22

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 6:22–23

This paragraph is a complex metaphor. It uses the figures of speech of a lamp, light, darkness, the eye, and the body. Jesus used this complex metaphor to teach people that they should focus their attention on what God wanted them to do. If their spiritual eyesight was good, they would understand the danger of being distracted by earthly wealth (6:19). They would clearly see that they needed to serve God with undivided loyalty (6:24).

These verses occur with almost identical wording in Luke 11:34–35, but the context is different. Jesus used the same complex metaphor in different contexts to teach slightly different truths. However, the metaphor itself is the same, so you should translate both passages in a similar way.

Jesus used the singular form for “you” and “your” here, but what he was saying applies to anyone and everyone. In some languages, it may be more natural to use other pronouns here. For example:

^{22a}The eye is the lamp of a person’s body. ^{22b}When a person’s eyes are good, ^{22c}his whole body also is full of light. ^{23a}But when his eyes are bad, ^{23b}his body also is full of darkness.

^{22a}The eyes are the lamp of our^(incl) body. ^{22b}When our eyes are good, ^{22c}our whole body also is full of light. ^{23a}But when our eyes are bad, ^{23b}our body also is full of darkness.

6:22a

The eye is the lamp of the body.

- ¶ “The eye is the lamp of/for the body.
- ¶ “The eyes are like a lamp that lights/illuminates a person.
- ¶ “Your eyes are like your lamp.

The eye is the lamp of the body: This clause is the first part of the metaphor. It compares a person’s eye with a lamp. They are similar in that both a lamp and an eye enable a person to see. A person’s physical eyes enable him to see where he is going. His spiritual eyes enable him to understand the truth of Jesus’ message.

Here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

The eye is the lamp of the body.

The lamp of the body is the eye.

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

The eyes are like a lamp for the body (GNT)

- Change the metaphor to a simile and make explicit the similarity between the eye and the lamp. For example:

The eye is like a lamp that illuminates/lights the body.

Your eyes are like a lamp. They let light enter your mind.

- You may want to add a footnote to explain what the Jews understood about the eye, the mind, and the body. A sample footnote is: Davies and Allison (page 635) challenge the view that light enters the body through the eye. They claim that according to Jewish thought, the eye produced its own light. However, a

strong majority of commentaries on both Matthew and Luke understand that the Jews considered the eye to be the organ or means by which light entered the body. This view is supported by the Old Testament view of the eye as the entrance to the mind or heart. See Michael V. Fox. Proverbs 1–9. The Anchor Bible. Volume 18a. New York: Doubleday, 2000, page 220.

In the time of Jesus, people considered the eye to be a source of light. They thought that the eye was the part of the body that shined light into a person's mind or heart.

eye: This word is singular, but it refers to a person's eyes in general. In some languages, it may be more natural to use the plural "eyes." For example:

eyes (NIV)

lamp: A lamp was a small clay container that people put oil in. It had a wick that they lit at night to provide light for their house. See how you translated this word in 5:15.

of the body: The phrase the body is a figure of speech. It represents the person as a whole.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

The eye is a person's lamp

Your eyes are your lamp

6:22b

If your eyes are good,

- So, if your eye is healthy/good,
- So, if you can see well/clearly,
- If your eyes are strong/bright,

In Greek, this clause begins with a conjunction that is often translated as "so" (ESV) or "therefore" (RSV). This word introduces the next step in Jesus' reasoning. It indicates that the following statements are based on the comparison of the eye to a lamp. This word does not occur in the parallel passage in Luke 11:34b.

Many English versions leave this relationship implied. For example, the BSB and NIV say:

If your eyes are good (NIV)

Express this relationship in a natural way in your language.

If your eyes are good: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as eyes are good means that the person has good eyesight. He can see clearly. Figuratively, it means that the person has good spiritual eyesight. He can see/understand the truth about God and is able to focus his thoughts clearly on the truth. He has a good attitude toward Jesus and is willing to receive Jesus' message. In the context of not storing up earthly wealth, it probably also implies that the person has a generous attitude toward others. Many scholars point out that the Greek word (haplous) that is used here can mean "single" (KJV) in the sense of single-minded, having a single, undivided focus (France (2007), Osborne, Lenski, Davies and Allison, Tasker, and others). In contrast to a "bad" eye, it can also mean "good" or "healthy" (most versions). Related forms of this word are translated as "generous" in contexts that speak of giving to the poor (see Romans 12:8; 2 Corinthians 8:2, 9:11, 9:13; James 1:5).

Here are some ways to translate this clause:

If your eyes are good (NCV)

If you have clear/strong eyesight

If you can see clearly/well

In some languages, it may be necessary to make the figurative meaning of healthy eyes explicit. For example:

A person who is willing to receive my teaching is like someone with good/healthy eyes. If your thinking is like that,

In some languages, it will be good to explain the figurative meaning of healthy eyes in a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

A healthy eye represents a good attitude or clear thinking. A person who thinks clearly about God and money will not be greedy. He will be generous with others.

6:22c

your whole body will be full of light.

- your entire body will be as if filled with light.
- there will be light in/for your entire body.

- your whole body/mind will be completely illuminated/lighted like a room where a bright lamp is shining/burning.

your whole body will be full of light: This clause means that light enters the inside of the body from the eye and lights up the entire person. Here, the meaning of this figure of speech is that the person will fully understand the truth and will be filled with goodness.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the inside of your body will be lit

there will be light in the whole body

it is as if your entire mind/being will be illuminated

In some languages, it may be necessary to make the figurative meaning of light explicit. For example:

you will completely understand the truth. It will be as if your whole body is illuminated.

Matthew 6:23

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

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Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 6:22–23

This paragraph is a complex metaphor. It uses the figures of speech of a lamp, light, darkness, the eye, and the body. Jesus used this complex metaphor to teach people that they should focus their attention on what God wanted them to do. If their spiritual eyesight was good, they would understand the danger of being distracted by earthly wealth (6:19). They would clearly

see that they needed to serve God with undivided loyalty (6:24).

These verses occur with almost identical wording in Luke 11:34–35, but the context is different. Jesus used the same complex metaphor in different contexts to teach slightly different truths. However, the metaphor itself is the same, so you should translate both passages in a similar way.

Jesus used the singular form for “you” and “your” here, but what he was saying applies to anyone and everyone. In some languages, it may be more natural to use other pronouns here. For example:

^{22a}The eye is the lamp of a person’s body. ^{22b}When a person’s eyes are good, ^{22c}his whole body also is full of light. ^{23a}But when his eyes are bad, ^{23b}his body also is full of darkness.

^{22a}The eyes are the lamp of our^(incl) body. ^{22b}When our eyes are good, ^{22c}our whole body also is full of light. ^{23a}But when our eyes are bad, ^{23b}our body also is full of darkness.

6:23a

But if your eyes are bad,

- But if your eye is diseased/bad,
- But if you cannot see well/clearly,
- But if your eyes are weak/dim,

But if your eyes are bad: This clause means that the person’s eyes have something wrong with them, so they cannot see well. Figuratively, it means that the person has bad spiritual eyesight. He does not see/understand the truth about God and does not focus his thoughts on the truth. He has a bad attitude toward Jesus and is not willing to receive Jesus’ teaching. In the context of not storing up earthly wealth, it probably also implies that the person is selfish and is not willing to share with others.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

But if your eyes are diseased

but if you cannot see clearly/well

In some languages, it may be necessary to make the figurative meaning of bad eyes explicit. For example:

but a person who rejects my teaching is like someone with bad eyes. If your thinking is like that,

In some languages, it will be good to explain the figurative meaning of bad eyes in a footnote. A sample footnote is:

A bad eye represents a bad attitude. It represents the thinking of a person who is not willing to receive Jesus' teaching. When such a person thinks about money, he will be selfish. He will not want to share his money with others.

6:23b

your whole body will be full of darkness.

- your entire body will be as if filled with darkness.
- there will be darkness in/for your entire body.
- your whole body/mind will be completely dark like a room where no lamp is shining/burning.

your whole body will be full of darkness: This clause means that light cannot enter the body from the eye, so the inside of the person is completely dark. Here, the meaning of this figure of speech is that the person will not understand the truth at all. He will be filled with sinfulness and evil.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the inside of your body will be dark

there will be darkness in the whole body

it is as if your entire mind/being will be dark

In some languages, it may be necessary to make the figurative meaning of darkness explicit. For example:

you will not understand the truth at all. It will be as if your whole body is full of darkness.

6:23c

if then the light within you is darkness,

- So, if the light that should be in you is not there,
- If that which should illuminate you does not shine,
- So, if you think incorrectly that your mind is lighted/illuminated, but it is actually dark,

then: In Greek, this clause begins with a conjunction that the BSB translates as then. This conjunction in-

roduces the results of darkness where there should be light.

Here is another way to translate this conjunction:

So if the light in you is darkness (GNT)

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction.

If...the light within you is darkness: This clause refers to the situation where the eye is supposed to bring light into the body. But if the eye is bad, then the person will be in darkness. So in the place where there should be light, there was instead darkness. This means that a person who thought that he was filled with goodness is actually filled with evil.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

if the only light you have is really darkness (NCV)

And if the light you think you have is actually darkness (NLT)

6:23d

how great is that darkness!

- then you are in complete darkness.”
- your mind will be very dark.”
- then the darkness inside you is extreme/black indeed!”

how great is that darkness!: This clause indicates that the darkness is very great. This means that you completely fail to understand the truth and that there is a lot of sin/evil in you.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

how terribly dark it will be (GNT)

then you have the worst darkness (NCV)

Matthew 6:24

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

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Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 6:24

In this paragraph, Jesus compared his disciples to servants/slaves. He also compared God and money to two masters. He said that people who want to be his disciples cannot serve both God and money.

This verse is almost word-for-word the same as Luke 16:13.

6:24a

No one can serve two masters:

- ¶ “No slave can have two masters.
- ¶ “No one can fully work for two owners/bosses at the same time.

No one can serve two masters: The Greek word that the BSB translates as serve means “do the work of a slave.”

The word masters refers to “owners of slaves.”

This entire clause means that no slave can work for two masters/owners at the same time and be equally loyal to both.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

No slave can work for two owners at the same time

No one can completely obey two bosses at the same time

6:24b–c

Before you translate 6:24b–c, there are two issues to consider:

Issue 1: The way the clauses are connected

Verse 6:24b–c is the basis for the conclusion in 6:24a. The Greek introduces this basis with a conjunction that is often translated as “for.” However, the BSB does not translate this word.

In some languages, it is more natural to put the basis (6:24b–c) before the conclusion (6:24a). For example:

^{24b} If a servant has two masters, he will hate the one and love the other, ^{24c}or he will be devoted to

the one and despise the other. ^{24a}So/Therefore, no one can serve two masters.

Even if you do not translate this conjunction, you should think about the most natural way in your language to order the clauses in this verse.

Issue 2: Parallelism

The clause “he will hate the one and love the other” (in 6:24b) and the clause “he will be devoted to the one and despise the other” (in 6:24c) are a parallelism. A parallelism is a feature of poetry where two (or more) lines are related to each other in some way. In this parallelism, the two lines repeat the same information, but in a different order. The first part of 24b has a similar meaning to the last part of 24c, and the last part of 24b has a similar meaning to the first part of 24c. This is called a chiasmic parallelism. The similar parts are shown here:

^{24b}Either he will hate the one and **love** the other

^{24c}or he will be **devoted** to the one and despise the other

In some languages, it is not natural to repeat the same information in two ways. In other languages, the words “Either” and “or” will wrongly imply that a servant must choose either 6:24b or 6:24c.

Here are some other ways to translate this parallelism:

- Keep the parallelism but use a word like “also,” rather than “either/or.” For example:

He will hate one master and love the other. He will also be devoted to one master and despise the other.

- Combine the parallel parts. Put “hate” and “despise” in one statement, and “love” and “be devoted to” in the other statement. For example:

He will hate and despise one master, and he will love and be devoted to the other master.

- Use a comparison. For example:

He will love one master more than the other. He will be more devoted to one master than to the other.

6:24b**Either he will hate the one and love the other,**

- He will hate one master/boss, and love the other.
- If he tries to obey two bosses, he will love one boss more than the other boss.

Either: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *Either* introduces one possible attitude of a servant who was trying to serve two masters. A similar attitude is described in 6:24c. Since the two attitudes are not contradictory alternatives, it may be better to omit an explicit translation of the word *Either*.

Also, see the discussion about “or” in the note on 6:24c.

he will hate the one and love the other: This clause implies a situation in which a slave tries to serve two masters at the same time. In some languages, this information may need to be made explicit. For example:

if he had two masters, he would hate the one and love the other

if he tried to serve two masters, he would hate the one and love the other

hate...love: Jesus probably used the strong opposites of hate and love here in a comparative sense. By comparison with a slave’s feeling of love for one master, his feeling for the second master would seem like hatred. One way to translate this as a comparative is:

he will love one master more than the other master

Consider whether it will be more effective to use the absolute terms hate and love or a comparative statement.

the one...the other: The phrases the one and the other mean “one master” and “the other master.”

6:24c**or he will be devoted to the one and despise the other.**

- He will be loyal to one and not respect the other.
- He will be more faithful to one than the other.

or: The conjunction *or* introduces a statement that is parallel to 6:24b. It is not contradictory to 6:24b. So in some languages it may be best to omit an explicit translation of the word *or*.

Here are some other possible ways to connect 24c with 24b:

As I said,

I repeat,

See also the discussion above about “Either” and “or” in 6:24b–c.

he will be devoted to the one and despise the other:

This clause is parallel to 6:24b. It expresses the same idea using different words. The verb translated as *be devoted to* is a synonym of “love” in 6:24b. And the verb translated as *despise* is a synonym of “hate” in 6:24b. However, here the ideas are reversed for poetic effect. If it is not natural in your language to reverse the order of the verbs in this way, you may keep the same order as in 6:24b. For example:

he will despise one master and be devoted to the other.

be devoted to: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as *be devoted to* means “be loyal to.”

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

be faithful to

enthusiastically follow

be...loyal to (CEV)

despise: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as *despise* means “disrespect someone” and “treat someone with scorn and contempt.”

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

not respect

disdain

scorn

6:24d**You cannot serve both God and money.**

- Therefore, you^(plur) cannot serve God and money/ riches at the same time.”

- A person cannot have God as his master and money as his master at the same time.”

You cannot serve both God and money: Jesus was saying that a person who loves money and says he also loves God is like a slave who is trying to serve two masters. Either God or money can be the master of a person, but not both. A person must choose which one they will love and serve.

You: In Greek, the pronoun You is plural. However, 6:24d is a general statement that is true of everyone. So you should use your normal pronoun or phrase for general statements. For example:

You^(sing) cannot serve God and money

We^(incl) cannot serve God and money

A person cannot serve God and money

money: The Greek word that the BSB translates as money includes money, property, and possessions.

Here are some other ways to translate this entire clause:

You cannot serve God and wealth (NRSV)

You cannot serve both God and worldly riches (NCV)

If people in your area will not understand a literal translation of “serve wealth,” you may want to use the concept of “master” from 6:24a. For example:

You^(plur) cannot have both God as your master and wealth as your master

Or you may want to translate in a nonmetaphorical way. For example:

In the same way, you^(plur) cannot love God above all else and seek money above all else at the same time.

If money is what you love the most, then you cannot also love God the most.

Matthew 6:25

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

6:25a

Therefore I tell you,

- ¶ “For this/that reason I say to you^(plur),
- ¶ Then Jesus said, “That is why I tell you^(plur),

This verse begins a new section on not worrying; but Jesus continues speaking from 6:24. You may want to indicate that Jesus continued speaking. For example:

Jesus continued...

Therefore: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Therefore can also be translated as “for this/that reason.” The phrase joins this section (6:25–34) to previous sections in a general way.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

This is why (GNT)

Since God is our master

So (NCV)

6:25b

do not worry about your life, what you will eat or drink;

- do not worry about the things you need to live such as food or/and drink.
- do not worry about what you^(plur) will eat and drink to live.
- let your mind be at peace about what you need to live such as what you will eat, drink,

do not worry about your life, what you will eat or drink: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as do not worry means “do not be anxious” (as in the ESV). The phrase what you will eat or drink are specific examples of things that people often worry about regarding their life.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause with the parts somewhat reordered:

don't worry about the food or drink you need to live (NCV)

do not be worried about such things as the food and drink you need in order to stay alive

do not be concerned about what you will eat or drink to stay alive

6:25c

or about your body, what you will wear.

- And do not worry about the things you^(plur) need for your body, such as clothes to wear.
- Do not worry about clothes for your body.
- and wear.

or about your body, what you will wear: The clause what you will wear is an example of things people often worry about regarding their body. They worry about clothes. The verb phrase “do not worry” is implied from 6:25b. So the entire clause could be translated as:

or do not be worried about such things as clothes for your body

and do not be concerned about what you will wear

In some languages, it is more natural to translate the clause what you will wear along with food and drink as a list of things not to worry about. For example:

^{25b}Don't worry about having something to eat, drink, or ^{25c}wear. (CEV)

^{25b}Do not worry about food, drink or ^{25c}clothes.

6:25d

Is not life more than food,

- Is not life more important than food?
- Life is more important than food, is it not?

- Surely living is worth much more than eating!

Is not life more than food...?: This is the first part of a rhetorical question. It expects an answer of “yes, life is more important than food.” Jesus used this rhetorical question to emphasize this truth.

Here are some ways to translate this emphasis:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Is not life more important than food...? (NIV)

Life is more important than food, is it not?

isn't life worth more than food? (GNT)

- As a statement. For example:

Surely life is more important than food (JBP)

Your life is more valuable than food.

Translate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

life: Your language may use a verb for the meaning of the noun life:

being alive

living

6:25e

and the body more than clothes?

- Is not the body more important than clothes?
- The body is certainly more important than clothes, is it not?
- Surely your body is worth more than the clothes you wear!

and the body more than clothes?: This clause is the second part of the rhetorical question. The negative “Is not” of the previous clause is implied here:

Is not the body more important than clothing?

It expects an answer of “yes, the body is more important than clothing.” Jesus used this rhetorical question to emphasize this truth. Here are some other ways to translate this emphasis:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

and the body more important than clothes? (NIV)

and the body is more important than clothes, is it not?

And isn't the body worth more than clothes? (GNT)

- As a statement. For example:

and the body more important than the clothes you wear. (JBP)

Surely the body is worth much more than clothes.

Translate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

Matthew 6:26

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

6:26a

Look at the birds of the air:

- Consider the birds that fly around:
- Think about birds.

Look at the birds of the air: This clause begins an example of why his disciples should not worry. In some languages, it may be necessary to include some implied information to indicate that this is an example. Here is one way to do this:

For example, look at the birds of the air

Look at: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as Look at in this context means “Think about carefully.”

If people in your area will think this command is only to literally Look, you may want to use another verb. For example:

Consider

Think about

birds of the air: The phrase birds of the air is a Jewish way of saying simply “birds.” In many languages it will not be necessary to translate the words of the air. For example:

birds (GNT)

6:26b

They do not sow or reap or gather into barns—

- although they do not plant nor harvest nor gather grain in storage places/houses,
- They do not plant seeds nor harvest crops nor store food in granaries.

They do not sow: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sow means to “plant by throwing.” The particular method of planting is unimportant here. You will want to use a general verb for planting seeds or cultivating crops. For example:

they do not plant seeds (GNT)

They don't plant (CEV)

They do not make fields

or reap: The word reap means “harvest a crop.” The particular method of “reaping” is unimportant here. You will want to use a general verb for harvesting crops.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

gather a harvest (GNT)

or harvest (CEV)

harvest/cut grain

or gather into barns: The word barns refers to buildings used for storing food for later use. It is implied that Jesus was referring to the harvest or grain that is gathered into the barns.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

gather the grain and put in storerooms

put the crops/seed in storage places/bins

place the grain in a granary

6:26c

and yet your heavenly Father feeds them.

- yet your Father in heaven supplies food for them.
- But/Nevertheless they do not starve, because God your Father who lives in heaven gives food to them.

and yet: Verse 6:26c is an unexpected outcome of the statements about birds. The BSB has supplied the word yet to indicate this unexpected result. Birds do not plant, harvest, or store grain. In spite of that, they have enough food to eat.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

but (NCV)

nevertheless

but even so

your heavenly Father: The phrase your heavenly Father refers to God who lives in heaven. If the use of your implies that God is not also Jesus' Father, it may be more natural to say "our" father.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

your Father who is/lives in heaven

God, your/our^(incl) Father in heaven

feeds them: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as feeds them refers to providing food for the birds.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

provides food for them

takes care of them (GNT)

Implied in this statement is they do not starve because your heavenly Father feeds them.

6:26d

Are you not much more valuable than they?

- You^(plur) are much more valuable than they, are you not?
- And you^(plur) are surely much more important to God than birds are. So if he provides food for them, he will certainly provide food for you.

Are you not much more valuable than they?: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus used this rhetorical question to emphasize that you are truly more valuable to God than birds are. Jesus was using a method that is called arguing from the lesser to the greater. If God takes care of the less important birds, he will take care of you because you are more important. The pronoun you is emphasized in the Greek. Some ways to translate this emphasis are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

You are much more valuable than they are, are you not?

Are you not worth more than the birds? (REB)

- As a statement. For example:

And you know that you are worth much more than the birds. (NCV)

And of course, you are more valuable to God than mere birds are.

Translate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

The implied conclusion of this verse is that God will provide food for people too. If people in your area will not come to that conclusion, you may want to include it in the text or in a footnote.

Here is an example of including it in the text:

You are certainly much more valuable to God than the birds. So God will certainly provide the food you need.

Here is an example footnote:

Jesus expected the disciples to understand that God will provide the food they need.

Matthew 6:27

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

6:27

Who of you by worrying can add a single hour to his life?

- Who of you can add even one hour to the length of your life by worrying?
- If you worry, can you live even a short time longer? No!
- Worrying is useless. None of you by worrying can add even a little amount of time to how long he lives.

Who of you by worrying can add a single hour to his life?: This is a rhetorical question that expects the answer “no one can.” Jesus used this rhetorical question to emphasize that worrying is not helpful or beneficial because people are certainly not able to live longer by worrying.

Here are some ways to translate this emphasis:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Can any of you add a single hour to your life by worrying? (GW)

Can worry make you live longer? (CEV)

Even if you worry, can that make you live even one hour longer?

- As a statement. For example:

You cannot add any time to your life by worrying about it. (NCV)

Worrying is useless. It cannot make you live even a minute longer.

Translate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

a single hour: The Greek words that the BSB translates as a single hour refers to a short length of time. The Greek word that the BSB translates as “hour” is ambiguous. It normally refers to a measurement of length or height. It is about 46 centimeters. That is why the KJV translates this verse as “Which of you by taking thought can add one cubit unto his stature?” However, this word can also refer to a measurement of time. If it refers to the height of a person, it would be a sizeable amount. If it refers to time, it would be a small amount. In this context, a small amount of time makes more sense. Most English versions translate it like the BSB as a small amount of time. So the BSB translates it as a single hour.

Here is a more general way to translate this phrase:

any more time

a single moment (NLT)

to his life: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as to his life refers to the length of a person’s life.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

to his span of life (ESV)

In some languages, it will be more natural to translate life as the verb “live.” For example:

Can any of you live a bit longer by worrying about it? (GNT)

Matthew 6:28

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

6:28a

And why do you worry about clothes?

- ¶ “And why are you^(plur) worrying about clothes?”
- ¶ “In addition, do not worry about having enough clothes to wear.

And: In this paragraph, Jesus continued to talk about worry. But he changed the topic from worry about life to worry about clothes. Here are some ways to connect this paragraph to the previous paragraph:

And

Furthermore

In addition

In some languages, it may not be necessary to have a connecting word or phrase here.

why do you worry about clothes?: This is a rhetorical question. It expresses a rebuke. Jesus was rebuking his followers for worrying about having enough clothes.

Here are some other ways to translate this rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Why are you worrying about having enough clothes?

Why do you worry about what you will wear?

- As a statement. For example:

You should not worry about clothes.

It is wrong for you to be anxious that you may not have enough clothes to wear

Translate this rebuke in a way that is natural in your language.

6:28b

Consider how the lilies of the field grow:

- Think about the wild flowers and how they grow.

- Look at the plants that bloom/blossom and the way that they grow.

Consider: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Consider also means “observe.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Look (GNT)

Think about (NET)

Notice (GW)

how the lilies of the field grow: The Greek word that the BSB translates as lilies could refer to any one of several varieties of wild flowers. The phrase of the field indicates that these flowers were wild. They were not planted and cared for by people.

Here are some other ways to translate this word in its context:

- Use a generic word for flowers. For example:

how the wild flowers grow (GNT)

the plants that bloom/blossom and the way that they grow

- Use a word for a specific type of flower in your area. For example:

lilies/poppies and the way that they grow

6:28c

They do not labor or spin.

- They do not work hard or spin thread for cloth.
- They do not work or make clothes like people.

Verse 6:28c is what Jesus wanted his disciples to carefully consider.

They do not labor: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as labor means “work hard.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

toil (ESV)

work hard (CEV)

work (NET)

or spin: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as spin refers to twisting fibers together to make thread for weaving cloth. In this context it refers to making one's own clothes.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

spin yarn for clothes (GW)

make clothes for themselves (NCV)

Matthew 6:29

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

6:29a

Yet I tell you that not even Solomon in all his glory

- But I tell you^(plur) this: even King Solomon, with all the beautiful things that he had,
- But let me tell you that even the very rich King Solomon

Yet I tell you: The words Yet I tell you emphasize the words that follow. Use an expression that emphasizes the importance of what Jesus said in the rest of 6:29.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

But I tell you this

yet I assure you (NJB)

not even Solomon: The word Solomon is the name of one of Israel's kings. King Solomon was the richest of all Israel's kings (1 Kings 10:23). Solomon lived more than nine hundred years before Jesus' time. If people in your area are not familiar with Solomon, you may

want to include some implied information in the text or include a footnote.

Here are some examples of including implied information in the text:

King Solomon

the very wealthy King Solomon of long ago

Here is an example footnote:

Solomon was the richest of all Israel's kings (1 Kings 10:23). Solomon lived more than nine hundred years before Jesus' time.

in all his glory: The word glory refers to the many beautiful things including clothes that Solomon owned. If your language has a word that refers generally to beautiful things and can include beautiful clothes, you should use that.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in all his majesty (GW)

with all his wealth (CEV)

who had many beautiful things

6:29b

was adorned like one of these.

- was not dressed as beautifully as one of these.
- did not have clothes that surpass the beauty of one of these wild flowers.

was adorned like one of these: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as was adorned like one of these means “was dressed as beautifully as one of these wild flowers.” This phrase compares the beauty of Solomon in his beautiful clothes to the beauty of the “lilies of the field.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

was not dressed as beautifully as they are (NLT)

had clothes as beautiful as one of these flowers (GNT)

dressed in his beautiful clothes did not look as beautiful as one of these flowers

General Comment on 6:29a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of 6:29a and 6:29b. For example:

Yet I assure you^(plur) that one of these wild flowers is more beautiful than the most beautiful of King Solomon's clothes.

Matthew 6:30**Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain**

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

6:30

In Greek and the BSB, 6:30 is one long, complicated sentence. It contains several clauses. It also contains a rhetorical question. In some languages, it will be more natural to divide this long sentence into several shorter sentences. The GW is one example of an English version that divides this sentence into three sentences. Compare the BSB and the GW below:

^{30a}If that is how God clothes the grass of the field,
^{30b}which is here today and tomorrow is thrown into the furnace, ^{30c}will He not much more clothe you, ^{30d}O you of little faith? (BSB)

^{30a}That's the way God clothes the grass in the field.
^{30b}Today it's alive, and tomorrow it's thrown into an incinerator. ^{30c}So how much more will he clothe you people ^{30d}who have so little faith? (GW)

It is also possible to divide this long sentence into four shorter sentences. For example:

^{30a}That's the way God clothes the grass of the field. ^{30b}Today it's alive, and tomorrow it's thrown

into an oven. ^{30c}Will he not clothe you even more?
^{30d}You have so little faith!

Before you translate this verse, consider how many sentences you should have and what is the most natural order to put them in.

6:30a**If that is how God clothes the grass of the field,**

- If God clothes the grass in the countryside/bush like that,
- If/Since God makes wild grass so beautiful,
- God causes plants/weeds to have very beautiful flowers/blossoms.

If: The Greek words that the BSB translates as If can also be translated as “Since.” This is because the following statement is accepted as a fact.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

But if (ESV)

Since

that is how God clothes the grass of the field:

The clause that is how God clothes the grass of the field means that “God clothes the grass of the field in that way.” This is the way mentioned in 6:29. In other words, “God clothes grass/plants in a way that is more beautiful than Solomon's clothes.” This means that “God causes plants to have flowers/blossoms that are more beautiful than the expensive clothes that Solomon wore.” God does not actually give clothes to the plants, but he makes them look beautiful.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

That's the way God clothes the grass in the field.
(GW)

God gives such beauty to everything that grows in the fields (CEV)

God causes plants to have very beautiful flowers/blossoms

the grass of the field: The phrase the grass of the field is a Jewish way of saying “wild grass/plants.” This refers to plants that grow in the countryside without being cultivated. It includes flowers like lilies (in 6:28b). It does not just refer to green grass.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

wild grass (NET)

wildflowers (NLT)

plants/weeds

6:30b

which is here today and tomorrow is thrown into the furnace,

- which is alive today and tomorrow is thrown into an oven to burn,
- which only lives for a few days and then is put on a fire to burn,
- He does it even though they only live for a little while, and then soon dry up and people burn them up.

which is here today and tomorrow: The word today in this context means “for a short time,” and not a literal day. In the same way the word tomorrow here means “soon.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

that are here today and gone tomorrow (NLT96)

here for a short time and then

live for only a few days and shortly after

that last only a very short time before they die

is thrown into the furnace: The Greek word that the BSB translates as furnace refers to a dome-like structure made of clay. Some English versions translate this word as “oven” (ESV). People would heat it with wood to cook or bake food or warm themselves.

The verb is thrown is passive.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- As a passive. For example:

burned up in the oven (GNT)

is tossed into the fire to heat the oven (NET)

and thrown into a fire (CEV)

- As an active. For example:

people put into an furnace to burn

people throw into the fire

6:30c

will He not much more clothe you,

- will he not much more surely provide clothing for you?^(plur)
- So he will even more surely provide the clothes you^(plur) need!

will He not much more clothe you...?: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus used this rhetorical question to emphasize that God will certainly provide clothing for his people. God values people much more than grass, so he will provide for people’s needs even more than he provides beauty for the wild grasses.

Here are some other ways to translate this emphasis:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Won’t he be all the more sure to clothe you? (GNT)

He will much more surely provide clothes for you, won’t he?

- As a statement. For example:

So you can be even more sure that God will clothe you. (NCV)

You can know more certainly that God will provide the clothes you need to wear

Translate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

6:30d

O you of little faith?

- You^(plur) people have such little faith!
- You^(plur) trust/believe in him so little!

O you of little faith?: The Greek word that the BSB translates as O you of little faith describes the people listening and speaks directly to them.

The NET also uses a phrase here to speak directly to the disciples (“you people of little faith”). If this is natural in your language, then follow the BSB or NET. But if it is not natural in your language to speak directly to a person or persons and at the same time describe them, you may use a complete clause. For example:

You have such little faith!

How little faith you have! (REB)

You trust/believe in God so little!

Why do you have such little faith? (CEV)

See also believe, Meaning 2 in the Glossary.

General Comment on 6:30d

In some languages, it may be more natural to put 6:30d at the beginning of the verse. For example:

^{30d}You people of such little faith. ^{30a}If God beautifully clothes the wild grass in that way, ^{30b}which is alive today and tomorrow is thrown into the ovens, ^{30c}then will he not much more surely provide clothing for you?

Matthew 6:31

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

6:31

Verse 6:31 repeats the examples that are in 6:25–30: Jesus’ disciples should not worry about the material things which they need to live. See the notes above on 6:25–30 for more information.

6:31a

Therefore do not worry,

- ¶ “So do not be anxious^(plur)
- ¶ “So do not worry^(plur).
- ¶ “Therefore do not worry^(plur) about

Therefore: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Therefore introduces a conclusion based on God’s abundant and kind care.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

So (NIV)

In conclusion

For this/that reason

Because God so wonderfully provides,

do not worry: This same phrase occurs in 6:25b.

6:31b

saying, ‘What shall we eat?’

- and say^(plur) ‘What are we^(incl) going to eat?’
- Do not ask yourselves, ‘Will we^(incl) have enough/any food to eat?’
- what you^(plur) will eat

saying: The word saying introduces three questions that people may ask themselves. People do not necessarily ask these questions out loud.

Here are some other ways to introduce these questions:

and say (GW)

and ask yourselves (CEV)

Do not ask

What shall we eat?: This is a real question. It is implied that food is scarce and not easily acquired.

Here are some other ways to translate this question:

What are we going to eat? (GW)

Will we have anything to eat? (CEV)

6:31c

or ‘What shall we drink?’

- or ‘What are we^(incl) going to drink?’
- or ‘Will we have enough/any water to drink?’
- or drink

What shall we drink?: This too is a real question. The verb means “to drink anything.” It refers especially to water but also refers to anything else people drink with their meals. You will want to translate this clause similarly to the way you did the previous one. For example:

What are we going to drink? (GW)

Will we have anything to drink? (CEV)

6:31d

or ‘What shall we wear?’

- or ‘What are we^(incl) going to wear?’
- or ‘Will we^(incl) have enough/any clothes to wear?’
- or wear.

What shall we wear?: This also is a real question. You will want to translate this clause similarly to the way you did the two previous ones. For example:

What are we going to wear? (GW)

Will we have any clothes to wear? (CEV)

General Comment on 6:31a–d

In some languages it is more natural to use an indirect quotation for people’s thoughts. For instance:

Do not worry about what you will eat, drink or wear.

So don’t worry about having enough food or drink or clothing. (NLT96)

Matthew 6:32

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

6:32a

For the Gentiles strive after all these things,

- I say that because the pagans/heathen are always seeking/trying to get all these things,
- Those who do not follow God are always concerned/worrying about getting things like that.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For in this context indicates that 6:32 is the basis for the commands in 6:31.

Here is another way to translate this conjunction:

I say that because

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either.

the Gentiles: The word Gentiles refers to people who were non-Jews.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

people who don’t know God (CEV)

people who do not trust/believe in God

heathen (REB)

pagans (NIV)

This word also occurs in 6:7a, where the BSB translates it as “pagans.” You should translate it here as you did there.

strive after: The Greek word that the BSB translates as strive after means “desire,” “want,” or “wish for,” or “look/search for.” The Greek grammar indicates a continuous seeking or wishing for something.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

always concerned about (GNT)

always worrying about such things (CEV)

keep trying to get (NCV)

all these things: The phrase all these things refers to the food, drink, and clothes mentioned in 6:25–31. You

will want to use the proper word that refers back to these things. For example:

all these/those things

all the things I just mentioned

6:32b

and your heavenly Father knows that you need them.

- and I also say that because your^(plur) Father in heaven knows that you need them.
- God your^(plur) Father who lives in heaven knows that you need all these things and will provide/supply them.

and: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates here as and is the same conjunction that is translated as “For” in 6:32a. It introduces the second basis for the commands not to worry.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

I also say that because

you should not worry because

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either.

your heavenly Father: The phrase your heavenly Father refers to God. This phrase also occurs in 6:14b.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

God your heavenly Father

God your Father who is/lives in heaven

knows that you need them: This clause implies that God will also provide the things that you need. If people in your area will think that this clause indicates only that God knows but does not provide, you may want to include some implied information. For example:

knows that you need them and will give you all these things

them: The Greek words that the BSB translates as them are the same as those translated as “all these things” in the previous clause. It refers to food, drink, and clothes.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

all these things (GNT)

all your needs (NLT)

Matthew 6:33

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

6:33a

But seek first the kingdom of God and His righteousness,

- But above all else seek God’s kingdom and living righteously,
- Rather, be concerned about God’s kingship and living the way that he wants you^(plur) to live.
- Instead of being concerned/worried about those things, make it your greatest desire that God rule over you and that you live right/straight.

But: There is a contrast between 6:31–32 and 6:33. The contrast is between what believers should not seek (food, drink, and clothes) and what they should seek (the kingdom of God). The BSB introduces this contrast with the conjunction But.

Here are some other ways to introduce this contrast:

Instead of seeking all those things like the Gentiles do

Instead of worrying

seek first the kingdom of God: The clause seek first the kingdom of God means that a believer's priority must be to "desire, want, wish for, or look/search for the things that are important in the kingdom of God."

The word first in this context refers to priority or importance. It does not refer to time. Jesus' disciples are to make their greatest concern the kingdom of God. Their greatest concern must not be food, drink, clothes, and other things.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

be concerned above everything else with the Kingdom of God (GNT)

The thing you should want most is God's kingdom (NCV)

concentrate/focus on the things that are important in the kingdom of God

Make God's rule over you the most important issue in your life

the kingdom of God: The phrase the kingdom of God refers to God's activity of ruling and caring for his people as their king. It also refers to the relationship that God has with his people. He leads, protects, and cares for them. They obey, trust, and submit to him as their king. The phrase the kingdom of God does not refer to a land or country that he rules over.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- As a noun. For example:

the kingdom of God

God's kingship

God's rule over people

- As a verbal expression. For example:

the way that God rules his people

the way that God cares for his people as king

See how you translated "kingdom of heaven" in 5:3, 5:19, and 5:20. See also kingdom of heaven in the Glossary for more information.

and His righteousness: The phrase His righteousness refers to "what God requires people to do."

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

and with what he requires of you (GNT)

and seek to live according to what he considers right/straight

and live the righteous life that he wants

and do what he wants (CEV)

See the note on 5:6a and 6:1a and consider how you translated righteousness there.

6:33b

and all these things will be added unto you.

- and all those things will be provided for you^(plur).
- Then he will give you^(plur) all those other things that you need.

and all these things will be added unto you: The phrase all these things refers to the food, drink, and clothes mentioned in 6:25–31. The verb will be added means "will be provided" or "will be given."

The verb will be added is passive.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- As a passive. For example:

Then all these things will be provided for you. (GW)

Then all these other things you need will be given to you. (NCV)

- As an active. For example:

and he will provide you with all these other things (GNT)

and he will give you everything you need (NLT)

Matthew 6:34

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as "The Sermon on the Mount." In some translations, it may be helpful to

include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

6:34a

Therefore do not worry about tomorrow,

- Therefore do not worry about what may happen tomorrow,
- So do not worry about what problems/difficulties may come in the future.

Therefore: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Therefore introduces the conclusion to this section.

Here are some other ways to translate this Greek word:

So (NRSV)

So then (NET)

do not worry: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as do not worry means “do not be anxious.” It is the same phrase as in 6:25b and 6:31a.

about tomorrow: The phrase about tomorrow refers to the next day and also more generally to the future. Jesus commanded his followers not to worry about what they may need or what may happen in the future.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

about what you will need tomorrow

about what may happen tomorrow

about how the future will be

about the problems/difficulties that you may have in the days to come

6:34b

for tomorrow will worry about itself.

- because tomorrow will have its own worries.

- Tomorrow there will be enough issues to worry about.

for: The Greek word that the BSB translates as for introduces the basis for the command not to worry in 6:34a.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

because (NCV)

The reason I say this is that

Some English versions do not translate this word. In some languages, it may not be necessary to translate this word either.

tomorrow will worry about itself: This clause is like a proverb. It indicates that when tomorrow comes, there will be other difficulties and issues to worry about. So a believer should not add tomorrow’s problems to today’s problems.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

tomorrow will bring worries of its own (NRSV)

tomorrow will have its own worries (NCV)

in the future there will be other issues to worry about

tomorrow: As in 6:34a, the word tomorrow here means “the future.”

6:34c

Today has enough trouble of its own.

- Each day’s trouble is enough for that day.
- Each/every day there are enough problems to worry about.
- Each day a person has enough issues to worry about without adding more.”

Today has enough trouble of its own: This clause is also like a proverb. It indicates that “there is enough trouble each day.” Therefore we do not need to add worries about tomorrow to the troubles of today.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Each day has enough trouble of its own. (GW)

One day’s trouble is enough for one day (JBP)

There is no need to add to the troubles each day brings (GNT)

trouble: The Greek word that the BSB translates as trouble in this context refers to the difficulties and problems that people have.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

difficulties

problems

hardships

Matthew 7:1

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 7:1–5

Even though a new chapter begins at 7:1, Jesus continued “the Sermon on the Mount” which he began in chapter 5. In some languages, it may be natural to begin this chapter with something like:

Jesus continued,

Jesus continued to teach and said,

In other languages, no introduction is necessary here. You may want to begin this chapter as you began chapter 6.

7:1a

“Do not judge,

- ¶ “Do not harshly judge^(plur) others

- ¶ Jesus continued, “Do not condemn^(plur) other people

Do not judge: The Greek word that the BSB translates as judge means “judge or condemn harshly.” For example:

Don’t condemn others (CEV)

In this context the word judge does not refer to rendering a judgment in a court or council. This command does not forbid leaders to make decisions or judgments. It is a command not to judge in a harsh or unfair way.

7:1b

or you will be judged.

- so that you^(plur) will not be harshly judged.
- in order that God will not condemn you^(plur).

or you will be judged: There are several ways to interpret the Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as or:

1. It indicates purpose. For example:

so that you may not be judged (NRSV) (RSV, NRSV, ESV, NIV, GNT, NASB, GW, NET, KJV)

1. It indicates result. For example:

and you will not be judged (NLT) (BSB, NJB, NLT, CEV, JBP, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

in order that you not be judged

for the purpose that you not be condemned

you will be judged: This clause is passive.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

you will not be judged (NET)

- Use an active verb. God is the one who will judge/condemn. For example:

God will not judge you (GNT)

Matthew 7:2

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 7:1–5

Even though a new chapter begins at 7:1, Jesus continued “the Sermon on the Mount” which he began in chapter 5. In some languages, it may be natural to begin this chapter with something like:

Jesus continued,

Jesus continued to teach and said,

In other languages, no introduction is necessary here. You may want to begin this chapter as you began chapter 6.

7:2a

For with the same judgment you pronounce, you will be judged;

- For/Because you^(plur) will be judged in the same way that you judge others.
- God will condemn you^(plur) like/as you condemn other people.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *For* introduces the basis for the command not to judge (in 7:1).

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

because (NJB)

the reason is that

In some languages, it is not necessary to use a conjunction here.

with the same judgment you pronounce, you will be judged: This clause is a comparison. It compares the way you judge with the way you will be judged. In other words, if you judge someone harshly, you will be judged harshly. If you judge someone fairly, you will be judged fairly.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

You will be judged in the same way that you judge others (NCV)

You will be judged like you judge other people.

The way you condemn others will be the way you are condemned.

you will be judged: This clause is passive. Translate it like you translated “you will be judged” (7:1b). For example:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

you will be judged (BSB)

- Use an active verb. For example:

God will judge you (GNT)

7:2b

and with the measure you use, it will be measured to you.

- The measure/amount you^(plur) give to others will be the measure/amount given to you.
- And the standard you use to judge/condemn others will be the standard God will use to judge/condemn you.

Verse 7:2b is a proverb that people commonly used in Jesus’ time. This proverb also occurs in Mark 4:24. In each context, this proverb has a different application.

with the measure you use, it will be measured to you: In the New Testament, the noun *measure* literally refers to a measuring instrument. It can be:

1. a measuring cup that measures the quantity of something like grain that is sold in the marketplace.
2. a measuring stick that measures the length of something.

In the context of the marketplace, this refers to that fact that if you fill the measuring cup full when you sell something to others, people will also fill the measuring cup full when they sell something to you. But if you measure in a stingy way when you sell something to others, people will also measure in a stingy way when they sell something to you. In other words, if you are generous with people, they will be generous with you. If you are stingy with people, they will be stingy with you in return.

In the context of this verse, this proverb refers to the standards you use to judge someone. If the standards you use to judge someone are harsh, you will be judged harshly. If the standards you use to judge someone are fair, you will be judged fairly.

Here are some other ways to translate this proverb:

- Translate the meaning literally or generally. For example:

and the measure you give will be the measure you get (RSV)

and the amount you give to others will be given to you (NCV)

and the standard you use will be the standard used for you (NJB)

- Translate the meaning as it applies here. For example:

The standard you use in judging is the standard by which you will be judged. (NLT)

the rules you use to condemn others will also be the rules God will use to condemn you

it will be measured to you: This clause is passive.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

will be given to you (NCV)

- Use an active verb. You may have to supply a subject. Depending on the way you translate this first part of this proverb, the subject may be “God” or “people.” For example:

will be the measure you receive (NET)

will be the measure/amount other people will give to you

God will use the same measure/standard to judge you

Matthew 7:3

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 7:1–5

Even though a new chapter begins at 7:1, Jesus continued “the Sermon on the Mount” which he began in chapter 5. In some languages, it may be natural to begin this chapter with something like:

Jesus continued,

Jesus continued to teach and said,

In other languages, no introduction is necessary here. You may want to begin this chapter as you began chapter 6.

7:3a–b

Why do you look at the speck in your brother’s eye, but fail to notice the beam in your own eye?:

Before you translate 7:3a–b, there are two main issues to consider:

Issue 1: Rhetorical question

Verse 7:3 is a rhetorical question. It functions as a rebuke, and it continues the theme in 7:1–2. In 7:1–2 Jesus commanded his disciples not to judge/condemn other people harshly. Here he criticized them for judging/

condemning another person with a small fault when they themselves have something more serious in their own lives.

Here are some other ways to translate this rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Why do you look at the speck of sawdust in your brother's eye and pay no attention to the plank in your own eye? (NIV)

- As a question followed by a command. For example:

Why do you look at the speck of sawdust in your brother's eye? Instead, you should pay attention to the plank in your own eye!

- As a command. For example:

Do not look at the speck in your brother's eye. Rather pay attention to the plank in your own eye!

Translate this rebuke in a way that is natural in your language.

Issue 2: Metaphor

Verse 7:3 contains a metaphor. In this metaphor, a small sin/fault in your brother's life is compared to a speck in his eye. A large sin/fault in your life is compared to a log that is in your eye.

Here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. See the examples above. If you keep the metaphor, you may want to describe the meaning in a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

The "speck" represents a small sin/fault or a small number of sins. The "log" represents a large sin/fault or a large number of sins.

- Change the metaphor to a simile and make explicit how it is similar. For example:

Why do you judge/condemn your brother for a small sin/fault which is like a small speck in his eye, when you have a large sin/fault in your life which is like a log in your own eye?

Why do you who have many sins judge/condemn your brother who has few sins? It is like looking

at the speck in your brother's eye when you have a log in your own eye.

7:3a

Why do you look at the speck in your brother's eye,

- Why do you^(sing) look at the piece of dust in your brother's eye,
- Do not be concerned with the sawdust in your^(sing) friend's/neighbor's eye.
- Why do you^(sing) judge/condemn your fellow-believer for a small sin/fault that is like some dirt in his eye,

you: In Greek, 7:1–2 uses you plural. But here in 7:3, the Greek changes to you singular.

the speck: The Greek word that the BSB translates as speck refers to something that is very small and can get into a person's eyes. It could be some dust, a very small piece of wood, or something similar.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

the little piece of dust (NCV)

the piece of sawdust (GW)

splinter

your brother's: The phrase your brother's probably refers to something belonging to a companion or friend here. It may also include neighbors or people in general. It includes both male and female.

In some languages the word brother's refers only to something belonging to someone with the same father. If that is true in your language, you may want to use a more general word. For example:

your neighbor (NRSV)

your friend (NLT)

7:3b

but fail to notice the beam in your own eye?

- but you^(sing) do not notice/see the log/beam in your own eye?
- Rather, you^(sing) should pay attention to the log/beam that is in your own eye!
- when you have a large sin/fault in your life which is like a log in your own eye?

but: There is contrast between "look" of 7:3a and "fail to notice" in 7:3b. In some languages it is natural to

use the conjunction but here (as the BSB and some other English versions do). Your way to connect 7:3a and 7:3b will depend on the way you translate the rhetorical question and metaphor. (See the examples in the Display at 7:3a–b.)

fail to notice: The Greek verb that the BSB translates here as notice also means “consider,” “be concerned about,” or “pay attention to.”

Here are some other ways to translate this verb phrase:

pay no attention to (NIV)

do not think about

do not see

ignore

the beam in your own eye: The Greek word that the BSB translates as beam refers to a large, heavy piece of wood. It is usually used as a beam in building a house.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

wooden beam (GW)

big piece of wood (NCV)

plank (NIV)

Matthew 7:4

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 7:1–5

Even though a new chapter begins at 7:1, Jesus continued “the Sermon on the Mount” which he began in chapter 5. In some languages, it may be natural to begin this chapter with something like:

Jesus continued,

Jesus continued to teach and said,

In other languages, no introduction is necessary here. You may want to begin this chapter as you began chapter 6.

7:4a–b

In the Greek, 7:4a begins with word that is often translated as “or” (ESV). It functions to introduce more of Jesus’ teaching about the “speck” and the “log” in 7:3a–b.

Here is another way to translate this word:

And (NJB)

The BSB and some other English versions do not translate this word. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this word either.

How can you say to your brother, ‘Let me take the speck out of your eye,’ while there is still a beam in your own eye?: As in the previous verse, 7:4 is a rhetorical question. In addition, it continues the metaphor in 7:3. Furthermore, it has a quote within a quote. Consider these three issues before translating this verse:

Issue 1: Rhetorical question

This is a rhetorical question. Like 7:3, it functions as a rebuke and warns a disciple not to say to his brother, ‘Let me take the speck out of your eye,’ when there is a beam in his own eye.

Here are some other ways to translate this rebuke and warning:

- As a rhetorical question. In Greek, this rhetorical question begins with a word translated as “how.” However, in some languages, a rebuke does not begin with “how.” So some languages may have to begin this rebuke differently. For example:

And how dare you say to your brother, “Let me take that splinter out of your eye,” when, look, there is a great log in your own? (NJB)

How can you possibly say to your brother...?

Why do you say to your brother...?

- As a statement. For example:

There is no way you can possibly say to your brother, ‘Let me take the speck out of your eye,’ when there is a log in your own eye.

- As a command. For example:

^{4a}Do not say to your brother, ‘Let me take the speck out of your eye,’ ^{4b}when there is a log in your own eye!

^{4b}When there is a log in your own eye, ^{4a}do not say to your brother, ‘Let me take the speck out of your eye.’

Issue 2: Quote within a quote

In some languages, it will be more natural to translate the part in single quotes as indirect speech. For example:

How can you tell your brother that you want to take the speck out of his eye, when there is the log in your own eye?

Issue 3: Metaphor

Verse 7:4 contains the same metaphor as 7:3. In this metaphor, a small sin/fault in your brother’s life is compared to a speck in his eye. A large sin/fault in your life is compared to a log that is in your eye.

Here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. See the examples above. If you keep the metaphor, you may want to describe the meaning in a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

The “speck” represents a small sin/fault or a small number of sins. The “log” represents a large sin/fault or a large number of sins.

- Change the metaphor to a simile and make explicit how it is similar. (Note that even if you made the similarities in the metaphor explicit in 7:3, it may not be necessary to do the same thing here.) For example:

Or how can you say to your brother that you want to help him take the small sin out of his life. This is like taking a speck out of his eye. How can you say that when you have a large sin in your life which is like a log in your own eye?

7:4a

How can you say to your brother, ‘Let me take the speck out of your eye,’

- And how do you^(sing) dare say to your brother, ‘Allow me to remove the piece of dust from your eye,’
- Do not say to your friend/neighbor, ‘Let me remove the sawdust from your eye.’
- Why do you tell your fellow-believer that you want to remove the dirt from his eye,

brother: The word brother has the same meaning here as in 7:3a. It refers to a fellow believer.

7:4b

while there is still a beam in your own eye?

- when you have a log/beam in your own eye?
- Look at yourself! You have a log/beam in your own eye.
- when there is a big, wood log in your own eye?

while there is still a beam in your own eye: The Greek text here can be translated literally as “and look, the plank/log (is) in your eye.” The word translated “look” is used to bring attention to the words that follow.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Look! A plank/log is in your eye!

Look at yourself! You still have that big piece of wood in your own eye. (NCV)

And a log is in your own eye!

Matthew 7:5

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 7:1–5

Even though a new chapter begins at 7:1, Jesus continued “the Sermon on the Mount” which he began in chapter 5. In some languages, it may be natural to begin this chapter with something like:

Jesus continued,

Jesus continued to teach and said,

In other languages, no introduction is necessary here. You may want to begin this chapter as you began chapter 6.

7:5a

You hypocrite!

- Hypocrite! (NLT)
- Pretender!

You hypocrite!: The Greek word that the BSB translates as hypocrite literally refers to actors (in the theater). Figuratively it refers to people who pretend to be something that they are not. They say that they believe one thing, but they do something different. Or they appear religious or spiritual on the outside, but they do not have true hearts that desire to please God.

The BSB has added the word You here. In Greek, only the word hypocrite occurs here. For example:

Hypocrite! (NLT)

Pretender!

The word hypocrite also occurs in 6:2 and 6:16.

7:5b

First take the beam out of your own eye,

- First, remove the log/beam from your own eye,

7:5b–c

beam...speck: As in 7:3–4, the words beam and speck are metaphors referring to large sins and small sins. Because this is the third verse with these metaphors, you can probably keep the metaphors without making the meaning explicit.

7:5c

and then you will see clearly to remove the speck from your brother's eye.

- and then you will see well enough to remove the piece of dust from your brother's eye.
- then you will be able to see clearly, and you can remove the sawdust/dirt from the eye of your friend/fellow-believer.

brother's: Be careful to translate the word brother's as you did in 7:3a and 7:4a.

Matthew 7:6

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

7:6a–d

Do not give dogs what is holy...and then turn and tear you to pieces: Before you translate 7:6a–d, there are two main issues to consider:

Issue 1: Interpretation issue

There are three ways to interpret the way that the clause and then turn and tear you to pieces (7:6d) is connected to the rest of the verse:

1. It is connected to 7:6a and refers to what dogs will do. The dogs will turn and tear you to pieces. According to this interpretation, the four clauses in 7:6 are arranged in a special order called a “chiasmus.” In this chiasmus, the first clause (7:6a) goes together with the last clause (7:6d), and the two middle clauses go together. For example:

^{6a}Don't give holy things to dogs, ^{6b}and don't throw your pearls before pigs. ^{6c}Pigs will only trample on them, ^{6d}and dogs will turn to attack you. (NCV) (GNT, CEV, NCV, and many commentaries) Some commentators that follow the interpretation that

this verse is a chiasmus are Hagner, page 171; Morris, page 169, Osborne, page 260, Carson, page 185, Turner (2008), page 206, Davies and Allison, page 677, France (2007), page 277–278.

1. It is connected to 7:6b and refers to another thing that pigs will do. According to this interpretation, this verse is not a chiasmus. Swine/pigs will both trample the pearls (7:6c) and turn to attack you (7:6d). There is no description of what dogs will do. For example:

^{6a}Do not give dogs what is holy; ^{6b}and do not throw your pearls before swine, ^{6c}lest they trample them under foot ^{6d}and turn to attack you. (RSV) (RSV, NJB)

1. It, together with 7:6c, is connected to 7:6a–7:6b and refers to another thing that both dogs and swine/pigs will do. Dogs and swine will both trample pearls underfoot (7:6c) and turn and attack you (7:6d). For example:

Do not give dogs what is sacred; do not throw your pearls to pigs. If you do, they may trample them under their feet, and then turn and tear you to pieces. (NIV) (BSB, NIV, NET, GW, NLT, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Most commentaries follow this interpretation. Another way to translate this verse is:

^{6a}Don't give to dogs what belongs to God. ^{6d}They will only turn and attack you. ^{6b}Don't throw pearls down in front of pigs. ^{6c}They will trample all over them. (CEV)

Issue 2: Metaphor

Verse 7:6 is a proverb-like saying using metaphors of dogs, pigs, and pearls. The “dogs” and “swine” refer to people. They probably refer to people who have rejected the gospel of Jesus. The phrase “what is holy” and the word “pearls” refer to the truths of the gospel of the kingdom.

One way to translate this verse is to put an explanation before the metaphors. For example:

Do not give what is holy to people who do not value the good news and even attack it. That would be like giving something holy to dogs or like throwing pearls to swine/pigs. If you do, the

pigs will trample those things and the dogs will turn and attack you.

Some other ways to translate the metaphors are listed below.

7:6a

Do not give dogs what is holy;

- ¶ “Do not give^(plur) holy things to dogs,
- ¶ “Do not give what is holy to those who do not value the good news and even attack it. That would be like giving holy things to dogs
- ¶ “Do not give what belongs to God to people who act like wild dogs.

Do not give dogs what is holy: The word dogs is a metaphor. In this metaphor, certain people are compared to wild dogs. Like wild dogs attack other animals, certain people continually reject the message of the good news of the kingdom. They even attack those people who preach the good news.

Here the word dogs refers to wild or stray dogs. They are not dogs that people keep around their houses.

Here Jesus taught his disciples not to continue to teach the message of the good news to people who continue to reject and attack both the message and those who preach it.

Here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

Do not give what is holy to dogs (GNT)

Don't give holy things to dogs (NCV)

- Change the metaphor to a simile and make explicit the way that they are similar. For example:

Do not give what is holy to people who act like wild dogs.

Do not give what is holy to people who reject it like wild dogs.

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

Do not continue to give/teach the holy message of the good news to people who reject it.

Don't give what is holy to unholy people. (NLT96)
If you follow this option, you may want to include a footnote that gives the literal words. Here is a sample footnote:

Literally: "Do not give what is holy to dogs."

what is holy: The word holy means "dedicated to God." The phrase what is holy represents the good news of the kingdom of God.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

what belongs to God (CEV)

holy things (NCV)

what is sacred (NIV)

7:6b

do not throw your pearls before swine.

- nor throw/scatter your pearls to pigs.
- and tossing your expensive beads in front of pigs.
- Also, do not throw/give the valuable truths of God to people who act like pigs.

In Greek, 7:6b begins with a conjunction that indicates that another negative clause is coming. This conjunction can be translated as "nor," "and" and "or." For example:

Do not give what is holy to dogs nor throw...

Do not give what is holy to dogs or throw... (NET)

Do not give what is holy to dogs; and do not throw... (NRSV)

The BSB does not translate this conjunction, but connects 7:6a and b with a semi-colon (;).

do not throw your pearls before swine:

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

Don't throw pearls down in front of pigs. (CEV)

- Change the metaphors to similes and make explicit the way that they are similar. For example:

Do not give the valuable truths from God to people who do not value them. This is like throwing pearls to swine/pigs.

- Translate without the metaphor. For example:

Do not give the valuable truths from God to people who do not value them. You may then want a footnote that gives the literal words:

Literally: "Do not throw your pearls to swine/pigs."

do not throw: The verb phrase do not throw implies carelessly throwing away something. The truths of the gospel are valuable like pearls. Jesus tells his followers not to carelessly share these truths with people who will not value them.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

Don't give (NLT96)

Do not scatter/toss

Do not share

your pearls: The word pearls refers to round, stone-like beads about 5–10 millimeters (quarter to half an inch) across. Pearls are found in a kind of shellfish called an "oyster." Pearls are often very beautiful, and good ones are very valuable. People wear them in necklaces and as other jewelry.

In this context, the word pearls is a metaphor. Pearls represent the good news of the kingdom of God. They are similar in that both are valuable. The word pearls corresponds to the phrase "what is holy" in 7:6a.

Here are some other ways to translate the word pearls:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

valuable jewels called pearls

expensive beads

precious/costly stones

- Change the metaphor to a simile and make explicit the way that they are similar. For example:

the good news of the kingdom which is valuable like pearls

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

the good news of the kingdom

before swine: The word swine means “pigs.” It is a metaphor. In this metaphor, certain people are compared to pigs, also called swine. Like swine do not value pearls and so trample them, certain people do not value the message of the good news of the kingdom.

7:6c

If you do, they may trample them under their feet,

- If you do that, the pigs will trample those things under their feet.
- The pigs will step on them
- Otherwise, they will not value those things.

If you do: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as If you do links two actions. The first action was “throwing pearls before swine” in 7:6b. The second action is “they...trample them under their feet” in 7:6c. The first action prevents the second action from happening. Jesus was saying that a person should not throw pearls in front of swine/pigs (7:6b) to prevent the pearls from being trampled underfoot (7:6c).

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

lest (ESV)

otherwise (NET)

so that they do not

they: If you followed the recommended interpretation (1) in the note on 7:6a–d, the pronoun they refers to the pigs. In some languages, it will be good to make this explicit. For example:

Pigs will only trample on them (NCV)

trample them under their feet: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as trample them under their feet refers to purposely walking on something to crush it into the ground with your feet.

This clause continues the metaphor of 7:6b. Here are some other ways to translate this:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

trample them under their feet (NIV)

stomp them into the ground

walk/step on them

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

They will not value those things.

7:6d

and then turn and tear you to pieces.

- And the dogs will turn and attack you.”
- and the dogs will turn and bite you.”
- And the people who act like dogs will turn and attack/mock you.”

As mentioned above, this clause refers to what the dogs (in 7:6a) will do. In some languages, it will be good to make this explicit. For example:

and dogs will turn to attack you (NCV)

and then turn and tear you to pieces: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as turn and tear you to pieces refers to cutting flesh with the teeth.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

turn and tear you to pieces (NIV)

and turn and bite you

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

and the people who act like dogs will turn and mock/disrespect you

Matthew 7:7

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to

include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 7:7–11

In this paragraph, Jesus told his disciples that they should pray earnestly to God for the things that they need, and God will give them these things. God will give good things to his followers just as a human father gives good things to his children.

Matthew 7:7–8 has almost the same words as Luke 11:9–10, and they mean the same thing.

7:7a–c

In 7:7, Jesus instructed his disciples to pray to God for the things that they need. He restated this in three ways using three verbs: “ask,” “seek,” and “knock.”

The three sayings in 7:7 are like proverbs. Proverbs are short without much explaining. You may want to add little or no implied information to these sayings, as long as the sayings are natural in your language.

7:7a

Ask, and it will be given to you;

- ¶ “Ask God, and it will be given to you^(plur).
- ¶ Jesus continued, “Ask God for what you^(plur) need, and he will give it to you.

This is the first way to say that we should pray for the things we need, and then God will give them to us.

Ask: In this context, the verb Ask refers to asking God for something when praying. In some languages a literal translation would refer to asking in general. It would not refer to praying. If that is true in your language, you may want to include some implied information. For example:

Ask God

Ask in your prayers

Ask God for whatever you need

Jesus was speaking to his disciples, so this verb is plural.

it will be given to you: This clause is passive.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

it will be given to you (NIV)

- Use the active form of “give.” For example:

God will give to you (NCV)

- Use another verb. For example:

you will receive (GNT)

7:7b

seek, and you will find;

- Seek/Search for what you need, and you^(plur) will find it.
- Search for your^(plur) needs from God, and you will get/receive them.

This is the second way to say that we should pray for the things we need, and then God will give them to us.

seek, and you will find: The verb seek means to “search” or “look” for something. This is a figure of speech. It compares “asking God for something” to “searching for it.” It also compares “God answering the prayer” to “the person finding/receiving” what he was searching for.

If the meaning of this figure of speech will not be clear in your language, you may need to supply some information. For example:

seek from God what you need, and you will find it

search for what you need, and he/God will provide it for you

you will find: The verb find indicates that you will get/receive something that you did not have. It does not imply that you had lost something and found it again.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

you will get/obtain it

you will receive it

God will give it to you

7:7c

knock, and the door will be opened to you.

- Knock on the door, and it will be opened to you^(plur).
- Tap on the door, and God will open it for you^(plur).

This is the third way to say that we should pray for the things we need, and then God will give them to us.

knock, and the door will be opened to you: This clause is also a figure of speech. It compares asking God for something to knocking on a door to indicate that the person inside should open it. The image of the door being opened means that God responds favorably to the person's request.

In some languages it may be necessary to make explicit where a person should knock, and who would open it. For example:

knock on the door, and God will open it for you

To knock is a cultural gesture to announce that a person is at the door. In some cultures, people call out or clap to announce that they are there, then wait outside the door. If the custom of knocking on a door is not used or understood in your area, you may want to:

- Explain the meaning of the gesture of knocking in the text. For example:

Knock/Tap on the door to ask God to open it, and he will open it for you

- Use a gesture that has the right meaning in your area. For example:

Call/Clap at the door, and God will open it

Matthew 7:8

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 7:7–11

In this paragraph, Jesus told his disciples that they should pray earnestly to God for the things that they need, and God will give them these things. God will give good things to his followers just as a human father gives good things to his children.

Matthew 7:7–8 has almost the same words as Luke 11:9–10, and they mean the same thing.

7:8a

For everyone who asks receives;

- For/Because everyone who asks God for something, he will receive it,
- Whoever asks God for what he needs, he/God will give it to him.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For introduces the basis or reason for the previous commands to Ask, seek, and knock.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

Because

The reason is

In some languages, this relationship may be understood without using a connecting word such as For. For example:

Everyone who asks receives (NJB)

everyone who asks receives: As in 7:7a, it may again be necessary to say what is asked for, and from whom. For example:

everyone who asks God for something will receive it

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

whoever asks, he will receive

If anyone asks, it will be given to him

7:8b

he who seeks finds;

- and everyone who seeks what he needs, he will find it,
- Whoever searches for what he needs from God, he will get/receive it.

he who seeks finds: The meaning of the verbs seeks and finds are the same as in 7:7b.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the person who seeks something, he will find it

the person who seeks from God what he needs,
he will get it

If anyone searches for what he needs, he will
receive it.

7:8c

and to him who knocks, the door will be opened.

- and everyone who knocks on the door, the door will be opened for him.
- Whoever taps on the door, God will open it for him.

to him who knocks, the door will be opened: The meaning of the verb knocks and the clause the door will be opened are the same as in 7:7c.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the person who knocks on the door will have it
opened to him

If anyone taps on the door, God will open it for him

Matthew 7:9

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 7:7–11

In this paragraph, Jesus told his disciples that they should pray earnestly to God for the things that they need, and God will give them these things. God will give good things to his followers just as a human father gives good things to his children.

Matthew 7:7–8 has almost the same words as Luke 11:9–10, and they mean the same thing.

7:9b

will give him a stone?

- give a stone to him?
- none of you^(plur) would ever give him a stone.

7:9a–b

In the Greek, 7:9a begins with a conjunction that is often translated as “or.” It functions to introduce another example of Jesus’ teaching on prayer. The BSB and most English versions do not translate this word. You should translate it in a way that is natural in your language.

Which of you, if his son asks for bread, will give him a stone?: This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes the fact that no one would give a stone to his child if he asks for bread.

Here are some other ways to translate this emphasis:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

If/When your son asks for bread to eat, would any
of you give him a stone? No!

- As a statement. For example:

Certainly none of you would give a stone to your
son if/when he asks you for bread.

7:9a

Which of you, if his son asks for bread,

- If your^(plur) son asks for bread/food, would any of you
- If/When your^(plur) son asks you for some bread/food to eat,

Which of you, if his son: The pronoun his refers generally to any of the people addressed by the plural pronoun you. In some languages using the pronoun “your” is more natural here than his. Another possibility is to change the grammar to make the meaning clear. For example:

Which of you^(plur), if your^(plur/sing) son

Among you^(plur), whoever's son

bread: The word bread was the food which the Jewish people ate every day. Here it is implied that the son was asking for bread because he was hungry. In some languages bread made of flour is not the daily food. If that is true in your language, you may want to use a word for an everyday food which is also used to refer generally to food. Or you may want to use the general word. For example:

food

Matthew 7:10

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 7:7–11

In this paragraph, Jesus told his disciples that they should pray earnestly to God for the things that they need, and God will give them these things. God will give good things to his followers just as a human father gives good things to his children.

Matthew 7:7–8 has almost the same words as Luke 11:9–10, and they mean the same thing.

7:10a–b

Or: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Or functions to introduce another example of Jesus' teaching about giving good things to those who ask.

if he asks for a fish, will give him a snake?: This is a rhetorical question. It is similar to the rhetorical question in 7:9. Jesus used this rhetorical question to emphasize that no one would give a serpent to his child if he asks for a fish. The words “which of you” are implied but not repeated from 7:9a–b.

Here are some other ways to translate this emphasis:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Would you give your child a snake if the child asked for a fish? (CEV)

Or if your child asks for a fish, would you give him a snake? (GW)

- As a statement. For example:

If/When your son asks you for a fish to eat, certainly none of you would give a snake to him.

7:10a

Or if he asks for a fish,

- Or if he asks you^(plur) for a fish,
- And if your^(plur) son asks you for a fish to eat,

fish: At that time, people in Israel ate a lot of fish. Here it is implied that the son was asking for a fish because he was hungry. If people do not eat fish in your culture, you may need to:

- Use a word for “meat.”
- Substitute the name of another common food that is good for children to eat. If you use a cultural substitute, you may want to include a footnote to indicate the literal word. An example footnote:

Literally “fish.” People in Israel regularly ate fish.

7:10b

will give him a snake?

- would you^(plur) give a snake to him?
- none of you would ever give an inedible/poisonous snake to him!

will give him a snake: Jewish laws forbid eating a snake. So no Jewish father would give his son a snake when his son asked for a fish to eat.

But in some languages giving a snake would be good. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Add implied information to indicate that giving a snake is bad. For example:

inedible snake

snake forbidden to eat

- Use the name of a specific type of snake that people do not eat. For example:

viper

cobra

poisonous snake

- Use another type of snake-like creature that people do not eat. For example:

lizard

worm

- Translate the word snake in your translation and add a footnote to explain. For example:

In Jewish culture, giving a snake was bad, because Jewish law forbids it.

Matthew 7:11

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 7:7–11

In this paragraph, Jesus told his disciples that they should pray earnestly to God for the things that they need, and God will give them these things. God will give good things to his followers just as a human father gives good things to his children.

Matthew 7:7–8 has almost the same words as Luke 11:9–10, and they mean the same thing.

7:11

In Greek, as in the BSB, 7:11 is one long, complicated sentence. It includes several steps in a logical argument with one main conclusion:

1. People are evil.
2. However, people know how to give good gifts to their children.
3. (Implied) God is good.
4. Therefore, God most certainly knows how to give good gifts to his children.

Jesus compared the character of people and the kinds of gifts that they give (7:11a–b) to the character of God and the kinds of gifts that he gives (7:11c–d). He expected his followers to agree that God will give much better gifts than people do. Consider how people make this type of statement in your culture.

7:11a

So if you who are evil

- Therefore, if you^(plur) evil people
- Even though you^(plur) are evil/sinful,

7:11b

know how to give good gifts to your children,

- know how to give good gifts/things to your children,
- you know how to give good things to your children.

7:11a–b

So: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as So is often translated as “therefore.” It introduces a conclusion of 7:7–10.

Here are some other ways to introduce this conclusion:

So (NLT)

Therefore

In conclusion

In some languages, it is more natural to leave this conjunction untranslated. The context can imply the relationship without a conjunction. For example:

As bad as you are, you know how to give good things to your children. (GNT)

if you who are evil know how to give good gifts: This clause is literally “if you being evil know to give good gifts to your children.” The BSB has added the word how to make it natural English.

This if clause implies that the disciples knew how to give good gifts to their children. It also implies that they gave them good gifts regularly. There is no doubt about this.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Keep the if clause. For example:

So if you sinful people know how to give good gifts to your children (NLT)

- Make 7:11a–b a separate sentence. For example:

Even though you're evil, you know how to give good gifts to your children. (GW)

As bad as you are, you know how to give good things to your children. (GNT)

You are evil, but you know how to give good gifts to your children. If you do that...

you who are evil: The Greek word that the BSB translates as evil also means “bad,” “sinful,” or “wicked.” Jesus was not condemning his disciples here. He was not saying that they were evil and other people were good. He was simply stating that all people are sinful.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

you are bad (NCV)

you sinful people (NLT)

good gifts: The phrase good gifts refers to things that fathers give their children. These are things that are good for them. Bread and fish (7:9–10) are examples of good gifts. But good gifts includes more than just food.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

good things

7:11c–d

how much more will your Father in heaven give:

Here a contrast is made between the nature of man and the nature of God: man is sinful and (it is implied that) God is good. The first part of the contrast (that man is sinful) was stated explicitly in 7:11a. If it is necessary to make the second half of the contrast explicit in your language, you may say:

how much more will your father in heaven who is good...

But your heavenly father is good. It is even more certain that...

7:11c

how much more will your Father in heaven

- then your Father in heaven is much more willing/ready
- But God your heavenly Father is good. Therefore, he knows better than you how to

how much more: The phrase how much more compares two things. It compares God's willingness/readiness and man's willingness to give good gifts. (The comparison is not between the sizes of the gifts.) Man gives good gifts. But God is much more willing than people to give good gifts.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

God is even more ready/willing

God knows better than you how to give...

it is absolutely certain that

even more so with God

your Father in heaven: The phrase your Father in heaven refers to God. Here heaven refers to the place where God lives.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

your Father in heaven

God your heavenly Father

Be careful not to imply that Jesus has other fathers and only this one is in heaven.

7:11d

give good things to those who ask Him!

- to give good things/gifts to those who ask him!"
- give good things/gifts to the people who ask him!"

good things: The Greek word that the BSB translates as good things is simply the word “good.” God gives us what is good. He gives us what we need. It refers to “good gifts” as in 7:11b. It includes the Holy Spirit mentioned in Luke 11:13.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

good things (RSV)

good gifts (NIV)

what is good

Matthew 7:12

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

7:12a

In everything, then, do to others as you would have them do to you.

- ¶ “So, the way you want people to act toward you, act in the same way toward them,
- ¶ “Therefore, do for/to others what you^(plur) want them to do for/to you.

In everything, then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as then indicates that 7:12 is a conclusion. In this case, it is a general conclusion or summary of all that Jesus has taught in the Sermon on the Mount up to this point (5–7:11). The word then is not a time word.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

Therefore

In conclusion

To summarize all that I have said

In everything...do to others as you would have them do to you: This statement means “Behave

toward other people in the same way that you want them to behave toward you.”

In some languages it may be more natural to reverse the order of the verse. For example:

Treat others as you want them to treat you (CEV)

do for other people everything you want them to do for you (GW)

7:12b

For this is the essence of the Law and the Prophets.

- because this rule is a summary of the/God’s law and the words of the Prophets.”
- This principle is the teaching of the books of the laws of Moses and the books of the prophets.”

For: The conjunction For indicates that 7:12b is the basis for the command in 7:12a.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

because

The reason is that

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it may not be necessary to translate this conjunction either.

this is the essence of: The phrase this is the essence of means “the command in 7:12a is the general principle taught by...”

Here are some other ways to translate this is:

this is the meaning of (GNT)

This is a summary of all that is taught in (NLT96)

the Law and the Prophets: In this context, the phrase the Law and the Prophets refers to the whole Old Testament.

In some languages, a literal translation would not clearly refer to the whole Old Testament. If that is true in your language, you may want to include some implied information. For example:

the books of the laws that God gave to Moses and the books of the Prophets

the books of the laws of Moses and the Prophets

the Old Testament

See how you translated this phrase in 5:17, but note that the conjunction and is used here instead of the conjunction “or.”

Matthew 7:13

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

7:13a

Enter through the narrow gate.

- ¶ “Enter by the narrow gate. (ESV)
- ¶ Jesus continued, “Go through the small gate/entrance.

Enter through the narrow gate: Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Enter through the narrow door

Go through the small entrance

7:13b

For wide is the gate and broad is the way that leads to destruction,

- For/Because the gate that leads to the place of destruction is wide, and the path that goes there is easy to follow,
- The gate/entrance is wide and the road/path is wide that leads to hell.

For: This conjunction introduces the basis or reason for the command in 7:13a.

Here is another way to translate this conjunction:

because (GW)

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it may not be necessary to translate this conjunction either.

wide is the gate and broad is the way: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as broad is the way is more literally “the road/path is wide/broad.” English versions do at least two things with the word that the BSB translates as broad:

- Translate it more literally. For example:

The gate is wide and the road is wide (NCV)

- Focus on the result of the road being wide: it is easy to walk on. For example:

The gate...is wide, and the road...is easy to follow (CEV)

Whichever option you follow, make sure it contrasts with “small/narrow is the gate/way” in 7:14a.

that leads to destruction: The word destruction means “complete ruin.” In this metaphor, it refers to the place of destruction or hell.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

that leads to the place of destruction

that leads to hell (NCV)

Both the “gate” and the “way/road” lead to destruction. It is not only the road. Here is one way to make this clear:

The gate to destruction is wide, and the road that leads there is easy to follow. (CEV)

7:13c

and many enter through it.

- and those who enter by it are many. (ESV)
- A lot of people go through that gate/entrance.

and many enter through it: The pronoun it refers to the wide gate. Many people enter through the wide gate. It is implied that many people then walk on the wide road.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

and those who enter by it are many (ESV)

many people enter through that gate (NCV)

A lot of people go through that gate. (CEV)

Matthew 7:14

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

7:14a

But small is the gate and narrow the way that leads to life,

- But the gate that leads to eternal life is narrow, and the path that goes there is hard to follow,
- But the gate/entrance is small and the road/path is narrow that leads to life in heaven,

But: There is a textual issue here:

1. Some Greek manuscripts begin this verse with a word that functions as an exclamation. For example:

How narrow the gate (NAB)

1. Other Greek manuscripts begin this verse with the conjunction that means “For/because.” For example:

For the gate is narrow (RSV) (RSV, ESV, NASB, KJV)

The BSB, along with most English versions, do not follow option (2), but neither do they clearly translate option (1). Instead, they make explicit the contrast between 7:13 and 7:14 by beginning this verse with But. It is recommended that you also indicate the contrast between these two verses.

On the other hand, here is one way to indicate both the Greek exclamation and the contrast:

But very narrow is the gate

But the gate is really narrow

small is the gate: In the Greek, the word small is the same as “narrow” in 7:13a. You should translate it here as you did there. For example:

the gate is narrow

the entrance is small

narrow the way: The Greek word that the BSB translates as narrow refers to something being pressed/squeezed from both sides. This way/path is the opposite of the “wide/easy” path in 7:13b. You should translate it in a way that contrasts with “the way is easy.” For example:

the road is narrow (NCV)

The road that leads there is so hard to follow (CEV)

that leads to life: The word life refers to eternal life. In some languages a literal translation would refer only to life on earth. If that is true in your language, you may want to add some implied meaning. For example:

eternal life

life that never ends

life in heaven

Both the narrow gate and the narrow road lead to life. It is not only the narrow road. One way to make this clear is:

But the gate to life is very narrow. The road that leads there is so hard to follow (CEV)

7:14b

and only a few find it.

- and only a few people find it.”
- and few people find that gate and enter.”

only a few find it: The Greek word that the BSB translates as find includes the meanings: “find from searching,” “find accidentally,” and “obtain, secure, or receive” Here it probably refers to finding after searching.

The pronoun it could refer to the gate, the path, or life. Because this clause is parallel to “enter through it” in 7:13c, this pronoun probably refers to the narrow gate. One way to translate this clause is:

few people find that gate

In some languages, the word find may not also imply entering. If that is true in your language, you may want to include the implied information. For example:

only a few people find it and enter

Matthew 7:15

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

7:15a

Beware of false prophets.

- ¶ “Beware^(plur) of false prophets.
- ¶ Jesus continued, “Be careful of people who claim to be God’s prophets/spokesmen, but are liars.

Beware of: This phrase is a warning. Jesus warned his followers to be on guard against false prophets.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Be on your guard against (GNT)

Watch out for (NIV)

Be careful of (NCV)

false prophets: A false prophet is a person who claims to speak messages from God, but he did not really receive his messages from God. Such people are not real prophets.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

deceitful/lying prophets But this translation should not imply that they were truly God’s prophets but had lied about something else.

false religious teachers (JBP)

those who say they are prophets of God but/and whose teachings are lies

those who pretend to be spokesmen for God

In this context, the word prophets probably refers to all religious teachers. In some languages this phrase would refer to only those who call themselves prophets. If that is true in your language, you may want to use a more general word. For example:

false religious teachers (JBP)

See how you translated prophets in 4:14 and 5:12.

7:15b

They come to you in sheep’s clothing, but inwardly they are ravenous wolves.

- They come to you in sheep skins, but inside those sheepskins they are dangerous, hungry wolves.
- They come to you pretending to be gentle. But they are dangerous. They are like wild dogs wearing sheep skins.

They come to you in sheep’s clothing, but inwardly they are ravenous wolves: The phrases sheep’s clothing and ravenous wolves are metaphors.

Sheep are tame animals. The sheep represent things that are gentle and harmless.

The phrase sheep’s clothing refers to a skin from a sheep. It includes the hair/wool.

The word wolves refers to a kind of large, fierce, wild dog. The Greek word that the BSB translates as ravenous means “eager to attack and having a great desire to eat or take things from others.” The wolves represent danger.

In this metaphor, the wolves wear the skins of sheep in order to look like sheep. They do this to deceive other animals so that they can get near them and destroy them. In the same way, false prophets approach true believers and pretend to be one of them, but their teaching is dangerous.

Here are some other ways to translate these metaphors:

- Keep the metaphors and explain the meaning in a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

Wolves wearing the skins of sheep represents false prophets who pretend to be true believers. Just as wolves wearing sheep skins are deceitful and still dangerous, false prophets are deceitful. Their teachings are dangerous.

- Translate the metaphors as similes and explain the meaning in the text. For example:

who come disguised as harmless sheep but are really vicious wolves (NLT)

They come to you looking gentle like sheep, but they are really dangerous like wolves. (NCV)

They come to you pretending to be gentle, but they are really dangerous. It is as if they were fierce wolves wearing sheep skins.

wolves: Those animals, wolves, only live in certain parts of the world. If you live in an area where there are no wolves, you can substitute a wild animal that destroys other animals. For example:

wild dogs

lions/hyenas

Matthew 7:16

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

7:16–20

In 7:16–20, Jesus used an extended metaphor. In this metaphor, the deeds of false prophets are compared to the bad fruit that a bad tree/bush produces. The deeds of true prophets are compared to the good fruit that a good tree or good vine produces. Just as we can recognize a bad tree by the bad fruit it produces, so we can recognize false prophets by the deeds they do.

When you translate 7:16–20, you should keep most of the metaphor because:

1. it extends over five verses
2. Jesus explained it in 7:20

7:16a

By their fruit you will recognize them.

- You^(plur) will know what kind of people they are by their deeds/works.
- When you see what they do, you will know who they really are.

By their fruit: The word By here means “by means of” or “according to.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

From their fruits

Because of their fruits

When you see their fruits

their fruit: The word fruit is a metaphor. In this metaphor, the deeds/actions of the false prophets are compared to fruit. They are similar in that both allow something or someone to be identified. Just as fruit helps identify the type of tree it came from, deeds help identify the type of person who did them.

Here are some other ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Translate the verse literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

The “fruits” are the deeds of people. When we see a person’s deeds, we know whether that person

did something good or bad. This is like seeing the fruit on a tree and knowing the kind of tree it is.

- Translate the metaphor as a simile and explain the meaning in the text. For example:

You will know who they are by their deeds. It is like you will know a tree by its fruit.

- Translate the meaning without using a metaphor. For example:

You will know them by what they do (GNT)

you: The pronoun you is plural and refers to all of Jesus' listeners.

will recognize: The Greek word that the BSB translates as recognize also means simply "will know." For example:

will know (RSV)

them: The pronoun them refers to the false prophets.

7:16b–c

Are grapes gathered from thornbushes, or figs from thistles?: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus used this rhetorical question to emphasize the fact that people do not pick grapes from thorn bushes, and they do not pick figs from thistles. You should translate in a way that emphasizes this meaning.

Here are some other ways to translate this emphasis:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Do people pick grapes from thornbushes, or figs from thistles? (NIV)

People don't pick grapes from thornbushes or figs from thistles, do they? (GW)

- As a statement. For example:

People certainly do not pick grapes from thorn bushes, and they do not pick figs from thistles.

7:16b

Are grapes gathered from thornbushes,

- Do people pick fruit called grapes from bushes with thorns,

- People certainly do not pick vine fruit from small thorn trees.

grapes: The word grapes refers to small, round, edible fruit that grow in bunches on a vine. A grapevine does not have thorns.

Grapes only grow in certain parts of the world. If you live in an area where there are no grapes, you can:

- Use a general word for fruit and transliterate the word grapes into your language. For example:

fruit called grapes (Note that grapes and grape-fruit are not the same thing.)

- Use a general word for fruit and include that it was from a vine. But choose something that does not have thorns. For example:

vine fruit

- Use a word for fruit commonly eaten in your area. If possible choose one that is small, round, and grows in bunches. It should not grow on a bush with thorns.

thornbushes: The word thornbushes refers to a bush (or small tree) that has thorns. It does not bear edible fruit. It is not useful for anything, and is a problem plant for farmers.

7:16c

or figs from thistles?

- or figs from thorny weeds? Of course not!
- They do not pick tree fruit from thorny grass/plants.

or figs from thistles: The words "are...gathered" are implied from the previous clause but are not repeated here. In some languages, it is more natural to repeat some of those words. For example:

or are figs gathered from thistles

Do people pick figs from thistles

Ripe fig on a branch

figs: The word figs refers to medium-sized, edible fruit that grow on the "fig" tree. Figs only grow in certain parts of the world. If you live in an area where there are no figs, you can:

- Use a general word for fruit and transliterate the word figs into your language. For example:

tree fruit named figs

- Use a general word for fruit and include that it was from a tree, since the exact kind of fruit is not important:

tree fruit

- Use a word for fruit commonly eaten in your area. If possible choose one that is medium-sized and grows on trees. It should not grow on a thistle bush.

thistles: The word thistles refers to a bush that has many thorns on the leaves and stems. It does not bear edible fruit. It is not useful for anything, and is a problem plant for farmers.

Here is another way to translate this word:

thorny weeds (NCV)

Matthew 7:17

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

7:17a

Likewise, every good tree bears good fruit,

- Likewise, every good tree bears good fruit,
- In the same way, every good tree produces/gives tasty fruit.

Likewise: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Likewise here refers to something being similar. For example:

In the same way (NJB)

So (ESV)

every good tree: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as good tree can also be translated as “healthy tree” (as in the ESV). Here the word good contrasts with “bad” in 7:17b. So some versions translate it as “healthy.” It refers to a tree that produces good or tasty fruit.

bears good fruit: The phrase good fruit refers to fruit that people eat. It is tasty fruit.

7:17b

but a bad tree bears bad fruit.

- and every bad tree bears bad fruit.
- Every rotten tree produces/gives worthless fruit.

bad tree: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as bad tree means “rotten, diseased tree.” It refers to a tree that does not produce good or useful fruit. For example:

diseased tree (ESV)

rotten tree (GW)

bad fruit: The phrase bad fruit refers to fruit that does not taste good. It is worthless fruit. People do not eat it.

Matthew 7:18

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

7:18a

A good tree cannot bear bad fruit,

- A good tree is not able to produce bad fruit,
- A good tree does not produce worthless fruit.

7:18b

and a bad tree cannot bear good fruit.

- and a bad tree is not able to produce good fruit.
- A rotten tree does not produce tasty fruit.

7:18a–b

Verse 7:18 is a Jewish way to emphasize 7:17. It does this by stating that the opposites of 7:17a–b do not happen.

cannot bear...cannot bear: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as cannot is more literally “not able.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

does not

is not possible

Matthew 7:19

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

7:19

Every tree that does not bear good fruit is cut down and thrown into the fire.

- Every tree that does not produce good fruit is chopped down and thrown into the fire.
- If a tree does not produce good fruit, people/they will cut it down and throw it into a fire to burn.

Every tree that does not bear good fruit is cut down and thrown into the fire: The verbs cut down and thrown are passive.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- Use passive verbs. For example:

Every tree that produces bad fruit will be chopped down and burned. (CEV)

- Use active verbs. For example:

If a tree does not bear good fruit, people will cut it down and throw it into a fire

Matthew 7:20

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

7:20

So then, by their fruit you will recognize them.

- So, you^(plur) will know what kind of people they are by their deeds/works.”
- Therefore, when you see what the false prophets do, you will know who they really are.”

So then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as So then introduces the conclusion to this paragraph.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

So (GW)

Therefore

by their fruit you will recognize them: In Greek, this clause is the same as in 7:16. You should translate it in a similar way. For example:

you will know the false prophets by what they do (GNT)

when you see what they do, you will know who they are

Matthew 7:21

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

7:21a

Not everyone who says to Me, ‘Lord, Lord,’ will enter the kingdom of heaven,

- ¶ “Not all people who say to me, ‘Lord, Lord,’ will enter the kingdom of the one who lives in heaven.
- ¶ “Not everyone who calls me ‘Lord, Lord,’ will become a citizen/member of the kingdom of the one who lives in heaven.
- ¶ “Among the people who call me ‘My Lord,’ not all of them will be among those whom God rules.

Not everyone who says to Me, ‘Lord, Lord,’ will enter: The clause who says to Me, ‘Lord, Lord,’ means “who calls me their Lord/Master.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Among those who say to me, ‘Lord, Lord,’ not all of them will enter

Some people who say to me ‘Lord, Lord,’ will not enter

In some languages, it may be more natural to make Lord, Lord indirect speech. For example:

Not everyone who calls me his Lord/Master will enter

Lord, Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord means “master,” “owner” or “a person who has great authority.” It is used to refer to someone greater in status or power. People used it to address God the

Father and Jesus. See how you translated this word in 3:3 and 5:33.

The double address of Lord, Lord probably indicates honor, respect, and deep emotion. The speakers were insisting that Jesus is their Lord. But as 7:23 indicates, the people who said this were not true followers of Jesus.

In some languages this double address will indicate a different meaning. If that is true in your language, indicate the honor and respect in another way. For example:

my Lord

dear/beloved Lord

will enter the kingdom of heaven: In this context, the word enter refers to “becoming a citizen of.” When people believe in Jesus, they become citizens/members of the kingdom of heaven.

The phrase the kingdom of heaven refers to God’s activity of ruling and caring for his people as their king. It does not refer to a land or country that he rules over. It refers to the relationship that he has with his people. He leads, protects, and cares for them. They obey, trust, and submit to him as their king.

Here Matthew used the word heaven as a Hebrew idiom to humbly refer to God.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

become a citizen of the kingdom of heaven

become one of those who are in the kingdom of the one who lives in heaven

be added to those over whom God rules

will God make part of his reign

This clause also occurs in 5:20.

7:21b

but only he who does the will of My Father in heaven.

- But the person who does the things that my Father in heaven desires/wants will enter.
- Only the person who does what my Father in heaven wants will be a citizen/member of his kingdom.

- Only the person who does what my Father in heaven wants will be among them.

but only he who does the will of My Father in heaven: The verb and object from 7:21a are implied but are not repeated. The complete sentence would be: but only he who does the will of My Father in heaven will enter the kingdom of heaven.

It may be more natural in your language to include some of the implied words. For example:

but only he who does the will of my Father in heaven will become one of the people whom God rules

but the person whom God will make part of his reign is the person who does my heavenly Father's will

does the will of My Father in heaven: This clause means "does what God desires."

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

does what my Father in heaven wants (GW)

obey my Father in heaven (CEV)

My Father in heaven: The clause in heaven further describes Jesus' Father, namely, God. It does not imply that there are other fathers of Jesus and only this one is in heaven. In some languages, it will be necessary to translate the correct meaning in a different way. For example:

my Father in heaven (GNT)

my heavenly Father

Matthew 7:22

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as "The Sermon on the Mount." In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

7:22a

Many will say to Me on that day,

- On that day of judgment, many people will say to me,
- At the time when God judges all people, many people will say to me,

Many will say to Me: The word Many refers to people. For example:

many people will say to me (NCV)

on that day: The phrase on that day refers to the future time when God will judge all people.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

On the day of judgment (CEV)

At the time when God judges all people

7:22b–c

'Lord, Lord, did we not prophesy in Your name, and in Your name drive out demons and perform many miracles?': This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes the fact/claim that these people prophesied, drove out demons, and performed many miracles.

Here are some other ways to translate this emphasis:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Lord, Lord, we prophesied in your name, and in your name we drove out demons and performed many miracles. Isn't that so?

Lord, Lord, don't you remember? We prophesied in your name, we cast out demons in your name, and we performed many miracles in your name.

- As a statement. For example:

Lord, Lord! In your name we spoke God's message, by your name we drove out many demons and performed many miracles! (GNT)

In Greek, the phrase in Your name appears before each of the three verbs “prophesy,” “drive out,” and “perform.” Some ways to translate it are:

Lord, Lord, in your name did we not prophesy, and in your name cast out demons, and in your name do many mighty works?

Lord, Lord, in your name did we not prophesy, cast out demons, and do many mighty works?

7:22b

‘Lord, Lord, did we not prophesy in Your name,

- ‘Lord, Lord, we^(excl) spoke God’s message with/by your name,
- ‘My/Our Lord, we preached words from God using your power/authority,

Lord, Lord: As in 7:21a, the double address of Lord, Lord probably indicates honor, respect, and deep emotion. The speakers were insisting that Jesus is their Lord.

If you translated this double address of Lord, Lord in 7:21a in another way, you will want to do the same here.

did we not prophesy: This word prophesy means “speak a message on behalf of God.” God somehow communicates his message directly to his messenger. The messenger then speaks the message to people on behalf of God. These people were claiming to be God’s messengers.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

we spoke God’s message (GNT)

we preached words from God

in Your name: Here name represents the whole person. So the phrase in Your name means “by/using your authority” or “using your power.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

with your name

by the power and authority of your name (GW)

using the authority of your name

through your power

7:22c

and in Your name drive out demons

- and we caused demons to leave people with/by your name,
- and we forced demons out of people using your power/authority,

drive out demons: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as drive out demons refers to forcing demons to stop controlling people and leave.

Jewish people often spoke of evil spirits as being in someone. Different cultures have different ways of speaking about people being controlled by demons and being released from the control of demons. Use a natural expression for this in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

sent demons away

forced out demons (CEV)

caused demons to leave people

freed people who were controlled by an evil spirit

healed people sick with an evil spirit

demons: The Greek word that the BSB translates as demons refers to the same type of spirits as the Greek words that are often translated as “evil spirits” or “unclean spirits.” These evil spirits can control peoples’ actions and can make them sick.

Here are some other ways to translate demons:

- Use a word in your language that refers to a spirit that is evil and can control people. Do not use a word that refers to the spirit of a dead person.
- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

evil/bad spirits

spirits that do evil

spirits that oppose God

See also demon in the Glossary for more information.

7:22d**and perform many miracles?**

- and we did many miracles with/by your name. Isn't that so?
- and we did many amazing deeds using your power/authority!

perform many miracles: The Greek word that the BSB translates as miracles can also be translated as “mighty works” (as in the ESV). This word refers to events or acts that are impossible for men to do, but God can cause them to happen.

It is not clear whether these mighty works were true miracles or whether these people falsely claimed to do miracles in Jesus' name.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

mighty works (ESV)

amazing acts/deeds

surprising things

Matthew 7:23**Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain**

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

7:23a**Then I will tell them plainly,**

- Then I will clearly say to them,
- But I will tell them directly,
- But I will say in front of them that

In the Greek, 7:23a begins with a conjunction that is often translated as “and” or “but.” There is contrast between what the people of 7:22 wanted and what

Jesus said here. The BSB does not translate this conjunction but leaves the contrast implicit. In some languages, it will be more natural to make the contrast more explicit. For example:

But (CEV)

Nevertheless

However

I: The pronoun I refers to Jesus.

will tell them plainly: This phrase refers to openly saying something to the people of 7:22.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

will tell them clearly (NCV)

will say to them directly/frankly

will answer them

7:23b**‘I never knew you; depart from Me, you workers of lawlessness!’**

- ‘I do not recognize you. Leave me, you law breakers!’”
- ‘Evil doers! I do not consider you to be my people! Go away from me!’”
- I never knew them and that they should leave me because they are law breakers.”

I never knew you: The clause I never knew you indicates that Jesus did not consider these people to be his followers. All people will stand before Jesus at the final judgment, and Jesus will know their names and what they did. But the people of 7:22 never belonged to God's kingdom.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I do not consider you to be my people

You are not my people

I do not recognize you

depart from Me: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as depart from Me also means:

leave me

go away from me

you workers of lawlessness: The phrase workers of lawlessness refers to people who do deeds that are against the law. This phrase implies that they did these things as a habit, even though they claimed to do good.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

you who do evil (NCV)

you who break God's laws (NLT)

Some other issues to consider when you translate this phrase are:

- This phrase is also a direct address. Jesus used the expression like a title or a name. The BSB supplies the pronoun you to make the English natural. In some languages, it is more natural not to supply the pronoun. For example:

evil doers

law breakers

- In some languages, it is more natural to put this phrase first in 7:23b. For example:

Evil doers, I never knew you. Get away from me!

- This is a quote within a quote. So in some languages, it is more natural to state it more indirectly. For example:

I will say to them that they are evil doers and should go away because I refuse to acknowledge them as my people.

Matthew 7:24

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

7:24a

Therefore everyone who hears these words of Mine

- ¶ “Therefore, everyone who hears my teachings
- ¶ Jesus concluded, “So, everyone who hears what I said

Therefore: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Therefore introduces the final part of the Sermon on the Mount (5:3–7:27). This final part is a parable. In this parable, Jesus encouraged people to obey what he has said.

Here are some other ways to introduce this final section:

So then (GNT)

In conclusion

then (ESV)

everyone who hears these words of Mine: The phrase these words of Mine refers to the teaching in 5:3–7:23.

In some languages a literal translation would refer only to those who physically heard Jesus speak. If that is true in your language, you may want to use a more general expression for these words of Mine. For example:

everyone who hears my teachings

all those who hear what I have said

7:24b

and acts on them

- and obeys them
- and does/follows it

acts on them: The phrase acts on them refers to obeying Jesus' teachings.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

puts them into practice (NIV)

obeys them (GNT)

7:24c

is like a wise man who built his house on the rock.

- is like a wise/intelligent man who built his house on bedrock.
- is like a thoughtful man. This man built his house on solid rock to make it strong.

is like a wise man: The phrase a wise man refers to a man who has good sense and is thoughtful. It refers to a man who makes good decisions in day-to-day living. It is the opposite of a stupid man.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

sensible man (NJB)

thinking man

intelligent man

who built his house on the rock: In this context, the word rock refers to bedrock. It is rock that is often level with the ground or just under the ground and covers a wide area. It does not refer to a boulder.

In some areas of the world, bedrock does not exist. Or people do not build their houses on bedrock. If that is true in your area, you may want to explain what Jesus meant. For example:

who built his house on rock to make it strong

who built his house on a strong foundation stone

Matthew 7:25

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

7:25a

The rain fell, the torrents raged,

- The rain came, the rivers/streams flooded,
- It rained very hard and caused the river to overflow its banks.

The rain fell: In this context, the clause The rain fell refers to a heavy rain. It is the type of rain that could damage a house.

the torrents raged: The expression the torrents raged refers to so much water in the rivers that the water overflows the banks of the rivers.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the streams rose (NIV)

the rivers flooded over (GNT)

7:25b

and the winds blew and beat against that house;

- and winds also came and beat against that house,
- Some strong/big wind also blew hard on/against that house.

the winds blew: The phrase the winds blew means that they blew strongly. They were the type of winds that could damage a house.

The word for winds is plural in Greek. But in some languages, it is more natural to translate this as a singular noun and verb. For example:

the wind blew

a strong wind came

beat against that house: The words beat against that house refer to another thing that the winds did.

In some languages, the verb “beat” is something that only a human, animal, or supernatural spirit could do. If that is true in your language, then you may want to use a different word. For example:

the wind blew hard against that house (GNT)

7:25c

yet it did not fall, because its foundation was on the rock.

- but the house did not fall down/over because it was built on bedrock.
- The wise man had built the house on solid rock, that is why it did not collapse.

yet it did not fall: The verb fall here means “fall down,” or “collapse.” In spite of the rain, flood, and wind, the house was not ruined.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

did not fall down/over

did not collapse

was not destroyed

because its foundation was on the rock: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as was on the rock means “was firmly established” or “was built.” This verb refers to the base or lowest part of the house being placed on bedrock. So the house’s foundation was strong.

The clause is passive. Here are some other ways to translate this:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

it was built on solid rock (CEV)

it was built strongly

- Use an active verb. It was the wise man who built his house on the rock. For example:

he built it on the rock

he built it strongly

- Change the verb to a noun. For example:

it had its foundation on the rock (NIV)

rock: The Greek word that the BSB translates as rock means “bedrock.” It does not refer to loose stones on top of the ground. It refers to a solid rock mass or layer under the surface of the ground.

Matthew 7:26

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

7:26a

But everyone who hears these words of Mine

- But everyone who hears my teachings
- However, anyone who hears what I said

7:26b

and does not act on them

- and does not obey them
- and does not do/follow it

7:26a–b

But: Verse 7:26a–b contrasts with 7:24a–b. One way to indicate this contrast is to begin this verse with the word But. For example:

And (ESV)

everyone who hears these words of Mine and does

not act on them: These clauses are almost identical to 7:24a–b, but the word not is added to the second part. You should translate this in a similar way.

7:26c

is like a foolish man who built his house on sand.

- is like a foolish/stupid man who built his house on sand.
- is like a man with no sense. This man built his house on top of ground that was not hard.

foolish: The Greek word that the BSB translates as foolish refers to someone who has no sense or uses poor judgment. It means the opposite of “wise” in 7:24c.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

simple minded

unthinking

stupid (NJB)

built his house on sand: The word sand refers to “sandy ground” or “pure sand” with nothing firm underneath. The foolish man did not build his house on a strong foundation.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

built his house on top of sand/gravel

built his house in an unsafe/unstable place

did not dig deep holes for the foundation

Matthew 7:27

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

7:27a

The rain fell, the torrents raged,

- The rain came, the rivers/streams flooded,
- It rained very hard and caused the river to overflow its banks.

7:27b

and the winds blew and beat against that house,

- and winds also came and beat against that house,
- Some strong/big wind also blew hard on/against that house.

7:27a–b

The rain fell, the torrents raged, and the winds blew and beat against that house: In Greek these clauses are identical to 7:25a–b. You should translate them in the same way.

7:27c

and it fell—and great was its collapse!”

- and it fell down/over and was completely destroyed.”
- And it collapsed. The entire house was completely destroyed!”

and it fell—and great was its collapse!: These clauses indicate that the whole house fell down. It was completely destroyed.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

it fell down and was completely destroyed

and it collapsed; it was utterly destroyed! (NET)

Matthew 7:28

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 7:28–29

Verses 7:28–29 refer to what happened immediately after Jesus finished the Sermon on the Mount.

A few English versions have a section heading here. Usually a section includes more than two verses. But you may want to have a new section here for the new topic.

Here are some possible headings for this section:

The crowds were amazed at his teaching

The Authority of Jesus (GNT)

Jesus' teaching has authority

7:28a

When Jesus had finished saying these things,

- ¶ When Jesus finished saying these words,
- ¶ After Jesus finished teaching/preaching

When Jesus had finished saying these things: The phrase saying these things refers to everything that Jesus said in 5:3–7:27.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

When Jesus finished speaking (CEV)

When Jesus finished teaching/preaching

7:28b

the crowds were astonished at His teaching,

- the crowds were very surprised at/by his teaching,
- to the crowds, they were astonished by the way that he taught.

the crowds: In Greek the word for crowds is plural to indicate a very large number of people. They were the same crowds as in 5:1a.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

those same crowds

the very large group of people which had gathered

astonished: The Greek word that the BSB translates as astonished means that the people were very surprised. Jesus' teaching was very different from what they expected. It was a more powerful teaching than what they had heard from other Jewish teachers.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

surprised (CEV)

astounded

amazed (NIV)

at His teaching: The phrase at His teaching refers to:

1. the things that Jesus taught. He taught them things that they had never heard before.

2. the way/manner that he taught. He taught with authority.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

by his teaching (NET)

at the way he taught (GNT)

by what he said

Matthew 7:29

Section 5:1–7:29: Jesus preached a sermon on a mountain

For many years, English versions and Christians have commonly referred to Matthew 5–7 as “The Sermon on the Mount.” In some translations, it may be helpful to include a heading for chapters 5–7 that is on a level above the section heading for 5:1–12.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Sermon on the Mountain

The sermon that Jesus preached on a mountain

Jesus taught people on the side of a mountain/hill

Paragraph 7:28–29

Verses 7:28–29 refer to what happened immediately after Jesus finished the Sermon on the Mount.

A few English versions have a section heading here. Usually a section includes more than two verses. But you may want to have a new section here for the new topic.

Here are some possible headings for this section:

The crowds were amazed at his teaching

The Authority of Jesus (GNT)

Jesus' teaching has authority

7:29a

because He taught as one who had authority,

- because he spoke to them like a teacher who had true/great authority,

- He taught them like a person who had authority/power to teach.

because: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as because introduces the reason why the crowds were amazed at what he taught.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

for (ESV)

the reason they were amazed is that

He taught as one who had authority: The words had authority refers to having the right and the power to do something. Jesus taught with confidence. He did not quote what other experts had to say about the Bible.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he taught with real authority (NLT)

he taught as someone with the right to teach

he taught with power

7:29b

and not as their scribes.

- not like the teachers of the law.
- He did not teach the way that the teachers of the law of Moses taught.

and not as their scribes: The phrase not as their scribes indicates that Jesus did not teach in the same way that the scribes taught. When the scribes explained something, they always quoted other scholars to support their views. But Jesus did not quote other Jewish teachers to support the truth of what he said.

scribes: The Greek word that the BSB translates as scribes refers to men who studied, interpreted, and taught the law of Moses. These men were called scribes because their original work was to copy the laws of Moses by hand. In New Testament times, this was no longer their main task.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

teachers of the law (NIV)

teachers of the Law of Moses (CEV)

teachers of religious law (NLT)

experts in the law

This word also occurs in 5:20. You should translate it here as you did there. See also scribe in the Glossary for more information.

Matthew 8:1

Section 8:1–4: Jesus healed a man who had leprosy

In this section, Jesus showed his authority by healing a man who had a skin disease called leprosy. Jewish law declared that any person with leprosy was “ritually unclean.” Anyone who touched a person who had leprosy also became unclean. But when Jesus touched the man who had leprosy, Jesus did not become unclean. Instead, he healed the man who had leprosy.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus heals a leper

A man with leprosy

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 1:40–45 and Luke 5:12–16.

8:1a

When Jesus came down from the mountain,

- ¶ When he came down from the mountain, (ESV)
- ¶ As Jesus descended the hill,

When Jesus came down from the mountain: Jesus had gone up a mountain (in 5:1b) to preach the Sermon on the Mount. At some point after finishing his sermon, Jesus came down the same mountain.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

When/As Jesus came down the mountain

After he finished speaking to the people, Jesus descended the hill

mountain: You should use the same word for mountain here as in 5:1b. This mountain was where Jesus preached his sermon in 5:3–7:27.

The mountains/hills near Lake Galilee vary in height from about 30 meters (about 100 feet) to as high as

500 meters (1640 feet) above the lake. Use a term in your language that refers to this size of mountain/hill.

Here are some other ways to translate mountain:

hill (GNT)

mountainside (NLT)

8:1b

large crowds followed Him.

- a large group of people followed after him.
- many people who had listened to him went/came down along with him.

large crowds: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as large crowds is more literally “many crowds.” In Greek, the word crowds is plural. This word together with the word that the BSB translates as large refers to a “large number of people.” These were the people who had listened to Jesus’ sermon.

Here, the word crowds does not indicate that there were separate groups of people.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

many people

a large group of people

followed Him: Here, the verb followed is used in its normal sense. It indicates that the crowd went along with Jesus. Jesus was probably in front leading the crowd, and they followed behind him. The people had gathered on the side of the mountain to listen to Jesus, so they also descended the mountain as they followed Jesus.

In this context, the verb followed does not have the same sense as in 4:20 where Simon and Andrew “followed” Jesus and became his disciples.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

went with him

descended together/along with him

Matthew 8:2

Section 8:1–4: Jesus healed a man who had leprosy

In this section, Jesus showed his authority by healing a man who had a skin disease called leprosy. Jewish

law declared that any person with leprosy was “ritually unclean.” Anyone who touched a person who had leprosy also became unclean. But when Jesus touched the man who had leprosy, Jesus did not become unclean. Instead, he healed the man who had leprosy.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus heals a leper

A man with leprosy

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 1:40–45 and Luke 5:12–16.

8:2a

Suddenly a leper came and knelt before Him,

- All of a sudden, a leper came to him and got on his knees in front of him.
- After they reached the bottom of the hill, suddenly, a man with a terrible skin disease approached Jesus and bowed before him.

Suddenly: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Suddenly indicates that something extraordinary will happen. Here, the amazing event is that a leper came to Jesus, and Jesus healed him. If you have a way to indicate such an event, you may want to use it here.

Here is another way to translate this word:

And behold (ESV)

a leper: The Greek word that the BSB translates as leper refers to a person who had one of several different skin diseases. Scholars disagree as to whether these skin diseases included modern-day leprosy (Hansen’s disease). They agree that in the New Testament times the Greek word referred to dreaded skin diseases. One specific type of skin disease is leprosy.

People believed that these diseases were spread by contact with someone who had the disease. A person who had one of these diseases was considered ritually unclean. According to Jewish law, he was not allowed to associate with other people. He was not allowed to worship in the temple.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

- Use a word or phrase that refers to a person who has leprosy. For example:

a leper man

a man sick with/from leprosy

a man with leprosy (CEV)

- Use a general phrase that describes the nature or significance of the disease that this person had. For example:

a man suffering from a dreaded skin disease (GNT)

a man sick with a skin disease

a man whose skin was rotting

knelt before Him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *knelt* literally means “prostrate before.” This means kneeling and putting one’s face to the ground. Common people did this to people of great authority in order to show them great honor and submission.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

bowed low in front of him (NJB)

got on his knees before Jesus

8:2b saying, “Lord, if You are willing, You can make me clean.”

- He said, “Lord, if you want to, you can make me well.”
- He said, “Sir, I know that you can heal me if you want to. So please heal me.”

Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *Lord* means “master.” It was a polite title used when addressing a respected leader.

Here are some other ways to translate *Lord*:

Sir (GNT)

Master

Big/Important person

if You are willing, You can make me clean: This statement was a polite and indirect way for the man to ask Jesus to heal him of his leprosy. In some languages it may be necessary to make the request explicit. For example:

I know that if you want to, you can heal me. So please heal me.

Consider how the man would express his request politely in your language.

if You are willing: The clause *if You are willing* here means “if you want to.” The man believed that Jesus was able to heal him, but he was not sure that Jesus was willing to do so.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

if you want to (GNT)

if you choose (NRSV)

please, if you are willing

You can make me clean: The Greek verb that the BSB literally translates as *make...clean* has the sense of “healed” or “cured” when used with leprosy. According to BDAG, this verb means “the healing of diseases which make a person ceremonially unclean, esp. leprosy.” (sense 2. p. 488)

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

you have the power to make me well (CEV)

you can heal me (NCV)

According to Jewish law, a person became “ritually unclean” if he had certain diseases such as leprosy. In addition, touching “unclean” things such as a dead body or an open sore made a person unclean. Certain animals were unclean and could not be eaten. Any clothing that had mildew was unclean and had to be burned. A ritually “unclean” person could not live with other people. He had to live apart from the rest of society. He could not worship in the temple. If anyone came near him, the unclean person had to warn him by shouting out, “Unclean!”

So here the leper not only had a disease, he was “unclean.” (This does not mean that he was physically dirty and needed to be washed.) In order to be completely cleansed from leprosy, there were at least two steps:

1. he had to be cured/healed, and
2. he had to be declared clean by a priest and offer sacrifices.

When Jesus told the man to go show himself to the priest and offer the sacrifice (in 8:4b–c), Jesus commanded the man to take care of step b. This shows that when Jesus said “Be clean” (in 8:3b), he was not doing step b. He did not make the man “ritually clean” according to the law of Moses. Rather, Jesus was taking care of step a: healing. Furthermore, when the leper asked Jesus to make him “clean,” he was not asking Jesus to play the role of the priest (step b). When Jesus says “I will,” he meant “I will agree to your request to be healed.” Therefore, in this context, the Greek word is best translated as “healed/cured.”

Matthew 8:3

Section 8:1–4: Jesus healed a man who had leprosy

In this section, Jesus showed his authority by healing a man who had a skin disease called leprosy. Jewish law declared that any person with leprosy was “ritually unclean.” Anyone who touched a person who had leprosy also became unclean. But when Jesus touched the man who had leprosy, Jesus did not become unclean. Instead, he healed the man who had leprosy.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus heals a leper

A man with leprosy

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 1:40–45 and Luke 5:12–16.

8:3a

Jesus reached out His hand and touched the man.

- Jesus reached out, touched the man
- Jesus touched the man

Jesus reached out His hand and touched the man: It is significant that Jesus touched this man. Jews were very careful not to touch someone with this kind of disease because that would make them unclean as well. Sometimes, Jesus healed someone with words only. But here he not only used words, he deliberately touched the unclean man. By doing this, he showed that he had power over these types of diseases.

In some languages, it will be good to include a footnote with some of this information.

This clause means that Jesus extended his arm and touched him with his hand. In some languages, it may not be necessary to translate His hand in this clause. This is because this phrase may already be implied in the verb for reached out. It may not even be necessary

to translate reached out. It may be implied in the verb for touched. For example:

Jesus reached out and touched him (NLT)

Jesus put his hand on the man (CEV)

8:3b

“I am willing,” He said. “Be clean!”

- and said, “I want to. Become well!”
- and said, “I want to do it. I heal you!”

I am willing: The phrase I am willing means that Jesus was willing to heal the man. In some languages it is more natural or clear to include the implied information. For example:

I am willing to do as you ask.

I do want to heal you.

Be clean!: The command Be clean! indicates that Jesus healed the man. In some languages it may not be natural to use a command to express this idea. It may be necessary to indicate that Jesus himself was doing these actions. For example:

I heal you.

I cure you of your leprosy.

Now you are well. (CEV)

8:3c

And immediately his leprosy was cleansed.

- Instantly his leprosy was cured.
- And at once he/Jesus healed his terrible skin disease.

immediately: The Greek word that the BSB translates as immediately introduces what happened when Jesus spoke to the man. As soon as Jesus spoke, the man was healed.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

At once (GNT)

At that very moment

instantly (NLT)

his leprosy was cleansed: As in 8:2b and 8:3b, the verb translated cleansed means “cured” or “healed.”

This clause is passive. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

he was cured of his leprosy (NIV)

the man was healed of his disease (GNT)

- Use an active verb. For example:

Jesus healed him

- Use another type of verb. For example:

He was/became well

Matthew 8:4

Section 8:1–4: Jesus healed a man who had leprosy

In this section, Jesus showed his authority by healing a man who had a skin disease called leprosy. Jewish law declared that any person with leprosy was “ritually unclean.” Anyone who touched a person who had leprosy also became unclean. But when Jesus touched the man who had leprosy, Jesus did not become unclean. Instead, he healed the man who had leprosy.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus heals a leper

A man with leprosy

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 1:40–45 and Luke 5:12–16.

8:4a

Then Jesus instructed him, “See that you don’t tell anyone.”

- Then Jesus said to him, “Make sure that you do not tell anyone.
- Then Jesus told him, “Do not tell anyone what has happened.

See that you don’t tell anyone: The Greek word that the BSB literally translates as See that is a command that emphasizes Jesus’ warning to the man. Jesus was

not telling the man to look at something. This command warned the man not to tell people that Jesus healed him from leprosy.

Here are some other ways to translate this command:

Listen! Don’t tell anyone (GNT)

Don’t tell anyone about this! (GW)

Do not say to anyone that I healed you.

Jesus knew that the Jews were looking for a type of “messiah” who would free them from Rome. He did not want the crowds to hear about the miracle and begin to wrongly think that he was that type of “messiah.”

8:4b

But go, show yourself to the priest

- Instead, go and show your healed body to the priest,
- But go and show yourself to the priest so he can see that you are healed.
- But rather, go to the priest and let him examine you so he can see that your skin is healed/cured.

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But indicates a contrast. The contrast is between what the man should not do and what he should do.

Here are some other ways to translate this contrast:

Instead (GW)

But rather

go, show yourself to the priest: This clause is Jesus’ second command to the man. In this command, Jesus told the man to do what the Law of Moses commanded. According to Leviticus 14, a person healed of a skin disease must show himself to the priest. The priest would examine him to see whether his skin had really been healed. If he was healed, the priest would publicly declare him to be ritually “clean.”

In some languages, it may be necessary to make some of this information explicit. For example:

go, show yourself to the priest so that he can see that you have been healed

go and show the priest that you have been healed

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

go straight to the priest and let him examine you
(GNT)

go to the priest and let him examine you so he
can see you are cured

priest: The word priest refers to a Jewish man who offered sacrifices to God on behalf of the people. A priest also performed other rituals for the people.

Here are some other ways to translate priest:

- Use a descriptive term that focuses on the function of priests. For example:

a sacrificer

a man who offers sacrifices to God

a man who represents people to God

- Use a local word for priests. This option may be acceptable if the duties of local priests are similar to those of Jewish priests. You may need to indicate that the word refers to Jewish priests. For example:

Jewish people's priest/sacrificer

If possible, you should choose a term that can be used in both Old Testament and New Testament contexts.

See how you translated priest in the phrase "chief priests" 2:4. See also priest in the Glossary for more information.

8:4c

and offer the gift prescribed by Moses,

- and give the offering that Moses commanded
- And then make/do the sacrifice that the Law of Moses ordered.

and offer the gift prescribed by Moses: The Greek word that the BSB translates as offer means "bring, present." It indicates that the man was to give the gift to the priest who then offered it as a sacrifice to God.

In some languages, these types of "gifts" are called "sacrifices" or "offerings." And in some languages, the clause offer the gift would be "make a sacrifice" or "give an offering" or some other term.

Here are some other ways to translate this in English:

offer the sacrifice that Moses ordered (GNT)

present the offering that Moses commanded
(NASB)

Take along the offering required in the law of
Moses for those who have been healed of leprosy.
(NLT)

You should use a term that is natural in your language.

gift: According to Leviticus 14:10, the man was required to offer three lambs, some flour and oil. If he was poor, he could give one lamb, two doves, some flour and oil (Leviticus 14:21-22). The singular word gift refers to all those items as a group.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

sacrifice(s)

offering(s)

what Moses said you must present

all that Moses ordered you to give

8:4d

as a testimony to them."

- which will be evidence to the people."
- That will prove/show to everyone that you are cured."

as a testimony to them: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as as a testimony to them means "to prove to the priests/people that you are healed." After the priest had declared the man to be clean/well, and after he had offered his sacrifices, people would know and accept that he was healed and ritually clean. Then he could participate in public worship and live with his family again.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

to prove to everyone that you are cured (GNT)

and everyone will know that you have been healed
(CEV)

Matthew 8:5

Section 8:5-13: Jesus healed a Roman army officer's servant

This section tells the story of a Roman officer who had greater faith than many Jews. This Gentile officer

believed that Jesus had the power to heal his servant, even from a distance. Matthew used this story to show Jesus' power. He also used this story to show that believing Gentiles would also be in the kingdom of God.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The faith of a centurion

A believing Roman army officer

A Roman officer shows he believes strongly in Jesus' power

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 7:1-10.

8:5a

When Jesus had entered Capernaum,

- ¶ Then Jesus entered Capernaum,
- ¶ After Jesus entered the town of Capernaum,

When Jesus had entered: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Jesus is literally "he." The pronoun "he" refers to Jesus. Since this is the beginning of a new section, you may want to make this explicit, as the BSB does.

Capernaum: The word Capernaum refers to a town near the Lake of Galilee. In some languages, it may be good to make it explicit that Capernaum was a town. For example:

the town of Capernaum (CEV)

8:5b

a centurion came and pleaded with Him,

- and a Roman army officer/captain came and asked him to help.
- a leader of soldiers approached him and pleaded for his help.

centurion: A centurion was a Roman army officer. He was the leader of about one hundred soldiers. The word centurion literally means "leader of one hundred."

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

- Translate the literal meaning of the Greek word. For example:

officer/leader of one hundred soldiers

- Use a word for such an officer in the army in your country. For example:

captain

- Use a general word or phrase for an officer or commander. For example:

soldier leader

great/big soldier

soldier who commands others

You may also need to supply the information that this was a Roman officer. This is implied by the word centurion, which was used only by the Roman army. He was not a Jew leading Jewish soldiers. For example:

a Roman captain

a leader of Roman soldiers

came:

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

came to him (NIV)

met him (GNT)

approached him

pleaded with Him: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as pleaded with Him also means "begging him."

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

pleaded (NJB)

beg him for help (GW)

strongly asked him to help him

Matthew 8:6

Section 8:5–13: Jesus healed a Roman army officer's servant

This section tells the story of a Roman officer who had greater faith than many Jews. This Gentile officer believed that Jesus had the power to heal his servant, even from a distance. Matthew used this story to show Jesus' power. He also used this story to show that believing Gentiles would also be in the kingdom of God.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The faith of a centurion

A believing Roman army officer

A Roman officer shows he believes strongly in Jesus' power

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 7:1–10.

8:6a–b

Lord, my servant lies at home, paralyzed and in terrible agony: As in 8:2b, this statement was a polite way for the centurion to ask Jesus to help him. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this request explicit. For example:

Lord, my servant lies at home, paralyzed and in terrible agony. Please do something for him.

In other languages, the verb for “pleaded” in 8:5b will be enough to show that the centurion was asking Jesus for help.

8:6a

“Lord, my servant lies at home, paralyzed

- He said, “Lord, my servant is lying down at the house. He is paralyzed
- He said, “Sir, I have a servant boy who is very sick. He is at my house in bed and cannot move his body.

Lord: You should translate the word Lord here as you did in 8:2b.

my servant: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as my servant literally means “my male child.” In this context, the phrase probably indicates that the servant was not yet an adult and that the centurion liked him.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

my well-liked servant

my young servant (NLT)

lies: The Greek word that the BSB translates as lies indicates how sick the servant was. He did not just have a type of paralysis where he could sit. He was sick enough that he had to lie down. You should use an expression in your language that indicates this.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

lies in bed (NLT)

is sick in bed (GNT)

at home: The phrase at home refers to the home of the centurion. It does not refer to the servant's home. The servant probably lived at the home of the centurion. The servant may have had a room, but he probably did not have his own house. So if you need to specify whose home it was, you should say:

at my home/house

paralyzed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as paralyzed means that the servant was not able to move all or part of his body.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

He can't move his body (NCV)

he can't even move (CEV)

8:6b

and in terrible agony.”

- and is suffering severely.”
- He is in much/extreme pain. Please heal him.”

in terrible agony: This phrase indicates that the servant's condition caused him much pain and suffering.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

suffering much

is in much pain (NCV)

his condition is very serious

Matthew 8:7

Section 8:5–13: Jesus healed a Roman army officer's servant

This section tells the story of a Roman officer who had greater faith than many Jews. This Gentile officer believed that Jesus had the power to heal his servant, even from a distance. Matthew used this story to show Jesus' power. He also used this story to show that believing Gentiles would also be in the kingdom of God.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The faith of a centurion

A believing Roman army officer

A Roman officer shows he believes strongly in Jesus' power

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 7:1–10.

8:7

“I will go and heal him,” Jesus replied.

- Jesus said to him, “I will come/go and heal/cure him.”
- So Jesus replied, “I will go and make him well.”

I will go and heal him: Because Jesus offered to travel to the house of the centurion, it may be more natural to translate the verb go as “come.” Also, in some languages, it will be more natural to translate the verb heal as “make well.” For example:

I will go/come and make him well.

Jesus replied: This Greek phrase is literally “he said.” In some languages, it may be necessary to say to whom Jesus spoke. For example:

And he said to him. (ESV)

However, the context makes it clear that Jesus spoke to the centurion. Since the centurion is the only other person recently mentioned, it may be more natural in some languages to leave the phrase “to him” untranslated.

Since Jesus responded to the words of the centurion, it may be more natural in some languages to use replied

or “answered” instead of “said,” as the BSB does. For example:

Jesus answered

Matthew 8:8

Section 8:5–13: Jesus healed a Roman army officer's servant

This section tells the story of a Roman officer who had greater faith than many Jews. This Gentile officer believed that Jesus had the power to heal his servant, even from a distance. Matthew used this story to show Jesus' power. He also used this story to show that believing Gentiles would also be in the kingdom of God.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The faith of a centurion

A believing Roman army officer

A Roman officer shows he believes strongly in Jesus' power

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 7:1–10.

8:8a

The centurion answered,

- But the Roman army officer/captain said,
- Then the leader of soldiers said to Jesus,

In Greek this verse begins with the conjunction that is often translated as “but” or “and.” Here the Greek conjunction indicates a contrast. The contrast is between Jesus saying that he will go and the centurion saying that Jesus did not need to go. Some English versions, such as the BSB, do not begin this verse with a conjunction.

Here are some ways to begin this verse:

But (ESV)

Then (NLT96)

8:8b

“Lord, I am not worthy to have You come under my roof.

- “Lord, I am not worthy for you to come into my house.
- “Sir, I am not good/important enough for you come into my house. So please, do not bother yourself.

Lord, I am not worthy to have You come under my roof: This sentence is a polite way for the centurion to tell Jesus that he did not want Jesus to bother himself to go and enter his house. It does not mean “You are very kind to enter the house of someone who is so unworthy.” In some languages, it may be necessary to make this more explicit. For example:

Sir, please do not bother yourself. I am not worthy....

Sir, it is all right if you do not go. I am not worthy....

Lord, I am not worthy.... So please, it would be better if you did not come.

“Oh no, sir,”...“I do not deserve....” (GNT)

I am not worthy: The clause I am not worthy indicates that the centurion believed that he did not deserve a visit from Jesus. He knew that Jews did not enter the houses of Gentiles like himself. He also realized that God had given Jesus authority that was greater than his own.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

I’m not good enough (CEV)

I am not important/big enough

under my roof: The phrase under my roof is a figure of speech that means “in my house.” For example:

into my home (NLT)

8:8c

But just say the word, and my servant will be healed.

- But just say the/one word, and my servant will be healed.
- Please if you only say the word “be healed”, he will become well.

But: There is a contrast between 8:8b and 8:8c. The contrast is between what the centurion thought that Jesus should not do, and what he should do. In Greek,

this contrast is indicated with a conjunction that English versions translate as But.

just say the word, and my servant will be healed:

The clause just say the word indicates that the centurion believed that Jesus only had to say “your servant is healed” and his servant would become well. The officer knew that Jesus did not have to be present at his house in order to heal the servant. Jesus could heal him from a distance with a spoken word.

In some languages, it may be helpful to make explicit what kind of word this was. For example:

Speak/say the words “be healed” and my servant will be healed

Just give the order, and my servant will get well. (GNT)

The clause say the word is a polite request. The centurion was politely asking Jesus to heal his servant. He was not ordering Jesus to do something. Use a sentence form that can be used as a polite request in your language. For example:

Please just say the words “be healed” and my servant will be healed.

I believe that if you would kindly say, “he is cured”, he would be cured.

Matthew 8:9

Section 8:5–13: Jesus healed a Roman army officer’s servant

This section tells the story of a Roman officer who had greater faith than many Jews. This Gentile officer believed that Jesus had the power to heal his servant, even from a distance. Matthew used this story to show Jesus’ power. He also used this story to show that believing Gentiles would also be in the kingdom of God.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The faith of a centurion

A believing Roman army officer

A Roman officer shows he believes strongly in Jesus’ power

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 7:1-10.

8:9

In 8:9, the words of the centurion show that he understood authority. He understood that when someone in authority gives a command, that command is obeyed. This implies that he recognized Jesus' authority and believed that Jesus had the power to heal his servant, even from a distance. As 8:10 says, Jesus was amazed at the centurion's faith.

Be careful that your translation of this verse does not imply that the centurion was ordering Jesus to heal his servant.

If people in your area will not understand the correct meaning of these words, you may want to add a footnote to explain. Here is a sample footnote:

In saying this, the centurion indicated that he believed that Jesus had the authority and power to heal by simply commanding it.

8:9a

For I myself am a man under authority,

- I also am under the authority of my higher officers,
- I know this because I have leaders who give me orders,

For: In this context, the Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *For* introduces an explanation for the centurion saying "just say the word" (in 8:8c). In this verse, the centurion explained that he knew that someone with authority could give a command, and the command would be obeyed. This implies that he recognized that Jesus had authority, and he believed that Jesus could heal his servant with a command.

Here are some ways to begin this verse:

- With a conjunction or introductory phrase that introduces the explanation. For example:

I know this because (NLT)

- Without any conjunction. For example:

I, too, am a man under the authority of superior officers (GNT)

I myself am a man under authority: The phrase a man under authority means "a man who is placed under the authority of others." A centurion in the Roman army was an officer, but he was not the highest

officer. There were senior officers who had authority over him. In some languages, it may be necessary to make some of this explicit. For example:

I am under the authority of my superior officers (NLT)

I have officers who give orders to me (CEV)

I myself: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *myself* probably has the sense of "also" here. The centurion used this word to compare himself to Jesus. Both had the authority to give commands.

It is perhaps going too far to say that the centurion was saying that Jesus is under authority like he was under authority. "...the point of comparison is in the issuing of effective commands, not in the respective hierarchical status of Jesus and this (subordinate) officer. There is in any case no problem in the recognition of Jesus as a "man" (which he was!), and if the centurion was sufficiently well informed to understand that Jesus was operating under the authority of the God of Israel as he himself was operating under the authority of his military superiors, Matthew would have no problem with this. But this pericope is not about defining Jesus' christological status, but about the recognition of his unquestioned authority." (France, p. 315) In most of this verse, the centurion spoke of his authority to give commands, not receive them. So he was comparing his authority to give commands with Jesus' authority. It is perhaps because of this difficulty that some English versions do not translate the word *myself*.

under authority: The phrase under authority refers to the centurion submitting to officers of higher rank than him. Greek and English use the words "under" and "over" to describe differing levels of authority. Other languages may use different words to describe this relationship such as "in front" and "behind." Translate this in a way that is natural in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

I must obey people with higher authority

I must do what people with greater power tell me

8:9b

with soldiers under me.

- and I have soldiers under my authority.
- and I also give orders to my soldiers.

with soldiers under me: This phrase means that the centurion had authority to command the soldiers that he led. He implied that, in the same way, he believed that Jesus had authority to heal people.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

I also have soldiers who must obey me

And I give orders to soldiers who are under me

8:9c

I tell one to go, and he goes;

- I say to one soldier, ‘Go,’ and he goes,
- If I tell one soldier to go somewhere, he will go there,

8:9d

and another to come, and he comes.

- and I say to another soldier, ‘Come,’ and he comes.
- and if I tell/call another soldier to come here, he will come.

8:9c–d

I tell one to go, and he goes; and another to come, and he comes: The phrases one and another refer generally to any of the soldiers under the centurion’s authority.

Here is another way to translate this:

I tell one soldier ‘Go’ and he goes; and I tell another soldier ‘come’ and he comes

I tell one to go: Here the command go means that the centurion was giving the soldier an order to “go somewhere” or to “go do something.” It does not mean that the centurion was chasing away the soldier. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this more explicit. For example:

I send one soldier saying, “Go over there.”

8:9e

I tell my servant to do something, and he does it.”

- And I say to my servant, ‘Do this,’ and he does it.”
- And if I tell my slave to do something, he will do it.”

my servant: The Greek word that the BSB translates as servant here is not the same Greek word as “servant” in verse 8:6a. Here the Greek word refers generally to any servant or slave. The Roman centurion also commanded his servants or slaves and they obeyed him.

Some English versions translate these two words differently. For example, the GNT translates this word as “slave.”

Use an expression that refers generally to any servant of the centurion. For example:

one of my servants

anyone who serves me

my slave (GNT)

General Comment on 8:9c–e

In the Greek, the words “go,” “come,” and “Do something” are direct speech. For example:

And I say to the one, ‘Go,’ and he goes, and to another, ‘Come,’ and he comes, and to my servant, ‘Do this,’ and he does it. (ESV)

However, in some languages, it may be more natural to translate these commands as indirect speech, as the BSB models.

Matthew 8:10

Section 8:5–13: Jesus healed a Roman army officer’s servant

This section tells the story of a Roman officer who had greater faith than many Jews. This Gentile officer believed that Jesus had the power to heal his servant, even from a distance. Matthew used this story to show Jesus’ power. He also used this story to show that believing Gentiles would also be in the kingdom of God.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The faith of a centurion

A believing Roman army officer

A Roman officer shows he believes strongly in Jesus’ power

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 7:1–10.

8:10a

When Jesus heard this, He marveled

- ¶ When Jesus heard him say this, he was amazed
- ¶ Jesus was astonished upon hearing those words.

He marveled: The Greek word that the BSB translates as marveled implies that Jesus was surprised but pleased. It pleased Jesus that the centurion recognized his authority and had such great faith in him. Do not use a word that means to be amazed about something bad or displeasing.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

was pleasantly surprised

was amazed and pleased

was impressed

8:10b

and said to those following Him,

- and said to the people following him,
- He said to the crowd who followed him,

those following Him: This clause probably includes Jesus' disciples and other people. Wherever Jesus went, crowds followed him.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

the crowd following him (CEV)

8:10c

“Truly I tell you,

- “I assure you^(plur) that
- “I can guarantee this truth:

Truly I tell you: Jesus often used the words that the BSB translates as Truly I tell you to introduce a statement that he wanted to emphasize. When he began a statement with these words, he was asking people to listen with extra attention.

Here are some other ways to introduce this:

I assure you (NLT96)

Listen to this:

Let me tell you this:

If you have another way in your language to emphasize a statement or to alert people to listen with special attention, consider using it here.

This same Greek phrase first occurs in 5:18a. You should translate it here as you did there.

8:10d

I have not found anyone in Israel with such great faith.

- I have not seen anyone in the land of Israel who has faith as great/big as his faith.
- Among the Israelites/Jews, I have not met one person who believes as strongly in me as he!

I have not found anyone in Israel with such great faith:

This sentence means that Jesus had not seen any Israelite/Jew who believed in him as much as this Roman soldier did. This indicates that this Gentile had more faith than any Jew.

In this context, the word found means that this was the first time that Jesus met someone with such great faith. The word found does not imply that he was searching in some way.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

I haven't seen faith like this in all the land of Israel! (NLT96)

I have not seen/met anyone in Israel who has as much faith as this man.

Even among the Jews, I have not met a person who believes as strongly in me as this person

anyone in Israel: This phrase means “any person living in the land of Israel.” In other words, it refers to the Jews.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

anyone among the people of Israel

a Jew

such great faith: In this context, the words such great faith means “a strong and sincere faith/belief.” The centurion strongly believed that Jesus was able to heal his servant.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

faith as great as this (GW)

believes so strongly in me

has such confidence/trust in me

Matthew 8:11

Section 8:5–13: Jesus healed a Roman army officer's servant

This section tells the story of a Roman officer who had greater faith than many Jews. This Gentile officer believed that Jesus had the power to heal his servant, even from a distance. Matthew used this story to show Jesus' power. He also used this story to show that believing Gentiles would also be in the kingdom of God.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The faith of a centurion

A believing Roman army officer

A Roman officer shows he believes strongly in Jesus' power

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 7:1–10.

8:11–12

Many Jews believed that when the messiah came, he would establish a kingdom where there would be happiness and rest. They believed that one example of this happiness was a big feast. At that feast, they (the Jews) would have the privilege of celebrating with their important ancestors: Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. All other people (the Gentiles) would be outside in the dark.

Jesus shocked the Jews by telling them that:

1. The people at the feast will be those who believe. This will include Gentiles.
2. Many Jews will be the ones outside in the dark.

In some languages, it will be necessary to indicate that 8:11–12 refers to events in the future. Some ways to indicate this are:

I tell you, one day, many will come...

I tell you, in the future, many will come

8:11a

I say to you that many will come from the east and the west

- I tell you^(plur) that many people will come from countries to the east and the west of Israel.
- I tell you that, in the future, many people who are not Israelites/Jews will arrive from all over the world.

I say to you: The words I say to you emphasize the following words. But this expression is less strong than “Truly, I tell you” (8:10c).

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I tell you (ESV)

Think about this

Listen

many will come from the east and the west: This clause refers to people who live to the east and west of the land of Israel. They are not from Israel. In other words, they are not Jews. They are Gentiles who have faith like the centurion. It may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

many people who are not Jews will come from east and west of Israel

many Gentiles will come from all over the world—from east and west (NLT)

many...from the east and the west: This phrase refers to Gentiles from all areas of the world. In some languages, a literal translation of the east and the west would only refer to two locations. If that is true in your language, you may want to make it clearer. For example:

many Gentiles...from all over the world (NLT96)

Many people...from everywhere (CEV)

8:11b

to share the banquet with Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob

- They will sit and eat with Abraham, Isaac and Jacob
- They will sit and eat at the feast with our great ancestors Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob

to share the banquet: In Greek this clause is literally “and will recline.” Some English versions translate this clause literally. For example:

and recline at table (ESV)

The word “recline” refers to the customary position for eating at that time. Jesus used this clause to refer to the future feast that the Jews were hoping for (described above). The position for eating was to lie on one’s side with the elbow propped to raise the shoulders and head.

The exact position while eating is not important here. What is important is that people understand that this clause refers to eating at the great feast in the kingdom of heaven.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

will...sit down...at the feast (GNT)

will sit and eat (NCV)

Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob: These three men were the first ancestors of the Jews. God gave his promises to them. The Jews expected them to be in heaven. In some languages people are not familiar with whom Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob are. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Include some implied information. For example:

our ^(incl) ancestors Abraham, Isaac and Jacob

- Explain in a footnote. An example footnote is:

These three men were the first ancestors of the Jews. God gave his promises to them. The Jews expected them to be in heaven.

8:11c

in the kingdom of heaven.

- in the kingdom of the one who lives in heaven.
- in the kingdom where God rules.

the kingdom of heaven: When translating the phrase the kingdom of heaven, there are two issues to consider:

Issue 1: The meaning of heaven

In the phrase the kingdom of heaven, the word heaven is a figure of speech called metonymy. In this figure of speech, heaven refers to God, but it refers to him indirectly by naming the place where he lives and rules. The Jews considered God’s name to be so holy that they hesitated to say it. So instead of pronouncing God’s name directly, they often used the name of

the place where he lives and rules. Because Matthew was writing primarily to Jews, he often used the word heaven to refer to God.

Therefore, the kingdom of heaven means the same thing as “the kingdom of God.” The phrase the kingdom of heaven only occurs in the book of Matthew. The expression “the kingdom of God” is found in all other books, and it even occurs five times in Matthew.

Here are some other ways to translate heaven in this context:

- Make some information explicit. For example:

the one/Lord who lives in heaven

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

God

Issue 2: The meaning of the kingdom of heaven

Both the kingdom of heaven and “the kingdom of God” refer to God’s activity of ruling over his people. God’s rule is not simply giving orders or commands to people. It also includes his protection, care, and blessing for them. God leads, protects, and cares for his people. They obey, trust, and submit to him as their king. The phrase kingdom of heaven does not refer to a land or country that God rules over.

Here are some other ways to translate the kingdom of heaven:

- As a noun. For example:

the kingdom/rule of the one who lives in heaven

the kingdom of God

God’s kingship

God’s rule over people

- As a verbal expression. For example:

God rules his people

God cares for his people as king

This phrase also occurs in 5:19c. See also kingdom of heaven in the Glossary for more information.

Matthew 8:12

Section 8:5–13: Jesus healed a Roman army officer's servant

This section tells the story of a Roman officer who had greater faith than many Jews. This Gentile officer believed that Jesus had the power to heal his servant, even from a distance. Matthew used this story to show Jesus' power. He also used this story to show that believing Gentiles would also be in the kingdom of God.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The faith of a centurion

A believing Roman army officer

A Roman officer shows he believes strongly in Jesus' power

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 7:1–10.

8:12a

But the sons of the kingdom

- But those who are supposed to belong to this kingdom
- However, many of the people of Israel for whom the kingdom was prepared,

But: There is a contrast between 8:11 and 8:12. The contrast is between those who eat in the kingdom, and those who are cast out. The BSB and many English versions begin this verse with the conjunction But, which indicates this contrast.

the sons of the kingdom: The phrase the sons of the kingdom is an idiom. It refers to the people who belong to/in the kingdom of God. These people are the Jews. They are the people whom God first chose to rule. They are the ones who were supposed to be citizens in the kingdom of God. They were destined to be in the kingdom. But they did not believe in Christ, so they will not be in the kingdom.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

those who should have belonged to the kingdom (JBP)

those for whom the Kingdom was prepared (NLT)

the ones who should have been in the kingdom (CEV)

many of the Jews who are supposed to be citizens of the kingdom of God

8:12b

will be thrown into the outer darkness,

- will be thrown outside into the darkness.
- God will throw them out of the kingdom and into the most dark place!

will be thrown into the outer darkness: This clause is passive.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

will be thrown out into the dark (CEV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

God will throw them out of the kingdom and into the darkness

into the outer darkness: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the outer darkness refers to the place that is outside the kingdom and far away from its light. The Jews considered this dark place to be hell.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

out into the darkness (GNT)

into the dark (CEV)

into the dark far away from God

General Comment on 8:12a–b

Verse 8:12a–b contains a hyperbole. Not all Jews will be outside the kingdom. Some Jews believe in Christ and will be citizens of the kingdom. One way to make this clear is to add some information. For example:

But many of the people of Israel who should have been in the kingdom will be thrown into the outer darkness.

8:12c

where there will be weeping and gnashing of teeth.”

- There they will wail and grind their teeth!”
- There they will cry loudly and clench their teeth in pain and anger!”

where there will be weeping: The Greek word that the BSB translates as weeping refers to the loud sound that people make when they have much grief and sorrow. It is not a quiet sobbing.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

where there will be wailing (REB)

People will cry (GW)

and gnashing of teeth: The phrase gnashing of teeth refers to grinding of teeth because of pain, anger, and bitterness. In hell, people will be in pain. They will also be angry at what happened to them.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

- Use an expression in your language that describes what people do with their teeth when they are in pain and are also angry. For example:

grind teeth

clench teeth

- Add some information. For example:

they will grind their teeth in pain and anger

- Translate the meaning of the action. For example:

and be in extreme pain there (GW)

Matthew 8:13**Section 8:5–13: Jesus healed a Roman army officer’s servant**

This section tells the story of a Roman officer who had greater faith than many Jews. This Gentile officer believed that Jesus had the power to heal his servant, even from a distance. Matthew used this story to show Jesus’ power. He also used this story to show that believing Gentiles would also be in the kingdom of God.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The faith of a centurion

A believing Roman army officer

A Roman officer shows he believes strongly in Jesus’ power

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 7:1–10.

8:13a

Then Jesus said to the centurion,

- ¶ Then Jesus said to the Roman army officer/captain,
- ¶ Then Jesus said to the leader of soldiers,

8:13b

“Go! As you have believed, so will it be done for you.”

- “Go. The healing of your servant is done for you just like you believed!”
- “Go home. Your servant is healed just as/like you believed he would be healed.”
- “You may go home. I heal your servant because you believed.”

8:13a–b

Then Jesus said to the centurion, “Go!: The word Go is a polite command to the centurion. Your translation should not imply that Jesus rebuked the centurion or chased him away.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Go home (GNT)

Go back home. (NLT)

You may go home now. (CEV)

As you have believed: These words mean that Jesus healed the centurion’s servant just like the centurion believed he would heal him. The centurion believed that Jesus could heal his servant with a command, and that’s what Jesus did.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

just as you believed he would (NCV)

just like you believed

It is also possible to translate this clause as the reason for the healing. For example:

Because you believed (NLT)

so will it be done for you: By pronouncing these words, Jesus did a miracle and healed the centurion's servant. This type of statement is similar to "let there be light" in Genesis. When God or Jesus pronounced words like this, the thing happened.

This statement is more than just a wish or a blessing. It is a command that the servant be healed. In 8:3b, Jesus healed the leper by saying "Be clean." Here he also healed a man by simply speaking words.

Here the word it refers to the centurion's request that Jesus heal his servant.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Let/May it happen to/for you

Your request for your servant to be healed is done for you

Your servant is healed

I heal your servant

Some English versions use the future tense here. For example:

It will be done (NIV)

However, these words are not a prediction that the centurion's servant would be healed sometime in the future. As soon as Jesus said these words, the servant was healed. Be careful to choose a tense that implies an immediate healing.

8:13c

And his servant was healed at that very hour.

- And his servant was healed immediately!
- And his servant became well at that exact moment!

And his servant was healed: The clause is passive.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

the servant was cured (NJB)

- Use an active verb. For example:

Jesus healed the servant

at that very hour: This expression means "immediately."

Here are some other ways to translate this:

at that same exact time

right then (CEV)

immediately

Matthew 8:14

Section 8:14–17: Jesus healed many people

In this section Jesus healed people and forced demons to leave people. These miracles showed Jesus' power. They also fulfilled a prophecy of Isaiah about the Christ.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus healed Peter's mother-in-law and many others

Jesus Heals Many at Peter's House (NRSV)

Jesus fulfilled prophecy by healing many people

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 1:29–31 and Luke 4:38–39.

8:14a

When Jesus arrived at Peter's house,

- ¶ Later, Jesus went into Peter's house,
- ¶ Then Jesus went to Peter's house. When he entered,

When Jesus arrived at Peter's house: Peter's house was in the town of Capernaum. Capernaum was also the town where Jesus was when he healed the centurion's servant. So this story takes place in the same town, and it takes place sometime after the previous section. The Greek does not indicate how much time passed between these two stories.

Here are some other ways to begin this new section:

Later, Jesus entered into Peter's house

Then Jesus went to Peter's house. When he entered...

8:14b

He saw Peter's mother-in-law sick in bed with a fever.

- and he saw that Peter's mother-in-law had a fever and was lying down.
- he found that the mother of Peter's wife was sick and lying in bed because she had a fever.

He saw Peter's mother-in-law: The pronoun He refers to Jesus. The term mother-in-law refers to the mother of Peter's wife.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he saw Peter's mother-in-law

Jesus found the mother of Peter's wife

sick in bed with a fever: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as sick in bed with a fever is more literally "lying and having a fever." To have a fever means that the body is hotter than normal. The fact that the woman was lying down indicates how serious the fever was. The BSB has added the word sick to make the meaning more clear.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

lying down, sick with a fever (NET)

sick and lying down because she had a fever

Matthew 8:15

Section 8:14–17: Jesus healed many people

In this section Jesus healed people and forced demons to leave people. These miracles showed Jesus' power. They also fulfilled a prophecy of Isaiah about the Christ.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus healed Peter's mother-in-law and many others

Jesus Heals Many at Peter's House (NRSV)

Jesus fulfilled prophecy by healing many people

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 1:29–31 and Luke 4:38–39.

8:15a

So He touched her hand, and the fever left her,

- He touched her hand, and the fever ended.
- Jesus touched/took her hand, and she became well.

So He touched her hand, and the fever left her: This sentence indicates that when Jesus touched the hand of Peter's mother-in-law, she was miraculously healed. The clause the fever left her means that the sickness was gone and the woman's body cooled and became normal again.

Here are some other ways to translate this sentence:

Jesus touched her hand, and the fever went away (GW)

He touched her hand, and the fever ended/finished.

He touched her hand and immediately she became well.

8:15b

and she got up and began to serve them.

- Then she got up and took care of them.
- Then she got up and gave them something to eat.

she got up and began to serve them: The phrase began to serve them means that the woman started to take care of Jesus' and the others' needs. This probably means that she began to serve food.

However, you should not say that she cooked a meal for Jesus. According to the parallel passages in Mark and Luke, Jesus healed this woman on the Sabbath. On that day, it was forbidden for women to cook. She gave him food that had already been prepared.

Here are some other ways to translate this sentence:

Then she got up and began to take care of Jesus.

Then she got up and served Jesus a meal. (CEV)

Matthew 8:16

Section 8:14–17: Jesus healed many people

In this section Jesus healed people and forced demons to leave people. These miracles showed Jesus' power.

They also fulfilled a prophecy of Isaiah about the Christ.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus healed Peter's mother-in-law and many others

Jesus Heals Many at Peter's House (NRSV)

Jesus fulfilled prophecy by healing many people

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 1:29–31 and Luke 4:38–39.

8:16a

When evening came, many who were demon-possessed were brought to Jesus,

- ¶ That evening, people brought to him many people whom evil spirits controlled.
- ¶ After sunset, people brought many demon-possessed people to Jesus.

When evening came: The word evening refers to sundown or perhaps an hour or two after the sun had gone down. The people waited until then because the Sabbath was over at sundown. After sundown, they were permitted to do the work of carrying sick people to Jesus.

many who were demon-possessed were brought to Jesus: The clause many who were demon-possessed refers to people who were controlled by demons. Demons controlled the thoughts and actions of these people.

Languages have different ways to refer to possession by demons or evil spirits.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

many people with demons in them (CEV)

people controlled by demons

people on whom evil spirits had fastened

This clause also occurs in 4:24d. You should translate it here as you did there.

demon-possessed: The word demon-possessed refers to spirit beings who were once angels, but who rebelled against God. Demons are also referred to as “evil spirits.” Demons are not spirits of dead people.

Some ways to translate “demons” are:

- Use a general term in your language that refers to spirits that are evil and can control people. For example:

demons

devils

- Use a specific term in your language that refers to a certain type of spirit. Do not use a term that refers to the spirit of a dead person.
- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

evil/bad spirits

See demon in the Glossary for more information.

8:16b

and He drove out the spirits with a word

- He spoke a word and caused the evil spirits to leave.
- He commanded the demons to leave, and they did/left.

8:16c

and healed all the sick.

- And he healed all the people who were sick.
- Everyone who was sick, he made them well.

8:16b–c

He drove out the spirits: The clause He drove out the spirits means that Jesus caused the evil spirits to leave people and stop controlling them.

Different cultures have different ways of speaking about people being controlled by demons and being released from the control of demons. Use a natural expression for this in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

he sent the demons away

he freed people whom demons controlled

spirits: The word spirits refers to the demons (8:16a). You should use a word or expression that clearly refers back to the demons.

with a word: The phrase with a word indicates that Jesus simply spoke a few words. He was not like other people who tried to cast out demons at that time. They used many, long magical chants and techniques. Jesus simply commanded the demons to leave, and they left.

Here are some other ways to translate this entire clause:

Jesus spoke and the demons left them (NCV)

He forced the [evil] spirits out of people with a command (GW)

Matthew 8:17

Section 8:14–17: Jesus healed many people

In this section Jesus healed people and forced demons to leave people. These miracles showed Jesus' power. They also fulfilled a prophecy of Isaiah about the Christ.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus healed Peter's mother-in-law and many others

Jesus Heals Many at Peter's House (NRSV)

Jesus fulfilled prophecy by healing many people

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 1:29–31 and Luke 4:38–39.

8:17a

This was to fulfill what was spoken through the prophet Isaiah:

- All that/this occurred so that the words spoken through the prophet Isaiah would come true:
- This/That all happened to bring about what God said through his spokesman Isaiah long ago. He said,

This was to fulfill what was spoken through the prophet Isaiah: There are two ways to interpret the way that 8:17a is connected to 8:16b–c:

1. It is the purpose for which Jesus healed people. According to this interpretation, Jesus cast out demons and healed the sick so that scripture would be fulfilled. For example:

He did this to make come true what the prophet Isaiah had said (GNT) (BSB, NIV, GNT, ESV, KJV, NASB, REB, RSV, NCV)

1. It is the result of Jesus healing people. According to this interpretation, Jesus cast out demons and

healed the sick, and as a result scripture was fulfilled. For example:

So God's promise came true, just as the prophet Isaiah had said (CEV) (GW, CEV, NLT, JBP)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The Greek conjunction in this sentence clearly indicates purpose.

A similar clause occurs in 1:22. See how you translated that clause.

to fulfill: The word fulfill means "to make come true" or "to make happen as it was foretold/prophesied."

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

He did this to make come true what the prophet Isaiah had said (GNT)

He did these things to bring about what Isaiah the prophet had said (NCV)

what was spoken through the prophet Isaiah: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as through the prophet Isaiah can also be translated as "by the prophet Isaiah" (as also in the ESV). This phrase indicates that the following words did not come from Isaiah himself. They came from God through Isaiah. God spoke the following words to Isaiah, and Isaiah then spoke them to the people. Isaiah also wrote them down.

This is a passive clause. Some ways to translate it are:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

what was spoken through the prophet Isaiah (NIV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

the word of the Lord through the prophet Isaiah, who said (NLT)

what God spoke to the people through the prophet Isaiah

prophet: A prophet is a person who spoke on behalf of God. God spoke to the prophet Isaiah through words and visions. Then the prophet told God's message (the prophecy) to the people or wrote it down for their use.

See how you translated prophet in 1:22 and 4:14. See also prophet in the Glossary for further information.

8:17b

“He took on our infirmities and carried our diseases.”

- “He took away our^(incl) sicknesses and removed our diseases.”
- “He healed our diseases and made us well.” (CEV)
- “He removed all our sicknesses.”

Verse 8:17b is a quote from Isaiah 53:4. It is also a Hebrew form of poetry called a parallelism. In a parallelism, an idea is repeated.

In the example below, one parallel pair in 8:17b is underlined. The other parallel pair is made bold. Notice that the parts of each pair are similar in meaning.

He took on **our infirmities**

and carried **our diseases.**

In some languages, people will think that the parallel parts in 8:17b describe different events. In other words, they will think that “He took on our infirmities” and “carried our diseases” describe different events.

If that is true in your language, you should:

- Indicate that both expressions refer to the same thing. For example:

He took on our infirmities,

I repeat, he carried our diseases.

- Combine the parallel parts. For example:

He took on our infirmities and diseases.

He took away all our infirmities.

He took on our infirmities and carried our diseases:

Early Christians understood these words from Isaiah to refer to Jesus dealing with sin, sorrow and sickness when he died on the cross. The verb took on means that in some sense Jesus “took away” people’s sins and diseases, and he “took them on himself.” The verb carried is a synonym. He “carried away” or “removed” people’s sins and sicknesses, and he “carried/bore” them on himself on the cross. He paid for them and removed them when he died. In the passage from

Isaiah, the verbs took and carried seem to have only a spiritual sense.

However, Matthew applied this verse to Jesus healing people. The way Matthew applied this verse from Isaiah, the verb took means “took away” and the verb carried mean “removed” in the sense of “healed.” These verbs have a physical sense.

Here are some other ways to translate these verbs:

- Use verbs that refer only to the spiritual sense of “bearing” people’s sickness as found in Isaiah. For example:

He took our suffering on him and carried our diseases. (NCV)

- Find verbs that can be used in both a spiritual and physical sense. For example:

He himself took our sickness and carried away our diseases. (GNT)

- Use verbs that refer to the physical healing in the Matthew context. For example:

He healed our diseases and made us well. (CEV)

He: The pronoun He is emphasized in the Greek. Some English versions show this emphasis. For example:

He himself (NJB)

General Comment on 8:17b

Old Testament prophets sometimes used the past tense to speak a prophecy about an event that would happen in the future. The past tense views the event from God’s viewpoint after the event happened. Isaiah lived more than 600 years before Jesus. Isaiah spoke this prophecy that was fulfilled in 8:16–17. It may be more natural in your language to use something other than past tense here. For example:

He will take away our illnesses and will remove our diseases.

But to a reader of your translation, all these events are past. So using the past tense may be acceptable.

Matthew 8:18

Section 8:18–22: The cost of following Jesus

In this section two people told Jesus they wanted to follow him. He replied with two sayings that indicate that being his disciple is difficult.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

To follow Jesus is difficult/hard

Two people who wanted to follow Jesus

8:18a

When Jesus saw a large crowd around Him,

- ¶ When Jesus saw a crowd surrounding him,
- ¶ One day, Jesus saw that there were many people around him.

When: The story in this section probably did not happen on the same day as the story in the previous section.

Here are some other ways to begin this section:

One day

On another day

Another time

a large crowd: There is a textual issue here:

1. Some Greek manuscripts have a crowd. For example:

When Jesus saw the crowd around him (NIV) (NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, ESV, NLT, GW, CEV, REB, NCV)

1. Other Greek manuscripts have large crowds. For example:

Now when Jesus saw great crowds around him (RSV) (BSB, RSV, NET, KJV, NLT96, JBP)

It is recommended to follow option (1) and the majority of English versions.

Here is another way to translate this:

many people

8:18b

He gave orders to cross to the other side of the sea.

- he commanded his disciples to go across to the other side of the lake.
- So he told his disciples to get ready to cross Lake Galilee.

He gave orders: This clause means “he commanded.” It is implied that Jesus gave orders to his disciples.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he ordered his disciples (GNT)

he told his followers (NCV)

he instructed his disciples (NLT)

to cross to the other side of the sea: This clause means that Jesus ordered his disciples to go over to the other side of the Sea of Galilee.

The verb cross means “go across” a river or lake. The meaning of to the other side may be included in the meaning of the verb in your language. For example:

cross the lake Galilee

The disciples probably made a boat ready, but they did not cross the lake with Jesus until 8:23. Your translation should not indicate or imply that they crossed the lake in this verse.

General Comment on 8:18b

Verse 8:18b has indirect speech. Many languages can translate this as indirect speech. But it may be more natural in some languages to translate as direct speech. For example:

he told his disciples, “Let us go across to the other side of the lake.”

Matthew 8:19

Section 8:18–22: The cost of following Jesus

In this section two people told Jesus they wanted to follow him. He replied with two sayings that indicate that being his disciple is difficult.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

To follow Jesus is difficult/hard

Two people who wanted to follow Jesus

8:19a

And one of the scribes came to Him and said,

- Then a teacher of the law came to him and said,
- But before they left, a teacher of the law of Moses approached Jesus and said,

And: Before Jesus and his disciples got into the boat to go across the lake, two men came and spoke to him (8:19, 21). In this verse, you may want to indicate that Jesus and the disciples did not yet cross the lake. For example:

But before they left,

one of the scribes: The Greek word that the BSB translates as one of the scribes refers to a man who studied, interpreted, and taught the Law of Moses. Such men were called scribes because their original work was to copy the laws of Moses by hand. In New Testament times, this was no longer their main task.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

A teacher of the Law of Moses (CEV)

one of the teachers of religious law (NLT)

a teacher of the law (NIV)

an expert in the law

See how you translated this expression in 2:4a or 7:29b. See also scribe in the Glossary for more information.

8:19b

“Teacher, I will follow You wherever You go.”

- “Teacher, I will follow you everywhere you go.”
- “Teacher, I want to go with you as your disciple every place you go.”

Teacher: Here, the word Teacher refers to a religious teacher. It was a polite title for a Jewish man who had authority to teach the things about God. Use a title that is an appropriate way to address a religious teacher in your culture. It should not refer only to a school teacher.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Sir

Master

I will follow You: The teacher used the verb follow in both a literal and a figurative sense. He meant that he wanted to go with Jesus, and he wanted to be a disciple of Jesus. A disciple usually traveled with his teacher, lived with him, and learned from him.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I will follow you as your disciple

I want to follow you and be your disciple

Matthew 8:20

Section 8:18–22: The cost of following Jesus

In this section two people told Jesus they wanted to follow him. He replied with two sayings that indicate that being his disciple is difficult.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

To follow Jesus is difficult/hard

Two people who wanted to follow Jesus

8:20a

Jesus replied, “Foxes have dens and birds of the air have nests,

- Jesus replied, “Foxes have their holes and birds have their nests,
- But Jesus said to him, “Wild dogs live in holes, and birds live in their nests.

In the Greek, 8:20a begins with a conjunction that is often translated as “and” or “but.” There is contrast between the desire of the teacher of the law and how Jesus responds. The BSB does not translate this conjunction, but leaves the contrast implicit. In some languages, it may be natural to show this contrast. For example:

But (NLT)

Foxes: Foxes are a kind of small, wild dog. They each weighed about 7 kilograms (15 pounds), and are about 1 meter (36–40 inches) long from nose to rump (not including the tail). They have orange-red or gray fur with white markings. They live in holes.

If foxes are unknown in your language, there are several ways to translate:

- Use a general expression such as:

wild dogs

- Use a name of a wild animal known in your area that is about the size of a fox and lives in a hole.

birds of the air: This phrase is a Jewish way of referring to birds. In many languages, it is more natural to just translate this phrase as “birds.” For example:

and birds have nests (GNT)

This phrase also occurs in 6:26a. You should translate it here as you did there.

nests: The word nests refers to birds’ homes.

8:20b

but the Son of Man has no place to lay His head.”

- but the Son of Man has no place to lay his head and rest.”
- But I, the Son of Man have no house where I can lie down and rest/sleep.”

the Son of Man: In Greek, the phrase that English versions translate as the Son of Man is more literally “the Son of the human/person.” Jesus used this title as a way to refer to himself without using the pronoun “I.” He used this title to imply that:

1. He was a true human being, and he represented all people.
2. He came from God and had authority from God (because this title hints at Daniel 7:13–14).

Try to use an expression that implies both meanings. Here are some other expressions that translators have used:

the Man whom God Sent

the True Man from God/Heaven

the Representative of Mankind

The Older Brother of All People

In some cases, an unusual title may correctly suggest a deeper meaning. For example:

the Child of a Person

the One who was Born as a Human

Translators have also used expressions that are more literal. These more literal expressions may be appropriate where readers are familiar with a literal title in another version.

In some languages it may be necessary to use a form like “I” or “me” to indicate that Jesus was referring to himself. For example:

I, the Son of Man (NLT96)

See also Son of Man in KBT for more information.

no place to lay His head: The phrase lay His head refers to resting and sleeping. This whole phrase refers to not having a permanent home where Jesus could sleep.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

nowhere to sleep (GW)

have no home of my own, not even a place to lay my head (NLT96)

has no permanent place where he can sleep/rest

Matthew 8:21

Section 8:18–22: The cost of following Jesus

In this section two people told Jesus they wanted to follow him. He replied with two sayings that indicate that being his disciple is difficult.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

To follow Jesus is difficult/hard

Two people who wanted to follow Jesus

8:21a

Another of His disciples requested,

- ¶ Another man who was one of Jesus’ disciples said to him,
- ¶ Then another of Jesus’ followers said to him,

Another of His disciples: The phrase Another of His disciples refers to a man who was one of the larger group who was following Jesus. He was not one of the twelve disciples.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Another man who was one of the many disciples of Jesus

Another man, one of Jesus' followers (NCV)

Another disciple (CEV)

As is shown in 8:21b, this man was not yet a serious disciple of Jesus. So here a word like "follower" may be a good way to translate the word "disciple."

disciples: The word disciples means "learners" who are in a relationship with a teacher. The learners commit themselves to their teacher in order to learn from him and live according to his teaching and example. In the New Testament, disciples refer specifically to people who were learning from a religious teacher. Disciples often lived with their teacher and followed him wherever he went.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

- Use a word or phrase that refers to people who learn from a teacher or expert. It is helpful if the word or phrase also implies that the learners are often with their teacher. For example:

students

apprentices Be careful not to use a word that would refer only to students in a school or classroom.

- Use a word or phrase that refers to people who follow a teacher or leader by obeying his teaching. It is helpful if this word or phrase also implies learning from the teacher and actually following the teacher wherever he goes. For example:

followers

those who are committed/faithful (to a teacher/leader)

- Use a word or phrase that includes both the idea of learning from someone and also of having close association with him. For example:

companions whom Jesus taught

See how you translated disciples in 5:1c. Or see disciple in the Glossary for more information.

8:21b

"Lord, first let me go and bury my father."

- "Lord, I will follow you but first let me go and bury my father."
- "Sir/Master, let me go and wait until my father dies and I bury him, and then I will really be your follower."

Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord means "master." It was a polite title used when addressing a respected leader.

This word also occurs in 8:2b. You will probably want to translate it here as you did there.

first let me go and bury my father: This clause is an idiom. It means "let me go and help my father until he dies and I bury him." Bailey (page 26) says, "The phrase 'to bury one's father' is a traditional idiom that refers specifically to the duty of the son to remain at home and care for his parents until they are laid to rest respectfully." The man implied that he wanted to seriously follow Jesus, but at a later time. That later time was possibly years in the future. He first wanted to go take care of his father.

In some languages a literal translation would not clearly indicate or imply that meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain the meaning in the text. For example:

I will follow you, but first let me go and bury my father.

I want to really follow you, but first let me go home until my father dies so I can bury him.

Matthew 8:22

Section 8:18–22: The cost of following Jesus

In this section two people told Jesus they wanted to follow him. He replied with two sayings that indicate that being his disciple is difficult.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

To follow Jesus is difficult/hard

Two people who wanted to follow Jesus

8:22a**But Jesus told him,**

- But Jesus said to him,
- But Jesus replied to him,

But Jesus told him: There is a contrast between the way we might expect Jesus to respond to the man, and the way Jesus actually responded. The BSB and some English versions indicate this contrast with the word But.

8:22b**“Follow Me,**

- “Follow me now.
- “Come with me and become my disciple.

Follow Me: Here Jesus used the word Follow in both a literal and spiritual sense. He commanded the man to go with him, and he commanded the man to become his disciple.

In 8:21a, this man is already called one of Jesus’ disciples. The people who followed Jesus had varying degrees of seriousness or commitment. So here Jesus was probably telling the man to become a committed disciple.

Here are some other ways to translate this command:

Follow me and become my disciple

Come with me and be my true disciple

The command Follow Me probably implies that Jesus commanded the man to follow him immediately, not in the future. In some languages, it may be good to make this explicit. For example:

Follow me now. (NLT)

8:22c**and let the dead bury their own dead.”**

- Allow dead people to bury their own dead people.”
- Allow the people who are as if dead bury their own kind when they are dead.”

let the dead bury their own dead: This saying is like a proverb. It is short, and its meaning is not immediately obvious. One thing that makes it difficult is that the word dead is used in two different senses.

The first time dead occurs, it is used in a spiritual sense. It refers to people who are spiritually dead. They are people who do not know God. The second time dead occurs, it is used in its normal sense. It

refers to physically dead people. So Jesus said that spiritually dead people should bury those who are physically dead.

In Jewish culture, it was very important for a son to properly bury his father. So Jesus’ statement would have shocked this man. Jesus used this statement to tell the man that he should not allow burial customs (or other customs) to hinder him from following the Lord.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Translate it literally and keep the saying like a proverb. For example:

let the people who are dead bury their own dead (NCV) If you follow this option, it may be helpful to add a footnote. Here are some sample footnotes:

The first word “dead” refers to people who do not follow Jesus. They are “dead” to the kingdom of God. They can take the time to bury dead people. Jesus used this saying to tell the man that his customs, such as burial customs, must not hinder him from following Jesus.

- Explain the meaning in the text. For example:

Leave those who are like dead people to bury those who have died.

Let the spiritually dead bury their own dead. (NLT)

Let the people who do not believe in me bury their own kind when they are dead.

their own dead: The phrase their own dead would normally refer to people from their own families. However, in this context it may refer more specifically to people who are spiritually dead like them. When such people die physically and need to be buried, others who are spiritually dead should bury them.

Here is another way to translate this:

their own kind when they are dead

Matthew 8:23

Section 8:23–27: Jesus commanded a storm to stop In this section Jesus performed the miracle of stopping the winds from blowing and of calming the waves. This showed that he had power over nature.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus calmed a storm on the lake

Jesus stopped the wind and waves

Jesus demonstrated his power over storms/nature

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 4:35–41 and Luke 8:22–25.

8:23a

When He got into the boat,

- ¶ After he/Jesus got into the boat,
- ¶ Then Jesus entered into the boat,

In the Greek, 8:23a begins with a conjunction that is often translated as “and” (ESV). It indicates that this section continues the story from 8:18 where Jesus commanded his disciples to get ready to cross the lake.

Here is another way to begin this section:

Then (NIV)

When He got into the boat: This boat was a fishing boat that may have had a sail. It was big enough for Jesus and his twelve disciples to sit inside.

This same word occurs in 4:21d. See the note there for more information.

8:23b

His disciples followed Him.

- his disciples went with him.
- and his disciples followed him into the boat, and they began crossing the lake.

His disciples followed Him: The verb followed indicates that the disciples entered into the boat with Jesus, then began to travel with him across the lake.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

his disciples followed him into the boat

his disciples got into the boat with him and they began to cross the lake

his disciples followed him and also got into the boat and together they started crossing the lake

Matthew 8:24

Section 8:23–27: Jesus commanded a storm to stop

In this section Jesus performed the miracle of stopping the winds from blowing and of calming the waves. This showed that he had power over nature.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus calmed a storm on the lake

Jesus stopped the wind and waves

Jesus demonstrated his power over storms/nature

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 4:35–41 and Luke 8:22–25.

8:24a

Suddenly a violent storm came up on the sea,

- Suddenly, a big storm arrived on the lake,
- Then unexpectedly, a strong/big wind started blowing on the water,

The storm probably occurred while Jesus and the disciples were far from shore. In some languages, the danger will be made clearer by including some implied information. For example:

When they were far from shore, then

In the middle of crossing the lake,

While crossing the lake

Suddenly: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Suddenly indicates that something extraordinary is going to happen. Here, it is a storm that is unexpected.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

And behold (ESV)

Unexpectedly

Without warning (NIV)

a violent storm: In this context, the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as a violent storm refers to a storm

with very strong winds. This storm quickly blew the water into big waves.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

a severe storm (GW)

a big/strong wind

came up: The expression came up is a figurative way of saying that the storm began.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

came/arrived

blew

occurred/happened

on the sea: The phrase on the sea refers to lake Galilee.

8:24b

so that the boat was engulfed by the waves;

- and the waves started entering into the boat.
- and water started filling the boat.

so that: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as so that introduces a result of 8:24a. The storm was so great that, as a result, waves were entering the boat.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

with the result that

and so

In some languages, it is more natural to leave this conjunction untranslated. See the examples below.

the boat was engulfed by the waves: The Greek word that the BSB translates as was engulfed means “covered.” Here, this phrase indicates that the waves were higher than the boat. The waves were coming over the top of the boat and filling it with water.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

The waves were covering the boat (GW)

and waves started splashing into their boat (CEV)

and the boat was in danger of sinking (GNT)

8:24c

but Jesus was sleeping.

- But he was sleeping.
- During that time, Jesus was asleep.

but: It is surprising and unexpected that Jesus was sleeping in the boat during the furious storm. The BSB indicates this unexpected event with the conjunction but.

Here are some other ways to indicate that the following event is unexpected:

Yet (GW)

However

Matthew 8:25

Section 8:23–27: Jesus commanded a storm to stop

In this section Jesus performed the miracle of stopping the winds from blowing and of calming the waves. This showed that he had power over nature.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus calmed a storm on the lake

Jesus stopped the wind and waves

Jesus demonstrated his power over storms/nature

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 4:35–41 and Luke 8:22–25.

8:25a

The disciples went and woke Him, saying,

- The disciples went to him and woke him up. They shouted,
- His disciples came to him and woke him up. Then they said,

8:25b

“Lord, save us! We are perishing!”

- “Lord, save us!^(incl) We^(incl) are about to die!”
- “Master, save us! We^(incl) are going to drown!”

8:25a–b

Lord, save us!: The word save means “rescue from danger or trouble.” The BSB had added the pronoun us,

because this pronoun is clearly implied in the Greek text.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

rescue us

help us

We are perishing!: The Greek word that the BSB translates as perishing in this context means “going to die.” It refers to the disciples dying from drowning because of the storm.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

We are about to die! (GNT)

We’re going to drown! (NIV)

We: In this context the disciples probably included Jesus in the word We. Use a form that includes all the people in the boat including Jesus. The disciples did not yet fully understand who Jesus was. So it was possible for them to believe that Jesus could die with them if he did not do something to stop the storm.

Matthew 8:26

Section 8:23–27: Jesus commanded a storm to stop

In this section Jesus performed the miracle of stopping the winds from blowing and of calming the waves. This showed that he had power over nature.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus calmed a storm on the lake

Jesus stopped the wind and waves

Jesus demonstrated his power over storms/nature

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 4:35–41 and Luke 8:22–25.

8:26a

“You of little faith,” Jesus replied, “why are you so afraid?”

- ¶ He said to them, “Why are you^(plur) so afraid, you men of little faith?”

- ¶ Jesus replied, “You^(plur) should not be afraid! You people have so little faith!”

“You of little faith,” Jesus replied: The BSB places the words Jesus replied in the middle of what Jesus said. This is good English style. In some languages, it may be more natural to place these words at the beginning of 8:26a. For example:

And he said to them, “Why are you so afraid, O you of little faith?” (ESV)

You of little faith: This expression is the translation of one Greek word. Jesus said this to the disciples. He spoke directly to them like calling them by name or by a title.

In many languages speaking like this is natural. But in some languages, it may be necessary to have a complete sentence. For example:

You have such little faith!

How little faith you have! (REB)

You trust/believe in God so little!

This expression also occurs in 6:30d. You should translate the same way in both places.

why are you so afraid?: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus rebuked his disciples for being afraid of the storm. You should translate in a way that indicates a rebuke.

Here are some other ways to translate this rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Why are you so frightened? (GNT)

- As a statement or command. For example:

You should not be afraid!

Stop being afraid!

8:26b

Then He got up and rebuked the winds and the sea,

- Then he stood up and ordered the wind and the waves to stop.
- Then Jesus stood up and commanded the wind to stop blowing and the waves/water to stop moving.

rebuked the winds and the sea: The word rebuked indicates that Jesus commanded the wind and the waves to stop. In some languages, a person can only rebuke another person. He cannot rebuke things like wind and water. So another verb like “commanded” or “ordered” must be used.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

ordered the winds and the waves to stop (GNT)

ordered the wind and the waves to calm down (CEV)

said to the wind and waves, “Be calm!”

winds: It may be more natural in your language to translate this plural word as the singular “wind.”

the sea: Here the phrase the sea refers to the waves. So some English versions use the word “waves” instead of sea here. It is also possible to simply say “water” here.

8:26c and it was perfectly calm.

- And at once the wind and the water became completely calm/still.
- As a result, the wind and waves stopped.

it was perfectly calm: The word calm means that the wind stopped blowing and the water stopped making waves.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

a great calm came

suddenly all was calm (NLT)

the wind and lake became completely calm

Matthew 8:27

Section 8:23–27: Jesus commanded a storm to stop
In this section Jesus performed the miracle of stopping the winds from blowing and of calming the waves. This showed that he had power over nature.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus calmed a storm on the lake

Jesus stopped the wind and waves

Jesus demonstrated his power over storms/nature

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 4:35–41 and Luke 8:22–25.

8:27a The men were amazed and asked,

- The men were amazed. They said,
- The disciples were very surprised and said to one another,

The men: The Greek phrase that the BSB literally translates as The men refers to the men in the boat. In other words, it refers to the disciples.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

The men in the boat (CEV)

The disciples (NLT)

were amazed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as were amazed also means “marveled.” The disciples were genuinely surprised that Jesus had this kind of authority.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

were amazed (NLT)

were astonished at what had happened (REB)

This same word occurs in 8:10a.

asked: The disciples were speaking to one another, not to Jesus. For example:

saying to one another

and said to each other

8:27b “What kind of man is this?”

- “What sort of person is this man?”
- “This man is amazing!”

8:27c Even the winds and the sea obey Him!”

- Even the wind and the water obey him!”

- Even the winds and the water do as he says/ commands!”
- He has power over even the wind and the water!”

8:27b–c

What kind of man is this? Even the winds and the sea obey Him!: This is a rhetorical question. It expresses surprise and amazement. The disciples expressed amazement that Jesus had such great power.

There are several ways to translate this amazement:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

What kind of man is this, that even the winds and the sea obey him? (NRSV)

- As a question and an exclamation. For example:

What kind of man is this? Even the winds and the waves obey him! (NIV)

Who is this? Even the wind and the waves obey him. (CEV)

- As one or two exclamations:

This man is amazing! Even the wind and water obey him!

obey Him!: The verb obey indicates that the winds and the seas did as Jesus commanded. In some languages, the verb obey can only be used with people or animals, not wind and water. So another verb must be used. For example:

He even controls the wind and the waves

He has power over even the wind and the waves.

Even the winds and the waves do as he says!

Matthew 8:28**Section 8:28–34: Jesus commanded demons to leave two men**

In this section Jesus and his disciples crossed Lake Galilee to a region called Gadara. In the region was a town of the same name. The town was about five miles southeast of Lake Galilee. But Jesus probably stayed close to the lake. The people of Gadara took care of pigs, so they were not Jews. The Law of Moses forbade

the Jews from eating pigs, so they did not take care of pigs.

The demons that controlled the two men were strong and violent. But Jesus caused the demons to leave. So, this story shows that Jesus has more power than demons.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus healed two demon-possessed men

Two men whom demons controlled

Jesus had power to heal two demon-possessed men

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 5:1–20 and Luke 8:26–39.

8:28a**When Jesus arrived on the other side**

- ¶ When Jesus arrived at the other side of the lake,
- ¶ Jesus finished crossing the lake with his disciples, and they arrived/landed

When Jesus arrived on the other side: This phrase refers to the other side of Lake Galilee. Jesus and his disciples finished their journey in the boat across the lake.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

When Jesus arrived on the other side of the lake (NLT)

After Jesus had crossed the lake (CEV)

Jesus: It is also implied that Jesus arrived with his disciples. The focus is on Jesus here. But in some languages it is more natural to include the disciples. For example:

Jesus arrived with his disciples

8:28b**in the region of the Gadarenes,**

- he was in the area where the people of Gadara lived.
- at the region/district of the people of the city/town of Gadara.

in the region of the Gadarenes: There is a textual issue in 8:28a: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have

Gadarenes (“people of Gadara”) (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, JBP, REB, ESV, NCV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have Gergesenes (“people of Gergesa”) (KJV only). It is recommended that you follow option (1). This phrase refers to the ground/land controlled by the people of the city of Gadara. The city of Gadara was probably small compared to cities of today, but was more important than the towns of that time. Use a word in your languages for a small city or large town.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

in the region of the city/town of Gadara

to the territory of Gadara (GNT)

8:28c

He was met by two demon-possessed men coming from the tombs.

- There two men who had demons came to Jesus. They^(dual) came from the tombs/cemetery,
- There two men whom demons controlled came out of the burial caves and approached Jesus.

He was met: The verb met probably means that the two men saw Jesus at a distance and then went to him. The verb met does not mean a planned meeting.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

came to him (CEV)

went to him

approached him

two demon-possessed men: The word demon-possessed refers to people who are controlled by demons. This same word occurs in 8:16a. You should translate it here as you did there.

the tombs: The word tombs refer to caves or small rooms that were cut out of a rock hillside. These tombs were the cemetery where people buried dead people. The two men may have lived in one of the tombs.

In some languages the usual word for “tombs” is not a place where someone is able to live. If that is true in your language, you may want to describe the burial place here. For example:

burial caves

cemetery caves

8:28d

They were so violent that no one could pass that way.

- and were so violent/fierce that no one was able to go through that area.
- They^(dual) were very dangerous, so nobody walked through/by that area.

They were so violent that no one could pass that way: This is general information about the two men. It does not refer only to when Jesus arrived.

violent: This word refers to people who always want to fight and hurt others.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

fierce (ESV)

dangerous (NCV)

no one could pass that way: This clause indicates that no one was able to walk anywhere near the tombs, because the two men would come and attack them.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

no one could go through that area (NLT)

No one could travel along that road (GW)

Matthew 8:29

Section 8:28–34: Jesus commanded demons to leave two men

In this section Jesus and his disciples crossed Lake Galilee to a region called Gadara. In the region was a town of the same name. The town was about five miles southeast of Lake Galilee. But Jesus probably stayed close to the lake. The people of Gadara took care of pigs, so they were not Jews. The Law of Moses forbade the Jews from eating pigs, so they did not take care of pigs.

The demons that controlled the two men were strong and violent. But Jesus caused the demons to leave. So, this story shows that Jesus has more power than demons.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus healed two demon-possessed men

Two men whom demons controlled

Jesus had power to heal two demon-possessed men

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 5:1–20 and Luke 8:26–39.

8:29a

“What do You want with us, Son of God?”

- “Son of God, what relationship/business do you have with us?^(excl)”
- “Son of God, why are you bothering us?^(excl)”
- “Son of God, do not bother/disturb us!”

8:29b

they shouted.

- they shouted unexpectedly.
- the men yelled at Jesus suddenly.
- all of a sudden they screamed at Jesus.

8:29a–b

The Greek of 8:29a begins with a word that is often translated as “behold.” It indicates that something extraordinary will happen. Here, the amazing event is that the demon-possessed men shouted at Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Suddenly (CEV)

Unexpectedly

“What do You want with us, Son of God?” they shouted: The BSB places the words they shouted in the middle of what the two demon-possessed men said. In some languages, it may be more natural to put these words in the beginning of 8:29a. For example:

they cried out, “What have you to do with us, O Son of God?” (ESV)

What do You want with us...?: In Greek, this sentence is literally “What to us and to you?” This is an idiom. It means “What connection/relation do we^(excl) have with you?”

This is a rhetorical question that implies “we have no connection/relation” or “we have nothing in common.” It also implies a request or rebuke, that is, “since we have nothing in common, you should not trouble us.” In this context, the demons, in fear or panic, were

pleading with Jesus not to cause them to leave the men.

Here are some other ways to translate this rebuke and plea:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Why are you bothering us...? (NLT96)

What business do we have with each other...? (NASB)

- As a statement or command. For example:

Do not bother/disturb us!

We have nothing to do with one another!

leave us alone! (NET)

Son of God?: The phrase Son of God is a title for Jesus. This title indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God. It also indicates that the relationship between God the Father and Jesus, his Son, is similar in some way to the relationship between human fathers and sons. God the Father does not have a physical body. He did not have a sexual relationship that resulted in Mary becoming pregnant and giving birth to Jesus.

The phrase Son of God occurs at 4:3b. You should translate it here as you did there. For further information, see the note on “My...Son” at 3:17b.

It may be more natural in some languages to put the phrase Son of God first in the clause. For example:

Son of God, what do you want with us?

they shouted: The pronoun they refers to the two men. These two men shouted the words that the demons wanted them to say.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

they shouted (NIV)

they screamed (GNT)

8:29c

“Have You come here to torture us before the appointed time?”

- “Have you come here to torture us before the right time?”
- “Why have you come here? Is it to punish us before it is time?”
- “Do not come here to make us suffer before the time that God determined!”

“Have You come here to torture us before the appointed time?”: This is a rhetorical question. It expresses a rebuke. The demons did not want Jesus to punish them before the time that God had determined.

Here are some other ways to translate this rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Have you come to torture us before the proper time? (JBP)

Why have you come here? Is it to torment us before the right time?

- As a statement or exclamation. For example:

Do not begin to torture us before the proper time!

torture: The verb torture refers to causing great pain to someone to make them suffer. For example:

torment (ESV)

punish (GNT)

cause to suffer severely

before the appointed time: This phrase refers to the time that God set to punish the demons. The demons knew that their time to torment humans was limited.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

before the right time (GNT)

before God’s appointed time (NLT)

before it is time (GW)

Matthew 8:30

Section 8:28–34: Jesus commanded demons to leave two men

In this section Jesus and his disciples crossed Lake Galilee to a region called Gadara. In the region was a town of the same name. The town was about five miles southeast of Lake Galilee. But Jesus probably stayed close to the lake. The people of Gadara took care of pigs, so they were not Jews. The Law of Moses forbade the Jews from eating pigs, so they did not take care of pigs.

The demons that controlled the two men were strong and violent. But Jesus caused the demons to leave. So, this story shows that Jesus has more power than demons.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus healed two demon-possessed men

Two men whom demons controlled

Jesus had power to heal two demon-possessed men

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 5:1–20 and Luke 8:26–39.

8:30

In the distance a large herd of pigs was feeding.

- Somewhat far from them, a large herd of pigs was eating.
- At that time many pigs were eating at a distance from them.

This verse gives some background information. The pigs were there all along, but it is at this point that Matthew tells the reader that they were there. Some English versions indicate this background information with the word “now.” For example:

Now... (ESV)

Many English versions do not have a word or phrase to introduce this information.

In the distance: The pigs were far from Jesus and the demon-possessed men, but they were close enough to be seen.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

at a distance from them (NASB)

somewhat far from them

a large herd of pigs: The word herd refers to a group. This herd was large.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

a herd of many pigs (ESV)

many pigs

pigs: “Hogs” or “swine” (RSV) are also called pigs in English. These were domestic pigs and not wild pigs. Jewish law said that pigs were ritually unclean, and Jews did not eat their meat.

In some languages people are not familiar with pigs. If that is true in your language, here are possible ways to translate pigs:

- Use a general expression along with the word for pigs from another language. For example:

animals called “pigs”

- Use a general word or expression for farm animals. For example:

livestock

domestic animals

- Use the word from the major language, if it is well-known by people of your language.

You might also want to use a picture of pigs in your translation.

was feeding: The word feeding indicates that the pigs were eating food. They were probably digging in the ground and looking for things to eat.

Matthew 8:31

Section 8:28–34: Jesus commanded demons to leave two men

In this section Jesus and his disciples crossed Lake Galilee to a region called Gadara. In the region was a town of the same name. The town was about five miles southeast of Lake Galilee. But Jesus probably stayed close to the lake. The people of Gadara took care of pigs, so they were not Jews. The Law of Moses forbade

the Jews from eating pigs, so they did not take care of pigs.

The demons that controlled the two men were strong and violent. But Jesus caused the demons to leave. So, this story shows that Jesus has more power than demons.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus healed two demon-possessed men

Two men whom demons controlled

Jesus had power to heal two demon-possessed men

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 5:1–20 and Luke 8:26–39.

8:31a

So the demons begged Jesus,

- The demons begged Jesus,
- The demons pleaded with Jesus,

the demons begged Jesus: Here it is obviously the demons who are talking. They are talking through the men.

begged: The Greek word that the BSB translates as begged also means “asked” or “requested.” For example:

pleaded (NJB)

8:31b

“If You drive us out, send us into the herd of pigs.”

- “If you make us^(excl) leave, send us into the group of pigs.”
- “If you force us to come out of these men, please allow us to go enter those pigs.”

If You drive us out: The words drive us out refers to causing the demons to leave the men and forbidding their return. This word also occurs in 7:22c.

Jewish people often spoke of evil spirits as being in someone. Different cultures have different ways of speaking about people being controlled by demons and being released from the control of demons. Use a natural expression for this in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

If you throw/chase us out

If you force us out (CEV)

If you make us leave these men (NCV)

send us into the herd of pigs: This clause is a command that is used as a request. The demons wanted Jesus to allow them to enter into the pigs and control them as they had the men.

Here are some other ways to translate the clause:

let us go into the herd of pigs

please send us into those pigs (CEV)

Matthew 8:32

Section 8:28–34: Jesus commanded demons to leave two men

In this section Jesus and his disciples crossed Lake Galilee to a region called Gadara. In the region was a town of the same name. The town was about five miles southeast of Lake Galilee. But Jesus probably stayed close to the lake. The people of Gadara took care of pigs, so they were not Jews. The Law of Moses forbade the Jews from eating pigs, so they did not take care of pigs.

The demons that controlled the two men were strong and violent. But Jesus caused the demons to leave. So, this story shows that Jesus has more power than demons.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus healed two demon-possessed men

Two men whom demons controlled

Jesus had power to heal two demon-possessed men

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 5:1–20 and Luke 8:26–39.

8:32a

“Go!” He told them.

- ¶ He replied to them, “Go!”
- ¶ Then Jesus told them to go.

“Go!” He told them: The BSB places the words He told them after what Jesus said. In some languages, it may be more natural to place these words at the beginning of 8:32. For example:

And he said to them, “Go.” (ESV)

Go!: The Greek word translated as Go! means “Go away” or “Depart.” By saying Go!, Jesus ordered the demons to leave the men. It is implied that he also gave them permission to enter the pigs.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

All right, go! (NLT)

Then go! (JBP)

In some languages, it will be natural to translate this as indirect speech. For example:

He told them to go.

8:32b

So they came out and went into the pigs,

- So they came out of the two men and entered into the pigs.
- So the demons exited the two men and went and entered into the pigs.

they came out: This clause means that the demons came out of the two men. It refers to the demons no longer controlling the men.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

the demons came out of the men (NLT)

they abandoned the men

they stopped controlling them and left

went into the pigs: This clause indicates that the demons entered into the pigs and began controlling them as they had been controlling the two men.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

entered the pigs (NLT)

went and began controlling the pigs

went into the pigs and possessed them

8:32c

and the whole herd rushed down the steep bank into the sea

- Suddenly, the whole group of pigs charged down the steep hillside into the lake.
- Then unexpectedly, all the pigs ran down the side of the hill and into the lake.

The Greek of 8:32c begins with a word that is often translated as “behold.” The BSB does not translate this word. It indicates that something extraordinary will happen. Here, the amazing event is that the pigs ran into the water and drowned.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

suddenly (NRSV)

Unexpectedly

This word also occurs in 8:29a–b.

the whole herd rushed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as rushed refers to running with no regard to safety.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

all the pigs ran recklessly

the whole herd charged (NJB)

the whole herd rushed madly (JBP)

the steep bank: This phrase indicates that the place where the pigs were feeding was on the side of a hill. The hill was very sloped. The pigs rushed down the steep slope directly into the water. They did not fall or jump off a cliff. Morris in footnote 88 on page 211 says, “*κρημνός* is variously understood. GNB and JB have “cliff,” but the pigs would have gone over a cliff, not rushed down it (but perhaps *κατὰ* as a meaning like “over and down”). So with REB’s “the edge.” It seems that Matthew is writing about a steep slope, but not a precipice.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the steep slope (NET)

the steep hillside (NLT)

8:32d

and died in the waters.

- They drowned in the water.
- They all died in the water.

died in the waters: This phrase indicates that all the pigs died in the lake. The demons did not die.

Matthew 8:33

Section 8:28–34: Jesus commanded demons to leave two men

In this section Jesus and his disciples crossed Lake Galilee to a region called Gadara. In the region was a town of the same name. The town was about five miles southeast of Lake Galilee. But Jesus probably stayed close to the lake. The people of Gadara took care of pigs, so they were not Jews. The Law of Moses forbade the Jews from eating pigs, so they did not take care of pigs.

The demons that controlled the two men were strong and violent. But Jesus caused the demons to leave. So, this story shows that Jesus has more power than demons.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus healed two demon-possessed men

Two men whom demons controlled

Jesus had power to heal two demon-possessed men

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 5:1–20 and Luke 8:26–39.

8:33a

Those tending the pigs ran off

- Then the pig watchers fled
- The pig herders saw all that and ran away.

Those tending the pigs: The phrase Those tending the pigs refers to the men who took care of the pigs as their job. Some languages will have a specific term such as “pig herders.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

The herdsmen (ESV)

The people taking care of the pigs (CEV)

ran off: The Greek word that the BSB translates as ran off means “ran away” or “fled.” These pig herders ran away possibly because they were frightened by what had happened.

It is implied that the pig herders saw the pigs rush down the hill and drown in the lake. In 8:33c, it is also implied that they saw Jesus and what he did to the demon-possessed men. In some languages, it will be natural to include some of this implied information. For example:

saw that/this and ran away

8:33b into the town and reported all this,

- and returned to the town and told everything that had happened,
- They ran and went to the city/town. There they told the townspeople about everything that had happened to their pigs.

town: The word town here refers to the town of Gadara. The city of Gadara is mentioned in 8:28b. If you used a word such as “city” or “town” to describe Gadara in 8:28b, you should use the same word here.

reported all this: The herdsmen publicly told the people in the town everything that had happened.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

they told everything (ESV)

they recounted all of this

8:33c including the account of the demon-possessed men.

- and what had happened to the two men who had demons.
- They also told them about the two men who had been controlled by demons.

including the account of the demon-possessed men: The Greek word that the BSB translates here as including is a common Greek conjunction. It usually means “and,” “even,” or “also.” There are several ways to interpret this word in this context:

1. It means and. According to this interpretation, the herdsmen gave a report about their pigs, and they also gave a report about the demon-possessed men. For example:

they told about all of this and what had happened to the men who had demons (NCV) (RSV, GNT, NCV, REB, KJV)

1. It means including. According to this interpretation, the herdsmen gave a report about everything that happened, and this report included what happened to the demon-possessed men. For example:

reported all this, including what had happened to the demon-possessed men (NIV) (BSB, NIV, NASB, NJB)

1. It means especially. According to this interpretation, the main emphasis of the herdsmen’s report was about what happened to the demon-possessed men, but they also reported about everything else. For example:

told everything, especially what had happened to the two men (CEV) (ESV, GW, CEV)

1. It introduces an explanation of 8:33b. According to this interpretation, the herdsmen’s report was only about what happened to the demon-possessed men. So 8:33b and 8:33c can be combined. For example:

and told everything that had happened to the demon-possessed men (NET) (NET, NRSV, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The herdsmen were certainly upset when their pigs died. It is likely that a main part of their report was about the loss of their pigs. Morris on page 211 says, “An interesting little problem centers on and. This word can mean something like “namely,” in which case they described “everything, namely what happened to the demon-possessed men.” But it is incredible that they omitted the fate of the pigs, and, if we take and to mean an addition, the meaning is that their big story was the loss of the pigs, after which they added the healing of the men.”

Here are some other ways to translate 8:33a–c:

^aThe herdsmen fled ^band went into town where they told about everything that happened to their pigs ^cand also what happened to the demon-possessed men.

General Comment on 8:33b–c

The event of the demon-possessed men occurred before the event with the pigs. In some languages it is more natural to have the phrase “demon-possessed men” first. For example:

went into town and told the whole story about what happened to the demon-possessed men and the pigs

Matthew 8:34**Section 8:28–34: Jesus commanded demons to leave two men**

In this section Jesus and his disciples crossed Lake Galilee to a region called Gadara. In the region was a town of the same name. The town was about five miles southeast of Lake Galilee. But Jesus probably stayed close to the lake. The people of Gadara took care of pigs, so they were not Jews. The Law of Moses forbade the Jews from eating pigs, so they did not take care of pigs.

The demons that controlled the two men were strong and violent. But Jesus caused the demons to leave. So, this story shows that Jesus has more power than demons.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus healed two demon-possessed men

Two men whom demons controlled

Jesus had power to heal two demon-possessed men

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 5:1–20 and Luke 8:26–39.

8:34a**Then the whole town went out to meet Jesus.**

- Then all the people of the town went out of the town to see Jesus.
- Then many of the townspeople left the city/town and went out to talk with Jesus.

The Greek of 8:34 begins with a word that is often translated as “behold.” The BSB does not translate this word. It indicates that something extraordinary is going to happen. Here, the amazing event is that the entire town went out to meet Jesus.

The usual translation of this word (suddenly/unexpectedly) does not fit well here. In this context, it may be better to leave this word untranslated, as the BSB does.

the whole town: The phrase the whole town is a figure of speech. It refers to all the people of the town. For example:

everyone from the town (GNT)

The word whole is an exaggeration. Probably most or nearly all of the people of the town went out to see Jesus. If your language does not use exaggeration in a context like this, you may want to translate whole in another way. For example:

most of the people of the town

nearly everyone in the town

went out to meet Jesus: The people of the town probably went out to see Jesus and everything that had happened. They did not go to introduce themselves to Jesus or to learn who he was.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

went out to see Jesus (NCV)

went out to talk with Jesus

8:34b**And when they saw Him, they begged Him to leave their region.**

- When they saw him, they begged him to leave their land.
- When they saw him, they pleaded with him, “Please leave our area.”

they begged Him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as begged also occurred in 8:31a. In this context, the Greek verb means “urgently ask.” You may want to translate it in the same way as you did in 8:31a.

to leave their region: This phrase is indirect speech. In some languages, it is more natural to translate this as direct speech. For example:

“Please leave our region/territory.”

“Would you please depart from our area/district?”

Matthew 9:1

Section 9:1–8: Jesus forgave and healed a paralyzed man

In this section, Matthew continued to write about the power that Jesus has to heal people. But more importantly, he showed that Jesus also has the authority and power to forgive sins (9:6a). In addition, he again showed that faith is important.

When Jesus first told the paralyzed man that his sins were forgiven (9:2d), it began a conflict with the Jewish leaders. (This is the first time that Matthew showed a conflict between Jesus and the Jewish leaders.) This conflict continues in the next sections.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus healed a paralyzed man

Jesus has the power to forgive sins

Healing and Forgiving a Paralytic (NET)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 2:1–12 and Luke 5:17–26.

9:1a

Jesus got into a boat, crossed over,

- ¶ Then Jesus got into the boat and crossed back to the other side of the lake,
- ¶ So Jesus got back into the boat, and he and his disciples returned across the lake.

The Greek of 9:1a begins with a word that is often translated as “and.” The BSB omits this word. The events in this paragraph happened immediately after the events in 8:34. In 8:34, the people of the town of Gadara begged Jesus to leave their region. So Jesus got back into a boat and returned across the lake.

Here are some other ways to begin this paragraph:

So (REB)

Then

Jesus got into a boat: The Greek word that the BSB translates as got into refers to entering a boat. This same verb occurs in 8:23a. Use an expression that is natural in your language for getting into a boat.

The boat was probably the same boat that Jesus used to get there (to the town of Gadara). It was mentioned

in 8:23–24. So some versions translate this clause as “getting back into the boat.” For example:

He got back in the boat (NJB)

Jesus re-embarked on the boat (JBP)

Also, the disciples went with Jesus, but the text does not refer to them because the focus is on Jesus here. In some languages, it is more natural to mention the disciples.

Jesus climbed into the boat taking the disciples

Jesus and his disciples entered the boat.

crossed over: This phrase refers to going from one side of the lake (of Galilee) to the other side. In this context, Jesus went back across the lake to Capernaum. He had started in Capernaum. He then went across the lake to Gadara. Finally, he returned to Capernaum.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

crossed the water (NJB)

went back across the lake (GNT)

crossed to the other side (NET)

9:1b

and came to His own town.

- and arrived at his own town.
- They landed on the shore of Jesus’ own town of Capernaum, and he and his disciples got out of the boat.

and came to His own town: The verb came means “arrived (by boat).” The phrase His own town refers to Capernaum. Capernaum was next to the lake, and Jesus and his disciples came to the town by boat. The verb came does not indicate a separate journey from the boat to town. For example:

and arrived at his own town

It is implied that Jesus and his disciples got out of the boat after arriving at the landing place near Capernaum. In some languages it is necessary to say

that they got out of the boat, or it will be understood that they were still in the boat. For example:

and arrived at his own town, and he and his disciples got out of the boat

and came to the shore of his own town, and he and his disciples got out of the boat

His own town: The phrase His own town refers to Capernaum. That is where Jesus lived during his years of ministry. In this context, the phrase does not mean that he was born there or that his family lived there. He was born in Bethlehem, and he was raised in Nazareth.

If people will think that the phrase His own town refers to Bethlehem or Nazareth, you may want to:

- Explain it in the text. For example:

the town where he lived (CEV)

his own town of Capernaum

- Explain it in a footnote. For example:

“His own town” refers to Capernaum. That is where Jesus was living at the time.

Matthew 9:2

Section 9:1–8: Jesus forgave and healed a paralyzed man

In this section, Matthew continued to write about the power that Jesus has to heal people. But more importantly, he showed that Jesus also has the authority and power to forgive sins (9:6a). In addition, he again showed that faith is important.

When Jesus first told the paralyzed man that his sins were forgiven (9:2d), it began a conflict with the Jewish leaders. (This is the first time that Matthew showed a conflict between Jesus and the Jewish leaders.) This conflict continues in the next sections.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus healed a paralyzed man

Jesus has the power to forgive sins

Healing and Forgiving a Paralytic (NET)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 2:1–12 and Luke 5:17–26.

9:2a

Just then some men brought to Him a paralytic lying on a mat.

- Suddenly, some people came to Jesus with a paralyzed man lying on a mat.
- Some men unexpectedly came to Jesus carrying a man whose body was paralyzed. He was lying on a mat/stretchers.

Just then: The Greek words that the BSB translates as Just then are literally “and behold” (as in the ESV). They indicate that something extraordinary will happen. Here, what is unexpected is that some men brought a paralyzed man to Jesus, and Jesus told him that his sins were forgiven.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

And behold (ESV)

And suddenly (NJB)

Unexpectedly

some men brought to Him a paralytic: The word paralytic refers to a person who is paralyzed. He cannot move all or part of his body. The fact that this paralyzed man was lying on a mat probably indicates that it was more than his legs that were paralyzed.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

a paralyzed man (GNT)

a crippled man (CEV)

a man who had part of his body dead

This same term occurs in 4:24f and 8:6a.

lying on a mat: The Greek word that the BSB translates as mat can mean “sleeping mat” or even “stretchers” for carrying sick people. It probably does not refer here to a normal “bed” for sleeping, because there is a different Greek word for “bed.” Use an expression that is natural in this context for carrying a person who cannot walk.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

lying on a bed (ESV)

lying on a stretcher (NET)

9:2c

He said to the paralytic,

- he said to the paralyzed man,
- so he said to the man,

9:2b–d

When Jesus saw their faith, He said to the paralytic, “Take courage, son; your sins are forgiven.”

The clause When Jesus saw their faith is what prompted Jesus to say to the paralytic, Take courage, son; your sins are forgiven. In some languages this may be expressed as a reason for what Jesus says. For example:

Jesus saw their faith. Therefore he said...

Jesus saw their faith and so he said...

In other languages, it is sufficient to let the context show the connection. For example:

Jesus saw their faith. He said...

In other languages it may be more natural to put the reason after what he said. For example:

^{2c}Jesus said to the paralytic, “Take heart, son; your sins are forgiven.” ^{2b}He said that because he saw their faith.

9:2b

When Jesus saw their faith,

- When Jesus saw/noticed their faith,
- Jesus realized that they believed that he could heal him,

saw their faith: In this context, the word saw means that Jesus “perceived,” “noticed” or “understood” that they had faith. In some languages, it is more natural to use a different verb. For example:

realized that they had faith

perceived how much faith they had

their: This pronoun probably refers to both the paralytic and the people bringing him. Your translation

should allow that the word their refers to both the paralytic and the people bringing him.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

that they had

that all of them showed

faith: In this context, the word faith indicates that the men believed that Jesus could heal the paralyzed man. They probably had heard of Jesus healing other people, so they believed that he could heal a paralyzed man as well. If your language needs to say what they believed in, you should refer to Jesus or his power. For example:

faith in him

faith that he had the power to heal

they believed in him

they believed that he had the power to heal

Your translation should not say that they believed Jesus to be the Christ or the Savior here.

9:2d

“Take courage, son; your sins are forgiven.”

- “My friend, do not worry. Your sins are forgiven!”
- “My brother, be happy. I forgive/pardon your sins!”

Take courage: The Greek word that the BSB translates with the idiom Take courage means “cheer up” or “be encouraged.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

don’t worry! (CEV)

Be encouraged (NCV)

Cheer up (GW)

son: The word son shows Jesus’ love for the man. It does not mean that Jesus was his father. In some languages, it is more natural to use a different term to express love/compassion for a person in need. For example:

My friend (CEV)

my younger brother

your sins are forgiven: In this context, the verb are forgiven indicates that as Jesus spoke, he was canceling the paralytic's sins. The man would not be punished for them. God would treat him as though he had not offended him in any way. Jesus was not referring to a past event.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

your sins are taken away

your sins are canceled at this moment

your sins are now pardoned

In many languages, there may be an idiom for this. For example:

are erased

are wiped away

This clause is passive. Here are some other ways to translate this:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

Your sins are forgiven/canceled

- Use an active verb. For example:

I forgive/pardon your sins

Jesus referred here to the man's sins against God. This statement does not imply that the man had offended Jesus in some way. In some languages, it will be necessary to make this more clear. For example:

all your sins are forgiven

your sins against God are forgiven

This verb also occurs in 6:12a.

sins: The word sins refers to offenses against God or another person. Sins include acts, thoughts, and attitudes that are not what God wants or approves.

A person can also offend God by not doing what God wants him to do.

Try to translate sins with a general term that can include any wrongdoing against God. Here are problems to avoid:

1. The term should not imply that only serious crimes like murder or stealing are sins. Other offenses like gossip and greed are also sins.
2. The term should not include accidents or mistakes that are not against God's will.

Here are some other ways to translate sins:

wrong acts

offenses against God

evil deeds

In some languages it may be natural to translate sins with a phrase that includes a verb. For example:

wrong things that you have done

Matthew 9:3

Section 9:1–8: Jesus forgave and healed a paralyzed man

In this section, Matthew continued to write about the power that Jesus has to heal people. But more importantly, he showed that Jesus also has the authority and power to forgive sins (9:6a). In addition, he again showed that faith is important.

When Jesus first told the paralyzed man that his sins were forgiven (9:2d), it began a conflict with the Jewish leaders. (This is the first time that Matthew showed a conflict between Jesus and the Jewish leaders.) This conflict continues in the next sections.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus healed a paralyzed man

Jesus has the power to forgive sins

Healing and Forgiving a Paralytic (NET)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 2:1–12 and Luke 5:17–26.

9:3a

On seeing this, some of the scribes said to themselves,

- Surprisingly, some of the teachers of the Law said in their hearts/minds,
- Some of the teachers of religious law were there. They thought,

The Greek of 9:3a begins with a word that is often translated as “behold.” It indicates that something extraordinary will happen. The BSB does not translate this word. Here, what is unexpected is that, instead of being happy for the paralyzed man, some people there were upset with Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

At this (NIV)

Surprisingly

Unexpectedly

scribes: This is the first time in this section that the text refers to scribes. In some languages, it may be helpful to introduce them here. For example:

And some scribes were there. They said to themselves

The word scribes also occurs in 5:20a and 8:19a. You should translate this word here as you did there.

See also scribe in the Glossary for more information.

said to themselves: The phrase said to themselves is an idiom. It means “thought.” The scribes said the following words in their minds/hearts. They did not say them out loud.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

thought (GW)

said in their hearts/minds

9:3b

“This man is blaspheming!”

- “This guy greatly slanders/insults God!”
- “This fellow dishonors God. He claims to do what only God can do.”
- “This person is making himself equal with God. That’s evil talk!”

This man: The Greek word that the BSB translates as This man is more literally “this one.” It was a way for the scribes to dishonor Jesus. They did not say something respectful like “The teacher” or “The master.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

This fellow (NIV)

This guy

is blaspheming!: The verb is blaspheming means “intentionally say something that greatly harms a person’s reputation.” The scribes thought that Jesus was blaspheming/dishonoring God by claiming to do something that only God had the authority and ability to do. They believed that such talk harmed God’s reputation.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

He’s dishonoring God (GW)

greatly slanders/insults God

speaks against God

This man is evil. He speaks as if he were God.

He makes himself equal with God. That is evil talk!

Matthew 9:4**Section 9:1–8: Jesus forgave and healed a paralyzed man**

In this section, Matthew continued to write about the power that Jesus has to heal people. But more importantly, he showed that Jesus also has the authority and power to forgive sins (9:6a). In addition, he again showed that faith is important.

When Jesus first told the paralyzed man that his sins were forgiven (9:2d), it began a conflict with the Jewish leaders. (This is the first time that Matthew showed a conflict between Jesus and the Jewish leaders.) This conflict continues in the next sections.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus healed a paralyzed man

Jesus has the power to forgive sins

Healing and Forgiving a Paralytic (NET)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 2:1–12 and Luke 5:17–26.

9:4a

But Jesus knew what they were thinking and said,

- ¶ But Jesus knew what they were thinking. He said,
- ¶ Jesus knew what was in their hearts/minds, and so he said,

But: There is a contrast between 9:3b and 9:4a. The contrast is between the scribes thinking things without saying them out loud, and Jesus knowing what they were thinking.

Some English versions indicate this contrast with the conjunction *But*. Other English versions do not use a conjunction here. Indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language.

Jesus knew what they were thinking and said:

The clause *knew what they were thinking* is what prompted Jesus to say what he said to the scribes (in 9:4b–6a). In some languages, this may be expressed grammatically as a reason for what Jesus says. For example:

Jesus knew what they were thinking, so he asked them (NLT)

In other languages, it is best to translate this clause as a separate sentence. For example:

Jesus knew what they were thinking. He asked them (GW)

9:4b

“Why do you harbor evil in your hearts?”

- “Why do you^(plur) think evil thoughts in your hearts/insides?
- “You are wrong to be thinking these evil thoughts concerning me!

Why do you harbor evil in your hearts?: This is a rhetorical question. It is a rebuke. Jesus did have authority to forgive sins. So he rebuked the scribes for thinking that he had blasphemed God.

Here are some other ways to translate the rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Why are you thinking evil thoughts? (NCV)

How is it that you think evil thoughts in your hearts?

- As a statement. For example:

You are wrong for having evil thoughts in your hearts!

You should not think such evil thoughts in your hearts about me!

Translate this rebuke in a way that is natural in your language.

harbor evil in your hearts: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as *harbor evil in your hearts* is more literally “think evil things in your hearts.” The phrase in your hearts refers to the innermost being. In some languages, it is more natural to say “in your mind” or “inside.” For example:

have such evil thoughts in your minds (JBP)

The meaning of the phrase in your hearts may be already understood from the expression *harbor evil*. So, in some languages, it may not be necessary to translate the phrase in your hearts. For example:

thinking such evil things (GNT)

thinking evil thoughts (NCV)

Matthew 9:5

Section 9:1–8: Jesus forgave and healed a paralyzed man

In this section, Matthew continued to write about the power that Jesus has to heal people. But more importantly, he showed that Jesus also has the authority and power to forgive sins (9:6a). In addition, he again showed that faith is important.

When Jesus first told the paralyzed man that his sins were forgiven (9:2d), it began a conflict with the Jewish leaders. (This is the first time that Matthew showed a conflict between Jesus and the Jewish leaders.) This conflict continues in the next sections.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus healed a paralyzed man

Jesus has the power to forgive sins

Healing and Forgiving a Paralytic (NET)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 2:1–12 and Luke 5:17–26.

9:5a–c

Which is easier: to say, ‘Your sins are forgiven,’ or to say, ‘Get up and walk?’: Before translating 9:5a–c, there are at least three issues to consider:

Issue 1: Comparing two statements

The clause Which is easier introduces a question that compares two statements: sins are forgiven and Get up and walk. It is easier to say that sins are forgiven, because people cannot see whether sins are actually forgiven. The harder thing to say is Get up and walk. It is harder because everyone can immediately see whether a miracle happens. “Although it is certainly not easier to forgive sins than it is to heal disease, it is easier to pronounce the forgiveness of sins than to command someone to walk, this because only the latter can be objectively verified.... But Jesus, as the following verses show, can in fact heal the paralytic. So he can do the harder thing, and this should cause his critics to wonder whether he cannot also forgive sins....” (Davies and Allison, page 92).

Consider how people in your language would ask such a question.

Here are some other possible ways to translate this:

Is this easy to say, ‘Your sins are forgiven,’ or is this easy to say, ‘Rise and walk?’

Saying to the man, ‘Your sins are forgiven’ or ‘Rise and walk,’ between these two things, which one is easy?

I can say to the man, ‘Your sins are forgiven.’ I can also say, ‘Rise and walk.’ Which one is easy and which one is difficult?

Issue 2: Rhetorical question

This is a rhetorical question. Jesus asked this question to emphasize that it is easier to say Your sins are forgiven. It is implied that the harder thing to say is Get up and walk. It is harder because everyone can immediately see whether a miracle happens.

Here are some other ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- As a question. For example:

Is it easier to say, ‘Your sins are forgiven,’ or to say, ‘Get up and walk?’ (GW)

- As a statement followed by a tag question. For example:

It is easier to say ‘Your sins are forgiven’ than to say ‘Get up and walk.’ Isn’t that right?

- As a statement. For example:

Consider whether it is easier to say, ‘Your sins are forgiven’ or to say ‘Rise and walk.’

It is easier to say ‘Your sins are forgiven’ than to say ‘Rise and walk.’

It is easy to say, ‘Your sins are forgiven.’ It is hard to say, ‘Rise and walk.’

Issue 3: Quotes with a quote

The two statements Your sins are forgiven and Get up and walk are quotes within a quote. In some languages, it may be more natural to make these two statements indirect speech. For example:

Is it easier for me to tell this crippled man that his sins are forgiven or to tell him to get up and walk? (CEV)

9:5a

Which is easier:

- Which of these is easier,
- Consider^(plur) whether it is easier
- It is easy

In Greek, this verse begins with a conjunction that is often translated as “for” (ESV). This conjunction probably introduces a basis for Jesus’ statement in 9:4b. The basis is given in 9:5a–6b. The relationship is something like the following:

^{4a}Jesus told the scribes, ^{4b}“You should not think that I blasphemed God when I told this paralyzed man that his sins are forgiven, ^{5a}because...^{6a}I have authority on earth to forgive sins.”

The BSB and many English versions do not translate this conjunction. In many languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either.

9:5b

to say, 'Your sins are forgiven,'

- to say, 'Your^(sing) sins are forgiven,'
- to tell him, 'Your sins are forgiven,'
- to say, 'I forgive your sins.'

Your sins are forgiven: This is a passive clause.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

Your sins are forgiven/canceled

- Use an active verb. For example:

I forgive/pardon your sins

9:5c

or to say, 'Get up and walk?'

- or to say, 'Arise and walk?'
- or whether it is easier to tell him, 'Stand up and walk.'
- It is hard to say, 'Stand up and walk.'

Get up: The phrase Get up is a command to stand up from the mat.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Rise (ESV)

Stand up (NET)

Matthew 9:6

Section 9:1–8: Jesus forgave and healed a paralyzed man

In this section, Matthew continued to write about the power that Jesus has to heal people. But more importantly, he showed that Jesus also has the authority and power to forgive sins (9:6a). In addition, he again showed that faith is important.

When Jesus first told the paralyzed man that his sins were forgiven (9:2d), it began a conflict with the Jewish leaders. (This is the first time that Matthew showed a conflict between Jesus and the Jewish leaders.) This conflict continues in the next sections.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus healed a paralyzed man

Jesus has the power to forgive sins

Healing and Forgiving a Paralytic (NET)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 2:1–12 and Luke 5:17–26.

9:6a

But so that you may know that the Son of Man has authority on earth to forgive sins..."

- But I will show you that the Son of Man has the right to forgive sins here on earth. (CEV)
- But now I will say the other/hard thing so that you^(plur) may know that I the Son of Man have the power on earth to forgive sins."

But: There is some contrast here. The contrast is between the easy thing to say and the hard thing to say. The easy thing to say is "Your sins are forgiven" (in 9:5). In 9:6, Jesus also did the hard thing. He healed the paralyzed man.

Some English versions show this contrast with the conjunction But. Other English versions do not have a conjunction here.

so that you may know that the Son of Man has authority on earth to forgive sins...: This clause expresses Jesus' purpose for healing the paralytic. He wanted the scribes and everyone else to know that he had the authority to forgive sins.

In Greek, as in the BSB, this is not a complete sentence. The BSB uses an ellipsis (...) to show that this is not a complete sentence.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Translate this purpose as a complete sentence. For example:

I want you to know that the Son of Man has authority on earth to forgive sins. (GW)

I will show you that the Son of Man has the right to forgive sins here on earth. (CEV)

- Add some implied information to make it a complete sentence. For example:

But now I will say the other/hard thing so that you may know that the Son of Man has authority on earth to forgive sins

the Son of Man: Jesus used the phrase the Son of Man to refer to himself. In some languages it may be necessary to add the pronoun “I” to show that Jesus was referring to himself. For example:

I, the Son of Man

This phrase also occurs in 8:20b. You should translate it here as you did there. See also Son of Man in KBT for more information.

has authority: The words has authority refer to having the right and the power to do something. God gave Jesus the right and the power to forgive sins.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

has the right (CEV)

has the power

on earth: The phrase on earth indicates that Jesus had the authority to forgive sins while he lived on earth. It was not only at a future time of judgment in heaven that he would have that authority.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

here on earth (CEV)

even on earth

9:6b

Then He said to the paralytic, “Get up, pick up your mat, and go home.”

- Then he said to the paralyzed man, “Get up, pick up your mat and go home.”
- So then he said to the man whose body was paralyzed, “Stand up, take your mat and return to your home.”

Get up: This is the same word as in 9:5c. You should translate it here as you did there.

pick up your mat: The Greek word that the BSB translates as mat is the same word as in 9:2a. It can mean “sleeping mat” or even “stretcher” for carrying sick people.

Here are some other ways to translate this command:

Pick up your mat (CEV)

take your mat (NCV)

go home: Jesus told the man to go back to his home. Jesus wanted to show that the man was healed and could walk. He was not implying that he was annoyed or bothered by the man.

Here are some other ways to translate this command:

return home

you may go home now

Matthew 9:7

Section 9:1–8: Jesus forgave and healed a paralyzed man

In this section, Matthew continued to write about the power that Jesus has to heal people. But more importantly, he showed that Jesus also has the authority and power to forgive sins (9:6a). In addition, he again showed that faith is important.

When Jesus first told the paralyzed man that his sins were forgiven (9:2d), it began a conflict with the Jewish leaders. (This is the first time that Matthew showed a conflict between Jesus and the Jewish leaders.) This conflict continues in the next sections.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus healed a paralyzed man

Jesus has the power to forgive sins

Healing and Forgiving a Paralytic (NET)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 2:1–12 and Luke 5:17–26.

9:7

And the man got up and went home.

- And the man got up and went home!
- Immediately, the man was healed. He stood up and returned to his house.

And the man got up and went home: There is implied information here. Jesus healed the man so that he was able to get up and go home. In some languages, it may be more natural to include this implied information. For example:

And the man was healed, got up and went home

Immediately, the man was healed. He stood up and went home

General Comment on 9:6–7

When Jesus healed the man, this action proved that he had the authority to forgive sins. If people in your area will not see that, you may want to add a footnote to explain. Here is a sample footnote:

Jesus healed the man. This miracle also proved that Jesus had the authority to forgive sins.

Matthew 9:8

Section 9:1–8: Jesus forgave and healed a paralyzed man

In this section, Matthew continued to write about the power that Jesus has to heal people. But more importantly, he showed that Jesus also has the authority and power to forgive sins (9:6a). In addition, he again showed that faith is important.

When Jesus first told the paralyzed man that his sins were forgiven (9:2d), it began a conflict with the Jewish leaders. (This is the first time that Matthew showed a conflict between Jesus and the Jewish leaders.) This conflict continues in the next sections.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus healed a paralyzed man

Jesus has the power to forgive sins

Healing and Forgiving a Paralytic (NET)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 2:1–12 and Luke 5:17–26.

9:8a

When the crowds saw this, they were filled with awe

- When the crowd saw what happened, they were afraid,
- When the people saw that the man was healed, they were filled with awe.

the crowds: The word crowds here refers to the people watching the miracle.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

the group of people

the people

saw this: The pronoun this refers to the miracle of the man being healed. In some languages, it may be necessary to include this information. For example:

When the crowd saw this man healed

When the crowd saw the man get up and walk

they were filled with awe: There is a textual issue in this verse:

1. Some Greek manuscripts have the word that means afraid. For example:

they were afraid (GNT) (BSB, NIV, ESV, GNT, RSV, NJB, NET, GW, CEV, NLT, JBP, NASB, REB)

1. Some Greek manuscripts have the word that means amazed. For example:

they were amazed (NCV) (NCV, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and the majority of English versions. Even though the BSB uses the Greek manuscripts that have the word for afraid, the word awe in the BSB is ambiguous and could mean either “afraid” or “amazed” (or perhaps both).

This Greek word can also mean that the crowd “had feelings of reverence and wonder all at once.” Seeing the power of God caused the people to be afraid and be filled with awe.

Here is another way to translate this word:

They felt fear and great reverence

9:8b

and glorified God, who had given such authority to men.

- and they praised God for giving that kind of authority to people.
- They honored God because he had given such power to human beings.

and glorified God, who had given such authority to men:

The BSB translates 9:8b as a type of relative clause. This type of relative clause is called a non-restrictive relative clause or a descriptive relative clause. Another name for this type of relative clause

is a parenthetical relative clause. (A relative clause is a clause that usually starts with a relative pronoun. Here, the relative pronoun is the word *who*.) This type of relative clause describes God.

In some languages, this type of relative clause will imply that there are two Gods, one who has given authority and one who has not given authority. For those languages, it will be necessary to translate this part of the verse without using a relative clause.

Here are some other ways to translate these clauses:

and they glorified God because he had given such authority to a person/Jesus

and praised God for giving such authority to people (GNT)

glorified: This word indicates that they honored and praised God. For example:

praised (NIV)

honored (NET)

such authority: In this context, the phrase *such authority* could refer to the authority to forgive sins or the authority to heal a paralyzed person or both. It probably refers to both.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

power like this (NCV)

authority like that

that kind of authority

to men: The word *men* is general in this context and refers to people. The people saw Jesus as a prophet to whom God gave power. So they made a general statement about God empowering people.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

to people (GNT)

to human beings (NCV)

Matthew 9:9

Section 9:9–13: Jesus invited Matthew to be his disciple

In this section, Jesus asked a tax collector named Matthew to follow him and be his disciple. Most Jews considered tax collectors to be traitors and thieves. They were traitors because they were Jews who collected taxes for the conquering Roman government. They were thieves because they forced fellow Jews to give them more taxes than the Romans required. Then they kept the extra money and got rich.

Not only did Jesus ask a tax collector to be one of his disciples, he also ate and fellowshiped with other tax collectors and sinners. The Pharisees criticized him for doing this. Jesus responded by telling them that his purpose in coming into the world was to call such sinners to repent. He did not come for people who are righteous or for those who are well. Jesus showed his critics that associating with sinners in order to help them to repent was a proper attitude for believers.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Chooses Matthew (CEV)

The Call of Matthew (NRSV)

The Call of Matthew; Eating with Sinners (NET)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 2:13–17 and Luke 5:27–32.

Paragraph 9:9

In this paragraph, Matthew began another story concerning Jesus. This time he wrote about his own meeting with Jesus. There is movement to another location, and he introduced himself as a new participant. Use whatever is natural in your language for introducing another story in the life of Jesus.

Here are some other ways to introduce this new story:

Then

Next

After that happened

9:9a

As Jesus went on from there,

- ¶ Jesus left that place, and as he walked along, (GNT)
- ¶ Then Jesus left that place. As he was walking,

As Jesus went on from there: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as went on can also mean “move along.” It probably indicates that Jesus left the town of Capernaum (where he had healed the paralyzed man) and was walking along the Sea of Galilee.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

As Jesus went on from there (NIV)

Jesus left that place, and as he walked along (GNT)

9:9b

He saw a man named Matthew sitting at the tax booth.

- he saw a man named Matthew sitting in the tax office.
- he saw a man working in the tax collection place. His name was Matthew.

He saw a man named Matthew: Here Matthew, the author of this Gospel, wrote about himself. He was not trying to focus attention on himself, but rather to focus on Jesus. So he wrote about himself in the third person as if he were another person.

sitting at the tax booth: This expression indicates that Matthew was working as a tax collector when Jesus came by. He was not just sitting there waiting to pay his taxes. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this clearer. For example:

sitting in a booth collecting taxes

working in the tax collector’s booth

at the tax booth: The term tax booth probably refers to some sort of small table under a shelter. Matthew sat there to receive taxes from the people.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in a tax office (GW)

at the place for paying taxes (CEV)

at the place where taxes are collected

9:9c

“Follow Me,” He told him, and Matthew got up and followed Him.

- He said to him, “Follow me.” Matthew rose and followed him.
- Jesus said to him, “Come and follow me as my disciple.” So Matthew got up and followed him.

“Follow Me,” He told him: The BSB places the words He told him after what Jesus said. This is good English style. However, in some languages it may be necessary to put these words at the beginning of 9:9c. For example:

and he said to him, “Follow me.” (ESV)

Follow Me: When Jesus told Matthew to follow him, he meant two things:

1. He wanted him to literally go with him;
2. He wanted him to become his disciple.

If people in your area will think that this is only a literal command to walk behind Jesus, you may want to:

- Include the figurative meaning in the text. For example:

Follow me and be my disciple (NLT)

Come, follow me as my disciple

- Translate the figurative meaning:

Become my disciple

This clause also occurs in 4:19a and 8:22b. You should translate it here as you did there.

He told him: The pronoun He refers to Jesus and the pronoun him refers to Matthew. It may be more natural in your language to translate one of the pronouns as a noun. For example:

Jesus said to him

he told Matthew

Matthew 9:10

Section 9:9–13: Jesus invited Matthew to be his disciple

In this section, Jesus asked a tax collector named Matthew to follow him and be his disciple. Most Jews considered tax collectors to be traitors and thieves. They were traitors because they were Jews who collected taxes for the conquering Roman government. They were thieves because they forced fellow Jews to give them more taxes than the Romans required. Then they kept the extra money and got rich.

Not only did Jesus ask a tax collector to be one of his disciples, he also ate and fellowshiped with other tax collectors and sinners. The Pharisees criticized him for doing this. Jesus responded by telling them that his purpose in coming into the world was to call such sinners to repent. He did not come for people who are righteous or for those who are well. Jesus showed his critics that associating with sinners in order to help them to repent was a proper attitude for believers.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Chooses Matthew (CEV)

The Call of Matthew (NRSV)

The Call of Matthew; Eating with Sinners (NET)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 2:13–17 and Luke 5:27–32.

9:10a

Later, as Jesus was dining at Matthew's house,

- ¶ Later, Jesus went to Matthew's house. While he was eating,
- ¶ Later, Matthew invited Jesus and his disciples to eat at his house. While they were eating,

Later, as Jesus was dining at Matthew's house:

Some events happened between Jesus asking Matthew to follow him (in 9:9c), and Jesus reclining to eat a meal in Matthew's house (in 9:10a). Somewhere between these two events, Matthew invited Jesus and his disciples to come and eat at his house, and they went.

In some languages, it is important to include some of this implied information. For example:

Later Matthew invited Jesus and his disciples to eat at his home. While they were eating

Later, Matthew invited Jesus and his disciples to his home as dinner guests (NLT)

Later, as Jesus: In Greek, only Jesus is mentioned here. However, in 9:10c, Jesus' disciples are also mentioned. In some languages, it will be more natural to mention the disciples here. For example:

Jesus and his disciples (CEV)

was dining: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *was dining* is literally just “reclined” or “lay.” The Greek text does not mention eating explicitly. However, the BSB and many other English versions translate this word to imply eating because it is common for many people in western cultures to “recline” at tables to eat. Also 9:10c explicitly mentions eating, so it likely that this Greek verb indicates Jesus' physical posture as he ate.

In this context, the Greek word probably means that Jesus was lying on his side on a low couch or cushion as he ate. His head was propped on one elbow. This was one of the positions that people of Jesus' time used when they ate, especially if it was a special meal.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

was having a meal (GNT)

was eating

at Matthew's house: This phrase refers to Matthew's house.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

in Matthew's house (GNT)

9:10b

many tax collectors and sinners came

- many tax collectors and many sinners surprisingly came
- many collectors of taxes and many other evil/sinful people came

The Greek of 9:10b begins with a word that is often translated as “behold.” It indicates that something extraordinary will happen. The BSB does not translate this word. Here, what is unexpected is that Jesus and his disciples ate with tax collectors and other sinners. This is something that Pharisees would not do.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

it happened (NJB)

unexpectedly

tax collectors: The term tax collectors refers to Jews who collected taxes from their fellow Jews. These Jews were employed by the conquering Romans to do this. The Romans did not pay them wages. Rather they allowed the tax collectors to take extra taxes as their pay. But many tax collectors took a lot extra and made themselves rich. So most Jews considered them to be traitors who worked for an oppressive foreign power. They also considered them to be thieves. And since tax collectors had contact with the Gentile Romans, they were also considered to be religiously contaminated (“unclean”).

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

people who collect taxes

people who took money from the people for the Roman government

This term also occurs in 5:46b.

If people in your area will not think of tax collectors as bad people, you may want to include some implied information.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- Include some implied information in the term tax collectors. For example:

corrupt tax collectors

evil tax collectors

- Include some implied information in the term sinners that reflects on tax collectors. For example:

tax collectors and other sinners (CEV)

sinners: The word sinners refers to two other types of Jews:

1. Jews who were sinful/immoral. They did not follow the laws of Moses, and
2. Jews who did not follow the strict laws of the Pharisees regarding how to remain ceremonially clean/pure.

The Pharisees believed that they would become unclean/impure if they associated with either of these types of people. So they shunned them.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

lawbreakers

other people whom the Jewish leaders regarded as sinful people

people who were thought/said to be evil/sinful

outcasts (GNT)

9:10c

and ate with Him and His disciples.

- and were eating with Jesus and his disciples.
- and ate with them.

ate with Him and His disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as ate is literally “reclined with” or “lay with.” It is a similar word to the one used of Jesus in 9:10a (“was dining”). As in 9:10a, the word ate indicates that the tax collectors and sinners ate a meal with Jesus and his disciples.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

and ate with him and his disciples (NIV)

and joined them at the meal

Matthew 9:11

Section 9:9–13: Jesus invited Matthew to be his disciple

In this section, Jesus asked a tax collector named Matthew to follow him and be his disciple. Most Jews considered tax collectors to be traitors and thieves. They were traitors because they were Jews who collected taxes for the conquering Roman government. They were thieves because they forced fellow Jews to give them more taxes than the Romans required. Then they kept the extra money and got rich.

Not only did Jesus ask a tax collector to be one of his disciples, he also ate and fellowshiped with other tax collectors and sinners. The Pharisees criticized him for doing this. Jesus responded by telling them that his purpose in coming into the world was to call such sinners to repent. He did not come for people who are righteous or for those who are well. Jesus showed his

critics that associating with sinners in order to help them to repent was a proper attitude for believers.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Chooses Matthew (CEV)

The Call of Matthew (NRSV)

The Call of Matthew; Eating with Sinners (NET)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 2:13–17 and Luke 5:27–32.

9:11a

When the Pharisees saw this, they asked His disciples,

- When the Pharisees saw this/that/it, they asked his disciples,
- Some of the Pharisee people saw them all eating together, and they said to Jesus' disciples,

the Pharisees: The word Pharisees refers to men who were members of a particular Jewish religious group. The Pharisees believed that it was necessary to strictly obey all the laws of the Old Testament. It was also very important to them to carefully obey many other religious laws that they added. They also said that other people must obey these laws.

The Pharisees and the Sadducees were the two most influential religious groups of the time. There were many more Pharisees than Sadducees.

Here are some other ways to translate Pharisees:

- Transliterate the word Pharisees according to the sounds of your language and indicate that it refers to a group of people. For example:

Farisi members

Parise adherents

- Transliterate the word Pharisees and indicate that it refers to a group of people with certain beliefs. For example:

people belonging to the Farise religious sect/
group

members of the Jewish group called the Farasi

This word Pharisees also occurs in 3:7a and 5:20a.

Also, not all the Pharisees were there. In some languages, it is more natural to follow the GNT which says:

Some Pharisees (GNT)

saw this: The word this refers to Jesus and his disciples eating with tax collectors and sinners. In some languages, it may be more natural to use the word “that” or to describe what they saw. For example:

saw that/it

saw them all eating together

observed what was happening

9:11b

“Why does your Teacher eat with tax collectors and sinners?”

- “Why does your^(plur) teacher eat with tax collectors and other sinners?”
- “Your teacher should not eat with such wicked people!”

Why does your Teacher eat with tax collectors and sinners?: This is a rhetorical question. It is a rebuke.

The Pharisees rebuked and criticized Jesus for associating with sinners. Eating with them showed that he accepted them. The Pharisees also believed that a religious person would become unclean/impure if he ate with a sinner. They wanted everyone to realize that it was wrong for Jesus to eat with these types of people, and they did not approve of it.

Here are some other ways to translate this rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

How is it that your teacher eats with tax collectors and other sinful people?

Why does your teacher eat with such wicked people?

- As a statement. For example:

It is wrong for your teacher to eat with tax collectors and other sinners!

Jesus should not be eating with such sinful people.

Translate this rebuke in a way that is natural in your language.

tax collectors and sinners: Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- Translate it the same way as you did in 9:10b.
- Shorten it. For example:

with such people (GNT)

Matthew 9:12

Section 9:9–13: Jesus invited Matthew to be his disciple

In this section, Jesus asked a tax collector named Matthew to follow him and be his disciple. Most Jews considered tax collectors to be traitors and thieves. They were traitors because they were Jews who collected taxes for the conquering Roman government. They were thieves because they forced fellow Jews to give them more taxes than the Romans required. Then they kept the extra money and got rich.

Not only did Jesus ask a tax collector to be one of his disciples, he also ate and fellowshiped with other tax collectors and sinners. The Pharisees criticized him for doing this. Jesus responded by telling them that his purpose in coming into the world was to call such sinners to repent. He did not come for people who are righteous or for those who are well. Jesus showed his critics that associating with sinners in order to help them to repent was a proper attitude for believers.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Chooses Matthew (CEV)

The Call of Matthew (NRSV)

The Call of Matthew; Eating with Sinners (NET)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 2:13–17 and Luke 5:27–32.

9:12a

On hearing this, Jesus said,

- ¶ But when Jesus heard it/that, he said,
- ¶ But when Jesus heard what they said, he responded with this proverb,

There is a contrast here. The Greek of 9:12a begins with a conjunction that is often translated as “but.” The contrast is between the belief of the Pharisees that Jesus was doing wrong, and the truth that Jesus was helping these sinners come back to God. Some English versions indicate this contrast with the conjunction “but.” For example:

But when he heard it. (ESV)

The BSB omits this conjunction and leaves the contrast with 9:11 implicit.

On hearing this, Jesus said: Jesus heard the question of the Pharisees to his disciples, and he answered it himself.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus heard them and answered (GNT)

When Jesus heard that, he said (GW)

9:12b–c

It is not the healthy who need a doctor, but the sick:

Jesus responded to the Pharisees’ rhetorical question with a proverb. In this proverb, Jesus used the words healthy, sick, and doctor in a spiritual sense. The people who are healthy represent the Pharisees. They think that they are well and do not need any spiritual help. The people who are sick represent the tax collectors and sinners. They know that they need Jesus’ help. The doctor represents Jesus, who can help the sinners to become righteous.

In some languages, it may be necessary to put some of the above information in a footnote to explain this proverb.

Also, in some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of the clauses. For example:

Those who are sick need a doctor, not those who are well.

9:12b

“It is not the healthy who need a doctor,

- “People who are well do not need a doctor,
- “People who are healthy do not seek a doctor to cure/heal them.

the healthy: This clause refers to people who are healthy and physically well.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Those who are well (ESV)

people who are not sick

who need a doctor: The word doctor is another word for a physician. This clause means that people who are healthy do not need a doctor to cure/treat them.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

do not need a doctor

do not seek a doctor to cure them

9:12c but the sick.

- but people who are sick.
- It is the people who are not healthy who seek a doctor to cure them.

but the sick: Some words from the previous clause are implied but not repeated here. In some languages, it may be more natural to repeat some of those words from the previous clause. For example:

but it is sick people who need a doctor

but the people who need a doctor to cure them
are the people who are not well

Matthew 9:13

Section 9:9-13: Jesus invited Matthew to be his disciple

In this section, Jesus asked a tax collector named Matthew to follow him and be his disciple. Most Jews considered tax collectors to be traitors and thieves. They were traitors because they were Jews who collected taxes for the conquering Roman government. They were thieves because they forced fellow Jews to give them more taxes than the Romans required. Then they kept the extra money and got rich.

Not only did Jesus ask a tax collector to be one of his disciples, he also ate and fellowshiped with other tax collectors and sinners. The Pharisees criticized him for doing this. Jesus responded by telling them that his purpose in coming into the world was to call such sinners to repent. He did not come for people who are righteous or for those who are well. Jesus showed his critics that associating with sinners in order to help them to repent was a proper attitude for believers.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Chooses Matthew (CEV)

The Call of Matthew (NRSV)

The Call of Matthew; Eating with Sinners (NET)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 2:13-17 and Luke 5:27-32.

9:13a But go and learn what this means:

- Go^(plur) and learn what it means when God said,
- Read/Study more carefully and learn the correct meaning of these words that God said,

But go and learn: The clause go and learn is an expression that rabbis used when teaching their students. It means that the person should look more closely at the passage and learn what its real meaning is.

The Greek word translated here as go does not mean to literally “go.” It is a way of challenging the people to study the passage more carefully. If people will think that this word literally means to go somewhere, then it may be good to leave it out.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Study/Read more carefully and learn

Go and learn to follow

Learn (GW)

what this means: The word this refers to the quote from the book of Hosea that follows. In some languages, it may be good to indicate that what follows is a quote from the Bible.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

what it means when God said

the correct meaning of the words which are written in God’s book

9:13b ‘I desire mercy, not sacrifice.’

- ‘Kindness is what I want, not sacrifice.’
- ‘I want you to have pity on others more than I want your sacrifices.’

I desire mercy, not sacrifice: This quote from Hosea is a comparison of two things: mercy and sacrifice. It means that mercy is more important than sacrifice. It does not mean that God wanted his people to stop offering sacrifices. God did not abolish animal sacrifice for the Jews with this saying. God spoke these words about 700 years before Jesus came. At that time, the Jews were following all the correct rituals in worship, but were murdering and stealing and doing many other bad things to each other (Hosea 6:7–10).

In some languages, it may be more natural to express this comparison in another way. For example:

I want kindness more than I want animal sacrifices. (NCV)

I: The pronoun I refers to God. Jesus quoted words that God spoke. If people will think that the pronoun I is Jesus speaking about himself, you should indicate that God spoke here. For example:

when God said, ‘I...’

desire mercy: The word mercy means “compassion, concern, or pity toward someone in serious need.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

It is kindness that I want (GNT)

want you to pity

In some languages it may be necessary to indicate who should have mercy and to whom. For example:

I want you to be merciful to others. (CEV)

I want people to pity/love others.

sacrifice: The word sacrifice refers to the killing of animals at the temple and offering them to God. God required the Jews to offer animal sacrifices to him regularly.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

animal sacrifices (GNT)

offering sacrifices to me (CEV)

9:13c

For I have not come to call the righteous,

- I did not come to call people who do what is right,
- I eat with such people, because I did not come to earth to invite to repent those who think that they are upright.

Jesus’ quote from Hosea finished at the end of 9:13b. Here Jesus resumed speaking in his own words. If this is not clear in your translation, you may want to add some type of introduction. For example:

Jesus continued

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For introduces the final part of Jesus’ answer to the Pharisees’ question (in 9:11b). It introduces the reason clause (4:6b) of a reason-result statement. The result is implied. The implied information is: “I eat with tax collectors and sinners.”

result (implied)	I eat with tax collectors and sinners ,
reason	for/because I came not to call the righteous, but sinners.

Without the implied information, the word For does not make much sense. Many English versions leave it untranslated.

I have not come: Jesus used the clause I have not come to introduce a general statement about the purpose of his ministry. He used the verb come here in the sense that he came “to the earth” or came “from God.” He was not referring to coming to Matthew’s house.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I did not come to earth

The reason I came from God was not to call the righteous

to call: The verb call means “invite.” It does not mean to shout or use a loud voice.

Matthew did not specify exactly what Jesus was calling sinners to do. In this context, the word call may refer to:

1. A call to repent (which is based on Jesus dealing with sinners and the theme of forgiveness in 9:6a).

2. A call to follow him and become his disciple (which is based on Jesus calling Matthew in 9:9c).
3. A call to accept him as Savior (which is one of the major themes of the book of Matthew).

The parallel passage in Luke 5:32 says “call...to repentance.” So if you use a verb that requires you to indicate the purpose of the call, you should indicate that it is a call to repent.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

to call to repent

to invite to turn to God

the righteous: The word righteous refers to people who live according to God’s standards. In other words, they consistently do what is right.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

those who obey God’s law

people who do what is right

In some languages there may be an idiom to describe this. For example:

people who follow a straight path

upright/straight people

In this context Jesus was using irony. There are no truly righteous people because everyone has sinned. He may have referred to people who think that they are doing what is right and do not recognize their sins.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

those who think they are righteous (NLT)

9:13d but sinners.”

- but/instead I came to call sinners.”
- Rather I came to call/invite sinners to repent.”

but: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between what was not Jesus’ purpose in coming to earth (in 9:13c), and what was his purpose in coming (in 9:13d). Some English versions indicate this contrast with the conjunction but.

In some languages, no conjunction is necessary. The clauses themselves will indicate the contrast. For example:

“I didn’t come to invite good people to be my followers. I came to invite sinners. (CEV)

sinners: Some words from the previous clause are implied but not repeated here. In some languages, it may be more natural to repeat those words. For example:

I came to invite sinners. (CEV)

I have come to call/urge sinners to repent.

General Comment on 9:13c–d

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of the clauses in 9:13c–d. For example:

I have come to call sinners, not those who think they are already good enough. (NLT96)

Matthew 9:14

Section 9:14–17: Jesus’ new teachings are better than the old customs

In this section, a third group of people, John’s disciples, criticized Jesus. (The first group was the scribes in 9:3. The second group was the Pharisees in 9:11.) They criticized Jesus and his disciples for not fasting. Jesus explained that there is a time for fasting and a time for not fasting. He explained that one day his followers would fast, but they would not fast while he was with them. This was different than the custom of always fasting twice a week like the Pharisees (and probably also the disciples of John) did.

So Jesus again showed that his new teachings were different than the old customs that the Jewish religious leaders had adopted. (He had started showing this in 6:16–18, where he taught his followers how to fast. They should fast in a way that other people do not notice that they are fasting. This was different from the Jewish practice of fasting with a sad face so other people would notice.)

Then Jesus told two parables to continue to explain that his new teachings are different than old Jewish religious customs. These parables indicate that his new teachings cannot be mixed with the old customs. They cannot be added to the old customs.

Many English translations begin this section with a heading like “Jesus Questioned About Fasting” (NIV)

or “The Question about Fasting” (GNT). However, since 9:16–17 includes more than fasting, you should follow the heading above or one of the examples below:

The Superiority of the New (NET)

The new ways of Jesus are better than the old ways

Concerning the new ways that Jesus taught

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 2:18–22 and Luke 5:33–39.

9:14a

At that time John’s disciples came to Jesus and asked,

- ¶ Then the disciples of John came to Jesus and asked,
- ¶ One day, some of John the Baptist’s disciples came to Jesus. They said to him,

At that time: The conjunction At that time introduces a new story. This story did not necessarily happen immediately after the previous section, but it was probably close to the same time. The Greek text does not indicate how much time passed between these two stories.

Here are some other ways to introduce this new story:

One day (CEV)

Then (ESV)

In those same days

John’s disciples: In the same way that Jesus had disciples who followed him and learned from him, John the Baptist also had disciples who followed him and learned from his teachings. You should translate the word disciples here in the same way as for Jesus’ disciples. Your translation of the term disciples should be general enough to allow for other people to have disciples as well. (9:10c).

In some languages, it will be good to make it clear that the name John refers to John the Baptist. For example:

the disciples of John the Baptist (NLT)

See how you translated “John the Baptist” in 3:1.

Also, probably only some of John’s disciples came. If people will think that all of them came, you may want to make it clear. For example:

some of the disciples of John

9:14c

but Your disciples do not fast?”

- but your^(sing) disciples do not fast?”
- What is the reason that your disciples do not abstain from eating?”

9:14b–c

Why is it that we and the Pharisees fast so often, but Your disciples do not fast?: This is a real question. The main part of the question is “Why is that...Your disciples do not fast?” The words we and the Pharisees fast are information that was already known and not really part of the question. Make sure that people do not misunderstand the question and think that John’s disciples were asking why they (John’s disciples) and the Pharisees were fasting.

Here are some other ways to translate this question to make these things clearer:

- Divide the question into a statement and a question. For example:

We and the Pharisees fast. How is it that your disciples do not fast?

We and the Pharisees fast, but your disciples do not fast. Why?

- Change the order. For example:

Why don’t your disciples fast like we do and the Pharisees do? (NLT)

9:14b

“Why is it that we and the Pharisees fast so often,

- “How is it that we^(excl) and the Pharisees often fast,
- “We^(excl) regularly abstain from eating, and so do the Pharisees.

Why is it that: These words introduce a real question. They ask the reason for something. In some languages, a question that begins with the word Why will imply that what follows is a rhetorical question that is a rebuke. So be careful to translate this as a real question.

Here are some other ways to introduce this question:

Why do

How is it that (NIV)

What is the reason that

we and the Pharisees fast so often: There is a textual issue here:

1. Some Greek manuscripts include a word that means “often.” (BSB: so often). For example:

we and the Pharisees fast often (GNT) (BSB, GNT, NET, KJV, NRSV, CEV, GW, NCV)

1. Some Greek manuscripts do not include the Greek word that means “often.” For example:

we and the Pharisees fast (RSV) (NIV, ESV, NASB, RSV, NLT, REB, JBP, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). Many Greek manuscripts have it, and many English versions follow it. This word does occur in the UBS Greek New Testament, 4th edition, but it is given a C rating indicating that the committee had difficulty in deciding whether to place it in the text. In addition, even if the word “often” were not part of the Greek text, it would be natural to add it in some languages to make the meaning clear.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

we and the Pharisees fast regularly

we fast often, and so do the Pharisees

we: The pronoun we is exclusive. It refers to John the Baptist’s disciples but not to Jesus’ disciples.

fast: The word fast means “choose not to eat for religious reasons.” People fast to humble themselves, to show sadness for their sins, or to seek God’s will or help. People usually fasted for one day, but it could be a shorter or longer period of time.

John’s disciples and the Pharisees fasted once or twice a week.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

do not eat to honor God

stop eating to dedicate the day to God

abstain from eating to worship God

The word fast also occurs in 6:16a.

Matthew 9:15

Section 9:14–17: Jesus’ new teachings are better than the old customs

In this section, a third group of people, John’s disciples, criticized Jesus. (The first group was the scribes in 9:3. The second group was the Pharisees in 9:11.) They criticized Jesus and his disciples for not fasting. Jesus explained that there is a time for fasting and a time for not fasting. He explained that one day his followers would fast, but they would not fast while he was with them. This was different than the custom of always fasting twice a week like the Pharisees (and probably also the disciples of John) did.

So Jesus again showed that his new teachings were different than the old customs that the Jewish religious leaders had adopted. (He had started showing this in 6:16–18, where he taught his followers how to fast. They should fast in a way that other people do not notice that they are fasting. This was different from the Jewish practice of fasting with a sad face so other people would notice.)

Then Jesus told two parables to continue to explain that his new teachings are different than old Jewish religious customs. These parables indicate that his new teachings cannot be mixed with the old customs. They cannot be added to the old customs.

Many English translations begin this section with a heading like “Jesus Questioned About Fasting” (NIV) or “The Question about Fasting” (GNT). However, since 9:16–17 includes more than fasting, you should follow the heading above or one of the examples below:

The Superiority of the New (NET)

The new ways of Jesus are better than the old ways

Concerning the new ways that Jesus taught

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 2:18–22 and Luke 5:33–39.

9:15d
then they will fast.

- and then they will fast.
- That is when they will abstain from eating.

9:15a-d

Jesus replied, “How can the guests of the bridegroom mourn while He is with them? But the time will come when the bridegroom will be taken from them; then they will fast....”: In this verse, Jesus used an illustration or extended metaphor to answer the question that John’s disciples asked. He compared himself to a bridegroom and his disciples to a bridegroom’s friends.

The people listening to Jesus would have understood this comparison. If your readers will not understand it, it may be necessary to make it explicit.

Here are some other ways to translate this extended metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor as in the BSB.
- Change the metaphor to a simile and make Jesus and the disciples explicit. For example:

He compared himself to a bridegroom, and his disciples to the bridegroom’s guests. He said, “Can the wedding guests mourn as long as the bridegroom is with them?...”

My disciples are like guests at a wedding. Can they be sad while I, the groom, am still with them? The time will come when I, the groom, will be taken away from them. Then they will fast.

Can the wedding guests mourn as long as the bridegroom is with them? No! My disciples are like that. One day, I, the bridegroom will be taken away from them, and then they will fast

- Translate the meaning directly in the text and add a footnote explaining the metaphor. For example:

Can my disciples be sad while I am still with them? The time will come when I will be taken away from them. Then they will fast.

Sample footnote:

Jesus said that his disciples did not fast because he was still with them. In Greek, he illustrated this teaching by using an illustration of the friends of a bridegroom. The friends would not be sad at the wedding while the bridegroom was still with them. It is only after the bridegroom is taken away

from them that they would become sad and would fast. So his disciples would be sad and fast when Jesus’ enemies would take him away from them.

9:15a

Jesus replied,

- And Jesus said to them, (ESV)
- Then Jesus answered them with a parable,
- Jesus answered them with a story/illustration. He said,

Jesus replied: The words that follow are in reply to the question in 9:14. Use a verb that is natural in your language in this context. For example:

Jesus answered (NIV)

Jesus answered their question with a parable. Use a natural way in your language to introduce the parable. For example:

Jesus answered them with a proverb/parable

9:15b

“How can the guests of the bridegroom mourn while He is with them?”

- “Do the friends of the groom mourn while he is with them?”
- “The friends of the man getting married cannot grieve while he is with them.
- “My disciples are like the friends of the groom. Do they mourn while I, the groom, am still with them? No!

How can the guests of the bridegroom mourn while He is with them?: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus used this rhetorical question to emphasize that the guests will/can not mourn while the bridegroom is with them. A wedding is a happy time.

Here are some other ways to translate this emphasis:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Do wedding guests mourn while celebrating with the groom? Of course not. (NLT)

- As a statement. For example:

The friends of the bridegroom are not sad while he is with them. (NCV)

Translate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

guests of the bridegroom: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as guests of the bridegroom refers to the friends of the bridegroom. They help the bridegroom organize the wedding, and they help him during the wedding.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

friends of the bridegroom (NCV)

the wedding guests (ESV)

In some cultures, marriage customs may be so different from those of the Jews that the term guests may be difficult to translate. For example, there may be no celebration at the time of a couple's marriage, or the bridegroom may not be involved in the celebration. If that is true in your culture, you may need to use a very general phrase. For example:

people invited to the wedding

friends who are celebrating with the man-who-has-gotten-a-wife

bridegroom: The word bridegroom refers to the man who is getting married. In modern English, this man is simply called the "groom."

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

groom (GW)

young man getting married

mourn: The Greek word that the BSB translates as mourn means "be sad, grieve, or weep." It is what people do at a funeral, not a wedding.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

be sad (GNT)

grieve

while He is with them: The Greek word that the BSB translates as He is literally "the bridegroom." However, since the BSB already used the word "bride-

groom" in the expression "the guests of the bridegroom," it uses the pronoun here.

Additionally, the BSB capitalizes the pronoun He to make it clear that Jesus is referring to himself. If this would be confusing in your language, consider making it clear that the pronoun refers to the "bridegroom."

9:15c

But the time will come when the bridegroom will be taken from them;

- But the day will come when the bridegroom will be taken away from them,
- But one day, someone/people will take the groom from them.

But: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between the current time of happiness (15a-b) and the later time of sadness and fasting (15c-d). Some English versions indicate this contrast with the conjunction But. However, some English versions, like the ESV, omit this conjunction.

the time will come: This clause refers to a future time when Christ, the bridegroom, will be taken away from the disciples.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the day will come (GNT)

the time will come (NIV)

someday (NLT)

one day

when the bridegroom will be taken from them: This clause refers to the time when Jesus, the bridegroom, will be forcibly taken away from his disciples. It refers to his arrest, trial, and crucifixion. It does not refer to the bridegroom leaving on his own.

The verb will be taken is passive. Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

when the groom will be taken away from them (GW)

- Use an active verb. For example:

when people will take away the bridegroom

Matthew 9:16

Section 9:14–17: Jesus' new teachings are better than the old customs

In this section, a third group of people, John's disciples, criticized Jesus. (The first group was the scribes in 9:3. The second group was the Pharisees in 9:11.) They criticized Jesus and his disciples for not fasting. Jesus explained that there is a time for fasting and a time for not fasting. He explained that one day his followers would fast, but they would not fast while he was with them. This was different than the custom of always fasting twice a week like the Pharisees (and probably also the disciples of John) did.

So Jesus again showed that his new teachings were different than the old customs that the Jewish religious leaders had adopted. (He had started showing this in 6:16–18, where he taught his followers how to fast. They should fast in a way that other people do not notice that they are fasting. This was different from the Jewish practice of fasting with a sad face so other people would notice.)

Then Jesus told two parables to continue to explain that his new teachings are different than old Jewish religious customs. These parables indicate that his new teachings cannot be mixed with the old customs. They cannot be added to the old customs.

Many English translations begin this section with a heading like "Jesus Questioned About Fasting" (NIV) or "The Question about Fasting" (GNT). However, since 9:16–17 includes more than fasting, you should follow the heading above or one of the examples below:

The Superiority of the New (NET)

The new ways of Jesus are better than the old ways

Concerning the new ways that Jesus taught

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 2:18–22 and Luke 5:33–39.

Paragraph 9:16–17

In this paragraph, Jesus told two other parables or extended metaphors to illustrate that his way cannot just be added to the old Jewish ways. If it is, both ways are destroyed. You may want to begin with some words to remind people that Jesus continues to speak. For example:

Jesus also said,

Jesus continued with two stories/parables,

9:16a–d

No one sews a patch of unshrunk cloth on an old garment. For the patch will pull away from the garment, and a worse tear will result: This is an extended metaphor. In this metaphor, Jesus compared his teaching to cloth that has not yet shrunk. This is a new cloth. He compared the traditions of the Jews to an old garment. No one uses a piece of unshrunk (new) cloth to patch an old garment. In the same way, people should not simply add his teaching to their traditions.

Here are some other ways to translate this extended metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor and add a footnote to explain the meaning. Here is a sample footnote:

In this parable, Jesus compared his teaching to new cloth that no one has washed yet. He compared the traditions of the Jews to an old garment. No one uses a piece of new cloth to patch an old cloth. In the same way, people should not add his teaching to their old customs.

- Add some words of introduction before the metaphor to explain it. For example:

Then Jesus told a parable to explain that his new teachings cannot fit into the old teachings. He said, "No one sews a patch of unshrunk cloth on an old garment...."

- Make explicit some of the meaning within the metaphor. For example:

If my teaching is mixed with the old traditions, it will be like putting a piece of unshrunk cloth on an old garment. No one does that, because the new piece will shrink and tear the old cloth. My teaching will become unusable just like the cloth.

Whichever method you choose, you should also indicate some of the meaning in the section heading. See the examples listed above under the section heading.

9:16a

No one sews

- ¶ No one stitches
- ¶ Then Jesus told some parables to explain that his new teachings cannot fit into the old teachings. He said, People do not patch

- ¶ If my teaching is mixed with the old traditions, it is as if someone mends/repairs

No one: The phrase No one introduces a general statement. It says something that is true of everyone. In some languages, it may be natural to introduce this statement with a general word like “people” or with a pronoun like “you” or “they.” For example:

People do not put a piece of unshrunk cloth on an old garment.

You do not put a piece of unshrunk cloth on an old garment.

sews: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sews also means “lays on.” The parable clearly indicates that the piece of new cloth is attached to the old garment. So a more specific word for this is something like “sew.”

Here are some other ways to translate this:

patches up (GNT)

puts (ESV)

attaches

9:16b

a patch of unshrunk cloth on an old garment.

- an unshrunk/new piece of cloth on an old piece of clothing,
- a tear in old clothes with a new piece of cloth that will shrink.
- a hole in an old coat with a piece of new cloth that will shrink. No one does that.

a patch of unshrunk cloth: This phrase refers to a piece of cloth that is new and has not yet been washed. Some types of cloth shrink (that is, get a little smaller) when they are washed for the first time. Before being washed, such cloth is unshrunk.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

a piece of new cloth (GNT)

a new piece of cloth that will shrink (GW)

an old garment: This phrase refers to any kind of old clothing.

The piece of new cloth is sewed over a hole or tear in the old clothing. You may want to make some of this information explicit. For example:

over a hole in an old coat (NCV)

a tear in an old piece of clothing

9:16c

For the patch will pull away from the garment,

- because the new patch will pull/rip away from the cloth
- If they do, the new piece of cloth will shrink and tear away from that part of the old cloth,

For: The conjunction For introduces the reason why “no one sews a patch of unshrunk cloth on an old garment.” It is because the new unshrunk cloth would shrink when the garment was washed, but the old part of the garment would not. This then would create a tear in the garment.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

because

The reason is that

There is some information in 9:16b that is not stated but implied. It is “if someone were to sew a patch of unshrunk cloth on an old garment.” It may be more natural in your language to include this implied information in the translation. For example:

because if someone were to sew a patch of unshrunk cloth on an old garment

If he does (NCV)

the patch will pull away from the garment: This clause indicates that the patch of new cloth shrinks and pulls away from the part of the old garment it was sewn to.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the new patch will shrink (GNT)

the new patch would shrink and rip away from the old cloth (NLT)

9:16d and a worse tear will result.

- and make the tear bigger/longer.
- and the hole will become bigger.

and a worse tear will result: This clause means that the tear/hole in the cloth will become bigger.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

and the tear will become worse (GW)

and the hole will become bigger

Matthew 9:17

Section 9:14–17: Jesus' new teachings are better than the old customs

In this section, a third group of people, John's disciples, criticized Jesus. (The first group was the scribes in 9:3. The second group was the Pharisees in 9:11.) They criticized Jesus and his disciples for not fasting. Jesus explained that there is a time for fasting and a time for not fasting. He explained that one day his followers would fast, but they would not fast while he was with them. This was different than the custom of always fasting twice a week like the Pharisees (and probably also the disciples of John) did.

So Jesus again showed that his new teachings were different than the old customs that the Jewish religious leaders had adopted. (He had started showing this in 6:16–18, where he taught his followers how to fast. They should fast in a way that other people do not notice that they are fasting. This was different from the Jewish practice of fasting with a sad face so other people would notice.)

Then Jesus told two parables to continue to explain that his new teachings are different than old Jewish religious customs. These parables indicate that his new teachings cannot be mixed with the old customs. They cannot be added to the old customs.

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The Superiority of the New (NET)

The new ways of Jesus are better than the old ways

Concerning the new ways that Jesus taught

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 2:18–22 and Luke 5:33–39.

Paragraph 9:16–17

In this paragraph, Jesus told two other parables or extended metaphors to illustrate that his way cannot just be added to the old Jewish ways. If it is, both ways are destroyed. You may want to begin with some words to remind people that Jesus continues to speak. For example:

Jesus also said,

Jesus continued with two stories/parables,

9:17a–e

Neither do men pour new wine into old wineskins. If they do, the skins will burst, the wine will spill, and the wineskins will be ruined. Instead, they pour new wine into new wineskins, and both are preserved: This verse is also an extended metaphor. This metaphor teaches the same thing as the metaphor in 9:16. It teaches that Jesus' new teaching cannot fit with the old Jewish customs.

man carrying a wineskin

In this metaphor Jesus used an illustration from wine making. The Jews made wine in a container that was a whole goat skin whose legs had been tied shut. (See the illustration above.) After they poured the grape juice into the skin, they then tied shut the neck. When the wine fermented, it expanded. A new skin stretches to hold the wine. But an old skin is brittle and does not stretch. An old skin would break or split and all the wine would spill out.

Jesus compared his teaching to new wine and new wineskins. Jewish traditions were like old wineskins. Jesus' new teaching was too different to fit into the old traditions of the Jews.

Here are some other ways to translate this extended metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor and add a footnote to explain the meaning. Here is a sample footnote:

In this parable, Jesus compared his teaching to new wine and a new wineskin. He compared the traditions of the Jews to an old wineskin. No one pours new wine into an old wineskin. In the same way, people should not add his teaching to their old customs.

- Add some words of introduction before the metaphor to explain it. For example:

Jesus told another parable to explain that his new teachings cannot fit into the old teachings. He said, “Neither do men pour new wine into old wineskins....”

Jesus compared his teaching with new wine. He said, “Neither do men pour new wine into old wineskins....”

- Make explicit some of the meaning within the metaphor. For example:

No one pours new wine into old wineskins.... My teaching is like new wine. It cannot fit into the old customs.

If my teaching is mixed with the old traditions, it will be like someone pouring new wine into old wineskins. No one does that. If they do, the skins burst....

9:17a

Neither do men pour new wine into old wineskins.

- Also, no one puts new wine into old animal skin containers.
- Similarly, people do not pour the new/unfermented juice of grapes into old bags made of skin/leather.

Neither do men: The word Neither indicates that what follows is similar to 9:16. People do not sew a new patch on an old garment, and they do not pour new wine into old wineskins.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

And no one (NET)

Also, people never (NCV)

Similarly

new wine: The phrase new wine refers to the juice of grapes that have been recently squeezed. The juice is not yet fermented or is just beginning to ferment.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- Use your word for an alcoholic drink made from the juice of a fruit.

- Use a phrase to describe what wine is. For example:

fresh juice of grapes ready to bubble/ferment

new juice of vine fruit called grapes about to ferment/mature

- Use a local word for an alcoholic drink. For example:

new beer

old wineskins: As mentioned above, a “wineskin” is a container usually made of a whole goat skin. It was used like a pot to store liquids. People tied shut the legs, and after pouring liquid into it, would also tie shut the neck to keep in the liquid. Jews made wine in this type of container.

a wineskin

An old wineskin was one in which wine had already been made. It had already stretched. An old wineskin is stiff and can easily crack.

Here are some other ways to translate old wineskins:

old goatskin containers/bags

old containers made of skin/leather

dried leather/skin gourds

9:17b

If they do, the skins will burst,

- Otherwise, when the wine ferments, the containers will burst,
- If they do, the juice will bubble and the bags will expand and break.

If they do: This phrase indicates that the following words are a result of doing what was not normally done. In this case, it indicates what would happen if someone did pour new wine into old wineskins.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

otherwise (NJB)

If someone were to pour new wine into old wine-skins

the skins will burst: When wine ferments, it creates bubbles that cause the skins to expand. An old skin

has already stretched, and so it will break. In some languages, it may be necessary to include some of this implied information. For example:

the wine will ferment and the containers will burst

the wine will bubble and the bags will expand and break

9:17c

the wine will spill, and the wineskins will be ruined.

- the wine will spill, and the containers will be spoiled/destroyed.
- The wine will pour out and the old bags will become useless/bad.

the wine will spill: This clause refers to the wine pouring out of the torn wineskins.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the wine will pour out (GNT)

the juice will come/run out on the ground

the wineskins will be ruined: This clause refers to the wineskins becoming useless.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the skins are destroyed (ESV)

the bags will not be good for anything

9:17d

Instead, they pour new wine into new wineskins,

- Instead, new wine is put into new animal skin containers,
- Rather, people pour fresh juice of grapes into new bags made of skin/leather.

Instead: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between the thing that people do not do (in 9:17a–c) and the thing that they do (in 9:17d). The BSB indicates this contrast with the conjunction *Instead*.

Here are some other ways to show this contrast:

No (NIV)

But (ESV)

Rather (GW)

Several English versions do not translate this Greek word and let the context indicate the negative-positive contrast.

new wineskins: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as new wineskins can also be translated as “fresh wineskins.” For example:

fresh wineskins (ESV)

These are wineskins that have not yet been used.

9:17e

and both are preserved.”

- and then both will keep/remain in good condition.”
- Then neither one will be spoiled/destroyed.”

and both are preserved: This clause means that both the new wine and the new wineskins remain good and are not ruined.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

and both are saved (GW)

Then both will continue to be good (NCV)

and nothing will be ruined/lost

Matthew 9:18

Section 9:18–26: Jesus healed a sick woman and raised a dead girl

In this section, Matthew continued to write about the power that Jesus has to heal people. In addition, he again showed that faith is important.

There are two stories in this section. In one story Jesus healed a woman who had a bleeding problem for twelve years. This story is told in the middle of another story. In that story, he raised to life a girl who had recently died.

According to the law of Moses, a woman who had a bleeding problem was unclean. If a normal Jew came in contact with such a woman, he became impure. Also, according to the law of Moses, a dead body was unclean. If a normal Jew touched a dead body, he became unclean. But these two women did not contaminate Jesus. Instead, power went out from Jesus to heal the bleeding woman, and his supernatural power caused the girl to become alive again.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

A Dead Girl and a Sick Woman (NIV)

A sick woman is healed and a dead girl lives again

Jesus Heals in Response to Faith (NLT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 5:21–43 and Luke 8:40–56.

9:18a

While Jesus was saying these things,

- ¶ While he/Jesus was saying those things to them,
- ¶ While Jesus was still speaking with John's disciples,

While Jesus was saying these things: The phrase these things refers to the words that Jesus spoke in 9:14–17.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

While Jesus was still speaking (CEV)

while he was talking to John's disciples (GW)

9:18b

a synagogue leader came and knelt before Him.

- a religious leader suddenly came and bowed down before him
- a leader of the synagogue unexpectedly came and prostrated himself before him.

The Greek of 9:18b begins with a word that is often translated as “behold.” It indicates that something extraordinary will happen. Here, what is unexpected is that a religious leader arrived with sad news.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

suddenly (NRSV)

unexpectedly

a synagogue leader: The Greek word that the BSB translates as synagogue leader is literally “ruler.” This word can refer to a political or religious leader. Mark and Luke refer to this person as “a ruler in the synagogue” (Mark 5:22, Luke 8:41). So you should use a term that refers to a religious leader.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

a Jewish religious leader

the leader of a synagogue (NLT)

See how you translated the word “synagogues” in 4:23.

knelt before Him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as knelt before is more literally “prostrated himself before.” This word refers to kneeling and putting one's face to the ground with arms outstretched. In Jewish culture, this position showed humility and an earnest desire for one's request to be accepted.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

bowed low in front of him (NJB)

knelt down before him (NLT96)

prostrated himself before him

9:18c

“My daughter has just died,” he said.

- and said, “My daughter has just died,
- He said, “Sir, my daughter has just now died.

has just died: The phrase has just died indicates that the girl died very recently, probably minutes before the ruler spoke to Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

has just now died (CEV)

has died not long ago

9:18d

“But come and place Your hand on her, and she will live.”

- but she will live if you come and place/put your hand on her.”
- Please come and touch her, and she will live again.”

But come and place Your hand on her, and she will live: Verse 9:18d–e is a request. The ruler asked Jesus to make his daughter alive again.

There is also a contrast here. The contrast is between the daughter dying and the daughter living again. The BSB indicates this contrast with the conjunction But.

Some ways to connect 9:18d–e to the rest of the verse are:

- Make the contrast clearer by changing the order of the clauses in 9:18d–e. For example:

“My daughter has just died,” he said, “but you can bring her back to life again if you just come and lay your hand on her.” (NLT)

- Make the request clearer and lessen the contrast. For example:

“The man said, “My daughter has just now died!
“Please come and place your hand on her. “Then she will live again.” (CEV)

come and place Your hand on her: This is a polite request. It is not a command. By first bowing down, the ruler showed that he respected Jesus and was politely asking him to come to his house and raise his daughter to life. In some languages, it may be necessary to add something to show that the ruler was politely asking Jesus to raise his daughter. For example:

Please come and place your hand on her. (CEV)

I beg you to come and touch her.

In some languages, it may also be necessary to indicate in 9:18c that the ruler was being polite. For example:

Sir, my daughter has just died.

she will live: The daughter had died, but the father wanted her to live again.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

she will live again (CEV)

she will return to life

The ruler believed that Jesus was able to cause his daughter to live again. So he used the future tense and not words of possibility such as “she might live.” Your translation should indicate or imply that the ruler believed that Jesus was able to cause his daughter to live again.

Matthew 9:19

Section 9:18–26: Jesus healed a sick woman and raised a dead girl

In this section, Matthew continued to write about the power that Jesus has to heal people. In addition, he again showed that faith is important.

There are two stories in this section. In one story Jesus healed a woman who had a bleeding problem for twelve years. This story is told in the middle of another story. In that story, he raised to life a girl who had recently died.

According to the law of Moses, a woman who had a bleeding problem was unclean. If a normal Jew came in contact with such a woman, he became impure. Also, according to the law of Moses, a dead body was unclean. If a normal Jew touched a dead body, he became unclean. But these two women did not contaminate Jesus. Instead, power went out from Jesus to heal the bleeding woman, and his supernatural power caused the girl to become alive again.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

A Dead Girl and a Sick Woman (NIV)

A sick woman is healed and a dead girl lives again

Jesus Heals in Response to Faith (NLT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 5:21–43 and Luke 8:40–56.

9:19

So Jesus got up and went with him, along with His disciples.

- And/So Jesus got up and went with him, and his disciples did likewise.
- So Jesus and his disciples stood up and began to follow him to the/his house.

So Jesus: Jesus responded positively to the ruler’s request to go to his house to bring his daughter back to life. In some languages, it may be more natural to indicate that this is a response to the ruler’s request. For example:

In response Jesus got up

Jesus agreed. He got up

got up: The verb got up refers to Jesus standing from his position of reclining while eating (9:10). For example:

rose (ESV)

stood

and went with him: Here the verb went with is used in its literal sense. It indicates that Jesus allowed the ruler to lead the way to his house. Jesus followed the ruler to his house. Here this verb does not imply that Jesus became his disciple.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

and followed him (ESV)

and accompanied him

While Jesus and his disciples were on their way to the ruler's house, a woman (9:20–22) interrupted his journey in order to get healed. So they do not complete their journey to the house of the ruler until 9:23. In some languages, it may be necessary to indicate that Jesus only began his journey. For example:

began going with him

started following him to his house

along with His disciples: This phrase indicates that Jesus' disciples also "got up" and "went with" the ruler. The information about the disciples is after the actions of Jesus. This is perhaps to show that it was Jesus who made the decision to go with the ruler.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

and his disciples did likewise

and his disciples also went with him

Jesus and his disciples got up and followed him (NET)

Matthew 9:20

Section 9:18–26: Jesus healed a sick woman and raised a dead girl

In this section, Matthew continued to write about the power that Jesus has to heal people. In addition, he again showed that faith is important.

There are two stories in this section. In one story Jesus healed a woman who had a bleeding problem for twelve years. This story is told in the middle of another story. In that story, he raised to life a girl who had recently died.

According to the law of Moses, a woman who had a bleeding problem was unclean. If a normal Jew came in contact with such a woman, he became impure. Also, according to the law of Moses, a dead body was unclean. If a normal Jew touched a dead body, he became unclean. But these two women did not contaminate Jesus. Instead, power went out from Jesus to heal the bleeding woman, and his supernatural power caused the girl to become alive again.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

A Dead Girl and a Sick Woman (NIV)

A sick woman is healed and a dead girl lives again

Jesus Heals in Response to Faith (NLT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 5:21–43 and Luke 8:40–56.

9:20a

Suddenly a woman who had suffered from bleeding for twelve years

- ¶ Just then, a woman who had been bleeding for twelve years
- ¶ There was a certain woman. She had been bleeding for twelve years. While Jesus was on his way she suddenly
- ¶ While they were walking along, a certain woman who had been bleeding for 12 years

Suddenly: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Suddenly indicates that something extraordinary will happen. Here, what is unexpected is that while they were going to the ruler's house, a woman came and touched Jesus' robe.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

And behold (ESV)

unexpectedly

Just then (NIV)

a woman: In some languages, it is necessary to introduce a new main participant in a certain way. In that case the woman should be introduced in a way that is natural in the language. For example:

There was a certain woman. She had a bleeding sickness for twelve years. While Jesus was on his way, she suddenly...

who had suffered from bleeding for twelve years:

The Greek word that the BSB translates as suffered from bleeding is more literally “bleeding.” The word suffered is not in Greek.

The Greek does not indicate where the woman was bleeding from. She was probably bleeding from the womb at times that were not normal. For politeness sake, the Greek term is general. She had started bleeding twelve years prior to this time and probably bled most of the twelve years.

In some languages, there is a term for this kind of bleeding. In other languages, it is more natural to use a polite form (euphemism). Here is an example of each:

who had been bleeding for twelve years (CEV)

who had continual menstrual bleeding for twelve years

General Comment on 9:20a

The clause “who had suffered from bleeding for twelve years” is information about the woman. In English, such information is often put in a relative clause, as it is here. In some languages, it may be more natural to give this information in a separate sentence. Notice how the following examples give the information about the woman:

Then a woman came up behind Jesus and touched the edge of his clothes. She had been suffering from chronic bleeding for twelve years. (GW)

There was a certain woman. She had been bleeding for twelve years. She approached Jesus from behind and touched the edge of his clothes.

9:20b

came up behind Him and touched the fringe of His cloak.

- came close behind Jesus and touched one of the tassels on his coat.
- approached him from the rear and touched the strings/threads on the edge of his robe.
- approached Jesus from behind and touched the border/hem of his clothes.

came up behind Him: This expression indicates that the woman approached Jesus from behind. She had probably been following Jesus, and she walked quickly so she could get close enough to him to touch his clothes.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

came close to him from the rear

approached him from behind (JBP)

Tassels on a Jewish man’s prayer shawl

touched the fringe of His cloak: The Greek word that the BSB translates as fringe probably refers to one of the “tassels” that were attached to Jesus’ clothes. The Jews made these tassels by tying strings together, and they attached these tassels to the four corners of their outer clothes. When they saw these tassels, they were supposed to remember to follow God’s commandments. (Num. 15:37-38; Deut. 22:12).

Like any male Jew, Jesus probably wore tassels. The woman probably touched this part of Jesus’ clothing so he would not feel the touch.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

- Translate it with a word or phrase that refers specifically to tassels. For example:

touched the strings/threads on the hem of his clothes

- Translate it with a word or phrase that refers generally to the hem or edge of his clothes. For example:

touched the edge of his clothes (GW)

touched the hem/border of his robe

cloak: The Greek word that the BSB translates as cloak is a general word that means clothing. In this context, this word refers to the outer layer of clothing.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

garment (ESV)

clothes (CEV)

robe (NLT)

coat (NCV)

Matthew 9:21

Section 9:18–26: Jesus healed a sick woman and raised a dead girl

In this section, Matthew continued to write about the power that Jesus has to heal people. In addition, he again showed that faith is important.

There are two stories in this section. In one story Jesus healed a woman who had a bleeding problem for twelve years. This story is told in the middle of another story. In that story, he raised to life a girl who had recently died.

According to the law of Moses, a woman who had a bleeding problem was unclean. If a normal Jew came in contact with such a woman, he became impure. Also, according to the law of Moses, a dead body was unclean. If a normal Jew touched a dead body, he became unclean. But these two women did not contaminate Jesus. Instead, power went out from Jesus to heal the bleeding woman, and his supernatural power caused the girl to become alive again.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

A Dead Girl and a Sick Woman (NIV)

A sick woman is healed and a dead girl lives again

Jesus Heals in Response to Faith (NLT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 5:21–43 and Luke 8:40–56.

9:21a

She said to herself, “If only I touch His cloak,

- She did this because she was saying to herself, “If I just touch his coat/robe,
- She was thinking, “If I only touch his clothes,
- She did that because she thought that if she could only touch his robe,

The Greek of 9:21a begins with a word that is often translated as “for.” It introduces the reason for the woman touching Jesus’ clothes. She touched Jesus clothes (9:20b), for/because she thought she would be healed (9:21).

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

because

The reason she did this was because

The BSB and some other English versions do not translate this word and allow the context to imply the connection.

She said to herself: The words said to herself probably means that she thought the words rather than spoke them aloud.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

she was saying to herself (NASB)

she was thinking (NJB)

If only I touch His cloak: The woman believed that she would be healed just by touching Jesus’ clothes. She thought that it was not necessary to touch Jesus’ body to be healed. She also thought that Jesus did not need to say something or touch her for her to be healed.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

If I can just touch his clothes (CEV)

Even if I only touch his clothes

9:21b

I will be healed.”

- I will get well!”
- God will heal me.”
- she would become well.

I will be healed: This clause is passive.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

General Comment on 9:21

- Use a passive verb. For example:

I will be made well (ESV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

God will heal me

In some languages, it may be more natural to use indirect speech here. For example:

She thought that if she only touched his coat, she would become well.

General Comment on 9:20–21

The woman was saying those things to herself before she touched Jesus' clothes. In some languages, it may be more natural to place 9:21a–b before 9:20b. For example:

^{20a}A woman with a bleeding sickness for twelve years was there. ^{21a}She was saying to herself, "If I just touch his clothes, ^{21b}I will get well!" ^{20b}So she came close behind Jesus and touched the edge of his robe.

Matthew 9:22**Section 9:18–26: Jesus healed a sick woman and raised a dead girl**

In this section, Matthew continued to write about the power that Jesus has to heal people. In addition, he again showed that faith is important.

There are two stories in this section. In one story Jesus healed a woman who had a bleeding problem for twelve years. This story is told in the middle of another story. In that story, he raised to life a girl who had recently died.

According to the law of Moses, a woman who had a bleeding problem was unclean. If a normal Jew came in contact with such a woman, he became impure. Also, according to the law of Moses, a dead body was unclean. If a normal Jew touched a dead body, he became unclean. But these two women did not contaminate Jesus. Instead, power went out from Jesus to heal the bleeding woman, and his supernatural power caused the girl to become alive again.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

A Dead Girl and a Sick Woman (NIV)

A sick woman is healed and a dead girl lives again

Jesus Heals in Response to Faith (NLT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 5:21–43 and Luke 8:40–56.

9:22a

Jesus turned and saw her. "Take courage, daughter," He said,

- Jesus turned and saw her and said, "Daughter, cheer up!
- Then Jesus turned around, and when he saw the woman he said, "My child, do not worry.

This verse begins abruptly. In some languages, it may be more natural to begin this verse with a conjunction or some type of phrase to connect it to the previous verses. For example:

But Jesus turned (KJV)

Then Jesus turned

When she did that, Jesus turned

Jesus turned and saw her: The verb turned indicates that Jesus turned around to face the woman who was behind him.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus turned around and saw her (GNT)

Jesus turned around, and when he saw her (NLT)

Take courage: The Greek word that the BSB translates with the idiom Take courage means "Cheer up" or "Be encouraged." It is a word of encouragement. The woman expected Jesus to be angry at her for touching him. So, he tried to comfort her.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Cheer up, (GW)

Be encouraged (NCV)

Don't worry! (CEV)

This word also occurs in 9:2d.

daughter: The word daughter indicates that Jesus cared for the woman. She was precious to him. You should use an expression that would be appropriate for Jesus to use to indicate his care and concern for a woman in need.

If using the word daughter in your language will indicate that this woman was Jesus' real daughter, you should use another word that indicates that Jesus cared for her. For example:

dear one

my friend

my child

9:22b

“your faith has healed you.”

- Your faith/believing has caused you to be healed.”
- You trusted in me, and that is why you have been cured.”

your faith has healed you: In this clause Jesus told the woman why she was healed. She was healed because of her faith. It was not a magical touching of Jesus' clothes that healed her.

In this context, the words your faith refers to the woman believing that Jesus had the power to heal her.

In some languages, it is more natural to translate the noun faith with a clause. For example:

your believing has made you well

you have trusted in me, and that is why you have been healed

because you believed that I could heal you, you have been made well

your believing has caused you to be made well

has healed you: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as has healed is the same verb as in 9:21b. You should use the same expression here.

The tense of this verb indicates that the woman had already been healed when Jesus spoke these words.

She was healed because of her faith when she touched the clothes of Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

you are cured

has healed you (NIV)

you are made well/better

9:22c

And the woman was cured from that very hour.

- From that time on, the woman was healed.
- From that day on, the woman was cured of that sickness.

was cured: The Greek word that the BSB translates as cured is the same verb as “healed” in 9:22b. You should use the same verb here.

This clause refers to the woman being healed from her bleeding sickness only. It does not indicate that she was always healthy without any type of sickness afterwards. In some languages, it may be necessary to include some implied information here. For example:

was healed from that sickness

from that very hour: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as from that very hour is more literally “from that hour/time.” There are two ways to interpret this phrase:

1. It means that the woman was healed from the time that she touched Jesus' clothes. In other words, she was healed as soon as she touched Jesus' clothes. According to this interpretation, the words “your faith has healed you” are an explanation of why the woman was healed. This interpretation is supported by Carson who says, “The woman was healed on touching Jesus' cloak. He said that it was her faith that was effective, not the superstition mingled with it. This seems better than the view that holds that Jesus first encouraged the woman...and then healed her without any reference to touching.... The final clause of v. 22 should therefore be interpreted to mean, not that the woman was healed from the “moment” Jesus spoke, but that she was healed from the hora (lit., “hour”) of this encounter with Jesus.” (p. 230–231) For example:

From that day on, the woman was healed.

1. It means that the woman was healed as soon as Jesus said the words “your faith has made you well.” According to this interpretation, the words “your faith has made you well” are what caused the woman to be healed. This interpretation is supported by Hagner who says, “It is clear that from Matthew’s perspective, it was Jesus who had made the woman whole again.... Matthew stresses the immediate occurrence of the healing, after or by the word of Jesus. Thus Jesus sovereignly announces that the woman has been healed, and from the hour she is healed.” (p. 249) For example:

And instantly the woman was made well. (RSV)

Many English versions translate the Greek phrase literally, and it is not possible to tell which interpretation they follow. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). In the parallel passage in Luke 8:44, it is clear that the woman’s bleeding stopped as soon as she touched Jesus’ clothes. She was already healed when Jesus said “your faith has made you well.” So you should not use an expression that indicates that she was healed only when Jesus spoke in 9:22a–b.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

From that time on

From that day on

Matthew 9:23

Section 9:18–26: Jesus healed a sick woman and raised a dead girl

In this section, Matthew continued to write about the power that Jesus has to heal people. In addition, he again showed that faith is important.

There are two stories in this section. In one story Jesus healed a woman who had a bleeding problem for twelve years. This story is told in the middle of another story. In that story, he raised to life a girl who had recently died.

According to the law of Moses, a woman who had a bleeding problem was unclean. If a normal Jew came in contact with such a woman, he became impure. Also, according to the law of Moses, a dead body was unclean. If a normal Jew touched a dead body, he became unclean. But these two women did not contaminate Jesus. Instead, power went out from Jesus to heal the bleeding woman, and his supernatural power caused the girl to become alive again.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

A Dead Girl and a Sick Woman (NIV)

A sick woman is healed and a dead girl lives again

Jesus Heals in Response to Faith (NLT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 5:21–43 and Luke 8:40–56.

Paragraph 9:23–26

This paragraph finishes the story started in 9:18–19 about the girl who died. If you have a way to show that the story of the girl continues at this point, you may want to use it here. For example:

After that, Jesus went into the official’s house.

Jesus continued along with the leader and went into his house. (NCV)

Then Jesus continued walking to the official’s house. When he arrived...

9:23a

When Jesus entered the house of the synagogue leader,

- ¶ Then Jesus went and arrived at the house of the religious leader.
- ¶ Then Jesus continued walking to the synagogue leader’s house. When he arrived there, he entered

entered the house of the synagogue leader: This clause can mean that Jesus “arrived at the synagogue leader’s house,” or that he “entered into the synagogue leader’s house.” For example:

Jesus arrived at the official’s home (NLT)

Jesus went into the home of the official (CEV)

You should translate whichever one is most natural in your culture.

synagogue leader: This is the same synagogue leader who was mentioned in 9:18b. Use the same word for this person as you did there.

9:23b

He saw the flute players and the noisy crowd.

- He saw flute players and a crowd making noise.
- and saw musicians playing funeral songs and a crowd wailing and making noise.

flute players: This clause refers to people who were paid to come to a house where someone died. They were paid to play sorrowful tunes on a flute.

A flute is a musical instrument. It is a tube closed at one end and with holes along the length. A person blows in or across an opening at one end to make the sounds.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the funeral flute players

people playing musical instruments

musicians playing funeral songs

people playing songs of mourning

the noisy crowd: This clause refers to people who were paid to come to a house where someone died. They were paid to wail and make other noises of mourning. It probably also includes the noise of people coming and going and talking over the wailing and music.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the crowd making noise

a crowd wailing/mourning

Matthew 9:24

Section 9:18–26: Jesus healed a sick woman and raised a dead girl

In this section, Matthew continued to write about the power that Jesus has to heal people. In addition, he again showed that faith is important.

There are two stories in this section. In one story Jesus healed a woman who had a bleeding problem for twelve years. This story is told in the middle of another story. In that story, he raised to life a girl who had recently died.

According to the law of Moses, a woman who had a bleeding problem was unclean. If a normal Jew came in contact with such a woman, he became impure. Also, according to the law of Moses, a dead body was unclean. If a normal Jew touched a dead body, he

became unclean. But these two women did not contaminate Jesus. Instead, power went out from Jesus to heal the bleeding woman, and his supernatural power caused the girl to become alive again.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

A Dead Girl and a Sick Woman (NIV)

A sick woman is healed and a dead girl lives again

Jesus Heals in Response to Faith (NLT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 5:21–43 and Luke 8:40–56.

Paragraph 9:23–26

This paragraph finishes the story started in 9:18–19 about the girl who died. If you have a way to show that the story of the girl continues at this point, you may want to use it here. For example:

After that, Jesus went into the official's house.

Jesus continued along with the leader and went into his house. (NCV)

Then Jesus continued walking to the official's house. When he arrived...

9:24a

“Go away,” He told them. “The girl is not dead, but asleep.”

- He said, “Leave! The girl is not dead but asleep.”
- He said to them, “Get out of here! The girl is only sleeping. She is not dead.”

“Go away,” He told them: The BSB places the words He told them after what Jesus said. In some languages, it may be necessary to place these words at the beginning of 9:24a. For example:

he said, “Go away...” (ESV)

Go away...The girl is not dead: The Greek of 9:24a uses a conjunction that is often translated as “for” (ESV) to introduce the basis for the command to leave. For example:

Go away, for the girl is not dead (ESV)

Many English versions allow the context to indicate this, and they leave this word untranslated.

Go away: The words Go away are a command to the people to leave the house.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Get out of here (NJB)

Leave

girl: Mark and Luke describe the dead girl as being twelve years old. Use a term for a girl of that age.

is not dead, but asleep: Jesus knew that the girl was dead, but he alone knew that her death was temporary. He knew that he would soon bring her back to life. So, he figuratively referred to her as asleep. As someone wakes from sleep, Jesus would bring the girl back from death.

Jesus was purposely speaking in a way that could be misunderstood. The meaning of his words would only be clear when the girl was alive again. So it is recommended that you translate the word asleep literally.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

is not dead; she is asleep (NJB)

the girl is only sleeping, she is not dead

If people in your area will think that Jesus was confused or wrong when he said that the girl was not dead, but asleep, you may want to include a footnote to explain. A footnote could include some of the above information.

9:24b

And they laughed at Him.

- Then they began making fun of him.
- When they heard that, they started ridiculing/mock-ing him.

And: The crowd reacted to Jesus' words by laughing at him. In some languages, it is natural to introduce this type of reaction with a word or phrase. For example:

But they laughed at him. (NIV)

Then they all started making fun of him. (GNT)

When they heard this, they laughed at him

they laughed at Him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as laughed at can also mean "ridicule." Since they knew the girl was dead, they probably thought Jesus was wrong or stupid to say that she was asleep.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

they began making fun of him (NET)

they ridiculed him (NJB)

they laughed, making fun of him

Matthew 9:25

Section 9:18–26: Jesus healed a sick woman and raised a dead girl

In this section, Matthew continued to write about the power that Jesus has to heal people. In addition, he again showed that faith is important.

There are two stories in this section. In one story Jesus healed a woman who had a bleeding problem for twelve years. This story is told in the middle of another story. In that story, he raised to life a girl who had recently died.

According to the law of Moses, a woman who had a bleeding problem was unclean. If a normal Jew came in contact with such a woman, he became impure. Also, according to the law of Moses, a dead body was unclean. If a normal Jew touched a dead body, he became unclean. But these two women did not contaminate Jesus. Instead, power went out from Jesus to heal the bleeding woman, and his supernatural power caused the girl to become alive again.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

A Dead Girl and a Sick Woman (NIV)

A sick woman is healed and a dead girl lives again

Jesus Heals in Response to Faith (NLT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 5:21–43 and Luke 8:40–56.

Paragraph 9:23–26

This paragraph finishes the story started in 9:18–19 about the girl who died. If you have a way to show that

the story of the girl continues at this point, you may want to use it here. For example:

After that, Jesus went into the official's house.

Jesus continued along with the leader and went into his house. (NCV)

Then Jesus continued walking to the official's house. When he arrived...

9:25a

After the crowd had been put outside, Jesus went in

- When the crowd had been sent outside, he entered the room
- But Jesus made the crowd leave. When they left, he went into the girl's room

There is a contrast here. The Greek of 9:25a begins with a conjunction that is often translated as "but." At first, the people did not obey Jesus' order to leave. They only laughed at him. But he did not give up. He still made them leave the house. Some English versions introduce this verse with a "But." For example:

But as soon as the people had been put out (GNT)

The BSB and some other English versions do not begin this verse with any conjunction. You should begin this verse in a way that is natural in your language.

After the crowd had been put outside: The Greek word that the BSB translates as had been put outside is literally "thrown out" (as in the NCV). Here this word refers to forcing the crowd out of the house. Jesus had already told the crowd to leave, so he probably again ordered them to leave. The family may have also helped him make the crowd leave. The crowd was probably not literally grabbed and thrown out.

The clause is passive. Here are some ways other ways to translate this:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

after the crowd had been sent out of the house (CEV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

Jesus again ordered/commanded them to go outside and they went

Jesus went in: This clause implies that Jesus entered the room of the dead girl. He was already in the house.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus went into the girl's room (NCV)

he entered the room where the dead girl was lying

9:25b

and took the girl by the hand, and she got up.

- and took hold of her hand, and she got up.
- and held the girl's hand. She became alive again and sat/stood up.

and took the girl by the hand: In this context, the verb took means "held."

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

took hold of her hand (NCV)

held her hand

and she got up: This clause indicates that the girl either sat up or stood up. The clause implies that she returned to life.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

she sat/stood up

she became alive again and got up

Matthew 9:26

Section 9:18-26: Jesus healed a sick woman and raised a dead girl

In this section, Matthew continued to write about the power that Jesus has to heal people. In addition, he again showed that faith is important.

There are two stories in this section. In one story Jesus healed a woman who had a bleeding problem for twelve years. This story is told in the middle of another story. In that story, he raised to life a girl who had recently died.

According to the law of Moses, a woman who had a bleeding problem was unclean. If a normal Jew came in contact with such a woman, he became impure. Also, according to the law of Moses, a dead body was unclean. If a normal Jew touched a dead body, he became unclean. But these two women did not conta-

minate Jesus. Instead, power went out from Jesus to heal the bleeding woman, and his supernatural power caused the girl to become alive again.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

A Dead Girl and a Sick Woman (NIV)

A sick woman is healed and a dead girl lives again

Jesus Heals in Response to Faith (NLT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 5:21–43 and Luke 8:40–56.

Paragraph 9:23–26

This paragraph finishes the story started in 9:18–19 about the girl who died. If you have a way to show that the story of the girl continues at this point, you may want to use it here. For example:

After that, Jesus went into the official's house.

Jesus continued along with the leader and went into his house. (NCV)

Then Jesus continued walking to the official's house. When he arrived...

9:26

And the news about this spread throughout that region.

- The report of this miracle swept through the entire countryside. (NLT)
- As a result, people began telling others about this healing all over the country.

This verse gives a summary of the results of this healing. People told the story of this miracle throughout the whole region. Some languages have a special way of introducing this type of result at the end of a true story. For example:

And the result is that this news spread...

And so the news of this spread...

And the news about this spread: The word this refers to the miracle of raising the dead girl. People told

others about this miracle so that people throughout a large area heard about it.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

News of this spread (NIV)

The report of this miracle swept (NLT)

People told others about this miracle

throughout that region: The Greek word that the BSB translates as region also means “land, district.” It probably refers to the district of Galilee.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

through all that district (ESV)

through the entire countryside (NLT)

throughout all the nearby villages

Matthew 9:27

Section 9:27–34: Jesus healed two blind men and a mute man

In this section, Jesus performed two more miracles of healing. First, he healed two blind men because they had faith in him. Afterward he asked them not to tell other people about him healing them because he did not want people to try and make him an earthly king. But they were so happy that they told people anyway.

Then Jesus healed a man who was unable to talk because a demon was controlling him. The Pharisees did not believe that Jesus' power was from God, so they said Jesus got his power from Satan, the leader of demons.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Two blind men and a mute man are healed by Jesus

Jesus healed two blind men and forced a demon out of a mute man

9:27a

As Jesus went on from there, two blind men followed Him,

- ¶ Then Jesus left that place. While he was walking, two blind men followed him.
- ¶ Then Jesus and his disciples left that house. As they were walking along, two men who could not see started following them

The Greek of 9:27a begins with a conjunction that is often translated as “and.” It indicates that this is the beginning of a new story in the life of Jesus. The BSB omits this conjunction. Use a natural way in your language to indicate this. For example:

Then

Jesus left the ruler’s house and

After that happened, Jesus left the ruler’s house.

As Jesus went on from there: The Greek word that the BSB translates as went on indicates that Jesus left the house of the religious leader and his daughter. It also indicates that he was moving away from the house. He was walking. This same word occurs in 9:9a.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus left that place, and as he walked along (GNT)

As Jesus was walking along (CEV)

Then Jesus left there. While he was walking

Jesus’ disciples were certainly with him. In some languages, it may be natural to mention their being with him. For example:

Then Jesus and his disciples left that place. As they were walking

two blind men: The word blind means “not able to see.” Another way to translate this is:

two men who could not see

followed Him: In this context, the verb followed is used in its literal sense. It indicates that the blind men were walking some distance behind Jesus. As 9:27b indicates, they wanted to speak to Jesus. Here this verb does not imply they were his disciples.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

walked behind him

followed along after him

9:27b

crying out, “Have mercy on us, Son of David!”

- They were shouting, “Son of David, pity us!”
- and yelling, “You the promised Descendant of King David, please show kindness to us and help/heal us!”

crying out: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as crying out means that the men were “shouting.” They were shouting to be sure that Jesus would hear them. This phrase does not mean that the men were weeping loudly.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

shouting (NET)

calling out (NIV)

yelling

The blind men were shouting while they followed Jesus.

Have mercy on us, Son of David!: This clause is the blind men’s polite request for Jesus to heal them. Translate it in a way that shows that the men were being polite. For example:

Please have mercy on us, Son of David.

In some languages, it may also be necessary to make explicit that the men wanted Jesus to heal them. For example:

Son of David, please have mercy on us and heal us

Have mercy on us: The word mercy means “compassion” or “pity” towards someone. The blind men wanted Jesus to pity them, and therefore heal them.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Show kindness to us

pity us and heal us

This word also occurs in 9:13b.

Son of David: This phrase is a title that means that Jesus was a descendant of King David. The Jews used this title to refer to the Messiah (Christ), because God promised that the Messiah would be a descendant of David (Isaiah 9:6–7, 11:1–5, Jeremiah 23:5). In some languages, it may be necessary to make this information explicit. For example:

the Descendant of King David

the promised Son/Descendant of King David

In some languages, it may be helpful to add a footnote. A sample footnote is:

God promised that one of King David's descendants would be the Messiah (Isaiah 9:6–7, 11:1–5, Jeremiah 23:5). The Jews were expecting this promised person to come, and they referred to him by the title "Son of David."

Matthew 9:28

Section 9:27–34: Jesus healed two blind men and a mute man

In this section, Jesus performed two more miracles of healing. First, he healed two blind men because they had faith in him. Afterward he asked them not to tell other people about him healing them because he did not want people to try and make him an earthly king. But they were so happy that they told people anyway.

Then Jesus healed a man who was unable to talk because a demon was controlling him. The Pharisees did not believe that Jesus' power was from God, so they said Jesus got his power from Satan, the leader of demons.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Two blind men and a mute man are healed by Jesus

Jesus healed two blind men and forced a demon out of a mute man

9:28a

After Jesus had entered the house, the blind men came to Him.

- Then he went into his house, and the blind men followed him and approached him.

- When Jesus arrived at the house where he was staying, he entered. The two men who could not see also entered and approached him.

After Jesus had entered the house: The phrase the house probably refers to the house where Jesus stayed when he was in Capernaum. The house of the ruler was probably also in Capernaum. So, in this story, Jesus did not travel far.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

After Jesus went inside (NCV)

When Jesus arrived at the house where he was staying, he entered.

When Jesus arrived at his house, he entered, and

the blind men came to Him: The clause the blind men came to Him means that the blind men also entered the house and approached him. They still wanted to be healed.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

and the blind men followed him (GW)

the men who could not see went in also and approached him

9:28b

"Do you believe that I am able to do this?" He asked.

- He asked them, "Do you^(dual/plur) believe that I can heal you?"
- He asked them, "Do you believe that I am able to cause you to see?"

"Do you believe that I am able to do this?" He asked: The BSB places the words He asked after the words that Jesus said. In some languages, it may be necessary to place these words at the beginning of 9:28b. For example:

and Jesus said to them, "Do you believe that I am able to do this?" (ESV)

The word this refers to healing their blindness. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this information more explicit. For example:

Do you believe that I can heal you? (GNT)

Do you believe I can make you see? (NLT)

9:28c

“Yes, Lord,” they answered.

- They said, “Lord, yes!”
- They answered, “Lord, yes! We^(dual) believe that you are able to heal us.”

“Yes, Lord,” they answered: The BSB places the words they answered after what the blind men said. In some languages, it may be necessary to place these words at the beginning of 9:28c. For example:

They said to him, “Yes, Lord.” (ESV)

Yes, Lord: In some languages, it is more natural to have the word Lord first. For example:

Lord, yes!

It is also more natural in some languages to include what they are saying Yes to. For example:

Yes, Lord, we believe

Lord, yes, we believe that you are able to heal us

Lord: The word Lord means “master.” It was a polite title used when addressing a respected leader.

This word also occurs in 8:21b. You will probably want to translate it here as you did there.

Matthew 9:29

Section 9:27–34: Jesus healed two blind men and a mute man

In this section, Jesus performed two more miracles of healing. First, he healed two blind men because they had faith in him. Afterward he asked them not to tell other people about him healing them because he did not want people to try and make him an earthly king. But they were so happy that they told people anyway.

Then Jesus healed a man who was unable to talk because a demon was controlling him. The Pharisees did not believe that Jesus’ power was from God, so they said Jesus got his power from Satan, the leader of demons.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Two blind men and a mute man are healed by Jesus

Jesus healed two blind men and forced a demon out of a mute man

9:29a

Then He touched their eyes

- Then he/Jesus touched their eyes

9:29b

and said, “According to your faith will it be done to you.”

- and said, “Because of your faith, let/may it happen to you.”
- and said, “I heal you, because you believe.”
- and said, “Because you believe that I am able to heal you, be healed.”

9:29a–b

According to your faith: This phrase means “Because of your faith” or “Because you believe.” For example:

Because of your faith (NLT)

Because you believe I can make you see again (NCV)

The word faith also occurs in 9:2b. It is the noun form of the verb “believe” (in 9:28b).

will it be done to you: By pronouncing these words, Jesus did a miracle and healed the blind men. This type of statement is similar to “let there be light” in Genesis. When God or Jesus pronounced words like this, the thing happened.

This statement is more than just a wish or a blessing. It is a command that the blind men be healed.

Here the word it refers to the healing.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Let/May it happen to you

it will happen (NLT)

you will be healed (CEV)

I heal you

The same statement occurs in 8:13a–b where Jesus healed the centurion’s servant.

Matthew 9:30

Section 9:27–34: Jesus healed two blind men and a mute man

In this section, Jesus performed two more miracles of healing. First, he healed two blind men because they had faith in him. Afterward he asked them not to tell other people about him healing them because he did not want people to try and make him an earthly king. But they were so happy that they told people anyway.

Then Jesus healed a man who was unable to talk because a demon was controlling him. The Pharisees did not believe that Jesus’ power was from God, so they said Jesus got his power from Satan, the leader of demons.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Two blind men and a mute man are healed by Jesus

Jesus healed two blind men and forced a demon out of a mute man

9:30a

And their eyes were opened.

- And they were able to see.
- And immediately their eyes became well.
- As soon as he said that, their eyes were healed.

And their eyes were opened: This clause is an idiom. It means that the two men’s eyes were healed, and they were able to see. It does not mean that their eyes had been closed, and now they were open.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

They were able to see (CEV)

Then the men were able to see. (NCV)

The men were immediately healed when Jesus spoke the words of 9:29. The NIV indicates that with a semicolon (;) at the end of 9:29, and the GNT indicates that with a long dash (—). If people in your area will not think that the healing was immediate, you may want to use punctuation, grammar, or another way to indicate so. Here are some examples:

and immediately they could see

and at the very moment he said that, they could see

9:30b

Jesus warned them sternly, “See that no one finds out about this!”

- Then Jesus strongly warned them, “Do not let anyone know this/that!”
- Jesus severely ordered them, “Do not tell this to anyone.”
- Jesus emphatically told them not to tell anyone what had happened.

warned them sternly: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as warned them sternly is a strong warning, but it is not an angry warning.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

strongly cautioned them

insisted thoroughly

severely commanded/ordered

said emphatically

See that: In this context, the Greek verb that the BSB translates as See that is a warning that means “Be careful” or “Do not” It is a word of warning not to do something. Here it does not mean “look” at something.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

Don’t tell (GNT)

Don’t let (JBP)

no one finds out about this: This clause means that the two men should not tell anyone that Jesus had healed them.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Let no one know about this/that

do not tell that/this to anyone

do not tell anyone that I healed you

General Comment on 9:30b

In some languages, it may be more natural to translate 9:30b as indirect speech. For example:

Jesus strongly warned them not to tell anyone what had happened.

Matthew 9:31

Section 9:27–34: Jesus healed two blind men and a mute man

In this section, Jesus performed two more miracles of healing. First, he healed two blind men because they had faith in him. Afterward he asked them not to tell other people about him healing them because he did not want people to try and make him an earthly king. But they were so happy that they told people anyway.

Then Jesus healed a man who was unable to talk because a demon was controlling him. The Pharisees did not believe that Jesus' power was from God, so they said Jesus got his power from Satan, the leader of demons.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Two blind men and a mute man are healed by Jesus

Jesus healed two blind men and forced a demon out of a mute man

9:31a

But they went out

- But they^(dual) went out
- However, when they exited the house, they went

But: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between Jesus' warning not to tell anyone, and what the men actually did. Make sure that it is understood that the men did not do what Jesus told them to do. The BSB indicates this with the conjunction But. In other languages, this is indicated in some other way. For example:

But they did not listen/obey

Instead/However

they went out: This clause refers to the blind men going out of the house and going to the surrounding area.

In some languages, this idea will be translated with two verbs. For example:

they left the house and went

they exited the house and went

the healed men departed from there and went

9:31b

and spread the news about Him throughout the land.

- and spread this news about him throughout all that part of the country.
- and told everyone in all that area what Jesus had done.

and spread the news about Him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as spread the news about Him means "make known the news." The two men told many people that Jesus healed them.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

spread his fame (ESV)

talked about him (NJB)

told everyone what he had done

throughout the land: The Greek word that the BSB translates as land also means "district, region, or area." This phrase is almost identical to the phrase in 9:26. You can translate it in a similar way.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

through all that region (NIV)

all around that area (NCV)

in all the nearby villages

Matthew 9:32

Section 9:27–34: Jesus healed two blind men and a mute man

In this section, Jesus performed two more miracles of healing. First, he healed two blind men because they had faith in him. Afterward he asked them not to tell other people about him healing them because he did not want people to try and make him an earthly king. But they were so happy that they told people anyway.

Then Jesus healed a man who was unable to talk because a demon was controlling him. The Pharisees did not believe that Jesus' power was from God, so they said Jesus got his power from Satan, the leader of demons.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Two blind men and a mute man are healed by Jesus

Jesus healed two blind men and forced a demon out of a mute man

Paragraph 9:32–34

Verse 9:31b is a summary about the deeds of the two men during the days or weeks after they were healed. This paragraph resumes the story from 9:31a after the men had just left Jesus. Some languages may have a special way to indicate that 9:32a resumes the story from 9:31a.

9:32a

As they were leaving,

- ¶ As they were going away, (ESV)
- ¶ As the two men were leaving the house,

As they were leaving: There are two ways to interpret the pronoun they:

1. It refers to the two blind men. For example:

When the two men were leaving (NCV) (GNT, NCV) The commentaries that support this interpretation are: France, page 369; Davies and Allison, page 138; Hagner, page 257; Osborne, page 357; Lenski, page 379.

1. It refers to Jesus and his disciples. For example:

As Jesus and his disciples were on their way (CEV) (CEV, JBP)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The BSB and most English versions have they, so it is not possible to tell which interpretation they follow. However, most commentaries follow interpretation (1).

Also, the nearest referent for the pronoun they is the two men whom Jesus healed of blindness. The disciples are completely unimportant to this story. They are not mentioned at all between 9:20–36.

were leaving: The form of the word that the BSB translates as were leaving indicates that these two men were in the process of going out. This could mean that, as the two men were leaving the house, they passed the other group on their way into the house.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

As the men were leaving (GNT)

When the two men were leaving (NCV)

9:32b

a demon-possessed man who was mute was brought to Jesus.

- a man was brought to Jesus. A demon controlled this man and made him mute.
- suddenly some other people came with a man to Jesus. This man could not talk because an evil spirit was in him.

The Greek of 9:32b begins with a word that is often translated as “behold” (ESV). It indicates that something extraordinary will happen. Here, what is unexpected is that some men brought a demon-possessed man to Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

suddenly (NJB)

unexpectedly

a demon-possessed man who was mute: The term demon-possessed man refers to a man who was controlled by a demon. A demon controlled his thoughts and actions. This term also occurs in 8:16a. The word mute means “not able to talk.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

a man who was demon-possessed and could not talk (NIV)

a man who could not talk because a demon was in him (CEV)

a mute man. The reason he was mute was because a demon had entered him.

was brought: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as was brought is an active verb. It can be translated as “they brought.” The word “they” refers to people other than the two men of 9:31, but no words describe exactly who “they” were.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

some people brought

they arrived/came with

Matthew 9:33

Section 9:27–34: Jesus healed two blind men and a mute man

In this section, Jesus performed two more miracles of healing. First, he healed two blind men because they had faith in him. Afterward he asked them not to tell other people about him healing them because he did not want people to try and make him an earthly king. But they were so happy that they told people anyway.

Then Jesus healed a man who was unable to talk because a demon was controlling him. The Pharisees did not believe that Jesus’ power was from God, so they said Jesus got his power from Satan, the leader of demons.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Two blind men and a mute man are healed by Jesus

Jesus healed two blind men and forced a demon out of a mute man

Paragraph 9:32–34

Verse 9:31b is a summary about the deeds of the two men during the days or weeks after they were healed. This paragraph resumes the story from 9:31a after the men had just left Jesus. Some languages may have a special way to indicate that 9:32a resumes the story from 9:31a.

9:33a

And when the demon had been driven out, the man began to speak.

- After the demon was forced to leave, the man spoke.
- When Jesus made the evil spirit come out of the man, the man who could not talk started talking.

And when the demon had been driven out: The verb driven out means that Jesus caused the demon to leave and no longer control the man. This verb also occurs in 8:16b. You should translate here as you did there.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

after the demon had been sent/chased away

After Jesus forced the demon to leave (NCV)

when Jesus freed the man from the demon who controlled him

The clause is passive.

Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

as soon as the demon was forced out (GW)

- Use an active verb. For example:

After Jesus had forced the demon out (CEV)

demon: The Greek word that the BSB translates as demon refers to the same type of spirit as the Greek words that are often translated as “evil spirit” or “unclean spirit.” These evil spirits can control peoples’ actions and can make them sick.

Here are some other ways to translate demon:

- Use a word in your language that refers to a spirit that is evil and can control people. Do not use a word that refers to the spirit of a dead person.
- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

evil/bad spirit

spirit that does evil

spirit that opposes God

See also demon in the Glossary for more information.

the man began to speak: This clause indicates that Jesus had healed the man.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he was able to speak (NCV)

the man started talking (CEV)

the man who had been mute spoke (NIV)

9:33b

The crowds were amazed and said,

- The crowds were very surprised and said,
- The people there were astonished and said,

The crowds: The word crowds here refers to the people watching the miracle.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

the group of people

the people

were amazed: This word means “had great surprise or wonder at something.” It refers to the feeling of awe that comes from seeing or hearing about something extraordinary.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

marveled (ESV)

was surprised

9:33c

“Nothing like this has ever been seen in Israel!”

- “Something like this has never been seen in Israel!”
- “In our country, Israel, nothing like this has ever happened!”

Nothing like this has ever been seen in Israel!: This clause indicates that no one had ever healed a mute person in the history of Israel. This type of miracle had never happened.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Nothing like this has ever happened in Israel!
(CEV)

Our nation of Israel has never seen anything like this.

in Israel: The word Israel is the name of the nation of the Jews.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in our nation Israel

in Israel, our country

Matthew 9:34

Section 9:27–34: Jesus healed two blind men and a mute man

In this section, Jesus performed two more miracles of healing. First, he healed two blind men because they had faith in him. Afterward he asked them not to tell other people about him healing them because he did not want people to try and make him an earthly king. But they were so happy that they told people anyway.

Then Jesus healed a man who was unable to talk because a demon was controlling him. The Pharisees did not believe that Jesus’ power was from God, so they said Jesus got his power from Satan, the leader of demons.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Two blind men and a mute man are healed by Jesus

Jesus healed two blind men and forced a demon out of a mute man

Paragraph 9:32–34

Verse 9:31b is a summary about the deeds of the two men during the days or weeks after they were healed. This paragraph resumes the story from 9:31a after the men had just left Jesus. Some languages may have a special way to indicate that 9:32a resumes the story from 9:31a.

9:34a

But the Pharisees said,

- But the Pharisees were saying,
- However some people of the religious sect/group called the Pharisees said,

But: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between the crowd’s reaction to Jesus’ miracle in 9:33b and

the Pharisee's reaction in 9:34a–b. The BSB shows this contrast with the conjunction But.

the Pharisees said: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as said can also be translated as “were saying.” For example:

the Pharisees were saying (NASB)

The form of the verb indicates that the Pharisees probably said the following words on more than one occasion. In fact, in 12:24, they do say the same thing.

Pharisees: For help in translating this word, see the note in 9:11a.

9:34b

“It is by the prince of demons that He drives out demons.”

- “It is the chief of demons who gives him the power to force demons out of people.”
- “Satan, the ruler of demons helps/empowers him to cause demons to leave people.”

It is by the prince of demons that He drives out demons: The Pharisees falsely claimed that the prince of demons gave Jesus the power to drive out demons. But in truth, God had given Jesus that power.

In Greek, the phrase by the prince of demons is emphasized. If you have a natural way to emphasize this phrase, you may want to do so. For example:

The prince of demons is the one that gives him power to force demons out. (NCV)

Here is another way to translate this sentence:

The leader of the demons gives him the power to force out demons

prince of demons: In this context, the Greek word that the BSB translates as prince refers generally to a leader or chief. Here it refers specifically to Satan, the leader of all demons. Here it does not refer to the “son of a king.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the chief of the demons (GNT)

the ruler of demons (NET)

Satan, the leader of demons

Matthew 9:35

Section 9:35–38: The harvest is plentiful, the workers are few

This short section is a transitional section. The section begins with what is probably a summary of Jesus' activities in chapters 5–9: he traveled around teaching, preaching, and healing people. The section ends with a call to pray to God to send more workers into the harvest. This is an introduction to Jesus sending out the twelve disciples in chapter 10.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The need for more workers in God's kingdom

Jesus' workers are few

Jesus Has Pity on People (CEV)

9:35

This verse introduces the summary of Jesus' activities in chapters 5–9.

Here are some ways to begin this summary:

So

In this way

9:35a

Jesus went through all the towns and villages,

- ¶ Jesus traveled and passed through all the towns and villages.
- ¶ So, in those days Jesus went from village to village and visited all the big villages and small villages in that area.

Jesus went through: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as went through indicates that Jesus traveled from village to village and visited each one. He probably stayed for a day or two in each village. Your translation should not imply that he passed through these villages without stopping.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Jesus went around visiting (GNT)

Jesus traveled through (NCV)

Jesus took his disciples along with him during his trips. Notice that they are with him in 9:37a. In some languages, it may be necessary to add this information here. For example:

Jesus and his disciples went throughout

all the towns and villages: This phrase probably refers to all the cities and villages in a certain area of the country of Israel. It may have been the district of Galilee, but the exact area is not specified. It probably does not refer to all the cities and villages in the entire country.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

all the towns and villages of that area (NLT)

towns and villages: The Greek word that the BSB translates as towns refers to communities that are larger and more important than villages. Do not use a word that refers only to large, modern cities of today.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

cities and villages (ESV)

the big villages and the small villages

9:35b–d

Verse 9:35b–d is exactly the same as 4:23b–d. You should translate these two verses the same way.

9:35b

teaching in their synagogues,

- He taught about God in the synagogues of those people,
- At each place, he taught the Jews in their prayer/worship houses.

teaching: In some languages, it may be necessary to say what Jesus was teaching. For example:

teaching about God

teaching God's word

in their synagogues: The word synagogues refers to buildings where Jews gathered to pray, read Scripture, teach their beliefs, and worship God. The Jews also gathered in synagogues for cultural activities. There was only one temple, but each Jewish community had a synagogue.

The pronoun their refers to the Jews in each town.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in the prayer-houses of the Jews

in the meeting-places of the Jews

in their buildings for worship

in each of the houses for gathering together

This word first occurs in 4:23b. See the note there for more information.

If a literal translation of in their synagogues would imply that Jesus was not a Jew, you should leave the word their untranslated. For example:

in the synagogues (GNT)

9:35c

preaching the gospel of the kingdom,

- and he told people the good news/words about the kingdom of God,
- He also announced the good news that God is starting to rule over his people.

preaching: The word preaching refers to announcing news in a public manner.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

proclaiming (ESV)

announcing (NLT)

This word also occurs in 4:23c.

the gospel of the kingdom: The Greek word that the BSB translates as gospel is sometimes translated as “good news” (as in the NIV). In the New Testament, this Greek word specifically means “the good news that God has made a way to save sinful people through Jesus.”

In Matthew, the word kingdom is usually referred to by the fuller expression “kingdom of heaven.” It refers to God's rule in a person's life.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the good message about God's kingdom

the good news concerning God's kingship/ruling

the good news about submitting to God's rule/
authority

This phrase also occurs in 4:23c. You should translate it the same in both places.

9:35d

and healing every disease and sickness.

- and he healed people who had every type of disease and illness.
- He cured people from all types of diseases, illnesses, disabilities, and other sicknesses.

healing every disease and sickness: The words disease and sickness are a doublet. This means that these words have almost the same meaning. Together, these words refer to every type of illness and physical problem that people can have.

Different cultures categorize diseases and physical problems in different ways. As you translate this clause, remember that Jesus healed people of leprosy, fever, blindness, demon-possession, and various handicaps. You should find terms that cover all (or most) of these.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Use two terms. For example:

healing all kinds of diseases and sicknesses (NCV)

healing every disease and handicap

curing every illness and injury

- Use more than two terms. For example:

he cured people who were sick, handicapped, and injured

he healed people who had every type of disease, illness, disability, and other sickness

- Use one term. For example:

healing every kind of sickness

curing everyone who was not well

Matthew 9:36

Section 9:35–38: The harvest is plentiful, the workers are few

This short section is a transitional section. The section begins with what is probably a summary of Jesus' activities in chapters 5–9: he traveled around teaching, preaching, and healing people. The section ends with a call to pray to God to send more workers into the harvest. This is an introduction to Jesus sending out the twelve disciples in chapter 10.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The need for more workers in God's kingdom

Jesus' workers are few

Jesus Has Pity on People (CEV)

9:36a

When He saw the crowds, He was moved with compassion for them,

- When he saw the crowds, he felt compassion for them,
- Each time Jesus saw the people, he pitied them,

He was moved with compassion for them: The Greek word that the BSB translates as moved with compassion means "had pity or sympathy." Jesus understood the people and cared about their problems.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

He felt compassion for them (NASB)

he felt sorry for them (GW)

he pitied them

You may have an idiom to translate this term. In English, here are some examples:

his heart was filled with pity for them (GNT)

his heart went out to them

9:36b

because they were harassed and helpless,

- because they had many difficulties, and they were without help,
- because they had many problems/troubles, and no one helped them.

because: The word because introduces the reason that Jesus pitied the people. He pitied them because they were harassed.

In some languages, it is more natural to put some of this part of the verse before 9:36a. For example:

^aJesus saw that ^bthe crowds were harassed and helpless. ^cThey were like sheep without a shepherd. ^aSo he had compassion for them.

they were harassed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as harassed refers to being oppressed or having troubles.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

they had many difficulties/troubles

they had many burdens

people oppressed them

and helpless: The word helpless means that the people “did not have the ability to take care of themselves.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

no one helped them

they didn’t know where to go for help (NLT96)

9:36c

like sheep without a shepherd.

- like sheep that did not have a shepherd.
- They were like sheep who had no one to take care of them.

like sheep without a shepherd: This is a simile. In this simile, the crowd is compared to sheep without a shepherd. The way that they are similar is that both are helpless without a leader.

A shepherd leads the sheep to places with food and protects them from wild animals. The people had political and religious leaders, but the leaders were not leading and protecting well.

Here are some other ways to translate this simile:

like sheep with no shepherd

like sheep who have no one to take care of them

shepherd: The word shepherd means “a person who takes care of sheep and guards them.”

Here is another way to translate this word:

a person who cares for sheep

Matthew 9:37

Section 9:35–38: The harvest is plentiful, the workers are few

This short section is a transitional section. The section begins with what is probably a summary of Jesus’ activities in chapters 5–9: he traveled around teaching, preaching, and healing people. The section ends with a call to pray to God to send more workers into the harvest. This is an introduction to Jesus sending out the twelve disciples in chapter 10.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The need for more workers in God’s kingdom

Jesus’ workers are few

Jesus Has Pity on People (CEV)

9:37a

Then He said to His disciples,

- Then he/Jesus said to his disciples,

9:37b

“The harvest is plentiful,

- “The crops that are ready to harvest are abundant,
- “There are many people to harvest, (NCV)
- “Many people are ready to believe in me like lots of grain is ripe for harvest.

9:37a–b

The harvest is plentiful: This is the first part of an extended metaphor. In this part, people who are ready to believe are like fruit/grain that is ready to be picked/cut and put in a safe place. There are many of these people just like the ripe fruit/grain is plentiful.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

The harvest is large (GNT)

The grain/fruit is ripe, and it is plentiful.

The time to pick the grain has arrived, and the grain is abundant.

- Keep the metaphor and put the meaning in a footnote. A sample footnote is below under General Comment on 9:37–38.
- Make the topic explicit. For example:

There are many people to harvest (NCV)

- Change the metaphor to a simile and make the parts explicit. For example:

Many people are ready to believe in me like lots of crops that are ready to be harvested.

9:37c but the workers are few.

- but there are few people to do the harvesting.
- but only a few workers to help harvest them. (NCV)
- But there are few people to tell them the good news about me like there are few workers to gather/bring in the grain.

but: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between the large number of people needed to harvest the plentiful harvest, and the actual number of people available. The BSB indicates this contrast with the conjunction but.

the workers are few: This is the second part of the metaphor. In this part, the few people who are available to tell people the good news are compared to the few laborers/workers who are available to harvest the crop.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

there are few workers to gather it in (GNT)

there are not many harvesters

- Change the metaphor to a simile and make the parts explicit. For example:

But there are few people to tell them the good news about me like there are few workers to harvest the crops.

Matthew 9:38

Section 9:35–38: The harvest is plentiful, the workers are few

This short section is a transitional section. The section begins with what is probably a summary of Jesus' activities in chapters 5–9: he traveled around teaching, preaching, and healing people. The section ends with a call to pray to God to send more workers into the harvest. This is an introduction to Jesus sending out the twelve disciples in chapter 10.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The need for more workers in God's kingdom

Jesus' workers are few

Jesus Has Pity on People (CEV)

9:38a Ask the Lord of the harvest, therefore,

- So seriously ask^(plur) the Lord of the harvest
- So pray to God to send out workers to cause people to believe in me. This is like begging the master of the harvest

Ask the Lord of the harvest, therefore: The BSB places the word therefore in the middle of the sentence. This is good English style. However, in some language, it may be necessary to place this word at the beginning of 9:38a. For example:

therefore pray earnestly to the Lord of the harvest (ESV)

Ask the Lord of the harvest: This is the last part of this extended metaphor. In this part, God is compared to the lord/owner of the harvest. Just as the lord/owner of the harvest is in charge of bringing in the harvest, God is in charge of bringing people into the kingdom.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

pray to the Lord who is in charge of the harvest (NLT)

Pray to the owner of the harvest (GNT)

- Change the metaphor to a simile and make the parts explicit. For example:

pray to God to send out workers to cause people to believe in me. This is like asking the owner of the harvest

pray to God to commission more workers to bring people into his kingdom. This is like asking the master of the harvest

Ask: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Ask also means “beg, plead, or ask seriously.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

pray earnestly (ESV)

Pray (NLT)

the Lord of the harvest: In this context, the word Lord means “owner” or “master.” In this context, it is the one who is in charge of the harvest. This phrase refers figuratively to God, so the BSB capitalizes the word Lord.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the owner of the harvest (GNT)

the Lord in charge of the harvest (CEV)

the Lord, who owns the harvest, (NCV)

In some languages people may not naturally use a word that means “owner” or “master” to refer to God. If this is true in your language, you can also use your word for God. For example:

God the Lord

God, the master/owner

See Lord in the Glossary.

therefore: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as therefore indicates that 9:38 is a type of conclusion. This conclusion is an appeal to pray for God to send out workers.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

For this reason

Because of that

So (NLT)

Some English versions do not translate this word.

9:38b
to send out workers into His harvest.”

- to send more workers into his field to harvest them.”
- to send out other people to join in bringing in the crops/grain.”

to send out workers: The word workers refers to the people who do the work of harvesting. Figuratively this refers to people who bring others to God to be part of his kingdom.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

that he will send more workers (NCV)

to send men (JBP)

that he will send others to join them

into His harvest: In some languages, it will be natural to add another verb here. In other languages, it will be natural to make the word harvest a verb. For example:

to gather in his harvest (GNT)

to bring it in (CEV)

to bring in the ripe crops

General Comment on 9:37–38

In some languages, it is helpful to explain the meaning of the metaphor in a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

This metaphor/parable shows us that many people are ready to believe in Jesus, but there are not many people to go and bring them into the kingdom. Jesus told his followers to pray for God to send more people to go help them trust in him.

Matthew 10:1

Section 10:1–4: Jesus appointed the twelve disciples as apostles

In the previous section, Jesus challenged the disciples to pray that God would send out workers into the spiritual harvest. In this section, Jesus appointed his twelve closest disciples as apostles or “sent ones.” He gave them power to cast out evil spirits and heal people. Matthew used this occasion to list the names of these twelve men.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Chooses His Twelve Apostles (CEV)

The Twelve Apostles (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 3:13–19 and Luke 6:12–16.

10:1a

And calling His twelve disciples to Him,

- ¶ Later he summoned his twelve disciples,
- ¶ After that, Jesus asked/told his twelve disciples to come to him.

And: This is the beginning of a new section. This section is loosely connected to the previous section.

Here are some other ways to begin this new section:

Then (NRSV)

Later

After that

calling His twelve disciples to Him: In this context, the verb calling means that Jesus was “asking the disciples to come” to him. According to the parallel passages in Mark and Luke, Jesus did this when he was in the hills around Lake Galilee.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus summoned his twelve disciples (NRSV)

Jesus called together his twelve disciples (CEV)

Jesus told/asked his twelve disciples to come to him

disciples: The word disciple also occurs in 8:21a. See the note there for help in translating this term. See also disciple in the Glossary for more information.

10:1b

Jesus gave them authority over unclean spirits, so that they could drive them out

- and he gave to them the power to force demons out of people
- He gave to them the power to expel evil spirits from people.

Jesus gave them authority over unclean spirits, so that they could drive them out: This phrase means that Jesus gave his disciples the power to cast unclean spirits out of people. Up to this point, only Jesus had this power.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

He gave them the power to force out evil spirits (CEV)

and gave them the power to make unclean spirits leave people

unclean spirits: The term unclean spirits refers to the same beings as “evil spirits” and “demons” (8:16a). You can translate these three terms with the same term.

The Jews believed that anyone who had an evil spirit was unclean. So an evil spirit was also called an unclean spirit.

Here are some other ways to translate unclean spirits:

- Use a general term in your language that refers to spirits that are evil and can control people. For example:

demons

devils

- Use a specific term in your language that refers to a certain type of spirit. Do not use a term that refers to the spirit of a dead person.
- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

evil spirits (NIV)

See demon in the Glossary for more information.

they could drive them out: The phrase drive them out means “to cause evil spirits to leave people and stop controlling their lives.”

Different cultures have different ways of speaking about people being controlled by evil spirits and being released from the control of evil spirits. Use a natural way to say this in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

to send away evil spirits

to free people whom demons controlled

to expel evil spirits from people

The term drive...out also occurs in 8:16c.

10:1c

and heal every disease and sickness.

- and to heal every disease and every sickness.
- He also gave them the power to cure every type of disease, illness, disability, and other sickness.

and heal: This is the second thing that Jesus gave his disciples power to do. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

and he also gave them the power to heal

every disease and sickness: The words disease and sickness are a doublet. This means that these words have almost the same meaning. Together, these words refer to every type of illness and physical problem that people can have.

This same pair of words occurs in 4:23d and 9:35d. See the notes there for more information.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- Use two terms. For example:

every kind of disease and sickness (NCV)

every disease and handicap

every illness and injury

- Use more than two terms. For example:

people who were sick, ill, or had a disease

- Use one term. For example:

every kind of sickness

everyone who was not well

Matthew 10:2

Section 10:1–4: Jesus appointed the twelve disciples as apostles

In the previous section, Jesus challenged the disciples to pray that God would send out workers into the spiritual harvest. In this section, Jesus appointed his twelve closest disciples as apostles or “sent ones.” He gave them power to cast out evil spirits and heal people. Matthew used this occasion to list the names of these twelve men.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Chooses His Twelve Apostles (CEV)

The Twelve Apostles (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 3:13–19 and Luke 6:12–16.

10:2a

These are the names of the twelve apostles:

- The names of the twelve apostles are these: (ESV)
- Here are the names of the twelve messengers of Jesus:

These are the names of the twelve apostles: This clause introduces the names of the twelve apostles. These twelve apostles are the same men as the twelve disciples mentioned 10:1a.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Here are the names of the twelve apostles (NLT)

These are the names of the twelve apostles: (NIV)

apostles: The word apostles means “messengers,” or “people who are sent on a mission or with a message.” These people represent and have the authority of the person who sent them. Here apostles refers to the disciples whom Jesus sent and gave the power to cast out evil spirits and heal the sick.

Here are some other ways to translate apostles:

- Translate the meaning of the Greek word apostles. For example:

people sent to speak/act for him

special messengers

representatives

men with authority from Jesus

- Indicate the role or function of apostles. For example:

chief leaders of Jesus' work

people who are in charge of Jesus' work

Be careful to choose different terms for "apostles," "angels," "elders," and "prophets."

10:2b

first Simon, called Peter, and his brother Andrew;

- first is Simon, also called Peter, and his brother Andrew,
- the greatest is Simon whose other name was Peter, and his younger brother Andrew,

first: There are at least two ways to interpret the word first:

1. It means that Peter was, in some sense, the leader or most honored of the disciples/apostles. This interpretation is followed by Carson, page 237; Davies and Allison, page 154; Hagner, page 266; Osborne, page 372; Lenski, page 389; Morris, page 243; Bruner, page 455; Gibbs, page 497; Albright and Mann, page 117. For example:

first and foremost (GW) (GW)

1. It means that Peter was the first person mentioned on the list. For example:

first, Simon (also called Peter), then Andrew (Peter's brother) (NLT) (NLT, and perhaps NCV)

Most English versions are ambiguous and it is not possible to tell which interpretation they follow. It is

recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Most commentaries follow this interpretation.

If your word for first only means first in a list or first in line, you should find another way to translate this word. For example:

the highest/greatest

Simon, called Peter: Simon is the Jewish name of the first apostle. Jesus also gave him the Greek name of Peter.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Simon, also called Peter (REB)

Simon, whose other name was Peter

his brother Andrew: The Bible does not definitely tell us whether Andrew was older or younger than his brother Simon. But some believe that Andrew was younger because his name usually appears after Peter's name in lists. If your language only has terms for "younger-brother" and "older-brother," you should use "younger-brother" for Andrew. For example:

and his younger brother Andrew

10:2c

James son of Zebedee, and his brother John;

- James the son of Zebedee and James' brother John,
- and James and his younger brother John. They were sons of Zebedee.

James son of Zebedee, and his brother John: John was the brother of James, and both were sons of Zebedee. John was probably younger than James.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

James and his younger brother John, they were sons of Zebedee

Be careful to translate this in a way that does not imply that John was the brother of Zebedee.

Matthew 10:3

Section 10:1–4: Jesus appointed the twelve disciples as apostles

In the previous section, Jesus challenged the disciples to pray that God would send out workers into the spiritual harvest. In this section, Jesus appointed his

twelve closest disciples as apostles or “sent ones.” He gave them power to cast out evil spirits and heal people. Matthew used this occasion to list the names of these twelve men.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Chooses His Twelve Apostles (CEV)

The Twelve Apostles (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 3:13–19 and Luke 6:12–16.

10:3a

Philip and Bartholomew;

- and Philip and Bartholomew,

10:3b

Thomas and Matthew the tax collector;

- Thomas and Matthew the tax collector,
- and Thomas and Matthew who formerly took money from the people for the government,

10:3a–b

Matthew the tax collector: Matthew was a tax collector, but probably quit that job when he became a disciple of Jesus. If people will think that Matthew still collected taxes, you may want to include some implied information. For example:

Matthew, who was formerly a tax collector

tax collector: The conquering Romans employed certain Jews to collect taxes for them from other Jews. The Romans did not give them wages, rather they allowed the tax collector to take extra taxes for his wages.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

who collected taxes

who took money from the people for the government

The term tax collector first occurs in 9:10b. You should translate it here as you did there.

10:3c

James son of Alphaeus, and Thaddaeus;

- Alphaeus’ son James, and Thaddaeus,

- and another James, whose father was Alphaeus, and Thaddaeus,

James son of Alphaeus: This James was a different “James” than the one in 10:2c. Alphaeus was his father.

and Thaddaeus: Thaddaeus was another disciple. This person was not James’ mother. If someone were to read the BSB phrase “James son of Alphaeus, and Thaddaeus” without the pause at the comma, it would sound like Alphaeus and Thaddaeus were the parents of James. But the BSB puts the comma in to separate Thaddaeus from the modifier “son of.” And he was also not a son of Alphaeus. Make sure this is clear in your translation. Here is an example:

Alphaeus’ son James and Thaddaeus

James whose father was Alphaeus, and Thaddaeus

Matthew 10:4

Section 10:1–4: Jesus appointed the twelve disciples as apostles

In the previous section, Jesus challenged the disciples to pray that God would send out workers into the spiritual harvest. In this section, Jesus appointed his twelve closest disciples as apostles or “sent ones.” He gave them power to cast out evil spirits and heal people. Matthew used this occasion to list the names of these twelve men.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Chooses His Twelve Apostles (CEV)

The Twelve Apostles (GNT)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 3:13–19 and Luke 6:12–16.

10:4a

Simon the Zealot,

- Simon, the Eager/Zealous One,
- and Simon the nationalist

Simon the Zealot: The word that the BSB translates as Zealot is literally “Cananaean.” This word is transliterated from the Greek. It refers to someone being greatly interested and excited about something. It does not refer to someone from the locations of Cana or Canaan. It is more commonly translated in English versions as Zealot, as the BSB does. It is not men-

tioned here what Simon was interested and excited about. He was probably strongly in favor of Israel becoming independent from the Roman government. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- Simon, known as the Eager One (CEV)
- Simon the nationalist
- Simon the Patriot (GNT)

10:4b
and Judas Iscariot, who betrayed Jesus.

- and Judas Iscariot who gave/sold Jesus to his enemies.
- and Judas Iscariot, the one who would later turn Jesus over to his enemies.

Judas Iscariot, who betrayed Jesus: The word Iscariot may have some meaning. But it is best to follow the English versions and translate the word Iscariot as a second name or surname for this last disciple.

who betrayed Jesus: The word betrayed means “put someone in danger by giving information about him to his enemy.” Later in the story, Judas betrayed Jesus by helping Jesus’ enemies arrest him.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- who sold Jesus to his enemies
- who gave/delivered Jesus to his enemies

Since Matthew wrote this after Judas betrayed Jesus, he used the past tense. But at this point in the story, Judas had not yet betrayed him. It may be more natural in your language to indicate that he betrayed Jesus later in the story. For example:

- who later betrayed him

Matthew 10:5

Section 10:5–42: Jesus instructed the twelve apostles

In this section, Jesus gave various instructions to the twelve apostles. In 10:5–15, he gave them some practical instructions for preaching the good news. In 10:16–33, he described the opposition that they would see when they went out. Lastly, in 10:34–42, he described

the commitment required to be a disciple and the reward for being a disciple.

You may want to break this long section into several shorter sections. Here is an example:

Section 10:5–15	The things the apostles should/must do when sent
Section 10:16–33	The difficulties the apostles will face
Section 10:34–42	The cost and reward of following Jesus

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

- Jesus gave directions/instructions to the twelve apostles for preaching the gospel
- The Mission of the Twelve (GNT)
- Instructions for the Twelve Apostles (CEV)

10:5a
These twelve Jesus sent out with the following instructions:

- ¶ These twelve men, Jesus sent with these instructions:
- ¶ Then Jesus sent out those twelve disciples. But first he told them these things:

These twelve: This phrase refers to the twelve disciples/apostles just named. In some languages, it will be natural to add a noun to go with the number twelve. For example:

- These twelve men (GNT)
- Those twelve disciples
- the twelve apostles (CEV)

Jesus sent out with the following instructions: This clause indicates that the words that follow in 10:5b–42 are the commands that Jesus gave to his twelve disciples, and then he sent them out. He did not send them out first, then instruct them later.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Jesus sent out after instructing them (NASB)

Jesus sent these twelve t with the following instructions (GW)

Jesus sent out these twelve men. But first he told them

10:5b
“Do not go onto the road of the Gentiles or enter any town of the Samaritans.

- “Do not go to other nations/tribes or to any of the towns of Samaria.
- “Do not go to foreigners/strangers. Do not go to any town of the people of the land of Samaria.

Do not go onto the road of the Gentiles: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Gentiles is literally “nations.” The Jews used this word to refer to all the people groups besides themselves.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Don’t go among people who are not Jewish (GW)

Do not go to other nations

Do not go to foreigners/strangers

or enter any town of the Samaritans: The word Samaritans is the name of a people group who lived in the land of Samaria. Samaria was between the two Jewish areas of Galilee and Judea. Although Samaritans spoke the same language as the Jews, the Jews considered them a different people group.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

and don’t go to any Samaritan town (CEV)

do not go to any town where the people/tribe of Samaria live

This is the only time that Matthew mentioned the word Samaritans. So it may be good to have a footnote here. A sample footnote is:

Samaritans descended partly from a group of Jews and partly from foreign nations. They did not follow the same religion as the Jews. So the Jews considered them a different people group and despised them. Jesus would later send the disciples to all people groups (28:19), but he wanted

his disciples to start by preaching to their fellow Jews.

Matthew 10:6

Section 10:5–42: Jesus instructed the twelve apostles

In this section, Jesus gave various instructions to the twelve apostles. In 10:5–15, he gave them some practical instructions for preaching the good news. In 10:16–33, he described the opposition that they would see when they went out. Lastly, in 10:34–42, he described the commitment required to be a disciple and the reward for being a disciple.

You may want to break this long section into several shorter sections. Here is an example:

Section 10:5–15	The things the apostles should/must do when sent
Section 10:16–33	The difficulties the apostles will face
Section 10:34–42	The cost and reward of following Jesus

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus gave directions/instructions to the twelve apostles for preaching the gospel

The Mission of the Twelve (GNT)

Instructions for the Twelve Apostles (CEV)

10:6
Go rather to the lost sheep of Israel.

- But instead, go to the people of Israel. They are like lost sheep.
- Go instead to the people of Israel. They are like sheep who have strayed away from their shepherd.

Go rather to the lost sheep of Israel: The phrase lost sheep of Israel is a metaphor. In this metaphor, Jesus compared the nation of Israel to lost sheep.

They were lost in the sense that they had strayed from their shepherd (God).

Here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

Instead, go to the lost sheep of the nation of Israel (GW)

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

Go only to the people of Israel, because they are like a flock of lost sheep. (CEV)

- Change the metaphor to a simile and add how sheep and Israel are similar. For example:

Go only to the descendants of Israel. They are like sheep who have strayed from their shepherd.

Matthew 10:7

Section 10:5–42: Jesus instructed the twelve apostles

In this section, Jesus gave various instructions to the twelve apostles. In 10:5–15, he gave them some practical instructions for preaching the good news. In 10:16–33, he described the opposition that they would see when they went out. Lastly, in 10:34–42, he described the commitment required to be a disciple and the reward for being a disciple.

You may want to break this long section into several shorter sections. Here is an example:

Section 10:5–15	The things the apostles should/must do when sent
Section 10:16–33	The difficulties the apostles will face
Section 10:34–42	The cost and reward of following Jesus

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus gave directions/instructions to the twelve apostles for preaching the gospel

The Mission of the Twelve (GNT)

Instructions for the Twelve Apostles (CEV)

10:7a

As you go, preach this message:

- As you^(plur) travel, preach this,
- While traveling/going, announce that

As you go, preach this message: The verb preach also means “proclaim” or “announce” news in a public manner. Jesus told his disciples to preach that ‘The kingdom of heaven is near.’ He told them to do this as they traveled from place to place throughout the country.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

As you go, spread this message (GW)

When you go, preach this (NCV)

Go and announce to them (NLT)

10:7b

‘The kingdom of heaven is near.’

- ‘The kingdom of the one who lives in heaven has begun.’
- God is ready to rule his people.

‘The kingdom of heaven is near’: This same clause also occurs in 3:2b and 4:17c. You should translate it here as you did there. Some translation advice is in the notes below.

When you translate the phrase The kingdom of heaven, there are two issues to consider:

Issue 1: The meaning of heaven

In the phrase The kingdom of heaven, the word heaven is a figure of speech called metonymy. In this figure of speech, heaven refers to God, but it refers to him indirectly by naming the place where he lives and rules. The Jews considered God’s name to be so holy that they hesitated to say it. So instead of pronouncing God’s name directly, they often used the name of the place where he lives and rules. Because Matthew was writing primarily to Jews, he often used the word heaven to refer to God.

Therefore, The kingdom of heaven means the same thing as “the kingdom of God.” The phrase The kingdom of heaven only occurs in the book of Matthew. The expression “the kingdom of God” is found in all other places in the New Testament, and it even occurs five times in Matthew.

Here are some other ways to translate heaven in this context:

- Make some information explicit. For example:

the one/Lord who lives in heaven

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

God

Issue 2: The meaning of the kingdom of heaven

Both The kingdom of heaven and “the kingdom of God” refer to God’s activity of ruling over his people. God’s rule is not simply giving orders or commands to people. It also includes his protection, care, and blessing for them. God leads, protects, and cares for his people. They obey, trust, and submit to him as their king. The phrase kingdom of heaven does not refer to a land or country that God rules over.

Here are some other ways to translate The kingdom of heaven:

- As a noun. For example:

the kingdom/rule of the one who lives in heaven

the kingdom of God

God’s kingship

God’s rule over people

- As a noun and a verb. For example:

God rules his people

God cares for his people as king

See kingdom of heaven in the Glossary for more information.

is near: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *is near* literally means “has approached.” In this passage it indicates that something will “soon happen.” It is used in the sense of time and not location.

So the entire clause “the kingdom of heaven is near” means:

the time for God to rule over people is about to happen

God’s kingship will soon happen/occur

the kingdom of Heaven will soon be here (CEV)

the time is near when God will rule over you^(plur)

General Comment on 10:7b

In some languages, it will be more natural to translate 10:7b as an indirect quote. For example:

proclaim that the kingdom of Heaven is close at hand (NJB)

Matthew 10:8

Section 10:5–42: Jesus instructed the twelve apostles

In this section, Jesus gave various instructions to the twelve apostles. In 10:5–15, he gave them some practical instructions for preaching the good news. In 10:16–33, he described the opposition that they would see when they went out. Lastly, in 10:34–42, he described the commitment required to be a disciple and the reward for being a disciple.

You may want to break this long section into several shorter sections. Here is an example:

Section 10:5–15	The things the apostles should/must do when sent
Section 10:16–33	The difficulties the apostles will face
Section 10:34–42	The cost and reward of following Jesus

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus gave directions/instructions to the twelve apostles for preaching the gospel

The Mission of the Twelve (GNT)

Instructions for the Twelve Apostles (CEV)

10:8a
Heal the sick, raise the dead,

- Heal sick people, cause dead people to live again,
- Also, use God’s power to heal sick people, and make alive dead people,

Heal the sick: This command refers to healing sick people by using God’s power. It does not refer to healing as a doctor does. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this more explicit. For example:

By God’s power, heal the sick

raise the dead: This command refers to causing a dead person to return to life. This command does not refer to lifting a dead body.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

raise the dead back to life

cause the dead to live again

10:8b
cleanse the lepers, drive out demons.

- heal lepers, and force demons out of people.
- and cure those with skin diseases, and expel demons from people.

cleanse the lepers: In this context, the word cleanse means “heal.” For example:

cure those with leprosy (NLT)

heal people who have leprosy (CEV)

lepers: The Greek word that the BSB translates as lepers refers to people who had various kinds of infectious skin diseases. The disease today called “leprosy” turns the skin white and the affected flesh eventually dies.

If you are in an area where “leprosy” is not known, you may want to follow the GNT that translates it as:

dreaded skin diseases (GNT)

drive out demons: The phrase drive out also occurs in 10:1b. You should translate it here as you did there.

10:8c
Freely you have received;

- You^(plur) received this power without paying me.
- I gave you power to do miracles and did not ask you to pay me for it.

Freely you have received: This clause means that Jesus gave the disciples the power to heal and do other miracles, and he did not ask them to pay him money for that power. He gave it to them freely, as a gift.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

You received this power without paying money

You received this power to heal from me, and you did not pay for it.

I give you these powers freely (NCV)

10:8d
freely give.

- Give help to others without asking them to pay.
- So help/heal people and do not ask them to pay you for it.

freely give: This clause means that the disciples must give people aid/help without asking them to pay for it. The disciples must heal people and do miracles freely, without cost.

give people help without asking them to pay

help other people freely (NCV)

do these things without charging people for them

Matthew 10:9

Section 10:5–42: Jesus instructed the twelve apostles

In this section, Jesus gave various instructions to the twelve apostles. In 10:5–15, he gave them some practical instructions for preaching the good news. In 10:16–33, he described the opposition that they would see when they went out. Lastly, in 10:34–42, he described the commitment required to be a disciple and the reward for being a disciple.

You may want to break this long section into several shorter sections. Here is an example:

Section 10:5–15	The things the apostles should/must do when sent
Section 10:16–33	The difficulties the apostles will face
Section 10:34–42	The cost and reward of following Jesus

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus gave directions/instructions to the twelve apostles for preaching the gospel

The Mission of the Twelve (GNT)

Instructions for the Twelve Apostles (CEV)

10:9
Do not carry any gold or silver or copper in your belts.

- Do not take along any gold, silver or copper money in your^(plur) belts,
- When you go, do not take/carry any money with you.

Do not carry any: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as carry also means “get” or “buy.” It refers to preparing for the journey. This verb applies to the “gold or silver or copper” money of this verse, and the “bag,” “tunic,” “sandals,” and “staff” of 10:10a. Instead, the disciples were to rely on the hospitality of the people they stayed with.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

Do not take along (NIV)

Acquire no (ESV)

gold or silver or copper: The words gold, silver and copper are different types of metal. Here they refer to coins made of these metals or to pieces of these metals that could be used like money.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

any gold, silver, or copper coins (CEV)

any money with you—gold or silver or copper (NCV)

any money (NLT96)

in your belts: The Greek word that the BSB translates as belts refers to cloth belts in which Jews typically carried their money. They folded money in these belts and then wrapped them around their waists.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in your money belts (NLT)

in your pockets (GNT)

with you (NCV)

Matthew 10:10

Section 10:5–42: Jesus instructed the twelve apostles

In this section, Jesus gave various instructions to the twelve apostles. In 10:5–15, he gave them some practical instructions for preaching the good news. In 10:16–33, he described the opposition that they would see when they went out. Lastly, in 10:34–42, he described the commitment required to be a disciple and the reward for being a disciple.

You may want to break this long section into several shorter sections. Here is an example:

Section 10:5–15	The things the apostles should/must do when sent
Section 10:16–33	The difficulties the apostles will face
Section 10:34–42	The cost and reward of following Jesus

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus gave directions/instructions to the twelve apostles for preaching the gospel

The Mission of the Twelve (GNT)

Instructions for the Twelve Apostles (CEV)

10:10a
Take no bag for the road, or second tunic, or sandals, or staff;

- nor bag for your trip, nor extra clothes or sandals, nor walking stick,
- Do not take a travelling bag for your trip, or a second shirt, or extra shoes or a walking stick.

Take no bag for the road: In the Greek, this clause is literally “no bag for the road.” The word Take is not in the Greek of 10:10a but the words “Do...carry” are implied from 10:9. In some languages, it will be necessary to repeat the verb used in 10:9, as the BSB does.

The word bag refers to the type of bag used when traveling. It is a bag in which clothes and other things are carried.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

traveler’s bag (NLT)

knapsack (JBP)

or second tunic: The Greek word that the BSB translates as tunic refers to a long “shirt” or “undergarment” that covered the body from the shoulders to the knees. Both men and women wore this kind of garment next to the skin and then put an outer garment over it.

This same word occurs in 5:40a.

The phrase or second tunic means that the disciples should not take an extra tunic along with them. They could wear one, but not take a second one along.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

an extra shirt (GNT)

extra clothes (NCV)

a second shirt

or sandals: The word sandals refers to a type of shoe. They are flat pieces of leather with straps to tie to the feet.

This phrase probably means that Jesus prohibited his disciples from taking extra sandals. He was not telling them to go barefoot. (See the parallel passage in Mark 6:9 where Jesus told his disciples to wear sandals.)

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

extra sandals/shoes

a second pair of shoes

or staff: This word refers to a walking stick, which helped a person walk in difficult places. He also used it to protect himself against animals, snakes, and robbers.

Here is another way to translate this word:

walking stick (GNT)

10:10b

for the worker is worthy of his provisions.

- because the worker is worthy of his support.
- I say this because it is proper for people to supply your needs when you do the work of the Lord among them.

for: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as for introduces the basis for the command not to take along any gold or these other things (10:9–10a). The disciples should not take along these things for/ because they are God’s workers and deserve their food.

Here are some other ways to introduce this basis:

because

I say this because

the worker is worthy of his provisions: This clause was probably a Jewish proverb. Jesus used it to apply to his workers, the disciples.

It means that other people should take care of the needs of a disciple when he works for God. This would include the food and whatever other needs he might have.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the worker deserves to have his needs met (GW)

the worker is worthy of receiving his living

it is appropriate/right that you be given what you need from/by the people to whom you give the word of God

Matthew 10:11

Section 10:5–42: Jesus instructed the twelve apostles

In this section, Jesus gave various instructions to the twelve apostles. In 10:5–15, he gave them some practical instructions for preaching the good news. In 10:16–33, he described the opposition that they would see when they went out. Lastly, in 10:34–42, he described the commitment required to be a disciple and the reward for being a disciple.

You may want to break this long section into several shorter sections. Here is an example:

Section 10:5–15	The things the apostles should/ must do when sent
Section 10:16–33	The difficulties the apostles will face
Section 10:34–42	The cost and reward of following Jesus

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus gave directions/instructions to the twelve apostles for preaching the gospel

The Mission of the Twelve (GNT)

Instructions for the Twelve Apostles (CEV)

10:11a
Whatever town or village you enter, find out who is worthy there

- ¶ “Whichever city or village you^(plur) go into, look for a worthy person there
- ¶ “Whenever you enter a small village or a large village, find a person who is willing to welcome you.

Whatever town or village you enter: The Greek word that the BSB translates as town refers to either a town or a city. It is larger and more important than a village.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Whenever you arrive in a town or village

When you arrive in a large village or a small village

find out: The Greek verb that the BSB has translated as find out means “question, examine.” In this context, it refers to looking for and finding the right kind of person.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

look for (GNT)

search for (NIV)

who is worthy: The Greek word that the BSB translates as worthy means “of value,” “of merit” or “fitting,” “proper,” or “suitable.” This phrase probably refers to a respected person who was willing and able to give hospitality to the disciples.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

someone who is willing to welcome you (GNT)

someone who is respected (JBP)

some suitable person (REB)

10:11b
and stay at his house until you move on.

- and live with him until you leave that place.
- Stay with that person until you leave that village.

stay at his house until you move on: In this context, the verb stay refers to sleeping and probably eating there. Jesus did not want the disciples to go from one house to another looking for better food or a better bed.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

stay with him until you leave (NJB)

live there until you leave that town

This phrase does not mean that the disciples could not leave the house. They could go out of the house and preach and do other activities.

Matthew 10:12

Section 10:5–42: Jesus instructed the twelve apostles

In this section, Jesus gave various instructions to the twelve apostles. In 10:5–15, he gave them some practical instructions for preaching the good news. In 10:16–33, he described the opposition that they would see when they went out. Lastly, in 10:34–42, he described the commitment required to be a disciple and the reward for being a disciple.

You may want to break this long section into several shorter sections. Here is an example:

Section 10:5–15	The things the apostles should/must do when sent
Section 10:16–33	The difficulties the apostles will face
Section 10:34–42	The cost and reward of following Jesus

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus gave directions/instructions to the twelve apostles for preaching the gospel

The Mission of the Twelve (GNT)

Instructions for the Twelve Apostles (CEV)

10:12

As you enter the home, greet its occupants.

- When you^(plur) go into his house, give it your blessing of peace.
- When you enter his home, say to the people of the house, “May God give you peace.”

As you enter the home, greet its occupants: The word greet refers to a blessing of peace, as 10:13 indicates. So this clause means that when a disciple enters the house of the person who has given him a place to stay, he should bless the people of that house.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

When you are invited into someone’s home, give it your blessing. (NLT96)

When you enter a house, greet the people of that house and bless them.

It is also possible to translate the greeting as direct speech. For example:

When you enter that home, say, ‘Peace be with you.’ (NCV)

Matthew 10:13

Section 10:5–42: Jesus instructed the twelve apostles

In this section, Jesus gave various instructions to the twelve apostles. In 10:5–15, he gave them some practical instructions for preaching the good news. In 10:16–33, he described the opposition that they would see when they went out. Lastly, in 10:34–42, he described the commitment required to be a disciple and the reward for being a disciple.

You may want to break this long section into several shorter sections. Here is an example:

Section 10:5–15	The things the apostles should/ must do when sent
Section 10:16–33	The difficulties the apostles will face
Section 10:34–42	The cost and reward of following Jesus

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus gave directions/instructions to the twelve apostles for preaching the gospel

The Mission of the Twelve (GNT)

Instructions for the Twelve Apostles (CEV)

10:13a

If the home is worthy,

- If that household is worthy/deserving of your blessing,
- If the people of that house receive/treat you^(plur) well,

If the home is worthy: The word home refers figuratively to the people of that home. In Jewish culture the word “house” is often used figuratively to refer to the people of the house. The word worthy is the same word as in 10:11a. If the people in the home sincerely want to help the disciples, those people are worthy/deserving of the blessing.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

And if the people of that house are worthy/ deserving of your blessing

If the people in that house welcome you (GNT)

10:13b

let your peace rest on it;

- let your blessing of peace stay on them.
- your prayer of peace will bless them,

let your peace rest on it: This clause refers to the blessing of peace given in 10:12. The phrase rest on it refers to the blessing remaining on those people and continuing to work in their lives.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

let your peace rest on it (NIV)

let your greeting of peace remain (GNT)

allow your blessing of peace to remain on them

your greeting will bless them

peace: The Jewish concept of peace includes both an absence of war and a state of well-being, safety, health, and economic prosperity. All this comes from God for those who are in a relationship with him.

Few languages will have a word for “peace” that is as broad as the Jewish concept. Some languages will have a word to describe the absence of war or conflict and a different word to describe a general state of well-being. If possible, choose your word that has the broadest range of meaning. (If you must make a choice, a word that describes a state of well-being is preferable in this context.)

it: The pronoun it refers to the house. Again, it refers figuratively to the people of that house.

10:13c
but if it is not,

- But if they are not worthy/deserving,
- but if they do not receive/treat you well,

but if it is not: This clause refers to the opposite case: the people of that home do not deserve the blessing.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

if it is not deserving

but if the people of that house do not welcome you

10:13d
let your peace return to you.

- take back your blessing of peace.
- your prayer of peace will not bless them.

let your peace return to you: Instead of the blessing staying on those people, it returns to the disciples. It is as if the blessing of peace is an animal that returns to its owner. Therefore, it does not bless the people of that house.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

let your peace come back to you (REB)

take back your blessing of peace (CEV)

ask God to remove your blessing of peace

your greeting will not bless them

Matthew 10:14

Section 10:5–42: Jesus instructed the twelve apostles

In this section, Jesus gave various instructions to the twelve apostles. In 10:5–15, he gave them some practi-

cal instructions for preaching the good news. In 10:16–33, he described the opposition that they would see when they went out. Lastly, in 10:34–42, he described the commitment required to be a disciple and the reward for being a disciple.

You may want to break this long section into several shorter sections. Here is an example:

Section 10:5–15	The things the apostles should/must do when sent
Section 10:16–33	The difficulties the apostles will face
Section 10:34–42	The cost and reward of following Jesus

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus gave directions/instructions to the twelve apostles for preaching the gospel

The Mission of the Twelve (GNT)

Instructions for the Twelve Apostles (CEV)

10:14a
And if anyone will not welcome you or heed your words,

- If anyone does not welcome you or listen to your message,
- If any household or any town will not take care of you, and if they will not listen to your words about me,

And if anyone will not welcome you: This clause refers to someone or even the whole town (10:14b) refusing to give hospitality to the disciples.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

And if some home or town will not welcome you (GNT)

Whoever does not take care of you

And whoever refuses to give you hospitality

or heed your words: This phrase is the second thing that the household or town refuses to do: they will not listen to what the disciples say. It refers to these

people not listening to the good news about Jesus. It does not refer to words in general. For example:

listen to your message (CEV)

10:14b
shake the dust off your feet when you leave that home or town.

- when you leave that household or village, shake the dust off your feet.
- leave that place and shake the dust off your feet to show that you reject them.

shake the dust off your feet: Here Jesus told his disciples to shake or remove the dust that was on their feet (and sandals). They probably did this by shaking their feet or brushing off the dust with their hands.

This was a cultural gesture that had a symbolic meaning. When a Jewish person shook the dust of a place off of his feet, it indicated that he did not have any relationship with the people in that place. It showed that he rejected those people.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Explain it in the text. For example:

shake the dust off your feet to show that you reject them
- Explain it in a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

When the Jews wanted to show that they had rejected a place, they had a custom of shaking the dust off their feet.

when you leave that home or town: In Greek, this clause occurs before the command to “shake the dust off your feet.” This clause may also be translated as part of that command. For example:

leave that house or city, and shake its dust off your feet (GW)

Matthew 10:15

Section 10:5–42: Jesus instructed the twelve apostles

In this section, Jesus gave various instructions to the twelve apostles. In 10:5–15, he gave them some practical instructions for preaching the good news. In 10:16–33, he described the opposition that they would see when they went out. Lastly, in 10:34–42, he described

the commitment required to be a disciple and the reward for being a disciple.

You may want to break this long section into several shorter sections. Here is an example:

Section 10:5–15	The things the apostles should/ must do when sent
Section 10:16–33	The difficulties the apostles will face
Section 10:34–42	The cost and reward of following Jesus

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus gave directions/instructions to the twelve apostles for preaching the gospel

The Mission of the Twelve (GNT)

Instructions for the Twelve Apostles (CEV)

10:15a
Truly I tell you,

- I assure you^(plur),
- I tell you^(plur) with certainty,

Truly I tell you: Jesus often used the words Truly I tell you to introduce a statement that he wanted to emphasize. When he began a statement with these words, he was asking people to listen with extra attention.

Here are some other ways to show this emphasis:

- As a phrase before Jesus’ statement. For example:

I assure you (NLT96)

Listen to this:

Let me tell you this:

- As an emphatic word within Jesus’ statement. For example:

It will certainly be more bearable on the day of judgment for the land of Sodom

If you have another way in your language to emphasize a statement or to alert people to listen with

special attention, consider using it here. See how you translated this clause in 6:16d and 8:10c.

10:15b

it will be more bearable for Sodom and Gomorrah on the day of judgment than for that town.

- on the day of judgment, God will show more mercy to the people of Sodom and Gomorrah than to that town.
- on the day that God judges all people, the punishment that he gives to the people of that town will be greater/heavier than the punishment that he gives to the people of the towns of Sodom and Gomorrah.

it will be more bearable for Sodom and Gomorrah on the day of judgment than for that town: This sentence compares two things. It talks about the punishment that God will give to the people of Sodom and Gomorrah, and compares it to the punishment that God will give to the people of the town that does not receive the disciples. Jesus said that the punishment of Sodom and Gomorrah will be more bearable than the punishment of that town. This means God will punish the people of Sodom and Gomorrah less than he will punish the people of a town that rejected his disciples. The people of Sodom and Gomorrah will suffer less.

Here are some other ways to translate this comparison:

on the Judgment Day it will be better for the towns of Sodom and Gomorrah than for the people of that town (NCV)

on the Judgment Day God will show more mercy to the people of Sodom and Gomorrah than to the people of that town (GNT)

on Judgment Day, the punishment that God will give that town will surpass the punishment of Sodom and Gomorrah

Sodom and Gomorrah: The words Sodom and Gomorrah are the names of two towns. God destroyed these two towns and their people because of their many sins (Genesis 19). If people in your area are not familiar with the story of Sodom and Gomorrah, you may want to include some implied information in the text or in a footnote. For example:

the very sinful people of the towns of Sodom and Gomorrah

on the day of judgment: This phrase refers to the time when God will judge all people for the things they have said and done on earth.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

on the day that God judges all people

at the time when God judges everyone

that town: This phrase refers to the town spoken of in 10:14b. It is the town whose people reject Jesus’ disciples. Make sure that the reference is clear in your translation. The example below puts the phrase that town before the phrase Sodom and Gomorrah:

on the day of judgment, the people of that town will be punished more greatly than the people of the towns of Sodom and Gomorrah

Matthew 10:16

Section 10:5–42: Jesus instructed the twelve apostles

In this section, Jesus gave various instructions to the twelve apostles. In 10:5–15, he gave them some practical instructions for preaching the good news. In 10:16–33, he described the opposition that they would see when they went out. Lastly, in 10:34–42, he described the commitment required to be a disciple and the reward for being a disciple.

You may want to break this long section into several shorter sections. Here is an example:

Section 10:5–15	The things the apostles should/must do when sent
Section 10:16–33	The difficulties the apostles will face
Section 10:34–42	The cost and reward of following Jesus

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus gave directions/instructions to the twelve apostles for preaching the gospel

The Mission of the Twelve (GNT)

Instructions for the Twelve Apostles (CEV)

10:16a

Behold, I am sending you out like sheep among wolves;

- ¶ “Listen! I am sending you^(plur) into danger like sheep among wolves.
- ¶ “I am sending you^(plur) out to cruel/evil people. It is like sending sheep into the middle of wild dogs.

Behold: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Behold indicates that something extraordinary or important will happen or be said. Here, the amazing thing is the danger that the disciples will face.

Here is another way to translate this word:

Listen! (GNT)

Watch out!

I am sending you out: This clause refers to Jesus sending the disciples to preach the good news, heal the sick, and so forth (10:7-8).

like sheep among wolves: This phrase is a comparison called a simile. In this simile, Jesus compared the disciples to sheep. He compared the people they will face to wolves. Sheep are in danger when they are among wolves. In the same way, the disciples will be in danger when they tell the good news to people who do not want to accept it.

Here are some other ways to translate this simile:

- Keep the simile. For example:

like sheep among wild dogs

- Make the comparison explicit in the text. For example:

into danger like sheep among wolves

like sheep among dangerous wild dogs

- Make the parts of the simile explicit. For example:

I am sending you out to cruel/evil people. It is like sending sheep to wild dogs.

- Explain the simile in a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

This is a picture of dangerous situations, because wolves attack sheep and eat them. Telling the good news of Jesus will sometimes be dangerous.

wolves: The word wolves refers to a type of wild dog. They weigh 60–80 kilograms. They roam around in groups and attack other animals and eat them.

If people in your area are not familiar with wolves, you may want to:

- Use different animals that have similar characteristics to wolves. For example:

panthers

hyenas

- Use a more general term. For example:

wild dogs

dangerous/wild animals

10:16b

therefore be as shrewd as snakes and as innocent as doves.

- So be^(plur) careful/cautious like snakes and be harmless like doves.
- Therefore, be wise/careful and gentle in those dangerous situations.

therefore: In 10:16b Jesus gave two commands. The basis for these commands is the danger that he warned them about in 10:16a. These commands are introduced with a conjunction that the BSB translates as therefore.

Here is another way to introduce these commands:

so (ESV)

be as shrewd as snakes: This is a command. It is also a simile. In this command, Jesus told his disciples to be wise like serpents are wise.

The Greek word that the BSB translates as shrewd means “sensible” or “prudent.” It refers to having good judgment in difficult situations. In Jewish culture, snakes were thought to be good examples of being cautious and careful.

If people in your area do not think of snakes as wise, translate the meaning without using a simile. For example:

be wise

be cautious/careful

as innocent as doves: This is a command. It is also a simile. In this command, Jesus told his disciples to be innocent like doves are innocent.

The Greek word that the BSB translates as innocent refers to being harmless (NLT) or gentle (GNT). Here it refers to not harming your enemies.

The doves are small birds like pigeons. In Jewish culture, doves were thought to be good examples of being innocent. If people in your area do not think of doves as innocent, you should translate the meaning without using a simile. For example:

be gentle

be harmless

Matthew 10:17

Section 10:5–42: Jesus instructed the twelve apostles

In this section, Jesus gave various instructions to the twelve apostles. In 10:5–15, he gave them some practical instructions for preaching the good news. In 10:16–33, he described the opposition that they would see when they went out. Lastly, in 10:34–42, he described the commitment required to be a disciple and the reward for being a disciple.

You may want to break this long section into several shorter sections. Here is an example:

Section 10:5–15	The things the apostles should/ must do when sent
Section 10:16–33	The difficulties the apostles will face
Section 10:34–42	The cost and reward of following Jesus

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus gave directions/instructions to the twelve apostles for preaching the gospel

The Mission of the Twelve (GNT)

Instructions for the Twelve Apostles (CEV)

10:17a
But beware of men;

- Watch out^(plur) for certain people,
- Be careful!

beware of men: The Greek word that the BSB translates as beware of also means “be careful of, be alert about, or watch out for.” The disciples should realize that some people are enemies of the good news of Jesus, and so they must be prepared for opposition.

In this context, the word men refers generally to “people.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Be on your guard against men (NIV)

Watch out for people (GW)

Be careful of people (NCV)

10:17b
for they will hand you over to their councils

- because they will bring you^(plur) before the local courts
- Some people will arrest you^(plur) and take you to the judges.

for: Verse 10:17b gives the basis for the command to beware of men (in 10:17a). The Greek introduces this basis with a conjunction that the BSB translates as for. Beware of men (17a) for/because they will hand you over to the local councils. (17b)

Here are some other ways to introduce this basis:

because (NCV)

The reason is that

In some languages, it will be more natural to put the basis before the command. For example:

^{17b}Men will deliver you over to courts ^{17c}and flog you in their synagogues. ^{17a}So beware of them.

they: The word they refers to the “men” in 10:17a. They are the people who are opposed to the message of

Jesus as the Messiah. They are likened to wolves in 10:16a.

If it is not natural to simply translate the pronoun they, you may want to add some information to clarify who these people are. For example:

those who oppose/reject your message about me

The people who are like wolves

will hand you over: This phrase refers to handing someone over for trial and judgment. These enemies will set the disciples before the local councils, and these councils will decide how to punish them for preaching about Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

will arrest you and take you (GNT)

will hand you over (NIV)

to their councils: The Greek word that the BSB translates as councils refers to local courts. Such courts in Israel decided religious, civic, and criminal matters. Every Jewish town or village that had a synagogue would likely also have councils.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

to their courts (ESV)

to the judges

to trial

10:17c
and flog you in their synagogues.

- and whip you^(plur) in their synagogues.
- They will condemn you and hit/strike you with a whip in their prayer houses.

flog you: The word flog means whip or strike someone with a whip of leather. The usual Jewish punishment was to flog thirty-nine times. They struck twenty-six times on the back and thirteen times on the chest.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

whip (GNT)

hit/strike with a whip of leather

It is implied that the courts would decide that the disciples were guilty and therefore give them the punishment of flogging. In some languages, it may be necessary to include this information. For example:

who will condemn you and whip you

who will declare that you are guilty and whip you

in their synagogues: The word synagogues refers to buildings where Jews gathered to pray, read Scripture, teach their beliefs, and worship God. The Jews also gathered in synagogues for cultural activities. There was only one temple, but each Jewish community had a synagogue.

The pronoun their refers to the Jews in each town.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in the prayer-houses of the Jews

in the meeting-places of the Jews

in their buildings for worship

in each of the houses for gathering together

This word also occurs in 4:23b and 9:35b.

Matthew 10:18

Section 10:5–42: Jesus instructed the twelve apostles

In this section, Jesus gave various instructions to the twelve apostles. In 10:5–15, he gave them some practical instructions for preaching the good news. In 10:16–33, he described the opposition that they would see when they went out. Lastly, in 10:34–42, he described the commitment required to be a disciple and the reward for being a disciple.

You may want to break this long section into several shorter sections. Here is an example:

Section 10:5–15	The things the apostles should/must do when sent
Section 10:16–33	The difficulties the apostles will face

Section 10:34-42	The cost and reward of following Jesus
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Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus gave directions/instructions to the twelve apostles for preaching the gospel

The Mission of the Twelve (GNT)

Instructions for the Twelve Apostles (CEV)

10:18a

On My account, you will be brought before governors and kings

- You^(plur) will be led before governors and kings because of me.
- Others will force you to go before rulers of provinces and rulers of countries on account of me.

On My account: This phrase indicates that the enemies of Jesus will bring the disciples before governors and kings to be judged because the disciples follow Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

for my sake (ESV)

because you are my followers (NLT)

Because of me (GW)

you will be brought: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as will be brought is literally “will be led.” In this context, this verb implies that the disciples were arrested and were forced to appear before a judge. The situation is similar to 10:17b where it says that people “will hand you over.”

This verb is passive. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

you will be led

you will also be arrested and taken

- Use an active verb. For example:

they will bring you

governors: This word refers to government leaders of provinces or regions within a country. They were not as powerful as kings. Use a term that refers to a ruler who is lower than a king.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

provincial rulers

chiefs

kings: Here, kings are rulers of whole countries. As an example, King Herod ruled all of Israel at the time of Jesus’ birth.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

supreme rulers

rulers of whole nations/countries

highest/biggest rulers

This word also occurs in 2:1b.

10:18b

as witnesses to them and to the Gentiles.

- In this way, you will tell the good news to them and to the other nations/tribes.
- This will be an opportunity for you to tell the rulers and the foreigners about me.

as witnesses to them and to the Gentiles: This phrase expresses the purpose for God allowing the disciples to be arrested and taken before governors and kings. His purpose was so that these leaders and the Gentiles would hear the gospel.

The Greek word that the BSB translates as witnesses refers to telling the good news about Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

In this way, you will give testimony before them and the Gentiles

This will be a way/opportunity for you to tell the good news to them and the Gentiles.

But this will be your opportunity to tell the rulers and other unbelievers about me. (NLT)

them: The pronoun them refers to the governors and kings. For example:

the rulers (NLT)

the Gentiles: The word Gentiles was used by the Jews to refer to all the people groups beside themselves. See how you translated this term in 10:5b.

Matthew 10:19

Section 10:5–42: Jesus instructed the twelve apostles

In this section, Jesus gave various instructions to the twelve apostles. In 10:5–15, he gave them some practical instructions for preaching the good news. In 10:16–33, he described the opposition that they would see when they went out. Lastly, in 10:34–42, he described the commitment required to be a disciple and the reward for being a disciple.

You may want to break this long section into several shorter sections. Here is an example:

Section 10:5–15	The things the apostles should/must do when sent
Section 10:16–33	The difficulties the apostles will face
Section 10:34–42	The cost and reward of following Jesus

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus gave directions/instructions to the twelve apostles for preaching the gospel

The Mission of the Twelve (GNT)

Instructions for the Twelve Apostles (CEV)

10:19a

But when they hand you over,

- When they bring you^(plur) before those rulers,
- Whenever they hand you over for trial, (NET)

But when they hand you over: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as hand you over is the same phrase as in 10:17b. It refers to handing someone over for trial and judgment. In this context, this clause probably refers to the situation in 10:18: “you will be brought before governors and kings.” The disciples will

be brought to trial before powerful people like governors and kings.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Whenever they hand you over for trial (NET)

When they give you to the authorities

When you are arrested (NCV)

10:19b

do not worry about how to respond or what to say.

- do not worry about what to say or how to say it.
- do not be concerned about the words you^(plur) should say or the manner in which you should say them.

do not worry: This phrase also means “do not be anxious.” For example:

do not be anxious (ESV)

This phrase also occurs in 6:34a.

about how to respond or what to say: The clause how to respond refers to the manner in which the disciples should speak. It can refer to whether to speak in a bold or friendly or other manner. It can also refer to the type of arguments they should use. In other words, the disciples should not worry about carefully preparing a good speech.

The phrase what to say refers to which words the disciples should use.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

what to say or how to say it (NIV)

the words you should say or the manner in which you should say them

10:19c

In that hour you will be given what to say.

- I say this because you will be given/told the words to say when the time comes.
- At the right time, you will receive the words that you should say.

In the Greek, 10:19c begins with a conjunction that is often translated as “for.” Verse 10:19c is the basis of the command not to worry. The BSB does not translate this conjunction but leaves the connection with 10:19b implicit.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

I say this because

The reason is

In that hour: This phrase refers to the time when the disciple is to speak at his trial.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

when the time comes (GNT)

at the right time (NLT)

you will be given what to say: The clause is passive.

Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

you will be given the words to say (CEV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

you will receive what to say

the Spirit of your Father will tell you what to say

Matthew 10:20

Section 10:5–42: Jesus instructed the twelve apostles

In this section, Jesus gave various instructions to the twelve apostles. In 10:5–15, he gave them some practical instructions for preaching the good news. In 10:16–33, he described the opposition that they would see when they went out. Lastly, in 10:34–42, he described the commitment required to be a disciple and the reward for being a disciple.

You may want to break this long section into several shorter sections. Here is an example:

Section 10:5–15	The things the apostles should/ must do when sent
Section 10:16–33	The difficulties the apostles will face
Section 10:34–42	The cost and reward of following Jesus

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus gave directions/instructions to the twelve apostles for preaching the gospel

The Mission of the Twelve (GNT)

Instructions for the Twelve Apostles (CEV)

10:20a

For it will not be you speaking,

- For/because the words that you speak will not be yours,
- I say this because what you say will not come from your thinking.

For: Verse 10:20 more fully explains why the disciples should not worry when they stand before rulers. Like 10:19c, this verse is a basis for the command not to worry, but it explains it in more detail. The Greek introduces this basis with a conjunction that the BSB translates as For.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

I say this because

The reason is

The same conjunction appears at the beginning of 10:19c. In some languages, it is not natural to have the same conjunction repeated here. So some English versions do not translate the conjunction here.

it will not be you speaking: The disciples will be speaking, but God will be responsible for guiding them to say the right things. This clause is not referring to magic or something like demon-possession.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

it will not be really you who are speaking (JBP)

the words you will speak will not be yours (GNT)

what you say will not be words which come from your thinking

10:20b

but the Spirit of your Father speaking through you.

- but rather they will be words from the Spirit of your heavenly Father.
- Rather/Instead, it will come from the Spirit of God your Father speaking to you.

but: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between the disciples’ speaking for themselves and the Holy Spirit speaking through them. The Greek indicates this contrast with a conjunction that the BSB translates as but.

You should indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language.

the Spirit of your Father: This phrase refers to the Holy Spirit. The word Father refers to God the Father. If people in your area will think that this phrase might refer to the spirit of someone’s earthly father, you may want to include some implied information. For example:

the Spirit of your heavenly Father

the Spirit of your Father God

Also, Jesus probably used the pronoun your to focus on the relationship that the disciples have with God, even though God was his Father as well. If people in your area will think that by using the pronoun your, Jesus was referring to a different Father than God, you may want to use the pronoun “our”^(incl) instead.

speaking through you: The Holy Spirit of God will direct the disciples to say what God wants them to say. This is not the Holy Spirit projecting his voice through the disciples.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

will tell you what to say (CEV)

will put in your minds what you are to say

will cause you to know what you should say

Matthew 10:21

Section 10:5–42: Jesus instructed the twelve apostles

In this section, Jesus gave various instructions to the twelve apostles. In 10:5–15, he gave them some practical instructions for preaching the good news. In 10:16–33, he described the opposition that they would see when they went out. Lastly, in 10:34–42, he described

the commitment required to be a disciple and the reward for being a disciple.

You may want to break this long section into several shorter sections. Here is an example:

Section 10:5–15	The things the apostles should/ must do when sent
Section 10:16–33	The difficulties the apostles will face
Section 10:34–42	The cost and reward of following Jesus

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus gave directions/instructions to the twelve apostles for preaching the gospel

The Mission of the Twelve (GNT)

Instructions for the Twelve Apostles (CEV)

10:21a

Brother will betray brother to death,

- ¶ “A brother will hand over his own brother to the authorities who will put him to death,
- ¶ “Some people will betray their own brothers/siblings who believe in me and give them to those who will put them to death.

Brother will betray brother to death: This clause indicates that siblings will betray one another. In some languages, it will be more natural to use the plural “Brothers” here.

The word Brother can refer to any older or younger brother. If your language has specific words for older brother and younger brother, you can translate Brother and brother in one of the following ways:

An older brother will deliver over his younger brother

A younger brother will deliver over his older brother

Some people will deliver over their younger brothers and older brothers

will betray...to death: The Greek word that the BSB translates as betray...to is the same Greek word that

occurs in 10:19a. Someone who does not believe in Jesus will hand over his believing brother to people who will kill him.

Here are some other ways to translate this entire clause:

People will hand over their own brothers to be put to death (GNT)

A brother will give his brother who believes in me to those who will put him to death

People will betray their siblings who believe in me to those who will kill them

10:21b and a father his child;

- and a father will do likewise to his child,
- And men who do not believe will likewise betray their children who believe and give them to those who will put them to death.

and a father his child: Some words from the previous clause are implied but not repeated here. You may need to repeat some of those words here. Or you may need to use words that indicate the same action as the previous clause. For example:

and a father will hand over his child to be put to death

and fathers will give their children to those who will kill them

and men will betray their own children

In this context, the father is not a believer, and the child is a believer. In some languages, it may be necessary to include some of this implied information. For example:

a father who does not believe will hand over his child who believes to be put to death

10:21c children will rise against their parents and have them put to death.

- and children will rebel against their parents and cause them to be put to death.

- And people will turn against their parents who believe in me and permit/cause other people to kill them.

children will rise against their parents: The verb rise against means “oppose or fight against people in power.”

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

oppose

turn against (GNT)

rebel against (NIV)

In this context, the children are older children, not infants. If the word children in your language only indicates young children, you may have to use another word. For example:

people will rebel against their parents

These children are not believers, and the parents are believers. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

children will oppose their parents who believe in me

non-believing people will rebel against their believing parents

have them put to death: This phrase indicates that children will give their parents to authorities who will judge them guilty and cause them to be killed.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

cause them to be killed (NLT)

and have them killed (CEV)

Matthew 10:22

Section 10:5–42: Jesus instructed the twelve apostles

In this section, Jesus gave various instructions to the twelve apostles. In 10:5–15, he gave them some practical instructions for preaching the good news. In 10:16–33, he described the opposition that they would see when they went out. Lastly, in 10:34–42, he described

the commitment required to be a disciple and the reward for being a disciple.

You may want to break this long section into several shorter sections. Here is an example:

Section 10:5-15	The things the apostles should/must do when sent
Section 10:16-33	The difficulties the apostles will face
Section 10:34-42	The cost and reward of following Jesus

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus gave directions/instructions to the twelve apostles for preaching the gospel

The Mission of the Twelve (GNT)

Instructions for the Twelve Apostles (CEV)

10:22a

You will be hated by everyone because of My name,

- You^(plur) will be hated by all people on account of my name.
- Everyone will hate you because of me. (GNT)

You will be hated by everyone: This clause is passive.

Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

you will be hated by everyone (NET)

- Use an active verb. For example:

Everyone will hate you (GNT)

The word everyone is hyperbole. This means that it is an exaggeration to emphasize that many people would hate the disciples. If people in your area will think that everyone literally means “everyone,” you should make an adjustment to your translation. For example:

you will be hated by many, many people

because of My name: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as because of My name is more literally “on

account of my name.” Here the word name represents Jesus. Many people hate Jesus, and so they hate the people who follow him and believe in him.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

on account of my name (NJB)

because of me (GNT)

because you follow me (NCV)

10:22b

but the one who perseveres to the end will be saved.

- But those people who continue to follow me to the end of their lives will be saved.
- But if you^(plur) continue to believe/trust in me until the end of your lives, God will save/deliver you from punishment/hell.

but: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between the implied possibility of abandoning one’s faith, and enduring to the end. Persecution may tempt a believer to abandon his faith. But if he remains firm and endures to the end, he will be saved. The BSB and many English versions indicate this contrast with the conjunction but.

the one: This phrase refers to either a man or a woman. In some languages, it may be natural to use a pronoun or a plural. For example:

you (CEV)

the person (GW)

whoever (GNT)

everyone (NLT)

perseveres: This word indicates that a person continues to be loyal to Jesus even though people hate him and cause him to suffer.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

remain faithful (CEV)

continues to believe/trust in me

do not stop believing/following me

to the end: The phrase to the end means “until the end of his life” or “until the end of the time of persecution.”

will be saved: This phrase refers to someone being saved or rescued from harm or danger. In this context, it refers to a believer being saved by God from eternal punishment that results from sin.

The verb is passive. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

will be saved/rescued from being punished for his sins

- Use an active verb. For example:

God will save him from sin/hell

Do not imply here that people will be saved from physical death. Jesus indicated that some disciples would indeed die because of persecution.

This verb also occurs in 1:21c.

Matthew 10:23

Section 10:5–42: Jesus instructed the twelve apostles

In this section, Jesus gave various instructions to the twelve apostles. In 10:5–15, he gave them some practical instructions for preaching the good news. In 10:16–33, he described the opposition that they would see when they went out. Lastly, in 10:34–42, he described the commitment required to be a disciple and the reward for being a disciple.

You may want to break this long section into several shorter sections. Here is an example:

Section 10:5–15	The things the apostles should/must do when sent
Section 10:16–33	The difficulties the apostles will face
Section 10:34–42	The cost and reward of following Jesus

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus gave directions/instructions to the twelve apostles for preaching the gospel

The Mission of the Twelve (GNT)

Instructions for the Twelve Apostles (CEV)

10:23a
When they persecute you in one town, flee to the next.

- When you^(plur) are persecuted in one village, run/hurry to another village.
- When people in one town/place cause you to suffer, run away and go to another town/place.

When they persecute you: The word persecute means “deliberately harm someone,” “mistreat someone,” or “cause someone to suffer.” People can persecute others physically, such as beating them or forcing them to leave their homes and taking their possessions forcefully. People can also persecute others verbally by saying hurtful things.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

treated badly (NCV)

cause to suffer

oppress

This word also occurs in 5:10a and 5:12b. You should translate it here as you did there.

in one town: This phrase refers to any of the towns or villages that the disciples will visit.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in one place (NIV)

in any town/village

flee: To flee means to move quickly away from danger and seek a safer place.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

run away (GNT)

escape

get away from the danger

10:23b

Truly I tell you,

- I assure you^(plur),
- I tell you^(plur) with certainty,

The Greek of 10:23b begins with a conjunction that is often translated as “for.” Verse 10:23b–c is the basis for the command to flee to another village (in 10:23a). Many English versions leave this conjunction untranslated, as the BSB does. In some languages, it will also not be necessary to translate this conjunction.

Truly I tell you: Jesus often used these words to introduce a statement that he wanted to emphasize.

Here are some other ways to show this emphasis:

- As a phrase before Jesus’ statement. For example:

I assure you (NLT96)

Listen to this:

Let me tell you this:

- As an emphatic word within Jesus’ statement. For example:

You will certainly not have gone through all the towns of Israel before the Son of Man comes

If you have another way in your language to emphasize a statement or to alert people to listen with special attention, consider using it here. See how you translated this clause in 10:15a.

10:23c

you will not reach all the towns of Israel before the Son of Man comes.

- you will not finish your work in all the towns of Israel before the Son of Man comes. (GNT)
- I the Son of Man will come before you finish teaching the good news in all the towns/villages of Israel.”

you will not reach all the towns of Israel: In Greek, this clause is more literally, “you will not finish the towns of Israel.” The thing to be finished is left implied in the Greek. The context implies that the disciples will not finish their ministry of traveling from one town to the next to preach the good news to the Jews (10:5–17).

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

you will not finish going through all the towns of Israel (NET)

you will not finish your work in all the towns of Israel (GNT)

you will not finish going and preaching the good news in all the towns of Israel

before the Son of Man comes: There are many ways to interpret this clause. Here are the main interpretations:

1. It refers to Jesus’ coming back to his disciples after the resurrection.
2. It refers to Jesus’ coming to his father at the time of the ascension.
3. It refers to Jesus coming in judgment against Israel in 70 AD when Jerusalem and the temple were destroyed.
4. It refers to the second coming of Jesus at the end of the world.
5. It refers to Jesus coming to and joining his disciples later on their trip.

There is much debate and disagreement among commentators about this verse. But this clause can be translated well without interpreting it. So it is recommended that you translate this clause literally and not try to interpret it.

the Son of Man: Jesus used the phrase the Son of Man to refer to himself. In some languages it may be necessary to add the pronoun “I” to show that Jesus was referring to himself. For example:

I, the Son of Man

This phrase also occurs in 8:20b and 9:6a. You should translate it here as you did there. See also Son of Man in KBT for more information.

Matthew 10:24

Section 10:5–42: Jesus instructed the twelve apostles

In this section, Jesus gave various instructions to the twelve apostles. In 10:5–15, he gave them some practical instructions for preaching the good news. In 10:16–33, he described the opposition that they would see when they went out. Lastly, in 10:34–42, he described the commitment required to be a disciple and the reward for being a disciple.

You may want to break this long section into several shorter sections. Here is an example:

Section 10:5-15	The things the apostles should/must do when sent
Section 10:16-33	The difficulties the apostles will face
Section 10:34-42	The cost and reward of following Jesus

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus gave directions/instructions to the twelve apostles for preaching the gospel

The Mission of the Twelve (GNT)

Instructions for the Twelve Apostles (CEV)

10:24a

A disciple is not above his teacher,

- ¶ “No student is greater than his teacher,
- ¶ “A pupil is not more important than his teacher.

A disciple is not above his teacher: Here the word disciple refers to disciples or students in general. It does not refer only to Jesus’ disciples. Some English versions translate this word as “student” or “pupil.”

The word above is used in this context to refer to something greater in importance. Students are not more important than their teachers.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

No pupil is greater than his teacher (GNT)

A student is not better than his teacher (NCV)

A student is not more important/honored than his teacher.

10:24b

nor a servant above his master.

- and no slave is greater than his owner.
- A servant is not more important than his boss/master.

nor a servant above his master: This clause means that a servant/slave is not more important than his

master. This clause is similar in meaning to the clause in 10:24a.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

no slave is greater than his master (GNT)

and a servant is not better than his master (NCV)

servant: The Greek word that the BSB translates as servant is often translated as “slave.” But the difference between a “slave” and a “servant” is not important here. It refers to someone who serves or works for another person. For example:

worker/laborer

one who serves

master: This word refers to the person who owns the slave, or the person who rules the servant.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

boss/owner

one who rules

Matthew 10:25

Section 10:5–42: Jesus instructed the twelve apostles

In this section, Jesus gave various instructions to the twelve apostles. In 10:5–15, he gave them some practical instructions for preaching the good news. In 10:16–33, he described the opposition that they would see when they went out. Lastly, in 10:34–42, he described the commitment required to be a disciple and the reward for being a disciple.

You may want to break this long section into several shorter sections. Here is an example:

Section 10:5-15	The things the apostles should/must do when sent
Section 10:16-33	The difficulties the apostles will face
Section 10:34-42	The cost and reward of following Jesus

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus gave directions/instructions to the twelve apostles for preaching the gospel

The Mission of the Twelve (GNT)

Instructions for the Twelve Apostles (CEV)

10:25a

It is enough for a disciple to be like his teacher,

- A student should be satisfied to become like his teacher, (NCV)
- If a pupil is treated like his teacher, he must be satisfied/content.

It is enough for a disciple to be like his teacher: The Greek word that the BSB translates as It is enough refers to something being sufficient or adequate. If a student becomes like his teacher, that is good enough for the student. He must be satisfied with that. He needs nothing else.

Jesus used this saying to tell his disciples that they should expect difficulties. They will not be honored more than he was honored while on earth. They will not be treated better than he was treated.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

A student becoming equal to his teacher, that is sufficient/adequate

a pupil should be satisfied to become like his teacher (GNT)

If a student is treated like his teacher, he should be satisfied.

10:25b

and a servant like his master.

- a servant should be satisfied to become like his master. (NCV)
- And/Also if a servant is treated like his boss/master, he must be satisfied/content.

and a servant like his master: Some words from the previous clause are implied but not repeated here. In some languages, it may be more natural to include some of those words. For example:

and a servant becoming equal to his master, that is sufficient/adequate

a servant should be satisfied to become like his master (NCV)

And if a servant is treated like his master, he must be satisfied.

10:25c–d

If the head of the house has been called Beelzebul, how much more the members of his household!:

The first part of this sentence is an If clause. But there is no doubt that people have already called Jesus Beelzebul. In order to make this clear, it may be necessary in some languages to make some adjustments. For example:

And since I, the master of the household, have been called the prince of demons, the members of my household will be called by even worse names! (NLT)

They have called the master of the house Beelzebul. So/Therefore, they will say even worse things to those of the household.

10:25c

If the head of the house has been called Beelzebul,

- Since/Because they have called the head of the house ‘Beelzebul,’
- People have called me who am the head of the family ‘Satan,’
- I am the master of the house. People have called me ‘Satan.’

If the head of the house has been called Beelzebul:

The head of the house is the person in charge of those who lived in the house. In this context, the master of the house represents Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

If they have called the owner of the house Beelzebul (GW)

If the head of the family is called Beelzebul (GNT)

And since I, the master of the household, have been called the prince of demons (NLT)

Beelzebul: This word refers to Satan.

There is a spelling issue here. In some manuscripts, this word is spelled Beelzebul (as in the ESV and BSB).

In other manuscripts it is spelled “Beelzebub” (as in the NIV and KJV). You should follow the spelling in your major language version.

Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Transliterate the word Beelzebul and include a footnote to explain its meaning. Here is a sample footnote:

“Beelzebul” is a name that the Jews sometimes used to refer to Satan without honoring him by using his name.

- Use the name “Satan.” For example:

If people call the head of the family Satan (CEV)

- Translate the name with a descriptive phrase that clearly refers to Satan. For example:

the prince of demons (NLT)

the ‘Prince of Evil’ (JBP)

10:25d

how much more the members of his household!

- they will certainly call the family members even worse names.
- so they will call you, the members of the family, bad names that surpass even that name!
- So will they treat you, the members of the family, better than that?

how much more the members of his household!:

The BSB literally represents the Greek here. Some English versions add the word “will they malign” to make the sense more clear. (The word “malign” means to say unpleasant and untrue things about someone.) For example:

how much more will they malign those of his household. (ESV)

This phrase indicates that people will do the same things to the disciples (the members of the household) as they did to Jesus (the master of the house). And they will do these things much more readily, quickly, or severely. In other words, people will treat the disciples worse than they treated Jesus. More specifically, they will call the disciples worse names than they called Jesus. The disciples should not expect to be treated any better than Jesus was treated.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

General Comment on 10:24–25

- Use a statement. For example:

they will treat you the members of the house even more harshly/severely

the members of the family will be called even worse names! (GNT)

they will certainly say even worse things to the family members

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

what will they say about the rest of the family? (CEV)

will they treat you the members of the house any better?

The relationship between Jesus and the disciples is like the relationship between a teacher and his student (10:24a, 10:25a), the master to his servant (10:24b, 10:25b), and the head of the house to the members of his household (10:25c, 10:25d). So, just as the Pharisees insulted Jesus by calling him Beelzebul/Satan, the disciples will also be insulted and worse. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this more explicit. For example:

- Make the relationships explicit in the text. For example:

^c I am like the master of a house, and you are like the people of the house. If people call the master of the house bad names like “devil,” ^dthen they will call the people of the house even worse names.

- Explain the relationships in a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

In this parable, Jesus is like “the head of the house” and the disciples are like “the members of his household.” Just as Jesus was insulted, the disciples will be insulted worse.

Matthew 10:26

Section 10:5–42: Jesus instructed the twelve apostles

In this section, Jesus gave various instructions to the twelve apostles. In 10:5–15, he gave them some practical instructions for preaching the good news. In 10:16–33, he described the opposition that they would see when they went out. Lastly, in 10:34–42, he described the commitment required to be a disciple and the reward for being a disciple.

You may want to break this long section into several shorter sections. Here is an example:

Section 10:5–15	The things the apostles should/ must do when sent
Section 10:16–33	The difficulties the apostles will face
Section 10:34–42	The cost and reward of following Jesus

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus gave directions/instructions to the twelve apostles for preaching the gospel

The Mission of the Twelve (GNT)

Instructions for the Twelve Apostles (CEV)

10:26a

So do not be afraid of them.

- ¶ “So do not be afraid of those people,
- ¶ “Therefore, do not fear those who persecute you.

So: Verse 10:26 is the conclusion to the previous verses. The Greek introduces this conclusion with a conjunction that the BSB translates as So.

Here is another way to translate this conjunction:

Therefore

do not be afraid of them: This is a command. Jesus told his disciples not to be afraid of the people who will persecute them.

Here are some other ways to translate this command:

have no fear of them (ESV)

don’t be afraid of those who threaten you (NLT)

do not be afraid of those who persecute you

10:26b–c

For: Verse 10:26b–c gives the basis for the command in (10:26a). Jesus told his disciples not to be afraid of their persecutors, for/because God will expose what these people have said and done.

Here are some other ways to introduce this basis:

because

I say this because

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it may also not be necessary to translate it.

there is nothing concealed that will not be disclosed, and nothing hidden that will not be made known: Before translating this part of the verse, there are two issues to consider:

Issue 1: Interpretation

There are two ways to interpret this clause:

1. The word nothing means no sins. According to this interpretation, this part of 10:26 goes together with the preceding verses. People who persecute Jesus and his disciples make their plans in secret. Their sins are now a secret. But on judgment day, God will reveal them.
2. The word nothing means no part of the gospel. According to this interpretation, this part of 10:26 goes together with the following verse. There Jesus instructed his disciples to proclaim from the rooftops what he had told them in secret.

English versions are ambiguous and it is not possible to tell which interpretation they follow. If you cannot translate ambiguously, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This interpretation better fits with the way that 10:26b–c is connected with 10:26a. Jesus instructed his disciples not to fear those who persecute them, for/because one day God will reveal their sins and judge them.

Issue 2: Parallelism

Verse 10:26b–c is a Hebrew form of poetry called a parallelism. In a parallelism, an idea is repeated. Often, the idea is repeated to emphasize it. In this particular parallelism, the ideas in 10:26b are repeated in 10:26c.

The parallel parts in 10:26b–c that are similar in meaning are shown here:

^{26b} there is nothing concealed **that will not be disclosed**,

^{26c} and nothing hidden **that will not be made known**

In some languages, people will think that the parallel parts in 10:26b–c describe different events. In other words, they will think that “concealed” and “hidden” describe different events, and “that will not be disclosed” and “that will not be made known” also describe different events.

If that is true in your language, you should:

- Indicate that both clauses refer to the same thing. For example:

^{26b} nothing is concealed that will not be disclosed,

^{26c} I repeat, is hidden that will not be made known

- Combine the parallel parts and emphasize it in some way. For example:

certainly nothing is covered/hidden that will not be made known

10:26b

For there is nothing concealed that will not be disclosed,

- because nothing is now covered that will not be shown/exposed,
- God will show all sins that people have covered/hidden.

there is nothing concealed that will not be disclosed: As mentioned above, the word nothing refers to people’s sins. These sins may be a secret today, but one day they will be shown.

This clause is passive. It also has two negatives: nothing and not. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

nothing is now covered that will not be uncovered

no sin is now covered that will not be shown

- Use a passive verb and no negatives. For example:

Whatever is now covered up will be uncovered (GNT)

whatever sin/behavior that is now covered will be revealed

- Use an active verb with both negatives. For example:

nothing is covered that God will not reveal

no sin is now covered/hidden that God will not reveal

- Use an active verb and no negatives. For example:

God will show whatever is now covered

God will expose all sin/behavior that people have covered/hidden.

10:26c

and nothing hidden that will not be made known.

- and nothing is secret that will not be made known.
- I repeat, every sin that people hide, God will make known.

and: In this context, the word and indicates that 10:26b and 10:26c have the same meaning.

Here are some other ways to indicate this:

- Use another conjunction. For example:

or (ESV)

- Introduce 10:26c with a phrase that indicates that the meaning is the same as 10:26b. For example:

I repeat

- Put one clause immediately after the other with no connector or introductory phrase. For example:

Nothing has been covered that will not be exposed. Whatever is secret will be made known. (GW)

nothing hidden that will not be made known: As mentioned above, this part of the clause means the

same thing as 10:26b. In Jewish culture, it was common to repeat an idea with words of similar meaning to emphasize that idea.

Some words from the previous part of the clause are implied but not repeated here. In some languages, it may be more natural to include some of those words. For example:

There is nothing hidden that will not be made known.

Like in 10:26b, the verb in 10:26c is passive. This part of the clause also has two negatives: nothing and not. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

nothing is secret that will not be made known (NET)

there is no secret sin that will not be made known

- Use a passive verb and no negatives. For example:

everything now hidden will be made clear (NJB)

every sin now hidden will be made known

- Use an active verb with both negatives. For example:

nothing is secret that God will not make known

there is no secret sin that God will not make known

- Use an active verb and no negatives. For example:

God will uncover every secret

God will make known all sin/behavior that people have hidden.

Matthew 10:27

Section 10:5–42: Jesus instructed the twelve apostles

In this section, Jesus gave various instructions to the twelve apostles. In 10:5–15, he gave them some practical instructions for preaching the good news. In 10:16–33, he described the opposition that they would see

when they went out. Lastly, in 10:34–42, he described the commitment required to be a disciple and the reward for being a disciple.

You may want to break this long section into several shorter sections. Here is an example:

Section 10:5–15	The things the apostles should/must do when sent
Section 10:16–33	The difficulties the apostles will face
Section 10:34–42	The cost and reward of following Jesus

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus gave directions/instructions to the twelve apostles for preaching the gospel

The Mission of the Twelve (GNT)

Instructions for the Twelve Apostles (CEV)

10:27a–b

Verse 10:27a–b is also a parallelism. In this particular parallelism, the ideas in 10:27a are repeated in 10:27b using different words.

The parallel parts in 10:27a–b that are similar in meaning are shown here:

^{27a} What I tell you in the dark, **speak in the daylight;**

^{27b} what is whispered in your ear, **proclaim from the housetops.**

In some languages, people will think that the parallel parts in 10:27a–b describe different events. In other words, they will think that “What I tell you in the dark” and “what is whispered” describe different events. And they will think that “speak in the light” and “proclaim from the housetops” also describe different events.

If that is true in your language, you should:

- Indicate that both parts of the clause refer to the same thing. For example:

^{27a}What I tell you in the dark, speak in the daylight.

^{27b} I repeat, what is whispered in your ear, proclaim from the housetops.

- Combine the parallel parts and emphasize it in some way. For example:

What I have told you in secret, you must now tell people publicly.

10:27a

What I tell you in the dark, speak in the daylight;

- The things that I say to you^(plur) in secret/private, tell in public,
- The things that I tell to you^(plur) alone, tell them to everyone.

What I tell you in the dark, speak in the daylight:

Here, the words in the dark figuratively refer to “in private” or “in secret.” The words in the daylight figuratively refer to “in public.” Jesus told his disciples to announce publicly the things that he had taught them in private.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Keep the figurative language. For example:

the things I tell you in the dark, speak in the daylight

- Translate the meaning directly without using any figurative speech. For example:

The things I tell you privately, tell them publicly.

- Explain the meaning in a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

Jesus figuratively used the word dark for “privately,” and the word daylight for “publicly.”

10:27b

what is whispered in your ear, proclaim from the housetops.

- and the things that I whisper in your ear, announce in the open.
- I repeat, the things that I whisper to you, tell them loudly for everyone to hear.

The Greek of 10:27b begins with a conjunction that is often translated as “and.” It is the same conjunction that is used in 10:26c to connect that verse with 10:26b. It indicates that 10:27a and 10:27b have similar

meanings. The BSB omits this conjunction, but implies the connection between 10:27a and 10:27b by using a semicolon (;) at the end of 10:27a. Other English versions translate the conjunction. For example:

and (ESV)

Another way to show this is:

I repeat

what is whispered in your ear: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as what is whispered in your ear is literally “what you hear in the ear” (as in the KJV). This clause has a similar meaning to “what I tell you in the dark” in 10:27a. It refers to the things that Jesus has told his disciples alone in private.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

what is whispered in your ear (NIV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

What I whisper in your ear (NLT)

what you have heard in private (GNT)

proclaim from the housetops: This clause has a similar meaning to the clause “speak in the daylight” in 10:27a. It refers to announcing something publicly.

Jewish houses of that time had flat roofs. People often went up and stood on these flat roofs to announce important messages.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Keep the cultural information and include some implied information. For example:

announce it publicly from your flat rooftops

- Translate the meaning without mentioning the place. For example:

announce it to everyone

tell it loudly so that everyone can hear

Matthew 10:28

Section 10:5–42: Jesus instructed the twelve apostles

In this section, Jesus gave various instructions to the twelve apostles. In 10:5–15, he gave them some practical instructions for preaching the good news. In 10:16–33, he described the opposition that they would see when they went out. Lastly, in 10:34–42, he described the commitment required to be a disciple and the reward for being a disciple.

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Section 10:5–15	The things the apostles should/must do when sent
Section 10:16–33	The difficulties the apostles will face
Section 10:34–42	The cost and reward of following Jesus

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus gave directions/instructions to the twelve apostles for preaching the gospel

The Mission of the Twelve (GNT)

Instructions for the Twelve Apostles (CEV)

10:28a

Do not be afraid of those who kill the body but cannot kill the soul.

- Do not fear people who can kill the body but cannot kill the soul.
- Do not be afraid of people. They are able to kill you^(plur), but they are not able to kill your spirits.

Do not be afraid of those who kill the body but cannot kill the soul: The word *those* refers to people in general. Specifically, it refers to the people who persecuted the disciples and had the authority to kill them.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Don't be afraid of people, who can kill the body but cannot kill the soul. (NCV)

Don't be afraid of people. They can kill you, but they cannot harm your soul. (CEV)

soul: The soul is the part of a person that continues to exist when his body dies. In some languages, this is called the spirit of a person.

10:28b

Instead, fear the One who can destroy both soul and body in hell.

- Rather/Instead, fear the one who can destroy both the soul and the body in hell.
- Be afraid of God. He is able to destroy the body and also the spirit of a person in the place of eternal punishment.

Instead, fear the One who can destroy both soul and body in hell: The words *the One who can destroy both soul and body* refers to God. Only God can destroy both the soul and the body.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

rather be afraid of God, who can destroy both body and soul in hell. (GNT)

Fear only God, who can destroy both soul and body in hell. (NLT)

destroy: This word means “ruin, demolish.” When something is destroyed, it cannot work or act, and it cannot be repaired. This verb does not refer to something that disappears and is gone.

hell: The word *hell* refers to the place of eternal punishment. It is the place where God will send unbelievers following the final judgment. God will also send the devil and his angels there.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

place of eternal punishment

place of unending fire

This word also occurs in 5:22c.

Matthew 10:29

Section 10:5–42: Jesus instructed the twelve apostles

In this section, Jesus gave various instructions to the twelve apostles. In 10:5–15, he gave them some practical instructions for preaching the good news. In 10:16–33, he described the opposition that they would see when they went out. Lastly, in 10:34–42, he described the commitment required to be a disciple and the reward for being a disciple.

You may want to break this long section into several shorter sections. Here is an example:

Section 10:5-15	The things the apostles should/must do when sent
Section 10:16-33	The difficulties the apostles will face
Section 10:34-42	The cost and reward of following Jesus

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus gave directions/instructions to the twelve apostles for preaching the gospel

The Mission of the Twelve (GNT)

Instructions for the Twelve Apostles (CEV)

10:29-31

This parable shows that God is greatly concerned for the well-being of people who believe in him. The parable shows this by comparing the way God values sparrows to the way he values people.

10:29a

Are not two sparrows sold for a penny?

- Two sparrows are sold for a single coin, isn't that right/so?
- You^(plur) can buy two small birds with/for little money.

Are not two sparrows sold for a penny?: This is a rhetorical question. The rhetorical question emphasizes the fact that people put little value on sparrows. A penny is the smallest amount of money. Yet, people could buy two sparrows with one penny.

Here are some other ways to translate the emphasis:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Can you not buy two sparrows for a penny? (NJB)

Two sparrows are sold for only a penny, isn't that right?

- As a statement. For example:

Two sparrows are sold for just a penny

For only a penny you can buy two sparrows (GNT)

Translate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

sparrows: The word sparrows refers to a kind of small bird that was sold for food. Here are some other ways to translate this word:

- Use a descriptive phrase and transliterate the word sparrow. For example:

small birds called sparrows

sparrow birds

- Use a generic phrase. For example:

small birds

- Use a common bird in your area that is small and that people eat. For example:

rice birds

penny: The Greek word that the BSB translates as penny refers to a small coin. It had little value. Sixteen of these coins were equal to one denarius. (A denarius was the usual wage for a farm worker for one day at that time.) Because the value of money changes, it is recommended that you use a general term. For example:

a small coin

very little money

10:29b

Yet not one of them will fall to the ground apart from the will of your Father.

- Yet not one of them will fall to the ground dead without your Father's permission.
- Even so not one of them will die unless your Father God wants it to happen.

Yet not one of them will fall to the ground: This clause is an idiom. It means "not one bird will die." For example:

not even one of them can die (NCV)

apart from the will of your Father: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as apart from the will of your

Father is more literally “without your Father.” There are several ways to interpret this phrase:

- 1. This phrase refers to the will of God regarding the sparrows. Not one sparrow dies without God willing it. For example:

apart from the will of your Father (NIV) (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, GW, NET)

- 1. This phrase refers to the knowledge of God regarding the sparrows. Not one sparrow dies without God knowing it:

without your Father knowing (NJB) (NJB, NLT, CEV, JBP, REB, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) because it seems to best fit the context. Just as a sparrow will not die unless it is the will of God, a disciple will not be persecuted unless it is the will of God.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- without your Father’s permission (GW)
- only if/when your heavenly Father allows it
- unless/except your Father God wants it to happen

Matthew 10:30

Section 10:5–42: Jesus instructed the twelve apostles

In this section, Jesus gave various instructions to the twelve apostles. In 10:5–15, he gave them some practical instructions for preaching the good news. In 10:16–33, he described the opposition that they would see when they went out. Lastly, in 10:34–42, he described the commitment required to be a disciple and the reward for being a disciple.

You may want to break this long section into several shorter sections. Here is an example:

Section 10:5–15	The things the apostles should/must do when sent
Section 10:16–33	The difficulties the apostles will face
Section 10:34–42	The cost and reward of following Jesus

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus gave directions/instructions to the twelve apostles for preaching the gospel

The Mission of the Twelve (GNT)

Instructions for the Twelve Apostles (CEV)

10:30
And even the very hairs of your head are all numbered.

- As for you, even the hairs of your head have all been counted. (GNT)
- But as for you^(plur), God knows how many hairs you^(plur) each have on your^(sing) head.

And: There is a comparison and contrast between birds in 10:29a and people here in 10:30. Jesus used the argument that if God cares for small birds, which are not worth much, this indicates that he is even more concerned with every detail of people’s lives.

Some English versions are like the ESV and introduce this comparison and contrast with the word “But.” Other versions are like the BSB and NIV and introduce this comparison and contrast with an And. Still other versions such as the GNT allow the context to indicate the comparison and contrast.

Use what is natural in your language for introducing this comparison and contrast.

even the very hairs of your head are all numbered:

This clause means that God knows the exact number of hairs on each person’s head. This clause does not refer to each hair having a number assigned to it.

This clause is passive. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:
 - even the hairs of your head are all counted (NRSV)
- Use an active verb. For example:

God even knows how many hairs are on your head. (NCV)

your: The pronoun your is emphasized in the Greek by being first in the clause. If you have a natural way to

emphasize the pronoun, you may want to do so. For example:

As for you, even the hairs of your head have all been counted (GNT)

Matthew 10:31

Section 10:5–42: Jesus instructed the twelve apostles

In this section, Jesus gave various instructions to the twelve apostles. In 10:5–15, he gave them some practical instructions for preaching the good news. In 10:16–33, he described the opposition that they would see when they went out. Lastly, in 10:34–42, he described the commitment required to be a disciple and the reward for being a disciple.

You may want to break this long section into several shorter sections. Here is an example:

Section 10:5–15	The things the apostles should/must do when sent
Section 10:16–33	The difficulties the apostles will face
Section 10:34–42	The cost and reward of following Jesus

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus gave directions/instructions to the twelve apostles for preaching the gospel

The Mission of the Twelve (GNT)

Instructions for the Twelve Apostles (CEV)

10:31

So do not be afraid; you are worth more than many sparrows.

- Therefore do not be afraid. You are more valuable than many sparrows.”
- So, do not fear anyone/anything, because you are more important to God than many of these small birds.”

So do not be afraid: This is Jesus’ conclusion in the form of a command. On the basis of what he has said in 10:29–30, he now concludes So do not be afraid.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Therefore do not be afraid

Fear not, therefore (ESV)

For this reason do not be afraid

you are worth more than many sparrows: This clause summarizes the basis for the command not to be afraid. Do not be afraid, because God values people more than many sparrows. So he will care for you.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

because you are worth more than many sparrows

I say this because you are more valuable to God than many of these small birds

This clause implies that God will care for his people. If people in your area do not understand that implication, you may want to explain it in a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

This means that God will certainly care for his people.

Matthew 10:32

Section 10:5–42: Jesus instructed the twelve apostles

In this section, Jesus gave various instructions to the twelve apostles. In 10:5–15, he gave them some practical instructions for preaching the good news. In 10:16–33, he described the opposition that they would see when they went out. Lastly, in 10:34–42, he described the commitment required to be a disciple and the reward for being a disciple.

You may want to break this long section into several shorter sections. Here is an example:

Section 10:5–15	The things the apostles should/must do when sent
Section 10:16–33	The difficulties the apostles will face
Section 10:34–42	The cost and reward of following Jesus

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus gave directions/instructions to the twelve apostles for preaching the gospel

The Mission of the Twelve (GNT)

Instructions for the Twelve Apostles (CEV)

10:32a

Therefore everyone who confesses Me before men,

- ¶ “So, the person who says before people that he belongs to me,
- ¶ “Therefore, if you^(plur) stand in front of others and tell them that you believe in me,

Therefore: This paragraph is the conclusion to the previous verses about persecution. Jesus told his disciples not to be afraid of persecution. Therefore, they must not deny him in front of their persecutors.

Here are some other ways to introduce this conclusion:

So in conclusion

So (ESV)

Introduce this conclusion in a natural way in your language.

everyone who confesses Me before men: The Greek word that the BSB translates as confesses means “acknowledge,” “admit” or “declare publicly.” In this context, this clause refers to publicly declaring that Jesus is the Savior and that he believes in Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Those who declare publicly that they belong to me (GNT)

If you tell others that you belong to me (CEV)

All those who stand before others and say they believe in me (NCV)

men: The Greek word that the BSB translates men is general and refers to people.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

people

others

10:32b

I will also confess him before My Father in heaven.

- I will also say in the presence of my Father in heaven that he is my follower.
- I will also say in front of my Father in heaven that you belong to me.

I will also confess him: This clause refers to Jesus declaring that the person of 10:32a is his true follower. He belongs in heaven.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I will do the same for them (GNT)

I will tell my Father in heaven that you are my followers. (CEV)

I will say before my Father in heaven that they belong to me. (NCV)

before: In this context, the word before refers to being physically in front of God.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

in the presence of (NJB)

in front of (GW)

My Father in heaven: This phrase refers to God.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

my heavenly Father

my Father who lives in heaven

my Father God in heaven

Matthew 10:33

Section 10:5–42: Jesus instructed the twelve apostles

In this section, Jesus gave various instructions to the twelve apostles. In 10:5–15, he gave them some practical instructions for preaching the good news. In 10:16–33, he described the opposition that they would see when they went out. Lastly, in 10:34–42, he described

the commitment required to be a disciple and the reward for being a disciple.

You may want to break this long section into several shorter sections. Here is an example:

Section 10:5-15	The things the apostles should/must do when sent
Section 10:16-33	The difficulties the apostles will face
Section 10:34-42	The cost and reward of following Jesus

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus gave directions/instructions to the twelve apostles for preaching the gospel

The Mission of the Twelve (GNT)

Instructions for the Twelve Apostles (CEV)

10:33a

But whoever denies Me before men,

- But the person who says before people that he doesn't know me,
- However, if you stand in front of others and tell them that you don't believe in me,

But: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between those who confess they are Jesus' disciples (10:32) and those who deny they are his (10:33).

Here are some other ways to indicate this contrast:

However

In contrast

whoever denies Me before men: The word denies refers to denying that Jesus is the Savior and denying that he believes in Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

those who reject me publicly (GNT)

the person who tells others that he doesn't know me (GW)

all who stand before others and say they do not believe in me (NCV)

10:33b

I will also deny him before My Father in heaven.

- I will also say in the presence of my Father in heaven that I don't know him."
- I will also say in front of my heavenly Father that you do not belong to me."

I will also deny: In this context, this clause refers to Jesus denying that the person is a true follower of Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I will reject (GNT)

I will say that I do not know him

I will say...that they do not belong to me. (NCV)

Matthew 10:34

Section 10:5-42: Jesus instructed the twelve apostles

In this section, Jesus gave various instructions to the twelve apostles. In 10:5-15, he gave them some practical instructions for preaching the good news. In 10:16-33, he described the opposition that they would see when they went out. Lastly, in 10:34-42, he described the commitment required to be a disciple and the reward for being a disciple.

You may want to break this long section into several shorter sections. Here is an example:

Section 10:5-15	The things the apostles should/must do when sent
Section 10:16-33	The difficulties the apostles will face
Section 10:34-42	The cost and reward of following Jesus

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus gave directions/instructions to the twelve apostles for preaching the gospel

The Mission of the Twelve (GNT)

Instructions for the Twelve Apostles (CEV)

10:34a
Do not assume that I have come to bring peace to the earth;

- ¶ “Do not think/believe that I have come to bring peace/harmony to the world.
- ¶ “You are wrong if you think that I have come to the earth to prevent fighting.

Do not assume that: The word assume refers to having a belief about something.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Do not believe that

Do not say that

You are wrong if you think that

I have come: This clause refers to Jesus coming to earth. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

I have come to the earth/world

This clause does not refer to recently coming to Capernaum.

to bring peace: These words refer to causing people to live in harmony/unity with each other. It refers to people living in good relationships with each other without fighting.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

to cause people to live in harmony/unity

to prevent fighting

The word peace also occurs in 10:13b, but there it has a more general meaning.

10:34b
I have not come to bring peace, but a sword.

- I have not come to bring peace/harmony, but disagreements/trouble.
- I did not come to prevent fighting, but I came to bring/cause fighting.

but a sword: Some of the words of the previous clause are implied but not repeated here. You may want

to repeat some of these words to make this phrase natural in your language. For example:

but I have come to bring a sword

a sword: A sword is a long knife used for fighting and cutting. The swords of that time were 60–120 centimeters long and made of metal.

Here the word sword is a figure of speech. It refers to fighting or arguments between people. Jesus was saying that the spreading of the good news would cause fighting and opposition. This opposition would come not only from a person’s enemies but even from a person’s own family.

Here are some other ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Keep the figure of speech. For example:

but a long knife

but I have come to bring a machete/bush-knife

- Translate the meaning directly without using a figure of speech. For example:

I didn’t come to bring peace but conflict (GW)

I did not come to bring harmony. I came to bring disagreements/trouble.

I did not come to prevent fighting, but to cause fighting

Matthew 10:35

Section 10:5–42: Jesus instructed the twelve apostles

In this section, Jesus gave various instructions to the twelve apostles. In 10:5–15, he gave them some practical instructions for preaching the good news. In 10:16–33, he described the opposition that they would see when they went out. Lastly, in 10:34–42, he described the commitment required to be a disciple and the reward for being a disciple.

You may want to break this long section into several shorter sections. Here is an example:

Section 10:5–15	The things the apostles should/must do when sent
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Section 10:16–33	The difficulties the apostles will face
Section 10:34–42	The cost and reward of following Jesus

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

- Jesus gave directions/instructions to the twelve apostles for preaching the gospel
- The Mission of the Twelve (GNT)

Instructions for the Twelve Apostles (CEV)

10:35–36

Most of 10:35–36 is a quote from Micah 7:6. Some English versions show this by putting the part from Micah in single quotes. For example:

- ³⁵I have come so that
- ‘a son will be against his father,
- a daughter will be against her mother,
- a daughter-in-law will be against her mother-in-law.
- ³⁶A person’s enemies will be members of his own family.’ (NCV)

10:35a

For I have come to turn ‘a man against his father,

- For I have come to cause a man to turn/rebel against his father,
- I have come so that ‘a son will be against his father, (NCV)

For: In this context, 10:35–36 explains 10:34. The Greek introduces this explanation with a conjunction that the BSB translates as For.

Here are some other ways to introduce this explanation:

- What I mean is
- Let me explain

I have come to turn ‘a man against his father: The Greek word that the BSB translates as turn means “divide,” “turn against,” “rebel,” or “reject.” When a father (10:35a) believes in Jesus, his unbelieving son often turns or rebels against his father because of their different beliefs.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- I have come to see a man against his father (ESV)
- I have come to cause a son to rebel against his father.
- I have come so that ‘a son will be against his father (NCV)

man: In this context, the word man refers to a son. Some versions make this explicit. See the example above from the NCV.

10:35b

a daughter against her mother,

- and to cause a daughter to turn/rebel against her mother,
- a daughter will be against her mother, (NCV)

daughter: In this context, the word daughter probably refers to a grown woman and not a child.

10:35c

a daughter-in-law against her mother-in-law.

- and to cause a daughter-in-law to turn/rebel against her mother-in-law.
- and a son’s wife to turn/rebel against her husband’s mother.
- a daughter-in-law will be against her mother-in-law. (NCV)

a daughter-in-law: The word daughter-in-law refers to the wife of a woman’s son.

mother-in-law: The word mother-in-law refers to the mother of a woman’s husband.

Matthew 10:36

Section 10:5–42: Jesus instructed the twelve apostles

In this section, Jesus gave various instructions to the twelve apostles. In 10:5–15, he gave them some practical instructions for preaching the good news. In 10:16–33, he described the opposition that they would see when they went out. Lastly, in 10:34–42, he described the commitment required to be a disciple and the reward for being a disciple.

You may want to break this long section into several shorter sections. Here is an example:

Section 10:5-15	The things the apostles should/must do when sent
Section 10:16-33	The difficulties the apostles will face
Section 10:34-42	The cost and reward of following Jesus

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus gave directions/instructions to the twelve apostles for preaching the gospel

The Mission of the Twelve (GNT)

Instructions for the Twelve Apostles (CEV)

10:36

A man's enemies will be the members of his own household.'

- A person's enemies will be the people who live in his own house.'
- Your worst enemies will be in your own family. (CEV)
- A person's enemies will be members of his own family.' (NCV)

The Greek of 10:36 begins with a conjunction that is often translated as "and." However, some English versions like the BSB do not translate this conjunction. Because this verse is probably a summary of 10:35, translate the connection of 10:36 to 10:35 in a way that indicates this verse has the same general meaning as 10:35.

Here is one way to introduce this summary:

What I mean is

In some languages, no connecting word or phrase is necessary.

A man's enemies will be: In some languages, it may be more natural to use "your" instead of "a man's." For example:

Your enemies will be (NLT)

the members of his own household: This phrase refers to the people who live in the man's house. This would include any relative or servant.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

those who live in his own house (JBP)

members of his own family (NCV)

in your own family (CEV)

Matthew 10:37

Section 10:5-42: Jesus instructed the twelve apostles

In this section, Jesus gave various instructions to the twelve apostles. In 10:5-15, he gave them some practical instructions for preaching the good news. In 10:16-33, he described the opposition that they would see when they went out. Lastly, in 10:34-42, he described the commitment required to be a disciple and the reward for being a disciple.

You may want to break this long section into several shorter sections. Here is an example:

Section 10:5-15	The things the apostles should/must do when sent
Section 10:16-33	The difficulties the apostles will face
Section 10:34-42	The cost and reward of following Jesus

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus gave directions/instructions to the twelve apostles for preaching the gospel

The Mission of the Twelve (GNT)

Instructions for the Twelve Apostles (CEV)

10:37a

Anyone who loves his father or mother more than Me

- ¶ "The person who loves his father or mother more than me
- ¶ "If your^(sing) love for your father or mother is greater than your love for me,

Anyone who loves his father or mother more than Me: The words Anyone who introduce a statement that is true of everyone. In some languages, it may be natural to introduce this statement with a phrase like “the person who” or with a pronoun like “you.” For example:

The person who loves his father or mother more than me (GW)

If you love your father or mother...more than me (CEV)

Those who love their father or mother more than me (GNT)

**10:37b
is not worthy of Me;**

- does not deserve to be my follower.
- you are not fit to be my disciple.

is not worthy of Me: This phrase refers to someone not being fit or deserving to belong to Jesus. For example:

are not fit to be my disciples (GNT)

does not deserve to be my disciple (GW)

**10:37c
anyone who loves his son or daughter more than Me**

- And the person who loves his son or daughter more than me
- And if your^(sing) love for your son or daughter is greater than your love for me,

**10:37d
is not worthy of Me;**

- does not deserve to be my follower.
- you are not fit to be my disciple.

Matthew 10:38

Section 10:5–42: Jesus instructed the twelve apostles

In this section, Jesus gave various instructions to the twelve apostles. In 10:5–15, he gave them some practical instructions for preaching the good news. In 10:16–33, he described the opposition that they would see when they went out. Lastly, in 10:34–42, he described

the commitment required to be a disciple and the reward for being a disciple.

You may want to break this long section into several shorter sections. Here is an example:

Section 10:5–15	The things the apostles should/ must do when sent
Section 10:16–33	The difficulties the apostles will face
Section 10:34–42	The cost and reward of following Jesus

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus gave directions/instructions to the twelve apostles for preaching the gospel

The Mission of the Twelve (GNT)

Instructions for the Twelve Apostles (CEV)

**10:38a
and anyone who does not take up his cross and follow Me**

- And the person who is not willing to carry his cross and follow me, I mean to suffer and die for me
- If you^(sing) are not willing to suffer and even die for me to be my disciple,

and anyone who: As in 10:37a, the words anyone who introduce a statement that is true for everyone. In some languages, it may be natural to introduce this statement with a phrase like “the person who” or with a pronoun like “you.” For example:

The person who does not take his cross

And unless you are willing to take up your cross (CEV)

Those who do not take up their cross (GNT)

does not take up his cross: The phrase take up his cross means “carry his cross.” For example:

Whoever is not willing to carry the cross (NCV)

This phrase refers to the way that Roman soldiers made criminals suffer and die. They forced a con-

demned criminal to pick up a large wooden cross. He had to carry it to the place where he would be put to death. Carrying a heavy cross was painful. Then the soldiers nailed him on the cross to die.

In this context, Jesus used this phrase figuratively. Jesus meant that anyone who wanted to become his disciple had to be willing to suffer and die. As Jesus was willing to suffer and carry his cross to the place where he died, a believer must also be willing to suffer for Christ even if it means dying.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- Translate the figure of speech literally and add a footnote that explains the meaning. Here is a sample footnote:

In the time of Jesus, a person who was condemned to be nailed to a cross was forced to carry the cross. He carried it to the place where he would be nailed to it. So what Jesus means here is that a person who wants to be his follower must be ready to suffer and die in order to follow Jesus.

- Translate the figure of speech and also explain the meaning in the text. For example:

anyone who is not willing to carry his cross,
meaning to suffer and die for me

- Translate the meaning directly without using a figure of speech. For example:

anyone who is not willing to suffer and even die
for me If you follow this option, consider adding
a footnote that gives Jesus’ literal words.

follow Me: This phrase refers to being a disciple of Jesus. It does not mean to walk behind Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

follow me and be my disciple

be my disciple

10:38b
is not worthy of Me.

- does not deserve to be my follower.
- you are not fit to be my disciple.

is not worthy of Me: This phrase is the same as the phrase in 10:37b. You should translate it here as you did there.

Matthew 10:39

Section 10:5–42: Jesus instructed the twelve apostles

In this section, Jesus gave various instructions to the twelve apostles. In 10:5–15, he gave them some practical instructions for preaching the good news. In 10:16–33, he described the opposition that they would see when they went out. Lastly, in 10:34–42, he described the commitment required to be a disciple and the reward for being a disciple.

You may want to break this long section into several shorter sections. Here is an example:

Section 10:5–15	The things the apostles should/ must do when sent
Section 10:16–33	The difficulties the apostles will face
Section 10:34–42	The cost and reward of following Jesus

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus gave directions/instructions to the twelve
apostles for preaching the gospel

The Mission of the Twelve (GNT)

Instructions for the Twelve Apostles (CEV)

10:39a–b

This verse is similar to Luke 9:24 and Luke 17:33. If you have already translated Luke, you may want to look there for ideas in translating this verse.

10:39a

Whoever finds his life will lose it,

- The person who tries to guard/preserve his life will lose eternal life,
- If you try to save/protect your life on earth, you will not receive life in heaven.

Whoever finds his life: The Greek word that the BSB literally translates as finds in this context means “tries to save” or “wants to protect/preserve.” It does not mean that something was lost and then found. This clause refers to someone who is not willing to suffer and die for Jesus (10:38). Instead, he wants to

save/preserve his earthly life. He tries to escape persecution and being a martyr.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

The person who tries to preserve his life (GW)

If you try to save your life (CEV)

If you cling to your life (NLT)

The person who tries to protect/guard his life instead of following me

will lose it: The phrase lose it refers to losing true life, that is, life with God that lasts forever. The person will fail to experience that life either here on earth or in heaven after he dies. He will eventually lose his physical life because no one can live forever. He will also lose the opportunity to gain true life with God.

In some languages, a literal translation of lose may imply that a person misplaces something and is unable to find it. It may also imply that a person who already has eternal life will lose it. Be careful to avoid both these implications.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

will not get true life

will not receive eternal life

10:39b
and whoever loses his life for My sake will find it.

- but the person who loses his life because of me will get eternal life.”
- But if you die because of your faith/belief in me, you will receive life in heaven.”

and: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between losing one’s life (10:39a) and finding it (10:39b). Some versions indicate this contrast with the conjunction “but.” For example:

but (GNT)

whoever loses his life for My sake will find it: This clause indicates that the person who is willing to suffer and die for Jesus will gain eternal life with God in heaven.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

but the person who loses his life for me will preserve it (GW)

but if you die because of me, you will get eternal life

Matthew 10:40

Section 10:5–42: Jesus instructed the twelve apostles

In this section, Jesus gave various instructions to the twelve apostles. In 10:5–15, he gave them some practical instructions for preaching the good news. In 10:16–33, he described the opposition that they would see when they went out. Lastly, in 10:34–42, he described the commitment required to be a disciple and the reward for being a disciple.

You may want to break this long section into several shorter sections. Here is an example:

Section 10:5–15	The things the apostles should/must do when sent
Section 10:16–33	The difficulties the apostles will face
Section 10:34–42	The cost and reward of following Jesus

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus gave directions/instructions to the twelve apostles for preaching the gospel

The Mission of the Twelve (GNT)

Instructions for the Twelve Apostles (CEV)

10:40a
He who receives you receives Me,

- ¶ “He who welcomes you welcomes me,
- ¶ “The person who gives you hospitality also gives me hospitality.
- ¶ “If people take you in to their house, it’s as if they have taken me in.

He who receives you receives Me: In this context, the word receives refers to giving hospitality to someone. It refers to taking people into one’s house and caring for them by feeding them or helping them as they need it.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Anyone who welcomes you welcomes me (NJB)

Whoever accepts you also accepts me (NCV)

The words receives Me are somewhat figurative in meaning. The disciples were messengers of Jesus. So when someone received one of them into his house, it was as if this person received Jesus into his house. If people in your area will understand the words receives Me only in the sense of Jesus physically entering the house, you may want to make some changes. For example:

The person who takes care of you, it is as if he takes care of me.

10:40b
and he who receives Me receives the One who sent Me.

- and he who welcomes me welcomes the one who sent me.
- The person who gives me hospitality, gives hospitality to the Father who sent me.
- If people take me in, they have also taken in God the Father. He sent me.

he who receives Me receives the One who sent Me:
The phrase the One who sent Me refers to God the Father. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

he who receives me receives the father, who sent me

he who welcomes me welcomes God the Father.
He sent me.

Matthew 10:41

Section 10:5–42: Jesus instructed the twelve apostles

In this section, Jesus gave various instructions to the twelve apostles. In 10:5–15, he gave them some practical instructions for preaching the good news. In 10:16–33, he described the opposition that they would see when they went out. Lastly, in 10:34–42, he described the commitment required to be a disciple and the reward for being a disciple.

You may want to break this long section into several shorter sections. Here is an example:

Section 10:5–15	The things the apostles should/must do when sent
Section 10:16–33	The difficulties the apostles will face
Section 10:34–42	The cost and reward of following Jesus

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus gave directions/instructions to the twelve apostles for preaching the gospel

The Mission of the Twelve (GNT)

Instructions for the Twelve Apostles (CEV)

10:41a
Whoever receives a prophet because he is a prophet

- He who welcomes a prophet because that person is a prophet
- The person who gives hospitality to a prophet because he sees that he is a messenger of God,
- If people take a prophet in to their house because they know that that person is a prophet,

Whoever receives a prophet: As in the previous verse, the word receives refers to giving hospitality to someone. It refers to taking a person into one’s house and caring for him by feeding him or helping him as he needs it.

In this verse, Jesus is expanding his teaching about receiving people into one’s home. Here it includes prophets. In 10:41c, he expands it further to include righteous people who are serving Christ.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

The person who receives/takes a prophet into his house

The person who welcomes a prophet (GW)

prophet: A prophet is a person who speaks on behalf of God.

The word prophet also occurs in 1:22 and 8:17a. You should translate it here as you did there. See also prophet in the Glossary for further information.

because he is a prophet: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as because he is a prophet is literally “in the name of a prophet” (as in the NET). This phrase indicates that the person knew that he was a prophet and therefore gladly received him.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

as a prophet (GW)

because that person is a prophet (CEV)

because he knows/recognizes that he is a messenger of God

10:41b
will receive a prophet’s reward,

- will receive a prophet’s reward.
- the reward that he will receive is the same reward that a prophet will receive.
- God will give to them the same reward that he will give to a prophet.

will receive a prophet’s reward: The word reward refers to wages or a gift given for worthy behavior. God gives a reward to prophets for serving him. God will also give the same reward to the person who welcomes a prophet.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

will be given the same reward as a prophet (CEV)

the reward that he will receive is the same reward that a prophet will receive

10:41c
and whoever receives a righteous man because he is a righteous man

- He who welcomes a good person because he is a good person
- The person who gives hospitality to a good/straight person because he sees that he is a good/straight person,
- If people take a holy person in to their house because they know that that person is holy,

10:41d
will receive a righteous man’s reward.

- will receive a good person’s reward.
- the reward that he will receive is the same reward that a good/straight person will receive.

- God will give to them the same reward that he will give to a holy person.

10:41c–d
and whoever receives a righteous man: A righteous man is a person who lives by God’s standards. He constantly does what is right and good in God’s sight.

This word also occurs in 9:13c.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

And whoever welcomes a good man because he is good (GNT)

anyone who welcomes a holy man (JB)

the person who welcomes a person who obeys God’s law

He who gives hospitality to a person who does what is right

In some languages there may be an idiom to describe this. For example:

If you welcome a person who follows a straight path

He who welcomes a good/straight person

Matthew 10:42

Section 10:5–42: Jesus instructed the twelve apostles

In this section, Jesus gave various instructions to the twelve apostles. In 10:5–15, he gave them some practical instructions for preaching the good news. In 10:16–33, he described the opposition that they would see when they went out. Lastly, in 10:34–42, he described the commitment required to be a disciple and the reward for being a disciple.

You may want to break this long section into several shorter sections. Here is an example:

Section 10:5–15	The things the apostles should/must do when sent
Section 10:16–33	The difficulties the apostles will face
Section 10:34–42	The cost and reward of following Jesus

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus gave directions/instructions to the twelve apostles for preaching the gospel

The Mission of the Twelve (GNT)

Instructions for the Twelve Apostles (CEV)

10:42a

And if anyone gives even a cup of cold water to one of these little ones

- He who gives even a cup/drink of cold water to one of these ordinary people
- If anyone gives even a cup of cool water to drink to one of these humble disciples of mine

And if anyone gives even a cup of cold water to one of these little ones: The phrase one of these little ones refers to any disciple of Jesus. The word little is used in a figurative way to refer to a disciple of low status, not his age. He is an ordinary person and is not important.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

one of the least of these my followers (GNT)

any of my humble followers (GW)

one of these least important disciples of mine

even a cup of cold water: Giving someone a cup of cold water to drink was a common example at that time of the smallest deed of hospitality. Even a poor person could go to the community well and get water for someone to drink.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

even a cup of cold water to drink

even a drink of water (JBP)

10:42b

because he is My disciple,

- because that person is my disciple,
- because he sees/knows that that person is my disciple,

because he is My disciple: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as because he is My disciple is literally “in the name of a disciple” (as in the NET). The meaning is the same as the similar phrase in 10:41a. This phrase indicates that the person knew the other person was a disciple and therefore gave him a cup of cold water.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

because that person is my disciple (GW)

because he knows/recognizes that he is my disciple

10:42c

truly I tell you, he will never lose his reward.”

- I assure you^(plur), he will surely not lose his reward.”
- I tell you^(plur) with certainty, he will receive a reward for helping that disciple.”
- God will definitely give him a reward.”

truly I tell you: Jesus often used these words to introduce a statement that he wanted to emphasize.

Here are some other ways to show this emphasis:

- As a phrase before Jesus’ statement. For example:

I tell you the truth (NIV)

Listen to this:

Let me tell you this:

- As an emphatic word within Jesus’ statement. For example:

he will certainly never lose his reward

If you have another way in your language to emphasize a statement or to alert people to listen with special attention, consider using it here. See how you translated this clause in 10:23b.

he will never lose his reward: The phrase never lose is a figure of speech. It means that he “will definitely receive” a reward. Here lose does not mean that the person had a reward and then lost it.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he will not fail to receive a reward

will certainly receive a reward (GNT)

God will certainly give him a reward

Matthew 11:1

Section 11:1–19: Jesus praised John the Baptist

Long before Jesus was born, God spoke of a messenger who would prepare the people for the coming of the Messiah (Malachi 3:1). John the Baptist was that messenger. When John's ministry was ending, he began to doubt that Jesus was the Messiah. So John sent some of his disciples to verify that Jesus was the Messiah (11:3). Jesus indicated that his miracles and preaching were proof that he was the expected Messiah whom God spoke of (11:4–5).

Jesus then showed that John was very important in God's eyes (11:7–14).

Jesus and John did God's work in very different ways, but most people refused to listen to either person (11:16–19).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The question of John the Baptist

Jesus talked about John the Baptizer

Messengers from John the Baptist (NRSV)

Jesus and John the Baptizer's actions prove who they are

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 7:18–35.

11:1

Some English versions (like the NIV) put this verse with the last section of chapter 10. Other versions put this verse with the first section of chapter 11. The context probably indicates that this verse is a conclusion to the previous section. The three reasons why this verse probably goes with the previous section are: (1) After Jesus finishes speaking in 10:42, there is no other concluding statement about finishing his teaching and sending the twelve disciples. (2) 11:1b is a general statement and not strongly connected to 11:2 in regards to place or time. (3) 11:2 begins with the Greek conjunction *de*, which sometimes indicates a new episode in a narrative. So, if the major language version in your area puts 11:1 with the previous sec-

tion, you may want to put 11:1 with the previous section.

11:1a

After Jesus had finished instructing His twelve disciples,

- ¶ When Jesus finished commanding/teaching his twelve disciples,
- ¶ After Jesus finished saying these words to his twelve disciples, he sent them out. Then

After Jesus had finished instructing His twelve disciples:

The Greek verb that the BSB translates as instructing refers to giving commands, orders, or instructions. It is a different Greek word than the word translated as "teach" in 11:1b, but the meaning is related.

This clause refers to 10:5–42. There Jesus gave his disciples certain commands, and he taught them about things that would happen. If possible, use an expression that refers to both commands and teachings. For example:

After Jesus finished telling these things to his twelve followers (NCV)

When Jesus finished commanding and teaching his twelve disciples

It was probably at this point that Jesus sent out the twelve disciples. He sent them out to begin the ministry that he had given them. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this information explicit. For example:

After Jesus gave/explained these commands to his twelve disciples he sent them out. Then

11:1b

He went on from there to teach and preach in their cities.

- he left there and went to some Jewish towns to preach to the people.
- he left that place and went to the towns in that area and taught the good news.

He went on from there: This clause indicates that Jesus left the place where he had been instructing his disciples. (This place was probably in the hills around Lake Galilee.) He left that place and went to some of the towns in the district of Galilee.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he left that place (GNT)

he went away from there

As mentioned above, Jesus probably sent out the disciples before he left that place. So when he left, the disciples were no longer with him. If your readers will think that Jesus left with his disciples, you may want to include some implicit information. See the example above in 11:1a.

teach and preach: The phrase teach and preach is a doublet. This means that these two verbs mean almost the same thing. They refer to announcing news in a public manner. In some languages, both verbs can be translated by one verb or by one verb phrase. For example:

teach his message (GW)

tell the good news

announce God's news

in their cities: The pronoun their refers to the Jews (as it does in the phrase "their synagogues" in 9:35). It does not refer to the disciples.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in the Jewish towns

in the towns near there (GNT)

in towns throughout the region (NLT)

cities: The Greek word that the BSB translates as cities refers to either towns or cities. They are larger and more important than villages, which is a different Greek word. The Jewish towns of Galilee most likely had less than three thousand people in each town. Do not use a word that refers only to large, modern cities of today.

Matthew 11:2

Section 11:1–19: Jesus praised John the Baptist

Long before Jesus was born, God spoke of a messenger who would prepare the people for the coming of the Messiah (Malachi 3:1). John the Baptist was that messenger. When John's ministry was ending, he began to doubt that Jesus was the Messiah. So John sent some

of his disciples to verify that Jesus was the Messiah (11:3). Jesus indicated that his miracles and preaching were proof that he was the expected Messiah whom God spoke of (11:4–5).

Jesus then showed that John was very important in God's eyes (11:7–14).

Jesus and John did God's work in very different ways, but most people refused to listen to either person (11:16–19).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The question of John the Baptist

Jesus talked about John the Baptizer

Messengers from John the Baptist (NRSV)

Jesus and John the Baptizer's actions prove who they are

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 7:18–35.

11:2a

Meanwhile John heard in prison about the works of Christ,

- ¶ While these things were happening, John was in prison. While there, he heard about the wonderful deeds that the Christ was doing,
- ¶ During that time, John the Baptizer heard about the things that the Christ/Messiah was saying and doing. Because John was in prison,

Meanwhile: Verse 11:2 begins a new paragraph. The BSB indicates the start of this new paragraph with the word Meanwhile.

John was already in prison in 4:12. It was while he was in prison that he heard about the teachings (chapters 5–7) and miracles of Jesus (chapters 8–9).

Here are some other ways to indicate that this new paragraph is beginning:

At that time

While these things were happening

John: The John that Matthew referred to here is John the Baptist, not the disciple named John. In some

languages, it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

John the Baptist (GNT)

heard in prison: The word prison refers to a building where the government puts people and locks them in so they cannot leave.

Here is another way to translate this word:

jail

People are usually in prison because they have broken the law. But John was in prison because King Herod was upset at his preaching. Your translation should not indicate that John had broken the law.

about the works of Christ: This clause refers to the teaching, preaching, and miracles that Jesus was doing in chapters 5–9.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

about the wonderful deeds that the Christ was doing

about the things that the Christ was doing and saying

Christ: Here Matthew used the word Christ as a descriptive title for Jesus. Christ is not just a name for Jesus. It has meaning, and the meaning of the title is in focus in this context.

During the time when the New Testament was written, the Jews used the term “the Christ” or “the Messiah” to refer to the special person whom God had promised to appoint and send to them. They believed that when he came, he would save their nation from their enemies. He was to be their King, Redeemer, and Savior.

Note that Christ as a title means the same thing as “the Messiah.” Christ is the Greek translation of the Hebrew word Messiah. So when Christ is used as a title, some English versions translate it as “the Messiah” to clearly show that it is a title for Jesus, not his name.

Here are some other ways to translate Christ:

- Transliterate Christ and indicate in some way that it is a title. For example:

the Kristi

- Transliterate Christ and include a phrase that explains the meaning. For example:

Karisiti, the appointed one

Cristo, the Savior whom God promised to send

- Use a title or a descriptive phrase in your language that has the same meaning as Christ. For example:

the Messiah

the Promised Deliverer

the Rescuer-King whom God sent

If you do not indicate the meaning of Christ in the text, you may want to include a footnote to explain the meaning of Christ. Or you may want to explain the meaning in a glossary. For example:

The word/title “Christ” refers to the King and Savior whom God had promised to send.

See also Christ in the Glossary.

11:2b

and he sent his disciples

- so he sent some of his disciples to Jesus.
- he sent some of his disciples to Jesus with a message.

and he sent his disciples: There is a textual issue here. Some Greek manuscripts have the word “two” here. For example, the KJV has “two of his disciples.” The earlier Greek manuscripts do not have the word “two.” Most English versions follow the earlier manuscripts.: This clause indicates that John sent some of his own disciples to Jesus with a message.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

sent his own disciples (REB)

he sent some of his disciples (GNT)

he sent some of his own disciples to Jesus with this message

Matthew 11:3

Section 11:1–19: Jesus praised John the Baptist

Long before Jesus was born, God spoke of a messenger who would prepare the people for the coming of the Messiah (Malachi 3:1). John the Baptist was that messenger. When John's ministry was ending, he began to doubt that Jesus was the Messiah. So John sent some of his disciples to verify that Jesus was the Messiah (11:3). Jesus indicated that his miracles and preaching were proof that he was the expected Messiah whom God spoke of (11:4–5).

Jesus then showed that John was very important in God's eyes (11:7–14).

Jesus and John did God's work in very different ways, but most people refused to listen to either person (11:16–19).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The question of John the Baptist

Jesus talked about John the Baptizer

Messengers from John the Baptist (NRSV)

Jesus and John the Baptizer's actions prove who they are

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 7:18–35.

11:3a

to ask Him, "Are You the One who was to come,

- They asked him, "Are you^(sing) the person whom the prophets said would come,
- When they arrived, they asked him, "Master/Teacher, God promised that someone would come to save us. Are you^(sing) that person?

to ask Him: This clause implies that the disciples left John and went to where Jesus was to ask the question. In some languages, it may be necessary to make some of this explicit. For example:

When they arrived, they asked him

Are You the One who was to come: This is a real question. John's disciples certainly asked Jesus this question in a polite way. In some languages, a literal translation of the question may sound impolite. It may

be necessary to begin the question with a term of respect. For example:

Master/Teacher, are you the one who is to come...?

Please, are you the one who is to come...?

the One who was to come: In this context, the phrase the One who was to come refers to "the Christ." The Old Testament prophets had said that the Christ would come. John too was a prophet. He said that the Christ would come and that Jesus was the Christ. But for some unknown reason, when he was in prison, he began to doubt that Jesus was the Christ.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

are you the one whom God said will come...?

are you the person whom we were told would come to save us...?

The prophets said that someone would come to save us. Are you that person?

You may want to add a footnote to explain these words. Here is a sample footnote:

Based on Old Testament prophecies, the Jews were expecting God to send a special person to save them. This person was called "the Christ." The words "the one who was to come" refer to the Christ.

11:3b

or should we look for someone else?"

- or should we^(excl) wait for another person to come?"
- Or should we^(excl) continue to look for someone else?"

we: The pronoun we refers to all the Jews, not only John's disciples. Many Jews expected the Christ to come and lead them to victory over the Romans. Jesus was not included in the pronoun we, because they were asking Jesus if he was the Christ.

look for someone else: The Greek word that the BSB translates as look for means "expect" or "wait for." The Jews were waiting for the person whom God had promised to send to them. This person was called "the Christ." But many Jews were expecting the Christ to come and win earthly victory over their enemies. Jesus was not fulfilling those popular expectations.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

wait for another (NRSV)

expect someone else

continue looking for him

Matthew 11:4

Section 11:1–19: Jesus praised John the Baptist

Long before Jesus was born, God spoke of a messenger who would prepare the people for the coming of the Messiah (Malachi 3:1). John the Baptist was that messenger. When John's ministry was ending, he began to doubt that Jesus was the Messiah. So John sent some of his disciples to verify that Jesus was the Messiah (11:3). Jesus indicated that his miracles and preaching were proof that he was the expected Messiah whom God spoke of (11:4–5).

Jesus then showed that John was very important in God's eyes (11:7–14).

Jesus and John did God's work in very different ways, but most people refused to listen to either person (11:16–19).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The question of John the Baptist

Jesus talked about John the Baptizer

Messengers from John the Baptist (NRSV)

Jesus and John the Baptizer's actions prove who they are

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 7:18–35.

11:4a

Jesus replied, "Go back and report to John

- Jesus answered them, "Go back and tell John about
- Jesus replied, "My friends, return to John and give him a report

Jesus replied: The verb replied introduces Jesus' answer to the question that John's disciples asked in 11:3. It indicates that Jesus did not ignore the question even though his answer was indirect. He wanted

John's disciples to see the miracles that he was doing. The miracles showed that he was the Christ, the one whom the prophets said would come.

So the implied direct answer is "Yes, I am the Christ/Messiah." But he did not openly say "Yes, I am the Christ" until his trial (26:62–64). So your translation should keep the implied answer of "Yes, I am the Christ" as implied only.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus answered John's disciples (GW)

Jesus replied (NIV)

Go back and report to John: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as report refers to giving information about something. Jesus instructed John's disciples to go give a report to John about the things that they heard and saw.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Go back to John and tell him (NLT)

Go back and report to John (NIV)

11:4b

what you hear and see:

- the things that you^(plur) hear and see, which are
- of the things that you^(plur) hear me say and see me do. These things are
- of the words that you hear and the deeds that you see.

what you hear and see: The words what you hear and see refer to the words and deeds of Jesus. According to Luke 7:21, Jesus was healing people while John's disciples were there with him. So John's disciples were eye witnesses to at least some of Jesus' miracles. It is possible that they did not see all the miracles that Jesus mentioned, but they had heard reports about them. They probably also heard Jesus preach.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

what you are hearing and seeing (GNT)

the words that you are hearing and the deeds that you are seeing

what you hear me say and see me do

Matthew 11:5

Section 11:1–19: Jesus praised John the Baptist

Long before Jesus was born, God spoke of a messenger who would prepare the people for the coming of the Messiah (Malachi 3:1). John the Baptist was that messenger. When John's ministry was ending, he began to doubt that Jesus was the Messiah. So John sent some of his disciples to verify that Jesus was the Messiah (11:3). Jesus indicated that his miracles and preaching were proof that he was the expected Messiah whom God spoke of (11:4–5).

Jesus then showed that John was very important in God's eyes (11:7–14).

Jesus and John did God's work in very different ways, but most people refused to listen to either person (11:16–19).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The question of John the Baptist

Jesus talked about John the Baptizer

Messengers from John the Baptist (NRSV)

Jesus and John the Baptizer's actions prove who they are

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 7:18–35.

11:5

In 11:5 Jesus referred to the prophecies in Isaiah 35:5–6 and 61:1. These verses in Isaiah tell about things that would happen when the Christ, the Messiah, came. Jesus was doing these things. So he mentioned them to answer the disciples of John and to show them that he was the Christ.

11:5a

The blind receive sight, the lame walk,

- people who were blind now see. Those who were lame now walk,
- the blind are healed by me. The lame are healed by me.
- I am healing the blind, the lame,

The blind receive sight: This clause refers to blind people whom Jesus healed and so they began seeing.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

The blind are seeing

People who were blind can now see

I heal the blind and so now they are able to see

the lame walk: The word lame refers to those who could not walk or use their legs properly.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the crippled are walking

people who had crippled legs can now walk

I heal those with bad legs and so now they are able to walk

11:5b

the lepers are cleansed,

- and people who had leprosy have been healed.
- The lepers are being healed by me.
- those with dreaded/serious skin diseases,

the lepers are cleansed: The Greek word that the BSB translates literally as cleansed means “healed” in this context. For example:

People with leprosy are being healed (CEV)

This clause is passive. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

the lepers are cured (NLT)

- Use another type of verb. For example:

I heal people who have leprosy

People with leprosy are well again

the lepers: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the lepers refers to people who have various kinds of infectious skin diseases. It probably included the disease that we call leprosy today. Leprosy turns the skin white and the affected skin eventually dies.

Here is another way to translate this word:

those who have leprosy (NIV)

If you are in an area where leprosy is not known, you can:

- Use a general term for a skin disease. For example:

dreaded/serious skin disease

- Use a term for another specific type of serious skin disease. For example:

skin fungus

11:5c

the deaf hear, the dead are raised,

- Those who were deaf now hear. People who were dead have been made alive again,
- The deaf are being healed by me. The dead are being made alive again by me.
- and the deaf. I am bringing back to life some people who have died.

the deaf hear: This clause refers to deaf people whom Jesus healed and so they began hearing.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the deaf are hearing

I heal deaf people and so now they are able to hear

the dead are raised: In this context, the word raised refers to causing a dead person to “live again.”

This clause is passive. Here are some other ways to translate it:

General Comment on 11:5a–c

- Use a passive verb. For example:

dead people are brought back to life (GW)

- Use a verb that is not passive. For example:

Dead people are living again

I make dead people alive again

The healing in 11:5a–c refers to miracles of healing. These clauses do not refer to healing as a doctor heals people through medicine or surgery.

If people in your area will think that the healing refers to the way a doctor heals, you may want to:

- Include some implied information. For example:

The blind miraculously receive sight, the lame are miraculously cured and walk, those who have leprosy are miraculously cured, the deaf are miraculously cured and hear, the dead are miraculously raised and live again.

- Include a footnote. For example:

All these healings are miracles that Jesus did.

11:5d

and the good news is preached to the poor.

- and poor people are hearing good news.
- The poor are being told God’s good news by me.
- And I am also preaching good news to poor people.

the good news is preached to the poor: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as good news is preached refers to the gospel. This is the good news that God has made a way to save sinful people through Jesus.

This verb is passive. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

the Good News is being preached to the poor (NLT)

- Use an active verb. For example:

and poor people hear the Good News (GW)

I am preaching the Good News to the poor

the poor: This phrase refers to people who are in poverty. They have little money and other physical things. Here this phrase does not refer to those who are “poor in spirit.”

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

poor people (GW)

General Comment on 11:5a–d

If it is not clear in your language that Jesus’ answer showed that he was the one who was to come (11:3), you may want to explain it in a footnote at the end of 11:5. Here is a sample footnote:

The deeds spoken of in 11:5 are deeds that Jesus had been doing. These deeds matched the prophecies in the Old Testament about the Christ/Messiah. The Christ/Messiah was the special person whom the Jews were expecting to come from God to save them. These deeds showed that Jesus was this special person.

Matthew 11:6

Section 11:1–19: Jesus praised John the Baptist

Long before Jesus was born, God spoke of a messenger who would prepare the people for the coming of the Messiah (Malachi 3:1). John the Baptist was that messenger. When John's ministry was ending, he began to doubt that Jesus was the Messiah. So John sent some of his disciples to verify that Jesus was the Messiah (11:3). Jesus indicated that his miracles and preaching were proof that he was the expected Messiah whom God spoke of (11:4–5).

Jesus then showed that John was very important in God's eyes (11:7–14).

Jesus and John did God's work in very different ways, but most people refused to listen to either person (11:16–19).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The question of John the Baptist

Jesus talked about John the Baptizer

Messengers from John the Baptist (NRSV)

Jesus and John the Baptizer's actions prove who they are

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 7:18–35.

11:6

Blessed is the one who does not fall away on account of Me."

- Blessed/Favored is the person who does not doubt me."
- God approves/blesses the person who does not reject/desert me because of what I do."

In 11:6, Jesus encouraged John and his disciples to continue to believe that he was the Messiah/Christ.

Blessed is the one: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Blessed refers to the good situation/condition that a person is in when a superior person does something good to him. When God does something good to a human being and is kind to him, that person is in a good situation. He is "blessed," "fortunate," and "favored."

Here are some other ways to translate Blessed:

Favored/fortunate

God favors/approves

Joyful/desirable is the situation of

How good it is for

This word does not primarily refer to a feeling. However, a person in this good situation will frequently have good feelings like happiness and joy. Do not use a word that only refers to material prosperity or physical health. Do not use a word that refers only to being lucky. See also bless, Meaning 2, in the Glossary.

does not fall away on account of Me: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as does not fall away on account of Me means "does not doubt me" or "does not stop believing me."

Jesus did some things that people did not expect the Messiah to do. And he did not do some things that they expected the Messiah to do. This caused some people to be offended by him. As a result, they began to doubt whether Jesus was the Messiah. Some people rejected and deserted him and refused to believe that he was the Messiah.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

have no doubts about me (GNT)

doesn't reject me because of what I do (CEV)

turn away because of me (NLT)

does not stop believing in me

Matthew 11:7

Section 11:1–19: Jesus praised John the Baptist

Long before Jesus was born, God spoke of a messenger who would prepare the people for the coming of the

Messiah (Malachi 3:1). John the Baptist was that messenger. When John's ministry was ending, he began to doubt that Jesus was the Messiah. So John sent some of his disciples to verify that Jesus was the Messiah (11:3). Jesus indicated that his miracles and preaching were proof that he was the expected Messiah whom God spoke of (11:4-5).

Jesus then showed that John was very important in God's eyes (11:7-14).

Jesus and John did God's work in very different ways, but most people refused to listen to either person (11:16-19).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The question of John the Baptist

Jesus talked about John the Baptizer

Messengers from John the Baptist (NRSV)

Jesus and John the Baptizer's actions prove who they are

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 7:18-35.

11:7a

As John's disciples were leaving,

- ¶ While John's disciples were going back,
- ¶ Then the disciples of John began to leave. As they were going away,

As John's disciples were leaving: The Greek word that the BSB translates as John's disciples is the pronoun "they." They turned around and started to leave Jesus to return to John.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

While they were going away (NET)

As they went away (NRSV)

11:7b

Jesus began to speak to the crowds about John:

- Jesus started talking to the crowd about John and asked,
- Jesus turned to the crowds and began talking with them about John. He said,

Jesus began to speak to the crowds about John:

Jesus changed from speaking to John's disciples to speaking to the crowd. John's disciples had probably walked a small distance away when Jesus began to speak to the crowd. The text does not say whether they heard Jesus when he spoke the words of 11:7c-15.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

Jesus turned to the crowd and began to talk with them about John

11:7c

"What did you go out into the wilderness to see?"

- "What kind of person did you go into the wilderness to see?
- "When you^(plur) went out in the wilderness, did you go to see
- "When you^(plur) went into the desert, you certainly did not go to see

What did you go out into the wilderness to see?:

This is a rhetorical question. Jesus repeated a shortened form of this same rhetorical question in 11:8a and 11:9a. In each case, this rhetorical question introduces another rhetorical question. Jesus used the first two pairs of rhetorical questions to state who John obviously was not. Then he used the last pair to emphasize who John actually was.

Translate this rhetorical question in a way that indicates that Jesus knew the kind of person John was but wanted the people to think about what kind of person John was. Jesus was not asking these rhetorical questions to criticize the people for going out to see John.

Here are some other ways to translate this introductory question:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

What sort of person did you go out into the desert to see? (CEV)

When you went out into the wilderness to see John, what kind of man did you expect to see?

- As the introductory clause in a rhetorical question or statement. For example:

When you went into the wilderness, did you go to see...

When you went into the wilderness, you certainly did not go to see...

Use a natural way in your language to translate this type of expression.

wilderness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as wilderness refers to a wild, desolate area where few people lived. Some versions like the NIV translates this word as “desert.” It was often a dry area, but it was not just sand and barren. Some wild grasses and bushes grew there. The focus here is that few people lived there, not that it was dry.

Some languages have a special word to refer to such an area, such as “the bush” (Africa) or “steppes” (Asia). It may be appropriate to use such a word here.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

desert (NIV)

empty land

region where no one lives

11:7d

A reed swaying in the wind?

- A man who is like tall grass that the wind blows?
- a man who easily changes his mind like tall grass that the wind sways? No!
- a man who is easily swayed by the opinions of others like tall grass that easily bends in the wind!

A reed swaying in the wind?: The Greek word that the BSB translates as reed refers to tall grass that grows beside the Jordan river.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

- Use a general term. For example:

tall grass (CEV)

- Use a specific term in your language for a type of reeds/grass that grows beside rivers and lakes.

There are four issues to consider when translating this clause: implied information, passive, metaphor, and rhetorical question.

Issue 1: Implied information

Some words from the previous rhetorical question are implied but not repeated here. It may be more natural

in your language to include some or all of the implied words. For example:

Did you go out into the wilderness to see a reed shaken by the wind?

Issue 2: Passive

This clause is passive. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

A reed swayed by the wind? (NIV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

A reed that the wind sways?

Issue 3: Rhetorical question

This clause is also a rhetorical question. Jesus used this rhetorical question to emphasize that the people did not go out to see a reed shaken by the wind.

Here are some other ways to translate this emphasis:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Was he anything like a reed swayed by the wind?

A reed swayed by the wind? Certainly not!

- As a statement. For example:

You certainly did not go out to see a reed swayed by the wind.

You certainly did not go out to see a man who is like a reed swayed by the wind.

Translate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

Issue 4: Metaphor

Also, this clause is a metaphor. In this metaphor, Jesus asked whether John was like a reed. A reed represents a man who has a weak character. He often changes his opinions because he is influenced by what other people think of him.

Here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

Tall grass swaying in the wind? (GW)

- Change the metaphor to a simile and make the topic explicit. For example:

Was he like tall grass blown about by the wind? (CEV)

- Make the topic and point of similarity explicit. For example:

Was he a weak reed, swayed by every breath of wind? (NLT)

Did you go out to see a man who is weak/wavering like a reed blowing in the wind?

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

A man who always changes his mind?

Matthew 11:8

Section 11:1–19: Jesus praised John the Baptist

Long before Jesus was born, God spoke of a messenger who would prepare the people for the coming of the Messiah (Malachi 3:1). John the Baptist was that messenger. When John's ministry was ending, he began to doubt that Jesus was the Messiah. So John sent some of his disciples to verify that Jesus was the Messiah (11:3). Jesus indicated that his miracles and preaching were proof that he was the expected Messiah whom God spoke of (11:4–5).

Jesus then showed that John was very important in God's eyes (11:7–14).

Jesus and John did God's work in very different ways, but most people refused to listen to either person (11:16–19).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The question of John the Baptist

Jesus talked about John the Baptizer

Messengers from John the Baptist (NRSV)

Jesus and John the Baptizer's actions prove who they are

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 7:18–35.

11:8a

Otherwise, what did you go out to see?

- If not, then, what kind of person did you go out to see?
- So when you went into the wilderness, did you go to see
- When you went into the desert, you certainly did not go to see

Otherwise: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Otherwise is more literally “But what” (as in the KJV and NASB). This phrase indicates a contrast. The contrast is between going out to see a man wavering like a reed (11:7c–d) and the type of person whom the people really went out to the desert to see.

By using a contrastive phrase in Greek here, Jesus made it clear that he answered “no” to the rhetorical question in 11:7c. The people certainly did not go out to see that kind of man. Then Jesus asked a similar question here.

To help the transition from “no” to the question which follows, you may want to add “so” or “then.” Here is another way to translate this:

No? Then what did you go out to see? (REB)

what did you go out to see?: This rhetorical question is almost identical to the rhetorical question in 11:7c, but it does not contain the phrase “into the wilderness.” This rhetorical question together with the rhetorical question in 11:8b emphasize who John was not.

Here are some other ways to translate this emphatic statement:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

What kind of man did you go out to see? (CEV)

When you went out to see John, what kind of man did you expect to see?

- As the introductory clause in a rhetorical question or statement. For example:

When you went out, did you go to see...

When you went out, you certainly did not go to see...

Use a natural way in your language to translate this type of expression.

11:8b

A man dressed in fine clothes?

- Did you^(plur) go to see a man who wears expensive clothes?
- a man who wears beautiful clothes? No!
- a man dressed in clothes that rich people wear.

A man dressed in fine clothes?: Some words from the previous sentence are implied but not repeated here. It may be more natural in your language to include some or all the implied words. For example:

Did you go to see a man dressed in soft clothes?

This is also a rhetorical question. Jesus used this rhetorical question to emphasize that they did not go out to see a man dressed in fine clothes.

Here are some other ways to translate this emphasis:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Was he a man dressed in soft clothes?

Did you go to see a man dressed in soft clothes?
No!

- As a statement. For example:

You certainly did not go out to see a man dressed in soft clothes.

Translate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

dressed in fine clothes: This phrase refers to the soft, expensive clothes that rich people wore. John's clothes were made of camel hair and were rough. Jesus contrasted the soft and luxurious lifestyle of kings and their officials with John's rough and difficult life in the desert.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

dressed in expensive clothes (NLT)

wearing clothes that rich people wear

11:8c

Look, those who wear fine clothing are found in kings' palaces.

- No, people who wear expensive clothes are in the houses of kings.
- People who dress like that live in kings' palaces.

Look: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Look emphasizes the words that follow. Some languages emphasize a sentence with a word or phrase at the beginning. Other languages do it with a word or phrase at the end. For example:

Of course not! Those who wear soft clothing are in kings' houses.

Those who wear soft clothing are in kings' houses, aren't they?

Emphasize the following words in a way that is natural in your language.

those who wear fine clothing are found in kings' palaces: This clause refers to the king and his family. They are people who are rich and wear expensive, fine clothes.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Those who wear fine clothes are in royal palaces.
(GW)

People who dress like that live in the king's palace. (CEV)

Matthew 11:9

Section 11:1–19: Jesus praised John the Baptist

Long before Jesus was born, God spoke of a messenger who would prepare the people for the coming of the Messiah (Malachi 3:1). John the Baptist was that messenger. When John's ministry was ending, he began to doubt that Jesus was the Messiah. So John sent some of his disciples to verify that Jesus was the Messiah (11:3). Jesus indicated that his miracles and preaching were proof that he was the expected Messiah whom God spoke of (11:4–5).

Jesus then showed that John was very important in God's eyes (11:7–14).

Jesus and John did God's work in very different ways, but most people refused to listen to either person (11:16–19).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The question of John the Baptist

Jesus talked about John the Baptizer

Messengers from John the Baptist (NRSV)

Jesus and John the Baptizer's actions prove who they are

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 7:18–35.

11:9a

What then did you go out to see?

- So, what kind of person did you go out to see?
- So when you went into the wilderness, did you go to see
- When you went into the desert, you went to see

What then did you go out to see?: This rhetorical question is exactly the same as the rhetorical question in 11:8a. However, you may have to translate this rhetorical question slightly differently than the one in 11:8a. This is because the expected answer to the pair of rhetorical questions in 11:9a–b is “yes.”

11:9b

A prophet?

- Did you^(plur) go to see a prophet?
- a prophet?
- a prophet.

A prophet?: Some words from the previous sentence are implied but not repeated. It may be more natural in some languages to include some or all of the implied words. For example:

Did you go to see a prophet?

This is a rhetorical question. Jesus used this rhetorical question to emphasize that they did go out to see a prophet.

Here are some other ways to translate this emphasis:

- As a rhetorical question. Your translation should imply that the expected answer was “Yes, they went out to see a prophet.” For example:

Did you go to see a prophet?

You went out to see a prophet, right?

- As a statement. For example:

You certainly did go to see a prophet.

It was a prophet whom you went out to see.

Translate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

prophet: See how you translated this word in 1:22 or 10:41a. Also see prophet in the Glossary for further information.

11:9c

Yes, I tell you, and more than a prophet.

- Yes! I tell you that he is more important than a prophet.
- Of course! And I tell you that he is greater/higher than a prophet.
- And John is certainly greater than all the other prophets.

Yes, I tell you: The word Yes shows what is the expected answer to the rhetorical question in 11:9b. The words I tell you emphasize the following statement.

Here are some other ways to show this emphasis:

- As a phrase before Jesus' statement. For example:

Let me tell you (GW)

- As an emphatic word within Jesus' statement. For example:

He is certainly more than a prophet

more than a prophet: The words more than a prophet mean that John was not only a prophet, he was greater than all the other prophets. Among the Jews, the highest religious position a man could have was to be called a prophet. So Jesus' statement showed that John was indeed a very important person.

In Malachi 3:1, it was prophesied that a messenger would come to prepare the way of the Lord. That messenger was John. John was the only prophet who had that privilege. Because of that, he was greater than all the other prophets.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

John is more than a prophet (NCV)

he is greater/higher than a prophet

the prophet you saw is greater than the other prophets

Matthew 11:10

Section 11:1–19: Jesus praised John the Baptist

Long before Jesus was born, God spoke of a messenger who would prepare the people for the coming of the Messiah (Malachi 3:1). John the Baptist was that messenger. When John's ministry was ending, he began to doubt that Jesus was the Messiah. So John sent some of his disciples to verify that Jesus was the Messiah (11:3). Jesus indicated that his miracles and preaching were proof that he was the expected Messiah whom God spoke of (11:4–5).

Jesus then showed that John was very important in God's eyes (11:7–14).

Jesus and John did God's work in very different ways, but most people refused to listen to either person (11:16–19).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The question of John the Baptist

Jesus talked about John the Baptizer

Messengers from John the Baptist (NRSV)

Jesus and John the Baptizer's actions prove who they are

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 7:18–35.

11:10a

This is the one about whom it is written:

- John is the person about whom it is written:
- John is the man whom the prophet wrote about long ago when God said:

This is the one about whom it is written: This clause refers to John the Baptist. He is the person about whom the following clauses (11:10b–c) are written.

The Greek verb that the BSB translates as it is written is passive. God told the prophet Malachi about John, and Malachi wrote down God's words. He did this four hundred years before the time of John.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

John is the person about whom it is written:

- Use an active verb. For example:

This is the one about whom the prophet wrote when God said

John is the person whom the prophet wrote about long ago

11:10b–c

The words of 11:10b–c refer to the prophecy in Malachi 3:1. Many years before John the Baptist was born, Malachi wrote down the prophecy that God told him. John the Baptist fulfilled that prophecy.

11:10b

'Behold, I will send My messenger ahead of You,

- 'Listen! I will send my messenger before you.
- 'I will send my messenger to go ahead of you.

Behold: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Behold indicates that the speaker will say something important or surprising, and he wants people to listen carefully to it. If you have a word in your language that emphasizes the importance of the words that follow, you can use it here. Here are some examples:

Listen!

Pay attention!

This is important!

Take note of this!

Many English versions do not translate this word.

I will send My messenger ahead of You: In many cultures at that time, a king would choose a person to go as his messenger to tell people that he was coming. The messenger would tell the people to prepare for the king's coming.

In this context, the pronouns I and My refer to God. The pronoun You refers to the Christ/Messiah. God indicated that he would send a messenger to tell people to prepare for the Christ/Messiah who was coming. Jesus implied that John was that messenger.

ahead of You: The Greek phrase that the BSB literally translates as ahead of You means “before you.” In this context, this phrase may indicate either or both of the following options:

1. I will send my messenger before I send you.
2. I will send my messenger to go in front of you.

In some languages there may be a natural way to translate this clause so that both meanings are possible. If you must choose one of these meanings, choose option (a).

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

before your face (ESV)

to go ahead of you

to go ahead of where you go

11:10c

who will prepare Your way before You.’

- He will open the way/road ahead of you.’
- He will prepare the people for your coming.’”

who will prepare Your way before You: This clause is a metaphor. In this metaphor, preparing people’s hearts for the coming of the Messiah is compared to preparing a road for the coming of the king. (This metaphor is also used in Mark 1:2–3, Luke 3:4–6, and Luke 7:27.)

Here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

and he will prepare your way before you (REB)

to open the way for you (GNT)

he will repair the road before you come

- Put the meaning of the metaphor in a footnote. For example, here is a sample footnote:

These words mean that John will prepare people’s hearts for the coming of the Christ/Messiah.

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

He will prepare people’s hearts for your coming like a person prepares the road before a king comes.

- Translate the meaning of the metaphor. For example:

to tell people to prepare themselves for your coming

get the people ready to accept/receive you

Matthew 11:11

Section 11:1–19: Jesus praised John the Baptist

Long before Jesus was born, God spoke of a messenger who would prepare the people for the coming of the Messiah (Malachi 3:1). John the Baptist was that messenger. When John’s ministry was ending, he began to doubt that Jesus was the Messiah. So John sent some of his disciples to verify that Jesus was the Messiah (11:3). Jesus indicated that his miracles and preaching were proof that he was the expected Messiah whom God spoke of (11:4–5).

Jesus then showed that John was very important in God’s eyes (11:7–14).

Jesus and John did God’s work in very different ways, but most people refused to listen to either person (11:16–19).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The question of John the Baptist

Jesus talked about John the Baptizer

Messengers from John the Baptist (NRSV)

Jesus and John the Baptizer’s actions prove who they are

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 7:18–35.

11:11

Verse 11:11 indicates that John was the boundary between the end of the Old Testament and the beginning of the kingdom. He was the last Old Testament prophet. There was no one greater than John. But in the period of the kingdom, even the least person is

greater than the greatest person in the period of the law.

11:11a

Truly I tell you,

- I assure you^(plur) that
- Then Jesus said, “I tell you^(plur) with certainty,

In 11:10 Jesus quoted a verse from the Old Testament. But 11:11 is Jesus’ own words. If this is not clear from the grammar of your language, you may want to add something to make it clear. For example:

Jesus said,

Jesus continued speaking:

Truly I tell you: Jesus often used the words that the BSB translates as Truly I tell you to introduce a statement that he wanted to emphasize. When he began a statement with these words, he was asking people to listen with extra attention.

Here are some other ways to introduce this:

I assure you (NLT96)

Listen to this:

Let me tell you this:

If you have another way in your language to emphasize a statement or to alert people to listen with special attention, consider using it here.

This clause also occurs in 10:42. You should translate it here as you did there.

11:11b

among those born of women there has risen no one greater than John the Baptist.

- John the Baptist is the greatest person who has ever been born.
- John the Baptist is the most important human being who has ever lived.

among those born of women there has risen no one greater than John the Baptist: The clause those born of women is a figurative way to refer to human beings (as opposed to spirit beings). The verb has risen also means “has lived.” It does not refer to rising from sleep or from the dead.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Of all the people ever born, no one is greater than John the Baptizer (GW)

John the Baptist is greater than anyone who has ever lived (GNT)

John the Baptist is the most important human being who has ever lived.

no one greater than John the Baptist: This phrase means that no human being had a more important role than John. John was the one whom God chose to prepare people for the Messiah’s coming.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

John...is the most important person

of all the people who have ever lived, John...has the greatest position/privilege

11:11c

Yet even the least in the kingdom of heaven is greater than he.

- But even so, the lowest person in the kingdom of heaven/God is greater than John.
- However, under God’s rule/chieftaincy, even the person of the smallest status/rank is more important than John.

Yet: Verse 11:11c seems to conflict with 11:11b, but it is also true. The two parts are a paradox.

Here are some other ways to introduce this part of the paradox:

But (GNT)

However

even the least in the kingdom of heaven is greater than he: This sentence compares a person in the time of the kingdom of God with John (who lived at the end of the time of the law). It indicates that even a person who has the lowest status in the kingdom of God is greater than John. Even insignificant people in the kingdom are more important than the most important people in the time of the Old Testament law. This implies that the new way that Jesus was establishing (the kingdom) is better than the old way (the law).

Here are some other ways to translate this sentence:

in the kingdom of heaven, even the lowest person is greater/higher than John

the least important person in the kingdom of heaven is greater than John (GW)

the person of the lowest rank/status in the kingdom of God is great/important compared with John

even the least: This phrase refers to the person who has the lowest status, rank, or position in the kingdom of God.

the kingdom of heaven: In the phrase the kingdom of heaven, the word heaven is a figure of speech called metonymy. In this figure of speech, heaven refers to God, but it refers to him indirectly by naming the place where he lives and rules. The Jews considered God's name to be so holy that they hesitated to say it. So instead of pronouncing God's name directly, they often used the name of the place where he lives and rules. Because Matthew was writing primarily to Jews, he often used the word heaven to refer to God.

Therefore, the kingdom of heaven means the same thing as "the kingdom of God." The phrase the kingdom of heaven only occurs in the book of Matthew. The phrase "the kingdom of God" is found in all other places in the New Testament, and it even occurs five times in Matthew.

Here are some other ways to translate heaven in this context:

- Make some information explicit. For example:

the one/Lord who lives in heaven

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

God

This phrase also occurs in 3:2b, 5:3b and 10:7b. Also see kingdom of heaven in the Glossary.

Matthew 11:12

Section 11:1–19: Jesus praised John the Baptist

Long before Jesus was born, God spoke of a messenger who would prepare the people for the coming of the Messiah (Malachi 3:1). John the Baptist was that messenger. When John's ministry was ending, he began to doubt that Jesus was the Messiah. So John sent some

of his disciples to verify that Jesus was the Messiah (11:3). Jesus indicated that his miracles and preaching were proof that he was the expected Messiah whom God spoke of (11:4–5).

Jesus then showed that John was very important in God's eyes (11:7–14).

Jesus and John did God's work in very different ways, but most people refused to listen to either person (11:16–19).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The question of John the Baptist

Jesus talked about John the Baptizer

Messengers from John the Baptist (NRSV)

Jesus and John the Baptizer's actions prove who they are

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 7:18–35.

11:12a

From the days of John the Baptist until now,

- From the day John the Baptist began preaching until now,
- From the time that John the Baptist began his work/preaching until today,

From the days of John the Baptist: This phrase refers to the period of time that began with John the Baptist's preaching.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

And from the time John the Baptist began preaching (NLT)

From the time John preached his message (GNT)

From the beginning of the work of John

until now: The phrase until now refers to the period of time up till the time when Jesus said these words.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

until this very day (GNT)

up to today

until this present time

up to this time

11:12b

the kingdom of heaven has been subject to violence,

- the kingdom of heaven/God has been violently attacked,
- violent people are attacking God's rule/chieftaincy,

the kingdom of heaven has been subject to violence: There are two ways to interpret the Greek verb that the BSB translates as has been subject to violence:

1. The verb is passive and means that the kingdom is being violently attacked. According to this interpretation, this clause refers to persecution from evil spiritual beings or evil humans who are attacking God's kingdom. One example of the kingdom being "violently attacked" was that Herod put John in prison and later killed him. Later, Jesus and many of the disciples were also killed. For example:

the Kingdom of heaven has suffered violent attacks (GNT) (BSB, NIV2011, RSV, GNT, NJB, NET, NASB, REB, KJV, CEV, ESV)

1. The verb has an active sense and means that the kingdom has been forcefully advancing. According to this interpretation, this clause indicates that God is defeating evil, and he is gathering people into his kingdom. Some examples of the kingdom "forcefully advancing" were that John forcefully preached, and Jesus cast out demons and did other miracles. For example:

the kingdom of heaven has been going forward in strength (NCV) (NIV, NLT, GW, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This interpretation best fits with the next clause "the violent take it by force." Also, the majority of English versions and commentaries follow this interpretation.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

the kingdom of heaven has been attacked with force

- Use an active verb. In this case, the subject should be "the violent" referred to in 11:12c. For example:

violent people have been attacking the kingdom of heaven

11:12c

and the violent lay claim to it.

- and fierce/evil people are trying to seize it.
- and they are trying to grab/capture it by force.

the violent: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the violent. There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as the violent: (1) It has a negative meaning and refers to violent people. Violent people are those who are attacking the kingdom of heaven. For example, the GNT says: violent men (BSB, NIV2011, RSV, GNT, NJB, NASB, REB, KJV, CEV, ESV) (2) It has a neutral meaning and refers to forceful people. Forceful men such as John the Baptist have seen the value of the kingdom of heaven and strongly desire to enter it. For example, the NET says: forceful people (NIV, GW, NET, JBP). It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The majority of English versions and commentaries follow this interpretation. Also, if you followed interpretation (1) for the clause "the kingdom of heaven has suffered violence," you should follow interpretation (1) here. Generally, when an English version follows interpretation (1) for the clause "the kingdom of heaven has suffered violence," it also follows interpretation (1) for the phrase "violent men." There are two exceptions: (a) the NLT which follows the interpretation that "the kingdom is forcefully advancing" (interpretation 2), but then follows interpretation (1) for "violent men." For example: the Kingdom of Heaven has been forcefully advancing, and violent people are attacking it. (NLT) (b) and the JBP which seems to do the opposite of the NLT: it follows interpretation (1) then interpretation (2). For example: the kingdom of Heaven has been taken by storm and eager men are forcing their way into it (JBP) refers to violent/fierce people who are attacking the kingdom.

Here is another way to translate this word:

fierce/evil people

lay claim to it: This clause means that violent men are trying to "seize" the kingdom of God. This again refers

to evil people persecuting believers. It also refers to the battle between good and evil.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

grab it using force/strength

capture/plunder it

Matthew 11:13

Section 11:1–19: Jesus praised John the Baptist

Long before Jesus was born, God spoke of a messenger who would prepare the people for the coming of the Messiah (Malachi 3:1). John the Baptist was that messenger. When John's ministry was ending, he began to doubt that Jesus was the Messiah. So John sent some of his disciples to verify that Jesus was the Messiah (11:3). Jesus indicated that his miracles and preaching were proof that he was the expected Messiah whom God spoke of (11:4–5).

Jesus then showed that John was very important in God's eyes (11:7–14).

Jesus and John did God's work in very different ways, but most people refused to listen to either person (11:16–19).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The question of John the Baptist

Jesus talked about John the Baptizer

Messengers from John the Baptist (NRSV)

Jesus and John the Baptizer's actions prove who they are

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 7:18–35.

11:13

For all the Prophets and the Law prophesied until John.

- I say this because all the Prophets and the Law foretold the kingdom until John came.
- Before John came, all the Law and the Prophets told about what would happen regarding the kingdom of God. When he came, their prophecies started to become true.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For indicates that 11:13 explains something. Here this conjunction introduces more details about John and the kingdom.

Jesus explained that John was the turning point between the Old Testament and the New Testament. The Old Testament period was a time of prophecy about the Messiah and his kingdom. The New Testament period was the time when these prophecies were fulfilled.

Here is another way to translate this conjunction:

I say this because

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it may not be necessary to translate this conjunction either.

all the Prophets and the Law: This phrase refers to the books of the prophets and the five books of Moses in the Old Testament. These two groups of books represent all the Old Testament.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

All the Books of the Prophets and the Law of Moses (CEV)

all the books of the prophets and all the books of the law of Moses

Normally, Jews said “the Law and the Prophets.” Here Matthew reversed the normal order. He perhaps did this to focus on the function of prophecy in the Old Testament.

prophesied: The verb prophesied means “spoke a message on behalf of God.” The Old Testament Scriptures spoke about many future things. Some of those prophecies were about the coming Messiah and his kingdom. In the context of 11:11–13, the topic is the kingdom of God. So here, Jesus was referring to prophecies about the kingdom. In some languages, it will be natural to make this explicit. For example:

spoke about the Kingdom (GNT)

told about what would happen regarding the kingdom of God

The word prophecy also occurs in 7:22b.

until John: The phrase until John refers to John's coming or time on earth. The coming of John marked the end of the Old Testament period and the beginning of the time of the kingdom. The period of the prophets and their prophecies about the kingdom was from Moses to John. When John came, these prophecies started to be fulfilled.

In many languages, it will be necessary to make some of this information explicit. For example:

Until the time of John all the prophets and the Law of Moses spoke about the Kingdom (GNT)

All the Prophets and the Law prophesied about the kingdom until John came. When he arrived, he began to fulfill what they had said.

Before John came, all the Prophets and the Law prophesied about the kingdom. When he arrived, those prophecies started to become true.

Matthew 11:14

Section 11:1–19: Jesus praised John the Baptist

Long before Jesus was born, God spoke of a messenger who would prepare the people for the coming of the Messiah (Malachi 3:1). John the Baptist was that messenger. When John's ministry was ending, he began to doubt that Jesus was the Messiah. So John sent some of his disciples to verify that Jesus was the Messiah (11:3). Jesus indicated that his miracles and preaching were proof that he was the expected Messiah whom God spoke of (11:4–5).

Jesus then showed that John was very important in God's eyes (11:7–14).

Jesus and John did God's work in very different ways, but most people refused to listen to either person (11:16–19).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The question of John the Baptist

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Messengers from John the Baptist (NRSV)

Jesus and John the Baptizer's actions prove who they are

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 7:18–35.

11:14a

And if you are willing to accept it,

- If you are willing to accept/believe it, you will understand that
- Whether you^(plur) are willing to believe this/me or not,
- Even though you^(plur) may not be willing to accept/believe what I say,

And if you are willing to accept it: In Greek, the verb that the BSB translates as accept does not have an object. Something must be accepted/believed, and there are two ways to interpret what that something might be:

1. It is the second half of the verse: he is the Elijah who was to come. For example:

if you will believe me (NJB) (BSB, NIV, RSV, ESV, NET, NASB, REB, KJV, NJB, NLT, JBP)

1. It is the prophets in 11:13. For example:

if you believe them (CEV) (GNT, GW, CEV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This fits the context best and is the interpretation that most English versions follow.

if you are willing to accept it: This is an if clause, but it is not a normal if clause. The second part of this verse (he is the Elijah who was to come) is true even if people were not willing to accept it.

Many people in the time of Jesus mistakenly believed that Elijah would literally come back to earth. Jesus probably used this if clause to draw attention to their mistaken belief and to emphasize the truth of what he was about to say.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

if you are willing to accept/believe what I say, you will understand that

whether you are willing to accept/believe this or not

Even though you may find it hard to accept/believe, I tell you the truth.

This clause does not imply that if the people are not willing to accept it, then John is not the Elijah who is to come.

11:14b

he is the Elijah who was to come.

- he/John fulfilled the Scripture/prophecy that Elijah would come.
- John is the one who came as Elijah whom the Scriptures said is coming.
- John is the person whom the prophet was talking about when he foretold that Elijah will come.

he is the Elijah who was to come: This clause indicates that John was the fulfillment of Malachi 4:5. In that verse, God said that he would send the prophet Elijah. This prophecy took place after Elijah had already gone to heaven. Because of this verse, the Jews were expecting Elijah to come back down among them.

In Luke 1:17, God told John's father that John would go before the Lord "in the spirit and power of Elijah." John was not the actual Elijah reborn, rather God gave him power just like he had given power to Elijah. So when the prophet Malachi said that Elijah would come, he was actually talking about a man who would be like Elijah. That man was John.

If you translate this clause literally and people think that John and Elijah are the same person, you may want to:

- Add some implied information about the prophecy. For example:

John fulfilled the prophecy about Elijah coming

John is the man whom the prophet was talking about when he said that Elijah would return

- Use "like" or "as" to show that John was not Elijah reborn. For example:

John is the one who came as Elijah whom the Scriptures said was to come

who was to come: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as who was to come indicates that Elijah's coming was prophesied. The prophet Malachi foretold that Elijah would come.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

whose coming was predicted (GNT)

the one the prophets said would come (NLT)

whom the prophet foretold would come

Matthew 11:15

Section 11:1–19: Jesus praised John the Baptist

Long before Jesus was born, God spoke of a messenger who would prepare the people for the coming of the Messiah (Malachi 3:1). John the Baptist was that messenger. When John's ministry was ending, he began to doubt that Jesus was the Messiah. So John sent some of his disciples to verify that Jesus was the Messiah (11:3). Jesus indicated that his miracles and preaching were proof that he was the expected Messiah whom God spoke of (11:4–5).

Jesus then showed that John was very important in God's eyes (11:7–14).

Jesus and John did God's work in very different ways, but most people refused to listen to either person (11:16–19).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

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Messengers from John the Baptist (NRSV)

Jesus and John the Baptizer's actions prove who they are

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 7:18–35.

11:15

He who has ears, let him hear.

- Everyone who is able to hear should listen to what I am saying.
- You^(plur) who are able to hear what I say, think about it.

The saying in this verse also occurs in Mark 4:9, Mark 4:23, Luke 8:8, Luke 14:35. You should translate all these passages in the same way.

He who has ears, let him hear: These words are a saying that Jesus used to command or urge the crowd to carefully think about the words that they had just heard. This saying assumes that everyone in the crowd

had ears and were able to hear. So it is addressed to all the people who were listening to Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this saying:

- Use “they” or “you” instead of he. For example:

All those who have ears to hear, let them hear.

All of you who have ears to hear, hear/listen.

- Use a different type of clause. In some languages it may be more natural to use an “if” clause or a reason clause. For example:

If/Since you have ears that can hear, then pay attention.

- Translate the saying without including the word ears. For example:

You people who can hear me, listen! (NCV)

let him hear: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as let him hear is a command in the third person. It does not express permission.

Here is one way to make this more clear:

Anyone who has ears should listen! (NJB)

In some languages, it may be necessary to say what the listener should be listening to. For example:

let him listen to me

let him listen to what I say

Matthew 11:16

Section 11:1–19: Jesus praised John the Baptist

Long before Jesus was born, God spoke of a messenger who would prepare the people for the coming of the Messiah (Malachi 3:1). John the Baptist was that messenger. When John’s ministry was ending, he began to doubt that Jesus was the Messiah. So John sent some of his disciples to verify that Jesus was the Messiah (11:3). Jesus indicated that his miracles and preaching were proof that he was the expected Messiah whom God spoke of (11:4–5).

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There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 7:18–35.

Paragraph 11:16–19

In this paragraph, Jesus compared the people of his generation to children playing in the market. The people of that generation criticized John’s harsh lifestyle and did not respond to his message. They also criticized Jesus’ joyous lifestyle and did not respond to his message. They were like children who refused to dance to happy songs, but they also refused to mourn to sad songs. They were never satisfied. They rejected both John and Jesus.

11:16a

To what can I compare this generation?

- ¶ “To what/whom can I compare today’s people?
- ¶ “Here is what the people who are now living are like.

Verse 11:16a begins a new topic. The Greek introduces this new topic with a conjunction that is often translated as “but.” However, there is no contrast here. In most languages, it will be better to begin this paragraph without the word “but,” as the BSB and many other English versions do.

To what can I compare this generation?: This is a rhetorical question. It is the type of rhetorical question that a teacher asks a class. The teacher knows the answer, but he asks the class this type of question to make them think about the issue. Here Jesus also used this question to introduce a new topic.

Be careful not to translate this in a way that would imply that Jesus was searching for an answer to his question. Jesus himself gave the answer in 11:16b–17.

Here are some other ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

What/Whom shall I compare this generation to?

- As a statement. For example:

Here is what I would compare this generation to:

Translate this rhetorical question in a way that is natural in your language.

this generation: This phrase refers to all the people who lived at the same time as Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the people of this day (GNT)

the people who are living now (GW)

11:16b

They are like children sitting in the marketplaces

- I can compare them to children sitting in the market
- They are like some children sitting in the public/village square

They are like: The pronoun They refers to “this generation.” In some languages, it will be more natural to say:

This generation is like

children sitting in the marketplaces: The Greek word that the BSB translates as marketplaces refers to a large, open area where people came to buy and sell things. There was room for children to play there. It was a place where many public events happened.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

market (CEV)

public/village square

middle of the village

11:16c

and calling out to others:

- and shouting to their friends,

- and shouting/complaining to the other children,

calling out: The words calling out refer to speaking loudly so that people some distance away can hear. Some English versions translate this word as “shout,” but it is not the type of shout that angry people do. Here it is more of a complaint.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

call out (NET)

complain (NLT)

to others: The Greek word that the BSB translates as to others refers to the other children who were there. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

to the others

to their friends (NLT)

Matthew 11:17

Section 11:1–19: Jesus praised John the Baptist

Long before Jesus was born, God spoke of a messenger who would prepare the people for the coming of the Messiah (Malachi 3:1). John the Baptist was that messenger. When John’s ministry was ending, he began to doubt that Jesus was the Messiah. So John sent some of his disciples to verify that Jesus was the Messiah (11:3). Jesus indicated that his miracles and preaching were proof that he was the expected Messiah whom God spoke of (11:4–5).

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There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 7:18–35.

Paragraph 11:16–19

In this paragraph, Jesus compared the people of his generation to children playing in the market. The people of that generation criticized John's harsh lifestyle and did not respond to his message. They also criticized Jesus' joyous lifestyle and did not respond to his message. They were like children who refused to dance to happy songs, but they also refused to mourn to sad songs. They were never satisfied. They rejected both John and Jesus.

11:17a

'We played the flute for you, and you did not dance;

- “‘We^(excl) played wedding music on a flute for you^(plur), but you did not dance!
- “‘We^(excl) played happy music for you^(plur), but you refused to dance!

We played the flute for you, and you did not dance:

This sentence means that some children wanted the others to dance for them when they played happy music on a flute. But the other group of children did not want to play that game.

The Jews usually played flute music so that people would dance. They played this music at feasts and other happy occasions like weddings. In some languages it may be helpful to make this explicit. For example:

We played wedding music for you, but you wouldn't dance! (GNT)

We played/made happy music for you, but you did not dance!

flute: A flute is a musical instrument. It is a tube closed at one end with holes along the length. A person blows in or across an opening at one end to make the sounds.

and: There is contrast between what one group of children wanted and what the other group did. It may be more natural in your language to use the word “but” here instead of and. For example:

We played the flute, but you would not dance! (CEV)

11:17b

we sang a dirge, and you did not mourn.'

- We^(excl) sang a funeral song, but you^(plur) did not mourn!
- We^(excl) sang a sad song, and/but you^(plur) refused to weep/cry!

we sang a dirge: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sang a dirge refers to singing a song of mourning to express grief and sorrow. People usually sang such songs at funerals or burials.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

We sang funeral songs (GNT)

We sang songs sung at burials

We sang sad songs of death

If the people in your language area do not have funeral songs, you can translate in a more general way. For example:

we sang a sad song (NCV)

and you did not mourn: The word mourn means “express grief and sorrow.” Even though some of the children pretended to be at a funeral, the other children would not play along and pretend to cry.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

but you did not cry (NCV)

but you didn't show any sadness (GW)

Matthew 11:18

Section 11:1–19: Jesus praised John the Baptist

Long before Jesus was born, God spoke of a messenger who would prepare the people for the coming of the Messiah (Malachi 3:1). John the Baptist was that messenger. When John's ministry was ending, he began to doubt that Jesus was the Messiah. So John sent some of his disciples to verify that Jesus was the Messiah (11:3). Jesus indicated that his miracles and preaching were proof that he was the expected Messiah whom God spoke of (11:4–5).

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In this paragraph, Jesus compared the people of his generation to children playing in the market. The people of that generation criticized John's harsh lifestyle and did not respond to his message. They also criticized Jesus' joyous lifestyle and did not respond to his message. They were like children who refused to dance to happy songs, but they also refused to mourn to sad songs. They were never satisfied. They rejected both John and Jesus.

11:18a

For John came neither eating nor drinking,

- When John came to do God's work, he neither feasted nor drank wine,
- This generation is like those children, because during John's time of ministry, he did not eat good/ordinary food or drink alcohol.

For: In verses 11:18–19, Jesus explained his comparison in 11:16–17. The generation of people in Jesus' time were like children because they did not want to follow John or Jesus. In Greek, this explanation is introduced with a conjunction that the BSB translates as *For*.

Here are some other ways to introduce this explanation:

They can be compared to them because

They are just like those children because

In the same way

John came: Here the word *came* is used in a general way to describe the time when John was preaching in the wilderness. It introduces the way John usually

lived. It does not indicate that John “came” to a particular place.

In some languages, a literal translation may imply a wrong meaning. If that is true in your language, here are some other ways to translate this:

John had the custom of

during the ministry of John

John came and was doing God's work

neither eating: There are two ways to interpret the clause that the BSB translates as *neither eating*:

1. John did not eat normal, good food. According to 3:4c, he ate locusts and wild honey. Furthermore, he did not go to feasts and parties where people spent a lot of time eating fancy food. Pleasures and comforts like food were not important to him. For example:

did not eat...like other people (NCV) (CEV, NCV, NLT)

1. John did not eat food very often. This means that he frequently fasted. For example:

he fasted (GNT) (GNT, NLT96)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Many Jews fasted, so it is unlikely that they would have thought that John “had a demon” (11:18b) because he fasted.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

did not feast

did not eat good food

did not eat well

didn't spend his time eating (NLT)

nor drinking: The word *drinking* refers to “drinking wine.” (See Luke 7:33 where the word “wine” is explicit in the text.) For example:

didn't drink wine (NLT96)

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- Use a general word for alcoholic beverages. For example:

did not drink alcohol

- Use a common alcoholic beverage that is used in a general sense in your area. For example:

not drink millet beer

not drink palm wine

not drink something like palm wine

- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

not drink fermented grape juice

The Jews allowed drinking wine, but drinking too much and getting drunk was considered wrong. John never drank any wine, as Luke 1:15 explains. This was unusual for a Jew.

11:18b

and they say, 'He has a demon!'

- and they say, 'A demon controls him!'
- So, people were saying, 'He is demon possessed!'
- As a result, people rejected him and said that a demon is in him!

and: Verse 11:18b is a result of the people seeing John's way of life (in 11:18a). The people rejected John's message and so made wrong statements about him.

Here are some other ways to begin this part of the verse:

So (NCV)

and as a result

they say, 'He has a demon!': This clause means that the people were saying that John was possessed by a demon.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

He's possessed by a demon. (NLT)

That man has a demon in him! (CEV)

This clause shows that the people rejected John. The saying 'He has a demon' is a lie. If people in your area will think that 'He has a demon' is true about John, you may want to make the text more clear. For example:

they rejected John saying, 'He has a demon'

they falsely said, 'He has a demon'

demon: Another way to translate this word is:

evil spirit

For more help in translating the word demon, see the note under 7:22c.

Matthew 11:19

Section 11:1–19: Jesus praised John the Baptist

Long before Jesus was born, God spoke of a messenger who would prepare the people for the coming of the Messiah (Malachi 3:1). John the Baptist was that messenger. When John's ministry was ending, he began to doubt that Jesus was the Messiah. So John sent some of his disciples to verify that Jesus was the Messiah (11:3). Jesus indicated that his miracles and preaching were proof that he was the expected Messiah whom God spoke of (11:4–5).

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In this paragraph, Jesus compared the people of his generation to children playing in the market. The people of that generation criticized John's harsh lifestyle and did not respond to his message. They also criticized Jesus' joyous lifestyle and did not respond to his message. They were like children who refused to dance to happy songs, but they also refused to mourn to sad songs. They were never satisfied. They rejected both John and Jesus.

11:19a**The Son of Man came eating and drinking,**

- And when the Son of Man came, he feasted and drank wine,
- But when I, the Son of Man came to do God's work, I ate good/ordinary food and drank good drink.

Verse 11:19 is the second example of the people being like the children in the parable. The people who rejected Jesus are like the children who refused to dance to happy music.

In some languages, it may be natural to add a conjunction to connect this verse to 11:18. For example:

And

But (CEV)

Then (JBP)

The Son of Man: Jesus used the title The Son of Man to refer to himself. In some languages it may be necessary to add the pronoun "I" to show that Jesus was referring to himself. For example:

I, the Son of Man,

This phrase also occurs in 8:20b, 9:6a and 10:23c. For help to translate this phrase, see the note under 8:20b. See also Son of Man in KBT for more information.

came: The verb came has the same meaning here as in 11:18a. It refers to the time of Jesus' public ministry rather than him coming to a location.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

during the ministry of the Son of Man

came and while doing God's work

eating and drinking: Here the word eating implies "eating good food." The word drinking implies "drinking wine." John probably avoided feasts and celebrations, but Jesus went to joyous events like weddings. He celebrated like a normal person.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

eating and drinking well

eating good food and drinking good drink

ate and drank with/like other people

11:19b**and they say, 'Look at this glutton and drunkard,**

- and these people say, 'Look at that man! He eats too much and drinks too much.
- As a result, people reject me and say that I am someone who does nothing but eat and drink.

and: Verse 11:19b is a result of the people seeing Jesus' way of life (in 11:19a). The people rejected Jesus' message and so made wrong statements about his way of life.

Here are some other ways to begin this part of the verse:

so

and as a result

Look at this: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Look at this is literally "look, a man." These words introduce the following words of disgust and ridicule, and show that the people rejected Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Look at this man! (GNT)

That man (CEV)

Well!

glutton and drunkard: Many of the people rejected Jesus' message and ridiculed him by saying, "He is a glutton and drunkard." The saying glutton and drunkard is a lie. If people in your area will think that this saying is true about Jesus, you may want to make the text more clear. For example:

but they rejected Jesus saying, 'He is a glutton and a drunkard'

but they falsely said, 'He is a glutton and a drunkard'

glutton: This word refers to a person with an excessive appetite for food. This kind of person spends his life eating and thinking about eating. Some people were wrongly saying that Jesus was this kind of person.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

his appetite is too great

he does nothing but eat

He eats too much (NCV)

drunkard: The word drunkard refers to a person with an excessive appetite for alcoholic beverages. He drinks too much alcohol and is frequently drunk. Again, some people were wrongly saying that Jesus was this kind of person.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

he is a drunk

drinks too much wine (NCV)

11:19c

a friend of tax collectors and sinners!'

- He is even a friend of tax collectors and other sinners!'
- They say that I am a friend of hated men who collect taxes and a friend of other sinners.'

a friend of tax collectors: People used the phrase a friend of tax collectors to ridicule Jesus and show that they did not accept him. Jews considered tax collectors to be traitors and thieves. Jews also hated them because they worked for the Romans. They did not like tax collectors, and they did not like people who associated with them and were their friends.

The term tax collectors also occurs in 9:10b. See the note there for help in translating this term.

and sinners: The word sinners refers to two other types of Jews:

1. Jews who were sinful/immoral. They did not follow the laws of Moses, and

2. Jews who did not follow the strict laws of the Pharisees regarding how to remain ceremonially clean/pure.

Religious Jews like the Pharisees believed that they would become unclean/impure if they associated with either of these types of people. So they shunned them. In their minds, Jesus was also unclean because he associated with sinners.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

lawbreakers

other people who are sinful people

people who were evil/sinful

outcasts (GNT)

The term sinners also occurs in 9:10b. You should translate it here as you did there.

11:19d

But wisdom is vindicated by her actions."

- However, a person's deeds will prove/show who is the wise one."
- But when a person has/receives God's/true wisdom, the things that he does will show it."

But: There is a contrast between this verse and the words that people were saying (in 11:18-19c). The Jews of Jesus' generation rejected John and Jesus, but Jesus defended John and himself with the proverb in this verse. Many English versions introduce the verse with a conjunction that expresses contrast. For example:

Yet (RSV)

however (GNT)

In some languages, it may be natural to make the connection between this verse and 11:18-19c more clear.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

They say those things but

Although they say these words nevertheless

wisdom is vindicated by her actions: This sentence is probably a Jewish saying or proverb. In it wisdom is talked about as if it were a person. This saying

indicates that a wise person's deeds prove who is following the right path. A person's deeds show who is truly wise.

In this context, the deeds of John and Jesus showed that they had God's wisdom. John's deeds of preaching and baptizing brought people into the kingdom. Jesus' deeds of healing people released them from their suffering. On the other hand, the teachings of the Pharisees put a burden on people.

You should translate these words as a proverb in your language. For example:

The results of a person's deeds prove whether he is truly wise.

If a person has God's wisdom, his deeds will show it.

A person's deeds will show who is on the path of true wisdom

wisdom: The word wisdom in general means "the ability to understand events and know the right action." In this context, it probably refers to the things that God was doing through John and Jesus. But the saying is speaking generally about wisdom.

Here are some other ways to translate wisdom:

the wise things to do

acting wisely

Matthew 11:20

Section 11:20–24: Jesus spoke against people who did not repent

In this section, Jesus rebuked the Jews of certain towns. They had heard him preach and had seen him do miracles, but still they refused to repent and believe in him. Jesus stated that many Gentiles were more likely to trust him than the Jews were. As a result, God will judge these Jews more harshly than he will judge the Gentiles. Jesus said these things because he hoped that some of them would be shamed into repenting and believing him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus warns the Jews of Chorazin, Bethsaida, and Capernaum

Judgment for the Unbelievers (NLT)

11:20a

Then Jesus began to denounce the cities

- ¶ Then Jesus began to rebuke the towns
- ¶ After that, Jesus scolded/criticized the people in the towns

Then: This verse is the beginning of a new story/section. The events in this section probably happened immediately after the events in the preceding section. The Greek text introduces this story with the conjunction normally translated as Then.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Immediately after that

After that

In some languages, a time word or phrase is not necessary. Introduce this story in a natural way in your language.

Jesus began to denounce: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as denounce means "say that someone/something is evil" or "say that someone has done something wrong." The people of these cities saw Jesus' miracles, but they did not repent. So he reprimanded them.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

rebuke

criticized (NCV)

scold

the cities: The phrase the cities is a figure of speech. It refers to the people of the cities. For example:

The people in the towns (GNT)

This phrase refers to either towns or cities. They are larger and more important than villages, which is a different Greek word. The Jewish towns of Galilee most likely had less than three thousand people in each town. Do not use a word that refers only to large, modern cities of today.

11:20b

in which most of His miracles had been performed,

- where most of his miracles had been done,
- in which he did many of his amazing deeds/acts.

in which most of His miracles had been performed:

The Greek word that the BSB translates as miracles can also be translated as “mighty works” (as in the ESV). These are unusual events which can only be explained as a special action by God.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

in which he had done many of his miracles (NET)

11:20c

because they did not repent.

- because they had not turned back to God. He said,
- He criticized them because they did not turn away from their sins and turn to God. He said,

they did not repent: The Greek word that the BSB translates as repent refers in a general way to changing one’s mind. In this context, it refers to changing one’s mind about sin and God. It means to stop sinning and begin to obey God.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

they hadn’t turned from their sins and turned to God (NLT96)

the people refused to turn to God (CEV)

the people did not change their lives and stop sinning (NCV)

they did not leave/abandon the ways of sin and follow the ways of God

This word also occurs in 3:2a and 4:17b. You should translate it here as you did there.

General Comment on 11:20a–c

It may be clearer in your translation to have the clause with “denounce” near the words he used to denounce them (in 11:21–24). For example:

^bThe people of the cities where Jesus had done most of his miracles ^cdid not repent, ^aso he began to denounce them saying:

Matthew 11:21

Section 11:20–24: Jesus spoke against people who did not repent

In this section, Jesus rebuked the Jews of certain towns. They had heard him preach and had seen him do miracles, but still they refused to repent and believe in him. Jesus stated that many Gentiles were more likely to trust him than the Jews were. As a result, God will judge these Jews more harshly than he will judge the Gentiles. Jesus said these things because he hoped that some of them would be shamed into repenting and believing him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus warns the Jews of Chorazin, Bethsaida, and Capernaum

Judgment for the Unbelievers (NLT)

11:21–22

Verses 11:21–22 contain a figure of speech called apostrophe. The name of this figure of speech is spelled and pronounced the same as the punctuation mark used to show contractions, but with a different meaning. For more information, see Translation Problems A to Z, Apostrophe. In this figure of speech, Jesus spoke to the towns of Chorazin and Bethsaida as if they were persons.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse:

- Keep the apostrophe as in the BSB.

^{21a}Woe to you, Chorazin! Woe to you, Bethsaida!

^{21b}For if the mighty works done in you had been done in Tyre and Sidon, ^{21c}they would have repented long ago in sackcloth and ashes.

- Translate it so that Jesus is speaking to the people of those towns. For example:

^{21a}You people of Chorazin are in for trouble! You people of Bethsaida are in for trouble too! ^{21b}If the miracles that took place in your towns had happened in Tyre and Sidon, ^{21c}the people there would have turned to God long ago.

11:21a

“Woe to you, Chorazin! Woe to you, Bethsaida!”

- “Chorazin, you^(sing) will have trouble! Bethsaida, you^(sing) will have trouble!

- “People of Chorazin, God will punish you!^(plur) People of Bethsaida, God will punish you!

Woe to you: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Woe expresses a warning. It is a warning of God’s coming judgment and a call to people to change the way that they are living. Jesus knew that God would punish the people who lived in the town of Chorazin. They had seen Jesus do miracles, but most people did not believe in him.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

How terrible it will be for you (GNT)

Great trouble awaits you

It will be bad for you

God will punish you

Chorazin: The word Chorazin is the name of a town in the northern region of Galilee. (Notice that some English versions spell this word Korazin.) By naming the town, Jesus was speaking to the people of the town. These people were Jews. In some languages, it will be natural to make some of this information explicit. For example:

people of Chorazin

Jews who live in the town of Korazin

In some languages, it will be natural to put the town before the word “woe.” For example:

People of Chorazin, woe to you!

Woe to you, Bethsaida!: The same words of woe are repeated for the Jewish town of Bethsaida. This is done to emphasize the woe to each of these two towns. If repeating the phrase Woe to you does not emphasize that phrase in your language, you may want to emphasize the phrase in another way. For example:

Chorazin and Bethsaida, you will certainly have trouble!

11:21b–c

For if the miracles that were performed in you had been performed in Tyre and Sidon, they would have repented long ago in sackcloth and ashes: This is a long sentence that begins with an if clause. It is further complicated because it contrasts two situations. The first situation is a real situation: Jesus did miracles in the Jewish towns of Chorazin and Bethsaida. It is implied that they did not repent. The second situation is a hypothetical situation: If Jesus had done those same miracles in the Gentile towns of Tyre and Sidon, the people there would have repented.

In some languages, it will be natural to divide this long sentence into several shorter sentences. For example:

I did miracles in your towns, but you did not repent. If, for example, I had done these same miracles in the towns of Tyre and Sidon, they would have put on sackcloth and ashes to show that they had repented.

I did miracles in your towns, but you did not repent. Suppose that I had done these same miracles in the towns of Tyre and Sidon. They are not Jews, but they would have repented long ago. They would have shown their repentance by putting on sackcloth and putting ashes on their heads.

11:21b

For if the miracles that were performed in you had been performed in Tyre and Sidon,

- I say this because if I had done the miracles in the towns of Tyre and Sidon which I did in your^(dual) towns,
- I did miracles in your towns, but you did not repent. If I had done these same miracles in the Gentile towns of Tyre and Sidon,
- I did miracles in your towns, but you did not turn away from your sins. Suppose that I had done these same miracles in the towns of Tyre and Sidon. The people of those towns are not Jews, but

For: Verses 11:21b–22 explain the reason why Jesus warned the towns of Chorazin and Bethsaida (in 11:21a). The Greek introduces this explanation with a conjunction that the BSB translates as For.

Here is another way to introduce this explanation:

I say this because

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it may not be necessary to translate this conjunction either.

if the miracles that were performed in you: The Greek word that the BSB translates as miracles can also be translated as “mighty works” (as in the ESV). Here Jesus referred to the miracles that he has done in the Jewish towns of Chorazin and Bethsaida. It is implied that even though he did miracles there, the Jewish people in those towns did not repent.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

if the miracles I did in you (NLT)

If the miracles that took place in your towns (CEV)

I did amazing deeds/acts in your towns, but you Jews did not repent

had been performed in Tyre and Sidon: This part of the “if” clause is hypothetical. This means that it refers to something that did not happen. Jesus did not do miracles in the towns of Tyre and Sidon. But if he had done miracles there, the people there would have repented.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

had been done in Tyre and Sidon but they were not done

I did not do miracles in Tyre and Sidon. But if I had done miracles there

If, for example, I had done these same miracles in the towns of Tyre and Sidon

in Tyre and Sidon: Tyre and Sidon were two towns where Gentile (non-Jewish) people lived. God had punished them for their sins. This happened about 700 years before Jesus was born. The Jews knew about this situation from Isaiah 23. So the Jews considered them bad people. But Jesus showed the Jews that they were even worse sinners than the people of Tyre and Sidon.

If it is not clear to your readers that the comparison is between Jews and Gentiles, you may want to:

- Include some implied information in the text. For example:

in the non-Jewish towns of Tyre and Sidon

in the Gentile/foreign towns of Tyre and Sidon

- Include a footnote. For example:

Chorazin and Bethsaida were Jewish towns. Tyre and Sidon were Gentile towns. Jesus was showing that the Gentiles were more likely to repent and believe in him than the Jews were.

11:21c

they would have repented long ago in sackcloth and ashes.

- they would have long ago repented and shown it by wearing rough cloth and putting ashes on their heads.
- they would have quickly turned from their sins. They would have put on rough clothes and put ashes on their heads to show it/repentance.

they would have repented long ago: This clause is another part of the hypothetical statement. The Gentile people in the towns of Tyre and Sidon would have repented long ago if they had seen Jesus’ miracles. They would not have waited to repent. But Jesus did not do miracles there, and the people did not repent.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

they would have quickly repented

they would not have waited to turn from their sins

in sackcloth and ashes: This phrase indicates two ways that people at that time showed that they had repented. They wore an itchy cloth called sackcloth, and they put ashes on their heads.

The word sackcloth refers to a rough cloth made of animal hair and then made into clothing. Wearing such clothing was not comfortable because the cloth was scratchy. To add to their misery, people also either sat in ashes or they poured ashes on their heads.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- Explain in the text that sackcloth and ashes were ways of showing they had sincerely repented. For example:

They would have worn rough cloth and put ashes on themselves to show they had changed. (NCV)

put on sackcloth and sprinkled ashes on themselves, to show that they had turned from their sins! (GNT)

- Explain this custom in a footnote. A sample footnote is:

The custom of those people at that time was to put on rough cloth and to sprinkle ashes on themselves. This showed that they had turned from their sins.

Matthew 11:22

Section 11:20–24: Jesus spoke against people who did not repent

In this section, Jesus rebuked the Jews of certain towns. They had heard him preach and had seen him do miracles, but still they refused to repent and believe in him. Jesus stated that many Gentiles were more likely to trust him than the Jews were. As a result, God will judge these Jews more harshly than he will judge the Gentiles. Jesus said these things because he hoped that some of them would be shamed into repenting and believing him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus warns the Jews of Chorazin, Bethsaida, and Capernaum

Judgment for the Unbelievers (NLT)

11:22a

But I tell you,

- But I say to you^(plur) that
- But even though they never repented, I assure you that

But: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between the Jews' thinking and Jesus' thinking. The Jews thought that the Gentile people of Tyre and Sidon were evil, but Jesus indicated that the Jews were worse. The Greek indicates this contrast with a conjunction that the BSB translates as But.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

But even though they were bad

But even though they never repented

You may think that they were very evil people but

I tell you: The words I tell you emphasize the following words. This expression is less strong than “Truly, I tell you” (in 8:10c).

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I say to you that

think about this

listen

This phrase also occurs in 11:9c and 8:11a. You should translate it here as you did there.

11:22b

it will be more bearable for Tyre and Sidon on the day of judgment than for you.

- on the great day of judgment, the punishment that God gives to Tyre and Sidon will be less/lighter than the punishment he gives to you^(plur).
- when God judges people, he will punish you people from Chorazin and Bethsaida more than he will punish the people from Tyre and Sidon.

it will be more bearable for Tyre and Sidon on the day of judgment than for you:

This clause compares the suffering of two groups of people. The Gentiles of the towns of Tyre and Sidon will suffer. And the Jews of the towns of Chorazin and Bethsaida will suffer. But the suffering of the Gentile people from Tyre and Sidon will be more bearable than the suffering of the Jews from Chorazin and Bethsaida. This means that the Gentiles from those towns will suffer less than the Jews. God will punish them less than he will punish the Jews from those two towns.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

on the Judgment Day it will be better for Tyre and Sidon than for you (NCV)

on Judgment Day, God will punish the people of Tyre and Sidon less than he will punish you

on Judgment Day, the punishment that God will give you will surpass the punishment of Tyre and Sidon

the day of judgment: This phrase refers to the time when God will judge all people for the things they have said and done on earth.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the Judgment Day (GNT)

the day that God judges all people

at the time when God judges everyone

This phrase also occurs in 10:15b. You should translate it the same in both places.

Matthew 11:23

Section 11:20–24: Jesus spoke against people who did not repent

In this section, Jesus rebuked the Jews of certain towns. They had heard him preach and had seen him do miracles, but still they refused to repent and believe in him. Jesus stated that many Gentiles were more likely to trust him than the Jews were. As a result, God will judge these Jews more harshly than he will judge the Gentiles. Jesus said these things because he hoped that some of them would be shamed into repenting and believing him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus warns the Jews of Chorazin, Bethsaida, and Capernaum

Judgment for the Unbelievers (NLT)

11:23–24

Verses 11:23–24 contain a figure of speech called apostrophe. The name of this figure of speech is spelled and pronounced the same as the punctuation mark used to show contractions, but with a different meaning. For more information, see Translation Problems A to Z, Apostrophe. In this figure of speech, Jesus spoke to the town of Capernaum as if it were a person.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse:

- Keep the apostrophe as in the BSB.

And you, Capernaum, will you be exalted to heaven?

- Translate it so that Jesus is speaking to the people of the town. For example:

^{23a}People of Capernaum, do you think you will be honored in heaven? (CEV)

11:23a

And you, Capernaum, will you be lifted up to heaven?

- And you^(sing), Capernaum, do you^(sing) think that you will be lifted to heaven? You will not!
- As for you^(plur) people of the town of Capernaum, do not think that God will lift you^(plur) up to heaven to honor you.

And you, Capernaum: The phrase And you, Capernaum shows that Jesus had finished talking about Chorazin and Bethsaida at the end of 11:22. Here in 11:23 he was beginning to talk about Capernaum. Consider how to show this change in subject in your language. For example:

And as for you, Capernaum! (GNT)

Capernaum: The word Capernaum is the name of another town where Jews lived. Jesus often stayed in the town of Capernaum during his ministry around Lake Galilee. Although he did many miracles in this town, most of the people there did not believe in him. The people of Capernaum were like the people of Chorazin and Bethsaida: many people did not believe in Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

the town of Capernaum

people of the town of Capernaum

will you be lifted up to heaven?: Before you translate this clause, there are three issues to consider:

Issue 1: Meaning

The Greek word that the BSB translates as lifted up means “caused to have high status” or “honored.” In order to show this high status, a person was often lifted higher than other people.

This verb is contrasted with “brought down” in 11:23b. So, if possible, you should translate both the aspect of “honor” and the aspect of “lifted up.” To do this, you may need to use two verbs. For example:

lifted to heaven and honored there

English versions focus on only one aspect. For example:

lifted to heaven (GW)

honored in heaven (NLT)

Issue 2: Rhetorical Question

This is a rhetorical question. It expresses in question form what the people of Capernaum probably believed about themselves. They were proud of themselves and believed that they would be exalted/lifted to heaven and honored there. Jesus used this rhetorical question to emphasize that they certainly would not be lifted/raised to a position of honor in heaven. His words also imply a rebuke to the people of Capernaum.

Here are some other ways to translate this rebuke and emphasis:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

do you think that you will be lifted/raised to a position of great honor in heaven?

do you think you will be honored in heaven? (CEV)
In Greek, the form of this rhetorical question implies that the people of Capernaum would not be lifted to heaven. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

And you, Capernaum, will you be exalted to heaven? No. (NET)

- As a statement. For example:

you are certainly not going to be raised to heaven and honored there.

you should not think that you will be lifted to heaven and honored there more than other people.

Issue 3: Passive

This clause is passive. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

will you be lifted up to heaven (NCV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

will God lift you to heaven to honor you?

11:23b

No, you will be brought down to Hades!

- You^(sing) will be thrown down to hell.
- Instead, he will throw you^(plur) down to the place of fire/punishment.

you will be brought down: There is a textual issue here:

1. Some Greek manuscripts have a verb that means “you will be brought/thrown down.” This verb implies the use of force. For example:

you will be thrown down (GNT) (BSB, RSV, ESV, GNT, NJB, NET, REB, KJV, NCV, NLT96)

1. Other Greek manuscripts have a verb that means “you will go down.” For example:

You will descend (NASB) (NIV, NASB, NLT, GW, CEV, JBP)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This interpretation corresponds with the passive in 11:23a and is a direct contrast with it. Instead of being lifted up and honored, the people of Capernaum will be brought down to a place of humiliation and punishment.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

you will be thrown down (NCV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

God will throw you down

to Hades: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Hades means “the world of the dead.” In this context, it refers to hell. It is the place where God will punish people who did not believe in Jesus. It is the opposite of “heaven” in 11:23a.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

hell (GNT)

the place of the dead (NLT)

the place of fire/punishment

11:23c–d

if the miracles that were performed in you had been performed in Sodom, it would have remained to this day: This is another long sentence that begins with an if clause. It is further complicated because it contrasts two situations. The first situation is a real situation: Jesus did miracles in the Jewish town of Capernaum. It is implied that the people of that town did not repent. The second situation is a hypothetical situation: If Jesus had done those same miracles in the Gentile town of Sodom, the people of that town would have repented and the town would still exist.

In some languages, it will be natural to divide this long sentence into several shorter sentences. For example:

I did miracles in your town, but you did not repent. If, for example, I had done these same miracles in the town of Sodom, that town would still exist today.

I did miracles in your town, but you did not repent. Suppose that I had done these same miracles in the town of Sodom. The people of that town are not Jews, but they would have repented long ago. As a result, their town would still remain.

11:23c

For if the miracles that were performed in you had been performed in Sodom,

- I say this because if I had done the miracles in the town of Sodom which I did in your^(sing) town,
- I did miracles in your town, but you did not repent. If I had done these same miracles in the town of Sodom,
- I did miracles in your town, but you did not turn away from your sins. Suppose that I had done these same miracles in the town of Sodom. The people of that town were not Jews, but

For: Verses 11:23c–d explain the reason why Jesus rebuked the people of the town of Capernaum (in 11:23a–b). The Greek introduces this explanation with a conjunction that the BSB translates as For.

Here is another way to introduce this explanation:

I say this because

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it may not be necessary to translate this conjunction either.

if the miracles that were performed in you: The Greek word that the BSB translates as miracles can also be translated as “mighty works” (as in the ESV). Here Jesus referred to the miracles that he has done in the Jewish town of Capernaum. It is implied that even though he did miracles there, the Jewish people in Capernaum did not repent.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

If the miracles I did in you (NLT)

If the miracles that took place in your town (CEV)

I did miracles in your town, but you Jews did not repent

had been performed in Sodom: This part of the “if” clause is hypothetical. This means that it refers to something that did not happen. Jesus did not do miracles in the town of Sodom. But if he had done miracles there, the people there would have repented.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

had been done in Sodom but they were not done

I did not do miracles in Sodom. But if I had done miracles there

If, for example, I had done these same miracles in the town of Sodom

Sodom: The word Sodom refers to a town that God destroyed long before Jesus’ time because the people were so evil (Genesis 19).

11:23d

it would have remained to this day.

- it would still be standing today.
- the people of that town would have repented and their town would still exist today.
- they would have repented, and God would not have destroyed them and their town.

it would have remained to this day: This clause means that the town of Sodom would have remained in existence. God would not have destroyed it. The people of Sodom, after seeing the miracles, would

have repented, and God would not have destroyed them and their town.

This clause is another part of the hypothetical statement. The Gentile people in the town of Sodom did not see Jesus' miracles. They did not repent, and God did not spare their town. He destroyed it.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

it would still be there today (GW)

that town would still be standing (CEV)

God would not have destroyed it

Matthew 11:24

Section 11:20–24: Jesus spoke against people who did not repent

In this section, Jesus rebuked the Jews of certain towns. They had heard him preach and had seen him do miracles, but still they refused to repent and believe in him. Jesus stated that many Gentiles were more likely to trust him than the Jews were. As a result, God will judge these Jews more harshly than he will judge the Gentiles. Jesus said these things because he hoped that some of them would be shamed into repenting and believing him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus warns the Jews of Chorazin, Bethsaida, and Capernaum

Judgment for the Unbelievers (NLT)

11:24a

But I tell you that

- But I tell you^(plur) that
- But even though they never repented, I assure you that

But: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between the Jews' thinking and Jesus' thinking. The Jews thought that the Gentile people of Sodom were evil, but Jesus indicated that the Jews in Capernaum were worse. The Greek indicates this contrast with a conjunction that the BSB translates as But.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

But even though they were bad

But even though they never repented

You may think that they were evil people but

I tell you that: This clause is exactly the same as the clause in 11:22a. You should translate it here as you did there.

11:24b

it will be more bearable for Sodom on the day of judgment than for you."

- on the great day of judgment, the punishment that God gives to Sodom will be less/lighter than the punishment he gives to you."^(plur)
- when God judges people, he will punish you people of Capernaum more than he will punish the people of Sodom."

This verse should be translated in a similar way to 11:22b.

it will be more bearable for Sodom on the day of judgment than for you:

This clause compares the suffering of two groups of people. The Gentiles in and around the town of Sodom will suffer. And the Jews of the town of Capernaum will suffer. But the suffering of the Gentile people in Sodom will be more bearable than the suffering of the Jews in Capernaum. God will punish them less than he will punish the Jews of Capernaum.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

on the Judgment Day it will be better for Sodom than for you. (NCV)

on Judgment Day, God will punish the people of Sodom less than he will punish you

on Judgment Day, the punishment that God will give you will surpass the punishment of the people of Sodom

the day of judgment: This phrase refers to the time when God will judge all people for the things they have said and done on earth.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the Judgment Day (GNT)

the day that God judges all people

at the time when God judges everyone

This phrase also occurs in 10:15b and 11:22b. You should translate it the same in all places.

Matthew 11:25

Section 11:25–30: Jesus promised rest for the weary

In this section, Jesus prayed to God. He also invited people who were tired from following the law to come to him for rest.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Offers Rest to People (NCV)

Come to Me and Rest (GNT)

Jesus offers rest to weary people

11:25a

At that time Jesus declared,

- ¶ At that time Jesus said,
- ¶ Then Jesus prayed,

At that time: This phrase indicates that Jesus spoke the words in 11:25–26 soon after 11:20–24. He probably also spoke them at the same place.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

It was during that time

Then

After saying those things

Jesus declared: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as Jesus declared can also simply be translated as “Jesus said” (as in the NIV).

The words that Jesus said are a prayer. In some languages, it may be natural to use a verb that introduces a prayer. For example:

prayed this prayer (NLT)

11:25b

“I praise You, Father, Lord of heaven and earth,

- “Father, Lord over heaven and earth, I thank you
- “My Father, you are ruler over everything and everyone on earth and heaven. I praise you

I praise You: Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

I thank you (ESV)

I am grateful (CEV)

Father, Lord of heaven and earth: The word Father and the phrase Lord of heaven and earth are two titles for God the Father. In some languages, these two titles may imply that Jesus was referring to two different people. If that is true in your language, you may have to translate this as:

My Father, you are Lord of heaven and earth

Lord of heaven and earth: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord means “owner,” “master,” or “ruler.” It refers to someone who has authority over something. God the Father is the Lord who rules everyone and everything in heaven and earth.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

owner of heaven and earth

master over everything in heaven and on earth

you rule everything and everyone on earth and in heaven

11:25c

because You have hidden these things from the wise and learned,

- for hiding these things/truths from wise and intelligent people,
- because you have hidden all this from people who are very intelligent/educated,

these things: The words these things probably refer to the deeper meaning behind the miracles and teachings of Jesus. These things showed that Jesus was the Christ, the Savior sent from God.

If people in your area will think that things refers to “physical things,” you may want to use a different word. For example:

these truths

the truth (NLT96)

all this (CEV)

the wise and learned: This phrase is a doublet. This means that the words wise and learned mean almost the same thing. These two words refer to people who are intelligent.

Here are some other ways to translate these two words:

- Use two words that both describe intelligent people. For example:

people who are wise and smart (NCV)

wise and educated people (CEV)

- Use one word. For example:

intelligent people

- Use one word with a modifier. For example:

people who are very intelligent

11:25d

and revealed them to little children.

- and for showing them to people who are like little children.
- and you have revealed it to ordinary/uneducated people.

little children: This is a metaphor. In this metaphor, Jesus compared humble believers to little children. They are similar in that they realize that they do not know very much about spiritual issues, and they are willing to learn. They realize that they have to depend on God as a child depends on his parents. Jesus contrasted this type of people to those who are “wise and understanding.”

Here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

infants (NRSV)

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

those who are like little children (NCV)

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

ordinary people (CEV)

the unlearned (GNT)

Matthew 11:26

Section 11:25–30: Jesus promised rest for the weary

In this section, Jesus prayed to God. He also invited people who were tired from following the law to come to him for rest.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Offers Rest to People (NCV)

Come to Me and Rest (GNT)

Jesus offers rest to weary people

11:26

Yes, Father, for this was well-pleasing in Your sight.

- Father, you did this because it was your will/desire.”
- My Father, doing it this/that way pleased you.”

Yes, Father: Jesus used the word Yes to summarize and confirm what he said in 11:25. In many languages, the word Yes is only used to answer a question. If that is true in your language, you should find another way to translate this word. For example:

Father, you have done that

My Father, this is true

for: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as for indicates that the rest of 11:26 is the reason that God hid things from wise people and revealed them to people who are like children.

Here is another way to translate this conjunction:

because

this was well-pleasing in Your sight: This clause means that it was God’s will to hide those truths from

some people and reveal them to others. It was his will/desire to do it that way. It made him happy.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

it pleased you to do it this way (NLT)

this is what you really wanted (NCV)

Matthew 11:27

Section 11:25–30: Jesus promised rest for the weary

In this section, Jesus prayed to God. He also invited people who were tired from following the law to come to him for rest.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Offers Rest to People (NCV)

Come to Me and Rest (GNT)

Jesus offers rest to weary people

Paragraph 11:27

In this paragraph, Jesus began speaking again to the crowd. His prayer in 11:25–26 was finished. You may want to make this clear in your translation. For example:

Then Jesus said to the crowd

Jesus finished praying and then continued speaking with the people

11:27a

All things have been entrusted to Me by My Father.

- ¶ Then Jesus said, “All authority/power has been given to me by my Father.
- ¶ Then he said to the people, “God my Father has given me authority/power over everything.

All things have been entrusted to Me by My Father: The Greek word that the BSB translates as have been entrusted here means “authority/power has been given.” God the Father gave Jesus authority over everything. This includes nonphysical things such as knowledge. It does not mean that God gave Jesus all material goods.

This word is used with a similar meaning in Luke 4:6 where Satan said, “I will give you all their authority and splendor, for it has been given to me...” (NIV)

This clause is passive. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

All things have been committed to me by my Father. (NIV)

Everything has been put in my hands by my Father (JBP)

- Use an active verb. For example:

My Father has given me authority over everything. (NLT96)

My Father has entrusted everything to me (NLT)

My Father: This phrase refers to God the Father. It does not refer to Joseph. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this more clear. For example:

my Father God

my heavenly Father

11:27b

No one knows the Son except the Father,

- No one truly knows God’s Son if not God the Father.
- Nobody knows me, God’s Son well. Only/Just God the Father knows me well.
- The only person who knows the Son well is the Father.

11:27c

and no one knows the Father except the Son

- And no one truly knows God the Father if not his Son,
- Nobody knows God the Father well. Only/Just I, his Son know him well,
- The only people who know the Father well are the Son

11:27b–c

No one knows the Son except the Father: Here Jesus spoke of himself as the Son. In some languages, this may give the impression that Jesus was referring to someone other than himself. If this is true in your language, you should:

- Explain who the Son refers to. For example:

No one knows me the Son except the Father

- Explain in a footnote that Jesus is referring to himself. For example:

Jesus was referring to himself when he spoke of “the Son.”

knows: The Greek word that the BSB translates as knows in this context means “knows exactly, completely, through and through.” This does not mean to just make an acquaintance of someone or to know about someone. Jesus knows God fully, in a very intimate way.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

truly knows (NLT)

really knows

knows well

the Son: The phrase the Son or “the Son of God” is a title for Jesus. This title indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God. It also indicates that the relationship between God the Father and Jesus, his Son, is similar in some way to the relationship between human fathers and sons. God the Father does not have a physical body. He did not have a sexual relationship that resulted in Mary becoming pregnant and giving birth to Jesus.

For further information, see the note on “My...Son” at 3:17b.

11:27d

and those to whom the Son chooses to reveal Him.

- and anybody the Son decides to show him to.”
- and the people to whom I, the Son, want to make him known. These people also know the Father well.
- and the people to whom the Son wants to make him known.”

and those to whom the Son chooses to reveal Him:

These are the other people who know the Father. Jesus has shown the ways of the Father to his followers. All followers of Jesus will know the Father.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

and the person to whom the Son wants/wishes to show him

Also, the Son decides to make known the Father to certain people. These people also know the Father.

chooses: The Greek word that the BSB translates as chooses can also be translated as:

decides (NET)

wishes/wants

plans

reveal: This word means “make known” or “show openly.” The word refers to clearly showing what the true nature of something or someone is.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

show

disclose

Matthew 11:28

Section 11:25–30: Jesus promised rest for the weary

In this section, Jesus prayed to God. He also invited people who were tired from following the law to come to him for rest.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Offers Rest to People (NCV)

Come to Me and Rest (GNT)

Jesus offers rest to weary people

11:28a

Come to Me, all you who are weary and burdened,

- ¶ “All of you who are tired and carry heavy loads, come to me,
- ¶ “All of you who are tired from obeying all the laws, come to me. All of you for whom obeying the law is like carrying a heavy burden, come to me.

all you who are weary and burdened: This clause refers to the hard work involved in obeying the Jewish law. Obeying all the laws made people tired. Jesus compared it to carrying a heavy burden. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

all who are tired and are carrying the heavy burden of the law

Everyone who is tired from obeying all the laws, and everyone for/to whom obeying the law is like carrying a heavy burden

This clause does not refer to literally carrying some heavy material goods.

weary: The Greek word that the BSB translates as weary has two related meanings:

1. It means tired/weary. For example:

are tired (NCV) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NRSV, NASB, CEV, REB, JBP, NCV, GW, NET, NLT)

1. It means hard work. For example:

labor (RSV) (RSV, NJB, ESV, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It is the meaning that the majority of English versions use. Here the focus is probably on those who are tired as a result of hard work.

burdened: The Greek word that the BSB translates as burdened means “carry a heavy burden/load.” As mentioned above, the law was considered to be a load.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

carry heavy burdens (NLT)

have heavy loads (NCV)

11:28b

and I will give you rest.

- and I will enable/cause you to rest.
- I will relieve your fatigue/tiredness.

I will give you rest: This clause means “I will refresh you” or “I will give you relief from these burdens.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

I will cause/allow you to rest

I will give you relief from your fatigue/tiredness.

I will remove your burden.

Matthew 11:29

Section 11:25–30: Jesus promised rest for the weary

In this section, Jesus prayed to God. He also invited people who were tired from following the law to come to him for rest.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Offers Rest to People (NCV)

Come to Me and Rest (GNT)

Jesus offers rest to weary people

11:29a

Take My yoke upon you

- Put my yoke on your shoulders/neck
- Obey me like an animal with a yoke obeys his owner,
- Submit to me and serve me,

Take My yoke upon you: A yoke is a piece of wood carved to fit over the neck or shoulders of an animal. A yoke is put on an animal for pulling a cart or plow. The picture below is a double yoke for two animals.

The clause Take My yoke upon you is a metaphor. In this metaphor, Jesus compared being his disciple to carrying a light yoke. They are similar in that both an animal and a disciple must submit to his owner and work for him.

Here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

Place my yoke over your shoulders (GW)

Wear my harness If you follow this option, you may want to include a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

A yoke is a symbol of submitting to an owner and working for him.

- Change the metaphor to a simile and make the point of comparison explicit. For example:

submit to me like an animal/ox that wears a yoke submits to his owner

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

Accept my teachings (NCV)

Follow/obey my commands/laws

Submit yourself to me and serve me You may then want to include a footnote to explain the literal clause. Here is a sample footnote:

Literally “Take my yoke upon you.” A yoke is a symbol of submitting to an owner and working for him.

11:29b and learn from Me;

- and learn from me,
- and let me teach you,

and learn from Me: Here are some other ways to translate this:

Let me teach you (NLT)

Let me guide/instruct you in how you should live

11:29c for I am gentle and humble in heart,

- because I am gentle and humble.
- because I am not harsh or proud.

for: The Greek word that the BSB translates as for introduces the basis for the commands in 11:29a-b. A disciple of Jesus should submit to him and learn from him because he is gentle.

I am gentle: The Greek word that the BSB translates as gentle means “considerate” or “not rough/violent.” Jesus is a gentle master.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

considerate/patient

not forceful

not harsh

humble: The Greek word that the BSB translates as humble means “of low position,” or “not proud.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

lowly (ESV)

not proud

in heart: This indicates that Jesus is humble in attitude or manner. It does not refer to his status.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

in spirit (GNT)

in attitude

In some languages, the expressions for “gentle” and “humble” already indicate a humble attitude or manner. If that is the case in your language, you can leave the phrase in heart untranslated.

11:29d and you will find rest for your souls.

- With me, your souls will be/become rested/re-freshed.
- As a result, you will find rest in your inner being.

and you will find rest for your souls: This clause indicates that, with Jesus, a disciple’s inner being (and therefore his whole being) will be rested and not troubled.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

and your whole being will become rested

and with me your inner being will become peaceful

This clause is a result of 11:29a-c. You may want to make that clear in your translation. Here are some examples:

so you will find rest

as a result you will find rest

souls: This word refers to the inner being of a person. Here are some other ways to translate this word:

hearts/livers/stomachs

yourselves (GW)

General Comment on 11:29a–d

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of some of the clauses in 11:29. For example:

^{29c}I am gentle and humble in heart, ^{29a}so take my yoke upon you ^{29b}and learn from me, ^{29d}and you will find rest for your souls.

^{29a}Take my yoke upon you ^{29b}and learn from me, ^{29d}and as a result you will find rest for your souls. ^{29c}because I am gentle and humble in heart.

Matthew 11:30

Section 11:25–30: Jesus promised rest for the weary

In this section, Jesus prayed to God. He also invited people who were tired from following the law to come to him for rest.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Offers Rest to People (NCV)

Come to Me and Rest (GNT)

Jesus offers rest to weary people

11:30a–b

For My yoke is easy and My burden is light: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For introduces another basis for the commands to take Jesus' yoke and learn from him (in 11:29a–b). A disciple of Jesus should take his yoke on him because Jesus' yoke is easy.

Here is another way to introduce the basis for these commands:

Do this because

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it may not be necessary to translate this conjunction either.

My yoke is easy and My burden is light: The words My yoke refer to the yoke that Jesus gives to his followers. Similarly, the words My burden refer to the burden that Jesus gives to his followers. These words do not refer to a yoke or burden that Jesus himself carries. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this more clear. For example:

For the yoke I will give you is easy, and the load I will put on you is light. (GNT)

11:30a

For My yoke is easy

- Do this because the yoke that I give you is pleasant/comfortable to wear,
- Following my teachings is as easy as wearing a comfortable/well-fitted yoke.
- It is not difficult to submit to me.

My yoke is easy: This clause means that the yoke that Jesus gives his followers is comfortable to wear. It will not be tight, pinch, make sores on the skin, or hurt the person who wears it.

As in 11:29a, the word yoke is a metaphor for submitting to Jesus. Submitting to Jesus is similar to wearing a comfortable yoke. Both are easy.

Here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

my yoke is easy to bear (NET)

my yoke fits perfectly (NLT96)

the yoke that I give you is easy to wear/carry. If you follow this option, you may want to include a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

A yoke is a symbol of submitting to an owner. Submitting to Jesus is easy.

- Change the metaphor to a simile and make the point of comparison explicit. For example:

submitting to me is easy like wearing a comfortable yoke

following my teachings is easy like wearing a comfortable yoke

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

The teaching that I ask you to accept is easy (NCV)

my commands/laws are easy to obey

Submitting to me is easy You may then want to include a footnote to explain the literal clause. Here is a sample footnote:

Literally “my yoke is easy.” A yoke is a symbol of submitting to an owner. Submitting to Jesus is easy.

11:30b and My burden is light.”

- and the load that I give to you to carry is light.”
- Doing the work that I give to you is as easy as carrying a load that is light.”
- It is not hard to do the work that I give to you.”

My burden is light: This clause means that the burden/load that Jesus gives to his followers to carry is light. It is not heavy. It is easy to carry.

This clause is also a metaphor. In this metaphor, Jesus compares the work that he gives his disciples to carrying a light burden. They are similar in that both are easy to do.

Here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

the load I give you to carry is light (NCV)

- Change the metaphor to a simile and make the point of comparison explicit. For example:

the work that I give to you is as easy to do as carrying a load that is light

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

the work that I give you is not hard

Matthew 12:1

Section 12:1–14: Jesus is the Lord of the Sabbath

There are two main events in this section. One is about picking grain on the Sabbath. The other is about

healing on the Sabbath. These two events show that Jesus has the authority to decide which deeds are acceptable to do on the Sabbath.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus showed that he has authority over Sabbath rules

Lord of the Sabbath (NIV)

The Pharisees criticize Jesus because of what he did on the Sabbath

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 2:23–3:6 and Luke 6:1–11.

12:1a

At that time Jesus went through the grainfields on the Sabbath.

- ¶ Soon after that, Jesus was walking through some fields of grain. It was on a Sabbath.
- ¶ One Sabbath day, Jesus and his disciples were walking between some fields where grain was growing.

At that time...on the Sabbath: The phrase At that time indicates that this story probably took place soon after the events in chapter 11. (This same phrase occurs in 11:25a.) The Greek does not indicate how much time passed between these two chapters. It could have been several days or several weeks.

Here are some other ways to translate these phrases:

- Translate both phrases. For example:

Not long afterward Jesus was walking through some wheat fields on a Sabbath. (GNT)

- Combine the two phrases into one. For example:

One Sabbath, Jesus and his disciples were walking through some wheat fields.

Jesus: The disciples are not mentioned until 12:1b, but they were certainly walking together with Jesus. In some languages, it may be more natural to mention the disciples here in 12:1a. For example:

Jesus and his disciples (CEV)

went through the grainfields: Jesus and his disciples were probably walking on a path that had grainfields on both sides. They were not trampling on the crops or trespassing on private property.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

walking through some fields of grain (NCV)

walking on a path and passing through some fields of grain

grainfields: These were areas of land where the people grew wheat or barley or a similar type of grain. Notice that some English versions (KJV, NJB, REB) call these “cornfields.” In these versions, “corn” has the general sense of “grain.” It does not refer to “maize” (which Americans call “corn”). The areas were probably a hectare (100 meters wide by 100 meters long) or more in size. They used the grain for making bread and other food.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

- Use your term for field and a general term for grain. For example:

fields of grain (NCV)

- Use your term for field and a specific type of grain. For example:

wheat fields (GNT)

barley farms

fields where people grew something like millet/ rice

- Use a general expression for a field where people grow crops for food. For example:

cultivated fields

fields/land for growing food

farms/gardens

the Sabbath: The word Sabbath is the name of the seventh and last day of the week for the Jews. The Sabbath was the special day of the week when the

Jews rested and worshiped God. The Law of Moses said that the Jews must not do any work on that day (Deuteronomy 5:12–15).

Here are some other ways to translate Sabbath:

- Translate the meaning. For example:

the rest day

the Jewish day for resting

- Transliterate the word Sabbath and spell it using the sounds of your language. For example:

Sabat

Sabati

If you transliterate the word Sabbath, you may also want to:

1. Include a phrase to explain the meaning, at least the first time it occurs. For example:

the Sabat, the Jews' rest day

1. Explain the meaning of the word in a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

The word Sabat is the name of the seventh and last day of the week for the Jews. The Sabat was the special day of the week when the Jews rested and worshiped God.

Be careful that the term you choose is not confused with Sunday. The Sabbath began at sundown on Friday and went until sundown on Saturday.

12:1b

His disciples were hungry

- His disciples were walking with him, and they were hungry,
- His followers felt hungry,

His disciples: For help in translating this term, see the note in 8:21a. See also disciple in the Glossary.

12:1c

and began to pick the heads of grain and eat them.

- and they began picking some clusters of grain and eating them.
- so they started to pull/strip off some grain/seeds and eat them.

began to pick the heads of grain: The phrase pick the heads of grain means “pull/pick clusters of seeds off the stalk of the grain plants.” Grain plants like wheat and barley grow clusters of seeds on the top of a stalk. These clusters are the heads of grain.

The disciples snapped off the heads of grain with their fingers. They did not use tools.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

began to pull off the seeds

started to pick the grains from the stalk

According to Luke 6:1c, after the disciples picked the grains, they rubbed them in their hands. They did this to remove the thin husk that surrounds the grain before they ate it. In some languages, it may be natural to make some of this information explicit. For example:

began to pick some heads of grain and remove the husk

and eat them: The disciples ate the grain raw. In some languages, there is a specific word for eating grain, or eating uncooked grain.

Here is an example in English:

and crunched it

Matthew 12:2

Section 12:1–14: Jesus is the Lord of the Sabbath

There are two main events in this section. One is about picking grain on the Sabbath. The other is about healing on the Sabbath. These two events show that Jesus has the authority to decide which deeds are acceptable to do on the Sabbath.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus showed that he has authority over Sabbath rules

Lord of the Sabbath (NIV)

The Pharisees criticize Jesus because of what he did on the Sabbath

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 2:23–3:6 and Luke 6:1–11.

12:2a

When the Pharisees saw this, they said to Him,

- But/However, when some Pharisees saw them doing this, they said to him/Jesus,
- Some men from the Pharisee group were there and saw what the disciples were doing. They said to Jesus,

This verse introduces a conflict that the Pharisees had with the disciples who plucked and ate grain on the Sabbath. If you have a word or phrase that introduces a conflict of this type in your language, you should use it here. One way to do this in English is to use the word “But.”

Here is another way to introduce this conflict:

However

In some languages it is not necessary to add a special word or phrase to introduce a conflict in a historical event such as this.

When the Pharisees saw this: Some, but not all, of the Pharisees were there and saw what the disciples did. In some languages, it will be necessary to make some of this information explicit. For example:

Some Pharisees noticed this (CEV)

Some men of the Pharisee group were there and saw what the disciples were doing

Pharisees: For help in translating this word, see the note in 9:11a.

12:2b

“Look, Your disciples are doing what is unlawful on the Sabbath.”

- “Look at that! Your disciples are doing what the Law says is wrong to do on the Sabbath day!”
- “Teacher/Sir, look at your disciples! They are breaking the law about working on the Sabbath.”
- that what his disciples were doing was not allowed on the Sabbath because it was work.

Look: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Look is the same word that is sometimes translated as “Behold.” This word focuses attention on what follows and indicates that it is important, unexpected, or amazing. In this context, the Pharisees are amazed

and surprised that the disciples picked grain on the Sabbath.

Here, this word is also used in a somewhat literal sense, because the Pharisees want Jesus to notice what the disciples are doing.

Here are some examples:

See!

Look here!

In some languages, it is natural to begin this sentence with a term of respect. For example:

Teacher/Sir, Do you see what they are doing?

Your disciples are doing what is unlawful on the Sabbath: The Pharisees criticized the disciples for breaking the law which says that people must not work on the Sabbath. The Pharisees believed that even picking a small handful of grain for a snack was harvesting and therefore work. They also believed that rubbing that small amount of grain and blowing away the husk was threshing and therefore work as well.

According to Deuteronomy 23:25, people were allowed to pick and eat a little grain for a snack. It was not stealing. The Pharisees said that what the disciples did was wrong because they were doing it on the Sabbath.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

General Comment on 12:2b

- Explain what was unlawful in the text. For example:

Look, your disciples are breaking the law by harvesting grain on the Sabbath. (NLT)

Why are your disciples picking grain on the Sabbath? They are not supposed to do that! (CEV)

Look! Your disciples are breaking the law about working on the Sabbath

- Explain what was unlawful in a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

God allowed people to pick and eat a handful of grain from other people's fields (Deuteronomy 23:25). But the Pharisees said that such picking

was work and therefore not allowed on the Sabbath.

In some languages, it may be natural to translate 12:2b as indirect speech. For example:

that his disciples were doing what was not allowed in the Sabbath

Matthew 12:3

Section 12:1-14: Jesus is the Lord of the Sabbath

There are two main events in this section. One is about picking grain on the Sabbath. The other is about healing on the Sabbath. These two events show that Jesus has the authority to decide which deeds are acceptable to do on the Sabbath.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus showed that he has authority over Sabbath rules

Lord of the Sabbath (NIV)

The Pharisees criticize Jesus because of what he did on the Sabbath

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 2:23-3:6 and Luke 6:1-11.

12:3-4

In 12:3-4 Jesus responded to the Pharisees' accusation by referring to a story about King David. This story is found in 1 Samuel 21:1-6.

In this story, David was fleeing from King Saul. He and his men were hungry.

They came to the tabernacle, and David asked the priest for food. The only food available was the consecrated bread. Only priests were allowed to eat that bread. However, the priest gave the bread to David and his men to eat. Even though David did something that the law did not allow, God did not punish him or his men.

In order for people to understand this passage, they need to know this background information. It may be necessary to include footnotes in your translation to explain it. You may also need to make some of the implied information explicit in the text. The notes on these verses will give suggestions.

In Greek, 12:3–4 is one, long question. It is a rhetorical question. Some English versions translate 12:3–4 as one long, rhetorical question (see the ESV).

The BSB and other English versions translate 12:3–4 as a rhetorical question and a statement. For example:

³He answered, “Haven’t you read what David did when he and his companions were hungry? ⁴He entered the house of God, and he and his companions ate the consecrated bread—which was not lawful for them to do, but only for the priests. (NIV)

You should translate this long, rhetorical question in a way that is natural in your language.

12:3a

Jesus replied, “Have you not read what David did

- ¶ He responded, “Have you^(plur) never read what David did
- ¶ Jesus said to them, “Did you^(plur) read in vain what David did
- ¶ Jesus said, “Surely you^(plur) have read what David did

12:3b

when he and his companions were hungry?

- when he and those who were with him were hungry?
- when he and his men were hungry?
- at the time that he and his companions felt hungry!

12:3a–b

Have you not read what David did when he and his companions were hungry?: This is a rhetorical question. It expresses a rebuke. Jesus rebuked the Pharisees because they accused the disciples of breaking the Sabbath laws. The Pharisees had of course read the story about David. Jesus accused them of not understanding the teaching in this story.

Here are some other ways to translate this rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Have you read in vain what David did when he and his companions were hungry?

Did you not understand anything when you read what David did when he and his companions were hungry?

- As a statement. For example:

You surely must have read what David did when he and his followers were hungry. (CEV)

You have read the story of what David did when he and his companions were hungry. You should have understood the teaching behind this story. But you did not!

Translate this rebuke in a way that is natural in your language.

his companions: The Greek text is literally “the ones with him.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

his men (GNT)

his followers

Matthew 12:4

Section 12:1–14: Jesus is the Lord of the Sabbath

There are two main events in this section. One is about picking grain on the Sabbath. The other is about healing on the Sabbath. These two events show that Jesus has the authority to decide which deeds are acceptable to do on the Sabbath.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus showed that he has authority over Sabbath rules

Lord of the Sabbath (NIV)

The Pharisees criticize Jesus because of what he did on the Sabbath

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 2:23–3:6 and Luke 6:1–11.

12:4a

He entered the house of God, and he and his companions ate the consecrated bread,

- He entered God’s tent and ate the bread presented/offered to God.
- He went into the courtyard of the worship place of God and was given the bread/food that was an offering to God. Then he and his men ate it.

He entered the house of God: The phrase the house of God was a Jewish expression that could refer to

either the tabernacle or the temple. Here it refers to the tabernacle. The tabernacle was a movable tent. It was the special worship place for the Jews before they built the temple. It was the place where Jewish people presented sacrifices to God and where God revealed his presence to them.

If your word for house is general enough to include the Jewish tabernacle, you may follow the BSB. If people in your area will think only of a permanent house, you may want to use your expression for the Jewish tabernacle.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the tent of worship to God

the worship place of God

the tabernacle

The term house of God refers not only to the tent of worship but also the courtyards around it. Since only priests were allowed to enter the tent, David probably entered only the courtyard and the priest gave him the bread there. If you feel that this detail is important here, you may want to include the implied information. For example:

He entered the court/courtyard of the house of God

and he and his companions ate: There is some implied information here:

1. According to Luke 6:4 and 1 Samuel 21:1–6, David asked the priest for the bread, and the priest gave it to him. David did not steal the bread. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this information explicit. For example:

he was given the bread of the Presence and ate it

he received the holy bread and ate it

1. According to 12:4b, David's men also ate the bread. David was not the only person to eat it. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this information explicit here. For example:

and he and his men ate

the consecrated bread: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the consecrated bread is more literally “the bread of the presentation.” It had this name because a priest presented/offered this bread to God by placing it on a table in the tabernacle. Every Sabbath the bread was replaced with fresh bread. Then, only the priests were allowed to eat the old bread. See Leviticus 24:5–9 and Exodus 25:30.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the bread offered to God (GNT)

the bread that had been placed before God

the holy bread (NCV)

bread: The word bread refers to the main food of the Jewish people. It was the food they ate every day.

If bread is not known in your area, you can:

- translate this word with a general term. For example:

food

- use the name of the food that is eaten at most meals in your area, but only if the word can also be used in a general sense to refer to any food.

12:4b

which was not lawful for them to eat, but only for the priests.

- It was against the law for him or his companions to eat that bread. Only the priests were allowed to eat it.
- Moses' law permits only priests to eat that bread. The law did not permit David and his men to eat it.

which was not lawful for them to eat, but only for the priests: The law of Moses did not allow anyone but/except priests to eat this special bread (Leviticus 24:9). It was against the law for David and his men to eat it.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

it was against the Law for them to eat it—only the priests were allowed to eat that bread. (GNT)

The law did not allow anyone except the priests to eat it. David and his men were not allowed to eat it.

If not for the priests, the law did not allow anyone to eat this bread. He and his men were not allowed to eat it.

priests: The word priests refers to Jewish men who offered sacrifices to God on behalf of the people. Priests also performed other rituals for the people.

Here are some other ways to translate priests:

- Use a descriptive term that focuses on the function of priests. For example:

sacrificers

men who offer sacrifices to God

men who represent people to God

- Use a local word for priests. This option may be acceptable if the duties of local priests are similar to those of Jewish priests. You may need to indicate that the word refers to Jewish priests. For example:

Jewish people's priests/sacrificers

If possible, you should choose a term that can be used in both Old Testament and New Testament contexts.

The word "priest" first occurs in 8:4b. See also how you translated "priest" in the phrase "chief priests" in 2:4. See also priest in the Glossary for more information.

General Comment on 12:4a–b

God was not angry with David or the priest who gave the bread to him. Instead, God is pleased when his people help others in need. This is the implied conclusion based on 12:7b. You may want to explain some of this in a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

The priest had mercy on David and gave him the bread. This broke the law that said that only the priests were permitted to eat that bread. But God was not angry with the priest or David. Instead God was happy that the priest had mercy on David, as 12:7 explains. The intent of the law is to be merciful toward poor and needy people and to help them when they are in need.

Matthew 12:5

Section 12:1–14: Jesus is the Lord of the Sabbath

There are two main events in this section. One is about picking grain on the Sabbath. The other is about

healing on the Sabbath. These two events show that Jesus has the authority to decide which deeds are acceptable to do on the Sabbath.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus showed that he has authority over Sabbath rules

Lord of the Sabbath (NIV)

The Pharisees criticize Jesus because of what he did on the Sabbath

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 2:23–3:6 and Luke 6:1–11.

12:5a–c

haven't you read in the Law that on the Sabbath the priests in the temple break the Sabbath and yet are innocent?: This is a rhetorical question. It expresses a rebuke. Jesus rebuked the Pharisees because they accused the disciples of breaking the Sabbath laws. The Pharisees had of course read the law. Jesus accused them of not applying some of the principles in the law.

Here are some other ways to translate this rebuke:

Here are some other ways to translate this rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

have you read in vain in the law that on the Sabbath the priests in the temple profane the day and yet are not guilty?

did you not understand anything when you read in the law that on the Sabbath the priests in the temple desecrate the day and yet are innocent?

- As a rhetorical question and a statement. For example:

have you not read in the law of Moses that on every Sabbath day the priests in the Temple break this law about the Sabbath day? But the priests are not wrong for doing that. (NCV)

- As a statement. For example:

surely you have read in the Law that on the Sabbath the priests in the temple desecrate the day and yet are innocent.

Translate this rebuke in a way that is natural in your language.

12:5a

Or haven't you read in the Law

- Also, have you^(plur) never read in the book of the law
- Again, did you^(plur) read in vain in the law of Moses
- Surely you^(plur) have read in the law

Or: This word indicates that 12:5 is a second part of Jesus' response. It is parallel to the first rhetorical question in 12:3–4.

Here are some other ways to introduce this second part:

Also

Again

Next

In this rhetorical question, Jesus reminded the Pharisees that one law requires the priests to offer sacrifices on the Sabbath. Another law prohibits work on the Sabbath. These two laws apparently conflict. However, everyone agreed that the law to offer sacrifices on the Sabbath was more important than the law not to work.

Jesus used a type of reasoning that Jewish teachers regularly used. They would not have been able to argue with his conclusion.

in the Law: This phrase refers to the law that Moses wrote. This law is in the first five books of the Old Testament. The Jews would know that the phrase the Law referred to the Law of Moses, but you may want to make it clear for your readers. For example:

in the Law of Moses (GNT)

In God's law that Moses wrote

12:5b

that on the Sabbath the priests in the temple

- that on the Sabbath, when the priests offer sacrifices in the temple,
- that on the Sabbath, the priests work in the temple? By doing that, they
- that on the Day of Rest the priests in the temple do not rest.

12:5c

break the Sabbath

- they defile/spoil the Sabbath?
- break the Sabbath law.
- They do not obey/follow the law concerning resting on that day.

12:5b–c

on the Sabbath the priests in the temple break the Sabbath: This clause refers to two laws that apparently conflict. One of Moses' laws prohibits people from working on the Sabbath. Another of Moses' laws requires the priests to offer sacrifices on the Sabbath. Slaughtering an animal and offering it as a sacrifice was normally considered work. So by obeying one law, the priests were breaking another law. They were profaning, disrespecting, or breaking the Sabbath law.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

on every Sabbath day the priests in the Temple break this law about the Sabbath day (NCV)

on the Sabbath, when the priests work in the temple, they do not follow/obey the Sabbath law

on the Day of Rest, the priests offer sacrifices in the temple. So they do not rest on that day

temple: The word temple refers to the temple building and the walls and courtyards that surrounded it. The temple was in Jerusalem and was the most important place where Jews worshiped God.

Here are some other ways to translate the word temple:

- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

house/building of God

place of sacrifice

house/place of worship

holy/sacred house

- If your language has a word for "temple," consider using it. But you may need to modify it by saying:

temple of the Jews/Lord

Be sure to use a different term from the one you have chosen for “synagogue” (in 9:35b). There was only one temple, but there were many synagogues.

The word temple first occurs in 4:5b. See also the word temple, Meaning 1, in the Glossary for more information.

break the Sabbath: The Greek word that the BSB translates as break also means “defile” or “make unclean.” The Sabbath is a holy day, and doing work on that day makes the day unholy or unclean.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

- Keep the idea of profaning the Sabbath. For example:

desecrate the Sabbath (NET)

defile/spoil the Sabbath

- Focus on the idea of breaking the Sabbath law. For example:

break the Sabbath law (GNT)

do not follow/keep the law about not working on the Sabbath

12:5d

and yet are innocent?

- But no one has said that they have done wrong.
- But they have not sinned.
- And yet they are innocent.

and yet are innocent: The word innocent means “not guilty” or “innocent” of a crime or sin. Even though the priests worked on the Sabbath by offering sacrifices, their actions were not wrong. They were doing what God had told them to do.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

not guilty (GNT)

innocent (NIV)

not wrong

Matthew 12:6

Section 12:1–14: Jesus is the Lord of the Sabbath

There are two main events in this section. One is about picking grain on the Sabbath. The other is about healing on the Sabbath. These two events show that Jesus has the authority to decide which deeds are acceptable to do on the Sabbath.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus showed that he has authority over Sabbath rules

Lord of the Sabbath (NIV)

The Pharisees criticize Jesus because of what he did on the Sabbath

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 2:23–3:6 and Luke 6:1–11.

12:6

But I tell you that something greater than the temple is here.

- I say to you that something more important than the temple is here.
- I assure you^(plur) that someone is here who is more valuable than the temple.

I tell you: The words I tell you emphasize the words that follow.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Use a phrase before Jesus’ statement. For example:

I say to you

I assure you

I can guarantee (GW)

- Include an emphatic word or phrase such as “certainly” within the following statement. For example:

something greater than the temple is certainly here

that something greater than the temple is here: The Greek word that the BSB literally translates as something probably refers to Jesus. In some languages, it

is possible for Jesus to refer to himself as something. In other languages, it will be more natural to say:

one greater than the temple is here (NIV)

someone more important than the temple is here

greater: In this context, the word greater refers to higher in status and not to bigger in size. Jesus was more important than the temple.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

more important (JBP)

more valuable

with/of greater authority

Matthew 12:7

Section 12:1–14: Jesus is the Lord of the Sabbath

There are two main events in this section. One is about picking grain on the Sabbath. The other is about healing on the Sabbath. These two events show that Jesus has the authority to decide which deeds are acceptable to do on the Sabbath.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus showed that he has authority over Sabbath rules

Lord of the Sabbath (NIV)

The Pharisees criticize Jesus because of what he did on the Sabbath

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 2:23–3:6 and Luke 6:1–11.

12:7a–c

(reordered) (GNT:) The scripture says, ‘It is kindness that I want, not animal sacrifices.’ If you really knew what this means, you would not condemn people who are not guilty.

Before you translate 12:7, carefully consider the most natural way in your language to order the clauses. In some languages, it will be more natural to put 12:7b before 12:7a. For example:

^bThe scripture says, ‘It is kindness that I want, not animal sacrifices.’ ^aIf you really knew what this means, ‘you would not condemn people who are not guilty....’ (GNT)

12:7a

If only you had known the meaning of

- If you^(plur) had understood these words:
- You^(plur) should have known the meaning of the following words that God spoke,

If only you had known the meaning of: This clause is an “if” clause. Jesus used this “if clause” to rebuke the Pharisees. He rebuked them because they did not know/understand the true meaning of the quote in 12:7b, but they should have understood it. They knew the quote, but they did not understand how to apply it in their everyday lives.

Here are some other ways to translate this rebuke:

- As an “if” clause. For example:

If you really knew what this means (GNT)

If you had grasped the meaning of the scripture (JBP)

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Don’t you know what the Scriptures mean when they say...? (CEV)

- As a statement plus an “if” clause. For example:

You don’t really know what those words mean. If you understood them... (NCV)

Translate this rebuke in a way that is most natural in your language.

the meaning of: The words the meaning of refer to the significance of the words that follow in 12:7b. 12:7b is from Hosea 6:6. You may want to introduce 12:7b indicating that God spoke these words. For example:

these words of God

the following words that God spoke in Scripture

12:7b

‘I desire mercy, not sacrifice,’

- ‘Kindness is what I want, not sacrifice,’

- ‘I want you to have concern/pity for others more than I want your sacrifices.’

I desire mercy, not sacrifice: This is a quote from Hosea. (This quote also occurs in 9:13b.) It is a comparison of two things: mercy and sacrifice. It means that God considers it more important for people to show mercy to other people than for them to follow the laws concerning sacrifices. It does not mean that God wanted his people to stop offering sacrifices.

In some languages, it may be more natural to express this comparison in another way. For example:

I want you^(plur) to show mercy to each other. That is more important than your sacrifices to me.

I want kindness more than I want animal sacrifices. (NCV)

mercy: The word mercy means “compassion” or “concern” or “pity” towards someone else. For example:

compassion (NASB)

kindness (NCV)

In some languages it may be necessary to indicate who should have mercy and to whom. For example:

I want you to be merciful to others. (CEV)

I want people to pity/love others.

sacrifice: The word sacrifice refers to the killing of animals at the temple and offering them to God. God required the Jews to offer animal sacrifices to him regularly.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

animal sacrifices (GNT)

offering sacrifices to me (CEV)

12:7c

you would not have condemned the innocent.

- you would not have judged people who have not broken the law.
- If you had known the meaning of those words, you would not blame/criticize people who are innocent.

you would not have condemned: The word condemned means “judge and call guilty or evil.” The Pharisees condemned the disciples when they said that the disciples had broken the Sabbath law. Jesus said that the Pharisees should not have condemned his disciples.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

you would not judge (NCV)

you would not blame/criticize

you would not find guilty

you would not decide/say that they are lawbreakers

the innocent: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates the innocent means “people who are not guilty of a crime or sin.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

those who have not broken the law

these innocent disciples of mine (CEV)

those who have done nothing wrong (NCV)

Matthew 12:8

Section 12:1-14: Jesus is the Lord of the Sabbath

There are two main events in this section. One is about picking grain on the Sabbath. The other is about healing on the Sabbath. These two events show that Jesus has the authority to decide which deeds are acceptable to do on the Sabbath.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus showed that he has authority over Sabbath rules

Lord of the Sabbath (NIV)

The Pharisees criticize Jesus because of what he did on the Sabbath

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 2:23–3:6 and Luke 6:1–11.

12:8

For the Son of Man is Lord of the Sabbath.”

- I say this because the Son of Man is master/ruler of the Sabbath day.”
- I, the Son of Man, have authority over what is right to do on the rest day.”
- The Son of Man has the authority to say what people can and cannot do on the day for resting.”

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *For* indicates that 12:8 is the basis for Jesus declaring that the disciples were innocent (12:7). It is also the basis for Jesus deciding what was allowed on the Sabbath (12:1–7).

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

Because

I say this because

In some languages, it may be natural to simply begin a new sentence here without translating the conjunction.

the Son of Man: Jesus used the title the Son of Man to refer to himself. In some languages it may be necessary to add the pronoun “I” to show that Jesus was referring to himself. For example:

I, the Son of Man (NLT96)

This phrase also occurs in 8:20b, 9:6a, 10:23c, and 11:19a. For help in translating this phrase, see the note under 8:20b. See also Son of Man in KBT for more information.

is Lord of the Sabbath: In this context, the word *Lord* means “owner” or “the one in authority over (something).” It refers to Jesus’ authority over the Sabbath day. He had this authority because he was the Son of Man, whom God sent. He had the authority to decide what people could or could not do on the Sabbath day.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I...am master even of the Sabbath. (NLT96)

I...have authority over the rest day.

I...have the right to decide what a person can do on the Sabbath.

I...have the authority to say what people are allowed to do on the Sabbath.

Matthew 12:9

Section 12:1–14: Jesus is the Lord of the Sabbath

There are two main events in this section. One is about picking grain on the Sabbath. The other is about healing on the Sabbath. These two events show that Jesus has the authority to decide which deeds are acceptable to do on the Sabbath.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus showed that he has authority over Sabbath rules

Lord of the Sabbath (NIV)

The Pharisees criticize Jesus because of what he did on the Sabbath

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 2:23–3:6 and Luke 6:1–11.

12:9

Moving on from there, Jesus entered their synagogue,

- ¶ Then Jesus left that place and went to a synagogue.
- ¶ Then Jesus and his disciples exited the grainfields and went to a prayer/worship house of the Jews and entered it.

Moving on from there, Jesus entered their synagogue: After the discussion with the Pharisees (12:1–7), Jesus and his disciples left the grainfields and went to a synagogue. They went to the synagogue on that same Sabbath day.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Then Jesus left that place and entered their synagogue. (NET)

Jesus left that place and went to a synagogue (GNT)

Then Jesus and his disciples exited the grainfields and went to the synagogue.

entered: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as entered is more literally “went/came into.” In some languages, it is natural to say that Jesus entered a synagogue. In other languages, it is natural to simply say that Jesus went to a synagogue. You should use the most natural expression in your language.

their synagogue: The phrase their synagogue refers to the synagogue of the Jews of that area. (This same expression occurs in 4:23b and 9:35b.) In many languages, it is natural to simply say that Jesus went to “a synagogue.” For example:

a synagogue (GNT)

Matthew 12:10

Section 12:1–14: Jesus is the Lord of the Sabbath

There are two main events in this section. One is about picking grain on the Sabbath. The other is about healing on the Sabbath. These two events show that Jesus has the authority to decide which deeds are acceptable to do on the Sabbath.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus showed that he has authority over Sabbath rules

Lord of the Sabbath (NIV)

The Pharisees criticize Jesus because of what he did on the Sabbath

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 2:23–3:6 and Luke 6:1–11.

12:10a and a man with a withered hand was there.

- A certain man was there whose hand was paralyzed/crippled.
- There was a man there in the prayer-house. His one hand was dead/dried.

and a man...was there: In Greek, this verse begins with an expression that can be translated as “and behold.” This word focuses attention on what follows and indicates that it is important, unexpected, or amazing. In this passage, this expression introduces

and focuses attention on the man with a withered hand.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

a certain man was there

now a man was there (NJB)

There was a man there

with a withered hand: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as withered hand is more literally “dried hand.” This phrase indicates that the man’s hand was paralyzed/crippled. The man could not move his hand or use it.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

who had a paralyzed hand (GNT)

whose hand was crippled (CEV)

his hand was dried/dead

hand: The Greek word for hand refers to the end of the man’s arm that included his fingers, palm, and back of his hand. It could also include the wrist and forearm. Here the Greek text does not specify how much of the man’s hand was crippled. It is possible that the area from the fingers to the elbow was paralyzed.

In some languages, the “hand” and “arm” are often referred to using the same word. In Greek, there are two different words: one for arm and one for hand. Here the Greek word refers specifically to the part at the end of the man’s arm. You can use a word that includes the area from the fingers to the wrist, or the area from the fingers to the elbow. If possible, you should not use a word that can also mean the entire arm up to the shoulder.

12:10b–c

The Pharisees believed that healing was work. Therefore, healing was not allowed on the Sabbath. They believed that Jesus was wrong to heal on the Sabbath. So they asked Jesus a question to encourage him to say something that was against God’s law. Then they could accuse him in court of being wrong.

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of 12:10b–c. For example:

“And they asked him, “Is it lawful to heal on the Sabbath?”—^bso that they might accuse him.

12:10b

In order to accuse Jesus,

- So that they could accuse him, They asked this question to cause/trick him to say something wrong.
- Because they were looking for a way to blame him for breaking the Sabbath law,

In order to accuse Jesus: There is some implicit information here. The Pharisees asked their question and hoped that Jesus would answer in a way that contradicted the law. Then they could accuse him. So this clause indicates that the purpose of the Pharisees’ question in 12:10c was to trick Jesus to say something wrong so that they could accuse him.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Keep the conjunction In order and the purpose clause, and include some implied information. For example:

They were hoping he would say yes, in order that they could bring charges against him. (NLT)

They asked him this question to force/cause him to say something wrong so that they could accuse him.

- Translate this clause as the reason that the Pharisees asked their question. For example:

They asked this question because they wanted to accuse him of breaking the law.

accuse: This word means “say before authorities that (someone) has broken the law,” so that the person will be arrested.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

accuse him of doing something wrong (GW)

claim that he is a lawbreaker

blame him for breaking the law

12:10c

they asked Him, “Is it lawful to heal on the Sabbath?”

- Some people asked him, “Does the law allow someone to heal another person on the Sabbath?”
- the Pharisees asked him, “Teacher/Sir, does the law permit someone to cure a sick/handicapped person on the day of rest?”

they asked Him: The pronoun they refers to some Pharisees who were in the synagogue. The pronoun Him refers to Jesus, not the man with a withered hand.

Is it lawful to heal on the Sabbath?: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Is it lawful is more literally “Is it permitted.” This means “Does God’s/Moses’ law permit healing on the Sabbath day?” The Pharisees believed that it was against God’s law to heal on the Sabbath.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Is it permitted to cure somebody on the Sabbath day? (NJB)

Is it against our Law to heal on the Sabbath? (GNT)

Teacher, is it not against God’s law to heal a sick/handicapped person on the day of rest?

Matthew 12:11

Section 12:1–14: Jesus is the Lord of the Sabbath

There are two main events in this section. One is about picking grain on the Sabbath. The other is about healing on the Sabbath. These two events show that Jesus has the authority to decide which deeds are acceptable to do on the Sabbath.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus showed that he has authority over Sabbath rules

Lord of the Sabbath (NIV)

The Pharisees criticize Jesus because of what he did on the Sabbath

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 2:23–3:6 and Luke 6:1–11.

12:11a–b

If one of you has a sheep and it falls into a pit on the Sabbath, will he not take hold of it and lift it out?:

This is a rhetorical question. Jesus used this rhetorical

question to emphasize that a person would certainly help a sheep out of a pit on the Sabbath. He would not abandon it.

Here are some other ways to translate this emphasis:

- As a rhetorical question. You may then want to indicate the implied answer. For example:

If any of you has a sheep, and it falls into a pit on the Sabbath, would you take hold of it and lift it out? Of course you would!

Suppose you have a sheep. If it falls into a pit on the Sabbath day, do you leave it there? Of course not! You grab it and lift it out.

- As a statement. For example:

If any of you has a sheep, and it falls into a pit on the Sabbath, you would surely/certainly take hold of it and lift it out.

Translate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

12:11a

He replied, “If one of you has a sheep and it falls into a pit on the Sabbath,

- Jesus asked them, “If any of you has a sheep, and it falls into a pit on the Sabbath,
- But/So Jesus responded, “Suppose one of you has a sheep. If it falls into a hole on the Sabbath day,

If one of you has a sheep and it falls into a pit on the Sabbath:

Here are some other ways to translate these clauses:

Suppose one of you has a sheep. If it falls into a pit on a day of worship (GW)

If you had a sheep that fell into a ditch on the Sabbath (CEV)

a sheep: The word sheep first occurs in 7:15b. It also occurs in 9:36c. You should translate it here as you did there.

pit: This word can refer to a hole that someone dug, or a hole that occurs naturally. The Greek does not specify which type of hole. What is important is that the word you use refer to a deep hole. If an animal like a sheep fell into such a hole, it could not get out by itself.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

deep hole

ditch (CEV)

12:11b

will he not take hold of it and lift it out?

- you grab it and lift it out, do you not? Of course!
- do you leave it there? Of course not! You reach in, grab ahold of it, and pull it out.
- you would certainly rescue it!

take hold of it and lift it out: These two clauses refer to grasping the sheep and lifting it out of the pit. In some languages, it may be necessary to translate these two clauses using more than two verbs. In other languages, one verb is enough. For example:

reach in, grab it and pull it out

rescue it

Matthew 12:12

Section 12:1–14: Jesus is the Lord of the Sabbath

There are two main events in this section. One is about picking grain on the Sabbath. The other is about healing on the Sabbath. These two events show that Jesus has the authority to decide which deeds are acceptable to do on the Sabbath.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus showed that he has authority over Sabbath rules

Lord of the Sabbath (NIV)

The Pharisees criticize Jesus because of what he did on the Sabbath

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 2:23–3:6 and Luke 6:1–11.

12:12a

How much more valuable is a man than a sheep!

- A person is certainly worth much more than a sheep!
- Sheep are valuable, but people are more valuable to God than sheep!

How much more valuable is a man than a sheep!:

This clause emphasizes the fact that a human being is much more valuable than a sheep.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

And a human being is worth much more than a sheep! (GNT)

Certainly, a human is more valuable than a sheep! (GW)

Is not a person much more important than a sheep? Of course!

valuable: The Greek word that the BSB translates as valuable means “be of worth.” God values people more than sheep.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

worth (GNT)

important (NJB)

man: The word man is general and refers to people.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

a person

a human being (GNT)

12:12b

Therefore it is lawful to do good on the Sabbath.”

- So, the law allows doing good deeds on the Sabbath.”
- Therefore, the law permits someone to help another person on the Sabbath day.”

it is lawful: Translate this phrase as you did in 12:10c.

to do good: Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

do good things (NCV)

do good deeds

help someone

Matthew 12:13**Section 12:1–14: Jesus is the Lord of the Sabbath**

There are two main events in this section. One is about picking grain on the Sabbath. The other is about healing on the Sabbath. These two events show that Jesus has the authority to decide which deeds are acceptable to do on the Sabbath.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus showed that he has authority over Sabbath rules

Lord of the Sabbath (NIV)

The Pharisees criticize Jesus because of what he did on the Sabbath

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 2:23–3:6 and Luke 6:1–11.

12:13a

Then Jesus said to the man, “Stretch out your hand.”

- Then he told the man, “Reach out your hand.”
- Then Jesus said to him, “Extend your hand/arm!”

12:13b

So he stretched it out,

- The man reached out his hand,
- So he extended his hand/arm,

12:13a–b

Stretch out your hand: With this clause, Jesus commanded the man to extend his arm so that his hand was out in front of him.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Extend your hand

Reach out your hand

Hold out your hand (CEV)

12:13c

and it was restored to full use, just like the other.

- and it was healed/cured and as healthy as his other hand.
- and his hand became completely well again just like the other one.

restored: This word means “brought back to the original good condition.” The man’s hand became completely healthy again.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

healed/cured

well again (NCV)

normal again (GW)

just like the other: The Greek has a word before this phrase that the BSB leaves untranslated because its meaning is similar to “restored.” Some other English translations translate the word, which means “well” or “healthy.” For example:

healthy like the other (ESV)

Matthew 12:14

Section 12:1–14: Jesus is the Lord of the Sabbath

There are two main events in this section. One is about picking grain on the Sabbath. The other is about healing on the Sabbath. These two events show that Jesus has the authority to decide which deeds are acceptable to do on the Sabbath.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus showed that he has authority over Sabbath rules

Lord of the Sabbath (NIV)

The Pharisees criticize Jesus because of what he did on the Sabbath

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 2:23–3:6 and Luke 6:1–11.

12:14

But the Pharisees went out and plotted how they might kill Jesus.

- But the Pharisees left and made plans for ways to kill Jesus.
- Then the Pharisees departed from there and discussed how they might have Jesus killed.

But: There is a contrast between 12:13 and 12:14. The contrast is between what we might expect people to

do after a miracle, and how the Pharisees reacted in 12:14. The BSB indicates this contrast with the conjunction But.

Here are some other ways to translate this in English:

However

Nevertheless

In spite of this

This verse is also the next event in this story. Some versions indicate this rather than the contrast. For example:

Then (GNT)

went out: The Greek word that the BSB translates as went out indicates that the Pharisees left the synagogue.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

left (GNT)

exited

plotted: The verb plotted means “made plans.” In this case, their plans were evil.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

made plans to (GNT)

planned how

met and discussed ways to

Matthew 12:15

Section 12:15–21: Jesus is the Servant whom God chose

About seven hundred years before Jesus was born, God told the prophet Isaiah that the Christ would be kind and gentle and would announce God’s way of saving people and making them righteous (Isaiah 42:1–4). And Jesus fulfilled that prophecy (12:17–21).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

God's Chosen Servant (NIV)

Jesus Is God's Chosen Servant (NCV)

Jesus fulfilled what the prophet Isaiah had said

12:15a

Aware of this, Jesus withdrew from that place.

- ¶ But Jesus knew what they planned to do, so he left that place.
- ¶ Jesus knew what the Pharisees wanted to do, so he went away from there.

The Pharisees secretly made plans to kill Jesus, but they did not kill him at that time. Jesus knew about their plans, and he left that area. In some languages, it may be natural to begin this verse with the conjunction “but.” For example:

But (NLT)

Aware of this, Jesus: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Aware is the word that simply means “knew.” Jesus “knew” that the Pharisees planned to kill him.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

But Jesus knew what they were planning. (NLT)

Jesus knew what the Pharisees were doing (NCV)

withdrew: The Greek word that the BSB translates as withdrew means “went away” or “left.” This word is often used when someone goes away from danger. Jesus withdrew from the Pharisees and their plans to kill him. He did not flee in fear, but rather he went away because it was not yet time for him to die.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

went away (GNT)

left (CEV)

12:15b

Large crowds followed Him, and He healed them all,

- Many people followed him, and he healed all the sick people among them.
- Many people went along with him, and he cured all of them who were sick.

Large crowds followed Him: There is a textual issue here:

1. Some Greek manuscripts have many followed him. For example:

many followed him (RSV) (ESV, NASB, NIV, RSV, NJB, REB)

1. Other Greek manuscripts have many crowds followed him. For example:

many crowds (NRSV) (BSB, GNT, NET, NRSV, CEV, JBP, KJV)

In this case, the particular Greek text that you follow is not that important. What is important is that you should translate this clause in a way that indicates that many people followed Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

many people followed him (NLT)

large crowds followed him (CEV, BSB)

Many crowds followed him (NRSV)

followed: In this context, the verb followed only refers to “went after.” Here this verb does not imply that the people were disciples of Jesus. Use your normal verb for “followed” here.

He healed them all: This clause indicates that Jesus healed everyone among them who was sick. It does not imply that everyone who followed Jesus needed to be healed.

Here are some other ways to make this clear:

He healed all the sick among them (NLT)

he healed all who were sick (NCV)

Matthew 12:16

Section 12:15–21: Jesus is the Servant whom God chose

About seven hundred years before Jesus was born, God told the prophet Isaiah that the Christ would be kind and gentle and would announce God's way of saving people and making them righteous (Isaiah 42:1–4). And Jesus fulfilled that prophecy (12:17–21).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

God's Chosen Servant (NIV)

Jesus Is God's Chosen Servant (NCV)

Jesus fulfilled what the prophet Isaiah had said

12:16

warning them not to make Him known.

- He warned them not to tell others about him.
- But he commanded them not to tell others the things that he had done.
- He told them, "Do not tell anyone about me!"

warning them: The pronoun them probably refers to the people whom Jesus healed. It does not refer to everyone who followed him. In 8:4a and 9:30b, Jesus also commanded people whom he healed not to tell anyone what had happened.

not to make Him known: This phrase refers:

1. generally to spreading the news of his activities. Jesus did not want the people whom he healed to talk about his miracles and so make him famous. He did not want to encourage the Pharisees to try to kill him before it was time.
2. specifically to spreading the news of his identity. The Jews were expecting a Messiah who would deliver them from Rome. They did not yet understand what type of Messiah he really was. Jesus did not want them to spread false information.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

not to tell others about him (GNT)

not to tell anyone what he had done

not to tell who he was (NIV)

In some languages, it may be natural to translate this phrase as direct speech. For example:

"Do not tell anyone about me!"

Matthew 12:17

Section 12:15–21: Jesus is the Servant whom God chose

About seven hundred years before Jesus was born, God told the prophet Isaiah that the Christ would be kind and gentle and would announce God's way of saving people and making them righteous (Isaiah 42:1–4). And Jesus fulfilled that prophecy (12:17–21).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

God's Chosen Servant (NIV)

Jesus Is God's Chosen Servant (NCV)

Jesus fulfilled what the prophet Isaiah had said

12:17

This was to fulfill what was spoken through the prophet Isaiah:

- He did those things in order to make come true what was spoken through the prophet Isaiah:
- He did these things to make happen what God said through the prophet Isaiah:

This was: The word This refers to Jesus' activities in 12:15–16. These activities were that he withdrew from the area where the Pharisees were. He also commanded people not to tell others about him.

Here are some other ways to begin this verse:

He did these things (NCV)

He did this (GNT)

to fulfill: The word fulfill means "to make come true" or "to make happen as it was foretold/prophesied."

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

to make come true (GNT)

to bring about (NCV)

what was spoken through the prophet Isaiah: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as through the prophet Isaiah indicates that the following words did not come from Isaiah himself. They came from God through Isaiah. God spoke the following words to Isa-

iah, and Isaiah then spoke them to the people. Isaiah also wrote them down.

This is a passive clause. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

what was spoken through the prophet Isaiah (NIV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

what God had said through the prophet Isaiah (GNT)

what God spoke to the people through the prophet Isaiah

This same phrase occurs in 8:17a. You should translate it here as you did there.

Matthew 12:18

Section 12:15–21: Jesus is the Servant whom God chose

About seven hundred years before Jesus was born, God told the prophet Isaiah that the Christ would be kind and gentle and would announce God's way of saving people and making them righteous (Isaiah 42:1–4). And Jesus fulfilled that prophecy (12:17–21).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

God's Chosen Servant (NIV)

Jesus Is God's Chosen Servant (NCV)

Jesus fulfilled what the prophet Isaiah had said

12:18a

"Here is My Servant, whom I have chosen,

- "Behold, my servant whom I have chosen, (ESV)
- "This one here is my servant. I chose him,

As mentioned above, God is the one who spoke through Isaiah. In some languages, it will be natural to make this explicit at the beginning of the quote. For example:

God said

Here is My Servant: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Here is literally "Look." This word focuses attention on what follows and indicates that it is important, unexpected, or amazing. In this context, this word introduces the main character of the quote from the Old Testament.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Here is my servant (NIV)

This one is my servant

My Servant: A Servant is someone who works for another person and is submissive to him. God called the Christ (the Messiah) his servant to show that he is humble and submissive to God. The term you use in your translation should include these qualities of humility and submission.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

my humble worker

the one who serves me

the one who does my will

whom I have chosen: This is a relative clause. It further describes the person whom God called his servant. Be careful to translate this clause in a way that does not imply that God has another servant whom he did not choose.

In some languages, it may be more natural to translate this relative clause as a separate sentence. For example:

I have chosen him.

12:18b

My beloved, in whom My soul delights.

- the one I love, and I am very pleased with him.
- I love him, and I am very delighted/happy with him.

My beloved: This phrase means "the person whom I love." It is yet another way to describe the person whom God also called "My Servant" in 12:18a.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

he is the one whom I love

I love him (CEV)

in whom My soul delights: The phrase My soul here refers to one's self. In this case, it refers to God himself.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I am very pleased with him

he pleases me (CEV)

my heart is very glad with him

Some languages have idioms to translate this clause.

12:18c

I will put My Spirit on Him,

- I will give him my Spirit,
- I will send my Spirit to him to help him,

I will put My Spirit on Him: The words put My Spirit on Him refer to giving the servant power. God will cause the Holy Spirit to help the servant to know things and do miracles.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I will give him my Spirit (CEV)

I will send my Spirit to him to do the deeds that I want him to do

12:18d

and He will proclaim justice to the nations.

- and he will announce to all people the message of my right/correct judgment.
- and he will tell all nations that I will judge people fairly/honestly.

He will proclaim: The Greek word that the BSB translates as proclaim means “make known publicly.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

announce (GNT)

declare (JBP)

tell (NCV)

justice: The Greek word that the BSB translates as justice also means “judgment” (as in the GNT). This word

does not only imply punishment. It refers to judging and rewarding those who accept God, and judging and punishing the wicked. God is fair and will act rightly. His judgment is honest and without corruption. For this reason, many English versions translate this word as justice.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

my justice (NCV)

true/right judgment

that my/God's judgment is honest

that I/God will judge honestly

that my government is honest/fair

the nations: There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as nations:

1. It is used in its most wide sense to refer to all people groups, including Jews. Jesus came to proclaim justice to all nations. For example:

all people (NCV) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NJB, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, REB, NCV)

1. It is used in its restricted sense to refer to all people groups except the Jews. When a Jew referred to other people groups, he used this word. In those cases English versions translate it as “Gentiles.” For example:

the Gentiles (RSV) (RSV, NASB, JBP, ESV, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Jesus came to proclaim God's justice to everyone, especially the Jews.

Matthew 12:19

Section 12:15–21: Jesus is the Servant whom God chose

About seven hundred years before Jesus was born, God told the prophet Isaiah that the Christ would be kind and gentle and would announce God's way of saving people and making them righteous (Isaiah 42:1–4). And Jesus fulfilled that prophecy (12:17–21).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

God's Chosen Servant (NIV)

Jesus Is God's Chosen Servant (NCV)

Jesus fulfilled what the prophet Isaiah had said

12:19a

He will not quarrel or cry out;

- He will not argue or shout,
- He will not dispute with people or yell at them.

He will not quarrel: The word quarrel means “argue with some degree of anger.” Jesus certainly disagreed with the Pharisees and used strong words with them. But when they disagreed with him and wanted to kill him, he left them. He did not quarrel with them.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

argue (GNT)

dispute with people

cry out: The Greek word that the BSB translates as cry out means “shout” or “scream.” It means that he will not make a lot of noise. The word cry here in English does not mean “weep.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

shout (GNT)

yell (CEV)

12:19b

no one will hear His voice in the streets.

- and no one will hear his loud voice in the streets.
- He will not draw attention to himself in public.

no one will hear His voice in the streets: This clause is a figure of speech. It means that Jesus will not speak loudly in public simply to attract attention to himself. It refers to the fact that he will be humble and gentle. He will be the opposite of the hypocrites in Matthew 6:5 who pray on the street corners to be seen by men.

It does not mean that he will never speak in public.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

he will not speak with a loud voice in public places

make loud speeches in the streets (GNT)

he will not draw attention to himself in public

in the streets: This phrase means “in public.” In Jesus' time, the streets were loud, noisy places. If the term you normally use for streets is not a busy place, you may need to use a term where lots of people often gather. For example:

in the village center

in the marketplace

in public places

Matthew 12:20

Section 12:15–21: Jesus is the Servant whom God chose

About seven hundred years before Jesus was born, God told the prophet Isaiah that the Christ would be kind and gentle and would announce God's way of saving people and making them righteous (Isaiah 42:1–4). And Jesus fulfilled that prophecy (12:17–21).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

God's Chosen Servant (NIV)

Jesus Is God's Chosen Servant (NCV)

Jesus fulfilled what the prophet Isaiah had said

12:20a

A bruised reed He will not break,

- A damaged reed, he will not break off,
- He will not harm anyone who is weak/hurt like a damaged reed.
- He will be gentle with those who are weak/hurt.

A bruised reed He will not break: This is a metaphor. In this metaphor, a person who is hurt in some way or who is spiritually weak is compared to A bruised reed. (See the explanation of A bruised reed below). Reeds were very common, and normally, people would throw away such a reed. But Jesus is compared to a person that will not break/bend the reed. This means that he will be gentle with such a person and help him. He will not hurt or damage him.

Here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

He will not break off a bent reed (GNT)

He will not break a crushed blade of grass (NCV)

He will not destroy a damaged reed

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

Those who are weak like a bruised reed, he will not harm

Anyone who is hurt like a bruised reed, he will help him

- Translate the meaning of the metaphor. For example:

He will not crush those who are weak (NLT96)

He will be gentle with those who are weak

bruised reed: Reeds are tall grasses that have long, hollow stems which can be easily crushed or broken. A bruised reed would be one that is damaged and almost broken off.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

bent/damaged reed

partially cut/broken piece of grass

12:20b

and a smoldering wick He will not extinguish,

- and a wick about to burn out, he will not extinguish it.
- Anyone who has problems is like a smoldering wick. He will not harm him.
- He will encourage the person who has no hope.

a smoldering wick He will not extinguish: This is a metaphor. The meaning of this metaphor is similar to the meaning of the metaphor in 12:20a. In this metaphor, a person who is hurt in some way or who is spiritually weak is compared to the wick of a lamp. This wick is smoking, but not burning with a bright flame. Normally, people would cut off such a wick and throw it away. But Jesus is compared to a person who will not quench the flame. This means that he will be gentle with such a person and help him. He will not hurt him.

Here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

He will not even put out a smoking wick (GW)

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

A person who has many problems is like a smoldering wick. He will not extinguish it/him.

Anyone who is hurt like a smoldering wick, he will not smother/harm him

- Translate the meaning of the metaphor. For example:

He will be gentle with anyone who is in pain.

He will encourage the person who has no hope.

a smoldering wick: A wick is the part of a lamp which burns. The phrase a smoldering wick refers to a wick which is burning red and smoking but without a flame.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

a smoking wick (GW)

a weak flame (NCV)

not extinguish: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as extinguish refers to putting out a fire/flame.

Here is another way to translate this verb:

quench (ESV)

12:20c

till He leads justice to victory.

- He will do/be like this until he makes justice win over evil.
- He will continue doing so until he causes everyone to receive what he deserves.

till: The servant will continue to be gentle (12:18d-20b) till he leads justice to victory. In some languages, it may be necessary to make some of this explicit. For example:

He will be like that until

He will continue to be gentle until

This does not imply that after he brings justice to victory, he will no longer be gentle.

He leads justice to victory: This is a figure of speech. In this figure of speech, justice is talked about as if it were a person who wins a victory. Justice wins a battle with evil. Jesus is the person who makes this victory possible.

In other words, one day Jesus will establish justice. He will fairly judge and punish people who are evil, and he will fairly judge and reward people who are righteous. In this sense, he will cause justice to be victorious over evil.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Keep the figure of speech. For example:

he will cause justice to be victorious (NLT)

he makes justice win the victory (NCV)

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

he will make sure that justice is done (CEV)

he will be successful in causing everyone to receive what he deserves

until he causes all things to be done justly

Matthew 12:21

Section 12:15–21: Jesus is the Servant whom God chose

About seven hundred years before Jesus was born, God told the prophet Isaiah that the Christ would be kind and gentle and would announce God's way of saving people and making them righteous (Isaiah 42:1–4). And Jesus fulfilled that prophecy (12:17–21).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

God's Chosen Servant (NIV)

Jesus Is God's Chosen Servant (NCV)

Jesus fulfilled what the prophet Isaiah had said

12:21

In His name the nations will put their hope."

- The nations will trust in him."
- All peoples will have confidence in him to do what he promised."

In His name: The name of a person represents the person himself. So the phrase In His name means "in/on him." For example:

in him (CEV)

on him (GNT)

the nations: This is the same word in Greek as the word translated as the nations in 12:18d. So you should translate it in the same way as you did in 12:18d. As there, it is used here in its most wide sense to refer to all people groups, including Jews. So here are some better ways to translate this word:

the nations (NIV)

all peoples (GNT)

will put their hope: The Greek word that the BSB translates as hope is a bit stronger than the modern English word "hope." In Greek it means "trust," "have confidence in" or "expect." (In modern English, the word "hope" means to "wish for something that might be possible.")

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

trust (KJV)

have confidence in

Some languages have an idiom for this word.

In some languages, it is natural to say what the nations hope Jesus will do. If this is true in your language, you can say:

The nations will trust in him to do as he promised

The nations will have confidence in him to save them

Matthew 12:22

Section 12:22–32: Jesus showed that he did not use Satan's power

In this section, Jesus healed a man whom demons had been controlling. The Pharisees said that he did it by the power of Satan. Doing something by the power of Satan is sorcery. Sorcery was punishable by death in the Jewish law. Jesus explained to them why it could not be true that he cast out demons by the power of Satan. He also warned them that they must not look at something he had done by the Holy Spirit's power and say that Satan gave him the power to do it. This is blaspheming the Holy Spirit (12:31).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Pharisees accuse Jesus of working with Satan

Jesus' power is greater than Satan's power

The power of Jesus comes from the Holy Spirit, not from Satan

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 3:22–30 and Luke 11:14–23.

12:22a–b

This new section and paragraph begin with the miracle of Jesus healing a man. Before you translate this verse, consider the most natural way to begin this new section. Here are some possibilities:

- The man is not a major character in this story. He is only present in one verse. What is important is the conversation that resulted from Jesus healing the man. So in some languages, it may be important to change the order of the clauses in 12:22a–b to show what is important. For example:

^b One day Jesus healed a man who could not see or speak. ^aThis man had been brought to Jesus because he was demon-oppressed. ^bWhen Jesus healed him, he was able to both speak and see.

- In some languages, it may be natural to introduce this man using several sentences. For example:

^aThere was a certain man who was demon-oppressed. He was blind and mute. One day people brought him to Jesus, ^band Jesus healed him.

12:22a

Then a demon-possessed man who was blind and mute was brought to Jesus,

- ¶ Then a man was brought to Jesus. This man had a demon in him, and he was blind and mute.
- ¶ After that some people came to Jesus with a certain man. A demon controlled this man. He could not see or talk.

Then: This word indicates that this section took place sometime after the events in the previous section. But it does not mean that this section took place immediately after the previous section.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

After that

One day

a demon-possessed man who was blind and mute:

The Greek word that the BSB translates as demon-possessed man indicates that a demon controlled the man in some way. In this case, the demon caused the man to be blind and mute.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

a man who was blind and could not talk because he had a demon in him (CEV)

a man whom a demon controlled and caused to be blind and mute

There was a man who was demon possessed. He was not able to see or talk.

blind: The word blind means “not able to see.”

mute: The word mute means “not able to talk.” For example:

could not talk (GNT)

was brought to Jesus: This clause is passive.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

was brought to Jesus (NLT)

- Use an active verb. For example:

some people brought to Jesus (GNT)

they came to Jesus with...

12:22b

and He healed the man so that he could speak and see.

- Jesus healed him, and as a result the man was able to talk and see.
- Jesus did a miracle and cast out the demon and healed him. This caused the man to be able to speak and see.

and He healed the man: This clause indicates that Jesus miraculously caused the demon to leave the man. The demon had caused the man to be blind and mute, so when the demon left, the man became able to see and talk.

If people in your area will think that Jesus healed the man but did not cast out the demon, you may want to:

- Explain it in the text. For example:

Jesus healed him by casting out the demon

- Explain it in a footnote. For example:

Jesus healed the man by causing the demon to leave the man so the demon no longer controlled him.

In some languages, it may be necessary to explain that Jesus performed a miracle when he cast out the demon and healed him. For example:

Jesus did a miracle and healed him

Matthew 12:23

Section 12:22–32: Jesus showed that he did not use Satan's power

In this section, Jesus healed a man whom demons had been controlling. The Pharisees said that he did it by the power of Satan. Doing something by the power of Satan is sorcery. Sorcery was punishable by death in the Jewish law. Jesus explained to them why it could not be true that he cast out demons by the power of Satan. He also warned them that they must not look at something he had done by the Holy Spirit's power and say that Satan gave him the power to do it. This is blaspheming the Holy Spirit (12:31).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Pharisees accuse Jesus of working with Satan

Jesus' power is greater than Satan's power

The power of Jesus comes from the Holy Spirit, not from Satan

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 3:22–30 and Luke 11:14–23.

12:23a

The crowds were astounded and asked,

- All the people were very amazed at this and said,
- This miracle astonished everyone. They said to one another,

The crowds were astounded: The Greek word that the BSB here translates as astounded is an idiom. Its literal meaning is “stood outside themselves.” The people were often surprised at Jesus' miracles (as in 9:33b). This idiom indicates that they were even more surprised than normal.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

were astonished (NIV)

were very surprised

In some languages, it may be natural to say what amazed the people. For example:

were very amazed by what Jesus did

This miracle really surprised the people

asked: The people probably spoke the following words to each other and not directly to Jesus. But they probably spoke them publicly because the Pharisees heard them (12:24a).

In some languages, it may be natural to make some of this information explicit. For example:

said to one another

12:23b

“Could this be the Son of David?”

- “Is it possible that this man is the Son/Descendant of David?”
- “Maybe/Perhaps this man is the promised Son/Descendant of King David!”

Could this be the Son of David?: This is a rhetorical question. It expresses surprise and uncertainty. Jesus was not the type of Messiah that the people were expecting. However, he did things that only the Messiah could do. So the people were confused. They were not certain that Jesus of Nazareth was the Messiah, but they were beginning to think that maybe he was. It was a surprising thought.

Here are some other ways to translate this surprise and uncertainty:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Could it be that Jesus is the Son of David, the Messiah? (NLT)

Is it possible that this man is the Son of David?

- As a statement. For example:

Perhaps this man is the Son of David! (NCV)

this: The word this refers to Jesus. Some languages may need a noun to go with the word this. For example:

this man (GW)

the Son of David: This phrase is a title that the Jews used to refer to the Messiah. God had promised that the Messiah would be a descendant of David (Isaiah 9:6–7, 11:1–5, Jeremiah 23:5). In some languages, it may be necessary to make this information explicit. For example:

the Descendant of King David

the promised Son/Descendant of King David

In some languages, it may be helpful to add a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

God promised that one of King David’s descendants would be the Messiah (Isaiah 9:6–7, 11:1–5, Jeremiah 23:5). The Jews were expecting this

promised person to come, and they referred to him by the title “Son of David.”

This phrase also occurs in 9:27b. You should translate it here as you did there.

Matthew 12:24

Section 12:22–32: Jesus showed that he did not use Satan’s power

In this section, Jesus healed a man whom demons had been controlling. The Pharisees said that he did it by the power of Satan. Doing something by the power of Satan is sorcery. Sorcery was punishable by death in the Jewish law. Jesus explained to them why it could not be true that he cast out demons by the power of Satan. He also warned them that they must not look at something he had done by the Holy Spirit’s power and say that Satan gave him the power to do it. This is blaspheming the Holy Spirit (12:31).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Pharisees accuse Jesus of working with Satan

Jesus’ power is greater than Satan’s power

The power of Jesus comes from the Holy Spirit, not from Satan

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 3:22–30 and Luke 11:14–23.

12:24a

But when the Pharisees heard this, they said,

- But when the Pharisees heard those words, they said,
- But when the Pharisees heard what the people were saying, they said,

But: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between what the people were starting to believe about Jesus (in 12:23b), and what the Pharisees believed about him. The BSB indicates this contrast with the conjunction But.

Here is another way to introduce this contrast in English:

However

when the Pharisees heard this: The word *this* refers to what the people were saying/asking about Jesus (12:23b).

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

when the Pharisees heard that

when the Pharisees heard those words

when the Pharisees heard what the people were saying

they said: The words that the Pharisees said in 12:24b were not said directly to Jesus, because 12:25a says that Jesus knew their thoughts. They probably spoke the following words to each other and to some of those who were wondering if Jesus might be the Messiah. If it is natural in your language to say who was spoken to, use a phrase that does not include Jesus. For example:

said to each other (JBP)

they said among themselves

12:24b

“Only by Beelzebul, the prince of demons, does this man drive out demons.”

- “The only reason that this fellow is able to cast demons out of people is because Beelzebul, the ruler of demons, gave him the power to do it.”
- “This person has received power from Satan, the chief of evil spirits. That is why he is able to make evil spirits leave people.”

Only by Beelzebul, the prince of demons, does this man drive out demons: In this clause, the Pharisees accused Jesus of using the power of Beelzebul (Satan) to cast demons out of people. This was a charge of sorcery.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

He forces out demons by the power of Beelzebul, the ruler of the demons (CEV)

Jesus uses the power of Beelzebul, the ruler of demons, to force demons out of people (NCV)

Beelzebul, the prince of demons, gives him power. That is why he is able to cast out demons.

Beelzebul: This word refers to Satan. The Jews sometimes used this name instead of Satan to refer to the devil.

There is a spelling issue here. Some English versions spell this word “Beelzebul” (as in the BSB). Other English versions spell this word “Beelzebub” (as in the NIV). You should follow the spelling of the major language version in your area.

If people in your area will not understand that Beelzebul refers to Satan, you may want to:

- Include a footnote explaining Beelzebul. Here is a sample footnote:

Beelzebul is a name that the Jews sometimes used for Satan.

- Use the name “Satan” rather than Beelzebul. For example:

No wonder he can cast out demons. He gets his power from Satan, the prince of demons. (NLT)

prince: The Greek word that the BSB translates as prince also has a general sense that means “ruler.” The English term “prince” often implies a “secondary ruler under a king.” But in this context the Greek word refers generally to any ruler.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

ruler (GNT)

chief

demons: The Greek word that the BSB translates as demons refers to the same type of spirits as the Greek words that are often translated as “evil spirits” or “unclean spirits.” These evil spirits can control peoples’ actions and can make them sick.

Here are some other ways to translate demons:

- Use a word in your language that refers to a spirit that is evil and can control people. Do not use a word that refers to the spirit of a dead person.
- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

evil/bad spirits

spirits that do evil

spirits that oppose God

See also demon in the Glossary for more information.

this man: The Greek text is literally “this (one).” It is likely the Pharisees said “this one” to show that they despised Jesus. You may want to translate this phrase with a term that shows that they disliked or despised Jesus. For example:

this fellow

Matthew 12:25

Section 12:22–32: Jesus showed that he did not use Satan’s power

In this section, Jesus healed a man whom demons had been controlling. The Pharisees said that he did it by the power of Satan. Doing something by the power of Satan is sorcery. Sorcery was punishable by death in the Jewish law. Jesus explained to them why it could not be true that he cast out demons by the power of Satan. He also warned them that they must not look at something he had done by the Holy Spirit’s power and say that Satan gave him the power to do it. This is blaspheming the Holy Spirit (12:31).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

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The power of Jesus comes from the Holy Spirit, not from Satan

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 3:22–30 and Luke 11:14–23.

12:25a

Knowing their thoughts, Jesus said to them,

- ¶ Jesus knew what they were thinking, so/and he said to them,
- ¶ Because Jesus knew what the Pharisees were thinking, he told them,

Knowing their thoughts: Jesus supernaturally knew what the Pharisees were thinking. Your translation should not imply that someone told Jesus what they were thinking.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus knew what they were thinking (GNT)

Jesus knew what the Pharisees were thinking (NCV)

Jesus said to them: It is implied that the reason Jesus said the words of 12:25–32 was because he knew what the Pharisees were thinking. In some languages, it may be natural to make the connection more explicit. For example:

Since Jesus knew what they were thinking, he said to them (GW)

so he said (NCV)

12:25b

“Every kingdom divided against itself will be laid waste,

- “Every country whose people fight against one another will destroy itself.
- “If the people of a country fight one another, they will destroy/ruin their country.

Every kingdom divided against itself: This clause describes a civil war. It refers to any nation/country where the people within that country divide into groups and fight one another.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Any kingdom divided by civil war (NLT)

Any country that divides itself into groups which fight each other (GNT)

Any kingdom where people fight each other (CEV)

will be laid waste: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as will be laid waste means “will be destroyed” or “will be ruined.” The two sides killing each other would cause the country to be destroyed/ruined. It is implied that few people will remain alive in that country.

The clause is passive. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

will be ruined (NIV)

will be destroyed (NCV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

If the people of a certain country fight against one another, they will destroy their country

12:25c

and every city or household divided against itself will not stand.

- Also, no town or family whose people fight against one another will remain/continue.
- Any town or family whose people fight each other will destroy/ruin itself.
- A city whose people fight against one another will be destroyed. A family whose members argue with one another will not stay together.

Verse 12:25c teaches the same principle as 12:25b.

and every city or household: The Greek word that the BSB literally translates as household is a figure of speech. It refers to the people in the house.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

house (ESV)

family (GNT)

divided against itself will not stand: The Greek verb that the BSB literally translates as stand is a figure of speech. It refers to remaining or existing.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

will not last (GW)

will fall apart (NLT)

In some languages, it may be necessary to use a different verb to describe the destruction of a city and a family. For example:

A city whose people fight against one another will be destroyed. A family whose members argue with one another will not stay together.

Matthew 12:26

Section 12:22–32: Jesus showed that he did not use Satan's power

In this section, Jesus healed a man whom demons had been controlling. The Pharisees said that he did it by the power of Satan. Doing something by the power of Satan is sorcery. Sorcery was punishable by death in the Jewish law. Jesus explained to them why it could not be true that he cast out demons by the power of Satan. He also warned them that they must not look at something he had done by the Holy Spirit's power and say that Satan gave him the power to do it. This is blaspheming the Holy Spirit (12:31).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Pharisees accuse Jesus of working with Satan

Jesus' power is greater than Satan's power

The power of Jesus comes from the Holy Spirit, not from Satan

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 3:22–30 and Luke 11:14–23.

12:26a

If Satan drives out Satan, he is divided against himself.

- If Satan expels his own demons, he is fighting against himself.
- If Satan forces one of his own demons out of a person, then his kingdom is divided and is fighting against itself.

If Satan drives out Satan: Notice that the word Satan occurs two times. Scholars agree that in the second occurrence of Satan, the word Satan is used to represent one or more of the demons over which he rules. There are two ways to interpret the first occurrence of Satan:

1. It is literal and refers to Satan himself. According to this interpretation, Jesus was saying that "if Satan casts out one of his own demons...." In this sense, Satan casts out Satan. So 12:26a is another example (like a kingdom, city, or house) of something that cannot stand if it is divided against itself. The application of these examples begins in 12:27. Here is an example of this interpretation:

if Satan forces out himself (NCV) (BSB, NCV, CEV)

1. It is figurative and represents one or more of Satan's demons. According to this interpretation, the first occurrence of Satan has the same meaning as the second occurrence of Satan. Jesus was saying that "if one group in Satan's kingdom fights against another group..." So, in 12:26a Jesus began to apply the principle that something divided against itself cannot stand. For example:

So if one group is fighting another in Satan's kingdom (GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It is better to consider 12:26a as another example parallel with the examples of a kingdom, city, and house. Most English versions are literal and it is not possible to tell which interpretation they follow.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

if Satan forces out himself (NCV)

if Satan casts out one of his evil spirits

if the prince of evil spirits expels his own evil spirits

he is divided against himself: The phrase divided against himself has the same meaning as the phrase "divided against itself" in the examples above (12:25b-c).

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he is fighting against himself (NLT96)

he is divided and fighting against himself (NLT)

his kingdom is divided and fighting against itself

12:26b

How then can his kingdom stand?

- Will his kingdom remain? Of course not!
- Then his kingdom will certainly be ruined/destroyed.

How then can his kingdom stand?: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus used this rhetorical question to emphasize that Satan's kingdom would certainly fall if it were divided.

Here are some other ways to translate this emphasis:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

How will his kingdom stand? It will not.

Would his kingdom continue? Of course not!

- As a statement. For example:

His kingdom would certainly not stand/remain.

His own kingdom will not survive. (NLT)

Translate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

Matthew 12:27

Section 12:22-32: Jesus showed that he did not use Satan's power

In this section, Jesus healed a man whom demons had been controlling. The Pharisees said that he did it by the power of Satan. Doing something by the power of Satan is sorcery. Sorcery was punishable by death in the Jewish law. Jesus explained to them why it could not be true that he cast out demons by the power of Satan. He also warned them that they must not look at something he had done by the Holy Spirit's power and say that Satan gave him the power to do it. This is blaspheming the Holy Spirit (12:31).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Pharisees accuse Jesus of working with Satan

Jesus' power is greater than Satan's power

The power of Jesus comes from the Holy Spirit, not from Satan

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 3:22-30 and Luke 11:14-23.

12:27a

And if I drive out demons by Beelzebul,

- If I cast out demons by/using the power of Beelzebul/Satan,
- If it were true that Satan gives me the power to expel evil spirits from people,
- You say that I use the power of Beelzebul to force out demons. If that is true, (NCV)

And if I drive out demons by Beelzebul: The Pharisees were saying that Jesus was driving out demons by the power of Beelzebul/Satan. That was not true.

Jesus did not cast out demons by the power of Satan. However, Jesus said this clause as if it were true for the sake of his argument. It is hypothetical.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Indicate in the text that this clause is hypothetical. For example:

If it were true that I expel demons from people by Satan's power

You say that I use the power of Beelzebul to force out demons. If that is true, (NCV)

- Explain it in a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

Jesus did not drive out demons by the power of Satan. Jesus asked this "if" question to show that the Pharisees' thinking was wrong.

12:27b

by whom do your sons drive them out?

- then by/using whose power do your^(plur) disciples cast out demons?
- then who gives your followers the power to expel them?
- your^(plur) people also use his/Satan's power to force demons out of people.

Verse 12:27b is based on the common knowledge that some of the followers of the Pharisees also drove out demons.

by whom do your sons drive them out?: This is a rhetorical question. It expresses a rebuke. The Pharisees believed that their own followers cast out demons by the power of God. When they said that Jesus cast out demons by the power of Satan, they were actually condemning their own followers. So Jesus implied that the Pharisees could not claim that he cast out demons by the power of Satan. They were wrong to make such a statement, and he rebuked them for it.

Here are some other ways to translate this rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

your people drive them out with whose power?

who gives your people the power to cast them out? Is it Satan?

- As a statement. For example:

then your people must do likewise!

Translate this rebuke in a way that is natural in your language.

by whom: This phrase asks "who gave the authority/power to do (something)."

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in whose name

by/using whose power/authority

who gives your followers the power

your sons: In this context, the Greek word that the BSB translates as sons is a Jewish idiom that means "followers." Not all followers of the Pharisees were driving out demons. Probably only a few had the power to do this special work.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

your followers (GNT)

your people (NCV)

12:27c

So then, they will be your judges.

- So, they will show that you are wrong.
- So, their work confirms/shows that what you have said about me is not true.

So then: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as So then introduces the conclusion to Jesus' statements in 12:25–27b.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Therefore (ESV)

so (NLT)

For that reason

they will be your judges: The pronoun they refers to the followers of the Pharisees. The word judges refers to "people who show/say that others are wrong." When the followers of the Pharisees cast out demons,

it showed that God was at work, not Satan. Jesus did the same things. So their actions showed that what the Pharisees said about Jesus was wrong.

Here, this clause does not refer to the final judgment. It does not refer to a court that decides the guilt or innocence of a person. It does not mean that the followers of the Pharisees will sit in judgment of the Pharisees. It means that their actions show that what the Pharisees said about Jesus was not true.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

What your own followers do proves that you are wrong (GNT)

their work shows that what you said about me is wrong

they will condemn you for what you have said (NLT)

they will say that what you said is not the truth

Matthew 12:28

Section 12:22–32: Jesus showed that he did not use Satan's power

In this section, Jesus healed a man whom demons had been controlling. The Pharisees said that he did it by the power of Satan. Doing something by the power of Satan is sorcery. Sorcery was punishable by death in the Jewish law. Jesus explained to them why it could not be true that he cast out demons by the power of Satan. He also warned them that they must not look at something he had done by the Holy Spirit's power and say that Satan gave him the power to do it. This is blaspheming the Holy Spirit (12:31).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Pharisees accuse Jesus of working with Satan

Jesus' power is greater than Satan's power

The power of Jesus comes from the Holy Spirit, not from Satan

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 3:22–30 and Luke 11:14–23.

12:28a

But if I drive out demons by the Spirit of God,

- But, if/since I cast out evil spirits by/using the power of God's Spirit,
- But it is the Spirit of God who gives me the power to cast out demons. This shows/proves that

But: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between what the Pharisees were wrongly saying about Jesus (in 12:27a) and what is the truth (12:28a). The BSB shows this contrast with the conjunction But.

if I drive out demons by the Spirit of God: This clause is parallel to the clause in 12:27a.

^{27a}if I drive out demons by Beelzebul

^{28a}if it is by the Spirit of God that I drive out demons

Jesus proved his point by using an if-clause in both 12:27a (which is false), and here in 12:28a (which is true). Some languages do not use if-clauses to prove a point that is true. If that is true in your language, you may have to translate this as:

because it is by the Spirit of God that I cast out demons

when I force out demons by the power of God's Spirit (CEV)

No, it is not Beelzebul, but God's Spirit, who gives me the power to drive out demons, which proves that (GNT)

the Spirit of God: This phrase refers to the Holy Spirit. Use the same word for Spirit when translating the Spirit of God as when you translate "Holy Spirit."

12:28b

then the kingdom of God has come upon you.

- then God's kingdom has already come/arrived among you^(plur).
- God has started to rule among you^(plur).

the kingdom of God: This phrase refers to God's activity of ruling and caring for his people as their king. It also refers to the relationship that God has with his people. He leads, protects, and cares for them. They obey, trust, and submit to him as their king. The phrase the kingdom of God does not refer to a land or country that he rules over.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- As a noun. For example:

the kingdom of God

God's kingship

God's rule over people

- As a verbal expression. For example:

the way that God rules his people

the way that God cares for his people as king

See how you translated "kingdom of God" in 6:33a. See also kingdom of heaven in the Glossary for more information.

has come upon you: This phrase means that God had already begun to rule among the people to whom Jesus was speaking. God was exercising his authority and power through Jesus. This is why Jesus was able to cast demons out of people.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

has begun among you

has arrived among you (NLT)

God has begun to rule among you

Matthew 12:29

Section 12:22–32: Jesus showed that he did not use Satan's power

In this section, Jesus healed a man whom demons had been controlling. The Pharisees said that he did it by the power of Satan. Doing something by the power of Satan is sorcery. Sorcery was punishable by death in the Jewish law. Jesus explained to them why it could not be true that he cast out demons by the power of Satan. He also warned them that they must not look at something he had done by the Holy Spirit's power and say that Satan gave him the power to do it. This is blaspheming the Holy Spirit (12:31).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Pharisees accuse Jesus of working with Satan

Jesus' power is greater than Satan's power

The power of Jesus comes from the Holy Spirit, not from Satan

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 3:22–30 and Luke 11:14–23.

12:29

Verse 12:29 is a parable. In this parable, the "strong man" represents Satan. The strong man's "house" represents Satan's kingdom. "His possessions" represent people whom Satan controls. Jesus is the one who is stronger than Satan. He binds Satan and takes those people out of Satan's kingdom.

Jesus told this parable to show people that he was working against Satan. Satan was not the one who was giving him power to cast out evil spirits.

In some languages, it may be good to explain the meaning of this parable in a footnote. A sample footnote is:

In this parable, Satan is the strong man. The strong man's house is Satan's kingdom. The possessions of the strong man are those people whom Satan controls. Jesus is the one who breaks into Satan's kingdom and takes away or frees the people whom he controls.

12:29a–c

Or again, how can anyone enter a strong man's house and steal his possessions, unless he first ties up the strong man?:

This is a rhetorical question. Jesus used this rhetorical question to emphasize that no one can enter a strong man's house and carry off his possessions unless he first ties up the strong man.

Here are some other ways to translate this emphasis:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

How can anyone break into a strong man's house and steal his things, unless he first ties up the strong man? (CEV)

- As a rhetorical question followed by a statement. For example:

How can anyone go into a strong man's house and steal his property? First he must tie up the strong

man. Then he can go through his house and steal his property. (GW)

- As a statement. For example:

No one can break into a strong man's house and take away his belongings unless he first ties up the strong man.... (GNT)

If anyone wants to enter a strong person's house and steal his things, he must first tie up the strong person. Then he can steal the things from the house. (NCV)

Translate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

12:29a

Or again, how can anyone enter a strong man's house

- Similarly, how can anyone enter a strong man's house
- Or to say it another way, no one can break into the house of a strong man like Satan

Or again: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Or again indicates that this parable is another way of looking at the point of 12:28. That point is that Jesus is not working with Satan. He is working against Satan.

You may want to use a conjunction that shows that 12:29 is connected in thought with 12:28. Here are some examples:

Similarly

Or to say it another way,

how can anyone enter a strong man's house: The phrase strong man's house refers to the house of a man who is physically strong. In this parable, the strong man represents Satan. The strong man's house represents Satan's kingdom. In some languages, it may be necessary to make some of this information explicit. For example:

who is powerful enough to enter the house of a strong man like Satan (NLT)

Satan can be compared to a strong person. No one can enter his house...

This parable assumes that the strong man is home and guarding his possessions. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this more explicit. For example:

enter a strong man's house when he is home

enter: In some languages, it may be better to use a stronger word or phrase than the word enter. For example:

break into (GNT)

break and enter

12:29b

and steal his possessions,

- and steal his possessions?
- and take his things

steal: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as steal means "forcefully take away" or "rob." In this context, it refers to taking the strong man's possessions against his will.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

plunder (ESV)

rob (NLT96)

In some languages, a verb like steal will hinder people from understanding that the point of the parable is that Jesus is stronger than Satan. The point is not that Jesus is bad like a robber and steals things. So in some languages, it may be better to use a different type of verb here. For example:

take away (GNT)

carry away/off

his possessions: The Greek word that the BSB translates as possessions also means "property." These things are the man's belongings. They are the things he has in his house. In this parable, this word represents the people whom Satan owns or controls.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

his property (GW)

his belongings (GNT)

his possessions (NIV)

12:29c

unless he first ties up the strong man?

- He must first tie up the strong man.
- if he does not first overpower the strong man and tie him with a rope.

unless he first ties up the strong man: The phrase ties up means “binds.” In some languages, it may be necessary to include a previous action. For example:

if he does not first overpower the strong man and tie him up

General Comment on 12:29a–c

In some language, it may be more natural to change the order of the clauses so that they are in chronological order. For example:

Or again, ‘only if someone first ties up a strong man ^acan he then enter the strong man’s house ^band carry off his possessions.

12:29d

Then he can plunder his house.

- Then he can steal everything in the strong man’s house.
- Then he can take everything that is in the strong man’s house.

Then he can plunder his house: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as plunder is a stronger form of the same Greek verb in 12:29b. The same action is meant here as in 12:29b, but the manner of “thoroughly” is included here. You may use the same verb for “plunder” in 12:29b and here in 12:29d, but you may want to use an extra word to show the completeness of the action. For example:

Then he can thoroughly plunder the house. (NET)

Then he can completely rob his house

Then he can take everything (CEV)

Then he could seize all the strong man’s things

Matthew 12:30

Section 12:22–32: Jesus showed that he did not use Satan’s power

In this section, Jesus healed a man whom demons had been controlling. The Pharisees said that he did it by the power of Satan. Doing something by the power of Satan is sorcery. Sorcery was punishable by death in the Jewish law. Jesus explained to them why it could not be true that he cast out demons by the power of Satan. He also warned them that they must not look at something he had done by the Holy Spirit’s power and say that Satan gave him the power to do it. This is blaspheming the Holy Spirit (12:31).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Pharisees accuse Jesus of working with Satan

Jesus’ power is greater than Satan’s power

The power of Jesus comes from the Holy Spirit, not from Satan

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 3:22–30 and Luke 11:14–23.

12:30a

He who is not with Me is against Me,

- ¶ The person who does not join/stand with me is against me.
- ¶ Anyone who is not on my side is against me.

He who is not with Me is against Me: The phrase is not with Me means “is not on my side,” “does not support me,” or “is not my friend/ally.”

This clause indicates that there are two sides in the spiritual conflict: Jesus’ side and Satan’s side. There is no middle or neutral position.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Anyone who is not helping/supporting me opposes me

If you are not on my side, you are against me (CEV)

The person who does not join with me is against me.

The person who does not work with me works against me

12:30b

and he who does not gather with Me scatters.

- The person who does not gather in the harvest with me, he scatters it.
- Anyone who does not gather people into God's kingdom with me scatters them.

and he who does not gather with Me scatters: This clause is a figure of speech. This figure of speech means the same thing as 12:30a: anyone who is not helping Jesus in his work is opposing him.

Jesus did not say what he was gathering. Many scholars think he was comparing himself to a shepherd gathering sheep. Other scholars think he was comparing himself to a farmer gathering crops. In either case, he was comparing his action of gathering people into God's kingdom to a human action.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Use the specific example of sheep. For example:

He who does not help me gather my sheep is scattering them.

- Use the specific example of crops. For example:

If you don't gather in the harvest with me, you scatter it. (CEV)

- Use a more generic word for gather. For example:

anyone who isn't working with me is actually working against me (NLT)

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. Here this means that if someone is not calling people to come to God, like Jesus is, he is actually pushing people away from God. For example:

He who does not help me bring people to God scatters them so that they go away from God.

Translate this figure of speech in a way that is most natural in your language.

Matthew 12:31

Section 12:22–32: Jesus showed that he did not use Satan's power

In this section, Jesus healed a man whom demons had been controlling. The Pharisees said that he did it by the power of Satan. Doing something by the power of Satan is sorcery. Sorcery was punishable by death in the Jewish law. Jesus explained to them why it could not be true that he cast out demons by the power of Satan. He also warned them that they must not look at something he had done by the Holy Spirit's power and say that Satan gave him the power to do it. This is blaspheming the Holy Spirit (12:31).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Pharisees accuse Jesus of working with Satan

Jesus' power is greater than Satan's power

The power of Jesus comes from the Holy Spirit, not from Satan

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 3:22–30 and Luke 11:14–23.

12:31a

Therefore I tell you, every sin and blasphemy will be forgiven men,

- So, I say to you that every sin and every evil talk against others can be forgiven,
- For that reason I say to you, God can forgive people for every sin and slander/insult that they do.

Therefore: Verse 12:31 is the conclusion of the things that Jesus said in 12:25–30. The Greek introduces this conclusion with a phrase that the BSB translates as Therefore.

Here are some other ways to introduce this conclusion:

In conclusion

For this reason (GNT)

So (REB)

I tell you: The words I tell you emphasize the words that follow.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Use a phrase before Jesus' statement. For example:

I say to you

- Include an emphatic word or phrase such as "certainly" within the following statement. For example:

every sin and blasphemy will certainly be forgiven people

every sin and blasphemy: The noun sin is a general term. The noun blasphemy refers to one particular type of sin. It means to "intentionally say something that greatly harms a person's reputation." It includes serious slander and insults. Some languages have idioms for blasphemy.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

every sin including insults

every sin and every slander (REB)

all abusive/evil talk and other sins

In some languages, it may be natural to translate one or both of these nouns as verbs. For example:

any sin and any evil thing they say (GNT)

if a person sins or slanders/insults another person

The word blasphemy sometimes refers to speaking evil of God. Here in 12:31a, it is probably more general. It does not refer to speaking evil of God. God will forgive blasphemy against other people. But blasphemy against the Holy Spirit (in 12:31b), God will not forgive.

will be forgiven men: The form of the Greek verb that the BSB translates as will be forgiven often refers to an event in the future. However, this part of the verse is not a promise that God will forgive every sin. Rather it means that it is possible that God will forgive every sin. In particular, he will forgive those who repent.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

any sinful thing you do or say can be forgiven (CEV)

it is possible for God to forgive any sin or insult

This clause is passive. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive clause. For example:

every sin and blasphemy that people do will/can be forgiven

- Use an active clause. For example:

God can forgive people

12:31b

but the blasphemy against the Spirit will not be forgiven.

- but people who speak evil against the Holy Spirit will not be forgiven.
- But God will not forgive those who slander/insult the Holy Spirit.

but: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between the type of blasphemy that will be forgiven (12:31a) and the type of blasphemy that will not be forgiven. The BSB indicates this contrast with the conjunction but.

the blasphemy against the Spirit will not be forgiven: The phrase the blasphemy against the Spirit refers to slandering the Holy Spirit. In this context, it refers to what the Pharisees did. They said that Jesus' power to cast out evil spirits came from Satan. They did not accept that his power came from God or the Holy Spirit. This was slandering/insulting the Holy Spirit.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

those who slander/insult the Spirit will not be forgiven

God will not forgive people who talk evil like this against the Holy Spirit

Matthew 12:32

Section 12:22–32: Jesus showed that he did not use Satan's power

In this section, Jesus healed a man whom demons had been controlling. The Pharisees said that he did it by the power of Satan. Doing something by the power of Satan is sorcery. Sorcery was punishable by death in the Jewish law. Jesus explained to them why it could not be true that he cast out demons by the power of Satan. He also warned them that they must not look

at something he had done by the Holy Spirit's power and say that Satan gave him the power to do it. This is blaspheming the Holy Spirit (12:31).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Pharisees accuse Jesus of working with Satan

Jesus' power is greater than Satan's power

The power of Jesus comes from the Holy Spirit, not from Satan

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 3:22–30 and Luke 11:14–23.

12:32a

Whoever speaks a word against the Son of Man will be forgiven,

- And, anyone who speaks evil against the Son of Man can be forgiven,
- God can forgive the people who slander/insult me, the Son of Man.

12:32b

but whoever speaks against the Holy Spirit will not be forgiven,

- but anyone who speaks evil of the Holy Spirit will not be forgiven,
- But God will not forgive those who slander/insult the Holy Spirit.

12:32a–b

Whoever speaks a word against: The phrase speaks a word against means “speaks an evil word against” or simply “speaks against.” It is similar in meaning to the term “blasphemy” in 12:31a.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Anyone who says something against (GNT)

anyone who slanders/insults

those who speaks evil of

the Son of Man: Here Jesus refers to himself as the Son of Man. In some languages, it may be necessary to add the pronoun “I” to make it clear that Jesus was referring to himself. For example:

I, the Son of Man

This phrase also occurs in 12:8. You should translate it here as you did there. For help in translating this phrase, see the note under 8:20b.

will be forgiven: As in 12:31a, the form of the Greek verb that the BSB translates as will be forgiven often refers to an event in the future. However, this part of the verse is not a promise that God will forgive every sin. Rather it means that it is possible that God will forgive every sin. In particular, he will forgive those who repent.

This clause is passive. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive clause. For example:

whoever...can be forgiven

- Use an active clause. For example:

God can forgive people

12:32c

either in this age or in the one to come.

- either in this life/world or in the life/world to come.”
- He will not forgive them now. He will not forgive them later.”

either in this age or in the one to come: This phrase is a Jewish expression. In this context it means “never ever.”

The Jews believed in two ages:

1. this age which refers to the time of living in the present evil world, and
2. the one to come which refers to the future wonderful time of living in heaven.

Together these two phrases emphasized the fact that God would never forgive someone who spoke against the Holy Spirit.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

- Use a similar expression. For example:

either in this life or in the life to come (CEV)

either in this world or in the next (NJB)

- Translate the meaning more directly. For example:

now or ever (GNT)

now or in the future (NCV)

never

Matthew 12:33

Section 12:33–37: Your words show whether you are good or bad

In this section, Jesus continued to respond to the Pharisees' accusation that he cast out evil spirits by the power of Satan. First, he said that the Pharisees needed to be consistent in their beliefs about him. Then he warned them that God would judge them for the words that they said.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

A tree is known by its fruit

A tree and its fruit

People know you by your words (NCV)

Paragraph 12:33–37

This paragraph begins a new section. In this paragraph Jesus continued speaking. In some languages, it may be natural to make it explicit that Jesus continued speaking. For example:

Jesus continued and said,

12:33a

Make a tree good and its fruit will be good,

- ¶ “Either consider the tree good and its fruit good, (Common English Bible)
- ¶ “Either call the tree good and its fruit good, (The Simplified English Bible)
- ¶ Then Jesus said, “You must have the same opinion/ thinking of both a tree and its fruit. You must decide whether the tree and its fruit are good,

12:33a–b

Make a tree good and its fruit will be good, or make a tree bad and its fruit will be bad: This is a metaphor. There are many ways to interpret this metaphor. Here are some of the main interpretations:

1. Jesus compared himself to a tree. According to this interpretation, the verb make has the sense of a mental process of thinking, considering, judging, or believing. Also, the verb make is the implied verb in the phrase “make its fruit good.” Jesus told the

Pharisees that they needed to be consistent in their beliefs about him (the tree) and his healings (fruit). They needed to consider both him and his works to be either good or bad. They could not say that his healings were good, then turn around and say that he himself was bad. While Jesus was talking primarily to the Pharisees, he was perhaps also addressing the people in the crowd who were there listening. He was perhaps also telling them that they needed to be consistent in their beliefs about their religious leaders. These leaders could not be good when they were saying evil things. Here are some ways to translate this verse according to this interpretation: One commentator who holds this view is Turner. On page 324 he says, “Jesus demands that the Pharisees be consistent. They must either view Jesus (the tree) and its fruit (his words and deeds) as worthless or view them as good (12:33).”

Make the tree and its fruit good, or make the tree and its fruit bad.

Either call the tree good and its fruit good, or call the tree bad and its fruit bad. (The Simplified English Bible)

1. Jesus compared the Pharisees to a tree. According to this interpretation, the verb make has the sense of change/repent. Also, the full form of the second clause would be “and then its fruit will be good.” Jesus told the Pharisees that they needed to repent. They needed to change themselves. That would be like making a tree good. Then their works (fruit) would also be good. Here are some ways to translate this verse according to this interpretation: One commentator who holds this view is Bruner. On page 570 he says, “This is a call to conversion. Jesus is saying, ‘Stop playing around: either get converted (“make the tree good”) or get out (“make the tree bad”)!’”

Make a tree good, and then its fruit will be good (GW)

Make yourselves, the tree, good, then your deeds, the fruit will also be good

1. Jesus compared people to two types of trees: a good tree and a bad tree. According to this interpretation, Jesus used this metaphor in the same way as he used similar metaphors in other places where he talked about a tree and its fruit. He was saying that

both he and his deeds are good, and the Pharisees are bad. Here are some ways to translate this verse according to this interpretation: One commentator who holds this view is France. On page 485 he says, “The point of the proverb is the same as in 7:16–20: a person’s true nature is perceived by how they behave.”

If you make a tree good, its fruit will also be good.

If a tree is good, its fruit will be good. (NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Among the main interpretations, this one fits best with the grammar and context of Matthew. Most English versions translate this verse quite literally. Even though they may appear to follow interpretation (1), it is not certain. If possible, you should translate this verse in a general way so that any of the above interpretations are possible.

Here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

make the tree good, and its fruit good; or make the tree bad, and its fruit bad (RSV)

Make the tree and its fruit good, or make the tree and its fruit bad.

- Translate the meaning of the verb make. For example:

Either call the tree good and its fruit good, or call the tree rotten and its fruit rotten. (The Simple English Bible)

Either consider the tree good and its fruit good, or consider the tree rotten and its fruit rotten. (Common English Bible)

You must make your opinion of a tree and of its fruit the same. If you regard a tree as good, then you must also regard its fruit as good. If you regard a tree as bad, then you must also regard its fruit as bad.

- Make the topic of the metaphor explicit. For example:

You must decide whether I, the tree, and my deeds, the fruit, are good, or whether I and my deeds are bad.

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

You must have the same opinion of both me and my deeds. Decide whether I and my deeds are good, or whether they are bad.

12:33b

or make a tree bad and its fruit will be bad;

- or consider the tree rotten and its fruit rotten. (Common English Bible)
- or call the tree bad and its fruit bad. (The Simplified English Bible)
- or whether a tree and its fruit are bad.

make a tree bad and its fruit will be bad: The Greek word that the BSB translates as bad is literally “rotten, unusable, unwholesome.” If possible, you should use an adjective that can be used to refer to both a bad tree and bad fruit. For example:

rotten

not good

In some languages, it may be necessary to use a different adjective to describe a tree and its fruit. For example:

bad tree and fruit that is not good/sweet

12:33c

for a tree is known by its fruit.

- A tree can be recognized because of its fruit.
- The fruit of a tree shows what type of tree it is.
- People know a tree by its fruit.

for: Verse 12:33c is the basis for the command in 12:33a–b. The Greek introduces this basis with a conjunction that the BSB translates as for.

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, a conjunction will not be necessary here either.

In some languages, it may be more natural to put the basis before the command. For example:

^cA tree is known by its fruit, ^aso make a tree and its fruit good, ^bor make a tree and its fruit bad.

a tree is known by its fruit: The verb is known refers to looking at the fruit and easily knowing the kind of tree it is.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

is recognized (NIV)

is shown

is distinguished

This clause is passive. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

a tree is recognized by its fruit (NIV)

a tree is known because of its fruit

- Use an active verb. For example:

people know/recognize a tree by its fruit

The fruit of a tree shows what kind of tree it is.

Matthew 12:34

Section 12:33–37: Your words show whether you are good or bad

In this section, Jesus continued to respond to the Pharisees' accusation that he cast out evil spirits by the power of Satan. First, he said that the Pharisees needed to be consistent in their beliefs about him. Then he warned them that God would judge them for the words that they said.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

A tree is known by its fruit

A tree and its fruit

People know you by your words (NCV)

Paragraph 12:33–37

This paragraph begins a new section. In this paragraph Jesus continued speaking. In some languages, it may be natural to make it explicit that Jesus continued speaking. For example:

Jesus continued and said,

12:34a

You brood of vipers,

- You children of poisonous snakes!
- Then Jesus criticized them by saying, “You^(plur) are as evil/dangerous as poisonous snakes!

You brood of vipers: The word vipers refers to poisonous snakes. The phrase brood of vipers means “children/offspring of poisonous snakes.” It refers to having the same characteristics as vipers.

a viper

This phrase is a metaphor. (It also occurs in 3:7b.) In this metaphor, Jesus compared the Pharisees to a brood of vipers. Jesus used this metaphor to criticize the Pharisees.

The way that these men and snakes are similar is that both are evil and dangerous.

Here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Make the point of comparison clear. For example:

You are a bunch of evil snakes (CEV)

- Use a simile and make the point of comparison clear. For example:

You^(plur) are as evil/dangerous as a group of vipers!

- Translate the metaphor but leave the word brood untranslated. Jesus was not saying that the people were young or childlike. So some English translations do not explicitly translate the word brood. For example:

You snakes (GNT)

- Translate the meaning without a simile or metaphor. For example:

You^(plur) wicked people!

- Use a simile and explain the meaning. For example:

You evil people! You are like poisonous snakes.

If calling someone a poisonous snake is not an insult in your culture, you may also need to add something to make it more explicit. For example:

Jesus insulted/criticized them by saying

12:34b

how can you who are evil say anything good?

- How can you evil people say anything good?
- You cannot say good/helpful words because you are evil.

how can you who are evil say anything good?: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus used this rhetorical question to rebuke the Pharisees and to emphasize that they could not say anything good.

Here are some other ways to translate this rebuke and emphasis:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

How can you evil people say anything good? (GW)

- As a statement followed by a rhetorical question. For example:

You are evil people, so how can you say anything good? (NCV)

- As a statement. For example:

Since you are evil, you cannot say anything good!

You cannot say anything good because you are evil/bad.

Translate this rebuke and emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

how can you who are evil say anything good: The phrase say anything good means say good words. The Pharisees did not say things that were good and positive. They said things that were harmful. This clause does not mean speak well/elegantly.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

how can you say good things (GNT)

speak what is good and right (NLT)

12:34c

For out of the overflow of the heart, the mouth speaks.

- Whatever fills a person's heart, that is what comes out of his mouth.
- I say this because a person's words show what is in/filling his heart/thoughts.

For: Verse 12:34c is the reason that the Pharisees cannot say anything good. Evil people cannot say anything good because the mouth says what is in the heart. The Greek introduces this reason with a conjunction that the BSB translates as For.

Here are some other ways to introduce this reason:

You cannot do it because

That is true because

The reason you cannot do this is that

Some English versions do not translate this word. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this word either.

out of the overflow of the heart, the mouth speaks:

The Greek word that the BSB translates as overflow means "abundance" or "fullness." It describes a quantity of something that fills a container so completely full that it overflows. In this clause it is used in a figurative way. It pictures a person's heart so full of certain thoughts that they come out of his mouth. This means that a person acts and speaks according to what is in his heart.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

whatever is in/filling a person's heart, that is what comes out of his mouth/lips

The mouth speaks the things that are in the heart. (NCV)

Your words show what is in your hearts. (CEV)

What a person says comes from what is in his heart/thoughts

heart: In Greek culture, the heart is the center and source of inner life. This is where thinking, feeling, and decision- making happen. Some languages use a

different organ such as “liver” for this concept. Or it may be a general term such as “insides.”

the mouth speaks: This clause means that the person speaks or says something. In some languages, a literal translation would not be natural. If that is the case in your language, you may want to change this phrase so as not to use the word mouth. For example:

a person speaks

what you say (NLT)

your words (CEV)

Matthew 12:35

Section 12:33–37: Your words show whether you are good or bad

In this section, Jesus continued to respond to the Pharisees’ accusation that he cast out evil spirits by the power of Satan. First, he said that the Pharisees needed to be consistent in their beliefs about him. Then he warned them that God would judge them for the words that they said.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

A tree is known by its fruit

A tree and its fruit

People know you by your words (NCV)

Paragraph 12:33–37

This paragraph begins a new section. In this paragraph Jesus continued speaking. In some languages, it may be natural to make it explicit that Jesus continued speaking. For example:

Jesus continued and said,

12:35

This verse is a parable with a similar meaning to 12:34c. A good person will say good things and do good deeds because his mind is filled with good thoughts, feelings, and desires. But an evil person will say evil things and do evil deeds because his mind is filled with evil thoughts, feelings, and desires.

12:35a

The good man brings good things out of his good store of treasure,

- A good person says the good words that are in his good heart.
- Good people have good things in their hearts/minds, so they do and say good things.

The good man: This phrase refers to a man who is moral and upright. It refers to any good person. It does not refer to a specific person.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

A good person (GNT)

A moral/upright man

Good people (REB)

brings good things: This phrase refers to nonphysical things that figuratively “come out” of a person. These are the good words that he says and the good deeds that he does.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

do the good things (GW)

they say good things (NCV)

Here are some other ways to translate this entire clause:

A good person says the good words that come from his good heart

Good people have good things in their hearts, and so they say good things (NCV)

Good people do the good things that are in them (GW)

out of his good store of treasure: The Greek word that the BSB translates as treasure can refer to “valuable things” or “the place where valuable things are stored.” In the context of this paragraph speaking of the heart (12:34b), it probably refers primarily to the place. So the treasure is the treasury/storehouse. This is a figure of speech that refers to the heart/insides.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

from the treasury of a good heart (NLT)

out of their hearts (CEV)

from his good heart/insides

The phrase “a good heart” refers to the upright/moral inner qualities of a person. It does not mean a physically healthy heart. In some languages, it may be more natural to speak of “the good things in a person’s heart.” For example:

have good things in their hearts (NCV)

12:35b

and the evil man brings evil things out of his evil store of treasure.

- An evil person says the evil words that are in his evil heart.
- But evil people have evil things in their hearts/minds, so they do and say evil things.

and the evil man brings evil things out of his evil store of treasure: This clause has the same grammatical structure as 12:35a. So you should translate it in the same way. For example:

An evil/bad person says the evil words that come from his evil heart

But evil people have evil in their hearts, so they say evil things. (NCV)

But evil people do the evil things that are in them. (GW)

Matthew 12:36

Section 12:33–37: Your words show whether you are good or bad

In this section, Jesus continued to respond to the Pharisees’ accusation that he cast out evil spirits by the power of Satan. First, he said that the Pharisees needed to be consistent in their beliefs about him. Then he warned them that God would judge them for the words that they said.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

A tree is known by its fruit

A tree and its fruit

People know you by your words (NCV)

Paragraph 12:33–37

This paragraph begins a new section. In this paragraph Jesus continued speaking. In some languages, it may be natural to make it explicit that Jesus continued speaking. For example:

Jesus continued and said,

12:36a

But I tell you that men will give an account on the day of judgment

- I tell you^(plur) that on the day of judgment, people will be required to explain
- I tell you that when God judges people, he will ask them to tell the reason why

I tell you: The words I tell you emphasize the words that follow. Some ways to translate this clause are:

- Use a phrase before Jesus’ statement. For example:

I say to you

Listen carefully to what I say

- Include an emphatic word or phrase such as “certainly” within the following statement. For example:

people will certainly give account

men will give an account: The Greek word that the BSB translates as give an account can also be translated as “explain” here. God will ask everyone why they have said careless words, and they will have to explain. You should use a verb that describes what a person does in court or before a tribunal when he is asked to explain his words/actions.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

people will have to explain

people will be required to tell God the reasons why they have said

God will ask everyone to testify why they have said

on the day of judgment: The phrase day of judgment refers to the time when God will judge all people for the things they have said and done on earth.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

on the Judgment Day (GNT)

on the day that God judges all people

This phrase also occurs in 11:24b. You should translate it here as you did there.

12:36b
for every careless word they have spoken.

- every word/thing that they said that had no worth/value.
- they have said every word that they should not have said.

every careless word they have spoken: The Greek word that the BSB translates as careless also means “useless.” God will not only judge and condemn evil deeds. He will also judge words that were spoken without thought as to whether they might hurt someone.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

every thoughtless word you speak (REB)

every worthless word they speak (NET)

every time they said something that they should not have said

Matthew 12:37

Section 12:33–37: Your words show whether you are good or bad

In this section, Jesus continued to respond to the Pharisees’ accusation that he cast out evil spirits by the power of Satan. First, he said that the Pharisees needed to be consistent in their beliefs about him. Then he warned them that God would judge them for the words that they said.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

A tree is known by its fruit

A tree and its fruit

People know you by your words (NCV)

Paragraph 12:33–37

This paragraph begins a new section. In this paragraph Jesus continued speaking. In some languages, it may be natural to make it explicit that Jesus continued speaking. For example:

Jesus continued and said,

12:37

Before you begin translating this verse, think about the most natural way to translate it in your language. This verse has two parallel parts:

^aby your words you will be acquitted

^bby your words you will be condemned

In some languages, it will be natural to combine these two parts. For example:

The words you say will either acquit you or condemn you. (NLT)

they will be told that they are either innocent or guilty because of the things they have said. (CEV)

12:37a

For by your words you will be acquitted,

- That is true because you will be declared innocent based on your words,
- God will judge and declare a person not guilty because of the words he has spoken,
- God will use your words to judge you either innocent

This clause continues to refer to what will happen on the day of judgment.

For: Verse 12:37 explains what Jesus said in 12:36. The Greek introduces this explanation with a conjunction that the BSB translates as For.

Here are some other ways to introduce this explanation:

Let me explain further

That is true because

Some English versions do not introduce this explanation with a conjunction. In some languages, a conjunction will not be necessary here either.

by your words you will be acquitted: This clause means that your words will determine whether God declares you innocent. In other words, on judgment day, God will examine your words and declare you either innocent or guilty. If you have spoken good words, God will declare you “not guilty.”

This clause is passive. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

By your words you will be declared innocent (GW)

A person will be declared innocent because of the words that he has said

- Use an active verb. For example:

God will judge you and declare you innocent because of the words you have said

God will use the words that a person has said to judge him innocent

your words you: In 12:36, Jesus spoke of “men”/people. Here in 12:37 he switched and used the singular pronouns your and you. But 12:37 still has a general application to all people. The pronoun you was not meant for only a single person in the crowd listening to Jesus. In some languages, it will be more natural to continue to use “people” or the singular “a person” here in 12:37. For example:

God will judge and declare a person innocent based on his words.

12:37b

and by your words you will be condemned.”

- and/or you will be judged as evil/sinful based on your words.”
- or God/he will judge and declare a person guilty because of the words he has spoken.”
- or guilty.”

and: Each person will be declared either innocent or guilty. It may be more natural in some languages to use “or” instead of and here. For example:

or by your words you will be declared guilty (GW)

by your words you will be condemned: This clause is parallel to the clause in 12:37a. It means that your words will determine whether God declares you guilty. In other words, on judgment day, God will examine your words and declare you either innocent or guilty. If you have spoken careless words, God will declare you “guilty.”

This clause is passive. Here are some other ways to translate it:

Use a passive verb. For example:

by your words you will be declared guilty (GW)

a person will be declared guilty because of the words that he has said

Use an active verb. For example:

God will judge you and declare you guilty because of the words you have said

God will use the words that a person has said to judge/declare him guilty

condemned: In this context, the Greek word that the BSB translates as condemned means “declared guilty.”

Here are some other ways to translate condemned:

declare...guilty (GNT)

judged as evil/sinful

This word also occurs in 12:7c.

Matthew 12:38

Section 12:38–45: Jesus rebuked those who asked for a sign

In this section, the conflict between Jesus and the religious leaders increases. Jesus had already said several times that he was someone special. He said that he was greater than the temple (12:6). He said that he was Lord of the Sabbath (12:8). In this section, the religious leaders wanted to see a miraculous sign to confirm that he was really from God.

Jesus rebuked the religious leaders for asking for a sign, and he refused to give them an immediate sign.

A sign would come later. It would be the sign of Jonah. By referring to the sign of Jonah, Jesus meant that he would be in the grave three days (12:40) before God resurrected him. He then told two stories and said that he was greater than Jonah and Solomon. Jesus warned them that if they did not recognize God's work among them, they would be condemned.

Finally, Jesus told a story to warn the religious leaders of the spiritual dangers that faced them if they did not have the Holy Spirit in their lives.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The religious leaders ask for a sign/miracle

The sign of Jonah

There is a parallel passage for 12:38–42 in Luke 11:29–32. There is a parallel passage for 12:43–45 in Luke 11:24–26.

12:38a

Then some of the scribes and Pharisees said to Him,

- ¶ Then some of the teachers of the Law and the Pharisees said to him,
- ¶ Then some of the Pharisees and teachers of religious law said,

Then: The events in this section probably happened soon after the events in the previous section. The Greek indicates how closely these events happened with a conjunction that the BSB translates as Then.

Here are some other ways to begin this section:

After that

Next

scribes: The Greek word that the BSB translates as scribes can also be translated as “teacher of the law” (as in the NIV). This word also occurs in 9:3a. You should translate it here as you did there. For help in translating this word, see the note at 2:4a.

Pharisees: This word also occurs in 12:24a.

said to Him: The Greek word that the BSB leaves untranslated here means “answered.” It indicates that the scribes and Pharisees responded to Jesus' words in 12:34–37. It does not indicate that they were answering a question.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

answered him, saying (ESV)

said (CEV)

12:38b

“Teacher, we want to see a sign from You.”

- “Teacher, we^(excl) want to see you do a miracle from heaven.”
- “Teacher, please do a surprising sign to show us that God has sent you.”

Teacher: Here, the word Teacher refers to a religious teacher. It was a polite title for a Jewish man who had authority to teach the things about God. Use a title that is an appropriate way to address a religious teacher in your culture. It should not refer only to a school teacher.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Sir

Master

This word also occurs in 8:19b.

we want to see a sign from You: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sign refers to a special miracle which is regarded as having some special meaning. (This is the first time in Matthew that this word occurs.) The Pharisees and scribes had already seen Jesus heal many sick people. So they were not just asking Jesus to do another miracle of healing. They wanted Jesus to do a special miracle to make it plain that God had sent him.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

we want you to show us a sign from heaven (CEV)

we want you to show us a miraculous sign to prove that you are from God (NLT96)

please do a miracle that will show us that God has sent you

Matthew 12:39

Section 12:38–45: Jesus rebuked those who asked for a sign

In this section, the conflict between Jesus and the religious leaders increases. Jesus had already said several times that he was someone special. He said

that he was greater than the temple (12:6). He said that he was Lord of the Sabbath (12:8). In this section, the religious leaders wanted to see a miraculous sign to confirm that he was really from God.

Jesus rebuked the religious leaders for asking for a sign, and he refused to give them an immediate sign. A sign would come later. It would be the sign of Jonah. By referring to the sign of Jonah, Jesus meant that he would be in the grave three days (12:40) before God resurrected him. He then told two stories and said that he was greater than Jonah and Solomon. Jesus warned them that if they did not recognize God's work among them, they would be condemned.

Finally, Jesus told a story to warn the religious leaders of the spiritual dangers that faced them if they did not have the Holy Spirit in their lives.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The religious leaders ask for a sign/miracle

The sign of Jonah

There is a parallel passage for 12:38–42 in Luke 11:29–32. There is a parallel passage for 12:43–45 in Luke 11:24–26.

12:39a

Jesus replied, “A wicked and adulterous generation demands a sign,

- Jesus answered them, “The people who ask me for a miracle from heaven are evil/bad and like a married woman who is immoral.
- Jesus replied, “You want to see a surprising sign because you are evil/bad people. You are people who do not follow/obey God.

Jesus responded to the scribes and Pharisees in a way that showed that he refused to do what they wanted. The Greek introduces this refusal with a conjunction that is often translated as “but.”

In some languages, it is not natural or necessary to use a “but” here.

Jesus replied: The Greek word that the BSB literally translates as replied indicates that Jesus responded to the scribes and Pharisees. It does not indicate that he was answering a question.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

He responded (GW)

He said to them

wicked: This word also means “bad,” “evil,” or “sinful.”

adulterous generation: The word adulterous refers to someone who is unfaithful to his/her spouse. Here this word is used in a figurative way. Jesus called the scribes and Pharisees adulterous because they were unfaithful to God. They were unfaithful in the sense that they did not obey him and follow him with all their hearts.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

you are people who are unfaithful to God like an adulterous spouse/wife

you are like a married woman who is immoral

- Translate the meaning. For example:

you are not following God

you do not obey God

generation: The word generation refers to all the people who lived at the same time as Jesus. Here it refers specifically to the scribes and Pharisees.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

the people of this day (GNT)

you are people who

demands a sign: The Greek word that the BSB translates as demands also means “wants, seeks, desires.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

asks for (NIV)

want (CEV)

want to see (NCV)

12:39b

but none will be given it except the sign of the prophet Jonah.

- But no miracle will be done for them except the miracle like the one that happened to the prophet Jonah.
- The only the sign that I will show you is a sign like the one that God did to/for the prophet Jonah long ago.

but: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between what the people wanted, and what Jesus would give them. The BSB introduces this contrast with the conjunction *but*.

none will be given it: This clause means that “no sign will be done” or “no sign will be shown” to this wicked and adulterous generation.

This clause is passive. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

no sign will be shown to this wicked and adulterous generation

no sign will be given to them (NCV)

no sign will be done for you

- Use an active verb. For example:

the only sign I will give them (NLT)

this generation will receive no sign

you will not see any miracle

except the sign of the prophet Jonah: This clause refers to the miracle that happened to the prophet Jonah. He was in the stomach of a huge fish for three days. Then he came out alive.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

except a sign like what happened to the prophet Jonah

a miracle that is like the one that God did to the prophet Jonah long ago

This clause does not mean that Jonah did a miracle.

Matthew 12:40

Section 12:38–45: Jesus rebuked those who asked for a sign

In this section, the conflict between Jesus and the religious leaders increases. Jesus had already said several times that he was someone special. He said that he was greater than the temple (12:6). He said that he was Lord of the Sabbath (12:8). In this section, the religious leaders wanted to see a miraculous sign to confirm that he was really from God.

Jesus rebuked the religious leaders for asking for a sign, and he refused to give them an immediate sign. A sign would come later. It would be the sign of Jonah. By referring to the sign of Jonah, Jesus meant that he would be in the grave three days (12:40) before God resurrected him. He then told two stories and said that he was greater than Jonah and Solomon. Jesus warned them that if they did not recognize God’s work among them, they would be condemned.

Finally, Jesus told a story to warn the religious leaders of the spiritual dangers that faced them if they did not have the Holy Spirit in their lives.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The religious leaders ask for a sign/miracle

The sign of Jonah

There is a parallel passage for 12:38–42 in Luke 11:29–32. There is a parallel passage for 12:43–45 in Luke 11:24–26.

12:40a

For as Jonah was three days and three nights in the belly of the great fish,

- Just as Jonah was in the stomach of a big fish for three days and three nights,
- Jonah was in the belly of a huge fish for three whole days.

For: Verse 12:40 explains what “the sign of the prophet Jonah” (12:39b) is. The Greek introduces this explanation with a conjunction that the BSB translates as *For*. Here this word does not mean “because.” It does not introduce a reason.

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, no conjunction is necessary here either. In other languages, there may be other ways to introduce an explanation. For example:

In other words

What I mean is

Let me explain

as: These words introduce a comparison. Here, 12:40a is compared with 12:40b.

Here are some other ways to introduce this comparison:

just as (ESV)

In the same way that (GNT)

In some languages, it is natural to mark only the second clause of a comparison, not the first clause. For example:

^aJonah was in the stomach of the big fish for three days and three nights. ^bIn the same way, the Son of Man will be in the grave three days and three nights. (NCV)

Jonah was three days and three nights: The phrase three days and three nights refers to three full days in a row: a day and a night, a day and a night, and a day and a night.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

three days and nights (GNT)

three full days

three whole days

in the belly of the great fish: The Greek word that the BSB translates as great fish refers to any very large creature that lives in the sea. It was large enough that it swallowed Jonah whole.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in the stomach of a large fish

inside a huge fish

12:40b

so the Son of Man will be three days and three nights in the heart of the earth.

- even so will the Son of Man be buried in the earth for three days and three nights.
- In the same way, I, the Son of Man, will be in a grave/tomb for three full days.

so: This word indicates that 12:40b is the second part of a comparison. As mentioned in the note above, some languages mark only the second part of a comparison. For example:

^aJonah was in the stomach of the big fish for three days and three nights. ^bIn the same way, the Son of Man will be in the grave three days and three nights. (NCV)

the Son of Man: Here Jesus refers to himself as the Son of Man. In some languages, it may be necessary to add the pronoun “I” to make it clear that Jesus was referring to himself. For example:

I, the Son of Man

This phrase also occurs in 12:32a. You should translate it here as you did there. For help in translating this phrase, see the note under 8:20b.

in the heart of the earth: This phrase is a poetic way of saying “in a grave.” Jesus was referring to the time when he would be dead and buried.

This phrase is parallel to the phrase “in the belly of the great fish” in 12:40a. In some languages, it may be possible to keep this poetic structure. For example:

in the belly of a big fish...in the belly of the earth

in a big fish...in the earth/ground

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in a grave/tomb

buried

Matthew 12:41

Section 12:38–45: Jesus rebuked those who asked for a sign

In this section, the conflict between Jesus and the religious leaders increases. Jesus had already said

several times that he was someone special. He said that he was greater than the temple (12:6). He said that he was Lord of the Sabbath (12:8). In this section, the religious leaders wanted to see a miraculous sign to confirm that he was really from God.

Jesus rebuked the religious leaders for asking for a sign, and he refused to give them an immediate sign. A sign would come later. It would be the sign of Jonah. By referring to the sign of Jonah, Jesus meant that he would be in the grave three days (12:40) before God resurrected him. He then told two stories and said that he was greater than Jonah and Solomon. Jesus warned them that if they did not recognize God's work among them, they would be condemned.

Finally, Jesus told a story to warn the religious leaders of the spiritual dangers that faced them if they did not have the Holy Spirit in their lives.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The religious leaders ask for a sign/miracle

The sign of Jonah

There is a parallel passage for 12:38–42 in Luke 11:29–32. There is a parallel passage for 12:43–45 in Luke 11:24–26.

12:41a

The men of Nineveh will stand at the judgment

- On the day of judgment, the people of the city of Nineveh will stand up
- On the day when God judges people, the Ninevites will give testimony

The men of Nineveh: This phrase refers to the people/inhabitants of the city of Nineveh.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

The people of the city of Nineveh

The Ninevites

will stand: There are two ways to interpret the Greek verb that the BSB translates as will stand:

1. It means will stand up, or will appear. According to this interpretation, this verb refers to court proceedings when a person or people stand to give testimony. For example:

the people of Nineveh will stand up (GNT) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NET, GW, CEV, NLT, JBP, NLT, REB, NJB, NASB)

1. It means will rise from the dead, or will live again. This view is supported by some commentators.

The ESV, RSV, and KJV translate the verb literally as “rise” or “arise,” which can be understood either way. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and the majority of English versions.

When translating this verb, you should use a verb that is appropriate for appearing in court to condemn someone. It may not be the verb rise or stand. For example:

The men of Nineveh will appear in court when this generation is on trial (REB)

The people of Nineveh will give testimony

at the judgment: This phrase refers to the day when God judges everyone.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

On the Judgment Day (GNT)

On the day of judgment (CEV)

on the day when God judges people

12:41b

with this generation and condemn it;

- together with the people of today and will accuse them of sinning,
- against you people living today and will show that you are guilty.

with this generation: This phrase means “together with the people who are living now (that is, at Jesus’ time).” This means that the people of Nineveh will be standing at the same time as these people. It does not mean that they will stand in support of them. In fact, the people of Nineveh will stand to condemn them. To make this clear, the NLT says:

against this generation (NLT)

and condemn it: In this context the Greek word that the BSB translates as condemn means “say that someone is guilty of sin.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

testify against it

show that you are guilty (NCV)

accuse you of sin

it: This pronoun refers to “this generation” (12:41b).

Here are some other ways to translate this:

them

that generation

12:41c
for they repented at the preaching of Jonah,

- because the people of Nineveh repented when they heard Jonah preach God’s message,
- They will show that you are guilty because they turned from their sins when Jonah preached God’s message to them,

for: Verse 12:41c is the reason that the people of Nineveh will condemn this generation. The Greek introduces this reason with a conjunction that the BSB translates as for.

Here are some other ways to introduce this reason:

because

They will accuse them because

they repented at the preaching of Jonah: This clause means that the people of Nineveh changed their minds about sin when they heard Jonah preach to them. They felt sorry for their sins and turned to God.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the people of Nineveh repented when Jonah preached

they turned from their sins when they heard Jonah preach (GNT)

When Jonah preached to them, they were sorry and changed their lives. (NCV)

12:41d
and now One greater than Jonah is here.

- and someone greater than Jonah is here, but this generation did not repent.
- but you did not turn from your sins even though someone more important than Jonah is here.

There is some important, implied information in this part of the verse. Jesus implied here “but you did not repent.” Jonah preached, and the people of Nineveh repented. Jesus is greater than Jonah. But when Jesus preached, the people did not repent.

Here are some other ways to include this implied information:

- Put it after 12:41d. For example:

and something greater than Jonah is here, but you did not repent when he preached.

- Put it before 12:41d. For example:

But you did not repent even though something greater than Jonah is here.

and: Verse 12:41d is also part of the reason for the people of Nineveh to condemn this generation (12:41b).

There is a contrast here. The contrast is between the reaction of the people of Nineveh and the implied reaction of the people of this generation. In some languages, it may be natural to introduce this contrast with a conjunction. For example:

But (GW)

now: The Greek word that the BSB translates as now literally means “look” or “see.” It focuses attention on what follows and indicates that it is important, unexpected, or amazing. Here this word indicates that the words that follow are important and amazing: something greater than Jonah is here.

Here are some other ways to show that the words that follow are important:

look (GW)

I tell you (NLT)

Listen to what I am about to say

One greater than Jonah is here: The Greek word that the BSB literally translates as One probably refers to Jesus. In some languages, it is possible for Jesus to refer to himself as One. In other languages, it will be more natural to say:

someone more important than Jonah is here

A similar expression (“something greater than the temple is here”) occurs in 12:6.

greater: In this context, the word greater refers to higher in status and not to bigger in size. Jesus was more important than Jonah.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

more important

more valuable

Matthew 12:42

Section 12:38–45: Jesus rebuked those who asked for a sign

In this section, the conflict between Jesus and the religious leaders increases. Jesus had already said several times that he was someone special. He said that he was greater than the temple (12:6). He said that he was Lord of the Sabbath (12:8). In this section, the religious leaders wanted to see a miraculous sign to confirm that he was really from God.

Jesus rebuked the religious leaders for asking for a sign, and he refused to give them an immediate sign. A sign would come later. It would be the sign of Jonah. By referring to the sign of Jonah, Jesus meant that he would be in the grave three days (12:40) before God resurrected him. He then told two stories and said that he was greater than Jonah and Solomon. Jesus warned them that if they did not recognize God’s work among them, they would be condemned.

Finally, Jesus told a story to warn the religious leaders of the spiritual dangers that faced them if they did not have the Holy Spirit in their lives.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The religious leaders ask for a sign/miracle

The sign of Jonah

There is a parallel passage for 12:38–42 in Luke 11:29–32. There is a parallel passage for 12:43–45 in Luke 11:24–26.

12:42a

The Queen of the South will rise at the judgment

- On the day of judgment, the queen of a southern country also will stand up
- Also, on the day when God judges people, the Queen of Sheba will give testimony

12:42b

with this generation and condemn it;

- together with the people of today and will accuse them of sinning,
- against you people living today and will show that you are guilty.

12:42a–b

Verse 12:42 is another example like the example in 12:41. In some languages, it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

Also

Likewise

The Queen of the South: This phrase refers to the Queen of Sheba in 1 Kings 10:1–13. Her country was far to the south of Israel.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

The Queen of Sheba (GNT)

The queen of a country to the south

will rise at the judgment with this generation: The Greek word that the BSB translates as rise is a different Greek verb than “stand” in 12:41a. But it is probably similar in meaning. There are the same issues of interpretation as with “stand” in 12:41a. Follow the same interpretation here as there.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

will also stand up against this generation on judgment day (NLT)

will also give testimony against you on the day when God judges people

12:42c

for she came from the ends of the earth to hear the wisdom of Solomon,

- because she came from far away to hear the wise words of King Solomon,
- She will show that you are guilty because she traveled a long way to listen to King Solomon's wise counsel/words,

for: Verse 12:42c is the reason that the queen of the South will condemn this generation. The Greek introduces this reason with a conjunction that the BSB translates as *for*.

Here are some other ways to introduce this reason:

because

She will accuse them because

she came from the ends of the earth: The phrase the ends of the earth is an expression that means “the places on earth that are very far away.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

she came from a distant land (NLT)

she came from far away (NCV)

She traveled a long way (CEV)

to hear the wisdom of Solomon: The word wisdom means “the ability to understand events and know the right action to take.” Solomon was king of Israel after his father David, and God gave very great wisdom to him.

In some languages, it may not be possible to speak about wisdom as a noun. If this is true in your language, here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Solomon's wise words

Solomon's right and just thinking

Solomon: Solomon was one of the kings of Israel. In some languages, it might be good to make this clear in the text. For example:

King Solomon

12:42d

and now One greater than Solomon is here.

- and someone greater than King Solomon is here, but this generation did not listen to him.”
- but you did not listen to the person among you who is more important than King Solomon.”

As in 12:41d, there is some important, implied information in this part of the verse. Jesus implied here “but you did not listen to me.” The Queen of Sheba traveled a long distance to listen to King Solomon. Jesus was right there with the people, but they did not listen to him.

Here are some other ways to include this implied information:

- Put it after 12:42d. For example:

and someone greater than King Solomon is here, but you did not listen to him.

- Put it before 12:42d. For example:

But you did not listen to the person among you who is greater than King Solomon.

and now One greater than Solomon is here: Translate this clause as you translated 12:41d, using the name of Solomon instead of Jonah.

Matthew 12:43

Section 12:38–45: Jesus rebuked those who asked for a sign

In this section, the conflict between Jesus and the religious leaders increases. Jesus had already said several times that he was someone special. He said that he was greater than the temple (12:6). He said that he was Lord of the Sabbath (12:8). In this section, the religious leaders wanted to see a miraculous sign to confirm that he was really from God.

Jesus rebuked the religious leaders for asking for a sign, and he refused to give them an immediate sign. A sign would come later. It would be the sign of Jonah. By referring to the sign of Jonah, Jesus meant that he would be in the grave three days (12:40) before God resurrected him. He then told two stories and said that he was greater than Jonah and Solomon. Jesus warned them that if they did not recognize God's work among them, they would be condemned.

Finally, Jesus told a story to warn the religious leaders of the spiritual dangers that faced them if they did not have the Holy Spirit in their lives.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The religious leaders ask for a sign/miracle

The sign of Jonah

There is a parallel passage for 12:38–42 in Luke 11:29–32. There is a parallel passage for 12:43–45 in Luke 11:24–26.

Paragraph 12:43–45

This paragraph warns that removing evil from a person's life is not enough. The person must also fill himself with good. The way that someone fills himself with good is not explicitly mentioned. The implied way is by following Jesus and having the Holy Spirit fill him.

Jesus used the present tense for all the verbs in 12:43–45. The present tense shows that this is a general example: these events commonly happen for this situation. Use the proper tense in your language to show that this is a general example.

12:43a

When an unclean spirit comes out of a man,

- ¶ “When an evil spirit leaves a person,
- ¶ Jesus continued, “Suppose an evil spirit is forced to leave someone.

When an unclean spirit comes out of a man: An unclean spirit would not normally “go out” of a person unless someone forced it to leave. So it is probably implied that someone forced the unclean spirit to leave the person it possessed. In some languages, it may be necessary to make some of this information explicit.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

When an evil spirit leaves a person (CEV)

When an evil spirit comes out of a person (GW)

Suppose an evil spirit is caused/forced to leave a person it possessed

unclean spirit: The term unclean spirit refers to the same beings as “evil spirit” and “demon.” You can translate these three terms with the same term. The plural form of the term unclean spirit occurs in 10:1b.

The Jews believed that anyone who had an evil spirit was unclean. So an evil spirit was also called an unclean spirit.

Here are some other ways to translate unclean spirit:

- Use a general term in your language that refers to a spirit that is evil and can control people. For example:

demon

devil

- Use a specific term in your language that refers to a certain type of spirit. Do not use a term that refers to the spirit of a dead person.
- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

evil spirit (NIV)

See demon in the Glossary for more information.

12:43b

it passes through arid places seeking rest

- it goes through dry lands and looks for a place to rest,
- He wanders/roams in dry lands looking for a place to stay/live.

it passes through arid places: The phrase arid places refers to areas that are dry or a desert. The evil spirit wanders/roams around in such places, but it does not stay there. It passes through these places.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

it travels through the desert (CEV)

it goes through dry places (GW)

it wanders through waterless places (JBP)

seeking rest: In this context, the word rest refers to a “place to stay/live” or a “home.” The unclean spirit was looking for a place where it could stop wandering around and start to live. In this context, a place to rest would refer to another person to possess. It does not mean that the unclean spirit was tired.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

hunting for a place to stay/live

looking for a home

**12:43c
and does not find it.**

- but it does not find any.
- But he does not find one.

and does not find it: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as and is most often translated that way. There is a contrast between what the evil spirit sought and what happened: it did not find a place to stay. In some languages, it may be more natural to use “but” instead of and.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

But it doesn't find any. (GW)

But when the demon doesn't find a place (CEV)

and never finding it (JBP)

If it/he does not find a place to stay

Matthew 12:44

Section 12:38–45: Jesus rebuked those who asked for a sign

In this section, the conflict between Jesus and the religious leaders increases. Jesus had already said several times that he was someone special. He said that he was greater than the temple (12:6). He said that he was Lord of the Sabbath (12:8). In this section, the religious leaders wanted to see a miraculous sign to confirm that he was really from God.

Jesus rebuked the religious leaders for asking for a sign, and he refused to give them an immediate sign. A sign would come later. It would be the sign of Jonah. By referring to the sign of Jonah, Jesus meant that he would be in the grave three days (12:40) before God resurrected him. He then told two stories and said that he was greater than Jonah and Solomon. Jesus warned them that if they did not recognize God's work among them, they would be condemned.

Finally, Jesus told a story to warn the religious leaders of the spiritual dangers that faced them if they did not have the Holy Spirit in their lives.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The religious leaders ask for a sign/miracle

The sign of Jonah

There is a parallel passage for 12:38–42 in Luke 11:29–32. There is a parallel passage for 12:43–45 in Luke 11:24–26.

Paragraph 12:43–45

This paragraph warns that removing evil from a person's life is not enough. The person must also fill himself with good. The way that someone fills himself with good is not explicitly mentioned. The implied way is by following Jesus and having the Holy Spirit fill him.

Jesus used the present tense for all the verbs in 12:43–45. The present tense shows that this is a general example: these events commonly happen for this situation. Use the proper tense in your language to show that this is a general example.

12:44a

Then it says, 'I will return to the house I left.'

- Then it says, 'I will go back to live in the house I left.'
- Then he says to himself, 'I will go back to the person who was my former house.'

Then it says: The pronoun it refers to the unclean spirit. Here the unclean spirit is talking to itself.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Then he says to himself

I will return to the house I left: The phrase the house I left is a figure of speech. It refers to the person whom the unclean spirit had been possessing.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- Keep the figure of speech. For example:

I will go back to my house. (GNT) If you follow this option, you may want to include a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

The unclean spirit refers to the person he possessed/controlled as his “house.”

- Explain in the text that the house refers to the person. For example:

I will return to the person who was my house

I will go back to the person in whom I lived/resided

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

I will return to the person I came from. (NLT)

12:44b

On its return, it finds the house vacant, swept clean, and put in order.

- When it arrives, it sees that the house is empty, clean and everything put in its place.
- When he returns to the person he had left, he discovers that the person is like a house that is ready for someone to live in. It is empty, clean, and tidy.

On its return: This clause means “when the unclean spirit returns to its house.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

When the unclean spirit comes back to its house

When the evil spirit returns to the person whom he had left

it finds: Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

it discovers

he sees that

the house vacant, swept clean, and put in order: This is a metaphor. In this metaphor, the person whom the unclean spirit had left is compared to a house that is vacant, clean, and put in order. The person and the house are similar in that both are ready for someone to come and live in them.

Here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

the place empty, clean, and fixed up (CEV)

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

the person is like a house that is empty, swept, and put in order

- Change the metaphor to a simile and make explicit how the person and the house are similar. For example:

the person is like a house that is empty, cleaned, arranged neatly and ready for someone to live there

no one is living in him. He is like a house that is ready to inhabit. It is empty, clean, and put in order.

vacant: The word vacant indicates that no one is living in the “house.” This word indicates that the person has not asked either a demon or Jesus to live in his inner being and be ruler in his life.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

no one is living there

vacant

swept clean: This word means to clean the floor by brushing it with a broom.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

swept (ESV)

clean (GNT)

put in order: This phrase indicates that the things in the house are in their right places. This is another way to describe that the house is ready for someone to live in.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

tidy (REB)

made neat (NCV)

fixed up (GW)

everything is in its proper place

Matthew 12:45

Section 12:38–45: Jesus rebuked those who asked for a sign

In this section, the conflict between Jesus and the religious leaders increases. Jesus had already said several times that he was someone special. He said that he was greater than the temple (12:6). He said that he was Lord of the Sabbath (12:8). In this section,

the religious leaders wanted to see a miraculous sign to confirm that he was really from God.

Jesus rebuked the religious leaders for asking for a sign, and he refused to give them an immediate sign. A sign would come later. It would be the sign of Jonah. By referring to the sign of Jonah, Jesus meant that he would be in the grave three days (12:40) before God resurrected him. He then told two stories and said that he was greater than Jonah and Solomon. Jesus warned them that if they did not recognize God's work among them, they would be condemned.

Finally, Jesus told a story to warn the religious leaders of the spiritual dangers that faced them if they did not have the Holy Spirit in their lives.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The religious leaders ask for a sign/miracle

The sign of Jonah

There is a parallel passage for 12:38–42 in Luke 11:29–32. There is a parallel passage for 12:43–45 in Luke 11:24–26.

Paragraph 12:43–45

This paragraph warns that removing evil from a person's life is not enough. The person must also fill himself with good. The way that someone fills himself with good is not explicitly mentioned. The implied way is by following Jesus and having the Holy Spirit fill him.

Jesus used the present tense for all the verbs in 12:43–45. The present tense shows that this is a general example: these events commonly happen for this situation. Use the proper tense in your language to show that this is a general example.

12:45a

Then it goes and brings with it seven other spirits more wicked than itself,

- Then it goes away and finds seven other spirits that are more evil than itself. It brings them along,
- Then he goes away and invites/calls seven other unclean/evil spirits. They are more evil than he is. He brings them back with him to the person,

Then it goes and brings with it seven other spirits more wicked than itself: This clause means that the unclean spirit goes away, finds seven other unclean spirits, and brings them back to his house. In some languages, it may be necessary to divide this long clause into several sentences. For example:

it goes off and finds seven other evil spirits even worse than itself. They all come (CEV)

Then he goes away and invites seven other unclean/evil spirits. These spirits are even worse than he is. He brings them with him

seven other spirits: These spirits are unclean/evil spirits like the first one. But they are even more evil.

12:45b

and they go in and dwell there;

- and they enter that house and remain there.
- and they enter the person and live there and possess/control him.

they go in and dwell there: The pronoun they refers to the unclean spirit plus the seven other evil spirits. These eight evil spirits are pictured as entering and living in the person like people enter and live in a house.

Here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor of the house. For example:

they enter that house and live there

- Use terms that refer directly to evil spirits possessing a person. For example:

they all enter the person and live there (NLT)

they possess the person

- Use general terms that could refer to either a house or a person. For example:

they go in and live there (NCV)

12:45c

and the final plight of that man is worse than the first.

- The later life of that person is worse than his earlier life.
- So, that person will suffer more than before.

the final plight of that man is worse than the first:

The word plight refers to the man's "state of being" or his "life." The eight demons will make this man's life much worse than when the one demon was controlling his life.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the person has even more trouble than before (NCV)

the life of that person is worse than before

the sufferings/troubles of that person will surpass those of before

12:45d

So will it be with this wicked generation.”

- And it will be the same with the evil people living today.”
- That is the same thing that will happen to you wicked people of today.”

So will it be with this wicked generation: This clause is the conclusion or application of what Jesus said in 12:43–44. In this clause, Jesus compared the people of this evil generation to the person who had the evil spirit. He said that the end of the lives of the people of this generation will be worse than the beginning of their lives.

The people of this evil generation had seen Jesus cast out an evil spirit. If they did not replace the evil in their lives with the Holy Spirit, they would suffer.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

It is the same way with the evil people who live today. (NCV)

That is like what will happen to the evil people who live today.

The lives of the people of this evil generation will be like the life of the person with a demon. The end will be worse than the beginning.

this wicked generation: This phrase refers to the people who lived at the same time as Jesus. Many of them were evil/bad. A similar phrase occurs in 12:39a.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

evil people who live today

bad people who are alive now

Matthew 12:46

Section 12:46–50: Jesus taught about who is his true family

In this section, Jesus showed that all who obey God are members of his/Jesus’ spiritual family.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The True Family of Jesus (NLT)

The people whom Jesus considered to be his true family

People who do the will of God are like the true family of Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 3:31–35 and Luke 8:19–21.

12:46a

While Jesus was still speaking to the crowds,

- ¶ While Jesus was still speaking to the crowd,
- ¶ As Jesus continued talking to the people,

While Jesus was still speaking to the crowds: Verse 12:46a connects this paragraph with the preceding paragraphs. Even though Jesus had been speaking primarily to the scribes and Pharisees in 12:38–45, other people were also listening since 12:23.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

While Jesus was still talking to the crowds (GW)

Jesus continued talking with the people.

12:46b

His mother and brothers stood outside,

- his mother and younger brothers arrived and stood outside the house.
- his mother and his younger brothers arrived at the house. They stood outside

The Greek word that begins this clause is left untranslated in the BSB, but some English versions translate it as “behold.” This word focuses attention on what follows and indicates that it is important, unexpected, or amazing. In this context, this word introduces the main topic of this paragraph: Jesus’ mother and brothers. Many English versions translate this word as “look” or “behold” in this context.

His...brothers: Church groups differ in what they believe about Jesus' brothers. Here are the three main views:

1. They were the sons of Joseph and Mary, born after Jesus.
2. They were Jesus' cousins. Scholars who follow this view most commonly think that they were the children of Clopas (Joseph's brother or brother-in-law) and Mary (the sister of Jesus' mother). For a good presentation and analysis of the various views, see Arndt's commentary on 8:19.
3. They were children of Joseph from a previous marriage. That is, they were Jesus' step-brothers.

The Hebrew and Aramaic words for "brother" do not distinguish between biological brothers and cousins. It is good to use a general word for "brother" that could apply to any of the views above. For example, you may have a word that could refer to:

1. brothers with the same father and mother,
2. brothers with the same father but different mothers, and
3. cousins who are children of one of the parents' brothers or sisters.

If you must use a more specific word, it is recommended that you consult with all major church groups in your language area. You will want to choose a word that is acceptable to the churches.

If your language must distinguish between "older" and "younger" brothers, it is recommended that you use a term for "younger brothers" here. If your language does not use terms that distinguish male and female, such as brother or sister, it may be more natural to use general terms. For example:

siblings

younger-siblings

stood outside: There is some implied information in this part of the verse:

1. Jesus was at this time speaking from inside a house.
2. Jesus mother and brothers had not been present in the crowd in the previous paragraph, but now they arrived.

In some languages, it may be necessary to make some of this information explicit. For example:

came and stood outside (CEV)

stood outside the house

when his mother and brothers arrived. They stood outside (GNT)

12:46c

wanting to speak to Him.

- They wanted to talk to him.
- and said that they wanted to speak to him.

wanting to speak to Him: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as wanting can mean "seeking/trying," "wanting," or "asking." So this clause can simply mean that "they wanted to speak to Jesus." Or it can mean that "they told people that they wanted to speak with him." Either one is possible and acceptable.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

They wanted to talk to him. (GW)

trying to find a way to talk to him. (NCV)

They said that they wanted to speak with Jesus.

Matthew 12:47

Section 12:46–50: Jesus taught about who is his true family

In this section, Jesus showed that all who obey God are members of his/Jesus' spiritual family.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The True Family of Jesus (NLT)

The people whom Jesus considered to be his true family

People who do the will of God are like the true family of Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 3:31–35 and Luke 8:19–21.

12:47a

Someone told him, "Look, Your mother and brothers are standing outside,

- Someone said to him, "Teacher, your mother and your younger brothers are standing outside.
- Someone told Jesus that his mother and younger brothers were standing outside the house

12:47b wanting to speak to You.”

- They want to talk to you.”
- and were wanting/waiting to speak with him.

12:47a–b

Someone told Him, “Look, Your mother and brothers are standing outside, wanting to speak to You.”:

There is a textual issue here.

1. Some Greek manuscripts include 12:47. Most English versions follow these manuscripts. (BSB, NIV, GNT, NRSV, NET, KJV, NASB, CEV, GW, NLT, REB, NCV, JBP)
2. Some Greek manuscripts do not include 12:47. A few English versions follow these manuscripts. (ESV, RSV, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). Most English versions follow this option. Also, option (1) helps connect 12:46 and 12:48.

The person who told Jesus the news certainly talked to Jesus with respect. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this respect explicit. For example:

Teacher, your mother and brothers are standing outside, wanting to speak to you.

Excuse me, your mother and your younger brothers are standing outside the house. They want to speak with you.

In some languages, it may be natural to translate this verse as indirect speech. For example:

Someone told Jesus that his mother and younger brothers were standing outside the house and wanted to talk with him.

Matthew 12:48

Section 12:46–50: Jesus taught about who is his true family

In this section, Jesus showed that all who obey God are members of his/Jesus’ spiritual family.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The True Family of Jesus (NLT)

The people whom Jesus considered to be his true family

People who do the will of God are like the true family of Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 3:31–35 and Luke 8:19–21.

12:48a

But Jesus replied,

- Jesus asked this person,
- Jesus said,

But: The Greek word that the BSB translates as But simply indicates a change from one speaker to another. In this context, it does not indicate a contrast. Many English versions do not translate this word. In many languages, it will not be necessary to translate this word either.

Jesus replied: This clause introduces Jesus’ rhetorical question. In some languages, it may be natural to shorten this clause. For example:

Jesus said to this person

Jesus asked (NLT)

Translate this clause in a way that indicates that Jesus spoke to the man who told him about his mother and brothers.

12:48b

“Who is My mother, and who are My brothers?”

- “Who is my mother? Who are my younger brothers?”
- “Let me tell you who is my mother and who are my younger brothers.”

Who is My mother, and who are My brothers?: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus used it to introduce a new idea. The new idea is that people who do the will of God are Jesus’ true family. Since Jesus and the crowd knew that the people waiting outside were his biological mother and brothers, Jesus said this to make them think. He wanted them to think about what kinds of people should be treated as brothers and sisters and mothers and fathers. His answer in 12:49–50 shows that we should treat our fellow Christians as brothers and sisters and mothers and fathers.

Here are some other ways to introduce this new idea:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Who is my mother, and who are my brothers?
(RSV)

Who is my mother? Who are my brothers? (NCV)

- As a statement. For example:

Let me tell you who my mother and my brothers are.

I will tell you who my mother and my brothers are.

Use a natural way in your language to introduce this new idea. Be careful to translate this in a way that does not imply that Jesus did not know who his family was. Also, be careful to translate this in a way that does not imply that Jesus was saying that the people waiting for him were not his mother and brothers.

Matthew 12:49

Section 12:46–50: Jesus taught about who is his true family

In this section, Jesus showed that all who obey God are members of his/Jesus' spiritual family.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The True Family of Jesus (NLT)

The people whom Jesus considered to be his true family

People who do the will of God are like the true family of Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 3:31–35 and Luke 8:19–21.

12:49a

Pointing to His disciples, He said,

- Then he motioned with his hand at his disciples and said,
- Then he pointed at his disciples and said,

Pointing to His disciples: This clause describes Jesus' gesture. Jesus used this gesture to show the crowd that he was talking about his disciples.

The particular gesture Jesus used was to stretch/reach out his arm and hand. He probably moved his arm and hand in an arc with all fingers extended toward his disciples.

Here are some other ways to translate this gesture:

Then he pointed to his disciples (CEV)

He motioned toward his disciples

In some cultures it is not appropriate to point toward someone with your hand. If that is true in your language, use a physical motion that is natural in this context which causes people to look at something. For example:

He indicated his disciples

12:49b

“Here are My mother and My brothers.

- “These people are like my mother and my younger brothers.
- “These people have become my mother and my younger brothers.

Here are My mother and My brothers: This clause indicates that Jesus loved his disciples and they had become his family. They were his spiritual family.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

These people are my mother and my younger brothers.

These people have become like my mother and my brothers.

Matthew 12:50

Section 12:46–50: Jesus taught about who is his true family

In this section, Jesus showed that all who obey God are members of his/Jesus' spiritual family.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The True Family of Jesus (NLT)

The people whom Jesus considered to be his true family

People who do the will of God are like the true family of Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 3:31–35 and Luke 8:19–21.

12:50

For whoever does the will of My Father in heaven is My brother and sister and mother.”

- Whoever does what my heavenly Father wants him to do is my brother and sister and mother.”
- My younger brother and younger sister and mother are those who obey God, my heavenly Father.”

For: Verse 12:50 explains what Jesus said in 12:49. The Greek introduces this explanation with a conjunction that the BSB translates as For.

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either.

whoever does the will of My Father in heaven: This clause means “whoever does what my Father wants/ desires” or “whoever obeys God.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Whoever does what my Father in heaven wants (GNT)

The person who does what my heavenly Father wants him to do

Anyone who obeys my Father in heaven (CEV)

is My brother and sister and mother: Some languages distinguish between older brother and sister, and younger brother and sister. If that is true in your language, you should use the term for younger brother and younger sister. For example:

is my younger brother and younger sister and mother

is like my younger sibling and my mother

Matthew 13:1

Section 13:1–17: Jesus told the parable about the man who sowed seeds

In this section, Jesus told the first of eight. Some commentators do not consider 13:51–52 a parable, so they count seven parables in this chapter. Parables about the kingdom of heaven. These parables helped the disciples understand the kingdom of heaven. They also helped the disciples understand why some people did not accept Jesus’ message.

The first parable is about a farmer who sows seed in different kinds of soil. The different kinds of soil represent different kinds of people and how they accept God’s Word. In 13:18 Jesus referred to this parable as “the parable of the sower.”

After Jesus told this parable, he explained why he told parables (13:10–17).

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

A story about a farmer planting seed

The parable about the four kinds of soil

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 4:1–12 and Luke 8:4–10.

13:1a

That same day Jesus went out of the house

- ¶ That same day Jesus left the house
- ¶ On that same day Jesus exited the house where he was staying.

That same day: This phrase indicates that the events in this section occurred on the same day as the events at the end of chapter 12.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

On that same day

That day also

Jesus went out of the house: The phrase the house refers to the house that was implied in 12:46. It was the house where he was teaching. This house was probably in the town of Capernaum where Jesus often stayed.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus left the house where he had been teaching

Jesus exited the house where he was staying

13:1b

and sat by the sea.

- and sat down on the shore of the lake.
- He went to the lake of Galilee and sat down by the shore to speak/teach.

sat: In Jewish culture, a teacher sat to teach and the learners stood. In this context, Jesus did not sit because he was tired. In some languages, it may be necessary to make some of this information explicit. For example:

sat down to teach (GNT)

sat down to speak

If it is necessary in your language to say who Jesus taught or what he taught about, you can say:

he sat down to teach the people about the kingdom of God/heaven

by the sea: The phrase the sea refers to Lake Galilee. This lake is 23 kilometers long and 10 kilometers wide. It is a freshwater lake. It does not contain salt water.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

beside Lake Galilee (CEV)

on the shore/edge of the lake

Matthew 13:2

Section 13:1–17: Jesus told the parable about the man who sowed seeds

In this section, Jesus told the first of eight. Some commentators do not consider 13:51–52 a parable, so they count seven parables in this chapter. Parables about the kingdom of heaven. These parables helped the disciples understand the kingdom of heaven. They also helped the disciples understand why some people did not accept Jesus' message.

The first parable is about a farmer who sows seed in different kinds of soil. The different kinds of soil represent different kinds of people and how they accept God's Word. In 13:18 Jesus referred to this parable as "the parable of the sower."

After Jesus told this parable, he explained why he told parables (13:10–17).

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

A story about a farmer planting seed

The parable about the four kinds of soil

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 4:1–12 and Luke 8:4–10.

13:2a

Such large crowds gathered around Him

- The crowds that gathered around him were so large
- Many people surrounded him to listen to him,

13:2b

that He got into a boat and sat down,

- that he entered a boat and sat in it.
- so he stepped into a boat to speak to them. Then he sat down to teach

13:2a–b

Such large crowds gathered around Him that He got into a boat: The reason that Jesus got into a boat was because a large group of people gathered around him. He got into a boat so he could better speak to all the people.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

A large crowd soon gathered around him, so he got into a boat. (NLT)

He got into a boat because a very large crowd had gathered

The crowd that gathered around him was so large that he got into a boat (GNT)

large crowds: The plural large crowds indicates that the size of the crowd was very large.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

a very large crowd

very many people

He got into a boat: Jesus entered a boat so he could more easily speak to the large crowds. In this way more people could hear him. He did not get into a boat to flee from the crowd. In some languages, it may be necessary to make some of this information explicit. For example:

he entered a boat to more easily speak to the crowd

got: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as got is a specific verb for entering a boat. Here are some other ways to say this:

entered

descended into

stepped/climbed into

You should use whichever verb is appropriate in your language for entering a boat.

boat: This word probably refers to a wooden boat used for fishing. It may or may not have had sails. It was probably big enough for eight to twelve people to sit inside.

sat down: As in 13:1b, Jesus sat down to teach the people. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

sat down to teach

13:2c

while all the people stood on the shore.

- The whole crowd stood along the shore.
- while the people were standing by the edge of the water.

while: This conjunction indicates that the crowd stood on the shore at the same time as Jesus was in the boat.

Here is another way to translate this:

and

all the people: This phrase refers to everyone in the large crowds of 13:2a.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the entire crowd (GW)

all the people (NIV)

shore: This word describes the land close to the edge of a lake or sea. The people stood on the land next to the lake.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

beach (ESV)

beside/near the water

at the edge of the water

Matthew 13:3

Section 13:1–17: Jesus told the parable about the man who sowed seeds

In this section, Jesus told the first of eightSome commentators do not consider 13:51–52 a parable, so they count seven parables in this chapter. parables about the kingdom of heaven. These parables helped the disciples understand the kingdom of heaven. They also helped the disciples understand why some people did not accept Jesus' message.

The first parable is about a farmer who sows seed in different kinds of soil. The different kinds of soil represent different kinds of people and how they accept God's Word. In 13:18 Jesus referred to this parable as "the parable of the sower."

After Jesus told this parable, he explained why he told parables (13:10–17).

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

A story about a farmer planting seed

The parable about the four kinds of soil

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 4:1–12 and Luke 8:4–10.

13:3a

And He told them many things in parables, saying,

- Then he told them many things using parables. One he told was this:
- He taught them many things by means of stories. Here is one:

And He told them many things in parables: This clause indicates that Jesus used parables to teach the people many things.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

He used parables to tell them many things (GNT)

He taught them many things by means of stories

parables: The Greek word that the BSB translates as parables is literally "comparisons." Parables teach a lesson or truth by showing how it is like something that people already know about. Jesus used several types of parables including metaphors, wise sayings,

and stories taken from everyday life. The hearer usually has to discover the lesson for himself.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

- Use a general term in your language that can be used to describe the different types of parables that Jesus used. Here are some examples:

illustrations

metaphors

- Use a descriptive term. For example:

symbolic sayings/words/stories

- Use more than one word or descriptive term for the different types of parables that Jesus used. For example:

stories and illustrations

symbols and sayings

saying: In this context, the verb saying indicates that the following words are a parable.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

such as this one: (NLT)

and began: (JBP)

One parable he told was this:

and he told one saying,

If your language has a way to signal the beginning of a parable, you should consider using it here.

13:3b

“A farmer went out to sow his seed.

- “A farmer went to his field/garden to plant/scatter seeds.
- “A man went to throw/plant seeds on his land/farm.

farmer: The Greek word that the BSB translates as farmer is literally “one who sows/plants (seed).” It refers to a farmer who is doing a specific type of farm work. He is sowing seeds.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

sower (ESV)

a man (GNT)

went out: The Greek word that the BSB translates as went out probably indicates that the farmer left his house and went to his field.

to sow his seed: The word sow refers to a specific method of planting seed. In this method, a farmer throws seeds in a way that scatters the seeds to the side and in front of him. This method allowed a farmer to plant a large area quickly. This method is different than planting the seeds one by one in the ground.

This method of planting is important to this parable, because some seed accidentally fell in bad places. This method does not describe a foolish farmer.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

- Explain the method in the text:

throw seeds

scatter seeds to plant

- Include a footnote to explain this method. For example:

The Jewish custom was to scatter seeds over ground that the farmer had plowed. In this way, the farmer could plant a large area quickly, even though some seed fell in bad places.

It may also be helpful to include a picture here of a farmer scattering his seeds.

Matthew 13:4

Section 13:1–17: Jesus told the parable about the man who sowed seeds

In this section, Jesus told the first of eightSome commentators do not consider 13:51–52 a parable, so they count seven parables in this chapter. parables about the kingdom of heaven. These parables helped the disciples understand the kingdom of heaven. They also helped the disciples understand why some people did not accept Jesus’ message.

The first parable is about a farmer who sows seed in different kinds of soil. The different kinds of soil represent different kinds of people and how they accept God’s Word. In 13:18 Jesus referred to this parable as “the parable of the sower.”

After Jesus told this parable, he explained why he told parables (13:10–17).

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

A story about a farmer planting seed

The parable about the four kinds of soil

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 4:1–12 and Luke 8:4–10.

13:4a

And as he was sowing,

- As he planted/scattered,
- While he planted them,

13:4b

some seed fell along the path,

- some seeds/grain fell on a path,
- some of them landed on a footpath.

13:4a–b

some seed: The seeds that the farmer sowed were some type of grain seeds. It was probably wheat or barley. If you need to say what kind of seed the farmer was planting, here are some suggestions:

- Use a general word for grain.
- Use a specific word for wheat or barley, which were grown in Israel in that time.
- Compare this to something that is commonly grown in your area. For example:

a farmer went out to plant something like rice

fell along the path: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as along the path describes an area where the soil was not cultivated and was hard. Because of the method of planting, some seeds accidentally fell on such places. In these areas birds could easily find the seeds and eat them.

The Greek word that the BSB translates as along normally means “beside.” However, in this context, it is probably more natural in many languages to translate it as “on.” For example:

fell on a footpath (NLT)

the path: This word refers to a footpath through or alongside a field. People who walk there trample on the soil and make it hard.

13:4c

and the birds came and devoured it.

- and birds came and ate all of them.
- Some birds flew in/down and pecked them until they were finished.

the birds: The phrase the birds refers to birds in general and does not refer to any birds mentioned before. Introduce the birds in the story in the most natural way in your language. For example:

birds

some birds

came: It may be more natural in your language to use the verb “fly” rather than the verb came. For example:

the birds flew there

swooped down (JBP)

devoured it: The Greek word that the BSB translates as devoured refers to eating something completely.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

ate it up (NIV)

ate all of them

If you have a specific word or phrase that describes the way that birds eat, such as the English word “pecked,” you should use that word here. For example:

pecked them until they were gone

gobbled them up (JBP)

it: The pronoun it refers to the seeds. If you used the plural form “seeds” in 13:3b, you should use the plural pronoun here. For example:

them

Matthew 13:5

Section 13:1–17: Jesus told the parable about the man who sowed seeds

In this section, Jesus told the first of eight. Some commentators do not consider 13:51–52 a parable, so they

count seven parables in this chapter. parables about the kingdom of heaven. These parables helped the disciples understand the kingdom of heaven. They also helped the disciples understand why some people did not accept Jesus' message.

The first parable is about a farmer who sows seed in different kinds of soil. The different kinds of soil represent different kinds of people and how they accept God's Word. In 13:18 Jesus referred to this parable as "the parable of the sower."

After Jesus told this parable, he explained why he told parables (13:10-17).

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

A story about a farmer planting seed

The parable about the four kinds of soil

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 4:1-12 and Luke 8:4-10.

13:5a

Some fell on rocky ground, where it did not have much soil.

- Other seeds/grain fell on bedrock covered with a little soil.
- Some seeds/grain fell on shallow soil which had solid rock underneath.

Some: The word Some refers to another group of seeds.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Other seeds (NLT)

Some of the seeds

fell: Translate this verb as you did in 13:4b.

rocky ground, where it did not have much soil: The Greek word that the BSB translates as rocky ground refers to ground that has a layer of solid rock underneath. This kind of ground did not have much soil over the solid rock. It was shallow ground. This clause does not refer to soil and rocks mixed together.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

shallow soil with underlying rock (NLT)

solid rock with a thin layer of soil

bedrock where there is only a little soil on top

it: The pronoun it refers to the seeds. In some translations, a pronoun here is not necessary. For example:

where there was little soil (GW)

did not have much soil: The word soil refers to the kind of ground/earth where plants grow. In this situation, there was very little soil on top of the layer of rock.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

there wasn't much dirt (NCV)

13:5b

It sprang up quickly because the soil was shallow.

- These seeds/grain sprouted quickly because the soil was shallow/thin.
- The soil wasn't deep, so the seeds grew quickly.

It sprang up quickly: This clause refers to the seeds quickly sprouting and becoming plants.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

The seeds soon sprouted (GNT)

The plants came up quickly

It: As in 13:5a, the pronoun It refers to the seeds.

because: The Greek word that the BSB translates as because introduces the reason why the seeds sprang up quickly.

Here is another way to translate this word:

because

the soil was shallow: The clause the soil was shallow has a similar meaning to "it did not have much soil" in 13:5a. It means that they (the seeds) did not have much soil in which to grow.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

the soil was not deep

General Comment on 13:5b

The clause “It sprang up quickly” is the result clause, and the clause “because the soil was shallow” is the reason clause here. In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of these clauses. For example:

Since the soil was shallow, the seeds sprang up quickly

The soil was shallow, so the seeds sprang up quickly

Matthew 13:6

Section 13:1–17: Jesus told the parable about the man who sowed seeds

In this section, Jesus told the first of eightSome commentators do not consider 13:51–52 a parable, so they count seven parables in this chapter. parables about the kingdom of heaven. These parables helped the disciples understand the kingdom of heaven. They also helped the disciples understand why some people did not accept Jesus’ message.

The first parable is about a farmer who sows seed in different kinds of soil. The different kinds of soil represent different kinds of people and how they accept God’s Word. In 13:18 Jesus referred to this parable as “the parable of the sower.”

After Jesus told this parable, he explained why he told parables (13:10–17).

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

A story about a farmer planting seed

The parable about the four kinds of soil

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 4:1–12 and Luke 8:4–10.

13:6a

But when the sun rose, the seedlings were scorched,

- But when the sun rose high in the sky, the plants wilted.
- When the sun got hot, the plants drooped

But: There is something unexpected here. The seeds sprouted quickly (13:5b), but the plants did not live long (13:6). The BSB indicates this unexpected event with the conjunction But.

In some languages, it may be more natural to use a different conjunction or a phrase here. For example:

Then

In other languages, no conjunction is necessary here. For example:

When the sun came up

when the sun rose: This clause refers to the hottest part of the day. This was some hours after sunrise. Here this clause does not refer to soon after sunrise. It may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

when the sun rose high in the sky

when the sun became hot

the seedlings were scorched: The word scorched also means “burned.” This word indicates that the heat from the sun caused the plants to become dry and brown.

This is a passive clause. Here are some ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

the plants were dried by the sun

- Use an active verb. For example:

the sun burned the plants

- Use another type of verb. For example:

the plants soon wilted (NLT)

the plants drooped

13:6b

and they withered because they had no root.

- They did not have deep roots, so they died.
- and shriveled and died because they did not have many roots.

they withered: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as withered means “became dry.” When a plant becomes dry, its leaves shrink and turn brown, and the plant dies.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the plants dried up (NCV)

they died (NLT)

they withered/shriveled

because they had no root: The phrase had no root exaggerates the fact that the plants had few roots. The plants did not have deep enough roots to live under the hot sun. The roots could not grow down past the rock to find water. In some languages, it may be more natural not to exaggerate here. For example:

because they did not have deep roots (NCV)

since their roots could not go deep

they did not have enough roots

root: The word root is singular, but refers to any number of roots here. In some languages, it may be more natural to use the plural “roots” here.

General Comment on 13:6b

The clause “because they had no root” is the reason clause. The clause “they withered” is the result clause. In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of these clauses. For example:

And since they had no root, they withered away.
(ESV)

and because the roots had not grown deep enough, the plants soon dried up. (GNT)

Matthew 13:7

Section 13:1–17: Jesus told the parable about the man who sowed seeds

In this section, Jesus told the first of eight. Some commentators do not consider 13:51–52 a parable, so they count seven parables in this chapter. Parables about the kingdom of heaven. These parables helped the disciples understand the kingdom of heaven. They also helped the disciples understand why some people did not accept Jesus’ message.

The first parable is about a farmer who sows seed in different kinds of soil. The different kinds of soil rep-

resent different kinds of people and how they accept God’s Word. In 13:18 Jesus referred to this parable as “the parable of the sower.”

After Jesus told this parable, he explained why he told parables (13:10–17).

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

A story about a farmer planting seed

The parable about the four kinds of soil

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 4:1–12 and Luke 8:4–10.

13:7a

Other seed fell among thorns,

- Other seeds/grain fell on ground that had thorn plants
- Some other seeds/grain fell in a place where there were thorny weeds/thistles,

Other seed fell among thorns: The phrase fell among thorns probably refers to soil where roots or seeds of thorny plants were present. So when the seeds began to grow, the thorn plants also grew. It is also possible that these seeds fell along the edge of the field where thorny plants were already growing.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Some other seeds fell where thornbushes grew up (CEV)

Other seeds fell where thorns habitually grow

Other seeds fell upon soil with thorn seeds/roots

fell: Translate this verb as you did in 13:4b and 13:5a.

sowing seeds near thorns

thorns: The Greek word that the BSB translates as thorns refers to any kind of thorny plant. In this context, this word refers to either:

1. young thorny plants
2. the seeds or roots of thorny plants

Some ways to translate the word thorns are:

- Use a general term in your language for thorny plants or for undesirable plants that compete with grain plants. For example:

young thorny plants/bushes

thorn seeds/roots

thistles/briars

- Use a specific word that describes a strong, fast-growing plant from your area that is annoying to farmers. If you choose a specific plant, try to choose one that has thorns. In 13:7b, these thorns grow tall, perhaps one meter or more. So do not use a word for a plant that only grows close to the ground.

13:7b

which grew up and choked the seedlings.

- that grew and crowded/squeezed them.
- and those weeds/thistles grew and hindered the good plants from growing well.

which grew up: The phrase which grew up refers to the thorn plants growing tall.

choked the seedlings: The Greek word that the BSB translates as choked means “grab at the neck and squeeze so (the person) cannot breathe.” In this context, the verb choked figuratively refers to the thorn plants crowding the good plants. The plants did not have enough room, soil, water, or sunlight to grow well.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

crowded the grain/good plants

squeezed/drowned them

hindered the grain from growing well

Matthew 13:8

Section 13:1–17: Jesus told the parable about the man who sowed seeds

In this section, Jesus told the first of eight. Some commentators do not consider 13:51–52 a parable, so they count seven parables in this chapter. Parables about the kingdom of heaven. These parables helped the disciples understand the kingdom of heaven. They also helped the disciples understand why some people did not accept Jesus’ message.

The first parable is about a farmer who sows seed in different kinds of soil. The different kinds of soil represent different kinds of people and how they accept

God’s Word. In 13:18 Jesus referred to this parable as “the parable of the sower.”

After Jesus told this parable, he explained why he told parables (13:10–17).

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

A story about a farmer planting seed

The parable about the four kinds of soil

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 4:1–12 and Luke 8:4–10.

13:8a

Still other seed fell on good soil and produced a crop—

- Some other seeds/grain fell in good soil, and the plants bore a crop.
- But other seeds fell on good ground. They sprouted, grew, and yielded a harvest.

There is a contrast here. The contrast is between the seeds which failed to grow in 13:4–7 and the seeds here in 13:8. Some versions indicate this contrast with the conjunction “but.”

Still other seed fell: Translate fell as you did in 13:4b.

good soil: This phrase refers to the kind of soil in which plants grow well.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

fertile soil (NLT)

and produced a crop: There is some implied information here. The implied information is that the seeds on good soil “sprouted and grew into mature plants.” Only then could these plants produce seeds/fruit. In some languages, it may be necessary to make some of this implied information explicit. For example:

where it grew and produced a crop (NCV)

They sprouted and grew and produced a crop of grain.

produced a crop: The word crop here refers to the seeds/fruit in the mature plants that are ready for harvest.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

produced grain (ESV)

yielded a good harvest

fructified

13:8b

a hundredfold, sixtyfold, or thirtyfold.

- Some of these bore/produced one hundred times what was planted, some sixty times, and some thirty times.
- Some plants yielded a hundred seeds each, some produced sixty seeds each, and others produced thirty seeds each.

a hundredfold, sixtyfold, or thirtyfold: The numbers a hundredfold, sixtyfold and thirtyfold are the multiple numbers of new seeds/grain that the mature plants produced. For each seed that was sown, that much more was produced from it. Some plants produced heads of grain that had a hundred seeds. Other plants produced heads that had sixty seeds. Some plants produced heads with thirty seeds.

Each of these numbers represents good harvests of various sizes. If this is not clear to your readers, you may want to indicate that these numbers are relative. For example:

such as thirty, sixty, or even a hundred times

for example thirty, sixty, or even a hundred times

You may also want to add a footnote. For example:

All of these were very good harvests. The average amount that people harvested in the provinces of Galilee and Judea at that time was ten seeds for every seed that was sown.

Here are some other ways to translate these numbers:

- Use numerals or number words from the major language in the area. For example:

such as 30, 60, or even 100 times

- Use descriptive words instead of numbers. For example:

a good harvest, a great harvest, and an amazing harvest

Matthew 13:9

Section 13:1–17: Jesus told the parable about the man who sowed seeds

In this section, Jesus told the first of eight. Some commentators do not consider 13:51–52 a parable, so they count seven parables in this chapter. Parables about the kingdom of heaven. These parables helped the disciples understand the kingdom of heaven. They also helped the disciples understand why some people did not accept Jesus' message.

The first parable is about a farmer who sows seed in different kinds of soil. The different kinds of soil represent different kinds of people and how they accept God's Word. In 13:18 Jesus referred to this parable as "the parable of the sower."

After Jesus told this parable, he explained why he told parables (13:10–17).

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

A story about a farmer planting seed

The parable about the four kinds of soil

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 4:1–12 and Luke 8:4–10.

13:9

He who has ears, let him hear."

- Everyone who is able to hear should listen to what I am saying."
- You^(plur) who are able to hear what I say, think about it."

The saying in this verse also occurs in Matthew 11:15, Mark 4:9, Mark 4:23, Luke 8:8, Luke 14:35. You should translate all these passages in the same way.

He who has ears, let him hear: These words are a saying that Jesus used to command or urge the crowd to carefully think about the words that they had just heard. This saying assumes that everyone in the crowd had ears and were able to hear. So it is addressed to all the people who were listening to Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this saying:

- Use "they" or "you" instead of He. For example:

All those who have ears, let them hear.

All of you who have ears, hear/listen.

- Use a different type of clause. In some languages it may be more natural to use an “if” clause or a reason clause. For example:

If/Since you have ears, then pay attention.

- In some languages, it may be more natural to refer to the event of hearing instead of the fact of having ears. For example:

You people who can hear me, listen. (NCV)

Anyone who can hear, think about that parable.

let him hear: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as let him hear is a command in the third person. It does not express permission. For example:

Anyone who is willing to hear should listen and understand!

You people who can hear me, listen (NCV)

In some languages it may be necessary to supply some information and say what the listener should be listening to. For example:

let him listen to me

he should hear my words

he must listen to what I say

Matthew 13:10

Section 13:1–17: Jesus told the parable about the man who sowed seeds

In this section, Jesus told the first of eight. Some commentators do not consider 13:51–52 a parable, so they count seven parables in this chapter. Parables about the kingdom of heaven. These parables helped the disciples understand the kingdom of heaven. They also helped the disciples understand why some people did not accept Jesus' message.

The first parable is about a farmer who sows seed in different kinds of soil. The different kinds of soil represent different kinds of people and how they accept God's Word. In 13:18 Jesus referred to this parable as “the parable of the sower.”

After Jesus told this parable, he explained why he told parables (13:10–17).

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

A story about a farmer planting seed

The parable about the four kinds of soil

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 4:1–12 and Luke 8:4–10.

Paragraph 13:10–17

Jesus began a new topic here. He explained why he used parables. Some English versions begin a new section here. If you want to do that, here are some possible section headings:

Jesus explained the reason he taught using parables

The Purpose of the Parables (NRSV)

13:10a

Then the disciples came to Jesus and asked,

- ¶ Later the disciples approached him and asked him,
- ¶ Afterwards the disciples went to Jesus and asked him,

Then the disciples came to Jesus and asked: Mark 4:10a tells us that Jesus was alone when the disciples came to him in private and asked him why he taught in parables. This indicates that 13:10–23 did not happen immediately after Jesus told the parable. It happened later, away from the crowds.

If people in your area will think that the disciples interrupted Jesus or asked this question in front of the crowd, you may want to:

- Make some of this implied information explicit in the text. For example:

Later the disciples came to him

The disciples came to him privately

- Include a footnote to explain the implied information. For example:

The disciples came to him privately after the crowds were gone (Mark 4:10).

came to Jesus and asked: This phrase shows that the disciples approached Jesus and started the discussion. They started the discussion by asking him a question.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

approached him and asked (JBP)

came to him with a question and asked

13:10b

“Why do You speak to the people in parables?”

- “Why do you use parables when you talk to the people?” (NLT)
- “Lord, when you speak to the people, why do you use stories?”

Why do You speak to the people in parables?: This is a real question. It is not a rhetorical question or a rebuke. Translate this clause as a real question.

Here are some other ways to translate this question:

Why do you use parables when you talk to the people? (GNT)

Teacher/Lord, when you speak to the people, why do you use parables?

to the people: The phrase the people refers to the large crowds of people introduced in 13:2.

in parables: See how you translated this phrase in 13:3.

Matthew 13:11

Section 13:1–17: Jesus told the parable about the man who sowed seeds

In this section, Jesus told the first of eight. Some commentators do not consider 13:51–52 a parable, so they count seven parables in this chapter. Parables about the kingdom of heaven. These parables helped the disciples understand the kingdom of heaven. They also helped the disciples understand why some people did not accept Jesus’ message.

The first parable is about a farmer who sows seed in different kinds of soil. The different kinds of soil represent different kinds of people and how they accept God’s Word. In 13:18 Jesus referred to this parable as “the parable of the sower.”

After Jesus told this parable, he explained why he told parables (13:10–17).

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

A story about a farmer planting seed

The parable about the four kinds of soil

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 4:1–12 and Luke 8:4–10.

Paragraph 13:10–17

Jesus began a new topic here. He explained why he used parables. Some English versions begin a new section here. If you want to do that, here are some possible section headings:

Jesus explained the reason he taught using parables

The Purpose of the Parables (NRSV)

13:11a

He replied,

- He answered them,

He replied: In Greek, there is a word that occurs after this phrase. The BSB does not translate this word. There are two ways to interpret this Greek word:

1. It is a speech introducer and means that. It introduces Jesus’ answer. So most English versions do not translate this word. For example:

He replied, “The knowledge....” (NIV) (BSB, NIV, GNT, RSV, NET, ESV, NLT, NASB, GW, CEV, REB, NCV)

1. It is a conjunction and means because. It introduces the reason that Jesus spoke in parables. For example:

He replied, “Because the knowledge...” (NIV2011) (NIV2011, NJB, JBP, KJV)

Here are some issues to consider when deciding which interpretation to follow:

- The majority of English versions follow interpretation (1). And the quote in the parallel passage in Mark 4:11 begins without the conjunction “because.”

- The meaning of the verse does not change if you choose interpretation (2). It may even be more natural in some languages to start the quote with “I use parables because...” Many commentators also follow this interpretation.

13:11b

“The knowledge of the mysteries of the kingdom of heaven has been given to you,

- “You^(plur) have been permitted to know the secrets regarding the kingdom of heaven,
- “God has revealed/told to you the secrets of his kingdom,

The knowledge of the mysteries of the kingdom of heaven has been given to you: Another way to translate this clause is: “The secrets of the kingdom of heaven have been given to you to know.”

In some languages, secrets are not something that can be given. They are “revealed” or “told.” You should use the verb that is most natural in your language for telling a secret. In this context, it is God through Jesus who has revealed certain secrets to the disciples.

This clause is passive. Here are some ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

You have been given the opportunity to know the secrets of the kingdom of heaven (NET)

You are permitted/allowed to know the secrets of the kingdom of heaven

- Use an active verb. For example:

God has revealed/shown to you the secrets of the kingdom of heaven

God has told you the secrets about the kingdom of heaven

I have explained the secrets about the kingdom of heaven to you (CEV)

Notice that in the active examples above, the phrase The knowledge of is not translated. When secrets are revealed, it is implied that the person now knows them. So it may not be necessary to translate the phrase The knowledge of.

the mysteries: The Greek word that the BSB translates as mysteries refers to truths that were previously hidden or unknown. They were previously a mystery to everyone. Now, God reveals these truths only to certain people.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

secret/hidden truths

mysteries (NJB)

the kingdom of heaven: In the phrase the kingdom of heaven, the word heaven is a figure of speech called metonymy. In this figure of speech, heaven refers to God, but it refers to him indirectly by naming the place where he lives and rules. So the phrase the kingdom of heaven means the same thing as “the kingdom of God.”

Here are some ways to translate heaven in this context:

- Make some information explicit. For example:

the one/Lord who lives in heaven

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

God

This phrase also occurs in 3:2b, 5:3b, 10:7b, and 11:11c. Also see kingdom of heaven in the Glossary.

13:11c

but not to them.

- but they have not been permitted to know them.
- but he has not revealed/told these secrets to them.

but: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between two types of people: the ones who know the secrets, and the ones who do not know them. The BSB indicates this contrast with the conjunction but.

In Greek, this contrast is also emphasized by putting the two groups first in each clause. For example:

^{11b} to you it has been given

^{11c} to them it has not been given

If there is a way in your language to emphasize and contrast the two groups of people, you should consider doing it here.

not to them: Some words are implied from 13:11b but not repeated here. It may be more natural in your language to repeat some or all of the implied words. For example:

these secrets have not been revealed to them

he has not told/explained the secrets about the kingdom of heaven to them

Matthew 13:12

Section 13:1–17: Jesus told the parable about the man who sowed seeds

In this section, Jesus told the first of eight. Some commentators do not consider 13:51–52 a parable, so they count seven parables in this chapter. Parables about the kingdom of heaven. These parables helped the disciples understand the kingdom of heaven. They also helped the disciples understand why some people did not accept Jesus' message.

The first parable is about a farmer who sows seed in different kinds of soil. The different kinds of soil represent different kinds of people and how they accept God's Word. In 13:18 Jesus referred to this parable as "the parable of the sower."

After Jesus told this parable, he explained why he told parables (13:10–17).

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

A story about a farmer planting seed

The parable about the four kinds of soil

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 4:1–12 and Luke 8:4–10.

Paragraph 13:10–17

Jesus began a new topic here. He explained why he used parables. Some English versions begin a new section here. If you want to do that, here are some possible section headings:

Jesus explained the reason he taught using parables

The Purpose of the Parables (NRSV)

13:12a

Whoever has will be given more,

- The person who has that knowledge will be given more,
- Those who have understanding will be given more, (NCV)
- The person who understands these things, God will help him understand even more things,

Verse 13:12 gives more information about the teaching in 13:11. The Greek introduces this extra information with a conjunction that the many English versions translate as "For." In this context, it does not mean "because." Do not translate this verse as if it were the reason for 13:12.

Here is another way to translate this conjunction:

Furthermore

The BSB and many other English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate it either.

Whoever has will be given more: Some words from 13:11 are implied but not repeated in this verse part. In 13:11b, knowledge was given, and here more will be given. In some languages, it may be natural to make this information explicit. For example:

Whoever has that knowledge will be given more

Those who have understanding will be given more (NCV)

Those who understand [these mysteries] will be given [more knowledge] (GW)

In some languages, it may be necessary to have an object for the verb has and given, even if it is not the word "knowledge" or "understanding." For example:

Everyone who has something will be given more. (CEV)

will be given more: This verb is passive. God is the one who will give more knowledge/understanding.

Here are some ways to translate this clause as an active clause:

God will give him more

God will help him understand even more things

13:12b

and he will have an abundance.

- and that person's knowledge will be abundant/much.
- and they will have all they need. (NCV)
- and he will understand many, many things.

he will have an abundance: The Greek word that the BSB translates as abundance means "more than enough, full to overflowing." The word refers to God giving that person so much knowledge that the person will have no lack.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he will have more than enough of knowledge

he will have lots of it

13:12c

Whoever does not have,

- But whoever does not have that knowledge,
- But those who do not have understanding, (NCV)
- However, the person who does not understand these things,

13:12d

even what he has will be taken away from him.

- even what he has will be taken from him.
- even what they have will be taken away from them. (NCV)
- God will remove even the little bit that he had/understood.

13:12c-d

The Greek begins this clause with a conjunction that indicates contrast here. The contrast is between the different types of people: the one who has, and the one who does not have. Many English versions indicate this contrast with the conjunction "but."

Here is another way to indicate this contrast:

however

Whoever does not have, even what he has will be taken away from him: As in 13:12b, some words from 13:11 are implied but not repeated in this verse part. In 13:11b, knowledge was given. Here that knowledge/understanding will be taken away. In some languages,

it may be natural to make this information explicit. For example:

those who do not have understanding, even what they have will be taken away from them (NCV)

some people don't understand [these mysteries].... Even what they understand will be taken away from them (GW)

people who don't have anything will lose even what little they have (CEV)

The phrase does not have is an exaggeration. It refers to a person who has very little understanding/knowledge. In some languages, it may be more natural to translate the meaning without exaggerating. For example:

whoever understands very little, even the little he has will be taken from him

for those who are not listening, even what little understanding they have will be taken away from them (NLT)

even what he has will be taken away from him: This clause is passive. God is the one who will take this understanding/knowledge away.

Here are some ways to translate this clause as an active clause:

even what he has, God will take it from him

God will take away even the little knowledge that he has

Matthew 13:13

Section 13:1-17: Jesus told the parable about the man who sowed seeds

In this section, Jesus told the first of eight. Some commentators do not consider 13:51-52 a parable, so they count seven parables in this chapter. Parables about the kingdom of heaven. These parables helped the disciples understand the kingdom of heaven. They also helped the disciples understand why some people did not accept Jesus' message.

The first parable is about a farmer who sows seed in different kinds of soil. The different kinds of soil rep-

resent different kinds of people and how they accept God's Word. In 13:18 Jesus referred to this parable as "the parable of the sower."

After Jesus told this parable, he explained why he told parables (13:10–17).

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

A story about a farmer planting seed

The parable about the four kinds of soil

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 4:1–12 and Luke 8:4–10.

Paragraph 13:10–17

Jesus began a new topic here. He explained why he used parables. Some English versions begin a new section here. If you want to do that, here are some possible section headings:

Jesus explained the reason he taught using parables

The Purpose of the Parables (NRSV)

13:13a

This is why I speak to them in parables:

- That is the reason why I speak to them in parables,
- So/Therefore I speak to them using stories.

This is why I speak to them in parables: There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as This:

1. It refers to the things that Jesus had already said in 13:11–12. In other words, "The secrets of the kingdom have been revealed to you, my disciples, but not to the crowd. That is the reason why I speak to the crowd in parables." For example:

This is why I speak to them this way. (GW) (RSV, ESV, GW, NLT, JBP, KJV, NASB, REB)

1. It refers to the things that Jesus will say in 13:13b–c. In other words, "This/Here is the reason I speak to the crowd in parables: they do not see, hear, or understand." For example:

The reason I use parables in talking to them is (GNT) (BSB, NRSV, NIV, GNT, NET, CEV, NCV, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). In all other places in Matthew where the Greek phrase translated as This is why occurs, it refers to something that has already been said. It does not refer to something yet to be said.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

That is why I speak to them in parables (REB)

So/Therefore, I speak to them in parables.

13:13b

'Though seeing, they do not see;

- because even though they look, they do not see,
- I also speak to them using parables/stories because, they see things, but they do not really see them.

This verse part begins with a Greek conjunction that is often translated as "because." It introduces the reason why Jesus spoke to the people in parables. He spoke to them in parables because they did not see, hear, or understand (13:13b–c).

Here are some ways to translate this word:

- Use the word "because" or "for." For example:

For

- Repeat part of 13:13a. For example:

I speak like this because

I speak to them in parables because

- Leave it untranslated. For example:

^aThis is why I speak to them this way. ^bThey see, but they're blind. (GW)

Though seeing, they do not see: The Greek words that the BSB translates as seeing and see are different forms of the same verb. However, they are used in different senses here. The word seeing refers to literally seeing something with the eyes; something like a person, object, or event. The word see refers to figuratively seeing something with the mind. This means understanding the meaning of what is seen. There is a contrast between these two words that the BSB expresses with the word Though. Some versions indicate this contrast with a conjunction like "but."

Here are some ways to translate this clause:

- Use different verbs for these ideas. For example:

when they look, they cannot see (CEV)

- Modify one of the verbs. For example:

They see, but they don't really see. (NCV)

In some languages, it may be necessary to supply objects for the two verbs. For example:

they see things, but they do not perceive them

13:13c

though hearing, they do not hear or understand.'

- and even though they listen, they do not hear or understand.
- They hear things, but they do not really hear or understand.

In the Greek, a word that is often translated as "and" connects the first half of the saying (13:13b) with the second half of the saying (13:13c). The BSB indicates the connection with a semi-colon at the end of 13:13b. The NCV begins a new sentence here and allows the context to imply the connection. Translate this connection in a way that is natural in your language.

though hearing, they do not hear or understand:

This clause is parallel to 13:13b. The word hearing refers to literally hearing something with the ears. The word hear refers to figuratively hearing something with the mind. This means understanding the meaning of what is heard.

There is a contrast between these two words that the BSB expresses with the word though. Some versions indicate this contrast with a conjunction like "but."

Here are some ways to translate this clause:

- Use different verbs for these ideas. For example:

when they listen, they cannot hear (CEV)

- Modify one of the verbs. For example:

They hear, but they don't really hear (NCV)

In some languages, it may be necessary to supply objects for the two verbs. For example:

they listen to things, but they do not hear them

Matthew 13:14

Section 13:1–17: Jesus told the parable about the man who sowed seeds

In this section, Jesus told the first of eightSome commentators do not consider 13:51–52 a parable, so they count seven parables in this chapter. parables about the kingdom of heaven. These parables helped the disciples understand the kingdom of heaven. They also helped the disciples understand why some people did not accept Jesus' message.

The first parable is about a farmer who sows seed in different kinds of soil. The different kinds of soil represent different kinds of people and how they accept God's Word. In 13:18 Jesus referred to this parable as "the parable of the sower."

After Jesus told this parable, he explained why he told parables (13:10–17).

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

A story about a farmer planting seed

The parable about the four kinds of soil

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 4:1–12 and Luke 8:4–10.

Paragraph 13:10–17

Jesus began a new topic here. He explained why he used parables. Some English versions begin a new section here. If you want to do that, here are some possible section headings:

Jesus explained the reason he taught using parables

The Purpose of the Parables (NRSV)

13:14a

In them the prophecy of Isaiah is fulfilled:

- The prophecy of Isaiah is fulfilled in them. He said,
- They have made come true the things that Isaiah foretold/prophesied when he said,

The Greek conjunction that the BSB leaves untranslated literally means "and" (as in the NET). This conjunction simply connects this verse to the previous verse.

Here is another way to connect this verse to the previous verse:

- Indicate that this verse is the result or conclusion of the previous verse. For example:

So (GNT)

In them the prophecy of Isaiah is fulfilled: The pronoun *them* refers to the people in 13:13. It refers to the Jews of Jesus' time who did not believe in Jesus. The phrase *In them* indicates that they made Isaiah's prophecy come true.

This clause is passive. Here are some ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

The prophecy of Isaiah is being fulfilled in them (REB)

- Use an active verb. For example:

they make Isaiah's prophecy come true (GW)

- Use another type of verb. For example:

The things that the prophet Isaiah foretold/predicted, these things have come true through them.

The things that the prophet Isaiah foretold have happened to them.

fulfilled: The word fulfilled means "come true."

This word last occurred in 12:17.

13:14b

'You will be ever hearing but never understanding;

- "'You^(plur) will surely/repeatedly hear, but you will not understand.
- "'Even though you^(plur) will hear the truth well/clearly, you will never understand it.

In 13:14b-15g, Jesus quoted a passage from the Old Testament book of Isaiah.

You will be ever hearing: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as *You will be ever hearing* is more literally "Hearing you will hear." This expression emphasizes the fact that the Jews will hear God's truth.

Here are some ways to translate this clause:

- Focus on the fact that the Jews will definitely hear the message. For example:

You will surely/certainly hear

You will hear clearly (GW)

You will hear well

- Focus on the fact that the Jews will hear the message more than once. For example:

You will repeatedly hear

You will listen and listen (NCV)

but never understanding: There is a contrast between the two clauses in 13:14b. The contrast is between the verbs "hearing" and never understanding. Many English versions indicate this contrast with the conjunction *but*.

Other English versions do not put a conjunction here. For example:

you will not understand (NLT)

13:14c

you will be ever seeing but never perceiving.

- You^(plur) will surely/repeatedly see, but you will not comprehend,
- Even though you^(plur) will see well/clearly what I do, you will never understand it.

you will be ever seeing: This clause is parallel to 13:14b. It emphasizes the fact that the Jews will see what God does.

Here are some ways to translate this clause:

- Focus on the fact that the Jews will definitely see what God does. For example:

you will certainly/clearly see

You will see clearly (GW)

you will see well what I do

- Focus on the fact that the Jews will see God work more than one time. For example:

You will repeatedly see

You will look and look (NCV)

but never perceiving: The verb perceiving refers to understanding what is seen.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

but never comprehend (GW)

but never understand it

Matthew 13:15

Section 13:1–17: Jesus told the parable about the man who sowed seeds

In this section, Jesus told the first of eight. Some commentators do not consider 13:51–52 a parable, so they count seven parables in this chapter. Parables about the kingdom of heaven. These parables helped the disciples understand the kingdom of heaven. They also helped the disciples understand why some people did not accept Jesus' message.

The first parable is about a farmer who sows seed in different kinds of soil. The different kinds of soil represent different kinds of people and how they accept God's Word. In 13:18 Jesus referred to this parable as "the parable of the sower."

After Jesus told this parable, he explained why he told parables (13:10–17).

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

A story about a farmer planting seed

The parable about the four kinds of soil

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 4:1–12 and Luke 8:4–10.

Paragraph 13:10–17

Jesus began a new topic here. He explained why he used parables. Some English versions begin a new section here. If you want to do that, here are some possible section headings:

Jesus explained the reason he taught using parables

The Purpose of the Parables (NRSV)

13:15

In 13:14, God talks to the people. In 13:15, God talks about them. So the pronouns change from "you" to "they."

If people in your area think that 13:15 refers to a different group of people, you may want to:

- Add a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

The words in 13:15 are still directed toward the Jews.

- Change the pronouns in 13:14 from "you" to "they" so they are the same as in 13:15. For example:

^{14b} This people will listen and listen, but not understand; ^{14c} they will look and look, but not see, (GNT)

13:15a

For this people's heart has grown callous;

- because the minds of these people have become slow/closed,
- These people will be like that because they are not able to understand the truth.

For: Verse 13:15 is the reason for the people not understanding what they see and hear (13:14). The Greek introduces this reason with a conjunction that the BSB translates as For.

Here are some other ways to introduce this reason:

because (GNT)

They will be like that because

In some languages, the context can imply the connection, and it will not be necessary to translate the conjunction.

this people's heart has grown callous: The word heart refers to a person's inner being. It includes the mind, the emotions, and the will. In this context, the word heart probably refers specifically to the mind.

The Greek word that the BSB translates as callous is more literally "thick" or "fat." People with "thick/fat hearts" are people who understand things slowly. When it comes to spiritual things, they are not mentally sharp. They have become this way because they have deliberately refused to listen to the truth.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Translate it using another expression. For example:

the minds of these people have become slow/
closed

the minds of these people do not work/function
well

- Translate the meaning more directly. For example:

These people understand slowly

These people have difficulty understanding the
truth

this people's: The phrase this people's refers to all
the Jewish people as a group.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

this people-group's

this nation's

13:15b they hardly hear with their ears,

- and they have difficulty hearing,
- They do not hear well.

they hardly hear with their ears: This clause indicates that the Jews have reached a point where they have difficulty hearing/understanding spiritual truths. This does not indicate that they are physically deaf.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

they are hard of hearing (NET)

they do not hear/understand God's truth well

The phrase with their ears is already included in the meaning of the verb hear. In some languages, it may be more natural not to translate the phrase with their ears (as in the examples above).

13:15c and they have closed their eyes.

- and they have shut their eyes,
- They have refused to see the truth.

they have closed their eyes: This clause indicates that the Jews have deliberately closed their eyes to the truth. They refuse to see it.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

they refuse to see/understand

they have closed their eyes to the truth

13:15d Otherwise they might see with their eyes, hear with their ears,

- so that their eyes would not see and their ears would not hear
- They did those things in order not to see, or hear,

Otherwise they might see with their eyes: The Greek conjunction the BSB translates as Otherwise expresses negative purpose. It means "in order not to." These people shut their eyes so that they would not see.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

so that they would not see with their eyes (NET)

in order not to see/understand

to avoid using their eyes to see (NJB)

hear with their ears: The conjunction "otherwise" also applies to this clause. In other words:

and so that they would not hear with the ears

The phrase with their ears is already included in the meaning of the verb hear. It may be more natural in your language to leave the phrase with their ears implied.

13:15e understand with their hearts,

- and their minds would not understand.
- or understand the truth.

understand with their hearts: The conjunction "otherwise" also applies to this clause. In other words:

and so that they would not understand with their heart

As in 13:15a, the word hearts refers to their minds. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

their mind understand (REB)

In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate the phrase with their heart. For example:

or understand (CEV)

13:15f and turn,

- They did not want to turn/repent
- They also did those things in order not to turn to me

and turn: The verb turn here refers to repenting.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

turn to me (REB)

changing their ways (NJB)

The conjunction “otherwise” from 13:15d also applies to this verb. In other words:

and so that they would not turn

In some languages, it will be natural to begin a new sentence here. Here are some ways to do that:

They also did those things so that they would not turn/repent

They did not want to turn to me

13:15g and I would heal them.’

- and let me heal them.’
- and be healed. (NCV)

and I would heal them: This clause goes together with the verb “turn” in 13:15f.

Here are some ways to translate it:

and let me heal them

for healing (GW)

and be healed (NCV)

The verb heal probably refers to spiritual healing. But it may also refer to physical healing. For that reason, it is best to translate it literally.

Matthew 13:16

Section 13:1–17: Jesus told the parable about the man who sowed seeds

In this section, Jesus told the first of eightSome commentators do not consider 13:51–52 a parable, so they count seven parables in this chapter. parables about the kingdom of heaven. These parables helped the disciples understand the kingdom of heaven. They also helped the disciples understand why some people did not accept Jesus’ message.

The first parable is about a farmer who sows seed in different kinds of soil. The different kinds of soil represent different kinds of people and how they accept God’s Word. In 13:18 Jesus referred to this parable as “the parable of the sower.”

After Jesus told this parable, he explained why he told parables (13:10–17).

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

A story about a farmer planting seed

The parable about the four kinds of soil

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 4:1–12 and Luke 8:4–10.

Paragraph 13:10–17

Jesus began a new topic here. He explained why he used parables. Some English versions begin a new section here. If you want to do that, here are some possible section headings:

Jesus explained the reason he taught using parables

The Purpose of the Parables (NRSV)

13:16a

But blessed are your eyes because they see,

- But as for you^(plur), your eyes are blessed because they see,
- Then Jesus said to his disciples, “But God has blessed you because you see

The quote from Isaiah finished at the end of 13:15g. In this verse, Jesus began talking to the disciples.

Here are some ways to make this clear:

As for you, (GNT)

Then Jesus said to his disciples,

But: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between the Jewish people described in the quote in 14b–15g and the disciples in 16a–b. The BSB indicates this contrast with the conjunction But.

blessed are your eyes because they see: This clause means that the disciples are blessed because they can see the truth. They are not like other Jews who look at things but do not see/understand them.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

God has blessed you, because your eyes can see (CEV)

You are blessed because you can see

blessed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as blessed refers to the good situation/condition that a person is in when a superior person does something good to him. When God does something good to a human being and is kind to him, that person is in a good situation. He is “blessed,” “fortunate,” and “favored.”

Here are some ways to translate blessed:

Favored/fortunate

God favors/approves

Joyful/desirable is the situation of

How good it is for

This word does not primarily refer to a feeling. However, a person in this good situation will frequently have good feelings like happiness and joy. Do not use a word that only refers to material prosperity or physical health. Do not use a word that refers only to being lucky. This word first occurs in 5:3a. See also bless, Meaning 2, in the Glossary.

13:16b

and your ears because they hear.

- and your ears are blessed because they hear.
- and hear.

and your ears because they hear: Some words from 13:16a are implied but not repeated here. Here is the complete clause:

and blessed are your ears, for they hear

This clause means that the disciples are blessed because they can hear and understand the truth. They are not like other Jews who hear things but do not understand them.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

and your ears can hear (CEV)

and hear

Matthew 13:17

Section 13:1–17: Jesus told the parable about the man who sowed seeds

In this section, Jesus told the first of eight. Some commentators do not consider 13:51–52 a parable, so they count seven parables in this chapter. Parables about the kingdom of heaven. These parables helped the disciples understand the kingdom of heaven. They also helped the disciples understand why some people did not accept Jesus' message.

The first parable is about a farmer who sows seed in different kinds of soil. The different kinds of soil represent different kinds of people and how they accept God's Word. In 13:18 Jesus referred to this parable as “the parable of the sower.”

After Jesus told this parable, he explained why he told parables (13:10–17).

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

A story about a farmer planting seed

The parable about the four kinds of soil

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 4:1–12 and Luke 8:4–10.

Paragraph 13:10–17

Jesus began a new topic here. He explained why he used parables. Some English versions begin a new section here. If you want to do that, here are some possible section headings:

Jesus explained the reason he taught using parables

The Purpose of the Parables (NRSV)

13:17a**For truly I tell you,**

- You are blessed because I assure you^(plur) that
- I tell you^(plur) with certainty,

For: Verse 13:17 explains how the disciples are blessed (13:16). The Greek introduces this explanation with a conjunction that the BSB translates as For.

Here is another way to translate this:

You are blessed because

Many English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either.

truly I tell you: Jesus often used the words truly I tell you to introduce a statement that he wanted to emphasize. When he began a statement with these words, he was asking people to listen with extra attention.

Here are some ways to show this emphasis:

- As a phrase before Jesus' statement. For example:

I assure you (NLT96)

Listen to this:

Let me tell you this:

- As a phrase at the end of Jesus' statement. For example:

many prophets and righteous people longed to see what you see, and did not see it.... That is the truth.

If you have another way in your language to emphasize a statement or to alert people to listen with special attention, consider using it here. See how you translated this clause in 11:11a.

13:17b**many prophets and righteous men longed to see what you see**

- many prophets and good people wanted very much to see the things that you see,
- many prophets and people who did what was right greatly desired to see the things that you now see,

many prophets and righteous men: The phrase righteous men refers to people who live by God's standards. They do what is right and good in God's sight.

Here are some other ways to translate righteous men:

people who do what is right

good people (CEV)

people who obey God's laws

longed to see: The Greek word that the BSB translates as longed means "greatly desired."

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

wanted very much to see (GNT)

were eager to see (CEV)

what you see: The words what you see refer to the deeds of Jesus. God told prophecies about what the Christ would do, and prophets and righteous people wanted to see the Christ and his deeds.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

the things that you now see (NCV)

13:17c**but did not see it,**

- but they did not see them,

but did not see it: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between what the prophets wanted to see (13:17b), and what they actually saw (13:17c). Some English versions indicate this contrast with the conjunction but. Other translations leave the contrast implicit. For example:

and did not see it (ESV)

13:17d**and to hear what you hear but did not hear it.**

- and to hear the things that you hear, but they did not hear them.
- And they wanted to hear the words that you hear, but they did not hear them.

and to hear what you hear: The words what you hear refer to the things/words that Jesus said.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

And they wanted to hear the things that you now hear (NCV)

and hear the words that you hear

but did not hear it: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between what the people wanted to hear, and what they actually heard. Some English versions, including the BSB, indicate this contrast with the conjunction but.

General Comment on 13:17

In some languages, it will be natural to put the phrases “see what you see” and “hear what you hear” together. For example:

^bMany prophets and good people were eager to see what you see ^dand to hear what you hear. ^aBut I tell you that ^cthey did not see ^dor hear. (CEV)

Matthew 13:18

Section 13:18–23: Jesus explained the parable of the man who sowed seeds

In this section, Jesus explained the meaning of the parable of the sower. As you translate this section, it is important to understand and remember the main elements in this parable and what they represent.

There are three main metaphors in this parable:

1. The seed represents the message about the kingdom.
2. The sowing of the seed represents telling the message to people.
3. The four types of soil represents four types of people who hear the message.

The first type of soil is the soil along the path. This soil represents people whom Satan causes to forget the message of the kingdom. The second type of soil is the rocky soil. This soil represents people who initially accept the message, but when troubles or persecution happen to them, they quickly reject the message. The third type of soil is the thorny soil. This soil represents people who accept the message, but worries about daily living cause them to not do anything for God. Finally, the fourth type of soil is the good soil. This soil represents people who hear and understand the message, and the message produces results in their lives.

In these verses, the Greek text sometimes keeps the metaphor and sometimes explains the meaning of the metaphor. For example 13:19c–d has: “the evil one comes and snatches away what was sown in his heart.” The words “snatches away what was sown” keep the metaphor of birds eating the grain that the farmer sowed. But the words “the evil one comes” explains the meaning of the metaphor of “birds” (13:4c).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus explained the parable of the four soils

The Parable of the Sower Explained (NRSV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 4:13–20 and Luke 8:11–15.

13:18

Consider, then, the parable of the sower:

- ¶ “Listen to the meaning of the parable about the farmer who planted/scattered seeds.
- ¶ “So listen and I will explain the story about the man who went to sow/scatter seeds.

Consider, then, the parable of the sower: These words introduce Jesus’ explanation of the meaning of this parable. Be careful to translate this clause in a way that does not give the impression that Jesus was going to tell the parable again. He was going to explain the meaning of the parable.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Listen to what the story about the farmer means. (GW)

So listen to the meaning of that story about the farmer. (NCV)

then: This word is a conjunction that can also mean “therefore.”

Here is another way to translate this conjunction:

So (NJB)

the parable: For help in translating this word, see the note in 13:3a.

Matthew 13:19

Section 13:18–23: Jesus explained the parable of the man who sowed seeds

In this section, Jesus explained the meaning of the parable of the sower. As you translate this section, it is important to understand and remember the main elements in this parable and what they represent.

There are three main metaphors in this parable:

1. The seed represents the message about the kingdom.
2. The sowing of the seed represents telling the message to people.
3. The four types of soil represents four types of people who hear the message.

The first type of soil is the soil along the path. This soil represents people whom Satan causes to forget the message of the kingdom. The second type of soil is the rocky soil. This soil represents people who initially accept the message, but when troubles or persecution happen to them, they quickly reject the message. The third type of soil is the thorny soil. This soil represents people who accept the message, but worries about daily living cause them to not do anything for God. Finally, the fourth type of soil is the good soil. This soil represents people who hear and understand the message, and the message produces results in their lives.

In these verses, the Greek text sometimes keeps the metaphor and sometimes explains the meaning of the metaphor. For example 13:19c–d has: “the evil one comes and snatches away what was sown in his heart.” The words “snatches away what was sown” keep the metaphor of birds eating the grain that the farmer sowed. But the words “the evil one comes” explains the meaning of the metaphor of “birds” (13:4c).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus explained the parable of the four soils

The Parable of the Sower Explained (NRSV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 4:13–20 and Luke 8:11–15.

13:19

Before you translate 13:19, carefully consider the most natural way in your language to order the clauses. In some languages, it will be more natural to put 13:19e first. Putting this clause first will follow the same order

as in 13:20, 13:22, and 13:23. Compare the example below:

^aWhen anyone hears the word of the kingdom
^band does not understand it, ^cthe evil one comes
and snatches away ^dwhat has been sown in his
heart. ^eThis is what was sown along the path.
(ESV)

^eThe path/road that the seeds fell upon represents
^apeople who hear the message about the
kingdom, ^bbut they do not understand its mean-
ing. ^cThen the evil one comes and causes them to
forget ^dthe message they heard.

13:19a

When anyone hears the message of the kingdom

- When a person hears the message about the kingdom of God
- Some people hear the message/news about God’s kingdom/rule,

When anyone hears the message: The Greek word that the BSB translates as message is more literally “word,” but also means “talk,” “news.”

In some languages, it may be natural to use the plural “people” instead of a singular noun. For example:

When some people hear the word

Those who hear the message (GNT)

the kingdom: The word kingdom refers to “the kingdom of God” or “kingdom of heaven” as Matthew often wrote. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

the kingdom of God

God’s rule/kingship

For advice on translating the phrase “the kingdom of God,” see the note at 12:28b.

13:19b

but does not understand it,

- and/but does not understand it,
- but they do not understand the meaning of the message.

but does not understand it: There is a contrast here that the BSB indicates with the conjunction but. The

contrast is between hearing the message and understanding it.

13:19c

the evil one comes and snatches away

- the evil one comes and grabs
- Then Satan, the evil one, comes and seizes
- So the devil comes and causes them to forget

the evil one: This phrase refers to Satan. He is compared to birds (in 13:4c) who come and eat the seed along the path.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- Translate this phrase literally and include a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

“The evil one” refers to Satan, the leader of demons.

- Include the name Satan in the text. For example:

the evil one, namely Satan,

Satan, the evil one,

- Use the name only. For example:

Satan

snatches away: The Greek word that the BSB translates as snatches away means “remove forcefully.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

- Keep the metaphor of a bird and Satan taking away the seed. For example:

grabs

seizes

takes away (NCV)

- Explain the meaning of the metaphor. Satan snatches away the seed/word in the sense that he makes the person “forget” what they have heard. For example:

causes them to forget

13:19d

what was sown in his heart.

- the message that was sown/planted in his heart.
- the message that someone told them.
- the message that they heard.

what was sown in his heart: This phrase explains what Jesus meant in 13:3b when he said that the farmer sows seed that falls along a path. The seed represents the message of the kingdom. Sowing the seed represents telling/announcing the message. The soil along a path represents the heart of certain people.

Notice that in this explanation, the phrase what was sown keeps the metaphor. This phrase refers to the message about the kingdom. On the other hand, the phrase in his heart explains part of the metaphor.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- In some languages, it is possible to mix the metaphor and the meaning. For example:

what was planted in that person’s heart (NCV)

- In other languages, it will be necessary to explain the entire metaphor. For example:

the message which was put in his heart/mind

- In other languages, it will be necessary to leave in his heart untranslated. For example:

the message that he heard

the message that someone told him

in his heart: The word heart refers to the inner being of a person.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in his mind

in him (GW)

As mentioned above, in some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this phrase.

13:19e

This is the seed sown along the path.

- This is the meaning of the seeds that were sowed/scattered on the path.

- That is the meaning of what happened to the seeds that the farmer sowed/scattered on the path.

This is the seed sown along the path: This clause indicates that 13:19a–d is the explanation of what happened when seed fell in the soil along/on the path.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

This is like the seed sown by the road-side (JBP)

This is what the seed planted along the road illustrates (GW)

That is the meaning of what happened to the seed which the farmer sowed/scattered on the path.

Your translation should not indicate that the seed represents the person who hears the message. The seed is the message.

This: The word This refers back to what Jesus just said in 13:19a–d. In some languages, it may be more natural to use “that” here.

sown: Here are some other ways to translate this word:

planted (GW)

scattered/thrown

along the path: If you translated along the path in 13:4b as “on the path,” you should do the same thing here.

13:19a–e (reordered) The path on which some seed fell shows/illustrates people who hear the message about the kingdom, but don’t understand it. Then the evil one comes and snatches the message from their hearts.

Matthew 13:20

Section 13:18–23: Jesus explained the parable of the man who sowed seeds

In this section, Jesus explained the meaning of the parable of the sower. As you translate this section, it is important to understand and remember the main elements in this parable and what they represent.

There are three main metaphors in this parable:

1. The seed represents the message about the kingdom.

2. The sowing of the seed represents telling the message to people.
3. The four types of soil represents four types of people who hear the message.

The first type of soil is the soil along the path. This soil represents people whom Satan causes to forget the message of the kingdom. The second type of soil is the rocky soil. This soil represents people who initially accept the message, but when troubles or persecution happen to them, they quickly reject the message. The third type of soil is the thorny soil. This soil represents people who accept the message, but worries about daily living cause them to not do anything for God. Finally, the fourth type of soil is the good soil. This soil represents people who hear and understand the message, and the message produces results in their lives.

In these verses, the Greek text sometimes keeps the metaphor and sometimes explains the meaning of the metaphor. For example 13:19c–d has: “the evil one comes and snatches away what was sown in his heart.” The words “snatches away what was sown” keep the metaphor of birds eating the grain that the farmer sowed. But the words “the evil one comes” explains the meaning of the metaphor of “birds” (13:4c).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus explained the parable of the four soils

The Parable of the Sower Explained (NRSV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 4:13–20 and Luke 8:11–15.

13:20a

The seed sown on rocky ground

- The rocky places where some seed fell
- The meaning of what happened to the seeds that the farmer sowed/scattered on bedrock

The seed sown on rocky ground: This clause indicates that another explanation is coming. It is the explanation of what happened when some seed fell on rocky ground. Be careful not to imply that the seed is being compared to a person. The comparison is to the entire situation.

This clause is passive. Here are some ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

The meaning of what happened to the seeds that were planted on rocky places is this:

- Use an active verb. For example:

As for the seeds that the farmer planted on bedrock, that is like

- Use another type of verb. For example:

As for the shallow ground where some seeds fell, that is like

sown: Some English translations (like the NIV and GNT) translate sown here as “fell.” This indicates that the farmer did not sow the seeds on the rocky ground on purpose.

rocky ground: The Greek word that the BSB translates as rocky ground is the same word that occurs in 13:5a. It refers to ground that has a layer of solid rock underneath. There is not much soil on top of the solid rock. This clause does not refer to soil and rocks mixed together.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

shallow soil with underlying rock

solid rock with a thin layer of soil

bedrock where there is only a little soil on top

13:20b is the one who hears the word

- show/represent a person who hears the message
- is this: some people hear the message/truth about the kingdom,

is: The word is indicates a comparison. It means “the situation in 13:20a represents....” In other words, sowing on rocky ground “is like” or “represents” someone who hears the word and immediately receives it with joy. For example:

represents (NLT)

stand for (GNT)

the one who hears the word: The word one refers to a certain type of person. In some languages, it may be more natural to use a plural word here. For example:

the people who gladly hear the message (CEV)

those who hear the message (NLT)

the word: This word refers to the “message,” “talk,” or “news” of the kingdom. You should translate the word in the same way as you translated it in 13:19a (BSB: “the message”).

13:20c and at once receives it with joy.

- and immediately accepts it and is glad/happy.
- and right away they welcome/believe it with gladness.

at once: Here are some other ways to translate this word:

without hesitation

immediately (ESV)

as soon as they hear it (GNT)

receives it with joy: The word receives indicates that the person accepts the message about God’s kingdom. He accepts it and is happy.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

welcomes it...with joy (NJB)

accepts it...with joy (REB)

believes it and is happy

Matthew 13:21

Section 13:18–23: Jesus explained the parable of the man who sowed seeds

In this section, Jesus explained the meaning of the parable of the sower. As you translate this section, it is important to understand and remember the main elements in this parable and what they represent.

There are three main metaphors in this parable:

1. The seed represents the message about the kingdom.
2. The sowing of the seed represents telling the message to people.
3. The four types of soil represents four types of people who hear the message.

The first type of soil is the soil along the path. This soil represents people whom Satan causes to forget the message of the kingdom. The second type of soil is the rocky soil. This soil represents people who initially accept the message, but when troubles or persecution happen to them, they quickly reject the message. The third type of soil is the thorny soil. This soil represents people who accept the message, but worries about daily living cause them to not do anything for God. Finally, the fourth type of soil is the good soil. This soil represents people who hear and understand the message, and the message produces results in their lives.

In these verses, the Greek text sometimes keeps the metaphor and sometimes explains the meaning of the metaphor. For example 13:19c-d has: “the evil one comes and snatches away what was sown in his heart.” The words “snatches away what was sown” keep the metaphor of birds eating the grain that the farmer sowed. But the words “the evil one comes” explains the meaning of the metaphor of “birds” (13:4c).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus explained the parable of the four soils

The Parable of the Sower Explained (NRSV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 4:13-20 and Luke 8:11-15.

13:21a

But since he has no root,

- But he has no/few roots from the seed/message growing in him,
- But he does not let God’s word grow deep in his heart/mind,
- But they do not allow the word/message to really change them.

In this verse, Jesus explained the meaning of the seed that had few roots and withered away (13:6b). Jesus explained the meaning by keeping part of the metaphor.

But: Something unexpected happens here. We would expect a person who “receives [the message] with joy” (in 13:20c) to continue receiving/believing the message. But he does not. The BSB introduces this unexpected event with the conjunction But.

Here is another way to introduce this unexpected event:

yet (NRSV)

since he has no root: This clause means “this type of person has no roots from the seed/message growing in him.” This means that this person has not allowed the roots of the message to enter his heart/mind and really change him.

Remember that Jesus compared people to different types of soil. And he compared the message to seed. So it is the seed that produces roots, not the person. The person is the thin soil in which the seed grows no roots.

As in 13:6b, this is an exaggeration. It means that the person has not allowed many roots to enter the soil of his heart/mind and really change him.

Here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Make the metaphor more complete. For example:

he has no/few roots from the seed/word growing in him

- Translate some of the meaning of the metaphor. For example:

he does not let God’s word grow deep in his heart/mind

- Translate the meaning of the phrase without the metaphor. For example:

he does not let the teaching go deep into his life (NCV)

he does not allow the message to deeply enter his heart

he does not allow the word/message to really change him

13:21b

he remains for only a season.

- so he stays/is that way only a short time.
- They do not welcome/believe it for very long.

The Greek conjunction that the BSB leaves untranslated and some English versions literally translate as “but” occurs when a pair of clauses is related, and the first clause (13:21a) contains the word “no.” This conjunction does not always introduce a clear contrast. In

many languages, it will be better to introduce 13:21b with another conjunction. For example:

so (NCV)

and (GNT)

remains for only a season: This phrase indicates that the person accepts the message for only a short time.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

does not endure (NET)

receives it only for a short time

he lasts only a little while (GW)

13:21c

When trouble or persecution comes because of the word,

- When difficulty comes and people make him suffer because of the word,
- Then when they have problems and people harass them because they believed in the word of God,

trouble: The word trouble generally describes troubles or difficulties of all kinds.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

suffering (GW)

difficulty

tribulation (ESV)

In some languages, it will be more natural to translate this noun as a verb. For example:

when people make him suffer

persecution: This word refers to “deliberately harming someone,” “mistreating someone,” or “causing someone to suffer.” Persecution occurs when people harass others physically, such as beating them or forcing them to leave their homes and taking their possessions. Persecution also occurs when people say hurtful things.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

oppression

harassment

In some languages, it will be more natural to translate this noun as a verb. For example:

when people oppress/harm him

The verb form (“persecute”) of this word occurs in 10:23a.

comes: This word can also be translated as “arises.” However, in some languages, it is not natural to say that tribulation and persecution “come” or “arise.” In some languages, it will be more natural to say:

when they have problems and when people are cruel to them

because of the word: The words because of indicate that “because he heard and received the word,” others persecuted him.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

due to the word of God

because he received/welcome the word

the word: You should translate the word in the same way as you translated it in 13:19a (“the message”) and 13:20b.

13:21d

he quickly falls away.

- he quickly turns away from the message.
- they soon stop believing it.

he quickly falls away: This clause means that the person quickly stops believing the message.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he soon turns away from the message

it is not long before he stops believing God’s message

he quickly gives up (NCV)

Matthew 13:22

Section 13:18–23: Jesus explained the parable of the man who sowed seeds

In this section, Jesus explained the meaning of the parable of the sower. As you translate this section, it is important to understand and remember the main elements in this parable and what they represent.

There are three main metaphors in this parable:

1. The seed represents the message about the kingdom.
2. The sowing of the seed represents telling the message to people.
3. The four types of soil represents four types of people who hear the message.

The first type of soil is the soil along the path. This soil represents people whom Satan causes to forget the message of the kingdom. The second type of soil is the rocky soil. This soil represents people who initially accept the message, but when troubles or persecution happen to them, they quickly reject the message. The third type of soil is the thorny soil. This soil represents people who accept the message, but worries about daily living cause them to not do anything for God. Finally, the fourth type of soil is the good soil. This soil represents people who hear and understand the message, and the message produces results in their lives.

In these verses, the Greek text sometimes keeps the metaphor and sometimes explains the meaning of the metaphor. For example 13:19c–d has: “the evil one comes and snatches away what was sown in his heart.” The words “snatches away what was sown” keep the metaphor of birds eating the grain that the farmer sowed. But the words “the evil one comes” explains the meaning of the metaphor of “birds” (13:4c).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus explained the parable of the four soils

The Parable of the Sower Explained (NRSV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 4:13–20 and Luke 8:11–15.

13:22a

The seed sown among the thorns

- The thorns where some seed fell
- The meaning of what happened to the seeds that the farmer sowed/scattered among the thorns

The seed sown among the thorns: This clause refers to what happened when some seed fell among thorns. Be careful not to imply that the seed is being compared to a person. The comparison is to the entire situation.

This clause is passive. Here are some ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

The meaning of what happened to the seeds that were planted among thorns is this:

- Use an active verb. For example:

As for the seeds that the farmer planted among thorns, that is like

- Use another type of verb. For example:

As for the thorns where some seeds fell, that is like

This clause is similar to 13:20a, so translate it in a similar way.

thorns: The Greek word that the BSB translates as thorns refers to any kind of thorny plant. This same word occurs in 13:7a.

13:22b

is the one who hears the word,

- show/illustrate a person who hears the message,
- is this: some people hear the message,

is the one who hears the word: This clause is exactly the same as 13:20b. You should translate both clauses in the same way.

is: The word indicates a comparison. It means “the situation in 13:22a represents....” In other words, sowing among thorns “is like” or “represents” someone who hears the word, but...it proves unfruitful. For example:

represents (NLT)

stand for (GNT)

the one who hears the word: The word one refers to a certain type of person. In some languages, it may be more natural to use a plural word here. For example:

people who hear the message (CEV)

those who hear God's word (NLT)

13:22c

but the worries of this life

- but the concerns about daily living
- but they are so concerned/worried about daily life,

the worries of this life: The Greek word that the BSB translates as worries means “anxieties, worries, concerns.”

The phrase of this life refers to living in this world. It is contrasted with life in heaven.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the cares of the life on earth

the worries of life (GW)

the worries/concerns of daily living

In some languages, it may be more natural to use a verb here rather than the noun worries. For example:

but worrying about life,

but they are so worried about daily life

13:22d

and the deceitfulness of wealth choke the word,

- and the lure/seduction of riches crowd thoughts about the message out of his mind,
- and money tricks/fools them so much that they do not think about the message,

the deceitfulness of wealth: The Greek word that the BSB translates as deceitfulness describes something that deceives, tricks, or fools someone. The word riches refers to wealth/money. Money deceives people into thinking that it will make them happy, but it does not. Money also deceives people so that they seek riches more than they seek ways to follow God.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

lure of riches (NJB)

seduction/enticement of money

the lie that wealth will make one happy

In some languages, it is more natural to use a verb here rather than the noun deceitfulness. For example:

wealth lead him astray

they...are fooled by the desire to get rich (CEV)

choke the word: The verb choke refers to the way that weeds and thorns crowd other plants and prevent them from growing normally. This same word occurs in 13:7b.

Here, this word is used metaphorically. It refers to the way that “the worries of this life and the deceitfulness of wealth” keep a person's mind too busy to think about the message of God.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

prevent the word of God from growing

crowd/press the message out of his mind

cause him not to think about the message

overpower the word of God in their mind/thinking

13:22e

and it becomes unfruitful.

- and the message produces/gives no fruit/change in his life.
- and as a result it does nothing in their lives.

and it becomes unfruitful: The word it refers back to “the word.” When the word of God is choked, it is made unfruitful. Like the grain plants that were crowded and did not produce a crop, the word of God was crowded out of this person's mind/heart and did not “bear fruit.”

unfruitful: The word unfruitful means “not producing fruit.” In the New Testament, fruit is a metaphor for “doing good deeds/actions.” Here the word unfruitful refers to the word of God having no effect on the person's life.

Here are some other ways you could translate this:

- Keep the metaphor of being unfruitful. For example:

the word becomes unfruitful

the word produces no fruit in that person's life

- Translate the meaning of the metaphor. For example:

there is no response in that person's life

and so they do not act and think according to God's message

Matthew 13:23

Section 13:18–23: Jesus explained the parable of the man who sowed seeds

In this section, Jesus explained the meaning of the parable of the sower. As you translate this section, it is important to understand and remember the main elements in this parable and what they represent.

There are three main metaphors in this parable:

1. The seed represents the message about the kingdom.
2. The sowing of the seed represents telling the message to people.
3. The four types of soil represents four types of people who hear the message.

The first type of soil is the soil along the path. This soil represents people whom Satan causes to forget the message of the kingdom. The second type of soil is the rocky soil. This soil represents people who initially accept the message, but when troubles or persecution happen to them, they quickly reject the message. The third type of soil is the thorny soil. This soil represents people who accept the message, but worries about daily living cause them to not do anything for God. Finally, the fourth type of soil is the good soil. This soil represents people who hear and understand the message, and the message produces results in their lives.

In these verses, the Greek text sometimes keeps the metaphor and sometimes explains the meaning of the metaphor. For example 13:19c–d has: “the evil one comes and snatches away what was sown in his heart.” The words “snatches away what was sown” keep the metaphor of birds eating the grain that the farmer sowed. But the words “the evil one comes” explains the meaning of the metaphor of “birds” (13:4c).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus explained the parable of the four soils

The Parable of the Sower Explained (NRSV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 4:13–20 and Luke 8:11–15.

13:23a

But the seed sown on good soil

- The good soil where some seed fell
- The meaning of what happened to the seeds that the farmer sowed/scattered on good soil

But the seed sown on good soil: This clause refers to what happened when some seed fell on good ground. Be careful not to imply that the seed is being compared to a person. The comparison is to the entire situation.

This clause is passive. Here are some ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

The meaning of what happened to the seeds that were planted on good soil is this:

- Use an active verb. For example:

As for the seeds that the farmer planted on good soil, that is like

- Use another type of verb. For example:

As for the good soil where some seeds fell, that is like

This clause is similar to 13:20a and 13:22a. You should translate it in a similar way.

sown: This same word occurs in 13:19d, 13:20a and 13:22a. But here the seed was sown on the good soil on purpose. You may want to:

- Be consistent and use the same term here as in 13:19d, 13:20a and 13:22a.
- Indicate that the seed was sown here on purpose, and so use the term for “sow” that you used in 13:4a.

good soil: This phrase refers to the kind of soil in which plants grow well.

Here is another way to translate this:

fertile soil

This same phrase occurs in 13:8a.

13:23b**is the one who hears the word and understands it.**

- shows/represents a person who hears the message and understands it.
- is this: some people hear the message and understand it,

is the one who hears the word and understands it:

This clause is very similar to 13:20b and 13:22b. The only difference is the added phrase and understands it.

is: The word is indicates a comparison. It means “the situation in 13:23a represents....” In other words, sowing in good soil “is like” or “represents” someone who hears the word and understands it. For example:

represents (NLT)

stand for (GNT)

the one who hears the word and understands it: The word one refers to a certain type of person. In some languages, it may be more natural to use a plural word here. For example:

those who hear the message and understand it (GNT)

those who truly hear and understand God’s word (NLT)

13:23c**He indeed bears fruit**

- This type of person produces a crop.
- and it produces results in their lives like plants that

He indeed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as indeed is a weak marker of emphasis. Here it emphasizes that among all the soils on which seed fell, the good soil is the only one that bears fruit. At this point in the explanation of the parable, the good soil (a good person) and the seed (the message) merge. They are together pictured as producing grain.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

He is the one who

he does bear fruit

Most English versions do not translate this word.

bears fruit: The verb bears describes what a plant or tree does when it develops grain or fruit. Notice that here Jesus kept the metaphor in his explanation.

This verb has the opposite meaning of “unfruitful” in 13:22e. Also see how you translated the similar phrase “produced a crop” in 13:8a.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- Translate the metaphor in a natural way in your language. For example:

produces crops (GW)

- Translate the metaphor as a simile. For example:

the message has results in their lives like a plant producing a crop

13:23d**and produces a crop—a hundredfold, sixtyfold, or thirtyfold.”**

- Some produce a hundred seeds/grains, others sixty, and others thirty.”
- produce a hundred, sixty or thirty seeds.”

and produces a crop—a hundredfold, sixtyfold, or thirtyfold:

The Greek text is more literally “this one produces a hundred, and another sixty and another thirty.” This phrase continues the metaphor of the plants producing a harvest. This phrase is similar to 13:8b.

Here the singular “one” represents a group of people. Some people do many good deeds and they are like a plant that produces one hundred seeds of grain. Other people’s good deeds are like sixty seeds of grain. Still other people’s good deeds are like thirty seeds of grain.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- Translate the metaphor in a natural way in your language. For example:

produces fruit/grain, some produce a hundred grains, some sixty grains, and some thirty

- Translate the metaphor as a simile. For example:

some people’s good deeds are like a plant bearing a hundred seeds, other people are like a plant that bears sixty seeds other people are like a plant that bears thirty seeds

a hundredfold, sixtyfold, or thirtyfold: For advice on translating these numbers, see the note at 13:8b.

Matthew 13:24

Section 13:24–30: Jesus told the parable about the weeds in the wheat

In this section, Jesus told the parable about the weeds and the wheat. He explained the meaning of this parable later in 13:36–43.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable of the weeds

Weeds among the wheat

This parable occurs only in Matthew.

13:24a

Jesus put before them another parable:

- ¶ Then Jesus told another parable to the people:
- ¶ Here is another story that Jesus told the people:

Jesus put before them another parable: This clause is a figure of speech. It compares placing a parable before people to putting food in front of people for them to eat.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus told them another parable (NIV)

Here is another parable he gave them (REB)

Here is another story Jesus told (NLT)

them: This pronoun refers to the crowds mentioned in 13:2 and later in 13:34. It does not just refer to the disciples. You may want to make this clear in your translation. For example:

the people

the crowd

13:24b

“The kingdom of heaven is like

- “The kingdom of heaven is like this:
- “God’s rule/chieftaincy is like the story about

The kingdom of heaven is like: Here Jesus compared the kingdom of heaven to the whole situation described in the parable in 13:24–30. He did not compare the kingdom of heaven to just the man.

If people in your area will think that the comparison is only to the man, you may want to indicate that the comparison is to the whole parable. Here are some ways to do this:

The kingdom of heaven may be compared to (ESV)

The kingdom of heaven is like the story about

The kingdom of heaven is like what happened when (CEV)

kingdom of heaven: This phrase last occurred in 13:11b. You should translate it here as you did in other places in Matthew such as 11:11c.

13:24c

a man who sowed good seed in his field.

- A man scattered good seeds in his field.
- a man who planted good seeds in his field.

a man who sowed: The verb sowed is the same verb as in the parable of the sower (13:3–8, 13:19–23). It refers to scattering seed by throwing.

The way that the farmer sowed the seed in this parable is not important to the meaning of the parable. So if scattering seed is not a normal way of sowing, you may want to use a more general term for planting seed here. For example:

planted (NLT)

good seed: We would expect that when a farmer sows seed in his field, he would always sow good seed. So the word good would not normally be necessary. The fact that it is here indicates that a problem is coming.

field: This word refers to a large area of ground that the farmer has prepared for planting food plants.

Matthew 13:25

Section 13:24–30: Jesus told the parable about the weeds in the wheat

In this section, Jesus told the parable about the weeds and the wheat. He explained the meaning of this parable later in 13:36–43.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable of the weeds

Weeds among the wheat

This parable occurs only in Matthew.

13:25a

But while everyone was asleep,

- But while he and his people were sleeping,
- But that night as everyone slept, (NLT96)

But: Something unexpected happens in this verse. An enemy comes and plants weeds in the man's field. Many English versions are like the BSB and introduce this unexpected event with the conjunction But.

In some languages, no conjunction is necessary here. For example:

One night, when everyone was asleep (GNT)

while everyone was asleep: There are two ways to interpret the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as everyone:

1. It refers to people in general. For example:

while everyone was sleeping (NIV) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NET, NRSV, REB, NJB, GW, CEV, NLT96, NCV)

1. It refers specifically to the workers of the man who owned the field. For example:

while his men were sleeping (NASB) (ESV, NASB, NLT, JBP)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This phrase probably includes everyone in the man's household: the man, his family, and his servants.

13:25b

his enemy came and sowed weeds among the wheat, and slipped away.

- his enemy came and scattered weed seeds on top of the wheat and then left.
- an enemy came and planted weed seeds in that same wheat/rice field. Then he left.

sowed weeds: The Greek word that the BSB translates as weeds refers to a specific type of weed. The name of this plant is darnel as in the REB. This weed looks

very similar to wheat, but the seeds it produces are not edible.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- Use a generic word for weeds. For example:

sowed weed seeds

planted seeds of bad plants

scattered poisonous weed seeds

- Use a word that refers to a specific type of weed in your area. This type of weed should resemble grass or wheat.

wheat: The word wheat refers to a grain plant that is common in that area of Israel. The wheat plant produces grains that are ground into flour to make bread.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

- Use the specific word for wheat.
- Compare this to something that is commonly grown in your area. For example:

something like rice/millet

Matthew 13:26

Section 13:24–30: Jesus told the parable about the weeds in the wheat

In this section, Jesus told the parable about the weeds and the wheat. He explained the meaning of this parable later in 13:36–43.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable of the weeds

Weeds among the wheat

This parable occurs only in Matthew.

13:26a

When the wheat sprouted and bore grain,

- So when the wheat grew and started producing heads of grain,
- When the wheat/rice sprouted and the plants grew and began to form heads of grain,

When the wheat sprouted and bore grain: This clause indicates that the wheat seed sprouted and

grew into plants. Then grain began to appear at the top of the stalk.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Later, the wheat sprouted and the heads of grain grew (NCV)

When the plants grew and the heads of grain began to form (GNT)

13:26b

then the weeds also appeared.

- then the weeds showed themselves also.
- people could see that some plants were weeds.

then the weeds also appeared: This clause indicates that people could now see that some plants were weeds. The wheat and the weeds were growing together. When they were young, they looked very similar. But when the wheat plants began to grow heads of grain, this made it clear that not all the plants were wheat. The weeds looked different.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

then they could see that some plants were weeds

the farmer's servants could see the weeds (CEV)

Matthew 13:27

Section 13:24–30: Jesus told the parable about the weeds in the wheat

In this section, Jesus told the parable about the weeds and the wheat. He explained the meaning of this parable later in 13:36–43.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable of the weeds

Weeds among the wheat

This parable occurs only in Matthew.

13:27a

The owner's servants came to him and said,

- ¶ The servants of the head of the house came to him and said,
- ¶ So the workers of the man, the field owner, went to him and said,

servants: This word refers to the people who worked for the owner of the land.

Here is another way to translate this word:

workers

to him: The to him refers to the man introduced in 13:24c. This man was head of the household and probably owned the house and land.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the head of the house

the man who owned the field

13:27b

'Sir, didn't you sow good seed in your field?

- 'Sir, was it not good seed that you sowed in your field? (REB)
- 'Father/Boss, it was good seed that you planted in your field.

Sir: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Sir is the same word translated "Lord" when referring to God. This word is a term of respect and indicates that the person spoken to is greater in status.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Master (ESV)

Boss/Chief/Father

didn't you sow good seed in your field?: This is a rhetorical question. It expresses surprise and emphasizes that they knew that he had planted good seeds. They were surprised that there were weeds in the field, because he had sown good seed.

Here are some ways to translate this surprise and emphasis:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Sir, was it not good seed that you sowed in your field? (REB)

- As a statement. For example:

You planted good seed in your field. (NCV)

Translate this surprise and emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

13:27c

Where then did the weeds come from?

- Then how did your field become so full of weeds?
- Where did all these weeds come from?

Where then did the weeds come from?: This is a real question. There were many more weeds than normal, and the servants did not know where the extra weeds came from.

Here are some other ways to translate this question:

How then does it have weeds? (ESV)

Then how does your field have all these weeds?

Then in what way did your field become so full of weeds?

Matthew 13:28

Section 13:24–30: Jesus told the parable about the weeds in the wheat

In this section, Jesus told the parable about the weeds and the wheat. He explained the meaning of this parable later in 13:36–43.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable of the weeds

Weeds among the wheat

This parable occurs only in Matthew.

13:28a

'An enemy did this,' he replied.

- He replied, 'Some enemy did that!'
- He said, 'It was an enemy who planted them!'

An enemy did this: The word this refers to planting weeds in the wheat field.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

It was some enemy who did this (GNT)

An enemy planted weeds. (NCV)

13:28b

So the servants asked him, 'Do you want us to go and pull them up?'

- Then the servants asked him, 'Do you want us^(excl) to go and remove them?'
- The servants asked him, 'Do you want us^(excl) to go and pull up/out the weeds?'

So: Verse 13:28b is the servants' response to the field owner's statement. The BSB introduces this response with the conjunction So. Many English versions do not have a conjunction here. In some languages, no conjunction will be necessary here either.

Do you want us to go and pull them up: The Greek word that the BSB translates as pull them up means "gather" or "collect." Here it refers to removing the weeds. The word them refers to the weeds.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

pull up the weeds (CEV)

pull out the weeds (NLT)

Matthew 13:29

Section 13:24–30: Jesus told the parable about the weeds in the wheat

In this section, Jesus told the parable about the weeds and the wheat. He explained the meaning of this parable later in 13:36–43.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable of the weeds

Weeds among the wheat

This parable occurs only in Matthew.

13:29a

'No,' he said, 'if you pull the weeds now,

- He said, 'No, don't do that, so that you don't also
- He said, 'No, because if you remove the weeds,
- He answered, 'No, don't do that, because

Verse 13:29 is the owner's refusal to allow the servants to pull out the weeds. Some English versions introduce this refusal with the conjunction "But." Other English versions, including the BSB, do not have a conjunction here. In some languages, it will not be necessary to have a conjunction here either.

if you pull the weeds now: The Greek phrase the BSB translates as if you pull the weeds now is more literally “lest, gathering the weeds,....” The word “lest” expresses negative purpose: It means “in order not to.” (This same word occurs in 13:15d.) The owner told the servant not to pull out the weeds so that they would not also pull out the wheat.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

No, do not do that, so that you don’t also

No, do not pull them out, because you might also

No. If you pull out the weeds, you may (GW)

13:29b
you might uproot the wheat with them.

- uproot the wheat along with them.
- you might also pull out the roots of the wheat at the same time.
- you might also accidentally pull out the wheat.

you might uproot the wheat with them: The verb that the BSB translates as uproot means to pull out a plant along with its roots. The roots of the weeds and the roots of the wheat were growing together in the ground. So if the servants pulled out the weeds and their roots, they might also cause the roots of the wheat to come out, and the wheat plants would die.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

you may uproot the wheat with them (NET)

you might also pull up the wheat (NCV)

you might accidentally uproot the wheat with them

Matthew 13:30

Section 13:24–30: Jesus told the parable about the weeds in the wheat

In this section, Jesus told the parable about the weeds and the wheat. He explained the meaning of this parable later in 13:36–43.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable of the weeds

Weeds among the wheat

This parable occurs only in Matthew.

13:30a
Let both grow together until the harvest.

- Let both of them grow together until harvest time.
- Leave it alone. Allow the weeds and the wheat to grow until the wheat is ready to be cut.

Let both grow together: The word both refers to the weeds and the wheat.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Let them both grow together (REB)

Let the weeds and the wheat grow together (NCV)

Leave it alone. Allow both of them to grow together

until the harvest: The harvest refers to the time when the wheat is mature and ready to pick. At that time, the workers cut down the wheat, gathered it and put it in a safe place.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

until harvest time/season

until it is time to gather/cut the grain

13:30b
At that time I will tell the harvesters:

- When harvest time arrives, I will tell the men who harvest,
- Then when the time for cutting grain arrives, I will tell the/my workers

At that time: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as At that time is more literally “in the time of the harvest.” This phrase repeats most of the phrase in 13:30a. In some languages, it will not be natural to repeat it, which is why the BSB does not repeat the word “harvest.” If that is true in your language, you can say:

When that time comes

Then (GNT)

I will tell the harvesters: The harvesters are the people whom the owner of the field hired to cut down the wheat and gather it.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

reapers (ESV)

the harvest workers (GNT)

those who cut the wheat/grain

13:30c

First collect the weeds and tie them in bundles to be burned;

- “Collect the weeds and tie them in bundles in order to burn them.
- to first cut the weeds, gather them, and bundle them for burning.

First collect the weeds: It is implied that the weeds are cut or pulled out and then collected/gathered. You may want to include some of the implied information. For example:

First cut and collect the weeds

First pull out and collect the weeds

tie them in bundles: During harvest time when the wheat plants were cut, it was common to tie the plants into bundles. The owner told the workers to do the same thing with the weeds. This made it easy to carry them.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

bind them in bundles (ESV)

tie them together (NCV)

to be burned: The verb be burned is passive. The owner or his workers will burn the weeds. If a passive verb is not natural in your language here, you should use an active verb. For example:

in order to burn them

for burning

so we/you can burn them later

13:30d

then gather the wheat into my barn.”

- Then gather the wheat and bring it all into my barn.”
- Then they should cut and gather the wheat and put it into my granary.”

then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as then indicates some contrast here. The contrast is between what the owner told the workers to do with the weeds (in 13:30c), and what he told them to do with the wheat (in 13:30d). Many English versions indicate this contrast with the conjunction “but.”

Here is another way to connect this part of the verse with the previous part:

and then (GNT)

gather the wheat: The Jews harvested wheat by first cutting the wheat stalks with a large curved knife. The verb “cut” is implied. In some languages, it may be natural to include some of this implied information. For example:

Then cut and gather the wheat

into my barn: The word barn refers to a building used for storing food such as grain.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

storage house

granary

General Comment on 13:30b–d

In Greek, 13:30c–d is direct speech. The owner tells his servants the words that he will say to the harvesters. In some languages, it may be more natural to translate 13:30c–d as indirect speech. For example:

Then I will tell the harvest workers to pull up the weeds first, tie them in bundles and burn them, and then to gather in the wheat and put it in my barn. (GNT)

Matthew 13:31

Section 13:31–35: Jesus told the parables of the mustard seed and the yeast

In this section, Jesus told two parables: the parable of the mustard seed and the parable of the yeast. These

parables show something about the growth and size of God's kingdom.

The parable about the mustard seed shows that God's kingdom will grow from a very small beginning to a very large size. The size of God's kingdom represents the number of people in the kingdom.

The parable of the yeast shows that God's kingdom will spread throughout the world.

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 4:30–32 and Luke 13:18–21.

13:31a

He put before them another parable:

- ¶ Then Jesus told another parable to the people:
- ¶ Here is another story that Jesus told the people:

He put before them another parable: This clause is exactly the same as the clause in 13:24a.

Here are some other ways to translate it:

He told them another parable (NIV)

This is another parable he gave them (REB)

Then Jesus told another story (NCV)

13:31b–c

The kingdom of heaven is like a mustard seed: This clause is a simile. It compares the kingdom of God to what happens when a mustard seed is planted. The Jewish people considered the mustard seed to be one of their smallest seeds. However, the mustard plant can grow to be a tree as large as three meters high.

The point of similarity in this comparison is the growth from something small to something large. Like the mustard plant, the kingdom of God is very small at its beginning, but it becomes very large.

The comparison is about the whole growth process, not just what the seed is like. One way to make this clear is:

The kingdom of heaven is like what happens when a farmer plants a mustard seed in a field. (CEV)

13:31b

“The kingdom of heaven is like a mustard seed

- “The kingdom of heaven is like a mustard seed
- “God's rule/chieftaincy is like a small seed of a mustard plant.

The kingdom of heaven: This phrase last occurred in 13:24b. You should translate it here as you did there.

is like: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as *is like* is very similar to the word translated as “is like” in 13:24b. This phrase introduces a comparison. Here Jesus compared the kingdom of heaven to a mustard seed.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

can be compared to

resembles

a mustard seed: The BSB translates the Greek phrase literally as a mustard seed. To Jewish people, the mustard seed was a symbol of smallness.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- Use your word for seed and transliterate the word mustard according to the sounds of your language. For example:

a musutarade seed

a seed of the plant/tree called mutar

- Use a generic phrase. For example:

a tiny seed

- Use the name of a local seed that is known to be very small, but grows into a tree. If you use this option, you may want to indicate the literal name in a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

The Greek text is literally “a mustard seed.”

Regardless of the way you translate mustard seed, you may want to add a footnote that explains the significance of mustard seed in the Jewish culture. For example:

For the Jews, the mustard seed was a symbol of something that was very small. But the mustard seed that was planted in the country of the Jews grew into a tree that grew up to three meters high.

13:31c

that a man planted in his field.

- that someone took and planted in his field.
- A man took it and planted it in his field.

that a man: Here, the Greek includes a verb that means “picked up in his hand.” In some languages it may be natural to leave this action implicit, as the BSB has done. In other languages, it may be natural to include this action. For example:

that a man took and sowed in his field (ESV)

planted in his field: The Greek word that the BSB translates as planted is the same word as the word “sowed” throughout the parable of the sower. This word first occurs in 13:3b. Here the man does not sow many seeds. He only sows one. The method of planting is not in focus here. So you may use whatever term is natural in your language for planting this kind of seed in a vegetable garden or field.

Matthew 13:32

Section 13:31–35: Jesus told the parables of the mustard seed and the yeast

In this section, Jesus told two parables: the parable of the mustard seed and the parable of the yeast. These parables show something about the growth and size of God’s kingdom.

The parable about the mustard seed shows that God’s kingdom will grow from a very small beginning to a very large size. The size of God’s kingdom represents the number of people in the kingdom.

The parable of the yeast shows that God’s kingdom will spread throughout the world.

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 4:30–32 and Luke 13:18–21.

13:32a

Although it is the smallest of all seeds,

- The mustard seed is the smallest of all herb/garden seeds,
- Although it is one of the smallest seeds,

it is the smallest of all seeds: The Greek text is literally “which is smaller than all the seeds.” The Greek text exaggerates the smallness of the seed to emphasize its smallness. This helps teach the point about the kingdom of God starting with only a few people.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- Translate literally. For example:

It is the smallest of all seeds (GNT)

- Explain the exaggeration. For example:

it is the smallest of all garden seeds

- Indicate in a general way that the mustard seed is a very small seed. For example:

It’s one of the smallest seeds (GW)

It is a very small seed.

13:32b

yet it grows into the largest of garden plants

- but it grows into the tallest of the herb/garden plants.
- when it has grown, it is bigger than all the other herb/garden plants.

yet: There is something unexpected here. We would expect a small seed to grow into a small plant. But a small mustard seed grows into a large plant.

Here are some ways to introduce this unexpected thing:

- Use a conjunction in 13:32b. For example:

However, when it has grown (GW)

- Use a conjunction in 13:32a. For example:

^{32a} Although it is the smallest of all seeds, ^{32b}it grows larger (CEV)

Use whatever is natural in your language to indicate that something unexpected is about to be said.

it grows into the largest of garden plants: The Greek word that the BSB translates as garden plants refers to vegetable and herb plants. These plants do not normally grow more than one meter high. However, the mustard plant can grow as high as three meters high. It was the largest plant that the Jews planted in their vegetable gardens.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

when it has grown, it is taller than the garden plants (GW)

when it has grown, it is bigger than all the other plants in the vegetable garden

13:32c

and becomes a tree, so that the birds of the air come and nest in its branches.”

- It becomes a tree so big that birds come and make nests in its branches.”
- It grows into a tree that is big enough for birds to come and build their nests in its branches.”

becomes a tree: A mustard plant can grow up to three meters tall, and it has branches. It is more like a large shrub than a tree. Jesus said becomes a tree to make a strong connection to the Old Testament symbol of a great kingdom. (See more on this issue under the General Comment below.)

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

it grows into a tree (NLT)

it grows big enough to be considered/called a tree

so that the birds of the air come: The phrase the birds of the air is the Jewish way of referring to “birds.” In many languages, it will be more natural to just say “birds.” For example:

so that birds come (GNT)

that is large enough for birds (GW)

and nest in its branches: The Greek word that the BSB translates as nest means “live, dwell, settle.” Most English versions translate this word as “make nests” or as the verb “nest.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

perch in its branches (NIV)

shelter in its branches (NJB)

General Comment on 13:32

When a Jew heard about a tree so large that birds could come and make their nests in it, he would immediately think of some Old Testament passages (Ezekiel 17:23, Daniel 4:20–22) that had similar wording. Such passages were about great kingdoms. So a Jew would understand that Jesus was talking about the kingdom of heaven/God becoming a great kingdom.

You may need a footnote to explain the Jewish symbolism for the tree and birds. Here is a sample footnote:

In the Old Testament, God compared several great kingdoms to great trees that were so large that birds came and nested in its branches. When Jesus spoke of God’s kingdom being like a tree with birds perching in its branches, the Jews would quickly understand that God’s kingdom would become great as well.

Matthew 13:33**Section 13:31–35: Jesus told the parables of the mustard seed and the yeast**

In this section, Jesus told two parables: the parable of the mustard seed and the parable of the yeast. These parables show something about the growth and size of God’s kingdom.

The parable about the mustard seed shows that God’s kingdom will grow from a very small beginning to a very large size. The size of God’s kingdom represents the number of people in the kingdom.

The parable of the yeast shows that God’s kingdom will spread throughout the world.

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 4:30–32 and Luke 13:18–21.

13:33a**He told them still another parable:**

- ¶ Then Jesus told another parable to the people:
- ¶ Here is another story that Jesus told the people:

He told them still another parable: The Greek word that the BSB translates as told is the same word as in 13:3a. It is not “put before” as in 13:24a and 13:31a. However, the meaning is the same in all four places.

13:33b**“The kingdom of heaven is like**

- “The Kingdom of heaven is like this. (GNT)
- “God’s rule/chieftaincy is like what happens when

13:33b–c**The kingdom of heaven is like leaven that a woman took and mixed into three measures of flour:**

As in the previous parable, this clause is a simile. It compares the kingdom of God to what happens when leaven/yeast is mixed with bread dough. A small amount of yeast spreads through a large amount of dough and affects it in a good way. In the same way, the effect of God’s rule among a few people spreads through the whole world.

This simile is about the effect of yeast in a lump of dough. It is not simply a description of what yeast itself is like. Here are some ways to make this clear:

The kingdom of heaven is like what happens when a woman mixes a little yeast into three big batches of flour. (CEV)

The Kingdom of heaven is like this. A woman takes some yeast and mixes it with a bushel of flour (GNT)

13:33c

leaven that a woman took and mixed into three measures of flour,

- A woman takes some yeast and mixes it into a large amount of flour
- a woman mixes a little yeast into a lot of flour.

leaven: The Greek word that the BSB translates as leaven means “yeast.” It refers to a substance that makes bread dough rise/swell. A person mixes this substance with water and flour. Then it spreads throughout the flour and makes the dough expand. The dough is then baked into bread.

Here are some other ways to translate leaven:

- Use an expression that describes the yeast. For example:

what spreads to make bread rise

bread-expanding substance

what spreads through the bread dough and causes it to rise/swell

- Use a term from the national language and indicate its meaning. For example:

yeast that spreads to make bread swell

- Borrow a word and explain it in a footnote. Here is an example of a possible footnote:

Yeast is something that spreads in flour dough and causes it to rise so that after the dough is baked, it is soft to eat.

a woman took: In this context the word took means “picked up in her hand.” In some languages, it may be more natural to translate this verb and the next verb (hid) together as one verb. For example:

a woman mixes (CEV)

and mixed into: In this context, the phrase mixed into refers to placing something inside of something else. In this case, it refers to placing the small amount of yeast into the large amount of flour.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

put (NLT)

Although some English versions translates this word as “hid,” it does not refer to hiding something so that no one can see it or find it.

three measures of flour: The term three measures refers to a large amount. It could have been as much as twenty-three kilograms of flour. Here, the exact amount is not in focus. What is important is that it refers to a very large amount of flour.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

much flour

a large amount of flour (GW)

13:33d

until all of it was leavened.”

- until the yeast spreads through all the flour.”
- After a while, the yeast spreads throughout all the flour/dough.”

until all of it was leavened: This clause indicates that the leaven/yeast spread throughout all the flour and caused all of it to rise.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

until it caused the flour to rise

it spread through the whole lump of dough and caused it to rise

General Comment on 13:33a–d

If people in your area do not understand the parable of the leaven, you may want to include a footnote to explain it. A sample footnote is:

A small amount of yeast can spread throughout a large amount of flour. In the same way, the kingdom of God started small with just a few disciples and grew. It continues to spread throughout the whole world and affect it in a good way.

Matthew 13:34

Section 13:31–35: Jesus told the parables of the mustard seed and the yeast

In this section, Jesus told two parables: the parable of the mustard seed and the parable of the yeast. These parables show something about the growth and size of God's kingdom.

The parable about the mustard seed shows that God's kingdom will grow from a very small beginning to a very large size. The size of God's kingdom represents the number of people in the kingdom.

The parable of the yeast shows that God's kingdom will spread throughout the world.

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 4:30–32 and Luke 13:18–21.

13:34a

Jesus spoke all these things to the crowds in parables.

- ¶ Jesus spoke all those things to the crowd using parables.
- ¶ Jesus used stories to tell the people all those things about God's kingdom.

Jesus spoke all these things to the crowds in parables: The phrase all these things refers to the teachings about God's kingdom. He used the parables in 13:1–33 to teach these things.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus used parables to tell all these things to the crowds (GNT)

Jesus spoke all those things about God's kingdom in/using parables.

13:34b

He did not tell them anything without using a parable.

- He did not say anything about God's kingdom to them without using a parable.
- In fact, everything he said to them about God's kingdom was with a story.

Verse 13:34b says the same thing as 13:34a, but in a negative way. This is a way to emphasize 13:34a. Some English versions introduce this emphatic statement with the word “indeed.”

Here is another way to introduce this emphatic statement:

In fact (NLT)

In some languages, it will be natural to simply begin a new sentence here, as the BSB does. For example:

^{34a}Jesus used illustrations to tell the crowds all these things. ^{34b}He did not tell them anything without illustrating it with a story. (GW)

He did not tell them anything without using a parable: This clause means the same thing as 13:34a, but it says it in a negative way. It means that Jesus did not talk to the people about the kingdom of God unless he used a parable. On later occasions, Jesus did not use parables. But during this part of his ministry, every time he taught about the kingdom of God, he used parables.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he said nothing to them when/if it was not with/in parables

he did not say anything about the kingdom of heaven to them unless he used a parable

In some languages, it may be necessary to translate this clause as a positive statement. In this case, this clause will be very similar to 13:34a. For example:

^{34a}Jesus used stories to tell all these things to the people; ^{34b}he always used stories to teach them. (NCV)

Matthew 13:35

Section 13:31–35: Jesus told the parables of the mustard seed and the yeast

In this section, Jesus told two parables: the parable of the mustard seed and the parable of the yeast. These parables show something about the growth and size of God's kingdom.

The parable about the mustard seed shows that God's kingdom will grow from a very small beginning to a very large size. The size of God's kingdom represents the number of people in the kingdom.

The parable of the yeast shows that God's kingdom will spread throughout the world.

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 4:30–32 and Luke 13:18–21.

13:35a

So was fulfilled what was spoken through the prophet:

- He did this to fulfill what the prophet had said:
- Jesus spoke in parables to make come true the words that the prophet said. He said,

So was fulfilled what was spoken through the prophet: This clause is almost identical to 8:17a. There are two ways to interpret the way that this clause is connected to 13:34:

1. It is the purpose for which Jesus spoke in parables. According to this interpretation, Jesus spoke to the crowd in parables so that scripture would be fulfilled. For example:

He did this to make come true what the prophet had said (GNT) (GNT, ESV, RSV, NJB, KJV, NASB, REB, NCV, JBP)

1. It is the result of Jesus speaking in parables. According to this interpretation, Jesus spoke to the crowd in parables, and as a result scripture was fulfilled. For example:

So God's promise came true, just as the prophet had said (CEV) (BSB, NIV, NET, GW, CEV, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The Greek conjunction in this sentence clearly indicates purpose.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

He did this to fulfill what the prophet had said.

He taught in parables in order to make come true what the prophet had said.

13:35b

"I will open My mouth in parables;

- "I will open my mouth and speak in parables.
- "I will speak using stories.

I will open My mouth in parables: The clause I will open My mouth is an idiom that means "I will speak." For example:

I will speak to you in parables (NLT)

13:35c

I will utter things hidden since the foundation of the world."

- I will announce things that have been secret since the creation of the world."
- I will tell things that people have not known since the beginning of the world."

I will utter: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as utter means "declare" or "proclaim."

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

I will announce (NET)

I will tell them (GNT)

things hidden: This phrase refers to truths about God's kingdom that God had not yet revealed to people. These things had been a secret. Human beings did not know these things until Jesus came.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

things kept secret (REB)

things unknown (GNT)

since the foundation of the world: The Greek word that the BSB translates as foundation means "founding" or "beginning."

Here are some other ways to translate this entire clause:

since the creation of the world (NIV)

since the world was made (REB)

from the beginning of the world

Matthew 13:36

Section 13:36–43: Jesus explained the parable of the weeds

In this section, Jesus explained the meaning of the parable of the weeds to his disciples. This parable shows God's patience. Jesus announced that the kingdom of God had come, but not everyone accepted his message. However, God does not immediately destroy them. He permits people who do not follow him to live on the earth together with his people. They will live together until the day that God judges people. He will

then separate them, bringing his people into heaven and throwing nonbelievers into hell.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The meaning of the weeds in the wheat

Jesus explains the meaning of the weeds to his disciples

This passage occurs only in Matthew.

13:36a

Then Jesus dismissed the crowds and went into the house.

- ¶ Then he left the crowds and entered the house.
- ¶ After that, Jesus left the people, returned to the house where he was staying, and entered it.

Then Jesus dismissed the crowds: According to 13:2b, Jesus had been in a boat talking to the people by the lake of Galilee. When he finished talking to the people, he left them and went back to his house.

and went into the house: This house is likely the house in Capernaum where Jesus was staying at that time (8:14, 9:10). It was the house he left in 13:1a.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

went into the house where he was staying

returned to his house and entered it

13:36b

His disciples came to Him and said,

- His disciples approached him and said,
- His disciples followed him and asked,

His disciples came to Him: The phrase came to Him indicates that the disciples approached Jesus. This implies that they had returned to the house with Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

his disciples approached him (NRSV)

his disciples followed him

13:36c

“Explain to us the parable of the weeds in the field.”

- “Please explain to us^(excl) what the parable about the weeds in the field means.”
- “Lord, tell us^(excl) the meaning of the story you told about the weeds among the wheat in the field?”

Explain to us: This command is used as a polite request. Use a natural way to express a polite request in your language. For example:

Master/Lord, could you tell us

Please explain to us

the parable of the weeds in the field: This was the parable that Jesus told in 13:24-30.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the parable of the weeds among the wheat in the field

the meaning of the parable/story of the weeds that you told the people

Matthew 13:37

Section 13:36–43: Jesus explained the parable of the weeds

In this section, Jesus explained the meaning of the parable of the weeds to his disciples. This parable shows God’s patience. Jesus announced that the kingdom of God had come, but not everyone accepted his message. However, God does not immediately destroy them. He permits people who do not follow him to live on the earth together with his people. They will live together until the day that God judges people. He will then separate them, bringing his people into heaven and throwing nonbelievers into hell.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The meaning of the weeds in the wheat

Jesus explains the meaning of the weeds to his disciples

This passage occurs only in Matthew.

13:37

He replied, “The One who sows the good seed is the Son of Man.”

- He answered, “The man who scattered the good seeds is like the Son of Man.
- Jesus said, “The man who planted the good seed represents me, the Son of Man.

The One who sows: The Greek word that the BSB translates as One is masculine. It refers to the man of 13:24c.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

The man who sowed (GNT)

The one who scattered (CEV)

The man who planted (NCV)

the good seed: You should translate this phrase in the same way as you did in 13:24c.

is: In this context, the word indicates that the man in the parable represents Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

represents

is like

is compared to

the Son of Man: Here Jesus refers to himself as the Son of Man. In some languages, it may be necessary to add the pronoun “I” to make it clear that Jesus was referring to himself. For example:

I, the Son of Man

This phrase also occurs in 12:40b. You should translate it here as you did there. For help in translating this phrase, see the note under 8:20b. See also Son of Man in KBT for more information.

Matthew 13:38

Section 13:36–43: Jesus explained the parable of the weeds

In this section, Jesus explained the meaning of the parable of the weeds to his disciples. This parable shows God’s patience. Jesus announced that the kingdom of God had come, but not everyone accepted his message. However, God does not immediately destroy them. He permits people who do not follow him to live

on the earth together with his people. They will live together until the day that God judges people. He will then separate them, bringing his people into heaven and throwing nonbelievers into hell.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The meaning of the weeds in the wheat

Jesus explains the meaning of the weeds to his disciples

This passage occurs only in Matthew.

13:38a

The field is the world,

- The field is like the earth,
- The field represents the world.

The field is the world: The field in the parable represents the earth, the place where all people live.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

The field represents the earth

The field is like the world

13:38b

and the good seed represents the sons of the kingdom.

- and the good seed is like the people who belong to God’s kingdom.
- The good seed represents the people who are in God’s rule/chieftaincy.

the good seed represents the sons of the kingdom:

The phrase sons of is a Hebrew idiom that means “the people who belong to.” It refers to both men and women who belong to God’s kingdom.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

The good seeds are those who belong to the kingdom. (GW)

the good seed represents the people of the Kingdom (NLT)

the good seed is like the people who have submitted to God’s rule

13:38c**The weeds are the sons of the evil one,**

- The weeds are like the people who belong to the evil one,
- The weeds represent the people who follow Satan.

The weeds are the sons of the evil one: As in 13:38b, the phrase sons of means “the people who belong to.” The weeds represent the people who belong to the evil one. The evil one is another name for Satan.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

The weeds are the people who belong to the evil one. (NLT)

The weeds represent the people who follow Satan

weeds: This is the same word that occurs in 13:25b. You should translate it here as you did there. For example:

weed seeds

seeds of bad plants

poisonous weed seeds

Matthew 13:39**Section 13:36–43: Jesus explained the parable of the weeds**

In this section, Jesus explained the meaning of the parable of the weeds to his disciples. This parable shows God’s patience. Jesus announced that the kingdom of God had come, but not everyone accepted his message. However, God does not immediately destroy them. He permits people who do not follow him to live on the earth together with his people. They will live together until the day that God judges people. He will then separate them, bringing his people into heaven and throwing nonbelievers into hell.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The meaning of the weeds in the wheat

Jesus explains the meaning of the weeds to his disciples

This passage occurs only in Matthew.

13:39a**and the enemy who sows them is the devil.**

- and the enemy who planted them is like the devil.
- The enemy who planted the weeds represents Satan.

the enemy who sows them is the devil: The pronoun them refers to the weeds. The man’s enemy who planted the weeds represents the devil. His name is Satan.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the enemy who planted the weeds is like the devil

the man’s enemy who planted the weeds represents the devil

the devil: This word refers to Satan. If people in your area will think that “the devil” and “the evil one” (in 13:38c) are different beings, you should consider using the same term in both places. For example:

the evil one

Satan

13:39b**The harvest is the end of the age,**

- The harvest time/season is like the end of this time on earth,
- The time when the wheat/grain is cut represents the end of the world.

The harvest: The noun harvest refers to the time when mature crops are cut and gathered.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

harvest time

harvest season

The word harvest also occurs in 13:30a.

the end of the age: This phrase refers to the end of the world. At that time, God will judge the people of the world (13:40–42). The current way of living on earth will end.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the end of the world (GW)

the end of this time on earth

13:39c and the harvesters are angels.

- and the people who harvest are like angels.
- The people who cut and gather the wheat/grain represent angels.

the harvesters: The harvesters are the people who cut down the wheat and gather it.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

reapers (ESV)

the harvest workers (GNT)

those who cut the ripened wheat/grain

This word also occurs in 13:30b.

are angels: The Greek word that the BSB translates as angels means “messengers.” Here it refers to supernatural, spiritual beings who serve God.

Here are some ways to translate this term:

- Use a descriptive word or phrase. For example:

messengers from God

holy spirit-beings

- Use a local term that fits the biblical meaning.
- In some areas the churches may already be using a borrowed term or a transliterated word for “angels.” Be sure that this term fits the biblical meaning. If some people do not understand the right meaning from this term, you may need to indicate the meaning in some way. For example:

angelos messengers from God

sacred angelos spirits

See angel, Meaning 1, in the Glossary for more information.

Matthew 13:40

Section 13:36–43: Jesus explained the parable of the weeds

In this section, Jesus explained the meaning of the parable of the weeds to his disciples. This parable shows God’s patience. Jesus announced that the kingdom of God had come, but not everyone accepted his message. However, God does not immediately destroy them. He permits people who do not follow him to live on the earth together with his people. They will live together until the day that God judges people. He will then separate them, bringing his people into heaven and throwing nonbelievers into hell.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The meaning of the weeds in the wheat

Jesus explains the meaning of the weeds to his disciples

This passage occurs only in Matthew.

13:40a

As the weeds are collected and burned in the fire,

- Just like the weeds are gathered and burned in the fire,
- The harvesters collecting the weeds and burning them in a fire

As: The Greek word that the BSB translates as As introduces the first part of a comparison. (The second part of the comparison is 13:40b–42b.)

Here are some other ways to introduce this comparison:

Just as (ESV)

Like

In some languages, only the second part of the comparison is marked. See the examples under 13:40b.

the weeds are collected and burned in the fire: This clause has two passive verbs: collected and burned.

Here are some ways to translate this clause:

- Use passive verbs. For example:

Just as weeds are gathered and burned (GW)

- Use active verbs. For example:

As the harvesters gathered the weeds and burned them

Like they gathered and burned the weeds

collected: The Greek word that the BSB translates as collected means “gather” or “collect.” Here it refers to removing the weeds from the grain/wheat and collecting them together.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

collected

pulled up (NCV)

This same verb occurs in 13:28b, where the BSB translates it as “pull...up.”

burned in the fire: In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate the phrase in the fire. For example:

burned (GW)

13:40b

so will it be at the end of the age.

- like that it will be/happen at the end of this time on earth.
- represent the things/events that will happen at the end of the world.

so: The Greek word that the BSB translates as so introduces the second part of a comparison. (The first part of the comparison is 13:40a.)

Here are some other ways to introduce this part of the comparison:

that is like

like that also

that represents

will it be at the end of the age: This clause refers to certain events that will happen at the end of the world. These events are like what happens to weeds. More specifically, this means that evil people will be

gathered and thrown into the fire of hell. These details are found in the following verses (13:41–42).

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the same thing will happen at the end of the age (GNT)

the things/events that will happen to evil people at the end of the world

the end of the age: This phrase refers to the end of the world. This same phrase occurs in 13:39b.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the end of the world (NLT)

the end of this time on earth

Matthew 13:41

Section 13:36–43: Jesus explained the parable of the weeds

In this section, Jesus explained the meaning of the parable of the weeds to his disciples. This parable shows God’s patience. Jesus announced that the kingdom of God had come, but not everyone accepted his message. However, God does not immediately destroy them. He permits people who do not follow him to live on the earth together with his people. They will live together until the day that God judges people. He will then separate them, bringing his people into heaven and throwing nonbelievers into hell.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The meaning of the weeds in the wheat

Jesus explains the meaning of the weeds to his disciples

This passage occurs only in Matthew.

13:41a

The Son of Man will send out His angels,

- The Son of Man will send his angels,
- I, the Son of Man will send my angels to the earth

The Son of Man: As in 13:37, here Jesus refers to himself as The Son of Man. In some languages, it may be necessary to add the pronoun “I” to make it clear that Jesus was referring to himself. For example:

I, the Son of Man

will send out His angels: Jesus will send angels to earth from heaven. In some languages, it may be natural to include some of this information. For example:

will send his angels from heaven

will send his angels to the earth

If you translated “the Son of Man” as “I, the Son of Man” then you should use the phrase “my angels” rather than “his angels” here.

13:41b and they will weed out of His kingdom

- and they will gather from his kingdom
- to gather and remove from my rule/chieftaincy

they will weed out of His kingdom: This clause refers to gathering certain things and removing them from Jesus’ kingdom.

The word weed is the same verb that is used in 13:30c and 13:40a. There it referred to gathering weeds. Here it refers to gathering evil people.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

they will gather/collect and remove from his kingdom

they will remove from his Kingdom (NLT)

His kingdom: The pronoun His refers to the Son of Man, Jesus. The kingdom of the Son of Man and the kingdom of God/heaven are all the same.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

his rule/chieftaincy

If you translated “the Son of Man” as “I, the Son of Man” then you should translate this phrase as “my kingdom” to make it clear that Jesus was referring to his own kingdom.

13:41c every cause of sin and all who practice lawlessness.

- everyone who causes sin and all who always break God’s laws.
- everyone who causes other people to sin and everyone who does not follow God’s laws.

every cause of sin: There are two ways to interpret the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as every cause of sin:

1. It refers to all people who cause other people to sin. For example:

all those who cause people to sin (GNT) (GNT, CEV, NCV)

1. It refers to all things that cause people to sin. For example:

everything that causes sin (NIV) (BSB, NIV, ESV, NET, RSV, KJV, NASB, REB, GW, NLT, JBP, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Most English versions translate the Greek word literally. However, in the context of 13:39c, the weeds represent people who follow Satan. The weeds do not represent other things.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

everyone who...causes others to sin (CEV)

everyone who causes someone else to sin

all who practice lawlessness: This phrase refers to everyone who breaks God’s laws on purpose.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

all who are always breaking God’s laws

everyone who does not follow God’s laws

all who do evil (NIV)

Matthew 13:42

Section 13:36–43: Jesus explained the parable of the weeds

In this section, Jesus explained the meaning of the parable of the weeds to his disciples. This parable shows God’s patience. Jesus announced that the kingdom of God had come, but not everyone accepted his message. However, God does not immediately destroy them. He permits people who do not follow him to live on the earth together with his people. They will live together until the day that God judges people. He will then separate them, bringing his people into heaven and throwing nonbelievers into hell.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The meaning of the weeds in the wheat

Jesus explains the meaning of the weeds to his disciples

This passage occurs only in Matthew.

13:42a

And they will throw them into the fiery furnace,

- They will throw them into the furnace/oven/place where the fire is hot/big.
- The angels will throw those evil people into the great fire of hell.

And they will throw them: The angels will throw evil people into the fire. Here the word throw refers to “forcefully putting” someone in a place that he does not want to go.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the angels will throw them

the angels will throw these evil people

into the fiery furnace: A furnace is like an oven. It is a metal box or clay construction that has a fire inside and openings for air and fuel. It is designed to make the fire very hot. Here, the furnace refers to hell. The word fiery refers to the fire in the furnace. It is very hot. This refers to the intense punishment and suffering of those there.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

into the oven with a great fire

into the place of hot/strong fire

into the great fire of hell

13:42b

where there will be weeping and gnashing of teeth.

- There they will wail and grind their teeth!
- There they will cry loudly and clench their teeth in pain and anger!

where there will be weeping: The Greek word that the BSB translates as weeping refers to the loud sound

that people make when they have much grief and sorrow. It is not a quiet sobbing.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

where there will be wailing (REB)

People will cry (GW)

This same clause is found in 8:12c.

and gnashing of teeth: This phrase refers to grinding of teeth because of pain, anger, and bitterness. In hell, people will be in pain. They will also be angry at what happened to them.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- Use a term in your language that describes what people do with their teeth when they are in pain and are also angry. For example:

grind teeth

clench teeth

- Add some information. For example:

they will grind their teeth in pain and anger

- Translate the meaning of the action. For example:

and be in extreme pain there (GW)

This verb also occurs in 8:12c.

Matthew 13:43

Section 13:36–43: Jesus explained the parable of the weeds

In this section, Jesus explained the meaning of the parable of the weeds to his disciples. This parable shows God’s patience. Jesus announced that the kingdom of God had come, but not everyone accepted his message. However, God does not immediately destroy them. He permits people who do not follow him to live on the earth together with his people. They will live together until the day that God judges people. He will then separate them, bringing his people into heaven and throwing nonbelievers into hell.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The meaning of the weeds in the wheat

Jesus explains the meaning of the weeds to his disciples

This passage occurs only in Matthew.

13:43a

Then the righteous will shine like the sun in the kingdom of their Father.

- Then the righteous people will be bright like the sun in the kingdom of their father God.
- But the good people will go to the rule/chieftaincy of their father God. There he will honor/glorify them.

Then the righteous: The phrase the righteous refers to the people who do what is right and good in God's sight. It refers to believers. This same Greek word is translated as "righteous men" in 13:17b.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

everyone who has done right (CEV)

the good people (NCV)

the people who obey God's laws

will shine like the sun: This phrase is a simile. In this simile, righteous people are compared to the sun. They are similar in that both will shine. This indicates that righteous people will share in Christ's glory and honor.

This description of righteous people is similar to 17:2b. There Jesus was transfigured before his disciples and his face "shone like the sun."

Here are some other ways to translate this simile:

- Keep the simile. For example:

God will cause righteous people to shine/glow like the sun

righteous people will be bright like the sun

good people will be like the sun shining brightly

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

righteous people will receive glory/honor

God will honor righteous people

in the kingdom of their Father: This phrase refers to the same kingdom as in 13:41b and 13:38b. The kingdom of God the Father is the same kingdom as the kingdom of his son Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the kingdom of God their Father

the rule/chieftaincy of their Father who is God

The kingdom of their Father is the place where the righteous will go. It contrasts with the fiery furnace where the law-breakers will go. In some languages, it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

But the righteous people will go to the kingdom of their Father. There they will shine like the sun.

their Father: This phrase refers to God the Father. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

God their Father

13:43b

He who has ears, let him hear.

- Whoever is able to hear should listen to and accept the words I said/say.
- All of you listening, accept what I just said."

The saying in this verse also occurs in Matthew 11:15, 13:9, Mark 4:9, Mark 4:23, Luke 8:8, and Luke 14:35. You should translate all these passages in the same way.

He who has ears, let him hear: These words are a saying that Jesus used to command or urge the crowd to carefully think about the words that they had just heard.

Here are some other ways to translate this saying:

You people who can hear me, listen. (NCV)

Anyone with ears to hear should listen and understand. (NLT)

You who are listening, think about what you have just heard.

Matthew 13:44

Section 13:44–50: Jesus told some more parables about the kingdom of God

In this section, Jesus told three more parables. Each parable teaches something about the kingdom of God. The first parable tells a story about a treasure, and the second parable tells a story about a pearl. Both parables show that being in God's kingdom is worth much more than all a person has. The third parable tells a story about a fishing net. Its meaning is similar to the parable of the weeds. It shows that good and bad people will live together for a while. But in the end, God will judge all people.

If the major language translation in your area breaks each parable into a separate section, you may want to follow that example. For example: 13:44 is “The parable of the hidden treasure,” 13:45–46 is “The parable of the pearl,” and 13:47–50 is “The parable of the fish net.”

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Three parables

Parables about a treasure, a pearl, and a fishing net

These three parables occur only in Matthew.

Paragraph 13:44

The parable of the treasure in a field teaches us that the most important thing in a person's life is to belong to God's kingdom. A person should seek to belong to God's kingdom at all cost.

This parable does not teach that a person can buy his way into God's kingdom. If people in your area will not understand the teaching of this parable, you may want to explain it in a footnote. A sample footnote is:

This parable shows that the most important thing in a person's life is to belong to God's kingdom. The parable does not show that someone can buy their way into God's kingdom.

13:44a

The kingdom of heaven is like treasure hidden in a field.

- ¶ “The kingdom of heaven is like riches that were buried in a field.
- ¶ Jesus continued, “God's rule/chieftaincy is also like coins/gold that someone/they buried in a field.

The kingdom of heaven is like treasure hidden in a field: This clause is a simile. It compares the kingdom of heaven/God to a hidden treasure. The point of similarity in this comparison is that both are worth much more than everything that a person owns. A person should do anything necessary to get them.

The kingdom of heaven: This phrase last occurred in 13:33b–c. For help in translating this phrase, see the note at 13:11b.

treasure: This word refers to an object or objects that are very valuable. The Greek text does not tell us exactly what the treasure was. It could have been coins, jewels, or something else that was worth a lot of money.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

- Use a specific term for something that is very valuable. For example:

gold/silver

coins/money

- Use a general term for an object that is very valuable. For example:

an object worth much money

something very valuable

hidden in a field: In this context, the word hidden probably means “buried.” In those days, it was common for people to bury their valuable possessions in the ground. They did this so that thieves or enemy soldiers could not find them and steal them.

This word is passive. Here are some ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

buried in a field (GW)

- Use an active verb. For example:

that they/someone had buried in a field

13:44b

When a man found it, he hid it again,

- A man came upon it, and covered it up again.

- When someone accidentally uncovered it, he covered/buried it again.

When a man found it: This clause refers to someone accidentally finding/discovering a treasure. It does not indicate that the person was deliberately looking for it. The person was probably a worker plowing or hoeing another person's field, and he accidentally unearthed a treasure.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

a man discovered it (GW)

a man accidentally uncovered it

a man came upon it

he hid it again: This phrase indicates that the man put the treasure back the way he found it. He hid/buried it again.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he covered it up again

he buried it again (GW)

13:44c

and in his joy he went and sold all he had

- Then he went with joy and sold everything that he owned
- He was very happy. He went and sold everything he owned to get enough money.

and in his joy he went: The phrase in his joy refers to the entire situation. The man was happy that he found a treasure. And he was happy to sell everything he had in order to buy the field. You should put this phrase where it is most natural in your language. For example:

He was so happy that he went (NCV)

He went with joy and sold...

He went and happily sold...

sold all he had: The man did not own the field where the treasure was, so he could not legally keep the treasure. He had to first buy the field in order to claim

the treasure. In order to have enough money to buy the field, he had to sell everything he owned.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

sold all his possessions

sold everything he owned to get enough money (NLT)

13:44d

and bought that field.

- and bought that field.
- Then he bought that field to own/keep the treasure.

and bought that field: The man had to buy the field in order to own the treasure. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this information explicit. For example:

and buys that field to own/keep the treasure

Matthew 13:45

Section 13:44–50: Jesus told some more parables about the kingdom of God

In this section, Jesus told three more parables. Each parable teaches something about the kingdom of God. The first parable tells a story about a treasure, and the second parable tells a story about a pearl. Both parables show that being in God's kingdom is worth much more than all a person has. The third parable tells a story about a fishing net. Its meaning is similar to the parable of the weeds. It shows that good and bad people will live together for a while. But in the end, God will judge all people.

If the major language translation in your area breaks each parable into a separate section, you may want to follow that example. For example: 13:44 is "The parable of the hidden treasure," 13:45–46 is "The parable of the pearl," and 13:47–50 is "The parable of the fish net."

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Three parables

Parables about a treasure, a pearl, and a fishing net

These three parables occur only in Matthew.

Paragraph 13:45–46

In this paragraph, Jesus compared the kingdom of heaven to a pearl of great value (in 13:46a). The comparison is not to the merchant in the next phrase (13:45b).

In order to make the comparison clear, it may be necessary in some languages to change the order of some of the clauses in 13:45–46. For example:

^{45a}Again, the kingdom of heaven is like ^{46a}a pearl of great value. ^{45b}When a merchant who was searching for one ^{46a}found one, ^{46b}he went and sold all that he had and bought it.

This parable teaches us the same lesson as the parable of the hidden treasure: the most important thing in a person's life is to belong to God's kingdom. A person should seek to belong to God's kingdom at all cost.

13:45a**Again, the kingdom of heaven is like**

- ¶ “Also, the kingdom of heaven is like this:
- ¶ “Here is what God's rule/chieftaincy is also like.

Again: This word refers to the fact that Jesus spoke another parable about God's kingdom. The teaching of this parable is similar to the teaching of the parable of the treasure. It does not mean that he repeated what he had already said.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Also (GNT)

Furthermore

the kingdom of heaven is like: This clause begins a simile. This simile compares the kingdom of heaven to a pearl of great value (in 13:46a). (As mentioned above, the comparison is not to the merchant.) The point of similarity is that both the kingdom of heaven and a valuable pearl are worth much more than everything that a person owns. A person should do anything necessary to get them.

Here are some other ways to begin this simile:

the Kingdom of heaven is like this: (GNT)

Here is what the kingdom of heaven can be compared to:

13:45b**a merchant in search of fine pearls.**

- A trader was searching for beautiful little stones called pearls.
- A man was looking for beautiful beads to buy.

merchant: This word refers to someone who buys and sells goods.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

trader

businessman

man (GNT)

fine pearls: The word pearls refers to round, stone-like beads about 5–10 millimeters across. Pearls are found in a kind of shellfish called an “oyster.” Pearls are often very beautiful, and good ones are very valuable. People wear them in necklaces and as other jewelry.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

expensive beads

precious/costly stones

- Use the major language word for “pearl” and explain it in the text. For example:

expensive jewels called pearls

This word also occurs in 7:6b.

fine: This word means “beautiful” or “free from defects” here.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

beautiful

choice (NLT)

Matthew 13:46**Section 13:44–50: Jesus told some more parables about the kingdom of God**

In this section, Jesus told three more parables. Each parable teaches something about the kingdom of God.

The first parable tells a story about a treasure, and the second parable tells a story about a pearl. Both parables show that being in God's kingdom is worth much more than all a person has. The third parable tells a story about a fishing net. Its meaning is similar to the parable of the weeds. It shows that good and bad people will live together for a while. But in the end, God will judge all people.

If the major language translation in your area breaks each parable into a separate section, you may want to follow that example. For example: 13:44 is "The parable of the hidden treasure," 13:45–46 is "The parable of the pearl," and 13:47–50 is "The parable of the fish net."

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Three parables

Parables about a treasure, a pearl, and a fishing net

These three parables occur only in Matthew.

Paragraph 13:45–46

In this paragraph, Jesus compared the kingdom of heaven to a pearl of great value (in 13:46a). The comparison is not to the merchant in the next phrase (13:45b).

In order to make the comparison clear, it may be necessary in some languages to change the order of some of the clauses in 13:45–46. For example:

^{45a}Again, the kingdom of heaven is like ^{46a}a pearl of great value. ^{45b}When a merchant who was searching for one ^{46a}found one, ^{46b}he went and sold all that he had and bought it.

This parable teaches us the same lesson as the parable of the hidden treasure: the most important thing in a person's life is to belong to God's kingdom. A person should seek to belong to God's kingdom at all cost.

13:46a

When he found one very precious pearl,

- When he found a very valuable one,
- One day he found one that was very expensive. So

he: This word refers back to the merchant in 13:45b.

one very precious pearl: The Greek word that the BSB translates as very precious means "precious," "valuable" or "genuine." This is a different Greek word than the word translated as "fine" in 13:45b.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

very expensive

one that cost a lot of money

13:45–46

(reordered) Again, the kingdom of heaven is like a pearl of great value. When a merchant who was searching for one found one, he went and sold all that he had and bought it.

13:46b

he went away and sold all he had and bought it.

- he went and sold everything he owned and bought it.
- he went and sold all his possessions. Then he took the money and bought that bead."

went away and sold all he had and bought it: This phrase is very similar to 13:44c. It implies that the merchant did not have enough money to buy the pearl. In order to buy it, he first had to go and sell all his possessions. Then with the money, he was able to buy the pearl.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

went and sold everything he owned and bought it

went and sold all his possessions to get enough money. Then he bought it.

Matthew 13:47

Section 13:44–50: Jesus told some more parables about the kingdom of God

In this section, Jesus told three more parables. Each parable teaches something about the kingdom of God. The first parable tells a story about a treasure, and the second parable tells a story about a pearl. Both parables show that being in God's kingdom is worth much more than all a person has. The third parable tells a story about a fishing net. Its meaning is similar to the parable of the weeds. It shows that good and bad people will live together for a while. But in the end, God will judge all people.

If the major language translation in your area breaks each parable into a separate section, you may want to follow that example. For example: 13:44 is "The parable of the hidden treasure," 13:45–46 is "The parable of the pearl," and 13:47–50 is "The parable of the fish net."

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Three parables

Parables about a treasure, a pearl, and a fishing net

These three parables occur only in Matthew.

Paragraph 13:47–50

The parable of the net in this paragraph has a similar meaning to the parable of the weeds. In both parables, Jesus told us that good and bad people will live together for a while. But in the end, the angels will separate them.

13:47a

Once again, the kingdom of heaven is like a net

- ¶ “Also, the kingdom of heaven is like a fish net
- ¶ “God’s rule/chieftaincy is also like a net for fishing.

Once again: The words Once again introduce another parable about the kingdom of heaven. This same word occurs in 13:45a. You should translate it here as you did there. For example:

Also (GNT)

the kingdom of heaven is like a net: This clause is a simile. It compares the kingdom of heaven/God to a fishing net. The point of similarity in this comparison is that both are spread over a variety of things. A net catches a variety of fish. The message of the kingdom will be preached to a variety of people both good and bad.

net: This net was a large net that fishermen used to catch fish. It required at least two people to use. It had floats along the top and weights along the bottom. They spread the net in the water and then pulled it to the shore or a boat.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

fish net

dragnet

13:47b

that was cast into the sea and caught all kinds of fish.

- that was thrown into the lake. It caught many kinds of fish.

- Fishermen let it down into the lake and it caught/trapped many different kinds of fish.

that was cast into the sea: The net was cast so that it spread out before falling into the water. This is the normal way to put this type of net into the water. Be sure not to use a word that implies that the fishermen threw their nets away.

The verb was cast is passive. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

that was let down into the lake (NIV)

that was put into the lake (NCV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

Some fishermen throw their net out in the lake (GNT)

the sea: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sea here is a general word that can also be translated as “lake” (as in the NIV). The English word “sea” often implies salt water. But the Greek word can refer to a freshwater lake.

caught all kinds of fish: In this context, the Greek word that the BSB translates as caught refers to catching fish. For example:

caught all kinds of fish (NIV)

caught many different kinds of fish (NCV)

In the parable, this phrase refers to the message of the kingdom being broadcast to both good and bad people.

Matthew 13:48

Section 13:44–50: Jesus told some more parables about the kingdom of God

In this section, Jesus told three more parables. Each parable teaches something about the kingdom of God. The first parable tells a story about a treasure, and the second parable tells a story about a pearl. Both parables show that being in God’s kingdom is worth much more than all a person has. The third parable tells a story about a fishing net. Its meaning is similar to the parable of the weeds. It shows that good and

bad people will live together for a while. But in the end, God will judge all people.

If the major language translation in your area breaks each parable into a separate section, you may want to follow that example. For example: 13:44 is “The parable of the hidden treasure,” 13:45–46 is “The parable of the pearl,” and 13:47–50 is “The parable of the fish net.”

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Three parables

Parables about a treasure, a pearl, and a fishing net

These three parables occur only in Matthew.

Paragraph 13:47–50

The parable of the net in this paragraph has a similar meaning to the parable of the weeds. In both parables, Jesus told us that good and bad people will live together for a while. But in the end, the angels will separate them.

13:48a

When it was full, the men pulled it ashore.

- When the net was full, the fishermen pulled it onto the shore.
- When the net was full of fish, they dragged it onto the side/edge of the lake.

When it was full, the men pulled it ashore: The Greek word that the BSB translates as pulled also means “pulled up.” When the net was full of fish, the fishermen pulled it up out of the water and onto the shore.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

When the net was full, they dragged it up onto the shore (NLT)

When it was full, the fishermen pulled the net to the shore (NCV)

13:48b

Then they sat down and sorted the good fish into containers,

- They sat down and picked out the good fish and put them into pots,
- Then they sat down and divided the good from the bad. They put the good fish into buckets.

Then they sat down and sorted the good fish: The phrase sorted the good means that the fishermen picked/gathered the good fish out from among the bad fish.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

gathered the good fish (GW)

put all the good fish (NCV)

In some languages, it may be more natural to explain the action of sorting the fish in two steps. For example:

sit down to separate the fish. They keep the good ones (CEV)

sit down to divide the fish: the good ones go into the buckets (GNT)

sat down and separated the good fish from the bad. They put the good fish

the good fish: This phrase refers to fish that are good to eat.

into containers: The Greek word that the BSB translates as containers generally refers to a type of pot that can hold a liquid like water. It is different than a basket. Putting fish into these types of containers would keep the fish alive and fresh longer.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

buckets (GNT)

clay pots

barrels (JBP)

Here the type of container is not in focus. If people in your culture usually put live fish in baskets, you can use the word baskets here (as in the NIV).

13:48c

but threw the bad away.

- and threw away the bad fish.
- The bad ones they threw away.

but: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between what the fishermen did with the good fish, and what they did with the bad fish. The BSB indicates this contrast with the conjunction but.

Here are some other ways to connect 13:48c to the rest of the verse:

and threw away the bad fish (NCV)

The fish that were not good, they threw them away.

threw the bad away: This phrase means that the fishermen threw away or “discarded” the fish that were not good to eat. They either threw them back into the water, or onto the shore. The place where they threw them is not in focus.

Matthew 13:49

Section 13:44–50: Jesus told some more parables about the kingdom of God

In this section, Jesus told three more parables. Each parable teaches something about the kingdom of God. The first parable tells a story about a treasure, and the second parable tells a story about a pearl. Both parables show that being in God’s kingdom is worth much more than all a person has. The third parable tells a story about a fishing net. Its meaning is similar to the parable of the weeds. It shows that good and bad people will live together for a while. But in the end, God will judge all people.

If the major language translation in your area breaks each parable into a separate section, you may want to follow that example. For example: 13:44 is “The parable of the hidden treasure,” 13:45–46 is “The parable of the pearl,” and 13:47–50 is “The parable of the fish net.”

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Three parables

Parables about a treasure, a pearl, and a fishing net

These three parables occur only in Matthew.

Paragraph 13:47–50

The parable of the net in this paragraph has a similar meaning to the parable of the weeds. In both parables, Jesus told us that good and bad people will live together for a while. But in the end, the angels will separate them.

13:49a

So will it be at the end of the age:

- It will be that way at the end of this time on earth.
- That is how it will be like at the end of the world.

So will it be: This clause indicates that 13:49b–50 explains the parable in 13:47–48. The Greek word that the BSB translates as So means “even so,” “like that,” or “in the same way.” It does not mean “therefore.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

The same thing will happen (GW)

That is the way it will be (NLT)

at the end of the age: This phrase refers to the day when God will judge the people of the world. This same phrase occurs in 13:40b.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

at the end of the world (NCV)

at the end of this time on earth

13:49b

The angels will come and separate the wicked from the righteous,

- The angels will come and separate/divide the evil people from the people who do what is right/good.
- The angels will go and will take/pick the bad people from among the good people.

The angels will come: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as will come is literally “will go out.” In the context of 13:41a where Jesus sends out the angels, this verb probably means that the angels will go out from heaven.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the angels will go out (GNT)

and separate: This verb refers to separating or dividing things into groups. In this context, the angels will separate or pick out evil people from among good people.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

divide

pick out

the wicked: This word describes people who do evil deeds as a way of life.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

evil people (NCV)

bad people

the righteous: This word describes people who do what is right and good. They follow God's rules/commands.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

those who do what is right

good people

This word also occurs in 13:43a.

Matthew 13:50

Section 13:44–50: Jesus told some more parables about the kingdom of God

In this section, Jesus told three more parables. Each parable teaches something about the kingdom of God. The first parable tells a story about a treasure, and the second parable tells a story about a pearl. Both parables show that being in God's kingdom is worth much more than all a person has. The third parable tells a story about a fishing net. Its meaning is similar to the parable of the weeds. It shows that good and bad people will live together for a while. But in the end, God will judge all people.

If the major language translation in your area breaks each parable into a separate section, you may want to follow that example. For example: 13:44 is "The parable of the hidden treasure," 13:45–46 is "The parable of the pearl," and 13:47–50 is "The parable of the fish net."

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Three parables

Parables about a treasure, a pearl, and a fishing net

These three parables occur only in Matthew.

Paragraph 13:47–50

The parable of the net in this paragraph has a similar meaning to the parable of the weeds. In both parables, Jesus told us that good and bad people will live together for a while. But in the end, the angels will separate them.

13:50a

and throw them into the fiery furnace,

- They will throw them into the furnace/oven/place where the fire is hot/big.
- The angels will throw those evil/bad people into the great fire of hell.

This is the same clause as in 13:42a. Translate it in the same way.

them: This pronoun refers to the evil people. It does not refer to the righteous people. Make sure this is clear in your translation.

13:50b

where there will be weeping and gnashing of teeth.

- There they will wail and grind their teeth!
- There they will cry loudly and clench their teeth in pain and anger!

This is the same clause as in 13:42b. Translate it in the same way.

Matthew 13:51

Section 13:51–52: Jesus told the parable about the owner of a house

In this parable, Jesus compared Christian teachers to a house owner who shares his riches with others. Christian teachings are like the house owner's riches. These teachers will teach to others the things that they have learned about the scriptures at that time (the Old Testament). They will also teach others the new things that Jesus had been teaching them.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus told the parable of the head of a house

New and Old Treasures (CEV)

This parable occurs only in Matthew.

13:51a

Have you understood all these things?"

- ¶ Jesus asked, "Do you^(plur) understand all these teachings?"

- ¶ Then Jesus asked his disciples, “Do you^(plur) understand all that I have said?”

Have you understood: The pronoun you refers to Jesus’ disciples. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this explicit. It may also be necessary to make explicit that Jesus was talking. For example:

Jesus asked the disciples , “Have you understood”

all these things: This phrase refers to Jesus’ teachings through the parables in 13:3–50.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

all those teachings

all that I have said to you

13:51b

“Yes,” they answered.

- They answered him, “Yes, we^(excl) do understand.”
- They told him that they did understand.

“Yes,” they answered: The pronoun they refers to his disciples.

In some languages, it may be more natural to translate this as indirect speech. For example:

They told him that they did understand.

Matthew 13:52

Section 13:51–52: Jesus told the parable about the owner of a house

In this parable, Jesus compared Christian teachers to a house owner who shares his riches with others. Christian teachings are like the house owner’s riches. These teachers will teach to others the things that they have learned about the scriptures at that time (the Old Testament). They will also teach others the new things that Jesus had been teaching them.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus told the parable of the head of a house

New and Old Treasures (CEV)

This parable occurs only in Matthew.

13:52a

Then He told them, “For this reason, every scribe

- Then he said to them, “So every teacher of the law of Moses
- Then he said to them, “Every person who knows God’s law and

Then: In this verse, Jesus responded to the disciples’ answer.

Here are some other ways to begin this verse:

And... (ESV)

So... (GNT)

For this reason: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For this reason usually indicates a conclusion. However, in this context, 13:52 is more a result of the disciples’ understanding. They understood what Jesus was teaching, so they are teachers who are like the master of a house.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

So (NCV)

That is why (GW)

Since/Because you understand, then

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it may not be necessary to translate it either.

every scribe: In this context, the Greek word that the BSB translates as scribe probably refers to a person who is a disciple/follower of Jesus. He is also a person who has received some training in the things of God.

In the book of Matthew, the word scribe normally refers to the teachers of the law whom Jesus criticized. But in this context, Jesus probably used this term in the more general sense of “religious scholar” or “learned one.”

Jesus’ twelve disciples were some of this group of “scribes.” As Jewish men, they had some education in God’s law. Jesus had also taught them many additional things about God and his rule.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

- Use your normal term for scribe. This word last occurred in 12:38a. For example:

teacher of the law (NIV)

- Translate the term scribe in a more general way. For example:

one who knows the Law (JBP)

person learned in the law of Moses

person who knows God's law

13:52b

who has been disciplined in the kingdom of heaven

- who becomes a disciple of the kingdom of heaven
- who submits/commits himself to God's rule/chief-taincy

who has been disciplined in the kingdom of heaven:

This clause describes the particular type of scribe (teacher of the law) who is like the master of a house. He is a scribe who:

1. has received training about the kingdom of heaven. Jesus taught his disciples about the kingdom through the parables in this chapter.
2. has become a disciple of the kingdom of heaven. This is the basic meaning of the Greek verb that the BSB translates as disciplined. This verb has the same root as "disciple."

In addition, this clause is passive. Here are some ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

who is made a disciple in the kingdom of heaven

who has been taught about the kingdom of heaven (NCV)

- Use an active or reflexive verb. For example:

who has submitted himself to the kingdom of heaven

who has committed himself to God's rule/chief-taincy

- Use another type of verb. For example:

who becomes a disciple in the Kingdom of heaven (GNT)

13:52c

is like a homeowner

- is like the owner of a house.
- is compared to the head of a household.

is like a homeowner: This is a simile. In this simile, a scribe is compared to a homeowner. The way that they are similar is that both people share things. The owner of a house shares his possessions. The scribe shares what he has learned about the kingdom.

homeowner: The Greek word that the BSB translates as homeowner refers to a man who owns and manages his own house and land. This includes his own family, slaves, and other workers. The fact that he brings things out of his treasure (13:52d) indicates that he is probably rich.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

owner of a household

a rich man

13:52d

who brings out of his storeroom new treasures as well as old."

- He brings out from his storeroom old and new things to share."
- He takes both old and new possessions/teachings out of the place where he stores them to help others."

This part of 13:52 contains the second relative (who) clause in this verse. In many languages, it will be natural to divide this verse into several sentences and begin a new sentence here.

who brings out of: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as brings out implies that the man takes/removes some of his possessions to share them or give them away. He brings them out to help his family and others. He does not bring out his possessions simply to look at them. This is like the teacher sharing his knowledge with others.

In some languages, it will be natural to make this explicit. For example:

brings out to share

takes out to help others

his storeroom: The Greek word that the BSB translates as his storeroom can refer to the place where treasure is stored, or to the treasure itself (as in 13:44a). Here it refers to the place where the treasure is stored.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

his treasure chest (GW)

the place where he stores/keeps his valuable things

new treasures as well as old: The phrase new treasures refers to the man's new possessions/things. The phrase as well as old refers to the man's old possessions/things. For example:

new and old things (GNT)

new things and old things (NCV)

In the context of the parable, the word new represents the teachings of Jesus (13:51a). The word old represents the teachings in the Old Testament. Both are good. As a translator, you should not put this information into the text. You may put it in a footnote.

Matthew 13:53

Section 13:53–58: The people of Nazareth rejected Jesus

Jesus grew up in the town of Nazareth. The people there knew him and his family. They were ordinary people. So when the people of Nazareth heard that Jesus was teaching and doing miracles, they had difficulty believing that he had so quickly become a great prophet.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Rejection at Nazareth (NET)

Nazareth does not honor Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:1–6 and Luke 4:16–30. See also John 4:44, 6:42.

13:53

Verse 13:53 is a transitional verse from one section to another. Some English versions (like the NRSV and GW) put this verse at the end the previous section. If

the major language version in your area has 13:53 in the previous section, you may want to follow that.

13:53a

When Jesus had finished these parables,

- ¶ When Jesus finished teaching/telling these parables,
- ¶ When Jesus finished teaching using these stories,

When Jesus had finished these parables: This clause refers to Jesus finishing his teaching using parables.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

When Jesus finished telling these parables

When Jesus finished teaching with these stories (NCV)

When Jesus finished teaching people using these parables

13:53b

He withdrew from that place.

- then he left that place.
- he went away from that area

He withdrew from that place: The phrase from that place refers either to the house in Capernaum where Jesus was staying or more generally to the town of Capernaum.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he left that place (GNT)

he left that part of the country (NLT)

Matthew 13:54

Section 13:53–58: The people of Nazareth rejected Jesus

Jesus grew up in the town of Nazareth. The people there knew him and his family. They were ordinary people. So when the people of Nazareth heard that Jesus was teaching and doing miracles, they had difficulty believing that he had so quickly become a great prophet.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Rejection at Nazareth (NET)

Nazareth does not honor Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:1–6 and Luke 4:16–30. See also John 4:44, 6:42.

13:54a

Coming to His hometown,

- He went up to his hometown,
- and went back to the town where he grew up. When he got there,

Coming to His hometown: The Greek word that the BSB translates as hometown refers to the town/place where a person lived with his parents while he was growing up. Jesus' hometown was Nazareth.

Capernaum is in a valley, and Nazareth is on a large hill. The walk from Capernaum to Nazareth is a one or two day journey of about forty kilometers to the west. It is a rise in elevation of about 550 meters.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

and went over to his hometown

and went up to the town where he grew up

and went back to his hometown (GNT)

13:54b

He taught the people in their synagogue,

- and began teaching the people in their synagogue,
- he started to teach in a prayer/worship house of the Jews.

their synagogue: This phrase refers to the synagogue of the Jews of that area. (This same phrase occurs in 4:23b, 9:35b, and 12:9.) In many languages, it is natural to simply say that Jesus went to “a synagogue.” For example:

a synagogue (GNT)

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

their worship place

their prayer house

a local house of worship

13:54c

and they were astonished.

- and they were very surprised.
- Everyone there was astonished at his wise teaching

and they were astonished: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as and indicates a connection. When Jesus taught, the result was that:

1. people were astonished, and
2. they asked themselves a number of rhetorical questions (in 13:54d–56b).

Here are some other ways to begin this clause:

- Use the conjunction “and.” For example:

and those who heard him were amazed (GNT)

- Begin a new sentence here. For example:

They were astonished (NET)

they were astonished: The people were astonished at Jesus' wisdom and teaching. Jesus had more wisdom than anything he learned at school as a child. The Holy Spirit gave this wisdom to him. The people of Nazareth knew Jesus from when he was a child, and so they were not expecting such great wisdom.

Here are some other examples:

everyone was amazed

they were very surprised at his wisdom

13:54d

“Where did this man get such wisdom and miraculous powers?” they asked.

- They asked themselves, “Where did this guy get this wisdom and the power to do these miracles?”
- and said to one another, “We wonder where this fellow became wise/clever like that. We wonder where he got the power to do these miracles. What a surprise!”

Where did this man get such wisdom and miraculous powers?: This is a rhetorical question. It expresses surprise. The people were surprised that Jesus had such wisdom and could do miracles. They asked themselves about the source of these things.

Here are some other ways to translate this surprise:

- As a rhetorical question or questions. For example:

Where did this man get this wisdom and this power to do miracles? (NCV)

Who taught this man? Who gave him the power to do these miracles?

- As a statement. For example:

We wonder where this man got his wisdom and the power to do these miracles. It is very surprising.

Translate this surprise in a way that is natural in your language.

this man: The Greek word that the BSB translates as this man is more literally “this (one).” The people referred to Jesus like this even though they knew his name. They did not say “our brother” or “our son.” This probably implies a lack of respect. If there is a way to show a lack of respect in your language when addressing someone, translate in that way.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

this fellow/guy

such wisdom: The phrase such wisdom refers to the wise teachings of Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

this knowledge/learning

these wise teachings

In some languages, it may be natural to translate the noun wisdom as an adjective. For example:

become smart/clever/wise

miraculous powers: The Greek word that the BSB translates as miraculous powers refers to the miracles that Jesus did.

In some languages, it may not be natural to say “where did he get these miracles.” It may be necessary to say:

the power to do these miracles (GW)

they asked: The people asked themselves these questions. They did not ask Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

and they said to each other

and they asked themselves

Matthew 13:55

Section 13:53–58: The people of Nazareth rejected Jesus

Jesus grew up in the town of Nazareth. The people there knew him and his family. They were ordinary people. So when the people of Nazareth heard that Jesus was teaching and doing miracles, they had difficulty believing that he had so quickly become a great prophet.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Rejection at Nazareth (NET)

Nazareth does not honor Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:1–6 and Luke 4:16–30. See also John 4:44, 6:42.

13:55–56a

All the questions about Jesus’ family (in 13:55–56a) are rhetorical questions. The people of Nazareth knew Jesus’ father, mother, brothers, and sisters. Using rhetorical questions implies that they believed that Jesus was an ordinary person like them and his family. Therefore, they doubted that Jesus could become someone important. The way you translate these rhetorical questions should not indicate that the people were unsure who Jesus’ family was.

13:55a

“Isn’t this the carpenter’s son?”

- Is not this guy only/merely the carpenter’s son?
- He is just the son of a carpenter. (NCV)

Isn’t this the carpenter’s son?: This is a rhetorical question. It expresses surprise and emphasizes that the people of Nazareth knew that Jesus was the son of a carpenter. The people doubted that Jesus could become someone important, because he was only the son of a carpenter.

Here are some other ways to translate this surprise, doubt, and emphasis:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Isn't this person only the carpenter's son?

This man is only the carpenter's son, isn't he?

- As a statement. For example:

He is just the son of a carpenter. (NCV)

Translate this surprise, emphasis, and doubt in a way that is natural in your language.

carpenter's son: The Greek word that the BSB translates as carpenter's also can mean "builder's." Jesus' father probably worked with wood, but he may have also made things with stone.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the son of a woodworker

the son of a builder

13:55b

Isn't His mother's name Mary,

- And is not his mother named Mary?
- His mother is Mary. (NCV)

Isn't His mother's name Mary...?: This is a rhetorical question. It expresses surprise and emphasizes that the people of Nazareth knew that Jesus was the son of Mary. The people doubted that Jesus could become someone important, because he was only the son of Mary. They did not see Mary as someone important, so they thought that her son could not be important either.

Here are some other ways to translate this surprise, doubt, and emphasis:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Isn't his mother's name Mary (NIV)

His mother is only Mary, isn't she?

- As a statement. For example:

His mother is only/just Mary!

His mother is Mary (NCV)

Translate this surprise, emphasis, and doubt in a way that is natural in your language.

Isn't His mother's name Mary: This clause means that Jesus' mother is the woman whose name is Mary. For example:

Isn't his mother named Mary? (NET)

Is not his mother called Mary? (ESV)

13:55c

and aren't His brothers James, Joseph, Simon, and Judas?

- Isn't he only/just the older brother of James, Joseph, Simon and Judas?
- His younger brothers are only James, Joseph, Simon and Judas.

and aren't His brothers James, Joseph, Simon, and Judas?:

This is a rhetorical question. It expresses surprise and emphasizes that the people of Nazareth knew that Jesus was a brother to James, Joseph, Simon, and Judas. The people doubted that Jesus could become someone important, because his brothers were not important people. So they thought that their brother Jesus could not become an important person either.

Here are some ways to translate this surprise, doubt, and emphasis:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Isn't he only/just the older brother of James, Joseph, Simon, and Judas?

- As a statement. For example:

his brothers are James, Joseph, Simon, and Judas (NCV)

Translate this surprise, emphasis and doubt in a way that is natural in your language.

His brothers James, Joseph, Simon, and Judas:

Jesus was the first-born and so he was the older brother of these four men. If your language has separate words for older brother and younger brother, you should use the word for younger brothers to refer to James, Joseph, Simon, and Judas.

Matthew 13:56

Section 13:53–58: The people of Nazareth rejected Jesus

Jesus grew up in the town of Nazareth. The people there knew him and his family. They were ordinary people. So when the people of Nazareth heard that Jesus was teaching and doing miracles, they had difficulty believing that he had so quickly become a great prophet.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Rejection at Nazareth (NET)

Nazareth does not honor Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:1–6 and Luke 4:16–30. See also John 4:44, 6:42.

13:56a

Aren't all His sisters with us as well?

- Is it not true that all his younger sisters are with us?^(incl)
- And all his younger sisters live here in this town.

Aren't all His sisters with us as well?: This is a rhetorical question. It expresses surprise and emphasizes that the people of Nazareth knew that his sisters lived there. The people doubted that Jesus could become someone important, because his sisters were not important people and did not marry anyone important.

Here are some ways to translate this surprise, doubt and emphasis:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

All his sisters are still with us, aren't they?

- As a statement. For example:

All his sisters are still with us in this town.

All his sisters live here too.

Translate this surprise, emphasis, and doubt in a way that is natural in your language.

His sisters: Jesus was the first-born, so his sisters were younger sisters.

13:56b

Where then did this man get all these things?"

- So where did this man get/receive all these things?"
- We wonder where/how this man received/learned all these things."

Where then did this man get all these things?: This is a rhetorical question. It expresses both surprise and doubt. This clause is similar to the rhetorical question in 13:54d. Translate this clause in a similar way.

Here are some ways to translate this surprise and doubt:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

So where did this man get/learn all these things?

- As a statement. For example:

We wonder where/how this man got/received these things!

Translate this surprise and doubt in a way that is natural in your language.

Where then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as then is the conjunction that is normally translated as "therefore." This word indicates the conclusion of something. Here, the people concluded all their rhetorical questions about Jesus with this general question.

Here is another way to translate this word:

So, where

all these things: The words all these things refer to the "wisdom and miraculous powers" of 13:54d.

Matthew 13:57

Section 13:53–58: The people of Nazareth rejected Jesus

Jesus grew up in the town of Nazareth. The people there knew him and his family. They were ordinary people. So when the people of Nazareth heard that Jesus was teaching and doing miracles, they had difficulty believing that he had so quickly become a great prophet.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Rejection at Nazareth (NET)

Nazareth does not honor Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:1–6 and Luke 4:16–30. See also John 4:44, 6:42.

13:57a

And they took offense at Him.

- And so they rejected him. (GNT)
- So the people refused to believe in him.

And: This part of 13:57 can be considered the result of all the rhetorical questions. Another way to begin this verse is:

So (REB)

they took offense at Him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as took offense means “were offended” or “were repelled.” This word also means “stopped believing.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

they rejected him (GNT)

the people were upset with Jesus (NCV)

they turned against him (REB)

they were deeply offended and refused to believe in him (NLT)

This same word occurs in 11:6, where the BSB translates it as “fall away.”

13:57b

But Jesus said to them,

- ¶ Jesus said to them,
- ¶ Then Jesus told them, (NLT)

But Jesus said to them: In this section, there is a conflict/argument between two sides: the people and Jesus. The first side (the people) has already spoken. In English, when the second side responds, it is natural to begin the response with the conjunction But.

Here is another way to begin this response:

Then Jesus told them (NLT)

In some languages, it is not necessary to begin Jesus’ response with a conjunction. For example:

Jesus said to them (GNT)

13:57c

“Only in his hometown and in his own household is a prophet without honor.”

- “A prophet is respected everywhere except in his hometown and by his own family.” (GNT)
- “People everywhere honor/respect a prophet. Only the people in his own village and his own family do not honor/respect him.”

Verse 13:57c is a saying or proverb that was familiar to the Jewish people at the time that Jesus lived. Jesus quoted this saying or proverb to show that people “in his hometown” of Nazareth treated him “without honor.” They did not believe that Jesus was a prophet or anyone important. Therefore they did not show him honor/respect.

Only in his hometown and in his own household is a prophet without honor:

This clause means that a prophet is normally honored everywhere else. People usually give a prophet the honor and respect that he deserves.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- Translate the noun honor as a verb. For example, the Greek is literally:

a prophet is not dishonored except in his hometown and in his own household

- State this in a positive way. For example:

A prophet is honored everywhere except in his own hometown and among his own family (NLT)

A prophet is respected everywhere except in his hometown and by his own family (GNT)

- Use an active verb. For example:

People honor/respect a prophet everywhere except in his hometown and in his own household

in his hometown: The Greek word that the BSB translates as hometown refers to the place where a person lived with his parents while he was growing up. It can refer to a town or region. Here Jesus was referring to the people in the town of Nazareth.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

in the town/village where he grew up

by the people in his village

This same word occurs in 13:54a.

in his own household: The Greek word that the BSB translates as household refers to the people of the house. This refers to Jesus' own family.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

in his own house (NIV)

in his own family (REB)

Matthew 13:58

Section 13:53–58: The people of Nazareth rejected Jesus

Jesus grew up in the town of Nazareth. The people there knew him and his family. They were ordinary people. So when the people of Nazareth heard that Jesus was teaching and doing miracles, they had difficulty believing that he had so quickly become a great prophet.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Rejection at Nazareth (NET)

Nazareth does not honor Jesus

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:1–6 and Luke 4:16–30. See also John 4:44, 6:42.

13:58

And He did not do many miracles there, because of their unbelief.

- So he did only a few miracles there because they had no faith.
- Since they did not believe in him, Jesus did not do many miracles there.

And He did not do many miracles there: This clause means that Jesus did only a few miracles in Nazareth.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

And he did not do many mighty works there (ESV)

And so he did only a few miracles there (NLT)

because of their unbelief: Here is another way to translate this phrase:

because they had no faith (NCV)

because they did not believe in him

Matthew 14:1

Section 14:1–12: The story about how John the Baptist died

In this section, Matthew wrote how John the Baptist was killed. This section can be difficult to translate because the events are not in chronological order.

Verses 1–2 refer to events that happened after John the Baptist died. But verses 3–12 refer back to events that had happened before John the Baptist died, and they include the story of his death. You will need to clearly indicate the change in time at 14:3.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Death of John the Baptist (GNT)

John the Baptist Beheaded (NASB)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:14–29 and Luke 9:7–9.

14:1

At that time Herod the tetrarch heard the reports about Jesus

- ¶ During that time, Herod the ruler heard the report/news about Jesus,
- ¶ In those days, Herod, the chief of the district of Galilee, heard news of the deeds and words of Jesus.

At that time: This phrase refers to the time of the events in chapter 13. It was the time when Jesus was teaching people and doing miracles. It was the time when people were hearing about the things Jesus was saying and doing.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

In those days

During that time

Herod: Herod was the government leader of the Jewish district of Galilee. His full name was Herod Antipas. He was one of the sons of King Herod the Great who was ruler when Jesus was born (in 2:1). Both the father and the son had the name Herod.

In some languages, it may be necessary to distinguish this Herod from the Herod in chapter 2. If that is true in your language, you can:

- Include his full name in the text. For example:

Herod Antipas

- Explain it in a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

This refers to Herod Antipas, one of the sons of King Herod the Great (2:1).

the tetrarch: This word is the title of a government leader who ruled one fourth of a country. This Herod ruled over one fourth of the land that his father, King Herod the Great, had ruled over.

A tetrarch is a higher title than governor, but it is lower than king. In spite of that, Herod is called the king in 14:9a.

Here are some other ways to translate this title:

the ruler of Galilee (GNT)

the king

the ruler/chief

the governing one

heard the reports about Jesus: The Greek word that the BSB translates as reports refers to the news/stories that people were telling about Jesus and his miracles.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

heard about the fame of Jesus (ESV)

heard the news about Jesus (CEV)

heard about Jesus (GNT)

heard news of the deeds and words of Jesus

Matthew 14:2

Section 14:1–12: The story about how John the Baptist died

In this section, Matthew wrote how John the Baptist was killed. This section can be difficult to translate because the events are not in chronological order.

Verses 1–2 refer to events that happened after John the Baptist died. But verses 3–12 refer back to events that had happened before John the Baptist died, and they include the story of his death. You will need to clearly indicate the change in time at 14:3.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Death of John the Baptist (GNT)

John the Baptist Beheaded (NASB)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:14–29 and Luke 9:7–9.

14:2a

and said to his servants, “This is John the Baptist;

- and he said to his advisers/aides, “This man is John the Baptist.
- He mistakenly said to his officials, “That man is the John who baptized people.

his servants: This word refers to assistants who advised rulers about their decisions. This is a different Greek word than the word translated as slaves.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

advisers (NLT)

officials (GNT)

aides/helpers/workers

This is John the Baptist: Herod mistakenly thought that Jesus was John the Baptist. The words that Herod said in this verse were his opinion. They were not the truth.

Here are some ways to make this clear:

he mistakenly said to his servants, “This man is John the Baptist.

He thought that Jesus was John the Baptist. So he said to his servants, “That man is John the Baptizer.

John the Baptist: You should translate this phrase as you did in 3:1a.

14:2b

he has risen from the dead!

- He has returned from death.
- He has become alive again.

he has risen from the dead!: Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

He has come back from the dead

He has returned from the place of the dead

He has become alive again.

The text does not say who Herod thought raised John. So you should avoid saying that “God” raised him from the dead.

14:2c

That is why miraculous powers are at work in him.”

- That is the reason why he has the power to do miracles.”
- It is for that reason that he is able to do such surprising/amazing things.”

That is why: This phrase introduces the result part of a reason-result pair of clauses. The reason is “he has risen from the dead” (in 14:2b). Herod believed that if someone came back from the dead, he would have special powers. So he believed that the miracles that he heard about were the result of John coming back from the dead.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

that is the reason why

for this reason

and as a result

miraculous powers are at work in him: This clause means that John had the power to do miracles.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he has the power to perform these miracles (GW)

he can do such miracles (NLT)

he has received the power to do those miracles

he is able to do those miracles

miraculous powers: The Greek word that the BSB here translates as miraculous powers is the same word as in 13:54d. You can translate both passages using the same term.

General Comment on 14:2b–c

The clause “he has risen from the dead” (14:2b) is the reason clause. The clause “That is why miraculous powers are at work in him” (14:2c) is the result clause. In some languages, it may be natural to change the order of the reason and result clauses. For example:

^{2c}He has the power to do these miracles ^{2b}because he has been raised from the dead.

Matthew 14:3

Section 14:1–12: The story about how John the Baptist died

In this section, Matthew wrote how John the Baptist was killed. This section can be difficult to translate because the events are not in chronological order.

Verses 1–2 refer to events that happened after John the Baptist died. But verses 3–12 refer back to events that had happened before John the Baptist died, and they include the story of his death. You will need to clearly indicate the change in time at 14:3.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Death of John the Baptist (GNT)

John the Baptist Beheaded (NASB)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:14–29 and Luke 9:7–9.

14:3a

Now Herod had arrested John and bound him

- ¶ Herod said that because some time earlier he had John arrested, tied with ropes/chains
- ¶ Months before that, Herod had commanded his soldiers to arrest John, tie him up,

Now: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Now is usually translated as “For.” It indicates that the events in 14:3–12a are the reason/basis for Herod’s statements in 14:2. Herod wrongfully killed John (14:7–10), so he may have thought that God corrected that wrong by causing John to live again.

The events of 14:3–5 happened several months or even a year before 14:1–2. The story of Jesus does not resume until 14:12b. You may want to indicate that a change in time begins here at 14:3.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Because earlier

For previously

He said that because some months earlier

Some time earlier

Herod had arrested John: This clause means that Herod commanded his soldiers to arrest John. Herod himself did not arrest John.

Here are some other ways to make this clear:

Herod had earlier ordered his men to arrest John

Herod sent his soldiers, and they went and arrested John

and bound him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as bound means “tie” a person so that he cannot escape. Here the soldiers tied John’s arms and/or legs with either ropes or chains.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

and tied him with ropes/chains

and he had him tied up (GNT)

This word does not imply that the soldiers tied John so tightly that he could not move.

14:3b

and put him in prison

- and locked up in prison.
- and imprison him. So they did it.

and put him in prison: In some languages the idea of put him in prison is expressed as a verb. For example:

caused him to be imprisoned

Other languages do not have a specific word for prison. These languages can express the idea of “put in prison” as:

locked/tied in a room

14:3c

on account of Herodias, his brother Philip’s wife,

- He did this because of Herodias who had been the wife of his brother Philip,
- He did those things to please his wife. Her name was Herodias. Herodias had earlier been the wife of his older brother Philip.

on account of Herodias: The Greek word that the BSB translates as on account of means “because of” Herodias. When John told Herod that it was not lawful for him to have Herodias, he offended both Herod and Herodias. As a result, Herodias had a grudge against John (Mark 6:19a). So Herod put him in prison “to appease Herodias” or “to make Herodias happy.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

because of Herodias (NIV)

as a favor to...Herodias (NLT)

Herod did this for Herodias (GW)

Herodias: The word Herodias is the name of a woman. You should write the name Herodias according to the spelling system that your language uses for a woman’s name.

She is a new person in the story. If your language has a particular way to introduce new people into a story, you should use it here.

his brother Philip’s wife: Herodias had been married to Philip. Philip was Herod’s older brother. While there is no direct statement in the Bible or in Josephus that Philip was Herod’s older brother, Josephus does state that Herod the Great married Philip’s mother before he married Herod Antipas’ mother. So it is assumed that Philip was born before Herod Antipas. Herod divorced his first wife to marry Herodias. And Herodias divorced

Philip to marry Herod. Then Herod and Herodias got married while Philip was still alive.

Because Herodias was no longer married to Philip, it may not be natural in your language to use the phrase Philip's wife. You may need to say:

Herodias, who had previously been married to Herod's older brother Philip

Herodias, who was formerly the wife of Philip, older brother of Herod

Matthew 14:4

Section 14:1–12: The story about how John the Baptist died

In this section, Matthew wrote how John the Baptist was killed. This section can be difficult to translate because the events are not in chronological order.

Verses 1–2 refer to events that happened after John the Baptist died. But verses 3–12 refer back to events that had happened before John the Baptist died, and they include the story of his death. You will need to clearly indicate the change in time at 14:3.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Death of John the Baptist (GNT)

John the Baptist Beheaded (NASB)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:14–29 and Luke 9:7–9.

14:4a

because John had been telling him,

- and because John was always telling Herod,
- He also did those things because John had repeatedly told Herod

because: In this context, the Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as because indicates that 14:4 continues the explanation that began in 14:3c. Both 14:3c and 14:4 explain the reason that Herod put John in prison.

Here are some other ways to continue this explanation:

and because

He also did this because

John had been telling him: These words introduce what John said to Herod before Herod arrested John. The form of the Greek verb that the BSB translates as had been telling indicates that John said the following things to Herod more than once.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

John was always saying to him

John had repeatedly said to him

14:3–4

(reordered) He said that because some time earlier Herod had married the wife of his brother Philip. Her name was Herodias. Because of that John had been saying to him, “It is not lawful for you to have her.” So, to please Herodias, Herod had arrested John and bound him and put him in prison.

14:4b

“It is not lawful for you to have her.”

- “It is against the/our^(incl) law for you to marry her.”
- “You are not permitted/allowed to be married to her.”
- that it was wrong for him to be married to his older brother's wife.

It is not lawful for you to have her: The phrase not lawful means “not right according to the law.” Here, the reference is to the law that God gave to Moses. In this context, have her means to “be married to your brother's wife.” It was against God's law for a man to marry a woman who previously had been his brother's wife while his brother was still living (Leviticus 20:21).

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

It's not right for you to be married to her. (GW)

You are not permitted/allowed to have your older brother's wife.

It is contrary to God's laws/instructions to marry your older brother's wife.

In some languages, it may be necessary to explain some of this information in a footnote. A sample footnote is:

This marriage was unlawful according to Jewish law (Leviticus 20:21) because Herod married Herodias while his brother Philip was still living.

General Comment on 14:3–4

14:3a–b occurred after 14:3c–4b. In some languages, it may be more natural to combine verses 3–4. In that way, you can change the order of the clauses and put them in the proper order. For example:

He said that ^{3c}because some time earlier Herod had married his brother Philip's wife Herodias. ⁴So John had been saying to him, "It is not lawful for you to have her." ^{3a}As a result, Herod had arrested John and bound him ^{3b}and put him in prison.

Matthew 14:5

Section 14:1–12: The story about how John the Baptist died

In this section, Matthew wrote how John the Baptist was killed. This section can be difficult to translate because the events are not in chronological order.

Verses 1–2 refer to events that happened after John the Baptist died. But verses 3–12 refer back to events that had happened before John the Baptist died, and they include the story of his death. You will need to clearly indicate the change in time at 14:3.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Death of John the Baptist (GNT)

John the Baptist Beheaded (NASB)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:14–29 and Luke 9:7–9.

14:5a–b

Although Herod wanted to kill John, he was afraid of the people: There is some implicit information here.

Here is the implicit information:

^aEven though Herod wanted to kill John, ^bhe did not give orders to kill him at that time, because he feared the people.

^aHerod wanted to kill John, ^bbut he did not do it at that time, because he feared the people.

14:5a

Although Herod wanted to kill John,

- Although Herod wanted to kill John,
- Herod wanted to order his men to kill John,

Although Herod wanted to kill John: In Greek, this clause is literally "wanting to kill him." This means that Herod wanted to kill John.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Herod wanted to order his men to kill John

14:5b

he was afraid of the people,

- he was afraid of what the people might do,
- but he did not do it at that time, because he was afraid that the people might riot.

he was afraid of the people: Herod was afraid that if he killed John, the people would become angry. They might riot or try to remove him from the government. So Herod did not kill John at that time. In some languages, it may be natural to make some of this information explicit. For example:

he was afraid that the people might rebel

but he did not kill him at that time, because he was afraid that the people might riot

the people: The word people refers to the people that Herod ruled. They were mostly Jewish people, but there were also other kinds of people living in the land he ruled.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

the people he ruled

his subjects

14:5c

because they regarded John as a prophet.

- because they believed that John was a prophet.
- They might do that because they considered John to be a prophet.

they regarded John as a prophet: This clause means that the people "believed that" or "considered" John to be a prophet. For example:

they considered John to be a prophet (GNT)

they thought John was a prophet (GW)

they believed John was a prophet (NCV)

prophet: For help in translating the word prophet, see the note in 1:22.

Matthew 14:6

Section 14:1–12: The story about how John the Baptist died

In this section, Matthew wrote how John the Baptist was killed. This section can be difficult to translate because the events are not in chronological order.

Verses 1–2 refer to events that happened after John the Baptist died. But verses 3–12 refer back to events that had happened before John the Baptist died, and they include the story of his death. You will need to clearly indicate the change in time at 14:3.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Death of John the Baptist (GNT)

John the Baptist Beheaded (NASB)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:14–29 and Luke 9:7–9.

14:6a

On Herod's birthday, however,

- ¶ But some time later, at Herod's birthday feast,
- ¶ Months later, Herod celebrated the day of the year on which he had been born. During the party

On: Between the events of 14:3–5 and this paragraph, John has been in prison for several months to a year. Here are some other ways to indicate this:

some time later, when it was

months later, when it was

Herod's birthday: The Greek term that the BSB translates as birthday means a “birthday celebration.” Herod was celebrating the day of the year when he had been born. He celebrated by having a feast. In Roman culture, these feasts often included wine to get drunk and women for sex. The family of Herod followed much of the Roman culture.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Herod's birthday feast/celebration

the day when another year of Herod's life was finished

the day of the year on which Herod had been born

however: There is a contrast here. In the previous paragraph, even though Herod wanted to kill John, he did not do it. But in this paragraph, he does have him killed. The BSB introduces this contrast with the conjunction however.

Some English versions do not begin this paragraph with the conjunction however. In some languages, a conjunction like “but” will not be necessary either.

14:6b

the daughter of Herodias danced before them

- the daughter of Herodias danced in front of the people whom he invited.
- the daughter of Herodias danced while/and Herod and his guests watched.

the daughter of Herodias: This was the daughter of Herodias by her previous husband. She was not the daughter of Herod. She was of marriageable age in that culture, probably between thirteen and eighteen years old.

danced: The daughter danced to entertain the people at the celebration. In that culture, it could have been a kind of dance that was sensual.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

entertained them by dancing

danced to please Herod

before them: This phrase indicates that the daughter of Herodias danced “in front of the people at the celebration.” She danced so that the people at the celebration could watch her. This included Herod's guests, and also Herod.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in front of the whole group (GNT)

for the people whom Herod invited

while the people watched her

14:6c and pleased Herod

- She made Herod very happy,
- Herod liked her dance very much.

and pleased Herod: Herod thoroughly enjoyed the dancing of the young woman. The subject of the verb pleased is either “the daughter of Herodias” or “the dancing.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

she pleased Herod (NRSV)

Herod was so delighted with her (GW)

a dance that greatly pleased him (NLT)

Matthew 14:7

Section 14:1–12: The story about how John the Baptist died

In this section, Matthew wrote how John the Baptist was killed. This section can be difficult to translate because the events are not in chronological order.

Verses 1–2 refer to events that happened after John the Baptist died. But verses 3–12 refer back to events that had happened before John the Baptist died, and they include the story of his death. You will need to clearly indicate the change in time at 14:3.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Death of John the Baptist (GNT)

John the Baptist Beheaded (NASB)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:14–29 and Luke 9:7–9.

14:7a so much that he promised with an oath

- and so he promised and vowed
- That is why he promised, “I vow/swear

so much that: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as so much that introduces a result. The dance pleased Herod. As a result, he made an oath. This conjunction also means “so” or “therefore.”

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

So (NCV)

For that reason

That is why

he promised with an oath: The phrase promised with an oath refers to the strongest possible type of promise. It is the type of promise made in front of witnesses. Making an oath often involves the person asking God (or a god) to punish him if he does not keep his promise.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he promised and he vowed

he made a vow

In some languages, it will be natural to translate part of this clause as direct speech. For example:

he made a promise saying, “I vow that

he promised her, “I swear that (GNT)

14:7b to give to her whatever she asked.

- that whatever she asked for, he would give it to her.
- that I will give to you whatever you ask me.”

to give to her whatever she asked: In some languages, it will be more natural to translate this phrase as direct speech. For example:

“...I will give you anything you ask for!” (GNT)

“Whatever you ask me, I will give it to you.”

Matthew 14:8

Section 14:1–12: The story about how John the Baptist died

In this section, Matthew wrote how John the Baptist was killed. This section can be difficult to translate because the events are not in chronological order.

Verses 1–2 refer to events that happened after John the Baptist died. But verses 3–12 refer back to events that had happened before John the Baptist died, and they include the story of his death. You will need to clearly indicate the change in time at 14:3.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Death of John the Baptist (GNT)

John the Baptist Beheaded (NASB)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:14–29 and Luke 9:7–9.

14:8a

Prompted by her mother, she said,

- Her mother told her what to say. So she said to Herod,
- She asked her mother, and her mother urged/encouraged her to say,

Prompted by her mother: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Prompted means that her mother, Herodias, urged/encouraged her daughter what to say to Herod.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the girl's mother told her to say (CEV)

Herodias told her daughter what to ask for (NCV)

The parallel passage in Mark 6:24 tells us that the daughter left the room of men and went to ask her mother what to do. In some languages, it may be natural to make some of this information explicit. For example:

She asked her mother, and her mother told her to say

14:8b

“Give me here on a platter the head of John the Baptist.”

- “Give to me here John the Baptist's head on a tray.”
- “Put the head of John the Baptizer on a plate and bring it here to me.”

Give me here...the head of John the Baptist: This clause implies that the daughter asked Herod to kill John by cutting off his head. Cutting off the head was a common method of killing someone in Roman culture.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I want the head of John the Baptist (NLT)

Bring to me here the head of John the baptizer

on a platter: The word platter refers to a large flat plate usually used for carrying food. But here the platter was only a way to carry the head. It does not imply serving the head as food.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

on a tray (NLT)

on a plate

If the purpose of bringing the head on a platter is not clear in your area, you may want to explain in a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

Cutting off the head was a common way to kill someone in Roman culture. Herodias wanted the head on a platter so she could see that John had been killed. The head would then be thrown away.

Matthew 14:9

Section 14:1–12: The story about how John the Baptist died

In this section, Matthew wrote how John the Baptist was killed. This section can be difficult to translate because the events are not in chronological order.

Verses 1–2 refer to events that happened after John the Baptist died. But verses 3–12 refer back to events that had happened before John the Baptist died, and they include the story of his death. You will need to clearly indicate the change in time at 14:3.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Death of John the Baptist (GNT)

John the Baptist Beheaded (NASB)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:14–29 and Luke 9:7–9.

14:9a

The king was grieved,

- The king was very sad,
- King Herod regretted making the oath,

The king: This phrase refers to Herod. In 14:1 he was called “the tetrarch.” So it is likely that the term king

here is used in a general sense of “ruler.” You can use the same title here as in 14:1.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

The ruler

King Herod

was grieved: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *was grieved* means “became sad, sorrowful, or distressed.” Herod was distressed about killing a holy man (Mark 6:20).

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

was very sad (NCV)

regretted his promise (GW)

was sorry for what he had said (CEV)

14:9b but because of his oaths and his guests,

- but because he did not want to break his oaths/vows in front of his guests,
- but he had made oaths and his dinner guests had heard them,

but because of his oaths and his guests: This phrase indicates the reasons why Herod ordered that John be killed (in 14:9c–10). He did not want to break his oaths in front of his guests.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

but because he had made oaths and his guests had heard them

But he did not want to break the promise he had made in front of his guests. (CEV)

his guests: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *his guests* is literally “those reclining at the table with (him).” These are the people Herod had invited and were eating with him at the feast.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

the people whom he had invited

those sitting at the feast with him

14:9c he ordered that her wish be granted

- he commanded his men to do what she had asked.
- so he ordered his soldiers to give her the thing that she had asked for.

he ordered that her wish be granted: This clause means that Herod ordered that John’s head be given to the daughter of Herodias. Herod told one of his soldiers to do as the daughter asked.

The verb *be granted* is passive. Here are some other ways to translate this entire clause:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

he gave orders that she should be given what she had asked (JBP)

- Use an active verb. For example:

he commanded one of his men to do as she asked

he ordered that they bring the girl the thing that she had asked for

Matthew 14:10

Section 14:1–12: The story about how John the Baptist died

In this section, Matthew wrote how John the Baptist was killed. This section can be difficult to translate because the events are not in chronological order.

Verses 1–2 refer to events that happened after John the Baptist died. But verses 3–12 refer back to events that had happened before John the Baptist died, and they include the story of his death. You will need to clearly indicate the change in time at 14:3.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Death of John the Baptist (GNT)

John the Baptist Beheaded (NASB)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:14–29 and Luke 9:7–9.

14:10 and sent to have John beheaded in the prison.

- He sent them to go and cut off John’s head in prison,
- He sent soldiers to the prison to cut off John’s head. (NCV)

and sent: This means that Herod sent one or more of his soldiers. For example:

He sent soldiers (NCV)

to have John beheaded in the prison: This means that Herod ordered one of his men to kill John by cutting off his head.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

caused John to be beheaded in prison

to get John and cut/chop off his head in prison

to the prison to cut off John's head. (NCV)

Matthew 14:11

Section 14:1–12: The story about how John the Baptist died

In this section, Matthew wrote how John the Baptist was killed. This section can be difficult to translate because the events are not in chronological order.

Verses 1–2 refer to events that happened after John the Baptist died. But verses 3–12 refer back to events that had happened before John the Baptist died, and they include the story of his death. You will need to clearly indicate the change in time at 14:3.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Death of John the Baptist (GNT)

John the Baptist Beheaded (NASB)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:14–29 and Luke 9:7–9.

14:11a

John's head was brought in on a platter and presented to the girl,

- and his head was brought back on a tray and given to the young woman.
- They cut it off and came back with his head on a plate and gave it to the daughter.

John's head was brought in on a platter and presented to the girl: These clauses are passive. Here are some ways to translate them:

- Use passive verbs. For example:

The head was brought in on a plate and given to the girl (GNT)

- Use active verbs. For example:

they brought it on a platter and gave it to the girl (NCV)

the girl: This refers to Herodias' daughter. She was probably thirteen to eighteen years old. Use an expression in your language that applies to a young woman of that age.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

young lady

Herodias' daughter

14:11b

who carried it to her mother.

- Then she took/delivered it to her mother.
- Then she took the platter and went with it to her mother and gave it to her.

who carried it to her mother: The daughter took the severed head to her mother, who was in another room, and gave it to her. Your translation should not imply that the mother was in the same room as the men. And your translation should not imply that the daughter kept the head. In some languages, it may be necessary to make some of this information explicit. For example:

she went with the head to her mother and gave it to her

she took the platter and went with it to her mother

Matthew 14:12

Section 14:1–12: The story about how John the Baptist died

In this section, Matthew wrote how John the Baptist was killed. This section can be difficult to translate because the events are not in chronological order.

Verses 1–2 refer to events that happened after John the Baptist died. But verses 3–12 refer back to events that had happened before John the Baptist died, and they include the story of his death. You will need to clearly indicate the change in time at 14:3.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Death of John the Baptist (GNT)

John the Baptist Beheaded (NASB)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:14–29 and Luke 9:7–9.

14:12a

Then John's disciples came and took his body and buried it.

- Later, John's disciples came and got his body and buried it.
- When John's disciples heard about this, they went to the prison, took/got his corpse, and buried it.

John's disciples: This phrase refers to John's disciples. In the same way that Jesus had disciples who followed him and learned from him, John the Baptist also had disciples who followed him and learned from his teachings. John's disciples are first mentioned in 9:14a. This term also occurs in 11:2b.

In some languages, it may be natural to add some implied information at the beginning of this verse. For example:

Later, John's disciples (NLT)

When John's disciples heard about his death

When John's disciples heard what had happened

came and took: John's disciples came/went to the prison and probably asked for permission to take the body. Your translation should not imply that they came and took the body secretly.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

came and got his body (NCV)

buried it: In Mark 6:29, John's disciples buried his body in a proper burial place. Your translation here should imply a proper burial.

14:12b

And they went and informed Jesus.

- Then they went and reported this to Jesus.
- Then they went to Jesus and told him what had happened.

And they went and informed Jesus: Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Then they went and told Jesus what had happened. (NLT)

Then they went and told the news to Jesus. (JBP)

Matthew 14:13

Section 14:13–21: Jesus fed over five thousand people

In this section, Jesus showed his love for people by healing the sick and providing food for everyone. He provided food for them by miraculously multiplying a few pieces of bread and a few fish. He also tested the disciples to see how they would respond to the need of the people.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus miraculously gives food to five thousand men

Five Thousand Fed (NASB)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:30–44, Luke 9:10–17, and John 6:1–14.

14:13a

When Jesus heard about John,

- ¶ When Jesus heard this news,
- ¶ When Jesus heard that they had killed John,

When Jesus heard about John: This clause refers to Jesus hearing the news from John's disciples that he had been killed.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

When Jesus heard what had happened (NIV)

When Jesus heard the news about John (GNT)

14:13b

He withdrew by boat privately to a solitary place.

- he got into a boat and went away from there to a place where there were no people.
- he and his disciples entered into a boat and left that place. They went to a place where he could be alone.

He withdrew by boat: The Greek word that the BSB translates as withdrew in this context means “move away,” or “take refuge.” Jesus first got into a boat,

then he left the place where he had been. He left to get away from the crowds.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he left in a boat (NCV)

he got into a boat and left that area

privately: In this context, the word privately implies that only Jesus' twelve disciples went with him. Jesus would have needed the disciples to sail the boat. No one else was with them.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

with only his disciples

without the crowds

to a solitary place: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as a solitary place refers to an area where there were no other people.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

isolated place

lonely place (RSV)

desolate place (ESV)

In some languages, it will be possible to translate this phrase and the next phrase together as:

to a place where he could be alone (GW)

14:13c

But the crowds found out about it and followed Him on foot from the towns.

- But when the people heard that Jesus had gone away, they left their villages and walked around the lake to follow him.
- When the people from the nearby towns heard that Jesus had left their area, many followed him on foot to the other side of the lake.

But: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between Jesus' desire to be alone, and the crowd's desire to be with him. The BSB indicates this contrast with the word But.

Here is another way to indicate this contrast:

However

the crowds found out about it: This clause refers to the people of the towns hearing that Jesus had left their area.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

when the crowd heard that he had left

when the crowd heard where he was going

the crowds: The plural word crowds refers to different groups of people. One group came from one town, and another group came from a different town.

Here is another way to translate this word:

people

followed Him on foot from the towns: The phrase on foot means that they walked rather than going in a boat or by other means.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

they left their towns and followed him on land

they left their villages and walked around the lake to follow him

Matthew 14:14

Section 14:13–21: Jesus fed over five thousand people

In this section, Jesus showed his love for people by healing the sick and providing food for everyone. He provided food for them by miraculously multiplying a few pieces of bread and a few fish. He also tested the disciples to see how they would respond to the need of the people.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus miraculously gives food to five thousand men

Five Thousand Fed (NASB)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:30–44, Luke 9:10–17, and John 6:1–14.

14:14a

When He stepped ashore and saw a large crowd,

- When he stepped out of the boat, he saw many people.
- When the boat arrived at the other side, Jesus got out and saw that a large crowd had followed him.

When He stepped ashore: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as When He stepped ashore is more literally “Having gotten out.” This phrase refers to Jesus getting out of the boat. When the boat arrived at the far shore, Jesus stepped out of the boat onto land.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

So as he stepped ashore (NJB)

Jesus got out of the boat, and (GNT)

When the boat arrived at the shore, Jesus got out

saw a large crowd: The phrase large crowd refers to many people.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he saw many people waiting for him

14:14b

He had compassion on them and healed their sick.

- He felt compassion for them and he healed the sick people among them.
- He pitied them, and he miraculously healed those who were sick among them.

He had compassion on them: The Greek word that the BSB translates as had compassion means “had pity” or “felt sympathy.” Jesus understood the people and their troubles, and he wanted to help them.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he pitied them

He felt sorry for them (GW)

You may have an idiomatic way to translate this term. In English, here are some examples of an idiomatic translation:

his heart was filled with pity for them (GNT)

his heart went out to them (REB)

healed their sick: The phrase their sick means the sick people among the crowd. These were probably sick people whom the healthy people brought along. Jesus miraculously healed these people. He healed them by God’s power. He did not heal them as a doctor heals people with medicine.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

healed those who were sick (NCV)

miraculously healed the sick people whom they had brought

Matthew 14:15

Section 14:13–21: Jesus fed over five thousand people

In this section, Jesus showed his love for people by healing the sick and providing food for everyone. He provided food for them by miraculously multiplying a few pieces of bread and a few fish. He also tested the disciples to see how they would respond to the need of the people.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus miraculously gives food to five thousand men

Five Thousand Fed (NASB)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:30–44, Luke 9:10–17, and John 6:1–14.

14:15a

When evening came, the disciples came to Him and said,

- ¶ When it was late afternoon, Jesus’ disciples approached him and said,
- ¶ Late in the day, Jesus’ disciples came near and said to him,

When evening came: In this context, this phrase likely refers to a time in the late afternoon. This same phrase occurs in 14:23c, but there it was several hours later than here.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

In late afternoon

the disciples came to Him: The disciples were already with Jesus. So in this context, the words came to Him

mean that they approached him to speak to him. For example:

came near to him

approached him

14:15b

“This is a desolate place, and the hour is already late.

- “This is an isolated place, and the day is almost over/ finished.
- “Lord, this place is far from any village, and it will soon start getting dark.

When the disciples spoke to Jesus, they spoke politely. In some languages, it may be natural to begin the disciples’ quote with a term of respect. For example:

Lord/Master

This is a desolate place, and the hour is already late:

These words indicate that Jesus and the crowd were far from any town or village, and it was late afternoon.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

Nobody lives around here, and the day is almost over/done

No one lives here, and evening is coming

There are no villages near here, and it will soon be getting dark,

14:15c

Dismiss the crowds

- Dismiss the people/crowd
- Please tell the people to leave

Dismiss the crowds: This command was used as a request. The disciples were not forcing Jesus to do something nor speaking harshly to him. They were suggesting to Jesus what they thought was a reasonable thing to do.

If a command in your language can be used as a suggestion when students speak to their teacher, you may follow the BSB.

If a command is too strong or impolite for a student to speak to a teacher, you may want to use a polite or

respectful expression in your language. Here are some examples:

Could you send the crowds away...?

Please send the crowds away...

We suggest that you send the crowds away...

Lord, the people need to...

14:15d

so they can go to the villages and buy themselves some food.”

- so that they may go to the villages/towns and buy some food for themselves.”
- and go buy something to eat in the villages around here.”

so they can go: The Greek word that the BSB translates as so is more literally “in order that.” This word indicates that the following words are the purpose for the command “Dismiss the crowds.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

that they may go (NASB)

in order that they may go

the villages: This word refers to small towns or villages. It does not refer to large cities.

buy themselves some food: The disciples suggested that the people use their own money to buy food to eat.

Matthew 14:16

Section 14:13–21: Jesus fed over five thousand people

In this section, Jesus showed his love for people by healing the sick and providing food for everyone. He provided food for them by miraculously multiplying a few pieces of bread and a few fish. He also tested the disciples to see how they would respond to the need of the people.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus miraculously gives food to five thousand men

Five Thousand Fed (NASB)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:30–44, Luke 9:10–17, and John 6:1–14.

14:16a

“They do not need to go away,” Jesus replied.

- But Jesus said, “They do not have to go.”
- Jesus said to them, “It is not necessary for them to leave and buy food.”

Jesus did not agree with his disciples’ request. He had another idea. Many English versions introduce Jesus’ different idea with the phrase “But Jesus said” at the beginning of the verse.

Some English versions like the BSB do not begin Jesus’ idea with a conjunction. In some languages, it may not be necessary to use a conjunction here either.

They do not need to go away: The word need refers to something being necessary or required to do. The verb “buy” (14:15d) is implied but not repeated here.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

They don’t have to leave (GNT)

That isn’t necessary (NLT)

They do not need to go and buy food

14:16b

“You give them something to eat.”

- You^(plur) give them some food to eat.”
- You yourselves give them something to eat.”

You give them something to eat: The pronoun You is emphasized in the Greek text. Here is one way to show this:

You yourselves give them something to eat! (GNT)

Matthew 14:17

Section 14:13–21: Jesus fed over five thousand people

In this section, Jesus showed his love for people by healing the sick and providing food for everyone. He provided food for them by miraculously multiplying a few pieces of bread and a few fish. He also tested the disciples to see how they would respond to the need of the people.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus miraculously gives food to five thousand men

Five Thousand Fed (NASB)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:30–44, Luke 9:10–17, and John 6:1–14.

14:17

“We have here only five loaves of bread and two fish,” they answered.

- They replied, “We^(excl) only have five loaves of bread and two fish.”
- They answered, “We^(excl) do not have anything except five small breads and two dried fish.”

We have here only: The Greek text is literally “We do not have (anything) here except.” The disciples knew that the little they had would not feed the crowd of thousands.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

we haven’t anything here...except (JBP)

We have nothing here but (NRSV)

All we have here are

five loaves of bread and two fish: This is a meal for one person or at most two people.

loaves of bread: The Greek word that the BSB translates as loaves of bread probably refers to flat breads. One person could eat three to five of these loaves at one meal. It was the common food for a meal.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

loaves of bread

small breads

fish: This was probably a kind of small fish that was already smoked or dried. If your language has a specific word for fish that is already cooked or dried or salted so that it is ready to eat, you should use it here. Otherwise, you should use a general term for fish. The kind of fish is not important.

Matthew 14:18

Section 14:13–21: Jesus fed over five thousand people

In this section, Jesus showed his love for people by healing the sick and providing food for everyone. He provided food for them by miraculously multiplying a few pieces of bread and a few fish. He also tested the disciples to see how they would respond to the need of the people.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus miraculously gives food to five thousand men

Five Thousand Fed (NASB)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:30–44, Luke 9:10–17, and John 6:1–14.

14:18

“Bring them here to Me,” Jesus said.

- He said, “Bring them to me here.”
- Jesus said to them, “Bring me the bread and the fish.” And they did.

Bring them here to Me: When Jesus told his disciples to bring the bread and the fish to him, the text implies that they did what he told them to do. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this information explicit. For example:

He said, “Bring them here to me,” and they did

Matthew 14:19

Section 14:13–21: Jesus fed over five thousand people

In this section, Jesus showed his love for people by healing the sick and providing food for everyone. He provided food for them by miraculously multiplying a few pieces of bread and a few fish. He also tested the disciples to see how they would respond to the need of the people.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus miraculously gives food to five thousand men

Five Thousand Fed (NASB)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:30–44, Luke 9:10–17, and John 6:1–14.

14:19a

And He directed the crowds to sit down on the grass.

- Then he commanded the people to sit down on the grass/ground.
- Then he told the people to sit down on the fresh grass to eat, and they did.

And He directed the crowds: The Greek word that the BSB translates as directed means “commanded” or “urged.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Then he commanded the people

Then he told the people to (NLT)

This word does not imply that Jesus shouted angrily or harshly at the crowd.

the crowds: As mentioned in 14:13c, the plural word crowds refers to different groups of people. They were all gathered together in one place.

Here is another way to translate this word:

the people

to sit down: The Greek word that the BSB translates as to sit down is more literally “to recline.” This is the word used to describe the position that people at that time got in for eating. So Jesus implied that the people were supposed to get into a position to eat a meal. In some languages, it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

to sit down to eat

When he told the people to sit down, the text implies that they did what he said. In some languages, it may be natural to make this information explicit. For example:

Then he told the people to sit down..., and they did.

on the grass: According to the parallel passage in Mark 6:39, the grass was green grass. This means that it was fresh grass. It was not dried, brown grass. The

grass in that area was relatively short and comfortable to sit on.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

on the fresh/young grass

If people in your area will think of grass that is meters tall and not comfortable to sit on, you can say:

on the ground

You may then want to explain it in a footnote. For example:

Literally “on the grass.” The area there was grassy hills.

14:19b

Taking the five loaves and the two fish

- He took/held the five loaves of bread and the two fish,
- Then Jesus took/held the five breads and the two fish in his hands.

Taking: In this context, the Greek word that the BSB translates as Taking also means “held.” Jesus prayed as he held the bread and fish in his hands.

14:19c

and looking up to heaven, He spoke a blessing.

- looked up toward heaven, and thanked God.
- While he looked up toward the sky, he thanked God for the food.

and looking up to heaven: The Greek word that the BSB translates as heaven here refers to the sky as a symbol of God’s dwelling place. Jesus looked up toward the sky/heaven because he was about to thank God. Jewish people commonly looked upward toward heaven while they prayed. Since Jesus literally looked upward at the sky, you could translate the word heaven here with the usual word for sky. You do not have to use a special term that refers to the place where God lives.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he looked up toward the sky

he looked upwards

He spoke a blessing: There are two ways to interpret the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as spoke a blessing:

1. It refers to thanking God for the food. For example:

he thanked God for the food (NCV) (NIV, GNT, NET, JBP, NCV)

1. It refers to blessing the food. For example:

blessed them (NLT) (BSB, ESV, RSV, NLT, NASB, GW, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). As a custom, Jews praised God and thanked him for the food that he provided for them.

In some languages the meaning of He spoke a blessing needs to be expressed with a direct quote. For example:

He said, “Thank you.”

14:19d

Then He broke the loaves and gave them to the disciples,

- Then he tore into pieces the loaves of bread and gave them to the disciples
- Then he divided the bread into pieces and gave them to his disciples.

He broke the loaves: This clause means that Jesus broke/tore the bread into smaller pieces. This was the normal way a meal was begun. You should use the normal verb in your language for dividing bread. For example:

he tore the breads in pieces

Jesus divided the bread (NCV)

and gave them: The pronoun them refers to the pieces of bread.

14:19e

and the disciples gave them to the people.

- and they gave the food to the people.
- Then his disciples distributed the bread to the people. They did the same with the fish.

the disciples gave them to the people: The clause means that the disciples distributed the pieces of bread to the people. For example:

who distributed it to the people (NLT)

Matthew did not mention the fish, but Jesus certainly divided the fish into pieces as well and gave them to his disciples. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this information explicit. For example:

they did the same thing with the fish

Matthew 14:20

Section 14:13–21: Jesus fed over five thousand people

In this section, Jesus showed his love for people by healing the sick and providing food for everyone. He provided food for them by miraculously multiplying a few pieces of bread and a few fish. He also tested the disciples to see how they would respond to the need of the people.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus miraculously gives food to five thousand men

Five Thousand Fed (NASB)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:30–44, Luke 9:10–17, and John 6:1–14.

14:20a

They all ate and were satisfied,

- They all ate as much as they wanted.
- Everyone ate until they were full.

They all ate and were satisfied: This clause indicates that everyone had plenty of food to eat. They ate as much as they wanted.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Everyone ate and had enough (GNT)

They all ate as much as they wanted (NJB)

They all ate until they were full

Matthew did not explain when or how the five loaves of bread and two fish became enough to feed so many people until they were satisfied. If it is not clear to people in your area that Jesus caused the food to multiply, you could include some implied information. For example:

Jesus multiplied the food so that they all ate and were satisfied

Jesus did a miracle so that everyone had enough to eat

14:20b

and the disciples picked up twelve basketfuls of broken pieces that were left over.

- Then they picked up the food that remained and filled twelve baskets.
- Then the disciples collected the leftovers and filled twelve baskets with them.

the disciples picked up: The clause that the BSB translates as the disciples picked up is more literally “they picked up.” There are several ways to interpret the pronoun “they”:

1. It refers to the disciples. For example:

Jesus’ disciples picked up (CEV) (BSB, NIV, GNT, CEV, NCV, NLT)

1. It refers to the crowd. Looking back to the previous clause (14:20a), “they took up” would grammatically refer to the crowd.
2. It refers to the disciples and the crowd.

Many English versions translate this literally as “they,” and it is not possible to tell which interpretation they follow. You may also translate this in a similar way, unless your readers will understand that only the crowd picked up the food. If your readers will understand that the disciples did not participate, then you should follow interpretation (1) and explicitly say the disciples, as the BSB does.

picked up: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as picked up means to lift up and carry away. In this context it probably indicates that the disciples gathered or collected pieces of uneaten food from the crowd. They probably did not pick up crumbs from the ground.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

took up (ESV)

collected (NJB)

twelve basketfuls: The amount of left-over food that the disciples collected was enough to fill twelve baskets. This indicates how great the miracle was. The

amount of left-over food was greater than the amount of food that Jesus started with.

The size of the baskets is not known, but they were probably medium in size. BDAG (page 563) and Louw & Nida (page 71) define the Greek word used here, *kophinos*, as a large basket for carrying food and produce. But Osborne (page 567) defines this word as “a small wicker basket used for carrying provisions when traveling.” It is possible that each disciple filled one basket; perhaps his own basket that he used for carrying his things when traveling. If your language has different words for different kinds of baskets, use a word for a basket that is usually medium in size.

broken pieces that were left over: This phrase refers to the pieces of bread and fish that remained after everyone had eaten. While the term “broken pieces” probably refers specifically to the bread that was broken, Mark 6:43 states that twelve baskets were filled with the broken pieces of bread and fish.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the leftover pieces of food (NCV)

food that remained

leftovers (CEV)

Matthew 14:21

Section 14:13–21: Jesus fed over five thousand people

In this section, Jesus showed his love for people by healing the sick and providing food for everyone. He provided food for them by miraculously multiplying a few pieces of bread and a few fish. He also tested the disciples to see how they would respond to the need of the people.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus miraculously gives food to five thousand men

Five Thousand Fed (NASB)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:30–44, Luke 9:10–17, and John 6:1–14.

14:21a

About five thousand men were fed,

- There were about five thousand men there who ate,

- The number of men who ate the food was about five thousand.

14:21b

in addition to women and children.

- without/not counting the women and children there who also ate!
- They did not count the women and children who also ate.

14:21a–b

About five thousand men were fed, in addition to women and children:

In addition to the five thousand men who ate the food, there were also women and children there who also ate. No one counted the women and children in the crowd. But someone estimated that there were About five thousand men. There were probably as many women and children as men, or perhaps more.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

The number of men who ate was about five thousand, not counting the women and children. (GNT)

There were about five thousand men who ate the food. They did not count the number of women and children who also ate.

Matthew 14:22

Section 14:22–36: Jesus walked on the water

In this section, Jesus showed that he has power over nature and sickness. When the disciples were in a boat during a storm, Jesus walked on the surface of the lake, and he calmed the storm. This caused the disciples to believe that Jesus was the Son of God, which was a title that the Jews used for the Christ. When they arrived at the shore, Jesus also healed many sick people.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Walking on Water (NET)

Jesus walks on top of water

Jesus showed his power over nature/creation

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:45–56 and John 6:15–21.

14:22a**Immediately Jesus made the disciples get into the boat**

- ¶ Immediately after that, Jesus caused his disciples to get into the boat
- ¶ As soon as the disciples finished collecting the food, Jesus told them to enter into the boat

Immediately: This word tells us that as soon as the disciples finished picking up the food (14:20b), Jesus told them to get into the boat. In this context, the word does not imply hurry.

Here are some other ways to begin this paragraph:

Immediately after this (NLT)

As soon as they had finished (REB)

Jesus made the disciples get into the boat: The Greek word that the BSB translates as made means “compel” or “force.” Jesus commanded or caused the disciples to get into the boat. The verb does not imply that the disciples were unwilling to get into the boat.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus told his followers to get into the boat (NCV)

Jesus ordered/caused his disciples to get into the boat

the boat: This is the same boat as mentioned in 14:13.

14:22b**and go on ahead of Him to the other side,**

- and go before him back to the other side of the lake.
- and return to the other side of the lake ahead of him. So they started off.

go on ahead of Him: This phrase means that Jesus wanted his disciples to go first. He would come after them at a later time.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

go before him (ESV)

to the other side: These words refer to the other side of Lake Galilee. This was the side of Lake Galilee that they started from in 14:13.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

back across the lake

back to the other side of the lake

14:22c**while He dismissed the crowds.**

- While they were going, he sent the people away/home.
- He stayed behind to tell the crowds to go home.

while: This word indicates that two events happened at the same time: the event of the disciples starting to cross the lake and the event of Jesus dismissing the crowd.

He dismissed the crowds: The word dismissed refers to telling someone that their time together was at an end. Jesus told the people to go home.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he sent the people home (NLT)

he caused the people to leave

Matthew 14:23**Section 14:22–36: Jesus walked on the water**

In this section, Jesus showed that he has power over nature and sickness. When the disciples were in a boat during a storm, Jesus walked on the surface of the lake, and he calmed the storm. This caused the disciples to believe that Jesus was the Son of God, which was a title that the Jews used for the Christ. When they arrived at the shore, Jesus also healed many sick people.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Walking on Water (NET)

Jesus walks on top of water

Jesus showed his power over nature/creation

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:45–56 and John 6:15–21.

14:23a**After He had sent them away,**

- After he did that,
- After/When they left,

14:23b**He went up on the mountain by Himself to pray.**

- he ascended into the hills by himself to pray.
- he climbed up a mountain/hill to pray to God alone.

14:23a–b

He went up on the mountain: In Greek, this clause is more literally “he went-up to the mountain.” This clause indicates that Jesus went at least part way up a nearby mountain. He did not necessarily go to the very top of the mountain.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

he went up a mountain (GW)

Lake Galilee is in a long valley with the surrounding area being about 500 meters higher than the valley. Jesus likely climbed part way out of the valley to be alone. Use the word in your language for this kind of mountain/hill. For example:

he went up a hill (GNT)

he went...up into the hills (NCV)

by Himself: This phrase means “alone,” “privately,” or “apart.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

alone

where he could be alone (CEV)

to pray: The word pray refers to speaking to God. Jesus praised God, thanked him, or asked him something. This term does not refer to ritualistic words or words of magic.

14:23c**When evening came, He was there alone,**

- After the sun had gone down, he was there alone.
- While he was there, it became dark.

When evening came: This is the same Greek phrase as in 14:15a. But it was several hours later than 14:15a. The crowd had eaten, the disciples had gathered the leftovers, Jesus had sent the crowd home, and he had gone into the mountain to pray. So you should use a term in your language that refers to a time in the evening later than the term you used in 14:15a. Use a term that refers to the time when the sky becomes dark. For example:

Night fell (NLT)

Later that evening (CEV)

Matthew 14:24**Section 14:22–36: Jesus walked on the water**

In this section, Jesus showed that he has power over nature and sickness. When the disciples were in a boat during a storm, Jesus walked on the surface of the lake, and he calmed the storm. This caused the disciples to believe that Jesus was the Son of God, which was a title that the Jews used for the Christ. When they arrived at the shore, Jesus also healed many sick people.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Walking on Water (NET)

Jesus walks on top of water

Jesus showed his power over nature/creation

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:45–56 and John 6:15–21.

14:24a**but the boat was already far from land,**

- By this time, the boat was quite far from shore.
- Meanwhile, the boat that his disciples were in had gone far from land.

but: There is some contrast between Jesus alone on the mountain praying and the disciples together in the boat being tossed by the waves. The BSB indicates this contrast with the conjunction but. Other versions use another word to begin this verse. For example:

and (GNT)

Some English versions do not have a conjunction here. In some languages, a conjunction will not be necessary here either.

already: The Greek word that the BSB translates as already indicates that two events were taking place at the same time. At the same time that Jesus was praying, the boat had traveled a long way from land.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Meanwhile (NLT)

by now (NJB)

far from land: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as far from land is literally “many stadia.” (The RSV says “many furlongs.”) This distance was at least several hundred meters. So, if the boat sank in the storm, it would be very difficult for the disciples to swim to shore.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

far out in the lake (GNT)

far away from land (NLT)

hundreds of meters from land

14:24b

buffeted by the waves because the wind was against it.

- It was being rocked by the waves because the wind was blowing against it.
- The wind was blowing against them and waves were tossing the boat.

buffeted by the waves: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as buffeted in this context means “tossed about.” The waves were crashing against the boat and making it sway and pitch/bounce violently.

This verb is passive. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

was being tossed around by the waves (CEV)

was being thrown around by the waves (GW)

- Use an active verb. For example:

the waves were tossing/rocking the boat

the waves were swaying the boat

because: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as because indicates that the following clause is the reason that the waves were tossing the boat. The waves were tossing the boat for/because the wind was blowing against them.

In some languages, it will be more natural to put the reason first. For example:

the wind was blowing against them, that is why the waves were tossing the boat

It was going against the wind and was being tossed around by the waves. (CEV)

the wind was against it: This clause means that the wind was “blowing” against them or the wind was “blowing” in their face. The disciples were trying to row into the wind.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the wind was blowing against it (GNT)

they were facing a strong wind

In Greek, this clause is literally “the wind was contrary.” There is no pronoun it. The BSB had added the pronoun it to make the sense more clear. This pronoun refers to the boat carrying the disciples.

Matthew 14:25

Section 14:22–36: Jesus walked on the water

In this section, Jesus showed that he has power over nature and sickness. When the disciples were in a boat during a storm, Jesus walked on the surface of the lake, and he calmed the storm. This caused the disciples to believe that Jesus was the Son of God, which was a title that the Jews used for the Christ. When they arrived at the shore, Jesus also healed many sick people.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Walking on Water (NET)

Jesus walks on top of water

Jesus showed his power over nature/creation

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:45–56 and John 6:15–21.

14:25a

During the fourth watch of the night,

- Sometime before dawn,
- A little before the sun rose,

During the fourth watch of the night: This phrase refers to the time between 3:00–6:00 a.m. This phrase

comes from the work of soldiers who stand guard for three hours at a time during the night. The first soldiers begin at 6:00 pm.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Between three and six o'clock in the morning
(GNT)

A little while before morning (CEV)

Sometime before dawn

14:25b

Jesus went out to them, walking on the sea.

- Jesus went to them walking on the surface of the lake/water.
- Jesus having already left the mountain walked on top of the water and went toward his disciples in the boat.

Jesus went out to them: Jesus approached the disciples who were in the boat. If people in your area will think that the pronoun them refers to the crowd, you may want to use the words “the disciples” instead.

walking on the sea: In this miracle, Jesus was walking on the surface of the water as if walking on dry ground.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

walking on the surface of the lake

walking on top of the water

Matthew 14:26

Section 14:22–36: Jesus walked on the water

In this section, Jesus showed that he has power over nature and sickness. When the disciples were in a boat during a storm, Jesus walked on the surface of the lake, and he calmed the storm. This caused the disciples to believe that Jesus was the Son of God, which was a title that the Jews used for the Christ. When they arrived at the shore, Jesus also healed many sick people.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Walking on Water (NET)

Jesus walks on top of water

Jesus showed his power over nature/creation

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:45–56 and John 6:15–21.

14:26a

When the disciples saw Him walking on the sea,

- When the disciples saw him walking on the surface of the lake/water,
- When they saw him walking on top of the water,

The Greek word that the BSB leaves untranslated simply indicates a change from one participant to another. Here the change is from Jesus to the disciples. In this context, it does not indicate a contrast, although some English versions translate it as “But.” Many English versions do not translate this word. In many languages, it will not be necessary to translate this word either.

14:26b

they were terrified.

- they were very afraid
- they were extremely frightened

they were terrified: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as were terrified means “frightened.” The disciples were in great fear and distress.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

they were afraid (NCV)

they were panicked

14:26c

“It’s a ghost!” they said, and cried out in fear.

- and said “It is a ghost!” and yelled in fear.
- and said that it was a spirit! They began to scream because they were afraid.

It’s a ghost: The Greek word that the BSB translates as ghost refers to the spirit of someone who had died. Or it can refer to someone’s spirit who has left his body.

Here is another way to translate this:

It is a spirit

cried out in fear: This clause refers to yelling or shouting because of their great fear. The phrase cried out does not refer to weeping.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

screamed with fear (GNT)

began to scream because they were afraid (GW)

Matthew 14:27

Section 14:22–36: Jesus walked on the water

In this section, Jesus showed that he has power over nature and sickness. When the disciples were in a boat during a storm, Jesus walked on the surface of the lake, and he calmed the storm. This caused the disciples to believe that Jesus was the Son of God, which was a title that the Jews used for the Christ. When they arrived at the shore, Jesus also healed many sick people.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Walking on Water (NET)

Jesus walks on top of water

Jesus showed his power over nature/creation

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:45–56 and John 6:15–21.

14:27a

But Jesus spoke up at once:

- But Jesus immediately said to them,
- Without delay Jesus said to them,

But: In this verse, Jesus corrected the disciples' thinking. They thought that they were seeing a ghost. Here he told them that they were wrong. He was not a ghost. The thing that they were seeing was Jesus himself. The BSB indicates this correction with the conjunction But.

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate it either.

14:27b

“Take courage! It is I. Do not be afraid.”

- “Calm yourselves, it is me. Do not be afraid!”
- “Be courageous! I am Jesus. Do not fear!”

Take courage: This phrase is an idiom. Jesus used this idiom to calm the disciples and encourage them. You should use an expression in your language that people

commonly use when trying to calm someone. Some languages use a different idiom for this.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Calm yourselves

It's okay

Do not worry

See how you translated this phrase in 9:2c–d or 9:22a.

It is I: In this clause Jesus was identifying himself. The pronoun I is emphasized in the Greek.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I am here (NLT)

I am Jesus (CEV)

Matthew 14:28

Section 14:22–36: Jesus walked on the water

In this section, Jesus showed that he has power over nature and sickness. When the disciples were in a boat during a storm, Jesus walked on the surface of the lake, and he calmed the storm. This caused the disciples to believe that Jesus was the Son of God, which was a title that the Jews used for the Christ. When they arrived at the shore, Jesus also healed many sick people.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Walking on Water (NET)

Jesus walks on top of water

Jesus showed his power over nature/creation

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:45–56 and John 6:15–21.

14:28a–b

“Lord, if it is You,” Peter replied, “command me to come to You on the water.”: Peter wanted Jesus to confirm that the person on the water was really him. It was dark and stormy, and the disciples could not clearly see. But they had heard Jesus' voice. Peter believed that if it was really Jesus, he would enable Peter to walk on the water.

Here are some other ways to translate this sentence:

Lord, if it is really you, order me to come out on the water to you (GNT)

Lord, if it is truly you, tell me to come to you walking on the water

14:28a

“Lord, if it is You,” Peter replied,

- ¶ Peter said, “Lord, if it is really you,
- ¶ Peter said, “Master, if it is truly you,

Peter replied: Peter did not answer a question. So, in many languages, it will be better to say:

Peter said to him

Then Peter called to him (NLT)

14:28b

“command me to come to You on the water.”

- order me to come to you on top of the water!”
- tell/invite me to come to meet you by walking on the surface of the water!”

on the water: Peter wanted to walk on the surface of the water just as Jesus was doing.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

on top of the water

on the surface of the water

Matthew 14:29

Section 14:22–36: Jesus walked on the water

In this section, Jesus showed that he has power over nature and sickness. When the disciples were in a boat during a storm, Jesus walked on the surface of the lake, and he calmed the storm. This caused the disciples to believe that Jesus was the Son of God, which was a title that the Jews used for the Christ. When they arrived at the shore, Jesus also healed many sick people.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Walking on Water (NET)

Jesus walks on top of water

Jesus showed his power over nature/creation

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:45–56 and John 6:15–21.

14:29a

“Come,” said Jesus. Then Peter got down out of the boat,

- He said, “Come!” So Peter stepped out of the boat
- So Jesus said to Peter, “Come to me!” Then Peter exited the boat

Peter got down out of the boat: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as got down out of the boat probably indicates that Peter stepped down from the boat onto the water. If the direction is important in your language, you may want to follow the BSB which says got down out of the boat. If the direction down is not usual in this context, you should use your normal verb for getting out of a boat.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Peter left the boat (NCV)

Peter went over the side of the boat (NLT)

Peter stepped over the side of the boat

14:29b

walked on the water, and came toward Jesus.

- and walked on top of the water to/toward Jesus.
- and started walking on the surface of the water to/toward Jesus.

walked on the water, and came toward Jesus: This phrase indicates that Peter started walking on top of the water towards Jesus. He got near Jesus, but he did not arrive at the place where Jesus was. Verse 14:31a mentions that Jesus reached out and grabbed him, so Peter probably had walked far enough to be within arm’s reach of Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

walked on the water toward Jesus (GW)

started walking on the water toward him (CEV)

walked on the surface of the water to/toward Jesus

Matthew 14:30

Section 14:22–36: Jesus walked on the water

In this section, Jesus showed that he has power over nature and sickness. When the disciples were in a boat during a storm, Jesus walked on the surface of the lake, and he calmed the storm. This caused the disciples to believe that Jesus was the Son of God, which was a title that the Jews used for the Christ. When they arrived at the shore, Jesus also healed many sick people.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Walking on Water (NET)

Jesus walks on top of water

Jesus showed his power over nature/creation

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:45–56 and John 6:15–21.

14:30a

But when he saw the strength of the wind, he was afraid,

- But when he felt/noticed the strong wind blowing, he became frightened
- But when he saw the waves that the strong wind was blowing, he became afraid.

But: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between Peter walking on top of the water (in 14:29b) and Peter sinking into the water (in 14:30b). The BSB indicates this contrast with the conjunction But.

when he saw the strength of the wind: There is a textual issue here:

1. Some Greek manuscripts have the adjective “strong” here. For example:

when he saw the strong wind (NET) (BSB, GNT, NET, KJV, NRSV, CEV, GW, NLT, REB, JBP)

1. Some Greek manuscripts do not have an adjective here. For example:

when he saw the wind (RSV) (NIV, RSV, ESV, NASB, NCV, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). It has the most version support.

he saw the strength of the wind: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as he saw the strength of the wind indicates that Peter noticed the effects of a strong wind. He saw the waves and felt the strong wind blowing.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

he felt the strength of the wind

he noticed the strong wind (GNT)

because of the strong wind

he saw the waves/water that the big wind was blowing

14:30b

and beginning to sink, cried out, “Lord, save me!”

- and began to sink. He shouted, “Lord, rescue me!”
- He started to sink into the water and immediately yelled, “Master, help me!”

beginning to sink: The verb sink refers to going down into the water. Peter walked on top of the water for a while, but his fear interfered with his faith and he began to sink into the water.

It is not known how far he sunk before calling out. But at least his head was still above the water. Perhaps part of his upper body was also above water.

cried out: This phrase refers to yelling or shouting. The phrase cried out does not refer to weeping.

Here is another way to translate this verb:

shouted (NLT)

save me: The Greek word that the BSB translates as save in this context means “rescue (from danger)” or “save (from death).” It is the same word used for eternal salvation, but you may need to use a different term to make the meaning of “rescue” clear.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

rescue me

save me from death

help me

Matthew 14:31

Section 14:22–36: Jesus walked on the water

In this section, Jesus showed that he has power over nature and sickness. When the disciples were in a boat during a storm, Jesus walked on the surface of the lake, and he calmed the storm. This caused the disciples to believe that Jesus was the Son of God, which was a title that the Jews used for the Christ. When they arrived at the shore, Jesus also healed many sick people.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Walking on Water (NET)

Jesus walks on top of water

Jesus showed his power over nature/creation

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:45–56 and John 6:15–21.

14:31a

Immediately Jesus reached out His hand and took hold of Peter.

- At once Jesus stretched out his hand and grabbed Peter.
- Jesus quickly reached out, grabbed him, and helped him get up.

Immediately Jesus reached out His hand: In some languages, it is not necessary to include the phrase His hand because that is understood by the verb reached.

The verb reached out is translated as “stretched out” in 12:13.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus immediately stretched out his hand

Jesus quickly extended his hand

At once Jesus reached out (GNT)

and took hold of Peter: The verb took hold indicates that Jesus grabbed Peter and kept him from sinking.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

grabbed hold of him (GNT)

caught him (JBP)

grabbed him and pulled him up

14:31b

“You of little faith,” He said, “why did you doubt?”

- He said to him, “Your faith is small/lacking. Why is it that you^(sing) doubted?”
- He said, “Why is your faith in me so little/lacking? Why did you doubt me?”
- He said, “You do not trust in me enough. You should not doubt me like that.”

You of little faith: This phrase is the translation of one Greek word. Jesus used this word to describe Peter and rebuke him. He spoke directly to Peter.

If it is not natural in your language to speak directly to a person and at the same time describe and rebuke him, you may use a complete clause. For example:

You have so little faith (NJB)

Your faith is small (NCV)

You do not trust in me enough.

In some languages, it may be more natural to translate this rebuke as a rhetorical question. For example:

Why is your faith in me so little/weak/lacking?

The plural form of this word occurs in 6:30d and 8:26a.

why did you doubt?: This is a rhetorical question. It is a mild rebuke. Jesus was rebuking Peter for doubting.

Here are some other ways to translate this rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Why did you doubt me? (NLT)

- As a statement. For example:

You should not have doubted.

It was wrong to doubt me

Translate this rebuke in a way that is natural in your language.

Matthew 14:32

Section 14:22–36: Jesus walked on the water

In this section, Jesus showed that he has power over nature and sickness. When the disciples were in a boat during a storm, Jesus walked on the surface of the lake, and he calmed the storm. This caused the disciples to believe that Jesus was the Son of God, which was a title that the Jews used for the Christ. When they arrived at the shore, Jesus also healed many sick people.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Walking on Water (NET)

Jesus walks on top of water

Jesus showed his power over nature/creation

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:45–56 and John 6:15–21.

14:32a

And when they had climbed back into the boat,

- After they went over and climbed into the boat,
- Then they went to the boat and stepped into it. After stepping in,

when they had climbed back into the boat: This clause refers to Jesus and Peter stepping up into the boat. The action of going to the boat is implied. Jesus and Peter were likely only a few meters from the boat. In some languages, it may be natural to include this implied information. For example:

when they went over to the boat and stepped in

Then they went to the boat. After they entered/stepped into it

14:32b

the wind died down.

- the wind stopped blowing.
- the wind became calm.

the wind died down: This clause refers to the wind no longer blowing. As a result, the lake became calm.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the wind stopped blowing

the wind became calm (NCV)

Matthew 14:33

Section 14:22–36: Jesus walked on the water

In this section, Jesus showed that he has power over nature and sickness. When the disciples were in a boat during a storm, Jesus walked on the surface of the lake, and he calmed the storm. This caused the disciples to believe that Jesus was the Son of God, which was a title that the Jews used for the Christ. When they arrived at the shore, Jesus also healed many sick people.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Walking on Water (NET)

Jesus walks on top of water

Jesus showed his power over nature/creation

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:45–56 and John 6:15–21.

14:33a

Then those who were in the boat worshiped Him, saying,

- Then the men in the boat got on their knees before Jesus and said,
- Then the disciples in the boat bowed in worship before him. They said,

those who were in the boat: This phrase refers to the disciples.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

The men in the boat (NJB)

the disciples in the boat

worshiped Him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as worshiped means “prostrate oneself before.” This word refers to kneeling and putting one’s face to the ground with arms outstretched. Common people did this to people of great authority in order to show them great honor and submission.

This same word occurs in 2:11c. There the magi worshiped the infant Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

got on their knees before him

bowed down in front of Jesus (GW)

14:33b

“Truly You are the Son of God!”

- “In truth, you are the Son of God.”
- “You really/certainly are God’s Son.”

Truly:

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

In truth

You really/certainly are...

Without a doubt

the Son of God: The phrase the Son of God is a title for Jesus. This title indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God. It also indicates that the relationship between God the Father and Jesus, his Son, is similar in some way to the relationship between human fathers and sons. God the Father does not have a physical body. He did not have a sexual relationship that resulted in Mary becoming pregnant and giving birth to Jesus.

See how you translated this phrase at 4:3b. For further information, see the note on “My...Son” at 3:17b.

Matthew 14:34

Section 14:22–36: Jesus walked on the water

In this section, Jesus showed that he has power over nature and sickness. When the disciples were in a boat during a storm, Jesus walked on the surface of the lake, and he calmed the storm. This caused the disciples to believe that Jesus was the Son of God, which was a title that the Jews used for the Christ. When they arrived at the shore, Jesus also healed many sick people.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Walking on Water (NET)

Jesus walks on top of water

Jesus showed his power over nature/creation

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:45–56 and John 6:15–21.

14:34a

When they had crossed over,

- ¶ Then they finished crossing the lake
- ¶ Then they finished sailing/going across the lake. When they arrived at the other side,

When they had crossed over: This clause means that Jesus and his disciples traveled/sailed the rest of the way across the lake in the boat. They reached the other side of the lake.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

After they finished crossing the lake

When they finished going across the lake and arrived at the other side

14:34b

they landed at Gennesaret.

- and went ashore near the village of Gennesaret.
- they landed in the area of Gennesaret. Then they got out of the boat.

they landed: This clause means that the disciples brought the boat to the land at the edge of the lake. That is where they landed and docked the boat. It is implied that they then got out of the boat onto the shore.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

they came to shore (NCV)

they came to land (ESV)

they reached the edge of the lake, then they got out of the boat

at Gennesaret: This was the name of a village and the surrounding area on the northwest shore of Lake Galilee. The village was south of the town of Capernaum. It is not known whether Gennesaret here refers to the village or to the area.

Here is another way to translate this word:

near the village of Gennesaret

Matthew 14:35

Section 14:22–36: Jesus walked on the water

In this section, Jesus showed that he has power over nature and sickness. When the disciples were in a boat during a storm, Jesus walked on the surface of the lake, and he calmed the storm. This caused the disciples to believe that Jesus was the Son of God, which was a title that the Jews used for the Christ. When they arrived at the shore, Jesus also healed many sick people.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Walking on Water (NET)

Jesus walks on top of water

Jesus showed his power over nature/creation

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:45–56 and John 6:15–21.

14:35a

And when the men of that place recognized Jesus,

- When the men who lived there saw Jesus, they knew who he was. So
- The men of that area saw that Jesus was there. So

the men of that place: There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as men:

1. It refers specifically to men. The Greek word is the more specific term “males,” so it should be translated as “men.” For example:

when the men of that place (NIV) (BSB, RSV, NIV, ESV, NASB, GW, JBP, KJV)

1. It refers generally to people. For example:

When the people there (NCV) (GNT, NJB, NRSV, CEV, NET, REB, NCV, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Matthew uses the specific Greek word for men rather than the more general word often translated as “people.” It would be the men who would be available and more likely to send messengers throughout the region. The women would most likely be in their homes or buying at the market.

This entire phrase refers to the men of the town and region of Gennesaret.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the men who lived there

the local men

the men there (GW)

recognized Jesus: The verb recognized refers to seeing and knowing who a person is. The men had seen Jesus before, so when they saw him this time, they knew who he was.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

identified Jesus

saw Jesus, they knew who he was

saw him and said that he was Jesus

14:35b

they sent word to all the surrounding region.

- they sent a message to the people in all the nearby areas,
- they spread the news all around there that Jesus had come.

they sent word: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sent word indicates that the men sent a message saying that Jesus was there.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

they sent a message

sent messengers (GW)

they told people (NCV)

they spread the news

to all the surrounding region: This phrase refers to the surrounding areas. It was likely those places that were a day’s walk away or less.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

to the whole surrounding area that Jesus had come

all around there that Jesus had come (NCV)

14:35c

People brought all the sick to Him

- and the people brought all their sick people to him.
- The people from the nearby areas brought to Jesus all those who were not well.

all the sick: This phrase refers to anyone who had something wrong with them, either physical, emotional, or mental. This phrase includes those controlled by a demon.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

those who had something wrong with them

those who were not well

Matthew 14:36

Section 14:22–36: Jesus walked on the water

In this section, Jesus showed that he has power over nature and sickness. When the disciples were in a boat during a storm, Jesus walked on the surface of the lake, and he calmed the storm. This caused the disciples to believe that Jesus was the Son of God, which was a title that the Jews used for the Christ. When they arrived at the shore, Jesus also healed many sick people.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Walking on Water (NET)

Jesus walks on top of water

Jesus showed his power over nature/creation

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 6:45–56 and John 6:15–21.

14:36a

and begged Him just to let them touch

- They begged Jesus to allow the sick people to touch only
- They urged Jesus to let the sick people touch just
- They pleaded with Jesus to allow those who were not well to touch as little as

begged Him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as begged means “ask urgently” or “request help.” The word begged in English could imply that Jesus was reluctant to agree, but the Greek word does not imply this.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

implored him (ESV)

urgently asked him

pleaded with him

just to let them touch: This clause indicates that the sick people wanted to touch something belonging to Jesus, even if it was a very little thing. They believed that if they touched a person like Jesus, they would be healed. They even believed that Jesus’ power went into his clothes, and if they touched even a little part of his clothes, they would be healed.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

to touch only/just

to allow them to touch just

to touch even as little as

14:36b

the fringe of His cloak.

- one of the tassels on his coat.
- the strings/threads on the edge of his robe.
- the border/hem of his clothes. And he allowed it.

the fringe of His cloak: The Greek word that the BSB translates as fringe probably refers to one of the “tassels” that were attached to Jesus’ clothes. The Jews made these tassels by tying strings together, and they attached these tassels to the four corners of their outer clothes. When they saw these tassels, they were supposed to remember to follow God’s commandments. (Num. 15:37–38; Deut. 22:12). Like any male Jew, Jesus probably wore tassels.

Tassels on a Jewish man’s prayer shawl

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

- Translate it with a word or phrase that refers specifically to tassels. For example:

the strings/threads on the hem of his clothes

- Translate it with a word or phrase that refers generally to the hem or edge of his clothes. For example:

the edge of his clothes (GW)

the hem/border of his robe

This same phrase occurs in 9:20b.

His cloak: The Greek word that the BSB translates as cloak is a general word that means clothing. In this context, this word refers to the outer layer of clothing.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

garment (ESV)

clothes (CEV)

robe (NLT)

coat (NCV)

14:36c

And all who touched Him were healed.

- Everyone who touched one/them was healed/cured.
- All the people who touched them became well.
- Everyone who touched it, the power of God made them well.

And: It is implied that Jesus allowed the sick people to touch his clothes. Some people may wrongly assume that Jesus did not want people to touch his clothes, but they touched them anyway. If that is true in your area, you should include some implied information. For example:

and he allowed them, and

and he said yes.

all who touched Him: This clause means that “everyone who touched Jesus’ clothes” was healed. For example:

Everyone who touched his clothes (GW)

all those who did so (JBP)

were healed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as were healed also means “were made well” or “were cured.”

This clause is passive. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

were made well (ESV)

were cured

- Use an active verb. For example:

the power of God healed them

- Use another type of verb. For example:

became well

their sickness left them

Matthew 15:1

Section 15:1–20: The deeds that make someone unclean in God’s eyes

Over the years, Jewish religious leaders added many oral rules to God’s written laws. The Pharisees and teachers of the law considered these oral rules (also called traditions) to be as important as God’s written laws. One of their rules was that a person must wash his hands a certain way before he ate food. If a Jew did not follow this rule before he ate, they considered him ceremonially “unclean.” This meant that they did not allow him to worship God in public for a certain amount of time. Jesus made it clear that there was something far more important than how a person washed his hands. The important thing was the condition of his heart.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Challenges the Pharisees’ Traditions (GW)

Jesus Teaches about Inner Purity/Cleanliness

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 7:1–23 and Luke 11:37–39.

15:1a

Then some Pharisees and scribes

- ¶ Then some Pharisees and teachers of the law
- ¶ After that, some people from the Jewish religious group called Pharisees and some experts in the law of Moses

Then: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Then indicates that the events of 15:1–20 came after the events of 14:22–36. The Greek text does not indicate how much time passed between these two events. These events could have happened the same day, or there could have been several days between them.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

After that

Later

some: The word some is not in the Greek text but the BSB and some other English versions (such as the NIV and GNT) add the word “some” to indicate that some, but not all, Pharisees came to Jesus.

Pharisees: The word Pharisees refers to men who were members of a particular Jewish religious group. The Pharisees believed that it was necessary to strictly obey all the laws of the Old Testament. It was also very important to them to carefully obey many other religious laws that they added. They also said that other people must obey these laws.

Here are some ways to translate Pharisees:

- Transliterate the word Pharisees according to the sounds of your language and indicate that it refers to a group of people. For example:

Farisi members

Parise group

- Transliterate the word Pharisees and indicate that it refers to a group of people with certain beliefs. For example:

people belonging to the Farise religious sect/
group

members of the Jewish group called the Farasi

The word Pharisees first occurs in 3:7a.

scribes: The Greek word that the BSB translates as scribes refers to men who studied, interpreted, and

taught the law of Moses. These men were called scribes because their original work was to copy the laws of Moses by hand. In New Testament times, this was no longer their main task.

Here are some ways to translate this term:

teachers of the Law of Moses (CEV)

teachers of religious law (NLT)

teachers of the law (NIV)

experts in the law

The word scribe first occurs in 2:4a.

15:1b came to Jesus from Jerusalem and asked,

- came from Jerusalem. They came/went to Jesus and asked him,
- left/exited Jerusalem and came to Jesus. They said to him,

came to Jesus from Jerusalem: In some languages, it may be more natural to add another verb here. For example:

came from Jerusalem and went to Jesus

left/exited Jerusalem and came to Jesus

and asked: The Greek word that the BSB translates as asked introduces a rhetorical question. For that reason, several English versions (such as the BSB) translate this word as asked.

Matthew 15:2

Section 15:1–20: The deeds that make someone unclean in God’s eyes

Over the years, Jewish religious leaders added many oral rules to God’s written laws. The Pharisees and teachers of the law considered these oral rules (also called traditions) to be as important as God’s written laws. One of their rules was that a person must wash his hands a certain way before he ate food. If a Jew did not follow this rule before he ate, they considered him ceremonially “unclean.” This meant that they did not allow him to worship God in public for a certain amount of time. Jesus made it clear that there was something far more important than how a person

washed his hands. The important thing was the condition of his heart.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Challenges the Pharisees' Traditions (GW)

Jesus Teaches about Inner Purity/Cleanliness

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 7:1-23 and Luke 11:37-39.

15:2a-b (reordered) Your disciples do not wash their hands before they eat. Why do they break the tradition of the elders like that?

Before you translate 15:2, think about the most natural order for 2a and 2b. In some languages, it may be more natural to put 2b first. For example:

^{2b}Your disciples do not wash their hands before they eat! ^{2a}Why do they break the tradition of the elders like that?

15:2a
“Why do Your disciples break the tradition of the elders?”

- “Why do your disciples not follow/obey the traditions/teachings of our^(incl) ancestors?”
- “Your disciples do not do what our ancestors taught us to do. Why?”
- “Your disciples break/disobey the customs of our forefathers.”

Why do Your disciples break the tradition of the elders?: This is a rhetorical question. It is a rebuke. The Pharisees and scribes who came to Jesus rebuked/scolded him because they believed that his disciples broke the tradition of the elders.

Here are some other ways to translate this rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Why do your disciples break the tradition of the elders?

Your disciples break the tradition of the elders. Why?

- As a statement. For example:

Your disciples break the tradition of the elders!

Your disciples should not break the tradition of the elders!

Translate this rebuke in a way that is natural in your language.

break: The Greek word that the BSB translates as break also means “disobey.” Use a verb in your language that refers to not following a tradition or custom.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

do not keep/follow

do not obey

the tradition of the elders: This phrase refers to the oral laws/rules that Jewish elders had added to the written law of Moses. These oral laws had been added and taught over a period of centuries. The Pharisees believed that it was as important to keep these oral laws as it was to keep the written law of Moses.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the traditions of our ancestors (GW)

the laws/rules that come from our forefathers

the customs/teachings of our fathers

what our ancestors taught us to do (CEV)

the elders: Here the word elders refers to Jewish religious leaders of earlier generations. These religious leaders passed down their teachings to the Jews of later generations.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

ancestors (GNT)

forefathers

15:2b
They do not wash their hands before they eat.”

- We ask/say this because they do not wash their hands before they eat.”

- They do not wash their hands according to our customs before they eat.”
- Before they eat, they do not wash their hands in the proper/correct way.”

The Greek begins this clause with a conjunction that is often translated as “For.” It indicates that 15:2b is the reason for the question in 15:2a.

Here is another way to introduce this reason:

We ask this because

In some languages, it may be more natural to leave this conjunction untranslated. This is what the BSB and NIV do.

They do not wash their hands before they eat: This sentence means that the disciples did not follow the elders’ rules. They did not wash/rinse their hands before they ate in the way that their ancestors said that they should. One of the teachings of the elders was to ceremonially rinse their hands before meals. They poured water over each hand in a certain way. Then they considered their hands to be ceremonially clean. That way, the food would remain ceremonially clean when they touched it and ate it.

The law of Moses did not require people to wash their hands in this way. This was one of the traditions that the elders added to the law.

Here are some other ways to translate this sentence:

They don’t wash their hands in the proper way before they eat! (GNT)

Before they eat, they do not follow the correct way to wash their hands.

Matthew 15:3

Section 15:1–20: The deeds that make someone unclean in God’s eyes

Over the years, Jewish religious leaders added many oral rules to God’s written laws. The Pharisees and teachers of the law considered these oral rules (also called traditions) to be as important as God’s written laws. One of their rules was that a person must wash his hands a certain way before he ate food. If a Jew did not follow this rule before he ate, they considered him ceremonially “unclean.” This meant that they did not allow him to worship God in public for a certain amount of time. Jesus made it clear that there was something far more important than how a person

washed his hands. The important thing was the condition of his heart.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Challenges the Pharisees’ Traditions (GW)

Jesus Teaches about Inner Purity/Cleanliness

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 7:1–23 and Luke 11:37–39.

15:3

Jesus replied, “And why do you break the command of God for the sake of your tradition?”

- Jesus answered, “Why do you^(plur) disobey God’s command because of your tradition?”
- Jesus asked them, “And you? Why do you follow your own traditions/customs and/but break the laws of God?”
- Jesus responded/said, “And what about you? You do not follow/obey God’s laws in order to follow your own customs. That’s not right!”

Jesus replied: Jesus responded to the question of the Pharisees and scribes with his own question. In some languages, it may be more natural to use a verb other than replied here. For example:

But Jesus responded

Jesus asked in reply

And: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as And connects this question to the Pharisees’ question in 15:2a. The Pharisees rebuked/scolded the disciples, and Jesus rebuked the Pharisees in reply.

In some languages, it may be more natural to leave this conjunction untranslated. For example:

Why do you break the commandment of God because of your traditions? (GW)

why do you break the command of God for the sake of your tradition?: This is a rhetorical question. It is a rebuke. Jesus rebuked/scolded the Pharisees and scribes because they followed their traditions even when it meant that they were required to break a command of God. Jesus implied that it was more serious to break a written commandment of God than break an oral tradition of the elders.

Here are some other ways to translate this rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Why do you disobey God's command in order to follow your own customs?

When you follow your own customs, it causes you to break one of God's laws? Why do you do that?

- As a statement. For example:

You break a command of God to follow your tradition. That's wrong!

Translate this rebuke in a way that is natural in your language.

you: The pronoun you is emphasized in Greek. Jesus used this emphasis to contrast the Pharisees and scribes with his disciples.

Here are some ways to translate this pronoun:

What about you?

How about you?

break: This word is the same word as the word "break" in 15:2a. You should translate it in the same way.

the command of God: This phrase refers to the commandments that God gave to his people through Moses. They are the written commandments/laws.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the law of God

for the sake of your tradition: The Greek word that the BSB translates as for the sake of means "because of" or "on account of."

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

you break the commandment of God because of your traditions (GW)

you set aside God's laws in order to follow your own customs

you disobey God and follow your own teaching (CEV)

by following your own customs, you do not obey God's laws

when you follow your own customs, it causes you to break God's laws

your tradition: This phrase is parallel to the phrase "the tradition of the elders" in 15:2a. But notice that Jesus, even though he was a Jew, did not say "our tradition" or "the tradition of the elders." He did not consider these traditions to be as important as God's written law.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

your traditions (GW)

your own laws/rules

your own teaching (CEV)

your own customs

Matthew 15:4

Section 15:1–20: The deeds that make someone unclean in God's eyes

Over the years, Jewish religious leaders added many oral rules to God's written laws. The Pharisees and teachers of the law considered these oral rules (also called traditions) to be as important as God's written laws. One of their rules was that a person must wash his hands a certain way before he ate food. If a Jew did not follow this rule before he ate, they considered him ceremonially "unclean." This meant that they did not allow him to worship God in public for a certain amount of time. Jesus made it clear that there was something far more important than how a person washed his hands. The important thing was the condition of his heart.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Challenges the Pharisees' Traditions (GW)

Jesus Teaches about Inner Purity/Cleanliness

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 7:1–23 and Luke 11:37–39.

15:4a

For God said, 'Honor your father and mother'

- For example God said, ‘You^(sing) must honor your father and mother,’
- God said, ‘Respect^(plural) your father and mother.’

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For introduces an explanation of 15:3.

Here are some other ways to introduce this explanation:

For example (GW)

For instance (NLT)

In some languages, it may be natural to give an example without any conjunction to introduce it.

God said: There is a textual issue here:

1. Some Greek manuscripts have God said. For example:

God said (BSB) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NET, NRSV, GW, NLT, JBP, NCV, NASB, REB, NJB)

1. Some Greek manuscripts have God commanded. For example:

God commanded (RSV) (ESV, KJV, RSV, CEV)

In this case, it is recommended that you follow the option that is most natural in your language.

Honor your father and mother: This is the fifth of the ten commandments (Exodus 20:12). The Greek word that the BSB translates as Honor also means “respect.” To honor/respect your parents meant that you should help them with their needs.

Here are some other ways to translate this command:

Respect your father and your mother (GNT)

You^(sing) must honor your father and your mother.

In Greek, this command is singular. But it is a command to each person. In some languages, it may be more natural to use a plural or another form. For example:

You^(plur) must honor your father and your mother.

A person must respect his father and his mother.

15:4b

and ‘Anyone who curses his father or mother must be put to death.’

- and ‘Anyone who speaks evil about his father or mother must be killed.’
- He also said, ‘People/they must kill a person who insults his father or mother.’

Anyone who curses his father or mother: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as curses means “speaks evil of,” “insults,” or “reviles.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Whoever reviles father or mother (ESV)

He who speaks evil of father or mother (RSV)

Whoever insults his father or mother (NET)

Anyone who says cruel things to his father or mother (NCV)

must be put to death: This phrase indicates that the person must be killed. It means that other Jews must kill the person who speaks evil of his parents.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

must surely die (ESV)

must be killed

people must kill him

General Comment on 15:4b

In some languages, it may be natural to change the order of the clauses in this part of the verse. For example:

They must kill him/the one who insults his father or mother

Matthew 15:5

Section 15:1–20: The deeds that make someone unclean in God’s eyes

Over the years, Jewish religious leaders added many oral rules to God’s written laws. The Pharisees and teachers of the law considered these oral rules (also called traditions) to be as important as God’s written laws. One of their rules was that a person must wash

his hands a certain way before he ate food. If a Jew did not follow this rule before he ate, they considered him ceremonially “unclean.” This meant that they did not allow him to worship God in public for a certain amount of time. Jesus made it clear that there was something far more important than how a person washed his hands. The important thing was the condition of his heart.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Challenges the Pharisees’ Traditions (GW)

Jesus Teaches about Inner Purity/Cleanliness

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 7:1–23 and Luke 11:37–39.

15:5a

But you say that if anyone says to his father or mother,

- But you say that if someone says to his father or mother,
- However, you teach that someone can say to his father or mother,

But you say: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between what God said/commanded (15:4a) and what you (the Pharisees and scribes) say/teach. The BSB indicates this contrast with the conjunction But.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

But you teach (GNT)

However, you say

if anyone says to his father or mother: The BSB translates this clause as direct speech. It is Jesus quoting the Pharisees and scribes. It is a quote within a quote and begins with a single quote mark.

It is also possible to translate this clause as indirect speech. For example:

But you say that if a man says to his father or mother (NIV)

But you say that whoever tells his father or mother (NRSV)

15:5b

‘Whatever you would have received from me is a gift devoted to God,’

- ‘The money/goods that you might otherwise have received from me, I have already vowed to be a gift to God,’
- ‘The things that I should/could have helped you with, I have promised to give to God,’
- ‘My parents, I have already vowed to give to God what I would have given to you.’

Whatever you would have received from me is a gift devoted to God: This clause refers to the following issues:

1. Adult children were supposed to give money or goods to their aging parents to help them.
2. Some Jews made vows dedicating their property, food, or money to God. The item in the vow was given to God in the sense that it was given to the temple when the person died.
3. While the person was alive, he could not use the vowed money or goods for other purposes. That meant that he could not even help his parents.
4. So, by making such a vow, a person could avoid helping his parents. This would not honor his parents.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

The thing that you would have received/gotten from me, I have already given to God.

Sorry, I can’t help you. For I have vowed to give to God what I would have given to you (NLT)

My parents, I do not have anything to help you with, because I have already vowed to give it to God.

Whatever you would have received from me: This clause refers to the money, property, or goods that someone should give to his parents to help them.

The verb received can also be translated as “gained” or “gotten.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

The help that you might otherwise have received from me

The money that I would have given to you

is a gift devoted to God: The word that the BSB translates as is a gift devoted to God is more literally “It is a gift” (as in the KJV). This word indicates that the person has made a vow. He has vowed to give his money/goods as a gift to God.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

has been offered to God (CEV)

I have given to God (GW)

I have vowed to give to God (NLT)

This belongs to God (GNT)

Matthew 15:6

Section 15:1–20: The deeds that make someone unclean in God’s eyes

Over the years, Jewish religious leaders added many oral rules to God’s written laws. The Pharisees and teachers of the law considered these oral rules (also called traditions) to be as important as God’s written laws. One of their rules was that a person must wash his hands a certain way before he ate food. If a Jew did not follow this rule before he ate, they considered him ceremonially “unclean.” This meant that they did not allow him to worship God in public for a certain amount of time. Jesus made it clear that there was something far more important than how a person washed his hands. The important thing was the condition of his heart.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Challenges the Pharisees’ Traditions (GW)

Jesus Teaches about Inner Purity/Cleanliness

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 7:1–23 and Luke 11:37–39.

15:6a

he need not honor his father or mother with it.

- then you say that he must not honor his father or mother.
- If he says that, then you teach that he is forbidden from honoring his parents with those things.

he need not honor his father or mother with it:

There are two ways to interpret the clause that the BSB translates as he need not honor his father:

1. It means that he is forbidden from honoring his father. He must not give to his father the money/things that he vowed to give to God. This is because a vow is sacred and must not be broken. If a vow is made pledging money to God, then that money must never be used for anything else. He must not honor/help his father with it. For example:

must not honour his father or his mother (REB)
(NIV, KJV, NASB, REB, NCV)

1. It means that he is not required to honor his father. He is free from the obligation to honor his father. He no longer needs to honor his father. For example:

they do not need to honor their father (GNT)

it is not necessary for him to honor his father
(BSB, GNT, ESV, RSV, NJB, NET, CEV, NLT, JBP)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This interpretation better fits the Greek. (The Greek is more literally “he shall not honor his father.”) It also fits the parallel passage in Mark 7:12 “you no longer permit him to do anything for his father or mother.”

Here are some other issues to consider when translating this clause:

1. This clause says that there are only certain ways that a person must not honor his parents. It applies only to the money, goods, or property that a person has already vowed to give to God. The Pharisees were not forbidding a person from honoring his parents in general. There were still many other ways they required a person to honor his parents. For this reason, the BSB adds the phrase with it. For example:

he is not to ‘honor his father’ with it (NIV)

he is forbidden from honoring his father with that money

1. This clause continues the teaching of the Pharisees. In some languages, it may be natural to make this more clear. For example:

You teach that person not to honor his father or his mother (NCV)

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

you say that he is forbidden from honoring his father and mother with those goods

you teach that person that he must not honor his parents with that money

his father or mother: Many Greek manuscripts have his father. Some Greek manuscripts add “and his mother.” Even in those manuscripts that have only his father, it is implied that the mother is included as well. In some languages, it may be more natural to include this implied information. For example:

his father or his mother (NCV)

your parents (CEV)

15:6b

Thus you nullify the word of God for the sake of your tradition.

- So, you make God’s word useless because of your tradition.
- Therefore, you reject what God said in order to follow your own customs.

Thus: Verse 15:6b is the conclusion that Jesus made. The BSB introduces this conclusion with the conjunction Thus.

Here are some other ways to introduce this conclusion:

In this way (NJB)

Therefore

you nullify the word of God: The Greek word that the BSB translates as nullify also means “cancel out,” “reject,” or “disregard.” People could justify not helping their parents. But in doing so, they broke the command to honor one’s parents.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

You rejected what God said (NCV)

you have destroyed the authority of God’s word (GW)

You ignore God’s commands (CEV)

for the sake of your tradition: In Greek, this phrase is the same phrase as in 15:3. It means “because of” or “on account of.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Because of your traditions (GW)

in order to follow your own customs

and follow your own teaching

by following your own customs

Matthew 15:7

Section 15:1–20: The deeds that make someone unclean in God’s eyes

Over the years, Jewish religious leaders added many oral rules to God’s written laws. The Pharisees and teachers of the law considered these oral rules (also called traditions) to be as important as God’s written laws. One of their rules was that a person must wash his hands a certain way before he ate food. If a Jew did not follow this rule before he ate, they considered him ceremonially “unclean.” This meant that they did not allow him to worship God in public for a certain amount of time. Jesus made it clear that there was something far more important than how a person washed his hands. The important thing was the condition of his heart.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Challenges the Pharisees’ Traditions (GW)

Jesus Teaches about Inner Purity/Cleanliness

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 7:1–23 and Luke 11:37–39.

15:7a

You hypocrites!

- You are pretenders!
- You who act like you are good!

You hypocrites: The Greek word that the BSB translates as hypocrites literally refers to actors (in the theater). Figuratively it refers to people who pretend to be people that they are not. They say that they believe one thing, but they do something different from what they say. Or they appear religious or spiritual on the outside, but they do not have hearts that desire to please God.

In this context, Jesus was referring to Pharisees who said that they carefully followed the word of God. But in reality, they broke certain commandments.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

You who act like you obey God!

You pretend to be good.

This word first occurs in 6:2. It also occurs in 7:5.

15:7b

Isaiah prophesied correctly about you:

- Isaiah spoke correctly about you^(plur) when he spoke this message which God said:
- The thing that God said through the prophet Isaiah about you was very true. He said that

Isaiah prophesied correctly about you: In Greek, this clause is more literally: “Isaiah prophesied correctly concerning you saying...” Isaiah’s prophecy was God’s words to the religious hypocrites of that time. But the prophecy was also fitting for the religious hypocrites of Jesus’ time.

God gave the words in 15:8–9 to Isaiah, and Isaiah spoke them to the people. You may want to make it clear that God is speaking in 15:8–9. For example:

Isaiah’s prophecy really applies to you in which God said

Isaiah prophesied correctly about you. God’s words were:

Isaiah: Isaiah is the name of a prophet. He lived many years before the time of Jesus.

prophesied: This verb means “spoke a message from God.” God told Isaiah something that only God knew, and Isaiah then told the people.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

spoke God’s message

proclaimed God’s words

In some languages, it may be more natural to change this verb to the noun “prophet” and a verb such as “spoke.” For example:

the prophet Isaiah spoke/said

Matthew 15:8

Section 15:1–20: The deeds that make someone unclean in God’s eyes

Over the years, Jewish religious leaders added many oral rules to God’s written laws. The Pharisees and teachers of the law considered these oral rules (also called traditions) to be as important as God’s written laws. One of their rules was that a person must wash his hands a certain way before he ate food. If a Jew did not follow this rule before he ate, they considered him ceremonially “unclean.” This meant that they did not allow him to worship God in public for a certain amount of time. Jesus made it clear that there was something far more important than how a person washed his hands. The important thing was the condition of his heart.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Challenges the Pharisees’ Traditions (GW)

Jesus Teaches about Inner Purity/Cleanliness

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 7:1–23 and Luke 11:37–39.

15:8a

‘These people honor Me with their lips,

- ‘These people honor me with their mouths/words,
- those people pretend to honor/respect him/God when they speak,

These people: When Isaiah originally spoke these words, the phrase This people referred to the Jewish people of that time. Jesus said that the Pharisees were also the people whom Isaiah had spoken about.

In some languages it may be natural to translate this phrase as:

You^(plur) people

All of you (CEV)

honor Me with their lips: The phrase honor Me with their lips is a figure of speech called a metonymy. In this figure of speech, the phrase their lips stands for “their words.” This means that the Pharisees honored/praised God with their words.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- Substitute a similar figure of speech. For example:

praise me with their mouths

- Omit the figure of speech and express the meaning directly. For example:

honor me when they talk

show honor to me with words (NCV)

This clause indicates that the honor is hypocritical. If people in your area will think that the honor is real, you may want to add some implied information. For example:

pretend to honor me with their words

me: Jesus was quoting from the book of Isaiah, which was quoting the words of God. So the pronoun me refers to God. In some languages it may be necessary to use indirect speech in order to make this clear. For example:

in which God said that those people honored him with their lips/words

15:8b

but their hearts are far from Me.

- but their minds/livers are far from me.
- but they do not really love him.

their hearts: In the New Testament, the word heart refers to the mind, emotions, and will of a person. It refers to the part of a person that he uses to think, feel, and make decisions.

In some languages people refer to this part of a person as the thoughts, mind, throat, liver, or stomach. They are not referring literally to that physical part of the body.

Your language may use a word other than the heart to talk about the center of emotions. In that case, you should use that word instead of “heart.”

are far from Me: The words far from me are a figurative expression that means that the people had turned away from God. They had turned away in the following ways:

1. They turned away with their minds and so they did not think of God.
2. They turned away with their will and so they did not obey God.
3. They turned away with their emotions and so they did not love God.

In your translation, try to find an expression that implies or suggests all of these things.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

but their minds/livers/stomachs are far from me

but in their hearts/throats/thoughts, they have turned away from me

but they do not mean what they say

If one term expresses only part of the meaning, you may be able to use a combination of terms. For example:

they do not truly love me or think about me

Matthew 15:9

Section 15:1–20: The deeds that make someone unclean in God’s eyes

Over the years, Jewish religious leaders added many oral rules to God’s written laws. The Pharisees and teachers of the law considered these oral rules (also called traditions) to be as important as God’s written laws. One of their rules was that a person must wash his hands a certain way before he ate food. If a Jew did not follow this rule before he ate, they considered him ceremonially “unclean.” This meant that they did not allow him to worship God in public for a certain amount of time. Jesus made it clear that there was something far more important than how a person washed his hands. The important thing was the condition of his heart.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Challenges the Pharisees’ Traditions (GW)

Jesus Teaches about Inner Purity/Cleanliness

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 7:1–23 and Luke 11:37–39.

15:9a

They worship Me in vain;

- They worship/praise me, but it has no value/worth.
- When they pray to God, it is useless,

They: When Isaiah spoke, the word they referred to the Jewish people who did not worship God properly. When Jesus quoted what Isaiah said, he used it to refer to the Pharisees and teachers of the law. If you have used the phrase “you people” in 15:8a, it will probably be best to continue using it here.

worship Me: The Greek word that the BSB translates as worship means to “show devotion and reverence” to God or a false god. People worship God in many ways. They give offerings and sacrifices, they pray, they bow down or kneel to show respect and submission, they serve him obediently, and they speak or sing about him.

In this context the meaning of worship is similar to the meaning of “honor” in 15:8a.

Here are some other ways to translate worship:

They praise me

They pray to me

Me: The word Me refers to God.

in vain: The Greek word that the BSB translates as in vain means “to no purpose,” “uselessly,” or “without result.” This word indicates that their worship has no result or no benefit.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Their worship of me is pointless (GW)

Their worship of me is worthless (NCV)

They praise me, but it has no value

When they pray to me, I am not touched/pleased.

15:9b

they teach as doctrine the precepts of men.”

- They teach man-made rules as if they were my laws.”

- because they teach man’s rules and say that they are God’s commandments.”

The clause in 15:9b is the basis for the statement in 15:9a that people were worshiping in vain. Some English versions make this clear by adding a connecting word. For example:

because they teach human rules as though they were my laws (GNT)

they teach as doctrine the precepts of men: The word doctrine refers to God’s laws. The phrase precepts of men refers to man-made rules.

This clause means that the Pharisees and scribes taught the rules that they made themselves. Not only that, they taught these rules as if they came from God.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

they teach human rules as though they were my laws! (GNT)

they teach man-made ideas as commands from God (NLT)

they teach their own rules and say that they are rules/laws from God

Matthew 15:10

Section 15:1–20: The deeds that make someone unclean in God’s eyes

Over the years, Jewish religious leaders added many oral rules to God’s written laws. The Pharisees and teachers of the law considered these oral rules (also called traditions) to be as important as God’s written laws. One of their rules was that a person must wash his hands a certain way before he ate food. If a Jew did not follow this rule before he ate, they considered him ceremonially “unclean.” This meant that they did not allow him to worship God in public for a certain amount of time. Jesus made it clear that there was something far more important than how a person washed his hands. The important thing was the condition of his heart.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Challenges the Pharisees’ Traditions (GW)

Jesus Teaches about Inner Purity/Cleanliness

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 7:1–23 and Luke 11:37–39.

15:10a

Jesus called the crowd to Him and said,

- ¶ Then Jesus asked the crowd to come near to him, and he said to them,
- After that, Jesus invited the crowd of people to gather around him. He said,

This verse begins a new part of the story. In some languages, it may be more natural to begin this paragraph with a time word. For example:

Then (GNT)

After that

Jesus called the crowd to Him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as called also means “summon, ask (someone) to come.” Jesus invited the people who had been listening to gather around him. He did this because he wanted to talk to them.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus called the crowd together (CEV)

Jesus told the crowd of people to gather around him

the crowd: When Jesus was talking with the Pharisees and scribes in 15:1–9, other people were standing around listening. Here Jesus began to speak directly to these people.

15:10b

“Listen and understand.

- “Listen to me and understand this:
- “Listen/Hear well so you^(plur) may understand what I am about to say:

Listen and understand: The expression Listen and understand indicates that:

1. Jesus intended to say something important to the crowd.
2. He strongly urged the people to listen carefully to what he said and understand it.

Listen means “concentrate on what I am saying.” The word understand emphasizes that everyone should think carefully about the meaning of what Jesus was about to say.

Use an expression in your language that people say when they want others to give careful attention and think about the meaning of what they hear. For example:

Pay attention and try to understand what I mean.
(CEV)

Listen and understand what I am saying (NCV)

This clause refers to the things that Jesus was about to say. Your translation should indicate that Jesus was referring to something that he was going to say. He is not talking about something that he had already said.

Matthew 15:11

Section 15:1–20: The deeds that make someone unclean in God’s eyes

Over the years, Jewish religious leaders added many oral rules to God’s written laws. The Pharisees and teachers of the law considered these oral rules (also called traditions) to be as important as God’s written laws. One of their rules was that a person must wash his hands a certain way before he ate food. If a Jew did not follow this rule before he ate, they considered him ceremonially “unclean.” This meant that they did not allow him to worship God in public for a certain amount of time. Jesus made it clear that there was something far more important than how a person washed his hands. The important thing was the condition of his heart.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Challenges the Pharisees’ Traditions (GW)

Jesus Teaches about Inner Purity/Cleanliness

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 7:1–23 and Luke 11:37–39.

15:11a

A man is not defiled by what enters his mouth,

- The thing that makes a person unclean in God’s eyes is not the thing that he puts in his mouth.
- The food that people put into their mouths doesn’t make them unfit before God.

A man is not defiled by what enters his mouth: The Greek word that the BSB translates as defiled means “made unclean or made something ritually unacceptable.” Many English versions translate this word as

“unclean.” In this context, it means “unfit before God.” It does not mean “dirty.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

It is not what people put into their mouths that makes them unclean (NCV)

the thing that makes a person unclean in God’s eyes is not what he puts into his mouth

The food that you put into your mouth does not make you unfit before God

15:11b but by what comes out of it.”

- Instead, it’s the evil words that come out of his mouth that make him unclean.”
- The thing that makes people unfit before God is what comes out of their mouths.”

but: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between what goes into a person’s mouth (15:11a) and what comes out of a person’s mouth (15:11b).

Here are some other ways to introduce this contrast:

instead

rather

by what comes out of it: The phrase what comes out of it refers to the words that a person says. The words that a person says show what is in his heart. If someone is right before God, he will say things that show that he is righteous. But if someone is not right before God, he will say things that show that he is not righteous. These bad words are what defile a person before God.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

it is what comes out of his mouth that makes him unclean/unacceptable in God’s eyes

the things that make people unclean before God are the words that come out of their mouths

Matthew 15:12

Section 15:1–20: The deeds that make someone unclean in God’s eyes

Over the years, Jewish religious leaders added many oral rules to God’s written laws. The Pharisees and teachers of the law considered these oral rules (also called traditions) to be as important as God’s written laws. One of their rules was that a person must wash his hands a certain way before he ate food. If a Jew did not follow this rule before he ate, they considered him ceremonially “unclean.” This meant that they did not allow him to worship God in public for a certain amount of time. Jesus made it clear that there was something far more important than how a person washed his hands. The important thing was the condition of his heart.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Challenges the Pharisees’ Traditions (GW)

Jesus Teaches about Inner Purity/Cleanliness

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 7:1–23 and Luke 11:37–39.

15:12a Then the disciples came to Him and said,

- Then the disciples approached him and asked,
- Later his disciples came/went to him in private and said,

Then the disciples came to Him and said: This clause indicates that the disciples had a private conversation with Jesus apart from the crowd. According to Mark 7:17, this conversation took place after Jesus and his disciples left the crowd and entered a house.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Later his disciples came to him and said (JBP)

Then the disciples approached and said to him (NRSV)

15:12b “Are You aware that the Pharisees were offended when they heard this?”

- “Do you realize that the Pharisees were insulted/shocked when they heard what you said?”
- “You know that the Pharisees were upset because of the words you said.”

Are You aware that the Pharisees were offended when they heard this?: This is a rhetorical question. The disciples were gently warning Jesus to be careful. The Pharisees had a lot of influence over the people, and people highly respected them. It was not wise to offend them.

Here are some other ways to translate this warning:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Do you realize that when the Pharisees heard your statement they were offended? (GW)

- As a statement. For example:

You know that the Pharisees were offended when they heard you say those words. Please be careful.

Are You aware: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as aware in this context means “know about,” “realize,” or “be aware of.” The disciples wanted to make sure that Jesus realized how much his words had offended the Pharisees. The disciples were concerned because Jesus spoke against the teachings of such an important religious group.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

Do you realize (GW)

Do you know (ESV)

the Pharisees were offended: The Greek word that the BSB translates as were offended also means “were upset,” “were shocked,” or “were angered” by something.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the Pharisees were upset

the Pharisees are angry (NCV)

The Pharisees are not at all happy

you insulted the Pharisees (CEV)

Some languages have idioms to translate this clause.

when they heard this: This clause means “when the Pharisees heard this thing that you said.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

when they heard what you said (NJB)

at the words that you said about them

because of what you said (NCV)

by what you said (GNT)

Matthew 15:13

Section 15:1–20: The deeds that make someone unclean in God’s eyes

Over the years, Jewish religious leaders added many oral rules to God’s written laws. The Pharisees and teachers of the law considered these oral rules (also called traditions) to be as important as God’s written laws. One of their rules was that a person must wash his hands a certain way before he ate food. If a Jew did not follow this rule before he ate, they considered him ceremonially “unclean.” This meant that they did not allow him to worship God in public for a certain amount of time. Jesus made it clear that there was something far more important than how a person washed his hands. The important thing was the condition of his heart.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Challenges the Pharisees’ Traditions (GW)

Jesus Teaches about Inner Purity/Cleanliness

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 7:1–23 and Luke 11:37–39.

15:13

But Jesus replied, “Every plant that My heavenly Father has not planted will be pulled up by its roots.”

- He answered, “My heavenly father will uproot any plant that he has not planted.
- He replied, “A farmer uproots every plant that he has not planted. Like that my heavenly father will punish/destroy everyone who does not belong to him.
- Jesus said, “My father in heaven will destroy any person who does not belong to him.

Every plant that My heavenly Father has not planted will be pulled up by its roots: The Greek word that the BSB translates as pulled up by its roots

refers to pulling a plant, including its roots, out of the soil. When this is done, the plant cannot regrow. It is destroyed.

This sentence is a metaphor. In this metaphor, Jesus compared:

1. God to a farmer
2. the Pharisees to plants/weeds that the farmer had not planted and that were not part of his garden/farm
3. eternal punishment to uprooting those plants.

A farmer uproots plants/weeds that he has not planted. These plants do not belong in his garden/farm. In the same way, God will judge and destroy all who do not belong in his kingdom.

The Jews considered their nation to be a plant that God had planted (as in Isaiah 60:21). Jesus used this metaphor to show that many of the Pharisees were not truly God's people.

Here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor: For example:

My Father in heaven will uproot any plant that he has not planted. If people in your area will not clearly understand the meaning of the metaphor, you may want to include a footnote to explain it. A sample footnote is:

Jesus used this metaphor to explain that God will punish many Pharisees. As a farmer uproots bad plants that he has not planted, God will destroy people who do not truly belong to him.

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

As a farmer uproots plants that he did not plant, my heavenly Father will punish/destroy anyone who does not belong to him.

A farmer uproots plants that he did not plant. In the same way, my heavenly Father will punish/destroy anyone who does not belong to him.

- Translate the meaning of the metaphor without using a figure of speech. For example:

My heavenly Father will destroy any person who does not belong to him. You may then want to include the metaphor in a footnote. For example:

In Greek, this is literally: My heavenly Father will uproot any plant that he has not planted.

will be pulled up by its roots: The clause is passive. Here are some ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

will be uprooted (NET)

- As an active verb. For example:

he/God will uproot

Matthew 15:14

Section 15:1-20: The deeds that make someone unclean in God's eyes

Over the years, Jewish religious leaders added many oral rules to God's written laws. The Pharisees and teachers of the law considered these oral rules (also called traditions) to be as important as God's written laws. One of their rules was that a person must wash his hands a certain way before he ate food. If a Jew did not follow this rule before he ate, they considered him ceremonially "unclean." This meant that they did not allow him to worship God in public for a certain amount of time. Jesus made it clear that there was something far more important than how a person washed his hands. The important thing was the condition of his heart.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Challenges the Pharisees' Traditions (GW)

Jesus Teaches about Inner Purity/Cleanliness

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 7:1-23 and Luke 11:37-39.

15:14a

Disregard them!

- Do not worry about them.
- Do not be troubled/concerned about them.

Disregard them: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Disregard them means "do not be concerned/worried about what the Pharisees think."

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Don't worry about them! (GNT)

Do not be troubled about them

ignore them (NLT)

15:14b

They are blind guides.

- They are like blind people who lead other blind people.
- They are people who do not see/understand what I am teaching. Yet they are the leaders of other people who also do not see/understand. They are like blind people who hold the stick/hand of other blind people to lead them.

They are blind guides: There is a textual issue here:

1. Some Greek manuscripts include a word at the end of this clause that can be translated as of the blind. For example:

they are blind guides of the blind (NASB) (NRSV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NLT, CEV, KJV)

1. Some Greek manuscripts do not include the words “of the blind.” For example:

they are blind guides (NIV) (BSB, RSV, NIV, ESV, NET, GW, JBP, REB, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). The UBS Greek New Testament contains this word. However, the UBS Committee gave “of the blind” a C rating and placed this word in brackets in the UBS GNT 4th edition to indicate its uncertainty.

The phrase They are blind guides is a metaphor. In this metaphor, Jesus compared the Pharisees to people who guide/lead blind people. Yet they themselves were blind. They were blind guides in the sense that they were spiritual leaders of other people. But they themselves did not “see” the spiritual truths that Jesus was explaining.

Here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

They are blind leaders of the blind (GNT)

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

They are like blind people leading other blind people (CEV)

- Change the metaphor to a simile and make explicit the way that they are similar. For example:

They are like blind people who lead other blind people. They teach other people, but they themselves do not understand the truths that I am saying.

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

They are people who do not understand the spiritual truths that I am teaching. Yet they are leaders of other people who also do not understand.

guides: In Greek, the word that the BSB translates as guides is a noun. In some languages, it will be more natural to change this noun into a verb. For example:

one blind person leads another blind person

You should use the normal expression in your language for someone who leads/guides a blind person. In some languages, the person leading holds a stick that the blind person also holds. In other languages, the person leading holds the hand of the blind person.

15:14c

If a blind man leads a blind man, both will fall into a pit.”

- If/When one blind person leads another blind person, both will fall into the same hole.
- When a blind person leads/guides another blind person, both of them will fall into a hole/ditch.

If a blind man leads a blind man, both will fall into a pit:

In this sentence, Jesus continued the metaphor that he began in 15:14b. Here, Jesus talked about the disaster that would happen to the Pharisees and their followers. He compared it to blind people falling into a pit.

Here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

And if a blind person leads a blind person, both will fall into a ditch. (NCV)

- Make the meaning of fall into a pit explicit. For example:

When a blind person leads another blind person, both people will fall into a ditch. This means that something bad will unexpectedly happen to them.

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

One day, something bad will unexpectedly/suddenly happen to both of them.

a pit: The Greek word that the BSB translates as a pit refers to any deep hole. It can be a hole that someone dug. Or it can be a hole like a ditch that rain and water made.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

ditch (GNT)

hole

Matthew 15:15

Section 15:1–20: The deeds that make someone unclean in God’s eyes

Over the years, Jewish religious leaders added many oral rules to God’s written laws. The Pharisees and teachers of the law considered these oral rules (also called traditions) to be as important as God’s written laws. One of their rules was that a person must wash his hands a certain way before he ate food. If a Jew did not follow this rule before he ate, they considered him ceremonially “unclean.” This meant that they did not allow him to worship God in public for a certain amount of time. Jesus made it clear that there was something far more important than how a person washed his hands. The important thing was the condition of his heart.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Challenges the Pharisees’ Traditions (GW)

Jesus Teaches about Inner Purity/Cleanliness

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 7:1–23 and Luke 11:37–39.

15:15

Peter said to Him, “Explain this parable to us.”

- Then Peter said, “Lord, please explain to us^(excl) the meaning of the parable/saying that you told the people.”
- Peter replied, “What did you mean when you talked about the things that make people unclean?” (CEV)
- Then Peter asked Jesus to explain to them the meaning of the words/saying that he told the people.

The Greek begins this verse with a conjunction that some English versions translate as “But.” It indicates a change from Jesus’ speech to Peter’s request. There is no contrast here. Some English versions, including the BSB, do not translate this conjunction.

Here is another way to begin this verse:

Then (NLT)

Peter said: There is a Greek verb that the BSB does not translate here. In this context it means “responded, spoke up.”

Explain this parable to us: This sentence is a polite request asking for information. Peter politely asked Jesus to explain the meaning of the parable/words that he said to the people in 15:11. Peter did not ask Jesus to explain the meaning of the words that he said to the disciples in 15:13–14. In order to make this clear, you may need to make some adjustments to this request. For example:

Lord, please explain to us the meaning of the parable/saying that you told the people.

Explain to us the parable that says people aren’t defiled by what they eat. (NLT)

What did you mean when you talked about the things that make people unclean? (CEV)

this parable: The Greek word that the BSB translates as parable can refer to a story, a saying, a proverb, or a parable.

Here Peter used this Greek word to refer to what Jesus said in 15:11. (It does not refer to what Jesus just said in 15:13–14.) Many English speakers would not consider the words in 15:11 to be a parable.

Here are some other ways to describe the words in 15:11:

this saying (GNT)

the example (NCV)

this illustration (GW)

Matthew 15:16

Section 15:1–20: The deeds that make someone unclean in God's eyes

Over the years, Jewish religious leaders added many oral rules to God's written laws. The Pharisees and teachers of the law considered these oral rules (also called traditions) to be as important as God's written laws. One of their rules was that a person must wash his hands a certain way before he ate food. If a Jew did not follow this rule before he ate, they considered him ceremonially "unclean." This meant that they did not allow him to worship God in public for a certain amount of time. Jesus made it clear that there was something far more important than how a person washed his hands. The important thing was the condition of his heart.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Challenges the Pharisees' Traditions (GW)

Jesus Teaches about Inner Purity/Cleanliness

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 7:1–23 and Luke 11:37–39.

15:16

"Do you still not understand?" Jesus asked.

- Jesus replied, "Why is it that until now you^(plur) also do not understand?"
- Jesus replied, "You should understand me, but even you, you still do not."

Do you still not understand?: This is a rhetorical question. It is a mild rebuke. Jesus rebuked/scolded the disciples because they did not understand the things that he taught. Not only did the crowds not understand his teaching, even his own disciples did not yet understand.

Here are some other ways to translate this rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Why is it that up to now you too do not understand?

Don't any of you know what I am talking about by now? (CEV)

- As a statement. For example:

You are still no more intelligent than the others. (GNT)

You should understand what I am teaching, but up to now, even you do not understand.

Translate this rebuke in a way that is natural in your language.

you: The plural pronoun you is emphasized in the Greek by moving it to the beginning of the clause. It emphasizes the comparison of the disciples with the crowd. If there is a natural way to emphasize this word in your language, you may want to do so.

There is a Greek word before you that the BSB does not translate. It is often translated as "also." It compares the disciples to the people in the crowd. The crowd did not understand Jesus' teaching. The disciples also did not understand.

Here are some ways to translate this phrase:

you too

even you

still: The Greek adverb that the BSB translates as still means "up to that time." Up to that time the disciples had not understood Jesus' teaching. When Jesus used the word still, he implied that they should have understood it before then.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

yet (GW)

by now (CEV)

not understand: The Greek word that the BSB translates as not understand also means "senseless" or "foolish." Jesus implied here that the disciples should have understood what he meant. Jesus did not imply that the disciples were stupid. He implied that they were not using their intelligence to understand spiritual truth.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

do not understand me

are ignorant

Matthew 15:17

Section 15:1–20: The deeds that make someone unclean in God’s eyes

Over the years, Jewish religious leaders added many oral rules to God’s written laws. The Pharisees and teachers of the law considered these oral rules (also called traditions) to be as important as God’s written laws. One of their rules was that a person must wash his hands a certain way before he ate food. If a Jew did not follow this rule before he ate, they considered him ceremonially “unclean.” This meant that they did not allow him to worship God in public for a certain amount of time. Jesus made it clear that there was something far more important than how a person washed his hands. The important thing was the condition of his heart.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Challenges the Pharisees’ Traditions (GW)

Jesus Teaches about Inner Purity/Cleanliness

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 7:1–23 and Luke 11:37–39.

15:17

Do you not yet realize that whatever enters the mouth goes into the stomach and then is eliminated?: This is a rhetorical question. It is a mild rebuke. It also emphasizes that whatever enters the mouth is not important. It is not important because it goes into the stomach and then out of the body.

Here are some other ways to translate this rebuke and emphasis:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Don’t you know that the food you put into your mouth goes into your stomach and then out of your body? (CEV)

- As a statement. For example:

Surely you know that all the food that enters the mouth goes into the stomach and then goes out of the body. (NCV)

Translate this rebuke and emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

15:17a

“Do you not yet realize that whatever enters the mouth

- Do you not know/understand that the things that enter someone’s mouth
- Surely you know/understand that the food that people put into their mouths

Do you not yet realize: In this context the Greek word that the BSB translates as realize means “understand.” For example:

Don’t you understand? (GNT)

Don’t you know (CEV)

whatever enters the mouth: This expression refers to the food that a person puts into his mouth. For example:

the food that enters the mouth (NCV)

the food you put into your mouth (CEV)

15:17b

goes into the stomach and then is eliminated?

- go into the stomach and then exit into the sewer?
- enters their stomachs and then passes out of their bodies.

is eliminated: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as is eliminated is literally “goes out into the latrine.” The BSB uses a euphemism here for the literal Greek words. (A euphemism is a figure of speech that substitutes acceptable words for words that may embarrass or offend people.)

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- Use a euphemism. For example:

then goes out of the body (NCV)

is eliminated (NASB)

- Translate it more literally. For example:

then passes out into the sewer (NET)

then into a toilet (GW)

You should use a term that will be acceptably polite when your translation is read aloud in church. You should not use a term that only applies to a modern toilet.

Matthew 15:18

Section 15:1–20: The deeds that make someone unclean in God’s eyes

Over the years, Jewish religious leaders added many oral rules to God’s written laws. The Pharisees and teachers of the law considered these oral rules (also called traditions) to be as important as God’s written laws. One of their rules was that a person must wash his hands a certain way before he ate food. If a Jew did not follow this rule before he ate, they considered him ceremonially “unclean.” This meant that they did not allow him to worship God in public for a certain amount of time. Jesus made it clear that there was something far more important than how a person washed his hands. The important thing was the condition of his heart.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Challenges the Pharisees’ Traditions (GW)

Jesus Teaches about Inner Purity/Cleanliness

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 7:1–23 and Luke 11:37–39.

15:18a

But the things that come out of the mouth come from the heart,

- But the words that exit a person’s mouth comes from his heart/stomach.
- But the evil things that people say come from what they think/feel.

But: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between what goes into a person’s mouth and what comes out of it. The BSB indicates this contrast with the conjunction But.

the things that come out of the mouth: This expression refers to the words that a person says. This verse starts with words similar to words in 15:17 so that the different results are emphasized.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

the words that come out of your mouth (CEV)

the evil/bad words that comes out of a person’s mouth

what people say with their mouths (NCV)

come from the heart: The Greek word that the BSB translates as come also means “comes out” (as in the NIV).

In Greek culture, the heart was the center and source of life. It is the inner part of a person that thinks, feels and makes decisions. Some languages refer to this part of a person as the throat, stomach, or liver. Use the expression that is natural in your language for this idea.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

comes from within (GW)

comes from the stomach/liver

comes from the way they think (NCV)

comes from the mind/thoughts

comes from inside

15:18b

and these things defile a man.

- It is the evil/bad words that make him unclean.
- These are the things that make them unfit/unacceptable to God.

and these things: The Greek word that the BSB translates as these things refers to the words that a person says. Specifically, it is the bad/evil words that a person says. In some languages, it may be more natural to make this explicit. For example:

it is these bad things

it is these evil words

defile a man: The word man is general and refers to people, both men and women.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

a person (ESV)

you (CEV)

defile: The Greek word that the BSB translates as defile means “make unclean or make something ritually unacceptable.” This same word occurs in 15:11a.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

makes unclean

make you unfit to worship God (CEV)

Matthew 15:19

Section 15:1–20: The deeds that make someone unclean in God’s eyes

Over the years, Jewish religious leaders added many oral rules to God’s written laws. The Pharisees and teachers of the law considered these oral rules (also called traditions) to be as important as God’s written laws. One of their rules was that a person must wash his hands a certain way before he ate food. If a Jew did not follow this rule before he ate, they considered him ceremonially “unclean.” This meant that they did not allow him to worship God in public for a certain amount of time. Jesus made it clear that there was something far more important than how a person washed his hands. The important thing was the condition of his heart.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Challenges the Pharisees’ Traditions (GW)

Jesus Teaches about Inner Purity/Cleanliness

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 7:1–23 and Luke 11:37–39.

15:19a

For out of the heart come

- I say this because the things that come from the heart/stomach of a person are
- The things that are in people’s hearts cause/make them

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For introduces the basis for the things that Jesus said in 15:18.

Here is another way to translate this:

I say this because

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it will not be natural to translate this conjunction either.

out of the heart come: The word heart is the same word as in 15:18a. You should translate it here as you did there.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

that which comes from the heart of a person are

the things that are in a person’s heart cause/make him to

In some languages, it will be more natural to put the phrase out of the heart come at the end of the verse. See the General Comment at the end of 15:19d for some examples.

15:19b

evil thoughts, murder,

- evil thoughts, killing,
- to think evil things, and kill people,

evil thoughts: There is an interpretation issue here. It involves how the expression evil thoughts relates to the rest of the terms in 15:19.

1. It is a specific term. It is the first of the seven terms in the list. These seven terms are all things that come out of the heart. For example:

evil thoughts, murder, adultery, sexual immorality, theft, false testimony, slander (NIV) (BSB, RSV, NIV, NET, ESV, NLT, NASB, GW, CEV, REB, KJV, NCV)

1. It is a general term. It is the thing that leads to the next six specific terms. Some versions show this by putting a colon after this term. For example:

evil intentions: murder, adultery, fornication, theft, perjury, slander (NJB) (GNT, NJB, JBP)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The majority of English versions follow this interpretation.

In some languages, it will be more natural to translate this noun phrase as a verb. For example:

he thinks evil things

murder: The Greek word that the BSB translates as murder is a plural noun. It also means “killings.” In this context, it refers to the illegal ending of someone’s life. It does not refer to executing a criminal or killing an enemy soldier in battle.

Here is another way to translate this word:

he kills/murders people

15:19c

adultery, sexual immorality,

- adultery, sexual sin,
- and sleep with someone who is not his/her spouse, and do other filthiness,

adultery: The Greek word that the BSB translates as adultery means “a married person having sex with someone other than his wife (or her husband).”

Here is another way to translate this word:

sleeping with someone to whom he is not married

sexual immorality: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sexual immorality is a general term referring to all sexual sin.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

[other] sexual sins (GW)

all other sexual immorality (NLT96)

fornication

he does other filthy/evil deeds

General Comment on 15:19c

Some languages have one term that covers the meaning of both “adultery” and “sexual immorality.” Other languages may need more than two terms. You should use as few or as many words as necessary to translate these two Greek words.

15:19d

theft, false testimony, and slander.

- stealing, lying, and saying bad things about others.
- and steal, and tell lies, and destroy the names of other people.

theft: The word theft refers to taking the property of someone else when the owner did not give permission to take it.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

robbery

he steals

false testimony: The Greek word here primarily refers to telling lies in court. It can also refer to telling lies in any situation.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

lying (NLT)

he tells lies

slander: In Greek this word refers to saying things that hurt the reputation of someone.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

speaking evil of others (NCV)

insulting others (CEV)

he destroys the name/reputation of other people

General Comment on 15:19a–d

In some languages, it will be more natural to change the order of some of the parts of this verse. For example:

Evil thoughts, murder, adultery, sexual immoralities, theft, lying, and slander all come from the heart.

Many evil things come from the heart such as evil thoughts, murder, adultery, sexual immoralities, theft, lying, and slander.

Matthew 15:20

Section 15:1–20: The deeds that make someone unclean in God’s eyes

Over the years, Jewish religious leaders added many oral rules to God’s written laws. The Pharisees and teachers of the law considered these oral rules (also called traditions) to be as important as God’s written laws. One of their rules was that a person must wash his hands a certain way before he ate food. If a Jew did not follow this rule before he ate, they considered

him ceremonially “unclean.” This meant that they did not allow him to worship God in public for a certain amount of time. Jesus made it clear that there was something far more important than how a person washed his hands. The important thing was the condition of his heart.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Challenges the Pharisees’ Traditions (GW)

Jesus Teaches about Inner Purity/Cleanliness

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 7:1–23 and Luke 11:37–39.

15:20a

These are what defile a man,

- It is those things/actions that make a person unclean.
- Those are the things/deeds that cause people to be unfit/unacceptable to God.

These are: The word These is emphasized in Greek. This word refers back to the list in 15:19.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

It is those things/actions that are

Those are the things/deeds that

It is because of those things/deeds

what defile a man: The word defile is the same word as in 15:11a–b and 15:18b. You should translate this word the same way here as you did there. For example:

makes a person unclean

make you unfit to/before God

15:20b

but eating with unwashed hands does not defile him.”

- But eating without washing the hands according to tradition, this does not make him unclean.”
- If people eat without washing their hands in the proper/correct way, this does not make them unfit/unacceptable to God.”

but: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between what defiles a man (20a) and what does not (20b). The BSB indicates this contrast with the conjunction but.

In some languages, it is not necessary to use a conjunction to indicate the contrast. The context will show the contrast even without a conjunction.

eating with unwashed hands: The term unwashed hands refers to the ceremonial rinsing as in 15:2b. You should translate this term here in the same way that you did there. For example:

to eat without washing your hands as they say
you should (GNT)

to eat without following the correct way to wash
the/your hands

General Comment on 15:17–20

In some languages, it will be more natural to use plural words like “people” or “men” rather than singular words like “person” or “man.” For example:

17 Do you not see that whatever food people eat goes into their stomachs and then into the sewer? 18 But the talk that comes out of peoples’ mouths comes from their hearts and defiles them. 19 Because out of peoples’ hearts come evil thoughts, murder, adultery, sexual immorality, stealing, false witness, speaking evil things about people. 20 These are what defile people. But for people to eat with unwashed hands, this does not defile them.

Matthew 15:21

Section 15:21–28: A Gentile woman strongly believed in Jesus

In this section, Jesus left his own country and met a Gentile woman. This woman had a daughter who was possessed by a demon. At first, Jesus refused to help the woman. He told her that his ministry was to the Jews. But the woman showed persistence and great faith. Jesus rewarded her faith by healing her daughter. He did the healing from a distance by only speaking some words.

This story follows the story about the spiritually “blind” Pharisees. It shows that Gentiles can also have true faith. While Jesus was on the earth, his ministry was primarily to the Jews. But he also ministered to Gentiles.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Faith of a Gentile Woman (NLT)

Jesus Helps a Non-Jewish Woman (NCV)

There is a parallel passage for this section in Mark 7:24–30.

15:21a

Leaving that place, Jesus

- ¶ Then Jesus left that area
- ¶ After that, Jesus and his disciples left that place

The story in 15:21–28 began sometime after the story in 15:1–20 ended. The Greek text does not indicate how much time passed between these two stories. In some languages, it is natural to begin a story with a time word or phrase. If your language is like that, use an expression here that is not too specific. For example:

Then (NLT)

After that

Leaving that place, Jesus: This clause means that Jesus left the area of Gennesaret. He had been in Gennesaret since 14:34. The fact that he went to the district of Tyre and Sidon means that he also left the district of Galilee. That meant that he also left the country of the Jews.

The disciples are with Jesus in 15:23. So the disciples also left the area with him.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus left that place (GNT)

Jesus left Galilee (NLT)

Jesus and his disciples left there

15:21b

withdrew to the district of Tyre and Sidon.

- and retreated to the region of Tyre and Sidon.
- and went to the area around the towns of Tyre and Sidon.

withdrew: The Greek word that the BSB translates as withdrew in this context means “left,” “moved away,” or “went to a safe place.” He withdrew from the con-

flict with the Pharisees. This word also occurs in 12:15a and 14:13b.

The distance he traveled is about 40–50 kilometers (25–30 miles) and over some hills and down to the seacoast. It is a walk of several days.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

and went away (RSV)

went (NET)

the district of Tyre and Sidon: Tyre and Sidon were towns in the country of Phoenicia. Phoenicia was not a Jewish country. The phrase the district of Tyre and Sidon refers to the land around these towns.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the area of Tyre and Sidon (NCV)

the region of Tyre and Sidon (GW)

the territory near the cities of Tyre and Sidon (GNT)

Matthew 15:22

Section 15:21–28: A Gentile woman strongly believed in Jesus

In this section, Jesus left his own country and met a Gentile woman. This woman had a daughter who was possessed by a demon. At first, Jesus refused to help the woman. He told her that his ministry was to the Jews. But the woman showed persistence and great faith. Jesus rewarded her faith by healing her daughter. He did the healing from a distance by only speaking some words.

This story follows the story about the spiritually “blind” Pharisees. It shows that Gentiles can also have true faith. While Jesus was on the earth, his ministry was primarily to the Jews. But he also ministered to Gentiles.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Faith of a Gentile Woman (NLT)

Jesus Helps a Non-Jewish Woman (NCV)

There is a parallel passage for this section in Mark 7:24–30.

15:22a

And a Canaanite woman from that region

- There was a woman of Canaan in that area. She suddenly
- A certain woman lived in that area. She was not a Jew.

The Greek word that the BSB leaves untranslated focuses attention on what follows. It indicates that what follows is important, unexpected, or amazing. Here a person who is not a Jew, and who is a woman, is an example to the disciples of someone with great faith.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Unexpectedly

Suddenly (CEV)

Many English versions do not translate this phrase. In some languages, it will not be natural to translate this phrase either.

a Canaanite woman: The word Canaanite refers to a person whose ancestors lived in the area that the Old Testament called Canaan. Canaan was the land that God promised to give to Abraham’s descendants. When the Israelites came out of Egypt, God told them to destroy all the people of Canaan because of their great sin. A few Canaanites survived. They and the Jews were enemies.

In this passage, instead of acting like an enemy, the Canaanite woman called to Jesus using a Jewish title for the Christ. That was very different from the religious leaders of the Jews. Those leaders should have accepted Jesus as the Christ, but they did not (15:1–20). In some languages, it may be necessary to put some of this information in a footnote.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

A Gentile woman (NLT)

a woman who was not a Jew

from that region: This phrase means that the Canaanite woman was from the area of Tyre and Sidon. Jesus had crossed the border between Israel and Phoenicia and was likely still close to the border. The woman was from that local area.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

from there

from that area (NCV)

who lived there

15:22b

came to Him, crying out,

- came and started shouting,
- As they were walking, she came/approached Jesus and began to shout,

came to Him: This phrase probably indicates that the woman came to Him from out of her house or her village, wanting to talk with Jesus. In some languages, it is more natural to simply say “came.” For example:

A Canaanite woman from that area came to Jesus (NCV)

crying out: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as crying out means “shouting” or “calling out with a loud voice” It does not mean “weeping.” The Greek tense of this verb indicates that the woman probably shouted the following words several times.

The woman was urgently seeking Jesus’ attention. The words she used show that she was respectful to him. She was not trying to be rude.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

pleading (NLT)

started shouting (NRSV)

15:22c

“Lord, Son of David, have mercy on me!”

- “Lord, Son of David! Have pity on me!
- “Master/Sir, descendant of King David! Please pity me and help me!

Before you translate 15:22c, think about the most natural order in your language for the parts of this verse. In the Greek, the phrase “Lord, Son of David” comes after the phrase “have mercy on me.” The BSB puts “Lord, Son of David” first because it is more natural in English. In some languages, it will be more natural to follow the Greek order. For example:

Have mercy on me, O Lord, Son of David (ESV)

Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates literally as Lord means “owner,” “master,” or “ruler.” It refers to someone who has authority over something. The woman probably used this word to politely speak to Jesus. She also showed that she saw him as someone of higher status and greater authority than she had.

Here are some other ways to translate Lord:

Sir

Master

The BSB translates this same Greek term as “Sir” in 13:27b.

Son of David: This is a title that the Jews used for the Christ (the Messiah). They used that title because God promised that the Christ would be a descendant of David. The woman probably learned some things about the Christ from her Jewish neighbors. She used this title to show her respect for Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this title:

the descendant of King David

you grandson of David

See how you translated this same term in 9:27b.

have mercy on me: The woman used these words to politely and indirectly ask Jesus to help her. She did not just want Jesus to pity her. She wanted him to help her by healing her daughter.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

have pity/mercy on me

please pity me and help me

15:22d

My daughter is miserably possessed by a demon.”

- My daughter has a demon, and she is suffering very much.” (NCV)
- A demon is in my daughter. It causes her to suffer greatly!”

My daughter is miserably possessed by a demon: These words indicate that a demon strongly controlled the daughter and was causing her to suffer.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

My daughter has a demon, and she is suffering very much. (NCV)

Please help my daughter. A demon is making her suffer greatly.

Matthew 15:23

Section 15:21–28: A Gentile woman strongly believed in Jesus

In this section, Jesus left his own country and met a Gentile woman. This woman had a daughter who was possessed by a demon. At first, Jesus refused to help the woman. He told her that his ministry was to the Jews. But the woman showed persistence and great faith. Jesus rewarded her faith by healing her daughter. He did the healing from a distance by only speaking some words.

This story follows the story about the spiritually “blind” Pharisees. It shows that Gentiles can also have true faith. While Jesus was on the earth, his ministry was primarily to the Jews. But he also ministered to Gentiles.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Faith of a Gentile Woman (NLT)

Jesus Helps a Non-Jewish Woman (NCV)

There is a parallel passage for this section in Mark 7:24–30.

15:23a

But Jesus did not answer a word.

- However, Jesus did not respond to her.
- He did not say anything to her.

But: We would expect Jesus to respond to the woman’s request, but he did not.

Here is another way to introduce this unexpected response:

However

In some languages, it is not necessary to have a conjunction here. For example:

Jesus did not say a word. (CEV)

Jesus did not answer a word: The Greek word that the BSB literally translates as answer indicates that Jesus did not respond to the woman. She did not ask Jesus a question. So, in some languages, a verb like “respond” is more natural here. For example:

he did not reply

Jesus gave her no reply (NLT)

Jesus did not say a word to her. (GNT)

Jesus did respond to her later in 15:28. So here he was probably testing her faith or persistence. In some languages, it may be natural to say:

At first, Jesus did not reply

15:23b

So His disciples came and urged Him,

- His disciples approached him and said,
- So she continued to shout. Then his disciples approached him and asked him

There is some implied information here. The disciples’ request indicates that the woman continued begging Jesus to have pity on her. In some languages, it may be natural to make this more explicit. For example:

But the woman kept following along and shouting (CEV)

His disciples came: The disciples were already with Jesus. They did not come to him from a distance. In this context, the word came means that they approached Jesus to speak to him. Your translation should not imply that they came from a distance.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

his disciples came near to him

they approached him

and urged Him: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as urged also means “asked” or “begged.”

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

and asked him (CEV)

pleaded with him (NJB)

15:23c

“Send her away, for she keeps crying out after us.”

- “Lord, tell her to leave. She continues following us^(incl) and shouting.”
- to send her away because she was continuing to shout at them.

Send her away: The disciples used these words to politely ask Jesus to tell the woman to leave.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Tell her to go away (NLT)

Please send her away

Lord, dismiss her

for: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as for introduces the reason that the disciples want Jesus to send the woman away.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

because

The reason is that

In some languages, it is more natural to begin a new sentence without using a conjunction. For example:

She keeps shouting behind us. (GW)

she keeps crying out after us: The Greek word that the BSB translates as keeps crying out means “keeps shouting” or “keeps calling out with a loud voice.” (This same word occurs in 15:22b). It does not mean “was weeping.”

The word after implies that the woman was following Jesus and his disciples on the road. She continued to follow them and shout for Jesus to pity her. In some languages, it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

She is following us and shouting (NCV)

General Comment on 15:23c

In some languages, it is more natural to change the order of the two clauses in 15:23c. For example:

She is following us and shouting, so send her away!

Matthew 15:24

Section 15:21–28: A Gentile woman strongly believed in Jesus

In this section, Jesus left his own country and met a Gentile woman. This woman had a daughter who was possessed by a demon. At first, Jesus refused to help the woman. He told her that his ministry was to the Jews. But the woman showed persistence and great faith. Jesus rewarded her faith by healing her daughter. He did the healing from a distance by only speaking some words.

This story follows the story about the spiritually “blind” Pharisees. It shows that Gentiles can also have true faith. While Jesus was on the earth, his ministry was primarily to the Jews. But he also ministered to Gentiles.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Faith of a Gentile Woman (NLT)

Jesus Helps a Non-Jewish Woman (NCV)

There is a parallel passage for this section in Mark 7:24–30.

15:24

He answered, “I was sent only to the lost sheep of the house of Israel.”

- He answered, “I was sent only to the people of Israel. They are like lost sheep.”
- He replied, “I was sent by God to help only the people of Israel. They are like lost sheep.”
- Jesus responded and said, “It is only to the people of Israel that God sent me. It is them whom I must help/rescue.”

He answered: There are several ways to interpret these words:

1. Jesus was talking to both his disciples and the woman. He was answering the disciples and intended the woman to also hear what he said.
2. Jesus was talking to his disciples. He agreed with them that the woman should be sent away. He thought that because he was sent to Israelites, not to Canaanites like her.
3. Jesus was talking to the woman. He was telling her that he would not help her because he had been sent only to Israel. For example:

Then Jesus said to the woman (NLT)

It is recommended that you not say who Jesus was talking to. You should leave it vague as most English versions do. For example:

Jesus said (CEV)

I was sent only to the lost sheep of the house of Israel: In Greek, this sentence is more literally “I was not sent to anyone except to the lost sheep of the house of Israel.” Also, the phrase to the lost sheep of the house of Israel is emphasized in the Greek.

Here are some other ways to translate this sentence:

I was sent to no one except the lost sheep of the nation of Israel

It is only to the lost sheep of Israel that I was sent

I was sent: This clause is passive. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive clause like in the BSB.
- As an active clause. For example:

God sent me (NCV)

to the lost sheep of the house of Israel: This is a metaphor. In this metaphor, Jesus compared the Israelites/Jews to lost sheep. They are like lost sheep in the sense that they need to be saved or rescued.

Here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

I was sent only to the lost sheep of the nation of Israel. (GW)

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

I was sent only to the people of Israel! They are like a flock of lost sheep. (CEV)

- Change the metaphor to a simile and make explicit the way that they are similar. For example:

I was sent only to the nation of Israel. They are like lost sheep who need to be saved/rescued.

I was sent only to help the people of Israel. They are like lost sheep.

- Translate the meaning of the metaphor without using a figure of speech. For example:

I was sent only to the people of Israel. They are lost and need to be saved/rescued.

the house of Israel: This phrase refers to “the nation of Israel,” “the people of Israel” or more simply “the Jews.” For example:

the nation of Israel (GW)

the people of Israel (CEV)

Matthew 15:25

Section 15:21–28: A Gentile woman strongly believed in Jesus

In this section, Jesus left his own country and met a Gentile woman. This woman had a daughter who was possessed by a demon. At first, Jesus refused to help the woman. He told her that his ministry was to the Jews. But the woman showed persistence and great faith. Jesus rewarded her faith by healing her daughter. He did the healing from a distance by only speaking some words.

This story follows the story about the spiritually “blind” Pharisees. It shows that Gentiles can also have true faith. While Jesus was on the earth, his ministry was primarily to the Jews. But he also ministered to Gentiles.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Faith of a Gentile Woman (NLT)

Jesus Helps a Non-Jewish Woman (NCV)

There is a parallel passage for this section in Mark 7:24–30.

15:25a

The woman came and knelt before Him.

- But the woman approached Jesus and got down on her knees in front of him,
- However, the woman came around in front of him and bowed with her face to the ground.

We might expect the woman to accept what Jesus said and go away. But she did not. Many English versions introduce what the woman did with the conjunction “But.”

Here are some other ways to introduce this unexpected behavior:

However

Then (NLT)

Some English versions like the BSB do not have a conjunction here. In some languages, a conjunction will not be necessary either.

The woman came and knelt before Him: The woman was following behind Jesus. But now she moved around and got in front of him.

The Greek word that the BSB translates as knelt before means “prostrate oneself.” To prostrate oneself means to kneel and then put one’s face down on the ground with hands outstretched. This shows submission to a greater person.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

she came around before him and got on her knees in front of Jesus

the woman approached him and kneeled with her face to the ground in humility

15:25b

“Lord, help me!” she said.

- and said, “Lord, help me.”
- She said, “Sir, please help me.”

Lord, help me: The woman used these words to respectfully, but urgently, ask Jesus to help her. You should translate this request in your language in a way that shows respect. For example:

Lord/Sir, please help me.

Matthew 15:26

Section 15:21–28: A Gentile woman strongly believed in Jesus

In this section, Jesus left his own country and met a Gentile woman. This woman had a daughter who was possessed by a demon. At first, Jesus refused to help the woman. He told her that his ministry was

to the Jews. But the woman showed persistence and great faith. Jesus rewarded her faith by healing her daughter. He did the healing from a distance by only speaking some words.

This story follows the story about the spiritually “blind” Pharisees. It shows that Gentiles can also have true faith. While Jesus was on the earth, his ministry was primarily to the Jews. But he also ministered to Gentiles.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Faith of a Gentile Woman (NLT)

Jesus Helps a Non-Jewish Woman (NCV)

There is a parallel passage for this section in Mark 7:24–30.

15:26a–b

But Jesus replied, “It is not right to take the children’s bread and toss it to the dogs.” Jesus responded to the women’s request by telling a parable. In this parable the “children” represent the Jews. The dogs represent the non-Jewish peoples of the world. The term bread refers to things that will benefit people. (In this context it refers specifically to the help that Jesus gave to people by healing them.) Jesus told the woman that he was in the world to give help to the Jews first. It was not proper for him to give these things to non-Jews before he gave them to Jews.

The meaning is clearer in the book of Mark. Mark includes the clause “First let the children have their fill” (Mark 7:27a). The dogs were fed later.

In some languages, it will be good to include a footnote to explain the meaning of the parable.

15:26a

But Jesus replied, “It is not right to take the children’s bread

- He replied, “It is not good/proper to take the children’s bread/food
- Jesus answered with a parable, “It is bad to give/feed the food for children

But Jesus replied: Jesus responded to the woman’s request by telling a parable. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

He answered with a parable

It is not right: The Greek word that the BSB translates as right also means “good.” For example:

It is not good (NASB)

It is not proper/fit

It is bad

to take the children’s bread: This phrase refers to “taking” or “picking up” bread that is set aside for children. Jesus says it is bad to not give the bread to children to eat, and give it to dogs instead. This phrase does not refer to “grabbing bread away from” children after it has already been given to them.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

to take the bread for children

to pick up the food of children

See the General Comment after 15:26b for another way to translate the verb take.

bread: Bread was the main food of the people who lived in that area at the time of Jesus. Here the word bread is used in a figurative sense to refer to all food. If the people in your area do not commonly eat bread, it may be more natural to translate the word bread as “food.” For example:

food (GW)

15:26b

and toss it to the dogs.”

- and throw/toss it to dogs.”
- to house dogs.”

and toss it to the dogs: The Greek word that the BSB translates as toss refers to the way that people gave food to dogs. In some languages, it is more natural to use another verb. For example:

and give it to the dogs (NCV)

and feed it to dogs (CEV)

Some languages have one word for “wild dogs” and another word for “house dogs.” If your language is

like that, you should use the word that means “house dogs.”

General Comment on 15:26a–b.

The Greek uses two verbs to describe what happens to the bread. It uses “take” in 15:26a and “toss” in 15:26b. In some languages, it may be more natural to translate the two verbs as one verb. For example:

to give children’s bread to dogs

to throw/toss children’s food to dogs

Matthew 15:27

Section 15:21–28: A Gentile woman strongly believed in Jesus

In this section, Jesus left his own country and met a Gentile woman. This woman had a daughter who was possessed by a demon. At first, Jesus refused to help the woman. He told her that his ministry was to the Jews. But the woman showed persistence and great faith. Jesus rewarded her faith by healing her daughter. He did the healing from a distance by only speaking some words.

This story follows the story about the spiritually “blind” Pharisees. It shows that Gentiles can also have true faith. While Jesus was on the earth, his ministry was primarily to the Jews. But he also ministered to Gentiles.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Faith of a Gentile Woman (NLT)

Jesus Helps a Non-Jewish Woman (NCV)

There is a parallel passage for this section in Mark 7:24–30.

15:27a

“Yes, Lord,” she said,

- She said, “Lord, I agree.
- She said, “Sir, that is right/true.

Yes, Lord: The woman used the word Yes to show that she agreed with Jesus. In some languages, it will be more natural to make this explicit. For example:

Lord, that’s true (CEV)

Yes, Lord, I know (JBP)

Sir, I agree

15:27b

“even the dogs eat the crumbs that fall from their master’s table.”

- But even the dogs eat the crumbs that fall off their owner’s table.”
- However, even the house dogs eat the little bits of food that fall on the ground/floor when their owners are eating.”

even the dogs: The Greek word that the BSB translates as even is used for emphasis. It emphasizes that those who were not children (that is, the dogs), were allowed to eat some of the children’s food.

Here is another way to translate this phrase is to begin it with “but.” For example:

but even dogs (CEV)

eat the crumbs: There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as crumbs:

1. It means crumbs. It refers to the small pieces of food that accidentally fall to the floor while eating. For example:

crumbs (NLT96) (BSB, RSV, NIV, ESV, NET, NLT96, NASB, CEV, KJV, NCV)

1. It means leftovers or scraps of food. It refers to the pieces of food that are not eaten. For example:

the scraps (NLT)

the leftovers (GNT) (GNT, NJB, REB, GW, JBP, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This interpretation makes the most sense in this context.

that fall from their master’s table: The Greek word that the BSB translates as master’s is the same word that is usually translated “Lord.” Here it refers to the owners of the dogs. Use whichever term that is natural in this context.

In Greek, the word master’s is plural. In some languages, it may be more natural to use a singular word here, as the BSB does. In other languages, it may be natural to follow the Greek and use a plural word here. For example:

their masters' table (ESV)

In some cultures where food is not placed on a table to be eaten, it will be more natural to say:

that fall on the ground/floor when their owners are eating

Matthew 15:28

Section 15:21–28: A Gentile woman strongly believed in Jesus

In this section, Jesus left his own country and met a Gentile woman. This woman had a daughter who was possessed by a demon. At first, Jesus refused to help the woman. He told her that his ministry was to the Jews. But the woman showed persistence and great faith. Jesus rewarded her faith by healing her daughter. He did the healing from a distance by only speaking some words.

This story follows the story about the spiritually “blind” Pharisees. It shows that Gentiles can also have true faith. While Jesus was on the earth, his ministry was primarily to the Jews. But he also ministered to Gentiles.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Faith of a Gentile Woman (NLT)

Jesus Helps a Non-Jewish Woman (NCV)

There is a parallel passage for this section in Mark 7:24–30.

15:28a

“O woman,” Jesus answered, “your faith is great!

- Then Jesus said to her, “Madam/sister, your faith is great!”
- Then Jesus replied, “You are a woman who believes/trusts very strongly in me.

O: The Greek word that the BSB translates as O has several functions. One of its functions is to show the emotions of the speaker. Here, this word probably shows that the woman’s faith pleased/impressed Jesus. A modern English equivalent might be the expression “Wow!”

Many English versions do not translate this word.

woman: In Greek, this word is a respectful title to use when speaking to a woman. Jesus used the same title with his mother (John 2:4, 19:26). Use a respectful title

that a man would use to speak a woman whom he did not know.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Dear woman (CEV)

Ma’am/Madam

My sister/daughter

In some languages, it may be more natural to say something about the woman instead of using it as a title. For example:

You are a woman of great faith (GNT)

your faith is great: This clause means that the woman’s belief/trust in Jesus was very strong/firm. Jesus had refused to help the woman three times. But the woman refused to give up. She was convinced that Jesus could help her.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

your faith is great (NLT)

you really do have a lot of faith (CEV)

you believe/trust in me very strongly

You truly believe in me

15:28b

Let it be done for you as you desire.”

- The thing that you wanted will be done for you!”
- I will do what you asked.” (NLT)

Let it be done for you as you desire: By saying these words, Jesus did a miracle and healed the woman’s daughter. This type of statement is similar to “let there be light” in Genesis. When God or Jesus said words like this, the thing happened.

This statement is more than just a wish or a blessing. It is a command that the daughter be healed.

Here the word it refers to the woman’s request that Jesus have mercy on her daughter and heal her.

This clause is passive. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive clause. For example:

the thing that you want, may/let it happen

What you wanted will be done for you (GW)

you will be given what you want (CEV)

- Use an active clause. For example:

I will do what you asked. (NLT)

A similar statement is found in 8:13a–b where Jesus heals the centurion’s servant. Another statement like that is found in 9:29a–b where Jesus heals the ten lepers.

15:28c

And her daughter was healed from that very hour.

- As a result, her daughter was immediately healed.
- As soon as Jesus said that, her daughter became well.

her daughter was healed: The daughter was delivered of her demon possession. You should use the verb in your language that normally refers to a healing or delivering from a demon.

This clause is passive. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive clause. For example:

Her daughter was restored to health (REB)

her daughter was freed from the demon

- Use a clause that is not passive. For example:

Jesus healed her daughter

the demon left her daughter and she became well

from that very hour: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as from that very hour means “at that moment” or “immediately.” The healing happened as soon as Jesus said the words in 15:28b.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

at that very moment (GNT)

immediately

as soon as Jesus said that

Matthew 15:29

Section 15:29–31: Jesus healed many people

In this short section, Jesus healed many people with different kinds of physical problems.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus healed many kinds of illnesses

Jesus made many people well

15:29a–b

Moving on from there, Jesus went along the Sea of Galilee: Jesus’ trip probably had three parts:

1. He left the region of Tyre and Sidon
2. He traveled several days and came to the Sea of Galilee
3. He walked part of the way around the Sea of Galilee. He stopped when he arrived at the base of a mountain that was beside the sea.

The disciples went with Jesus, but they are not mentioned because the focus is on Jesus. In some languages, it may be more natural to mention the disciples.

Also, part (b) of the trip is left implied in the BSB and other English versions. In some languages, it may be more natural to make this part more explicit. For example:

Then Jesus left there and traveled to the Sea of Galilee and walked beside it

Jesus and the disciples left the region of Tyre and Sidon and went/returned to the Sea of Galilee and walked part way around it

15:29a

Moving on from there, Jesus

- ¶ When Jesus left there,
- ¶ Then Jesus and his disciples left that region and

Moving on from there: This phrase means that Jesus and his disciples left the area of Tyre and Sidon.

Before Jesus had gone to the district of Tyre and Sidon (in 15:21b), he was in Gennesaret. Gennesaret is on the northwest shore of Lake Galilee. So here in this verse, when Jesus left Tyre and Sidon, he “returned” to the

area around Lake Galilee. In some languages, it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

Jesus returned to the Sea of Galilee (NLT)

Jesus left that area and returned to Lake Galilee

15:29b went along the Sea of Galilee.

- he went to the Sea of Galilee and walked beside it.
- returned to Lake Galilee. When they arrived there, they began to walk along its shore

the Sea of Galilee: Here, the Greek word that the BSB translates as Sea refers to a large freshwater lake. This lake is 23 kilometers long and 10 kilometers wide (14 miles long and 6 miles wide).

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

Lake Galilee (GNT)

Use the same expression for Sea as you did in 4:13b and 13:1b.

15:29c Then He went up on a mountain and sat down.

- Then he went part way up a hill/mountain and sat down.
- and then climbed up the side of a hill/mountain and sat down. While he was sitting there,

He went up on a mountain: The word mountain refers to a hill or a mountain about 500 meters high. In some languages, it is more natural to say “climbed” a mountain. For example:

He climbed a hill (GNT)

The phrase went up on a mountain also occurs in 14:23b. As is mentioned there, this phrase indicates that Jesus went at least part way up the side of a mountain. It does not say if he went to the top of the mountain. For example:

Then he went up on a mountainside (NIV)

and sat down: The Greek tense indicates that Jesus sat down and stayed sitting for some time. While he sat there, news of his arrival spread and the crowds brought their sick people (15:30). If it is natural in your language, you may want to indicate that he was sitting for some time. For example:

was sitting (NASB)

sat down. While he was sitting there

The Greek does not indicate why Jesus sat down. Many times, the words sat down indicate that Jesus was preparing to teach. However, here, Matthew only says that he healed people. Perhaps Jesus just sat down to rest. Here, you should not say why he sat down.

Matthew 15:30

Section 15:29–31: Jesus healed many people

In this short section, Jesus healed many people with different kinds of physical problems.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus healed many kinds of illnesses

Jesus made many people well

15:30a Large crowds came to Him, bringing

- Many crowds came to him and brought
- many people came to him. They came with

Large crowds: The Greek phrase the BSB translates as Large crowds can be translated more literally as “many crowds.” The plural crowds perhaps indicates that groups of people came from different areas. Perhaps one group came from one town, and another group came from another town.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

many groups of people

many people

15:30b the lame, the blind,

- paralyzed people, and blind people
- people who could not walk properly, and people who could not see,

the lame: The word lame refers to those who could not walk or use their legs well. There was something wrong with one or both legs.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the crippled

people who had crippled legs

those with bad legs

those who could not walk well

This word also occurs in 11:5a.

15:30c
the crippled, the mute,

- and handicapped people, and mute people,
- and people whose arm or leg was ruined/dried, and people who could not talk,

the crippled: The word crippled refers to people who have something wrong with an arm or a leg. Their arm or leg was deformed in some way. Or they may be missing part of an arm or a leg.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

the maimed (RSV)

those with ruined limbs

the handicapped

the mute: The word mute refers to people who are unable to talk. The RSV, GNT and NJB use the word “dumb,” which in this context, means the same as mute. Here it does not mean “stupid.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

those unable to talk

15:30d
and many others,

- and many other afflicted people.
- and many other people who were handicapped and sick.

many others: This phrase refers to other people who had other types of handicaps. It may also refer to those who had diseases. And it may also refer to people who were demon possessed. Some languages use different words for people who are handicapped, those who are sick with diseases, and those who are demon possessed. So it may be necessary to use two or more different expressions here. For example:

many other afflicted people

many other people who had handicaps and who were sick

15:30e
and laid them at His feet, and He healed them.

- They placed them in front of Jesus, and he healed them.
- They put them all before Jesus, and he healed them and made them all well.

and laid them at His feet: This clause means “they placed the handicapped people in front of Jesus.” For example:

They placed them...in front of Jesus (CEV)

and He healed them: Jesus miraculously healed everyone who was handicapped and everyone who was sick. He immediately made each person well. He did not heal them like a doctor heals.

As mentioned above, some languages use different words for people who are sick with a disease and people who are handicapped. In these languages, the verb healed may refer only to curing those who had a disease. Such languages may need to use a second verb to refer to Jesus restoring handicapped people. Or there may be a more general term to cover both. For example:

he made them all well

he miraculously healed them and made them well

Matthew 15:31

Section 15:29–31: Jesus healed many people

In this short section, Jesus healed many people with different kinds of physical problems.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus healed many kinds of illnesses

Jesus made many people well

15:31a
The crowd was amazed

- As a result, the crowd was amazed

- The people were astonished at what they heard and saw.

The Greek begins this verse with a conjunction that BSB leaves untranslated but that some English versions translate as “so that.” It means “for this reason, therefore, so.” This conjunction indicates that 15:31 is the result of 15:30.

Here are some other ways to begin this verse:

- Use a conjunction. For example:

As a result (NET)

Therefore/So

- Begin the verse without any conjunction. For example:

The people were amazed when they saw the mute speaking... (NIV)

The crowd: This phrase refers to the same people as the “large crowds” of 15:30a. The expression you use here should refer to the same group of people.

was amazed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as was amazed indicates that the people were amazed.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

were amazed (NIV)

were astonished (NJB)

marveled (NASB)

15:31b when they saw the mute speaking,

- to see mute people speaking,
- They heard people talking who were not able to talk before.

they saw the mute speaking: The crowd saw each type of handicapped person (the mute, crippled, lame, and blind) healed and functioning normally. In some languages, it may be more natural to say that the crowd “heard” the mute speaking rather than say that they saw the mute speaking. For example:

they heard the mute speaking. They saw...

Everyone was amazed at what they saw and heard. (CEV)

15:31c the crippled restored,

- and handicapped people made whole/complete,
- They saw people with ruined/dried arms and legs who now became well,

the crippled restored: The Greek word that the BSB translates as restored means “whole,” or “undamaged.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the maimed made whole/complete

they saw the handicapped made healthy

the crippled restored (NASB)

the crippled made well (NIV)

15:31d the lame walking,

- and lame people walking,
- and saw people walking normally who were not able to walk properly before,

15:31e and the blind seeing.

- and blind people seeing.
- and saw people seeing who were not able to see before.

15:31f And they glorified the God of Israel.

- So they praised the God of the people of Israel.
- As a result, they honored the God whom the Jews worship.

they: The pronoun they refers to the crowds. They are the same people who were amazed in 15:31a. The people whom Jesus healed probably also glorified God. But here the focus is on the crowds who saw all these miracles.

glorified: The Greek word that the BSB translates as glorified means “spoke well about.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

praised (NIV)

honored

spoke highly of

the God of Israel: The term Israel here refers to the “people of Israel.” Also the use of the word of indicates that the people of Israel have a relationship with God. It does not mean that God belongs only to Israel.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

God of the people/nation of Israel

God of the Jews/Israelites

God whom the people of Israel worship

General Comment on 15:31

It may be more natural in your language to list the people healed first and then the reaction of the crowd. Here is an example:

Therefore, the mute were now speaking, and the crippled were now well, and the lame were now walking and the blind were now seeing. The crowds saw all this and were astonished, and they praised the God of Israel.

Matthew 15:32

Section 15:32–39: Jesus provided food for over four thousand people

In this section, Jesus miraculously provided food for over four thousand people. He did something similar in 14:13–21. In both of these stories Jesus began with only a small amount of food, but he caused it to miraculously multiply so there was enough for all of them to eat. Matthew told us the number of the men only, even though many women and children were also there and ate.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Feeding the Four Thousand (NRSV)

Four Thousand Fed (NASB)

There is a parallel passage for this section in Mark 8:1–10.

15:32a

Then Jesus called His disciples to Him and said,

- ¶ Then Jesus called his disciples together. He said,
- ¶ Then Jesus called his disciples to come to him. When they gathered, he said,

Then: The events in this paragraph occurred soon after the events in 15:29–31. Here is another way to indicate this:

After that

Jesus called His disciples to Him and said: The Greek word that the BSB translates as called means “summoned.” It is implied that Jesus called/summoned his disciples to talk to them. It is also implied that after Jesus called his disciples, they came. Then he spoke the words of 15:32b.

This clause does not imply that Jesus called his disciples to him from a distant place. They disciples were already with Jesus. They traveled with Jesus wherever he went.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus called his disciples to come together. When they gathered, he said

Jesus called to his disciples, and they gathered to him. Then he said

15:32b

“I have compassion for this crowd,

- “I pity this group of people,
- “I feel sorry for these people.

I have compassion for this crowd: The Greek word that the BSB translates as have compassion means “feel sympathy or pity for the troubles that others have.” A person with compassion wants to help other people. Jesus understood that the people would have difficulty returning home because of their hunger. So he pitied them and wanted to help them.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I pity the crowd of people

I feel sorry for these people (GNT)

You may have an idiomatic way to translate this term. The JBP has one example in English:

My heart goes out to this crowd (JBP)

this crowd: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the crowd refers to the large crowds that were mentioned in 15:30a.

15:32c

because they have already been with Me three days and have nothing to eat.

- because they have been here with me for three days and have no food.
- This is now the third day that they are here with me, and they have nothing to eat.

because: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as because introduces the reason for Jesus having compassion (15:32b). In some languages, it may be more natural to put 15:32c before 15:32b. For example:

^{32c}The crowd has been with me now three days. They have had nothing to eat. ^{32b}That is why I have compassion on them.

they have already been with Me three days: The counting of the days included the day on which Jesus spoke. So he was referring to the day he spoke, the day before, and the day before that.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

this is the third day that they have been with me

have nothing to eat: The Greek does not say how long the people were without food. It was perhaps only the last day. Or perhaps they did not have anything to eat since they came to Jesus. Many English translations are also vague about this. It is recommended that you follow the BSB and other translations and translate in a general way. For example:

don't have anything to eat (CEV)

they have nothing left to eat (NLT)

15:32d

I do not want to send them away hungry,

- I do not want to dismiss them when they are hungry,
- I do not want to tell them to go home while they are hungry.

I do not want to send them away hungry: In this context, the Greek word that the BSB translates as send...away refers to telling the crowd go home. It does not mean "chase away."

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I do not want to send them away hungry (NIV)

I do not want to dismiss them while they are hungry.

15:32e

or they may faint along the way."

- so that they might not collapse on the way home."
- If I do, they may lose consciousness from hunger while walking/going home."

or: The Greek word that the BSB translates as or means "otherwise," "so that not," or "in order that not." This gives the purpose for not wanting to send the crowd away hungry. Jesus did not want them to go away if they would faint because of their hunger.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

so that not

if I do send them away like that

they may faint: The Greek word that the BSB translates as faint means "become exhausted" or "collapse." It refers to being unable to complete the journey because of hunger.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

they may collapse (NIV)

they may become exhausted (GW)

they may lose consciousness

along the way: The phrase on the way refers to the journey that the people would make in order to go home.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

while they are on their way home

while they are walking/going home

Matthew 15:33

Section 15:32–39: Jesus provided food for over four thousand people

In this section, Jesus miraculously provided food for over four thousand people. He did something similar in 14:13–21. In both of these stories Jesus began with only a small amount of food, but he caused it to miraculously multiply so there was enough for all of them to eat. Matthew told us the number of the men only, even though many women and children were also there and ate.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Feeding the Four Thousand (NRSV)

Four Thousand Fed (NASB)

There is a parallel passage for this section in Mark 8:1–10.

15:33a

The disciples replied,

- His disciples asked,
- His disciples responded/replied,

The disciples replied: The word replied introduces the disciples' response to what Jesus had just said. Their response is a question.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

The disciples asked him (GNT)

the disciples said to him (ESV)

15:33b

“Where in this desolate place could we find enough bread to feed such a large crowd?”

- “Where will we find enough food in this desert to feed this crowd?” (GNT)
- “This place is like a desert. Where can we find enough food to feed such a crowd?” (CEV)
- “There is certainly no place here in this wilderness where we^(incl) can find enough food to satisfy/fill so many people.”

Where in this desolate place could we find enough bread to feed such a large crowd?: This is a rhetorical question. It expresses an objection. The disciples did not agree with Jesus' idea. They wanted him to send the people home. They implied that it would be

impossible to find enough food in that remote place to feed that large crowd.

Here are some other ways to translate this objection:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Where will we find enough food in this desert to feed this crowd? (GNT)

- As a statement. For example:

There is certainly no place here in the wilderness where we could find enough food to feed so many people!

- As a statement and a rhetorical question. For example:

This place is like a desert. Where can we find enough food to feed such a crowd? (CEV)

How can we get enough bread to feed all these people? We are far away from any town. (NCV)

Translate this objection in a way that is natural in your language.

in this desolate place: The Greek word that the BSB translates as desolate place is literally “the desert.” In this context, it refers to an area where no one lived. It was a place that was far from any town or village.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

here in the wilderness (NLT)

in this place where no one lives (GW)

bread: The Greek word that the BSB translates as bread is literally “loaves.” It refers to loaves of bread. These loaves were pieces or units of bread, probably cooked in a round shape like buns or rolls. Bread was the main food of the Jewish people.

Here it is possible to use the more general word “food.” For example:

food (CEV)

However, you may need to use a more specific term for “bread” in 15:34a and 15:36.

In Matthew, this word first occurs in 4:3c. It also occurs in 14:17. See how you translated this word there.

to feed such a large crowd: The Greek word that the BSB translates as to feed can also mean “to satisfy, fill.” This same word also occurs in 15:37a where it is translated as “satisfied.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

to satisfy such a large crowd (NASB)

to feed all these people (NCV)

to give such a crowd enough food to satisfy them

Matthew 15:34

Section 15:32–39: Jesus provided food for over four thousand people

In this section, Jesus miraculously provided food for over four thousand people. He did something similar in 14:13–21. In both of these stories Jesus began with only a small amount of food, but he caused it to miraculously multiply so there was enough for all of them to eat. Matthew told us the number of the men only, even though many women and children were also there and ate.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Feeding the Four Thousand (NRSV)

Four Thousand Fed (NASB)

There is a parallel passage for this section in Mark 8:1–10.

15:34a

“How many loaves do you have?” Jesus asked.

- Then Jesus asked them, “How much bread/food do you^(plur) have?”
- Jesus asked, “Tell me how much food you have.”

How many loaves do you have?: This is a real question, not a rhetorical question. Jesus wanted his disciples to find out how much bread they already had.

loaves: This is the same word in Greek as the word that the BSB translates as “bread” in 15:33. It can refer to food in general or specifically to “bread.” Since it is not natural in English to use the plural of “bread,” the BSB translates this word as loaves.

Jesus likely used the word in the same general sense as the disciples did in 15:33b.

15:34b

“Seven,” they replied, “and a few small fish.”

- They said, “Seven breads and a few small fish.”
- They answered, “We^(excl) have seven loaves of bread. We^(excl) also have a few small fish.”

Seven: In the Greek, the word translated Seven refers to “seven loaves of bread.” Here it will probably be necessary to use a specific term for bread rather than a general word for food.

These loaves of bread probably refer to flat breads. One person could eat three to five of these loaves at one meal. It was the common food for a meal.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

seven loaves of bread

seven small breads

and a few small fish: The word that the BSB translates as fish refers here to fresh-water fish that have been salted or dried so that they were ready to eat.

Jesus asked the disciples how much bread they had. They answered that question. Plus, they added that they had a few fish.

Matthew 15:35

Section 15:32–39: Jesus provided food for over four thousand people

In this section, Jesus miraculously provided food for over four thousand people. He did something similar in 14:13–21. In both of these stories Jesus began with only a small amount of food, but he caused it to miraculously multiply so there was enough for all of them to eat. Matthew told us the number of the men only, even though many women and children were also there and ate.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Feeding the Four Thousand (NRSV)

Four Thousand Fed (NASB)

There is a parallel passage for this section in Mark 8:1–10.

15:35

And He instructed the crowd to sit down on the ground.

- Then he told the crowd to sit on the ground.
- Then he instructed the people to sit on the ground for eating.

And: In Greek, 15:35 begins with a common conjunction that the BSB translates as *And*. Here it introduces what Jesus did next.

Here are some other ways to begin this verse:

Then (NRSV)

After that

The NIV and some other English versions do not translate this word. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this word either.

He instructed the crowd to sit down on the ground:

The Greek word that the BSB translates as *instructed* also means “gave orders” or “commanded.” It indicates that Jesus gave instructions to the large crowd. Your translation of the word *instructed* should not imply that Jesus was speaking harshly to the people.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus told all the people to sit down on the ground (NLT)

In some languages it may be more natural to use a causative expression for this phrase. For example:

caused the people to sit down

to sit down: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *sit down* is literally to “recline.” To recline is to sit and then lean over on the left elbow with legs outstretched to the right. This was the normal Jewish position for eating.

You may want to use the usual position that people use when they eat in your culture. This is what most English versions do.

on the ground: Jesus told the people to sit on the ground because he was about to give them food. They were in the wilderness, so they had to sit on the ground.

In some languages it may be unnecessary to specify “on the ground,” since it may be clear from the con-

text. If that is true in your language, you may leave this phrase implicit. For example:

He told the people to sit down

Matthew 15:36

Section 15:32–39: Jesus provided food for over four thousand people

In this section, Jesus miraculously provided food for over four thousand people. He did something similar in 14:13–21. In both of these stories Jesus began with only a small amount of food, but he caused it to miraculously multiply so there was enough for all of them to eat. Matthew told us the number of the men only, even though many women and children were also there and ate.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Feeding the Four Thousand (NRSV)

Four Thousand Fed (NASB)

There is a parallel passage for this section in Mark 8:1–10.

15:36a

Taking the seven loaves and the fish,

- He took the seven breads and the fish,
- He got the seven loaves of breads and the fish from the disciples.

Taking the seven loaves and the fish: This clause indicates that Jesus took the loaves of bread and the fish from the disciples. Then he held them in his hands while he gave thanks for them.

15:36b

He gave thanks

- and said thanks to God.
- Then he thanked God for the food.

He gave thanks: These words mean that Jesus thanked God for the food. For example:

gave thanks to God (GNT)

thanked God for them (NLT)

and thanked God for the food

15:36c

and broke them. Then He gave them to the disciples,

- Then he broke them and gave the pieces to his disciples,
- Then he broke the bread and fish in pieces and began giving the pieces to his disciples,

broke them: This clause means that Jesus broke/tore the bread and the fish into pieces.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

and broke them into pieces (NLT)

he divided the food (NCV)

Some languages may have one verb for breaking bread, and another verb for breaking fish. You should use the words that are natural in your language.

gave them: The tense of the verb gave probably indicates a repeated or continued giving. Jesus miraculously multiplied the pieces of bread and fish as he was giving them to his disciples.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

started giving them (NASB)

began handing them (NJB)

15:36d

and the disciples gave them to the people.

- and the disciples distributed them to the people.
- and they shared/divided the pieces among the people.

and the disciples gave them to the people: In Greek, this phrase is more literally “and the disciples to the crowds.” The words gave and them are implied.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

who distributed the food to the crowd (NLT)

the disciples shared/divided the pieces among the people

Matthew 15:37

Section 15:32–39: Jesus provided food for over four thousand people

In this section, Jesus miraculously provided food for over four thousand people. He did something similar in 14:13–21. In both of these stories Jesus began with only a small amount of food, but he caused it to miraculously multiply so there was enough for all of them to eat. Matthew told us the number of the men only, even though many women and children were also there and ate.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Feeding the Four Thousand (NRSV)

Four Thousand Fed (NASB)

There is a parallel passage for this section in Mark 8:1–10.

15:37a

They all ate and were satisfied,

- They all ate until they satisfied/full.
- Everyone ate as much as they wanted to eat.

They all ate and were satisfied: The word satisfied indicates that everyone had plenty of food to eat. They all ate as much food as they wanted to eat.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

They all ate and had enough (GNT)

They all ate as much as they wanted (NJB)

They all ate until they were full (NLT96)

This same expression occurs in 14:20a.

15:37b

and the disciples picked up seven basketfuls of broken pieces that were left over.

- The food that remained filled seven large baskets.
- Then the disciples picked up the food that was left and filled seven large baskets with it.

and: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as and introduces what happened next in the story.

Here are some other ways to begin this part of the story:

Afterward (NIV)

Then (NCV)

the disciples picked up seven basketfuls of broken pieces that were left over: In Greek, this clause is more literally “and the leftovers of the fragments of food were seven basketfuls.” This clause refers to the pieces of bread and fish that were left after the crowd ate. This leftover food filled seven baskets. It shows how much food Jesus provided for the people. He gave them more than they could eat.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Follow the model of the CEV and do not say anything about who picked up the leftovers. For example:

the leftovers filled seven large baskets

- Follow the model of the BSB and say something about those who picked up the leftovers. This is what most English versions do. For example:

Then his followers filled seven baskets with the leftover pieces of food. (NCV)

The disciples picked up the leftover pieces and filled seven large baskets. (GW)

the disciples: The Greek text does not say who gathered the broken pieces. The crowd may have helped. But the disciples were probably the main ones responsible. In some languages, it may be natural to make this explicit like the BSB.

picked up: The BSB has supplied the verb picked up to indicate how the baskets were filled. This is the verb used in 14:20b when the disciples picked up the food remaining from the five thousand people.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

took up (ESV)

filled (NCV)

basketfuls: The Greek word that the BSB here translates as basketfuls refers to a certain type of basket that is larger than the baskets that are mentioned in 14:20b. Use the word or expression here that refers to large baskets. For example:

seven large baskets (CEV)

broken pieces: The broken pieces refer to the pieces of bread and fish that the people did not eat. This term does not refer to crumbs that had fallen to the ground.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

leftover pieces (GW)

the leftover pieces of food (NCV)

food that remained

This same term occurs in 14:20b.

Matthew 15:38

Section 15:32–39: Jesus provided food for over four thousand people

In this section, Jesus miraculously provided food for over four thousand people. He did something similar in 14:13–21. In both of these stories Jesus began with only a small amount of food, but he caused it to miraculously multiply so there was enough for all of them to eat. Matthew told us the number of the men only, even though many women and children were also there and ate.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Feeding the Four Thousand (NRSV)

Four Thousand Fed (NASB)

There is a parallel passage for this section in Mark 8:1–10.

15:38a

A total of four thousand men were fed,

- There were about four thousand men there who ate,
- The number of people who ate the food was four thousand men.

A total of four thousand men were fed: The Greek indicates that, among the people who ate, only the men were counted.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

There were 4,000 men who were fed that day (NLT)

The number of men who ate was four thousand (GNT)

were fed: While the BSB translates this clause as passive, it is active in Greek, and in some languages it may be more natural to translate it as active. For example:

Those who ate were four thousand men (ESV)

15:38b

in addition to women and children.

- in addition to the women and children there who also ate.
- They did not count the women and children who also ate.

in addition to women and children: The phrase in addition to indicates that women and children were there and ate, but they were not included in the count. There were probably as many women and children there as men. It is possible that there were even more women and children than men. Your translation should not imply that there were no women or children there.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

not counting the women and children (GNT)

in addition to all the women and children (NLT)

which didn't include the women and children who also ate

Matthew 15:39

Section 15:32–39: Jesus provided food for over four thousand people

In this section, Jesus miraculously provided food for over four thousand people. He did something similar in 14:13–21. In both of these stories Jesus began with only a small amount of food, but he caused it to miraculously multiply so there was enough for all of them to eat. Matthew told us the number of the men only, even though many women and children were also there and ate.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Feeding the Four Thousand (NRSV)

Four Thousand Fed (NASB)

There is a parallel passage for this section in Mark 8:1–10.

15:39a

After Jesus had dismissed the crowds,

- After Jesus let the crowd go home,
- Then Jesus sent the people away/home.

After Jesus had dismissed the crowds: In this context, the Greek word that the BSB translates as dismissed refers to telling the crowd go home. After the people ate as much as they wanted, Jesus told them to return to their homes. Your translation should not imply that Jesus was being rude or hostile toward the people.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

After he dismissed the crowd

Then Jesus sent the people home

Then Jesus told the crowd of people to go home

This same word occurs in 15:32d.

15:39b

He got into the boat and went to the region of Magadan.

- he entered a boat and went to the area of Magadan.
- Then he got in a boat with his disciples and went to the land of the town of Magadan.

He got into the boat: The disciples probably got into the boat with Jesus. But they are not mentioned because Jesus is in focus here. In some languages, it may be necessary to make the disciples explicit. For example:

he got into the boat together with the disciples

he and his disciples entered into a boat

the boat: The phrase the boat would normally refer to a boat that had previously been mentioned. This boat may be the same boat as in 14:33a. Or, it is possible that the boat belonged to one of the disciples.

Since no boat is mentioned in the immediate context, it is possible to simply say:

a boat (GNT)

and went to the region of Magadan: The word Magadan probably refers to a small village. This clause indicates that Jesus entered the area that belonged to the people of Magadan.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

went to the area of Magadan (NCV)

came to shore near the town of Magadan (CEV)

arrived at the land of the people of the town of Magadan

Matthew 16:1

Section 16:1–4: The Jewish leaders tested Jesus

The Pharisees and Sadducees were two groups of Jewish leaders who were often opposed to each other. Here, they joined together to test Jesus. They tested him by asking him to do a certain kind of miracle that would prove that God had sent him. This kind of miracle was called a “sign.”

Jesus rebuked them for asking for a sign. He said that the only sign that they would see would be like what happened to Jonah. Jonah was in a big fish for three days. Then God caused the fish to vomit Jonah onto land alive. Similarly, Jesus would be in the grave for three days. Then God would cause him to be alive again. This would prove that God had sent him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The leaders ask for a miracle

The Demand for a Sign

There is a parallel passage for this section in Mark 8:11–13. There is a parallel passage for 16:2–3 in Luke 12:54–56.

Paragraph 16:1–4

In this paragraph, the Pharisees and Sadducees tested Jesus. They tested him by asking him for a sign to prove that he was from God.

16:1a

Then the Pharisees and Sadducees came

- ¶ Then some Pharisees and Sadducees came
- ¶ There were some Pharisee members and Sadducee members who came to Jesus.

Then: This is the beginning of a new story. The Greek introduces this story with a word that the BSB translates as Then. Most English versions do not translate this word. In your translation, use a natural way to begin a new story. For example:

There were

Then

the Pharisees and Sadducees came: This clause means that “some” Pharisees and Sadducees came to Jesus. It does not mean that all of them came. Only some came representing both groups.

In some languages, it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

Some Pharisees and Sadducees...came (GNT)

Pharisees: The word Pharisees last occurred in 15:12b. You should translate it here as you did there.

Sadducees: Use the same term here as you used in 3:7a.

came: The Greek text does not indicate where the Pharisees and Sadducees came from. It also does not indicate where Jesus was when they came to him. In your translation, do not try to make these things explicit.

16:1b

and tested Jesus by asking Him to show them a sign from heaven.

- to test Jesus. They asked him to do something to show that he came from heaven.
- They came and asked him to do a miracle to show/prove that God had sent him. They did this to test/trap him.

and tested Jesus: In this context, the word tested means “tried to trick/trap” so that he would fail. The Pharisees and Sadducees wanted Jesus to fail to show that he was from heaven. If (or when) he failed, they could declare that he was not from God. Their purpose was to discredit Jesus so that people would not listen to him.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

wanting to trick him (NCV)

wanted to trap him (GNT)

by asking Him to show them a sign from heaven:

Here the word sign refers to a special miracle that shows a particular truth. The Pharisees and Sadducees asked Jesus to do a miracle to show that he truly came from heaven/God. They did this because they did not believe that he could actually prove that he came from God.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

by asking him to show them a miraculous sign from heaven (NLT96)

they asked him to show them a miracle from God (NCV)

they asked him to do a miracle to show/prove that God had sent him

from heaven: The Greek word that the BSB translates as heaven can mean either:

1. sky – the space above the earth where birds fly, or
2. heaven – the place where God lives.

If you can, use a word that means both sky and heaven. If you must make a choice, choose (b) heaven. Here, the Pharisees and Sadducees wanted to see something that showed that Jesus came from “heaven/God.”

In some languages, it may be necessary to make the Pharisees’ and Sadducees’ request more explicit. For example:

from God (NCV)

Matthew 16:2**Section 16:1–4: The Jewish leaders tested Jesus**

The Pharisees and Sadducees were two groups of Jewish leaders who were often opposed to each other. Here, they joined together to test Jesus. They tested him by asking him to do a certain kind of miracle that would prove that God had sent him. This kind of miracle was called a “sign.”

Jesus rebuked them for asking for a sign. He said that the only sign that they would see would be like what happened to Jonah. Jonah was in a big fish for three days. Then God caused the fish to vomit Jonah onto land alive. Similarly, Jesus would be in the grave for three days. Then God would cause him to be alive again. This would prove that God had sent him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The leaders ask for a miracle

The Demand for a Sign

There is a parallel passage for this section in Mark 8:11–13. There is a parallel passage for 16:2–3 in Luke 12:54–56.

Paragraph 16:1–4

In this paragraph, the Pharisees and Sadducees tested Jesus. They tested him by asking him for a sign to prove that he was from God.

16:2a**But He replied, “When evening comes, you say,**

- He replied, “At sunset you^(plur) say,
- He told them, “When the sun is going down, you^(plur) say that

But He replied: There is a textual issue here. Some of the earliest and best Greek manuscripts do not have the words in 16:2–3 after “He answered them.” The editors of the UBS Greek text considered these words to probably be original, but they put them in brackets to show that they are not completely certain. As a result, almost all English versions include these words. (See the REB for an exception.) Most English versions also include a footnote to explain the textual issue. For example, the NLT says: “Several manuscripts do not include any of the words in 16:2–3 after He replied.” You may also want to include a footnote to explain this issue. Here Jesus responded to the request of the Pharisees and Sadducees, but he did not answer a question. So in some languages, it will be more natural to use a different verb. For example:

He told them (CEV)

He said

When evening comes: Here the word evening refers to sunset or soon after.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

At sunset (NCV)

When the sun is going down

16:2b–3b

In 16:2b–3b, Jesus apparently repeated a common understanding among people about the weather in the land of Israel at that time. They used the way that the sky looked in the evening to predict what the weather would be like the next day. And in the morning, if the sky was red and overcast, they predicted that the day would be stormy. Jesus used this common saying to begin his response to their request.

In many areas, people do not use observations like this to predict what the weather will be like. So you may want to explain it in a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

Some people in Israel believed that the sky could tell them what the weather would be like later. If the sky was red in the evening, that meant that it would not rain the next day. If they saw a “red and threatening” sky in the morning, that meant that the day would be stormy. Jesus referred to the redness of the sky as a kind of sign of the weather.

16:2b

‘The weather will be fair, for the sky is red,’

- ‘It will be good weather, because the sky is red.’
- the sky is red, so it will not rain tomorrow.

The weather will be fair: The Greek word that the BSB translates as weather will be fair refers to a day with few clouds, little wind, and no rain or snow. This clause refers to the weather the next day.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

we will have good weather (NCV)

tomorrow will be a sunny day

there will be no rain or strong wind

for the sky is red: This clause is a basis/reason for the conclusion that “the weather will be fair.” In some languages, it will be more natural to put this clause first. For example:

Because the sky is red, it will be fair weather.

The sky is red, so it will be nice weather.

In some languages, it will be more natural to use indirect speech here. For example:

At sunset, you say that there will be fair weather because the sky is red.

In the evening when the sky is red, you say that the weather will be fair.

sky: This is the same word that was translated in 16:1b as “heaven.” Since Jesus was talking about the weather, it means sky here. But since it can also mean “heaven,” he was probably making a play on words. He used the same word to make fun of the request by the Pharisees and Sadducees to see a sign from “heaven.”

is red: The word red refers to the red color in the sky that sometimes occurs at sunset. Use an expression that is natural for this type of sky.

Matthew 16:3**Section 16:1–4: The Jewish leaders tested Jesus**

The Pharisees and Sadducees were two groups of Jewish leaders who were often opposed to each other. Here, they joined together to test Jesus. They tested him by asking him to do a certain kind of miracle that would prove that God had sent him. This kind of miracle was called a “sign.”

Jesus rebuked them for asking for a sign. He said that the only sign that they would see would be like what happened to Jonah. Jonah was in a big fish for three days. Then God caused the fish to vomit Jonah onto land alive. Similarly, Jesus would be in the grave for three days. Then God would cause him to be alive again. This would prove that God had sent him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The leaders ask for a miracle

The Demand for a Sign

There is a parallel passage for this section in Mark 8:11–13. There is a parallel passage for 16:2–3 in Luke 12:54–56.

Paragraph 16:1–4

In this paragraph, the Pharisees and Sadducees tested Jesus. They tested him by asking him for a sign to prove that he was from God.

16:3a and in the morning,

- And in the morning you^(plur) say,
- When the sun is rising you^(plur) say that

and in the morning: Some words from 16:2a are implied but not repeated here. In some languages it may be more natural to include some or all the implied words. For example:

And in the morning you say (GW)

in the morning: Here the word morning refers to sunrise or soon after.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

at sunrise

when the sun comes up

16:3b 'Today it will be stormy, for the sky is red and overcast.'

- 'A storm will come today, because the sky is red and gloomy.'
- the sky is red and has dark clouds, so today will be rainy.

Today it will be stormy: The Greek word that the BSB translates as stormy refers to a rainy and possibly windy day.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

It is going to rain (GNT)

it will be a rainy day (NCV)

for the sky is red and overcast: The Greek word that the BSB translates as overcast also means "gloomy" or "dark." A threatening/gloomy sky is one where dark clouds fill the sky and block the sun.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

for the sky is red and threatening (ESV)

the sky is red and gloomy (CEV)

because the sky is red and dark

the sky is red and there are clouds

This clause is a basis/reason for the conclusion that "Today it will be stormy." In some languages, it will be more natural to put this clause first. For example:

Because the sky is red and overcast, it will be stormy.

The sky is red and dark, so it will be stormy today.

In some languages, it will be more natural to use indirect speech here. For example:

In the morning, you say that there will be rain because the sky is red and cloudy.

When morning comes and the sky is red and overcast, you say that there will be rain.

16:3c–d
You know how to interpret the appearance of the sky, but not the signs of the times: This sentence is a rebuke. Jesus rebuked the Pharisees and Sadducees for understanding the signs in the sky, but not understanding the signs of that time.

Here are some other ways to translate this rebuke:

- As a statement. For example:

You see these signs in the sky and know what they mean. In the same way, you see the things that I am doing now, but you don't know their meaning. (NCV)

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

You know what the signs in the sky mean. Why don't you know what the signs of the times mean?

Translate this rebuke in a way that is natural in your language.

16:3c You know how to interpret the appearance of the sky,

- You^(plur) can understand the signs in the sky,
- You^(plur) can look at the sky and know what kind of day it will be.

You know how to interpret: The Greek word that the BSB translates as interpret also means "evaluate" or

“judge.” Jesus said that his listeners had the ability to look at these signs in the sky and judge/evaluate their meaning.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

You know how to judge correctly (NET)

You are able to predict/tell if it will rain or not rain

You can tell what will happen

the appearance of the sky: The Greek phrase the BSB translates as the appearance of the sky is more literally “the face of the sky.” The ability to read and understand the signs of the weather is much like the ability to understand a person from their facial expressions.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the look of the sky (JBP)

when you see the sky

by looking at the sky

16:3d

but not the signs of the times.

- but you^(plur) cannot understand the signs of the things happening now.
- But when you^(plur) see the signs/things that are happening now, why are you not able to know what they mean?

but not the signs of the times: These words mean that the Pharisees and Sadducees were not able to understand the events of that time. And they should have understood those events. The Pharisees and Sadducees were leaders of the nation of Israel. They were responsible for understanding what was going on around them and what God was doing. But they did not.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

you are not able to understand

why are you are not able to know

the signs of the times: This phrase refers to events that would happen when God would begin to establish

his kingdom in the last days. The Jews believed that at that time, God would redeem his people, defeat their enemies, and establish his righteous kingdom.

The Pharisees and Sadducees should have recognized that the miracles that Jesus did were some of these signs. These miracles showed that he was the Messiah sent from God.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the signs concerning these times (GNT)

the events of these important times

the events/things that are happening now

Matthew 16:4

Section 16:1–4: The Jewish leaders tested Jesus

The Pharisees and Sadducees were two groups of Jewish leaders who were often opposed to each other. Here, they joined together to test Jesus. They tested him by asking him to do a certain kind of miracle that would prove that God had sent him. This kind of miracle was called a “sign.”

Jesus rebuked them for asking for a sign. He said that the only sign that they would see would be like what happened to Jonah. Jonah was in a big fish for three days. Then God caused the fish to vomit Jonah onto land alive. Similarly, Jesus would be in the grave for three days. Then God would cause him to be alive again. This would prove that God had sent him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The leaders ask for a miracle

The Demand for a Sign

There is a parallel passage for this section in Mark 8:11–13. There is a parallel passage for 16:2–3 in Luke 12:54–56.

Paragraph 16:1–4

In this paragraph, the Pharisees and Sadducees tested Jesus. They tested him by asking him for a sign to prove that he was from God.

16:4a

A wicked and adulterous generation demands a sign,

- The people who ask me for a miracle are evil/bad and like a married woman who is immoral. You want to see a surprising sign because you are evil/bad people. You are people who do not follow/obey God.

Verse 16:4 has almost the same wording as 12:39. The only differences are that the words “Jesus replied” and “the prophet” are not in this verse. You should translate these two verses in the same way except for those words.

A wicked: This word also means “bad,” “evil,” or “sinful.”

adulterous generation: The word adulterous describes a person who is unfaithful to his/her spouse. Here Jesus used this word in a figurative way. He used it to refer to people who needed to see a sign in order to know that he was the Messiah. He implied that such people showed that they were not faithful to God by their unbelief.

This word is harsh. By calling his listeners adulterous, Jesus intended to upset them. It is how prophets often talked to the people. They did this to shake them out of their bad ways of thinking.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- Use the ordinary word for unfaithfulness to a spouse. For example:

You are a generation of adulterers

- Use a simile. Here is an example:

you are people who are unfaithful to God like an adulterous spouse/wife

you are like a married person who is immoral

- Translate the meaning without the figure of speech. Here are some examples:

you are not following God

you do not obey God

evil and godless...people of this day (GNT)

generation: The word generation refers to all the people of a similar age living at a particular time and place. For instance, all the adult Jews living in Israel

during Jesus’ ministry would be a generation. Jesus was referring to the people of Israel at that time.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

the people of this day (GNT)

the people who are living now

you are people who

demands: The Greek word that the BSB translates as demands means “wants, looks for, asks, demands, desires.” The Pharisees and Sadducees wanted to see a sign from Jesus proving that he was the Messiah. They refused to believe in him simply by faith.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

ask for (NCV)

want (CEV)

16:4b

but none will be given it except the sign of Jonah.”

- But no miracle will be done for them except the miracle like the one that happened to Jonah.
- The only the sign that I will show you is a sign like the one that God did to/for the prophet Jonah long ago.

none will be given it: This clause means that “no sign will be done for” or “no sign will be shown to” this wicked and adulterous generation.

This clause is passive. Here are some ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

no sign will be shown to this wicked and adulterous generation

no sign will be given to them (NCV)

no sign will be done for you

- Use an active verb. For example:

the only sign I will give them (NLT)

this generation will receive no sign

you will not see any miracle

except the sign of Jonah: This clause refers to the miracle that happened to the prophet Jonah. He was in the stomach of a huge fish for three days. Then God caused the fish to vomit him on the shore and delivered him from death.

God would also deliver Jesus from death. After being dead for three days in the tomb, God would resurrect him. This sign would prove that he was from God and his message was true.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

except a sign like what happened to the prophet Jonah

a miracle that is like the one that God did to the prophet Jonah long ago

This clause does not mean that Jonah did a miracle.

If people in your area are not familiar with the story of Jonah, you may want to include some information about it in a footnote. A sample footnote is:

In the story of the prophet Jonah, a large fish swallowed Jonah. He was in the stomach of the fish for three days and three nights. Then the fish vomited him onto dry ground, and he came out alive.

16:4c

Then He left them and went away.

- Then Jesus left them and walked away.
- Then Jesus left. (CEV)

Matthew 16:5

Section 16:5–12: Jesus warned against the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees

In this section, Jesus warned his disciples about the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees. The Pharisees and Sadducees refused to accept Jesus as the Messiah. And they tried to keep other Jews from believing that Jesus was the Messiah. They opposed Jesus and his message.

Jesus warned his disciples about the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees by telling them to be careful of their “leaven/yeast.” Jesus used leaven/yeast in a metaphorical sense to refer to their teaching. But the disciples thought that he referred to literal leaven/yeast. They thought that he said these things because

they had forgotten to take bread on their trip. Jesus rebuked them for not understanding. Then he used some rhetorical questions to help them understand the correct meaning of his words.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Guard Against Wrong Teachings (NCV)

The yeast of the Pharisees and Sadducees (NJB)

The teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees is compared to yeast

There is a parallel passage for this section in Mark 8:14–21.

Paragraph 16:5–12

In this paragraph Jesus warned the disciples about the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees.

16:5a–b

When they crossed to the other side, the disciples forgot to take bread: In the BSB, it may appear that first the disciples crossed to the other side of the lake, then they forgot to bring bread. You should make it clear in your translation that the disciples first forgot to bring bread, then they crossed to the other side of the lake.

Here are some other ways to make the order more clear:

- Add a word like “discovered” or “realized” to the second clause. For example:

Later, after they crossed to the other side of the lake, the disciples discovered they had forgotten to bring any bread. (NLT)

After Jesus and the disciples crossed to the other side of the lake, the disciples realized that they had forgotten to bring bread.

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

The disciples had forgotten to bring any bread when they crossed the lake. (CEV)

16:5a

When they crossed to the other side,

- ¶ When they arrived at the other side of the lake,

- ¶ Then Jesus and the disciples got into a boat and crossed to the other side of Lake Galilee,

When they crossed to the other side: The phrase the other side refers to the other (east) side of Lake Galilee. In some languages, it will be natural to make this information explicit. For example:

When the disciples crossed over to the other side of the lake (GNT)

when they went to the other side of the Sea of Galilee (GW)

Mark 8:13 makes it clear that Jesus went across the lake with the disciples. In some languages, it will be more natural to make that information explicit. For example:

When Jesus and the disciples reached the other side of the lake

16:5b the disciples forgot to take bread.

- the disciples discovered that they had forgotten to bring any bread.
- and the disciples realized that they had forgotten to bring bread.

the disciples forgot to take bread: As mentioned above in the note on 16:5a–b, it may be necessary to add the word “discovered” or “realized” before the word forgot. For example:

they discovered/realized that they had forgotten to bring any bread

See the note at 16:5a–b for more information.

bread: The Greek word that the BSB translates as bread sometimes means food in general. In this context, it refers specifically to bread. Later in the story this will be important, because Jesus refers to leaven/yeast, which is used to make bread.

If you have been using a local food such as rice, sago, etc. as a substitute for the word bread in other verses, you may want to:

- Use a local food word if people use yeast/leaven to make it.
- Borrow the major language word for bread here. You may then want a footnote to explain bread. For example:

Bread was the main daily food of the Jews. It was made from a mixture of wheat flour and water. Some kinds of bread dough (uncooked bread) were puffed up by adding leaven/yeast, then cooked in an oven as loaves. Bread could be eaten warm from the oven or carried along and eaten cold anywhere.

Matthew 16:6

Section 16:5–12: Jesus warned against the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees

In this section, Jesus warned his disciples about the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees. The Pharisees and Sadducees refused to accept Jesus as the Messiah. And they tried to keep other Jews from believing that Jesus was the Messiah. They opposed Jesus and his message.

Jesus warned his disciples about the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees by telling them to be careful of their “leaven/yeast.” Jesus used leaven/yeast in a metaphorical sense to refer to their teaching. But the disciples thought that he referred to literal leaven/yeast. They thought that he said these things because they had forgotten to take bread on their trip. Jesus rebuked them for not understanding. Then he used some rhetorical questions to help them understand the correct meaning of his words.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Guard Against Wrong Teachings (NCV)

The yeast of the Pharisees and Sadducees (NJB)

The teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees is compared to yeast

There is a parallel passage for this section in Mark 8:14–21.

Paragraph 16:5–12

In this paragraph Jesus warned the disciples about the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees.

16:6

“Watch out!” Jesus told them. “Beware of the leaven of the Pharisees and Sadducees.”

- Jesus said to them, “Be careful! Watch out for the leaven/yeast of the Pharisees and Sadducees.”
- Then Jesus said to them, “Be very careful of the yeast of the Pharisees and Sadducees.”

Watch out...Beware: The two verbs Watch out and Beware are a doublet. This means that these two verbs have almost the same meaning. Jesus used these two verbs with a similar meaning to emphasize the warning that he was giving his disciples. He warned them to pay attention to a possible danger.

In some languages, it is natural to emphasize a warning using two verbs. In other languages it may not be natural to use two verbs like this. If that is true in your language, you may need to emphasize the warning in another way. (See an example below.)

Here are some other ways to translate these verbs:

Be careful! Watch out (GW)

Look out! Beware of

Be very careful of

the leaven of the Pharisees and Sadducees: The Greek word that the BSB translates as leaven refers to a substance that is also called “yeast.” A person mixes leaven/yeast with water and flour. Then it spreads throughout the flour and makes the dough expand/rise. The dough is then baked in an oven and becomes bread.

Here Jesus used the word leaven as a metaphor to refer to the bad influences of the Pharisees and Sadducees. But at first the disciples misunderstood him. They thought that he was talking about real leaven/yeast. So you should translate leaven here in a normal, non-figurative way.

Here are some other ways to translate leaven/yeast:

- Use an expression that describes the leaven. For example:

what spreads to make bread swell/rise

bread-expanding substance

- Use a term from the national language and a descriptive phrase. For example:

yeast that spreads to make bread swell

- Borrow a word and explain it in a footnote. Here is an example of a possible footnote:

Yeast is something that spreads in flour dough and causes it to swell/rise so that after the dough is baked it is soft to eat.

Matthew 16:7

Section 16:5–12: Jesus warned against the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees

In this section, Jesus warned his disciples about the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees. The Pharisees and Sadducees refused to accept Jesus as the Messiah. And they tried to keep other Jews from believing that Jesus was the Messiah. They opposed Jesus and his message.

Jesus warned his disciples about the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees by telling them to be careful of their “leaven/yeast.” Jesus used leaven/yeast in a metaphorical sense to refer to their teaching. But the disciples thought that he referred to literal leaven/yeast. They thought that he said these things because they had forgotten to take bread on their trip. Jesus rebuked them for not understanding. Then he used some rhetorical questions to help them understand the correct meaning of his words.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Guard Against Wrong Teachings (NCV)

The yeast of the Pharisees and Sadducees (NJB)

The teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees is compared to yeast

There is a parallel passage for this section in Mark 8:14–21.

Paragraph 16:5–12

In this paragraph Jesus warned the disciples about the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees.

16:7a

They discussed this among themselves and concluded,

- They talked about it/that to each other and concluded,
- They began discussing his words to one another and decided,

They discussed this among themselves and concluded: Verse 16:7b contains a description of what the disciples decided about Jesus’ words. In some languages, it may be good to make this more clear in

16:7a, as the BSB has done. Here are some other ways to say this:

began discussing it among themselves and concluded, saying

were discussing this among themselves and decided

discussed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as discussed means “thought or reasoned carefully.” The tense of the Greek verb indicates that the disciples probably discussed Jesus’ words for a while.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

started discussing (GNT)

were talking about

this: This word refers to what Jesus said in 16:6. Your translation of this word should clearly refer to Jesus’ words of 16:6.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

his words

that/that

16:7b

“It is because we did not bring any bread.”

- “He said that because we^(incl) did not bring any bread.”
- “He said those words because we^(incl) did not bring any bread with us^(incl).”

It is because we did not bring any bread: There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that connects 16:7a and 16:7b:

1. It is a conjunction and means because. For example:

He says this because we didn’t bring any bread.
(GNT) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NJB, NLT, NASB, CEV, NET, KJV, NCV, NRSV)

1. It is a speech introducer and means that. In natural English, this word is not translated when it introduces direct speech. For example:

We brought no bread (RSV)

that they had not taken any bread along (GW)
(RSV, GW, JBP, REB, ESV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The majority of English versions follow this interpretation.

we: The disciples were talking among themselves, and they were not including Jesus when they used the pronoun we. If your language has an inclusive we and an exclusive we, use the inclusive we since they were not talking to Jesus.

bread: You should use the same word for bread here as you did in 16:5b.

Matthew 16:8

Section 16:5–12: Jesus warned against the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees

In this section, Jesus warned his disciples about the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees. The Pharisees and Sadducees refused to accept Jesus as the Messiah. And they tried to keep other Jews from believing that Jesus was the Messiah. They opposed Jesus and his message.

Jesus warned his disciples about the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees by telling them to be careful of their “leaven/yeast.” Jesus used leaven/yeast in a metaphorical sense to refer to their teaching. But the disciples thought that he referred to literal leaven/yeast. They thought that he said these things because they had forgotten to take bread on their trip. Jesus rebuked them for not understanding. Then he used some rhetorical questions to help them understand the correct meaning of his words.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Guard Against Wrong Teachings (NCV)

The yeast of the Pharisees and Sadducees (NJB)

The teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees is compared to yeast

There is a parallel passage for this section in Mark 8:14–21.

Paragraph 16:5–12

In this paragraph Jesus warned the disciples about the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees.

16:8a

Aware of their conversation, Jesus said, “You of little faith,

- Jesus knew what they were saying, and said, “Your faith is small/lacking!
- Jesus knew about their conversation, so he said, “You^(plur) are men of little faith.

The Greek begins this verse with a word that the BSB leaves untranslated, but some English versions translate it as “But.” It is a connector that can show mild contrast. But it often just moves the story along, and it is not always translated into English. For instance:

Aware of their discussion, Jesus asked (NET)

In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this word.

Aware of their conversation: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Aware is more literally “knowing.” It is not clear how Jesus knew what the disciples were discussing. He may have known their thoughts. Or he may have overheard them talking. The text does not say how Jesus knew, so your translation should also not say specifically how he knew.

The words of their conversation are not in Greek but are implied.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

knew about their conversation (GW)

knew what they were saying (NCV)

You of little faith: Jesus used the Greek word that the BSB translates as You of little faith to rebuke the disciples. He also used it to describe them. This is the first part of his rebuke.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the rebuke:

- As an exclamation. For example:

You have so little faith! (GW)

Your faith is so small!

- As a separate rhetorical question, or as the first part of the larger rhetorical question. For example:

Where is your faith? (REB)

You of little faith, why are you talking among yourselves about having no bread? (NIV)

This same phrase occurs in 6:30d and 14:31b.

We may have expected Jesus to say, “You have little intelligence!” The phrase You of little faith indicates that he rebuked them for not thinking of spiritual things. By thinking of food, they missed the spiritual warning he was giving them.

16:8b

why are you debating among yourselves about having no bread?

- Why you are talking among yourselves about having no bread?
- You should not be saying to each other that you have no bread.

why are you debating among yourselves about having no bread?: This is a rhetorical question. It expresses a rebuke. Jesus rebuked the disciples because they thought that he was talking about bread.

Here are some other ways to translate this rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Why are you talking about having no bread? (REB)

- As a statement. For example:

You have no reason to be saying to each other that you have no bread!

You should not be saying to one another that you have no bread.

Translate this rebuke in a way that is natural in your language.

Matthew 16:9**Section 16:5–12: Jesus warned against the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees**

In this section, Jesus warned his disciples about the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees. The Pharisees and Sadducees refused to accept Jesus as the Messiah. And they tried to keep other Jews from believing that Jesus was the Messiah. They opposed Jesus and his message.

Jesus warned his disciples about the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees by telling them to be careful of their “leaven/yeast.” Jesus used leaven/yeast in a metaphorical sense to refer to their teaching. But the

disciples thought that he referred to literal leaven/yeast. They thought that he said these things because they had forgotten to take bread on their trip. Jesus rebuked them for not understanding. Then he used some rhetorical questions to help them understand the correct meaning of his words.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Guard Against Wrong Teachings (NCV)

The yeast of the Pharisees and Sadducees (NJB)

The teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees is compared to yeast

There is a parallel passage for this section in Mark 8:14–21.

Paragraph 16:5–12

In this paragraph Jesus warned the disciples about the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees.

16:9a

Do you still not understand?

- Why do you still not understand?
- You still do not understand!

Do you still not understand?: This is another rhetorical question. It is a rebuke. Jesus scolded his disciples for thinking that the reason he warned them in 16:6 was because they did not bring bread. In 16:9–10 he reminded them that he had multiplied small amounts of bread to feed large crowds of people. When he spoke about the leaven/yeast of the Pharisees and Sadducees, he was warning against their dangerous influence or attitude. Clearly, Jesus expected his disciples to think about the danger of the Pharisees and Sadducees, not about bread.

Here are some other ways to translate this rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Why do you still not understand?

Do you not yet perceive? (ESV)

- As a statement. For example:

You still do not understand!

Translate this rebuke in a way that is natural in your language.

understand: The Greek word that the BSB translates understand can also be translated as “perceive” (as in the ESV).

16:9b–c

Do you not remember the five loaves for the five thousand, and how many basketfuls you gathered?:

This is yet another rhetorical question. It is also a rebuke. Jesus scolded his disciples for seeming to forget his recent miracle and what it meant.

Here are some other ways to translate this rebuke:

- As one or two rhetorical questions. For example:

Do you not remember that I fed five thousand men with five loaves of bread and how many baskets full of leftovers you gathered?

Did you forget that I fed five thousand men with the five loaves? Did you forget the number of baskets you gathered?

- As a statement. For example:

You seem to forget how five loaves fed five thousand men and how you picked up twelve baskets full of leftovers.

Translate this rebuke in a way that is natural in your language.

16:9b

Do you not remember the five loaves for the five thousand,

- Do you not remember how five loaves fed five thousand,
- Have you forgotten the feeding of five thousand men with five loaves of bread?

Do you not remember: Here is another way to translate this clause:

Have you forgotten (CEV)

the five loaves for the five thousand: This phrase refers to the miracle when Jesus fed five thousand men plus women and children. Matthew wrote about this story in 14:13–21.

If people in your area will not understand that this clause refers to Jesus feeding the five thousand, you

may want to include some implied information. Here are some examples:

the five loaves which fed the five thousand men

the feeding of five thousand men with five loaves of bread

loaves: The Greek word that the BSB translates as loaves probably refers to flat breads. One person could eat three to five of these loaves at one meal. It was the common food for a meal.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

loaves of bread

small breads

16:9c and how many basketfuls you gathered?

- and how many baskets full of leftovers you gathered?
- Have you forgotten the number of baskets of leftover food that you picked up?

and: Verses 16:9b and 16:9c contain two things that the disciples should have been thinking about. These two things are joined by the conjunction and.

In some languages, it will be more natural to make 16:9c a separate question. For example:

Do you not remember how many baskets you gathered?

how many basketfuls you gathered: This clause refers to the twelve baskets of leftover food that the disciples gathered after the five thousand men ate. Jesus did not mention the number of basketfuls. He just wanted the disciples to remember that he was able to provide much more bread than everyone needed.

In this whole story, Jesus seemed to make a point of not directly saying what he meant. Instead he tried to get the disciples to think again about events that they knew about. And he wanted them to see what they meant without him telling them.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the number of baskets you gathered

basketfuls: Here the word basketfuls represents the pieces of leftover food that the disciples gathered and put into the baskets. It does not refer to the baskets themselves. In other words, the disciples did not just gather empty baskets.

Here is another way to translate this to make it clearer:

the number of baskets of leftover food you gathered

The size of the baskets is not known. They were probably medium in size. Some languages have different words for different kinds or sizes of baskets. If your language is like that, use a word for one that is medium in size. Translate this word in the same way as you did in 14:20b.

Matthew 16:10

Section 16:5–12: Jesus warned against the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees

In this section, Jesus warned his disciples about the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees. The Pharisees and Sadducees refused to accept Jesus as the Messiah. And they tried to keep other Jews from believing that Jesus was the Messiah. They opposed Jesus and his message.

Jesus warned his disciples about the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees by telling them to be careful of their “leaven/yeast.” Jesus used leaven/yeast in a metaphorical sense to refer to their teaching. But the disciples thought that he referred to literal leaven/yeast. They thought that he said these things because they had forgotten to take bread on their trip. Jesus rebuked them for not understanding. Then he used some rhetorical questions to help them understand the correct meaning of his words.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Guard Against Wrong Teachings (NCV)

The yeast of the Pharisees and Sadducees (NJB)

The teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees is compared to yeast

There is a parallel passage for this section in Mark 8:14–21.

Paragraph 16:5–12

In this paragraph Jesus warned the disciples about the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees.

16:10a**Or the seven loaves for the four thousand,**

- Or how seven loaves fed four thousand,
- Do you not remember the feeding of four thousand men with seven loaves of bread?

Or: The word Or indicates that there is a second part to Jesus' question. In some languages, it will be natural to repeat some of the words in the first part of the question. For example:

Do you not remember...

the seven loaves for the four thousand: This phrase refers to the miracle when Jesus fed four thousand men plus women and children. Matthew wrote about this story in 15:33–38.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Or the seven loaves which fed the four thousand men.

Or do you not remember the feeding of four thousand men with seven loaves of bread

Also, have you forgotten how I fed four thousand men with seven loaves of bread?

16:10b**and how many basketfuls you gathered?**

- and how many large baskets full of leftovers you gathered?
- Do you not remember the number of large baskets of leftover food that you picked up?

and: Verses 16:10a and 16:10b contain two more things that the disciples should have been thinking about. These two things are joined by the conjunction and.

In some languages, it will be more natural to make 16:10b a separate question. For example:

Do you not remember how many baskets you gathered?

how many basketfuls you gathered: This clause is just like 16:9c, except that the Greek word for basketfuls is different. Here, the word for basketfuls refers to a larger type of basket than the kind in 16:9c. If your

language has words for two different sizes of baskets, use the word for the larger one here.

If your language has one word for all kinds of baskets, you may want to include a descriptive word. For example:

how many large baskets you gathered

The word for this larger type of basket also occurs in 15:37b. You should translate it here as you did there.

Matthew 16:11**Section 16:5–12: Jesus warned against the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees**

In this section, Jesus warned his disciples about the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees. The Pharisees and Sadducees refused to accept Jesus as the Messiah. And they tried to keep other Jews from believing that Jesus was the Messiah. They opposed Jesus and his message.

Jesus warned his disciples about the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees by telling them to be careful of their “leaven/yeast.” Jesus used leaven/yeast in a metaphorical sense to refer to their teaching. But the disciples thought that he referred to literal leaven/yeast. They thought that he said these things because they had forgotten to take bread on their trip. Jesus rebuked them for not understanding. Then he used some rhetorical questions to help them understand the correct meaning of his words.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Guard Against Wrong Teachings (NCV)

The yeast of the Pharisees and Sadducees (NJB)

The teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees is compared to yeast

There is a parallel passage for this section in Mark 8:14–21.

Paragraph 16:5–12

In this paragraph Jesus warned the disciples about the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees.

16:11a**How do you not understand that I was not telling you about bread?**

- Why don't you understand/see that I was not talking about bread?
- I was not talking to you about bread. Why did you not understand that?
- You should have understood that I was not talking to you about bread.

How do you not understand that I was not telling you about bread?: This is another rhetorical question. It is a rebuke. Jesus rebuked the disciples for not understanding what he was talking about in 16:6. When he referred to the “leaven of the Pharisees and Sadducees,” he was not talking about bread. The disciples should have understood that.

Here are some other ways to translate this rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

How could you even think I was talking about food? (NLT96)

Why don't you understand that I wasn't talking to you about bread? (GW)

- As a statement followed by a rhetorical question. For example:

I was not talking to you about bread. Why don't you understand that? (NCV)

- As a statement. For example:

You should have understood that I was not talking about bread

Translate this rebuke in a way that is natural in your language.

16:11b

But beware of the leaven of the Pharisees and Sadducees.”

- Watch out for the leaven/yeast of the Pharisees and Sadducees.”
- Be very careful of the yeast of the Pharisees and Sadducees.”

But beware of the leaven of the Pharisees and Sadducees: This clause is almost the same clause as in 16:6. The only difference is that the phrase “Watch out” is not repeated here. Translate this clause the same way you did in 16:6 without including that word.

Matthew 16:12

Section 16:5–12: Jesus warned against the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees

In this section, Jesus warned his disciples about the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees. The Pharisees and Sadducees refused to accept Jesus as the Messiah. And they tried to keep other Jews from believing that Jesus was the Messiah. They opposed Jesus and his message.

Jesus warned his disciples about the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees by telling them to be careful of their “leaven/yeast.” Jesus used leaven/yeast in a metaphorical sense to refer to their teaching. But the disciples thought that he referred to literal leaven/yeast. They thought that he said these things because they had forgotten to take bread on their trip. Jesus rebuked them for not understanding. Then he used some rhetorical questions to help them understand the correct meaning of his words.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Guard Against Wrong Teachings (NCV)

The yeast of the Pharisees and Sadducees (NJB)

The teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees is compared to yeast

There is a parallel passage for this section in Mark 8:14–21.

Paragraph 16:5–12

In this paragraph Jesus warned the disciples about the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees.

16:12a

Then they understood that He was not telling them to beware of

- Then they understood that Jesus was not telling them to watch out for
- Finally the disciples understood/realized that Jesus was not telling them to be careful of

beware: This word is the same word as in 16:6 and 16:11b.

16:12b

the leaven used in bread,

- the leaven used in the making of bread,
- the yeast that people use when making bread.

the leaven used in bread: This phrase means “the leaven/yeast used to make bread.” The disciples finally understood that Jesus was not talking about literal leaven/yeast.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the leaven/yeast used in the making of bread

the leaven/yeast put in bread

the leaven/yeast that people use when making bread

16:12c

but of the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees.

- but to watch out for the things that the Pharisees and Sadducees were teaching.
- Rather/Instead he was telling them to be careful of the teaching from the Pharisee members and the Sadducee members.

but: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between what Jesus was not talking about and what he was talking about. (He was not talking about guarding against the yeast used in bread. Instead, he was talking about guarding against the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees). Languages have different ways to indicate this negative-positive type of contrast. One of the functions of the Greek conjunction *ἀλλά* is to signal this negative-positive type of contrast. Here are some other ways to translate this:

- With the conjunction but.
- With a conjunction other than but. This is a common way in English to show this type of contrast. For example:

rather

on the contrary

Instead

- With no conjunction. For example:

^{12a-b}Then they understood that he did not tell them to beware of the leaven of bread. ^{12c}He told them to be aware of the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees.

of the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees: The words “to beware of” are implied from 16:12a but not repeated here. In some languages, it will be natural to make these words explicit. For example:

but to beware of the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees

the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees: This phrase refers to the things that the Pharisees and Sadducees taught. For example:

the things that the Pharisees and Sadducees taught

the teachings of the Pharisees and Sadducees

Matthew 16:13

Section 16:13–20: Peter declared that Jesus is the Christ

In this section, Peter declared that Jesus is the Messiah. Jesus agreed with Peter that he was the Messiah. But then he told the disciples that they must not yet tell this truth to other people. Jesus also described the community which he was creating—the church. And he told them that Peter would have a very important part in it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Peter’s Confession of Christ (NIV)

Peter declared his belief that Jesus is the Messiah

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 8:27–30 and Luke 9:18–22.

Paragraph 16:13–16

The story in 16:13–16 began sometime after the story in 16:5–12 ended. The Greek text does not say how much time passed between these two stories. In some languages, it is natural to begin a story with a time word or phrase. If your language does that, use an expression here that is not too specific. For example:

Then

16:13a

When Jesus came to the region of Caesarea Philippi,

- ¶ When/After Jesus came to the region of the town of Caesarea Philippi,
- ¶ Then Jesus and his disciples went to the area/land around the town called Caesarea Philippi. When they arrived there,

When Jesus came: This clause implies that this story happened after Jesus and his disciples arrived near Caesarea Philippi (see map above). They were still on the journey which started when they crossed the Sea of Galilee (in 16:5).

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

When Jesus came with his disciples

Then Jesus and his disciples arrived

to the region of Caesarea Philippi: The words Caesarea Philippi refer to a town in far northern Israel. The name of the town comes from the names of two men: Emperor Augustus Caesar and Herod Philip. Herod Philip had enlarged a small village there and named it after Caesar and himself. This town is different than the town of Caesarea located along the coast.

The phrase the region of Caesarea Philippi refers to the land around this town.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

to the district of Caesarea Philippi (ESV)

to the territory near the town of Caesarea Philippi (GNT)

near the town of Caesarea Philippi (CEV)

16:13b

He questioned His disciples: “Who do people say the Son of Man is?”

- he asked his disciples, “Who do people say/think that the Son of Man is?”
- he asked his disciples, “People say/believe that I, the Son of Man, am who?”

Who do people say the Son of Man is?: This question is asking more than who Jesus’ parents were, where he grew up, or what his name was. Jesus knew that the people who saw him do miracles had an opinion about how he got such power. The disciples’ answer shows that the people believed that Jesus was John the Baptist or one of the prophets. Translate this question in a way that fits the answer in 16:14a-c.

Here are some other ways to translate this question:

Who do people think that the Son of Man is?

Who do people believe that the Son of Man is?

say: In this context the verb say refers to what the people thought or believed, as well as to what they said. In some languages it may be more natural to use a verb like “think” or “believe” here.

the Son of Man: There is a textual issue here. Many manuscripts include the pronoun “I” here so that it reads, “I, the Son of Man.” However, a few important early manuscripts do not include the pronoun I. Most scholars think that that when someone copied a manuscript long ago, he wanted to make this story be told the way Mark tells it, and so he included the pronoun. The pronoun was then copied faithfully ever after into many subsequent manuscripts. Among English versions, only the KJV includes it. Jesus often referred to himself as the Son of Man. In some languages it may be necessary to make it clear that Jesus was referring to himself. For example:

I, the Son of Man

In Matthew, this phrase first occurs in 8:20b. See the Note there for more information on translating this phrase. This phrase last occurred in 13:41a.

Matthew 16:14

Section 16:13–20: Peter declared that Jesus is the Christ

In this section, Peter declared that Jesus is the Messiah. Jesus agreed with Peter that he was the Messiah. But then he told the disciples that they must not yet tell this truth to other people. Jesus also described the community which he was creating—the church. And he told them that Peter would have a very important part in it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Peter’s Confession of Christ (NIV)

Peter declared his belief that Jesus is the Messiah

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 8:27–30 and Luke 9:18–22.

Paragraph 16:13–16

The story in 16:13–16 began sometime after the story in 16:5–12 ended. The Greek text does not say how much time passed between these two stories. In some languages, it is natural to begin a story with a time word or phrase. If your language does that, use an expression here that is not too specific. For example:

Then

16:14a–c

Some say John the Baptist; others say Elijah; and still others, Jeremiah or one of the prophets: The disciples' answer indicates that the people thought that Jesus was a prophet. They also thought that he was a prophet who had already died and had come back to life.

The ideas that the people had about Jesus show that no one was quite sure who he was. Many Jews thought that at the end of the world, God would raise up certain prophets for special reasons. Since people thought that Jesus was one of these prophets, they must have expected the end to come soon. But they apparently were not clear exactly who he was or what role he would play.

If people in your area are not familiar with these prophets, you may want to:

- Include some implied information. For example:

Some people say that you are John the Baptist or Elijah or Jeremiah or some other prophet whom God has raised to life again.

- Include a footnote. For example:

At the time Jesus asked the question, none of these prophets were alive. Many Jews thought that at the end of the world, God would raise up certain prophets like John the Baptist, Elijah or Jeremiah, for special reasons.

16:14a

They replied, “Some say John the Baptist;

- They answered, “Some people say John the Baptizer,
- The disciples answered Jesus, “Certain people say that you are John the Baptist.

Some say: The words “you are” are implied. In some languages, it may be natural to make these words explicit. For example:

Some people say that you are

Certain people think that you are

John the Baptist: You should translate John the Baptist here as you did in 3:1a.

16:14b

others say Elijah;

- other people say the prophet Elijah,
- Other people say that you are the prophet Elijah.

others say: These words indicate that people had different ideas about who Jesus was. A second group of people thought that Jesus was the prophet Elijah.

The words “you are” are implied. In some languages, it may be natural to make these words explicit. For example:

other people say/think that you are

Elijah: Elijah was a prophet who lived more than 500 years before Jesus. In some languages, it may be natural to make this more explicit. For example:

the prophet Elijah

16:14c

and still others, Jeremiah or one of the prophets.”

- and still other people say Jeremiah or another prophet.”
- And other people say that you are Jeremiah or some other prophet whom God has raised to life again.”

and still others: These words indicate that there was a third opinion. A third group of people thought that Jesus was the prophet Jeremiah or one of the other prophets. In English, one way to indicate a third group is with the word still like the BSB.

The words “you are” are implied. In some languages, it may be natural to make these words explicit. For example:

and other people say/think that you are

Jeremiah: Jeremiah was a prophet who lived more than 500 years before Jesus. In some languages, it may be natural to make this more explicit. For example:

the prophet Jeremiah

or one of the prophets: John the Baptist, Elijah and Jeremiah were prophets. So this phrase refers to other prophets.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

some other prophet (CEV)

Matthew 16:15

Section 16:13–20: Peter declared that Jesus is the Christ

In this section, Peter declared that Jesus is the Messiah. Jesus agreed with Peter that he was the Messiah. But then he told the disciples that they must not yet tell this truth to other people. Jesus also described the community which he was creating—the church. And he told them that Peter would have a very important part in it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Peter's Confession of Christ (NIV)

Peter declared his belief that Jesus is the Messiah

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 8:27–30 and Luke 9:18–22.

Paragraph 16:13–16

The story in 16:13–16 began sometime after the story in 16:5–12 ended. The Greek text does not say how much time passed between these two stories. In some languages, it is natural to begin a story with a time word or phrase. If your language does that, use an expression here that is not too specific. For example:

Then

16:15

“But what about you?” Jesus asked. “Who do you say I am?”

- He asked, “And you, who do you^(plur) say I am?”
- Then he asked them, “And what about you^(plur)? Who do you say that am I?”

“But what about you?”... “Who do you say I am?”:

In Greek, this is more literally, “But you, who do you I am?” In Greek, the pronoun “you” is emphasized the first time it occurs in this clause. Jesus had just heard what other people said about him. Now he wanted to know who his own disciples thought that he was.

Here are some other ways to translate this question:

But you,...who do you say I am? (NJB)

And you, who do you say I am?

In Greek this is one question. Some English versions, including the BSB, add a separate question to show that the pronoun you is emphasized. For example:

But what about you?...Who do you say I am? (NIV)

Matthew 16:16

Section 16:13–20: Peter declared that Jesus is the Christ

In this section, Peter declared that Jesus is the Messiah. Jesus agreed with Peter that he was the Messiah. But then he told the disciples that they must not yet tell this truth to other people. Jesus also described the community which he was creating—the church. And he told them that Peter would have a very important part in it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Peter's Confession of Christ (NIV)

Peter declared his belief that Jesus is the Messiah

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 8:27–30 and Luke 9:18–22.

Paragraph 16:13–16

The story in 16:13–16 began sometime after the story in 16:5–12 ended. The Greek text does not say how much time passed between these two stories. In some languages, it is natural to begin a story with a time word or phrase. If your language does that, use an expression here that is not too specific. For example:

Then

16:16a

Simon Peter answered, “You are the Christ,

- Simon Peter answered, “You^(sing) are the Christ,
- Simon called Peter answered him, “You^(sing) are the Christ/Messiah.

Simon Peter answered: Peter was named Simon at birth. When Jesus first met Simon (John 1:42), he gave him the new name of Peter.

In some languages, it may not be clear that Simon Peter refers to one person who uses two names. In

those languages, you may need to make that clear in the translation. For example:

Simon also called Peter

You are the Christ: The word Christ is the Greek translation of the Hebrew word “Messiah.” “Messiah” refers to the person whom God had appointed and promised to send as king and savior. The words Christ and Messiah have the same meaning.

Here are some other ways to translate Christ:

- Transliterate Christ and indicate in some way that it is a title. For example:

the Kristi

- Transliterate Christ and include a phrase that explains the meaning. For example:

Karisiti, the appointed one

Cristo, the Savior whom God promised to send

- Use a title or a descriptive phrase in your language that has the same meaning as Christ. For example:

Messiah

Promised Deliverer

The Rescuer-King whom God sent

Some of you will not include the meaning of Christ in the text. In that case, you may want to include a footnote to explain the meaning of Christ. Or you may want to explain the meaning in a glossary. For example:

The word/title “Christ” refers to the King and Savior whom God promised to send.

The word Christ first occurs in 1:1a. It also occurs in 11:2a. You should translate it here as you did there.

16:16b

the Son of the living God.”

- you^(sing) are the Son of God, the living one!”
- You are the Son/Child of the God who is alive!”

the Son of the living God: The phrase “the Son of God” was a title that Jews often used to refer to a coming savior who would be a descendant of King David. This person was also called the “Messiah” or “Christ.” This title also indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God.

See how you translated the phrase “the Son of God” at 4:3b. For further information on translating this title, see the note on “My...Son” at 3:17b.

the living God: Jews used this phrase to refer to the true God. It showed that they were not talking about false gods and idols who do not have life. It was a common way to refer to God in the Old Testament.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the alive God

God, the living one

the God who is alive

Matthew 16:17

Section 16:13–20: Peter declared that Jesus is the Christ

In this section, Peter declared that Jesus is the Messiah. Jesus agreed with Peter that he was the Messiah. But then he told the disciples that they must not yet tell this truth to other people. Jesus also described the community which he was creating—the church. And he told them that Peter would have a very important part in it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Peter’s Confession of Christ (NIV)

Peter declared his belief that Jesus is the Messiah

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 8:27–30 and Luke 9:18–22.

16:17a

Jesus replied, “Blessed are you, Simon son of Jonah!”

- ¶ Jesus replied, “Simon son of Jonah, God has blessed you,
- ¶ Then Jesus said to him, “Simon son of Jonah, you are favored by God.

Jesus replied: Jesus responded to Simon Peter's answer. He did not answer a question. So in some languages, it will be more natural to use a different verb here. For example:

Jesus answered him (ESV)

Jesus said to him

Blessed are you: The word Blessed here refers to God doing good to someone or putting that person in a good position. Use the same word for Blessed here as you used in 5:3-11, 11:6 and 13:16a.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

God has blessed you

You are favored

God has favored you

God has done good to you

Simon son of Jonah: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates literally as son of Jonah is transliterated in some English versions. For example:

Simon Bar-Jonah (ESV)

Most English versions translate this word as son of Jonah or "Bar-Jonah." But the GNT and NLT translate this word as "son of John." This is probably based on John 1:42. (The names Jonah and John are spelled similarly in the Greek.) It is recommended that you use the name Jonah.

In some languages, it will be more natural to put this name first in the quote in 16:17a. For example:

Simon son of Jonah, you are blessed

16:17b

For this was not revealed to you by flesh and blood,

- because no human being showed this/that to you.
- No one of this earth has made known this truth to you.

For this was not revealed to you by flesh and blood: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For indicates that 16:17b is the reason that Simon

is blessed. The result is in 16:17a. In some languages, it may be more natural to put the reason before the result. For example:

^{17b}Flesh and blood has not revealed this to you.

^{17a}That is why you are blessed.

this was not revealed to you by flesh and blood: The phrase flesh and blood is a figurative way of speaking about human beings. It implies that a spirit being like God revealed to Simon Peter that Jesus is the Christ. Human beings did not reveal it to him.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

No human revealed this to you (GW)

no one of this earth showed that to you

no person taught you that (NCV)

this: The word this refers to Simon Peter's words in 16:16a-b, "You are the Christ, the Son of the living God."

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

this truth (GNT)

this understanding/knowledge

that I am the Christ

16:17c

but by My Father in heaven.

- Rather/Instead, my Father in heaven showed it to you.
- My heavenly Father did.

but: There is a contrast between who did not reveal this to Peter, and who did reveal it to him. The BSB indicates this contrast with the conjunction but.

Here are some other ways to indicate this contrast:

instead

rather

In some languages, a conjunction is not needed to indicate this contrast.

by My Father in heaven: The words “revealed to you” from 16:17b are implied but not repeated here. In some languages, it may be more natural to repeat some or all of the words. For example:

my Father who is in heaven revealed this to you

it was given to you directly by my Father in heaven
(GNT)

my heavenly Father showed you that I am the
Christ

My Father in heaven: This phrase refers to God.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

my Father God in heaven

my heavenly Father

my Father who lives in heaven

General Comment on 16:17a–c

In some languages, it may be more natural to state the positive clause (16:17c) first and the negative clause (16:17b) second. For example:

^{17c}My Father who is in heaven revealed this to you.

^{17b}Flesh and blood did not.

In some languages, it may also be natural to put part of 16:17a (the result) at the end of the verse after 16:17b–c (the reason). For example:

^{17a}Simon son of Jonah, ^{17c}my heavenly Father showed that to you. ^{17b}No one of this earth showed it to you. ^{17a}So you are blessed.

16:17a–c

(reordered) Jesus said, “Simon son of Jonah, my Father in heaven showed this to you. No human being showed this to you. That is why you are blessed.”

Matthew 16:18

Section 16:13–20: Peter declared that Jesus is the Christ

In this section, Peter declared that Jesus is the Messiah. Jesus agreed with Peter that he was the Messiah. But then he told the disciples that they must not yet

tell this truth to other people. Jesus also described the community which he was creating—the church. And he told them that Peter would have a very important part in it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Peter’s Confession of Christ (NIV)

Peter declared his belief that Jesus is the Messiah

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 8:27–30 and Luke 9:18–22.

16:18a

And I tell you that you are Peter,

- Me, I tell you that your name is Peter,
- I declare to you that you are Peter the rock.

And I tell you that: Peter had said something important about Jesus (16:16). Here Jesus said something important to him. The pronoun I is emphasized in the Greek. If there is a way to emphasize the pronoun in your language here, you may want to do so. Here is an example in English:

And I, I tell you

you are Peter: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Peter means “rock.” Jesus named Simon “Rock” (Peter) when he first met him (in John 1:42). Here Jesus used the meaning of the name as a basis for his metaphor in 16:18b.

This word probably refers to a large rock or a rock that no one can move. In the following metaphor, Jesus talked about building his church upon this rock. A stone that a person can throw or move is probably not meant.

In the next clause (16:18b), Jesus used the meaning of the word. So you should make the connection between the name Peter (16:18a) and its meaning rock (16:18b) clear. Here are some other ways to translate this:

- Use both the name Peter and the word “rock” to explain the meaning of the name in your translation. For example:

you are Peter, the Rock (REB)

- Use the name Peter and explain in a footnote that the name means “rock.” For example:

you are named Peter

your name is Peter A sample footnote on Peter is:

The meaning of the word translated Peter is “rock/boulder.”

16:18b

and on this rock I will build My church,

- the flat rock on whom I will build/establish my group of followers,
- Just like a man builds his house on a rock foundation to make it strong, I will use you, Peter the rock, to help my group of believers be strong.

and on this rock I will build: Here the word rock refers to a large rock on which a person can build a house. Building a house on a rock foundation makes the house strong and prevents it from falling down.

Christians have different opinions about who or what the phrase this rock refers to. Here are the three main interpretations:

1. It refers to Peter.
2. It refers to Peter’s confession in 16:16a–b that Jesus is the Christ the son of the living God.
3. It refers to Jesus.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is the interpretation that most modern commentators follow. This interpretation is followed by France, page 622; Blomberg, page 252; Hagner, page 470; Osborne, page 627; Davies and Allison, page 627; Turner, pages 404–405; and Wilkins, page 564. God used Peter to lead the early church and help it to grow and become established.

I will build My church: This clause is a metaphor. In this metaphor, Jesus compared the establishing of his group of Christian believers to the building of a building. He was talking about “building up” or “increasing” the number of believers and making them strong in their faith.

Jesus was not referring to building a literal church building. Remember that in the New Testament, the word “church” refers to a group of believers. It does not refer to a building.

Here are some other ways to translate this entire clause:

and on this rock foundation I will build my church
(GNT)

the flat rock on whom I will build my group of believers

In some languages, it will not be possible to say that Jesus “will build his group of believers.” In such languages, the challenge will be to find expressions for build and church that will go together.

One way to do this is to change the metaphor to a simile and make some parts of it more explicit. For example:

Like a man builds his house on a rock foundation, I will make you the foundation/support for my group of followers

Just like people build on a rock foundation to make a building strong, I will use you, Peter the rock, to help my group of believers be strong.

16:18c

and the gates of Hades will not prevail against it.

- and even the power of death will not defeat it.
- Satan will not have victory over my group.

gates of Hades: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as gates of Hades is a figure of speech. It refers to “the power of death” or “death” itself. For example:

the power of death (NCV)

death (GNT)

This phrase can also refer to the person who rules over death. For example:

Satan

power of Satan

evil powers

will not prevail against it: The Greek word that the BSB translates as prevail against refers to winning a victory over something, or defeating it.

The pronoun it refers to the church of Jesus. The church which Jesus will build will never be defeated or destroyed.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

will not overcome it (NIV)

will not be able to defeat it (NCV)

will not conquer it (NLT)

will not win a victory over the church

Matthew 16:19

Section 16:13–20: Peter declared that Jesus is the Christ

In this section, Peter declared that Jesus is the Messiah. Jesus agreed with Peter that he was the Messiah. But then he told the disciples that they must not yet tell this truth to other people. Jesus also described the community which he was creating—the church. And he told them that Peter would have a very important part in it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Peter's Confession of Christ (NIV)

Peter declared his belief that Jesus is the Messiah

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 8:27–30 and Luke 9:18–22.

16:19a

I will give you the keys of the kingdom of heaven.

- I will give to you^(sing) the keys of the kingdom of the one who lives in heaven.
- I will give to you^(sing) authority/power in the kingship/ rule of God.

I will give you the keys: Many commentators agree that the word keys here represents “power and authority.” Jesus gave Peter authority in the kingdom of heaven. He gave him the authority to bind and loose things. Jesus did not give Peter literal keys.

Here are some other ways to translate the word keys:

- Translate the word keys literally and include a footnote to explain what it represents. For example:

I will give you the keys

I will give to you the things to open the door

Here is a sample footnote:

“Keys” represent the authority of the person in charge of a house. He carries the keys which allow him to open and close all the doors in that house. Here Jesus gave Peter the authority to bind and loose things in the kingdom of heaven.

- Translate what the word keys represents. For example:

I will give you authority

the kingdom of heaven: When you translate the phrase the kingdom of heaven, there are two issues to consider:

Issue 1: The meaning of heaven

In the phrase the kingdom of heaven, the word heaven is a figure of speech called metonymy. A metonymy is a word that refers to something else that is related to the word. Here, heaven refers to God, but it refers to him indirectly by naming the place where he lives and rules. The Jews considered God's name to be so holy that they hesitated to say it. So instead of saying God's name directly, they often used the name of the place where he lives and rules. Because Matthew was writing primarily to Jews, he often used the word heaven to refer to God.

Therefore, the kingdom of heaven means the same thing as “the kingdom of God.” Matthew is the only book that uses the phrase the kingdom of heaven. All the other New Testament books use “the kingdom of God,” and even Matthew uses it five times.

Here are some other ways to translate heaven in this context:

- Make some information explicit. For example:

the one/Lord who lives in heaven

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

God

Issue 2: The meaning of the kingdom of heaven

Both the kingdom of heaven and “the kingdom of God” refer to God ruling over his people. God's rule is not simply giving orders or commands to people. It also includes his protection, care, and blessing for them. God leads, protects, and cares for his people. They obey, trust, and submit to him as their king. The phrase

kingdom of heaven does not refer to a land or country that God rules over.

Here are some other ways to translate the kingdom of heaven:

- As a noun. For example:

the kingdom/rule of the one who lives in heaven

the kingdom of God

God's kingship

the time of God's rule over his people

- As a verbal expression. For example:

God rules his people

God cares for his people as king

16:19b

Whatever you bind on earth will be bound in heaven,

- That which you forbid on earth will be forbidden by God in heaven,
- Anything that you do not allow on earth, God will not allow in heaven.

16:19c

and whatever you loose on earth will be loosed in heaven."

- and that which you permit on earth will be permitted by God in heaven."
- Anything that you allow in earth, God will also allow in heaven."

16:19b-c

Whatever you bind...whatever you loose: The Greek verbs that the BSB translates as bind and loose normally mean "tie" and "untie." Here they are used in a figurative way.

There are several ways to interpret these words. Here are the two main interpretations:

1. They refer to forbidding (binding) or permitting (loosing) various kinds of behavior and doctrine. According to this interpretation, Christ gave Peter the authority to decide which actions/deeds were forbidden and which were permitted.
2. They refer to preventing (binding) or permitting (loosing) people to enter God's kingdom. According

to this interpretation, Christ gave Peter the authority to lock or unlock the door of the kingdom. He could permit some people to enter, and he could prevent others from entering.

Churches interpret this verse in various ways. If possible, you should translate in a general way that will allow either interpretation.

Here are some other ways to translate bind and loose:

don't allow...allow (NCV)

forbid...permit

Whatever: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Whatever can refer to many different kinds of things.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

that which

the things (NCV)

anything (CEV)

you: In Greek, the pronoun you is singular. It refers to Peter.

will be bound in heaven...will be loosed in heaven:

The future passive verbs "will be bound" and "will be loosed" are in the Greek perfect aspect. Commentaries have various interpretations about these future perfect verbs. The majority of English versions translate it with a simple future (exceptions are NASB and NET). The Greek verbs that the BSB translates as will be bound and will be loosed are both passive. The phrase in heaven is a way to refer to something God does. So, these clauses indicate that God will also "bind" and "loose."

Here are some other ways to translate these verbs:

- Use passive verbs. For example:

will be bound by God in heaven...will be loosed by God in heaven

- Use active verbs. For example:

God in heaven will allow....he will not allow (CEV)

Matthew 16:20

Section 16:13–20: Peter declared that Jesus is the Christ

In this section, Peter declared that Jesus is the Messiah. Jesus agreed with Peter that he was the Messiah. But then he told the disciples that they must not yet tell this truth to other people. Jesus also described the community which he was creating—the church. And he told them that Peter would have a very important part in it.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Peter's Confession of Christ (NIV)

Peter declared his belief that Jesus is the Messiah

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 8:27–30 and Luke 9:18–22.

16:20

Then He admonished the disciples not to tell anyone that He was the Christ.

- Then he ordered his disciples to tell no one that he was the Christ.
- Then Jesus warned/told his disciples, “Do not tell anyone that I am the Christ/Messiah.”

He admonished the disciples: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as admonished means “commanded,” “ordered” or “warned.” For example:

Jesus ordered his disciples (GNT)

Jesus warned his followers (NCV)

not to tell anyone that He was the Christ: There is a textual issue here. Many manuscripts include the name “Jesus” here so that it reads, “Jesus the Christ.” However, a few important early manuscripts do not include the name. Only the KJV includes it. It is recommended that you do not include it in your translation. Jesus told the disciples not to tell anyone what Peter had said about him, even though it was true. It was not yet the right time for everyone to hear that he was the Messiah.

Jesus's command is in indirect speech. It may be more natural in some languages to use direct speech. For example:

he warned his disciples not to say to anyone:
“Jesus is the Christ.”

he warned his disciples: “Do not tell anyone that I am the Christ/Messiah.”

the Christ: The phrase the Christ is a title. It is not Jesus's surname. It is the Greek translation of the Hebrew word “Messiah.”

This title also occurs in 16:16a. You should translate it the same way in both places.

Matthew 16:21

Section 16:21–28: Jesus said that he would suffer and be killed

In the previous section, Peter declared that Jesus was the Christ (or Messiah). But Peter and the other disciples did not fully understand what it meant that Jesus was the Messiah. They probably had the same ideas as many other Jews at that time. They thought that the Messiah would be a fighting hero. He would defeat the enemies of Israel and establish a political kingdom.

In this section, Jesus began to try and teach them about the real work of Messiah. He did not come to lead armies and set up a kingdom like other countries. His work was to suffer and die and then be raised back to life again. He also told them that all those who want to follow him should prepare to suffer in the same way. He also promised that the true kingdom was coming very soon.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus foretold/predicted his death and resurrection

Jesus Speaks about His Suffering and Death (CEV)

Jesus Says that He Must Die (NCV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 8:31–9:1 and Luke 9:22–27.

Paragraph 16:21–23

In this paragraph Jesus told his disciples what was going to happen to him. This probably happened soon after the events in the previous paragraph.

16:21a

From that time on Jesus began to show His disciples

- ¶ Beginning at that time, Jesus began to explain to his disciples
- ¶ From that day, Jesus began to clearly tell his disciples
- ¶ From then on, Jesus began telling his disciples what would happen to him. He said, (CEV)

From that time on Jesus began: This phrase marks a transition in the story of Jesus. Here the story changes from the ministry of Jesus to the preparation for his suffering and death. (This same phrase occurs at 4:17 to mark the start of his ministry.)

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

From that time on Jesus began (GW)

Starting from then, Jesus began

From that day, Jesus started

to show: The Greek word that the BSB translates as show can also be translated as “explain” or “make clear.” Jesus had hinted before that he would suffer and die. Now he began to make it clear to his disciples.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

to say plainly (GNT)

to explain (NIV)

to clearly say/tell

16:21b

that He must go to Jerusalem

- that it was necessary for him to go to Jerusalem
- that God required him to go to Jerusalem.
- “I must go to Jerusalem

16:21b–e

that He must: The Greek word that the BSB translates as must is often used to talk about something that God’s will requires. It is sometimes translated in English as “it is necessary.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

that it was necessary for him (NLT)

that it was important/required that he

that it was God’s will for him

There are four things that were “necessary” for Jesus to do at that time to follow God’s will:

1. go to Jerusalem (16:21b)
2. suffer many things (16:21c)
3. be killed by the leaders (16:21d)
4. be raised on the third day (16:21e).

If possible, translate these clauses in a way that it is clear that Jesus must do these four things. For example:

he must go...and suffer...and be killed...and be raised...

In some languages, it may be natural to repeat “must” or “(it is) necessary” as the NIV does in 16:21c. For example:

he must go...and suffer many things...and that he must be killed and...be raised... (NIV)

In some languages, it will be natural to use direct speech for 16:21b–e. For example:

He said, “I must go to Jerusalem. There the nation’s leaders, the chief priests, and the teachers of the Law of Moses will make me suffer terribly. I will be killed, but three days later I will rise to life.” (CEV)

16:21c

and suffer many things at the hands of the elders, chief priests, and scribes,

- and to suffer much at the hands of the elders, the leaders of the priests and the teachers of the Law of Moses.
- There the elders, leading priests and teachers of the Jewish law would make him suffer pain in many ways.
- and suffer many things from the elders and chief priest and teachers of the law.

suffer many things: This is the second thing that Jesus must do.

The Greek word that the BSB translates as many things indicates that Jesus must suffer in different ways.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

suffer a lot (GW)

suffer many terrible things (NLT)

must have many hardships

at the hands of: The phrase at the hands of indicates that the elders, chief priests, and scribes were responsible for the suffering.

Here are some other ways to translate this idea:

from (ESV)

caused by

the elders, chief priests, and scribes: These three groups of men were the leaders of Israel. When Jesus mentioned these three groups, he was probably talking about the Sanhedrin. The Sanhedrin was the ruling body of the Jews.

In some languages, it may be good to include a footnote to make it clear that these groups were the rulers in Israel. Here is a sample footnote:

These three groups of men were the Sanhedrin. The Sanhedrin was the highest ruling body in Israel. These men lived and worked in Jerusalem.

the elders: The Greek word that the BSB translates as elders refers to the civil leaders of the Jews. These leaders were generally older men. People valued older men for their wisdom and experience.

Every location in Israel had elders who served in local governing groups. In Jerusalem the elders were a part of the Sanhedrin, the high council of the nation of Israel.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

the rulers/councilmen

the older Jewish leaders (NCV)

the nation's leaders (CEV)

chief priests: A priest was a religious leader who offered sacrifices to God for the people. Jewish priests led the people in worship at the temple in Jerusalem. The phrase chief priests refers to the leaders among these priests.

Here are some other ways to translate chief priests:

- Use a descriptive term that focuses on the duty of priests. For example:

the leaders of the sacrificers

the elders among the men who offer sacrifices to God

the leaders of those who represent people to God

- Use a local word for priest. This option may be acceptable if the duties of a local priest are similar to those of a Jewish priest. You may need to indicate that the word refers to a Jewish priest. For example:

Jewish people's leading priests/sacrificers

The term chief priests also occurs in 2:4a. You should translate it here as you did there.

scribes: The Greek word that the BSB translates as scribes refers to men who studied, interpreted, and taught the law of Moses. These men were called scribes because their original work was to copy the laws of Moses by hand. (A scribe is someone who copies manuscripts.) In New Testament times, this was no longer their main task.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

teachers of the Law of Moses (CEV)

teachers of religious law (NLT)

teachers of the law (NIV)

experts in the law

Translate this term in the same way as you did in 12:38a and 15:1a.

16:21d and that He must be killed

- It was also necessary for him to be killed,
- The leaders would cause him to die.
- They will kill me,

be killed: This is the third thing that Jesus must do. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this more explicit. For example:

and he must be killed

it is necessary for him to be killed

it was God's will for him to be killed

This verb is passive. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

be put to death (NJB)

- Use an active verb. For example:

the leaders must kill him

people would kill him

16:21e

and on the third day be raised to life.

- and to be raised back to life by God on the third day.
- But God would raise him from death to life on the third day.
- but God will raise me to life on the third day."

on the third day be raised to life: This is the fourth thing that Jesus must do. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this more explicit. For example:

and he must be raised on the third day

and it is necessary for him to be raised on the third day

and it is God's will for him to be raised on the third day

be raised to life: The verb be raised to life means "raised from the dead" or "brought back to life."

This verb is passive. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

then be raised from the dead (NCV)

then he must be raised back to life by God

- Use an active verb. For example:

God will raise him from death to life

God will cause him to live again

- Use another type of verb. For example:

he will become alive again

he will live again

Matthew 16:22

Section 16:21–28: Jesus said that he would suffer and be killed

In the previous section, Peter declared that Jesus was the Christ (or Messiah). But Peter and the other disciples did not fully understand what it meant that Jesus was the Messiah. They probably had the same ideas as many other Jews at that time. They thought that the Messiah would be a fighting hero. He would defeat the enemies of Israel and establish a political kingdom.

In this section, Jesus began to try and teach them about the real work of Messiah. He did not come to lead armies and set up a kingdom like other countries. His work was to suffer and die and then be raised back to life again. He also told them that all those who want to follow him should prepare to suffer in the same way. He also promised that the true kingdom was coming very soon.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus foretold/predicted his death and resurrection

Jesus Speaks about His Suffering and Death (CEV)

Jesus Says that He Must Die (NCV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 8:31–9:1 and Luke 9:22–27.

Paragraph 16:21–23

In this paragraph Jesus told his disciples what was going to happen to him. This probably happened soon after the events in the previous paragraph.

16:22a

Peter took Him aside and began to rebuke Him.

- Then Peter took him to the side and started to rebuke him by saying,
- Then Peter led Jesus apart from the other disciples and began to scold him for talking like that. He said,

Peter took Him aside: These words mean that Peter took/led Jesus a short distance away from the other disciples. He did this to speak to Jesus in private.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

took him on one side (JBP)

led/pulled him to the side

began to: In this context, the words began to mean “started but did not finish.” It probably implies that Peter wanted to say more, but Jesus interrupted him.

Here is another way to translate this:

started to (NJB)

rebuke Him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as rebuke also means “scold.” Peter scolded Jesus because of what Jesus had said. It shows how strongly Peter felt.

The Jews of that time expected that the Messiah would be a victorious military leader. Peter probably did not think that the Messiah would die before he accomplished that victory. So he told Jesus not to say these things about himself.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

scolded him

told him to stop talking like that (CEV)

16:22b

“Far be it from You, Lord!” he said. “This shall never happen to You!”

- “Lord, God forbid it! This will never happen to you!”
- “Lord, may God save you from those things! They will never happen to you!”

Far be it from You, Lord!: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as Far be it from You is more literally “Mercy to you.” This implies, “May God be merciful and spare you from this.” Another way to say it is, “May God never allow this to happen to you.” It is an expression of shock and denial.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

God save you from those things, Lord! (NCV)

Lord, may God forbid it!

This shall never happen to You!: This clause means almost the same thing as “Far be it from You.” Saying the same thing in two ways makes Peter’s words stronger.

Peter was shocked and sad to think that Jesus might suffer and die. The Greek uses two negative words to make this clause very strongly negative.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

In no way will that happen to you!

Those things will never happen to you! (NCV)

Matthew 16:23

Section 16:21–28: Jesus said that he would suffer and be killed

In the previous section, Peter declared that Jesus was the Christ (or Messiah). But Peter and the other disciples did not fully understand what it meant that Jesus was the Messiah. They probably had the same ideas as many other Jews at that time. They thought that the Messiah would be a fighting hero. He would defeat the enemies of Israel and establish a political kingdom.

In this section, Jesus began to try and teach them about the real work of Messiah. He did not come to lead armies and set up a kingdom like other countries. His work was to suffer and die and then be raised back to life again. He also told them that all those who want to follow him should prepare to suffer in the same way. He also promised that the true kingdom was coming very soon.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus foretold/predicted his death and resurrection

Jesus Speaks about His Suffering and Death (CEV)

Jesus Says that He Must Die (NCV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 8:31–9:1 and Luke 9:22–27.

Paragraph 16:21–23

In this paragraph Jesus told his disciples what was going to happen to him. This probably happened soon after the events in the previous paragraph.

16:23a

But Jesus turned and said to Peter, “Get behind Me, Satan!”

- Jesus turned toward Peter and said, “Satan, get out of my way!”
- Jesus faced Peter and said to him, “You are like Satan. Depart out of my sight!”

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *But* often shows contrast. Here it introduces the words that Jesus said. These words show that he did not agree with what Peter has just said. Some English versions do not translate this conjunction.

Jesus turned and said to Peter: Peter may have started to rebuke Jesus while they walked side by side and away from the other disciples. Here, when Jesus wanted to rebuke/scold Peter, he turned and faced him.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus turned to face Peter and said to him

Jesus faced Peter and said

Get behind Me, Satan!: This is a rebuke. Jesus rebuked Peter for saying things that came from Satan. Peter had tempted Jesus not to follow God’s will, and Jesus strongly rejected that idea.

These words do not mean that Jesus ordered Peter to go away. He told Peter not to stop him from following God’s will.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Get out of my way, Satan! (GW)

Out of my sight, Satan! (REB)

In some languages, it may be confusing for Jesus to call Peter Satan. If that is true in your language, you may need to make the meaning more explicit. For example:

You are like Satan. Get away from me.

That idea from Satan should go/be far from me!

What you are saying is from Satan. Get out of my way!

For help to translate the word Satan, see the Note at 4:10a.

16:23b

You are a stumbling block to Me.

- You are an obstacle in my way,
- You are blocking my path.
- You are trying to stop me from following God’s path/plan for me.

You are a stumbling block to Me: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *stumbling block* more literally means “a trap” (as in the NLT). This refers to a stone or other thing that blocks a path or causes a person to stumble. Peter was a stumbling block because he was trying to stop Jesus from following God’s plan. It is sometimes translated in English as “hindrance” (as in the ESV). It is often used figuratively to refer to something that tempts a person into sin.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

You are an obstacle in my way (GNT)

You are blocking my path

You are trying to stop me from following God’s plan/path

You are tempting me to sin (GW)

16:23c

For you do not have in mind the things of God, but the things of men.”

- because you^[sing] are not thinking about this like God thinks, but/rather like a human thinks.”
- Your thoughts are human thoughts. They are not God’s thoughts.”
- The way that you are thinking is what humans want. It is not what God wants.”

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *For* introduces the basis for the things that Jesus said in 16:23b. Peter was hindering Jesus (16:23b) for/because he was not thinking the way that God thinks (16:23c).

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

because (NJB)

The reason I say this is

Some English versions allow the context to indicate this connection. They do not explicitly translate this conjunction. Translate this connection in a natural way in your language.

you do not have in mind the things of God: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as have in mind means “think.” The words that Peter said in 16:22 came from his thoughts as a human being. They were not God’s thoughts or God’s will.

Peter thought that it was important for the Messiah to have a victory in the same way that people have victories. But God had a different plan.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

You aren’t thinking the way God thinks (GW)

these thoughts of yours don’t come from God (GNT)

the way you are thinking, it is not what God wants

you: The pronoun you here refers to Peter. It does not refer to Satan. Be sure that this is clear in your translation. For example, you might say:

you, Peter

the things of God: In this context, the phrase the things of God refers to God’s thoughts, plans and will. It does not refer to physical things.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the way God thinks (GW)

but: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between “not thinking the things of God,” and “thinking the things of man.” Languages have different ways to indicate this negative-positive type of contrast. Here are some of the ways:

- With the conjunction but.
- With a conjunction other than but. This is a common way in English to show this type of contrast. For example:

rather

on the contrary

Instead

- With no conjunction. For example:

You are not thinking the things of God. You are thinking the things of man.

the things of men: Some words from the previous clause are implied but not repeated here. In some languages, it may be more natural to repeat some of those words from the previous clause. For example:

you are thinking the way that humans think

these thoughts come from a human way of thinking

things of men: The Greek word that the BSB translates as men refers to “humans.” Here it does not refer only to males.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the way humans think (GW)

from a human point of view (NLT)

as people think

General Comment on 16:23c

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of the clauses and put the positive clause first. For example:

you think like everyone else and not like God (CEV)

Matthew 16:24

Section 16:21–28: Jesus said that he would suffer and be killed

In the previous section, Peter declared that Jesus was the Christ (or Messiah). But Peter and the other disciples did not fully understand what it meant that Jesus was the Messiah. They probably had the same ideas as many other Jews at that time. They thought that the Messiah would be a fighting hero. He would defeat the enemies of Israel and establish a political kingdom.

In this section, Jesus began to try and teach them about the real work of Messiah. He did not come to lead armies and set up a kingdom like other countries. His work was to suffer and die and then be raised

back to life again. He also told them that all those who want to follow him should prepare to suffer in the same way. He also promised that the true kingdom was coming very soon.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus foretold/predicted his death and resurrection

Jesus Speaks about His Suffering and Death (CEV)

Jesus Says that He Must Die (NCV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 8:31–9:1 and Luke 9:22–27.

Paragraph 16:24–28

In this paragraph Jesus spoke to all the disciples, including Peter. He is also speaking to all of us. He wanted to teach about how to understand things from God's perspective. He also hinted how the lives of those who follow him will change.

16:24a

Then Jesus told His disciples, "If anyone wants to come after Me,

- ¶ Then Jesus said to his disciples, "If anyone wants to follow me,
- ¶ Then Jesus told his followers/learners, "Those people who want to follow me and become my disciples/learners

If anyone: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *If* does not indicate uncertainty. So this phrase doesn't say that Jesus did not know whether anyone wanted to follow him. Jesus used this word to refer to all those who want to follow him.

Here are some other ways to translate it without making it seem uncertain:

Anyone who

Those who (GW)

The people who

anyone: Jesus was speaking to the disciples who were with him, but he talked about people everywhere at any time. Translate this in a way to include any person.

come after Me: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as *come after Me* refers to becoming a disciple of Jesus. Being a disciple often meant following a teacher around from place to place and learning from him.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

to be my follower (NLT)

to follow me (NCV)

to be my disciple

16:24b–d

he must deny himself and take up his cross and follow Me:

The Greek phrases that the BSB translates as *he must deny himself and take up his cross and follow Me* are three indirect commands. A person who desires to be one of Jesus' disciples must do three things:

1. He must deny himself
2. He must take up his cross

He must follow Jesus as a disciple.

Indicate in a natural way in your language that a person must do each of these actions in order to be a follower of Jesus.

16:24b

he must deny himself

- he must refuse to do what he wants to do,
- must say "no" to their own selfish desires,

he must deny himself: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as *deny himself* means "refuse to do what he wants to do." A disciple of Jesus must give up the right to do what he wants to do. He must do what his master wants him to do.

Here are some other ways to translate *deny himself*:

you must forget about yourself (CEV)

must say no to the things they want (GW)

he must let go of his own desires

he must not do what he wishes/wants to do but what I wish

In some languages, there will be an idiom or figure of speech for this. For example:

turn his back on himself

remove from his thinking the things he wants to do

16:24c and take up his cross

- and carry his cross which means to suffer and die for me,
- and they must be willing/ready to suffer and die,

take up his cross: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as take up means “carry.” For example:

carry your cross (GNT)

This same phrase occurs in 10:38a.

This phrase refers to the way that Roman soldiers made criminals suffer and die. They forced a condemned criminal to pick up a large wooden cross. He had to carry it to the place where he would be put to death. Carrying a heavy cross was painful. Then the soldiers nailed him on the cross to die.

In this context, Jesus used this phrase figuratively. He meant that anyone who wanted to become his disciple must be willing to suffer and die. Jesus was willing to suffer and carry his cross to the place where he died. So a believer must also be willing to suffer for Christ even if it means dying.

Here are some other ways to translate the phrase take up his cross:

- Translate the figure of speech literally and add a footnote that explains the meaning. Here is a sample footnote:

In the time of Jesus, a person who was condemned to be nailed to a cross was forced to carry the cross. He carried it to the place where he would be nailed to it. So Jesus was saying that a person who wants to be his follower must be ready to suffer and die.

- Translate the figure of speech and also explain the meaning in the text. For example:

he must be willing to carry his cross, meaning to suffer and die for me

- Translate the meaning directly without using a figure of speech. For example:

They must be willing even to give up their lives (NCV)

must willing to suffer and even die for me If you follow this option, think about adding a footnote that gives Jesus’ literal words.

16:24d and follow Me.

- and follow me and be my disciple.
- and they must become my disciples/learners.

and follow Me: This phrase is a figurative expression that means “be my disciple.” It means the same thing as “come after Me” in 16:24a. Disciples usually followed their teacher wherever he went. By doing this, they learned from his example and his teaching.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

follow me and be my disciple

be my disciple

Matthew 16:25

Section 16:21–28: Jesus said that he would suffer and be killed

In the previous section, Peter declared that Jesus was the Christ (or Messiah). But Peter and the other disciples did not fully understand what it meant that Jesus was the Messiah. They probably had the same ideas as many other Jews at that time. They thought that the Messiah would be a fighting hero. He would defeat the enemies of Israel and establish a political kingdom.

In this section, Jesus began to try and teach them about the real work of Messiah. He did not come to lead armies and set up a kingdom like other countries. His work was to suffer and die and then be raised back to life again. He also told them that all those who want to follow him should prepare to suffer in the same way. He also promised that the true kingdom was coming very soon.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus foretold/predicted his death and resurrection

Jesus Speaks about His Suffering and Death (CEV)

Jesus Says that He Must Die (NCV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 8:31–9:1 and Luke 9:22–27.

Paragraph 16:24–28

In this paragraph Jesus spoke to all the disciples, including Peter. He is also speaking to all of us. He wanted to teach about how to understand things from God's perspective. He also hinted how the lives of those who follow him will change.

16:25

This verse is similar to Luke 9:24, Luke 17:33, and Matthew 10:39. If you have already translated any of these verses, you may want to look there for ideas in translating this verse.

This verse is a paradox. A paradox is something that seems to disagree with itself. It is not usually possible to save something by losing it.

In this verse Jesus talked about two different types of "life." One type is "physical life." It is our life on earth that is filled with our wants and desires. This life ends with the death of the physical body. The other type of life is "spiritual life." It is eternal life that God gives to his people. Jesus said that if we want to keep our physical life, we will lose our chance for eternal life. But the opposite is true if we are willing to risk our physical life in order to follow him. If we are willing to do that, we will have the chance to receive eternal life.

16:25a

For whoever wants to save his life will lose it,

- The reason I say this is if a person wants to save/preserve his life, he will lose eternal life.
- People who want to continue to live on earth will not receive life that never ends.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For introduces the basis for what Jesus said in 16:24.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

Because

The reason I say this is

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either.

whoever wants to save his life: This clause refers to a person who wants to keep his life on earth. He wants to avoid physical death. He is not willing to deny himself and suffer for Jesus (16:24). Instead, he wants to save or preserve his own way of life.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Those who want to save their lives (NCV)

if you want to save your own life (GNT)

In some languages it may be necessary to translate life as a verb. For example:

whoever tries/seeks to continue living

whoever: Jesus was speaking to the disciples who were with him. But he talked about people everywhere at any time. Translate this in a way to include any person.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

a person who

people/anyone who

if you

will lose it: This phrase refers to losing true life, that is, life with God that lasts forever. The person will not experience that life either here on earth or in heaven after he dies. He will finally lose his physical life because no one can live forever. He will also lose the chance to gain true life with God.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

will not get true life

will not receive eternal life

In some languages, a literal translation of lose may imply that a person misplaces something and cannot find it. It may also imply that a person who already has eternal life will lose it. Be careful that you do not imply either of those things.

16:25b

but whoever loses his life for My sake will find it.

- But if he surrenders his life for me, he will find/receive eternal life.
- But people who are willing to die because they follow me, they will receive life that never ends.

whoever loses his life for My sake: This clause refers to the person who is willing to suffer and die because of Jesus. This person gives up his right to follow his own desires in order to follow Jesus. Some of these people will even die because they believe in Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

whoever lets go of his life for me

if a person dies because of me

a person who does not love his own life because he follows me

will find it: The pronoun it refers to a person's eternal life with God. The person who gives up his earthly life for Jesus will not experience spiritual death. He will gain true life with God in this world and in heaven.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

will find true life (NLT96)

will gain/experience eternal life

will have true life (NCV)

Here, the word find does not imply that something was lost. In this context it means to get or receive something.

Matthew 16:26

Section 16:21–28: Jesus said that he would suffer and be killed

In the previous section, Peter declared that Jesus was the Christ (or Messiah). But Peter and the other disciples did not fully understand what it meant that Jesus was the Messiah. They probably had the same ideas as many other Jews at that time. They thought that the Messiah would be a fighting hero. He would defeat the enemies of Israel and establish a political kingdom.

In this section, Jesus began to try and teach them about the real work of Messiah. He did not come to lead armies and set up a kingdom like other countries. His work was to suffer and die and then be raised back to life again. He also told them that all those

who want to follow him should prepare to suffer in the same way. He also promised that the true kingdom was coming very soon.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus foretold/predicted his death and resurrection

Jesus Speaks about His Suffering and Death (CEV)

Jesus Says that He Must Die (NCV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 8:31–9:1 and Luke 9:22–27.

Paragraph 16:24–28

In this paragraph Jesus spoke to all the disciples, including Peter. He is also speaking to all of us. He wanted to teach about how to understand things from God's perspective. He also hinted how the lives of those who follow him will change.

16:26a–b

(reordered) If a person gets/owns the entire world but does not get eternal life, is there any benefit to him? No!

What will it profit a man if he gains the whole world, yet forfeits his soul?: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus asked this question to emphasize something that everyone should know is true. If someone gets the world's riches but cannot live forever with God, it is worth nothing.

Here are some other ways to translate this emphasis:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

And what do you benefit if you gain the whole world but lose your own soul? (NLT)

- As a question with the response supplied. For example:

Will you gain anything if you own the whole world but lose your life with God? Of course not!

- As a statement. For example:

It is worth nothing for them to have the whole world if they lose their souls. (NCV)

Translate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

16:26a

What will it profit a man if he gains the whole world,

- Is there any benefit for a person if he owns/gets the whole world
- It is worth nothing for a man to get everything in the world

The Greek conjunction that begins this verse is left untranslated in the BSB, but many English versions translate it as “For.” It introduces another basis for Jesus’ statement in 16:24. There he says that a disciple must deny himself and take up his cross and follow Jesus (16:24). Here he says that that is true for/because he will not profit from gaining the entire world (16:26).

The only thing of true value is eternal life. Jesus gives eternal life to those who follow him.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

Because

Let me further explain

Some English versions, such as the BSB, do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either.

What will it profit a man: The Greek word that the BSB translates as profit means “benefit,” “help,” or “be of use to.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

what do you benefit (NLT)

What good will it do for people (GW)

what use/help will it be for a person

a man: The Greek word that the BSB translates as man refers to a human being. It does not just refer to a male.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

a person (NET)

people (GW)

he gains the whole world: This phrase refers to owning the entire world and everything in it. This is a hyperbole. It refers to being very successful in earning money and obtaining material things.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

own the whole world (CEV)

possesses/acquires everything in the world

becomes the richest person in the world

16:26b

yet forfeits his soul?

- but loses his life with God? No!
- and not get/receive life that is forever.

forfeits his soul: The Greek word that the BSB translates as forfeits means “loses.”

There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as soul:

1. It refers to a person’s soul. It is the part of a person that lives even after his body dies. So the phrase “forfeits/loses his soul” is a figurative of speech that means “dies spiritually.” It refers to “losing eternal life” or “losing his life in heaven.” For example:

they lose their souls (NCV) (BSB, NIV, ESV, NLT, NCV, KJV, NASB)

1. It refers to a person’s life (on earth). So the phrase “forfeits/loses his life” is a figure of speech that means “dies physically.” For example:

lose their lives (GW) (GNT, NET, RSV, GW, REB, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). In 16:25, Jesus moved from talking about physical life to talking about spiritual life. Here in 16:26, he continued to talk about spiritual life.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

loses his life with God

fails to get eternal life

does not get/receive life that has no end

General Comment on 16:26a–b

In some language, it will be more natural to change the order of some of the clauses in 16:26a–b. For example:

If a man gains the whole world but loses his own soul, is there any profit in that?

If a man owns the entire world but does not get eternal life, there is no benefit.

16:26c**Or what can a man give in exchange for his soul?**

- Or, to say it another way, what can a person trade/exchange for his life with God? Nothing!
- It is certainly not possible for a person to give/pay enough money to buy his life in heaven.

Or: Here the word Or introduces a rhetorical question that says something similar to the rhetorical question in 16:25a–b. This rhetorical question is another way to make a similar point as the first one.

Normally the word “or” links two things, and only one of them is correct/preferred. Or the listener is supposed to choose one of them. For example, “Did he go to Jerusalem or Bethlehem?” However, in this verse, Or is not used in that way. The response to both questions is “No” or “Nothing.”

Here is another way to introduce this second rhetorical question:

Or to say/ask it another way

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, a conjunction will not be necessary here either.

what can a man give in exchange for his soul?: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus asked this question to emphasize that nothing can buy true life with God. There is nothing that a person can give to God that would be a fair trade for his life.

Here are some other ways to translate this emphasis:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

what can a person give in exchange for his life?
(NET)

- As a question with the response supplied. For example:

Is there anything that a person can give to God so that God gives him eternal life in return? No!

- As a statement. For example:

It is certainly impossible for a person to pay God enough so that God will give him eternal life.

Translate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

give in exchange for his soul: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as give in exchange refers to the way people traded things before there was money. They traded/exchanged one thing for something else of equal value.

Here, Jesus said that nothing has enough value to be an equal trade for eternal life. That is even true if you had all the riches of the world. No one is able to pay enough to buy true life.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

there is nothing a person can give in trade for his life with God

What can a person trade/exchange to get eternal life?

Can a person pay enough money to buy his life in heaven?

Matthew 16:27**Section 16:21–28: Jesus said that he would suffer and be killed**

In the previous section, Peter declared that Jesus was the Christ (or Messiah). But Peter and the other disciples did not fully understand what it meant that Jesus was the Messiah. They probably had the same ideas as many other Jews at that time. They thought that the Messiah would be a fighting hero. He would defeat the enemies of Israel and establish a political kingdom.

In this section, Jesus began to try and teach them about the real work of Messiah. He did not come to lead armies and set up a kingdom like other countries. His work was to suffer and die and then be raised back to life again. He also told them that all those who want to follow him should prepare to suffer in the same way. He also promised that the true kingdom was coming very soon.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus foretold/predicted his death and resurrection

Jesus Speaks about His Suffering and Death (CEV)

Jesus Says that He Must Die (NCV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 8:31–9:1 and Luke 9:22–27.

Paragraph 16:24–28

In this paragraph Jesus spoke to all the disciples, including Peter. He is also speaking to all of us. He wanted to teach about how to understand things from God's perspective. He also hinted how the lives of those who follow him will change.

16:27a

For the Son of Man will come

- The Son of Man will indeed come
- I, the Son of Man, will certainly come.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *For* introduces another basis for Jesus' statement in 16:24. There he says that a disciple must deny himself and take up his cross and follow Jesus (16:24). Here he says that that is true *for/because* God will judge people according to their deeds.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

Because

The reason is that

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either.

the Son of Man: In Matthew, this phrase first occurs in 8:20b. See the Note there for more information on translating this phrase. This phrase last occurs in 16:13b. You should translate it here as you did there.

will come: There are three ways to interpret the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as *will come*:

1. It means that the Son of Man will certainly come. For example:

is going to come (NIV) (NIV, ESV, RSV, NJB, NASB, REB)

1. It means that the Son of Man will soon come. For example:

will soon come (CEV) (GNT, CEV)

1. It simply means that the Son of Man will come at some point in the future.

will come (NET) (BSB, NET, GW, NLT, JBP, NCV, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is the best way to understand the Greek phrase.

with His angels: Here the pronoun *His* refers to Jesus. Jesus was saying that he will come with his angels. Nolland on page 694 says, "Mark's 'the holy angels' has become 'his angels,' which after 13:41 is probably to be taken as 'the Son of Man's angels' (cf. also 24:31) rather than 'the Father's angels.'"

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

I the Son of Man will come with my angels

For help in translating the word *angels*, see the note in 13:39c.

16:27b

in His Father's glory with His angels,

- in/with his Father's glory/greatness with his angels.
- I will come surrounded by the honor/authority of my Father and with my angels.

in His Father's glory: The phrase in the glory of his Father indicates that Jesus will have/show the glory/greatness of his Father. When people see him come, they will see the same power, greatness and brightness that his Father has. As a person is dressed in clothes, Jesus will come in glory.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

with his Father's glory/greatness

in the middle of the honor/power of his Father

surrounded by the authority of his Father

His Father's: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *Father's* is the ordinary word used to refer to a male parent. By using a term like this, Jesus said something

about his relationship to God. He said that it is like the relationship between a human father and son. But it does not say that God is just like a human father. It also does not say that he created/produced Jesus in the way a human father produces a son.

In your translation you should use the ordinary term for father, just as Jesus did. If the people in your area might misunderstand the term in this context, you might add a footnote to help them understand. For instance:

Jesus spoke about God as his Father, but this does not mean that God gave birth to him. Instead, the term refers to a relationship between God as Father and Jesus as Son. Their relationship is close and intimate like a human father and son.

Here is another way to translate this word:

heavenly Father

glory: The word glory refers to qualities connected with brightness and brilliance. This sort of brightness is connected with things which are powerful, like the sun. It is also connected with things which are valuable, like sparkling jewels or shiny gold.

We can also use these qualities to describe people or God. They describe how they look, how they act and what people say about them.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

majesty/greatness

power/authority

splendor/radiance

16:27c

and then He will repay each one according to what he has done.

- He will give each person what he deserves based on what he did.
- At that time I will reward the people who have done good, and I will punish the people who have done bad.

repay each one: The Greek word that the BSB translates as repay includes both the idea of:

1. rewarding those who have done good, and
2. punishing those who have done evil.

Your translation of this word should include both meanings.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

give each person what he deserves

reward or punish each person

according to: The Greek word the BSB translates as according to indicates that a person's reward or punishment is based on what he has done.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

based on (GW)

matching

what he has done: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as what he has done is more literally "his deed" or "his activity." It probably refers to the person's decision to deny himself and take up his cross. Or it may refer to the whole of the person's life after that decision to follow Jesus. So, it is a restatement of what Jesus said in 16:25–26.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

his deeds (GNT)

his behavior

the good or bad he has done

the way he has lived

Matthew 16:28

Section 16:21–28: Jesus said that he would suffer and be killed

In the previous section, Peter declared that Jesus was the Christ (or Messiah). But Peter and the other disciples did not fully understand what it meant that Jesus was the Messiah. They probably had the same ideas as many other Jews at that time. They thought that the Messiah would be a fighting hero. He would defeat the enemies of Israel and establish a political kingdom.

In this section, Jesus began to try and teach them about the real work of Messiah. He did not come to lead armies and set up a kingdom like other countries. His work was to suffer and die and then be raised

back to life again. He also told them that all those who want to follow him should prepare to suffer in the same way. He also promised that the true kingdom was coming very soon.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus foretold/predicted his death and resurrection

Jesus Speaks about His Suffering and Death (CEV)

Jesus Says that He Must Die (NCV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 8:31–9:1 and Luke 9:22–27.

Paragraph 16:24–28

In this paragraph Jesus spoke to all the disciples, including Peter. He is also speaking to all of us. He wanted to teach about how to understand things from God's perspective. He also hinted how the lives of those who follow him will change.

16:28a

Truly I tell you, some who are standing here will not taste death

- I tell you^(plur) with certainty that some people standing here will not die
- I assure you that some of you standing here right now will not die (NLT96)

Truly I tell you: Jesus often used these words. They first occur in 5:18a. They last occur in 13:17a. You should translate these words here as you did there.

Jesus used these words introduce a statement that he wanted to emphasize. These words indicated that the following statement was important and totally reliable, and people should listen carefully to it. Sometimes they introduced a serious warning or prediction.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

- As a phrase before Jesus' statement. For example:

I assure you (GNT)

Listen to this:

Let me tell you this:

- As a phrase at the end of Jesus' statement. For example:

There are some standing here who will not die until they see the Son of Man coming in his kingdom. That is the truth.

Your language may have another way to emphasize a statement or to tell people to listen with special attention. If so, think about using it here.

some who are standing here: This clause refers to the disciples who were near Jesus. It does not mean that some disciples were sitting and others standing.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

there are some here (GNT)

some of you standing with me here

will not taste death: This phrase is an idiom that means "will not die." It means that some disciples "will not die until they have seen the Son of Man come as King" (GNT).

Here are some other ways to translate this idiom:

will not die (GNT)

before they die (NCV)

16:28b

before they see the Son of Man coming in His kingdom."

- before they see the Son of Man coming to rule in his kingdom."
- before you see me, the Son of Man, come to rule/reign."

coming in His kingdom: This phrase was a way to describe a king who was moving in a procession, displaying his splendor and majesty.

Scholars have many ideas about what time or event Jesus was referring to, but they do not agree much. If possible, translate this phrase just as written.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

coming with his kingdom (NJB)

coming as king (JBP)

coming to rule/reign

General Comment on 16:28

The clauses in this verse are not in chronological order. In some languages, it may be more natural to put the clauses in chronological order. Here is an example is:

I tell you the truth, some people standing here will see the Son of Man coming with his kingdom before they die. (NCV)

Matthew 17:1

Section 17:1–13: Three disciples saw Jesus' glory

In this section, Jesus changed his appearance. He made his face and his clothes shine very brightly. He did this in front of Peter, James and John. At the same time, the disciples saw Moses and Elijah. Then they heard the voice of God. When the disciples saw and heard all this, they understood that Jesus was not an ordinary teacher. They better understood that he really was the Messiah.

This section immediately follow 16:28 which says, "Truly, I tell you, some who are standing here will not taste death before they see the Son of Man coming in His kingdom." This section begins to fulfill that verse.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The disciples saw Jesus' appearance change

Jesus' glory was revealed on the mountain

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 9:2–12 and Luke 9:28–36.

17:1a

After six days Jesus took with Him Peter, James, and John the brother of James,

- ¶ After six days had passed, Jesus took Peter and James and his younger brother John
- ¶ Six days later, Jesus went with Peter, James and John, the younger brother of James

After six days: The events in this section occurred six days after the events at the end of chapter 16.

Here are some other ways to begin this section:

Six days later (GNT)

Six days after that

After six days passed

Jesus took with Him: This clause implies that Jesus asked Peter, James, and John to go with him. They went willingly with Jesus.

In some languages, it may be more natural to use a different verb here. For example:

Jesus asked/told...to go with him

Jesus invited/called...to go along with him

The verb took is closely connected to the verb "led" in 17:1b. In some languages it may be natural to use only one verb here. For example:

Jesus led Peter, James, and John up...

Peter, James, and John the brother of James: The phrase John the brother means that John was the brother of James. He was not the brother of Jesus.

In the New Testament, when James and John are mentioned, James is always listed first. This probably indicates that James was the older brother. If your languages make a distinction between older and younger brother, you can say:

James and John his younger brother

17:1b

and led them up a high mountain by themselves.

- and went with them up a high mountain to be alone.
- up a high mountain to a place where they were the only people.

and led them up: The Greek word that the BSB translates as led...up indicates that Jesus went/climbed up the mountain while the disciples followed behind him.

In some languages, it may be more natural to say:

and they followed him up

and they climbed up

a high mountain: The Greek text does not indicate whether the men went to the very top/peak of the mountain. They went up high enough to get away from other people. Perhaps they went to the very top. Perhaps they went to a private place on the side of the mountain.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

on a high mountain (NCV)

onto a high mountain

by themselves: This phrase indicates that only Jesus, Peter, James and John were on the mountain. There were no other people in that area.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

where they were alone (GNT)

away from other people

Only Jesus and his disciples were there.

Matthew 17:2

Section 17:1–13: Three disciples saw Jesus' glory

In this section, Jesus changed his appearance. He made his face and his clothes shine very brightly. He did this in front of Peter, James and John. At the same time, the disciples saw Moses and Elijah. Then they heard the voice of God. When the disciples saw and heard all this, they understood that Jesus was not an ordinary teacher. They better understood that he really was the Messiah.

This section immediately follow 16:28 which says, "Truly, I tell you, some who are standing here will not taste death before they see the Son of Man coming in His kingdom." This section begins to fulfill that verse.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The disciples saw Jesus' appearance change

Jesus' glory was revealed on the mountain

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 9:2–12 and Luke 9:28–36.

17:2a

There He was transfigured before them.

- There his appearance was changed in front of them.
- While they watched, he changed the way he looked to them.

In Greek, 17:2 begins with a conjunction that the BSB leaves untranslated, but many English versions translate it as "And." This conjunction joins the next event to the previous one. New Testament Greek uses this joining conjunction far more often than modern

English does. So in Greek, many verses in chapter 17 begin with this same conjunction. Since it is not always natural in English, many English versions do not translate it.

(The Translator's Notes will not always comment on this conjunction. If you see the conjunction "And" at the beginning of a verse, you should decide whether it is natural in your language to use a conjunction there.)

For 17:2a, some English versions, including the BSB, begin this verse with a location word. For instance:

There, he was transfigured (NIV)

He was transfigured: The Greek word that the BSB translates as transfigured means "changed his appearance." The way that Jesus changed is explained in 17:2b–c.

This clause is passive. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

Jesus' appearance was changed (NCV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

Jesus' appearance changed (GW)

Jesus changed the way he looked to them

Many cultures have terms to describe a major change in appearance. Often these changes have supernatural causes and purposes. If you consider using one of these terms, be sure that it does not communicate a wrong meaning. Jesus did not begin to look like someone else, and he did not become a different being. Also, his appearance did not change in any bad way.

before them: This phrase emphasizes the fact that Peter, James and John actually saw Jesus change.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

before their eyes (JBP)

While they watched

17:2b

His face shone like the sun,

- His face shone like the shining of the sun,
- His face became bright like the sun.

His face shone like the sun: This is a figure of speech called a simile. It describes how Jesus changed. In this simile, Matthew compared Jesus' face to the sun. The way that they are similar is that both shine/shone brightly.

The Greek verb that the BSB translates as shone indicates something that produces light, like a lamp. It is not something that just reflects light.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

his face shone like the shining/brightness of the sun

his face became bright like the sun (NCV)

17:2c and His clothes became as white as the light.

- and his clothes became white/bright like the light.
- His clothes became/turned very, very white.

His clothes became as white as the light: This is another simile that describes how Jesus changed. In this simile, Matthew compared Jesus' changed clothes to light. The way they are similar is that both are white or bright.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Keep the simile. For example:

his clothes became as white as light (NLT)

his clothes became/turned very bright like the light

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

his clothing became dazzling white (NLT96)

his clothes became very white

Matthew 17:3

Section 17:1–13: Three disciples saw Jesus' glory

In this section, Jesus changed his appearance. He made his face and his clothes shine very brightly. He did this in front of Peter, James and John. At the same time, the disciples saw Moses and Elijah. Then they heard the voice of God. When the disciples saw and heard all this, they understood that Jesus was not an

ordinary teacher. They better understood that he really was the Messiah.

This section immediately follow 16:28 which says, "Truly, I tell you, some who are standing here will not taste death before they see the Son of Man coming in His kingdom." This section begins to fulfill that verse.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The disciples saw Jesus' appearance change

Jesus' glory was revealed on the mountain

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 9:2-12 and Luke 9:28-36.

17:3 Suddenly Moses and Elijah appeared before them, talking with Jesus.

- Suddenly, Moses and Elijah appeared. They were talking with him.
- All at once, they saw the prophets Moses and Elijah talking with him/Jesus.

Suddenly: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Suddenly literally means "look" or "see." It focuses attention on what follows and indicates that it is important, unexpected, or amazing. In this passage, Moses and Elijah unexpectedly appeared.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Behold (ESV)

All of a sudden

unexpectedly

Translate this word in a way that you would ordinarily use to describe something sudden or startling.

Moses and Elijah: Moses and Elijah were both Old Testament prophets who lived many years before Jesus. But God brought them to the mountain to talk with Jesus.

If people in your area will not know that Moses and Elijah lived long before Jesus, you may want to include some implied information. For example:

Moses and Elijah, prophets of long ago

Moses: The name Moses first occurs in 8:4c. You should spell his name here as you did there.

Elijah: The name Elijah first occurs in 11:14b. You should spell his name here as you did there.

appeared before them: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as appeared is literally “was seen.” This form of the verb is often used to describe beings who appear in a supernatural manner. Here, this verb indicates that the disciples suddenly saw Elijah and Moses. The disciples did not see them coming from a distance.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Elijah and Moses appeared to them

Moses and Elijah were there (CEV)

They saw Elijah and Moses

before them: These words indicate that all three disciples saw the same thing.

In some languages, it will not be necessary to add this phrase. For example:

Moses and Elijah appeared (NLT)

talking with Jesus: In Greek, the grammar probably indicates that Moses and Elijah were already talking with Jesus when the disciples saw them. The grammar could also indicate that Moses, Elijah and Jesus were still talking when Peter interrupted them (17:4). Try to translate in a way that allows for either of those two meanings.

Matthew does not suggest that the disciples were close enough to hear what they were talking about. Matthew just indicates that the disciples could see from where they were standing that Jesus was talking with these two prophets.

Matthew 17:4

Section 17:1–13: Three disciples saw Jesus’ glory

In this section, Jesus changed his appearance. He made his face and his clothes shine very brightly. He did this in front of Peter, James and John. At the same time, the disciples saw Moses and Elijah. Then they heard the voice of God. When the disciples saw and heard all this, they understood that Jesus was not an ordinary teacher. They better understood that he really was the Messiah.

This section immediately follow 16:28 which says, “Truly, I tell you, some who are standing here will not taste death before they see the Son of Man coming in His kingdom.” This section begins to fulfill that verse.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The disciples saw Jesus’ appearance change

Jesus’ glory was revealed on the mountain

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 9:2–12 and Luke 9:28–36.

17:4a

Peter said to Jesus, “Lord, it is good for us to be here.”

- Peter said to Jesus, “Lord, it is good for us^(excl) to be here.
- Then Peter said to Jesus, “Sir, we^(excl) are happy/privileged to be here!

Peter said to Jesus: In Greek, this verse begins with a conjunction that sometimes indicates a change of participants. Here the change is from the prophets to Peter. Some English versions translate this conjunction as “And.” The BSB and many other English versions do not translate this conjunction.

Verse 17:4 is the next event in the story. So here are some other ways to begin this verse:

Then Peter said to Jesus (NRSV)

So Peter said to Jesus (NET)

Lord: For help in translating the term Lord, see the note at 15:22c.

it is good for us to be here: There are at least three ways to interpret Peter’s words:

1. Peter meant that he and the other disciples were happy to be there. They were happy to see the glory of Jesus. They were also happy to see the prophets Moses and Elijah. It was a privilege for them to be there. One commentator who follow this interpretation is Nolland who writes on page 702, “Peter expresses on behalf of the disciple group present a sense of the privilege of witnessing the scene before them.” The NLT probably follows this interpretation. It says:

it's wonderful for us to be here

1. Peter meant that it was good that he and the other disciples were there so that they could help Jesus and the prophets. One commentator who follows this interpretation is France who writes on page 649, "It is good that we are here' in context means not so much 'we are glad/privileged to be here' but rather 'it is a good thing that we are here because we are available to do what needs to be done.'" The NCV probably follow this interpretation. It says:

it is good that we are here

1. Peter meant that it was wonderful for all six men to be there together. One commentator who follows this interpretation of Blomberg who writes on page 262, "It is good for us to be here' will then mean not that it is good that Peter, James, and John can help put up the tents but that it is good that all of the participants can preserve this moment for some length of time."

Many English versions are ambiguous and it is not possible to tell which interpretation they follow. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Peter naturally thought about himself first and what he was experiencing. He first talked about what he thought and felt based on what he saw in front of him.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

we^(excl) are happy to be here

it is a privilege for us^(excl) to be here

us to be here: The pronoun us probably refers to Peter and the other two disciples. In other words, it probably excludes Jesus, Moses and Elijah. If your language has inclusive and exclusive pronouns, you should use the exclusive us here.

17:4b

If You wish, I will put up three shelters—

- If you want/desire, I will build three shelters.
- If you want me to, I will put up three temporary shelters.

17:4c

one for You, one for Moses, and one for Elijah."

- One will be for you, one for Moses and one for Elijah."
- I will put up one for you, another one for the prophet Moses and another for the prophet Elijah."

17:4b–c

If You wish: The Greek word that the BSB translates as wish could also be translated "want" or "desire." Peter used this phrase to offer his services to Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

If you want (NCV)

If you desire

I will put up three shelters: The Greek word that the BSB translates as shelters refers to temporary shelters. These shelters were often made of cloth or animal skins. They were held up by poles and tied down with ropes. These shelters were traditionally used by herders. They could put them up and take them down quickly as they followed their wandering herds. They could sleep in them at night or use them for shade during the day.

These shelters could also be made from sticks and branches. This must have been what Peter meant since he would not have had cloth or skins with him on the mountain.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I will make three tents here (ESV)

I will erect three shelters/huts

put up: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as put up is a general verb used to refer to building or constructing something. You should use a verb in your language that goes with building/making temporary shelters.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

build

Matthew 17:5

Section 17:1–13: Three disciples saw Jesus' glory

In this section, Jesus changed his appearance. He made his face and his clothes shine very brightly. He did this in front of Peter, James and John. At the same time, the disciples saw Moses and Elijah. Then they heard the voice of God. When the disciples saw and heard all this, they understood that Jesus was not an ordinary teacher. They better understood that he really was the Messiah.

This section immediately follow 16:28 which says, “Truly, I tell you, some who are standing here will not taste death before they see the Son of Man coming in His kingdom.” This section begins to fulfill that verse.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The disciples saw Jesus’ appearance change

Jesus’ glory was revealed on the mountain

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 9:2-12 and Luke 9:28-36.

17:5a

While Peter was still speaking, a bright cloud enveloped them,

- ¶ While he was speaking, they were suddenly in the shadow of a shining cloud.
- ¶ As he/Peter was talking, all at once a white cloud came over their heads, and they were in its shadow.

a bright cloud: The Greek begins this phrase with the same word that the BSB translates as “suddenly” in 17:3. It focuses attention on what follows and indicates that it is important, unexpected, or amazing. In this passage, the thing that is important and amazing is that a bright cloud appeared.

Here are some other ways to translate this word in its context:

suddenly a bright cloud (NJB)

all at once a bright cloud

The word cloud refers to the mist or fog that floats in the sky. If your language has specific terms for different kinds of clouds, use the term that refers to a white, puffy, fair-weather cloud. This was a bright cloud, not a dark storm cloud.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

a white cloud

a shining cloud (GNT)

This cloud shone.

bright: The Greek word that the BSB translates bright is related to the word in 17:2 which describes how

white Jesus’ clothing became. It means “shining” or “radiant.”

enveloped them: There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as enveloped:

1. It means cast its shadow or overshadowed. The cloud passed between them and the sun, and they were in its shadow. For example:

the shadow of a bright cloud passed over them (CEV) (ESV, RSV, NET, NJB, NASB, GW, CEV, NLT, JBP, REB, KJV)

1. It means surrounded or enveloped. They were on a mountain. So when the cloud came, it surrounded them so that they were in the middle of the cloud. It was like being in a fog. For example:

a bright cloud covered them (NCV) (BSB, NIV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with the majority of English versions. Even though most English versions support interpretation (1), many commentaries support interpretation (2). Both Louw & Nida (page 177 14.62) and BDAG (page 378) say that the cloud may function more like a covering than a shadow.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

a bright cloud cast its shadow on them

a bright cloud came over their heads, and they were in its shadow

17:5b

and a voice from the cloud said,

- They heard a voice from inside the cloud. It said,
- Suddenly they heard God’s voice speaking from inside the cloud. He said,

a voice from the cloud said: The Greek begins this phrase with the same word that the BSB translates as “suddenly” in 17:3 and leaves untranslated in 17:5a.

Matthew repeated this word to show that the whole scene was very amazing. If your language allows you to mark a high point of a story in some way, consider how you might do so here.

In some languages, it may not be natural to talk about a voice without describing whose voice it is. The voice was the voice of God. In some languages, it may be more natural to say that God was speaking.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

They heard a voice that came from the cloud. It said

God spoke from the cloud, and he said

They heard God speaking from the cloud. He said

This same expression occurs in 3:17a. You should translate it the same way in both places.

17:5c

“This is My beloved Son, in whom I am well pleased. Listen to Him!”

- “This is my dearly loved Son. I am very pleased with him. Listen to him!”
- “This person is my Son. I love him and am very happy with him. Listen to him and obey him!”

This is My beloved Son, in whom I am well pleased:

This same sentence occurs in 3:17b. You should translate it the same way in both places.

This is My beloved Son: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as This is My beloved Son is literally “This is my son the beloved.” The words “the beloved” indicate here that Jesus was God the Father’s one and only dear son. This phrase does not imply that God has other sons whom he did not love.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

This is my own dear Son (GNT)

This is my dearly loved Son (JBP)

This person is my son. I love him.

My...Son: See how you translated “My Son” at 3:17b. For further information, see the note on “My...Son” at 3:17b.

in whom I am well pleased: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as I am well pleased means “I am delighted” or “I am very pleased/satisfied.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

He makes me very happy/pleased.

he makes my heart glad

Listen to Him: The Greek command that the BSB translates as Listen is often translated “hear.” It includes the idea that the one who listens should obey what he hears.

Matthew 17:6

Section 17:1–13: Three disciples saw Jesus’ glory

In this section, Jesus changed his appearance. He made his face and his clothes shine very brightly. He did this in front of Peter, James and John. At the same time, the disciples saw Moses and Elijah. Then they heard the voice of God. When the disciples saw and heard all this, they understood that Jesus was not an ordinary teacher. They better understood that he really was the Messiah.

This section immediately follow 16:28 which says, “Truly, I tell you, some who are standing here will not taste death before they see the Son of Man coming in His kingdom.” This section begins to fulfill that verse.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The disciples saw Jesus’ appearance change

Jesus’ glory was revealed on the mountain

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 9:2–12 and Luke 9:28–36.

17:6a

When the disciples heard this,

- When the disciples heard the voice,
- When the disciples heard those words,

When the disciples heard this: The word this does not occur in Greek. Some English versions add it to make the sentence more natural. It refers to either the voice or the words that the voice spoke. In some languages, it may be more natural to make this explicit. For example:

When they heard this voice (JBP)

When the disciples heard the voice (GNT) When the disciples heard those words

17:6b

they fell facedown in terror.

- they became very afraid, and they threw themselves facedown on the ground.

- they were frightened so much that they quickly dropped down with their faces to the ground.

they fell facedown in terror: The disciples fell facedown because they were terrified. In other words, they were terrified first, and then they fell on their faces. In some languages it may be natural to change the order of these two clauses.

Here are some other ways to translate these two clauses:

they fell on their faces because they were terrified

they were so afraid that they fell flat on the ground (CEV)

they fell facedown: This is a Greek idiom. It means that the disciples dropped to the ground and lay with their faces down. Their arms were probably stretched out in front of them.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

they dropped with their faces on the ground

they threw themselves face downward on the ground (GNT)

in terror: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as in terror includes a word that means “greatly” or “exceedingly.” Their fear was extreme.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

and were very afraid

they were greatly frightened

Matthew 17:7

Section 17:1–13: Three disciples saw Jesus’ glory

In this section, Jesus changed his appearance. He made his face and his clothes shine very brightly. He did this in front of Peter, James and John. At the same time, the disciples saw Moses and Elijah. Then they heard the voice of God. When the disciples saw and heard all this, they understood that Jesus was not an ordinary teacher. They better understood that he really was the Messiah.

This section immediately follow 16:28 which says, “Truly, I tell you, some who are standing here will not

taste death before they see the Son of Man coming in His kingdom.” This section begins to fulfill that verse.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The disciples saw Jesus’ appearance change

Jesus’ glory was revealed on the mountain

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 9:2–12 and Luke 9:28–36.

17:7a

Then Jesus came over and touched them.

- Jesus came to them and touched them
- Then Jesus went over to them and touched them

Then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Then here functions to join the next event to the previous one. Here it does not show an obvious contrast. However, some English versions translate this word as “But.” Other versions do not translate it at all. For example:

But Jesus came and touched them. (ESV)

Jesus came to them and touched them. (GNT)

You should begin this verse in a way that is natural in your language.

Jesus came over: This story is told from the disciples’ perspective. So Jesus is described as coming from where he was to where the disciples were. But this event can also be told as if looking at the whole scene. For example:

Jesus went to them (NCV)

Jesus approached them

touched them: The Greek word that the BSB translates as touched indicates that Jesus put his hand on each of them briefly. It is the same sort of thing Jesus did when healing someone of a sickness.

Here is another way to translate this:

put/placed his hand on them

17:7b

“Get up,” He said. “Do not be afraid.”

- and said, “Stand up. Do not be afraid.”
- and said to them, “Do not fear. Get up”

Get up: The phrase Get up refers to someone getting up from the ground and standing. Here this word is a command.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Rise (ESV)

Stand up (NJB)

Do not be afraid: In modern English, this Greek phrase is usually translated as in the BSB.

General Comment on 17:7b

In some languages, it will be more natural to change the order of “rising” and “not fearing.” For example:

Don’t be afraid! Stand up!

Matthew 17:8

Section 17:1–13: Three disciples saw Jesus’ glory

In this section, Jesus changed his appearance. He made his face and his clothes shine very brightly. He did this in front of Peter, James and John. At the same time, the disciples saw Moses and Elijah. Then they heard the voice of God. When the disciples saw and heard all this, they understood that Jesus was not an ordinary teacher. They better understood that he really was the Messiah.

This section immediately follow 16:28 which says, “Truly, I tell you, some who are standing here will not taste death before they see the Son of Man coming in His kingdom.” This section begins to fulfill that verse.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The disciples saw Jesus’ appearance change

Jesus’ glory was revealed on the mountain

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 9:2–12 and Luke 9:28–36.

17:8a

And when they looked up,

- When they looked up,
- Then/So they lifted their heads from the ground

And: In Greek, this verse begins with a conjunction that has a variety of functions. Here it probably signals the end or conclusion of this paragraph. The BSB translates this conjunction as And. Many English versions do not translate this conjunction here.

Another way to begin this verse is to explicitly mark it as the end of this paragraph. For example:

So they looked up (GNT)

When/Then they looked up

17:8b

they saw no one except Jesus.

- the only person whom they saw was Jesus.
- and saw only Jesus.

they saw no one except Jesus: This phrase indicates that when the disciples looked, up they did not see Moses or Elijah any more. The only person whom they saw was Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

they saw no one but Jesus only (ESV)

they saw only Jesus (CEV)

Matthew 17:9

Section 17:1–13: Three disciples saw Jesus’ glory

In this section, Jesus changed his appearance. He made his face and his clothes shine very brightly. He did this in front of Peter, James and John. At the same time, the disciples saw Moses and Elijah. Then they heard the voice of God. When the disciples saw and heard all this, they understood that Jesus was not an ordinary teacher. They better understood that he really was the Messiah.

This section immediately follow 16:28 which says, “Truly, I tell you, some who are standing here will not taste death before they see the Son of Man coming in His kingdom.” This section begins to fulfill that verse.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The disciples saw Jesus’ appearance change

Jesus’ glory was revealed on the mountain

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 9:2–12 and Luke 9:28–36.

17:9a

As they were coming down the mountain,

- ¶ While/As they descended the mountain,
- ¶ Then Jesus and the three disciples started going down the mountain. On the way down,

As they were coming down the mountain: In some languages, it will be more natural to say “going” than coming. For example:

As they were going down the mountain

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

As they descended the mountain (NLT96)

On their way down from the mountain (CEV)

they: The pronoun they refers to Jesus and the three disciples.

17:9b

Jesus commanded them,

- Jesus gave them this command,
- he warned them

Jesus commanded them: The Greek word that the BSB translates as commanded means “directed,” or “gave orders.” Jesus ordered them to not tell other people what they saw.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus gave them this order (NJB)

Jesus warned his disciples (CEV)

Jesus instructed them (NIV)

17:9c

“Do not tell anyone about this vision

- “Do not tell anyone what you^(plur) just saw
- not to tell anyone what they had seen (CEV)

Do not tell anyone about this vision: The Greek word that the BSB translates as vision here refers to the things that the disciples actually saw on the mountain. Here it does not refer to something like a dream.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Don’t tell anyone what you have seen (NIV)

In some languages, it will be more natural to translate this clause as indirect speech. For example:

not to tell anyone about what they had seen (NCV)

17:9d

until the Son of Man has been raised from the dead.”

- until I the Son of Man comes back to life again after being dead.”
- until after he, the Son of Man, had died and became alive again.”

the Son of Man: Jesus used this phrase to refer to himself. In some languages, this phrase by itself would refer to someone other than Jesus. If that is true in your language, consider translating it as:

I, the Son of Man

In Matthew, this phrase first occurs in 8:20b. See the Note there for more information on translating this phrase. This phrase last occurs in 16:28b. You should translate it here as you did there.

has been raised from the dead: This phrase refers to returning to life after being dead.

Here are some other ways to translate it:

is brought back to life after being dead

has come to life again

dies and returns to life again

This clause is passive. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

has been raised from the dead (NLT)

- Use an active verb with the “Son of Man” as the subject. For example:

until the Son of Man rises from the dead

- Use an active verb with “God” as the subject and the “Son of Man” as the object. For example:

until after God raises the Son of Man from the dead

Matthew 17:10

Section 17:1–13: Three disciples saw Jesus' glory

In this section, Jesus changed his appearance. He made his face and his clothes shine very brightly. He did this in front of Peter, James and John. At the same time, the disciples saw Moses and Elijah. Then they heard the voice of God. When the disciples saw and heard all this, they understood that Jesus was not an ordinary teacher. They better understood that he really was the Messiah.

This section immediately follow 16:28 which says, "Truly, I tell you, some who are standing here will not taste death before they see the Son of Man coming in His kingdom." This section begins to fulfill that verse.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The disciples saw Jesus' appearance change

Jesus' glory was revealed on the mountain

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 9:2–12 and Luke 9:28–36.

17:10a

The disciples asked Him,

- ¶ Then his disciples asked him,
- ¶ Then his disciples asked him/Jesus,

The disciples asked Him: Here the phrase The disciples refers to the same three disciples (Peter, James and John) who were on the mountain with Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Then the disciples asked Jesus (GNT)

And his disciples asked him (KJV)

17:10b–c

Why then do the scribes say that Elijah must come first?: This is a real question. It is not a rebuke. The disciples asked this question because they were confused. They knew that Jesus was the Christ, and they had just seen Elijah on the mountain. This reminded them about the prophecy that Elijah would come back to preach before the Christ came. So here the disciples asked Jesus why they had not seen the public ministry of Elijah before he, Jesus, came.

Here are some other ways to translate this question:

Why do the teachers of religious law insist that Elijah must return before the Messiah comes? (NLT)

So why do the scribes say that it is necessary that Elijah return to the earth before the Christ comes?

17:10b

"Why then do the scribes say that

- "Why do the teachers of the Law say that
- "So, why do the teachers of the law of Moses say that

the scribes: The Greek word that the BSB translates as scribes refers to men who studied, interpreted, and taught the law of Moses. These men were called scribes because their original work was to copy the laws of Moses by hand. In New Testament times, this was no longer their main task.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

teachers of the Law of Moses (CEV)

teachers of religious law (NLT)

teachers of the law (NIV)

experts in the law

Translate this term in the same way as you did in 15:1a and 16:21c.

17:10c

Elijah must come first?"

- Elijah must come before the Christ/Messiah comes?"
- it is necessary for the prophet Elijah to return to the earth before the Christ/Messiah comes?"

Elijah must come first: These words mean that the prophet Elijah must return to earth before the Messiah comes.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

Elijah must come before the Messiah does (CEV)

Elijah must return before the Messiah comes (NLT)

must: In Greek, the word that the BSB translates as must is often used to indicate something that is required because it is God's will. The Scripture said that Elijah would come first. Therefore, it was necessary for him to come.

Here are some other ways to translate this whole clause:

it is necessary for Elijah to come first

it is required that Elijah come before the Messiah

Matthew 17:11

Section 17:1–13: Three disciples saw Jesus' glory

In this section, Jesus changed his appearance. He made his face and his clothes shine very brightly. He did this in front of Peter, James and John. At the same time, the disciples saw Moses and Elijah. Then they heard the voice of God. When the disciples saw and heard all this, they understood that Jesus was not an ordinary teacher. They better understood that he really was the Messiah.

This section immediately follow 16:28 which says, "Truly, I tell you, some who are standing here will not taste death before they see the Son of Man coming in His kingdom." This section begins to fulfill that verse.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The disciples saw Jesus' appearance change

Jesus' glory was revealed on the mountain

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 9:2–12 and Luke 9:28–36.

17:11a

Jesus replied, "Elijah does indeed come,

- Jesus answered, "Elijah will certainly come,
- Jesus said to them, "It is true that the prophet Elijah must come first,

Elijah does indeed come: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as Elijah does indeed come contains a word, indeed, that some English versions do not translate. Jesus used this word to confirm that what the disciples said is true. He also used this word to show that he will later (in 17:12) say something to contrast with this part.

Some English versions, including the BSB, translate the sense of this word. For example:

To be sure, Elijah comes (NIV)

come: In Greek, the verb come is present tense. But Jesus was referring to a passage in Malachi 4:5–6 which spoke of a future event. Here Jesus simply used the present tense to agree with the order of events: Elijah comes first.

In some languages, it may be natural to use another tense. Or it may be natural to repeat the words of the disciples. For example:

Elijah certainly will come (CEV)

Elijah must come first

Elijah is indeed coming first (GNT)

You should use what is most natural in your language.

17:11b

and he will restore all things.

- and he will set everything right again.
- and he will make/put everything the way it should be.

and he will restore all things: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as restore means "return something to a previously good condition," or "put something back in proper order." The original prophecy in Malachi 4:5–6 referred to restoring good relationships between parents and children.

Here Jesus was referring to the work of Elijah that John the Baptist did. John the Baptist taught people to repent. This restored their relationship with God so that they would be prepared for the Messiah to come.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

and will put everything in order again (GW)

he will make everything the way it should be (NCV)

he will return things to the way they are supposed to be

Several versions have a general phrase "will get everything ready" (as in the GNT). But it may be better to

use an expression that focuses more on the specific meaning of restore.

Matthew 17:12

Section 17:1–13: Three disciples saw Jesus' glory

In this section, Jesus changed his appearance. He made his face and his clothes shine very brightly. He did this in front of Peter, James and John. At the same time, the disciples saw Moses and Elijah. Then they heard the voice of God. When the disciples saw and heard all this, they understood that Jesus was not an ordinary teacher. They better understood that he really was the Messiah.

This section immediately follow 16:28 which says, "Truly, I tell you, some who are standing here will not taste death before they see the Son of Man coming in His kingdom." This section begins to fulfill that verse.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The disciples saw Jesus' appearance change

Jesus' glory was revealed on the mountain

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 9:2–12 and Luke 9:28–36.

17:12a

But I tell you that Elijah has already come,

- But I tell you^(plur) this, Elijah has already come,
- But I say to you^(plur) that Elijah already came,

But: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between Jesus' agreement with the scribes that "Elijah does indeed come" (in 17:11a), and his statement here that "Elijah has already come." The BSB indicates this contrast with the conjunction But.

Elijah has already come: Here Jesus was speaking about John the Baptist. But the disciples did not yet understand it. John the Baptist came and prepared the way for the Messiah. He fulfilled the prophecy about Elijah coming and restoring all things. In that sense, Elijah has already come. The historical Elijah did not actually come.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

Elijah already came

17:12b

and they did not recognize him,

- and they did not know him.
- but they did not realize who he was.

and: The Greek word that the BSB translates as and is the conjunction that usually joins the next event to the previous one. Since there is a mild contrast between 17:12a and 17:12b, some English versions connect these two parts with the conjunction "but." For example:

But the people did not recognize him (CEV)

If it would be clearer in your language to make the contrast explicit, you can use your word for "but" here.

they: This pronoun refers to Jewish people in general, and to the Jewish leaders in particular.

Here are some other ways to translate this pronoun:

people (GNT)

the leaders

did not recognize him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as recognize also means "know." People did not know that the prophecy about Elijah was fulfilled in John the Baptist. They did not understand what John's ministry really was.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

did not know him (RSV)

did not realize who he really was

17:12c

but have done to him whatever they wished.

- Instead/Rather, they did to him whatever they wanted to do.
- They did the bad things that they wanted to do to him.

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but indicates a contrast. The contrast is between what the people did not do (recognize him) and what they actually did (badly treated him). Some English versions indicate this contrast with the word but, as the BSB does.

Here are some other ways to show this contrast:

instead

rather

In some languages, it will be more natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

They did to him whatever they wanted to do. (NCV)

have done to him whatever they wished: These words imply that people did evil and hurtful things to John. This included killing him.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

treated him just as they pleased (GNT)

They did what they liked with him (JBP)

If people in your area will think that these words mean that the people did only good things to John, you may want to include some implied information. For example:

they did all the evil things that they wanted to do to him

they chose to abuse him (NLT)

17:12d

In the same way, the Son of Man will suffer at their hands."

- In the same way, Son of Man will certainly suffer in/by their hands."
- Like that also, they will surely make me the Son of Man suffer."

In the same way: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as In the same way indicates that people would treat the Son of Man "in the same way" as they treated John.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

So also (ESV)

Likewise/Similarly

the Son of Man: Jesus used this phrase to refer to himself. In some languages, this phrase by itself would refer to someone other than Jesus. If that is true in your language, consider translating it as:

I, the Son of Man

This same phrase occurs in 17:9d. You should translate it here as you did there.

will suffer at their hands: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as will suffer includes the ideas of:

1. the suffering will happen in the near future. The Son of Man will soon suffer.
2. God has decided that the suffering must happen. The Son of Man will certainly suffer, or must suffer.

Some English versions focus on (a). Other English versions focus on (b). Both are correct. For example:

the Son of Man is about to suffer (NRSV)

They will soon make the Son of Man suffer (CEV)

the Son of Man will certainly suffer (ESV)

at their hands: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as at their hands is more literally "by them." This phrase indicates who will cause the Son of Man to suffer. It makes this clause a type of passive.

Here are some other ways to translate it as an active clause:

they're going to make the Son of Man suffer (GW)

They will soon make the Son of Man suffer (CEV)

Matthew 17:13

Section 17:1-13: Three disciples saw Jesus' glory

In this section, Jesus changed his appearance. He made his face and his clothes shine very brightly. He did this in front of Peter, James and John. At the same time, the disciples saw Moses and Elijah. Then they heard the voice of God. When the disciples saw and heard all this, they understood that Jesus was not an ordinary teacher. They better understood that he really was the Messiah.

This section immediately follow 16:28 which says, "Truly, I tell you, some who are standing here will not taste death before they see the Son of Man coming in His kingdom." This section begins to fulfill that verse.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The disciples saw Jesus' appearance change

Jesus' glory was revealed on the mountain

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 9:2–12 and Luke 9:28–36.

17:13a

Then the disciples understood that

- Then the disciples understood that
- When Jesus said that, the disciples realized/knew that

Then the disciples understood: The Greek word that the BSB translates as understood can also be translated as “realized.” For example:

Then the disciples realized (NLT)

Then the disciples knew

17:13b

He was speaking to them about John the Baptist.

- he was talking to them about John the Baptist.
- the person/Elijah whom he was talking to them about was John the Baptist.

He was speaking to them about John the Baptist:

This clause indicates that the disciples now understood that John the Baptist fulfilled the prophecies about Elijah.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the person whom he was speaking to them about was John the Baptist

when he spoke of Elijah, he was really speaking to them about John the Baptist

Matthew 17:14

Section 17:14–20: Jesus healed a boy whom a demon controlled

In 10:1 Jesus had given power to his twelve disciples to cast out demons and heal sick people. Then the disciples went out in groups of two and did those things (Mark 6:7–13). But in this section, they could not cast out a demon that caused a boy to have severe physical problems. Only Jesus was able to force the demon to leave the boy. This story shows that the disciples' faith was not yet strong.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Cures A Demon-Possessed Boy (GW)

The Healing of a Boy With a Demon (NIV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 9:14–29 and at Luke 9:37–43.

17:14a

When they came to the crowd,

- ¶ Then they came to a crowd, and
- ¶ After Jesus and his disciples arrived at the bottom of the mountain, they came to a place where there was a group of people.

This is the beginning of a new section. The Greek begins this new section with a conjunction that usually joins the next event to the previous one. Many English versions translate this conjunction as “and,” but the BSB does not translate the word here.

You should begin this new section in a way that is natural in your language.

they came to the crowd: This clause implies that Jesus and his disciples came up to the edge of a crowd of people. They reached these people after walking down the mountain.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus and his disciples descended and arrived at a crowd of people

when they arrived at the bottom of the mountain, they came to a crowd of people

17:14b

a man came up to Jesus

- a man came/went to Jesus
- There, a man approached Jesus

a man: This man was most likely a Jewish man from the surrounding area. He was not a disciple of Jesus.

came up to Jesus: The Greek word that the BSB translates as came up means “approached.”

Here is another way to translate these words:

approached him/Jesus

17:14c

and knelt before Him.

- and knelt in front of him.
- and bowed before him.

and knelt before Him: The man got on his knees in front of Jesus to show that he understood that Jesus was more important than he was. He wanted to show his own humility and his respect for Jesus. He did this in front of Jesus to show that he wanted to talk with him.

In some cultures, these things are shown by bowing down in front of the person. For example:

and bowed before him (NCV)

Matthew 17:15

Section 17:14–20: Jesus healed a boy whom a demon controlled

In 10:1 Jesus had given power to his twelve disciples to cast out demons and heal sick people. Then the disciples went out in groups of two and did those things (Mark 6:7–13). But in this section, they could not cast out a demon that caused a boy to have severe physical problems. Only Jesus was able to force the demon to leave the boy. This story shows that the disciples' faith was not yet strong.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Cures A Demon-Possessed Boy (GW)

The Healing of a Boy With a Demon (NIV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 9:14–29 and at Luke 9:37–43.

17:15a

“Lord, have mercy on my son,” he said.

- He said, “Lord, have/take pity on my son,
- Then he said, “Sir/Master, please pity my son and help him.

Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord means “owner,” “master,” or “ruler.” In the parallel passages in Mark and Luke, the man addressed Jesus as “Teacher” rather than Lord. This shows that the man was addressing Jesus with respect. He did not necessarily understand that Jesus was the Son of God. So here you should use a term of respect that is natural in that sort of situation. For example:

Sir (GNT)

Master

have mercy on my son: The Greek word that the BSB translates as mercy means “have pity/compassion” for someone, or “be greatly concerned” for him. The man was pleading with Jesus to do something. He was indirectly asking Jesus to heal his son. He did this in a polite way.

Here are some other ways to translate this request:

have pity on my son (CEV)

please pity my son and help him

17:15b

“He has seizures and is suffering terribly.

- because he has epilepsy and suffers a lot.
- He has a shaking disease that is very bad.

There is a Greek conjunction at the beginning of this clause that some English versions translate as “for.” It introduces the reason for the man's plea for help.

Here is another way to translate this conjunction:

because (NET)

Many English versions, including the BSB, do not translate this conjunction here. Instead they let the context indicate the connection. In some languages, it will not be necessary to use a conjunction here either.

He has seizures: The Greek word that the BSB translates as has seizures refers to a person who has epilepsy. When a person with epilepsy has a seizure, he suffers various things. He loses consciousness, he falls down and may injure himself, and his body stiffens and begins to shake violently. After a while, the person stops shaking and regains consciousness.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

he has attacks/fits/spasms

he is an epileptic (ESV)

he has a shaking sickness

This same word occurs in 4:24e.

and is suffering terribly: This clause indicates that the boy's illness:

1. caused him great pain
2. was very severe.

Some English versions focus on (a). Other versions focus on (b). For example:

and is suffering very much (NCV)

and has such terrible attacks (GNT)

17:15c

He often falls into the fire or into the water.

- He often falls into a fire, and he often falls into water.
- When he shakes, he often falls into a fire or water.

In Greek, 17:15c begins with a conjunction. This conjunction indicates that what follows explains what the man meant by the phrase “suffering terribly.” Many English versions translate this conjunction as “For.”

Some English versions, including the BSB, do not translate this conjunction. Instead, they let the context suggest the connection. You should begin 17:15c in a way that is natural in your language.

often falls into the fire or into the water: These clauses together describe the effect that the seizures had on the boy. When he had a seizure, he fell down. He often fell into a fire or into water.

The boy did not always fall into a fire or water. He only fell when he was suffering from a seizure. In some languages, it will be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

when he shakes, he often falls into a fire or water

Matthew 17:16

Section 17:14–20: Jesus healed a boy whom a demon controlled

In 10:1 Jesus had given power to his twelve disciples to cast out demons and heal sick people. Then the disciples went out in groups of two and did those things (Mark 6:7–13). But in this section, they could not cast out a demon that caused a boy to have severe physical problems. Only Jesus was able to force the demon to leave the boy. This story shows that the disciples’ faith was not yet strong.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Cures A Demon-Possessed Boy (GW)

The Healing of a Boy With a Demon (NIV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 9:14–29 and at Luke 9:37–43.

17:16

I brought him to Your disciples, but they could not heal him.”

- I came with him here to your disciples, but they were not able to heal him.”
- I took him to your disciples to cure him, but they did not have the power to do it.”

I brought him: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as brought is the verb that Matthew frequently used when people were brought to Jesus for healing. Here the man probably brought his son to the disciples while Jesus was on the mountain.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I took/led him

I went with him

to Your disciples: These disciples were most likely the nine disciples who did not go up the mountain with Jesus.

but: There is a mild contrast here. The contrast is between the man’s expectation that the disciples could heal his son, and the disciples’ inability to do so. Some English versions do not indicate this contrast. For example:

and they could not heal him (ESV)

they could not heal him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as could not implies that the disciples tried to heal the boy, but they failed.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

they were not able to heal him (NET)

they did not have the strength/power to cure him

Matthew 17:17

Section 17:14–20: Jesus healed a boy whom a demon controlled

In 10:1 Jesus had given power to his twelve disciples to cast out demons and heal sick people. Then the disciples went out in groups of two and did those things (Mark 6:7–13). But in this section, they could not cast out a demon that caused a boy to have severe physical

problems. Only Jesus was able to force the demon to leave the boy. This story shows that the disciples' faith was not yet strong.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Cures A Demon-Possessed Boy (GW)

The Healing of a Boy With a Demon (NIV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 9:14–29 and at Luke 9:37–43.

17:17a

“O unbelieving and perverse generation!” Jesus replied.

- Jesus replied, “You^(plur) are an unbelieving and corrupt/evil generation!
- Jesus said, “You people lack faith. You do what is not right.

O: The Greek word that the BSB translates as O was used when someone addressed another person or group and was feeling strong emotion at the time. Some English translations substitute a pronoun for this word to achieve a similar effect. For example:

You unbelieving and perverted generation (NASB)

unbelieving: The Greek word that the BSB translates as unbelieving can also be translated as “faithless.” It refers to a lack of trust in God.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

faithless (ESV)

You people have no faith (NCV)

perverse: The Greek word that the BSB translates as perverse describes a person whose thinking and behavior are against God's desires. He has strayed from doing what is right.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

corrupt (NLT)

you have strayed off the right path

you don't know what is right

generation: The Greek word that the BSB translates as generation refers to all the members of a particular group (like a tribe or a country) alive at the same time. Here Jesus apparently included the disciples who could not heal the boy in that group.

Here is another way to translate this word:

people (GNT)

Jesus replied: Here Jesus did not answer a question. He responded to the man's statement and plea for help. So here are some other ways to begin this verse:

Jesus answered (ESV)

Jesus said (CEV)

17:17b

“How long must I remain with you?”

- How long must I stay with you? (GNT)
- Must I stay with you longer?
- I am frustrated that I may have to stay with you longer because you still do not believe/trust me.

How long must I remain with you?: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus used this rhetorical question to rebuke the people he was talking to, especially his disciples. He also used it to express his frustration with them. They should have had faith, but they did not.

Here are some other ways to translate this rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

How much longer must I be with you? (NET)

How long must I stay with you? (GNT)

- As a statement. For example:

I am frustrated that I may have to stay with you longer than necessary because you still do not believe/trust me.

Translate this rebuke and frustration in a way that is natural in your language.

How long: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as How long could also be translated as “until when.” Jesus used this phrase to indicate his frustration with the people's lack of progress.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

How much longer (NET)

must I remain with you: This phrase means “to live among you.” Jesus’ question could imply that their unbelief would force him to stay longer than necessary. Some English translations try to communicate this idea. For example:

how long must I stay with you (GNT)

17:17c

How long must I put up with you?

- How much longer must I endure you?
- I’m so frustrated that I may have to endure you longer.”

How long must I put up with you?: This is a rhetorical question. It is similar to the previous rhetorical question. Jesus used this rhetorical question to rebuke the people he was talking to, especially his disciples. He also used it to express his frustration with them. They should have had faith, but they did not.

Here are some other ways to translate this rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

How much longer must I endure you? (NET)

- As a statement. For example:

I am frustrated that I may have to endure you longer than necessary because you still do not believe/trust me.

Translate this rebuke and frustration in a way that is natural in your language.

must I put up with you: The Greek word that the BSB translates as put up with means “to endure/tolerate.” Jesus had to endure the people’s unbelief. As with the previous rhetorical question, Jesus implies that their unbelief would force him to endure them longer than necessary

17:17d

Bring the boy here to Me.”

- Bring^(plur) the boy to me here.”
- Then Jesus said, “Come^(plur) with the boy here to me.” They came with him.

In 17:17d Jesus suddenly switched from rebuking people to giving them a command. In some languages, it

may be more natural to introduce this command. For example:

Then Jesus said to them

Then Jesus told them

Bring the boy here to Me: In Greek, the word Bring is plural. This means that Jesus commanded several people to bring the boy to him. Jesus was not just speaking to the boy’s father.

Here are some other ways to translate this command:

Take him here to me.

Come with the boy to me.

The next verse shows that the people did what Jesus commanded and brought the boy to him. If that would not be clear from the context in your language, you may need to make it more explicit. For example:

So they brought the boy to him.

Matthew 17:18

Section 17:14–20: Jesus healed a boy whom a demon controlled

In 10:1 Jesus had given power to his twelve disciples to cast out demons and heal sick people. Then the disciples went out in groups of two and did those things (Mark 6:7–13). But in this section, they could not cast out a demon that caused a boy to have severe physical problems. Only Jesus was able to force the demon to leave the boy. This story shows that the disciples’ faith was not yet strong.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Cures A Demon-Possessed Boy (GW)

The Healing of a Boy With a Demon (NIV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 9:14–29 and at Luke 9:37–43.

17:18a

Then Jesus rebuked the demon, and it came out of the boy,

- Jesus rebuked the demon causing the epilepsy, and it went out of him.

- There was a demon in the boy causing the seizures. Jesus commanded the demon to leave the boy, and it left.

Then Jesus rebuked the demon, and it came out of the boy: It is only at this point in the story that we clearly see that a demon was causing the epilepsy in 17:15b. The demon was in the boy. Jesus rebuked this demon and caused it to leave the boy.

In some languages, it may be necessary to include some implied information here. For example:

Jesus rebuked the demon who was causing the epilepsy, and it came out of the boy.

There was a demon in the boy making him shake. Jesus ordered the demon to leave, and it left.

rebuked: The Greek word that the BSB translates as rebuked means “commanded,” “ordered,” or “spoke sternly” to the demon.

For example:

commanded (NCV)

ordered (GW)

the demon: The word demon refers to a spirit being who was once an angel, but who rebelled against God. A demon is also referred to as “evil spirit.” These evil spirits can control peoples’ actions and can make them sick. A demon is not the spirit of a dead person.

Here are some other ways to translate demon:

- Use a general term in your language that refers to a spirit that is evil and can control people. For example:

a demon

a devil

- Use a specific term in your language that refers to a certain type of spirit. Do not use a term that refers to the spirit of a dead person.
- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

an evil spirit

This word also occurs at 11:18b.

it came out of the boy: The words came out refer to exiting from inside something else. It is like someone coming out of a house.

The Greek text does not indicate that anyone saw the demon come out of the boy. The effect on the boy showed that the demon came out.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the demon went out of the boy

the demon exited the child

17:18b and he was healed from that moment.

- The boy was cured at that very moment.
- As a result, the boy became immediately well.

and he was healed from that moment: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as from that moment indicates that the boy was healed immediately. There was no delay between the exiting of the demon and the healing.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

At that moment the boy was cured. (GW)

This clause is passive. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

the boy was immediately cured

- Use another type of verb. For example:

right away, the boy became well

Matthew 17:19

Section 17:14–20: Jesus healed a boy whom a demon controlled

In 10:1 Jesus had given power to his twelve disciples to cast out demons and heal sick people. Then the disciples went out in groups of two and did those things (Mark 6:7–13). But in this section, they could not cast out a demon that caused a boy to have severe physical problems. Only Jesus was able to force the demon to leave the boy. This story shows that the disciples’ faith was not yet strong.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Cures A Demon-Possessed Boy (GW)

The Healing of a Boy With a Demon (NIV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 9:14–29 and at Luke 9:37–43.

17:19a

Afterward the disciples came to Jesus privately and asked,

- ¶ Later, when the disciples and Jesus were alone, they approached him and asked,
- ¶ Afterward the disciples and Jesus were by themselves. They went to him and asked him

Afterward: The events in this paragraph occur after Jesus and his disciples were by themselves. They either waited for the crowd to leave, or they walked away from the crowd.

Here are some other ways to begin this paragraph:

Then (ESV)

Later (CEV)

the disciples came to Jesus: The words came to refer to the disciples “approaching.” Jesus. They approached him with a question.

The disciples did not come to Jesus from a distance. They were already with him.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the disciples approached Jesus (JBP)

the disciples went to Jesus (CEV)

privately: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as privately is the same phrase that occurs in 17:1b. There the BSB translates it as “by themselves.” It means that when the disciples spoke with Jesus, there was no one else around.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

by themselves

When they were alone

17:19b

“Why couldn’t we drive it out?”

- “Why were we^(excl) not able to force out the demon?”
- to tell them the reason why they were not able to make demon leave the boy?

Why couldn’t we drive it out?: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as drive it out means “expel the demon” or “force the demon to leave” the boy. It refers to forcing the demon to stop controlling the boy and leave.

Jewish people often spoke of demons as being in someone. Different cultures have different ways of speaking about people being controlled by demons and being released from the control of demons. Use a natural expression for this in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this question:

Why couldn’t we force the demon out of the boy?
(GW)

Why were we not able to send the demon away?

Why were we not able to cause the demon to come/go out of the boy?

The expression drive...out also occurs in 7:22c. You should translate it the same way in both places.

General Comment on 17:19b

In some languages, it will be more natural to use indirect speech here. For example:

why they were not able to cast out the demon

Matthew 17:20

Section 17:14–20: Jesus healed a boy whom a demon controlled

In 10:1 Jesus had given power to his twelve disciples to cast out demons and heal sick people. Then the disciples went out in groups of two and did those things (Mark 6:7–13). But in this section, they could not cast out a demon that caused a boy to have severe physical problems. Only Jesus was able to force the demon to leave the boy. This story shows that the disciples’ faith was not yet strong.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Cures A Demon-Possessed Boy (GW)

The Healing of a Boy With a Demon (NIV)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 9:14–29 and at Luke 9:37–43.

17:20a

“Because you have so little faith,” He answered.

- He answered them, “Because your faith is small/lacking.
- Jesus answered, “It is because you^(plur) do not believe in God enough.

Because you have so little faith: Some words from 17:19b are implied here but not repeated. The complete sentence would be:

You could not cast it out because you have so little faith.

The Greek word that the BSB translates as little faith describes the kind of faith the disciples had. They did not believe very strongly or with confidence.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

It is because you don’t have enough faith! (CEV)

Because your faith is too small. (NCV)

Because your faith/trust is lacking.

Because you do not believe/trust in God enough.

Jesus also used the expression “little faith” in 14:31b. You should translate these two expressions in a similar way.

He answered: In 17:20a, Jesus began to answer the disciples’ question. So, in some languages, it may be more natural to use the verb “said” instead of answered. For example:

He said to them (ESV)

17:20b

“For truly I tell you,

- I assure you^(plur) that
- I tell you^(plur) with certainty,

For: In 17:20b–c, Jesus explained why he said that the disciples had little faith. The Greek introduces this explanation with a conjunction that the BSB translates as For. Many English versions do not translate this conjunction. They let the context indicate the

connection instead. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either.

truly I tell you: Jesus often used these words to introduce a statement that he wanted to emphasize. When he began a statement with these words, he was asking people to listen with extra attention.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

I assure you (NLT96)

Listen to this:

Let me tell you this:

If you have another way in your language to emphasize a statement or to alert people to listen with special attention, consider using it here.

This clause first occurs in 5:18a. You should translate it here as you did there.

17:20c

if you have faith the size of a mustard seed,

- if you^(plur) have faith even as small as a mustard seed,
- if you^(plur) have faith, even if it is as small as the smallest seed,

if you have faith the size of a mustard seed: This is a type of comparison called a simile. In this simile, Jesus compared effective faith to a mustard seed. They are similar in that both can be small, and both can do mighty things. Even a small amount of true faith can move mountains. (For help in translating the term mustard seed, see the note below.)

Here are some other ways to translate this simile:

- Make explicit the way faith and mustard seed are similar. For example:

if you have faith as small as a mustard seed (NIV)

if you had faith even as small as a mustard seed (NLT)

- Use a generic word for mustard seed. For example:

if you have faith, even if it is as small as the smallest seed

a mustard seed: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as a mustard seed can also be translated simply

as “a grain of mustard seed” (as in the ESV). To Jewish people, the mustard seed was a symbol of smallness.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- Use your word for seed and transliterate the word mustard according to the sounds of your language. For example:

a musutarade seed

a seed of the plant/tree called mutar

- Use a generic phrase. For example:

a tiny seed

- Use the name of a local seed that is known to be very small, but grows into a tree. If you use this option, you may want to indicate the literal name in a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

The Greek text is literally “a mustard seed.”

The phrase mustard seed also occurs in 13:31b–c. You should translate it the same way in both places.

17:20d

you can say to this mountain,

- you^(plur) might/could say to this mountain,
- you^(plur) could for example tell this/that mountain

you can say to this mountain: This is an example of the small (but effective) faith of 17:20c. In Greek, the verb that the BSB translates as can say is future. It is as if Jesus were predicting that the disciples were going to say this at some time. But the context indicates that Jesus was implying that the disciples could move the mountain if they needed to. Use words which show that moving a mountain is an example. For example:

you can say to this mountain (NIV)

you might for example say to this mountain

you could possibly tell this mountain

this mountain: This phrase probably refers to the mountain where Jesus had just been with his disciples. It is the mountain where his appearance had changed in front of them.

So you should translate this phrase as “this/that mountain.” You should not translate this phrase as “a mountain.”

17:20e

‘Move from here to there,’ and it will move.

- ‘Leave this place and move to that place,’ and it will do it!
- to move from where it is and go to another place, and it will obey you!

Move from here to there: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Move means to change position from one place to another. This word does not imply repeated movement back and forth.

The words from here to there indicate movement from a near place to a far place.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Leave from here and go over there.

Leave this place and go there.

In some languages, it will be more natural to use indirect speech here. For example:

to move from here to there

and it will move: Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

and it will do it

and it would obey you

17:20f

Nothing will be impossible for you.”

- There is nothing that you^(plur) will not be able to do.”
- All things will be possible for you. (NCV)

Nothing will be impossible for you: This clause indicates that, if the disciples have even a tiny bit of faith, there is nothing that they cannot do. They will be able to do anything.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

There is nothing that you will not be able to do.

There is nothing that you cannot do.

All things will be possible for you. (NCV)

Matthew 17:21

17:21

(NASB) [But this kind does not go out except by prayer and fasting.]

- But the only way to force out that kind of demon is by praying and going without eating. (CEV footnote)
- That kind of spirit comes out only if you use prayer and give up eating. (NCV footnote)

There is a textual issue here. The best Greek manuscripts do not have the words in 17:21. Most English versions do not include these words in the text. They include this verse only as a footnote. This verse was probably added later to make this story in the book of Matthew be like the story in the book of Mark.

It is good to include this verse only as a footnote, as many English versions do. Here is an example footnote:

Only some of the later Greek manuscripts include 17:21, which says: “But this kind does not go out except by prayer and fasting.”

(See below for help in translating this verse.)

If the major language version in your area includes this verse in the text, you may want to include it in brackets. For example:

[But this kind does not go out except by prayer and fasting.] (NASB)

If you put 17:21 in a footnote, here are several ways to number the verses:

- At the beginning of 17:20, put the verse numbers 20–21. Put the footnote marker at the end. For example:

^{20–21}Jesus replied: (CEV)

It is because you don’t have enough faith! But I can promise you this. If you had faith no larger than a mustard seed, you could tell this mountain to move from here to there. And it would. Everything would be possible for you. ‡

- Put in the number 21 after the last word of 17:20, and have the footnote marker after it. For example:

²⁰Jesus answered, “Because your faith is too small. I tell you the truth, if your faith is as big as a mustard seed, you can say to this mountain, ‘Move from here to there,’ and it will move. All things will be possible for you.” ²¹‡ (NCV)

- Do not include verse number 21. Put the footnote marker after verse 20. For example:

²⁰He told them, “Because you have so little faith. I can guarantee this truth: If your faith is the size of a mustard seed, you can say to this mountain, ‘Move from here to there,’ and it will move. Nothing will be impossible for you.” ‡ (GW)

(NASB) But this kind: The phrase this kind refers to “this kind of demon.” For example, the GW footnote says:

However, this kind of demon (GW)

(NASB) does not go out: These words refer to “casting out” the demon. For example, the CEV footnote says:

to force out (CEV)

(NASB) except by prayer and fasting: These words means that “only prayer and fasting” will force that type of demon out of a person. For example, the NCV footnote says:

only if you use prayer and give up eating (NCV)

Matthew 17:22

Section 17:22–23: Jesus again said that he would die and come back to life

In this section, Jesus again told his disciples that people would kill him and that he would become alive again. This is the second time in the book of Matthew that Jesus told this to his disciples. The first time was in 16:21–28.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus again foretells/predicts his death and resurrection

Jesus’ second prediction of his death and resurrection

Jesus Again Foretells That He Will Die and Come Back to Life (GW)

17:22a

When they gathered together in Galilee, Jesus told them,

- ¶ When they had gathered together in the region of Galilee, Jesus said to them,
- ¶ Then they left there went to the region of Galilee. There they met, and Jesus said to them,

When they: The pronoun they refers to the disciples. For instance:

When the disciples all came together (GNT)

gathered together: The Greek word that the BSB translates as gathered together means “were coming together” at a particular place. This word does not imply that the disciples had been widely separated. It simply means that they came/met together to listen to Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

came together (NIV)

met together

in Galilee: The word Galilee refers to the name of a region in the northern part of Israel.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

in the region of Galilee

17:22b

“The Son of Man is about to be delivered into the hands of men.

- “The Son of Man will soon be handed over to the control/power of evil men.
- “Someone will certainly betray me, the Son of Man, and give me to my enemies.

The Son of Man: Jesus used this phrase to refer to himself. In some languages, this phrase by itself would refer to someone other than Jesus. If that is true in your language, consider translating it as:

I, the Son of Man

This phrase last occurred in 17:12d.

is about to be delivered: The Greek word that the BSB translates as about refers to something that will definitely happen in the near future. It is not just a simple future tense.

It means that the Son of Man “will soon” be delivered. It also indicates that the Son of Man “will certainly” be delivered or “is destined” to be delivered because God has decided that it will happen.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

will soon be delivered

is going to be betrayed (NIV)

be delivered: The Greek word that the BSB translates as delivered means “handed over to the power of someone else.” It often refers to a person being betrayed and delivered to his enemies.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

be betrayed (NIV)

be handed over (GNT)

This is a passive verb. Here the text does not specify who would betray Jesus. From later in Matthew, it is clear that Judas would betray Jesus. This would fulfill God’s plan. However, you should not make Judas explicit here. If you need to use an active verb, translate in a general way. For example:

someone is going to betray

into the hands of men: This phrase is a figure of speech. It refers to people gaining power or control over someone. In this context, this expression refers to Jesus being under the power of people who will harm him. People who want to harm him will gain the power to do that. In some languages, this expression may already be implied in the verb “betrayed.” If so, it does not need to be explicitly translated. For example:

over to people (NCV)

Do not translate this in a way that means that people will protect him. In some languages, it may be necessary to make it clear that these people wish to do him harm. For example:

into the power of his/my enemies

into the power of people (REB)

In some languages, it may be natural to use a second verb with this phrase. For example:

and handed over to people (GW)

and given to people

Matthew 17:23

Section 17:22-23: Jesus again said that he would die and come back to life

In this section, Jesus again told his disciples that people would kill him and that he would become alive again. This is the second time in the book of Matthew that Jesus told this to his disciples. The first time was in 16:21-28.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus again foretells/predicts his death and resurrection

Jesus' second prediction of his death and resurrection

Jesus Again Foretells That He Will Die and Come Back to Life (GW)

17:23a

They will kill Him, and on the third day He will be raised to life."

- They will kill him, and after three days he will be raised from death."
- They will kill me, and/but three days later God will make me alive again!"

They will kill Him: Here, Jesus was still speaking about himself. In some languages, it will be more natural for Jesus to speak about himself using the pronoun "me" rather than Him. For example:

they will kill me

and: This is the conjunction that usually joins the next event to the previous one. Since the idea that someone could come back to life after dying is unexpected,

some English versions translate this conjunction as "but." For example:

but on the third day (NLT)

If it would be clearer in your language to make the contrast explicit, you should do so.

on the third day: This phrase indicates that Jesus would come back to life on the third day after he was killed. That is, the first day (Friday) he was killed and buried. The second day (Saturday) he was in the tomb. The third day (Sunday) he rose from death.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

three days later

three days after my death

He will be raised: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as will be raised means that Jesus will be raised from the dead. He will be brought back to life (by God).

Here, Jesus continued to talk about himself. In some languages, it will be more natural for Jesus to use the pronoun "I" rather than He. For example:

I will be raised

This verb is passive. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

he will be brought back to life (GW)

I will be raised from death

- Use an active verb. For example:

God will bring him back to life

God will make me live again

17:23b

And the disciples were deeply grieved.

- Then the disciples were extremely sad.
- When the disciples heard this, they became very sad.

And: This is the connecting word that usually joins the next event to the previous one. Some English versions do not translate it here.

Here are some other ways to connect 17:23b to 17:23a:

Then (GW)

When the disciples heard these words

the disciples were deeply grieved: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as deeply grieved means that the disciples became extremely sad. They did not understand the meaning of Jesus' words about his return to life after death. They only understood that he was going to be killed. They did not understand that it was God's plan for him to die.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

the disciples became very sad (GW)

Matthew 17:24

Section 17:24–27: Jesus taught about the temple tax

In this section, Jesus taught Peter an important lesson about his relationship to his heavenly father. He used a question about paying the temple tax to show Peter that both he and Jesus were sons of the Father. That meant that they really did not need to pay this tax. But Jesus did not want to offend people over this issue. So he did a miracle to provide the money to pay the tax.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Talks About Paying Taxes (NCV)

Payment of the Temple Tax (NLT)

The Temple Tax (NET)

17:24a

After they had arrived in Capernaum,

- ¶ After Jesus and his disciples came to Capernaum,
- ¶ Then Jesus and his disciples arrived in the town of Capernaum. While they were there,

17:24

After they had arrived in Capernaum: The pronoun they refers to Jesus and his disciples. The word Capernaum is the name of a town in the region of Galilee. In 17:22–23 Jesus and his disciples were somewhere in

the region of Galilee. In this verse they arrived in the town of Capernaum.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

When Jesus and his followers came to Capernaum (NCV)

Then Jesus and his disciples arrived in the town of Capernaum.

17:24b

the collectors of the two-drachma tax came to Peter and asked,

- the men who collected the temple tax came to Peter and asked him,
- some men who gathered/received money each year for the temple approached Peter and asked,

the collectors: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the collectors refers to some officials in Capernaum. These particular officials were responsible for collecting the temple tax and sending it to Jerusalem.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the tax collectors (NLT96)

the men who collected (NCV)

certain men who receive/gather money

the two-drachma tax: This phrase refers to a tax that all adult Jewish men were required to pay. They paid this tax once a year. It was used to pay for the services and maintenance of the temple in Jerusalem.

A “drachma” was a Greek coin. It was made of silver. It had about the same value as a Roman denarius. It was worth the same as the wages for a farm worker for one day of work. This was likely an average wage at that time in Israel.

In this verse, the important idea is that this was a tax for the temple. The amount of the tax can be explained in a footnote. (See a sample footnote below.)

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the temple tax (NET)

the money for the temple

the money that each Jewish man paid each year for the temple

Here is a sample footnote:

In Greek, this “tax” refers to a sum of money equivalent to two day’s work. All adult Jewish men paid this tax once a year. The money was used to maintain the temple in Jerusalem.

came to Peter: The Greek verb that the BSB here translates as came to also occurs in 17:7a. There the BSB translated this verb as “came over.” The translation of this verb depends on the storyteller’s point of view.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

went up to Peter (ESV)

approached Peter

17:24c

“Does your Teacher pay the two drachmas?”

- “Does your teacher pay the temple tax?”
- “Your teacher/master pays the money for the temple, does he not?”

Does your Teacher pay the two drachmas?: This is a real question. In Greek, this question is stated in a way that expects a positive answer. In other words, the collectors seemed to believe that Jesus did indeed pay the temple tax, and they wanted to confirm that with Peter.

Here is another way to translate this question:

Your teacher pays the tax, does he not?

You should translate in such a way that the reader will know the collectors expected “Yes” for an answer.

your Teacher: This phrase refers to Jesus. Here, the word Teacher refers to a religious teacher. It was a polite way to refer to a Jewish man who had authority to teach the things about God. Use a title that is an appropriate way to address a religious teacher in your culture. It should not refer only to a school teacher.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

your master

Matthew 17:25

Section 17:24–27: Jesus taught about the temple tax

In this section, Jesus taught Peter an important lesson about his relationship to his heavenly father. He used a question about paying the temple tax to show Peter that both he and Jesus were sons of the Father. That meant that they really did not need to pay this tax. But Jesus did not want to offend people over this issue. So he did a miracle to provide the money to pay the tax.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Talks About Paying Taxes (NCV)

Payment of the Temple Tax (NLT)

The Temple Tax (NET)

17:25a

“Yes,” he answered. When Peter entered the house,

- Peter replied, “Yes.” When he went into the house,
- Peter answered, “Yes, he pays it.” Then he entered the house.

“Yes,” he answered: Peter’s answer was a simple Yes. Because his answer was so short, it seems to express confidence.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

“Yes, he does,” he replied. (NIV)

He said, “Yes, he pays it.”

“Of course,” Peter answered. (GNT)

When Peter entered the house: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as entered can also be translated as “went into” or “came into.”

The Greek does not indicate how much time passed between Peter’s answer and his entering the house. However, by looking at 17:24b, we can see that Peter probably went into the house soon after he answered the tax collectors.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

Then he went into the house (NLT)

the house: The Greek does not indicate whose house this was. It was certainly the house where Jesus was at that time. It was probably the house where Jesus and his disciples were staying.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the house where Jesus was

the house where there were staying

17:25b

Jesus preempted him.

- Jesus spoke first and asked him,
- But before he could say anything, Jesus asked him,

Jesus preempted him: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as Jesus preempted him is more literally “Jesus anticipated him saying.” This clause indicates that Jesus already knew what the collectors had asked Peter. He already knew how Peter had responded. So Jesus spoke before Peter could report the conversation he had with the tax collectors.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

but before he could speak, Jesus said to him (NCV)

But before he had a chance to speak, Jesus asked him (NLT)

preempted him: The Greek verb that the BSB translates preempted means “said/spoke first.” But here it introduces a question. So it may be more natural to translate this as:

asked him (NLT)

17:25c

“What do you think, Simon?” He asked.

- “Simon, what do you think?”
- “Peter, what is your opinion?”

What do you think, Simon?: Jesus’ question was an invitation for Peter to think about something.

Here are some other ways to translate this question:

Simon, how does it seem to you?

Simon, what is your opinion? (GNT)

In some languages it will be more natural to put the name Simon at the beginning of the question.

Simon: Simon was Peter’s original name. Jesus added the name “Peter” to him later (see 16:18a). But when Jesus called him by name, he almost always called him Simon.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

- Transliterate the word Simon according the sounds of your language. You may also want to add a footnote to explain that Simon is Peter. Here is a sample footnote:

Simon was Peter’s original name. Jesus almost always used it when he called him by name.

- Use the word Peter. For example:

What do you think, Peter? (NLT)

17:25d

“From whom do the kings of the earth collect customs and taxes: from their own sons, or from others?”

- Earthly kings collect duties and taxes from whom? From their own sons? Or from others?”
- Do earthly kings require their own family to pay different kinds of taxes?” Or do they require the other citizens to pay different kinds of taxes?”

From whom do the kings of the earth collect customs and taxes: from their own sons, or from others?: Before you translate these two questions, consider the most natural way to do it. Here are some other ways to translate these two questions:

- As two questions. For example:

From whom do kings of the earth take toll or tax?
From their sons or from others? (ESV)

- As a statement followed by one or more questions. For example:

The kings of the earth collect different kinds of taxes. But who pays the taxes—the king’s children or others?” (NCV)

The kings of the earth collect different kinds of taxes. But who pays? Do the king’s children pay? Or do other people pay?

- As one question. For example:

Do kings tax their own family or other people?

From whom do the kings of the earth collect: The phrase kings of the earth refers to all human kings. It contrasts with God, the king of heaven.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

From whom do earthly kings take

From whom do human rulers collect

customs: The Greek word that the BSB translates as customs refers to tolls or duties that were charged people who sold things. For example, when merchants traveled around with their goods in Judaea, they would be charged a toll when they entered a town. This was the kind of tax that Matthew collected while he sat in his toll booth (in 9:9b).

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

toll (ESV)

duties (GNT)

taxes: The Greek word that the BSB translates as taxes refers to a government tax on people. This was a tax that Rome collected from each adult male in an area whenever a census was taken.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

poll tax

head tax

from their own sons: There are two ways to interpret the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as their own sons:

1. It is literal and refers to their own sons or the members of their family. For example:

from their family members (GW) (BSB, NRSV, GW, NCV, KJV)

1. It is figurative and refers to the citizens of their country. For example:

from their own people (REB) (GNT, CEV, NLT, JBP, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Many commentators follow this interpretation. In 17:26a, Peter seemed to answer correctly that kings do not collect taxes from their own sons. So this phrase probably does not refer to citizens. Citizens do pay the taxes. But the members of the king's family do not.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

from the people of his own house

Do they collect taxes from their own sons/family?

or from others: If you have chosen interpretation (1) above, then the word others refers to other people in the kingdom. It does not refer to foreigners or strangers outside the kingdom.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

from other people (GW)

Or do they collect taxes from other people?

General Comment on 17:25d

It is possible to translate the two words “customs” and “taxes” as one word or phrase. For example:

different kinds of taxes (NCV)

It is also possible to translate the phrase “collect customs and taxes” as a verb. For example:

Do kings tax their own people (NLT)

Matthew 17:26

Section 17:24–27: Jesus taught about the temple tax

In this section, Jesus taught Peter an important lesson about his relationship to his heavenly father. He used a question about paying the temple tax to show Peter that both he and Jesus were sons of the Father. That meant that they really did not need to pay this tax. But Jesus did not want to offend people over this issue. So he did a miracle to provide the money to pay the tax.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Talks About Paying Taxes (NCV)

Payment of the Temple Tax (NLT)

The Temple Tax (NET)

17:26a

“From others,” Peter answered.

- Peter replied, “They take/collect taxes from others.”
- Peter answered, “They require others to pay.”

From others: Some words from 17:25d are implied here but not repeated. The complete sentence would be:

They take/collect taxes from others.

17:26b

“Then the sons are exempt,” Jesus declared.

- Jesus said to him, “So then, the sons are exempt.
- Then Jesus said, “That’s true. So that means that the family is not required to pay different kinds of taxes. Likewise we^(incl) are not required to pay.

Then: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Then includes a word that is used for emphasis. The phrase could also be translated as “Surely then.” Jesus’ response is a necessary conclusion to Peter’s answer. If you can, find a way to put emphasis on this conclusion. For example:

Then indeed

Jesus’ answer indicates that Peter answered correctly. In some languages, it may be necessary to make that explicit. For example:

That’s right/correct. So

That is true. Therefore

the sons: The phrase the sons refers to the same people as in 17:25d. You should translate it in the same way. For example:

the family members (GW)

are exempt: The Greek word that the BSB translates as are exempt means “are free.” The sons of the king do not pay any sort of taxes.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

are not required to pay (CEV)

don’t have to pay taxes (NCV)

Matthew 17:27

Section 17:24–27: Jesus taught about the temple tax

In this section, Jesus taught Peter an important lesson about his relationship to his heavenly father. He used a question about paying the temple tax to show Peter that both he and Jesus were sons of the Father. That meant that they really did not need to pay this tax. But Jesus did not want to offend people over this issue. So he did a miracle to provide the money to pay the tax.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus Talks About Paying Taxes (NCV)

Payment of the Temple Tax (NLT)

The Temple Tax (NET)

17:27a

“But so that we may not offend them,

- But in order that we^(incl) not make them upset with us,
- But we^(incl) do not want to make them angry at us for/by not paying the tax. So
- But if we^(incl) do not pay, the tax collectors will be irritated with us. We do not want that to happen, so

But: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between what Jesus implied (that he and Peter should not be required to pay the tax), and what he commanded Peter to do (pay the tax for both of them). The BSB indicates this contrast with the conjunction But.

Here is another way to indicate this contrast:

However (ESV)

If people in your area do not understand this contrast, you may want to:

- Make the contrast explicit in the text. For example:

So then we are also exempt. However

Likewise we are not required to pay. But This implied information can be put at the end of 17:26 (as in the Display), or at the beginning of 17:27.

- Explain the contrast in a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

Jesus implied that God did not require Jesus and his followers to pay this tax for the temple.

so that we may not offend them: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as offend them also means “shock” or “anger.” It refers to someone doing something that causes others to be upset with him. If Jesus had refused to pay the temple tax, the tax collectors would have been angry or upset with him.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

so that we don’t offend them (NET)

we don’t want to upset these tax collectors (NCV)

we don’t want them to be angry/irritated at us by not paying the tax

If we do not pay the tax, these men will be upset with us. We don’t want to do that.

them: The pronoun them refers to the tax collectors.

Here are some other ways to translate this pronoun:

these people (GNT)

these tax collectors (NCV)

17:27b

go to the sea, cast a hook, and take the first fish you catch.

- go to the lake and throw out your fishing line. Take the first fish you catch,
- go to the lake and go fishing. After the first fish bites, take it,

go to the sea: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sea refers to a large freshwater lake. It was Lake Galilee which was also called the Sea of Galilee. This lake is 23 kilometers long and 10 kilometers wide (14 miles long and 6 miles wide).

Here is another way to translate this clause:

go to the lake (NIV)

The word sea last occurred in 15:29b. You should translate it here as you did there.

cast a hook: The Greek words that the BSB translates as cast a hook are more literally “throw a fishhook.” Jesus told Peter to catch a fish using a hook that a small rope or string was tied to. You should use your natural expression for catching a fish in this way.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

throw out your fishing line

fish with a line/hook

If your culture does not fish in this way, use a general expression for catching a fish. For example:

catch a fish

go fishing

take the first fish you catch: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as fish you catch probably refers to a fish swimming up from deep water to bite the hook. You should translate the idea of catching a fish in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Take the first fish that comes up (ESV)

Take the first fish that bites (JBP)

17:27c

When you open its mouth, you will find a four-drachma coin.

- open its mouth and you will find/see a large coin.
- and open its mouth. There you will find a coin that is worth the temple tax for two people.

you will find a four-drachma coin: The Greek word that the BSB translates as four-drachma coin is the name of a Greek coin called a stater. This coin was worth enough to pay the temple tax for two people.

Here is another way to translate this word:

a coin (GW)

a large silver coin (NLT)

a coin worth enough for my Temple tax and yours (GNT)

17:27d**Take it and give it to them for My tax and yours.”**

- Take that coin and give it to the tax collectors to pay for my tax and for yours.”
- Go and give that coin to the men who collect the tax. It will pay for you and me.”

Take it and give it to them: The pronoun it refers to the coin. The pronoun them refers to the tax collectors.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

Take that coin and give it to the tax collectors
(NCV)

for My tax and yours: The coin was worth enough to pay the temple tax for Jesus and Peter.

The BSB follows the Greek order and says My tax and yours. In some languages, it is more natural to say “you and me.” (See the CEV below.) You should follow the order that is most natural in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

to pay your taxes and mine (CEV)

and pay the tax for both of us (NLT)

Matthew 18:1**Section 18:1–4: Jesus’ disciples must be humble**

Jesus’ disciples were sometimes concerned about their own reputations. They were also concerned about what their roles would be in the kingdom that Jesus announced. In this section, they asked Jesus directly about this concern. (The parallel passage in Mark 9:34 shows that the twelve disciples were arguing among themselves about which one of them would be the greatest in God’s kingdom.) Jesus answered them in a way that showed that the greatest person in the kingdom was not whom they thought. Jesus told them that the greatest person in the kingdom is the person who humbles himself and becomes like a child.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Greatest in the Kingdom of Heaven (NIV)

Who is the greatest?

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 9:33–37 and Luke 9:46–48.

18:1a**At that time the disciples came to Jesus and asked,**

- ¶ About that time, the disciples approached Jesus and asked,
- ¶ Soon after that, Jesus’ disciples came/went to him and asked,

At that time: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as At that time is more literally “at that hour.” This phrase indicates that the events in this section happened shortly after the events at the end of chapter 17. It does not necessarily mean that this story happened an hour after the previous one.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

About that time (NLT)

Shortly/soon after that

Then/Later

the disciples came to Jesus: The words came to refer to the disciples “approaching” Jesus. They approached him with a question.

The disciples did not come to Jesus from a great distance. They were already with him in Capernaum. But the previous section talked about only Jesus and Peter. In this section, all the disciples are together with Jesus.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

the disciples approached Jesus

the disciples: For help in translating the word disciples, see the note at 5:1c.

18:1b**“Who then is the greatest in the kingdom of heaven?”**

- “Who is the most important person in God’s kingdom?”
- “Who has the biggest name/status under God’s rule?”

Who then is the greatest: The word greatest refers to the most important person. It is the person with the highest rank or status. It is the person whose name is above everyone else’s name.

In this question, the disciples were asking about themselves. They wanted to know which one of them

would be the greatest. They were not asking about Jesus himself or God.

Here are some other ways to translate this question:

Who is the most important person

Who among us is the most honored/respected person

Who has a name that exceeds every other name

in the kingdom of heaven: The phrase kingdom of heaven has the same meaning as the phrase “kingdom of God.” Both phrases refer to God’s activity of ruling and caring for his people as their king. Both refer to the relationship that God has with his people. He leads, protects, and cares for them. They obey, trust, and submit to him as their king. The phrase kingdom of heaven does not refer to a land or country that he rules over.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

- As a noun. For example:

the kingdom of God

God’s kingship

God’s rule over people

the rule of the one/Lord who lives in heaven

- As a verbal expression. For example:

The way that God rules his people

The way that God cares for his people as king.

See kingdom of heaven in the Glossary for more information.

This same phrase occurs in 4:17c and 5:3b.

Matthew 18:2

Section 18:1–4: Jesus’ disciples must be humble

Jesus’ disciples were sometimes concerned about their own reputations. They were also concerned about what their roles would be in the kingdom that Jesus announced. In this section, they asked Jesus

directly about this concern. (The parallel passage in Mark 9:34 shows that the twelve disciples were arguing among themselves about which one of them would be the greatest in God’s kingdom.) Jesus answered them in a way that showed that the greatest person in the kingdom was not whom they thought. Jesus told them that the greatest person in the kingdom is the person who humbles himself and becomes like a child.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Greatest in the Kingdom of Heaven (NIV)

Who is the greatest?

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 9:33–37 and Luke 9:46–48.

18:2a

Jesus invited a little child

- Jesus called a little child
- Jesus asked a small/young child to come,

Jesus invited a little child: This clause indicates that there was a child nearby, but not right next to Jesus. So Jesus called for the child to come close to him.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

Jesus invited a little child to come to him

In some languages it will be more natural to translate this clause as direct speech. For example:

Jesus invited a little child and said, “Come here.”

invited: This word indicates that Jesus asked or summoned the child to come. Jesus did not shout or talk loudly.

little child: The Greek word that the BSB translates as little child refers to a young child. In this context, it refers to a child who was old enough to stand and walk.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

small child (NLT96)

young child

18:2b

to stand among them.

- to come stand among them.
- and he stood the child in the middle of them.

to stand among them: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as to stand among them means that Jesus stood the child among them. He set or placed the child in a standing position in the middle of the disciples.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

whom he set among them (NJB)

and he placed him standing in the middle of them

among them: The words among them indicates that the child was in the middle of Jesus and the disciples. He was surrounded by them. The child was most likely standing, but the men could have been sitting down. It is very possible that they were all inside of a house.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in the midst of them (ESV)

in the middle of them all (JBP)

Matthew 18:3

Section 18:1–4: Jesus’ disciples must be humble

Jesus’ disciples were sometimes concerned about their own reputations. They were also concerned about what their roles would be in the kingdom that Jesus announced. In this section, they asked Jesus directly about this concern. (The parallel passage in Mark 9:34 shows that the twelve disciples were arguing among themselves about which one of them would be the greatest in God’s kingdom.) Jesus answered them in a way that showed that the greatest person in the kingdom was not whom they thought. Jesus told them that the greatest person in the kingdom is the person who humbles himself and becomes like a child.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Greatest in the Kingdom of Heaven (NIV)

Who is the greatest?

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 9:33–37 and Luke 9:46–48.

18:3a

“Truly I tell you,” He said,

- Then he said, “I assure you^(plur) that
- Then he said to his disciples, “Listen^(plur) to this:

Truly I tell you: Jesus often used the words that the BSB translates as Truly I tell you to introduce a statement that he wanted to emphasize. When he began a statement with these words, he was asking people to listen with extra attention.

Here are some other ways to introduce this:

I assure you (NLT96)

Listen to this:

Let me tell you this:

If you have another way in your language to emphasize a statement or to alert people to listen with special attention, consider using it here.

This clause first occurs in 5:18a. It also occurs in 17:20b. You should translate it here as you did there.

you: In Greek, the pronoun you is plural here. Jesus addressed his disciples, not the child.

18:3b

“unless you change and become like little children,

- if you^(plur) do not change and become like little children,
- you^(plur) must change your thinking and become like little children. If you do not,

unless you change: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as unless you change can also be translated as “if you do not turn.” Here the verb translated as change is used figuratively. It refers to an inward change of attitude.

Here are some other ways to translate the clause:

if you do not turn

if you do not change your mind/thinking

You must change your thinking.... If you do not

and become like little children: This clause is a comparison. Jesus told the disciples that it was necessary for them to become like children in their attitudes and thinking. Jesus meant that they should be humble like children. This idea is made clear in the next verse, so you should not put it here.

18:3c**you will never enter the kingdom of heaven.**

- you^(plur) will never enter the kingdom of the one who lives in heaven.
- you^(plur) will certainly not become a citizen/member of the kingdom of the one who lives in heaven.
- you^(plur) will never be among those whom God rules.

you will never enter: The BSB translates two Greek words as the single word never. In Greek, this is a double negative. This means that the two words make this negative statement emphatic.

Here are some other ways to translate this double negative:

you will certainly not enter

you absolutely cannot enter

enter the kingdom of heaven: In this context, the word enter refers to “becoming a citizen of.” When people change their attitudes and follow Jesus, they become citizens/members of the kingdom of heaven.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

become a citizen of the kingdom of heaven

become one of those who are in the kingdom of the one who lives in heaven

be added to those over whom God rules

This same expression occurs in 5:20b. You should translate it the same way in both places.

Matthew 18:4**Section 18:1–4: Jesus’ disciples must be humble**

Jesus’ disciples were sometimes concerned about their own reputations. They were also concerned about what their roles would be in the kingdom that Jesus announced. In this section, they asked Jesus directly about this concern. (The parallel passage in Mark 9:34 shows that the twelve disciples were arguing among themselves about which one of them would be the greatest in God’s kingdom.) Jesus answered them in a way that showed that the greatest person in the kingdom was not whom they thought. Jesus told them that the greatest person in the kingdom is the person who humbles himself and becomes like a child.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Greatest in the Kingdom of Heaven (NIV)

Who is the greatest?

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 9:33–37 and Luke 9:46–48.

18:4a**Therefore, whoever humbles himself like this little child**

- Therefore, anyone who lowers himself like this child
- So, the person who makes himself low/small to become low like this child,

Therefore: In Greek, this verse is connected to the previous verse with a conjunction that usually introduces a conclusion. Here, the BSB translates this word as Therefore.

Here is another way to introduce this verse:

And so (NJB)

whoever: This word is an indefinite word that refers to any person.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

anyone who (NLT)

the person who

humbles himself: In this context, the verb humbles refers to an action that causes someone to lose status. The person goes from a high position to a low one.

The pronoun himself indicates that the person causes his own loss of status.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

lowers himself

makes himself low/small in name

abandons making himself great

like this little child: There is some implied information here. If the implicit information is included, it will say:

and becomes like this child is humble

Be careful that your translation does not imply “like this child humbles himself.” The child was already humble.

18:4b
is the greatest in the kingdom of heaven.

- is the most important person in God’s kingdom”
- this person has the biggest name/status under God’s rule”

In Greek, 18:4b begins with a pronoun that can be translated as “this one.” The BSB does not translate this word. But in some languages, it will be more natural to include this word.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

you (CEV)

he (RSV)

this person

is the greatest in the kingdom of heaven: Here Jesus answered the disciples’ question using the same words that they used in 18:1b. You should translate these words here as you did there.

Matthew 18:5

Section 18:5–9: Do not cause anyone to sin

In the previous section, Jesus used a child to illustrate what it meant for a disciple to be great in the kingdom. In this section, he compared a humble disciple to a child. He warned people not to cause one of them to sin. If they did, the consequences would be serious.

Jesus also warned his disciples to eliminate the source of sin in their own lives.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Temptations To Sin (GNT)

Eliminate the cause of sin

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 9:42–48 and Luke 17:1–2.

Paragraph 18:5–6

Some English versions put verse 18:5 in the previous paragraph. But it is best to start a new paragraph here

(as in the NCV). It is true that Matthew used the term “child” again. But he changed from talking about the actual child that they were all looking at in 18:4. Here he talked about disciples who are like that child.

18:5a

And whoever welcomes a little child like this in My name

- ¶ “Anyone who welcomes a child like this on my behalf
- ¶ “If a person gives hospitality for my sake to one such humble believer who is like that child,

And whoever: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as whoever is similar to, but slightly different from, the word translated as “whoever” in 18:4a. This phrase is also indefinite and refers to any person.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Anyone who (NJB)

The person who

If someone

welcomes: In this context, the word welcomes refers to giving hospitality to someone. It refers to welcoming a person into one’s house and caring for him by feeding him or helping him as he needs it.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

receives (ESV)

shows/gives hospitality

This word also occurs in 10:40a. You should translate it here as you did there.

a little child like this: The Greek word that the BSB translates as like this refers to something or someone just mentioned. So this phrase means “a child similar to the one I just spoke about.”

There are two ways to interpret the word child in this verse:

1. It is figurative and refers to any person who is humble like a child. This could be a child or a humble adult.
2. It is literal and refers to any child just like the child still standing in their midst.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Many commentators follow this interpretation.

Here are some other ways to translate the phrase a little child like this according to interpretation (1):

- Translate the phrase literally. For example:

a child like this child If you follow this option, you may want to include a footnote. This is what the NJB had done. Here is a sample footnote:

The words a little child like this are figurative and refer to a humble follower of Jesus. Such a person is like a child.

- Include some implied information in the text. For example:

a humble person who is like this child

in My name: This phrase probably modifies the verb “welcomes” (as in the GNT). It indicates that someone welcomes the humble person on behalf of Jesus. He receives him under the authority of Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

because of me (CEV)

welcomes...on my behalf (NLT)

18:5b welcomes Me.

- welcomes me.
- it is the same as giving hospitality to me.

welcomes Me: The verb welcomes is the same verb here as in the first part of this verse. But here it is used in a figurative way. When someone receives/welcomes a believer, he honors Jesus. It is like he receives/welcomes Jesus.

In some languages, it may be necessary to include some of this implied information here. For example:

it is the same as welcoming me

it is like he would be giving me hospitality

honors me

Matthew 18:6

Section 18:5–9: Do not cause anyone to sin

In the previous section, Jesus used a child to illustrate what it meant for a disciple to be great in the kingdom. In this section, he compared a humble disciple to a child. He warned people not to cause one of them to sin. If they did, the consequences would be serious.

Jesus also warned his disciples to eliminate the source of sin in their own lives.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Temptations To Sin (GNT)

Eliminate the cause of sin

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 9:42–48 and Luke 17:1–2.

Paragraph 18:5–6

Some English versions put verse 18:5 in the previous paragraph. But it is best to start a new paragraph here (as in the NCV). It is true that Matthew used the term “child” again. But he changed from talking about the actual child that they were all looking at in 18:4. Here he talked about disciples who are like that child.

18:6a–c

Verse 18:6 contains a comparison that has some implied information. Before you begin to translate 18:6, read the information below and consider the best way in your language to translate this entire comparison. (Do not miss the discussion further below about the meaning of the words and phrases in the three parts of 18:6.)

In 18:6, Jesus talked about two bad things:

1. a bad crime: causing a child to sin
2. a bad punishment: drowning in the sea

Jesus said that the punishment of (b) is better than the implied punishment for (a). To say it another way, the punishment for (a) is worse than the punishment of (b).

Languages indicate such comparisons in various ways. One way is the way the BSB translates it. Here are some other ways:

- One punishment is big. The other is little. For example:

^{6a}But if anyone causes to sin one of these little ones who believes in me, God will give him a

really big punishment. ^{6b}If people tied a big stone around the neck of a person who did that ^{6c}and threw him in the ocean so that he drowned, ^{6b}that would be a little punishment.

- One punishment is bad. Another thing is very bad or worse. For example:

^{6b}It is a bad punishment for someone to have a great millstone fastened around his neck ^{6c}and to be drowned in the depth of the sea. ^{6a}But if anyone causes one of these little ones who believe in me to sin he will receive a worse punishment.

You should translate this comparison in a way that is natural in your language.

18:6a

But if anyone causes one of these little ones who believe in Me to stumble,

- But before anyone causes to sin one of these people who are like little children who believe in me,
- But if any person cause to sin one of these believers who are like little children, the/his punishment will be very bad.
- Such believers are like little children. If anyone causes one of them to sin, God will punish

But: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between doing a good thing (welcoming a child) in 18:5 and doing a bad thing (causing a child to sin) in 18:6. The BSB indicates this contrast with the conjunction But.

if anyone: The Greek words that the BSB translates as if anyone are the same as the words in 18:5a. You may want to use the same term here as in 18:5. For example:

anyone who (NJB)

the person who

if someone

causes...to stumble: The Greek verb that the BSB translates literally as causes...to stumble is used here with a figurative meaning.

There are several ways to interpret this verb:

1. It refers to causing a believer to sin. For example:

if anyone causes one of these little ones who believe in me to sin (NET) (RSV, NIV, NET, ESV, CEV, NCV, NLT)

1. It refers to causing a believer to stop believing. For example:

If anyone should cause one of these little ones to lose his faith in me (GNT) (GNT, NLT96, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with the majority of English versions.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

makes...sin

causes...to fall into sin (NLT)

This same verb occurs in 5:29a–b .

one of these little ones who believe in Me: The phrase one of these little ones refers to the same type of person as “a little child like this” in 18:5a. This means that Jesus used the term these little ones in a figurative sense. He was referring to people who are humble like children. He was referring to people of all ages who believe in him, both children and adults.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

one of these people who are like little children who believe in me

one of these believers who are like little children

These little ones believe in me. (GW)

18:6b

it would be better for him to have a large millstone hung around his neck

- it is better that people tie a large millstone around his neck
- It would be better in comparison if he were to have a large grinding stone hung from his neck
- him more/worse than if someone tied a heavy stone to his neck

it would be better for him: This clause introduces one half of a comparison of two punishments. The other half (what would be worse for him) is not stated. Both punishments are bad, but drowning is better, or not as bad.

If you are not able to make a comparison like this in your language, see the discussion above in 18:6a–c.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

it would be better in comparison for him

it would be less bad for him

a punishment that would not be as bad for him
would be to have

to have...hung around his neck: This verb means “to hang” something, as you would hang a lamp from a hook or a necklace around your neck.

This clause is passive. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

to have...fastened around his neck (ESV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

for someone to fasten/tie...to his neck

a large millstone: This phrase refers to a type of stone that was used to grind wheat seeds into flour. Specifically, it was a large, round stone meant to be pulled by a donkey so that it rolled over the seeds and crushed them. It was very heavy.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

a very large grinding stone

a heavy stone (CEV)

a large stone (NCV) a donkey pulling a millstoneL.
Bass graphic, C0000106.tif (How the Jews Lived
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18:6c

and to be drowned in the depths of the sea.

- and they throw him into the deep part of the sea to drown.
- and be thrown into a deep sea and drown.
- and threw him in the deepest part of the sea so that he drowns/dies.

to be drowned: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as to be drowned means “to sink” something in water.

In this context, a person who was thrown into the sea with a large stone tied around his neck would sink and would not be able to breathe air. So he would die under the water.

This clause is passive. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

to be drowned

- Use an active verb. For example:

so that he drowns

in the depths of the sea: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as in the depths means “in the deepest part.”

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

in the deepest part of the ocean (CEV)

General Comment on 18:6c

The Jews thought that drowning in the sea was a terrible way to die. They thought this in part because the body could not be buried and mourned over. You may want to include a footnote to explain some of this information. Here is an example footnote:

The Jews thought that drowning in the depths of the sea was one of the worst ways to die. So Jesus showed that causing a believer to sin was very bad indeed, because God would punish that person in a way that was worse than drowning in the depths of the sea.

Matthew 18:7

Section 18:5–9: Do not cause anyone to sin

In the previous section, Jesus used a child to illustrate what it meant for a disciple to be great in the kingdom. In this section, he compared a humble disciple to a child. He warned people not to cause one of them to sin. If they did, the consequences would be serious.

Jesus also warned his disciples to eliminate the source of sin in their own lives.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Temptations To Sin (GNT)

Eliminate the cause of sin

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 9:42–48 and Luke 17:1–2.

18:7a

Woe to the world for the causes of sin.

- ¶ It will be terrible for the world for tempting people to sin.
- ¶ Great trouble is waiting for the people of the world because they cause believers to sin.

Woe to the world: This clause means that the world will experience pain and deep sorrow. It is a prediction and warning by Jesus that something bad is going to happen to the world. It implies that God will judge and punish the world. It is not a curse.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

How terrible for the world (GNT)

The world is going to experience great pain and sadness

Great trouble is waiting for the world

The word Woe also occurs in 11:21a.

the world: This phrase refers to the people in the world. For example:

the people of the world (NCV)

These people are opposed to the people of God.

for the causes of sin: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the causes of sin is the noun form of the verb translated as “causes...to stumble” in 18:6a. Here it refers to the people of the world “causing others to sin.” More specifically, it refers to causing to sin these little ones who believe (in 18:6a).

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

because it tempts people to sin (NLT)

because of the way it causes people to sin (CEV)

because they tempt/cause believers to sin

18:7b

These stumbling blocks must come,

- Because temptations will certainly happen,
- The things that cause people/believers to sin will definitely occur,
- People of the world will always tempt/cause believers to sin,

Verse 18:7b is the reason that the people of the world will have pain and sorrow (in 18:7a). The Greek introduces this reason with a conjunction that many English versions translate as “For.”

Some English versions, including the BSB, do not translate this conjunction. Instead, they let the context indicate the connection. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either.

These stumbling blocks must come: The phrase stumbling blocks is the same word translated as “causes of sin” in 18:7a.

In some languages, it will not be natural to say that temptations come. So you may need to use another verb. Or you can translate the noun stumbling blocks as a verb. For example:

These temptations must/will happen

Such things will always happen (GNT)

People will always be tempted

People of the world will always tempt/cause believers to sin

must come: The Greek word that the BSB translates as must come indicates that temptations must/will happen. This is because the world is evil.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

must happen (REB)

will always happen (GNT)

18:7c

but woe to the man through whom they come!

- but it will be terrible for the person who causes these temptations to happen.
- but great trouble is waiting for the person who tempts/causes believers to sin.
- but God will punish the person who does that.

but: There is a contrast here. The contrast is that, even though temptations will certainly come (18:7b),

the person who is the source of them cannot escape responsibility (18:7c). The BSB indicates this contrast with the conjunction but.

woe to the man through whom they come: This is the same sort of clause as “Woe to the world” in 18:7a. However, here Jesus focused his prediction and warning on the person who causes the temptation rather than on the whole world.

This whole clause expresses a passive idea. It refers to the person who is the source of the temptation. He is the person who tempts/causes a believer to sin.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Great trouble is waiting for the person who tempts/causes a believer to sin

how terrible for the one who causes them to happen (NCV)

God will punish the person who does this.

Matthew 18:8

Section 18:5–9: Do not cause anyone to sin

In the previous section, Jesus used a child to illustrate what it meant for a disciple to be great in the kingdom. In this section, he compared a humble disciple to a child. He warned people not to cause one of them to sin. If they did, the consequences would be serious.

Jesus also warned his disciples to eliminate the source of sin in their own lives.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Temptations To Sin (GNT)

Eliminate the cause of sin

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 9:42–48 and Luke 17:1–2.

Paragraph 18:8–9

It is good to start a new paragraph at 18:8. Jesus was still talking here about things that cause people to sin. However, the focus shifts to the importance of avoiding sin in a person’s own life.

These verses are similar to what Jesus said in 5:29–30. You should compare the way you translated the verses there to the way you translate the verses here.

18:8a–b

If your hand or your foot causes you to sin, cut it off and throw it away: Jesus used these words to continue to show that things that cause sin are serious. These words are intended to shock the listener with extreme language.

When Jesus said that you should cut off your hand or your foot, he meant that you should do everything possible to keep yourself from sinning. This might even require extreme self-sacrifice.

If people in your area will think that this verse only refers to literally cutting off your hand or foot, you may want to:

- Indicate that this is figurative language. For example:

If for a figurative example your hand or your foot causes you to sin

If as a parable your hand or your foot causes you to sin

- Include a footnote to explain. Here is a sample footnote:

The “hand” and “foot” of this verse are figurative examples of causes of sin. Jesus was not saying that people should actually cut off parts of their bodies. Instead, he wanted them to understand how serious sin is. The real causes of sin (wrong attitudes, thoughts and beliefs) are to be removed as if it were removing a hand or foot in this parable.

18:8a

If your hand or your foot causes you to sin,

- ¶ Speaking in a parable, if your hand or your foot causes you to sin,
- ¶ If for a figurative example your hand or your foot makes you sin,

your: The pronouns “your” and “you” in 18:8–9 are singular.

hand: The Greek word that the BSB translates as hand refers to the part of the body that is at the end of the arm. It is the part to which the fingers are attached.

In some languages, there is a word that refers to both the arm and the hand. It is everything from the shoulder down. For Jesus’ illustration, it does not matter which meaning comes through in your translation.

foot: The Greek word that the BSB translates as foot refers to the part of the body that is at the end of the leg.

In some languages, there is a word that refers to both the leg and the foot. It is everything that is below the hip. For Jesus' illustration, it does not matter which meaning comes through in your translation.

causes you to sin: The verb causes...to sin is the same verb used in 18:6a. But here the phrase refers to something that causes the person himself to sin.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

makes you sin

18:8b

cut it off and throw it away.

- chop it off and throw it away.
- then you should cut it off and get rid of it.

cut it off: Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

chop it off

sever it

and throw it away: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as throw it away is more literally "throw it from you" (as in the NASB). The whole clause means to get rid of the thing that causes you to sin.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

and get rid of it

18:8c–d

It is better for you to enter life crippled or lame than to have two hands and two feet and be thrown into the eternal fire: This is a comparison. Some ways that languages may show this comparison are:

- One situation is better than the other (as in the BSB).
- One situation is worse than the other. For example:

Being thrown into eternal fire with two hands or two feet is worse than entering eternal life crippled or lame.

- One situation is good. The other situation is bad. For example:

If you enter into heaven, even if you have only one hand or one foot, that is good. But if you keep two hands or two feet and go to hell, that is bad.

Some languages do not use comparison words. One possible way to translate this verse without using such words is:

It is very bad if your hand or foot leads you into sinful ways. Those sinful ways will cause you later to be thrown into the eternal fire as punishment. Rather than let that happen, cut off your hand or foot before it causes you to sin, and throw it away. That way your body will be crippled, but you will still be able to enter into eternal life.

18:8c

It is better for you to enter life crippled or lame

- It is better in comparison for you to enter eternal life disabled or injured
- It may not seem good to enter life in heaven with one hand or one foot missing,
- If you enter eternal life with God even without one hand or one foot, this is good/preferred.

to enter life: In this context, the word life refers to eternal life.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

to enter eternal life (NLT)

to enter the place of eternal life

to enter heaven (NLT96)

to go live forever with God

crippled: This word refers to a person who has an arm or leg that is deformed or missing. Because this word is parallel to "hand" in 18:8a, Jesus was probably referring to a missing hand.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

maimed (NIV)

without a hand (GNT)

with only one hand (NLT)

lame: This word refers to a person who has a difficult time walking because one or both legs are deformed or missing. Because this word is parallel to “foot” in 18:8a, Jesus was probably referring to a missing foot.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

without...a foot (GNT)

with one foot

18:8d

than to have two hands and two feet and be thrown into the eternal fire.

- than for you to be thrown into the eternal fire of hell having two hands and two feet.
- but it is very bad for you with your two hands and two feet to be thrown into the place of fire that never dies.
- But if you keep both hands and both feet and then God throws you into the fire of hell that burns forever, that is bad.

than: This word connects two things that are being compared. The situation in 18:8c (entering eternal life crippled but alive) is compared to the situation in 18:8d (whole but punished in the fire). The first situation is preferable. If you are not able to make a comparison like this in your language, see 18:8c–d above for other possible ways to translate this verse.

to have two hands and two feet: This phrase refers to what would happen if you did not do what Jesus said. When your hand or foot caused you to sin, you did not cut it off. Then at the final judgment, you would have both hands and both feet. But you would be thrown into the fire of punishment because of that sin.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

with two hands or two feet (ESV)

to keep both hands and both feet (GNT)

In some languages, it will be more natural to put this phrase at the end of 18:8d. For example:

than to be thrown into eternal fire with both of your hands and feet (NLT)

and be thrown: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as be thrown is passive. This part of the verse refers

to the final judgment, so God is the person who will throw people into eternal fire.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

be cast (KJV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

God will throw you

into the eternal fire: This phrase refers to the fire that is the final punishment for sin. It is the same as “fire of hell” in 5:22c.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

into the fire that never goes out (CEV)

into the place where fire burns forever

into hell where fire always burns

Matthew 18:9

Section 18:5–9: Do not cause anyone to sin

In the previous section, Jesus used a child to illustrate what it meant for a disciple to be great in the kingdom. In this section, he compared a humble disciple to a child. He warned people not to cause one of them to sin. If they did, the consequences would be serious.

Jesus also warned his disciples to eliminate the source of sin in their own lives.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Temptations To Sin (GNT)

Eliminate the cause of sin

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 9:42–48 and Luke 17:1–2.

Paragraph 18:8–9

It is good to start a new paragraph at 18:8. Jesus was still talking here about things that cause people to sin. However, the focus shifts to the importance of avoiding sin in a person’s own life.

These verses are similar to what Jesus said in 5:29–30. You should compare the way you translated the verses there to the way you translate the verses here.

18:9a**And if your eye causes you to sin,**

- ¶ And speaking in a parable, if your eye causes you to sin,
- ¶ Also, if for a figurative example your eye makes you sin,

if your eye causes you to sin: This clause expresses the same idea as 18:8a, but here it refers to your eye. You should translate this clause in a similar way. For example:

if your eye makes you sin

18:9b**gouge it out and throw it away.**

- remove it and throw it away.
- then you should pull/take it out and get rid of it.

gouge it out: The Greek word that the BSB translates as gouge...out means “take out” or “remove.” You should use the verb in your language that is natural when referring to removing an eye from its socket.

Here are some other ways to translate gouge it out:

take it out (GNT)

tear it out (ESV)

pluck it out (RSV)

This same verb occurs in 5:29b.

and throw it away: This is the same clause as at 18:8b. Translate it here as you did there.

18:9c**It is better for you to enter life with one eye**

- It is better in comparison for you to enter eternal life with/having one eye
- It may not seem good to enter life in heaven with one eye missing,
- If you enter eternal life in heaven even without one eye, this is good/preferred.

It is better for you to enter life: This clause contains the same Greek words as in 18:8c. You should translate it the same way in both places..

with one eye: The Greek word that the BSB translates as with one eye is more literally “one-eyed” (as in the JBP).

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

with only one eye (GNT)

to have only one eye (NCV)

18:9d**than to have two eyes and be thrown into the fire of hell.**

- than for you to be thrown into the fire of hell having two eyes.”
- but it is very bad for you to be thrown into hell fire with your two eyes.”
- But if you keep both eyes and then God throws you into the fire of punishment in hell, that is bad.”

than to have two eyes and be thrown: This clause is the same as the clause in 18:8d (except here there are two eyes instead of two hands and two feet). You should translate it in a similar way. For example:

than to keep both eyes and be thrown (GNT)

As in 18:8d, the verb be thrown is passive. Here is one way to translate it using an active verb:

than to have two eyes and God throws you

into the fire of hell: This phrase means about the same thing as “eternal fire” in 18:8d. It refers to the place of eternal punishment where God will send unbelievers following the final judgment. In that place, unbelievers will be punished with fire.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

into the fires of hell (CEV)

where the dead are made to suffer in fire

into the place where the dead are punished with fire

This same phrase occurs in 5:22c. Translate it the same way in both places.

Matthew 18:10

Section 18:10–14: Jesus told a parable about a lost sheep

In this section, Jesus told a type of parable. In this parable, a shepherd rejoices more over finding one sheep that wandered away than over a large flock of sheep that did not wander. This parable shows that every believer is important to God. This section also shows that one believer should not look down on another one.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus used a lost sheep as an illustration

The parable about a lost sheep

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 15:3–7.

18:10a

See that you do not look down on any of these little ones.

- ¶ “Make sure that you^(plur) do not look down on one of these little/humble ones,
- ¶ “Be careful that you^(plur) do not consider any of these humble believers as worthless.

Jesus probably spoke the words in 18:10–14 immediately after 18:5–9. If it will be helpful for your readers, you may want to start this section with words that show that Jesus continued speaking. For example:

Jesus continued, ...

See that: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as See that is a warning.

Here are some other ways to translate this warning:

Beware that (NLT)

Be careful. (NCV)

This verb is not a command to look at something.

you do not look down on: The Greek word that the BSB translates as look down on means “look down on, think nothing of, treat with contempt, or scorn.” This clause is a warning not to consider humble believers as worth little.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

you do not despise (ESV)

Don’t think...are worth nothing (NCV)

any of these little ones: Jesus used this phrase in a figurative sense. He was referring to people who are humble like little children. He was referring to people of all ages who believe in him, both children and adults.

This is the same phrase as in 18:6a. Translate it the same way in both places. For example:

one of these people who are like little children

18:10b

For I tell you that their angels in heaven

- because I tell you that their angels in heaven
- I assure you that the angels who watch over them

For: Verse 18:10b is the reason for the command that the people should not despise one of these little ones (in 18:10a). The Greek introduces this reason with a conjunction that the BSB translates as For.

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. Instead, they let the context indicate the connection. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either.

Here is another way to introduce this reason:

Because

their angels in heaven: The pronoun their refers to “these little ones” (in 18:10a), the humble believers. This entire phrase probably refers to angels who take care of humble believers in some way. Humble believers are so important to God that even they have angels representing them before God in heaven.

In the Bible, the word angels usually refers to messengers from God. However, the idea that each person has an angel who guards him was common among the Jews at the time.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

angels from heaven who care for them

the spiritual beings in/from heaven who take care of them

in heaven: The Greek word that the BSB translates as heaven refers to the place where God lives. In some languages that will be the same word as “the sky.”

Also, in some languages, it will not be natural to have in heaven here and also at the end of the verse. If that is true in your language, you can combine the two phrases into one.

18:10c

always see the face of My Father in heaven.

- continually see the face of my Father in heaven.
- are always with my heavenly Father.
- always come before my Father in heaven.

always see the face of My Father in heaven: This whole clause indicates that the angels are present before God in heaven. That is why they can see the face of My Father.

The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as always indicates that the angels are able to approach God at any time. It does not mean that they never leave.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

are continually in the presence of my Father in heaven (NJB)

are always with my Father in heaven (CEV)

continually come before my Father in heaven

Matthew 18:11

Section 18:10–14: Jesus told a parable about a lost sheep

In this section, Jesus told a type of parable. In this parable, a shepherd rejoices more over finding one sheep that wandered away than over a large flock of sheep that did not wander. This parable shows that every believer is important to God. This section also shows that one believer should not look down on another one.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus used a lost sheep as an illustration

The parable about a lost sheep

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 15:3–7.

18:11

[[For the Son of Man came to save the lost.]] (ESV footnote)

- [[For the Son of Man came to save those people who are lost.]]
- [[I say this because I, the Son of Man, came into the world to rescue those people who live like they are lost.]]

There is a textual issue here. Verse 18:11 is not present in some of the earliest and best Greek manuscripts of Matthew. It was probably added in some of the later Greek manuscripts based on Luke 19:10. Many English translations are like the BSB, ESV, and NIV and do not include this verse as part of the text. They have it only as a footnote.

It is good to include this verse only as a footnote, as many English versions do. Here is an example footnote:

Only some of the later Greek manuscripts include 18:11. It says: For the Son of Man came to save the lost.

(See below for help in translating this verse.)

If the major language version in your area includes this verse in the text, you may want to include it in brackets. For example:

[For the Son of Man has come to save that which was lost.] (NASB)

If you put 18:11 in a footnote, here are several ways to number the verses:

- At the beginning of 18:10, put the verse numbers 10–11. Put the footnote marker at the end. For example:

^{10–11}Don't be cruel to any of these little ones! I promise you that their angels are always with my Father in heaven. ‡ (CEV)

- Put in the number 11 after the last word of 18:10, and have the footnote marker after it. For example:

¹⁰Be careful. Don't think these little children are worth nothing. I tell you that they have angels in heaven who are always with my Father in heaven.
¹¹‡ (NCV)

- Do not include verse number 11 in the text. Put it in the footnote. Put the footnote marker after verse 10. For example:

¹⁰Be careful not to despise these little ones. I can guarantee that their angels in heaven always see the face of my Father, who is in heaven. ‡ (GW)

the Son of Man: Jesus used this phrase to refer to himself. In some languages, this phrase by itself would refer to someone other than Jesus. If that is true in your language, consider translating it as:

I, the Son of Man

This phrase last occurred in 17:22b.

save: In this context, the word save refers to rescuing people from sin and eternal punishment so that they are reconciled to God.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

rescue

deliver

In some languages it may be necessary to say what a person is saved from or for. For example:

rescue from sin

help so they can have life with God

the lost: The Greek phrase that the ESV translates as the lost is used in a figurative way here. It refers to people who have sinned against God and are not able to reconcile with him unless they receive help.

In some languages a literal translation may not communicate the right meaning. If that is true in your language, here are some other ways to translate this:

- Use a simile to indicate that the word lost is used in a figurative way. For example:

people who live/act as if they are lost

- Use a simile and make the meaning explicit. For example:

those who are like people who are lost because they do not know the way to God

- Translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

people who need help to reconcile with God

In some languages there are similar figures of speech that could be used here. For example:

people who are far from God

those who have strayed away from the true path

Matthew 18:12

Section 18:10–14: Jesus told a parable about a lost sheep

In this section, Jesus told a type of parable. In this parable, a shepherd rejoices more over finding one sheep that wandered away than over a large flock of sheep that did not wander. This parable shows that every believer is important to God. This section also shows that one believer should not look down on another one.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus used a lost sheep as an illustration

The parable about a lost sheep

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 15:3–7.

18:12a–d

What do you think? If a man has a hundred sheep and one of them goes astray, will he not leave the ninety-nine on the hills and go out to search for the one that is lost?: Verse 18:12 contains two rhetorical questions. The first one is short, and the second one is long. The short one emphasizes that the second one is certainly true: A man will certainly leave all his sheep to search for one lost one.

Before you begin to translate this verse, carefully consider the best way in your language to translate these two rhetorical questions. There are many possibilities. Here are some possible ways:

- Divide the second (long) rhetorical question into shorter sentences. For example:

What do you think? Suppose a man has 100 sheep and one of them strays. Won't he leave the 99 sheep in the hills to look for the one that has strayed? (GW)

- Put the first rhetorical question in the middle of the second one. For example:

If a shepherd has one hundred sheep, and one wanders away and is lost, what will he do? Won't he leave the ninety-nine others and go out into the hills to search for the lost one? (NLT96)

- Put the first rhetorical question at the end of the verse. For example:

If a man has one hundred sheep, and one strays and gets lost, will he not leave the ninety-nine others and go into the hills to search for the lost one? What do you think he will do?

- Combine the two rhetorical questions. For example:

What do you think a man does who has one hundred sheep and one of them gets lost? He will leave the other ninety-nine grazing on the hillside and go and look for the lost sheep. (GNT)

18:12a-b

What do you think? If a man has a hundred sheep and one of them goes astray,

- ¶ What do you think about this? If a certain man owned a hundred sheep and if one of them strayed,
- ¶ Suppose a shepherd has one hundred sheep, and one wanders away and gets lost. What do you think he will do?
- ¶ There was a certain man who had one hundred sheep. If one of them got lost, what do you think he would do?

18:12a

What do you think?: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus used this rhetorical question to encourage the disciples to seriously think about what he was going to say. He also used this rhetorical question to emphasize that the next rhetorical question is certainly true.

Here are some other ways to translate this rhetorical question:

What do you think a man will do...

What do you think/say about this?

See also the examples above in the note on 18:12a-d for other ways to translate this rhetorical question.

Jesus used this same question in 17:25c.

you: Here, the pronoun you is plural, so he is speaking to the main group of disciples.

18:12b

If a man has a hundred sheep and one of them goes astray: This is the first part of the long rhetorical question. (The actual question is in 18:12c-d.)

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

If a man has a hundred sheep, and if one of them has gone astray...

Suppose a man has 100 sheep and one of them strays. (GW)

There was a certain man who had one hundred sheep. If one of them strays...

a man: This phrase refers to any shepherd. Jesus did not have a particular person in mind. Instead he just told a little story to make his point.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

a certain man

someone

a shepherd (NLT96)

has a hundred sheep: The Greek word that the BSB translates as has means "owns" or "possesses." It indicates that these sheep belong to the man. He is not just a watchman.

hundred: This is a large number, but the actual amount is probably not significant. Some languages do not regularly use numbers this big. If that is the case in your language, you may translate this as:

a lot of sheep

It is also possible to borrow the word for this number from a major language in your area. Or you can use the numeral "100."

one of them goes astray: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as goes astray means “wanders.” Sheep are animals that wander away from the flock easily.

This verb also implies that the sheep was lost. It could not find its way back to the rest of the sheep.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

one of them strays (GW)

one wanders away from the rest (JBP)

one wanders away and is lost (NLT96)

one of the sheep gets lost (NCV)

18:12c

will he not leave the ninety-nine on the hills

- will he not leave the ninety-nine others on the hill
- Will he leave the ninety-nine other sheep on the hillside
- He will leave the other sheep on the hills, will he not? Yes!

will he not leave: This part of the rhetorical question has a negative form (will he not leave), but it expects the answer, “Yes, of course.”

Here are some other ways to translate it:

- As a question that expects a “yes” answer. For example:

Will he not leave...?

- As a tag question. For example:

He will leave the ninety-nine, will he not?

He will leave the ninety-nine, true?

- As a statement of certainty. For example:

He will of course leave

Surely he will leave

leave: This verb means that the shepherd will temporarily abandon the other sheep. He will permit them to stay on their own while he goes in search of the lost one.

the ninety-nine: This is still a large number, but it is one less than the original number. If your language does not regularly use numbers this big, you might translate it as:

the rest of them

The idea that these are the rest of the “sheep” except for the one that wandered away is implicit in the number. If you need to, you may make that explicit. For example:

the ninety-nine others

the 99 other sheep

on the hills: The Greek word that the BSB translates as hills is singular. For example:

on the hillside (REB)

In this little story, the sheep are out away from any village and in the mountains/hills. It was normal practice for a shepherd to take a flock of sheep to places like that to find grass for them to eat. Sometimes he would be gone with them for days, weeks, or even months at a time.

This phrase indicates “in a mountain area,” but not necessarily at the top. Translate it in a way that is appropriate to your storytelling style.

18:12d

and go out to search for the one that is lost?

- and go and look for the one that strayed? Of course!
- and go to search for the one that strayed? Yes he will.
- He will go to look for the sheep that is lost.

go out to search for: In Greek, the two verbs that the BSB translates as go out to search for could also be translated as “go and seek.” That is, the shepherd would go to other places in the mountains where the lost sheep might be.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

go and look for (GNT)

go out to search (NLT)

the one that is lost?: The phrase the one refers to the sheep that went astray.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the lost sheep (NCV`)

Matthew 18:13

Section 18:10–14: Jesus told a parable about a lost sheep

In this section, Jesus told a type of parable. In this parable, a shepherd rejoices more over finding one sheep that wandered away than over a large flock of sheep that did not wander. This parable shows that every believer is important to God. This section also shows that one believer should not look down on another one.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus used a lost sheep as an illustration

The parable about a lost sheep

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 15:3–7.

18:13a

And if he finds it, truly I tell you,

- And if he happens to find it, I assure you^(plur) that
- I tell you the truth: if he finds it,

if he finds it: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as if he finds it can be more literally translated as “if he happens to find it.” In this story, it is possible that the shepherd does not find the lost sheep.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

if he should find it

if he actually finds it

When he finds it (GNT)

truly I tell you: Jesus often used these words to introduce a statement that he wanted to emphasize.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

I assure you (JBP)

Listen to this:

Let me tell you this:

This same clause occurs in 18:3a.

General Comment on 18:13a

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of the clauses in 18:13a. For example:

I tell you the truth, if he finds it,

18:13b

he rejoices more over that one sheep than over the ninety-nine that did not go astray.

- he is happier about that one sheep than he is about the ninety-nine sheep that did not stray.
- the joy he has for that one sheep is greater than the joy he has for the ninety-nine sheep that did not get lost.

he rejoices more over that one sheep than over the ninety-nine that did not go astray: This is a comparison. The shepherd’s joy concerning the one sheep that he found exceeds the joy he has for the other sheep. It does not imply that he is not happy about the ninety-nine other sheep.

Here are some other ways to translate this comparison:

he is happier about that one sheep than about the ninety-nine that did not wander off (NIV)

his happiness concerning that one sheep is greater than his happiness concerning the ninety-nine sheep that did not stray

even though he is happy about the other sheep, he is very happy about the one that he found again

he rejoices more over that one sheep: The Greek word that the BSB translates as over in this context means “concerning” or “about.” The shepherd is happy about the lost sheep that he found.

than over the ninety-nine: Some words are implied but not repeated here. The complete clause would be:

more than he rejoices over the ninety-nine sheep

that did not go astray: Here is another way to translate this clause:

that did not get lost (GNT)

Matthew 18:14

Section 18:10–14: Jesus told a parable about a lost sheep

In this section, Jesus told a type of parable. In this parable, a shepherd rejoices more over finding one sheep that wandered away than over a large flock of sheep that did not wander. This parable shows that every believer is important to God. This section also shows that one believer should not look down on another one.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus used a lost sheep as an illustration

The parable about a lost sheep

There is a parallel passage for this section in Luke 15:3–7.

18:14a

In the same way, your Father in heaven is not willing

- Similarly, your^(plur) Father in heaven does not want
- It is the same way, your^(plur) Father in heaven does not want/desire

In the same way: The Greek word that the BSB translates as In the same way introduces the application of the story that Jesus just told. This word indicates that God acts in the same manner as the shepherd in the story.

your Father in heaven is not willing: There is a textual issue here.

Some Greek manuscripts have your Father. For example:

it is not the will of your Father (NRSV) (BSB, NRSV, NIV, NET, NASB, REB, NJB, KJV, GNT, CEV, NCV, JBP, GW)

Other Greek manuscripts have my Father. For example:

it is not the will of my Father (RSV) (RSV, ESV, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). It seems more likely that a copyist changed the original “your” to “my” to make it the same as in 18:10 than the other

way around. Also, the majority of English versions follow this option.

Father in heaven: This phrase refers to God the Father.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Father who is in heaven (ESV)

heavenly Father

is not willing: This phrase refers to something that God does not want/desire. He does not desire that any little one should perish.

Here is another way to translate it:

does not want (GNT)

18:14b

that any of these little ones should perish.

- any of these people who are like little children to be lost eternally.”
- any of these humble ones to be separated from him by sin.”

any of these little ones: Jesus used this phrase in a figurative sense. He was referring to people who are humble like little children. He was referring to people of all ages who believe in him, both children and adults.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

one of these people who are like little children

one of these people who are not important

one of these simple/humble people

This same phrase occurs in 18:6a.

should perish: The Greek word that the BSB translates as perish means “die,” “be destroyed,” “be ruined,” and “be lost.” Here Jesus used this word in a spiritual sense. God does not want anyone to die in their sins. He does not want anyone to be eternally lost.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

become lost spiritually/eternally

be far from him

be separated from him

Many English versions are like the NIV and translate this word simply as “lost.” However, here Jesus was not talking about a little one who was lost and could not find his way. Be careful that your translation avoids this meaning.

Matthew 18:15

Section 18:15–20: Correct a brother who sins

In this section, Jesus told his disciples what to do when a fellow believer sins against one of them. Jesus gave them some steps to follow to deal with the problem in a gentle and loving manner. The main goal of these steps is to restore the relationship between two believers.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

When a Person Sins Against You (NCV)

What to do if a fellow believer sins against you

18:15a

If your brother sins against you,

- ¶ “If your^(sing) Christian brother or sister sins against you^(sing),
- ¶ “If/When a fellow believer does something wrong/evil to you^(sing),

If your brother: The Greek word that the BSB translates as brother refers to any fellow believer.

Here are some other ways to translate the phrase your brother:

your Christian brother

your fellow believer (NCV)

If the people in your area might think that this phrase would not include females, you could translate it as:

your Christian brother or sister

your: The pronouns “your” and “you” are singular throughout 18:15–17.

sins against you: There is a textual issue here:

1. Many Greek manuscripts have the phrase sins against you. The phrase “against you” is in brackets

in the United Bible Society’s Greek New Testament indicating its uncertainty in the text. The Committee gave this reading a C rating. For example:

sins against you (GNT) (BSB, ESV, NIV, RSV, GNT, CEV, NLT, NCV, KJV, JBP)

1. Some important, early Greek manuscripts have only the word sins. They do not have the added phrase against you here. For example:

sins (NET) (NET, NASB, GW, REB, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). Some important, early Greek manuscripts do not include these words. But the phrase “just between you and him alone” in 18:15b is one reason to include them.

You may want to include a footnote to explain that some translations omit the phrase against you. For example:

Some important, early Greek manuscripts do not have the words “against you.” Many translations do not include them either.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

wrongs you (JBP)

does something wrong/bad to you

does evil against you

18:15b

go and confront him privately.

- go and confront him in private about what he did wrong.
- you^(sing) should go and correct/rebuke him when the two of you are alone.

go: This verb is a command. It includes the idea of “to him.” For example:

go to him (GNT)

In other words, you should go and find the person who sinned against you.

confront him: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as confront him also means “show, condemn, rebuke, or reprove him.” It means “describe to him

what he has done wrong and tell him you disagree with what he has done.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

tell him what he has done wrong

show him his fault (NET)

privately: This phrase indicates that you should confront your brother in private.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in private (NCV)

But do it privately, just between yourselves. (GNT)

when the two of you are alone (NET)

18:15c

If he listens to you, you have won your brother over.

- If he listens to you and is sorry, then you have restored your brother to you.
- If he accepts your words, then you have reconciled that brother to you.

If he listens to you: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as listens is the general word that means “hear.” In this context, it indicates that the brother agrees with you and responds appropriately. He confesses his sin and asks for forgiveness.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

If he hears you and repents

If he listens to you and is sorry/regretful

If the other person listens and confesses it (NLT)

If he accepts your words

If he agrees with you

you have won your brother over: The Greek word that the BSB translates as won...over means “gotten back” or “won” your brother. It implies that the relationship is restored and the two people have reconciled.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

you have won your brother back (GNT)

you have restored that brother to you

you have helped that person to be your brother or sister again (NCV)

you and your brother are reconciled again

Matthew 18:16

Section 18:15–20: Correct a brother who sins

In this section, Jesus told his disciples what to do when a fellow believer sins against one of them. Jesus gave them some steps to follow to deal with the problem in a gentle and loving manner. The main goal of these steps is to restore the relationship between two believers.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

When a Person Sins Against You (NCV)

What to do if a fellow believer sins against you

18:16a

But if he will not listen,

- But if he does not listen to you^(sing),
- But if he does not accept your words,

But: There is a contrast between 18:15c and 18:16a. The contrast is between listening and not listening. The Greek indicates this contrast with a conjunction that the BSB translates as But.

if he will not listen: The phrase will not listen includes the same verb as in 18:15c.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

If he does not hear you and repent

If he does not listen to you and is not sorry/regretful

If he does not accept your words

If he does not agree with you

Some English versions translate this phrase in a way that suggests that he is not willing to listen and respond appropriately. For example:

if he refuses to listen (NCV)

18:16b

take one or two others along,

- get one or two others and take them with you,
- ask/call one or two other believers to return with you to him to discuss the problem again.

take one or two others along: This clause means that the one who was wronged should ask or call one or two other people to go along with him. It implies that he should visit the brother a second time. He should “return to your brother” with them. It implies that he has gone away after confronting the brother one time without success.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

take one or two others with you and go back again (NLT)

go to him again and take one or two other people with you (NCV)

ask/call one or two other people to accompany you to go back to your brother

one or two others: This phrase refers to one or two other people. It does not specify who they are, but the context suggests they are also Christians. For example:

take one or two other believers along

General Comment on 18:16b

It is implied that the person who was wronged and the others discuss the problem again with the brother. The one or two other believers try to help resolve the problem. But if the problem is not resolved, then they are able to explain everything to the church in the next step (18:17a).

In some languages, it may be necessary to include some of this implied information. Here are some examples:

and you and they discuss the problem with him again

and you speak to him again with the others

18:16c

so that ‘every matter may be established by the testimony of two or three witnesses.’

- so that ‘every accusation may have the support of two or three witnesses.’
- so that everything you say may be confirmed by two or three witnesses. (NLT)
- Do that so that two or three people will show/agree that everything that you said to him is true.

so that: Verse 18:16c is the purpose of taking along some believers (in 18:16b). The Greek introduces this purpose with a conjunction that the BSB translates as so that.

Here are some other ways to introduce this purpose:

in order that

that (ESV)

every matter may be established by the testimony of two or three witnesses:

This is a quote from Deuteronomy 19:15. That verse talks about someone who is charged with a crime. The law required there to be two or three witnesses to the crime in order for someone to be convicted of it.

Here Jesus used the same principle for establishing truth (some witnesses), but he applied it to a different situation. Here, the witnesses come to support the person who was wronged. They support the charge/accusation against the other brother. They try to convince the man to listen that what he has done is wrong.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Keep the wording of the original context. For example:

every complaint must be proven true by two or more witnesses (CEV)

- Adapt the wording to the current context. For example:

everything you say may be confirmed by two or three witnesses (NLT)

This clause is passive. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

every accusation may be verified by two or three witnesses (GW)

everything that you accuse him of may be confirmed/proven by two or three witnesses

- Use an active verb. For example:

two or three witnesses will confirm the things that you say that he has done wrong

every matter: The Greek word that the BSB translates as matter is more literally “word” (as in the RSV). In its original context in Deuteronomy, this word refers to the “accusation” that a person had committed a crime. Here, this word refers to the words that you say to tell the man his fault.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

every accusation (GNT)

everything you say (NLT)

may be established: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as may be established also means “may be confirmed” or “may be proven true.”

The verb is passive. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

may be verified (GW)

may be proved/shown

- Use an active verb. For example:

may support/confirm

will show

by the testimony: The Greek word that the BSB translates testimony is more literally “mouth.” This is a figure of speech that refers to talking. The work of witnesses was to tell what they saw or heard. So the evidence would be given by their words.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

by the evidence (ESV)

Some English versions do not translate this phrase. The phrase “two or three witnesses” includes this idea. For example:

Every case may be proved by two or three witnesses (NCV)

In some languages, this phrase may not be necessary either.

of two or three witnesses: The word witnesses refers to people who have seen or heard something.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

of two or three people who say what they have heard

of two or three other people who say the same thing

Matthew 18:17

Section 18:15–20: Correct a brother who sins

In this section, Jesus told his disciples what to do when a fellow believer sins against one of them. Jesus gave them some steps to follow to deal with the problem in a gentle and loving manner. The main goal of these steps is to restore the relationship between two believers.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

When a Person Sins Against You (NCV)

What to do if a fellow believer sins against you

18:17a

If he refuses to listen to them, tell it to the church.

- If he refuses to hear them, then report^(sing) the issue to the whole group of believers.
- And if he rejects their words, then tell^(sing) what has happened to the group of people who believe in Jesus.

If he refuses to listen to them: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as refuses to listen is a stronger word than “will not listen” in 18:16a. This word can also be translated “ignore, disobey.” It indicates that he has rejected what the witnesses say.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

If he ignores these witnesses (GW)

If he rejects their words

them: This pronoun refers to the one or two witnesses that you take along with you.

tell it to the church: The Greek command that the BSB translates as tell it to the church is more literally “tell the church.” In Greek, there is no pronoun it here. Many English versions are like the BSB and add the word it to make the sentence more natural. In some languages, it will also be natural to add this word, or some similar words.

This command means that you are supposed to tell the whole story to the church. This would include giving them a report about what the brother did to you. It would also include giving them a report about what you have tried to do to resolve this issue.

Here are some other ways to translate this command:

tell the church (NCV)

tell the whole thing to the church (GNT)

report the matter to the church (CEV)

the church: Here the word church refers to the group of Christian believers who worship together in the same place. In the New Testament, the word church does not refer to a building.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

the group of believers/followers

the group of people who believe in Jesus

The word church first occurs in 16:18b.

18:17b

And if he refuses to listen even to the church,

- And if he refuses to hear even the whole group of believers,
- If he rejects even them,

And if he refuses to listen: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as refuses to listen is the same one as in 18:17a. Translate it the same way in both places. For example:

If he ignores (GW)

If he rejects

even to the church: In this context, the Greek word that the BSB translates as even expresses something that would be surprising. The church is the final authority. We would normally expect the brother to listen and respond appropriately to the church. If he does not, it would be a surprising outcome.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

And if he even refuses to listen to the church

If he still refuses to listen

Finally, if he will not listen to the church (CEV)

18:17c

regard him as you would a pagan or a tax collector.

- then you^(sing) should act toward him as you would act toward an unbeliever or a tax collector.
- then you^(sing) should consider/regard him as a person outside the group such as a person who does not believe or a person who collects taxes.

regard him as you would: This is a type of command. Jesus commanded you (singular) to think/treat the sinning brother in a certain way. This command is not to the church as a whole.

Here are some other ways to translate this command:

treat him as you would (NIV)

consider^(sing) him as

think^(sing) of him as you would

act toward him as you^(sing) would act toward

a pagan or a tax collector: Both pagan and tax collector refer to kinds of people whom the Jews thought were bad. They were both outside the Jewish religious community. The Jews did not treat these people as well as they treated their fellow Jews within their community. (See the notes below where each term is explained.)

In some languages, it may be necessary to make some of this information explicit. For example:

an outsider such as a Gentile and a tax collector

a bad person such as a Gentile or a tax collector

Jesus was saying that a “Christian brother” who refuses to repent should no longer be considered a member of the group of believers.

a pagan: The Greek word that the BSB translates as pagan refers to a person who is not a Jew. Many other English versions translate this word as “Gentile.” The Jews considered a Gentile to be someone who did not know God.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

unbeliever (CEV)

a person who does not know God (NCV)

This word also occurs in 6:7a.

a tax collector: The term tax collector refers to a Jew who collected taxes from his fellow Jews. Jews hated tax collectors. They considered them to be traitors, thieves, and religiously contaminated (“unclean”).

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

a person who collects taxes

a person who gathers money from other people for the government

See the note at 5:46b for more information on the term tax collector.

Matthew 18:18

Section 18:15–20: Correct a brother who sins

In this section, Jesus told his disciples what to do when a fellow believer sins against one of them. Jesus gave them some steps to follow to deal with the problem in a gentle and loving manner. The main goal of these steps is to restore the relationship between two believers.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

When a Person Sins Against You (NCV)

What to do if a fellow believer sins against you

18:18a

Truly I tell you,

- ¶ “I assure you^(plur) that
- ¶ Jesus continued, “Listen^(plur) to this:

Truly I tell you: This same phrase occurs in 18:3a. Translate it the same way in both places. For example:

I assure you

Listen to this:

Let me tell you this:

you: Here the pronoun you is plural. Jesus spoke more generally here, but he continued to talk about dealing with a sinning brother.

18:18b

whatever you bind on earth will be bound in heaven,

- the things that you forbid on earth will be forbidden by God in heaven,
- Anything that you do not allow on earth, God will not allow in heaven.

18:18c

and whatever you loose on earth will be loosed in heaven.

- and the things that you permit on earth will be permitted by God in heaven.
- Anything that you allow on earth, God will also allow in heaven.

18:18b–c

whatever you bind on earth...whatever you loose

on earth: These same words occur in 16:19b–c. The only difference is that here the pronoun you is plural. Except for that change, translate it in the same way as you did there.

The Greek verbs that the BSB translates as bind and loose normally mean “tie” and “untie.” Here they are used in a figurative way. They refer to forbidding (binding) or permitting (loosing) various kinds of conduct and doctrine. Christ gave the disciples the authority to decide which actions/deeds were forbidden and which were permitted.

Here are some other ways to translate bind and loose:

the things you don’t allow.... And the things you allow (NCV)

the things you forbid.... The things you permit

will be bound in heaven...will be loosed in heaven:

The future passive verbs “will be bound” and “will be loosed” are in the Greek perfect aspect. Commentaries have various interpretations about these future perfect verbs. The majority of English versions translate it with a simple future (exceptions are NASB and NET). These same words occur in 16:19b–c. The only difference is that here the pronoun “you” is plural. Except for that change, translate it in the same way as you did there.

The Greek verbs that the BSB translates as will be bound and will be loosed are both passive. The phrase in heaven is a way to refer to something that God does. So, these clauses indicate that God will also “bind” and “loose.”

Here are some other ways to translate these verbs:

- Use passive verbs. For example:

will be bound by God in heaven...will be loosed by God in heaven

- Use active verbs. For example:

God in heaven will allow....he will not allow (CEV)

Matthew 18:19

Section 18:15–20: Correct a brother who sins

In this section, Jesus told his disciples what to do when a fellow believer sins against one of them. Jesus gave them some steps to follow to deal with the problem in a gentle and loving manner. The main goal of these steps is to restore the relationship between two believers.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

When a Person Sins Against You (NCV)

What to do if a fellow believer sins against you

18:19a

Again, I tell you truly

- Furthermore, I tell you^(plur),
- Also, I tell you^(plur) that

Again, I tell you truly: There is a textual issue here. In some Greek manuscripts, there is a word that means “truly.”

Some important Greek manuscripts do not have this Greek word. Most English versions follow these manuscripts. For example:

Again I say to you (RSV) (RSV, ESV, NIV, NASB, REB, KJV, NLT, GNT, NCV, JBP)

Other Greek manuscripts have this Greek word. A few English versions follow these manuscripts. For example:

Again, truly I tell you (NRSV) (BSB, NRSV, NET, NJB, CEV, GW)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) and the majority of English versions. Do not include a translation of the word “truly.”

Again: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Again indicates that Jesus wanted to say some more things to his disciples. It does not mean that he wanted to repeat something he had already said.

Here are some other ways to translate this word and its context:

And I tell you more: (GNT)

I also tell you this (NLT)

Also, I tell you that (NCV)

18:19b

that if two of you on the earth agree about anything you ask for,

- if two of you on earth agree about any matter you ask for,
- if two of you on earth agree about something and pray for it (NCV),

if two of you on the earth agree about anything you ask for:

This clause refers to two of Jesus’ disciples agreeing to ask God for something. It refers to agreeing about something and praying for it.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

if two of you on earth agree about anything and ask God for it

if two of you on earth agree about something and pray for it (NCV)

when any two of you on earth agree about something you are praying for (CEV)

In this context, this clause may refer to asking for wisdom to handle the issue of the brother who has sinned (in 18:15a). But it may include other issues as well. You should translate it in a general way so that it can refer to any issue.

two of you...you: The second you translates a form that is more literally “they.” However, both pronouns refer to Jesus’ disciples, so the BSB and some English versions change the pronoun “they” to you to make this clearer. In some languages, it would be natural to follow the Greek and use both you and “they” here. For example:

if two of you agree on earth about anything they ask (ESV)

In some languages, it may also be more natural to use the same pronoun here.

on the earth: This phrase on the earth contrasts with the phrase “in heaven” at the end of 18:19c. It refers to where people are, as opposed to where God is.

In some languages, it will be natural to put this phrase at a different place in the clause. For example:

if two of you agree on anything here on earth (GW)

about anything you ask for: The Greek word that the BSB translates as anything you ask for refers to any matter or thing of concern.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

about whatever (NET)

concerning any matter

18:19c

it will be done for you by My Father in heaven.

- my Father in heaven will do it for you.
- my Father in heaven will give it to you.

it will be done for you by My Father in heaven: This clause is passive. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb, as in the BSB.
- Use an active verb. For example:

my Father in heaven will do it for you (NET)

you will receive it from my Father in heaven

it will be done for you: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as will be done means “will do” what they asked for or “will answer” their prayer. You should use a verb in your language that refers to answering a prayer. For example:

my Father in heaven will answer their/your prayer

my Father in heaven will give it to them/you

my Father in heaven will fulfill what they/you asked

you: The pronoun you here, as in 18:19b, is more literally “them.” However, this pronoun refers to “you” in the phrase “two of you.” Therefore, the BSB and some other English versions change the “them” to you. In some languages, it would be natural to follow the Greek and use “they” here. For example:

it will be done for them (ESV)

Matthew 18:20

Section 18:15–20: Correct a brother who sins

In this section, Jesus told his disciples what to do when a fellow believer sins against one of them. Jesus gave them some steps to follow to deal with the problem in a gentle and loving manner. The main goal of these steps is to restore the relationship between two believers.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

When a Person Sins Against You (NCV)

What to do if a fellow believer sins against you

18:20a

For where two or three gather together in My name,

- Because if two or three people meet because of me,
- This is true because when two or three people gather as my followers,

For: Verse 18:20a is the explanation or the reason for what was said in 18:19. The Greek introduces this

reason with a conjunction that the BSB translates as For.

Here are some other ways to introduce this reason:

Because

This is true because (NCV)

That will happen because

two or three: This phrase refers to “two or three believers.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

two or three of you (CEV)

even when only two or three people

gather together in My name: The phrase in My name indicates that people are meeting as a group of believers. They have gathered to pray and worship Jesus. They have not just gathered for any reason.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

are assembled in my name (NET)

gather together as my followers (NLT)

meet because of me

18:20b
there am I with them.”

- I am right there among them.”
- I am there with them.”

there am I: The verb am is present tense. It indicates something that is true at all times, both now and in the future.

Here is a more natural English way to translate this:

I am there (NET)

with them: This phrase means that Jesus is present with them spiritually. His spirit is with them whenever and wherever they met. It does not mean that he is there physically.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

among them (ESV)

in their midst (RSV)

Matthew 18:21

Section 18:21–35: Jesus told a parable about a servant who did not forgive

In this section, Jesus continued to talk about relationships among believers. He did this by telling a parable about a servant and a king. The king canceled the servant’s large debt. But the servant refused to cancel the small debt of his fellow servant. As a result the king punished the servant.

Jesus told this parable to show us that God has forgiven our many sins. So we should forgive the few sins that other people commit against us. If we do not forgive others, God will not forgive us.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable of the servant who refused to forgive

The necessity for forgiveness (JBP)

18:21a
Then Peter came to Jesus and asked,

- ¶ Then Peter approached Jesus and asked,
- ¶ After that Peter came/went to Jesus and asked him,

Then: This word indicates that the events in this section happened sometime after the events in the previous paragraph. It does not necessarily mean that they happened immediately after it.

Here is another way to translate this word:

After that

Peter came to: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as came to simply means that Peter “came up to” or “came over to” Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

Peter came up (ESV)

Peter approached him (JBP)

and asked: The Greek and some other English Bible versions have the pronoun “him” after this phrase, but

the BSB lives it untranslated. This pronoun refers to Jesus. Since this is at the beginning of a new section, it may be natural in some languages to make this explicit. For example:

and asked Jesus

18:21b

“Lord, how many times shall I forgive my brother who sins against me?”

- “Lord, if a brother continues to sin against me, how many times must I forgive him?”
- “Sir/Master, how many times must I forgive a fellow believer who repeatedly does wrong to me?”

Lord: This word means “owner,” “master,” or “ruler.” It refers to someone who has authority over people or things. Peter used it to address Jesus because he was Jesus’ disciple.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Sir

Master (JBP)

This word last occurred in 17:15a.

how many times shall I forgive my brother who sins against me?: In Greek, the verbs sins and forgive are both future tense. The ESV literally translates the first verb as “will sin.” This can make it seem like Peter knows that a brother is going to sin against him over and over. However, this is a simple request for understanding. Peter wanted to know how often he was obligated to forgive a brother who repeatedly sinned against him. He probably thought that to forgive someone as many as seven times was a lot. Some English versions include that obligation with the verb forgive, usually with the word “must.” They may also use the word “if” with the verb “sin” to indicate Peter’s wondering about this. But the verb clauses then have to be reversed for good English style (as the BSB does). For example: Lord, how often must I forgive my brother if he wrongs me? (NJB) -or- Lord, how often do I have to forgive a believer who wrongs me? (GW) You should determine the best style for your language and audience. Peter asked this question to find out how many times he must forgive a person who repeatedly sinned against him. He probably thought that to forgive someone as many as seven times was a lot.

In some languages, it will be more natural to change the order of some of the words in this question. For example:

how often must I forgive my brother if he wrongs me? (NJB)

if my brother keeps on sinning against me, how many times do I have to forgive him? (GNT)

when my fellow believer sins against me, how many times must I forgive him? (NCV)

how many times: Here is another way to translate this:

how often (ESV)

I forgive: The Greek word that the BSB translates as forgive means “let go” or “cancel.” It refers to canceling any revenge or demand for compensation. It refers to letting go of any anger about the wrong.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

cancel the debt from my brother’s sin against me

will not hold my fellow believer’s sin against him

my brother: This phrase refers to another Christian, whether male or female. It does not only refer to Peter’s male sibling.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

a fellow believer

who sins against me: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as sins against also occurs in 18:15a. Translate it the same way in both places. For example:

wrong me (JBP)

does something wrong/bad to me

does evil to/against me

18:21c

Up to seven times?”

- Is it up to seven times?”

- Must I forgive him as many as seven times?”

Up to seven times?: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Up to can also be translated as “as many as” or “until.” Peter wondered if there were a maximum number of times he must forgive someone who sinned against him. He thought that it might be Up to seven times. This probably seemed like a large number of times to him.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

As many as seven times? (ESV)

Some words are implied but not repeated here. The complete clause would be:

Must I forgive him up to seven times?

Matthew 18:22

Section 18:21–35: Jesus told a parable about a servant who did not forgive

In this section, Jesus continued to talk about relationships among believers. He did this by telling a parable about a servant and a king. The king canceled the servant’s large debt. But the servant refused to cancel the small debt of his fellow servant. As a result the king punished the servant.

Jesus told this parable to show us that God has forgiven our many sins. So we should forgive the few sins that other people commit against us. If we do not forgive others, God will not forgive us.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable of the servant who refused to forgive

The necessity for forgiveness (JBP)

18:22a

Jesus answered, “I tell you, not just seven times,

- Jesus said to Peter, “I tell you, not only/just seven times,
- Jesus answered, “I tell you that you should forgive him not just up to seven times,
- Jesus said, “No, not just 7 times.

I tell you, not just seven times: This clause is Jesus’ reply to Peter’s question. Jesus understood why Peter asked his question. He knew that Peter probably expected the answer that seven was a good limit. So

Jesus started by denying what Peter expected him to say.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I say to you, not just seven times (GW)

Not just seven times (CEV)

No, not seven times (NLT)

Some words are implied but not repeated here. The complete clause would be:

I tell you, you must forgive him not just seven times.

I tell you, you must forgive him more than seven times. (NCV)

18:22b

but seventy-seven times!

- instead you should forgive him up to seventy-seven times.”
- You should forgive him 77 times.”

but: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between “not seven times,” and “seventy times seven.” Languages have different ways to indicate this negative-positive type of contrast. Some of the ways are:

- With the conjunction but.
- With a conjunction other than but. This is a common way in English to show this type of contrast. For example:

rather

Instead

- With no conjunction. For example:

Not seven times. Seventy times seven.

seventy-seven times: There are two ways to interpret the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as seventy-seven times:

1. It is the number 77. For example:

seventy-seven times (NRSV) (BSB, NRSV, NIV, NET, NJB, NABRE, CEV, NCV)

1. It means 70 x 7. This would be 490 times. For example:

seventy times seven (RSV) (RSV, ESV, NASB, REB, KJV, NLT, GNT, JBP, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This same Greek phrase occurs in the ancient Greek translation of Genesis 4:24. There, the number in the original Hebrew is clearly the number 77.

It is also recommended that you put one interpretation in the text and the other interpretation in a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

Or seventy times seven (490). Either way, Jesus meant a huge number of times to forgive.

Some words are implied but not repeated here. The complete clause would be:

you should forgive him seventy-seven times

Matthew 18:23

Section 18:21–35: Jesus told a parable about a servant who did not forgive

In this section, Jesus continued to talk about relationships among believers. He did this by telling a parable about a servant and a king. The king canceled the servant's large debt. But the servant refused to cancel the small debt of his fellow servant. As a result the king punished the servant.

Jesus told this parable to show us that God has forgiven our many sins. So we should forgive the few sins that other people commit against us. If we do not forgive others, God will not forgive us.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable of the servant who refused to forgive

The necessity for forgiveness (JBP)

18:23a

Because of this, the kingdom of heaven is like

- ¶ "Because this is true, I can compare the kingdom of heaven/God to
- ¶ "I say this because God's rule is like this next story/parable.

Because of this: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Because of this is more literally "because of this." This phrase introduces a parable about forgiveness in the kingdom of heaven. The parable illustrates that when God forgives a person for his many sins, that person must forgive his fellow man for his few sins. If he does not forgive, God will judge him. This parable is closely related to Jesus's command in verses 21–22 to forgive 77 times.

Here are some other ways to introduce this parable:

- Use a connecting word or phrase. For example:

Because this is true

You must forgive like that because

In order to make clear why you should do this

- Leave the connection between Jesus' command and the parable implied. For example:

This story will show you what the kingdom of heaven is like (CEV)

the kingdom of heaven: The phrase kingdom of heaven has the same meaning as the phrase "kingdom of God." This phrase also occurs in 18:1b. You should translate it the same way in both places. For example:

- As a noun. For example:

the kingdom of God

God's kingship

God's rule over people

the rule of the one/Lord who lives in heaven

- As a verbal expression. For example:

the way God rules his people

the way God cares for his people as king

is like: The phrase is like indicates that Jesus was going to compare one thing with another. He compared the kingdom of God (in particular forgiveness in the kingdom), to the forgiveness of the king in the parable.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

is like this

is like this parable:

18:23b

a king who wanted to settle accounts with his servants.

- a king who decided to ask his servants to come and repay the money that they owed him.
- There was a certain chief. One day, this chief decided to collect the money that his workers owed him.

a king: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as a king is more literally “a man a king.” This means “a man who was a king.” In most languages, it will not be necessary to translate the word “man.”

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

a certain king/chief

who wanted: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as wanted indicates that the king had made a decision.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

who decided (NLT)

who wished (ESV)

to settle accounts: In this context, the Greek word that the BSB translates as accounts refers to financial records. Usually these records were debts that need to be repaid. So the Greek verb that the BSB translates as to settle refers to arrangements to pay off those debts.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

to collect the money his servants owed him (NCV)

to ask his workers to pay him the money that they owed him

with his servants: The Greek word that the BSB translates as servants also means slaves. It usually refers to people who were owned by someone else. Many slaves in that time had absolutely no authority. But if they

were slaves of a rich person, and if they were capable people, they could be given great responsibility.

In this context, this word refers to people who were in charge of the king’s finances. In some languages, it may be better to use a word other than “servant” or “slave.” For example:

his important workers

his officials (CEV)

Matthew 18:24

Section 18:21–35: Jesus told a parable about a servant who did not forgive

In this section, Jesus continued to talk about relationships among believers. He did this by telling a parable about a servant and a king. The king canceled the servant’s large debt. But the servant refused to cancel the small debt of his fellow servant. As a result the king punished the servant.

Jesus told this parable to show us that God has forgiven our many sins. So we should forgive the few sins that other people commit against us. If we do not forgive others, God will not forgive us.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable of the servant who refused to forgive

The necessity for forgiveness (JBP)

18:24a

As he began the settlements,

- When he began to do this,
- As he began to collect his money,

As he began the settlements: This clause indicates that the king had many servants to settle accounts with. They probably came to him one by one.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

When he began to do this (GW)

When the king began to collect his money (NCV)

As began to collect his money

18:24b**a debtor was brought to him owing ten thousand talents.**

- a servant who owed him ten thousand large coins was brought to him.
- they brought to him one of the workers. This worker owed him millions.

a debtor was brought to him owing: The verb was brought indicates that other servants led in one by one each of the people who owed the king money. The picture is of the king perhaps on his throne with the servants who owed money waiting outside the throne room for their turn.

This verb is passive. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

one of them was brought in who owed him (GNT)

- Use an active verb. For example:

someone/they brought in one of the workers who owed him money

a debtor...owing: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as a debtor...owing is more literally “one debtor.” It refers to one of the servants who owed him money.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

one of his debtors...who owed him (NLT)

a man who owed him (NIV)

ten thousand talents: This phrase refers to an enormous sum of money. The number ten thousand was the largest number that could be named in Greek. The word “talent” refers to the weight of metal such as silver or gold (1 talent = about 30 kilograms). It was the largest weight at that time. So the phrase ten thousand talents refers to an amount of money that was almost beyond imagination.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

- Use the number 10,000 and borrow the word “talent” from English or a national language. Then explain the whole expression in a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

The number 10,000 was the largest number you could say in Greek. A talent was the largest weight at the time. This was an enormous sum of money. It was so big you could not count it.

- Use the number 10,000 and replace “talent” with another expression. For example:

10,000 large pieces of money

ten thousand bags of gold (NIVUK)

- Use an expression that means “an enormous sum of money.” For example:

millions of coins

The last two options could also include a footnote. For example:

This was an enormous sum of money. It was so big you could not count it.

Some English versions use the American currency “dollars.” It is not recommended that you translate the term ten thousand talents using an amount of money in your national currency. The value of the currency used may change over time. In addition, using a modern currency removes this story from its historical setting.

Matthew 18:25**Section 18:21–35: Jesus told a parable about a servant who did not forgive**

In this section, Jesus continued to talk about relationships among believers. He did this by telling a parable about a servant and a king. The king canceled the servant’s large debt. But the servant refused to cancel the small debt of his fellow servant. As a result the king punished the servant.

Jesus told this parable to show us that God has forgiven our many sins. So we should forgive the few sins that other people commit against us. If we do not forgive others, God will not forgive us.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable of the servant who refused to forgive

The necessity for forgiveness (JBP)

18:25a**Since the man was unable to pay,**

- Because he could not pay,
- He did not have enough money to pay/reimburse him. So

Since the man was unable to pay: This clause is the reason for the result in the next clause. Because he could not pay, his master ordered him to be sold.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Because he was not able to repay it (NET)

He couldn't pay, so... (NLT)

He was not able to reimburse the money

In some languages, it will be more natural to put this clause after the result clause in 18:25b. For example:

^{25b}His master ordered him to be sold ^{25a}because he could not pay what he owed.

was unable to pay: The verb was unable to pay implies that he did not pay because he did not have enough money.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

the servant did not have enough money to pay (NCV)

18:25b**the master ordered that he be sold to pay his debt,**

- his master commanded him to be sold
- the king/chief ordered them to sell the man as a slave

the master: The Greek word that the BSB translates as master refers to someone who has authority. It is the same word that English versions usually translate as "lord." Here it refers to the king.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

his master (NLT)

the king (GNT)

the chief

ordered that he be sold: This clause means that the king ordered the man to be sold as a slave. This was common practice in Jesus' time. Often this happened after people were captured in war. Sometimes a person sold himself as a slave in order to provide money for his family. Here, the king apparently intended to sell the servant both to get some of his money back and to punish the servant.

In some languages, it may be natural to make some of this information explicit. For example:

ordered him to be sold as a slave (GNT)

The verb be sold is passive. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

ordered that he should be sold

- Use an active verb. For example:

ordered his officials to sell him

In some languages, it may also be natural to use direct speech here. For example:

The master said, "Sell him as a slave."

Selling people as slaves may be strange or unknown to your readers. So you may wish to add a footnote to explain it. Here is a sample footnote:

The king intended to sell the servant to someone else as a slave. This would punish the servant and also bring in some money to pay off his debt.

to pay his debt: This phrase means that the money from the sale of the servant, his family and all his possessions would be given to the king to pay his debt.

In Greek the verb is passive. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

and payment to be made (KJV)

so that his debt would be paid

so that the money would be reimbursed

- Use an active verb as the BSB does. For example:

to pay the debt (NLT)

Then the money would be used to pay the king what the servant owed. (NCV)

18:25c

along with his wife and children and everything he owned.

- together with his wife and children and everything that he owned.
- and also sell his wife and children and all his possessions.

along with his wife and children: The Greek word that the BSB translates as along with is the same conjunction that is often translated as “and.” It is used to join all the items in this list. This indicates that even his family would be sold to pay the debt.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

and his wife and children

and everything he owned: This phrase refers to all the things that he owned.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

and all his possessions

Matthew 18:26

Section 18:21–35: Jesus told a parable about a servant who did not forgive

In this section, Jesus continued to talk about relationships among believers. He did this by telling a parable about a servant and a king. The king canceled the servant’s large debt. But the servant refused to cancel the small debt of his fellow servant. As a result the king punished the servant.

Jesus told this parable to show us that God has forgiven our many sins. So we should forgive the few sins that other people commit against us. If we do not forgive others, God will not forgive us.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable of the servant who refused to forgive

The necessity for forgiveness (JBP)

18:26a

Then the servant fell on his knees before him.

- ¶ So/Then the servant threw himself to the ground before him
- ¶ When he said that, the servant knelt/bowed down in front of the king.

Then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Then indicates that 18:26 is the result of what the master said in 18:25.

Here are some other ways to begin this verse:

When this happened

As a result

Some English versions do not translate this word. They allow the context to suggest the connection. In some languages, a conjunction will not be necessary here either.

the servant fell on his knees before him: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as fell on his knees is more literally “fell and prostrated himself before him.” This indicates that the servant wanted to show the king great respect and honor. A person usually did that by bending over with his face toward the ground, or actually lying face down on the ground. This does not mean that he tripped and fell.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

got down on his knees (CEV)

knelt/bowed down before him

threw himself to the ground before him (NIV)

18:26b

‘Have patience with me,’ he begged,

- and begged/pleaded, ‘Master, please be patient with me
- He said, ‘My king, please wait a while longer for me to get the money.

Have patience with me: There is a textual issue here. Some Greek manuscripts include the word “Lord” at the beginning of the servant’s plea. Other Greek manuscripts do not include this word.

1. Most English versions follow the Greek manuscripts that do not include this word. For example:

Have patience with me (NRSV) (BSB, NRSV, ESV, NIV, NET, NASB, REB, NJB, NLT, GNT, CEV, NCV, JBP, GW)

1. Many Greek manuscripts do include the word “Lord,” but only a few English translations follow them. For example:

Lord, have patience with me (RSV) (RSV, KJV, NLT96)

The word “Lord” was probably not in the original Greek text. However, remember that the servant spoke very politely to his master as he pleaded for patience. In some languages, this way of speaking includes the use of a title. In other languages, there are other ways to show respect with words. For example:

Please, be patient with me (NLT)

My master, be patient with me

Have patience: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as Have patience is a command. But because of whom the servant said this to, it is really a plea or a request for patience.

The servant pleaded with the master not to act quickly on his decision to sell him. Rather, he should wait a bit, even though the master had the right to do what he threatened.

Here are some other ways to translate this plea:

Sir, please, allow me to have some more time.

My king, have pity and wait a while.

he begged: The Greek word that the BSB here translates as begged is the common Greek verb that means “saying.” In this context, the servant’s speech implies that he pleaded with the master. So, many English versions, including the BSB, translate it as begged.

You can translate this word as begged or “said” or another word that is natural for this context.

18:26c

‘and I will pay back everything.’

- and I will pay everything that I owe to you.’
- I will return/reimburse all of it to you.’

and I will pay back everything: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as pay is the same word that the

master used in 18:25a. It means to “give back” or “return” something.

The word everything refers to everything that the servant owed.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I will pay you everything I owe. (NCV)

I will reimburse you for everything.

I will return all your money.

Matthew 18:27

Section 18:21–35: Jesus told a parable about a servant who did not forgive

In this section, Jesus continued to talk about relationships among believers. He did this by telling a parable about a servant and a king. The king canceled the servant’s large debt. But the servant refused to cancel the small debt of his fellow servant. As a result the king punished the servant.

Jesus told this parable to show us that God has forgiven our many sins. So we should forgive the few sins that other people commit against us. If we do not forgive others, God will not forgive us.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable of the servant who refused to forgive

The necessity for forgiveness (JBP)

18:27a

His master had compassion on him,

- The/His master had mercy on that servant,
- Then the king felt sorry for him

His master: The word master refers to the king in 18:23b.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the master of that servant (ESV)

The king (GNT)

had compassion on him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as had compassion comes from a noun that refers to a person’s intestines. As with many

other cultures in the world, Greek culture considered a person's intestines as the place of strong emotion. In this context, the emotion is pity or compassion. The master felt sorry for the servant. Consider how this sort of emotion is expressed in your language and translate in that way.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

took/had pity on him

felt sorry for him (GNT)

had mercy on him

18:27b

forgave his debt, and released him.

- canceled the debt, and let him leave.
- and told him that he did not have to pay back the money. Then he told him that he could go. And the servant left.
- and said to him, 'You do not need to pay your great debt. You may go now.'

forgave his debt: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as forgave also occurs in 18:21b in relation to sins. Here it refers to forgiving/canceling a debt. This means that the master no longer required the servant to pay back the money that he owed him. You should use whichever verb is natural in your language for this action.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

cancelled the debt (REB)

told him he did not have to pay it back (NCV)

debt: The Greek word that the BSB translates as debt could also be translated as "loan." It indicates that the debt which the servant had to repay was money that he borrowed from the king.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

debt (NIV)

loan

money (CEV)

released him: This phrase probably indicates that the servant was held in some way. As mentioned in 18:24b, some servants had brought this servant in before the king. They were perhaps still holding him. So the master commanded them to release him.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

let him go (NIV)

set him free (JBP)

General Comment on 18:27b

In some languages, it will be more natural to use direct speech here. For example:

and said to him, 'You do not have to pay back your debt. You may go now.'

Matthew 18:28

Section 18:21–35: Jesus told a parable about a servant who did not forgive

In this section, Jesus continued to talk about relationships among believers. He did this by telling a parable about a servant and a king. The king canceled the servant's large debt. But the servant refused to cancel the small debt of his fellow servant. As a result the king punished the servant.

Jesus told this parable to show us that God has forgiven our many sins. So we should forgive the few sins that other people commit against us. If we do not forgive others, God will not forgive us.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable of the servant who refused to forgive

The necessity for forgiveness (JBP)

18:28a

But when that servant went out,

- ¶ But that servant left
- ¶ Then that servant left there and

But: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between a king who forgave a large debt (18:24–27) and a servant who did not forgive a small debt (18:28–30). Some English versions (like the BSB) indicate this contrast by beginning this paragraph with the conjunction But.

In some languages, the contrast is obvious, and it may not be natural to introduce it with a conjunction like *But*. If that is true in your language, it may be more natural to begin this paragraph with a simple time word or phrase. For example:

Then (GNT)

Later (NCV)

You should do what is most natural in your language.

when that servant: This servant was the same man from 18:27. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

when that same servant (ESV)

Then the man (GNT)

went out: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *went out* indicates that the servant left the presence of the king or left the house of the king. If including the location is more natural in your language, you should use a general reference such as “there.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

left there

left the palace/house and then

18:28b

he found one of his fellow servants who owed him a hundred denarii.

- and later went to another servant who owed him a hundred denarii.
- went searching and found another servant who owed him only a hundred coins.

he found: There are several ways to interpret the Greek verb that the BSB translates as *found*:

The servant went searching for the other servant. For example:

he went to (NLT) (NLT) Nolland on page 758 says, “Does the released slave seek out his fellow slave or simply come upon him? *εὑρεν* (‘found’) could connote either, but since the verb is used in v. 13 for a deliberate seeking out, that is more likely

here. This also offers the best counterpart to the master’s initiative in the previous meeting.”

The servant met the other servant without planning to. For instance:

he came upon (RSV)

he happened to meet (CEV) (RSV, REB, NJB, CEV, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). There are several contrasts in this story, and this is one of them. The king had the servant brought to him. The king could do that because he was of higher status than the servant. But the servant did not have a higher status than his fellow servant. He had to go find him to get his money.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he went to (NLT)

he went searching for and found

one of his fellow servants: The words *fellow servants* refer to the fact that both people referred to in this verse were servants of the king.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

another servant (NCV)

a second servant of the king

a hundred denarii: The Greek word that the BSB transliterates as *denarii* is the plural of “denarius.” A denarius was the name of a Roman coin. This coin was worth the same as the wages for a farm worker for one day of work.

One hundred denarii was almost nothing in comparison with ten thousand talents.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

- Transliterate the word *denarii* or “denarius.” For example:

a hundred denarii (NIV) If you use this option, you may want to include a footnote. A sample footnote is:

A hundred denarii were worth the same as the wages for a farm worker for a hundred days of work. This may have been a large debt for the second servant. But it was very, very small compared to the debt of the first servant.

- Use the name of a general kind of coin. For example:

a hundred silver coins (NET)

- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

an amount much smaller than his own debt

a small debt

Some English versions use the American currency “dollars.” It is not recommended that you translate the term a hundred denarii using an amount of money in your national currency. The value of the currency used may change over time. In addition, using a modern currency removes this story from its historical setting.

18:28c

He grabbed him and began to choke him,

- He grabbed him and started choking him
- He grabbed him around the throat/neck and started squeezing

He grabbed him: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as grabbed means to “take hold of” or “seize” something. In this context, it probably means that he grabbed him by the throat. For example:

he grabbed him by the throat (NET)

he grabbed him around the neck

began to choke him: In this context, the Greek verb that the BSB translates as choke refers to putting his hands around the other servant’s throat and squeezing with an intent to kill.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he started choking him (CEV)

he started squeezing his neck

18:28d

saying, ‘Pay back what you owe me!’

- saying, ‘Pay back all that you owe me!’

- and said, ‘Give me the money that you owe me!’

saying: In Greek, the form of the verb saying indicates that the first servant spoke while he was choking the second servant.

Here are some other ways to indicate this:

at the same time he said

While he was doing this he said

Pay back what you owe me!: The Greek word that the BSB translates as what refers to the hundred denarii that he owed.

Here are some other ways to translate this command:

Pay back all that you owe me!

Pay me the money you owe me! (NCV)

Reimburse what you owe me!

Matthew 18:29

Section 18:21–35: Jesus told a parable about a servant who did not forgive

In this section, Jesus continued to talk about relationships among believers. He did this by telling a parable about a servant and a king. The king canceled the servant’s large debt. But the servant refused to cancel the small debt of his fellow servant. As a result the king punished the servant.

Jesus told this parable to show us that God has forgiven our many sins. So we should forgive the few sins that other people commit against us. If we do not forgive others, God will not forgive us.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable of the servant who refused to forgive

The necessity for forgiveness (JBP)

18:29a

So his fellow servant fell down and begged him,

- So/Then his fellow servant got on the ground and pleaded with him saying,
- When he said that, the second servant kneeled and begged him. He said,

So: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *So* indicates that 18:29 is the result of what the first servant did and said 18:28.

Here are some other ways to begin this verse:

When this happened

As a result

Some English versions do not translate this word. They allow the context to suggest the connection. In some languages, a conjunction will not be necessary here either.

This same conjunction occurs in 18:26a

his fellow servant: These words refer to the servant that owed a hundred denarii. Make sure that your translation refers to this second servant.

fell down: There is a textual issue here:

1. Some Greek manuscripts have only the word that is translated as *fell down*. For example:

fell down before him (NLT) (BSB, NIV, GNT, ESV, NET, RSV, NASB, CEV, NLT, NCV)

1. Other Greek manuscripts have the word that is translated as *fell down* plus the phrase *at his feet*. For example:

fell at his fellow-servant's feet (REB) (REB, NJB, KJV, JBP, GW)

The majority of English versions follow the Greek texts that have only “*fell down*.” However, here you should do what is most natural in your language. In some languages, it may be more natural to include a phrase like “*at his feet*.” See the paragraphs below for more advice.

The Greek word that the BSB translates as *fell down* is parallel to the phrase “*fell on his knees*” in 18:26a. It is not exactly the same in Greek, but it is close enough to be translated in a similar way.

This word indicates that the second man humbled himself before the first servant as he pleaded for mercy.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

knelt

fell to his knees (NIV)

got down on his knees (CEV)

threw himself down (NET)

This word does not mean that the man tripped and fell.

begged him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *begged* means “*pleaded*” or “*asked urgently*.” It is parallel to the word “*implored*” or “*begged*” in 18:26b. You may use the same translation here as you did there. For example:

begged him (NIV)

18:29b

‘Have patience with me, and I will pay you back.’

- ‘Be patient with me, and I will pay the money that I owe to you.’
- ‘Please wait a while longer. I will give/return the money to you.’

Have patience with me, and I will pay you back: In Greek, this sentence is almost exactly the same as 18:26b–c. (Here, this sentence does not include the word “*everything*” as in 18:26c.) You should translate it in almost the same way.

Here are some other ways to translate this sentence:

Be patient with me, and I will pay you what I owe.

Please, wait a while. I will return your money.

My friend, please give me some more time, and I will give you your money.

Matthew 18:30

Section 18:21–35: Jesus told a parable about a servant who did not forgive

In this section, Jesus continued to talk about relationships among believers. He did this by telling a parable about a servant and a king. The king canceled the servant’s large debt. But the servant refused to cancel the small debt of his fellow servant. As a result the king punished the servant.

Jesus told this parable to show us that God has forgiven our many sins. So we should forgive the few sins that other people commit against us. If we do not forgive others, God will not forgive us.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable of the servant who refused to forgive

The necessity for forgiveness (JBP)

18:30a But he refused.

- But the first servant refused to be patient. (NCV)
- But he was not willing to wait.

There is a contrast here. The contrast is between the way that the king treated the first servant, and the way that the first servant treated the second servant. The BSB and some English versions indicate this contrast with the conjunction “But.” For example:

But (NIV)

Other English versions let the context suggest the connection. You should do what is most natural in your language.

But he refused: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as But he refused is more literally “He was not willing” (as in the NASB). The first servant was not willing to do what the second servant begged him to do.

In some languages, it may be more natural to make explicit the thing that was refused. For example:

he refused the request

the first servant refused to be patient (NCV)

he was not willing to wait

18:30b Instead, he went and had the man thrown into prison

- Instead, he went and caused the man to be thrown into prison
- Rather, he went and told the officials/police, and they threw him into prison

Instead: The Greek conjunction that the BSB here translates as Instead occurs when a pair of clauses is related, and the first clause contains a negative term (“refused,” in 18:30a) or the word “not.” (In this case,

18:30a is the first clause. It is literally “He was not willing.”)

Here are some other ways to introduce this clause:

then (NRSV)

In some languages, no conjunction is necessary here. This is what the NCV does. For example:

^{30a}But the first servant refused to be patient. ^{30b}He threw the other servant into prison until he could pay everything he owed.

he went and had the man thrown into prison: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as thrown is more literally “throw.” It refers to an action with force.

The first servant did not throw the second one into prison himself. Rather, he went to the authorities, told them what happened, and asked them to throw him in prison/jail.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he had him thrown into prison (NJB)

he went and asked the authorities to throw him in prison/jail

18:30c until he could pay his debt.

- until he/someone paid back the money.
- for as long as he did not give/reimburse the money that he owed.

until he could pay his debt: In that time, someone with a debt that he could not pay, or refused to pay, could be put in prison. It was expected that his family or friends would then pay off the debt in order to release him.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

until someone paid off the debt

until the day that he reimbursed the money

for as long as he had not paid all the money that he owed

Matthew 18:31

Section 18:21–35: Jesus told a parable about a servant who did not forgive

In this section, Jesus continued to talk about relationships among believers. He did this by telling a parable about a servant and a king. The king canceled the servant's large debt. But the servant refused to cancel the small debt of his fellow servant. As a result the king punished the servant.

Jesus told this parable to show us that God has forgiven our many sins. So we should forgive the few sins that other people commit against us. If we do not forgive others, God will not forgive us.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable of the servant who refused to forgive

The necessity for forgiveness (JBP)

18:31a

When his fellow servants saw what had happened,

- ¶ When the other servants saw these things,
- ¶ The king's other servants saw what happened,

In Greek, this verse begins with the same conjunction that occurs in 18:29a. This conjunction indicates that 18:31 is the result of what the servant did in 18:30.

Here are some other ways to begin this verse:

When this happened

As a result

Most English versions do not translate this word. They allow the context to suggest the connection. In some languages, a conjunction will not be necessary here either.

When his fellow servants saw: The phrase fellow servants refers to other people who were all servants of the same king. The pronoun his refers to either the first servant or the second servant. It is also possible to translate this clause in a general way. For example:

When the other servants saw (GNT)

Probably some, not all, of the servants saw what had happened. In some languages, it may be more natural to say:

When some of the other servants saw (NLT)

fellow servants: This is the same word that occurs in 18:28b.

what had happened: This phrase can also be translated as “the things that happened.” It is not clear whether the other servants saw only the argument between the two servants, or whether they also saw how the king forgave the first servant. They probably knew about all these things even if they did not actually see them with their eyes. So translate this phrase in a general way. For example:

saw this (NLT)

saw what had taken place (ESV)

saw these things/events

18:31b

they were greatly distressed,

- they were deeply grieved.
- and they were very upset.

they were greatly distressed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as distressed also means “sad,” “sorrowful,” and “grieved.” The servants were very upset that the first servant did not show any compassion toward the second servant. The king had showed him such great compassion to him. But he did not show compassion to someone else.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

they were very upset (NET)

they were shocked

18:31c

and they went and recounted all of this to their master.

- They went to their master and told him all that had happened.
- So they went to the king and told him all that the first servant had done.

they went: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as went can also mean “came.” For example:

and came (NASB)

Here you should use the verb that is most natural in this context.

and recounted: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as recounted means “fully explained” something. Here is another way to translate this verb:

and told (NIV)

all of this: This phrase refers to the things that the first servant had done to the second servant.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

everything that the first servant had done

the whole affair (NJB)

all that the first servant did to the second servant

to their master: The word master refers to the king.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the king/chief

Matthew 18:32

Section 18:21–35: Jesus told a parable about a servant who did not forgive

In this section, Jesus continued to talk about relationships among believers. He did this by telling a parable about a servant and a king. The king canceled the servant’s large debt. But the servant refused to cancel the small debt of his fellow servant. As a result the king punished the servant.

Jesus told this parable to show us that God has forgiven our many sins. So we should forgive the few sins that other people commit against us. If we do not forgive others, God will not forgive us.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable of the servant who refused to forgive

The necessity for forgiveness (JBP)

18:32a

Then the master summoned him

- Then the master called for the first servant.

- Then the king sent an order that the first servant come to him. When he arrived,

Then: This word indicates that the events in this verse happened sometime after the events in the previous verse. It does not necessarily mean that they happened immediately after it.

Here is another way to translate this word:

After that

the master: This same phrase occurs in 18:25b. The Greek and some English versions have the pronoun “his,” which refers to the first servant.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

his master (ESV)

The king (CEV)

the chief

summoned him: The Greek word that the BSB here translates as summoned also means “called to.” This same verb occurs in 18:2a. There the BSB translates this word as “invited.”

Here, the context implies that the king told his servants to go get this man. Or he told the man himself to come present himself.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

called the servant in (NIV)

sent for the man (NJB)

18:32b

and declared, ‘You wicked servant!’

- He said, ‘You are a bad servant,
- the king said to him, ‘Evil servant,

You wicked servant: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as You wicked servant is simply “wicked servant.” Here the king spoke directly to the servant to criticize him. In English, the word You can be added to this phrase to show that the king spoke directly to the servant.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Evil slave! (NET)

You are a wicked servant/man!

You are wicked/bad!

wicked: This word describes something that is evil, worthless or bad. For example:

You worthless slave! (GNT)

18:32c

I forgave all your debt because you begged me.

- I canceled all your debt because you begged me.
- you begged me to be patient, so I told you that you did not need to pay back the money.

I forgave all your debt because you begged me: The clause I forgave all your debt is a result clause. The clause because you begged me is a reason clause. In some languages, it may be more natural to put the reason clause before the result clause. For example:

You begged me to have patience and so I did even more. I canceled all that debt.

When you begged for mercy, I said you did not have to pay back a cent. (CEV)

I forgave all your debt: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as I forgave refers to forgiving/canceling a debt. This same verb occurs in 18:27b.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I canceled your entire debt (GW)

I told you that you did not have to pay anything (NCV)

all your debt: This phrase refers to the enormous sum of money that the first servant owed. The king said all to indicate that the forgiveness was complete.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

that tremendous debt (NLT)

the whole amount you owed me (GNT)

all the money that you owed me

because: This conjunction indicates that the following clause is the reason why the king forgave the debt.

you begged me: The Greek word that the BSB translates as begged means “pleaded” or “asked urgently.” For example:

you pleaded with me (ESV)

This same verb occurs in 18:29a. You should translate it the same way in both places.

Matthew 18:33

Section 18:21–35: Jesus told a parable about a servant who did not forgive

In this section, Jesus continued to talk about relationships among believers. He did this by telling a parable about a servant and a king. The king canceled the servant’s large debt. But the servant refused to cancel the small debt of his fellow servant. As a result the king punished the servant.

Jesus told this parable to show us that God has forgiven our many sins. So we should forgive the few sins that other people commit against us. If we do not forgive others, God will not forgive us.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable of the servant who refused to forgive

The necessity for forgiveness (JBP)

18:33

This verse is a rhetorical question. The king used this rhetorical question to rebuke the servant.

Here are some other ways to translate this rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Shouldn’t you have mercy on your fellow servant, just as I had mercy on you? (NLT)

- As a tag question. For example:

You should have mercy on your fellow servant just as I had mercy on you, should you not?

- As a statement followed by a “why” question. For example:

I had mercy on you. Why did you not have mercy on your fellow servant?

- As a statement. For example:

You should have had mercy on your fellow servant, just as I had mercy on you. (GNT)

I had mercy on you. So you should also have mercy on your fellow servant.

Translate this rebuke in a way that is most natural in your language.

18:33a

Shouldn't you have had mercy on your fellow servant,

- Why did you not pity your fellow servant
- You should/must have mercy on your fellow servant

Shouldn't you have had mercy on your fellow servant: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Shouldn't you includes a verb that is often translated "it is necessary." In this context, it indicates what is the servant's duty.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

you must have mercy on your fellow servant

you are required/obligated to have mercy on your fellow servant

have had mercy on: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as have...mercy on means "pity" someone," or "have compassion" on someone because of their condition. For example:

show pity (CEV)

18:33b

just as I had on you?

- just as I pitied you?
- like the way that I had mercy on you, should you not?

just as I had on you: The verb had is the same verb as "had mercy" in 18:33a. The king expected the servant to pity his fellow servant as the king had pitied him.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

like I pitied you

like the way that I did to you

Matthew 18:34

Section 18:21–35: Jesus told a parable about a servant who did not forgive

In this section, Jesus continued to talk about relationships among believers. He did this by telling a parable about a servant and a king. The king canceled the servant's large debt. But the servant refused to cancel the small debt of his fellow servant. As a result the king punished the servant.

Jesus told this parable to show us that God has forgiven our many sins. So we should forgive the few sins that other people commit against us. If we do not forgive others, God will not forgive us.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable of the servant who refused to forgive

The necessity for forgiveness (JBP)

18:34a

In anger his master turned him over to the jailers to be tortured,

- His master was very angry and gave him to the prison guards to punish him
- The king was so angry that he sent him to prison to be tortured/punished

In anger his master: The Greek word that the BSB translates as In anger can also be translated as an independent verb. For example:

His master was so angry that (GW)

The king was very angry, and (GNT)

turned him over: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as turned him over means "transferred his control to" (another person). The king gave the wicked servant to other people to punish.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

gave/put him into the power of

sent the servant to (GNT)

handed him over to (NJB)

This same verb occurs in 17:22b when Jesus talked about what would happen to him. There the BSB translates it as “delivered.”

to the jailers: The Greek word that the BSB translates as jailers can also be translated as “torturers” (as in the NJB and GW). It describes officials in a jail whose job was to torture a prisoner in order to punish him and question him.

Some English versions are like the BSB and translate only the idea of jailers. Other English versions translate only the idea of torturers. It is best to use a term or phrase that includes both ideas. For example:

to the prison guards to be tortured (NET)

to jail to be punished (GNT)

in prison to be punished (NCV)

18:34b

until he should repay all that he owed.

- until he paid back all the money.
- for as long as he did not give/reimburse all the money that he owed.”

until he should repay all that he owed: This same phrase occurs in 18:30c (except here the word all is added). You should translate it in the same way. For example:

until he paid off all the debt

until the day that he reimbursed all the money

for as long as he had not paid all the money that he owed

Matthew 18:35

Section 18:21–35: Jesus told a parable about a servant who did not forgive

In this section, Jesus continued to talk about relationships among believers. He did this by telling a parable about a servant and a king. The king canceled the servant’s large debt. But the servant refused to cancel the small debt of his fellow servant. As a result the king punished the servant.

Jesus told this parable to show us that God has forgiven our many sins. So we should forgive the few

sins that other people commit against us. If we do not forgive others, God will not forgive us.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The parable of the servant who refused to forgive

The necessity for forgiveness (JBP)

18:35

In 18:35, Jesus gave the application of his parable. In some languages, it may be natural to make this clearer. For example:

And Jesus concluded (GNT)

Before you translate 18:35, consider what the most natural order for the parts of this verse is in your language. In some languages, it may be more natural to put 18:35b first. For example:

^{35b}If you do not forgive your brother from your heart, ^{35a}my heavenly Father will do the same thing to every one of you.

18:35a

That is how My heavenly Father will treat each of you

- My Father in heaven will deal with each of you^(plur) in the same way
- Then Jesus concluded/ended, “So my Father in heaven will do like that to each of you^(plur)”

That is how: The Greek word that the BSB translates as That is how also means “likewise” or “in this manner.” It indicates that the way that God will treat people who do not forgive their brother is similar to what the king in the story did.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

So also (ESV)

Like that

In the same way

My heavenly Father: Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

my Father in heaven (GNT)

my Father who is in heaven

This same phrase occurs in 15:13. You should translate it the same way in both places.

will treat each of you: This phrase refers to the way that God the Father will treat people. He will treat them harshly like the king treated the unforgiving servant harshly.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

will do to every one of you (ESV)

will deal with you (REB)

18:35b

unless you forgive your brother from your heart.”

- if you^(plur) do not truly/sincerely forgive your brother.”
- unless you^(plur) forgive your fellow believer with all your heart.”

unless you forgive your brother: In Greek, the pronoun that the BSB translates as your is literally “his” (as in the KJV). But because the final phrase has “your heart,” the BSB (and almost every other English version) translates it as your. You should follow these versions.

from your heart: The Greek phrase that the BSB literally translates as from your heart is an idiom. It means that your forgiveness should be sincere. It should be true forgiveness. Use a word or phrase that best describes that in your language.

Here are some other ways to say this in English:

with all your heart (CEV)

sincerely (GW)

18:35a–b

(reordered) Then Jesus concluded, “If you do not forgive your brother with all your heart, my Father in heaven will treat each of you in the same way.”

Matthew 19:1

Section 19:1–12: Jesus taught about divorce and marriage

In this section, Jesus led his disciples out of Galilee and passed through the land of Perea on his way to Jerusalem. While in Perea, some Pharisees came to him and asked him a question about divorce. They

hoped that he would say something that they thought was wrong so that they could shame him. But Jesus taught about divorce based on Scripture. (This section has more information about divorce than 5:31–32.)

Jesus also taught that believers may choose not to marry so that they can fully devote themselves to serving God. Jesus and Paul are examples of this way of living.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Teaching about divorce

Concerning divorce and not marrying

A Discussion About Divorce and Celibacy (GW)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 10:1–12 and Luke 16:18.

19:1a

When Jesus had finished saying these things,

- ¶ When Jesus finished these sayings/teachings,
- ¶ When Jesus finished saying these things,

When Jesus had finished saying these things: This is a time clause. It indicates that the previous part of Matthew’s story ended, and a new section of the story begins.

The BSB begins this section with the word When. You should follow the ordinary way in your language to begin a new section of a story.

The phrase these things refers to the parables and other things that Jesus said in chapter 18.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

When Jesus finished saying these things (GNT)

When Jesus finished teaching (CEV)

When Jesus finished teaching these things

19:1b

He left Galilee

- he left Galilee
- he departed from the land of Galilee with his disciples.

He left Galilee: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as left means that Jesus “departed” or “exited” the land of Galilee. For example:

he went away from Galilee (ESV)

It is implied that Jesus’ disciples went with him, because they are with him in 19:10. In some languages, it may be natural to make this information explicit here. For example:

he left Galilee with the disciples

he left Galilee and the disciples went along

Galilee: The word Galilee refers to the district of Galilee. Here it does not refer to the Sea of Galilee. It was a region north of Samaria and west of the Sea of Galilee. (See the map below.)

Here is another way to translate this word:

the land of Galilee

19:1c

and went into the region of Judea beyond the Jordan.

- and went into the land of Judea on the other side of the Jordan River.
- Then he crossed over the Jordan River and entered the land of Judea.

went into the region of Judea beyond the Jordan:

The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as beyond the Jordan is more literally “on the other side of the Jordan.” There are two ways to interpret this phrase:

1. It refers to land on the west side of the Jordan River. According to this interpretation, Matthew used the phrase “on the other side of the Jordan” from the perspective of someone who was traveling down the east side of the Jordan River. That was the normal route that a Jew took to go from Galilee to Judea to avoid going through Samaria, and Jesus took that route. He left Galilee by crossing the Jordan River. Then he walked south through Perea. Finally, he recrossed the river again to enter into Judea on the other side. This is where the land of Judea is located. (most commentaries)
2. It refers to land on the east side of the Jordan River. According to this interpretation, Matthew used the phrase “on the other side of the Jordan” in its normal sense. The normal sense is from the per-

spective of someone in Jerusalem or Judea (on the west side of the river). So “on the other side of the Jordan” means on the east side. Many Jews lived on the east side, and some people probably also referred to that area as Judea. So Matthew referred to Judea in the broad sense of the region south of Galilee. Many Jews lived on the east side of the Jordan River, and some people probably referred to this area as also part of Judea. For example:

and went to the part of Judea that is east of the Jordan River (CEV) (CEV, NLT) Most English versions are ambiguous, and it is not possible to tell which interpretation they follow. If possible, you should also translate this phrase simply as “on the other side of the Jordan” and not specify which side. If you must make a choice, it is recommended that you choose interpretation (1). Most commentaries follow this interpretation. For example, Morris on page 479 says, “Mark and Luke both speak of Jesus as going into Judea, but neither says anything about leaving Galilee. This, however, is important for Matthew, and he includes it. He also tells us that Jesus came into Judea beyond the Jordan. Since Judea lay to the west of the Jordan, this raises a problem. It may mean that he traveled to Judea by way of the region to the east of the Jordan (as Jews commonly did; it enabled them to avoid going through Samaritan territory). In favor of this is the fact that Jesus passed through Jericho on his way to Jerusalem (20:29). Or, as Argyle thinks, Matthew may be using Judea loosely, to include Perea as well as the territory to the west of the Jordan; this would be supported by the fact that many Jews in fact lived in Perea. But it is more likely that Matthew is saying that Jesus’ first entrance into the province of Judea was by way of the area beyond the Jordan.”

Here are some other ways to translate 19:1c:

he entered the land of Judea from the other side of the Jordan River

and traveled along the other side of the Jordan River to the territory of Judea (GW)

he crossed the Jordan River and entered the land of Judea

Matthew 19:2

Section 19:1–12: Jesus taught about divorce and marriage

In this section, Jesus led his disciples out of Galilee and passed through the land of Perea on his way to Jerusalem. While in Perea, some Pharisees came to him and asked him a question about divorce. They hoped that he would say something that they thought was wrong so that they could shame him. But Jesus taught about divorce based on Scripture. (This section has more information about divorce than 5:31–32.)

Jesus also taught that believers may choose not to marry so that they can fully devote themselves to serving God. Jesus and Paul are examples of this way of living.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Teaching about divorce

Concerning divorce and not marrying

A Discussion About Divorce and Celibacy (GW)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 10:1–12 and Luke 16:18.

19:2a

Large crowds followed Him,

- Big crowds followed him,
- Many people followed him,

Large crowds: The phrase Large crowds refers to a large number of people.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

many crowds

many groups of people

many people

followed Him: Here the phrase followed Him probably means “walked along with Jesus for some distance” (as in 4:25a). In other contexts, it can mean “became a disciple of Jesus.” Some people in the crowd may have followed Jesus for the purpose of being his disciples, but others followed him only to see what he did. Here you should translate followed in a literal way.

19:2b

and He healed them there.

- and there he healed those people who were sick.
- and he made the sick ones among them well again.

He healed them there: The pronoun them refers to the people in the crowds who were sick. It does not mean that all the people in the crowds were sick.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

he healed the sick people among them

there: The Greek word that the BSB translates as there refers to the area of Judea in which Jesus was walking.

Matthew 19:3

Section 19:1–12: Jesus taught about divorce and marriage

In this section, Jesus led his disciples out of Galilee and passed through the land of Perea on his way to Jerusalem. While in Perea, some Pharisees came to him and asked him a question about divorce. They hoped that he would say something that they thought was wrong so that they could shame him. But Jesus taught about divorce based on Scripture. (This section has more information about divorce than 5:31–32.)

Jesus also taught that believers may choose not to marry so that they can fully devote themselves to serving God. Jesus and Paul are examples of this way of living.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Teaching about divorce

Concerning divorce and not marrying

A Discussion About Divorce and Celibacy (GW)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 10:1–12 and Luke 16:18.

19:3a

Then some Pharisees came and tested Him by asking,

- Some Pharisees came to him and tried to trap him by asking,
- Then some Pharisees approached him and tried to get/make him say something that he should not say. They asked,

Then: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Then is the connecting word that usually joins the next event to the previous one. Some English versions do not translate it here. They allow the context to suggest the connection.

Here is another way to translate it:

And (ESV)

some Pharisees: Some Pharisees came to Jesus. Not all of them.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

some members of the Pharisee group

For help in translating the word Pharisees, see the note at 3:7a.

came: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as came means that they approached Jesus. There is no indication of where these Pharisees came from. It is good to keep this as a general statement. For example:

Pharisees approached him (NJB)

some Pharisees came to Jesus

and tested Him: The word tested means “tried to trick/trap” him so that he fails. The Pharisees wanted Jesus to fail to answer the question well. They hoped that he would say something that was against the law of Moses. Then they could accuse him.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in order to test him (NET)

and tried to trap him (GNT)

and tried to trick him (NCV)

and tried to trick him to give a bad answer

This same verb occurs in 16:1b. You should translate it here as you did there.

Him: The pronoun Him refers to Jesus. Since this sentence begins a new paragraph, it may be natural in some languages to use his name. For example:

and tested Jesus

by asking: In Greek, this phrase is more literally “and saying.” But the Pharisees’ trap for Jesus involved a question. So many English translations use the word “ask” here.

It is also possible to start a new sentence here. For example:

They asked (NIV)

19:3b

“Is it lawful for a man to divorce his wife for any reason?”

- “Does our^(incl) law allow a man to divorce his wife for any reason?”
- “Does God’s law permit a man to end his marriage for no matter what reason?”

Is it lawful: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Is it lawful is more literally “Is it permitted.” This means “Does God’s/Moses’ law permit (a man to divorce his wife)?”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Does our Law allow a man (GNT)

Is it permitted in the Law of Moses for a man

This same phrase occurs in 12:10c.

for a man to divorce his wife: The Greek word that the BSB translates as divorce means “release,” “reject,” or “send away.” In this context, it refers to breaking the covenant of marriage between a man and a woman. At that time, Jewish law allowed a man to break the marriage covenant with his wife, but the law made it very difficult for the woman to break it.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

to send away his wife

to break the marriage vows

his wife: The English phrase his wife is a way to speak in general.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

one’s wife (ESV)

for any reason: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as any reason can also be translated as “any cause.” For example:

for just any reason? (CEV)

for any and every reason (NIV)

for no matter what reason

Deuteronomy 24:1 says that a man could divorce his wife if he found something indecent about her. There were different ideas among the Pharisees themselves about how to interpret that verse. The Pharisees wanted to know what Jesus thought “something indecent” meant. Was it limited to just sexual unfaithfulness? Or could a man divorce his wife for anything he might be unhappy about? Their question reflects the intra-Pharisaic debate between the “schools” of Shammai and Hillel concerning the correct interpretation of Deut 24:1. In that passage God apparently permitted divorce for “anything indecent.” Shammai, placing the emphasis on “indecent,” took this to refer to sexual unfaithfulness; Hillel, placing the emphasis on “anything,” allowed divorce even for as trivial an offense as a wife burning her husband’s food (m. Git. 9:10).” (Bloomberg, page 288). Whichever way he answered, some Pharisees would disagree with him.

Matthew 19:4

Section 19:1–12: Jesus taught about divorce and marriage

In this section, Jesus led his disciples out of Galilee and passed through the land of Perea on his way to Jerusalem. While in Perea, some Pharisees came to him and asked him a question about divorce. They hoped that he would say something that they thought was wrong so that they could shame him. But Jesus taught about divorce based on Scripture. (This section has more information about divorce than 5:31–32.)

Jesus also taught that believers may choose not to marry so that they can fully devote themselves to serving God. Jesus and Paul are examples of this way of living.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Teaching about divorce

Concerning divorce and not marrying

A Discussion About Divorce and Celibacy (GW)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 10:1–12 and Luke 16:18.

19:4a–5c

Jesus answered, “Have you not read that from the beginning the Creator ‘made them male and female,’ and said, ‘For this reason a man will leave his father and mother and be united to his wife, and the two will become one flesh’ 19:5 Genesis 2:24 (see also LXX)?: Verses 19:4–5 are one long rhetorical question. Jesus used this rhetorical question to rebuke/shame the Pharisees. They were proud of their knowledge of Scripture. So Jesus began this rebuke by implying that they had not really read Scripture with understanding.

Here are some other ways to translate this rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question. In some languages, it will be more natural to divide this long, rhetorical question into several sentences. For example:

^{4a}Jesus answered, “Haven’t you read the scripture that says ^{4b}that in the beginning the Creator made people male and female? ^{5a}And God said, ‘For this reason a man will leave his father and mother ^{5b}and unite with his wife, ^{5c}and the two will become one.’ (GNT)

^{4a}“Haven’t you read the Scriptures?” Jesus replied.

^{4b}“They record that from the beginning ‘God made them male and female.’ ^{5a}And he said, ‘This explains why a man leaves his father and mother ^{5b}and is joined to his wife, ^{5c}and the two are united into one. (NLT)

^{4–5}Jesus said, “The Scripture says that in the beginning God created humans ‘as male and female.’ It also says ‘For this reason a man will leave his father and mother and be united to his wife, and the two will become one flesh.’ Surely you^(plur) have read those words of Scripture, haven’t you?”

- As a statement that rebukes the Pharisees for not reading this Scripture. For example:

^{4a}Jesus answered, “Surely you have read in the Scriptures: ^{4b}When God made the world, ‘he made them male and female.’ ^{5a}And God said, ‘So a man will leave his father and mother ^{5b}and be united with his wife, ^{5c}and the two will become one body.’ (NCV)

Translate this rebuke in a way that is natural in your language.

19:4a

Jesus answered, “Have you not read

- He answered, “Have you^(plur) not read the Scripture where it says
- Jesus answered, “Surely you have read in the Scriptures: (NCV)

Have you not read: Jesus expected his listeners to understand that he meant “Have you not read the Scriptures?” In some languages, it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

Haven’t you read the scripture that says (GNT)

Surely you have read in the Scriptures (NCV)

19:4b

that from the beginning the Creator ‘made them male and female,’

- that in the beginning the Creator ‘created a male and a female,’
- that at the beginning of the world, when God created people/humans, he ‘made a male and female.’
- When God made the world, ‘he made a man and a woman.’

from the beginning: This phrase refers to the beginning of the creation of the world, and of people.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in the beginning

at the beginning of the world

In some languages, it will be natural to put this phrase after the phrase “the Creator.” For example:

he who created them from the beginning (ESV)

the Creator: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the Creator is more literally “the creating one.” It is a title for God.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

he who created them (ESV)

God (NLT)

made them male and female: The pronoun them refers to Adam and Eve, the first man and the first woman.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

made a man and a woman (CEV)

when God created humans, he created a man and a woman

This clause is a quote from Gen 1:27. You may want to follow the example of some English versions and put the reference in a footnote. You may also want to show it is a quote by putting it in quotation marks. For example:

the Creator ‘made them male and female,’ (NIV)

Matthew 19:5

Section 19:1–12: Jesus taught about divorce and marriage

In this section, Jesus led his disciples out of Galilee and passed through the land of Perea on his way to Jerusalem. While in Perea, some Pharisees came to him and asked him a question about divorce. They hoped that he would say something that they thought was wrong so that they could shame him. But Jesus taught about divorce based on Scripture. (This section has more information about divorce than 5:31–32.)

Jesus also taught that believers may choose not to marry so that they can fully devote themselves to serving God. Jesus and Paul are examples of this way of living.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Teaching about divorce

Concerning divorce and not marrying

A Discussion About Divorce and Celibacy (GW)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 10:1–12 and Luke 16:18.

19:5

Many English versions put this verse in single quotes to show that Jesus was quoting from the Old Testament. It is from Genesis 2:24. You also may want to use single quotes and add a footnote with the reference.

19:5a

and said, ‘For this reason a man will leave his father and mother

- and he said, ‘For this reason, a man will leave his father and mother
- And God said, ‘So a man will leave his father and mother (NCV)

and said: This verse continues from 19:4, so the subject of the verb said is “the Creator.” Use the correct grammar in your language to show that “the Creator” spoke the following words. For example:

and he said

and God, the Creator said

For this reason: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as For this reason is more literally “On account of this.” This phrase introduces a conclusion based on something said just before.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Therefore (ESV)

That is why (NJB)

a man will leave his father and mother: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as will leave is future. It describes a universal truth. (It is not a command.) It means that the man who intends to marry a woman “will leave behind” his strong connection to his parents. He will change his primary relationship from a child-parent relationship to a husband-wife relationship.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

a man shall leave his father and his mother (ESV)

a man leaves his father and mother (CEV)

19:5b

and be united to his wife,

- and unite together with his wife,
- and join together with his wife,

and be united to his wife: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as be united to is more literally “stick” or “bind.” It indicates that the man separates himself from his parents and then joins himself to his wife. It

is also in the future tense and describes a universal truth.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

unite with his wife (GNT)

is joined to his wife (NLT)

will attach to his wife

19:5c

and the two will become one flesh’?

- and the two of them will become united as one body/person’
- and the two will become one body.’ (NCV)

the two: This phrase refers to the man and woman who come together in marriage.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the two of them

the man and the woman

will become one flesh: The Greek word that the BSB translates as flesh refers to the physical body. This is a description of sexual relations between the man and the woman. It also indicates that the intimate relationship that the man and woman have is different from the relationship that they had with their parents.

The Greek verb that the BSB translates as will become is also future, as the two previous verbs. It indicates a universal truth about marriage.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

will become one body

This clause is figurative language. The picture of two separate people becoming one flesh is a picture of the most intimate relationship possible between two people. You should translate this as close to the original as you can. However, you may also use a simile. For example:

He becomes like one person with his wife (CEV)

they become like one body

Matthew 19:6

Section 19:1–12: Jesus taught about divorce and marriage

In this section, Jesus led his disciples out of Galilee and passed through the land of Perea on his way to Jerusalem. While in Perea, some Pharisees came to him and asked him a question about divorce. They hoped that he would say something that they thought was wrong so that they could shame him. But Jesus taught about divorce based on Scripture. (This section has more information about divorce than 5:31–32.)

Jesus also taught that believers may choose not to marry so that they can fully devote themselves to serving God. Jesus and Paul are examples of this way of living.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Teaching about divorce

Concerning divorce and not marrying

A Discussion About Divorce and Celibacy (GW)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 10:1–12 and Luke 16:18.

19:6a

So they are no longer two, but one flesh.

- So they are no longer two people but united as one body/person.
- Therefore, now the man and his wife are not two separate people. They are one.

So: The Greek word that the BSB translates as So indicates that what follows is the logical result of what was said just before it.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Therefore

That is why

they are no longer two: The pronoun they refers to a man and woman who have joined together in marriage. As at 19:5c, here is another way to translate the word two:

two people

but one flesh: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but occurs when a pair of clauses is related, and the first clause contains the word “not” or “no.” In some languages, it is not necessary to translate this conjunction. For example:

they are one flesh (REB)

one flesh: The phrase one flesh is the same phrase as in 19:5c. You may translate it in the same way here. For example:

one body

one person

like one body

In some languages, it may not be necessary to repeat the word for flesh. For example:

but one (NIV)

19:6b

Therefore what God has joined together, let man not separate.”

- Therefore the people whom God has joined together, no one should separate them.”
- For this reason, no one should cause to divorce a man and a woman whom God has joined together.”

Therefore what: The BSB has not translated the two Greek words Therefore what in the same order as they are in Greek. In some languages, it will be more natural to follow the Greek order. For example:

What therefore (ESV)

Therefore: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Therefore indicates that what follows is the conclusion of what came just before it. It marks the big idea that Jesus wanted his hearers to understand.

Here is another way to translate this word:

So then (NJB)

what: The Greek word that the BSB translates as what can also be translated as “that which” or “the people whom.” It refers to the man and his wife. Here, this word is not a question word.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

the people whom

a couple that (CEV)

God has joined together: The verb joined together means “put together into a single unit.” It is related to the word for a bar (called a yoke) that joins two cows into a single unit to pull a plow or cart.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

God has yoked/united together

God has put/connected together

God has made into one

let man not separate: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as separate means to divide something into at least two portions. It refers to divorce. This is a command about what not to do.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

no one should separate

let no one split apart (NLT)

no one should cause them to divorce

man: The word man is a general word for “human being.” For example:

human being (GNT)

person

Matthew 19:7

Section 19:1–12: Jesus taught about divorce and marriage

In this section, Jesus led his disciples out of Galilee and passed through the land of Perea on his way to Jerusalem. While in Perea, some Pharisees came to him and asked him a question about divorce. They hoped that he would say something that they thought was wrong so that they could shame him. But Jesus taught about divorce based on Scripture. (This section has more information about divorce than 5:31–32.)

Jesus also taught that believers may choose not to marry so that they can fully devote themselves to serving God. Jesus and Paul are examples of this way of living.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Teaching about divorce

Concerning divorce and not marrying

A Discussion About Divorce and Celibacy (GW)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 10:1–12 and Luke 16:18.

19:7a

“Why then,” they asked, “did Moses order a man

- They asked him, “Then why did Moses command a man
- Then the Pharisees asked Jesus, “If that is so, then why did Moses command a man

Why then: The BSB has translated the two Greek words *Why then* in the same order as they are in Greek. In some languages, it will be more natural to change the order. For example:

Then why (JBP)

Why...did Moses order a man: In Greek, this question does not include the phrase *a man*. In other words, the verb order has no object. Some English versions, like the BSB, add the words *a man* because it is natural in English to have an object.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Why...did Moses command us (NET)

Why...did Moses command one (ESV)

Here the Pharisees referred to a portion of the law in Deuteronomy 24:1–4. They did not quote this passage. Instead they gave a sort of summary statement.

they asked: The pronoun *they* refers to the Pharisees who asked Jesus a question in 19:3. The Greek has the pronoun “him” as well, which refers to Jesus. In some languages, it will be natural to make this explicit.

The verb *asked* can also be translated as “said” since it introduces a question.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the Pharisees said to him

the Pharisees asked Jesus

19:7b

to give his wife a certificate of divorce and send her away?”

- to give his wife a letter of divorce and to send her away?”
- to give a paper of divorce to his wife and to divorce her?”

to give his wife: Here the Greek does not add any words to the word give. But in many languages, it will be more natural to add a phrase like “his wife” as the BSB has done. For example:

give his wife (NIV)

a certificate of divorce: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as a certificate of divorce refers to a legal paper. This paper recorded the separation of the man and woman from their marriage. It also included the reason for the separation and the statement that the woman was free to remarry.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

a letter/paper of divorce

a writing that they are divorced

This phrase also occurs in 5:31b. You should translate it the same way in both places.

and send her away: The Greek verb that the BSB here translates as send...away is the same verb that it translates as “divorce” in 19:8a. It can mean both “dismiss” and “release.” When the man gave his wife a divorce paper, he both ended the marriage and released the woman to marry again.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

and end the marriage

to divorce her (GW)

Actually, the passage in Deuteronomy does not command the giving of a certificate of divorce. It does not

command a man to send away his wife. But that is how the Pharisees describe it.

Matthew 19:8

Section 19:1–12: Jesus taught about divorce and marriage

In this section, Jesus led his disciples out of Galilee and passed through the land of Perea on his way to Jerusalem. While in Perea, some Pharisees came to him and asked him a question about divorce. They hoped that he would say something that they thought was wrong so that they could shame him. But Jesus taught about divorce based on Scripture. (This section has more information about divorce than 5:31–32.)

Jesus also taught that believers may choose not to marry so that they can fully devote themselves to serving God. Jesus and Paul are examples of this way of living.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Teaching about divorce

Concerning divorce and not marrying

A Discussion About Divorce and Celibacy (GW)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 10:1–12 and Luke 16:18.

19:8a–b

In the Greek, the reason (“your hardness of heart”) comes before the result (“Moses permitted you to divorce your wives”). In some languages, it will be more natural to change the order and put the reason after the result, as the BSB does. In other languages, it will be more natural to follow the Greek and put the reason first. For example:

^{8b}Because of your hardness of heart ^{8a}Moses allowed you to divorce your wives (ESV)

In other languages, it will be more natural to say something like:

You hearts were hard. That is why Moses permitted you to divorce your wives.

19:8a

Jesus replied, “Moses permitted you to divorce your wives

- Jesus said, “Moses permitted you^(plur) to divorce your wives
- Jesus said, “Moses gave you^(plur) permission in the law to divorce your wives.

Moses permitted you: Here the word Moses refers to the law which Moses received from God and wrote down long ago. In some languages, it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

In the law, Moses allowed/permitted you

to divorce your wives: The Greek word that the BSB here translates as divorce is the same word that it translates as “send away” in 19:7b. It means to break the bond of marriage.

19:8b because of your hardness of heart;

- because you are stubborn.
- He did that because you always refuse to obey God.

because of: The words because of indicate that 19:8b is a reason clause.

Here are some other ways to introduce this reason clause:

It was on account of

It was because of

your hardness of heart: The Greek word that the BSB translates as hardness of heart is an idiom. This idiom refers to a person’s sinful attitude. For Jews in Jesus’ time, the heart was the place where emotions were experienced. The expression “hard heart” indicates that the person cannot respond to God as he should. It indicates stubbornness and disobedience.

If you have this same idiom in your language, or if this idiom would be understandable in your language as is, then use it. Otherwise, if you have a similar idiom for stubbornness and disobedience, then you may consider using that.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

you were stubborn

you refused to accept God’s teaching (NCV)

you always refuse to obey God

19:8c but it was not this way from the beginning.

- But it was not like that at the beginning.
- But in the beginning of the world, God did not permit divorce.

but it was not this way: The pronoun it refers to the permission for divorce. The whole clause means that the permission for divorce was added after God created people, because of sin. It was not the way God intended things to be.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

it was not so (ESV)

it was not like that (GNT)

divorce was not allowed (NCV)

from the beginning: This phrase refers to “the beginning of the world” or “the beginning of creation.” It refers to the words that Jesus said in 19:4b. There he talked about the creation of man and woman in “the beginning.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

at the time of creation (GNT)

in the beginning of the world

at first

Matthew 19:9

Section 19:1–12: Jesus taught about divorce and marriage

In this section, Jesus led his disciples out of Galilee and passed through the land of Perea on his way to Jerusalem. While in Perea, some Pharisees came to him and asked him a question about divorce. They hoped that he would say something that they thought was wrong so that they could shame him. But Jesus taught about divorce based on Scripture. (This section has more information about divorce than 5:31–32.)

Jesus also taught that believers may choose not to marry so that they can fully devote themselves to serving God. Jesus and Paul are examples of this way of living.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Teaching about divorce

Concerning divorce and not marrying

A Discussion About Divorce and Celibacy (GW)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 10:1–12 and Luke 16:18.

19:9a

Now I tell you that whoever divorces his wife, except for sexual immorality,

- I tell you^(plur) that any man who divorces his wife but it is not because of adultery,
- I tell you^(plur) this: if a man's wife has not done sexual sin, and yet he divorces her

Now I tell you: The clause Now I tell you last occurred at 17:12a. Translate it here as you did there.

whoever divorces his wife: In this context, the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as whoever refers only to men.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

any man who divorces his wife (GNT)

anyone who divorces his wife (NIV)

except for sexual immorality: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as except for sexual immorality indicates that the only acceptable reason for divorce is sexual immorality.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

except for marital unfaithfulness (NIV)

for any cause other than her unfaithfulness (GNT)

and she has not committed adultery

and it was not because of adultery

In some languages, it will be more natural to put this clause at the end of 19:9. See the reordered example in the Display.

sexual immorality: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sexual immorality is a general term. It refers to any unacceptable form of sexual relations.

Here Jesus used this word to refer to sexual relations outside of marriage.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

adultery

sexual relations with another man (NCV)

19:9b

and marries another woman, commits adultery.”

- and he marries another woman, he commits adultery.”
- and marries someone else, he has become an adulterer.”

and marries another woman: The subject of the verb marries is the same as the subject of “divorces” in 19:9a. It is “any man.” So the phrase another woman refers to “any other woman.”

commits adultery: The Greek word that the BSB translates as commits adultery refers to the act of sexual relations with someone who is not your spouse. In the law of Moses, adultery was strictly forbidden.

General Comment on 19:9

The KJV follows some Greek manuscripts that add a phrase to this verse, probably to make it similar to 5:32. This phrase could be translated as “and whoever marries the woman who was divorced commits adultery.” Most English versions do not follow these manuscripts and add this phrase. It is recommended that you do not include it either.

19:9a–b

(reordered) (NCV:) I tell you that anyone who divorces his wife and marries another woman is guilty of adultery. The only reason for a man to divorce his wife is if his wife has sexual relations with another man.

Matthew 19:10

Section 19:1–12: Jesus taught about divorce and marriage

In this section, Jesus led his disciples out of Galilee and passed through the land of Perea on his way to Jerusalem. While in Perea, some Pharisees came to him and asked him a question about divorce. They hoped that he would say something that they thought was wrong so that they could shame him. But Jesus taught about divorce based on Scripture. (This section has more information about divorce than 5:31–32.)

Jesus also taught that believers may choose not to marry so that they can fully devote themselves to serving God. Jesus and Paul are examples of this way of living.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Teaching about divorce

Concerning divorce and not marrying

A Discussion About Divorce and Celibacy (GW)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 10:1-12 and Luke 16:18.

19:10a

His disciples said to Him, “If this is the case between a man and his wife,

- ¶ The disciples said to him, “If that is the only reason a man can divorce his wife,
- ¶ Then Jesus’s disciples said to him, “If a man can divorce his wife only for adultery,

His disciples: There is a textual issue here:

1. Some Greek manuscripts have the disciples here. For example:

The disciples (RSV) (NIV, ESV, NASB, RSV, CEV, GW, NET, REB, NCV, NJB)

1. Some Greek manuscripts have his disciples here. The UBS Greek New Testament gives the pronoun “his” a C rating indicating its uncertainty in the text. For example:

His disciples (GNT) (BSB, KJV, NRSV, NLT, GNT, JBP)

The majority of English versions follow the Greek texts that have “the disciples.” However, here you should do what is most natural in your language. In some languages, it is more natural to say “his disciples” or “Jesus’ disciples.”

For help in translating the word disciples, see the note at 5:1c.

If this is the case between a man and his wife:

This clause refers to Jesus’s teaching that a man can divorce his wife and remarry only if his wife has committed adultery.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

If that is the only reason a man can divorce his wife (NCV)

If a man can divorce his wife only for adultery

If this is the case (NLT)

If that is the way it is

19:10b

it is better not to marry.”

- it is better not/never to get married!”
- then it is better/good not to marry!”

it is better not to marry: The disciples thought that if a man could not divorce his wife (unless she committed adultery), it was better for him not to get married at all. They thought that it was better not to get married than to be stuck in an unhappy marriage.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

it is better not to get married

it is better that/if a man does not get married

Matthew 19:11

Section 19:1-12: Jesus taught about divorce and marriage

In this section, Jesus led his disciples out of Galilee and passed through the land of Perea on his way to Jerusalem. While in Perea, some Pharisees came to him and asked him a question about divorce. They hoped that he would say something that they thought was wrong so that they could shame him. But Jesus taught about divorce based on Scripture. (This section has more information about divorce than 5:31-32.)

Jesus also taught that believers may choose not to marry so that they can fully devote themselves to serving God. Jesus and Paul are examples of this way of living.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Teaching about divorce

Concerning divorce and not marrying

A Discussion About Divorce and Celibacy (GW)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 10:1–12 and Luke 16:18.

19:11a

“Not everyone can accept this word,” He replied,

- He said to them, “Not everyone can accept those/your words.
- Jesus said, “Not all people will agree with what you said.

Not everyone can accept this word: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as this word can also be translated as “this saying” (as in the ESV). There are two ways to interpret this phrase:

1. It refers to what the disciples said in 19:10b. (It is better not to get married.) For example:

Not everyone can do what you suggest. (GW) (BSB, GW, REB and many commentaries) Some commentators that follow this interpretation are: France (page 723); Blomberg (page 294); Hagner (550); Osborne (706); Carson (page 419); and Wilkins (page 645). For example, France (page 723) says, “But it is more likely that “this saying” refers not to Jesus’ own teaching but to the more immediate antecedent, the comment which the disciples have just made. In that case Jesus is here taking quite seriously what was probably intended by them as an ironical comment: celibacy is a real option, but it is not for everyone. I prefer this interpretation for two reasons. Firstly, for Jesus now to concede that the teaching he has given in vv. 4–9 is unworkable for some people would be a surprising climbdown from the absolute standard which he has so far insisted on maintaining against all current practice; to accept that for some the expectation of life-long marriage is “not given” would undermine what he has just been arguing. Secondly, the equally cryptic verse which follows, and which is linked to v. 11 by an explanatory “for,” talks not about divorce but apparently about celibacy. In that case the discussion of divorce has finished, and the disciples’ interjection has changed the agenda by raising (even if in their view facetiously) the option of voluntary celibacy.”)

1. It refers to Jesus’ teaching about divorce in 19:3–9. For example:

It is not everyone who can accept what I have said (NJB) (GNT, NRSV, NJB, CEV, NCV)

Many English versions are ambiguous and it is not possible to tell which interpretation they follow.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Verse 19:12 is clearly about people who do not get married. It is likely that here in 19:11, Jesus was referring to what the disciples said about not getting married (in 19:10b). In other words, the topic of discussion in this paragraph has changed from divorce to not getting married. Also, it seems unlikely that Jesus would have said that his teaching about divorce was not for everyone. Also, the Greek word that the BSB translates as this most often points to something in the immediate context (such as v. 10) rather than further away (such as in vv. 3–9).

Here are some other ways to translate this entire clause:

Not everyone can accept these/your words

Everyone will not agree with what you said

Not everyone will accept remaining unmarried

He replied: This clause begins with a Greek conjunction that is often translated as “But.” This conjunction here simply indicates a change from one speaker to another. In this context, it does not indicate a contrast. Many English versions, like the BSB, do not translate this word. In many languages, it will not be necessary to translate this word either.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

He said to them

Jesus said

19:11b

“but only those to whom it has been given.

- Only the people who have been given that ability/strength can accept them.
- The people who will agree are those to whom God gives the ability/strength not to get married.

but only: The Greek conjunction that the BSB here translates as but only occurs when a pair of clauses is related, and the first clause (19:11a) contains the word “not.” In some languages, it will be better to introduce 19:11b with another conjunction, or with no conjunction at all. For example:

except (NET)

^{11a}Not everyone can do what you suggest. ^{11b}Only those who have that gift can. (GW)

those to whom it has been given: The word it refers to the ability that God gives to some people not to marry

This clause is passive. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

those who have been given the ability not to marry

- Use an active verb. For example:

the people who can accept it are those to whom God has given the ability/strength

people to whom God has given the strength not to marry

Matthew 19:12

Section 19:1–12: Jesus taught about divorce and marriage

In this section, Jesus led his disciples out of Galilee and passed through the land of Perea on his way to Jerusalem. While in Perea, some Pharisees came to him and asked him a question about divorce. They hoped that he would say something that they thought was wrong so that they could shame him. But Jesus taught about divorce based on Scripture. (This section has more information about divorce than 5:31–32.)

Jesus also taught that believers may choose not to marry so that they can fully devote themselves to serving God. Jesus and Paul are examples of this way of living.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Teaching about divorce

Concerning divorce and not marrying

A Discussion About Divorce and Celibacy (GW)

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 10:1–12 and Luke 16:18.

19:12a

For there are eunuchs who were born that way;

- I say this because some men are born as eunuchs.
- Because there are different reasons why men do not marry. Some are not able to marry because they were born that way.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For introduces Jesus' explanation for what he said in 19:11.

Here are some other ways to introduce this explanation:

I say this because

Because there are different reasons why men do not marry: such as

For example (GW)

there are eunuchs: The Greek word that the BSB translates as eunuchs refers to men who do not have certain male body parts. Those body parts enable a man to have sexual relations with a woman. If you have a word or phrase for a person like this, use it here. If not, you may have to describe such a person. For example:

there are men who cannot have sexual relations with a woman

Some people are unable to marry (CEV)

Some men are unable to be with a woman

who were born that way: This phrase means that the reason why a man cannot have sexual relations with a woman is because he was born unable to.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

because of birth defects (CEV)

because they were born that way (GW)

19:12b

others were made that way by men;

- Others are eunuchs because men made them that way.
- Some do not marry because men have castrated them.

were made that way by men: In Jesus' time, some men had their male body parts cut off by others to make them eunuchs. This was often done by a ruler who wanted men who were "safe" to take care of his wives.

This clause is passive. Here are some ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

because they were castrated (GW)

- Use an active verb. For example:

because men made them that way (GNT)

If people in your area will not understand why some men were made eunuchs, you may want to include a footnote. A sample footnote is:

In some non-Jewish cultures of that time, a king might choose a man and then have one of his servants remove the man's testicles. That made him a eunuch. The king would appoint such a man to take care of his wives.

19:12c and still others live like eunuchs for the sake of the kingdom of heaven.

- Others have decided that they will not marry because they want to give themselves to serving the kingdom of heaven/God.
- Other men have decided that they will not marry in order to serve God more.

still others live like eunuchs: This clause is figurative language. It refers to men who chose not to marry or to not have sexual relations with a woman. It does not mean that men have castrated themselves.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

some men have renounced marriage

some men have given up marriage (NCV)

others have decided to be celibate (GW)

for the sake of the kingdom of heaven: This phrase means "because of the kingdom of heaven" or "because they want to work for the kingdom of heaven/God." Some men renounce marriage in order to be better committed to work for God and his kingdom.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

because they want to give themselves to work for God's kingdom

because they want to better serve God as their king

in order to serve God better (CEV)

See kingdom of heaven in KBT 1 (d) for more information.

19:12d

The one who can accept this should accept it."

- The one who is able to accept this way of life should accept it."
- The man who is able to live without being married should do so."

The one who can accept this should accept it: The Greek word that the BSB translates as The one is masculine. It refers to a man. The words this and it refer to the decision not to marry. The Greek word translated as accept is the same word as in 19:11a.

God gives the ability not to marry to only some people. So these people are encouraged to follow that way of life.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

The person who is able to agree to this way of life should live that way.

The man who can accept this way of life should accept it.

If anyone can do what you've suggested, then he should do it. (GW)

The man who is able to follow this should follow it.

Matthew 19:13

Section 19:13–15: Jesus blessed little children

In this section, some people brought their children to Jesus to bless them. The disciples probably thought that Jesus was too important a person to spend time doing that. So they prevented the people from bringing their children. But Jesus wanted to bless the children.

Jesus used this event to teach the disciples more about the kingdom of heaven. The people whom God rules should be like little children: they should humbly accept God's rule in their lives.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Jesus and Little Children (NET)

Jesus blesses some children

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 10:13–16 and Luke 18:15–17.

19:13a

Then the little children were brought to Jesus

- ¶ After that, young children were brought to Jesus
- ¶ One day, some people/parents brought their little children to Jesus.

Then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Then indicates that the next event in the story is about to happen. It does not necessarily mean immediately after.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

One day (GNT)

After that

the little children were brought to Jesus: This clause is passive. Most likely it was the parents who brought their children to Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Use a passive verb, as in the BSB.
- Use an active verb. For example:

Some people brought children to Jesus (GNT)

some parents brought their children to Jesus

little children: The Greek word that the BSB translates as little children refers to young boys or girls. In this context, it refers to children who were old enough to stand and walk.

Here is another way to translate this word:

children (ESV)

This same Greek word occurs in 19:14a. There, the BSB translates it as “little children.”

19:13b

for Him to place His hands on them and pray for them.

- so that he would put his hands on them and pray for them.
- They wanted him to put his hands on them and ask God to bless them.

for Him to place His hands on them and pray for them:

In the time of Jesus, parents commonly took their children to rabbis and elders to receive a blessing. The rabbis and elders blessed the children by placing their hands on them and praying for them. They probably placed their hands on the children's heads.

Here the word pray refers to praying to God to bless the children. It was not a general prayer to God.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

so that he could place his hands on them and pray for them (CEV)

They wanted him to put his hands on them and ask God to bless them.

19:13c

And the disciples rebuked those who brought them.

- But the disciples scolded the people who brought them.
- But Jesus' disciples told them not to bring them.

There is a contrast here. The parents wanted Jesus to bless their children. But the disciples did not want them to bother Jesus. Some versions indicate this contrast with the conjunction “But.” For example:

But the disciples rebuked those who brought them. (NIV)

And the disciples: This is probably a reference to the twelve disciples whom Jesus had chosen.

For help in translating the word disciples, see the note at 5:1c.

rebuked those who brought them: The Greek word that the BSB translates as rebuked also means “scolded.” The disciples scolded the parents and wanted to stop them from bringing their children.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

scolded the people (GNT)

told them to stop (NCV)

told the people to stop bothering him (CEV)

This verb also occurs in 16:22a.

Matthew 19:14

Section 19:13–15: Jesus blessed little children

In this section, some people brought their children to Jesus to bless them. The disciples probably thought that Jesus was too important a person to spend time doing that. So they prevented the people from bringing their children. But Jesus wanted to bless the children.

Jesus used this event to teach the disciples more about the kingdom of heaven. The people whom God rules should be like little children: they should humbly accept God’s rule in their lives.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Jesus and Little Children (NET)

Jesus blesses some children

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 10:13–16 and Luke 18:15–17.

19:14a

But Jesus said, “Let the little children come to Me,

- But Jesus said, “Permit^(plur) the young children to come to me.
- At that Jesus said, “You^(plur) should allow the little children to come to me.

But Jesus said: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between the desire of the disciples to keep the children away (19:13c), and the desire of Jesus to bless the children (19:14). The BSB indicates this contrast with the conjunction But.

Let the little children come to Me: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as Let means “allow” or “permit.” Jesus instructed the disciples to allow the children to come to him.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Allow the little children to come to me

You should permit the little children to come to me

the little children: The Greek word that the BSB here translates as little children also occurs in 19:13a. You should translate it the same way in both places.

19:14b

and do not hinder them!

- Do not stop them,
- Do not forbid them.

do not hinder them: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as hinder also means “prevent” or “forbid.” This also is an instruction to the disciples. They were not to do anything to prevent the children from coming to Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

do not stop them (GNT)

do not forbid their coming to me

them: This pronoun refers to the children.

19:14c

For the kingdom of heaven belongs to such as these.”

- because the kingdom of heaven belongs to people who are like these children.”
- People like these children are part/people of God’s kingdom.”
- God accepts people like these children as the people whom he rules over.”

For: This conjunction introduces the reason for Jesus’ command not to hinder the children from coming to him.

Here is another way to translate this word:

because

In some languages, it will be more natural to begin a new sentence without translating this word. For example:

People who are like these children belong to God's kingdom. (CEV)

the kingdom of heaven belongs: Jesus was saying that people like those children are the ones who are a part of the kingdom. They belong in it, and it belongs to them. These people are those who let God rule over them.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

are part of the kingdom of God (GW)

belong to God's kingdom (CEV)

God accepts them into his kingdom

are citizens of the kingdom of God

This same Greek phrase occurs in 5:3b and 5:10b.

to such as these: This phrase refers to people who are like the children who wanted to come to him.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

to people who are like these children (NCV)

to people like this

Matthew 19:15

Section 19:13–15: Jesus blessed little children

In this section, some people brought their children to Jesus to bless them. The disciples probably thought that Jesus was too important a person to spend time doing that. So they prevented the people from bringing their children. But Jesus wanted to bless the children.

Jesus used this event to teach the disciples more about the kingdom of heaven. The people whom God rules should be like little children: they should humbly accept God's rule in their lives.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

Jesus and Little Children (NET)

Jesus blesses some children

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 10:13–16 and Luke 18:15–17.

19:15a

And after He had placed His hands on them,

- He put his hands on them and prayed for them,
- Then he put his hands on them and asked God to bless them.

He had placed His hands on them: This is the same idea as in 19:13b. Jesus did what the parents wanted him to do. He put his hands on the children. It is implied that he prayed a prayer of blessing for them.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he put his hands on them and prayed for them

he placed his hands on their heads and blessed them (NLT)

Jesus blessed them (GW)

19:15b

He went on from there.

- and then he left that place.
- Then he left there.

He went on from there: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as went on from there is more literally "went away from there."

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

and went on his way (NJB)

he left there (NCV)

Matthew 19:16

Section 19:16–30: Jesus taught about entering the kingdom of heaven

In this section, a young man asked Jesus what he must do to get eternal life. Jesus gave him a standard answer, which was to obey God's commands.

The young man apparently felt that this was not enough and asked what else he should do (19:20). Then Jesus told him to sell his possessions, give the money to the poor, and follow him. The young man was rich, and he was not willing to sell his things. So he left.

Jesus then used the rich young man as an example. He explained that riches make it difficult to enter the kingdom (19:23–24). The saying of a camel going through the eye of a needle was probably a well-known proverb about something impossible to do. Without God making it possible, neither a rich person nor anyone else is able to enter the kingdom (19:26).

Jesus also gave a promise that those whom he asked to leave their possessions and family behind to serve him would receive great rewards (19:29).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Rich Young Man (NIV)

A rich young man's questions

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 10:17–31 and Luke 18:18–30.

19:16a

Just then a man came up to Jesus and inquired,

- ¶ Just then, a certain man came to Jesus and asked him,
- ¶ Then a young man approached Jesus and said,

Just then: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Just then literally means “look” or “see.” This word brings attention to the words that follow. If you have an expression in your language that someone uses when he wants to bring attention to something that he is about to say, you should use it here.

Here are some other ways to translate this word in its context:

And behold (ESV)

Then it happened that (JBP)

Many English versions do not translate this word here.

a man: The Greek word that the BSB translates as a man is more literally the word “one” (as in the RSV). In 19:22, Matthew called him a “young man.” So here most English versions translate it as a man.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

a certain man

a young man

came up to Jesus: At the end of 19:15, Jesus began to travel. So the clause came up to Jesus probably means that the man met Jesus along the way.

This sentence starts a new section. So in some languages, it will be natural to mention the name of Jesus again. For example:

approached Jesus

19:16b

“Teacher, what good thing must I do to obtain eternal life?”

- “Teacher, what good work must I do to get life that never ends?”
- “Master, what good thing should I do so that I can live forever in the kingdom of heaven?”

Teacher: Here, the word Teacher refers to a religious teacher. It was a polite title for a Jewish man who had authority to teach the things about God. Use a title that is an appropriate way to address a religious teacher in your culture. It should not refer only to a school teacher. There is a textual issue here. Some Greek manuscripts add a word that means “good.” Only the KJV follows these manuscripts. It is recommended that you follow the majority of English versions and translate only “teacher.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Sir

Master

what good thing must I do: The Greek word that the BSB translates as good thing is more literally just the adjective “good.” In this context it refers to deeds/activities that God considers good.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

what good must I do (REB)

I must do which good work

to obtain: The Greek word that the BSB translates as obtain means “have, obtain, possess.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

to possess (NJB)

to gain (REB)

to get (NIV)

eternal life: The word eternal refers to something that does not end. The phrase eternal life refers to life in God's kingdom. This life continues forever.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

unending life

life that never ends

In some languages, it may be best to translate life as a verb. For example:

to live eternally/forever

so that God will cause me to live forever

Matthew 19:17

Section 19:16–30: Jesus taught about entering the kingdom of heaven

In this section, a young man asked Jesus what he must do to get eternal life. Jesus gave him a standard answer, which was to obey God's commands.

The young man apparently felt that this was not enough and asked what else he should do (19:20). Then Jesus told him to sell his possessions, give the money to the poor, and follow him. The young man was rich, and he was not willing to sell his things. So he left.

Jesus then used the rich young man as an example. He explained that riches make it difficult to enter the kingdom (19:23–24). The saying of a camel going through the eye of a needle was probably a well-known proverb about something impossible to do. Without God making it possible, neither a rich person nor anyone else is able to enter the kingdom (19:26).

Jesus also gave a promise that those whom he asked to leave their possessions and family behind to serve him would receive great rewards (19:29).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Rich Young Man (NIV)

A rich young man's questions

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 10:17–31 and Luke 18:18–30.

19:17a

“Why do you ask Me about what is good?” Jesus replied.

- Jesus said to him, “Why do you^(sing) ask me about the good thing to do?
- Jesus answered, “You should not ask me about what is the good thing/deed to do.

Why do you ask Me about what is good?: This is a rhetorical question. It is a rebuke. Jesus rebuked the man for asking him to define what is good, when God had already made that clear.

Here are some other ways to translate this rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Why do you ask me concerning what is good?
(GNT)

Why do you ask me about what is the good thing/
deed to do?

Why do you ask me about that? (REB)

- As a statement or command. For example:

You should not ask me about what is good.

Do not ask me about what is the good thing/deed
to do.

You should not ask me that question.

Translate this rebuke in a way that is natural in your language.

about what is good: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as about what is good is more literally “about the good.” This phrase refers to the “good deed/thing” that the young man asked about in 19:16b.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

about what is the good thing to do

concerning the good deed to do

19:17b

“There is only One who is good.

- There is only one person who is good.
- Only God is good.

There is only One who is good: This clause refers to God. He is the only one who is good.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

There is only one person who is good

God is the only one/being who is good

Only God is good (CEV)

19:17c

If you want to enter life, keep the commandments.”

- If you want God to give you eternal life, obey/follow the laws of God.”
- If you want to live in the kingdom of God, do what he commands.”

If you want to enter life: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as enter life means the same thing as “obtain eternal life” in 19:16b.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

If you want to receive eternal life (NLT)

if you want to have life forever (NCL)

If you want to live forever in God’s kingdom

keep the commandments: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as keep means “obey” or “follow.” The word commandments refers to the commands/laws that God gave to his people through Moses.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

obey the laws of God

you must do/follow what God commanded

Matthew 19:18

Section 19:16–30: Jesus taught about entering the kingdom of heaven

In this section, a young man asked Jesus what he must do to get eternal life. Jesus gave him a standard answer, which was to obey God’s commands.

The young man apparently felt that this was not enough and asked what else he should do (19:20). Then Jesus told him to sell his possessions, give the money to the poor, and follow him. The young man was rich, and he was not willing to sell his things. So he left.

Jesus then used the rich young man as an example. He explained that riches make it difficult to enter the kingdom (19:23–24). The saying of a camel going through the eye of a needle was probably a well-known proverb about something impossible to do. Without God making it possible, neither a rich person nor anyone else is able to enter the kingdom (19:26).

Jesus also gave a promise that those whom he asked to leave their possessions and family behind to serve him would receive great rewards (19:29).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Rich Young Man (NIV)

A rich young man’s questions

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 10:17–31 and Luke 18:18–30.

19:18a

“Which ones?” the man asked.

- He asked, “Which ones do I need to obey?”
- The young man said, “Which of the/his commands should I do/keep?”

Which ones?: Some words are implied but not repeated here. The complete question would be:

Which commandments should I keep?

The Jews of that time counted 613 commandments in the five books of Moses. The young man’s question was about which of those commandments he was required to keep.

Here is another way to translate this question:

Which? (RSV)

Which commands? (NCV)

19:18b–19a

These commands are a quote from the Old Testament (either Exodus 20:12–16 or Deuteronomy 5:16–20). (But they are not in the same order as in those passages.)

You may want to add a footnote with these references in your translation.

In Greek, these commands are singular. But it is a command to each person. In some languages, it may be more natural to use a plural or another form. For example:

You^(plur) must not murder

A person must not murder

19:18b

Jesus answered, “Do not murder, do not commit adultery,

- Jesus answered, “Do^(sing) not murder, do not do adultery,
- Jesus told him, “Do^(sing) not kill someone on purpose. Do not have sexual relations with someone who is not your wife.

Do not murder: The Greek word that the BSB translates as murder means “kill illegally and on purpose.”

This verb, and the next three, are in the future tense. But together with the word not they form negative commands.

Here are some other ways to translate this commandment:

You shall not kill (RSV)

Do not commit murder (GNT)

This word also occurs in 5:21b and 15:19b.

do not commit adultery: The Greek word that the BSB translates as adultery means “have sexual relations with a woman who is married to another man.”

Here are some other ways to translate this commandment:

Do not have sexual relations with another man’s wife

Do not take another man’s wife to bed with you

Do not sleep with a married woman

See how you translated this word in 5:27b and 15:19c.

19:18c

do not steal, do not bear false witness,

- do^(sing) not steal, do not lie about someone,
- Do^(sing) not take what does not belong to you. Do not say in court what is not true concerning your neighbor.

do not steal: The Greek word that the BSB translates as steal means “secretly take the property of someone else without permission.”

Here is another way to translate this commandment:

do not take what is not yours

See how you translated this word in 6:19c and 15:19d.

do not bear false witness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as bear false witness means “testify something about a person which is not true.”

Here are some other ways to translate this command:

you must not tell lies about your neighbor (NCV)

do not accuse anyone falsely (GNT)

See how you translated this word in 15:19d.

Matthew 19:19

Section 19:16–30: Jesus taught about entering the kingdom of heaven

In this section, a young man asked Jesus what he must do to get eternal life. Jesus gave him a standard answer, which was to obey God’s commands.

The young man apparently felt that this was not enough and asked what else he should do (19:20). Then Jesus told him to sell his possessions, give the money to the poor, and follow him. The young man was rich, and he was not willing to sell his things. So he left.

Jesus then used the rich young man as an example. He explained that riches make it difficult to enter the kingdom (19:23–24). The saying of a camel going through the eye of a needle was probably a well-known proverb about something impossible to do. Without God making it possible, neither a rich person nor anyone else is able to enter the kingdom (19:26).

Jesus also gave a promise that those whom he asked to leave their possessions and family behind to serve him would receive great rewards (19:29).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Rich Young Man (NIV)

A rich young man's questions

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 10:17–31 and Luke 18:18–30.

19:19a**honor your father and mother,**

- respect your^(sing) father and your mother,
- Do^(sing) and say what honors your parents.

honor your father and mother: The Greek word that the BSB translates as honor also means “respect.” This verb is a command like the previous four, but a positive one.

Here is another way to translate this command:

respect your father and your mother (GNT)

See how you translated this expression in 15:4a.

19:19b**and love your neighbor as yourself.”**

- and love^(sing) your neighbor in the same way that you love yourself.”
- Also, be as kind to the people around you^(sing) as you are kind to yourself.”

This part of the verse is a quote from a different part of the Old Testament (Leviticus 19:18). You may want to add a footnote with this reference in your translation.

love your neighbor: See how you translated this clause in 5:43b.

love: The word love in this context means to show kindness to another person and value him highly.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Care greatly for

Show great kindness toward

Treat very well

Be very concerned for

your neighbor: The Greek word that the BSB translates as neighbor originally referred to someone who lives nearby. In Leviticus it refers to a fellow Jew.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

your countryman/fellowman

the people around you

your companion

as yourself: The phrase means to love those around you in the same way that you love and care for your own self.

Here is another way to translate it:

as much as you love yourself (CEV)

Matthew 19:20**Section 19:16–30: Jesus taught about entering the kingdom of heaven**

In this section, a young man asked Jesus what he must do to get eternal life. Jesus gave him a standard answer, which was to obey God's commands.

The young man apparently felt that this was not enough and asked what else he should do (19:20). Then Jesus told him to sell his possessions, give the money to the poor, and follow him. The young man was rich, and he was not willing to sell his things. So he left.

Jesus then used the rich young man as an example. He explained that riches make it difficult to enter the kingdom (19:23–24). The saying of a camel going through the eye of a needle was probably a well-known proverb about something impossible to do. Without God making it possible, neither a rich person nor anyone else is able to enter the kingdom (19:26).

Jesus also gave a promise that those whom he asked to leave their possessions and family behind to serve him would receive great rewards (19:29).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Rich Young Man (NIV)

A rich young man's questions

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 10:17–31 and Luke 18:18–30.

19:20a**“All these I have kept,” said the young man.**

- The young man said to him, “I have obeyed all those laws.

- The young man said, “I have done/followed all these commands.

All these I have kept: Some later manuscripts added the words “from my youth” to the text. The UBS editors rejected this as not original with near certainty. As in 19:17c, the Greek verb that the BSB translates as kept means “obeyed” or “followed.” The context implies that the young man felt that he had always followed all these commandments.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I have obeyed all these commandments (GNT)

I have carefully followed all of those commands/
laws

the young man: The Greek word that the BSB translates as young man refers to a relatively young man. He was perhaps between the ages of 21 and 28. This is the same person who asked Jesus the question in 19:16a.

19:20b

“What do I still lack?”

- What is still missing in my life?” (JBP)
- What do I still need to do to have eternal life?”

What do I still lack?: The Greek word that the BSB translates as lack means “miss something that is to one’s benefit.” The young man asked what more he needed to do have eternal life (19:16).

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

What is still missing in my life? (JBP)

What more do I need to do? (NJB)

What else must I do? (CEV)

Matthew 19:21

Section 19:16–30: Jesus taught about entering the kingdom of heaven

In this section, a young man asked Jesus what he must do to get eternal life. Jesus gave him a standard answer, which was to obey God’s commands.

The young man apparently felt that this was not enough and asked what else he should do (19:20). Then Jesus told him to sell his possessions, give the money to the poor, and follow him. The young man was rich, and he was not willing to sell his things. So he left.

Jesus then used the rich young man as an example. He explained that riches make it difficult to enter the kingdom (19:23–24). The saying of a camel going through the eye of a needle was probably a well-known proverb about something impossible to do. Without God making it possible, neither a rich person nor anyone else is able to enter the kingdom (19:26).

Jesus also gave a promise that those whom he asked to leave their possessions and family behind to serve him would receive great rewards (19:29).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Rich Young Man (NIV)

A rich young man’s questions

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 10:17–31 and Luke 18:18–30.

19:21a

Jesus told him, “If you want to be perfect,

- Jesus said to him, “If you^(sing) want to be perfect/complete,
- Jesus answered, “If you want your life to be without fault,

If you want to be perfect: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as to be perfect also means “to be complete/whole/mature.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

If you want to be complete

If you want to lack nothing

If you want to have no faults

19:21b

go, sell your possessions and give to the poor,

- go and sell your possessions and give the money to poor people.
- go back and sell everything that you own and give the money to the people who are poor/needily.

go: This is a command. It does not specify where the young man should go. It just assumes that he will have to go to where he lives to take care of what Jesus told him to do. It is the opposite of the verb “come” at the end of the verse.

sell: The verb sell assumes that the young man would get money for his possessions.

your possessions: In Greek, this phrase is plural. It refers to everything that the young man owned.

Here are some other ways to translate it:

what you possess (ESV)

everything you own (CEV)

all your property (JBP)

and give to the poor: This clause implies that the young man should take the money he received for his possessions and give it to the poor. For example:

and give the money to the poor (NCV)

the poor: This phrase refers to people who are in poverty. They have little money and possessions.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

poor people

19:21c

and you will have treasure in heaven.

- If you do that, you will have wealth/riches in heaven.
- As a result, God will give you a reward in heaven.

and: In Greek, 19:21c is joined to the beginning of the verse with the common conjunction that the BSB frequently translates as and.

Here are some other ways to begin 19:21c:

If you do this (NCV)

As a result

you will have treasure in heaven: The Greek word that the BSB translates as treasure refers to something that is very valuable. The phrase treasure in heaven probably refers to rewards from God. (This same phrase occurs in 6:20a.) God will reward his people for “acts of righteousness” such as giving to the poor (6:2–4).

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Use the same word for treasures as in 6:19a. Such a word can be used to refer to figurative or spiritual treasures. For example:

you will have treasure/wealth in heaven

you will have riches in heaven (GNT)

- Use a word or expression that refers to spiritual treasures. For example:

you will have rewards in heaven for doing good

you will receive that which is worth much in heaven

19:21d

Then come, follow Me.”

- Then come and follow me.”
- Then come and be my follower/disciple.”

Then come, follow Me: Here, Jesus used the verb follow in a figurative sense. He meant that the young man should become his disciple.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

Then come and be my follower (CEV)

This figurative sense of the word follow first occurs in 4:19a. See the note there for more information.

Matthew 19:22

Section 19:16–30: Jesus taught about entering the kingdom of heaven

In this section, a young man asked Jesus what he must do to get eternal life. Jesus gave him a standard answer, which was to obey God’s commands.

The young man apparently felt that this was not enough and asked what else he should do (19:20). Then Jesus told him to sell his possessions, give the money to the poor, and follow him. The young man was rich, and he was not willing to sell his things. So he left.

Jesus then used the rich young man as an example. He explained that riches make it difficult to enter the kingdom (19:23–24). The saying of a camel going through the eye of a needle was probably a well-known proverb about something impossible to do. Without God making it possible, neither a rich person nor anyone else is able to enter the kingdom (19:26).

Jesus also gave a promise that those whom he asked to leave their possessions and family behind to serve him would receive great rewards (19:29).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Rich Young Man (NIV)

A rich young man's questions

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 10:17–31 and Luke 18:18–30.

19:22a

When the young man heard this, he went away in sorrow,

- When the young man heard this/that, he became very sad and left,
- When he heard these/those words, he left grieving.

When the young man heard this: The word this refers to Jesus' words in 19:21.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

When the young man heard these/those words

When he heard this/that

he went away in sorrow: The Greek word that the BSB translates as in sorrow refers to an ongoing, deep grieving.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he went away grieving (NASB)

he left and he was very sad

19:22b

because he had great wealth.

- because he was very rich.
- The reason was that he was very rich and didn't want to sell all that he owned.

because: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as because introduces the reason why the young man went away sad.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

for (ESV)

The reason was that

he had great wealth: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as great wealth refers to a large number of things that the young man owned. Possessions are things like money, land, houses, clothing, etc.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he had many possessions (NRSV)

he was very rich (GNT)

he owned many things

Matthew 19:23

Section 19:16–30: Jesus taught about entering the kingdom of heaven

In this section, a young man asked Jesus what he must do to get eternal life. Jesus gave him a standard answer, which was to obey God's commands.

The young man apparently felt that this was not enough and asked what else he should do (19:20). Then Jesus told him to sell his possessions, give the money to the poor, and follow him. The young man was rich, and he was not willing to sell his things. So he left.

Jesus then used the rich young man as an example. He explained that riches make it difficult to enter the kingdom (19:23–24). The saying of a camel going through the eye of a needle was probably a well-known proverb about something impossible to do. Without God making it possible, neither a rich person nor anyone else is able to enter the kingdom (19:26).

Jesus also gave a promise that those whom he asked to leave their possessions and family behind to serve him would receive great rewards (19:29).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Rich Young Man (NIV)

A rich young man's questions

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 10:17–31 and Luke 18:18–30.

19:23a

Then Jesus said to His disciples, "Truly I tell you,

- ¶ Then Jesus told his disciples, "I assure you^(plur) that

- ¶ Then Jesus turned to his disciples and said, “Listen to this:

Then Jesus said to His disciples: Verse 19:23 begins a new paragraph. In this paragraph, Jesus stopped talking with the young man. He started talking with his disciples. To show this change, many English versions, including the BSB, begin this paragraph with the word Then.

Truly I tell you: Jesus often used these words to introduce a statement that he wanted to emphasize. When he began a statement with these words, he was asking people to listen with extra attention.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

I assure you that

Listen to this:

Let me tell you this:

If you have another way in your language to emphasize a statement or to alert people to listen with special attention, consider using it here. See how you translated this clause in 18:13a.

19:23b

it is hard for a rich man to enter the kingdom of heaven.

- it is difficult for a rich person to enter the kingdom of heaven.
- it is hard for rich people to become citizens/members of the kingdom of the one who lives in heaven.

it is hard for a rich man to enter the kingdom of heaven: The Greek word that the BSB translates as it is hard can also be translated as “with difficulty.” For example:

only with difficulty will a rich person enter the kingdom of heaven (NIV)

rich man: The word man is general and refers to people, both men and women.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

rich person (ESV)

someone who is rich (NIV)

In Greek, the term rich man is singular. And the verb to enter is future. However, this clause is a general principle. So, in some languages, it will be more natural make the term rich man plural and/or to use a present tense verb. For example:

it will be very hard for rich people to enter the Kingdom of heaven (GNT)

It’s terribly hard for rich people to get into the kingdom of heaven! (CEV)

To enter into the kingdom of heaven is very hard for rich people

to enter the kingdom of heaven: In this context, the phrase to enter refers to “become a citizen of.” When people believe in Jesus, they become citizens/members of the kingdom of heaven.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

become a citizen of the kingdom of heaven

become one of those who are in the kingdom of the one who lives in heaven

be added to the people over whom God rules

This same expression occurs in 5:20b and 18:3c. You should translate it the same way in all these places.

See how you translated the phrase kingdom of heaven in 19:12c and 19:14c. See also kingdom of heaven in KBT 1 (d) for more information.

Matthew 19:24

Section 19:16–30: Jesus taught about entering the kingdom of heaven

In this section, a young man asked Jesus what he must do to get eternal life. Jesus gave him a standard answer, which was to obey God’s commands.

The young man apparently felt that this was not enough and asked what else he should do (19:20). Then Jesus told him to sell his possessions, give the money to the poor, and follow him. The young man was rich, and he was not willing to sell his things. So he left.

Jesus then used the rich young man as an example. He explained that riches make it difficult to enter the kingdom (19:23–24). The saying of a camel going through the eye of a needle was probably a well-

known proverb about something impossible to do. Without God making it possible, neither a rich person nor anyone else is able to enter the kingdom (19:26).

Jesus also gave a promise that those whom he asked to leave their possessions and family behind to serve him would receive great rewards (19:29).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Rich Young Man (NIV)

A rich young man's questions

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 10:17–31 and Luke 18:18–30.

19:24a

Again I tell you,

- I say to you again,
- To say it another way,

Again I tell you: The Greek words that the BSB here translates as I tell you are the same words that the BSB translates as “I tell you” in 19:23a. These words together with the word Again emphasize a second time how difficult it is for a rich man to enter the kingdom of heaven.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

Furthermore

To say it another way

I'll say it again (NLT)

19:24b–c

In 19:24b–c, Jesus compared two things. He compared a difficult thing (a rich man entering the kingdom of God) to an impossible thing (a camel going through the eye of a needle). This comparison shows that it is also impossible for a rich man to enter the kingdom of God.

It may be more natural in your language to translate the comparison in another way. For example:

The difficulty for a rich man to enter the kingdom of God surpasses the difficulty for a camel to go through the eye of a needle.

It is not possible for a camel to go through the eye of a needle. But the difficulty for a rich man to enter the kingdom of God surpasses even that.

It is difficult for a camel to go through the eye of a needle. It is even more difficult for a rich man to enter the kingdom of God.

19:24b

it is easier for a camel to pass through the eye of a needle

- a camel can go through the hole in a needle more easily
- it is hard/difficult for a very large animal to go/pass through a tiny hole.

a camel: A camel is a large animal that carries people and cargo in desert areas. It was the largest animal that lived in the land of the Jews.

Here are some other ways to translate the word camel:

- Use the current word for camel in your language.
- Spell the word camel (or the major language word for camel) as a speaker of your language will say it. Use a picture with a camel and a person in it to show how large a camel is. Or you may want a footnote to explain. A sample footnote is:

A camel is a large animal that carries people and cargo. It generally lives in desert areas. It was the largest animal that lived in the land of the Jews.

- Spell the word camel (or the major language word for camel) as a speaker of your language will say it and add a descriptive phrase. For example:

a large domesticated animal called a camel

- Use a descriptive phrase instead of the word camel. For example:

a large domesticated animal

the eye of a needle: The Greek word that the BSB translates as needle is a thin, sharp piece of metal, wood or bone that is used to sew cloth or animal skins. It has a small hole at one end for thread to go through and be held during stitching. That hole is called the eye of the needle. It was the smallest hole that the Jews knew.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the hole of a needle

a sewing needle hole

19:24c

than for a rich man to enter the kingdom of God.”

- than a rich person can enter into God’s kingdom.”
- It is even more difficult for a rich person to become a citizen of the kingdom of God!”

a rich man: This is the same term as in 19:23b. Translate it the same way here as there.

to enter the kingdom of God: The verb enter also occurs in 19:23b. Translate it the same way here as there.

Matthew rarely used the kingdom of God. More frequently he used “kingdom of heaven.” In these two verses, he used both phrases in the same context. This shows that they mean the same thing.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

to become a citizen of the kingdom of God

to become one of those who are in God’s kingdom

to be added to the people over whom God rules

Matthew 19:25

Section 19:16–30: Jesus taught about entering the kingdom of heaven

In this section, a young man asked Jesus what he must do to get eternal life. Jesus gave him a standard answer, which was to obey God’s commands.

The young man apparently felt that this was not enough and asked what else he should do (19:20). Then Jesus told him to sell his possessions, give the money to the poor, and follow him. The young man was rich, and he was not willing to sell his things. So he left.

Jesus then used the rich young man as an example. He explained that riches make it difficult to enter the kingdom (19:23–24). The saying of a camel going through the eye of a needle was probably a well-known proverb about something impossible to do. Without God making it possible, neither a rich person nor anyone else is able to enter the kingdom (19:26).

Jesus also gave a promise that those whom he asked to leave their possessions and family behind to serve him would receive great rewards (19:29).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Rich Young Man (NIV)

A rich young man’s questions

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 10:17–31 and Luke 18:18–30.

19:25a

When the disciples heard this, they were greatly astonished

- When the disciples heard this, they were very amazed.
- The disciples heard that and were completely surprised.

When the disciples heard this: The word this refers to Jesus’ words of 19:23–24.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Hearing these/those words, the disciples

The disciples heard that and

they were greatly astonished: The Greek word that the BSB translates as astonished means “amazed to the point of being overwhelmed.” In this context it is made even stronger by the word that the BSB translates as greatly.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

they were completely amazed (GNT)

they were greatly surprised (CEV)

The Jews of that time thought that riches were an extra blessing from God. So the disciples were surprised that Jesus taught that riches made it hard for someone to enter the kingdom of God.

19:25b

and asked, “Who then can be saved?”

- They said, “In that case, who is able to be saved?”
- They said to him, “What!? Then will anyone get/receive salvation from punishment?”
- They said to Jesus, “What!? Then no one can be saved!”

Who then can be saved?: This is a rhetorical question. It has two functions: surprise and emphasis. The dis-

ciples used this question to express how surprised/astonished they were at Jesus' comment in 19:26a. And Jesus' response in 19:26b–c shows that he understood the disciples to emphatically imply "Then no one can be saved!"

Here are some other ways to translate this surprise and emphasis:

- As one or two rhetorical questions. For example:

Then who in the world can be saved? (NLT)

What!? Then can anyone be saved?

- As an expression of surprise followed by an emphatic statement. For example:

What!? Then no one can be saved!

- As an emphatic statement. For example:

Then no one can be saved!

Translate this surprise and emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

Who...can be saved: The word saved means "rescued from danger or trouble." In this context, it refers to being saved from punishment and destruction. It means the same as "enter the kingdom of heaven/God" in 19:23–24 and "obtain eternal life" in 19:16b.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Who...can be saved from punishment?

Who...can enter the kingdom of God?

Who...can get eternal life?

This is a passive clause. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

Who...can be saved?

- Use an active verb. For example:

Who...are the people who will get/receive salvation?

Who...can enter the kingdom?

See how you translated the word saved in 1:21c and 10:22b.

then: The Greek word that the BSB translates as then introduces a conclusion based on what Jesus just said. Here it is not a time word.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

In that case

If that's true

If it's like that

Matthew 19:26

Section 19:16–30: Jesus taught about entering the kingdom of heaven

In this section, a young man asked Jesus what he must do to get eternal life. Jesus gave him a standard answer, which was to obey God's commands.

The young man apparently felt that this was not enough and asked what else he should do (19:20). Then Jesus told him to sell his possessions, give the money to the poor, and follow him. The young man was rich, and he was not willing to sell his things. So he left.

Jesus then used the rich young man as an example. He explained that riches make it difficult to enter the kingdom (19:23–24). The saying of a camel going through the eye of a needle was probably a well-known proverb about something impossible to do. Without God making it possible, neither a rich person nor anyone else is able to enter the kingdom (19:26).

Jesus also gave a promise that those whom he asked to leave their possessions and family behind to serve him would receive great rewards (19:29).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Rich Young Man (NIV)

A rich young man's questions

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 10:17–31 and Luke 18:18–30.

19:26a
Jesus looked at them and said,

- Jesus looked directly at them and said,
- Jesus looked straight at them. He said,

The Greek begins this verse with a word that some English versions translate as “But.” It simply indicates a change from one speaker to another. In this context, it does not indicate a contrast. Many English versions, including the BSB, do not translate this word. In many languages, it will not be necessary to translate this word either.

looked at them: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as looked at is the Greek word for “look” plus a suffix that intensifies it.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

looked directly/intently

looked straight (GNT)

19:26b

“With man this is impossible,

- “It is not possible for people to do this,
- “People are not able to save themselves from punishment.

With man this is impossible: The Greek word that the BSB translates as With in this context means “on the part of” or “in relation to.”

The Greek word that the BSB translates as man is plural and in this context refers to all people.

The word this refers to “being saved.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

As for people, they are not able to do this

This is something people cannot do (NCV)

It is impossible for people [to save themselves] (GW)

In some languages, it may be necessary to say what people are saved from. As with 19:25b, “saved” here is equivalent to gaining eternal life and entering into the kingdom of Heaven. So the use of the verb saved implies saving from punishment and destruction. For example:

It is not possible for people to save themselves from punishment

19:26c

but with God all things are possible.”

- but for God all things are possible.”
- but God is able to do anything.”

but: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between what is impossible for man to do and what is possible for God to do. The BSB indicates this contrast with the conjunction but.

with God all things are possible: The phrase with God is parallel to the phrase “With man” in 19:26b. Translate it in the same manner. For example:

as for God, all things are possible

God can do all things (NCV)

all things: In this context, the phrase all things refers to any deed. God can do anything he desires, including saving people.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

all deeds

everything (GNT)

anything

Matthew 19:27

Section 19:16–30: Jesus taught about entering the kingdom of heaven

In this section, a young man asked Jesus what he must do to get eternal life. Jesus gave him a standard answer, which was to obey God’s commands.

The young man apparently felt that this was not enough and asked what else he should do (19:20). Then Jesus told him to sell his possessions, give the money to the poor, and follow him. The young man was rich, and he was not willing to sell his things. So he left.

Jesus then used the rich young man as an example. He explained that riches make it difficult to enter the kingdom (19:23–24). The saying of a camel going through the eye of a needle was probably a well-known proverb about something impossible to do. Without God making it possible, neither a rich person nor anyone else is able to enter the kingdom (19:26).

Jesus also gave a promise that those whom he asked to leave their possessions and family behind to serve him would receive great rewards (19:29).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Rich Young Man (NIV)

A rich young man's questions

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 10:17–31 and Luke 18:18–30.

19:27a

“Look,” Peter replied, “we have left everything to follow You.

- ¶ Then Peter said to him, “Look, we^(excl) have left everything in order to follow you.
- ¶ Then Peter said, “We^(excl) have abandoned all that we owned to become your followers/disciples.

“Look,” Peter replied: In Greek, the phrase Peter replied is more literally “Then answering, Peter said to him” and occurs at the beginning of the verse. Peter did not answer a question. He responded to the whole situation concerning the rich young man.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Then Peter said to him (NLT)

Then Peter said (REB)

Look: The Greek word that the BSB here translates as Look is “Behold” in many English versions. This word draws attention to what Peter wanted to say.

Here is another way to translate this word:

See (ESV)

Some English versions are like the NIV and do not translate this word. In some languages, it may not be necessary to translate this word either.

we have left everything: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as have left means “have left behind” or “have abandoned.” Peter did not just mean that they had moved away from their things. They had let go of them.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

we’ve given up everything (NLT)

we: In Greek, the pronoun we is emphasized. Peter seemed to want to contrast himself and the other

disciples with the rich young man who did not want to sell his possessions. If possible, emphasize this pronoun in your translation. For example:

as for us, we have left everything

What about us? We have left everything (REB)

everything: This is the same word as the word translated as “all things” in 19:26c. It is very general and implies that the disciples no longer possessed anything. Peter probably exaggerated a bit by saying that they had abandoned everything.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

everything we owned

all that we owned

to follow You: The Greek word that the BSB translates as follow is the same word as in 19:21d. Here Peter used this word in a figurative sense. He meant not only that they walked around with Jesus. He meant that they became his disciples.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

to be your followers (CEV)

to follow you and be your disciples

19:27b

What then will there be for us?”

- So, what reward will we^(excl) receive?”
- What will we^(excl) get/receive for doing that?”

What then will there be for us: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates literally as will there be for us refers to what the disciples can expect to gain from abandoning everything they had.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

What will we get? (NLT)

So what will we get out of it?

So what will be our reward?

then: This is the same word as in 19:25b. It introduces a conclusion based on what Peter just said. Here it is not a time word.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

In that case

So

Matthew 19:28

Section 19:16–30: Jesus taught about entering the kingdom of heaven

In this section, a young man asked Jesus what he must do to get eternal life. Jesus gave him a standard answer, which was to obey God's commands.

The young man apparently felt that this was not enough and asked what else he should do (19:20). Then Jesus told him to sell his possessions, give the money to the poor, and follow him. The young man was rich, and he was not willing to sell his things. So he left.

Jesus then used the rich young man as an example. He explained that riches make it difficult to enter the kingdom (19:23–24). The saying of a camel going through the eye of a needle was probably a well-known proverb about something impossible to do. Without God making it possible, neither a rich person nor anyone else is able to enter the kingdom (19:26).

Jesus also gave a promise that those whom he asked to leave their possessions and family behind to serve him would receive great rewards (19:29).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Rich Young Man (NIV)

A rich young man's questions

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 10:17–31 and Luke 18:18–30.

19:28a

Jesus said to them, "Truly I tell you,

- Jesus told them, "I assure you^(plur),
- Then Jesus said, "Listen to this:

Truly I tell you: This same expression occurs in 19:23a. You should translate it here as you did there. For example:

I assure you that

Listen to this:

Let me tell you this:

19:28b

in the renewal of all things,

- in the world/age that is coming,
- when God makes the world/earth new,

in the renewal of all things: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the renewal of all things is more literally "rebirth." It refers to the age to come (see 12:32) when God makes the world new again.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

In the age when all things are renewed (NET)

in the world to come (GW)

in the New Age (GNT)

when God makes the world/earth new again

19:28c

when the Son of Man sits on His glorious throne,

- when the Son of Man will sit on his great throne,
- I the Son of Man will sit on my king's chair in power/greatness to rule.

the Son of Man: Jesus used the phrase the Son of Man to refer to himself. In some languages, it may be necessary to add the pronoun "I" to show that Jesus was referring to himself. For example:

I, the Son of Man

In Matthew, this phrase first occurs in 8:20b. See the Note there for more information on translating it.

sits on His glorious throne: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as His glorious throne is more literally "throne of his glory" (as in the NRSV). This phrase does not only mean that the throne itself is glorious. It means that the person (Jesus) who sits on the throne is glorious. When Jesus sits on this throne, it shows that he has power and authority.

Also, Jesus will sit on this throne to rule. He will not sit on this throne because he needs to rest. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this explicit.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

will sit on his great throne (NCV)

will sit on his chief chair in glory/greatness to rule

will sit with his authority/power on his chair/stool to rule

In some languages, there may be a special verb that describes a chief sitting to rule. It may not be necessary to also translate the word throne. For example:

will sit in/with power to rule

glorious: The Greek word that the BSB translates as glorious is more literally “of glory.” Here it refers to the greatness and power of the person who sits on the throne.

throne: A throne is a special chair on which a king sits. He sits on this chair to judge and rule and show that he has authority.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

king’s chair

chief’s stool

19:28d

you who have followed Me will also sit on twelve thrones,

- you who followed me will also sit on twelve thrones,
- You, my twelve followers, will also each sit on a king’s chair,

you who have followed Me: This clause refers to the twelve disciples whom Jesus chose.

Here is another way to translate it:

you, my followers (GW)

you twelve followers of mine (GNT)

you, my disciples

will also sit on twelve thrones: The word thrones here is the same as in 19:28c. Translate it here in the same way.

19:28e

judging the twelve tribes of Israel.

- and rule the twelve clans of Israel.
- and rule/govern the twelve clans of Israel.

judging: There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as judging:

1. It refers to governing/ruling. According to this interpretation, it refers to using authority over a period of time. It is similar to Moses judging/ruling the people of Israel for forty years. For example:

to rule (GNT)

1. It refers to deciding whether people are guilty or innocent, and deciding how the guilty people must be punished. According to this interpretation, it refers to a single event on judgment day. The disciples will judge Israel. They will condemn some of the people of Israel for rejecting Christ.

If you can translate this word with a term that includes both interpretations, you should do that. If you must make a choice, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Jesus promised his disciples a reward for abandoning everything to follow him. That reward is that they will reign with him. Davies and Allison (vol. III pages 55–56) say, “What is meant by κρίνοντες? Many have understood the verb to refer not to lordship but to a one-time judgement: Israel will be judged—some would say condemned—by the twelve at the consummation. In support of this conclusion, many ancient Jewish and Christian texts foresee a group of saints judging the world in the sense indicated. Further, 19:28 recalls 25:31, which introduces a depiction of the last judgement. But it is better to hold that for Matthew and his tradition, κρίνοντες had the range of the Hebrew šāpaṭ. In this case, the sitting on the throne designates the exercise of authority over a period of time. As the twelve phylarchs once directed the twelve tribes under Moses, and as Israel was once ruled by judges, so shall it be at the end.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

rule/reign

govern

the twelve tribes of Israel: The word tribes refers to “clans.” The twelve clans started from the twelve sons of Israel who founded the nation of Israel.

Here the word tribes does not refer to distinct ethnic groups who spoke different languages and had different customs.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the twelve clans of Israel

the people who descended from the twelve sons of Israel

Matthew 19:29

Section 19:16–30: Jesus taught about entering the kingdom of heaven

In this section, a young man asked Jesus what he must do to get eternal life. Jesus gave him a standard answer, which was to obey God's commands.

The young man apparently felt that this was not enough and asked what else he should do (19:20). Then Jesus told him to sell his possessions, give the money to the poor, and follow him. The young man was rich, and he was not willing to sell his things. So he left.

Jesus then used the rich young man as an example. He explained that riches make it difficult to enter the kingdom (19:23–24). The saying of a camel going through the eye of a needle was probably a well-known proverb about something impossible to do. Without God making it possible, neither a rich person nor anyone else is able to enter the kingdom (19:26).

Jesus also gave a promise that those whom he asked to leave their possessions and family behind to serve him would receive great rewards (19:29).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Rich Young Man (NIV)

A rich young man's questions

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 10:17–31 and Luke 18:18–30.

19:29a

And everyone who has left

- Every person who has left
- All believers who have abandoned

everyone who: This phrase refers to any believer. It does not just refer to the twelve disciples.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Every person who

Any believer who

has left: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as has left is the same word as in 19:27a. Translate in the same way here. For example:

left behind

abandoned

19:29b

houses or brothers or sisters or father or mother or wife or children or fields

- his home or brothers or sisters or father or mother or children or lands
- their siblings or parents or children or houses or farms/gardens

houses: The Greek word that the BSB translates as houses is plural. But in some languages, it may be more natural to use a singular word here. It may also be more natural to add the pronoun “his” or “their” here. For example:

home (CEV)

his/their house

In some languages, it may also be more natural to put this word together with “lands” at the end of the list.

brothers or sisters: You should translate these two words according to the kinship terms in your language. For example:

older siblings or younger siblings

siblings

father or mother: There is a textual issue here. Some manuscripts add the words “or wife” in this list after the “mother.” The UBS editors found it difficult to decide whether that is the better text or not. Only the KJV follows that variant. In some languages, it will be natural to translate these two words as:

parents

fields: The Greek word that the BSB here translates as fields usually refers to lands which are used for growing food. This word can also refer generally to any land which someone owns. In 13:44a, the BSB translates this same word as “field.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

property

farms/gardens

lands (ESV)

19:29c for the sake of My name

- because of me
- to follow/serve me,

for the sake of My name: In this phrase, the word name represents Jesus and everything about him. So this phrase means “for the sake of Jesus” or “because of Jesus.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

for me (CEV)

to follow me (NCV)

because of me

because he serves/follows me

A similar phrase occurs in 10:22a.

19:29d will receive a hundredfold and will inherit eternal life.

- will receive a hundred times more than what he left, and will also receive life that never ends.
- they will receive much more than they left. They will also live forever in the kingdom of God.

will receive a hundredfold: The Greek word that the BSB translates as a hundredfold means “a hundred times as much.” It refers to the great reward that a person who serves Christ will receive. The idea is that such a believer will receive “much, much more” than he left.

This clause does not mean that for each item or person that a believer leaves, he will receive exactly one hundred of that same thing.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

will receive a hundred times more (GNT)

will receive many times as much (NASB)

will get much more than they left (NCV)

and: The conjunction and means that the person will receive eternal life in addition to the new abundance of family and possessions.

will inherit: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as will inherit also means “will get” or “will receive.”

eternal life: This is the same phrase as in 19:16b. Translate it the same way here as there. For example:

unending life

life that never ends

live forever with God after he dies

Matthew 19:30

Section 19:16–30: Jesus taught about entering the kingdom of heaven

In this section, a young man asked Jesus what he must do to get eternal life. Jesus gave him a standard answer, which was to obey God’s commands.

The young man apparently felt that this was not enough and asked what else he should do (19:20). Then Jesus told him to sell his possessions, give the money to the poor, and follow him. The young man was rich, and he was not willing to sell his things. So he left.

Jesus then used the rich young man as an example. He explained that riches make it difficult to enter the kingdom (19:23–24). The saying of a camel going through the eye of a needle was probably a well-known proverb about something impossible to do. Without God making it possible, neither a rich person nor anyone else is able to enter the kingdom (19:26).

Jesus also gave a promise that those whom he asked to leave their possessions and family behind to serve him would receive great rewards (19:29).

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Rich Young Man (NIV)

A rich young man's questions

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 10:17–31 and Luke 18:18–30.

19:30a

But many who are first will be last,

- But many who are big/great people now will be small/humble,
- Many people who are respected much now will be respected little in the future.

But: There is some contrast here between two types of people. The people who leave their possessions and family for Jesus' sake are contrasted with the people who are first in this world. The BSB indicates this contrast with the word But.

many who are first will be last: In this context, the Greek word that the BSB translates as first means “most important.” The Greek word that the BSB translates as last means “least important.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

many who are high/great now will become low/humble

many people who are big now will be small in the future

many people who are respected much now will be respected little in the future

Many who have the highest place now will have the lowest place in the future (NCV)

19:30b

and the last will be first.

- and many who are small/humble people now
- Many people who are respected little now will be respected much in the future.

and the last will be first: Some words are implied but not repeated here. The complete clause would be:

and many people who are last will be first

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

many who are low/humble now will become high/great

many people who are small now will be big in the future

many people who are respected little now will be respected much in the future

many who have the lowest place now will have the highest place in the future (NCV)

Matthew 20:1

Section 20:1–16: Jesus told a parable about vineyard workers

In this section, Jesus told a parable about some vineyard workers and the man who owned the vineyard. Even though the workers worked for a different number of hours, the owner gave them all the same pay. This parable continues the discussion about rewards for being a disciple (19:27–29). It also helps to explain the meaning of the saying “many who are first will be last, and the last will be first” (19:30). The main point of the parable is about God's grace. In the kingdom, God gives his servants much more than they deserve. In the kingdom, the values are different than the values here on earth.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The story about men who worked in a field of grapes

A story that shows God's generosity/grace

Rewards for serving God

This parable occurs only in the book of Matthew.

20:1a

“For the kingdom of heaven is like a landowner

- ¶ “Let me explain. The kingdom of heaven is like this story: a landowner
- ¶ To explain/illustrate, Jesus continued, “I can compare God's rule to this parable. There was a certain man who owned some land.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *For* introduces an explanation for something that was just said. In this case, the parable that follows explains the statement that Jesus made in 19:30. He said that, at the renewal of all things, many who are first will be last, and many who are last will be first.

Here are some other ways to introduce this explanation:

Let me explain

Jesus continued, explaining

the kingdom of heaven is like: Jesus compared the kingdom of heaven to the entire parable in 20:1–16. Jesus did not just compare the kingdom of heaven to the master of a house. Make sure your grammar indicates that. Here are some examples:

Here is what the kingdom of heaven is like:

The kingdom of heaven is like this story.

I can compare the kingdom of heaven to this parable.

the kingdom of heaven: The phrase the kingdom of heaven last occurred in 19:23b. You should translate it the same ways in both places. For help to translate this phrase, see the note at 18:23a.

a landowner: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates a landowner is more literally “a man a house-master.” Jesus often used the phrase “a man” to introduce the main character of a parable he told. Follow the pattern of your language to indicate that this man is the main character of the story. For example:

There was a certain man who owned some land

This phrase refers to someone who was rich enough to own a house and possibly other property and land.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

a master of the house (ESV)

a person who owned some land (NCV)

the owner of a farm/field

20:1b

who went out early in the morning to hire workers for his vineyard.

- went out early in the morning to find some men whom he would pay to work in his grape farm.
- One morning about sunrise, he left his house and went to the market to look for some men to work in his field of grapes.

who went out: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as *went out* indicates that the master of the house went outside his house. He went to the marketplace to find people willing to work for him. This is where people looking for work would gather. That place is made explicit in 20:3, but you may need to mention it here. For example:

who went out to the marketplace

He went to the public square

early in the morning: This phrase probably refers to a time soon after sunrise. It was as soon as there was enough daylight to work. In Israel this would have been about 6 o'clock in the morning.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

One morning...very early (NCV)

at daybreak (NJB)

to hire workers: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *to hire* is based on the word for “wage.” It means “to pay wages/money to.” The master of the house intended to give the men money for the work that they would do.

The Greek word that the BSB translates *workers* refers to people who do work which requires physical labor. (This same word occurs in 10:10b.)

Here are some other ways to translate this entire phrase:

to employ workers

to find people whom he would pay to work

to look for people to work

for his vineyard: A vineyard is a field where grapevines are planted. Grapevines are long, woody vines that produce a fruit called grapes. People used sticks to hold the vines off the ground so that the fruit hung down without touching the ground.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in his grape farm

in his field of grape vines

In some languages, there may not be a word for “vineyard” or for “grape.” If this is true in your language, here are two other options to consider:

- Borrow the word for “grape” from another language and add a general expression that describes what a grape farm is. For example:

farm for producing a fruit called grapes

farm for raising fruit from grape vines

- Use a general word for fruit that would fit in this context. For example:

farm to produce a fruit used to make wine

You may also want to add a footnote. For example:

The fruit called “grape” grows on a vine. The fruit is used for making wine.

Note that “grape” and “grapefruit” are not the same thing.

Matthew 20:2

Section 20:1–16: Jesus told a parable about vineyard workers

In this section, Jesus told a parable about some vineyard workers and the man who owned the vineyard. Even though the workers worked for a different number of hours, the owner gave them all the same pay. This parable continues the discussion about rewards for being a disciple (19:27–29). It also helps to explain the meaning of the saying “many who are first will be last, and the last will be first” (19:30). The main point of the parable is about God’s grace. In the kingdom, God gives his servants much more than they deserve. In the kingdom, the values are different than the values here on earth.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The story about men who worked in a field of grapes

A story that shows God’s generosity/grace

Rewards for serving God

This parable occurs only in the book of Matthew.

20:2a

He agreed to pay them a denarius for the day

- This landowner and the workers agreed that he would pay each of them one denarius coin to work for him that day,
- He discussed with some workers and agreed to pay each of them the normal wage for a day’s work.

He agreed to pay them: The laborers were employed for only one day at a time. So each time that a landowner wanted workers, he would discuss with them and agree upon a wage for that particular day.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

He made an agreement with the workers (NJB)

After agreeing with the laborers for (ESV)

The man agreed to pay the workers (NCV)

a denarius for the day: A denarius was a Roman coin made of silver. It was the usual wage for a full day of work on a farm.

The plural form of this word occurs in 18:28. Translate it here in the same way you did there.

Here are some ways to translate this word:

- Transliterate the Greek word denarius and add a descriptive phrase. For example:

a denarius money/coin

- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

a silver coin (GNT)

- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

the usual amount for a day's work (CEV)

To help your readers understand what is going on here, you may wish to add a footnote such as this:

A denarius was a Roman silver coin. It was the usual wage for a full day's work.

20:2b

and sent them into his vineyard.

- and then he sent them into his grape farm to work.
- Then he told them to go work in his field of grapes.

sent them into his vineyard: This clause implies that the master first described the work that he wanted the laborers to do. Then he sent them to do it.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

he sent them to work in his vineyard (GW)

Matthew 20:3

Section 20:1–16: Jesus told a parable about vineyard workers

In this section, Jesus told a parable about some vineyard workers and the man who owned the vineyard. Even though the workers worked for a different number of hours, the owner gave them all the same pay. This parable continues the discussion about rewards for being a disciple (19:27–29). It also helps to explain the meaning of the saying “many who are first will be last, and the last will be first” (19:30). The main point of the parable is about God's grace. In the kingdom, God gives his servants much more than they deserve. In the kingdom, the values are different than the values here on earth.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The story about men who worked in a field of grapes

A story that shows God's generosity/grace

Rewards for serving God

This parable occurs only in the book of Matthew.

20:3a

About the third hour he went out

- About 9 o'clock in the morning, he went out
- In the middle of the morning, he returned

About the third hour: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the third hour refers to the third hour after sunrise. That generally indicates 9 o'clock in the morning. The word About means that this is an approximate time.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

about 9 o'clock (NCV)

About 9 a.m. (GW)

at mid-morning

he went out: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as went out indicates that the master of the house went outside his house. He left his house and went back to the marketplace.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the man went to the marketplace (NCV)

he returned to the market

20:3b

and saw others standing in the marketplace doing nothing.

- to the market again and saw other men standing around doing nothing.
- to the public square and saw other men waiting there with no work to do.

saw others: The Greek word that the BSB translates as others refers to other men. They were men like the ones whom the master of the house first met.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the man saw some other people (CEV)

he found some more men

standing: The word standing means that the men were present in the marketplace. Some were possibly sitting or squatting as they waited for work. It does not necessarily mean that all the men were actually standing on their feet.

Here is another way to translate this word:

waiting around

in the marketplace: The marketplace was an open space in the middle of the village. It was used for a market. It was also a place where children played and where people gathered for any purpose at all.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

market (GNT)

public square

doing nothing: In this context, doing nothing means that these men were not working. They were waiting to be hired. Your translation should not imply that they were lazy or did not want to work.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

idle (ESV)

waiting for a job

Matthew 20:4

Section 20:1–16: Jesus told a parable about vineyard workers

In this section, Jesus told a parable about some vineyard workers and the man who owned the vineyard. Even though the workers worked for a different number of hours, the owner gave them all the same pay. This parable continues the discussion about rewards for being a disciple (19:27–29). It also helps to explain the meaning of the saying “many who are first will be last, and the last will be first” (19:30). The main point of the parable is about God’s grace. In the kingdom, God gives his servants much more than they deserve. In the kingdom, the values are different than the values here on earth.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The story about men who worked in a field of grapes

A story that shows God’s generosity/grace

Rewards for serving God

This parable occurs only in the book of Matthew.

20:4a

‘You also go into my vineyard,’ he said,

- He said to them, ‘You^(plur) men also go and work in my grape farm.
- So the landowner told them also to go and work in his field of grapes.

You also go into my vineyard: These words imply that the master asked the second group of men to go and work in his vineyard. In some languages, it will be more natural to make this explicit. For example:

You also go and work in my vineyard (NIV)

If you go and work in my vineyard (NCV)

20:4b

‘and I will pay you whatever is right.’

- Whatever is just/fair for your wage, I will give it to you.’
- He said that he would pay them a correct/good wage.

pay: In this context, this verb clearly refers to paying the men for their work. Use an expression that is natural in your language here. For example:

give (ESV)

give as pay

whatever is right: The Greek word that the BSB translates as right also means “just, good, proper.” The master of the house did not agree to a specific amount with these men. But he promised that he would act in a just manner toward them.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

whatever is good/appropriate

whatever is fair (CEV)

whatever is correct/proper

General Comment on 20:4a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to use indirect speech here. For example:

He told them to go and work in his vineyard and he would pay them what is right.

He said he would pay them what was fair, if they would work in his vineyard. (CEV)

Matthew 20:5

Section 20:1–16: Jesus told a parable about vineyard workers

In this section, Jesus told a parable about some vineyard workers and the man who owned the vineyard. Even though the workers worked for a different number of hours, the owner gave them all the same pay. This parable continues the discussion about rewards for being a disciple (19:27–29). It also helps to explain the meaning of the saying “many who are first will be last, and the last will be first” (19:30). The main point of the parable is about God’s grace. In the kingdom, God gives his servants much more than they deserve. In the kingdom, the values are different than the values here on earth.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The story about men who worked in a field of grapes

A story that shows God’s generosity/grace

Rewards for serving God

This parable occurs only in the book of Matthew.

20:5a

So they went.

- So they went to work in the grape farm.
- They agreed and went to work in the field of grapes.

So: Verse 20:5a is the result of what the master said to the workers in 20:4. The BSB introduces this result with the conjunction So.

they went: There is some implied information here. The full sentence would be:

they went to work in the vineyard. (NLT)

20:5b

He went out again about the sixth hour and the ninth hour

- At about 12 o’clock noon and again at about 3 o’clock, he went out again
- The landowner went to the public square again about mid-day and again about mid-afternoon.

He went out: The verb went out here is the same verb as in 20:3a. The landowner went outside his house. He left his house and went back to the marketplace. You should translate it here as you did there.

about the sixth hour and the ninth hour: These two phrases describe specific hours after sunrise (like “the third hour” in 20:3a). So, the sixth hour corresponds to 12 o’clock noon, and the ninth hour corresponds to 3 o’clock in the afternoon.

Here are some other ways to translate these phrases:

at twelve o’clock and again at three o’clock (GNT)

about noon and 3 p.m. (GW)

around midday and again in the middle of the afternoon

20:5c

and did the same thing.

- and hired more workers.
- Each time, he found more men and told them also to go work in his field of grapes.

did the same thing: The words did the same means that the master did the same action each time. Each time that he went out, he found more workers waiting around in the marketplace. And each time he sent them also into his vineyard to work.

In some languages, it will be more natural to make some of this information explicit. For example:

Each time, he found more workers standing around in the market. And each time, he told them to go and work in his vineyard.

each time he made the same agreement with others who were loafing around with nothing to do (CEV)

General Comment on 20:5b–c

In some languages, it will be natural to have the time phrases at the beginning of the sentence. In other languages, these phrases will be more natural at the end. For example:

About noon and about three o’clock he went out again and did the same thing.

He went out again and did the same thing at noon and at three o'clock.

Matthew 20:6

Section 20:1–16: Jesus told a parable about vineyard workers

In this section, Jesus told a parable about some vineyard workers and the man who owned the vineyard. Even though the workers worked for a different number of hours, the owner gave them all the same pay. This parable continues the discussion about rewards for being a disciple (19:27–29). It also helps to explain the meaning of the saying “many who are first will be last, and the last will be first” (19:30). The main point of the parable is about God’s grace. In the kingdom, God gives his servants much more than they deserve. In the kingdom, the values are different than the values here on earth.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The story about men who worked in a field of grapes

A story that shows God’s generosity/grace

Rewards for serving God

This parable occurs only in the book of Matthew.

20:6a

About the eleventh hour he went out

- About 5 o'clock in the afternoon, the landowner went to the market again,
- Finally, an hour before sundown he went again to the public square.

Verses 20:6–7 are about the master’s final trip to the marketplace. You should begin these verses in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Later

Then

Finally (CEV)

About the eleventh hour: The phrase the eleventh hour refers to 5 o'clock in the afternoon. It is about one hour before sundown.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

at about five o'clock (JBP)

an hour before sundown (REB)

About 5 p.m. (GW)

he went out: The Greek verb that the BSB here translates as he went out is the same verb that occurs in 20:3a and 20:5b. The master left his house and went to the market.

20:6b

and found still others standing around.

- and he found other men standing around doing nothing.
- He looked for and found some other men standing there with no work to do.

and found still others standing around: The verb found implies that the master was searching for more workers. Here the verb is not “saw” as in 20:3b.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

looking for some other workers and found some standing

and met some other men standing

standing: This is the same verb as in 20:3b. Translate it the same way in both places.

20:6c

‘Why have you been standing here all day long doing nothing?’ he asked.

- So he said to them, ‘Why have you been standing here all day doing nothing?’
- ‘How is it that you have been standing/waiting here the whole day with no work to do?’ he asked them.
- He asked them why they were standing there all day doing nothing.

Why have you been standing here: This is a real question. It is not a rhetorical question. In some languages, the word Why indicates a rebuke in a rhetorical question. If that is true in your language, you may need to change the form of the question. For example:

How is it that you have been standing here...?

have you been standing here: The form of the Greek verb that the BSB translates as standing indicates that these men had been waiting in the marketplace for a while.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

you have been standing here

all day long: This is a slight exaggeration, because the day was not yet over.

Here is another way to translate this whole clause:

Why haven't you been working today? (NLT)

doing nothing: The Greek word that the BSB translates doing nothing means that these men were not working. They were waiting to be hired. Your translation should not imply that they were lazy or did not want to work.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

idle (ESV)

waiting for a job

This same word occurs in 20:3b. Translate it the same way in both places.

he asked: The pronoun he refers to the landowner. The verb asked introduces a question.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

the landowner asked them

Matthew 20:7

Section 20:1–16: Jesus told a parable about vineyard workers

In this section, Jesus told a parable about some vineyard workers and the man who owned the vineyard. Even though the workers worked for a different number of hours, the owner gave them all the same pay. This parable continues the discussion about rewards for being a disciple (19:27–29). It also helps to explain the meaning of the saying “many who are first will be last, and the last will be first” (19:30). The main point of the parable is about God's grace. In the kingdom, God gives his servants much more than they deserve. In the kingdom, the values are different than the values here on earth.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The story about men who worked in a field of grapes

A story that shows God's generosity/grace

Rewards for serving God

This parable occurs only in the book of Matthew.

20:7a

‘Because no one has hired us,’ they answered.

- They replied, ‘Because no one gave us work.’
- They answered him, ‘No one asked/told us to work.’
- They said that no one had given them work.

Because no one has hired us: Some words from 20:6c are implied but not repeated here. In some languages, it may be more natural to include these implied words. For example:

We ^(excl) are standing idle because no one has hired us

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

No one has hired us (GW)

No one gave us a job. (NCV)

No one gave us work to do.

has hired us: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as has hired also occurs in 20:1b. Translate it here in a similar way. For example:

gave us work

told us to work

they answered: Verse 20:7a is the workers' answer to the master's question. So here is another way to translate this clause that puts the clause at the beginning of the verse, as in the Greek:

They answered him

20:7b**So he told them, ‘You also go into my vineyard.’**

- Then he said to them, ‘You^(plur) men also go and work in my grape farm.
- So the landowner told them also to go and work in his field of grapes.

You also go into my vineyard: This is the same exact clause as in 20:4a. Translate it the same way in both places.

Matthew 20:8**Section 20:1–16: Jesus told a parable about vineyard workers**

In this section, Jesus told a parable about some vineyard workers and the man who owned the vineyard. Even though the workers worked for a different number of hours, the owner gave them all the same pay. This parable continues the discussion about rewards for being a disciple (19:27–29). It also helps to explain the meaning of the saying “many who are first will be last, and the last will be first” (19:30). The main point of the parable is about God’s grace. In the kingdom, God gives his servants much more than they deserve. In the kingdom, the values are different than the values here on earth.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The story about men who worked in a field of grapes

A story that shows God’s generosity/grace

Rewards for serving God

This parable occurs only in the book of Matthew.

20:8a**When evening came, the owner of the vineyard said to his foreman,**

- ¶ When evening came/arrived, the owner of the grape farm said to his manager,
- ¶ At the end of the day, the owner of the field of grapes told his big/chief worker

When evening came: Jesus continued his parable in 20:8. The time in the parable was at least one hour later in the day than 20:7. You should connect 20:1–7 and 20:8 in a way that is natural in your language.

Here are some other ways to do this:

When evening came (NIV)

Then when evening came

That evening (CEV)

evening came: The Greek word that the BSB translates as evening refers to the end of the day. It could be just before the sun went down, or just after.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

at the end of the day (NCV)

the owner of the vineyard: The Greek word that the BSB here translates as owner is the same word that is often translated as “lord.” In this context, it refers to the same person as the word translated “landowner” in 20:1a.

In addition, this word can also provide a link in this story between the actions of the master of the house and the way that the Lord God acts. If possible, translate it as you would the term “lord.” For example:

the lord of the vineyard (KJV)

the master of the vineyard

his foreman: A foreman was a man who worked for the owner of the vineyard. He directed the other workers while they worked. The master of the house gave this person the responsibility to make sure that the work was done.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

his manager (NRSV)

the supervisor (GW)

the boss of all the workers (NCV)

the big/chief worker

20:8b**‘Call the workers and pay them their wages,**

- ‘Call/Tell the workers to come and give them their pay,
- to summon all the workers and give them their money.

Call the workers: This is a command from the owner to the foreman to call the workers to come. The owner had probably gone to the vineyard at the end of the day to give this command to the foreman.

Here are some other ways to translate this command:

Call/Tell the workers to come

Summon the workers

pay them their wages: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as pay has a general meaning of “give” or “give out.” The foreman was responsible to distribute money to the workers. The money came from the owner, not the foreman.

The owner probably instructed the foreman on what he was to pay each worker. He also told him the order that he was to pay them.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

give them their pay (REB)

give them their money (CEV)

20:8c

starting with the last ones hired and moving on to the first.’

- starting with the last workers and ending with the first ones.’
- He told him to pay the last workers first and pay the first workers last.

starting with the last ones hired and moving on to the first: These words indicate the order in which the foreman was supposed to pay the workers. The master told the foremen to first pay those who worked only an hour. Then he was supposed to pay those who worked longer. At the end, he was supposed to pay those who worked all day.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

starting with those who were hired last and ending with those who were hired first (GNT)

Start with the last, and end with the first. (GW)

First pay the people who began working at 5:00. After that, pay the people who began to work at

3:00. Continue until you get to the people who worked from early morning.

Matthew 20:9

Section 20:1–16: Jesus told a parable about vineyard workers

In this section, Jesus told a parable about some vineyard workers and the man who owned the vineyard. Even though the workers worked for a different number of hours, the owner gave them all the same pay. This parable continues the discussion about rewards for being a disciple (19:27–29). It also helps to explain the meaning of the saying “many who are first will be last, and the last will be first” (19:30). The main point of the parable is about God’s grace. In the kingdom, God gives his servants much more than they deserve. In the kingdom, the values are different than the values here on earth.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The story about men who worked in a field of grapes

A story that shows God’s generosity/grace

Rewards for serving God

This parable occurs only in the book of Matthew.

20:9a

The workers who were hired about the eleventh hour came

- When those who started about 5 o’clock in the afternoon came,
- So the men who began working an hour before sundown came.

In 20:9 the foreman began to carry out his master’s orders. In some languages, it will be natural to begin this verse with a conjunction such as “So” or “Then.” In other languages, no conjunction is necessary here. You should connect 20:8 to 20:9 in a way that is natural in your language.

workers who were hired about the eleventh hour came: As in 20:6a, the phrase the eleventh hour refers to eleven hours after sunrise. It was about five o’clock in the afternoon. Translate the time here in the same way you did there.

These were the very last people hired. They had worked only about an hour before the workday was

over. The verb came means that they responded to the foreman's call and came to be paid.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

when those men hired about five o'clock came

Those who had started work an hour before sunset came forward (REB)

Those who started working about 5 p.m. came (GW)

20:9b and each received a denarius.

- each one of them received one denarius coin.
- The big/chief worker gave each one of those workers one silver coin.

each: This word indicates that there was more than one worker. Each of the workers received the same wage.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

and each man (JBP)

received a denarius: The Greek word that the BSB translates as denarius also occurs in 20:2a. You should translate it the same way in both places. For example:

received one denarius

received one coin

Matthew 20:10

Section 20:1–16: Jesus told a parable about vineyard workers

In this section, Jesus told a parable about some vineyard workers and the man who owned the vineyard. Even though the workers worked for a different number of hours, the owner gave them all the same pay. This parable continues the discussion about rewards for being a disciple (19:27–29). It also helps to explain the meaning of the saying “many who are first will be last, and the last will be first” (19:30). The main point of the parable is about God's grace. In the kingdom, God gives his servants much more than they deserve. In the kingdom, the values are different than the values here on earth.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The story about men who worked in a field of grapes

A story that shows God's generosity/grace

Rewards for serving God

This parable occurs only in the book of Matthew.

20:10a–c

So ... But ... : In 20:10, something unexpected happens. The first workers expected to receive more than the last workers, but they did not.

In some languages, it will be natural to indicate this unexpected event with a word or phrase at the beginning of 20:10. The BSB has done this with the conjunction So.

In other languages, it will be natural to indicate this unexpected event only at the beginning of 20:10c. For example:

^aWhen the workers who were hired first came to get their pay, ^bthey thought they would be paid more than the others. ^cBut each one of them also received one coin. (NCV)

20:10a

So when the original workers came,

- When the men who were hired first came,
- Then those workers who started first came to receive their wages/money.

the original workers came: In Greek, this clause is more literally “when the first ones came.” The word original is not in Greek.

This clause refers to the men who were the first ones to start working. They started early in the morning. They had worked for twelve hours at the agreed wage of one denarius.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

When the men who started to work first came

When the workers who were hired first came to get their pay (NCV)

20:10b**they assumed they would receive more.**

- they thought that they would receive more money than the others.
- They expected to be paid more. money than those who had not worked the whole day.

they assumed: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as assumed indicates that these men expected or assumed something. For example:

they expected (NIV)

they thought (ESV)

they would receive more: This phrase means that these men thought that they would receive more money than the last workers. It is true that at the beginning of the day, they had agreed to work for a denarius. But men who worked only part of a day got one denarius. So these men thought that it was only fair that they would receive more than one denarius.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

that they would receive more money than the other workers

they would be given more than the others (CEV)

20:10c**But each of them also received a denarius.**

- But they also each received one denarius coin.
- However, the big/chief worker also gave/paid them only one silver coin.

But: In 20:10c, something unexpected happens. The BSB introduces this unexpected event with the conjunction But.

Here is another way to introduce this unexpected event:

However

each of them also received a denarius: If possible, translate this whole clause so that it is a surprising result. For example:

even they received a denarius

they also received only one denarius

Matthew 20:11**Section 20:1–16: Jesus told a parable about vineyard workers**

In this section, Jesus told a parable about some vineyard workers and the man who owned the vineyard. Even though the workers worked for a different number of hours, the owner gave them all the same pay. This parable continues the discussion about rewards for being a disciple (19:27–29). It also helps to explain the meaning of the saying “many who are first will be last, and the last will be first” (19:30). The main point of the parable is about God’s grace. In the kingdom, God gives his servants much more than they deserve. In the kingdom, the values are different than the values here on earth.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The story about men who worked in a field of grapes

A story that shows God’s generosity/grace

Rewards for serving God

This parable occurs only in the book of Matthew.

20:11**On receiving their pay, they began to grumble against the landowner.**

- When they received it, they started complaining to the landowner,
- After they had received their coin/wages, they began criticizing the owner of the field of grapes.

On receiving their pay: The words their pay refer to the single coin that the workers received as their wages.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

When they received their pay (NLT)

When they got their coin (NCV)

they began to grumble against: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as grumble means talked quietly and expressed unhappiness about something. In Greek, the form of this verb indicates that this grumbling started and was continuing.

The word translated as against also means “at.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

they began complaining to (CEV)

they started criticizing

the landowner: This phrase translates the same Greek word as in 20:1a. You should translate it here as you did there.

Matthew 20:12

Section 20:1–16: Jesus told a parable about vineyard workers

In this section, Jesus told a parable about some vineyard workers and the man who owned the vineyard. Even though the workers worked for a different number of hours, the owner gave them all the same pay. This parable continues the discussion about rewards for being a disciple (19:27–29). It also helps to explain the meaning of the saying “many who are first will be last, and the last will be first” (19:30). The main point of the parable is about God’s grace. In the kingdom, God gives his servants much more than they deserve. In the kingdom, the values are different than the values here on earth.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The story about men who worked in a field of grapes

A story that shows God’s generosity/grace

Rewards for serving God

This parable occurs only in the book of Matthew.

20:12a

‘These men who were hired last worked only one hour,’ they said,

- saying, ‘These last men worked for only one hour,
- They said, ‘Those men whom you hired last worked only for a short time.

These men who were hired last: This phrase refers to the last men whom the master hired. These were the men whom he hired at 5 o’clock.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

These last workers (GW)

These men who were hired last (NIV)

These men whom you hired last

This phrase is an important link to the topic of the “first will be last, and the last will be first” (see 19:30). It is important to keep the word last here.

worked only one hour: The phrase one hour refers to a short period of time compared to the twelve hours that the first men worked.

The word only is not in the Greek text, but most English versions include it. This word helps to make clear that the men were complaining.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

worked only for a short time

worked only at the end

20:12b

‘and you have made them equal to us

- but you have treated them the same as us,
- Yet you have paid them just as much as you paid us^(excl).

and: In 20:12b, the first men complain of an unexpected result. The last men worked only one hour. So the first men expected that less work would result in less pay. But the master paid the last workers the same as the first workers.

Here are some other ways to introduce this unexpected result:

But (NCV)

Yet (GW)

you have made them equal to us: This clause means that the master acted towards the last workers in the same way as he did the first workers. In this context, it refers to the master giving the same amount of money to the last workers as he gave to the first workers.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

You treated them in the same way that you treated us

you paid them the same that you did us (CEV)

you've paid them just as much as you paid us (NLT)

The first workers did not complain about how much money they received. Rather they were jealous that those hired last got the same amount.

them: The pronoun them refers to the last workers whom the master hired.

us: The pronoun us refers to the first group of workers whom the master hired. It does not refer to any other workers. If you have inclusive and exclusive pronouns in your language, choose the pronoun that refers to the first group.

20:12c

who have borne the burden and the scorching heat of the day.'

- even though we have done most of the work and endured the heat all day!
- We^(excl) are the ones who have worked hard all day under the hot sun!

Verse 20:12c is a relative clause. It is a sentence that explains something about the pronoun "us" in 20:12b. In some languages, it will be more natural to start a new sentence here. For example:

We bore the burden of the day and the scorching heat.

who have borne the burden: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as borne means "carry." To "carry the burden of the day" is figurative speech. It refers to doing a day of hard work. The first workers worked hard all day, not the last workers. The first workers did most of the work that day. In that sense, they carried the burden.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

we worked hard all day (GW)

We have done most of the work...all day (NIRV)

We endured working all day

and the scorching heat of the day: The Greek noun that the BSB translates as scorching heat comes from a verb that means "burn up." It refers to the heat of the middle of the day when the sun is shining strongly. The ones hired last did not experience the hot sun when they worked.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in the hot sun (CEV)

in all the heat (NJB)

while it was hot

Matthew 20:13

Section 20:1–16: Jesus told a parable about vineyard workers

In this section, Jesus told a parable about some vineyard workers and the man who owned the vineyard. Even though the workers worked for a different number of hours, the owner gave them all the same pay. This parable continues the discussion about rewards for being a disciple (19:27–29). It also helps to explain the meaning of the saying "many who are first will be last, and the last will be first" (19:30). The main point of the parable is about God's grace. In the kingdom, God gives his servants much more than they deserve. In the kingdom, the values are different than the values here on earth.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The story about men who worked in a field of grapes

A story that shows God's generosity/grace

Rewards for serving God

This parable occurs only in the book of Matthew.

20:13a

But he answered one of them,

- But he answered one of them,
- Then the owner said to one of those workers,

But he answered: In this verse, the owner responded to the workers' complaint. He responded by disagreeing with them. The BSB shows this by starting his response with the conjunction But. In some languages, it will also be natural to begin this verse with a conjunction like But. In other languages, it will not be natural.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

He responded

The owner said (GW)

one of them: The pronoun them refers to the workers who complained. A group of workers complained, but the owner responded to just one of them.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

to one of those workers (NCV)

20:13b

‘Friend, I am not being unfair to you.

- ‘Friend, I am being fair/right/just with you^(sing).
- ‘My friend, I have not cheated you^(sing).

Friend: The owner responded to one of the workers by calling him Friend. Here are some reasons why the owner probably used this word:

1. He wanted to show in a friendly way that he did not agree with him.
2. He was using a mild rebuke.

Use a word or phrase in your language that has a similar function. For example:

My friend/comrade

Listen, friend (GNT)

I am not being unfair to you: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as I am not being unfair to you is more literally “I am not being unjust to you.” In this context, the master is saying that he has not cheated the worker.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I have not cheated you (GNT)

I am being fair to you. (NCV)

I have not deceived/tricked you.

you: In Greek, this pronoun is singular.

20:13c

Did you not agree with me on one denarius?

- You agreed with me to work for a denarius coin, did you not?
- Remember, you agreed to do a day’s work for me for the normal wage/pay.

Did you not agree with me on one denarius?: This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes that the master and the worker had agreed on a denarius.

There are two ways to translate this emphasis:

- As a rhetorical question expecting a “Yes” response. For example:

You and I agreed to a denarius for the day, did we not?

We agree on a denarius, isn’t it so?

- As a statement. The statement could follow a short command. For example:

You and I agreed that I would pay you a denarius.

Remember, you agreed that I would pay you normal day’s wage.

Translate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

Matthew 20:14

Section 20:1–16: Jesus told a parable about vineyard workers

In this section, Jesus told a parable about some vineyard workers and the man who owned the vineyard. Even though the workers worked for a different number of hours, the owner gave them all the same pay. This parable continues the discussion about rewards for being a disciple (19:27–29). It also helps to explain the meaning of the saying “many who are first will be last, and the last will be first” (19:30). The main point of the parable is about God’s grace. In the kingdom, God gives his servants much more than they deserve. In the kingdom, the values are different than the values here on earth.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The story about men who worked in a field of grapes

A story that shows God’s generosity/grace

Rewards for serving God

This parable occurs only in the book of Matthew.

20:14a

Take your pay and go.

- Take what is yours and go.

- Take your money and go home.

Take your pay: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Take your pay is more literally “what is yours.” It refers to the denarius coin that the worker had just received as pay.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Take what is yours (NET)

Take your money (GW)

and go: In this context, the verb go indicates that the owner dismissed the worker. He told the worker to leave with his pay.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

and leave

and go home

20:14b

I want to give this last man the same as I gave you.

- I want to give the man who was hired last the same pay that I gave you. (NCV)
- It is my will/desire to give to this man who started to work last as much as I give to you.

I want: The Greek verb that the BSB translates literally as I want indicates that the owner acted according to his own will.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I choose (ESV)

It is my wish/desire

to give: This same verb occurs in 20:4b. Translate it the same way as you did there. In some languages, it will be natural to use the word “pay.” For example:

to pay (NLT)

to give as pay

this last man: In Greek this phrase is more literally “to this last.” In 20:13a the owner responded to one man in the first group of workers. In the same way, he referred to one man in the last group. This continues

the theme of “the first” and “the last” throughout this parable.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

to this last man

to this last person

the same as I gave you: In Greek, this phrase is more literally “as also to you.” The owner chose to pay all the workers the same amount.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the same as I also give to you

as much as I gave you (GNT)

Matthew 20:15

Section 20:1–16: Jesus told a parable about vineyard workers

In this section, Jesus told a parable about some vineyard workers and the man who owned the vineyard. Even though the workers worked for a different number of hours, the owner gave them all the same pay. This parable continues the discussion about rewards for being a disciple (19:27–29). It also helps to explain the meaning of the saying “many who are first will be last, and the last will be first” (19:30). The main point of the parable is about God’s grace. In the kingdom, God gives his servants much more than they deserve. In the kingdom, the values are different than the values here on earth.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The story about men who worked in a field of grapes

A story that shows God’s generosity/grace

Rewards for serving God

This parable occurs only in the book of Matthew.

20:15a

Do I not have the right to do as I please with what is mine?

- It is lawful for me to do what I want to with my money, is it not?

- I can do what I want with my own money. (NCV)

Do I not have the right to do as I please with what is mine?: This is a rhetorical question. The owner used this rhetorical question to emphasize that he had the right to do what he wanted to do with his own money. He also used this rhetorical question as a mild rebuke.

Here are some other ways to translate this emphasis and rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Don't I have the right to do what I want with my own money? (NIV)

It is lawful for me to do what I want with my own money, is it not?

- As a statement. For example:

I can do what I want with my own money. (NCV)

Translate this rebuke and emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

Do I not have the right: The Greek word that the BSB translates as have the right refers to doing something that is lawful or right.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Is it not lawful for me (KJV)

Is it against the law (NLT)

Don't I have the right (CEV)

to do as I please: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as I please is more literally "I want." The same verb occurs in 20:14b. Translate it here as you did there.

with what is mine?: The words what is mine refer to "my things" or "my money."

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

with what is mine

with my own money (REB)

20:15b

Or are you envious because I am generous?

- Why are you envious when I am generous?
- You should not be jealous of the people to whom I am generous/good."

Or: One of the functions of the conjunction Or is to introduce a question that is parallel to a previous question. This conjunction also adds additional information. Here Or does not function to separate things. It does not indicate that only one of the two questions is true.

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. For example:

Are you jealous because I am good to those people? (NCV)

In some languages, it will not be natural to translate this conjunction either.

are you envious because I am generous?: This is a rhetorical question. It is a rebuke. The owner rebuked the worker for being jealous of his generosity toward the other workers.

Here are some other ways to translate this rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Why should you be envious because I am generous? (NJB)

Are you jealous because I am good to those people? (NCV)

- As a statement. For example:

You should not be jealous because I am good/ generous towards other people

- As a command. For example:

Do not be jealous of the ones to whom I have been generous.

Translate this rebuke in a way that is natural in your language.

are you envious: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as are you envious is more literally "is your eye evil?" This is an idiom. In Jesus' time, there were many uses of this idiom. In this context, it probably refers to jealousy or envy.

Here are some other ways to translate this idiom:

are you envious (NET)

Why should you be jealous (CEV)

are you annoyed

because I am generous: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as because I am generous is more literally “because I am good.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

because I am good

because I am kind to others (NLT)

General Comment on 20:15b

Verse 20:15b is the end of the owner’s speech and the end of Jesus’ parable. The BSB indicates this with closing quotes. Your translation should clearly indicate that the parable ends here.

Matthew 20:16

Section 20:1–16: Jesus told a parable about vineyard workers

In this section, Jesus told a parable about some vineyard workers and the man who owned the vineyard. Even though the workers worked for a different number of hours, the owner gave them all the same pay. This parable continues the discussion about rewards for being a disciple (19:27–29). It also helps to explain the meaning of the saying “many who are first will be last, and the last will be first” (19:30). The main point of the parable is about God’s grace. In the kingdom, God gives his servants much more than they deserve. In the kingdom, the values are different than the values here on earth.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The story about men who worked in a field of grapes

A story that shows God’s generosity/grace

Rewards for serving God

This parable occurs only in the book of Matthew.

20:16a

So the last will be first,

- So those people who are last will be first,
- Then Jesus said, “In this way those people who are small/humble now will be big/great in the future.

The words in 20:16 are not part of Jesus’ parable. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this clear. Some ways to do this are to add some words of introduction. For example:

And Jesus concluded (GNT)

Jesus then said (CEV)

So: The Greek word that the BSB translates as So indicates that 20:16 is the conclusion that Jesus made from the parable.

Here are some other ways to translate it:

Therefore

In this way (GW)

the last will be first: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the last is more literally “the last ones.” It refers to people who are last. They are last in the sense of importance now. As the owner paid the last workers first, God will take those in the world who are lowest in status and make them great in his kingdom.

These words are similar to 19:30b. You should translate it in a similar way here. For example:

people who are last will be first

people who are low/humble now will become high/great

those who have the last place now will have the first place in the future (NCV)

The Greek does not necessarily imply that all who are last will be first. You should avoid words like “all” or “everyone” or even “many” here. In 19:30, the Greek has the word translated “many,” but here it does not. However, if translating without a word like “many” implies “all,” then you may want to use the word “many” from 19:30.

20:16b

and the first will be last.”

- and those people who are first will be last.”

- Those people who are big/great now will be small/humble in the future.”

and the first will be last: Some later Greek manuscripts include the clause “for many are called but few chosen.” The editors of the UBS Greek New Testament judged this clause most likely added by copyists who were thinking about the close of the parable in 22:14. Thus the editors decided with their highest confidence that this clause was not original and did not include it in the UBS Greek text. The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the first is more literally “the first ones.” It refers to people who are first. They are first in the sense of most importance now. But in the future, they will be last in importance.

These words are similar to 19:30a. You should translate it in a similar way here. For example:

and people who are first will be last

and people who are high/great now will become low/humble

and those who have the first place now will have the last place in the future (NCV)

Matthew 20:17

Section 20:17–19: Jesus said again that he will die

In this section, Jesus predicted his death a third time. Each time Jesus said that he would die (16:21, 17:23 and here), he also said that he would become alive again. This time, he further predicted that the Romans would crucify him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus again predicted his death and resurrection

Jesus spoke a third time about others killing him

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 10:32–34 and Luke 18:31–34.

20:17a

As Jesus was going up to Jerusalem,

- ¶ While Jesus was going up to Jerusalem,
- ¶ When Jesus was on the way/road to Jerusalem with his twelve disciples,

As: This is the beginning of a new section. In Greek, this section begins with a conjunction. Here, this

conjunction probably simply indicates that the story continues, which the BSB translates as *As*. There is no obvious connection between this section and what comes before it. Perhaps for that reason, many English versions do not translate this conjunction.

You should use a natural way in your language to begin this new section. For example:

When

While

Jesus was going up to Jerusalem: When the writers of the Bible said that people were going to Jerusalem, they usually said that they were going up to Jerusalem. This is because the city of Jerusalem was higher than most parts of the land of Israel. It was located in the mountains at an altitude of about 800 meters above sea level.

In some languages, it is natural to speak of going up or down when traveling on a road. In other languages, this may not be natural, or it may not be understood. If that is true in your language, you may use a more general expression. For example:

as Jesus was going to Jerusalem

The disciples were with Jesus on this journey, as 20:17b indicates. In some languages, it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

as Jesus was going up to Jerusalem with his disciples

as Jesus and his twelve disciples were going up to Jerusalem

20:17b

He took the twelve disciples aside and said,

- he took aside the twelve disciples and said to them on the road,
- he wanted to speak to them in private. So while they were walking he called them to the side and said,

He took the twelve disciples aside: There is a textual issue in this verse. The word disciples does not occur in all manuscripts.

Many Greek manuscripts, including early important ones, include the word disciples. Most English versions, including the BSB, follow these manuscripts.

(BSB, ESV, NIV84, NASB, RSV, KJV, NLT, GNT, CEV, JBP)

Some early Greek manuscripts do not include the word. A few English versions follow these manuscripts. For example:

he took the Twelve aside (NET) (NIV2011, NET, NJB, REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most English versions. Even if the word disciples were not part of the Greek text, it would be natural to add it in some languages to make the meaning clear.

He took...aside: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as took...aside means that Jesus went with his disciples apart from the larger group of people. He did this to speak to them in private. They were probably with a much larger group of pilgrims going up to Jerusalem for the Passover feast. But Jesus wanted to speak to his disciples alone.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

he called/asked the twelve disciples to gather by themselves

he asked his twelve disciples to separate themselves

and said: There are two ways to interpret the Greek phrase that the BSB leaves untranslated after and said:

It should be translated as a separate phrase. For example:

he took the twelve aside privately and said to them on the way (NET) (ESV, NET, NASB, RSV, REB, GNT, JBP)

The idea is included in the verb “going up” (in 20:17a). It is not translated separately. For example:

he took the twelve disciples aside and said to them (NIV) (BSB, NIV, NJB, KJV, NLT, CEV, NCV, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Jesus probably spoke to the disciples as they walked along the road. They did not stop for a meeting.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

along the way

while they were walking

Matthew 20:18

Section 20:17–19: Jesus said again that he will die

In this section, Jesus predicted his death a third time. Each time Jesus said that he would die (16:21, 17:23 and here), he also said that he would become alive again. This time, he further predicted that the Romans would crucify him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus again predicted his death and resurrection

Jesus spoke a third time about others killing him

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 10:32–34 and Luke 18:31–34.

20:18a

“Look, we are going up to Jerusalem,

- “Look, we^(incl) are going up to Jerusalem,
- “We^(incl) are going to Jerusalem.

Look: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Look draws attention to the words that follow. If it is natural in your language to use such a word or phrase, you may want to include it here. Here are some examples:

See (ESV)

Listen (GNT)

Pay attention to this

Some English versions do not translate this word. For example:

We are going up to Jerusalem (NIV)

In some languages, it may not be natural to translate this word either.

we are going up to Jerusalem: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as going up is the same verb as in 20:17a. You should use the same verb here.

20:18b

and the Son of Man will be delivered over

- and the Son of Man will be put into the hands
- There, someone will hand/give me, the Son of Man over

the Son of Man: Jesus used the phrase the Son of Man to refer to himself. In some languages, it may be necessary to add the pronoun “I” to show that Jesus was referring to himself. For example:

I, the Son of Man

In Matthew, this phrase first occurs in 8:20b. See the Note there for more information on translating it. This phrase last occurred in 19:28c.

will be delivered over: The Greek word that the BSB translates as delivered over means “handed over to the power of someone else.” It often refers to a person being betrayed and delivered to his enemies.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

will be betrayed (NIV)

will be handed over (GNT)

This is a passive verb. Here the text does not specify who would betray Jesus. From later in Matthew, it is clear that Judas would betray Jesus. This would fulfill God’s plan. However, you should not make Judas explicit here. If you need to use an active verb, translate in a general way. For example:

someone is going to betray

This same verb occurs in 17:22b.

20:18c to the chief priests and scribes.

- of the leaders of the priests and the teachers of the Law of Moses.
- to the leading priests and the teachers of religious law.

chief priests: A priest was a religious leader who offered sacrifices to God for the people. Jewish priests led the people in worship at the temple in Jerusalem. The phrase chief priests refers to the leaders among these priests.

Here are some other ways to translate chief priests:

- Use a descriptive term that focuses on the duty of priests. For example:

the leaders of the sacrificers

the elders among the men who offer sacrifices to God

the leaders of those who represent people to God

- Use a local word for priest. This option may be acceptable if the duties of a local priest are similar to those of a Jewish priest. You may need to indicate that the word refers to a Jewish priest. For example:

Jewish people’s leading priests/sacrificers

The term chief priests also occurs in 16:21c. You should translate it here as you did there.

scribes: The Greek word that the BSB translates as scribes refers to men who studied, interpreted, and taught the law of Moses. These men were called scribes because their original work was to copy the laws of Moses by hand. (A scribe is someone who copies manuscripts.) In New Testament times, this was no longer their main task.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

teachers of the Law of Moses (CEV)

teachers of religious law (NLT)

teachers of the law (NIV)

experts in the law

Translate this term in the same way as you did in 12:38a, 15:1a, and 16:21c.

20:18d They will condemn Him to death

- Then they will sentence him to die.
- They will judge him/me as guilty and give a punishment of death.

They will condemn Him to death: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as condemn Him means “will judge him guilty.” The addition of the phrase to death means that the punishment that they would give Jesus would be that he should die.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

They will sentence him to die (NLT)

they will say that he must die (NCV)

they will judge him as guilty of breaking the law and give a punishment of death

Matthew 20:19

Section 20:17–19: Jesus said again that he will die

In this section, Jesus predicted his death a third time. Each time Jesus said that he would die (16:21, 17:23 and here), he also said that he would become alive again. This time, he further predicted that the Romans would crucify him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus again predicted his death and resurrection

Jesus spoke a third time about others killing him

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 10:32–34 and Luke 18:31–34.

20:19a

and will deliver Him over to the Gentiles

- Then they will put him into the hands of the Gentiles,
- Then they in turn will give him/me to foreigners/Romans.

will deliver Him over to the Gentiles: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as deliver...over is the same verb as in 20:18b. Most English versions translate this Greek verb with the same English expression in both places. However, notice that the NIV uses different expressions. So does the NET.

20:18b

will be betrayed (NIV)

will be handed over (NET)

20:19a

turn him over (NIV)

turn him over (NET)

In 20:18b, Jesus said that someone would deliver him over to the chief priests and scribes to be judged. Then in 20:19a, he said that the chief priests and scribes would in turn deliver him over to the Gentiles to

be crucified/killed. The purpose was different in each case. Also, in the first case, it was one of his own disciples who delivered him over.

Here, you should use a verb that is appropriate for delivering someone over to be killed.

the Gentiles: Jews used the word Gentiles to refer to all the people groups beside themselves. In this context, this word refers to the Romans. They were the only ones with the authority to execute someone.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the Romans (NLT)

foreigners (CEV)

the non-Jewish people (NCV)

20:19b

to be mocked and flogged

- who will ridicule and severely whip him
- They will make fun of him/me and strongly whip me/him

to be mocked: The Greek word that the BSB translates as be mocked means “ridicule” or “make fun of.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

ridicule (JBP)

make fun of him (GNT)

abuse with words

and flogged: The Greek word that the BSB translates as flogged means “beat with a whip.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

whip (GNT)

hit/strike with a whip of leather

This word is also in 10:17c. You should translate it the same way in both places.

20:19c

and crucified.

- and nail him on a cross to die.
- and kill him/me on a cross.

and crucified: The Greek word that the BSB translates as crucified means “fastened to a cross to die.” This is the first time in Matthew that this word occurs.

Being crucified was a form of execution. Soldiers fastened the condemned person to an upright wooden post. They spread his arms out to either side. Then they fastened his arms to a cross-beam with ropes on his arms and/or nails through his wrists. They nailed his feet to the upright part of the cross. It was usually a long, agonizing and very public form of punishment. It ended when the person was no longer strong enough to push himself up with his feet and get a breath. So he suffocated and died. This sometimes happened days later.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

and kill him on a cross

and nail him on a wood post to kill him

20:19d

And on the third day He will be raised to life.”

- He will become alive again three days later.”
- On the third day after that, God will cause him to live again!”

on the third day He will be raised to life: The verb raised means “raised from the dead” or “brought back to life.”

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

he will become alive again

he will live again

This verb is passive. Here are some ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

on the third day, he will be raised to life again
(NCV)

he will be raised back to life by God on the third day

- Use an active verb. For example:

on the third day God will raise him from death to life

God will cause him to live again on the third day

This same clause is in 16:21e.

Matthew 20:20

Section 20:20–28: The mother of James and John asked Jesus for something

In this section, Jesus again dealt with the issue of who is important. In 18:1–4, the disciples had asked Jesus “Who then is the greatest in the kingdom of heaven?” Jesus had answered them there. Here, the mother of James and John asked Jesus to give her two sons the most important positions in his kingdom. Jesus again responded to the disciples’ concern to become important people.

Jesus said that the most important person in his kingdom is the person who behaves like a servant rather than like someone in charge. He finished by saying that he himself came to help other people rather than to ask other to help him. He showed that the values in his kingdom are different than the values here on earth.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Request of the Mother of James and John
(NRSV)

The mother of James and John asks Jesus to make her sons the most people in his kingdom

Jesus Teaches about Serving Others (NLT)

There is a parallel passage for this section in Mark 10:35–45.

20:20a

Then the mother of Zebedee’s sons came to Jesus with her sons

- ¶ Then the mother of the sons of Zebedee approached Jesus with her sons.
- ¶ After this the wife of Zebedee and her two sons came to Jesus.

Then: This verse is the beginning of a new section. The events in this section probably occurred immediately after the events in the preceding section. The Greek introduces this story with a word that the BSB translates as Then.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Soon after that

After that

the mother of Zebedee's sons: This woman was the mother of James and John. Her husband was Zebedee. She was probably Jesus' aunt. The name of this woman was probably Salome (see 27:56 and Mark 15:40). It is possible she was the sister of Jesus' mother (see John 19:25).

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the wife of Zebedee (GNT)

the mother of James and John, the sons of Zebedee (NLT)

The mother of James and John (CEV)

Zebedee's sons: In this section, Matthew does not mention the names of these two sons. From 4:21, we know that their names were James and John. They were the first disciples whom Jesus called.

In some languages, it will be natural to:

- Include their names in the text. For example:

James and John, the sons of Zebedee (NLT)

- Add a footnote explaining who these sons were. Here is a sample footnote:

The sons of Zebedee were James and John. They were the first disciples whom Jesus called. Their mother was probably named Salome and was possibly the sister of Jesus' mother.

with her sons: In some languages, it may be more natural to put this phrase before the verb "came." For example:

Then the wife of Zebedee and her two sons approached Jesus.

The mother was the one who asked Jesus a question, but James and John were also there at the time. In 20:22 Jesus spoke directly to those two men.

20:20b

and knelt down to make a request of Him.

- She got down on the ground before him and asked him to do something for her.
- She knelt/bowed down in front of him and said to him, "Lord, I want to ask you a favor."

and knelt down: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as knelt down is more literally "prostrating herself before him." This indicates that the woman wanted to show Jesus great respect and honor. A person usually did that by bending over with his/her face toward the ground, or actually lying face down on the ground.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

she prostrated herself before him

bowed before him (GNT)

she put her face to the ground in front of him

she got on the ground in front of him

Even though the woman and her two sons approached Jesus, the form of this verb is feminine. This means that only the mother knelt in front of Jesus.

This same word, in the same sort of context, is in 18:26a. You should translate it the same way in both places.

to make a request of Him: This verb phrase is more literally "she asked something from him."

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

she asked him to do something for her (NCV)

she begged him to do her a favor

In some languages, it may be more natural to translate this as direct speech. For example:

she said, "Please give me what I want."

"Lord, I want to ask you for something."

"Sir, I have a favor to ask you."

Matthew 20:21

Section 20:20–28: The mother of James and John asked Jesus for something

In this section, Jesus again dealt with the issue of who is important. In 18:1–4, the disciples had asked Jesus “Who then is the greatest in the kingdom of heaven?” Jesus had answered them there. Here, the mother of James and John asked Jesus to give her two sons the most important positions in his kingdom. Jesus again responded to the disciples’ concern to become important people.

Jesus said that the most important person in his kingdom is the person who behaves like a servant rather than like someone in charge. He finished by saying that he himself came to help other people rather than to ask other to help him. He showed that the values in his kingdom are different than the values here on earth.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Request of the Mother of James and John (NRSV)

The mother of James and John asks Jesus to make her sons the most people in his kingdom

Jesus Teaches about Serving Others (NLT)

There is a parallel passage for this section in Mark 10:35–45.

20:21a

“What do you want?” He inquired.

- He asked her, “What do you^(sing) want?”
- He asked her, “What is it that you^(sing) are asking for?”

“What do you want?” He inquired: Jesus asked the woman a question. So, here it may be more natural to use the verb “asked” rather than inquired. For example:

he asked her (JBP)

What do you want?: In Greek, the pronoun you is singular. Jesus asked the woman what she wanted.

20:21b

She answered, “Declare that in Your kingdom one of these two sons of mine may sit

- She said to him, “Promise that one of these two sons of mine will sit in your kingdom,
- And she replied, “Please allow/permit my two sons here to sit in the most honored positions when you become king.

Declare that: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as Declare that is the ordinary verb “speak.” Here it is in the form of a command, but the context indicates it is the mother’s request. Her request is that Jesus promise her something.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Promise that (NCV)

Please let (CEV)

Permit (NET)

I would like that

in Your kingdom: This phrase refers to the time when Jesus would reign as king. Here is another way to translate it:

when you are king (JBP)

when you sit to rule

one of these two sons of mine: The woman used the word these to refer to the two sons who were there with her. We cannot know how many sons she had in all. It’s possible she had more than two, but she was asking on behalf of these two. You should avoid translating in a way that implies that they were her only sons.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

one of my two sons here

may sit: In many cultures, the position of greatest honor and authority underneath the king is at the king’s side. The woman was asking Jesus to give her sons the second most important positions in his kingdom.

In some languages, it may be natural to include some of this implied information in the text. For example:

sit in places of honor next to you (NLT)

In other languages, this information can be included in a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

The right hand side of a king's throne was the place for the king's most powerful official. The left hand side was also an important position. In this context, both would be equally important.

20:21c

at Your right hand, and the other at Your left."

- one at your right hand and the other at your left hand."
- Allow one son to sit on your right side and the other son to sit on your left side."

at Your right hand: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as at Your right hand means "on your right side." It refers to the most important position next to the king.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

on your right side

and the other at Your left: The phrase that the BSB translates as at Your left means "on your left side." This place would usually be a lesser position near the king. But in this context, the mother did not name which son should be in which position. So the important meaning is that these were the most important places for anyone.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

on your left side

Matthew 20:22

Section 20:20–28: The mother of James and John asked Jesus for something

In this section, Jesus again dealt with the issue of who is important. In 18:1–4, the disciples had asked Jesus "Who then is the greatest in the kingdom of heaven?" Jesus had answered them there. Here, the mother of James and John asked Jesus to give her two sons the most important positions in his kingdom. Jesus again responded to the disciples' concern to become important people.

Jesus said that the most important person in his kingdom is the person who behaves like a servant rather than like someone in charge. He finished by saying that he himself came to help other people rather than to ask other to help him. He showed that the values

in his kingdom are different than the values here on earth.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Request of the Mother of James and John (NRSV)

The mother of James and John asks Jesus to make her sons the most people in his kingdom

Jesus Teaches about Serving Others (NLT)

There is a parallel passage for this section in Mark 10:35–45.

20:22a

"You do not know what you are asking," Jesus replied.

- Jesus said, "You^(dual/plur) do not understand what you^(dual/plur) are asking for.
- Jesus said to them, "You^(dual/plur) do not realize what you are requesting.

"You do not know what you are asking," Jesus replied: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as know means "have information about something." The disciples asked for these positions of authority without fully knowing what it might mean to have them. By asking to have authority with Jesus, they were asking to suffer with him.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

You do not understand what you are asking (REB)

You don't realize what you're asking. (GW)

You do not know what you are asking: In Greek, You do not know and you are asking are plural. The mother alone asked Jesus a question, but Jesus responded to the two sons. It is possible that he included the mother in his response. But because the two men answered in 20:22c, it is best to understand Jesus' response as addressed to the sons. If your language has both plural and dual pronouns, you should use dual pronouns here.

20:22b

"Can you drink the cup I am going to drink?"

- Are you^(plur/dual) able to drink from the cup of suffering that I am about to drink?"

- Do you^(plur/dual) have the strength/power to suffer like I will soon suffer?"

Can you drink the cup I am going to drink?: Some Greek manuscripts include a clause here and in the next verse: "and to be baptized with the baptism that I am baptized with." The UBS editors judged these clauses most likely added by a later copyist to make Matthew's account the same as Mark's. The editors decided with their highest confidence that these clauses were not original and did not include them in the UBS text. Only the KJV translates these clauses. The expression drink the cup is a complex figure of speech. The cup represents the contents of the cup. The expression drink the cup compares suffering with drinking the contents of a cup. This metaphor was used in the Old Testament to represent suffering. See Isaiah 51:17-23 and Lamentations 4:21. This metaphor is also used in the Old Testament to refer to God's judgment, particularly the punishment of the wicked, and even blessing. Here it refers to suffering.

In this context, Jesus used this figure of speech to refer to the suffering that he would experience. In the Bible, the Greek and Hebrew words that some English versions translate as cup sometimes refer to something that people had to experience. It could be something good (Psalm 116:13) or something bad (Isaiah 51:17). In other words, Jesus asked the disciples if they were able to suffer in the same way that he would suffer.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

- Keep the metaphor and clearly show that the word cup represents the contents of the cup. For example:

Are you able to drink from the cup that I must soon drink from? (CEV)

- Keep the metaphor but make explicit the meaning of the word cup. For example:

Can you drink the cup of suffering that I am about to drink? (GNT)

- Change the metaphor to a simile and make the meaning of cup explicit. For example:

Can you suffer with me, as though we drank suffering from the same cup?

- State the meaning directly. For example:

Can you endure the suffering that I will experience?

The word "cup" is used as a figure of speech in various places in both the Old and New Testaments. If it is not possible to use this figure of speech in your language, you may want to add a footnote that gives the literal meaning. Here is a sample footnote:

What Jesus literally said was, "Can you drink the cup that I drink?" The phrase "drink the cup" is a metaphor. In the Old Testament it often referred to the experience of suffering or of punishment from God. Here it refers to the suffering that Jesus was about to experience.

Can you: This Greek verb that the BSB translates as Can you means "Do you have the capacity to do something."

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

Is it possible for you

Are you capable

Do you have the strength/power

I am going to drink: In Greek, this clause is more literally "that I am about to drink." The Greek word that means "about to" indicates that this would happen in the near future.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

that I am about to drink (NET)

that I am soon to drink

20:22c

"We can," the brothers answered.

- They^(dual) answered him, "We^(excl/dual) are able."
- They^(dual) said, "Yes, we^(excl/dual) have the strength/power."

We can: In some languages, it may be natural to add the word "Yes" here. For example:

Yes, we are able

We: If your language has both inclusive and exclusive pronouns, the pronoun We should be exclusive here. If

your language has both plural and dual pronouns, the pronoun We should be dual here.

can: The verb can is the same verb as in 20:22b. You should translate it the same way in both places. For example:

Is it possible

We are capable

We have the strength/power

Matthew 20:23

Section 20:20–28: The mother of James and John asked Jesus for something

In this section, Jesus again dealt with the issue of who is important. In 18:1–4, the disciples had asked Jesus “Who then is the greatest in the kingdom of heaven?” Jesus had answered them there. Here, the mother of James and John asked Jesus to give her two sons the most important positions in his kingdom. Jesus again responded to the disciples’ concern to become important people.

Jesus said that the most important person in his kingdom is the person who behaves like a servant rather than like someone in charge. He finished by saying that he himself came to help other people rather than to ask other to help him. He showed that the values in his kingdom are different than the values here on earth.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Request of the Mother of James and John (NRSV)

The mother of James and John asks Jesus to make her sons the most people in his kingdom

Jesus Teaches about Serving Others (NLT)

There is a parallel passage for this section in Mark 10:35–45.

20:23a

“You will indeed drink My cup,” Jesus said.

- Then Jesus told them, “Indeed, you^(plur/dual) will drink the cup of suffering which I will drink.

- Jesus said, “You^(plur/dual) will certainly suffer like I will suffer.

You will indeed drink My cup: In Greek, this clause includes the word indeed, a word that the some versions do not translate. In this context, this word affirms the truth of this statement. The next clause (20:23b) is matched to it and gives a contrasting idea.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

You will indeed drink from my bitter cup (NLT)

You certainly will drink from my cup! (CEV)

It is true that you will suffer like I will soon suffer

drink My cup: As in 20:22b, the word cup represents suffering. The phrase My cup refers to the suffering that Jesus was going to experience in Jerusalem.

You should translate the expression drink My cup in a similar way to 20:22b.

20:23b

“But to sit at My right or left is not Mine to grant.

- But to sit on my right side or my left side, I am not the person who gives those seats.
- But I am not the person who gives someone a place to sit on my right hand and my left. But I am not the one who chooses/decides the person who will sit at my right side and the person who will sit at my left side.

But: There is a contrast between 20:23a and 20:23b–c. James and John would certainly suffer like Jesus (20:23a). But that does not mean that they will have the places of honor (20:23b–c) next to him.

The BSB indicates this contrast with the conjunction But.

to sit at My right or left: As in 20:21c, the phrase right or left means “left side or right side.” The left and right sides of a king were positions of honor.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

as for who sits on my right and left

the person will sit on my right side and left side

In some languages, it is more natural to put this clause after “is not Mine to grant.” See the Display for an example.

is not Mine to grant: In Greek, this clause is more literally “this is not mine to give.” Jesus implied that he did not have the authority to give those positions of honor to anyone.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I do not have permission to give

I do not have the authority to say who

I have no right to say who (NLT)

20:23c

These seats belong to those for whom My Father has prepared them.”

- Rather, those seats are for those people whom my Father chooses. He has already prepared those seats for them.”
- Instead, it is my Father who has prepared those seats for certain people, and he will give those seats to them.”
- My father has decided the people who will sit in those places/seats, and he has already prepared those seats for them.”

There is a contrast here. The contrast is between a negative clause (in 20:23b) and a positive clause here in 20:23c. The negative clause is “to sit at My right...is not Mine to grant.” The positive clause is “These seats belong to those for whom My Father has prepared them.” Languages have different ways to indicate this negative-positive type of contrast. Here are some of the ways:

- With the conjunction “but.”
- With a conjunction other than “but.” This is a common way in English to show this type of contrast. For example:

Rather (NET)

on the contrary

Instead

- With no conjunction. For example:

These places belong to those for whom they have been prepared by my Father. (NIV)

These seats belong to those: The BSB has added the words These seats belong. These words are not in Greek. The BSB has added them to make the sentence more natural in English.

The ESV expresses a similar idea by adding “it is for those,” probably using the singular word “it” to refer to the role or function that the two brothers wanted to have in the kingdom. It is also possible to use a plural word. For example:

Those places belong to those (NIV)

Those seats are for those people

for whom My Father has prepared them: This clause means that the Father has already decided who will sit on the right and left side of Jesus. He has already prepared that role/function for certain people. He has already made ready those places for people whom he has chosen.

In the Greek this clause is a passive. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

for whom they have been prepared by my Father (NIV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

for whom my Father has prepared them (GNT)

My Father has already prepared these positions for certain people. (GW)

My Father has already decided who will sit in those places.

Matthew 20:24

Section 20:20–28: The mother of James and John asked Jesus for something

In this section, Jesus again dealt with the issue of who is important. In 18:1–4, the disciples had asked Jesus “Who then is the greatest in the kingdom of heaven?” Jesus had answered them there. Here, the mother of James and John asked Jesus to give her two sons the most important positions in his kingdom. Jesus again responded to the disciples’ concern to become important people.

Jesus said that the most important person in his kingdom is the person who behaves like a servant rather than like someone in charge. He finished by saying that he himself came to help other people rather than to ask other to help him. He showed that the values in his kingdom are different than the values here on earth.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Request of the Mother of James and John (NRSV)

The mother of James and John asks Jesus to make her sons the most people in his kingdom

Jesus Teaches about Serving Others (NLT)

There is a parallel passage for this section in Mark 10:35–45.

20:24a

When the ten heard about this,

- ¶ When the ten others heard about that,
- ¶ When the other ten disciples heard about what the two brothers James and John had asked,

When the ten heard about this: Somehow, the other ten disciples heard/learned that James' and John's mother had asked Jesus to give them places of special honor. The text does not indicate who told them, or how they heard about it.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

When the ten heard it (ESV)

When the ten other disciples heard what James and John had asked (NLT)

the ten: This phrase refers to the other ten disciples. In some languages, it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

the other ten disciples (GNT)

20:24b

they were indignant with the two brothers.

- they became angry with the two brothers.
- they were upset/annoyed with them^(dual).

they were indignant: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as indignant means “angry.” Matthew uses it in two other places to describe inappropriate anger (21:15 and 26:8). The other disciples were upset that James and John were trying to get ahead of them. They were angry because they were jealous.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

became angry (GNT)

very upset/annoyed

Matthew 20:25

Section 20:20–28: The mother of James and John asked Jesus for something

In this section, Jesus again dealt with the issue of who is important. In 18:1–4, the disciples had asked Jesus “Who then is the greatest in the kingdom of heaven?” Jesus had answered them there. Here, the mother of James and John asked Jesus to give her two sons the most important positions in his kingdom. Jesus again responded to the disciples’ concern to become important people.

Jesus said that the most important person in his kingdom is the person who behaves like a servant rather than like someone in charge. He finished by saying that he himself came to help other people rather than to ask other to help him. He showed that the values in his kingdom are different than the values here on earth.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Request of the Mother of James and John (NRSV)

The mother of James and John asks Jesus to make her sons the most people in his kingdom

Jesus Teaches about Serving Others (NLT)

There is a parallel passage for this section in Mark 10:35–45.

20:25a

But Jesus called them aside and said,

- So Jesus called his disciples together and said,
- Jesus told all of them to gather together. Then he said to them,

But: There is a mild contrast here. The disciples were concerned about who among them would be the leader. Jesus was concerned about teaching them to be servants. The Greek indicates this contrast with the conjunction that the BSB translates as But.

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. Other versions use the word “So” here. You should connect this verse to the previous verses in a way that is natural in your language.

Jesus called them aside: This clause indicates that Jesus asked the disciples to gather around him. The pronoun them probably refers to all twelve disciples. It does not just refer to the two brothers.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus called them all together (GNT)

Jesus asked the disciples to gather around him

20:25b–c (combined)

- “You^(plur) know that the chiefs and big men of other nations rule/govern their people.

Verse 20:25b and 20:25c are a parallelism. This means that they are two ways of saying the same thing. Notice the parallel parts in these two statements:

^{25b}You know that the rulers of the Gentiles lord it over them, ^{25c}and their great ones exercise authority over them.

Jesus repeated this idea in order to emphasize it. You should show this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language. Some languages can repeat the idea. In other languages, it may be more natural to combine the two parts and translate them together. For example:

You know that the chiefs and big men of the Gentiles rule the people under them.

20:25b “You know that the rulers of the Gentiles lord it over them,

- “You^(plur) know that the Gentile rulers rule over their people,
- “You^(plur) know that the kings/chiefs of the non-Jews reign over their people.

You know that: Here Jesus stated something that the disciples already knew. He did not have to explain what he was talking about.

the rulers: The Greek word that the BSB translates as rulers refers to people who are in charge of others. In this context, it probably refers to people in charge of other countries.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

the leaders

chiefs/kings

of the Gentiles: Jews used the word Gentiles to refer to all the people groups beside themselves. This word also occurs in 20:19a.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

the non-Jewish people (NCV)

people who are not Jews

lord it over them: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as lord it over comes from the Greek noun which means “lord” or “master.” As a verb, this word refers to the action that a lord or master does. He rules over his people.

There are at least two ways to interpret this verb:

It is used in a neutral sense to simply mean rule. It is what rulers do. They rule/reign over their people. For example:

have power over (GNT) (GNT, GW, KJV)

It is used in a negative sense to mean abuse their power. For example:

love to show their power (NCV) (CEV, NCV)

Many English versions translate this verb using the same word as the noun “lord.” So it is not possible to tell which interpretation they follow.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This verb does not necessarily have a negative meaning associated with it. Recent scholarship (Kenneth W. Clark, “The Meaning of [κατα] κυριεύειν,” in *Studies in New Testament Language and Text* (ed. J. K. Elliott; NovTSup 44; Leiden: Brill, 1976), 100–105) suggests that

the verb with and without *κατα* attached mean essentially the same thing in their various contexts. Many other commentators [e.g. Osborne (741), Nolland (822), Davies and Allison (3.92), Carson (432)] agree that there should be no negative connotation to this word.

Jesus contrasted great men in this world with great men in the kingdom of God. Great men in this world rule over people. People serve them. Great men in the kingdom of God serve others. Jesus contrasted ruling and serving, not abusing power and serving.

them: The pronoun *them* refers to people governed by the rulers.

20:25c
and their superiors exercise authority over them.

- and their great men have authority over them.
- Their big men govern them.

their superiors: This phrase refers to men of high status who are in authority. It is parallel to “the rulers of the Gentiles” in 20:25b.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

great men (NJB)

those in high positions (NET)

their important leaders (NCV)

exercise authority over them: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as *exercise authority over* comes from the noun which means “authority.” As a verb, this word refers to the action that a man of authority does. He has/exercises authority over his people.

This verb is parallel to the verb “lord it over” in 20:25b. You should translate it in a similar way. For example:

have authority/power

rule/reign

govern

Matthew 20:26

Section 20:20–28: The mother of James and John asked Jesus for something

In this section, Jesus again dealt with the issue of who is important. In 18:1–4, the disciples had asked Jesus “Who then is the greatest in the kingdom of heaven?”

Jesus had answered them there. Here, the mother of James and John asked Jesus to give her two sons the most important positions in his kingdom. Jesus again responded to the disciples’ concern to become important people.

Jesus said that the most important person in his kingdom is the person who behaves like a servant rather than like someone in charge. He finished by saying that he himself came to help other people rather than to ask other to help him. He showed that the values in his kingdom are different than the values here on earth.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Request of the Mother of James and John (NRSV)

The mother of James and John asks Jesus to make her sons the most people in his kingdom

Jesus Teaches about Serving Others (NLT)

There is a parallel passage for this section in Mark 10:35–45.

20:26a
It shall not be this way among you.

- But that is not the way it should be among you^(plur).
- But you^(plur) must not be/act like that.

There is a contrast here. The contrast is between how the kings of the earth act (20:25b–c) and how the followers of Christ should act (20:26b–27). Some English versions indicate this contrast with the conjunction “But.” For example:

But it should not be that way among you. (NCV)

It shall not be this way among you: The pronoun *It* refers to the way leaders use their power and authority. The Greek word that the BSB translates this way means “like that.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Do not behave/act like that

You must not do/be like that

You must act differently

shall not be this way: The tense of the Greek verb that the BSB translates as shall not be is future. In this context, the future tense has the force of a command.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

must not be (NET)

should not be (NCV)

do not (CEV)

among you: The pronoun you refers to the disciples. Jesus spoke with the disciples as people who would become leaders of the church.

20:26b–27

As in 20:25b–c, verses 20:26b–c and 20:27 are a parallelism. This means that they are two ways of saying the same thing. (However, the statement in 20:27 is more intense.) Notice the parallel parts in these two statements:

^{26b} whoever wants to be great among you ^{26c} must be your servant, ²⁷ and whoever wants to be first among you must be your slave.

Jesus repeated this idea in order to emphasize it. You should show this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language. Some languages can repeat the idea. In other languages, it may be more natural to combine the two parts and translate them together. For example:

The person among you who wants to be an important person or the most important person, he must become like a slave and serve everyone.

Notice that this idea contrasts with the one in 20:25b–c.

20:26b

Instead, whoever wants to become great among you

- Instead, whoever wants to become great among you
- Rather, if any of you^(plur) wants to become an important/big person in God's kingdom,

Instead: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between a negative clause (in 20:26a) and a positive clause here in 20:26b. The negative clause is "It shall not be this way among you." The positive clause is "whoever wants to become great among you must be your servant." Languages have different ways to

indicate this negative-positive type of contrast. Here are some of the ways:

- With the conjunction *Instead*, as in the BSB.
- With a conjunction other than *Instead*. This is a common way in English to show this type of contrast. For example:

Rather

on the contrary

But (ESV)

- With no conjunction. For example:

it should not be that way among you. Whoever wants to become great among you must serve the rest of you like a servant. (NCV)

You should do what is natural in your language.

whoever wants to become great: The Greek verb phrase that the BSB translates as wants to become is more literally "might want to become." The word great refers to having high status/rank in God's kingdom.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

whoever would be great (ESV)

Whoever wants to be a leader (NLT)

If you desire/wish to be a big/important person in God's kingdom

among you: The pronoun you refers primarily to the twelve disciples Jesus addressed. But it also applies to the whole community of believers.

20:26c

must be your servant,

- must become the servant of the rest of you.
- he must serve the rest/others of you.

must be your servant: In Greek, the tense of must be future. But it functions as a command. Here the command is a bit unusual in that it is a third person command.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he must become the servant of the rest of you

it is necessary that he become your servant

your servant: The Greek word that the BSB translates as servant refers to someone who was responsible for household duties. It was a very low-status role. It is a different Greek word than the normal word for servant/slave (in 20:27).

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

servant of all the others (CEV)

servant of his companions

serve the rest/others of you

Matthew 20:27

Section 20:20–28: The mother of James and John asked Jesus for something

In this section, Jesus again dealt with the issue of who is important. In 18:1–4, the disciples had asked Jesus “Who then is the greatest in the kingdom of heaven?” Jesus had answered them there. Here, the mother of James and John asked Jesus to give her two sons the most important positions in his kingdom. Jesus again responded to the disciples’ concern to become important people.

Jesus said that the most important person in his kingdom is the person who behaves like a servant rather than like someone in charge. He finished by saying that he himself came to help other people rather than to ask other to help him. He showed that the values in his kingdom are different than the values here on earth.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Request of the Mother of James and John (NRSV)

The mother of James and John asks Jesus to make her sons the most people in his kingdom

Jesus Teaches about Serving Others (NLT)

There is a parallel passage for this section in Mark 10:35–45.

20:27a and whoever wants to be first among you

- And whoever wants to be the greatest person
- If any of you^(plur) wants to be the most important person, in God’s kingdom,

whoever wants to be: As in 20:26b, the Greek verb that the BSB translates as wants to be is more literally “might want to be.”

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

whoever would be (ESV)

if one of you desires/wishes

first among you: The Greek word that the BSB translates as first refers to the most important person in a group. This word is parallel to the word “great” in 20:26. But it is more intense. The word “great” refers to an important person. But the word first refers to the most important person.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

most important among you (GW)

the most important person among you

20:27b must be your slave—

- must become the slave of the rest of you.
- he must serve the rest of you as a slave.
- (combined)
- The person among you who wants to be an important person or the most important person in the kingdom, he must become like a slave and serve everyone.

must be your slave: As in 20:26c, the tense of must be is future in Greek. But it functions as a command. Here the command is a bit unusual in that it is a third person command.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he must become the slave of the rest of you

it is necessary that he become your slave

your slave: A slave was a person who was not free to do what he wanted. He had to follow the will of his owner. A slave was the lowest status and least important person in society. He was at the very bottom of the social order.

This word is parallel to the word “servant” in 20:26c. But it is more intense. The word “servant” refers to a person who had very low status in society. But the word slave refers to the person who was the lowest.

If your language does not have a separate word for slave, you should translate it in a similar way to “servant” but with a strengthening word. For example:

must serve all the rest of you in complete sub-
mission

must be like a common servant

Matthew 20:28

Section 20:20–28: The mother of James and John asked Jesus for something

In this section, Jesus again dealt with the issue of who is important. In 18:1–4, the disciples had asked Jesus “Who then is the greatest in the kingdom of heaven?” Jesus had answered them there. Here, the mother of James and John asked Jesus to give her two sons the most important positions in his kingdom. Jesus again responded to the disciples’ concern to become important people.

Jesus said that the most important person in his kingdom is the person who behaves like a servant rather than like someone in charge. He finished by saying that he himself came to help other people rather than to ask other to help him. He showed that the values in his kingdom are different than the values here on earth.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Request of the Mother of James and John
(NRSV)

The mother of James and John asks Jesus to make
her sons the most people in his kingdom

Jesus Teaches about Serving Others (NLT)

There is a parallel passage for this section in Mark 10:35–45.

20:28a

just as the Son of Man did not come to be served,

- just as the Son of Man did not come to be helped by others,

- In the same way, I, the Son of Man, did not come in order that others work for me/him.

just as: The Greek word that the BSB translates as just as means “in just the same way as.” This word indicates that what follows in 20:28 is similar in some way to what precedes. Jesus said that his followers should serve others just as he came to serve others.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

even as (ESV)

like (GNT)

In some languages, it will be natural to start a new sentence here. For example:

In the same way (NCV)

It’s the same way with the Son of Man (GW)

the Son of Man: Jesus used the phrase the Son of Man to refer to himself. In some languages, it may be necessary to add the pronoun “I” or “me” to show that Jesus was referring to himself. For example:

I, the Son of Man

In Matthew, this phrase first occurs in 8:20b. See the Note there for more information on translating it. This phrase last occurred in 20:18b.

did not come: The verb come refers to Jesus coming into the world. It does not refer to coming to the location near Jericho where he was when he spoke these words. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

came not into this world

did not become a human being

to be served: The Greek verb that the BSB translates to be served is based on the same word used in 20:26c that means “servant.” This verb means “to be given assistance/help.”

This is a passive clause. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

to be served (RSV)

to be helped

to have servants

- Use an active verb in a purpose clause. For example:

so that others would serve him

so that people work for him/me

so that people be his servants/helpers

20:28b

but to serve,

- rather/instead he came to help other people,
- I/He came in order to work for others/people,

but: This is the same contrasting conjunction as in 20:26b. It indicates a contrast between the negative clause “did not come to be served” (20:28a) and a positive clause “to serve” (here in 20:28b).

In some languages, it is more natural to use “rather” or “instead” here. In other languages, no conjunction is necessary (as in the NCV).

to serve: Some words from the previous clause are implied but not repeated here. In some languages, it may be necessary to make some of those words explicit. For example:

he came to serve others/people

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

to work for others

to help other people

he came to be the servant of other people

20:28c

and to give His life as a ransom for many.”

- and to die in order to pay to free many people from sin.”
- and to redeem/rescue many people with my his life.”

and to give His life: The phrase to give His life means “to die willingly for others” or “to voluntarily die to

benefit others.” Jesus willingly and freely came to die as a sacrifice for people’s sins.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

to give himself to be killed

to allow himself to be killed

to willingly die

as a ransom: The Greek word that the BSB translates as ransom means “the price of release.” This kind of payment was made either (a) to free prisoners captured in war or (b) to free slaves. Similarly, Jesus gave his life in order to pay to free people from their sin. His death was the ransom that released or redeemed people from their sin.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

as the way to buy/pay the freedom

to redeem (GNT)

to rescue (CEV)

to free

for many: The phrase for many means “on behalf of many people.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

for the sake of many people

so that many people may be saved

Matthew 20:29

Section 20:29–34: Jesus healed two blind people

In this section, Jesus healed two blind people. These blind people called Jesus the “Son of David” two times. This emphasizes who Jesus was just as he was about to enter Jerusalem as the Messiah. The blind people’s simple request to be healed is a stark contrast with James’ and John’s request for high positions.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Two blind men receive their sight

Jesus had mercy on two blind people and healed them

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 10:46–52 and Luke 18:35–43.

20:29

As they were leaving Jericho, a large crowd followed Him.

- ¶ Then, as Jesus and his disciples were leaving the town of Jericho, a large crowd followed him.
- ¶ Later Jesus and his disciples passed through the town of Jericho. As they were leaving, many people followed him.

The story in this section began sometime after the story in the previous section ended. The Greek text does not indicate how much time passed between these two stories. In some languages, it is natural to begin a new story with a time word or phrase. If your language is like that, use an expression here that is not too specific. For example:

Then

Later

In other languages, a time word or phrase is not necessary. Introduce this story in a natural way in your language.

As they were leaving Jericho: There is some implied information here. Matthew did not say that Jesus and his disciples had arrived at Jericho. He only says that they were leaving. In some languages, it may be important to include some of this implied information. For example:

Jesus and his disciples arrived at Jericho, and as they were leaving

After Jesus and his disciples had passed through Jericho

they: The pronoun they refers to Jesus and his disciples. In some languages, it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

Jesus and his disciples (NIV)

Jericho: Jericho was a town on the west side of the Jordan River. It was just a few kilometers from where the Jordan River runs into the Dead Sea. It was about

24 kilometer to the northeast of Jerusalem. Jerusalem was where Jesus and his disciples were going.

In some languages, it may be natural to say that Jericho is a town. For example:

the town of Jericho

a large crowd: The word large indicates that there was a great number of people in the crowd.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

a great many people (NCV)

a large group of people

followed Him: Here the phrase followed Him probably means “walked along with Jesus for some distance” (as in 19:2a). This probably indicates that the crowd was attracted to who Jesus was, what he said, and the miracles he did. The people wanted to see and hear him. They did not just happen to be on the same road as Jesus.

In other contexts, this word can mean “became a disciple of Jesus.” That is not the meaning here. Here you should translate followed in a more literal way. For example:

followed behind him

walked along behind/with him

Matthew 20:30

Section 20:29–34: Jesus healed two blind people

In this section, Jesus healed two blind people. These blind people called Jesus the “Son of David” two times. This emphasizes who Jesus was just as he was about to enter Jerusalem as the Messiah. The blind people’s simple request to be healed is a stark contrast with James’ and John’s request for high positions.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Two blind men receive their sight

Jesus had mercy on two blind people and healed them

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 10:46–52 and Luke 18:35–43.

20:30a

And there were two blind men sitting beside the road.

- Two blind men were sitting there beside/next to the road.
- On the side of the road sat two blind people.

The Greek word that the BSB leaves untranslated literally means “look” or “see.” Some English versions translate it as “behold.” This word brings attention to the words that follow. If you have an expression in your language that someone uses when he wants to bring attention to something that he is about to say, you should consider using it here.

Most English versions, including the BSB, do not translate this word here. See 19:16a and 19:27a for a similar context for this word.

there were two blind men: The Greek phrase the BSB translates as two blind men is more literally “two blind ones.” Most English versions translate this as two blind men. However, it is also possible that one of the two people was a woman. If possible, keep it as general as possible. For instance:

two blind people

sitting beside the road: Blind people in that part of the world usually had to beg for gifts from others in order to be able to eat. Worshipers going up to the Passover festival in Jerusalem were likely to give such gifts as a religious service. That is why these blind people were sitting beside the road.

The parallel passages in Mark and Luke use the word “beg.” However, Matthew does not make their begging explicit. If necessary, you can add a footnote to explain why the blind people were sitting beside the road. Here is a sample footnote:

These blind people were sitting beside the road in order to beg for gifts from the people going up to the Passover celebration.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

sitting by/beside the road

On the side of the road sat

20:30b

When they heard that Jesus was passing by, they cried out,

- When they heard people say that Jesus was passing by, they^(dual) shouted,
- As Jesus was passing by them, they^(dual) heard about it. So they^(dual) began to shout to Jesus,

When they heard that Jesus was passing by: The verb heard could indicate that:

1. these two people overheard the crowd talk about Jesus, or
2. someone actually told them Jesus was passing by.

It is even possible that both happened.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

they heard the crowd saying that Jesus was coming that way

when someone told them that Jesus was passing by

Someone said, “Jesus is going past,” so

they cried out: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as cried out means “shouted.” The context implies that they shouted like this so that Jesus would hear them. They were not shouting in an angry or impolite way.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

they shouted (NIV)

they began to shout (GNT)

20:30c

“Lord, Son of David, have mercy on us!”

- “Lord, Son of David, have pity on us!”
- “Sir, Descendant of David, please show kindness to us^(dual excl) and help us!”

Lord: There is a textual issue with the Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord: The UBS editors retained the word κύριε but placed it in brackets to show the uncertainty about its originality.

Some Greek manuscripts include this word. Most English versions follow these manuscripts. For example:

Lord, have mercy on us, Son of David! (NRSV) (BSB, ESV, NIV, NET, NRSV, NASB, KJV, NJB, NLT, GNT, CEV, NCV, JBP, GW)

Other Greek manuscripts do not include this word. Only a few English versions follow these manuscripts. For example:

Have mercy on us, Son of David! (RSV) (RSV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) and the majority of English versions.

The word Lord means “master.” It was a polite form that people used when they addressed a respected leader.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

sir (GNT)

Big man

Son of David: This phrase is a title that means that Jesus was a descendant of King David. The Jews used this title to refer to the Messiah (Christ), because God promised that the Messiah would be a descendant of David (Isaiah 9:6–7, 11:1–5, Jeremiah 23:5). In some languages, it may be necessary to make this information explicit. For example:

the Descendant of King David

the promised Son/Descendant of King David

In some languages, it may be helpful to add a footnote. Here is a sample footnote:

God promised that one of King David’s descendants would be the Messiah (Isaiah 9:6–7, 11:1–5, Jeremiah 23:5). The Jews were expecting this promised person to come, and they referred to him by the title “Son of David.”

This same phrase is in 9:27b. Translate it the same way in both places.

have mercy on us: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as have mercy on means “have compassion/pity for.” The Greek word translated as mercy is also the word from which the term for alms (see Matt 6:2) is derived. There, the BSB translates it as “give to the needy.” It is the kind of thing that beggars would ask

of people as they went past. The blind people were asking Jesus to help them in some way.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Have pity on us (REB)

pity us and help/heal us

show kindness to us

This expression is also in 9:27b. You should translate it the same way in both places.

Matthew 20:31

Section 20:29–34: Jesus healed two blind people

In this section, Jesus healed two blind people. These blind people called Jesus the “Son of David” two times. This emphasizes who Jesus was just as he was about to enter Jerusalem as the Messiah. The blind people’s simple request to be healed is a stark contrast with James’ and John’s request for high positions.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Two blind men receive their sight

Jesus had mercy on two blind people and healed them

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 10:46–52 and Luke 18:35–43.

20:31a

The crowd admonished them to be silent,

- The crowd scolded them so that they would be quiet,
- The people yelled at them to be quiet.
- Many in the crowd said to them^(dual), “Be quiet!”

The crowd admonished them: This clause indicates that some people or even many people in the crowd admonished the two blind people. This clause does not indicate that everyone in the crowd spoke in unison.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Many in the crowd admonished them

Many people admonished them^(dual)

admonished them: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as admonished means “spoke sternly” or “warned.”

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

scolded them (NET)

warned the blind men (NCV)

told them (GW)

to be silent: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as to be silent is more literally “in order that they might be silent.”

Here are some ways to translate this phrase:

- As the content of the rebuke. For example:

and told them to be quiet (NIV)

“Be quiet!” (NLT)

- As the purpose of the rebuke. This rendering is supported by Morris (515) and Osborne (748n5) as well as Hagner and Nolland in their translations. Further, BDAG offers this verse to support the function of ἵνα following ἐπιτιμάω (sense 1) as introducing “that which the censure or warning is to bring about or prevent.” For example:

to get them to be quiet (NET)

20:31b
but they cried out all the louder,

- but they shouted even louder,
- But instead, they^(dual) shouted with more force,

but: There is a contrast here. The crowd told the two blind people to be quiet, but they did not obey. The BSB indicates this contrast with the conjunction but.

Here are some other ways to indicate this contrast:

However

Instead

they cried out: The Greek word that the BSB translates as cried out means “shouted.” It is the same word as in 20:30b.

all the louder: The Greek word that the BSB translates as all the louder means “greater.” In this context it means “more.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

even more loudly (GNT)

with greater force

20:31c

“Lord, Son of David, have mercy on us!”

- “Lord, Son of David, have pity on us!”
- “Sir, Descendant of David, please show kindness to us^(dual excl) and help us!”

Lord, Son of David, have mercy on us: This is the exact same sentence as in 20:30c. You should translate it the same way in both places.

Matthew 20:32

Section 20:29–34: Jesus healed two blind people

In this section, Jesus healed two blind people. These blind people called Jesus the “Son of David” two times. This emphasizes who Jesus was just as he was about to enter Jerusalem as the Messiah. The blind people’s simple request to be healed is a stark contrast with James’ and John’s request for high positions.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Two blind men receive their sight

Jesus had mercy on two blind people and healed them

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 10:46–52 and Luke 18:35–43.

20:32a

Jesus stopped and called them.

- Jesus stood still and called them to come.
- Jesus heard them, and stopped walking and called them^(dual) to him.

Jesus stopped: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as stopped means “stood.” In this context, it indicates that Jesus stopped walking and stood still.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus stood still (NRSV)

called them: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as called means “called out to” or “summoned.” In this case, Jesus probably called the blind people to come to him. He did not just shout out to them from a distance. The parallel passage in Mark 10 reads: ⁴⁹Jesus stopped and said, “Call him.” So they called the blind man. “Take courage!” they said. “Get up! he is calling you.” ⁵⁰Throwing off his cloak, Bartimaeus jumped up and came to Jesus. (BSB)

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

called them over (NJB)

called them to come

called them to him

20:32b

“What do you want Me to do for you?” He asked.

- Then he said, “What deed would you^(plur) like me to do for you?”
- Then he asked them what they wanted him to do for them.

What do you want Me to do for you?: This is a similar question to the general one Jesus asked the mother of the two Zebedee brothers in 20:21a. Here it is a more explicit question about what he could do for these two.

In some languages, it may be more natural to translate this question as indirect speech. For example:

what they wanted him to do for them

Matthew 20:33

Section 20:29–34: Jesus healed two blind people

In this section, Jesus healed two blind people. These blind people called Jesus the “Son of David” two times. This emphasizes who Jesus was just as he was about to enter Jerusalem as the Messiah. The blind people’s simple request to be healed is a stark contrast with James’ and John’s request for high positions.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Two blind men receive their sight

Jesus had mercy on two blind people and healed them

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 10:46–52 and Luke 18:35–43.

20:33

“Lord,” they answered, “let our eyes be opened.”

- They answered, “Lord, we^(excl) want our eyes to be opened!”
- They replied, “Sir, we^(dual excl) want to be able to see!”

Lord: The word Lord means “master.” It was a polite form that people used when they addressed a respected leader.

This word also occurs in 20:30c and 20:31c. You should translate it here as you did there.

let our eyes be opened: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as eyes be opened is a figurative expression. It means that the blind people wanted to be able to see again.

This clause is passive. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

we want our eyes to be opened (NASB)

- With an active verb. For example:

let us have our sight back (NJB)

we want to be able to see

Matthew 20:34

Section 20:29–34: Jesus healed two blind people

In this section, Jesus healed two blind people. These blind people called Jesus the “Son of David” two times. This emphasizes who Jesus was just as he was about to enter Jerusalem as the Messiah. The blind people’s simple request to be healed is a stark contrast with James’ and John’s request for high positions.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Two blind men receive their sight

Jesus had mercy on two blind people and healed them

There are parallel passages for this section in Mark 10:46–52 and Luke 18:35–43.

20:34a**Moved with compassion, Jesus touched their eyes,**

- Jesus pitied them and he touched their eyes.
- Then/So Jesus felt sorry for them^(dual) and touched their eyes.

Moved with compassion, Jesus: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Moved with compassion comes from a noun that refers to a person's intestines. As with many other cultures in the world, Greek culture considered a person's intestines as the place of strong emotion. In this context, the emotion is pity or compassion. Jesus felt sorry for the blind people. Consider how this sort of emotion is expressed in your language and translate in that way. Here are some English examples:

Jesus' heart was filled with pity/compassion for them

Jesus' heart went out to them

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Jesus pitied them and

Jesus felt sorry for them and (CEV)

This word also occurs in 18:27a.

touched their eyes: This clause probably indicates that Jesus touched their eyelids with his fingers or placed his hand over their eyes.

20:34b**and at once they received their sight**

- Immediately, they were able to see again,
- Right away their eyes became well and they^(dual) could see.

and at once: The Greek word that the BSB translates as at once means that as soon as Jesus touched their eyes, they could see.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Instantly (NLT)

immediately (ESV)

they received their sight: There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as received their sight:

1. It means that they were able to see again. This implies that when they were born, they were able to see. Then later they became blind. So, when Jesus healed them, they were able to see again. For example:

they regained their sight (NRSV) (NRSV, ESV, NJB, GW, JBP, NASB, REB)

1. It means that they were able to see for the first time. This implies that they had been born blind. So, when Jesus healed them, they were able to see for the first time. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This interpretation is supported by BDAG (pages 50–51) “ἀναβλέπω **2.** to gain sight, whether for the first time or again, regain sight, gain sight **a.** lit. **α.** of blind persons, who were formerly able to see, regain sight” and Louw and Nida 24.42 “to become able to see, whether for the first time or again - ‘to gain sight, to be able to see, to regain one's sight, gaining of sight.’...It is, however, better to assume that it is a matter of regaining sight unless the context specifies ‘being blind from birth’ or ‘always blind.’” Here are some other ways to translate this word:

- Use a specific term that means “see again.” For example:

their sight returned (NJB)

they were able to see again

- Use a more general expression that means “see.” For example:

they were able to see (GNT)

20:34c**and followed Him.**

- and they began following him.
- So they^(dual) followed after/behind him.

and followed Him: The verb followed is the same verb as in 20:29. You should translate it the same way in both places.